

가을 판타지 소설

즉사기 들고 게임 속으로

Information

Table of Contents URL: <https://www.lightnovelworld.co/novel/i-fell-into-the-game-with-instant-kill-14072111>

I Fell into the Game with Instant Kill

즉사기 들고 게임 속으로

Author: [Gyaol](#)
RANK 284

4.1
293
Chapters
3.77M
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I Fell into the Game with Instant Kill novel is a popular light novel covering Action, Adventure, and Comedy genres. Written by the Author Gyaol. 293 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

I fell into a game world out of nowhere with an instant kill skill. And then somehow, I became a bigshot.

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Comments on the novel chapters for the last week.

(3 days ago)

: 1 comment on Chapter 33.3: Vampire (2)

- 1
l_pear_l
Reader
1mo

01.01.25 23:21 I finished this thing. Overall..not bad. Not the best thing I've ever read, not a world-class masterpiece, but it wasn't bad. Subjectively 7/10. It's sad that the ending is cut short and so many characters didn't play an important role in the end. There is a great sense of incompleteness, but as a relaxing light read it's not bad.

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1 0

- 6
TrainingFrance
Reader
3mo

Jesus f*ck*ng Christ this was a year ago? D*mn I've been here for a long time, shame about the upcoming purge...

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2 0

- 6
The_one_that_wasnt
[TrainingFrance](#)
Reader
26d

FFS not another one I'm still recovering from the last one

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0 0

◦ 6

NamelessShadow

[TrainingFrance](#)

Reader

2mo

Purge?

[Reply](#)

0 0

▪ 6

TrainingFrance

[NamelessShadow](#)

Reader

1mo

It was probably nothing, there have just been some people talking about a site(Webnovel I think) acting up. It is likely little more than rumors seeing as how a month was passed but according to them they might be installing some new anti-piracy stuff...

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• 1

MrCourtingDeath

Reader

3mo

Can anyone recommend novel similar to this one? Like instant kill or sth

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4 0

◦ 12

OnlySageLiving

[MrCourtingDeath](#)

Reader

1mo

“ My Instant Death Ability is So Overpowered, No One in This Other World Stands a Chance Against Me” It’s quite hilarious imo

[Reply](#)

1 0

• 2

Myma

Reader

4mo

I feel like I just ate a whole meal but did not burp

[Reply](#)

12 0

• 1

drakh

Reader

4mo

welp the million comments mentioning the rushed ending were right but still it was interesting for sure

[Reply](#)

- 7 0
- 2
VicPanda
Reader
5mo

The ending was rushed but the story is interesting. If you don't mind unanswered plotlines here and there then this is right up your alley

[Reply](#)

-
- 5 0
- 1
KiYoShIhErMaN
[VicPanda](#)
Reader
5mo

is this harem ? or just one gf?

[Reply](#)

-
- 1 0
- 1
Professionaro
[KiYoShIhErMaN](#)
Reader
2mo

One gf but what really crazy is that there's a lot of female characters. Maybe it's just me who reads novels with mainly main characters in it, but this was a real 45:55 split between males and females. I thought it was gonna be harem, but he does interact with a lot of females, NOT in any sort of romantic way or a way that insinuates it. The only one that stuff happens with is one.

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 1
KiYoShIhErMaN
[Professionaro](#)
Reader
1mo

Thanks

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 2
VicPanda
[KiYoShIhErMaN](#)
Reader
5mo

One. And not even definitely cause they don't actually get together but rather implied that they will do so eventually

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6 0

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- 1
Arian124
Reader
5mo

Is there any similar story to this one? The ending was too rushed for me to be satisfied T.T

[Reply](#)

2 0

○ 12

OnlySageLiving

[Arian124](#)

Reader

1mo

My Instant Death Ability is So Overpowered, No One in This Other World Stands a Chance Against Me But I think “Villain Wants To Live” has a lot of similarities to this even though it has a different premise

Edited: 1mo

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1 0

○ 1

greenmrbeast

[Arian124](#)

Reader

4mo

i'd like to know too

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0 0

▪ 12

OnlySageLiving

[greenmrbeast](#)

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novels like this one, ?

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79_amar
[OnlySageLiving](#)
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I read that

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0 0

- 12
OnlySageLiving
[79_amar](#)
Reader
1mo

Both?

[Reply](#)

0 0

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- 1
BeccaBDP
Reader
6mo

Can you guys tell me what chapter did the MC knight (a girl? i think) is about to fight one of the general who kill her tribe.

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 1
Saitamauchiha
Reader
6mo

Foi apressado... Fazer o que. Mas foi bom ler essa interessante obra.

[Reply](#)

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Chapter 0: Prologue

“There’s only a day left...”

I clicked my tongue lightly as I entered my ID and password in the familiar login window.

<End of game service>.

It was a few months ago that this announcement came out, but thinking that today was really the last time, I felt empty.

Rachronia Saga, abbreviated as RaSa, was an RPG that I had been obsessed with since I was in school and had been playing it for over eight years.

A game that was once quite popular with its excellent graphics, immersive story, expansive worldview, and relatively novel system.

Currently, it had long been branded as a game of obsolescence, and only several hardcore users remain. I poured a third of my life into this game. It had already become a part of my daily life.

However, such a game eventually announced the end of service.

It’s not that there weren’t signs. And to be honest, there was nothing strange about ending it. But I couldn’t help but feel empty and betrayed.

I moved my characters to visit the warehouse. It displayed the stored items on the screen. It also showed the inventory.

Many items accumulated while playing for nearly 10 years.

There were ordinary items, great items, and then there were the treasures that were even hard to find in the game. Looking back, I had too many of them.

I didn't stop there and opened the character information window and the skill window.

[Lv. 99]

RaSa's level system made it exponentially more difficult to level up as the level increased.

Starting from level 80, it not only needed experience points but also many difficult achievements.

At level 99, it was the unofficial maximum level of RaSa. No user had reached it yet. But not it had only become a 'one level of regret' for me.

I wanted to reach level 100.

Sky-piercing stats, all kinds of skills, and even the most gorgeous equipments were lined up on the screen.

It was a splendid character specification that even experienced users did not have. But now, it was all useless.

Why did I spend all that time to collect and strengthen these scraps of data?

“Shall we start?”

I moved the mouse, feeling the anticipation welling up.

It was for my last curiosity that I put all these things on the screen.

The place where the mouse cursor was directed was at the box-shaped item stuck in a corner of the warehouse.

[Box of Chaos].

- A box of chaos that could fuse everything in the world. Items, gold, skills, stats, whatever the character owned could be set as materials.
- [Rating: 9 Stars]

Compared to other RPG, RaSa had a lot of freedom.

So, there were a lot of things like hidden pieces from all over the world. And this 'Box of Chaos' was also an item I got from a dungeon I found by chance.

As you could see from the description, the effect was very interesting.

There was nothing special about simple item synthesis. But in this box of chaos, not only items but also character skills and stats could be synthesized.

In short, there were no restrictions on the type or number of materials that could be set.

Except for novelty, it's an item that doesn't really have much value.

However, the only time I used this item since I got it was when I wanted to use it for fun. It's the reason there were few nine-star items in my warehouse.

The efficiency was simply too low.

Usually, when something was synthesized, something of a higher value would come out.

However, in my case, the value did not improve but decreased.

What's the use of this item when that would usually happen 9 out of 10 times when fusion was attempted?

Of course, it was nice to experiment with since you could use anything as a material and you would never know what would come out. But it's just not worth it.

Until now.

Where else could there be an item as great as this to decorate the end?

[Set the materials for fusion.]

I activated the box of chaos and moved the cursor.

I clicked on items, gold, stats, skills, everything one by one.

I set the items it took me a lot of effort to get and the skills I had gained through luck as materials without hesitation.

Only then would the fusion be completed and the character would return to the first level. But so what? It's the last time, anyway.

If I synthesize everything without leaving a single thing, what will come out?

[Material settings have been completed.]

[Do you really want to fuse?]

Soon, the preparations were over.

I clicked 'yes' without hesitation and, at the same time, felt regretful.

I thought I had selected all of them, but I did not set one skill as a material.

[Soul of the King.]

- The spirit of the supreme emperor is imbued with it and is unshakable under any circumstances. Fully immune to all mental debuffs.
- Every word and action imbued with the dignity and coercion of a rule. Significantly increased the chance of gaining an upper hand in conversation with NPCs.
- Rating: 9 Stars.

- Type: Passive.
- Level: 1 (MAX)

RaSa's unofficial highest grade, 9-star skills or items, were extremely rare and their effects were fraudulent.

'Soul of the King' was also one of those 9-star skills.

[Convergence begins.]

Oh, it's starting.

It was regretful to leave out one, but it didn't matter, anyway.

I stared at the box of chaos vibrating violently on the screen, emitting a dark aura.

Why does the effect seems much chaotic than before?

A few seconds later, a brilliant light burst through the darkness that enveloped the box, and a notification popped up.

[Fusion complete.]

[Instant Kill (skill acquired)]

[Instant Kill]

- Instantly kills the target, ignoring all effects. It can be activated while in contact with the target, and there is no limit to the number of targets.
- Rating: 10 Stars.
- Type: Active
- Level: 1 (MAX)

- Cooldown: None

I blinked and looked at the skill that appeared because of the fusion.

And soon, I let out a low, astonished sigh.

“Wow, fuck.”

What was this?

The rating was not 9-stars but 10-stars?

The existence of a 10-star rating in RaSa was a fact that had never been revealed.

To be honest, I had no expectations. But the outcome was completely beyond my imagination.

I was even more shocked reading the skill description.

Instant death ignoring all kinds of effects? And there’s no cooldown or target limit?

An instant kill with no target limit. Did that mean that I could use it not only on normal mobs but also on boss mobs?

Even the heinous bosses who could only be caught after struggling for a few hours could also be subjected to instant kill?

It can’t be... no, but its rating has never been seen before, isn’t it?

I moved the character with an absurd expression on my face.

I should probably just check it out for myself.

I never thought that I would actually gain such an outrageous skill with one day left before the game ran out of service.

If I had known it would be like this, I would have done this sooner.

Woooo!

“...?”

For a moment, my vision shook, and the world suddenly sank into darkness.

I screamed in surprise, but I couldn't hear my voice. My body didn't even move.

Amid the strange sound that pierced my ears and the dizziness that seemed to turn the world upside down...

[Don't give up.]

Consciousness slowly faded.

Chapter 1: Escape (1)

Dingy floor. Musty smell of dust.

I blinked my eyes and lifted my drooping head.

“Ah~ When can I have a sip of alcohol?”

Right next to me, I saw a bald man muttering something with a stern expression.

Around us, people in similar clothing were crouching down in rows.

It took me a few seconds to realize that it was a prison uniform, and that this was a prison.

Thick chains were tied to each of their wrists and ankles. I could even see the densely strewn iron bars in front.

Besides, what was that semi-transparent blue curtain swaying beyond the bars? It seemed to come out of any fantasy... Wait- what was that?

Other than that, the clothes I was wearing were no different.

I blankly looked down at the heavy iron chains on my limbs.

What the heck...?

I couldn't understand the situation at all, so I searched for my memory.

I must have just been sitting in front of my computer playing RaSa.

Why I fused materials in the box of chaos, an amazing 10-star skill came out, and then... Ah, yes. My vision suddenly went dark. Did I faint?

And when I opened my eyes again, it was already like this.

The memories before this happened were clear. But the current situation was not. Rather, it got more confusing.

“What are you looking at?” The bald man next to me met my eyes and growled ferociously.

“Where is this?” I asked him.

The cool voice that came out naturally when I spoke surprised me.

“What? What is this crazy bastard saying?”

I stared at the man, who was swearing with an absurd expression on his face.

Then, he seemed to flinch, but soon replied with a reluctant expression.

“Where is it, inside a fucking convoy?”

“A convoy?”

“Did you doze off? We’re on our way to Archemon. That damned place, the prisoners’ grave!”

Archemon? Prisoners’ grave?

As soon as I recalled it had a somewhat familiar name, I almost reflexively asked, ‘what?’.

That’s right, because it was the name of a place that existed not in reality but in a virtual world.

In the game world that I knew too well.

“Hey.”

“What else?”

“Are you sure Archemon is referring to the prison camp managed by Lognar Kingdom?”

“Why do you keep asking the obvious?”

“This place, it’s not called ‘Earth’, but the continent of Rachronia, correct?”

The man now looked at me like I was a complete madman.

“Crazy... why did this guy suddenly change?”

The man who muttered so quietly moved away to the side.

I also shut my mouth and just remained silent.

It was because I felt like I finally understood what was what without asking further questions.

Including the numbers right above the heads of the prisoners, including the man next to him, that slowly appeared in his field of vision.

[Lv. 48]

[Lv. 51]

[Lv. 45]

Level display.

It was hard to believe, but it seemed like I had entered the world of Rachronia Saga. There was no other way to explain the current situation.

The vivid sensations were clearly letting me know that the present situation was not a dream.

Besides... this isn't even my real body, is it?

It would have been nice if there's a mirror. But even without looking at my face, I could tell that this wasn't my body.

The color of the skin, the voice, the body shape, everything was different. The body itself felt different from usual.

Possession? Did I possess a character in a game? How could this nonsense happen?

“...”

I quickly settled the confusion in my mind and sorted out the situation of this body first.

It wasn't difficult because I got enough information from the short conversation I just had.

The convoy, and the Archemon camp.

As the bald man said, the place did not differ from a prisoner's grave.

It was a place I knew well because it was one of the many processes that I went through while progressing through the main story.

A place where you can't even dream of being released or of escape, living your life in harsh labor and being experimented by, and then dying with all your blood sucked dry.

Apparently, I possessed one prisoner being escorted to that rough area.

Why did I enter this body? More than that, who, and for what purpose, put me in such a dog-like situation?

If you think about it, it's something that couldn't be easily figured out.

More than that, I had to do something first for my immediate survival problem.

At that moment, I suddenly realized the weird gap in my mentality.

Why am I so calm?

I suddenly entered a game and became a prisoner who was about to be taken to a concentration camp. Wasn't this a situation where it wouldn't be strange if I lose consciousness and started panicking? Usually, that would be the case.

But I was thinking of quickly sorting things out and solving the immediate crisis.

The agitation was only for a moment. What I felt right now was not fear or worry, but only a little confusion and doubt.

I used to think that I belonged to the rational side, but... was I the situation who could be remain calm in such an absurd situation?

Kwaaang!

Then, suddenly, a heavy explosion sounded.

The space shook from the explosions that sounded one after another without seemingly no end. What else was happening this time?

Embarrassed prisoners muttered and raised their bodies that had fallen to the floor.

“Fuck, what’s that? What’s going on?”

“Looks like something exploded upstairs.”

While the vibration of the hull continued for a long time, the prisoner’s eyes all at once turned towards the bars. All with eyes like surprised rabbits.

It was because the blue curtain that surrounded the outside of the prison was slowly losing its light and becoming blurry.

Eventually, as the curtain completely disappeared, someone shouted.

“The barrier is gone!”

As if that cry had been a signal, crunches echoed everywhere.

It was the sound of prisoners breaking the restraints tied to their hands and feet.

“Hahaha! What the heck is this? The mana has really returned!”

“Freedom! Let’s overturn everything!”

The prisoners who found their freedom in an instant ran amok with joy.

I stared blankly at the unprecedented mess happening in front of me. They were like monsters beyond common sense.

As if those iron bars were papers.

Soon the prisoners who had torn off the iron bars came out one by one.

Even then, I still had no choice but to sit alone and stare at what they’re doing in dismay.

With the sound of explosion and the rocking boat, I knew the situation was taking an unusual turn. But I had no option to escape.

Shit.

I cursed inwardly as I looked down at the restraints that wouldn’t budge, no matter how hard I tried.

The muscle strength of this body seemed to be at a normal level, not much different from my original body.

So, it’s only natural that I couldn’t break it, unlike the other prisoners.

At that moment, another explosion erupted. It was very close this time.

One prisoner who was first to come out suddenly went flying like a cannonball and crashed into the wall.

The other prisoners' eyes widened at the sight of that prisoner dying instantly with a huge hole in his chest. His shape was so distorted that it was hard to even recognize him.

“These bugs are jumping around excitedly. Where are you planning to crawl out?”

It was an old man with gray hair who entered and said that in a ghastly voice.

An old man who exuded a sense of intimidation like a mountain. He looked gigantic that all the rugged prisoners looked like children.

“Stop him...!”

Some prisoners who were unaware and tried to pounce ended up in a situation no different from the prisoner who had crashed into the wall earlier.

As if to drive away flies, the old man's fist turned to those who tried to attack him into a piece of minced meat.

He didn't stop there and started slaughtering all the remaining prisoners.

Speed and destructive power far beyond humans.

I couldn't follow his movements with my eyes. All I could see was the sight of prisoners' bodies bursting out one after another, which turned into fountains of red blood.

It was a sight that seemed infinitely unreal. Could it be that the human body could shatter so easily, like bursting a fruit?

Kwaaang!

In the meantime, a guy flew to where I was sitting and crashed into me. Blood splattered on my face.

He literally wiped the prisoners out in the blink of an eye, unable to resist or flee.

In fact, from the moment the old man appeared, it was easy to guess the result. Because...

[Lv. 91]

I could tell from the level displayed above his head.

He was a monster in a different level from others.

At most, no matter how many level 40 or 50 prisoners flocked to him, they could never touch the old man.

As with all RPGs, especially in RaSa, the larger the level gap, the harder it was to establish an equal battle. The number of prisoners was meaningless. Not to mention the vast difference in levels.

Fuck.

A terrible sight, a thick bloody smell.

Wiping the blood from my cheeks, I once again cursed inwardly.

I entered the game out of nowhere, became a prisoner of a convoy, something exploded and then shit happened, and the monster old man suddenly appeared and massacred the other prisoners.

So much had happened in a short amount of time.

The only thing that was certain was that my life was now in greater danger than hanging from a rotten rope on a cliff.

“Huh, is there still someone left?”

The old man looked my way curiously, brushed off the blood soaked in his fist and walked closer.

He climbed over the broken bars and entered the prison, looking down at me. I also looked up at him without speaking.

In fact, it was just that I couldn't get out of the restraints. But since I didn't run away and stayed calm, I had a tiny expectation that he would somehow save me.

But it seemed like a futile hope.

A cruel smile crept across the old man's lips.

"A guy with strange eyes. Such a waste that you have to be killed here."

He suddenly placed a huge hand on top of my head.

Even though it was just him placing a hand on my head, I felt the pressure as if my head would collapse at any moment.

If the old man put even a little of strength in his grip, my head would explode. And that was the future that would happen soon.

Am I going to die in vain like this?

Even amid this, my head was still calmly assessing the situation.

Maybe if I die like this, I can go back to my original world?

It was not without possibility. However, I couldn't just throw away my current life as easily as a game.

"...!"

In an instant, while desperately searching for a way out, I remembered something.

Last minute before entering the game.

The box of chaos, a skill that popped out because of merging everything that my character possessed.

[Instant Kill]

Instantly kills the target, ignoring all effects. I can activate it while in contact with the target, and there is no limit to the number of targets.

No way. That thought crossed my mind.

Because I entered this game right after the fusion ended.

There was no certainty. However, now it was a desperate situation where I had to grab at least a straw.

“I am the warrior, Garten. If you have any last words, I will listen to it.”

I met the old man’s eyes and opened my mouth.

“Die.”

The hand that had been placed on my head slipped away.

The old man’s huge body collapsed on the floor like a doll with its strings cut off.

Chapter 2.1: Escape (2)

“...”

I stared blankly at the fallen old man, lost for a moment.

Did it really happen?

The unfocused eyes, without the slightest movement, those definitely belonged to a dead person.

The effect of the skill had been activated successfully. At least that's what I wanted to believe.

If not, what else could be the reason for this monster to suddenly collapse?

I was now convinced that I possessed this body while retaining the instant kill skill that came out of the fusion.

Then what other skills do I have besides that instant kill?

My thoughts naturally flowed in that direction.

Even in RaSa, I was one of the high level players which could be counted in one hand.

If I maintained the other skills that my character had as they were... I would have danced happily right about now. But it wasn't the case.

Among the skills that I possessed, there were many passive skills that amplified the character's basic stats. So, if the skills were maintained, it wouldn't make sense for this body to be so weak now.

Even if I tried to use some of the active skills, none of them seemed to be usable.

There are no other skills, so why only instant kill? Ah...

I quickly realized the reason.

Why? Because all other skills and stats were used as fusion materials.

If the game character's abilities were transferred based on the point at which I completed fusion, then everything made sense.

This extremely weak physical ability, and that no skills other than instant kill existed... I sighed.

Could it really be like that? Really?

For a moment, I felt a chill behind my back.

Then, if there was no fusion, could it have been possible for my game character's abilities to have been maintained?

No, the current situation itself might not have occurred if that fusion never happened.

I possessed someone in the game right after I fused all of my game character's abilities and items. The correlation between the two was a bit of a reach. But it's the most plausible answer.

Either way, I shouldn't have done that damn fusion at all.

Regrets wouldn't help.

I calmed down the rage that was about to boil inside me and tried to regain my composure in an instant.

...Ah, was it like that?

Then I suddenly realized the reason I could maintain this nonsense composure without the slightest agitation.

[Soul of the King]

It imbued the supreme status of a king in the soul and was unshakable under any circumstance. Fully immune to all mental debuffs.

Every word and action imbued with dignity and coercion of a ruler. Significantly increased the chance of gaining an upper hand in conversations with NPCs.

A 9-star skill that I accidentally left out during fusion - the [Soul of the Emperor].

I wondered if its effects were affecting my psyche.

Thanks to this, it must be possible to continue maintaining composure even in this crazy situation, even in this chaos where I almost died, and the surroundings had become a sea of blood with pieces of corpses all around.

It would be truly be impossible if it was me before.

I moved my gaze again to the old man who had become a cold corpse.

By the way, did he say ‘the warrior Garten’?

One of the five stars of Santea, a person who could rank among the continental-class powerhouses in the worldview of RaSa, it referred to the label ‘warrior’.

I know the name ‘warrior’ very well. But the name ‘Garten’ was unfamiliar.

The warrior that appeared while I was playing RaSa was not Garten but someone different.

I’m sure I didn’t remember it wrong... could it be a different timeline?

Also, I was not sure why someone of such a status was aboard Archemon's convoy.

No, I should put aside those things for now.

What should I do from now on then?

It's good that my life was saved right away, but there's still a crisis at hand.

My hands and feet were still bound in restraints. And although the sound of the explosion had stopped, the ship's unsteady shaking seemed to get worse.

I was not sure what the heck was going on with this convoy. But if I continued to be tied up like this, there's a high possibility that my survival would be threatened again.

"...?"

At that moment, my gaze turned to one side.

It wasn't conscious; it was more like a reflex.

It's because something strange caught my eye in the corner of my field of vision - just beyond the bars.

[Lv. 89]

A level indicator floating on an empty space.

After thinking of the possibility of what was happening, I concluded quickly, with little difficulty.

Stealth-type skill...

There's no way a level indicator would float there when there's no one standing in that area.

It meant that someone invisible was there.

I was not sure how long this person had been hiding, but that wasn't the important part.

The level was not as high as the previous one, but it's still a monster with almost the same level.

I had to make the right decision about how I would act in front of that unknown opponent.

But before that, my mouth had already opened reflexively and spoke against my better judgment.

And in a very arrogant and careless tone, too.

“Stop acting like a rat and come out.”

...Did I suddenly go crazy and was secretly wishing to die?

I didn't know why those words suddenly popped up. Something like mere instinct overtook reason for a moment. I immediately realized where it was coming from.

Was there anything than the [Soul of the King] that could have a sudden impact on my current personality?

Fuck.

Whatever it was, it completely screwed me over.

Even if there's an instant kill skill, it couldn't be activated unless I was in contact with the target.

If that unknown opponent, angry at my provocation, launched an attack, my life would end just like that.

But fortunately, no such disaster occurred.

Squek.

After a while, darkness filled the air, and a man in a robe appeared.

Chapter 2.2: Escape (2)

Dayphon walked down the hallways, across the corpses of convoys and sailors.

Things went smoothly as planned.

The ship had been largely destroyed, so the convoy would soon sink.

Now, he only needed to kill the ‘warrior’ and he could return without leaving a single survivor.

He didn’t expect that the Rognar Kingdom would have any preparations, so it was quite unexpected that one of the five stars would appear.

Five Stars of Santea. It was unreasonable to deal with someone as strong as that alone, even if it was Dayphon.

But he wasn’t too concerned. Because there was a card prepared for such a variable.

Is it over there?

The strong energy felt from downstairs made Dayphon immediately convinced that the warrior was there.

The inside of the cabin, which appeared to be the prisoner’ confinement spaces, was already a gruesome scene with the bodies of the prisoners.

It was difficult to control even the rampaging prisoners when the convoy was attacked, so the person responsible for this must have dealt with them all.

Moving leisurely inside the cabin while hiding, he could find the warrior Garten as expected.

“I am the warrior, Garten. If you have any last words, I will listen to it.”

The warrior had his hand on top of a prisoner’s head.

Dayphon stood at a distance and watched the scene.

He didn’t know the full situation, but the warrior was planning to deal with the last surviving prisoner after he listened to his will.

I have to attack the moment he kills that prisoner.

If possible, it would be better to launch a surprise attack at the most appropriate time.

After deciding, Dayphon waited for the warrior to explode the prisoner’s head.

And soon, the prisoner’s mouth opened.

“Die.”

Dayphon’s eyes widened in astonishment at the sight that followed.

“...?!”

The warrior’s body collapsed on the floor at the prisoner’s words.

For a moment, he did not know what had happened.

Dead...?

No breathing, no heart beating.

The sign of life was completely cut off from the fallen warrior, and Dayphon could no longer feel any energy from him.

He's really dead.

In an instant, one of the Five Stars of Santea, a warrior with a high reputation throughout the continent, died just like that.

Dayphon reflexively stopped breathing and killed his presence as much as possible.

A prisoner with restraints on his hands and feet, staring down at the dead warrior.

It was hard to believe, but it was a sight that made one think he had killed the warrior, Garten.

But how?

The other didn't lift a finger. All the mad did was say a short word - 'die'.

...Spirit magic? Is it some kind of spirit?

However, how could there be a spirit capable of killing the warrior with just one word? What kind of spirit was that?

Dayphon stared at the man with confusion.

The appearance of a variable that was far beyond the assumption. He couldn't really decide what to do in this absurd situation.

Surprise attack? Doing that would be crazy, especially since he's up against a monster who killed the warrior in just an instant.

Even with the power provided by the King of the Dead, the original plan to kill the warrior, the odds of winning were unknown.

So, should I retreat like this? But to return without knowing the identity of that unknown person...

“...!”

For a moment, Dayphon felt goosebumps welling up all over his body.

It was because the man suddenly turned his gaze and was staring at where he was.

“Stop acting like a rat and come out.”

...Caught. Since when?

That his stealth skill was so easily discovered made Dayphon feel the greatest shock and disappointment.

It was because he had the highest stealth ability on all continents.

He was still thinking of escaping just now, but he soon gave up on that idea.

His life could easily end in an instant, just like what happened to the warrior just now. He couldn't risk that.

Squeak.

Dayphon appeared and met the man's eyes.

In the empty eyes that did not show any emotion, he felt an indescribable sense of coercion.

Dayphon only had a vague intuition.

That the man in front of him might be someone on par with the monarchs.

“...Who are you?”

After a moment of silence, Dayphon asked.

The man just stared at him with his mouth still closed, as if he had no intention of answering.

Unspoken pressure. Dayphon guessed the meaning of that gaze and thought about what to say.

The other's identity was unknown, but he was escorted to Archemon as a prisoner and he killed the warrior without hesitation.

At least there was no friendly relationship there, so it wouldn't matter if Dayphon revealed his identity. No, it would be better to make it clear.

"I am a member of the Calderic Monarchy, Dayphon. Not affiliated with the Rognar Kingdom or Santea Empire Alliance."

At those words, a slight change occurred in the man's expression. He wasn't sure what the other was thinking.

"...Calderic Monarchy?"

After mumbling like that, he paused and asked;

"What did you do to this ship?"

"...If you want to know the condition of the hull, the convoy will soon sink without reaching Archemon."

At those words, the man's expression slightly frowned for a moment and then straightened again.

The conversation ended like that.

As if that was all he was curious about, the man asked nothing else.

He seemed uninterested in why Calderic attacked a single convoy or the details behind it.

For now, is it fortunate that that's the case?

Dayphon was a little relieved at the other's attitude that didn't show any hostility.

No, rather than having no hostility... it seemed closer to not being interested anymore since Dayphon had already answered his question.

As long as Dayphon didn't attack, the man didn't seem to care anymore whether he escaped.

However, Dayphon hesitated to leave.

It's because he felt regretful about leaving just like this.

He, too, was in a state of growing doubts and curiosity about this bizarre man.

“Why is someone like you a prisoner in this convoy?”

A monster that killed the warrior in an instant and discovered him, whose ability and power were unfathomable.

To Dayphon, the situation seemed ridiculous. Like finding a dragon sleeping quietly curled up with meager shackled at the corner of a goblin cage.

Cooong!

The hull shook violently and tilted.

The man still did not take any action, and the answer to the question was not returned.

Dayphon, who was staring at him, suddenly realized something.

“...”

Empty eyes with cold emotions. Total indifference to the surroundings. A uniquely bored atmosphere.

He had seen a similar person.

That was clearly the attitude of someone who no longer felt any meaning in life.

Perhaps everything was irrelevant to that man.

Even now, even when the ship was sinking, the other did not even think of escaping. Whether he died, his life would not matter.

Killing the warrior and talking to Dayphon must have been just a momentary whim.

Waa!

Once again, the hull vibrated.

Dayphon felt a great disappointment.

A giant like this no longer had any interest or regret in the world and wanted to just sink to the cold seabed and disappear.

The regret made him come up with a rather impulsive, out-of-the-box proposal that didn't suit the situation at all.

“Would you like to go with me?”

He just hoped that he could ignite even the slightest spark of interest in this man's heart.

“To Calderic's overlord castle?”

Chapter 3.1: Escape (3)

Chapter 3.1: Escape (3)

An identified man wearing a black robe.

But at first glance, his attitude was extremely cautious.

I noticed right away that the other person was firmly mistaken about this situation.

...Can it be because of what happened to the warrior?

Were you watching me kill the warrior?

So, did this person perceived me as something more dangerous?

...Definitely misunderstood. If that was the case, the reaction was understandable.

If it wasn't like that, what else could be the reason a strong person comparable to the warrior be wary of a prisoner chained like this?

Anyway, for me right now, this illusion was something I was truly grateful for. So, I tried to keep my expression as expressionless as possible to match the rhythm.

The other had been asking who I was, but since I wasn't sure how to answer, it's better to just shut up.

If I showed any emotional agitation for no reason, it would put me in a more disadvantageous position.

“I am a member of the Calderic Monarchy, Dayphon. Not affiliated with the Rognar Kingdom or Santea Empire Alliance.”

The man introduced himself first.

“...Calderic Monarchy?”

What was Calderic?

It's one of the four major powers in RaSa, which divided the power of the continent along with Santea.

Could this guy be responsible for the current situation?

Besides the warrior, even Calderic. What the hell were these people doing gathering in this one convoy?

I was just guessing, but some unusual power struggle must be involved.

More than that, the important thing to me right now was not their purpose or background, but my immediate survival.

I glanced at the other and asked;

“What did you do to the ship?”

The shaking hadn't stopped since a while ago. But It's not like it's sinking or anything like that...

“If you want to know the condition of the hull, the convoy will soon sink without reaching Archemon.”

Hmm...?

Unknowingly, my poker face broke in an instant.

I would be soon be sentenced to drown in the middle of the sea, so I couldn't help but frown.

“Why is someone like you a prisoner in a convoy?”

I also wanted to grab the guy who threw me into this game and ask him, so please shut up.

What now?

Hands and feet were still tied. And in the meantime, the ship was said to be sinking soon. In addition, a monster close to level 90 was standing in front of me.

Far from improving, the situation was only getting worse.

Even if I kept my cool, was there any way to survive this situation?

Cooong!

The hull, which shook more violently, warned that time was running out.

But why is that guy so relaxed?

No matter how high the level was, could you escape the middle of the sea with your bare body?

But hey, he's the one responsible for this, so there must be an escape route.

Whether if there's another ship prepared or teleporting... Ah.

I realized that I was thinking too much.

That there was only one lifeline to lean on in this situation.

If I can get help from this person...

If so, wouldn't it be possible to at least avoid being buried with this ship?

But the obvious problem was...

There's no way he'll help me.

What reason did he have to do that?

There's clearly a 'boundary' between us.

Since he didn't know my strength, it must have been that he was taking a cautious attitude and not recklessly attacking.

In such a situation, could I really ask for help?

In fact, there was a much higher chance that my neck would be blown off immediately after he discovered I was nothing more than an insignificant piece of trash.

However, he was my only way out.

If I wanted to prolong my life, I had to think of a way.

Whether it's using the delusion he's harboring for me or whatever, he had to find a way to escape somehow...

"Would you like to go with me? To Calderic's overlord's castle?"

...What?

I looked at him, hiding my dumbfounded expression.

"The Overlord is someone who values ability above else. Race, origin, and your past don't matter in Calderic. A man like Sir is sure to be welcomed by the Overlord."

"..."

"Calderic differs from Santea in many things. At least there are many things that will interest you more than a land only for humans."

Even the title had changed to 'Sir'.

But what was he saying now?

It was unexpected, so it took me a while to understand.

...Was he scouting me?

Was that guy now proposing to recruit me to his faction?

No matter how much he overestimated my existence, but, seriously, to a prisoner whose identity was unknown?

More than I thought, I realized he was deeply mistaken about something.

Of course, this was a great opportunity.

The situation where he offered to take me out here without me desperately putting on a show.

If I accepted the offer, I could escape safely from this sinking ship. But...

The problem is what will happen after that.

In reality, I was just a scumbag with no special abilities. So, what was I going to do once I reached Calderic?

And what? Overlord Castle? He's going to take me directly to the Overlord of Calderic?

I'd rather stick my head through the tiger's jaws.

...But there was no other way.

Whether it's being crushed by the wreckage of a collapsing ship or drowning in the sea, if I didn't accept this offer, I would surely die on the spot.

Right now, my priority was to live. I'd just think of the aftermath later.

After a long silence, I quietly opened my mouth.

"Is this a recruitment offer?"

“Of course.”

A quick answer came back.

“It’s Calderic...” I muttered that and then continued, “It’s a little interesting.”

Chapter 3.2: Escape (3)

Chapter 3.2: Escape (3)

Oh, wait. That's probably a bit too much.

I immediately regretted what I said. What did I mean by 'interesting'? I probably went too far to create an atmosphere. It would have been okay to just nod and accept the other's offer.

Still, I was safe since Dayphon's face seemed to brighten up a little for an instant.

Fortunately, my earnestness seemed to have been conveyed, and he walked into the prison.

Kang!

An unknown intangible force easily smashed the restraints, and it scattered on the floor.

Only then could I regain my freedom.

When I glanced at him, he didn't look like he found anything strange.

Yeah, could you imagine that the guy who killed the warrior was a weakling who couldn't even break a single piece of metal?

"I formally greet you again. I am Dayphon Cladinel, Chief of Staff of the Overlord, belonging to the Overlord Castle of the Calderic Monarchy."

Overlord's direct chief of staff?

Somehow, the identity is amazingly high.

Only then did I know his true identity.

I didn't memorize all the names of the many NPCs in RaSa, so I couldn't immediately recall the names when I heard them.

Chief of staff of the Overlord of Calderic. He was the closest aide to the Overlord, and his actual influence was as great as that of the Nine Lords.

After he finished speaking, he stared at me.

It was a gaze waiting for an answer.

I felt uneasy. I didn't even know who this body belonged to, so how could I introduce myself?

After a moment of silence, I finally uttered a short word.

“Ron.”

There was no meaning behind it. Just a name that came to my mind randomly in an instant.

Because I couldn't even say my real name—Seok Ja—in this Western-style fantasy world.

Fortunately, Dayphon nodded without asking further.

“Oh, and excuse me, but can I have the warrior's corpse?”

“...?”

“There's probably someone else who might want this. Ownership of the body, of course, belongs to Sir Ron.”

No, I don't need any of that.

What did he mean by having ownership over a dead body? Who would want this?

Ah, is he talking about the King of the Dead?

Anyway, it was a good thing for me, so I replied he could take care of it in whichever way he wanted.

After a short thank you, Dayphon waved his hand at the warrior's corpse.

Then, a dark aura rose and in an instant swallowed the corpse without a trace.

“Then, Sir Ron, I will take you to the Overlord's Castle right now. I will teleport you, so please do not resist my magic.”

Dayphon said and held out his hand.

Come to think of it, one of the Chief of Staff's abilities must have been an ultra-long distance teleport. But wait a minute—

...To the Overlord's castle right now?

I stared at his outstretched hand with a trembling heart, then grabbed it and stood up.

Ugh.

Soon, the surrounding space slowly distorted with a soft blue light, and for an instant, I felt a sensation as if my body was floating.

...Felt like vomiting. How much time had passed? Had 10 seconds passed?

When my vision became clear again, I was no longer in the prison of a convoy.

I blinked my eyes, hiding my surprise at the scenery that changed in an instant.

A dark and spacious communal space.

On the walls in all directions, there were countless huge stones that glowed in blue, and the light emitted from them gathered right under the feet to form a geometric figure.

...Magic circle?

I looked down at it slowly disappearing, then raised my head and looked around.

Aside from the magic circle, the monsters in robes stood motionless like stone statues around them.

It's like an atmosphere that something would happen if one tried to even move.

“Sir Dayphon.”

A woman dressed to look like a butler came closer and bowed her head.

“Thank you for your hard work. I'm glad you returned safely.

Naturally, my eyes went to her pointy ears. An elf?

“What about the Overlord?”

“She's in her seat. The meeting of the lords will begin in a little while.”

“We came back at a very opportune time.”

After muttering that, Dayphon continued talking to the woman who glanced at me with a questioning gaze.

“This is a nobleman I will introduce to the Overlord directly. Let's do our best to serve him.”

“...!”

Those words obviously took her aback, but soon quickly returned to her expressionless expression.

Then, with one arm folded, she bowed with the utmost respect.

“I have committed disrespect. My name is Caren.”

...Should I say that things were moving in the right direction?

Even after escaping the convoy, the situation was still frantic.

So... this is the Calderic's Overlord's castle, right?

Did we really travel that long distance from the realm of Santea to Calderic in one go?

And from now on, would I have to face the Overlord of Calderic?

Of course, I somehow had already expected that, but... straight away?

I wondered what kind of reaction would Dayphon have if I changed my words and told him I would reject his offer?

Unlike the convoy from earlier, this was Dayphon's main base and the very center of Calderic's forces.

Was it too optimistic to expect someone to let go of me with a smile on their face?

“Welcome to Calderic's Overlord Castle, Sir Ron.”

Dayphon, who had no way of knowing how I was feeling, said that and I could only sigh.

The price of escaping a sinking ship was entering the tiger's den.

The Overlord of Calderic, Rashtain.

In addition, even in RaSa's worldview, one of the most powerful leader.

Ah, now I really didn't know what to do.

Whatever happens, happens, I guess?

Chapter 4.1: Council of Lords (1)

Chapter 4.1: Council of Lords (1)

The cavity must have been deep underground because the stairs going up felt like it would continue on forever.

Upon arriving on the ground, Dayphon apologized and went somewhere first. Caren guided me and I followed her.

“If Sir Ron needs a meal, a bath, or anything else, just tell me. I’ll get things ready right away.”

I replied I would take a bath first.

My appearance was filthy because I had been a prisoner just a while ago.

As if Caren had already expected that answer, she immediately ordered the servants to prepare.

The maids tried to help me bathe, but I told them all to go away.

It’s embarrassing to let someone else wash my body when I was just an ordinary modern person less than an hour ago.

“I will prepare a separate meal while you’re taking a bath...”

“No need.”

I just wanted to wash and clean up. I didn’t really have the urge to eat.

After somehow taking a bath, I changed into clean clothes and was escorted to my room. It was a very spacious and colorful room.

I walked in and stood in front of the mirror.

On the other side of the mirror, a very unfamiliar man was staring at me.

Jet-black hair, pale skin, two bright golden eyes, and distinct features.

How disgustingly handsome.

Putting aside the current situation, this was just a pure appreciation of the body I possessed.

I had already checked it while taking a bath, but it was a face I would never get used to.

More than that, this was not the avatar of my game character, which had blonde hair and blue eyes.

I moved, and this time stood by the window.

Since it was a room on a high floor, I could see the scenery of the castle well from the window.

The gigantic walls surrounding the outskirts, the tall and majestic buildings, and the soldiers and knights standing guard everywhere with a formidable spirit.

The Calderic Monarchy.

One of the continent's four major powers, with the Overlord Rashtain and her nine lords at the peak.

Unlike Santea, where almost only humans lived, it was a land where various races other than humans were mixed.

As can be seen from such characteristic, it was the most free and open-minded force among the four major powers.

The place where I was now was the Overlord Castle of Calderic.

The Overlord's castle was in the very center of Woborn, the capital of Dragore.

Dragore was also a familiar area that I used to frequent while playing RaSa.

Does the city of Woborn spread outside the wall?

Beyond the computer screen, it's hard to recognize places in reality that one had only seen through the game graphics.

If it had not been for this situation, I would have been able to enjoy the overwhelming scenery in front of me.

“Haa...”

I rested my chin on the windowsill and let out a deep sigh.

Really, how did this happen?

Why did I have to meet the overlord of Calderic?

Even if this all blew up from just one misunderstanding, it simply blew out of proportion.

Now, I could even transcend species and understand the mind of a cow being led to a slaughterhouse.

Suddenly, what Caren said earlier came to mind.

Come to think of it, they said the meeting of the lords would start soon...

I was one of the very first players of RaSa.

Of course, I knew a lot about Calderic.

Not only the main NPCs belonging to Calderic, but even the way the ruling class worked and their governing system were still quite detailed in my mind.

It was rare for users to play a game, knowing even the detailed settings that had nothing to do with the story progress, but the case was a little different when the game was RaSa.

RaSa was a game with a lot of hidden pieces, and sometimes one could find clues about them within the game settings.

That's why it was common for not only me, but for most of the players in RaSa to know the most trivial settings one after another.

The lords' meeting.

As the name suggested, it was a regular conference attended by the Overlord and all the nine lords.

And the place where the meeting was held was, of course, the Overlord Castle, where the Overlord lived.

Then, doesn't that mean that most of the other lords are also gathered here?

As I thought about it, a feeling of uneasiness welled up.

Somehow... I got the feeling that this timing wasn't very good.

Because from what I knew, the Overlord Rashtain was someone with a rather erratic personality.

After being in anguish for a while, a knock rang.

"Are you resting, Sir Ron?"

It was Dayphon, not Caren, who opened the door and entered.

I knew the time had come.

The words that followed proved the ominous premonition I had.

"The meeting of the Overlord and the other lords is about to begin. But the Overlord wants Sir Ron to attend it as well."

“...”

Oh.

The goddamn foresight was proven correct once again.

Chapter 4.2: Council of Lords (1)

Chapter 4.2: Council of Lords (1)

After a short talk, I immediately followed Dayphon.

Only the sound of two pairs of footsteps at regular intervals echoed in the wide and quiet hallway.

The destination was, as I heard earlier, the Overlord's conference hall.

Depending on what would happen next, it was a place that could become a public execution ground for me instead of just a conference hall.

Things are just getting more and more complicated.

No, why should I, a complete outsider, attend a meeting where only the lords of Calderic gathered?

Right now, I just wanted to hit the back of Dayphon's head, who was currently walking ahead of me.

After all, he was the culprit behind all this.

It's true that I could escape the convoy because of him, but it was also him who attacked it.

Otherwise, the ship would have been cruising across the sea by now without sinking.

Even though the destination was a concentration camp, compared to the current situation in which I had to face the rulers of Calderic in just a few minutes, wouldn't the former be better?

It's a useless assumption.

I moved on with a detached mind.

I couldn't even avoid it since I had already come this far.

We would soon find out which way was the better way.

Would I be able to survive safely in front of the lords, the pinnacle of Calderic, without revealing my insignificant self?

If worse comes to worst and I really got caught...

Even if it's only one instant death skill, it could still protect me. Even if just a little.

Since it also worked on the warrior, the effect was certain. But there was a fatal condition that I could only activate it upon contact.

Well, even if that was the case, there wouldn't be any other way, anyway.

I could use my vast knowledge of the game as a negotiating card with the Overlord. But I doubted if that would even help.

Of course, the best thing would be to get through this hurdle somehow without getting caught.

The more we walked further, the darker it seemed. Before I knew it, the windows in the hallway had completely disappeared.

Instead, glowing stones embedded in the ceiling lit up the darkness.

Eventually, as I entered the aisle covered with a dark red carpet, several knights stood solemnly lined up at what seemed to be the entrance.

The knights raised their swords and saluted.

Dayphon nodded to the knights and walked past them. And I followed, pretending to be calm.

After walking for a long time in the long hallway, I slowly saw a huge door at the end.

And the figure of someone standing in the front a little further away, as if they had just arrived like us.

It was a woman with red hair reminiscent of a blazing fire.

The beast's ears stood on either side of her head. A cut that ran in an oblique line from the forehead to the chin. And the huge sword on the back.

“Hey, chief of staff.”

The woman who was looking this way spoke in a light tone.

Contrary to that, Dayphon bowed his head politely.

“Fifth Lord.”

I knew her true identity from the moment I saw her, even without hearing her title or name.

[Lv. 95]

With that terrifying level and that appearance, there was only one person who came to mind.

The Fifth Lord – the Mad Lord, Ignel.

Even before entering the meeting room, one of the lords suddenly appeared like this.

I looked at her, feeling a little strange.

Even though she's just standing there, her presence seemed to weigh down the entire space.

I wasn't familiar with the 'warrior'. Dayphon was a character that was rarely involved in the game, but the Fifth Lord was different.

One of the most familiar names among the named boss characters in the game, which I struggled to defeat dozens of times.

Once again, I realized the fact that this was a world within the game.

“It would be a big deal if I didn’t arrive on time. But what is that?”

The Mad Lord asked with a chin gesture towards me.

“The Overlord herself is the one who gave permission to let this person attend the meeting.”

“...Hoh?”

At that, she put on a puzzled expression.

“The Overlord’s permission, that’s something rare. So, who is it?”

“This time, I accidentally brought them from outside...”

“Ah, come to think of it, you went to Santea. Where did you find such a guy...hmm?”

Her gaze turned back to me.

The beast’s pupils, which were torn vertically, scanned my whole body once, and I met a pair of terrifying eyes.

“It doesn’t look like much.”

Waa!

An explosive sound shattering the air.

Suddenly, her hair fluttered with the gust of wind, and the blade of her sword stopped right in front of my neck.

“...”

I just stared at her, who was holding a sword, stiff as a stone statue.

...What did she do? Did she wield her sword? When?

I wasn't even aware of her pulling the huge sword out of her back.

Unreasonable speed, as if it omitted altogether the process of going from point A to point B.

"Hmm?"

The Mad Lord grinned as she drew her sword back.

"No matter how lifeless it looks, I never thought you wouldn't react at all. You're tough compared to your appearance."

It's not that I didn't react, it's that I couldn't.

I felt like I just went back and forth on the Jordan River just now.

If it wasn't for the emperor's soul, I would have collapsed already because of how weak my legs became.

"Fifth Lord."

Thankfully, Dayphon stepped forward with a firm voice.

"Don't be too serious. It's just a light greeting."

Giggling, the Mad Lord retrieved the sword and turned around.

"You, let's talk together later when the opportunity arises. No matter how I look at it, I can't feel any magic power. So, I wonder what kind of ability you have."

What a terrible suggestion.

It seemed that more stacks of misunderstanding had accumulated unintentionally.

As I watched her from the back as she continued to walk towards the door, Dayphon bowed his head to me.

He seemed to apologize for what had just happened.

It would have been nice if he had stepped forward before Ignel swung her sword. Well, let's just be thankful that my neck was still intact.

Cooong!

The huge door opened wide with a heavy echo.

The Mad Lord opened the door first and went inside the meeting room.

All the other lords, aside from her, must have already been inside.

“Then, let's go in.”

I entered the meeting room with Dayphon, feeling as if I was walking through the jaws of a monster.

Chapter 5.1: Council of Lords (2)

Chapter 5.1: Council of Lords (2) Bonus chapter for today! Thank you to Melekono for donating! ^^

The air was heavy.

It was a literal expression, not a metaphor. This was the only way I could describe the atmosphere when I entered the conference room.

It was a much larger and slightly darker space than I had imagined.

The first thing that came into sight was the huge round table in the center, and the five people sitting around it... no, beings.

“Welcome Fifth Lord and Chief of Staff.”

Breaking the silence, an old man’s benevolent voice resounded.

It was a voice from a dwarf occupying a seat at the round table.

He was short, tanned skin, and had a thick beard that extended under his chin.

Above all, his rock-like muscular body was clearly visible, even from a distance.

There was only one being that could have all those features—a dwarf.

I also knew who he was.

The First Lord—the Wiseman, Agor.

All the gazes of the Lords of the Round Table, including him, were directed our way.

“Oh, it’s been a while old Agor.”

The Mad Lord approached one of the empty seats and sat down.

Other than that, there was no other greeting.

It’s just that the gazes filled with question were still lingering on Dayphon and I.

The Third Lord—the Heavenly Palace, the Second Lord—the Thunder Lord, the Sixth Lord, the Tyrant, and the Eight Lord, the Black Sea Empress. I also looked at their faces and matched them with the names in my memory one by one.

The lords of Calderic were of completely different races and characteristics, so it was easy to see who was who at a glance.

Is the Overlord not here?

Hadn’t she reached the conference room yet?

Besides the Overlord, the fourth, seventh, and ninth Lords were nowhere to be seen.

It was unknown whether they had not yet arrived or were absent altogether.

“By the way, who is the human next to you?”

The First Lord—the Wiseman, asked Dayphon.

As he explained to the Mad Lord earlier, Dayphon introduced me again.

“This is an honored guest brought in from the outside. The Overlord permitted him to attend the meeting.”

The reaction of the Lords to those words were varied.

“The Overlord gave... permission?”

The Wiseman, who asked, muttered in a mixture of doubt and surprise.

“Huh? What’s with this situation?”

The Eight Lord, the Black Sea Empress, rested her chin on the table and expressed interest.

“Anyway, our Overlord really prepared something good. At least this meeting hasn’t been boring from the start.”

The Tyrant also laughed as if he was having fun.

“...”

The Third Lord, the Heavenly Palace, was staring blankly into space as if he was not interested.

In the first place, he hadn’t even looked this way from the very beginning.

“Why did the Overlord allow an outsider to attend the Lords’ council?”

The only one who showed negative emotions was the Second Lord, the Thunder Lord.

An elf with long, sky-blue hair and long, pointy ears looked at me with blatantly displeased eyes.

I also don’t know why I’m here, so don’t look at me like that.

Then, the Mad Lord giggled and intervened.

“The Overlord gave permission, simple as that. Why are you acting strict and arguing here, kid?”

The Thunder Lord turned her gaze and glared at her.

“I already warned you not to call me ‘kid’, Fifth Lord.”

“Did you do that? What can I say? Something probably blocked my ears.”

At the Mad Lord’s act of pricking up her ears as if teasing, the Thunder Lord only clicked her tongue.

I just stood there and watched the scene.

As I was thinking about whether I should keep standing like this, Dayphon guided me to my seat.

“Please sit over here.”

So I took a seat at the round table and sat down.

Of course, I didn’t return the interest given by the other Lords.

Oh, I hate it. This kind of atmosphere.

Above all, the Eighth Lord, the Black Sea Empress, who was sitting in the seat in front of me, made me feel quite burdened by just her presence.

The moth-like antennae on the forehead, the huge membrane wings on the back, and the appearance of a mixture of human skin and insect exoskeleton were so grotesque that it was hard to look at her.

Don’t talk to me, please.

Among these monsters, all I could do was keep my eyes on the air and shut up with a blank expression.

As I was having such a hard time, the door to the meeting room opened again and someone came in.

It was a maid.

“...?”

No... maid?

A woman who entered the meeting hall alone bowed her head in greeting, approached the round table, and set down the teacups one by one.

Somehow, a more strange atmosphere filled the air.

The appearance of an ordinary attendant setting drinks before the start of the meeting shouldn't be a cause for worry.

But I couldn't take my eyes off her. Or more precisely, to the number above her head.

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Chapter 5.2: Council of Lords (2)

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That's right, there's no way an ordinary maid could have an insane level that could overwhelm even the other Lords.

...What the hell should I do with this?

"I wonder when the Overlord is going to arrive? Time is almost up."

The Black Sea Empress smiled at me and muttered slyly.

"She'll be here soon. Just wait patiently while we have tea."

Contrary to what he said, the Tyrant, who drank the steaming tea at once, licked his lips and asked the Fifth Lord.

"By the way, I heard you went to Brunhel, Fifth Lord. Was there anything interesting you want to share?"

"Don't act familiar with me, you vampiric bastard."

However, she mercilessly dismissed the question with a different cold voice from before.

The Tyrant shrugged his shoulders as if he was already used to such an attitude.

"How cold. I don't know why you're always impatient with me. Aren't I likable? Don't you think so, Second Lord?"

“Who would like something vulgar like you? I’ve said it many times, but don’t talk to me unnecessarily.”

“You are all too much. Didn’t we just fight on the same side earlier?”

Listening to those useless conversations, I fell into trouble.

How long did I have to watch this absurd play?

Can I test something?

Looking at the maid who came to my side one last time and set down the teacup, I opened my mouth and said;

“Overlord.”

The maid’s movement froze.

“When are you going to end this prank?”

I continued.

The other lords all looked this way with an expression of surprise.

Even the Third Lord, the Heavenly Palace, who had never looked at me before.

“...Hahaha!”

Only then did the maid, who threw off her mask, took a step back and burst into laughter.

“I heard you saw through Dayphon’s stealth at one glance. It’s been a while since a really interesting guest like you came.”

...Overlord Rashtain.

The master of all Calderic and the head of the Nine Lords.

And one of the people closest to the strongest in the worldview of RaSa.

Swish.

In an instant, a black aura wrapped around her whole body. And in the blink of an eye, it transformed her into a completely different person.

Her waist-length jet-black long hair and eyes, and even the clothes she was wearing, changed from a maid's uniform to a bright dress.

After walking to the seat of honor at the round table, she slumped down in her seat, fluttering the hem of her dress.

Dayphon, who had been standing near the entrance of the conference hall until just now, moved behind her and stood still.

“Let's see, the Fourth and Ninth Lords are absent because they're busy with their own business.”

The Overlord's gaze, which was looking around the round table, turned to the Wiseman.

“First Lord must have been busy, but you still worked hard and took part today.”

At those words, the Wiseman shook his head gently.

“It's not a big deal, Overlord. It's my duty as a Lord to attend the Lords' Council unless it's unavoidable.”

The Overlord turned her gaze to the Thunder Lord, this time with a faint smile.

“Second Lord, you look like you have a lot to say, don't you?”

“How are you, Overlord?”

The Thunder Lord nodded, glanced at me, and continued;

“It’s just hard to fathom the Overlord’s intentions in bringing an outside to the meeting.”

“Haha, is the Second Lord asking what I was thinking, doing such a thing?”

The Overlord smiled and waved her hand.

“Since everyone would gather here, I just wanted to make sure that I invited someone suitable.”

...Suitable? For what?

Then, she clapped her hands as if to lighten up the atmosphere.

“Okay then, let’s start the meeting! The first agenda, as you can see, is the recruitment of a new talent. Did you hear about it from the chief of staff?”

The attention of the Lords was focused again, and the Overlord smiled and made eye contact with me.

“First, I want you to tell me your name directly.”

“...Ron.”

This was the start.

There was no particular crisis yet, but I couldn’t let go of the tension.

Something had confused me ever since the Overlord appeared.

What was the reason for bringing me, a complete outsider, to the meeting of the Lords and sitting in this seat, as the Thunder Lord said?

I don’t think she would want me to fight with the Lords just to test my abilities...

“Okay. Then, Sir Ron, what is your purpose in coming to Calderic?”

...What kind of interview was this?

I was quite nervous because a more ordinary question came than what I thought.

I stared at her without answering the question right away.

“Ah, of course, I know it was our chief of staff who suggested it first. What I’m curious about is why you agreed.”

“...”

“Honestly, I’m in a state of shock right now. A person as powerful as you suddenly visit the castle. With your ability, it’s enough for enjoying whatever you want, wherever you want, as long as it’s a goal involving wealth and fame. So, what’s the special reason for coming to Calderic?”

Special reason my foot.

This place was just the only option I had after facing a dead end. There’s nothing more to that.

I knew all the Overlord’s abilities.

I knew it would be useless to lie, so I answered as honestly as I could.

“There is no specific purpose.”

The Overlord narrowed her eyes.

As if to gauge the true meaning of my words.

“...It’s just as I heard from Dayphon. Then, are you saying that you came here purely out of interest?”

She smiled again, raising the corners of her mouth, and nodded her head while humming, ‘good, good’.

She looked like a boyish girl, but I didn’t find it cute at all.

Because I knew the truth hidden inside was a monster that was nearly a thousand years old.

What you see now was just a polymorph shell, not her real body.

So, what's the point?

Anyway, I was sure I didn't end up sitting in this meeting just for those questions.

This was the real beginning.

I waited patiently for the words to follow.

The Overlord's mouth opened again.

“Sir Ron, do you want to become a Lord?”

Chapter 6.1: Council of Lords (3)

Chapter 6.1: Council of Lords (3)

“...”

What?

What did I just hear?

For a moment, I wondered if I misunderstood what she had just said, so I tried to replay it in my mind.

But no matter how much I interpreted it, it meant exactly just that.

This woman, the Overlord Rashtain, asked me if I wanted to become a Lord of Calderic.

Was she being serious?

No, it couldn't be.

Of course, it could only be a joke.

If even I took that seriously, then no wonder I was on edge.

“Ah. This was not just empty words. I'm asking you if you are really willing to be one.”

“...”

“Right now, the seat of the Seventh Lord has been vacant for several years. It just can't continue to be empty like that. But there's no one who I really

like. Just in time, Sir Ron came to visit the castle. And I really would like it if you take over the seat of the Seventh Lord.”

...What the hell was this woman talking about?

Take the position of the Seventh Lord? Who? I?

Hearing her say that, she probably really wasn't joking.

I could barely keep my expression, hiding the absurdity and bewilderment.

But why is the Seventh Lord's seat empty?

Where did the Seventh Lord—the Ghost, Lifrigon, that I knew evaporate?

It's like the warrior being a different guy from who I remembered. Was there really a time difference between the RaSa I played and the one I was experiencing now?

Since all the other Lords are the same, it's probably not the future. So, it's from the past... ah.

The timeline now was probably a few years before the game started.

Well, now wasn't really the time to think about that, but...

“Overlord... are you serious?”

Breaking the brief silence, the first one to speak was the Thunder Lord.

“I was wondering why you had an outsider attend the meeting suddenly, so it was because of this. Was it to decide here right away?”

The Tyrant also let out a laugh and buried his back in the chair.

The other Lords said nothing, but they all had expressions as if saying these were all absurd. Except for the Heavenly Palace, who looked like he was in his own world from the start.

But they were right to have those feelings.

The Nine Lords were beings with absolute power no one could touch except for the Overlord, Rashtain. They were also the symbol of Calderic.

The Overlord, right now, was trying to decide the person to sit in such a lofty seat, as if she was simply choosing a lunch menu.

I was so dumbfounded, but I wondered how the other Lords would be as shocked.

The Overlord laughed quietly to herself.

“It may be sudden, but everyone knows it, right? That there is nothing else necessary for the Lord’s seat except for ability.”

The Thunder Lord immediately protested.

“This is hard to understand. How did that man prove his ability?”

“He proved it enough. I heard he killed Santea’s warrior in one blow.”

“...!”

“Isn’t that right, Chief of Staff?”

“That’s right.”

Dayphon affirmed the Overlord’s question.

Naturally, she seemed to have heard of everything that had happened in the convoy.

“Huh? He killed the warrior?”

The Lords looked quite surprised.

Of course, all the Lords of Calderic were strong beings of a higher rank than the warrior.

In terms of simple numbers, it was only a difference of a few levels. But at high levels, especially in the 80s and 90s, each level was a big gap.

The point that surprised them was not the fact that I killed the warrior, but probably the part where I killed him with a single blow.

“Besides, he discovered my identity at once. Who else could do that?”

At those words, all the Lords fell silent.

Now it seemed that the other Lords had been subjected to similar pranks by the Overlord.

In the meantime, the Heavenly Palace, who had been quiet until now, suddenly raised his hand.

“Yes, except for the Third Lord.”

The Heavenly Palace lowered his hand and stared blankly into space once again.

The other Lords didn’t even care about him acting like that. As if they were already used to his eccentricity.

The Wiseman looked at Dayphon and asked.

“But High Overlord, I’m curious about the details of the Chief of Staff’s mission when he went to Santea this time.”

“Even if you didn’t ask, it was one of the meeting’s agenda, so let’s put it aside for now.”

The Overlord looked around the table.

“Anyway, I don’t think there’s much problem with Sir Ron sitting in the Lord’s seat. What do you think? Are there any objections?”

Then, the Thunder Lord opened her mouth once again.

“Then can I check it myself?”

Check?

It was clear what the other meant.

“We’re talking about the capabilities of this human called ‘Ron’. If the Overlord allows it, a light duel would be enough.”

...In an instant, my heart cooled down.

Calmness forced my heart to sink.

It had to happen.

From the time I entered the meeting room and got stuck with these monsters called ‘Lords’, the crisis I was concerned about had never gone down.

“Seriously, Second Lord? Are you trying to blow up the Overlord’s Castle?”

The Mad King rested her chin on the armrest of the chair and laughed.

“Is there any problem with that Overlord? Things are definitely going well.”

The Black Sea Empress also rustled her antennae and helped with a word.

All the other Lords also showed interest.

“Hmm, well...”

The overlord looked in my direction.

Seeing that smiley expression on her face, I had the feeling that she had expected something like this from the beginning.

“What do you think, Sir Ron?”

...There’s nothing to think.

Second Lord, the Thunder Lord, Elyse.

Fighting that monster that could even cause a lightning storm in an entire area if she used her full power?

A confrontation between an ant and an elephant would be much more rational than that.

With one gesture from her, my whole body would turn into black ash and fly away.

Except for one instant kill, I really didn't have any abilities.

Is there a hole where I can escape...?

Everyone was waiting for my answer.

If I avoided a fight for no reason, I didn't know what kind of reaction they would have.

But things were definitely not going in the right direction for me.

For a moment, a pretty plausible bravado came to mind.

I didn't know if it would work, but the atmosphere would get weird if I stayed silent here longer.

I glanced at the Thunder Lord and opened my mouth.

"If you don't mind being killed." And then added. "I have little talent for being moderate."

Chapter 6.2: Council of Lords (3)

Chapter 6.2: Council of Lords (3)

“...”

After just two sentences, a chilly silence descended on the conference hall.

Terrifying pressure spread next and filled the space.

“How dare you...”

Coo coo coo

The Thunder Lord had sparks all over her body and glared at me with murderous eyes.

A tingling sensation spread all over my body.

I calmly accepted the killing intent of the Thunder Lord and maintained my expressionless face.

The pressure was palpable, but thanks to the [Soul of the King], there was no emotional or mental agitation.

Rather than avoiding a fight, there was a reason I made the atmosphere bloody.

What I was aiming for was the Overlord's intervention.

I said that I would accept the duel as long as it was okay to kill the opponent, and the provocation enraged Thunder Lord as well. It was actually a much more violent reaction than I expected.

If a match was made in which neither side would end well, there would be no way the Overlord would allow a fight... wouldn't it?

Hurry and stop the duel.

The atmosphere felt like a lightning bolt would hit the spot when I was sitting at any moment.

The Overlord opened her mouth. There was some regret in her voice, perhaps because she realized she had been too hasty.

“Stop.”

Unlike before, it was a slightly serious voice.

After that, the Thunder Lord calmed down. But she was still glaring at me.

“There's nothing we can do about it. It won't be a light duel at all, will it?”

The Overlord, who said with an innocent voice, smiled as if to lighten the atmosphere.

I let out a deep sigh of relief.

I was glad that it went safely as I thought.

The other Lords, who all seemed unfathomable, seemed regretful that they missed out on a good spectacle.

“Well, I don't really care.”

The Mad King smiled and said.

“It doesn't seem like he's vulgar like that vampire. Appointing a monarch is the Overlord's authority anyway, so is there a reason to hear our approval?”

“Why am I being mentioned again?”

The Tyrant clicked his tongue and muttered.

The Wiseman also glanced at me and stepped in to help.

“It’s sudden, but I don’t doubt the Overlord’s eyesight. Also, the seat of the Seventh Lord can’t be vacant forever. The chief of staff is also not dissatisfied with the decision.”

Except for the Thunder Lord, no other Lords showed any complaint.

Rather than agreeing, it was close to showing signs of accepting, saying nothing because they were just not interested, or because the Overlord’s will was absolute.

But I hadn’t said I would accept it yet, so why was everything already confirmed?

...I wonder if that’s the case.

She is the ruler of Calderic.

She’s at the very apex of Calderic’s power, one of the four major powers on the continent. Who would normally refuse a seat she was offering?

The problem was that I didn’t really have any abilities that fit the position of a Lord.

Until now, everyone had a huge misunderstanding about my ability because of how the situation fit in. But even the lowest guard guarding the castle gate could kill me.

How long would this good fortune last?

If I accepted the Overlord’s offer and truly became the Seventh Lord, then I would cross the river of no return.

But if I refuse...

It was also a risky option.

It wasn't my will, but anyway, I came to the Overlord's castle and attended the meeting of the Lords in order to not have any enemies in Calderic.

And the Overlord offered the best conditions she could offer.

What kind of reaction would come back if I said I would reject it in an atmosphere like this?

Perhaps the Overlord's friendly demeanour could turn into hostility in an instant. Dare I took that risk?

I didn't know if it would be a foolish recklessness to check it out myself, or if the right choice was to avoid the worst.

Should I ask for time to think?

My brain felt congested.

Wouldn't it be better to postpone the decision for a while?

Then the Mad King looked at me and opened her mouth.

“Anyway, it's a pity. I promised in front of the meeting room that we should try duelling sometime.”

...When did you make that promise?

And what did that have to do with me being a Lord? But I soon understood.

Come to think of it, wasn't there a setting in Calderic that battles between Lords were strictly forbidden?

It was the minimum discipline for Lords with very strong individuality to coexist without major conflict.

“I also really hate ending things in moderation. At least until one side is dead, that's a proper duel, isn't it?”

“...”

The bloody sound of laughing suddenly reminded me of a terrifying possibility.

If I refused the position of a Lord, after the meeting was over, that crazy monster might get excited and start a fight with me.

Even during their first meeting, she pointed her sword at my neck without hesitation, so the possibility was there.

But was that all? Even now, the Thunder Lord next to me was glaring at me with eyes that seemed ready to eat me.

If I refused, I have to worry about what would happen after the meeting was over.

Accept or reject.

Either way, it's a choice between the worst and the lesser evil. Similar to what happened on the convoy ship.

I regretted that bringing the situation to this point.

After all, I had to somehow escape this damn castle in order to escape the reach of the Overlord.

...But regret was useless.

“Now, only Sir Ron's answer remains.”

The Overlord's final proclamation.

“As the Overlord of Calderic, I will make a formal proposal for you. Will you take the seat of the Sevent Lord?”

A quiet silence descended on the conference hall, and the attention of all the Lords on the round table was now focused on me.

Having finally decided, I opened my mouth with half resignation.

“...I accept.”

Chapter 7.1: Organize

Chapter 7.1: Organize

Even after the full-scale meeting started, I continued to sit in the conference room.

Of course, they talked about things I didn't know about, but there was no way I would intervene and open my mouth.

After the meeting, we talked about the dinner in the evening and future plans, and then I returned to my room.

“Haa...”

I sat on the bed and stared blankly into space, then let out a blank laugh.

...The Seven Lords of Calderic.

From now on, I was one of them.

Just a few hours ago, I was living an ordinary life and suddenly I now became a Lord. There's no story like this one.

The realm of Calderic could be divided into 10 areas, with the center as the Overlord's main domain and land of the First to Ninth Lords surrounding it.

The Lords were not just called Lords for nothing. Each ruled a land like a kingdom.

Now that I was the Seventh Lord, I could hold all the power over the area called 'Enlock'.

This was possible because the throne of Calderic had no succession by blood, and was only determined under the appointment of the Overlord.

But that didn't mean that the nine Lords swore absolute allegiance to the Overlord or anything like that.

Although the Overlord was the head of the Lords, as seen in the meeting, the relationship between them was more like a contractual relationship.

Except for a few set conditions, Lords could act freely without being bound by anything.

I remembered reading the reason this bizarre structure could be achieved and maintained in a setting book related to the origin of Calderic.

I remembered that the explanation was quite detailed, but this was the only key point that came to mind.

Because the ability of the Overlord was that great, and she had naturally solidified the power over a long period under such competence.

Some of the current Lords had already been with the Overlord for over a hundred years, and in particular, the First Lord, the Wiseman, had been a Lord for hundreds of years since the establishment of Calderic.

The system that had been carried on under such a long bond was in some ways more solid than the typical monarchy, like the Santean Empire Federation.

...That's all fine and good.

But where did things get so twisted?

After a series of regrets, I suddenly felt funny.

Where did it get twisted?

What did I do to enter this game in the first place? Even if something was twisted, did it really have to get this twisted?

I got out of bed and picked up a fruit that looked like an apple from a basket on the table.

I took a big bite and the sweet juice spread in my mouth.

It was subtly different from the apple flavor I was used to, but it tasted good anyway.

I just couldn't think of anything to eat because of the situation, but I had been hungry since earlier.

I ate a few fruits in an instant because of my sudden hunger, and then I sat down and leaned back in my chair.

There's really nothing complicated about it.

I had already crossed the river of no return, anyway.

Was there any need to regret every single thing and lament on the situation?

Rather than that, preparing for what lay ahead was much more productive.

As soon as I decided, the sluggish emotion disappeared in an instant.

Thanks to the [Soul of the King], a cold coolness was established at the very core of my heart so that I would not be shaken easily.

This was not Earth.

It wasn't even a modern world like the 21st century.

Monsters, war, demons... a wild and hideous land full of many dangers and where the value of life was insignificant.

In the end, unless I found a secure way to return to the original reality, this fragile life could be threatened.

I knew very well what kind of dark future awaited this world.

But there was nothing to be disappointed about.

As one of the early players of RaSa, I had a lot of knowledge and information about this world in my head.

It's also not like I didn't have any abilities at all.

Didn't I have an instant kill and the soul of a king, a mental sustainer that exerted absolute effects?

Of course, it would have been perfect if they transferred all the abilities of my game character.

Either way, it's not a bad situation if one looked at it well.

The title of the Seventh Lord of Calderic.

It came with a huge risk, but it could also give me a huge boost.

At least within Calderic's realm, I could exert absolute power.

It would depend on what I would do in the future, but it will be a great advantage to prepare for the upcoming dangers by using the information I had.

Anyway, the Overlord is...

A stream of thoughts led to Overlord Rashtain.

The Overlord was more unpredictable than anyone could have imagined.

I didn't know what exactly she had in mind for giving me a seat, but it made little sense at all.

I guess there's a reason she asked that.

Why did you come to Calderic?

That was the first question the Overlord asked me.

I was guessing, but maybe that wasn't just for confirmation.

Because she could distinguish the truth from the lies of the other person's words.

My answer, that I had no particular purpose, would have turned out to be true, so at least she would have known that I did not have any nefarious purpose.

Ah, I wonder if she noticed that the name Ron is a pseudonym.

At first glance, the Overlord seemed to have made a very spontaneous decision, but it wasn't.

Whatever it was, she was a person with the ability to rule the great power of Calderic for a long time.

Maybe she intended to make me sit on the Lord's seat and slowly observed the details of my abilities in the future.

Well, anyway.

For now, let's just do what we can.

After sorting out my complicated thoughts, I got up again.

It was clear what I had to do right away.

Organize information in your head and make plans for the future.

Chapter 7.2: Organize

Chapter 7.2: Organize

“As expected, it’s good to not let the seat be empty. Isn’t that right, Dayphon?”

Dayphon did not respond to Rashtain’s words.

It was because he knew she wasn’t looking for an answer.

But he also had the same idea.

Appointing a new Lord was the sole responsibility of the Overlord, but disposing of the Lord once appointed was not something even she could do on her own.

If it had not been for the empty seat, it would not have been appropriate to give any other Lord’s seat to the newly appointed Lord who had only appeared today.

“It was a little surprising, though.”

“Hmm, what? That I gave him the position of the Lord right away?”

“Sir Ron... I guess I should call him Seventh Lord from now on. Anyway, I expected you would offer him that position the moment he’s invited to the meeting.”

Rashtain grinned.

“Seeing him once was enough.”

Ron.

When she thought about it again, he was truly a strange human being.

She was genuinely surprised, especially when he discovered her disguise.

It was a half-joking test, but none of the other Lords previously recognized her identity at once, except for the current Third Lord, the Heavenly Palace.

Above all, if once reached her level, they could not only see the simple external elements but also the much more essential part within.

A supreme soul reminiscent of a king.

She didn't know what his true abilities were yet, but at least he was as strong as the other Lords.

“And didn't you see it? That bored expression on his face?”

“...”

“If I had spent a little more time unnecessarily, he would have definitely walked out, hahaha!”

Dayphon was also paying attention to Ron throughout the meeting.

The other's expression didn't change so much that he thought he might refuse the position of the Lord, but fortunately, that didn't happen.

“The Seventh Lord is going to move right away?”

“Perhaps he will stay in the castle a little longer. I had sent a messenger to Enlock.”

“Yes. Anyway, you've worked hard. This outcome was even a much bigger achievement than our original purpose.”

There was also the plan for the chief of staff, Dayphon, to move directly to Santea, but now, Rashtain was only thinking about Ron.

“I heard he was on the Archemon convoy as a prisoner.”

She heard everything before the meeting started about the incident in the convoy and the situation when Dayphon first met Ron.

Even how he killed the warrior, Garten.

“Did you really not feel any special energy when you kill the warrior?”

“Yes none. Maybe I simply didn’t recognize it, but I was at a close distance of less than ten steps...”

“Hmm, then I guess it’s not magic at all.”

From the moment she entered the meeting hall pretending to be a servant, Rashtain had paid close attention to Ron.

However, she obviously did not feel any magic power.

“It’s ridiculous that even my senses were deceived. It’s highly likely that it’s a ‘mystery’.”

“...”

“Or maybe it’s a racial trait I don’t know about at all. Just because he looks like he might be human doesn’t mean that he really is. I wonder what kind of ability it is.”

Looking at her murmuring with a wide smile of interest on her lips, Dayphon asked insinuatingly;

“Why don’t the Overlord find out more?”

“I told you, I don’t want him to become my enemy. At least, not yet. Besides, Ron wasn’t even his real name.”

“Ah... was that the case?”

“Yeah.”

Rashtain knew Ron hadn't given his real name.

It was easy for her to distinguish the truth from lies mixed in the other person's words.

"The rest of what he said was fine. But... I'd like to find out his identity myself. It surely has been a while since something like this happened, right?"

"...You mean you're going to Santea?"

"Haha, don't be too surprised. It's not right now, but maybe later, when I have time. Dayphon, you always worry too much."

Rashtain waved her hand and grinned.

"Anyway, let's watch him slowly. I'm looking forward to what our new Seventh Lord will do in the future."

Several days passed.

Life in the Overlord's castle was extremely comfortable. The meal was great, and the bed was comfortable.

There was nothing inconvenient as the attendants were waiting nearby and I could immediately order anything I needed.

"..."

I was standing by the window in a daze, getting some fresh air.

I could see knights gathering and training in a wide space like a plaza on one side of the castle.

The reason I was still staying here instead of moving to the Seventh Lord's territory was because I had to organize my thoughts.

I had a busy time in my own way, almost confined to my room for a few days.

First, I confirmed that this world had a time difference from the background of RaSa which I played, as expected.

It was the 759th year of the Rachronia continental calendar, exactly five years in the past.

Including what would happen in the future, important or even a little useful information was drawn from my memory and written. Lest I forgot it.

Since there was no way anyone would recognize the handwriting written in Korean, there was nothing to feel burdened by the memo.

And based on the above information, I also made a rough plan for the future.

What I needed most is power.

The top priority, of course, was to strengthen my personal specs.

I was too weak.

Including personal safety issues, there were limits to what could be done with only a level 1 force.

Then instant kill skill was a trump card that could kill anyone as long as there's contact, but that's all.

If I could level up by killing opponents and gaining experience points, just like when I played the game, then I don't have to worry about increasing my specs.

But now that the game had become a reality, unfortunately, that seemed impossible.

If the experience point system remained as it was, something should have changed when I killed the warrior.

In addition, there was no other systems such as stats, skill information window, or inventory. I tried to mumble into the air, just in case, but nothing came out.

Except for two skills I had and the level indicator in my field of vision, this was almost a perfect reality.

So, how could I be strong in this ‘reality’?

Of course, you just have to suffer and train yourself. Like those novels you have read.

But I couldn’t afford that.

By the way, nothing had changed that showed me that I had a great talent for things like swordsmanship or magic.

How much time would it take to train and become strong enough? Who would I be learning from?

After a few years, would I be able to barely become strong enough to level 30?

Even the weakest knight in the Overlord’s castle would have a much higher level than that.

Because of this, there was only one way.

I just needed to gain the ability that would allow me to become stronger in an instant with no effort.

Mysteries hidden all over the continent, or hidden pieces such as ruins.

Right now, there was a mystery that could be got just by travelling from the Overlord’s castle to the Seventh Lord’s territory.

It wouldn’t enhance my intrinsic fighting power, but anyway, it was the only way to instantly amplify my specs in a short period. But...

It won't be easy after all.

As with any fantasy novels, the place where the mystery was hidden was usually in a rough place. It was no different in here.

Whether it be monsters or traps, I could not overcome all dangers that I would face in reaching the destination.

Should I use the Lord's power to get someone who could do so?

I didn't know if I should really do that if there's no other way, but doing so would make me feel uneasy.

Also, there were things that couldn't be obtained unless I would go there myself.

In the first place, going around the continent to find those mysteries was something I couldn't do alone.

Because of this, an excellent assistant was needed.

As assistant who could take responsibility for my safety anytime, anywhere... yes, an escort.

Chapter 8.1: Asher Gronhilde (1)

Chapter 8.1: Asher Gronhilde (1) Bonus chapter! Thank you to Jess for donating! ^^

Level 70.

Considering this and that, an escort of at least level 70 was needed.

It's a shabby level compared to the Lords, but in the first place, they were monsters outside the standard, and even at level 70, that was actually already very strong.

If level 30 was a level that could massacre 100 ordinary soldiers alone, then level 70 could kill that level 30 easily.

It won't be a problem to find an escort itself, but...

Even if I just went to the Seventh Lord's castle right away, I could find a person who met the conditions without difficulty.

But the question was, how much could I trust them?

What I really wanted was a helper who would always stick by my side and escort me, but, of course, trust was a bigger problem than ability.

Just in case, I had to have someone I could trust as an escort.

“...haa.”

It's such a burden to be in a position that didn't fit one's ability.

I had done nothing yet, but just thinking about the future made me feel like I was already blocked.

I let out a small sigh and buried my back in the chair.

Then, with a sudden thought, I called Caren outside the room.

“I want to read a book. Is there a library in the castle?”

“Yes, there is.”

I asked just in case, but the answer was positive.

It was said that there was not just one, but several, and even the central library existed separately.

Come to think of it, there was nothing strange about having a library in the castle.

The Overlord’s castle did not differ from the Santea Empire’s imperial palace.

“If you tell me the type of book you want, I will immediately get it for you...”

“No need. I’m planning to go there myself, so guide me.”

“I’ll do that right away.”

Caren said something to the surrounding attendants.

Surprised by this, the attendants hurriedly ran to somewhere. I was just asking for guidance. What were they doing?

Anyway, I followed her to the library.

Every time I met someone walking down the hallway, some of them were startled and silent. I could feel their gaze in between.

I hardly showed my face, let alone did anything, but rumors about me had already spread throughout the castle.

Anyway, elves, beastmen, dwarves, giants, and even some rare races.

Here in Calderic, there were so many races.

It was still a landscape that wasn't easy to get used to, but it would probably get better.

The central library was a couple of buildings away from the building where my room was located.

The square where the knights who I saw training from the window were near the path, so I passed by and glanced at it.

As soon as I arrived at the library and entered, I saw an old man standing respectfully at the entrance, as if he had been waiting for me.

Judging by the petite body and the shape of the tail attached to the back, he was a member of the rat tribe among the beastmen.

“Welcome, Seventh Lord. It is an honor to have you here in the Central Library.”

...I was wondering why they were in such a hurry. Did they tell the news that I was coming here?

An old man from the rat tribe, who introduced himself as the director, offered to guide me, but I refused because it's unnecessary.

I left the two of them behind and strolled inside.

The inside of the library was empty with no one, so it was quiet, with no noise.

I didn't know if it was vacant from the beginning, or if they were all evicted before I came.

It's very wide.

After looking around, I could see why the director had offered to guide me.

The classification of books by bookshelf wasn't that detailed, so it seemed like it would take quite a while to find the book I was looking for.

But it didn't matter.

I wasn't looking for a book with a specific content, but anything like a swordsman's book or a magic book was fine.

This way.

I soon found a bookshelf full of magic books and stopped walking.

Then, after picking out a book, I started skimming through it.

There was no problem at all reading the contents.

From the moment I possessed this body for the first time, I could understand the common language of the Rachronia continent, the language of this world that I had never encountered.

“...”

Of course, apart from that, I couldn't understand a single thing in the book I was reading now.

Magic theory... It seemed to be related to some mathematical principle, but I did not know what it was.

Anyway, I can't.

Turning the pages to the end, I clicked my tongue and closed the book.

I didn't go here to find a magic book to leisurely learn magic.

It's because when I was playing the game, sometimes there were cases where I could learn a skill from a book-shaped item like a magic book, so I wanted to try if I could find one here.

However, my expectation was too high.

After looking at a few more books, I neatly threw away my lingering feelings.

After spending some time looking at other books, I left the library with Caren, who was waiting at the entrance.

Should I ask her to make me a snack since I'm hungry?

On the way back to the room while I was thinking nonsensical things, the knights training at the square came into my sight again.

A lot of time had passed since a while ago, but it was still a scene where the heated training was in full swing.

“...?”

As I stared at them with little thought, I had no choice but to stop my gaze at one spot.

It was because I suddenly discovered something disparate among the knights.

[Lv. 81]

A white-haired female knight clashing swords with another knight as if sparring.

Chapter 8.2: Asher Gronhilde (1)

Chapter 8.2: Asher Gronhilde (1)

She was the odd one out.

She was on a completely different level among the knights, who were mostly at level 40.

Above all, that face, it's like I had seen it somewhere...

“Is something the matter?”

When I stopped walking and stood still for a while, Caren looked puzzled.

I pointed to the knights and asked.

“What are they?”

“They are apprentice knights belonging to the White Star Knights of the Castle. They are doing their afternoon training.”

If it was the White Star Knights, it was an elite force directly under the Overlord.

By the way, average knights from aristocratic families were around level 30, but in the Overlord Castle, even those over level 40 were just apprentice knights...

“...!”

Oh, I remembered.

That pure white hair, a knight belonging to Calderic.

Of course, there was a big difference between the game graphics and the appearance in reality, but it was enough to evoke a strange familiarity.

“Is that man the superior of the knights?”

I asked, pointing to a man who seemed to walk around among the knights and guiding them.

“Yes, the vice-captain of the 5th White Star Knights...”

“Could you call him over here for a minute?”

It was a very sudden request. Even so, Caren was taken aback for a moment.

However, she immediately replied that she knew and approached the knights.

She talked to the man and quickly brought him in front of me. Now, this was power.

[Lv. 63]

“It’s an infinite honor to meet the Seventh Lord! I’m Camson, the depute commander of the 5th Knights of White Star.”

A man frozen with tension gave a stiff salute.

“There is something I want to ask you.”

“...Yes! I will do my best to answer anything!”

“That white-haired woman over there.”

I pointed at the woman and asked.

“What’s her name?”

Perhaps it was an unexpected question. Vice-captain Camson put on a puzzled expression for a moment before replying quickly.

“She’s Asher, an apprentice knight. She’s a newcomer who joined three months ago and is currently undergoing the apprenticeship process.”

...Huh.

The moment I heard that name, I felt a slight goose bump down my spine.

Could there really be such a coincidence?

Asher Gronhilde.

One of the main protagonists of RaSa’s main story.

At first, she appeared as an enemy, but as the story progressed, she was incorporated into the allied camp and was a powerful ally.

She was an apprentice knight in the Overlord’s castle.

One natural question was bound to follow.

Why did she become an apprentice knight?

If the level was over 80, it was a level that could go beyond the White Star Knights’ commander and become a member of the Black Star—the elite knights of the Overlord Castle. She actually belonged to the Black Star Knights when she first appeared in the game.

...It’s rough, but I know her background and circumstances.

Because of this, I could come up with a plausible guess right away.

She’s probably still wary of her surroundings, that’s why she joined while hiding her abilities.

What should I do with this?

After the sparring, Asher was holding the sword with no sign of fatigue.

This was a great opportunity.

Even if not, now I had to find a reliable escort. And if it was her, she was a character that could be trusted enough.

Besides, if i could use someone who was strong enough now, but who had the potential to grow to the level of a Lord in the future, she's definitely more than qualified to be an escort.

The problem is how to convince her.

Currently, Asher was a knight belonging to the Overlord Castle.

Of course, with the power of the Lord, it wouldn't be difficult to bring in an apprentice knight no matter if they belonged to the Overlord's castle, but there was another problem.

Asher had a clear purpose for becoming a knight here.

If I took her here with little thought, she might not only dislike me but also become hostile to me as well.

“...”

Let's try it.

Since I had already found her like this, it's too good to just give up and pass by.

Having decided, I opened my mouth again.

“When will training end?”

“We plan to continue for another hour...”

“I'd like to talk to her. Can I bring her with me when it's over?”

At my words, the vice-captain became dumbfounded. This was an unexpected reaction.

In Calderic, the Lord was in the sky.

It was a situation where such a Lord had something to do with an apprentice knight and would take them.

“Mm- of course! You can bring her with you right now...”

“No, an hour later.”

I said, with no area for refusal.

I needed time to organize my thoughts before we could talk.

“I’ll go back first, so when training is over, bring her to my room.”

At my words, Caren’s gaze became a little strange.

I regretted it immediately. My words could definitely cause a useless misunderstanding.

“I just want to talk.”

When I added something, she bowed her head as if to apologize.

I looked at Asher one last time and turned around.

My mind went busy. How could I entice her to be my escort?

Chapter 8.3: Asher Gronhilde (1)

Chapter 8.3: Asher Gronhilde (1)

It was about an hour later when Asher came to my room.

“It’s an honor to meet the Seventh Lord. My name is Asher, an apprentice knight belonging to the White Star 5th Knights.”

Saluting with an expressionless face, she was wearing casual clothes, not greaves for training.

“Sit down.”

I gestured to the seat opposite.

After standing silently for a moment, Asher sat down.

A table with two people sitting opposite each other. Silence pervaded the room.

Slurp.

I sipped my tea without saying a word and glanced at the other side.

Asher, who was staring down at the teacup in front of her, lifted her head, perhaps sensing my gaze.

I vaguely felt the various emotions in those bright scarlet eyes.

Tension, vigilance, and doubt. Eyes saying that she did not know what she was doing here.

...Honestly, this only made me more nervous.

The woman sitting in front of me right now was a monster over level 80, and what I was going to say from now on would definitely irritate her greatly.

But to persuade her, this would be the best way.

I opened my mouth.

“Are you hiding your ability?”

Straight to the point, with no procrastination.

“...”

Asher’s expression slowly hardened.

“I don’t understand why you’re an apprentice knight with such skills. I wonder why you’re hiding your power.”

“I don’t know what you mean.”

A weakly sharp, clearly wary voice.

“If you’re going to deny it, I’ll get straight to the point.”

Her eyes widened at my words.

“White Moon Tribe.”

“...!”

“I heard it was destroyed, but there’s clearly a survivor. Why did you come to the Overlord’s castle?”

The sharpened hostility immediately pierced my whole body.

Compared to the aura of the Thunder Lord I had experienced during the Lords' meeting, it was far behind, but it still contained great pressure.

Faced with her gaze as she glared at me with a fiercely distorted face, I said calmly.

“Stop thinking about useless things. It's impossible to win against me on your own.”

Of course, it was a bluff.

If she drew her sword and swung it here, I would die without even realizing that I was dying.

But I had faith that it wouldn't.

First, Asher was not the type to kill lightly. Although this was her past self when the game hadn't started yet. Her nature wouldn't be different.

Above all, she was not reckless enough to attack anyone much stronger than herself without hesitation.

No matter how proud she was of her skills, she must know the fact that a Lord of Calderic was a different being.

“...”

As if the bluff had worked, Asher bit her lip tightly and regained whatever killing intent she had released.

It was embarrassing to see the blood dripping down from her bitten lip.

Perhaps now she was even more confused.

She was completely confused about how I knew who she was and what my purpose was.

Persuasion had just begun.

Now, let's start with the negotiation.

Chapter 9.1: Asher Gronhilde (2)

Chapter 9.1: Asher Gronhilde (2) Bonus chapter! Thank you to Melekono for the donation! ^^

It was a free break after training, but Asher had no choice but to wash off her sweat and change her clothes and go somewhere right away.

As she walked behind Caren, she was lost in thought.

I wonder if he was the Seventh Lord.

The man who gave me a strange look during training earlier.

She knew that recently, rumors about the newly appointed Seventh Lord had been raging in the castle.

Asher, who had recently become a knight of the Overlord Castle after a long time of wandering, knew little about Calderic.

However, seeing vice-captain Camson, who was strict with his subordinates, frozen in front of the other, it made her realize the status of a Lord.

She did not know why the Seventh Lord suddenly called her.

Could it be that he noticed something? She felt a slight uneasiness in the corner of her heart.

“Please keep in mind that the person you are about to meet is the new Seventh Lord. Please be careful with your words and actions.”

“...”

After hearing the last warning from Caren, they reached the last room in the long corridor.

Clap.

As the door closed and she faced the Seventh Lord alone, Asher greeted him with a bow.

“It’s an honor to meet the Seventh Lord. My name is Asher, an apprentice knight belonging to the White Star 5th Knights.”

The bright golden eyes gazed intently at me.

“Sit down.”

The Seventh Lord gestured to the seat opposite him.

Asher sat down, feeling awkward.

For a moment, there was silence in the room.

The Seventh Lord savored the tea, saying nothing, and Asher, who had no place to look, stared down at the teacup.

Before long, an unexpected comment cut off the silence.

“Are you hiding your ability?”

“...”

“I don’t understand why you’re an apprentice knight with such skills. I wonder why you’re hiding your power.”

Two questions popped into Asher’s head with more bewilderment.

‘How did you know that, and why would you ask me about it?’

If he noticed it from the time he was watching the training earlier, it would have been truly astonishing.

At that distance, what on earth did you perceive and notice? Mana? Or some other difference?

“I don’t know what you mean.”

At first, it was denial.

Asher calmed her agitation and looked at the reaction of the Seventh Lord.

He continued talking without changing his expression at all.

“If you’re going to deny it, I’ll get straight to the point.”

Main point?

Until this very moment, she hadn’t realized it yet.

That the previous worry was not important at all.

“White Moon Tribe.”

...Her heart sank.

“I heard it was destroyed, but there’s clearly a survivor. Why did you come to the Overlord’s castle?”

For a moment, Asher’s mind went blank, and she could say nothing.

How...

She could somehow understand that he noticed she hid her true abilities.

But how did he find out that she was a White Moon?

It was the deepest secret that no one knew anymore, and none should have ever known.

It was a reflexive and unconscious action to show hostility at the being in front of her, who casually revealed such a secret.

“Stop thinking about useless things. It’s impossible to win against me on your own.”

Asher suddenly came to her senses at the indifferent voice she heard.

The gaze of the Seventh Lord was infinitely deep and calm.

Feeling overwhelmed by the static intimidation, she slowly withdrew her hostility.

“...”

Yes... it’s impossible.

The being sitting in front of her right now was a Lord of Calderic.

A top-notch powerhouse in all the continent. An existence that was said to be stronger than the monstrous Five Star of Santea.

Just looking at the fact that he saw through her hidden power at one glance, the difference in rank was definitely quite large.

Any attempt, be it a surprise attack or escape, would be futile.

Feeling helpless at that fact, Asher bit her lip tightly. She could taste the fishy taste of her blood.

I came all the way to this place, overcoming despair and despondency to move on, but would this be the end before I could even try anything?

“What do you want from me?”

Trembling with resentment, she squeezed her voice out, and the Seventh Lord made a strange expression.

“You seem to misunderstand something. I’m not trying to threaten you.”

“...”

“What are you so afraid of?”

At those words, Asher gritted her teeth.

She couldn't say anything.

No one would understand unless they were the person involved.

The sorrow of losing both their family and their home, the loneliness and anxiety of being thrown into the world as a single survivor, the pressure of wanting to do something.

This was Calderic, not Santea.

A land of power and opportunity where one could grab what they wanted if they had the ability.

In her head, Asher knew that, too.

However, the wariness deeply imprinted in her heart from the day her tribe was destroyed made her unable to trust anyone or anything easily.

But what the hell did this person even know?

“I do understand.”

Asher was taken aback.

“I can understand. The longing and sadness you have deep inside your heart, the anxiety and solitude. All the excessive vigilance you show me right now must have originated from that. Right?”

...What the hell was this guy talking about?

Asher looked at the Seventh Lord with a slightly dazed expression.

His mouth opened again.

“I will help you.”

Chapter 9.2: Asher Gronhilde (2)

Chapter 9.2: Asher Gronhilde (2)

There were various races in RaSa's worldview.

Leaving the demons out of the question, from humans, elves, beastmen, with the most dominant population and power, to many other weak and rare races.

The White Moon was a rare race with a tiny population.

A race that appeared to be beings no different from humans, but possesses the ability to convert magical powers into their own unique properties.

Most times, the weaker races did not mix with the world and live in tribal units in wild lands.

The White Moon tribe lived peacefully in their own home in the Alten Great Mountains in the extreme west of Santea.

But the downfall came suddenly.

Just a few years ago, from the present point, the White Moon tribe was completely annihilated by Santea, leaving only one survivor.

Asher, now sitting in front of me, was the only survivor.

If I remembered correctly, she wandered for a long time to find other survivors.

But Asher couldn't find anyone.

Despite taking all kinds of risks for several long years and wandering around the continent and asking around there was not a single person.

After a long time of wandering, the place where she settled was Calderic.

Because she couldn't give up hope in the end. Other than herself, there must be another survivor somewhere.

Calderic was a land that valued one's ability above all else.

If she proved her worth and established herself here, if she could make a name for herself throughout the continent as a White Moon warrior, maybe some survivors would hear the news and come find her.

Even if they didn't come, she might aim for even the smallest opportunity to take revenge on Santea by building up strength and power.

...Asher came to Calderic with that thought in mind.

The reason she hid her power and identity to be an apprentice knight was so she could observe the atmosphere since she just arrived at Calderic.

The White Moon tribe was usually indistinguishable from humans, but because of their unique trait, their entire body turned white when they exert their strength.

Eventually, soon, she fully revealed herself and became a Black Star knight of the Overlord Castle. But...

"I will help you."

Now, before that happened, I should first put her to my side.

I then opened my mouth.

"I can roughly guess the purpose of your coming to Calderic."

"..."

“Either to spread fame and make other survivors of your tribe reach out to you, or to get revenge on Santea. Maybe it’s both... Judging by your expression, it seems to be the correct answer.”

Asher’s face was now full of astonishment.

It was a natural reaction, since it seemed like I could see through her inner thoughts perfectly.

The time had come to bring out the main purpose of this talk.

“If that’s your purpose, then I suggest you become my escort knight.”

Asher became dumbfounded for a moment.

She’s probably wondering what kind of nonsense this was.

“What...”

“I will do many things from now on. So become my escort and follow me around. It will be a good opportunity to spread your reputation throughout the continent as the sword of the Seventh Lord of Calderic, as my closest aide, and as a warrior of the White Moon tribe.”

“...!”

“Don’t you think borrowing my name is much more effective in achieving your goals than relying on your own strength?”

It was the perfect excuse.

My suggestion would be a very effective way to achieve the goal of spreading fame as widely as possible across the continent.

Asher blinked silently.

Then she asked me again with a wary face that showed that he couldn’t understand.

“Why?”

Yes, of course she would ask that.

It was an expected reaction.

To her, my proposal would feel like a one-sided courtesy for no reason.

In her mind, beings like a Lord wouldn't do this because they really needed an escort.

Of course, I really needed an escort to act as my arms and legs, but I couldn't tell her the truth.

“There is no particular reason.”

I said dryly.

“If I had to explain it, it's because I understand your situation. And because your ability caught my eye by chance. That's why I was naturally interested in you.”

“...”

Asher was still mixed with disbelief.

After all, I couldn't convince her with such an ambiguous answer.

A good reason, huh.

I thought hard about it for an hour before we started this conversation, but in the end I couldn't find any other good excuse.

I thought of a typical scenario of having some kind of relationship with her tribe, but it didn't feel very plausible.

What could a human being have to do with a minority race living deep in the mountains?

Also, even if I concocted a story, there was a high risk that I would be caught in that lie easily.

Because I knew little about the White Moon.

Therefore, the conclusion that came to the end was to ignore that.

For now, it was enough to make Asher accept my offer somehow.

In the first place, it was arrogance to gain trust by exposing all the other person's circumstances and secrets from the first meeting.

I could slowly build a friendly relationship with her up in time.

“You still don't have an answer. But is the reason for me doing this really that important?”

I stressed that point once again.

“I want you to become an escort knight, so that you achieve your goals more easily. That's all.”

Whatever the reason, my proposal was a great opportunity for Asher.

There was no way for her now to have a better plan than borrowing the prestige of a Lord.

Asher's eyebrows narrowed. It was a sign of deep distress.

Further words would be unreasonable, so I quietly sipped my tea while waiting for an answer.

After being silent for a while, she opened her mouth.

“If you want to make me your subordinate, you can do as you wish, but why are you making such an offer and seeking my approval, for the matter?”

A Lord could do as much as they liked by taking an apprentice knight as a subordinate without their consent.

“Because I respect your wishes. Like I said, I’m not threatening you with your secret. If you have other better plan, you can decline the offer.”

Even though I said that, I knew my offer was hard to refuse.

The words ‘secret’ and ‘better plan’ were subtly inserted intending to pressure her a little.

“...Last question, how did you know I belong to the White Moon tribe?”

“It’s part of my abilities.”

I succinctly dismissed the question.

This was a world where magic, mysteries, and many abilities existed, so it was enough to pass it like that casually.

Asher, who was looking at me with slightly dissatisfied eyes, said as if she finally decided.

“I accept the offer. I will become an escort knight for the Seventh Lord.”

...Finally!

I smiled inwardly in satisfaction.

“Did you say your name is Asher? Do you have a last name?”

“...Gronhilde.”

Asher hesitated before uttering her full name.

“My name is Asher Gronhilde.”

Asher Gronhilde.

The only survivor of the White Moon tribe.

In the game, she served as a powerful helper for the player. And a character with the potential to become just as strong as the Lords of Calderic.

Right now, she wouldn't fully trust me and would be wary, but she would stick with me from now on, so there's plenty of time to build trust.

Anyway, with this, a reliable escort was obtained.

It was time to head to the Seventh Lord's territory.

Chapter 10.1: Super Regeneration (1)

Chapter 10.1: Super Regeneration (1)

Taking Asher as an escort was not as difficult as expected.

When I told Caren about it, as always, she just said that she knew and didn't ask for any more details.

I didn't know if this could be called personnel transfer, but anyway. Caren would take care of it with no problems.

After that, without delay, we prepared to leave for Enrock—the Seventh Lord's territory.

There was a hidden piece I could get on the way there.

It was a rough terrain with many monsters, so I was worried about whether I should skip it, but now that Asher was my escort, I now had a solution.

Why did so many people gather?

I looked at the colorful four-wheeled carriage parked at the entrance of the castle.

It's the one I would ride to Enrock.

Many people around it, including knights, were already on horseback and waiting. It was the manpower of the Overlord.

They asked me how should they prepare, so I told them to prepare however they wanted, and this was a procession that went beyond what I had imagined.

“Then, take care, Seventh Lord.”

Chief of staff Dayphon said goodbye.

The Overlord was away at the moment, so he came out to see me off instead.

Good timing.

I glanced at Asher, who was standing next to me.

I thought it was rather fortunate that Asher had been secretly concerned about being noticed by the Overlord.

If it was her, there would be nothing strange if she recognized Asher’s level at once.

In any case, it did not differ from stealing the castle’s talent.

Considering the Overlord’s personality, she probably wouldn’t care much, but still...

Anyway, even if she heard about it later, it’s best to just take Asher from here now.

“As for the coronation ceremony, if you change your mind, please let me know. If nothing special happens, then I’ll see you at the next Lords’ meeting.”

Coronation.

I had already expressed my intention not to hold an official coronation ceremony.

It was needlessly cumbersome, and I didn't want to be caught in the middle of the Lords again.

I probably wouldn't see the Overlord or the other Lords again until the next council meeting. I was even thinking of avoiding it. Although that would probably be impossible.

Until then, I have to raise my specs enough.

At the next meeting, there was a high probability that they would assign me a task that would be difficult to avoid.

The time was one year.

At least until then, I had to do my best to raise my specs as much as possible.

“We will set off.”

After getting on the carriage, the procession moved noisily.

It was the beginning of a serious struggle.

From the capital of Dragore to the capital of Enrock—it's like moving from the center of one country to another.

Of course, it was a very long distance, so it would take a considerable amount of time to arrive while passing by many cities in the middle.

It would be convenient and nice to just teleport there just like what Dayphon did in the convoy ship, but teleport in this world was not a convenient magic that one could use anytime, anywhere.

Riding the wagon felt unfamiliar at first. But since humans were creatures of adaptation, I could adapt enough to the situation.

Since the roads were not paved, the ride was uncomfortable. But not to the extent that it was unbearable.

Other than that, the servants were prepared for meals and sleeping, so it was not too inconvenient.

I quickly got used to it and killed boredom in my limited space—reading books I brought with me or organizing and checking information on my notebook while idly looking at the scenery outside.

It would have been much less boring if I had someone to talk to, but unfortunately, there wasn't one.

Although there were many people around me, they were almost the same as being non-existent.

Tup.

I closed the book I was reading and looked at the seat opposite.

Asher sat in an undisturbed posture with one hand close to the hilt of her sword.

Unlike me, who was doing this and that, Asher spent the whole day in the carriage doing nothing, in that same state.

I asked her, "Aren't you bored?"

As if it was surprising that I asked such a question, Asher replied with a strange expression.

"It's not boring."

"I'll lend you a book to read."

"No need, milord."

A resolute refusal as if saying she would be faithful to her escort mission.

And the conversation was over.

I sighed inwardly and looked outside the carriage again.

I'd rather look at the wall and talk.

I had the idea of having a conversation with Asher as we rode in the carriage together. As one could see, the result was something like this.

No matter what I asked, what came back was a simple response, so it was difficult to continue the conversation.

I was grateful that she was doing her duty diligently as an escort. But this was almost the same as having a stone statue riding with me.

I knew she had this personality, but as expected, building closeness and trust with her in the future would be difficult.

“...”

The flow of my thoughts suddenly led to one place.

About the hidden piece I needed to take care of before arriving at our destination.

Chapter 10.2: Super Regeneration (1)

Chapter 10.2: Super Regeneration (1) coming up ahead! Thank you to Havi for sponsoring 10 chapters! ^^

Except for the holy sword, there were three main types of power in this world.

Magic, racial traits, and mystery.

In the actual game play, there was no such distinction, and all were unified as a skill system, but once set up, they divided it like this.

Magical power was the most general and wide-ranging power that did not differ from the core of this world.

Basically, it was a power that anyone could handle with effort, but of course there were differences depending on innate talents and races. Except for some races such as demons, humans had the most affinity for magic.

Racial traits, as the name suggested, were a characteristic possessed by a particular race.

For humans, it was the affinity for magical power, for beastmen, physical ability, and for dwarves, dexterity.

In addition, it was not simply being excellent at a particular field, but there were also unique characteristics that only that race possessed, such as the power over spirits handled by the elves, the blood skills of vampires, and the white magic of the White Moon tribe.

Last, mystery.

Mystery was an unidentified power whose source was unknown.

Because it was extremely rare, very few people owned it, and some mysteries were even so powerful that it just made no sense.

On Earth, magical powers and racial traits were all supernatural powers beyond common sense, but in the concept of this world, mysteries were probably the one considered as 'supernatural powers'.

The most important part was this.

It's just these mysteries were very difficult to find, but once you found it and get it, anyone could use it without conditions.

In short, it was the most suitable and almost the only way to improve my abilities in a short period.

The hidden piece I planned to find on my way to my destination was also a mystery.

Super regeneration.

A healing type of mystery that amplified the body's regenerative power.

The mystery of super regeneration was located deep in the Rutus Mountains, where the city of Jenix was, on the border of the Overlord's territory.

We haven't even reached the first city yet, so it's a long way to Jenix.

In fact, going past Jenix was a bit of a detour, but if I could get that mystery, then it wouldn't be a big deal if my arrival was delayed.

There's no need to worry too much.

I glanced at Asher again.

Until I found the place where the super regeneration was hidden, it was her job as an escort to make sure that the monsters on the mountain didn't touch me.

Considering her level, there shouldn't be any problem.

Even in such a situation, she was only focused on her job as an escort, so I didn't have to worry that she wouldn't do her job.

Of course, that didn't mean that perfect safety was guaranteed. But this level of risk would happen more in the future, so I should get used to it.

Still, if I started with super regeneration, I wonder if my life would be easier.

It would have been much better if it was a defense-type of ability, but well, I had to take care of what I could get first.

I looked out the window.

Across the vast plain, I saw a series of mountain ranges like a picture. It was a wonderful natural scenery.

More time passed, and the carriage passed through several cities and finally arrived in Jenix City.

Located at the foot of a mountain range, Jenix had a stronger fortress compared to other cities they passed by.

“Having the Seventh Lord visit our humble city is an honor for us.”

Jenix's mayor was a middle-aged human male.

He seemed much more calm than the mayor of the previous city, who groaned and spit out many praises.

I walked with him and asked.

“Who in this city is the best in the geography of Rutus Mountains?”

The mayor pondered with a mixed expression of doubt, then answered cautiously,

“Unfortunately, I don’t know who is the best... but I think the adventurers of the Adventurer’s Guild know the geography of the mountain range.”

“I need a guide to go deep into the mountains. Find someone suitable, whether it be an adventurer or someone else.”

I remember where the mystery of super regeneration was hidden.

However, I didn’t have the confidence to go there with no proper guide.

Inevitably, there would be a big difference between the map seen through the computer monitor and the real world.

This world was a game, but it was now my reality.

The specifications of the field itself were different when playing the game.

The overall map size of most games was unrealistically small compared to reality. So much so that one could move from one area to another on foot.

That was a just a natural setting in the game since it was impossible to make the player take a year to travel.

I always needed to keep this difference in mind.

Just as it took a long time to get from the Overlord’s castle to this place, Jenix, the actual size of this continent would be thousands of times much bigger than in the game.

Since it was completely unknown what terrain or objects would fill the gap between them, a guide would be absolutely necessary.

There’s no way the location of the hidden piece will be different.

It wasn't just the terrain; it was a problem with the setting of the game.

I added to the mayor.

“If anyone knows of a ‘huge hourglass-shaped rock’ located deep in the mountains north of the city, be sure to bring them.”

Hourglass rock was a sure signpost to find the mystery.

Chapter 11.1: Super Regeneration (2)

Chapter 11.1: Super Regeneration (2)

The Rutus Mountain range was vast.

After crossing the foot of the mountain and entering the wooded area, I realized that bringing a guide was the best choice.

How could one find their way in such a complicated place?

If I only set out relying on my memory, I would have quickly lost my way back, let alone find the place where the mystery was hidden.

Finding the mystery seems to be more difficult than I thought.

After all, nothing was easy in this world.

After a short distraction, I took my eyes off the flowing valley water and got up.

“Keep going.”

“Yes, milord.”

Khan, who had been examining the surrounding land, moved in the lead again.

Asher and I followed suit.

Not to mention Asher. Khan wasn't also at a low level, so they couldn't tire of hiking like this, but I was different.

So, whenever I ran out of strength, I had no choice but to take a break like this, pretending to enjoy the surrounding scenery.

If they even saw him panting unsightly, the Lord's authority would fall to the ground.

It would have been nice if this damn body was above average...

Still, I wasn't the only one suffering, so I stopped complaining.

Khan, who was working hard as a guide, looked stiff even at a glance from earlier.

My existence was quite burdensome, but even that was much better than when we started.

I got it. He probably would have never imagined that in his life as an adventurer he would one day guide a Lord.

"How far into the mountains have we gone?"

I suddenly became curious and asked Khan.

I remember that some powerful monsters also inhabited the depths of Rutus Mountains.

"I've never been to a deep place. There were many ferocious monsters, so it's a dangerous place for me."

"What monsters have you encountered?"

"The one I remember the most was a giant bear. But it's not a normal bear. It's because it had sharp spikes sticking all over its body."

He meant Spike Bear.

As I asked about this and that, the tension seemed to have eased up, and Khan talked a lot. Originally, he had a talkative personality.

“And there’s also a crazy rumor going around lately. An adventurer said he saw an absurdly gigantic snake in the mountains to the north.”

Giant snake?

If it’s to the north, then it would be somewhere here.

“There was a time when that adventurer made a fuss about how no one would stop such a monster coming down to the city, that it would be a mess in no time, and that we would have to call the Overlord’s Castle for reinforcements when it happened.”

“What happened next?”

“First, the mayor listened and said that they would form an investigation team with the adventurer’s guild, but of course, most don’t believe it. According to the story, it’s a snake that’s much bigger than the city walls, but Rutus Mountains aren’t a demonic place. Would it make sense for that kind of monster to be here?”

A snake bigger than the walls of the fortress-like city of Jenix.

A list of snake-type monsters flashed through my head.

Among them, only one came to mind.

...Bellevagorah?

He’s not in a green mountain range like this, but a named boss that actually lived in the Devil’s Realm.

I wondered if I was just thinking too much and it was just a normal species of giant snake?

Do giant snakes even appear in the Rutus Mountains?

Well, in reality, only certain monsters appeared in certain areas.

Giant snakes lived in forest areas, so it wouldn't be strange for it to appear here.

If it's a full adult, its basic level would be at level 50, so it's a sufficiently catastrophic monster by normal standards.

But even if we actually ran into it, it probably wouldn't be a problem.

We had an even bigger on our side—Asher.

And the chance of us bumping into such a monster in this vast mountain range would probably be low...

Rustle.

Then the nearby bushes shook, and something appeared.

[Lv.22]

A wolf.

Its belly was larger than normal, and at the end of its long tail was something thick and pointed like a mace. Flail Wolf.

Khan put his hand on the hilt of his sword with a nervous face.

With its gaze fixed on this side, the wolf had turned its tail and let out a low cry before charging towards us.

A flash of blue light split it in half.

Scattered blood. The chunk of meat, neatly cut in two, rolled across the ground and scattered noisily.

I blinked and looked at the corpse, then moved my gaze to the side.

With an expressionless face, I could see Asher putting back the sword she had pulled out.

Khan, half stunned, looked back and forth between the half-cut corpse and Asher.

I pretended nothing was wrong.

“Let’s go.”

“Ah, yes...”

After all, there was no need to worry about monsters.

Because a strong escort was with them.

Chapter 11.2: Super Regeneration (2)

Chapter 11.2: Super Regeneration (2)

The deeper we went into the mountains, the more often we encountered monsters.

Besides the many beast-type monsters, including the Spike Bear mentioned by Khan, we also encountered a troll, a fairly powerful monster.

There were no attacks in the middle of the night, but in the middle of a bright day and breakfast, sometimes wild birds the size of humans suddenly flew from somewhere.

Not long after they started moving again, there were surrounded by a herd of wild boars.

These guys weren't ordinary beasts either. They were monsters called Armor Boar, whose whole body was as hard as armor...

Chow!

As Asher swung her sword, the huge sword energy that spread horizontally cut them all in one blow. It stained the forest with blood.

She was playing the role of an escort perfectly.

If none of the monsters we encountered came within five meters of me.

I asked Khan.

“Do you encounter monsters this often every time you climb the mountain?”

“I don’t run into them that often. Usually, I’m strictly vigilant so that I don’t run into them.”

Khan explained that if he saw even an ominous sign, he retreated or turn in a different direction.

It meant that he was only going straight, regardless of whether he found a trail. He probably realized that there’s no reason to be careful after seeing Asher’s strength. It would be just a waste of time.

We arrived at the bottom of a cliff by the time the sun rose in mid-sky.

It was a cliff high enough to be dozens of meters high, but Khan spat out absurd words.

“If you go up here and move a little further, we will arrive at our destination.”

What?

I looked at him, wondering what kind of bullshit he was saying, and Khan only smiled awkwardly.

“Oh, I’m fine. It’s a terrain with many places to step on, and I’m used to it because I’ve already climbed this kind of height once or twice.”

“...”

No, I’m not worried about you, I’m worried about me.

I looked up at the cliff.

I forgot about it for a while but for the superhumans in this world, climbing a cliff with no gears was no big deal.

The cliff was not a blocked road, but a path that could only be climbed.

“...Is this the only path?”

“Yes? If we look for it, there might be another way, but it’s a long way back. Then, I’ll go up first.”

Khan said that and moved first.

The other probably didn’t think that I wouldn’t be able to climb this much.

Should I have brought a wizard as well?

Khan clung to the wall like a lizard and started climbing the cliff quickly.

I looked at him in dismay, then moved my gaze to Asher.

...Not that it came to this, there’s no helping it.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Carry me up.”

“...Yes?”

Asher looked back with a doubtful expression, as if she was not sure if she heard me correctly.

I said it again as boldly as possible.

“I told you to carry me up.”

“...”

There was silence for a while.

She had a complicated expression on her face, showing that she couldn’t understand the intention of the order, but soon she knelt down and gave her back to me obediently.

Cooong!

And it took only a moment for us to arrive at the top.

It was because her body rose as if it exploded with just one cloud of footsteps, and we reached the top of the cliff without even stepping on the wall.

Most rides had a dizzying speed and the sense that your stomach was being emptied, but somehow I could withstand that and prevent myself from screaming.

...Uh.

I didn't want to do that twice.

I calmed down the tingling aftertaste and got off Asher's back.

Looking down, Khan was about a third of the way up. I thought he could come up soon.

If Asher helped him, he could arrive here quickly. But since it's weird to ask Asher that again, I just waited.

“...”

Asher stared somewhere.

I reflexively looked where her gaze was directed, but there was nothing.

Instantly, the fishy smell stung my nostrils.

The smell of blood...?

It was a bloody scent that I could easily recognize.

Soon after, Khan, who arrived at the top, also looked around, shaking off the dust from his clothes, as if he also smelled the scent. He even commented;

“It looks like there are some dead bodies of monsters nearby.”

We continued to move.

The further into the forest, the stronger the scent of blood. We seemed to get closer to the source.

When we reached a certain point, everyone was at a loss for words at the sight unfolding in front of us.

“...”

The identity of the corpse was that of a huge snake.

A huge snake with a gray coat, the size of a head and the length of a human body. It was, without a doubt, a giant snake.

What stood out was that it was dead.

The middle of the torso was cut off... No, it wasn't cut off, but the middle of the torso was completely gone.

It was as if something much bigger than itself had eaten it in one bite.

Chapter 11.3: Super Regeneration (2)

Chapter 11.3: Super Regeneration (2)

“This, this guy was the rumored...?”

Khan opened his mouth and murmured.

A giant snake that was said to be spotted in the northern mountains.

But it didn't matter at all whether this guy was the subject of the rumor or not. Because it's dead.

Who killed it?

I looked around.

As I looked for traces as I did a quick sweep of the nearby ground, a strange scene of fallen trees was reflected.

Zwik.

A faint sound echoed in my ears for a moment.

The ground shook with the eerie sound that seemed to stimulate life's instinctive fear.

The overgrown bushes on one side collapsed, and something huge came toward us. Still, no one could move.

Coo coo coo.

Before long, the overwhelming presence raised its body and cast a shadow on the ground.

Both Asher and Khan looked at 'it' with shocked faces.

[Lv.90]

It was a huge, dark snake.

It would not be strange to say that it was not a snake but a dragon, a snake that was definitely gigantic enough to make the dead giant snake seemed like a newborn baby snake.

I was well aware of its identity.

Bellevagorah.

One of the named bosses of the Demon realm.

The first thing I thought of when I heard the story of the giant snake, but I honestly believed that it would not be in a place like this.

Why the hell are you here?

The answer to the question came right away.

This was the five years into the past before the game started.

It hadn't moved to the demon realm yet.

That's right... if that was the case, then it actually made sense. I just never imagined that the giant snake of the rumors would really be this guy.

Zwik.

A huge, torn pupil came out and scanned the other two.

It was as if it was contemplating which food to try first.

Khan had a face that seemed like he would faint at any moment, and Asher was no different.

Far from preparing for battle, her face turned white, and I could see that the hand holding the sword hilt was shaking. Just like a frog before a snake.

Is this... 'Fear'?

Some monsters had a kind of 'Fear' ability that caused extreme fear and panic in weaker targets. Bellevagorah was one of them.

No matter how strong Asher was, there was no choice but to be greatly influenced by the 'Fear' of the opponent with a much higher level.

Even if one fought in perfect condition, they wouldn't be able to run properly when there was no chance of winning.

Because I had the [Soul of a King], 'Fear' did not affect me.

Still, it didn't change that the situation was the worst.

How could I quickly become out of luck?

I promised to take a certain risk, but it's already a crisis like this. I seriously wanted to laugh at this dumbfounding situation.

...As long as I could touch it somehow.

I knew I had no choice but to survive in this situation.

I only needed one contact.

It would be the end if I died from being crushed by that gigantic body before I had the time to activate my skill. But he had no choice but to risk his life.

I walked slowly towards Bellevagorah.

An overwhelming size that left one speechless.

It was absurd that she didn't even feel its presence, even though I was right next to it.

Asher knew for the first time at this moment that such a gigantic creature existed in the world.

She also instinctively felt that even if she fought it with all her might, she could never win.

No, she couldn't even fight right now.

I can't move my body...

My breath stopped just by facing it. It's hard to even lift a finger.

She gnashed her teeth and resisted 'Fear'. She did everything in her power to straighten out the fighting spirit that was about to be broken.

But she still couldn't pull out her sword.

The fear that engulfed her from the depths of her heart couldn't be shaken off, no matter what.

All she could do was feel hopeless and helpless and desperately raised her magical power to free herself from the bondage.

It was then.

The sound of footsteps breaking the silence.

Her eyes widened.

The Seventh Lord was slowly approaching the monster.

With a light step like as if this terrible pressure had no effect on him.

The monster tilted its head and slowly lowered its head.

The slightest movement raised wind pressure and made the ground tremble.

It was as if it was wondering why there was a prey that could move casually.

A distance close enough to touch if you stretch out your hand.

The Seventh Lord standing right in front of the monster looked like he was in danger, as if it would suck him in if it opened its mouth and breathed in.

The Seventh Lord slowly reached out his hand.

To Asher, it was a calm gesture that did not contain any murderous intent or energy. And the moment his fingertips touched the monster, he smiled and said softly.

“Did I look like your prey?”

....*Cooooong!!!*

The huge body of the monster collapsed with a huge vibration.

Chapter 12.1: Super Regeneration

(3)

Chapter 12.1: Super Regeneration (3)

Bellevagorah's body collapsed and hit the ground.

I almost fell over from the shock, but I regained my balance.

I looked at the fallen snake, literally feeling as if I had barely come back alive from the threshold of hell.

It died instantly with its eyes open, as if its soul had just disappeared, leaving behind a huge shell.

That was really close...

Just by their size difference, it was comparable to a human and an ant.

If Bellevagorah just flick his tongue, I would have been thrown off somewhere and died an unsightly death. I had to say that I was really lucky.

When I finally made contact safely, the ecstasy rose to the point of nonsense.

Even when I was on the verge of death, I still had that kind of composure. My mind must have gone twisted somewhere because of the [Soul of the King].

“Ugh... uh...”

Hearing that limp moan, I turned to where the two were.

I saw Khan slumped on the floor with a face that seemed like his soul was drained.

Asher stood with her eyes wide open, staring blankly at me. She was finally released from the effects of 'Fear'.

The atmosphere was engulfed in silence, so I said nothing.

"It's a monster that wasn't supposed to be in a place like this."

"..."

There was no clear response.

Khan was almost exhausted because of shock and fear. So, he continued moving after taking a break for a while.

"Sorry."

While I was sitting on a rock and looking at Bellevagorah's corpse, Asher said something out of the blue.

I turned my head and looked at her.

Basically, Asher's expressionless face made it difficult to read her emotions, but I clearly saw that the other had a sullen expression.

After thinking about what she apologized for all of a sudden, I realized.

Is she saying that she failed to escort me properly?

This was a completely unexpected disaster.

It was far beyond her ability, so there was no reason to blame her.

How could she deal with a monster that a Lord could only deal or someone of the same level?

However, she could not tolerate that she did not fulfil her responsibilities properly. She just had that kind of personality.

Asher was a person who had that kind of stubbornness, serious in everything and infinitely strict with herself.

Ah.. or is it because of that?

Perhaps it was the shock of not being able to resist even the slightest in front of Bellevagorah.

I opened my mouth.

“Some monsters and species that emit ‘Fear’ are rare.”

Asher blinked.

A reaction showing that she didn’t understand what I was trying to say. She probably also didn’t know about ‘Fear’.

‘Fear’ was a kind of ability that had little information about because monsters that had it were rare.

At her level, even if she met other monsters that emitted ‘Fear’, she probably would not have been affected at all.

So it was unreasonable if this unfamiliar experience hurt her pride.

“It is an ability that causes fear, especially in opponents weaker than oneself. Usually, they completely lose the will to fight and fall into a panic.”

“...Ah.”

Only then did Asher look back at Bellevagorah’s corpse as if surprised.

“You probably never experienced it before.”

“Yes.”

“That little creature was so powerful that it was rare to see even in the Demonic Realm.”

At the words of consolation, Asher looked a little taken aback.

She nodded her head without answering, then closed her mouth again and returned to silence. So, it's hard to know what she was thinking.

Soon, Khan also came back to his senses.

“If you're not feeling well, get some more rest.”

“Oh, no. I'm really sorry for bothering you.”

Khan seemed exhausted, but seemed to have recovered enough to move his body.

Since he was exposed to the 'Fear' of a level 90 monster, it's already good that he did not faint.

Perhaps this was just a short hike in his adventurer's life, but he wondered if it would be one of the most memorable adventure for him.

“If something like that had really come down to the city, it would have been ruined...”

As if he still couldn't feel the reality, Khan muttered blankly as he looked at Bellevagorah's corpse.

Then, as he turned his head this way, his eyes met mine, and for some reason, he flinched excessively and lowered his head.

...Wasn't his expression the same one he had when he first saw Bellevagorah?

Are you treating me as a monster?

It was not an incomprehensible reaction.

In their eyes, it would have looked like I killed the monster just by touching it.

Asher was pretending to be okay, but she was still secretly glancing at the corpse.

Anyway, since the crisis had safely passed, it was time to complete my purpose for coming here.

“Let’s move.”

All around, thick black trees were coloring the forest dark.

The hidden piece was close at hand.

Chapter 12.2: Super Regeneration (3)

Chapter 12.2: Super Regeneration (3)

As Khan said, it didn't take long before we finally reached our destination.

A huge rock lying alone in the middle of the forest.

Compared to the fat top and bottom, the middle part was constricted, and anyone could see that its shape was like an hourglass.

We finally arrived.

With the hourglass rock found, all that remained was to find the entrance.

Near to the rock was a cliff. It was a much lower cliff than the one we climbed earlier.

It seems like it was roughly that way... isn't it? Is it over there?

I looked around and guessed the direction.

However, my memory was ambiguous, and I was confused when I saw it in person, so I decided to just check it carefully.

I wandered around the base of the cliff, carefully examining everything.

The two followed me without saying a word, with faces that didn't know what they were doing.

After several tens of minutes, I found a fine crack on one side of the wall that was vertically split at a height similar to mine.

I could feel the faint chill seeping from the crack.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Break this gap moderately wide.”

Asher looked at the gap I pointed out and raised her hand, saying nothing.

I took a slight step back.

Kwaaang!

The wall crumbled as energy burst from her palm pressed against the crack.

The inside of the chasm was hollow, like a cave, with an entrance large enough for one or two people to enter.

Asher and Khan widened their eyes at the appearance of the hidden passage.

“Wait here.”

Leaving the two at the entrance, I went inside alone. The air was cold.

The passage led down a gentle slope, but as soon as I descended a little, the light from outside could no longer be seen, and I quickly lost sight of anything ahead.

At that moment, I took out a glowstone I had brought.

When I unwrapped the tightly wrapped cloth wrapping the stone, a bright white light spread and the surrounding instantly became brighter.

“...Uh.”

Bugs attached to the wall of the cave also appeared. There were quite a few things, like cockroaches and centipedes.

He clicked his tongue once and continued to move forward.

As the slope gradually continued downhill, I had to take my steps carefully.

When I finally reached the point where I couldn't go down without touching the ground with my hands, I broke out in a cold sweat.

If I slipped, I'd be done for.

Was the slope here originally in this shape? How much deeper would this slope be until I reached my destination?

I put the glowstone I was holding in my mouth and touched the ground with both hands.

It was fortunate that the ground was bumpy, so there was plenty of space to step on.

As long as it doesn't get steeper than this, I won't fall unless I stumble stupidly...

“Ah!”

In an instant, my feet slipped on the ground, and my body collapsed.

Fuck. Why did it have to be a flag as soon as I said it?

I desperately touched the floor with my hands, but it was enough.

My body rolled down the slope like a wheel into the darkness.

Cooong!

The fall stopped only after I felt a terrifying shock to my head and arms.

I wriggled for a while, then I got up. My whole body throbbed, and I felt a fishy taste in my mouth.

“Ugh...”

I felt like something was flowing down my face.

When I wiped it off, my hands were soaked in red. It was blood.

With a distorted expression, I wiped the blood from my chin and looked down at my left arm.

Likewise, it was so tattered and covered in blood that I could barely even move it. It might even look like it was broken.

It was the first time I had ever been hurt this badly, so I was embarrassed for a moment, but it soon subsided coldly.

The sharp pain stabbing my arm was excruciatingly painful, but my reason was not disturbed, as always.

After a moment of heavy breathing, I stumbled and looked around.

At the end of the downhill, I saw a small aisle bent to the side. Did it open like that after I hit it from rolling down?

It was a far short reward for my body being in disrepair, but I descended the slope in an instant, anyway.

I picked up the glowstone with my free arm and walked into the aisle.

A tingling pain came up every time I stepped on my right foot, as if I had sprained my ankle, but not that painful that I couldn't walk.

As I progressed, the aisle gradually widened, and a faint green light leaked from the inside.

“Wow.”

When I finally reached the end, I spit out a short admiration at the unfolding scenery.

A wide and empty cavity, with a green pattern engraved on the floor in the middle, emitting a soft light.

I forgot the pain and smiled brightly as I limped towards the pattern.

I knew what it was, so I didn't hesitate to approach it.

I finally found it. Mystery of super regeneration.

It's bigger than I thought.

The mysterious pattern was close to a circle like a magic circle, but it was so large that it was several meters in diameter.

Approaching it, I just stared down at it for a while.

I found it, but I didn't know how to get this mystery.

In the game, a message would pop up saying that once you found it and got close to it, you could get the mystery on its own.

Can I just touch it?

There was no other way, so I got down on one knee and stretched my hand towards the pattern.

Hwaak!

Then, the light of the pattern burst brightly for an instant.

I panicked and almost let go, then stopped.

It's because the light climbed up my hand that touched it and was absorbed into my body.

Soon all the light was absorbed, and the pattern disappeared without a trace. The cavity sank into darkness.

“...”

Feeling a little bewildered, I removed my hand from the floor and looked down at my left arm.

Broken wounds were healing and regenerating in an instant.

Chapter 13: Super Regeneration

(4)

Chapter 13: Super Regeneration (4)

Broken bones stuck together, torn skin healed, and new flesh grew.

It took only a few tens of seconds for the tattered arm to full regenerate.

I clenched my fist and checked my condition.

My wounds had all completely recovered. The same for the head wound and the sprained ankle.

The body, which had been damaged until just a moment ago, returned to its normal state in an instant.

“What a cheat.”

Indeed, it was an ability worthy of the name ‘super regeneration’.

Suddenly, curiosity arose. With this level, could severed body parts be regenerated?

Super regeneration in the game was just a passive skill that amplified the recovery of HP. Whether severed body parts were regenerated, it did not show it.

However, that didn’t mean that I would cut off a part of my intact body just to check it out. I was just curious.

In any case, the first mystery was successfully obtained.

Feeling refreshed, I picked up the glowstone and stood up.

Although the wounds had healed, the bloodstains on it were still there.

I couldn't go outside in this state, so I washed away the bloodstains with a canteen of water. And it soaked into my clothes.

The walls and the ground of the cavity were full of bugs, just like the passage through here.

As I looked at them, another thought came to my mind.

“...”

I narrowed my eyes and looked alternately at the blood and insects that had fallen on the floor.

Instant kill.

The only attack skill I had.

It was described as a skill that could kill any target once I contacted it.

The question that came to my mind was this.

What exactly did this ‘contact’ mean?

Until now, it was only natural to think of it as contact through the body.

However, if one thought about it carefully, they need to consider how far the standard of this ‘body’ was.

For example, blood was also part of the body.

Then, was the target that came into contact with my blood also within the range of instant kill?

...I definitely need to experiment.

I picked up a bug that was crawling under my feet.

Then, after putting the bug back on the spot where my blood fell, I activated [Instant Kill].

However, the bug did not die and was still alive.

I was a little disappointed with the results that were out of my expectations, and I thought of other possibilities.

Maybe it's because the blood had been discharged from the body for a long time.

“Well, let's test it.”

I found a sharp piece of stone on the ground and picked it up.

I could heal even broken bones in an instant, so cuts were no longer a big deal.

When I pressed the palm of my hand with the crude blade, the flesh tore open and blood flowed out. The wound immediately regenerated.

I dripped the blood from my palm on the insects crawling on the floor.

Then, when I activated [Instant Kill] again, to my surprise...

“Ha...”

They all died.

The bugs no longer wriggled and moved. It's the same even if I poked it my finger.

This time, it was real instant death.

I tried a few more times with different bugs, to be sure. The results were all the same.

Only then was I convinced that my guess was correct.

I can trigger instant kill not only through skin contact but also through blood.

However, it's assumed that there was a time limit, as the blood that had bled out of the body for quite a while had no effect.

Exactly how long it was was still unknown, but anyway, this was a pretty awesome discovery.

I never thought I could use it this way...

If blood could be used as a medium for instant kill, the ways to use it become endless.

I turned around, thinking that once I reached Enrock, I'd have to do a more accurate experiment.

When I went back through the passage and went out of the cave, I saw Asher and Khan standing side by side at the entrance.

The two of them gave me a startled expression.

I felt a little embarrassed because I knew very well that my clothes were torn, bloodstained, and dusty, and my appearance was a mess.

I tried my best to say calmly;

“Let's go back.”

Asher walked behind the Seventh Lord. She glanced at his back, especially at his left arm.

Blood soaked the torn sleeve red.

There were no visible injuries and serious marks.

...What the hell happened?

It was the Seventh Lord who turned even the monster, which was so huge that it could even be mistaken as a dragon, into a cold corpse in an instant. So, it's hard to believe that he was just in a fierce battle.

Overwhelming strength that truly deviated from reason.

But what was the identity of the cave, and what happened inside, so that he suffered such an aftermath?

Even if she thought it was just useless curiosity, she couldn't help but pay attention to it.

The Seventh Lord was someone who was hard to figure out.

This hike made it even harder to understand what purpose he had, let alone figure it out.

She wondered if the only thing she learned a little about was his personality.

From the way he had a casual conversation with the person who accompanied them as a guide, he didn't particularly care about status or rank.

He also seemed to hate moving his body roughly.

It was like that when she thought of how he stopped moving and leisurely looked at the scenery whenever he had a chance.

Especially when they had to climb the cliff. He even had to borrow her back. No, no matter how much she thought about it, she still couldn't understand his intentions.

He's a mysterious person.

As they reached the cliff they had climbed earlier, the Seventh Lord looked back this way.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Pick me up and go down.”

“...”

She really couldn't understand.

Asher decided to no longer think deeply about the other's eccentricity in the future.

The return to the city took much less time than when they climbed up the mountain range.

It was only natural since going downhill was faster, but besides that, there was also the effect of my super regeneration.

This was because super regeneration amplified not only the regenerative power of the body but also the physical strength, so I rarely felt tired. Unexpectedly, even the stamina issue was solved.

After returning to the city, Khan received a big pay as promised and they told the mayor about the monster.

“It's a giant snake that appeared in the northern mountains.”

“Ah, yes. I'm planning to dispatch an investigation team because there are rumors like that...”

“It's already dead. Just take care of its body.”

“...Yes?”

After that, there was nothing more to see or do, so I left Jenix City right away.

Soon after, the wagon entered the territory of the Seventh Lord, Enrock, and quickly headed for the capital, passing through several cities again. And...

Finally, arrived!

I stared at the massive city walls that appeared in the distance.

Excluding the Overlord's Castle, it was the tallest and most massive wall of any city I had ever passed.

The capital of the Seventh Lord's territory—Buckhorn.

We finally arrived at our destination.

Chapter 14.1: Alkimas Workshop

(1)

Chapter 14.1: Alkimas Workshop (1)

Big cities were symbols of congestion and diversity.

But now, on the road along which I was riding, there was only still silence.

Many soldiers and knights lined up at intervals with their swords on both sides of the path while citizens were watching.

I could see numerous emotions in the passing faces, but it was mostly tension and fear.

The solemn and heavy atmosphere made me feel like a great tyrant.

Is it because the Lord's seat had been empty for quite a while?

It was the first time in several years that a new ruler had been welcomed, so they were probably all anxious.

Because a Lord was an absolute being with omnipotent power, and if a madman sat on such a throne, it could become a literal living hell for them.

A typical example was the Sixth Lord—the Tyrant, or the Eight Lord—the Black Sea Empress.

But all their worries were for nothing.

I was already too busy taking care of my own life, so would there be time to sit down and play emperor?

I had no intention of directly intervening and ruling this land.

As long as I solve that one problem.

Alkimas Workshop was located here in Buckhorn City.

The owner of the place, the alchemist, Scarlett.

It's a matter that needed to be resolved before I left in search of another mystery.

She was the talent I was planning to pull to my side, just like Asher.

The top priority was to improve the specs, but I should also take care of the talented people I could take care along the way.

If it's this time, maybe they are currently being hit by the Varia Merchant Corps.

While thinking about this and that, the carriage soon arrived at a huge castle in the center of the city.

The procession of soldiers was filthy long, stretching all the way from the entrance of the city to the main gate of the castle. What kind of useless waste of manpower was this?

After passing through the front gate, I got off the carriage.

The two people who greeted me at the front were an elf wearing luxurious clothes and an old man with gray hair who looked like a butler at first glance.

The elf greeted me politely.

“Greetings to Enrock's new master. I am Baslan, who was the regent of the territory.”

Regent? Was there anything like that?

There was no way that they would leave the seat of the Lord empty, so something like a regent was only natural when I thought about it.

I thought the other would explain this and that while guiding me to the castle, but the words that followed were unexpected.

“I was waiting to see and greet the Seventh Lord before I returned to the Overlord Castle.”

“...Return?”

“Yes, I am originally an administrator belonging to the Overlord’s Castle. I was dispatched here under the command of the Overlord and acted as the regent.”

Oh, was it like that?

He was an official with a high enough ranking to take the place of a Lord.

The old man next to him also came forward and introduced himself.

“I’m Floto, the butler of the castle.

The real guide was this one.

The elf immediately left the castle, and I entered the central hall of the castle, following Floto’s guidance.

The interior was exactly what I had imagined.

A typical landscape that came to mind when talking about a castle in a fantasy world. Spacious, splendid, majestic.

“The banquet is ready, my lord.”

I nodded.

Originally, I would have rejected it. But...

A day or so would be fine.

It's not like I would leave the castle right away anyway, and it seemed like the other had already prepared everything. If I rejected it, I would ignore the effort made by the servants.

And since I had to look at the faces of the servants of the castle at least once, the banquet was, to some extent, was something that I just had to do.

...Honestly, it's all excuses. I'm human too. So, I also wanted to take a break for a while. Because I had a hard time getting here.

With the mindset to work hard again from tomorrow, I enjoyed a comfortable rest today.

A huge mansion on the outskirts of Buckhorn City.

It was the building of the Varia Merchant Corps, which completely dominated and monopolized the upper road from the northern border of Enrock to Buckhorn.

Two men were sitting opposite each other in the upper living room, talking.

“So, what about the information about the new Seventh Lord, Brother?”

At the words of the man wearing an eyepatch, the dignified man shook his head.

He was Varia, the owner of the merchant company.

“There's no particular gain. From what I've heard, he's a complete outsider. And he's human. Have you seen his face at the parade?”

“I've seen a glimpse from a distance. He's quite pale.”

“Bark, even if there are no ears around to hear, I always told you to watch your mouth.”

“It’s only the two of us anyway, so it’s okay to talk comfortably.”

Bark grumbled lightly.

“This is a good situation for us. Those tenacious alchemists are now without a windshield.”

Alkimas Workshop.

An old group of alchemists in Buckhorn City.

Many efforts had been made for a long time now to get them out. But with the vacancy of the Seventh Lord’s seat, it came to nothing for a while.

For the past few years, the newly dispatched regent managed the city strictly.

Of course, bribes didn’t work.

However, with crowning of the new Lord, the situation had changed.

There were the ones who reigned at the highest level.

The competition for power and interests of those lower was nothing more than a fight between worms to them, so they cared little. Just like the previous Seventh Lord did.

As long as the new Seventh Lord was not a lunatic like the Tyrant or the Black Sea Empress, the situation would turn in favor of the upper ranks again.

“I’ll have to visit the workshop tomorrow.”

“Are you going to pressure them right away?”

“It’s true that the situation is in our favor, but we still don’t know what kind of character the Seventh Lord has. It’s best to make those people from Alkimas to raise the white flag on their own as quickly as possible.”

“That’s right. The workshop owner and the elders must have their pants twisted by now.”

Varia and Bark smiled evilly at each other.

Chapter 14.2: Alkimas Workshop

(1)

Chapter 14.2: Alkimas Workshop (1)

The next day, after enjoying the banquet.

I started doing what I had to do.

He brought a lot.

I looked down at the wriggling caterpillars in a bucket full of them.

The butler brought it after receiving my order.

The larvae were experimental materials to be used for a precise investigation of instant kill.

“Shall we start?”

I picked up a knife.

The purpose of the experiment was to find out how long instant kill would take effect after the blood had been discharged from the body.

The method was simple.

I would drop blood on the caterpillar and activate [Instant Kill]. And every time it succeeded, five seconds would delay the activation time.

After sacrificing dozens of caterpillars, I completed the experiment.

About three minutes.

As a result of the experiment, the effective time for instant kill using my blood was about three minutes.

Blood that had flowed out of the body for over three minutes could not activate [Instant Kill].

The first thing that came to my mind while contemplating how to use this newfound knowledge was the vampire blood technique.

If I had the ability to freely manipulate blood, the synergy with [Instant Kill] would be truly amazing.

The problem is that I can't change my race.

There was usually no way to change the race one was born with in this world.

Even if I could change it, I wanted to remain human as much as possible.

A way to use blood magic even if I was not a vampire.

There was one thing that came to mind, but it was a way that had considerable risk.

Let's put it behind my mind for now.

Anyway, I got the information I needed, but there was still a lot I didn't know.

For example, what was the range of targets that could be instantly killed? Would instant kill work on the undead, as well as spiritual bodies?

These, too, should be checked later when the opportunity arose.

The next thing to deal with now was the Alkimas Workshop issue.

I said to Asher, who was waiting outside the room.

“I need to go out for a while.”

I was curious about how effective the potions in this world were, and I also wanted to look at the workshop.

Aria was an apprentice alchemist at the Alkimas Workshop.

Her morning job was to work at the counter in the store building.

The workshop’s main source of income was the city councils of nearby cities, including Buckhorn, and other adventurers as well.

The city council rarely came to the store directly because they made bulk purchases.

And adventurers were not yet active at this time of the day.

In short, Aria was having a leisurely time, as there were few guests.

Aria, who was yawning, saw the figure of a customer who just entered the store.

She hastily shut her mouth.

The guests were a young man and a woman. She looked like an escort. The two were both very attractive, especially the man.

Aria greeted brightly, thinking that her eyes were blessed so early in the morning.

“Welcome!”

The man silently nodded and looked at the potions on display.

Is he a young master from another city?

It was a face she hadn’t seen before.

The man, who had been looking at the potions for quite some time, came closer to the counter.

“Are all the potions you have currently on display?”

“Ah, all the potions on display are below average quality. High-quality potions are usually made-to-order.”

The man nodded and asked again.

“I want to buy the highest quality healing potion in the workshop.”

At that, Aria laughed inwardly.

Apparently, this ignorant young master didn't know how expensive the product was, especially the potion made by Alkimas.

“If you are talking about the highest quality healing potion, there is ‘Scarlet’.”

“Isn't that the name of the workshop owner?”

“Yes, since it was a potion invented by the owner, that is how it was named.”

“How much?”

Aria replied with a bright smile, thinking of teasing the other a little.

“Three platinum coins.”

In terms of gold coins, a whopping 300 coins.

It was an amount that couldn't be readily purchased with a light heart.

Aria looked at the man's face, expecting a shocked reaction.

But he just nodded his head without a change in his expression.

“I will buy it.”

“...Yes?”

“If it’s made to order, how long will I have to wait? Can I pay the full amount in advance?”

Saying that, the man took out a purse full of gold and platinum coins from his bosom.

Aria couldn’t close her wide-open mouth in shock, then she stuttered.

“Now, wait! I’ll bring the workshop owner right away!”

Chapter 15.1: Alkimas Workshop

(2)

Chapter 15.1: Alkimas Workshop (2)

Looking at the various potions sealed in flasks and sealed with corks, I felt a strangely laboratory-like atmosphere.

It wasn't long before the clerk, who hurriedly escaped, returned with two figures in two.

One was a woman with frizzy hair and wearing a dull robe, another was a man who looked like an escort guard.

I knew right away who the woman was.

Scarlett.

I didn't really intend to meet her right away, but somehow it just happened.

It was natural for the owner to step forward personally, since I was a customer who said he would buy a potion worth three platinum coins.

[Lv.41]

And the male side was... the younger brother, right?

I knew Scarlett had a younger brother.

Unlike Scarlett, I remembered it was a setting that was contributing to the force of the workshop by walking the path of swordsmanship rather than alchemy. At that level, he was quite capable.

Scarlett, who found me, strode towards me and greeted me right away.

“I’m Scarlett Artima, the workshop owner.”

It was a tired voice with haggard eyes.

Even in the game, it was not surprising to remember her as a character who was half crazy about alchemy research.

“I’ve heard the story. Are you planning to buy Scarlet?”

I knew it was the name of the potion, but somehow it sounded strange.

I nodded.

“Do I have to pay the whole amount now?”

“No, you just have to pay half the price in advance. Rather, I came here to explain the potion’s efficacy...”

She put on a strange expression, as if my attitude to purchase without asking was strange.

“If you don’t mind, may I ask you where you are from?”

“Should I tell you?”

“It’s unnecessary, but it’s better to have a clear identity. First, it’s an item that I invented, so you can’t blame me for being wary.”

She must be wondering if I was from a dangerous organization, or if I came from another workshop. She must be concerned about those.

A person willing to pay a large sum of three platinum coins couldn’t be just an ordinary customer.

I thought for a while and then replied.

“Shall we discuss your potion first?”

“Okay. I’ll treat you to tea, so let’s sit down for a while.”

She passed the topic with little concern and led me to a room in the main studio building.

I came here with the intention of just observing, but somehow it ended up like this.

I listened to Scarlett explain about the potion over tea.

“First, since it is basically a healing potion, its regenerative effect is very excellent. It is possible to attach parts that have been amputated as long as time has not passed. In addition, it can restore damage to the internal organs to some extent by drinking it. Of course, pouring it directly is much better and more effective.”

“Is it impossible to completely regenerate the severed parts?”

At my question, Scarlett looked at me with a slightly absurd expression.

“Even if it’s an elixir, that would be hard to do.”

Elixir was the name given to some of the best potions on the continent. In short, she was telling me not to talk nonsense.

“How long will it take to fully heal a broken bone?”

I asked this question because I wanted to compare the effect of my super regeneration to her best potion.

Scarlett replied.

“It depends on the location of the broken bone and the severity, but in case of a finger fracture, it usually heals within a minute. For an arm or leg, it takes at least a few minutes.”

As expected, my super regeneration was much better.

“Other side effects include...”

As I listened to the explanation that followed, I was lost in my thoughts for a while.

Scarlett was an excellent alchemist.

I didn't know exactly what her skill level was now, but in the game's story, with her own ability, she could create an elixir.

It meant that she was a talented person with the potential to develop that much in the future, even if she could not reach it right now. There was nothing wrong with keeping the kite together.

Scarlett's first appearance in the game was with the crumbling of Alkimas Workshop.

It was because the Varia Merchant Corps, who coveted the workshop's potions and Scarlett's ability, did several dirty tricks.

Didn't they say that they are almost monopolizing Enrock's northern merchants?

I asked Floto, the head butler, to get all the details.

Even though Alkimas was a historic workshop in the capital, such as capital and connections, they were far behind Varia.

According to the known future, after this, Alkimas would be half absorbed by them and would be completely tied up to them.

And originally, as the story progressed, the player's performance would safely restore her identity, but...

Now I just have to solve it.

It was too simple to do with my current influence.

Chapter 15.2: Alkimas Workshop

(2)

Chapter 15.2: Alkimas Workshop (2) Another bonus chapter! Thank you to Zxz for the donation! ^^

She ended her explanation after she finished detailing the usage and precautions.

Ending the conversation, I asked Scarlett.

“How long does it take to make?”

“It will take at least a month. By the way...”

Scarlett seemed to hesitate, she said.

“To be honest, I have a bottle of Scarlet already finished.”

I tilted my head.

Didn't they say that high-quality potions were made in advance?

She calmly explained the situation.

“I received a custom order from the mayor of Dartmad City just a while ago, but the deal fell through shortly.”

“Why?”

“They were deprived of their position and the monarchy confiscated all their property because of corruption. Of course, the advance payment that

had been received during the transaction was recovered during the investigation of the funds. The potions were just added to our inventory, so it was difficult.”

Oh.

“So I can give you the finished potion right away, but if you don’t want to receive it in advance, I’ll make a new one.”

“Do potions lose potency over time?”

“I can guarantee that there will be no degradation in efficacy unless you had not used it for several years. I swear on my honor, as well as my workshop.”

I nodded.

“Then I’ll take it.”

It obviously surprised Scarlett when I accepted so easily.

“Thank you, but are you really sure?”

“Didn’t you ask me to buy it while bringing up a story that didn’t have to be brought up?”

If they really wanted to deal with their inventory somehow, she wouldn’t have bothered to say this. Which meant that she only wanted to sell the potion.

So we made a deal right on the spot.

After a while, Scarlett brought the potion. The potion was bottled and sealed in a luxurious wooden box.

After paying three platinum coins and taking the potion, I left the workshop, and we said our goodbyes.

“By the way, didn’t you say that you would let me know where you came from once you get the goods?”

Oh, right.

I stared at Scarlett and said.

“I’ll see you soon, so let’s put it off.”

At my words, Scarlett’s expression became incomprehensible, but she still nodded.

I left the store and walked down the main street, taking the potion out of the box and examining it.

A reddish liquid flowing in a glass bottle.

Anyway, since I didn’t need potions anymore, it was something I had no use for.

But because of my curiosity, I still paid an exorbitant amount of money to buy this. After all, I now had a lot of money.

Even if it wasn’t for me, this potion might be something Asher could use later on, so I bought it as an emergency medicine.

I’d like to see the effect myself, but...

While I was walking with that thought in mind, I suddenly heard an urgent scream from somewhere.

“Help me! Someone please!”

I looked in the direction from which the sound had come and saw two boys.

The one being supported had blood dripping from his stomach as if he had been stabbed.

However, passers-by looked at them and either ignored them or clicked their tongues.

“What kind of fuss is that again? Noisy!”

“Looks like they’re having fun since morning. Back alley parasite bastards.”

...Ah, was this the case?

I could roughly grasp the situation by listening to what people were saying nonchalantly.

The one supporting was also not in good condition, so the two both fell to the ground as if he had lost his strength.

He squeezed out his voice with all his remaining strength and called for help.

“He’s my brother! If anyone has a potion, please give it to me! If you help me, I won’t forget the grace for the rest of my life, so please...!”

Someone laughed.

“Is that bastard crazy? He’s going to die, anyway. What kind of idiot would give him their precious potion?”

No one offered a helping hand to the earnest cry.

While looking at the scene, Asher’s expression suddenly caught my eye.

Rarely, the expressionless expression was broken. She was looking at the two children with pity.

Come to think of it, Asher also had a younger brother.

During the invasion of Santea, one of the Five Stars killed her younger brother right in front of her eyes. I remembered it being set up like that.

So, for her, it must have been a more unfortunate sight.

Asher glanced at the potion in my hand. Then she met my eyes and winced.

She seemed to have something to say, but in the end, she just bit her lip saying nothing.

How frustrating.

I clicked my tongue and walked towards the boys.

Regardless of Asher, I was thinking of helping them anyway. No matter how precious this potion was, was it more precious than human life?

As I approached, the little guy who had been screaming in a hoarse voice looked at me.

“Put it down here. I’ll treat you.”

I opened the stopper and drizzled the potion over the injured area.

The older brother watched the scene in a daze. Suddenly, the surroundings were quiet.

Soon, the flesh seemed to heal in an instant. The bleeding stopped and the cut that looked deep disappeared without a trace.

I didn’t think I used even a tenth of the amount in the bottle, but as Scarlett explained, its effect was great indeed.

“Uh, uhm...”

The younger brother, who was unconscious, blinked and opened his eyes.

The boy who urgently checked his brother’s condition finally cried out.

“Thank you! Sir! Thank you very much...!”

Leaving behind the boy who cried out in gratitude, I got up and turned around.

I said as Asher and I went back on our way.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Did you think I would regret using this potion? Or did you think that saving their lives wasn’t worth it?”

“...”

“From now on, if there’s anything you want to say, say it. Tell me what you think. What I want isn’t a doll that only obeys orders.”

Asher made a strange expression I had never seen before.

“...Yes, I will.”

After a moment of silence, she spoke again.

“Thank you, my lord. For helping them.”

It was an awkward way of showing her gratitude.

As if she knew it herself, Asher cleared her throat slightly after she said it.

I chuckled.

I don’t know if it’s an illusion, but it felt like the distance between us was gradually narrowed.

Chapter 15.3: Alkimas Workshop

(2)

Chapter 15.3: Alkimas Workshop (2)

“Who the hell was that, Sister?”

At the words of her brother, Thane, Scarlett shrugged.

“I don’t know.”

“Honestly, I’m concerned. He’s the one who paid such a huge amount right on the spot...”

“Well, judging from what he said, it looks like he’ll come back soon, so we’ll know then.”

Of course, Scarlett was also curious about the man’s identity.

The attitude of treating three platinum coins as if they were a small amount of money without even signing a contract.

It would be difficult for even the most wealthy or high-ranking aristocrats to do so.

There were some people who used money to bluff and then scammed businesses, but there were no lunatics who would do that using platinum coins. At that point, that would no longer be considered a bluff.

A human male with black hair and golden eyes...

Where the hell did he come from?

It occurred to her that the other might be someone who was not from Calderic at all.

Thane muttered.

“Come to think of it, there are rumors that the Seventh Lord who arrived in the city yesterday is also a black-haired human male...”

For a moment, the two of them closed their mouths and looked at each other.

Soon, Scarlett smiled and said.

“Say something that makes sense.”

“Haha, is that so? I just thought of it and said it.”

To think that a Lord would visit this workshop in person.

Rather, someone from a royal family of a neutral country would be much more realistic.

The flow of thoughts naturally led to the Seventh Lord.

Scarlett’s expression darkened slightly.

Regardless of what kind of person the new Seventh Lord would be, the problem with the high-ranking members of Varia was much bigger.

She knew well that the reason those people hadn’t been able to do big tricks so far was because of the regent.

However, that ended with the new Seventh Lord ascending to the throne.

Those people would slowly reveal their teeth to the workshop again.

I can expect the Seventh Lord to mediate.

The possibility that the Lord would be interested in the fight between Varia and the workshop, there was no hint of such a thing.

And if the Lord was indifferent, the side that the territory's high-ranking officials would side with was, of course, the Varia Merchant Corps, who could bring there more profits.

Scarlett sighed. She remembered her struggles with those people just a few years ago.

As the owner of the workshop and the head of the Atima family, the responsibility was heavy.

“How nice it would be if I could just focus on alchemy research without worrying about anything.”

At the words she spat out, as if grumbling, Thane looked at her with calm eyes.

He was also a member of the family, so he knew things were not going well.

“Don't worry too much, Sister. Those people would be busy to pay any attention to us, so they won't be able to do anything right away...”

It was then.

Knock knock.

“Come on in.”

A vassal entered the room with a dark expression.

“What's going on?”

“Varia Merchants accompanied Bark and visited the workshop directly.”

“...!”

“They say they want to have a formal conversation right now to fix our difference in opinion.”

Scarlett burst out laughing with a stunned expression.

“What formal conversation after coming here without a warning...”

“What should I do, house head?”

“Call the elders together. We’ll have to listen to what nonsense they’re going to say again.”

It was practically a threat, so she couldn’t ignore it.

Although she spoke calmly, Scarlett’s face showed her deep thoughts.

Varia’s side was moving into action much sooner than they thought.

Chapter 16.1: Alkimas Workshop

(3)

Chapter 16.1: Alkimas Workshop (3) Two ! Thank you to Orphylia for the donation! ^^

Returning to the castle, while busy reviewing plans, I heard the report from the head butler, Floto.

“Are you done cleaning up already?”

I just ordered it this morning, and they did it quickly.

I glanced at some papers he passed to me.

It was a rough list of the vile things that Varia Merchant Corps had committed so far.

Starting from the problems from the upper ranks of the group to the behavior of the people under them.

Still, the investigation didn't show something so big that could prevent the merchant group from continuing their activities. But this was enough.

In fact, there was no need to investigate.

In Calderic, the Lord was the law.

Whether or not Varia broke the law, it didn't matter. It's just that it's not possible to immediately dismantle them if I wanted to.

By the way, even when Floto gave me a detailed explanation of my job as a Lord, it was funny that he did not mention the power that the Lord had over his territory. Only a few restrictions. The great constitution enacted by the Overlord, the iron-rule of non-interference between the Lords' territories, and the inability to exercise independent military authority over other countries.

I really could do anything I wanted, as long as it wasn't a dictatorship that destroyed the basic structure of the monarchy.

Anyway, the reason I did this kind of investigation was because of a small bit of conscience.

I knew Varia was like a villain because I had played the game, but that's all I knew.

Wasn't it like stepping on someone with no justification just because I didn't like them?

"Butler."

"Yes, Seventh Lord."

"Bring the head of Varia, and Scarlett, the workshop owner of Alkimas, to the castle. Treat the workshop owner politely and with respect."

"I will do as you command immediately."

Floto did not show the slightest hint of surprise or doubt. He just walked away quickly after giving his answer.

He must have already known what my intentions were based on my series of commands.

I looked at the map again. I finished what I was doing and waited for the two of them leisurely.

I said that I'd see her again soon, but I never thought it would be this soon.

The large room of the Alkimas Workshop.

In a chilly atmosphere, Varia said calmly while savoring his tea.

“As expected, it’s a place where artisans gather, so the tea tastes great. It makes me want to learn the secret.”

Scarlett, who was sitting across from him, said with an expressionless face.

“You should drink it in moderation. After all, it might be too fine for your coarse taste.”

“I hope you don’t misinterpret my sincere compliment like that.”

“Let’s get down to the main topic. I would feel sorry for wasting the time of Varia’s busy owner.”

Varia raised the corner of his mouth and put the teacup down.

“What do I want to say? I’m just repeating the proposal I’ve always made, and the workshop owner will reject it as always.”

Scarlett replied calmly.

“It’s an obvious ploy to mass produce Alkimas potions with your capital, and to exploit the skills of our artisans.”

“As others say, the workshop owner is too full of negative prejudices about our group.”

“Who the hell was it that created that prejudice? Blocking the distribution materials, conciliating the workshop’s customers one by one, and mobilizing many petty things until just a few years ago to put pressure on the workshop?”

Bark, the man with an eyepatch sitting next to Varia, giggled.

“Workshop owner, be careful with what you say. We are not polite enough either. It would be unfair to accuse us like that without evidence.”

“...Ha!”

“What do the elders think? For the sake of the workshop’s future, shouldn’t the loyal vassals break the stubbornness of the head of your family?”

An older elder standing near Scarlett snorted.

“For the sake of the future of the workshop, it is a proposal that should not be accepted.”

“Haha, it really makes little sense. Our group would provide all the resources and funds necessary for potion production for the workshop. What the hell is wrong with this proposal?”

“And the price would be the technology of the workshop and the ability of the family head. You probably have a workshop in operation in the nearby city of Flicke. After a few years, they will absorb most of our technology and steal the workshop’s business partners one by one. In the end, our workshop will slowly fall, or you will force us to hand over the management rights of the workshop to you. Or is there a more elaborate and vicious strategy than this?”

Varia laughed at the elder’s sharp words.

“I envy you because you have like-minded and loyal vassals, workshop owner.”

Scarlett frowned.

It was because she already knew that the other attempted to bribe several elders. He failed, of course.

“They are proud people who have dedicated their lives to the well-being of our family. I don’t think there will be anyone who would have the same opinion as you.”

“That’s right.”

“Is it the turn of threats next?”

“Workshop owner.”

Varia gave a smile that bordered on sneering.

“You don’t have to pretend to be calm. You know that things have changed.”

“...”

“The new Seventh Lord arrived in the city just yesterday, and there was no more regent. Do you think the great Lord would take the slightest interest in such a trivial quarrel? Or, if he had one at all, whose side do you think he would be? Will he listen to you? Maybe if you have an elixir hidden in your family as an heirloom. If you donate it, he might be on your side.”

Bark interjected and said with a sinister laugh.

“Or, since the workshop owner is beautiful, you can seduce him. There’s a rumor that the new Lord is a human male, after all.”

“...Watch your words.”

Thane, who had been standing behind Scarlett and kept his mouth shut, spoke with gritted teeth.

The expression of the elders also turned stern at the remark openly insulting the head of the family.

However, Bark still spoke in that manner, as if he didn’t hear Thane.

“Just in case, how about marrying some young master? The workshop owner is not too old to be married. You shouldn’t just live in such a dull place like this, you should also know the joy of being a woman.”

“You—!”

Thane was about to explode, but Scarlett raised a hand to stop him.

“Did you just come here to do such a lowly provocation? You’ve thrown away your modesty.”

Varia stood up with a sneer.

“Today will probably be the last warning. I hope you make a wise choice for the future of the workshop, Miss Scarlett.”

“...”

“Then we will go now. No need to see us off.”

The elders looked at the two with dark expressions as they walked out of the room.

They came here without prior notice and threatened them.

The future situation turned too unfavorable for the workshop. Even from tomorrow, there was no way to know what kind of dirty tricks Varia Merchant Corps would use.

It was because until a few years ago, all the elders had been through so much that their teeth trembled at how nasty Varia had treated the workshop.

Scarlett touched her forehead as if her head hurt.

“Why don’t we gather again in the evening and hold a meeting, family head?”

“Yes, we should. Then, for now...”

Scarlett and the elders talked about the future.

Thane listened to the conversation with a firm expression, then sneaked out of the room.

Chapter 16.2: Alkimas Workshop

(3)

Chapter 16.2: Alkimas Workshop (3)

“Varia.”

Varia and Bark, who had passed through the workshop’s central hall and were heading towards the entrance, looked back.

The person who called them was none other than Thane.

“Do you need something?”

Thane looked at the two of them alternately, then continued to speak while glaring at Bark.

“Bark, I challenge you to a duel.”

At that statement, Bark widened his eyes and pointed at himself with a mischievous smile.

“Did you just say duel? With me?”

Varia stepped up and said.

“I don’t know what you’re trying to do. But Thane Atima, is this the meaning of the workshop?”

“No, I’m doing it on my own.”

“Why are you suddenly requesting a duel?”

“Because he insulted my sister. I don’t think the One-Eyed Slayer, Bark, would refuse because he was afraid of a young swordsman like me.”

Bark looked at Thane as if he was looking at some kind of puppy.

It was common in this world to resolve trivial conflicts through a duel.

However, that was only for opponents of equal standing. Bark was a warrior with a reputation for being the best in Varia. They even gave him the name One-Eyed Slayer.

If I show off my strength here by defeating Bark, Varia cannot act recklessly.

Thane did it because he thought it was worth it.

He was also an outstanding martial artist for his age and he had his own confidence because he had made great progress recently.

Bark glanced at Varia.

Varia smiled broadly and nodded his head as telling his brother to take care of it.

“Well, good. I’ll waste my time with you for a while.”

Bark smiled and stepped forward.

The central hall was wide enough for two people to cross swords.

“Thane Atima, you’ve been fairly well-known in the capital lately. Did you make it to the finals in the last Darthmad City swordsmanship competition? A young and talented warrior’s challenge is always welcome.”

Thane drew his sword first, and Bark drew his sword slowly as well.

He raised the corner of his mouth and switched his sword to his other hand.

“Shall I give you a handicap? I’m right-handed, so I will wield my sword in my left hand. That should be enough.”

“...Do as you please!”

Thane immediately went full force, intending to startle the other and force him to use both hands. The blade of his sword shimmered in blue.

Kaang!

The sword, which was swung with great force, was blocked languidly.

Before one knew it, Bark with one hand behind his back, was blocking the sword attack. Even the blade of his sword shimmered with a blue aura.

A blow that was blocked too easily.

Thane was a little taken aback by the other's sword that was not pushed and did not move at all, but he continued to attack again.

Kaang! Kang! Kakakang!

Blue lines intersecting in the air. A continuous roaring sound.

The flashes that were hard to see with the eyes of ordinary people continued to come and go.

Thane's sword was fast and sophisticated. He was clearly a high-level swordsman for his age.

However, all his attacks were blocked and destroyed by Bark's lightly swinging sword.

“Kuh..!”

As time passed, darkness fell on Thane's face as he wielded his sword.

He couldn't have imagined that the gap would be this large.

Jang!!

And at some point, pieces of metal scattered.

Bark's hand, which suddenly sped up, shattered Thane's sword.

"Kuk...!"

Thane, shocked as he was, let out a moan of pain and fell to his knees.

Looking down at him, Bark grinned.

People arrived at the same time. Scarlett and the elders immediately came out after hearing the commotion downstairs.

"...Thane!"

Scarlett shouted with an urgent expression and came running. She then glared intently at Varia.

"What did you do?"

"Ah, don't misunderstand. The one who challenged Bark for a duel was your younger brother."

Thane lowered his head with a horribly distorted expression, avoiding Scarlett's gaze. Realizing the situation, she let out a sigh.

"...I will apologize for my brother's rudeness. The victory had already been decided, so please stop the duel."

At that, Bark raised an evil corner of his mouth and said.

"He's the first to attack. Wouldn't it make sense if I finish it at least?"

Fu-wook!

He plunged the blade into Thane's arm as the other lay on the floor.

"Aarrgh...!"

The faces of Scarlett and the elders turned white.

“The younger brother of the workshop owner can’t control his hot bloodedness. So we should give him a chance to learn this time.”

“N-, wait... stop!”

“Tsk, tsk, it’s not like I’m going to kill him. Why are you so nervous? There are a lot of good quality potions here, so there shouldn’t be any problem with treatment.”

Bark said that and swung the blade into his arm. Thane couldn’t stand it and let out his screams of pain.

“Stop! Stop now!”

Scarlett completely lost her composure and cried out as if pleading.

Bark chuckled as if he was having fun.

“Haha! If you’re that desperate, get down on your knees and beg a little more earnestly, workshop owner. Then I’ll stop...”

It was then.

Rattle!

Suddenly, the entrance to the hall opened, and a series of knights appeared.

Everyone’s eyes were drawn to their sudden appearance.

Varia’s eyes widened.

He, who had just been watching the situation with a leisurely smile, murmured with a puzzled expression.

“...Iron Blood Knights?”

Iron Blood Knights directly under the Seventh Lord’s castle.

Varia couldn't understand why the most elite force of the Lord, who did not move unless it was a serious matter, suddenly appeared here.

Scarlett and the elders looked at them with bewildered expressions, and Bark dragged out the sword stuck in Thane's arm.

The blonde-haired man at the head of the knights looked around, then approached the center of the hall and opened his mouth.

“Varia, the owner of the Varia Merchant Corps.”

“...”

“Follow me right now. You have no right to refuse. I will not take questions.”

And this time, he turned his head to Scarlett and spoke in a much more polite tone.

“Are you Scarlett, the owner of Alkimas Workshop?”

“...Yes, I am.”

“Please, accompany us as well. The Lord is looking for you.”

“...!”

Everyone's faces were filled with astonishment.

If the knight called someone 'lord', then it couldn't be anyone than the Seventh Lord.

Meanwhile, Bark asked with a frown.

“Could it be that you're going to the Lord's castle? Why are you taking my older brother suddenly? At least give a reason...”

Whoa!

Bark's words were cut short.

It was because the knight he asked drew his sword and attacked him without warning.

Bark also hurriedly drew his sword and defended himself, but his blade shattered.

“Keuk...!”

Bark fell to his knees as fresh blood poured from his chest that had been split diagonally.

The knight looked down at him coldly and withdrew his sword.

“I said I wouldn't take questions. Do you dare to question the Lord's mandate?”

Chapter 17.1: Alkimas Workshop

(4)

Chapter 17.1: Alkimas Workshop (4)

Bark grabbed his bloody chest with trembling hands.

Varia, who was watching the situation, finally regained his composure and opened his mouth.

“...I apologize for the rudeness, so please have mercy, Sir Akin.”

If they didn't bow and apologize, it wouldn't be strange if someone's neck was blown off.

Even Varia, someone who had a great influence on the entire North, was just a meaningless existence in front of the Lord's power.

The knight who cut down Bark was Akin Kradel, the vice-captain of the Iron Blood Knights.

From the moment a big man like this showed up in person, he already had a hunch that something unusual had happened, but the words that came out of the other's mouth were beyond his imagination.

The Lord's order, why...

Why did the newly enthroned Seventh Lord ask for him and Scarlett?
Didn't he arrive in the capital just yesterday?

What was even more incomprehensible was the vice-captain's attitude.

Anyone could see that he was overbearing on their side, but was polite to Scarlett.

While Varia was confused, he couldn't help but feel an ominous feeling that something terrible was about to happen.

The vice-captain who drew the sword approached Scarlett and stood next to him without paying attention to the fallen Bark.

"Then we'll move right away."

Scarlett looked at Thane and the elders in embarrassment, as the others were looking at the knights at the same time.

"Umm, why are taking the family head..."

One elder opened his mouth involuntarily, but shut it back immediately.

He had no choice but to do so because Bark who did the same, was now in that kind of situation.

However, the vice-captain answered in a polite voice this time.

"Don't worry, the Lord asked us to escort the workshop owner, so it's definitely not a bad thing."

"..."

The elders had no choice but to remain silent.

Although they were worried about why the Seventh Lord was looking for the family head, but they couldn't stand in the way of the knights either.

"Si- sister."

Thane grabbed his wounded arm and stood up.

Scarlett saw that and was about to talk to the vice-captain, but another elder stepped forward and said.

“Family head, don’t worry and go. We will treat Thane’s arm right away.”

She hesitated, then nodded.

Knights were attached to both sides of Scarlett. Some knights then approached Varia.

Varia let out a small sigh and turned to Bark.

“Treat your wound.”

The knights led the two of them and moved straight to the Lord’s castle.

After passing through the main gate of the castle and entering the inner sanctuary, Scarlett looked around with a nervous expression.

Just looking at the sight of the knights standing guard throughout the castle, she felt the severity of the situation.

There was no way that she, a mere outsider, had ever entered the interior of the castle like this.

When I reached the huge building in the center, there was an elderly butler waiting at the entrance.

He bowed his head and greeted Scarlett.

“My name is Floto, the head butler. The Lord is waiting for you, let me lead you there.”

Then he turned his gaze and took a quick glance at Varia before he started walking in the lead.

Passing through a wide and long corridor and stairs, we arrived at the highest floor of the building.

When I arrived at the central hall on the top floor, I saw a man sitting on a chair looking at something, and a female knight standing behind him.

“...?”

Upon seeing the scene, Scarlett’s face was instantly filled with doubt and bewilderment.

It had to be. Because the faces of the two were familiar.

The unknown customer who visited the studio in the morning and bought a scarlet potion, and paid three platinum coins as if they were a penny.

But what were they doing here...

“My lord.”

Floto said and bowed his head.

Scarlett also looked at the man with a dazed expression.

Suddenly, the conversation she had with Thane flashed through her mind. A conversation about the newly enthroned Seventh Lord.

“As you commanded, I brought you the owner of Alkimas Workshop and the head of the Varia Merchant Corps.”

Putting down the thing he was holding in his hand, the man slowly turned his head to look at Scarlett and opened his mouth.

“We met again so soon, workshop owner.”

Scarlett, who finally grasped the whole situation, lost her mind for a while, then belatedly lowered her head.

“It’s an honor to meet the Seventh Lord...”

The Seventh Lord then turned his gaze to Varia this time.

Varia did not dare to make eye contact and hurriedly bowed his head.

“It’s a lifetime honor to meet the Seventh Lord...”

“Why do you think I called you?”

Varia felt his heart froze at that indifferent and cold voice.

Chapter 17.2: Alkimas Workshop

(4)

Chapter 17.2: Alkimas Workshop (4) Two ! Thank you to Jess for donating!
^^

Varia had noticed by now. Why did the Seventh Lord call him and Scarlett?

Unlike his side, the knights treated Scarlett politely, and then there was the reaction of the Lord now, as if they were already familiar with each other...

Varia desperately shook his head, feeling a sense of crisis and fear for the first time in his life. What kind of answer should he give?

Soon, Varia dropped to his knees and said.

“I have committed a mortal sin, my lord.”

In an instant, the hall became quiet.

Varia hung his head on the floor and waited for an answer.

After a while, the Seventh Lord opened his mouth again.

“What sin did you commit?”

“I coveted the talent and labor of Alkimas Workshop and did various dirty tricks on them. I blocked the distribution of materials, conciliated the workshop’s customers one by one, and threatened the workshop owner and elders like I did today.”

Varia confessed his sins like flowing water.

He started out empty-handed with nothing but a sense for money and built up the current merchant group.

No matter how much he thought about the most likely way to survive here, this was the best way. After all, the Lord would know everything.

Scarlett, who was standing next to Varia, looked down at him as if he was a little bewildered.

The Seventh Lord asked her this time.

“That’s right, workshop lord.”

“Ah, yes...”

“What do you want to do with the Varia Merchant Corps?”

Scarlett and Varia’s eyes met.

Varia looked up at her with the most earnest gaze.

“Please forgive me, workshop owner. I will formally apologize for everything I’ve done until now, and I will thoroughly compensate you for everything. And I promise that I will no longer be blinded by greed and commit dirty tricks against the workshop.”

Scarlett looked at him with a complicated expression on his face as he spoke up and pleaded.

Then she let out a small sigh and nodded her head.

“I get it.”

Varia was contemptuous enough to make her teeth tremble, but she didn’t want to ask his head for it.

The story ended blandly like that, and the Seventh Lord gazed down at Varia and said.

“Hopefully, I don’t have to call you here again.”

“...”

“Go.”

Varia shuddered from her seat and followed Floto out of the hall with a drained face.

Left alone, Scarlett stood still, with a bewildered expression on her face.

The Seventh Lord looked at her and said.

“You must be wondering why I am helping the workshop.”

“...Yes, that’s right.”

The problem with Varia, which had been hounding her, was quickly resolved with just a few words from the Lord. To be honest, it felt unrealistic.

As much as she was grateful, Scarlett did not know what the hell was he trying to do by helping her.

“The reason is simple. Your qualities as an alchemist stood out for me.”

“...?”

“The scarlet potion is quite good. I hope you will focus on your research and develop that potion even further. That’s why I solved the annoying problem for you.”

Scarlett’s face became even more incomprehensible.

“So what the Lord was saying is that you’re not planning to ask anything from me just because you highly valued my abilities?”

“Yes.”

“...”

“If you don’t understand, think of it as a debt. One day, there may come a time when I would need your ability. You can consider paying me that favor when that time comes.”

To Scarlett, that sounded even stranger.

How could a Lord ever need the help of an alchemist like himself?

“If you don’t have any further questions, you can go.”

Scarlett was silent for a moment, then bowed her head deeply.

“I have received a great grace from my lord. As you wished, if the time comes when the Lord would need my ability... I will do my best to help.”

After saying goodbye, Scarlett went outside, following Floto, who just returned.

The new Seventh Lord was truly mysterious, she thought.

After sending the two of them back, I finished drinking the tea I was drinking.

That guy acted pretty fast.

I thought of Varia kneeling down and apologizing, and I smiled.

Just like that, he lowered himself and confessed, so the investigation of Varia Merchang Corps was no longer necessary. The conversation only took a few minutes.

Anyway, this was the end of the workshop issue.

Varia noticed I was involved with the workshop, so he could no longer show his ambition. He even tried to mend his relationship with Scarlett.

Of course, I didn't need her ability right away.

However, if I formed a relationship with the NPCs who appeared as good characters in the game one by one like this, they might be a big help to me someday when I least expected it.

Then, what's left is...

I looked back at the map I had set down on my desk and crossed my arms.

The sooner I leave here, the better, so I could find the next mystery.

I'm a little worried about the route I should take.

My top priority right now was to collect all the mysteries within the realm of Calderic.

And among them, the most necessary was the defense-type ability.

Therefore, it's already fixed that the next mystery was the 'floating curtain'. But the route I should take to get there was still not fixed. I had to be careful about going around Calderic after all.

"Lord."

I was thinking about that when Floto came back and called me.

I wondered if there was anything left to say about the workshop or the merchant group, but the words he said next were totally unexpected.

"A guest has come."

"...?"

"The Fourth Lord is here. He said he came to see the Lord."

I almost spit out the tea I was drinking.

...Who's here?

Chapter 18.1: King of the Dead, Astra

Chapter 18.1: King of the Dead, Astra

The Fourth Lord, the King of the Dead, Astra.

As a newcomer and an undead lich, he perfectly suited the title of King of the Dead.

But why...

Why did he come looking for me suddenly?

“He’s waiting for you at the entrance of the castle.”

I let out a deep sigh, buried my back in the chair, and immersed myself in brief agony.

I wanted to avoid meeting another Lord until the next meeting, but why was this happening already?

I can’t just ignore this.

A Lord himself came here to visit.

He even said that he came to see me, so of course, I should welcome him. That’s why it’s hard for me to refuse.

This was my base, and it would be rude if I refused to see him. I already had a somewhat bad relationship with the Thunder Lord.

The Fourth Lord was the opposite of the Tyrant, a Lord who maintained a gentle relationship with all the other Lords. So, I wanted to avoid being his enemy.

In fact, a meeting with a Lord didn't mean that I have to take a huge risk.

Since I was also a Lord, the other would definitely not act recklessly.

However, since I was so weak, contact with someone much stronger still felt burdensome.

There's no way he came here without a reason...

Still, the King of the Dead was a Lord who belonged to the normal side among the Lords.

Having made my decision, I told Floto.

“Take him here.”

I wondered if I should go out and greet him myself, but I thought there was no need to do that since he was the one who came here himself.

It took a while before Floto, who bowed his head and retreated, returned with someone.

A black robe rimmed with gold. And a skull visible through the hood...

The place where the eyes should have been was empty, and I could see the ghostly blue eyes glowing faintly.

As the being entered the hall, the secluded atmosphere seemed to be filled with gloom.

He stopped at the entrance of the hall and made eye contact with me.

[Lv. 95]

...This skull was the King of the Dead, the Fourth Lord.

He looked nothing like what I saw in the game.

The King of the Dead was holding in one hand a huge wooden staff that was as tall as his height, and that was also the staff he was holding in the game.

“Nice to meet you, Seventh Lord.”

A strange voice that seemed not to be coming out of the throat rang in my ears.

Come to think of it, how did a guy who was a skeleton but had no vocal cords speak? Was that all magic?

“I’m sorry for coming here so suddenly, with no warning. I’m just here to have a quick chat. May I sit down?”

I gestured to the seat opposite.

The King of the Dead approached with brisk steps and sat down on a chair. Silence fell in an instant.

Sitting close to him, I could feel the energy surrounding him much more clearly.

If what I felt when facing the Mad King was the pressure that seemed to weigh down my whole body, what I felt from the King of the Dead was eerie. It’s as if death took shape and materialized as it was...

Now I’m really thankful for the [Soul of the King].

If it wasn’t for that, my body might have been already shaking without me realizing it.

Once again, I felt grateful for this absolute mind barrier skill.

“What the matter?”

I asked, feigning indifference. Since it was their first meeting, I couldn't think of anything that we could talk about.

And I wanted to end this conversation as soon as possible.

Interacting with him was much less gruesome than the Black Sea Empress, but it was equally burdensome to face a skeleton for a long time.

The King of the Dead, who was staring at me with his blue eyes shining, soon spoke in a voice that sounded like laughter.

“It surprised me when I heard the Overlord had appointed a new Lord straight from the meeting. Now I regret not being able to attend the last meeting.”

I made no reply.

When there was no reply, he continued to talk about useless things that he obviously didn't come here for.

“Seventh Lord, I have a lot of interest in you personally, especially after hearing what happened during the meeting. It's been the first time that a human sat on a Lord's throne after half a century...”

“King of the Dead.”

I cut him off.

“I don't like useless dialogue.”

The King of the Dead said nothing for a while, then burst into laughter.

“Then, I'll tell you right away. The corpse of the warrior you killed, Seventh Lord, I came for it.”

Those words brought back memories I had forgotten.

Chapter 18.2: King of the Dead, Astra

Chapter 18.2: King of the Dead, Astra

Right, there was that.

Didn't Dayphon take the warrior's body before escaping the convoy because there could be someone who might want it?

I thought the King of the Dead would be the only one who would want a dead body, seemed like my guess was correct.

Well, if it's the corpse of a strong man like the warrior, it's worth coveting.

A spirit magic that controlled the dead by reviving them.

The King of the Dead was the continent's strongest necromancer, with no one to compare him to.

He was a terrible enemy in the game.

Among the Lords of Calderic, there were two beings that had their own large armies aside from the troops of the Overlord, and that were the King of the Dead and the Black Sea Empress.

The army of corpses led by the King of the Dead was enough to be called a one-man army.

But why did he go here for that?

Dayphon had the body, so why did he go here to get it from me?

That's what I thought, but the words that he said next answered my question.

"Since you're the one who killed the warrior, you technically own the body. So, I'm here to ask permission to have it."

"..."

Oh yeah, ownership...

Come to think of it, Dayphon said that I owned the body.

So, the King of the Dead came to see me personally because he wanted to take over the authority of the corpse.

He really didn't need to go to me just for that.

Even if he didn't ask permission, I wouldn't have cared.

Still, from the perspective of the King of the Dead, I wondered if he asked for permission just in case I would question him about it later.

However, after coming all the way here and asking for permission like this... it really felt like just a waste.

As soon as I stared at him, the King of the Dead continued.

"I'll pay you a fair price."

A fair price.

Several things ran through my mind.

For example, magic items. Since the King of the Dead was a mage, shouldn't he have defense-type items I need the most right now?

But that's hard to say...

It's as if I'm openly confessing that I need items because I lack defensive skills.

And when I thought about it, I didn't even know if I could use magic items properly.

I thought about it for a while and then said.

"I want nothing from you."

Then the King of the Dead said.

"Then how about leaving it as a debt? Later, when you want something from me, I'll pay the price equal to the value of the warrior's corpse."

I nodded my head because it was ambiguous to ask for something right away, and it was not a bad suggestion.

I thought it would be better to end it at this point without poking further.

"Do you need anything else?"

"No. You don't seem to enjoy my company, so I'll be going right away."

After saying that, the King of the Dead got up from his seat and leisurely left the hall.

I buried myself in the chair, feeling empty for no reason, probably because the conversation I worried about ended blandly.

At that moment, Asher, who was standing behind me, let out a small trembling breath.

I glanced at her expression. The presence of the King of the Dead affected her this much.

I was fine because of the [Soul of the King], but the 'fear' that the King of the Dead exuded seemed to be a considerable burden to her.

Ugh...

Was I going to be continuously stuck between these monsters?

The conversation with the King of the Dead, which was short and bland, only gave me more hopelessness about the future.

But this was the path I chose.

I have to collect the hidden pieces as soon as possible.

An undead knight in black armor waiting in front of the castle gate bowed his head toward the King of the Dead, who walked out.

‘You came out right away.’

Necromancers and their subordinates were spiritually connected, allowing dialogue through their consciousness, as well as sharing images of what they saw.

The undead knight had doubts about the feelings of the King of the Dead, who were rarely happy.

The King of the Dead laughed mentally.

‘The new Seventh Lord is really interesting.’

Hundreds of years of leading immortality in the undead’s body.

Since death no longer meant anything to him, paradoxically, he could feel ‘death’ more clearly than anyone else.

But how long had it been since he felt this feeling?

‘...I never thought I would feel the fear of death.’

I couldn’t feel any aura or mana from the Seventh Lord.

Neither magical power nor physical strength could be felt, so he looked like an ordinary human with no real abilities.

But the other definitely could kill him.

The only person who he felt this kind of feeling after he became a lich was the hero of Santea, and it was only faintly felt even by the Overlord.

He had come in person to get the warrior's corpse and to see what kind of person the new Seventh Lord was, but it turned out to be more enjoyable than he thought.

'I can't wait to see what kind of request he will make later.'

That's why I was happy to even create a link through debt.

The King of the Dead pondered over the realization of death he had felt for the first time in a long while and firmly imprinted the existence of the Seventh Lord in his mind.

Chapter 19.1: Before Leaving

Chapter 19.1: Before Leaving

Now that I thought about it, I have never read so many books in my life.

Back in my ‘real’ life, I was only interested in playing RaSa, breaking achievements, and getting more items and skills.

If I wasn’t so crazy about this game, maybe shit like this wouldn’t have happened.

...My thoughts drifted away for a while, but anyway, the reason I suddenly had this thought was because of what I was doing.

“Hmm.”

I closed the book I was reading.

On one side of the desk, there was a heap of things that looked like old books, all of them related to vampires.

Currently, my daily routine in the castle was to look at a map or read a book repeatedly.

The books I read were all related to vampires.

These guys are also a rare species, so there isn’t much information.

Most of the rare races, like the White Moon tribe, lived somewhere in the depths of the forest among themselves.

Besides, among the many races in this world, vampires were a race that had a bad reputation.

Because of this, it was even more difficult to find information because other races had ostracised them from the world for a long time.

Even in the game, there were few stories related to vampires.

There are mysteries, but if I could use blood magic, the synergy with instant kill would be great...

The reason I was so obsessed with vampires was because of the racial trait, 'Blood Art'.

Each individual had a unique ability, but freely handling blood as if using telekinesis was a common skill that all vampires could use.

No matter how much I thought about it, there was no better way to maximize the efficiency of my instant kill than to get blood magic.

The problem was that in order to get it, I had to directly go to 'Elrod Forest', one of the hiding places of the vampires.

It's completely suicidal.

In this world, not all vampires lived by sucking blood.

Vampires were divided into tribes, and there were ones among them that did not suck the blood of other races and lived well among themselves.

But because there were still those who did, even those tribes lived while being ostracised and persecuted.

Because of this, most tribes who had been unfairly treated had quite severe hostility towards other race.

Elrod Forest was also a place where some vampire tribe lived. It wouldn't be strange if I, a human, would be attacked right away if I appeared there.

It's really difficult.

It's difficult to decide.

The order of obtaining the other mysteries was pretty much all set.

However, suddenly discovering a new way to use [Instant Kill] and blood magic, I couldn't help but wonder if I should visit Elrod Forest in the middle.

If Asher and I went there alone, things would definitely become bad.

But if I mobilize the troops of my territory, things would get too big.

It would be equivalent to going to war.

No matter how peaceful a tribe was, vampires themselves were a fairly warlike race, and they had a lot of hostility towards other races.

If I led my troops to Elrod Forest, the vampires there would definitely resist, no matter what kind of threat they faced.

If that happens, I will become a killer who massacred a whole tribe just to get a blood skill.

And since Elrod Forest was in a different Lord's territory, it would have been difficult to lead an army.

The reason I sought an escort like Asher in the first place was because I couldn't lead my army on the lands of the other Lords.

I sank into the chair and let out a sluggish breath. And I turned my thoughts elsewhere.

A way to use [Instant Kill] from a distance without blood magic.

In the Rutus Mountains, where I climbed to get super regeneration, I met Bellvagorah and almost died.

I had to travel all over Calderic looking for other mysteries, but I could encounter such unexpected dangers again that even Asher couldn't handle.

There's nothing wrong with preparing a way to use [Instant Kill] more efficiently to prepare for that time.

Long distance attack.

If there was a way to just cut a wound and splatter blood...

However, since that would only fly a few distances, it was difficult to even call it a long-range attack.

In this world overflowing with all kinds of monsters, if an enemy came within a few meters to attack me, I would be much more likely to die before I could do anything.

Another method was to smear blood on something and blow it off.

For example, shooting an arrow with blood on the arrowhead.

That would seem to be the best.

But, of course, there's one problem. I didn't know how to shoot a bow.

I just need to learn if I don't know how.

Anyway, the danger I was likely to face while searching for mysteries was huge monsters like Bellevagorah.

Those filthy strong guys should be able to dodge several shots from a poor archer.

I didn't intend to waste time, but it wouldn't hurt to learn how to shoot casually.

And because of the mystery of super regeneration, my stamina was overflowing, so you could practice as much as I want without needing to rest.

Then let's learn it.

I got up from my seat.

It's farfetched to ask the other knights of the castle to teach me how to use the bow.

Then, there's only one suitable person.

Chapter 19.2: Before Leaving

Chapter 19.2: Before Leaving

“You want to learn the... bow?”

Asher, who was standing guard in front of the door, asked the Seventh Lord, who came out of the room and spat out nonsensical words.

The other nodded.

“Don’t you know how?”

“...No, I know.”

“Then go straight to the gymnasium.”

With a slightly confused expression, she looked at the Seventh Lord, who spoke calmly.

This erratic Lord was doing something eccentric again, just like he did in Rutus Mountains.

A bow... what kind of request was it to suddenly ask her to teach him to shoot an arrow?

As if what she was thinking was clearly visible on her face, the Seventh Lord said.

“I just suddenly became interested.”

Asher couldn’t ask for anything more and had no choice but to follow the Seventh Lord.

The two moved to a spacious private gymnasium in the basement.

Butler Floto finished preparing the bows, arrows, and targets.

The Seventh Lord and Asher stood side by side, each holding a bow, keeping their distance from the target.

“Let’s shoot first.”

At the words of the Seventh Lord, Asher immediately put an arrow on the string and shot it at the target.

Piing!

The arrow flew with great force and accurately hit the center of the target.

He nodded and said.

“Now teach me.”

“...”

Asher asked, not knowing where to start.

“You don’t know how to shoot at all?”

“Yes.”

“...Then, start with the posture.”

She said to put an arrow on the string and pull it.

At that, the Seventh Lord hung an arrow on the string and pulled it lightly. It was a sloppy form.

“You lowered your right shoulder too much. And the hand holding the arrow...”

At Asher’s request, he slightly change his stance.

“...Aim at the target like what I just did, and now shoot.”

The Seventh Lord set up a demonstration.

The arrow flew sloppily and fell to the floor without even reaching the target.

Asher looked at it and said.

“You lost your posture the moment you fired.”

“Let’s try again.”

As the Seventh Lord continued to shoot arrows, Asher watched from the side and pointed out what was wrong.

About half an hour passed.

The Seventh Lord still could not hit a single arrow at the target, which was less than 30 paces away.

“...”

Asher looked at the arrows piled on the floor and the walls with a slightly stiff expression, then turned her gaze back to the Seventh Lord.

Piing!

The flying arrow hit the wall next to the target without fail.

“You made a mistake in your grip again.”

The Seventh Lord kept repeating what she had pointed out nearly ten times. Like a person who had no sense of moving his body at all.

The Seventh Lord lowered his bow and looked back at her.

“Are you mad?”

“...No.”

“Your voice is stiff. You must be angry.”

“I’m not.”

The Seventh Lord shook his head and said.

“How about correcting my posture once?”

It meant putting her hands directly on his body and guiding his posture.

Asher hesitated for a moment before moving closer.

Was it a big deal to touch a Lord’s body? She even carried him on her back in Rutus Mountains.

“Fix your shoulders like this...”

As she touched the Seventh Lord’s body here and there, Asher felt it again.

It’s really a soft body that hasn’t been trained in the slightest. As if it would break just by touching it.

...The image of the Seventh Lord who defeated the monster snake in the mountains suddenly flashed in her mind.

What was the source of that unreasonable power he showed?

She felt a bleakness that was hard to gauge from the Fourth Lord, the King of the Dead, whom she had unexpectedly seen before.

However, on the contrary, Asher did not dare to judge the Seventh Lord by any standard just because she felt nothing of the sort from him. Wouldn’t even this lousy body be a shell with little meaning to him...?

Piing!

As she corrected his posture, the Seventh Lord who shot the arrow finally hit the target for the first time.

He put on a slightly satisfied expression.

“I’m getting the hang of it.”

As he said, the Seventh Lord fired a few more shots, all the arrows hit the target, and the practice was over.

A/N: Update schedule for this novel is every other day. Which means that it could be Monday, Wednesday, Friday, and Sunday or Tuesday, Thursday, Saturday. will usually be posted on days that I’m not scheduled to update. (This will follow the GMT +8 timezone)^^

Chapter 20.1: Floating Veil (1)

Chapter 20.1: Floating Veil (1)

It had been a week since I arrived here in my territory.

I couldn't just stay here forever, so I finished all the planning I needed and prepared to leave.

"I'll probably not return until the next Lords' meeting."

Even without me, this territory would still function, so there was nothing to worry about.

Among the Lords, there were also some who left their territory and wandered outside. Like the Mad King, for example.

Floto bowed his head with the same expression as always.

"I'll prepare it right away, as you have instructed."

Except for Asher, I went with only one attendant.

It was because there had to be someone who was familiar with the geography of Calderic and could do miscellaneous tasks.

I had to go around other Lord's territories, so I thought one person was enough. I just couldn't drag a bunch of people around, and it made little sense to attach a few more people cumbersomely.

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"My name is Baros, a first-grade butler."

A cold-looking male elf wearing glasses greeted us politely.

Floto brought him under my command to find a suitable person to become my attendant regardless of age and gender.

The level was also quite high, well over 40.

“I’m going to wander all over Calderic. Can you guide me without us getting lost in the process?”

“Yes, Lord.”

“Then get ready to leave immediately.”

The composition of the crew was over, and Floto took care of the packing.

“Prepare a plain and inconspicuous wagon.”

It didn’t seem like a good idea to ride around in a huge, patterned, ornate carriage like the one I rode here from the Overlord’s castle.

Because it could have exposed my location and route to the other Lords.

Since I was planning to go to the other Lords’ territories without revealing my identity as much as possible.

Although there’s a rule that Lords couldn’t hurt each other, there was always an ‘if’. There’s nothing wrong with being careful.

After finishing all the preparations, Asher and I got on the wagon at the entrance of the castle and Floto saw us off.

“Safe travels, my lord.”

Passing by the knights who were saluting at the castle gate, the carriage briskly pulled out of the main gate.

The next mystery to be targeted was the ‘floating veil’, a defense-type mystery.

This mystery with a somewhat unusual name was an excellent mystery that could be said to be absolute, at least in terms of defensive ability.

Its level in the game was 9 stars, the same as the [Soul of the King].

Of course, there was one fatal penalty as well.

However, for me now, it was more important than anything else to get excellent defense, so the penalty wasn’t that important.

[Instant Kill] was the best offensive ability, but it had no defensive ability at all because it only activated once I was in direct contact with the target.

I was in a precarious situation in which, even if a level 20 hit me with a punch, my head would explode as it was. It was definitely necessary to improve somehow.

Tyrell Mountains.

The hidden location of the [Floating Veil] was somewhere in the Tyrell Mountains on the northern border of Sarogal, the 5th Lord’s territory.

I didn’t remember the exact location like the super-regeneration, because it was not a mystery that I found myself.

There was a video of another player who recorded getting the floating veil and it became a hot topic, so I kind of remember it.

It’s in a place like a ruined dungeon.

It wouldn’t be easy to find, but I was going to find it and get it somehow.

There might be a way to mobilize a good deal of manpower by seeking help from the Mad King, but it was a method I was reluctant to use.

It was because the Mad King herself was not a person who could communicate with others well. And if I was asked to explain the reason, I could not.

It's not a good idea to borrow someone else's power to get the mystery.

Because once someone touched the mystery pattern, that person would absorb the mystery.

If someone discovered the mystery first and they gobbled it up, there was no way I could make them spit it out.

It would be best to only hire a guide, as with super-regeneration.

Currently, the wagon was passing through the woods.

Calderic was a land formed with the Overlord's territory as the center and the lands of the nine lords surrounding it.

The road I chose to the 5th Lord's territory was to go obliquely past the outskirts of the 6th Lord's. It was the fastest straight route.

Baros, who's driving right now, would take care of it.

“...?”

Chapter 20.2: Floating Veil (1)

Chapter 20.2: Floating Veil (1)

I looked at Asher on the other side.

It was because she, who had been sitting motionless as always, glanced out the window.

Just when I thought something was wrong, the carriage came to a slow stop with the sound of a horse clattering.

“Hahaha! How dare you pass through such a forest fearlessly without an escort!”

A gruff voice echoed from outside the carriage.

Is it a thief?

In this medieval fantasy world, thieves and monsters were common on the road.

It was only when I headed to Enrock from the Overlord Castle that the escort knights were full, so I never encountered a group of bandits, but that was not the case now.

It's not a situation I didn't expect.

“Get off the wagon! Give everything you have and... Whoa!”

And the screams continued.

The sound of something being torn to pieces and a terrible scream echoed continuously, and soon it was quiet outside.

I sneakily opened the window and poked my head out to see the scattered corpses and Baros wiping the blood from his glasses.

Around him, something like the wind took shape, swaying, then disappearing... Was that a spirit?

Baros, who met my eyes, lowered his head as if to apologize.

“My apologies. We stopped moving because of the garbage.”

“...It’s fine.”

Baros climbed into the driver’s seat, and the carriage started again.

There seemed to be no need for Asher to take care of the thieves.

After that, our travel continued, encountering thieves and monsters intermittently.

After a long time, we finally arrived at our destination, the territory of the 5th Lord, Sarogal.

The city of Kwarzhen, a large city in the northern frontier.

After spending a night at a luxury inn to wash off my fatigue, the next day I immediately went to the adventurer’s guild in the city.

“That’s why, at that desperate moment, I grabbed the monster’s horn and left it...”

“Sally, how about a drink tonight, just the two of us? Huh? After earning a lot from the previous request, I can buy you expensive alcohol.”

How could I describe the inside of the guild building? The atmosphere was exactly what I had imagined.

A person carefully looking through the request forms pasted on the wall, a person who was continuously bragging about his heroic deeds, and a person who was flirting with the staff at the counter...

After looking at the scene for a while, I approached the counter and was greeted by a woman from a beast tribe who was doing her job with a smile.

“Welcome, young master. Do you have a request you want to apply for?”

She asked that probably after judging based on my outfit that I came here to request something.

I nodded and asked.

“Which adventurer in this city is the most knowledgeable with the geography of Tyrell Mountains?”

She answered without a moment’s thought.

“You are looking for an adventurer knowledgeable in the geography of the Tyrell Mountains. Do you want a guide?”

“Yes.”

“Does it matter if it’s an adventurer or just a normal individual?”

“Does not matter.”

“Then, I recommend the Blue Fox Adventurer Team. The leader, Mr. Rodin, is a first-class adventurer, and has a considerable reputation here in Kwarzhen. They are sitting right there right now. Would you like to meet them?”

At the place the woman pointed out, several men and women were sitting around and talking on the railing on the second floor.

As I followed her up the stairs and got closer, I met their questioning glances.

Five adventurers, men and women, each armed with various weapons such as swords, spears, and bows.

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Among them, the female receptionist talked to the man with the highest level, a huge sword standing next to the table.

“Mr. Rodin, there is a request for you. The young master said that he is looking for a guide who is knowledgeable about the geography of the Tyrell Mountains.”

“...Huh? A request?”

He looked back and forth between me and the receptionist, scratching his beard, then spoke to her.

“Chelsea, we already agreed to take on an escort request to Polyp City. Didn’t you know?”

“...Yes? Did you?”

“Yes. I’m sorry, but I don’t think I can take on that request, sir. Find another adventurer.”

Unaware of the fact, the receptionist had a puzzled expression on her face.

I asked her.

“Are these guys the most knowledgeable when it came to the geography of Tyrell Mountains?”

“Yes, that’s true, but... I’m sorry, young master. Since they already agreed to a prior request, I’ll introduce you to another.”

I shook my head.

Looking at the levels, the skills seemed clear, and I wanted to bring the best manpower.

“If it’s like that, I’ll pay more. So, can you cancel that request and take mine?”

At my words, a man named Rodin laughed a little and replied.

“I can’t do that, sir. If I cancelled the commission I already received, I have to pay several times the advance payment as a penalty.”

That was only natural since if the adventurer side arbitrarily cancelled the request, it would harm the client as well.

I asked again.

“How much is the cancellation fee?”

“Since the advance payment received is five gold, I will have to pay 10 gold, which is doubled.”

“I’ll hire you for 20 gold. How about it?”

Rodin’s eyes widened, as if my condition sounded quite unconventional.

But in the end, he shook his head.

“A penalty is also a penalty, but there is trust with the client. If we break the first request to take on another request, what will people think of our group?”

“I’ll double the commission to 40 gold.”

Rodin’s pupils twitched.

“I’m sorry, but I really can’t, sir...”

“Three times, 60 gold.”

“...There is a thing called credibility—”

“Five times, 100 gold. This is my last offer.”

Rodin’s words were cut off.

The other members also gulped and looked at Rodin.

He slowly got up from his seat, dragging his chair, and bent his back.

“Welcome, dear client.”

Chapter 21.1: Floating Veil (2)

Chapter 21.1: Floating Veil (2) Thank you to Havi for sponsoring 10 chapters! ^^

Under the contract signed with money, I had a more detailed discussion with the group of adventurers about the task to be commissioned.

Rodin, who had been listening to my story silently, asked in a puzzled tone.

“So... you mean you’re going to search all the peaks of the Tyrell Mountains?”

“Yes.”

Even if I said it, it sounded very absurd, but I couldn’t help it.

Unlike super-regeneration, the only topographical feature that I could remember about the location of the floating veil was that it was somewhere at the top of the peaks of a mountain range... and that it was probably a canyon-like terrain.

I might get a sense if I went and looked for it myself, but there was nothing else that came to mind right away.

In order to find this mystery, I had to be prepared to work even harder than during when I was looking for the super regeneration.

Still, one lucky thing was that the Tyrell Mountains were smaller than the Rutus Mountains.

“How long do you think it would take to go around all the canyons at the peaks of the Tyrell Mountains?”

Rodin let out a sigh and answered.

“It’s vague that I can’t get a proper estimate, but if I had to guess, it would take at least 15 days?”

Over a fortnight.

In fact, as he said, it was too vague, so in the end, it was something you could only be determined by going there yourself.

Rodin opened his mouth again and asked.

“But may I ask who you are?”

A client who asked for a guide in the mountains by paying a lot of money.

It would be natural for him to be curious about my identity, so I answered appropriately.

“I came from a family from another city nearby. It’s difficult to reveal my origin.”

“.....Then why do you want to climb the Tyrell Mountains?”

“I’m looking for something.”

“What do you mean?”

“That would be difficult to say.”

“Ah, yes...”

For a moment, there was silence in the place.

Rodin and his members looked quite disturbed, as if they didn’t expect that they had to do this after accepting my request.

I took a money bag from my pocket and put five or six gold coins on the table.

They focused their attention on the gold coins piling up on the table.

“I’ll give you 30 gold right now as a down payment. I know it’s not an easy request, but you will definitely receive a good pay.”

“...”

“Still, if you can’t take on the request, I will understand. So, will you do it?”

Rodin, who was troubled, seemed to exchange glances with his members, and finally nodded his head.

“Do we only have to guide the two of you?”

Rodin looked back and forth between me and Asher, who was standing behind me.

I nodded.

He, too, nodded and briefly introduced himself and his members.

“My name is Rodin, the leader of the Blue Fox Adventure Team. And starting from the left, Arma, Lud, Baxter, and Shien...”

Five people, including two men armed with swords, shields and spears, a woman holding a bow, a woman who looked like a wizard because she was unarmed, and Rodin.

A woman carrying a bow called Shien smiled and looked at the gold coins piled on the table.

“In fact, there are no other adventurers around who are as knowledgeable about the geography of the Tyrell Mountains as we are. You really came to the right place, young master.”

“That crazy bitch, look at how she’s staring at the money...”

Lud, who was sitting next to her, spoke as if muttering, and then was slapped on the back by Shien.

I also simply stated my name.

“My name is Ron. This is Asher, my escort.”

“Yes, anyway, thank you. We will accept this request.”

Rodin’s blue fox adventurers eventually accepted the request.

It didn’t matter if we started right away, but they also needed to prepare, so I had an extra day of rest.

Early the next morning, the adventurers and I gathered in front of the eastern gate of the city.

There was no need for Baros to be there, so he stayed at the inn and only Asher accompanied me.

“Then let’s go.”

“...”

I could feel Asher looking at me strangely as I came out of the inn room.

She must be looking at the bows and arrows I brought.

In her eyes, I could see that she wanted to ask why I have to bring these items when I couldn’t even shoot properly, but I ignored it.

Who knew what other unimaginable dangers there would be this time, like Bellevagorah?

Even the slightest complacency could lead to death.

Preparing everything that could be prepared was the right attitude to survive in this harsh world.

“Are you here?”

He met the adventurers waiting in front of the gate and headed straight for the Tyrell Mountains.

Tyrell Mountains.

One characteristic of this mountain range was that there were a lot of Orcs.

Orcs were common monsters that could be found anywhere, but they were especially common in the Tyrell Mountains.

However, since they were only level 20 at the highest level, there was nothing to worry about safety.

A few hours after I started climbing the mountain range, I could keep pace with the adventurers without running out of stamina anymore.

And not long after, we encountered a group of orcs.

Quiik.

Chapter 21.2: Floating Veil (2)

Chapter 21.2: Floating Veil (2)

Large, green-skinned monsters emerged from the brush and approached with low cries. They looked just like what one would see in the game.

Eight in total. Some of them had rusty iron swords or spears in their hands.

“Are these bastards crazy and coming down here to hunt?”

Rodin and his members did not hesitate to step forward and start slaughtering the Orcs.

Those with spear swords fought in front, and assisted in the battle by throwing arrows and magic from behind. Asher and I watched the scene in silence.

In particular, since there was Rodin who was over level 30, the battle ended simply.

We sat down for a while, rested, and chatted with the adventurers.

“Orcs are smarter than you think, so even seasoned adventurers can be hunted and killed if they make a mistake. The weapons the Orcs were holding earlier were originally used by stealing other adventurers’ weapons.”

“Right.”

Of course, that was something I knew.

Since Orcs lived in a community as a tribal unit, their intelligence was excellent for a monster.

As I accepted the conversation well, the adventurers also added more stories.

“Do you know about how the Orc monster wave happens?”

“Isn’t it something that rarely happens when a mutant king appears?”

“Yes, you knew. Originally, because of their tyrannical nature, they couldn’t gather in large groups. When a king is born, all of them unite under him and become a completely terrible disaster.”

Monster wave.

As the name suggests, it referred to a phenomenon in which a huge group of monsters rushes like a wave.

There were many causes, but one of them was the existence of a ‘king’, a mutant that was very rare among monsters.

The monsters from which the king was born were typically Orcs and Lizardmen. When the king was born, an overwhelming army of monsters, from thousands to tens of thousands, was formed and invaded human territory.

If it’s an Orc King, then it would be over level 70.

Anyway, such monster waves were major events that often occurred in the game’s story.

After taking a break, we started moving again.

It had been a week since we started searching the Tyrell Mountains.

As expected, the adventurers did not get lost and successfully guided them to their destinations.

However, after searching many peaks and canyons, I still hadn't found the mystery.

Even as I moved, I continued to search hard for my memory.

I'm sure it was a canyon terrain.

It was not narrow, but quite wide, and I remember that the slopes of the cliffs on both sides were gentle. Although not accurate.

None of the canyons I had passed so far matched my memory.

And what else was there...

"It's a canyon."

Rodin said as he looked at the scene that appeared in front of us.

It was now the fifth gorge they had encountered.

"..."

Uh? Wait a second—.

I narrowed my eyes at the shape of the gorge, which somehow seemed to match my vague memories.

I was busy moving my gaze and scanning the gorge, but there was a commotion around me. There were also orcs.

This time, instead of a few, Rodin and his members frowned at the horde of orcs that protruded in dozens.

"...There are a little more this time?"

"They're still just Orcs, though. Arma, prepare a big magic."

As always, Rodin and his men prepared for battle. Still, there were a lot of numbers this time, so they showed a bit of nervousness.

But they were still always the first to go into battle...

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Take care of everything.”

The orcs were a great hindrance to this situation, where I was trying to remember something.

At my words, Asher drew her sword and swung it at the slowly approaching group of Orcs.

Chow!

The gigantic blue aura that erupted from her sword cut the bodies of the orcs in two at once.

Rodin and the members, who were about to go into battle at the sight, instantly became stunned.

“Uh, uh...”

As the canyon became quiet again, I continued to look around and retrieve my memory.

Soon after, I rushed to one side when something came to my mind. Asher followed me.

...*Yes*

Obviously, this was it.

I moved while looking at the cliff, just like when I was looking for super regeneration, and stopped at a certain point. And I raised my head.

A convex cliff faced high overhead, and a tree standing alone at the edge.

The video of the user who got the floating veil clearly had this composition of view.

“Asher, try breaking down this wall.”

Kwaaang!

As Asher broke down the wall, the stone fragments came crashing down, revealing a passage inside.

Old stone stairs going down.

Seeing that, I smiled with joy.

I finally found it.

This was the dungeon where the mystery of the floating veil was hidden.

Rodin and the rest of his group also came up and looked at the entrance, wide-eyed.

I told them;

“Wait here for a while.”

Leaving them behind, I went down the stairs with Asher and headed inside.

Chapter 21.3: Floating Veil (2)

Chapter 21.3: Floating Veil (2)

I carried the glowstone I had brought and relied on the light to advance through the dark passage.

Huge stone statues stood on both sides of the old, wide hallway leading to a straight line, and Asher looked around at them with a slightly nervous look.

A dungeon was basically an artificial space created by ancient wizards.

There were traps, and there were guardians guarding them.

But I didn't worry and kept walking.

Because obviously, even when I saw the play video, this dungeon was already broken, so there were no traps or guardians.

There was no danger until we could reach the innermost hidden place where the mystery of the floating veil was.

Soon after reaching the end of the hallway, a huge door appeared.

“Hmm.”

I stopped walking for a while.

It was because there was a huge stone statue, like the one hanging on both sides of the hallway blocking the doorway leading inward.

That's no big deal either.

It was probably a stone statue that wouldn't move anyway, so I moved on again.

It's okay if Asher destroyed everything and went inside... Wait a minute.

【Lv. 85】

Why do I see the level of that guy?

There was a level above the statue's head. I sensed something strange and stopped walking.

Suddenly, a blue light shone in the statue's eyes, and he opened them and swung the spear he was holding.

Kwak Kwa Kwa Kwam!

“...!”

Goose bumps ran down my spine at the gigantic aura of blue light that passed right next to me.

Then, an inorganic voice flowed from the stone statue.

[I warn you. I will consider anyone who crosses that line an intruder. Those who don't deserve to enter, please go back.]

...What was that?

Wasn't this a dungeon without a guardian?

Confused, I looked down.

When I looked at it, I saw that the floor was dented and had a line-like mark. Were you going to attack me if I walked over this?

Another unexpected situation dumbfounded me, like the one I encountered with Bellevagorah.

I had come this far, but something happened like this again?

coo coo coo.

The expression of Asher next to me hardened, as if she sensed that the energy radiating from the stone statue was unusual.

Its level was much higher than Asher's, so it was impossible for her to deal with it.

I thought to myself.

Does instant kill work on golems too?

That guardian was, at a glance, a magical golem made of magic

To put it bluntly, it was more like an inanimate creature than a living thing, so it was doubtful whether instant death would work.

But there was no other way. I had no choice but to try.

It's still the one and only 10-star skill. Shouldn't it also work on golems?

I took out the arrow I had brought with me, scratched my palm, dipped it in blood, hung it on the string, and aimed at it.

Asher swallowed a gulp as she looked at the stone statue spewing out huge magical energy in front of her.

Could she win with all her might? She checked, but she wasn't sure.

What was this dungeon-like space for? What was that monster?

Although she had great confidence in her abilities and was always regarded as a genius among her clan, she somehow constantly encountered opponents she could not handle when traveling with the Seventh Lord.

“...?”

She suddenly looked to the side.

It was because the Seventh lord was suddenly aiming at the golem with an arrow on a string.

Piiing!

When the Seventh Lord let go of the string, the flying arrow hit the body of the stone statue and bounced off helplessly.

As she was watching him blankly, he muttered, as if he was sorry.

“I tried to aim at the head, but I still lack a lot.”

...What the hell were you doing now?

When a question arises about an act that seemed to play a joke that did not go well with the situation.

The Seventh Lord opened his mouth again.

“Now get out of here, stone. Don’t block the road.”

...Coooooung!

The stone statue lost its balance and fell to the ground.

Seeing the scene, Asher’s eyes widened in astonishment.

The Seventh Lord put his bow on his back and said.

“Go inside.”

“...”

Asher stared blankly at his back as he moved forward with light steps, then she moved her steps belatedly.

Chapter 22.1: Floating Veil (3)

Chapter 22.1: Floating Veil (3)

Waa!

Asher broke down the huge stone gate and we went inside.

Moving beyond the rubble of collapsed stone fragments, what appeared was a huge cavity.

Haa...

I sighed a little and looked around.

Unidentifiable geometric patterns drawn on the floor and walls below, structures, and even the luminous stones embedded in the ceiling dimly illuminated the space.

It must have been built quite a long time ago, but those glowstones were not still exhausted.

It was a scene that oozes a more mysterious atmosphere than the corridors I passed through.

I walked further in, feeling the same joy I had when I reached the end of the dungeon while playing the game. Now it was time to claim the reward.

Let's see.

On one side of the cavity was a door slightly smaller than the door where the stone statue that had just been demolished was. It must have been that way.

The user who I watched from the game video was disappointed in the dungeon without a single item like a relic, but they must have entered that door, discovered the mystery, forgotten about the feeling of loss, and danced in the pants of joy.

Come to think of it, it was strange why the mystery was hidden in this dungeon.

Mystery was the setting of an unknown power that had nothing to do with mana or magic, and the place where it appeared was completely random.

It could be just a crazy coincidence, or there could be a reason I didn't know about.

Of course, that was a good thing.

What mattered to me now was the existence of the mystery of the floating veil waiting for me beyond that door.

But it's not just that, right?

Suddenly, a possibility came to mind.

The timeline of the current world was a point in the past, five years ago in the world played in the game.

There's a possibility that the mystery hadn't been created yet. So there could be nothing in there?

"Asher, break down this door."

I ordered Asher, brushing the ominous assumptions out of my head that I did not want to imagine.

Standing behind me, looking around the cavity, she came over and broke down the door.

Asher, who was brought here so I could use her as an escort, was actually used more to destroy things.

“Wait here.”

After I told her that, I went inside alone.

As I went further along the path that was narrower than the corridor, another cavity came out.

The only difference was that there were traces of human life here.

“...”

I looked up and stared at the ceiling, not paying attention to anything else.

I was staring at a pattern drawn on the ceiling and shining brightly in white.

The corners of my lips rose slowly.

Excitement welled up along with relief.

“Floating Veil...”

Mystery was more powerful as the size of the pattern increased.

The pattern of the floating veil was much larger than the super-regeneration, so it could not fill the ceiling of the wide cavity and continued to the wall below.

I laughed for a moment at the joy of finding the mystery, but soon realized the situation and let out a small sigh.

“Haa...”

Come to think of it, was that painted on the ceiling in the game video?

I couldn't think because I was concentrating on other things.

The ceiling of the cavity was high enough to easily exceed several times my height. At a glance, it looked like it was 10 meters.

...It should be absorbed only when it was touched, but how should I absorb it?

I stared blankly at the ceiling like a dog chasing chickens, then glanced back.

Should I go back and get Asher?

However, even if it's Asher, I did not want to show her the existence of a mystery.

Was there another way?

“...”

I turned my gaze to the wall.

There were a lot of protruding parts, so I thought I could climb it if I tried hard enough.

Ugh.

Anyway, there was no easy way to get anything.

I let out a sigh and moved closer to the wall.

I never thought I would do rock climbing like this, which I had never done before in my life.

There was super regeneration anyway, so I didn't have to worry about getting hurt if I fell, and my stamina also wouldn't run out that easily.

Holding on clumsily to the protruding part, I climbed slowly, groping.

If it was my original physical ability, I would have climbed a few meters and my arms would have trembled, but thanks to super regeneration, the lack of strength was immediately filled.

As I slowly and slowly climbed up like that, I was already right under the ceiling before I knew it.

If I stumbled once and fell, I had to climb up again, so I carefully fixed my center of gravity, slowly released one hand, and stretched out.

Whoa!

Chapter 22.2: Floating Veil (3)

Chapter 22.2: Floating Veil (3)

The light of the pattern burst brightly and slowly was absorbed into my body.

I was feeling the elation in the middle of it, but suddenly the part I was stepping on crumbled and gravity pulled me down.

“Ugh...”

Just like that, my body fell and crashed on the ground.

I let out a suppressed moan and rolled onto the floor for a moment.

As I struggled in pain like that, the intense pain that had been piercing my back, as if a bone had been broken, soon disappeared.

“Ah, shit.”

I rubbed my back and lifted myself up.

Anyway, with this I got the mystery of the floating veil.

It was the same when I got super regeneration. From the moment I got floating veil, I had a sense of what kind of ability it was and how to use it.

I stretched out my arms forward for no reason and activated the floating veil.

“...!”

I couldn't see it with my eyes, but I could feel a protective barrier spreading around my body.

I was amazed for a moment, but then I realized something and immediately recalled my ability.

Then I muttered with a slightly puzzled expression.

“No... was the penalty not being able to breathe?”

Floating veil.

Absolute defense ability that could block any powerful attack.

However, the penalty was that the caster could not take any action while the veil was open.

So in the game, it was used as an invincible skill that chewed the boss's ultimate skill.

But when I tried using it myself... not only could I not move while using this ability, I couldn't even breathe.

I tried the ability once again.

As I practiced and used my abilities several times, I soon realized something was different.

This did not last continuously once used, but can be canceled at will, and there was no cooldown or activation delay.

Unlike in the game, it became an on-off type of ability that could be freely turned on and off.

I didn't know if the form of the ability had changed to match the reality, but it could be said that it was much improved than the game, anyway.

However, while the veil was active, no action could be taken, and even breathing was impossible.

“I get it roughly.”

I thought it was a decent penalty.

To be honest, it didn't feel like a huge penalty to me.

Because I didn't have any ability other than instant kill, so if I tried to use this ability, how would I use it?

Wouldn't I rather use it mostly just to stand still and block my opponent's attacks, anyway?

I just have to hold my breath for a while, and if I have to keep it activated, I can control it by turning it off and on in between.

Assuming this and that, I thought about how to use the floating veil in different situations.

In addition, it was possible to control the shape and size of the veil.

I could spread the veil to stick to my body like armor, or I could spread it around the body in a spherical shape, like a barrier of magic.

This was a great defensive ability.

“It's good.”

Besides super regeneration, I felt reassured at the thought that I now had one more means to protect myself.

I brushed the dust off my body and looked around.

After obtaining the mystery, the scenery of the cavity came into view.

There were traces of people's lives, such as desks and beds.

I wandered around and looked around to see if there was anything else I could get, but nothing came of it.

After looking around the cavity one last time, I moved toward the aisle.

After passing through the passage I passed through and coming out of the first joint, I saw Asher, who was wary of the surroundings.

When she saw me, she seemed a little relieved.

She was nervous that the same stone statue from earlier would come out.

In the end, I did not know what this dungeon was.

Maybe this was a dungeon that someone had already robbed, but I thought maybe mystery formed behind it because of an unfortunate coincidence.

Whatever it was, I got what I wanted, so I didn't care anymore.

“Let's go out.”

I moved to the aisle leading outside with Asher.

Chapter 23.1: Floating Veil (4)

Chapter 23.1: Floating Veil (4)

The adventurers were talking in front of the entrance.

“Shouldn’t we just leave now?”

The member, Lud said.

A slight uneasiness flared up between them.

An unknown passageway through which the two entered.

No matter how you look at it, it looked like a dungeon; they felt like they were involved in something unusual.

The dungeon was a treasure trove of ancient ruins.

No matter what dangers might lurk inside, it was also a greedy trap that made many adventurers dream of a chance to get rich.

He couldn’t believe it, but what that young master was looking for was a dungeon.

The problem was that the woman who was the escort of the client, Ron, was more powerful than he had imagined.

She could fire a huge sword force and tore all the orcs to pieces. They had never seen such a rare sight in their entire life.

There was no law saying that the client would not come out of the dungeon and try to kill everyone on this side to keep their mouth shut.

Among the nobles, there were many crazy people who would do anything to achieve their goal.

He also had a bit of regret that they had received an unclear request too hastily because money blinded them.

The boy didn't look like that kind of person, but...

Shien stepped forward and said.

“Hey, are you saying something crazy? I haven't even received the rest of the commission yet.”

“Didn't you see that the woman is not an ordinary strong woman? If she says that, she'll keep our mouth shut, and tries to kill us...”

“Had she meant to do that, she would have killed us before she even went in with that young master. Would she have left us intact here like this?”

“Since they don't know the way back, she might try to kill us after we guide them back—!”

“Are you not only an idiot but also a coward?”

Shien hit Lud's back with her bow.

Of course, what Lud said was just a hypothetical assumption.

If not, she would do something stupid by leaving the client behind even before completing the request. And she wouldn't even be able to get 70 gold.

She decided to wait a little longer, but then she heard a squishy cry.

Orcs appeared one by one again around them.

“Oh, those orcs again.”

Were there any tribes that have settled near this canyon?

The expressions of Rodin and his members, who were preparing for battle as if tired of it, slowly turned into dazed faces.

This was because the number of Orcs in sight continued to increase.

A few to ten, ten to dozens, and dozens to...

“...”

A group of Orcs filled the area.

Among the bushes, on top of the cliffs, orcs continued to appear in the middle of it, and now it completely looked like a green wave.

“Shit.”

No one could understand what the hell was going on.

They all stepped back with pale complexions and not even thinking about raising a weapon.

Strangely, there was an orderly atmosphere between the many orcs.

Like a well-organized large army, waiting for the leader's command to lead them.

Kruck.

A low, clear sound rang out in the stillness.

At the ferocious cry that aroused fear, Rodin and his members shuddered thinly.

As if one side of the green wave was splitting, the road seemed to open, and something slowly stepped out from between them.

A gigantic orc twice as large as the other orcs, and covered in large muscles all over the body.

Looking at him, Rodin muttered in disbelief.

“...King.”

King.

An existence that could unite and lead monsters that cannot be united.

They could understand now. How could so many orcs be gathered in one place?

Among the orcs of the Tyrell Mountains, the worst mutation that would cause a monster wave was born.

The eyes of the Orc King, shining red and bloody, turned to them.

It looked like it was full of murderous intent to tear them apart and kill them at any moment.

There was no other way to deal with that monster.

Even without fighting, everyone could instinctively realize that fact.

With orcs all around them, there was only one place to run.

As Rodin looked at the entrance to the dungeon next to him, he barely let out his voice.

“Arma, magic...”

Arma, who was half lost, suddenly came to her senses and prepared her magic.

She was thinking of throwing some kind of magic to slow it down for a moment and then running inside. There was no other way.

She pumped all of her magic with all her might.

The magic power that was flowing around and clumped together soon rose into flames.

The Orc King charged towards them with a heavy volley of feet.

A huge fireball the size of a man cut through the air and flew toward the other with fierce force.

Whoops!

“...Run inside!”

Everyone turned and ran toward the entrance of the dungeon.

But it was futile.

The fireballs fired by Arma didn't even hit the Orc King, let alone stop it for a moment.

It jumped out of the flames and closed the distance between them in an instant before everyone could take a few steps.

The first target the Orc King aimed at was Arma, who had cast magic.

Rodin, who was right next to her, reflexively threw himself, but was hit and bounced off the cliff, crashing.

“...Ah!.”

There was no time to use defensive magic.

Then, seeing the huge fist that was about to hit her body, Arma sensed her death and closed her eyes tightly.

That was the moment.

A gigantic blade of sword flew from inside the dungeon's entrance and cut down the Orc King.

It let out a cry of pain and stepped back, grabbing its bleeding arm.

Arma slowly opened her closed eyes. The other members also looked at the entrance where the sword force came from.

Two people, Ron and Asher, were slowly walking out from inside.

Chapter 23.2: Floating Veil (4)

Chapter 23.2: Floating Veil (4)

...What's all this?

Leaving the dungeon with light steps, I looked at the scene unfolding in front of me with absurd eyes.

Many orcs covering the gorge.

I didn't think it had been half an hour since I entered the dungeon, but in the meantime, shit was going on outside.

Is that... an Orc King?

As I looked at the howling giant orc with its arm cut off by Asher's sword blade, I immediately understood the situation.

【Lv. 72】

Its level was 72.

It was a very high level, even for a king.

To encounter a really rare Orc King like this, would all this mystery quest always going to be eventful until the end?

However, since Asher was at a level that could deal with it with no problems, I didn't worry too much.

“Take care of it.”

“Yes.”

At my words, Asher immediately approached the Orc King.

Somehow, it felt like she was trying to make up for not being able to deal with the statue guardian in the dungeon.

I turned my gaze to see Rodin, who was pinned against the wall to the side.

It looked like he was barely breathing as he was crying and bleeding all over his body.

“Leader!”

Members who had been in a state of fascination belatedly ran in that direction.

I took Rodin out of the wall and laid him on the floor.

Arma hurriedly reached out her hand to his battered body. A green light enveloped his body.

She seemed to pour out healing magic, but Rodin’s focus was only slowly dissolving, like someone who was about to die.

“Oh, no...! No!”

I watched her crying and casting her spell, then I pulled something out of my arms.

I know that in order to survive in this world; I have to live selfishly showing no favors.

However, I had no intention of living while ignoring the people dying in front of me.

“Get out of the way.”

I took out the Scarlet Potion and checked Rodin’s condition.

The hollow in his chest meant that this was a fatal wound. I poured the potion on it.

After a while, his wounds slowly regenerated, and I heard bones and muscles slowly reconstructing.

Soon Rodin's complexion eased, and his breathing returned to normal.

The other members were staring blankly at the sight, then they hurriedly bowed to me.

“Thank you, young master! Really, thank you...!”

“Okay, check his status further.”

Having finished my work, I turned my gaze to the side.

On one side, the battle between Asher and the Orc King was in full swing.

Kwak Kwa Kwa Kwam!

-It was a battle that was so fast that it was difficult to see the what was going on.

Every time Asher and the Orc King clashed, the surrounding ground turned upside down and all they swept away the trees. The wind pressure pushed up to where I was, which was quite far away.

Seeing Asher fight properly for the first time made me realize that she, too, was a monster.

Bellevagorah, the Guardian who is well over level 80, and the people I met so far were all monsters of a different calibre, so it's just that I hadn't been able to properly see Asher's skill.

Asher's sword raged like a storm, and the Orc King could not fight back and only poured out blood.

In fact, if Asher really gave her full power, it would be dead by now.

The nine level difference they had was huge.

But now, since she didn't use her racial trait, she was out of power.

The battle seemed to take longer than expected, but I thought it would be over soon, so I folded my arms and stared at the fight.

It was at one point.

Big!

The Orc King let out a roaring roar as if preparing for the final clash, then suddenly turned and charged towards us

That also took aback Asher, so she came up behind it a beat late, but it was already close to them.

In the blink of an eye, I saw the guy who came right in front of me and immediately used a mystery.

Floating veil.

An invisible, transparent veil spread between me and the Orc King.

Its fist stopped in front of me, and the ground next to me exploded with the impact.

“...”

Its attack, which would have shattered even a huge rock, did not shock me in the slightest.

I still stood with my arms crossed, staring at the bewildered Orc King with nonchalant eyes

That was its last moment.

Chow-ah!

Asher's sword followed in an instant and decapitated the Orc King.

Chapter 24.1: Tair Bamon (1)

Chapter 24.1: Tair Bamon (1)

Blood poured out and the Orc King's head that tumbled to the floor.

Watching its body collapse after losing its head, I removed the veil only then.

I let out a small sigh and met Asher's eyes as she brushed off the blood on her sword. She bowed her head with a look of guilt.

"Sorry."

"It's fine."

I was a bit surprised, but thanks to that, I could confirm the defense power of the floating veil.

Looking around, I saw the orcs who had lost their leader, wandering around in confusion.

There was no need to ask Asher to kill them because they soon scattered in all directions as if they were running away.

Even Orcs would have the intelligence to distinguish who would be annihilated if they attacked.

"Whew..."

The adventurers who were standing on the side watching the battle looked relieved.

Rodin was also getting up from his the ground, staggering as if he had picked himself up.

I told them;

“Now let’s go down.”

Finding this mystery was also eventful.

After coming down the mountain range and returning to the city, I paid the rest of the request money to the adventure group.

Rather, they stubbornly refused, saying that they did not have to receive it in the name of receiving grace, but a promise was a promise, so they were forced to accept it.

“Thank you very much, young master. I hope you have only glory on the road ahead.”

They thanked me with genuine respect in their eyes.

It was a natural reaction, given that I saved their leader’s life using a precious potion and even gave them such a huge amount of money.

However, thanks to them, I also successfully got an important defense-type mystery, so I didn’t think it was a waste.

And it was only a few hundred golds, anyway.

The money I took from my territory was dozens of platinum coins that I now have in my arms.

We left the city right after a day.

The boring carriage trip began again, and the next destination was the First Lord’s territory ruled by the Wiseman.

Thinking of the mysteries to be gained there, I blankly watched the scenery outside the wagon.

Then, out of habit, I turned my gaze to Asher, who was sitting across from me.

Her expression seemed weakly shadowed.

“Your complexion doesn’t look good.”

At my words, Asher looked this way.

“Did you have any injuries sustained in battle?”

“No. Just...”

As she licked her lips, her expression became a little darker, she said.

“Lord Ron appointed me as an escort.”

“...”

“I made a mistake against the Orc King before, not finishing the battle properly.”

Was it like that again?

Something like this happened when we ran into Bellevagorah before.

Whether it was dealing with junk mobs or breaking down walls, she was actually helping me so much that I couldn’t do what I needed to do without her.

However, she was having a difficult time because she couldn’t stand up to the really powerful ones.

I said nothing about that, but her naïve personality was really...

It’s annoying.

But, it was also cute.

Compared to the first Asher, who seemed like I was facing a wall, this was a great improvement.

Didn't the fact that she bring up such a story and have a conversation with me meant that her trust in me became deeper?

I was choosing what to say and then opened my mouth.

"I said that when I first met you, that I knew about your abilities."

"Yes."

"But it was more like talking about your potential, not your current abilities. I know your current limitations. I know what you can do and what you can't."

I continued talking to Asher, who was listening.

"The snake in the Rutus Mountains and the golem you met in the dungeon were all opponents you couldn't handle, even with all your might. That's why I've never been disappointed in you yet. Do you understand?"

"..."

"Of course, it was a mistake to miss the orc."

She seemed to chew on what I said, then bowed her head.

I looked out the window again and watched the passing scenery.

Chapter 24.2: Tair Bamon (1)

Chapter 24.2: Tair Bamon (1)

After quite a while, we arrived at Wilpeck, a city in the southeast of the Fifth Lord's territory.

We were driving along the boulevard in the carriage when something suddenly came into my mind.

Come to think of it, was that restaurant here in this city?

When I played the game, there was a very famous restaurant in the city of Wilpeck. Was the name of the restaurant, Gold Chicken?

There was also a sub-quests in the game to get ingredients for a chef who was struggling with a new menu.

More than anything, the reason this restaurant remained in my memory was because, as the name suggested, it was a restaurant that sold chicken.

In terms of the concept of this medieval fantasy world, the dish called fried chicken was quite unfamiliar and hard to find.

Shall we stop by?

After lodging in the city's luxurious inn, I said to Baros.

“Find out if there is a restaurant called Gold Chicken in this city.”

It was five years ago, so maybe it hadn't opened yet.

However, Baros, who returned shortly after, brought the news that the restaurant existed.

“This restaurant opened a while ago and is gradually becoming famous in the city. It is said that they mainly sell fried chicken dishes.”

We had dinner there and immediately left the inn.

When we arrived at the restaurant and went inside, quite a few people were eating. It had a moderately noisy atmosphere.

An employee walking around the hall saw us and greeted us brightly.

“Welcome! Are the three of you here for a meal?”

The employee guided me to a seat by the window, and I sat down first, with Asher and Baros sitting across from me.

This kind of seating arrangement was awkward at first to Baros, but he got used to it.

When I ate at the inn in the city that I first arrived after leaving the territory, I was annoyed that Baros didn't dare to sit down to eat with me. He would just stand by and wait on me.

He was a great man, in charge of all the chores on this journey, but if there was one thing, it was that he was too loyal.

The waiter held out the menu and asked.

“How would you like to order? If you are not familiar with our restaurant, please let me explain...”

“No, that's fine. I'll order three chickens.”

“Yes, I understand. Cooking takes a little time, so please forgive me!”

This medieval world, especially in a big city like this, had a lot of weirdly modern corners mixed in, like this restaurant.

It was a game world created by modern people in the first place, so it was probably just natural.

What's not natural is my situation after entering this game world.

Asher was by nature silent, and since Baros was someone I couldn't have a comfortable conversation with, I thought for a while, waiting for our food.

Why did I come into this world?

I had not yet found the answer.

Come to think of it, a god actually existed in this world.

The only god in the world of RaSa who gave the holy sword to the hero of Santea.

Maybe, that god could tell me why this happened?

“...”

Whatever it was, survival was the most important thing right now, so it was just a futile idea.

If I continued to survive, I could meet the hero someday. That was something to think about.

I leaned back in my chair, feeling a bit of a relief.

Then the door opened and two customers came in.

A luxuriously dressed woman who seemed to be the daughter of a certain family and her escort knight. But when she looked around the restaurant and frowned, she shouted in a clear voice.

“Manager! Are you not accepting guests soon?!”

It surprised the manager inside to see her face, and he hurried over.

“Welcome, Lady Denbri. It’s an honor to have you visit our store.”

“Tsk, dirty and sluggish.”

The woman looked around her.

“These days, this restaurant’s cuisine is so famous, so I came to taste it myself while out on an outing, but the inside is dirty and unfashionable.”

“Haha... I’m sorry. It’s still not enough to welcome the noble young lady.”

“What are you talking about? Quickly, guide me to the best seat.”

...Who was that idiot?

As I watched the scene, the atmosphere inside the store suddenly became quiet.

All the other guests were paying attention to her. She must have been quite a celebrity in this city. Lady Denbri?

Could she be the mayor’s daughter?

Chapter 24.3: Tair Bamon (1)

Chapter 24.3: Tair Bamon (1)

Calderic did not have an aristocratic class like Santea, a typical monarchy.

It was a structure of absolute centralization in which they concentrated all the power around the Lords. The presence of an aristocratic class to keep them in check was meaningless.

However, there were mayors or commanders who managed cities or fortresses in certain areas. Like the aristocrats of Santea, they form families and inherit positions.

Although there was no formal aristocratic class, in reality they could be called the nobles of Calderic.

“Then I’ll serve the dish as soon as you ordered.”

The woman in her seat looked around her once again.

She patted the fan she was holding in her hand with a sneer as she watched the other guests hurriedly lowered their eyes.

Looking at the superiority on her face, she seemed to openly enjoy such reactions.

What an ugly woman.

That’s what I thought, and I soon turned my attention away from her.

It was enough to quietly taste the chicken in another world and go out without paying attention to that woman.

Clink!

While I was waiting for the food, I ordered to come out, there was a commotion again.

This time, too, that woman was the source.

“I’m sorry!”

The waiter who was serving drinks had dropped his glass.

And, of course, it dropped near the woman.

She looked down at the hem of her dress to see if the drink had splattered on it.

Then, her expression soon became distorted with irritation and anger, and she jumped up from her seat and violently slapped the apologetic employee in the face.

“Ouch...!”

“Is this fucking bitch crazy? How dare you dirty my dress?!”

As if one cheek did not satisfy her, she grabbed him by the hair and knocked him down, and trampled him with her feet without mercy.

There was no one to stop it. The manager, who came out because of the commotion, just watched with a restless expression.

“...”

I was watching the scene, thinking that the woman was the real crazy bitch in this scenario. Then I saw the expression of Asher sitting in the seat in front of me, getting more and more hardened.

Basically good-natured, she was a character who could hardly overlook this kind of injustice.

It was the same for me. This one-sided violence was an eyesore.

I told her.

“I told you before, express your thoughts and opinions.”

Asher flinched and turned around.

Then she immediately nodded her head and opened her mouth.

“Can I help that employee?”

“Do whatever you want.”

It was when Asher was about to get up from her seat at my answer...

“Hey, young lady.”

A voice came from somewhere else.

It was a young man sitting in a corner seat.

As he approached the woman, he sneaked in front of the fallen employee and smiled servilely.

“I’m sorry for daring to intervene, but if you forgive him, this employee will be impressed by your generosity. So...”

“What are you? Aren’t you going to get lost?”

The woman pushed the man away and picked up a glass bottle that was on the table. With that, she seemed to want to hit the waiter on the head.

The man was startled and quickly grabbed her arm.

Teouk.

The escort knight standing next to her also grabbed the man’s arm.

I could see how hard the other had squeezed his arm as his face contorted in pain.

“...Huh?”

The woman staring in amazement at the hand that gripped her own wrist. She soon shifted her cold gaze to the man.

“Did you hold my arm? You dare?”

“I, I will remove it at once...”

“Gerold, cut off his wrists.”

The man’s expression hardened.

The knight, without hesitation, brought his hand to the hilt of his sword, as if he were really about to carry out the order.

That was the moment.

Bang!

Asher approached the knight and grabbed his arm.

The knight whose arm she grabbed looked back at Asher, frowning at her.

He then seemed to give strength as if to shake it off... but nothing happened.

When his arm didn’t budge at all, the knight looked puzzled.

“What is this again? Do these lowly things keep interrupting me as if they’re crazy?”

“...”

“What are you doing, Gerold! Cut this crazy bitch down!”

However, the knight's arm was still immovable.

Seeing his face completely red from the rush of blood, she seemed to be taken aback as if she had grasped the situation as well. Then she turned her gaze to look in my direction.

“Hey, black hair over there! This is your escort! Don't stop quickly?! Do you know who I am?!”

...Did she just call me black hair?

I couldn't even laugh because it was ridiculous, but Baros' expression became rather stern.

“You dare...”

He would summon his spirits and attack at any moment, so I gestured for him to stay still and opened my mouth.

“You're vulgar.”

“..... What? What?”

“It's so vulgar to see you run amok like a colt with her tail on fire. Stop making a fuss and get lost.”

Only then did Asher let go of the arm she's holding. The knight took his arm and stepped behind the woman.

The woman glared at me to death, and she screamed.

“Kill! Don't stay still like an idiot. Kill him right now!”

The knight hesitated, then reached his hand for the hilt of his sword.

I told Asher.

“If he draws his sword, cut them both.”

Translator: I'm translating another novel here. If you like age progression story related to acting, please check out **From a Child Actor to a World Star.** ^^

Chapter 25.1: Tair Bamon (2)

Chapter 25.1: Tair Bamon (2)

At my words, the knight's movements stopped.

He glanced at Asher and me with an expression that looked like he would break out in a cold sweat at any moment, then glanced at the woman again.

“What are you doing?! That bastard called me vulgar! Kill him quickly!”

Shouting loudly, she seemed to have finally lost her mind. It looked like a child throwing a tantrum.

It's annoying, really.

I said;

“If it sounds like empty words, pull out your sword. Or take that noisy thing and go away.”

The knight glared at me, then finally removed his hand from the hilt of his sword.

He seemed to have realized the difference in his skills after directly competing with Asher.

Instead, he opened his mouth and spoke in a menacing voice.

“I don't know who the young master is, but he's making a big mistake. She's the daughter of the mayor of this city...”

I didn't reply, but waved my hand at Asher.

As she brought her hand to the hilt of her sword, the knight fell silent and shut his mouth.

“This...!”

The woman, who was upset at the sight, trembled as if she couldn't overcome her anger, and she slapped the knight on the cheek.

The knight just silently let her hit him as she slapped his face several times.

The woman who had taken her anger out like that turned her gaze back and glared at me ferociously.

“You're really going to kill me. Do you know who my father is? He's the mayor of this city. This whole city belongs to my family.”

“...”

“I'll make sure you pay the price for fooling around with that lowly tongue. You'll never be able to walk on two legs again without crawling between my legs and begging.”

Then she turned around and strode out of the store.

Her escort knight also chased her out, and the restaurant fell silent. All eyes were focused on this direction.

Ha...

That's really great.

Admiring how the other could be that big of an idiot, I looked at the place where she had disappeared.

Baros also looked at the door from which she came out with his cold, sunken eyes, and spoke cautiously to me.

“Just give me a word and I'll meet the mayor of this city in person. That cheeky bitch...”

“Don’t trouble yourself.”

This was not my territory, so I didn’t want to make a fuss.

It could reveal my whereabouts to the other Lords, and if that happened, someone might unnecessarily take an interest in me.

But since it happened like this, could I do anything?

I knew from the moment I intervened, things would get annoying.

Thinking of seeing the face of the mayor who raised that great idiot tomorrow, I soon turned off my nerves.

“Are you okay?”

Asher raised the fallen employee.

The manager and other employees who had been watching approached them with belatedly apologetic faces.

She handed them over to them, and Asher returned to her seat and sat down with her head bowed shyly.

The man who had been standing awkwardly came this way.

He was the man who was threatened by that crazy woman, having his wrist cut off and all. Which didn’t happen because Asher intervened.

“Hey, thank you. Young master has helped me to survive. I almost lived as a disabled for the rest of my life.”

I nodded my head as I saw him conveying his thanks with a smile on his face.

Judging by his attire, he was a man who looked like an ordinary traveler.

Still, he was the only one among those who watched the mad woman’s atrocities and tried to stop it, so his personality seemed pretty good. I was

not blaming those who didn't step up since it's understandable if they couldn't.

...?

But wait a minute...

Having felt something familiar, I inspected the man's face.

It's the same feeling as when I first found Asher.

When I stared at him, the man also looked at me with puzzled eyes.

I asked him.

“What's your name?”

“Yes?”

He seemed taken aback for a moment, but then responded with a laugh again.

“My name is Lian, young master.”

Lian.

Only then did an NPC character appear in my memory.

A blond, green-eyed young man with the same appearance as the one in front of me.

Hah...

Surprised inwardly but also feeling awed at this bizarre coincidence, I repeated his name in my mind.

Not the pseudonym he just mentioned, but the real name he's hiding.

Tair Bamon.

The youngest prince of the neutral country, Earth Hill.

He was not to the extent of being the main character in the world of RaSa, but he was a person who could be said to be the main character among the supporting actors.

The episode of Earth Hill's Neutral Country related to him was one of my favorite main stories in the game.

Yes, since it was five years ago, he had not yet returned to the kingdom and was wandering around Calderic...

"I... the dish is ready."

The waiter came to the table holding the finished dish.

The fried chicken pieces that looked appetizing came out in a basket full of them.

I stared at the chicken, then at the table where Lian was sitting, then back to him.

And I asked

"This is also a fate. Shall we dine together?"

"...Yes?"

What kind of nonsense is this? – That was probably the guy was thinking as his eyes widened.

Asher and Barros, who were sitting in the seats in front of me, also looked at me with curious eyes, probably curious why I was doing this.

But this was a good opportunity

I wanted to have a conversation with him.

It was because I thought that there might be something to be gained from this relationship that happened by chance.

Chapter 25.2: Tair Bamon (2)

Chapter 25.2: Tair Bamon (2) Bonus chapter! Thank you to LKMKACHA for the donation! ^^

The Canes family was a family with a long history in the Fifth Lord's territory, holding the post of mayor of Wilpeck for the ninth generation.

Colton Canes, the mayor, was having a little late dinner with a distinguished guest who had visited the mansion after a long absence.

“So, there are rumors that the Seventh Lord who was crowned this time immediately crushed one of the merchant corps...”

When Colton hinted, the middle-aged guest nodded and said;

“It looks like the owner of the workshop the merchant group was trying to control had something to do with the Lord. I don't know the details. Whatever it was, the Lord completely captured the merchant group.”

“...That's worrisome. What kind of person do you think the Seventh Lord is? I've heard that you're an outsider.”

“How can I know that I'm just an administrator? I know nothing more than you.”

He was Laika, an administrator belonging to the Seventh Lord's castle, who stopped by here for a while on business.

Also, as you can see, he was also a close friend that a personal acquaintance with Mayor Colton.

“He did nothing other than what he did to the merchant corps. From what I heard, he was looking at a map all day until I left the castle.”

“Huh? A map, why...”

“The atmosphere on the side of Santea and the neutral countries has been unusual lately, so it may have something to do with it. I’m already saying too much by mentioning this, so don’t ask too much.”

Even if they were the only ones here, they still couldn’t talk lightly about a Lord.

The two soon turned to other topics.

Then there was a commotion at the entrance of the dining room.

Colton tilted his head at the sight of his daughter strutting into the dining room.

“You came back early, my dear. You said you would visit the night market, but the sun hasn’t even set yet.”

His youngest daughter, who was born to his late wife, was a precious treasure to him.

Her daughter, Denbri, greeted Laika first.

“I’m sorry for interrupting your meal.”

Laika nodded his head. He was a little offended, to be honest, but it was okay because he knew Colton cared so much for his youngest daughter.

She said to Colton.

“Do you know what insult I just went through out there, Father?”

“...?”

“A lowly person who doesn’t even know the subject dared to tell me I was vulgar! This idiot couldn’t even pull out his sword and just watched!”

Colton hardened his expression and wiped his mouth with a napkin.

Laika also paid attention to the story with an excited expression on his face.

It was a fact that no one in the city did not know that Lady Denbri was an unreasonable scumbag. But did she come back after being humiliated by someone?

“Tell me what happened.”

To that, Denbri explained what had happened at the restaurant.

The employee who spilled a drink on her dress, the escort knight, intervening while she was educating the employee, and even the verbal abuse from the knight’s owner.

As her explanation continued, Laika looked at her with a slightly bewildered eyes.

It dumbfounded him. She would so proudly say that she had committed such atrocious violence for such a small thing.

Colton’s expression was more serious.

What mattered to him was the insult she suffered, not her behavior.

“Do you know who that bastard is?”

“I don’t know. He must be from a filthy family.”

“Hmm...”

“I’m so humiliated that I’m going to die, Father. I can’t live without him beating his head to the floor and apologising.”

Colton asked Gerold, the escort knight, standing next to her.

“How was that knight’s skill? Be honest.”

“...She was much stronger than me. I’m sorry.”

He bowed his head as if he was sorry.

Colton sighed and stroked his chin.

Gerold was a knight with sufficiently excellent skills. That’s why he was given as an escort for his youngest daughter.

If the man involved was being escorted by a much better knight than him, he would, of course, not be an ordinary person.

Maybe not nobles from neighboring family, but nobles from another Lord’s territory or some distant city?

“Okay. Wait.”

Denbri’s expression brightened at Colton’s words.

He didn’t know which family he came from, but at least in this city, Colton was like a king.

But did that man dare to insult her daughter and even order her to be cut down?

“What are you thinking?”

“Whatever it may be, I have to bring that man here.”

Colton gave a simple answer to Laika’s question.

He was thinking of bringing them to the mansion and seeing his face to find out which family he belonged to.

And if it’s someone who belonged to a high family, he would suggest to solve things gently, otherwise I would make him pay for his actions.

“How do they look?”

“The man had black hair and the escort knight was a white-haired woman.”

Colton immediately called the knights and ordered them to find the two people and bring them to him.

Meanwhile, Laika, who was listening from the side, tilted his head.

A black-haired man and a white-haired female knight? Why was that...

What nonsense am I thinking?

Immediately dismissing it as an absurd imagination, he burst out laughing. I thought it was a pretty strange coincidence.

It made little sense. Why would the Seventh Lord, who should be in his territory, suddenly be here in the Fifth Lord's territory?

In any case, Laika thought he had a pretty interesting spectacle to watch, and waited for the knights to come and bring the fearless ones.

Chapter 26.1: Tair Bamon (3)

Chapter 26.1: Tair Bamon (3) Thank you to Gigachad Reader for sponsoring 10 chapters! ^^

“Then let’s eat!”

Lian licked his lips and looked at the chicken in front of him.

When I said that I would pay for the meal, he took a seat and sat down without the slightest hesitation.

“I was curious about the fried chicken dish, so I wanted to try it, but it was too expensive, so I was about to order something else, haha. Thanks to the young master, I’m now able to eat this.”

As he picked up a chicken leg with his hand and brought it to the plate in front of him, the expressions on Asher’s and Baros’ faces changed.

Originally, it’s okay to pick it up with your hands...

I wanted to eat comfortably, but I had to use a fork because it’s a matter of dignity.

As I took one leg, the other two also took their share.

Asher, who was unfamiliar with the food, did not dare to put it in her mouth and just stared at the part of the thigh that she had taken, and then she cut off the tip with a knife and ate it.

She then looked a little startled and started eating faster and faster. It seemed to suit her taste.

It tastes good.

It was chicken with its own unique taste different from the familiar taste.

How could a dish with fried meat not taste good?

As we ate in silence for a while, the manager served drinks we didn't even order.

"Thank you so much for helping the waiter. I won't charge you for the food, so please enjoy it."

After saying that, he looked at me with a worried look and continued talking.

"Hey, young master. Lady Denbri, whom you had a quarrel with earlier..."

"It's okay, just go to work."

He seemed to try to warn me about that idiot.

The manager backed away hesitantly, and Lian, who had chicken bones piled up on the plate in front of him, asked me.

"But would you really be all right with young master? If her father is the mayor, wouldn't he be like the king of this city?"

"If you knew that, why did you try to help the waiter?"

"Well... no matter the situation is, I can't just watch people being beaten like that. And to be honest, I didn't even know if that woman was the mayor's daughter. I'm not from this city."

"Wouldn't you help if you knew?"

"No, I would still have stepped out and help. Of course, I didn't expect my hand to be cut off, haha."

He laughed and talked, as if he was talking about someone else and not himself.

As one could see, this man had such an optimistic personality.

Even in the game, he smiled like this until right before he met his end.

“But she seemed to be a, well, weird woman. I know this is off-topic, but it might be better for you to leave the city as soon as possible, young master...”

I turned the topic to something else.

“Looking at your behavior, you seem to be a wanderer.”

“Ah, yes. I’m wandering around Calderic right now.”

“Why?”

“If you ask me why... What is the reason for the wandering of a traveler?

A smile hung on his lips, but somehow it sounded a little empty.

Because I knew what his situation was now.

Even if he went back, anyone would not welcome him, and he couldn’t bear to completely sever his kinship with his family.

Of course, what I was paying attention to right now was not his background, but something else.

The reason I was holding onto him and having a conversation was because there was something I wanted to confirm.

[Hmm? How did I spot the enemy ambush when there was no sign? Haha, because I have a good sense.]

[Okay, you’ve helped me a lot, so I’ll let you know in particular. Don’t tell anyone, please keep it a secret. In fact, I have a mystery.]

In the Earth Hill Kingdom episode, during the war with the enemy, this was the line that Lian, or Tair Bamon, gave to the player.

It's not exact, but I remembered him saying something like this.

He was an extremely rare mystery user on this continent.

He meant that there was a mystery that he held like me.

He said, 'I don't know what its name was. It was a mystery that amplified my senses and reflexes.'

Thanks to his mystical abilities, he was never caught or ambushed by the enemy during the war.

He also defeated enemy generals much stronger than himself, even with his not-so-great physical abilities.

There was one thing I wanted to check

Was this the point before or after he gained the mystery?

[How did I get the mystery? That was just a coincidence.]

[There was a time when I was wandering around the continent until a few years ago. I also worked as an adventurer, and I also explored uninhabited areas.]

[Somehow, at an antique store, a torn map was touted as a treasure map. It was a map showing the location of a dungeon. And that's where I got mysteries.]

As I recalled, he said he got a mystery from a dungeon marked on the map.

He roughly mentioned the location in the dialogue, but unfortunately I couldn't remember that far.

Chapter 26.2: Tair Bamon (3)

Chapter 26.2: Tair Bamon (3)

What if this was before he got the mystery?

Then I, too, had a chance to obtain that mystery.

A mystery that amplifies your senses and reflexes.

That was a very useful skill for me.

In the past, it would have been useless since my body wouldn't follow me at all, but now I had the floating tent.

Now that I had a means to counter the opponent's attack, the senses and reflexes to use it swiftly were also important.

...Come to think of it, it's a really necessary skill.

It was the same even when he thought about the time the Orc King attacked me before.

Even though the distance was quite far, the Orc King's was right in front of my nose in the blink of an eye.

Had I been a little late in opening the veil, one of its heavy fists would have shattered my body.

It's only level 70, but what about the monsters that are much higher than that? What about the other Lords?

If they attacked me with hostility, I would die before I could even open the veil in response, unless I was far away.

Or there was a risk of being ambushed or sniped by an opponent who was hiding somewhere or was very far away.

What's the use of an absolute defense if my throat was cut before I could even use it?

There must have been a huge gap between the speed of the superhumans of this world and my cognitive ability.

Of course, I was excited because I didn't know whether Lian had obtained a mystery yet.

I couldn't ask that outright, so I implied using another question.

"If you've been wandering around the continent, have you ever found something like a dungeon? Or a place where ruins are hidden."

"You mean dungeons or ruins. I've been looking for them, but unfortunately I haven't found one yet. Ah, I just remembered a story..."

Then, with an expression as if thinking of something, Lian took something out of his bosom.

An old-looking parchment that was rolled up.

He said with a laugh.

"This is the map I bought at the antique shop I stopped by in the city before, but the owner said it might be a treasure map pointing to where the ruins are hidden."

"...!"

I hid my surprise and looked at the map. No way?

It was to the point where I wondered if there was such a coincidence in such a perfect situation.

“It’s absurd. I tried to open it for no reason, but tore it up a little, so I was forced to buy it for a few silver coins. But since I bought it, I thought I’d visit it as it was on the map, so I was heading there.”

“Can I look?”

“As much as you like.”

Lian obediently handed me the parchment and turned his attention back to the chicken.

I slowly unfolded it and examined it.

A map so crude and sloppy that I couldn’t believe that the contents were real.

The location showed by the map was a place between the Fifth and Fourth Lords’ territories, but there was a strange code-like character written on it.

...Is this really true?

No matter how I looked at it, it looked like scribbled garbage..

After examining the map, I turned my attention back to Lian.

Anyway, if this was a map that would lead me to the place where the real mystery was hidden, as I remembered, and if I get that mystery.

It did not differ from swallowing the mystery he would have gained in the future.

“I will buy this map again. Do you intend to sell it?”

“...Yes?”

Lian looked at me in surprise.

Then he immediately clapped his hand and said.

“Sheesh, no. If you’re interested, just take it. I’ve also received favors from the young master.”

“...Don’t you think this could be a map where a real ancient artifact is hidden?”

“Then there’s nothing special. If you really find even an ancient magic artifact, young master, please use it favorably, haha.”

He didn’t even seem to think that this was really a treasure map.

...Even so, my conscience stings a little to be honest.

But I couldn’t be arguing about that right now.

If I was going to feel guilty every time something like this happened in the first place, I would not be able to properly use the knowledge of the future.

After I got the map and we finished our meal, we said goodbye to him in front of the store.

“Then thank you, young master. I’ll go first.”

I turned my body and looked at his back as he moved his steps, and I fell into trouble for a moment.

Could we just end this meeting like this?

The future war between neutral countries was an event that had a significant impact on the power structure of Calderic and Santea.

There’s nothing I could do about it by meddling in it right now. In the first place, I had my own problems to deal with, so I didn’t have time to care...

“...”

Chapter 26.3: Tair Bamon (3)

Chapter 26.3: Tair Bamon (3)

I finally opened my mouth.

Anyway, from the moment I possessed a character in this game and from the moment I became a Lord of Calderic, disorder about the future continued to pile up.

So I didn't have to be bound by the game's story. In the end, the decision was mine.

“Tair Bamon.”

At my words, Lian's steps halted.

He slowly turned his head and looked at me with very bewildered eyes.

“You can solve nothing by running away forever. It would be better to return to the kingdom as soon as possible.”

“...Wait a minute, how do you—“

“I am Ron, the Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

The sudden revelation startled Asher and Baros, who were next to and turned to me.

Lian or Tair's expressions changed variously, as if he didn't understand what I was saying, and finally asked back.

“What did you just say...?”

“You know that the situation between neutral countries is unusual. Go back to where you belong before it’s too late.”

“...”

“And if you really feel you can’t handle it, send a messenger to the Seventh Lord’s castle. Depending on the situation, maybe I can help Earth Hill.”

I left only those words and turned away from him, who stood there in a daze.

Asher and Baros followed me.

I don’t know if that guy will return to the kingdom right away with just this...

The minimum link was made, so the rest was up to his choice.

Back at the inn, I looked at the map again.

The location was in the forest area between the Fifth and Fourth Lords, so the path was not twisted.

It will take a long time to find this too...

It was nice to have one more mystery to get, but I felt tired already when I thought the hardships would increase much more.

I was about to lie down on the bed, but there was a commotion outside.

Knock knock.

Soon, a knock rang.

“Come in.”

Carefully opening the door, Baros glanced outside with a firm expression.

“The mayor’s knights came to the inn.”

At those words, I immediately understood the situation.

The sound of coming up the stairs echoed, and a series of knights appeared behind them. Asher blocked their way.

The knight standing at the forefront looked at Asher with a frown, then shifted his gaze to me and said.

“Is that the person who insulted Miss Denbri?”

“...”

“Looks like it’s right. The mayor has given the order to bring young master. Please, I hope you will follow obediently.”

I immediately grasped the situation and let out a blank laugh.

I was going to go there when the day was bright, but they found me right away like this.

“Guide me.”

Let’s see how far they would go.

I said that and shook my head.

“They say they are in the mansion’s hall right now, Mayor.”

“I get it.”

The attendant reported bringing in a thug who insulted his daughter. Colton nodded his head.

Denbri, who was sitting next to him, was also excited and jumped up from her seat.

At that sight, Administrator Laika clicked his tongue inwardly and turned to Colton.

“Can I come and see him too?”

“Do whatever you like.”

As he moved to the hall of the mansion, he saw three people standing in the middle.

Denbri spotted the man standing in the middle and raised her eyebrows.

The man also spotted her and met her eyes.

She said with a wicked grin.

“Did we just meet again? I said you’d pay the price, did I?”

Colton was about to open his mouth as he looked around at the man and the two people standing on either side of him.

“You insulted my daughter...”

He turned his head when he heard a sudden gasp next to him.

Laika was looking at them with an expression as if he had seen a ghost. He shuddered all over his body as if he had suddenly caught a chill.

Then he soon fell on his knees and bowed his head.

“I meet the Seventh Lord!”

...What?

Colton stopped thinking for a moment because he didn’t understand what he just heard.

Denbri, who was happily contemplating what kind of hell to show that damn guy, also made a stupid face.

“...Lord?”

A terrible silence fell in the hall.

The elf frowned and looked at Laika, who had his head bowed to the floor, then spoke cautiously to the man.

“This is Laika, the Administrator of the Seventh Lord’s Castle. It seems that he was on a business trip to this city.”

The man, the Seventh Lord, nodded and went over to one chair in the hall and sat down.

“You must have called me because you had something to say.”

He glanced over at Colton and the others, who stood still.

“Since you have summoned me like this, let’s hear what you want to say.”

Chapter 27.1: Super Sensory (1)

Chapter 27.1: Super Sensory (1)

His mind turned white.

Colton tried to understand this baffling situation.

Laika was lying face down with his head bowed on the floor beside him, motionless.

What the hell did he just say?

Lord?

Who the hell was that guy?

He wanted to believe that he had heard it wrong, but the situation unfolding in front of him clearly denied it.

The Seventh Lord sat in a chair, crossed his legs, and looked around at the people in the hall.

The knights who had brought him and stood proudly were also frozen and unable to breathe.

In time, Colton also gradually became contemplative.

In the suffocating silence, it didn't take long for him to come to terms with what he had done.

The new owner of the seat of the Seventh Lord, who had been talked about all over Calderic recently.

...The Seventh Lord was the man in front of him.

Baros carefully looked at the Seventh Lord and asked.

“By the way, why are you here with the mayor of Wilpeck, administrator?”

It was a tone full of pressure, as if he wanted Laika to prove his innocence.

If you couldn't do that, it wouldn't be strange if your neck fell off right here.

Laika felt fear and dread creeping through his body, swallowed his saliva in one gulp, and stuttered his mouth open.

“I was visiting the cities of the Fifth Lord one after the other for a related administrative matter. The reason I stayed with the mayor was because I had a personal relationship with him... He said he would bring those who insulted his daughter back to the mansion to resolve the situation. I followed him out of curiosity to observe. I never dared to imagine that you would be in this city. I am sorry.”

In fact, Laika felt really unfair. The situation was equally confusing.

For him, who was enjoying a brief retreat in Wilpeck, the situation came as a whirlwind. No, it wasn't even a lightning bolt; it was a disaster.

It was only because he knew the face of the Seventh Lord that he could act quickly with his survival instinct as soon as he saw them.

How could he have imagined that the Seventh Lord had left his territory and were in this city out of nowhere, and that he was the one who had a quarrel with the daughter of the mayor?

Of course, he couldn't ask the Seventh Lord, so there was only one thing Laika could do. He prostrated himself so that sparks would not fly to him.

Baros said, frowning.

“Anyway, didn't you just watch the situation and try to enjoy it as a game?”

“That, that’s...”

Cold sweat broke out on Laika’s back.

“No... is this... uh...?”

Meanwhile, Denbri, who was still muttering with a puzzled expression, turned to Colton.

Baros’ gaze turned to those two this time.

Because the Lord had decided to just mercifully do nothing, he had no choice but to watch that stupid girl walked away scathe free from the restaurant.

But she even dared to call the knights to this place even though the Lord had already given her one leniency?

“Mayor, will you continue to stand like that?”

Colton, who suddenly came to his senses, grabbed Denbri by the shoulders and knelt on the floor.

The biggest crisis came to the mayor’s life, which had suffered little for over 20 years.

Denbri, who was forced to kneel with him, reflexively frowned. She had never been on her knees since she was born.

She was completely taken aback, and when she saw Colton’s expression, she shut her mouth.

“My apologies... Seventh Lord.”

The Seventh Lord tilted his head to the side.

“I thought you called me here to tell me something, but what are you doing on your knees?”

“I’m sorry. I dared not know the great One and committed great disrespect.”

“Tsk.”

The voice of the Seventh Lord grew even colder.

“I told you to tell me why you called me. Are you going to keep doing that like a parrot?”

Colton bit his lip hard.

What could he say? Could he say that he was going to make the arrogant guy who dared to scorn her daughter pay for his crimes?

The other already knew everything, but the Lord was making him spit it out of his mouth himself.

Dead.

He’s really dead.

The family could perish right here and now. Even if the Seventh Lord tried to do so, no one could stop him.

What about the Fifth Lord when she heard about this later? Would she be furious that he had wreaked havoc in her territory and killed the mayor?

No, even if she heard the circumstances, she wouldn’t care.

In Calderic, a Lord was such a being.

No one but the same Lord dared to look at them at eye level, and if you tried to climb, they would trample you to death like an insect, no matter how high of a position you might hold.

Colton slammed his head on the floor instead of answering. Not just once, but repeatedly.

“I have committed a mortal sin!”

Bang bang!

Looking at Colton, who was constantly banging his head with his forehead shattered and blood flowing from it, Denbri, who was next to him, shuddered.

It was because it was only then that she realized the seriousness of the situation when she saw her father, who did not differ from an emperor in Wilpeck, act like this.

No matter how much she lived like no one could stop her, she knew what the status of a Lord meant in Calderic.

“Mayor, please stop. You dare in front of the Lord...”

Baros narrowed his eyes. He immediately cut off the mayor’s words and stepped back.

“Mayor.”

“...”

“This is the third time. Explain why you called me here.”

Chapter 27.2: Super Sensory (1)

Chapter 27.2: Super Sensory (1)

As if this was their last chance, the voice of the Seventh Lord was both indifferent and scary.

Only then did Colton realize.

He knew that no matter what he did, he couldn't get any sympathy from this monster. The best thing to do was just do what he was told, and pray that he would die a comfortable death.

“...I heard that someone had insulted my daughter, so I intended to bring him back here and make him pay for it.”

The Seventh Lord said.

“Did you get all the details on why that happened?”

“...Yes.”

“Tell me.”

“A waiter spilled a drink on my daughter's dress, so while my daughter was educating the waiter...”

“Education. Is that what it's called when you wield violence so ruthlessly over something like a stain on your clothes?”

“...”

“She even tried to slit the wrists of the person who stopped her. If that’s education, then what do you think is appropriate education for me in this situation? Here, the mayor of a border city ordered his knights to bring the Lord to him by force.”

Colton flinched.

The eyes of the Seventh Lord turned to Denbri.

“Did you say that you would make me unable to walk on my two legs without me crawling between yours?”

The complexion of Colton and Laika, who were lying down, became more swarthy. Did you even say such a thing?

Denbri couldn’t hold back the fear and said with tears dripping down her face.

“Now, I made a mistake. Lord. Help me. Help me...”

The Seventh Lord shook his head.

“I was planning to just let you off since I didn’t want to make a fuss in another Lord’s territory.”

“We’ve committed a mortal sin...”

“I still have the same thoughts. I’m too lazy to make a fuss over such a ridiculous thing.”

However, at the words that followed, Colton’s face turned pale.

“Since it happened in her territory, the Fifth Lord will take care of it later.”

...That too was tantamount to a death sentence.

What would happen if this news reached the ears of the Fifth Lord?

It didn't matter what the relationship between the Seventh Lord and the Fifth Lord was.

It was unacceptable that the likes of a mayor dared to insult a Lord in the slightest.

Even if the Seventh Lord didn't use his hands right away, it was a predetermined future that the Fifth Lord would directly punish them herself.

The Seventh Lord rose from his seat.

As if everything he had to say was finished, he turned to the entrance of the hall.

When Baros glanced around, the knights standing around him hurriedly knelt one by one.

The Seventh Lords stopped walking for a moment and looked back.

“If you've lived trampling on others with such unreasonable power, you should have been prepared to be trampled on like this someday, don't you think?”

There was nothing Colton could answer to the words of the Seventh Lords.

The figures of the Seventh Lords and his two attendants slowly moved away from the hall toward the exit.

By leaving the mansion, I completely turned my attention away from the mayor.

I had no intention of punishing them or anything like that in the first place.

It's not that I was showing mercy, it's just that I felt embarrassed to have my hands stained with blood for something like this.

And anyway, even if I did nothing, if this incident reached the ears of the Fifth Lord, the mayor and Denbri would... whatever it was, it would be a terrible end.

“Hmm...”

It was late at night.

Returning to the inn, I looked at the map I received from Tair again.

Also, I compared and matched the map with the map of the Fifth Lord's territory to identify the location of the map in more detail. With the help of Baros, of course.

“There's a forest on the northwestern border of the Fifth and Fourth Lords. That seems to be the point marked on this map.”

A slight detour from the path, but it didn't matter as long as the mystery could be obtained.

I stroked my chin and looked back at Tair's map.

But what is this letter?

Unknown strange characters written on one side of the map. Was it a password?

This also seemed to have something to do with the destination, but I couldn't figure out what it meant.

Oh, Tair could have known, so he should have asked. I was so distracted by the map that I couldn't even pay attention.

As I stared at the text, Baros spoke again.

“The forest, the greatest tree, when even the twilight completely subsides, it is written that lifeless branches will guide adventurers.”

“...?!”

I looked back at him in amazement.

“Can you read this?”

“Yes. One of the ancient cipher characters.”

I looked at him with eyes asking how he knew that, and the answer came back.

“I know a little about ancient letters because I was interested in exploring ruins while working as an adventurer in the past.”

“...Right.”

There’s really nothing he couldn’t do.

The reason he was so good at Calderic’s geography was because he had such a past.

By the way... the biggest tree?

I pondered for a moment and tried to interpret the meaning of the sentence.

Was the ‘biggest tree’ pertaining to the biggest tree in the forest, and ‘when twilight has completely subsided’ meant night time?

But what was the last ‘lifeless branch’?

“Do you know what the ‘lifeless branch’ meant?”

“I’m sorry, but I don’t know...”

I asked Baros again, but he seemed to not know what it meant.

As I turned my gaze to Asher, she stood there a little dazed, pretending to think quickly, then shook her head.

...I’ll have to see for myself.

Then, the immediate goal was set.

Go to the forest marked on the map and find the biggest tree.

Chapter 28.1: Super Sensory (2)

Chapter 28.1: Super Sensory (2)

The day was bright and we left the city of Wilpeck.

To the nameless forest on the northwestern border of the Fifth and Fourth Lords' territories.

Is this a dungeon again?

I gazed at the scenery outside the window, lost in thought in the carriage.

This time, the place where the mystery was hidden was probably also a dungeon. Because Tair said so.

The difference between a ruin and a dungeon was whether there was a risk factor or not.

If there were only hidden treasures, it was a ruin, and if there were dangers such as guardians or traps, it was a dungeon. Just like when I was looking for the floating veil last time.

The dungeon I had to find this time was a place I had no information about, so the danger was unknown.

It's said that Tair accidentally broke through the dungeon and found the mystery, so it doesn't sound like a very dangerous dungeon...

Tair was only at level 20, so there was a high probability that the level of the dungeon was at that level.

Of course, it's just speculation, and in the end, nothing was certain unless I experienced it myself.

Aside from the risk, there was also the problem of deciphering the code and then finding the dungeon.

Time passed, and we arrived at Oron City, on the northwestern border of the Fifth Lord's territory.

This time we arrived quite early in the day, so we could grab a lodging and I went straight to the adventurer's guild to hire a guide.

If they described it as the biggest tree in the forest, it would mean that it was so big that it would stand out, so I wondered if there would be many people who knew about it.

Upon entering the guild building, the hall was buzzing with overflowing adventurers.

I looked around for a moment and then spoke in a slightly louder voice.

"I will hire the best guide who meets the conditions for 10 gold."

Pop.

Like a miracle, the noise stopped, and all eyes turned this way.

I wondered if everyone had heard it correctly, but I spoke again as they were making faces that seemed concerned.

"I'll hire a guide for 10 gold. Does anyone know of the biggest tree in the Northwest Border Forest?"

Every time I hired a guide; I ended up spending money.

Well, there was an abundance of money, and it's the most effective way, so what about it?

The adventurers seemed to look at each other, but soon words came out one by one.

“...Are you talking about the Mengrodi tree?”

“I think you’re right. What else could be the tallest tree in the Northwest Forest?”

Looking at the reactions, it was a famous tree that everyone knew about.

It was a good thing. At least I wouldn’t have a hard time finding the tree.

“...Hire me! I know very well where the Mengrodi tree is!”

Soon, an adventurer raised his hand and shouted.

Starting with him, other adventurers also intervened one by one.

“You’re fucking shit. How many adventurers in this city don’t know that place!”

“I’m much better than that guy! I can guide you to your destination quickly and safely!”

In an instant, even the employment auction hall became open, and I could see the staff at the counter perplexed.

I said a bit of my apologies to them. Did this cause too much of a fuss?

Just then, we heard a loud cry from above.

“Shut up everyone! You said you would hire the best adventurer!”

The mouths of the adventurers who were making a fuss shut their mouths all at once at the gruesome voice, like a beast roaring.

I looked upstairs.

At the same time, someone jumped off the railing and came down.

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A beastman woman with scars all over her bare skin, carrying several short swords around her waist.

“Sir, I’m the best here, so hire me.”

She strode towards me and said with a confident smile.

Among adventurers, talents over level 40 were quite rare. Was she a first-class adventurer?

“No, Railo... you can receive so many other requests. Isn’t it too much to take such a request?”

An adventurer raised a disgruntled voice.

But when the woman turned her gaze to him and glared at him, he instantly shook and withdrew.

“Well, you idiots. If you’re complaining, do you think your skills are better than mine? You’ll get 10 gold after guiding the road with those skills? Have you lost your conscience?”

There were no adventurers who expressed their dissatisfaction further. They either frowned or sighed and turned around as if they had given up.

It was harsh, but not wrong. All the commissions one received were proportional to their skills.

Turning her gaze back to me, she introduced herself with a slightly business-like smile.

She said, “I am Railo, a first-class adventurer. There is no adventurer more skilled than me in Oron City, so you will not regret hiring me.”

I nodded and took the money out of my pocket.

“Here’s half the down payment.”

Railo smiled when she was handed the five gold coins.

“When are you planning to leave?”

“If possible, right now.”

“Okay. Then let’s go right away.”

So I quickly hired a guide who seemed pretty good at her job.

Chapter 28.2: Super Sensory (2)

Chapter 28.2: Super Sensory (2)

Since the forest was quite far from the city, we travelled by carriage.

There was no problem since there was a trail.

“Hey, it looks ordinary, but isn’t this a very high-class carriage?”

Railo, who was sitting in the other seat, said.

In the seat next to her, Asher sat silently, as always.

Outwardly, Asher always looked expressionless, but as I kept looking at her, she had a slight difference from normal.

Now, I felt she was in a bad mood. It could be because she was annoyed by the noisy Railo.

“Oh, I made a lot of noise. I’m sorry.”

She soon calmed down and looked out the window, as if she had noticed Asher’s reaction.

She then asked me after a while.

“By the way, can you tell me why you are looking for the Mengrodi tree?”

Was she asking that now?

If she was going to check who the client was and what the purpose of the request was, it would have been normal to check before accepting the

request.

Or would she accept any request without hesitation, knowing that she would get caught up in something dangerous?

This adventurer named Railo seemed to have that much confidence in her own skills. Looking at the level, it was probably true.

I was going to just say whatever, but I changed my mind.

Come to think of it, was there any reason to hide it this time?

Maybe she could even help find the dungeon. Even if she tried to do something, Asher was here.

“Have you ever explored a dungeon?”

Railo answered my sudden question.

“A few times. Why do you ask that?”

“Going to the Mengrodi tree is to search for a dungeon.”

“Ah... was it like that?”

I nodded my head.

“Honestly, I had a rough idea. Most of the men who ask for directions to some unexpected places are looking for ruins.”

It seemed like she had taken on this type of request quite a few times.

I asked again.

“Is there a lifeless branch associated with the tree called Mengrodi?”

“...Lifeless branch? Well, I’ve never heard of such a thing.”

Railo tilted her head, but soon became interested.

“Is that a code related to the dungeon? Finding a dungeon with a code is a lot of fun.”

After saying that, she murmured the word lifeless branch, deep in thought, and then brushed her hair.

“Anyway, finding a dungeon makes work much more fun. After guiding you to the tree, can I continue to help you? Of course, I have no intention of accepting more commission money.”

“It doesn’t matter, but if we find a dungeon, I have no intention of letting you explore the inside.”

At that, Railo giggled.

“Please give me an extra pay based on how much you think I’ve been helpful. And to be honest, I expect little. Ninety-nine times out of a hundred, finding ruins is a waste. What do you think?”

That’s right.

I took things a little too easily, perhaps because I was consistently successful in finding mysteries.

Dungeon was actually not that easy to find.

After arriving in the forest, we got off the wagon and started moving.

Baros had to guard the wagon, so we left him it at the entrance of the forest and I went inside with Asher. Railo took the lead and guided the way.

“But isn’t it funny when you think about it?”

“...?”

“Isn’t it said that dungeons are legacy left by ancient mages? But then, they could just pass it on to their disciples and let them inherit it. Instead, they

made dungeons could kill trespassers who tried to get their treasures.”

Well, those dungeons could be made by mages who didn’t have disciples to succeed them.

Or maybe eccentric mages just made it out of boredom.

In the first place, it was just the setting of the game, so I never mulled over about it.

It’s enough to attach the background in moderation, and rather, it’s strange if there were no dungeons in RPGs.

As they went deeper into the forest, monsters gradually appeared.

A giant rat, bigger than a human, appeared blocking the way. Was it a Giant Rat?

I didn’t know what monsters appeared in this forest.

No matter how much I played RaSa, I didn’t know all the monsters that appeared in this ordinary forest without a name.

Railo approached Giant Rat with a tap on her neck.

Crackling!

It roared and lunged at me with an intrusive cry.

Railo, who had stomped her foot, swung her fist without drawing her sword.

The Giant Rat, which bounced away with a sound like something exploded, had its head smashed to death.

Railo said, shaking off her fist with a slightly refreshed face.

“Let’s keep going.”

After that, we rarely encountered other monsters. Even if we ran into them, it was only about level 10 trash mobs like Giant Rats.

It seems that there aren't many monsters here in the first place.

By the time the sun went down, we reached our destination.

It took little time because the forest wasn't that big.

“Now, this is the Mengrodi tree.”

I looked up at the huge tree in front of me and admired it a little.

I expected it to be the biggest tree in the forest, but it was much bigger than I had imagined.

It was several tens of meters tall, and the circumference was wide enough for ten people to stand hand in hand.

After touching the surface of the tree for a moment, I turned my gaze to the sun setting in the sky.

The sun is setting just now...

The mightiest tree, when the twilight has completely subsided, the lifeless branches.

These were the three keywords of this dungeon search.

The biggest tree was here, and the time was soon to be night, and all that was left was the ‘lifeless branches’...

What the hell is a lifeless branch?

I raised my gaze to the dizzying branches of the Mengrodi tree.

As I did that, Asher and Railo started looking at the branches as well.

Then, suddenly, Asher opened her mouth.

“Hey, look at that.”

She stared somewhere behind me and pointed with her finger.

I looked to where she was pointing, but couldn't see anything. I narrowed my eyes.

What's there...

“...!”

I immediately widened my eyes.

A single twig intermingled among the lush branches.

However, upon closer inspection, it was different. Because only that branch had no leaves.

Was that a 'lifeless branch'?

Chapter 29.1: Super Sensory (3)

Chapter 29.1: Super Sensory (3)

“Huh? Only that branch has no leaves. It’s amazing.”

Railo also put her palm on her forehead and looked at the bare branches.

I furrowed my brows and was lost in thought.

A lifeless branch.

It must have meant that tree branch.

If not, what else could it be? It was an unnatural sight no matter who looked at it.

But how is such a thing possible?

Was it just the genetic characteristic of the tree, or did the creator of the dungeon who left the code did something to this tree?

I skipped it because it wasn’t really important.

Rather, if it was a ‘lifeless branch’, it meant that it was the most decisive hint to find the dungeon.

Because the code says that a lifeless branch would guide adventurers.

“...”

I stared up at the branch.

What and how could a branch attached to a tree guide me?

I thought for a moment. Maybe if it was cut down, the branches would fly around and give directions... But it didn't seem like that's the case no matter how much this was a fantasy world.

Direction? Is it a direction?

I thought of something simpler.

Were you just telling me to move in the direction the branch was extending?

It was confusing, but I couldn't think of anything else, so I moved. If it wasn't the case, then I could just come back.

I looked back at the two and said.

“Let's move over there.”

That's how we headed in the direction the branch was pointing.

The sun had completely passed before I knew it, and darkness fell over the forest.

I took out the glowstone and walked, carefully examining my surroundings. I didn't know where there might be traces suggesting the location of the dungeon.

After moving for several tens of minutes, something that clearly stood out came into view.

A single tree among the other trees emitted a sense of presence. Its leaves were dimly shining.

...Luminous tree?

Railo also found it and muttered in wonder.

“It’s a luminous tree. It’s hard to see, but who would think it was in this forest too?”

As the name suggested, the luminous tree was a tree with leaves that emitted light at night. Like fireflies.

It was located exactly on the route we were walking on, so there was something suspicious about it.

Could it be that?

When the twilight subsided, the reason the time of the day was included in the code.

If interpreted differently, it meant that something specific that could only be seen at night was a hint to the dungeon.

And the luminous tree was a tree that emitted light like this only at night.

Feeling something connected in my head, I moved closer to the luminous tree.

Hmm...

So what’s next?

I moved in the direction where the lifeless branch was pointing to and found a luminous tree standing there. What more did I have to do?

I asked Railo.

“Do you know something?”

“Yes?”

“The biggest tree, when the twilight has completely subsided, the lifeless branches will guide the adventurers. So I moved to the direction where that branch of the Mengrodi tree was pointing, and this luminous tree appeared.

It seems to be a signpost to the dungeon. Let me know if anything comes to mind.”

Railo stood there looking dumbfounded before she asked.

“I don’t know? More than that, why do you say this is a signpost to the dungeon?”

“What else stands out at night other than this?”

She seemed to think about it again, but then she looked surprised as if she realized it only then.

“Indeed, that’s it! Could you please explain?”

“...Have you really done a lot of dungeon explorations?”

“I’m better at using my body, and my other colleagues are good at using their brain.”

“Where are your friends now?”

“After finding one artifact and having a big meal, everyone retired. I’m an adventurer because it’s my calling, so I’m still active.”

Such a story.

Anyway, Railo didn’t seem to be of much help.

I wasn’t expecting anything, but I asked Asher as well.

“Do you think of anything?”

Asher seemed to think hard, then she carefully opened her mouth.

“That... it’s not.”

But instead of speaking to me, she shook her head.

One of the two ways to piss people off was to stop suddenly talking when they were about to say something.

“It’s okay, tell me.”

I urged her to speak again.

“I heard that most dungeons and ruins are located underground.”

“Right.”

Since ancient times to modern times, people had excavated more relics because the remains on the ground were more noticeable than underground.

“That’s why I thought maybe there’s a dungeon hidden right under this tree.”

“...”

It was a very simple opinion.

But so what? It seemed reasonable.

“Ah, that’s a bit. How could they hide it so blatantly like that?”

Railo interjected and said.

My reason for having doubt was the same as hers, but my intuition leaned in favor of Asher’s opinion.

After thinking about it, I ordered Asher.

“Dig deep right in front of the tree until I tell you to stop.”

“Yes.”

Asher gestured to Railo, who was standing still, to step back.

Railo, who stood next to me, looked at me as if it what I ordered was just absurd.

“Are you sure about this?”

“Nothing else comes to mind.”

“No matter how deep she dug, who would...”

Kwaaiang!

The sound of the explosion hitting her ears startled Railo, and she looked back.

Every time Asher struck with her fist, the ground burst open and the hole got deeper and deeper.

Railo stared at the absurd sight.

Time passed.

Asher, who had been digging the ground for a long time, suddenly jumped over the pit and she said.

“Something like a stone wall appeared and there’s a space inside.”

“...Stone walls?”

I moved closer to the pit, put the glowstone above it, and looked down. She dug too deep.

It was dark, so I couldn’t see it well, but as Asher said, the artificial stone walls seemed to be faintly visible.

So, it’s real?

I was dumbfounded and laughed out loud.

Did the guy who created the dungeon think no one could really find it?

Even after I found it, I was amazed at how the hell Tair found it.

“...?”

I tilted my head.

Wait a minute, wasn't something inconsistent?

Even if you estimate the depth of the hole Asher had dug, it was well over a few meters.

So, Tair, like Asher, dug this deep alone and found that... Did that make sense?

“...”

I felt a strange sense of difference, as if something was out of place, but I still had to go inside.

I said to Railo.

“I'll be back, wait here.”

“...Ah yes.”

She nodded her head gracefully.

Seeing Asher's strength, it felt like her tone had become a little more polite.

I jumped straight down the pit.

Chapter 29.2: Super Sensory (3)

Chapter 29.2: Super Sensory (3)

It was quite high, but there were no problems.

I had already confirmed that if I used the floating veil in the air, it would fix my body mid-flight.

In short, if I used it while falling, the force of falling disappeared, so I could use it for landing.

Teouk.

Right before landing, I used the floating veil to land safely on top of the stone wall.

There was a hole in the stone wall where Asher was standing.

When I brought the glowstone closer, I saw that there was a space inside, just as she said.

“Go in.”

“Yes.”

At my words, Asher jumped down the stone wall first.

After checking the height of the floor, I also jumped down. And...

“...”

I was a little dumbfounded and looked around at the scenery unfolding in front of me.

There was a very wide space inside the stone wall. It was a scale I had never guessed.

It was also very artificial.

The walls and passages were cut straight like an underground lair of a secret organization, and the glowstones on the walls emitted faint light as if their power was almost exhausted.

What the hell is this place?

No matter how one looked at it, it's not an ordinary dungeon.

No, was this even a dungeon?

Feeling the growing sense of alienation growing in my heart, I moved along the aisle ahead.

The aisle was very long. It was also twisted here and there and sometimes divided into several parts.

After moving for such a long time, we could reach a certain communal space.

...Altar?

That was the first thought that came to my mind when I first saw it.

A structure made of red stone placed in the middle of a large space.

The walls, ceiling, and floor around it were illuminated with magic circles and bizarre characters.

I had no choice but to pay attention to such trivial things.

It was because ‘something’ was sitting in the magic circle in the middle of that strange structure.

Wearing an old robe, something that looked like a human at first glance.

The moment I found it, an ominous feeling of unknown origin soared instinctively, and a number that made me doubt my eyes was reflected in my field of vision.

【Lv. 97】

...What the hell was that, the fuck.

I couldn’t help but understood that they were in a very shitty situation right now.

This place was not a dungeon where Tair found a mystery.

It was the moment she was about to tell Asher, who was holding the hilt of the sword with a nervous expression on her side, to escape...

Flash!

Violet rays flashed.

Asher, who was directly hit by the beam, was blown backwards before she had time to react.

“...!”

I hurriedly turned my head.

Asher was pinned against the wall and could not move. I thought she was dead, but she thankfully just fainted.

I slowly looked forward again at the sound of laughter.

“Kheuh... hehe, heuhhahaha...!”

The grotesque laughter that flowed from the monster in the robe reverberated through the space.

“It’s here, It’s finally here! After all, fate didn’t forsake me!”

As he got up from his seat, the robe he was wearing crumbled and flew away.

And the exposed body of the guy was just bizarre.

The skin was black like ink, the veins clearly rising above it were pure white, and the eyes were shining brightly with blood.

Peeing!

Immediately, I took out the bow I was carrying on my back, took aim and shot the arrow drenched in my blood.

However, the arrow was blocked by the shield that wrapped around the robed monster and only bounced helplessly.

Feeling very disappointed, I lowered my bow and opened my mouth.

“...What are you?”

The monster who had been laughing for a long time stopped laughing and said.

“Enpyrus Deima, the wizard who dreams of eternity.”

“...That’s a name I’ve never heard of.”

“Oh, so much time has probably passed since my name has already been forgotten.”

His level was 97. He only had a one level difference compared to the Overlord, Rashtain.

My life was in danger.

Asher was knocked out, and my instant kill ability couldn't reach him.

I kept my composure and stared at him with sunken eyes.

“Is the reason you attacked us because we invaded your territory?”

“Invasion? Hahaha! Quite the opposite! Do you know how long I've been waiting for someone to come here?! I couldn't step out of this small magic circle, barely maintaining my dead body!”

He said incomprehensible words.

However, I could tell from his words just now that he was an ancient mage, and that he had been imprisoned here for a very long time.

And he was thrilled by my presence here.

Fu-wook!

“...?!”

The light flashed again, and my stomach felt hot.

I knelt down as I felt my body drain from the intense pain that followed.

“Kuk...”

I looked down at my side, which had been completely ripped open and blood was pouring out of it.

I didn't even have time to activate the floating veil because I couldn't react to the attack at all.

At that moment, I heard the monster's voice.

“What are you? Why can't you block an attack like this when your soul level is so high?”

Gulleong!

The blood that flowed from me floated in the air and moved to him.

Soon, a voice full of joy filled the cavity.

“Well, it’s okay. The blood of someone as high as you can bring my body back to life! I can get out of this damn place and finally go out into the world again! Hehe! Hehahahaha!”

Hearing a buzzing sound in my ears, I raised my head.

He sucked up all the blood he had taken from me and began to greedily absorb it.

The more he did, the more his body repeated expansion and contraction as if it were revitalized, and a huge energy swirled around him.

I was dizzy from the pain, but I couldn’t help but burst out laughing at the sight.

After drinking all of my blood, the guy with a face full of elation tilted his head.

“What’s so funny?”

I barely opened my mouth and squeezed out my voice.

“Thank you for being so considerate...”

“What?”

“Die.”

Poof.

The monster’s body collapsed, and the energy that filled the cavity disappeared at once.

Chapter 30.1: Super Sensory (4)

Chapter 30.1: Super Sensory (4)

After confirming that the monster had died, I lowered my head.

It really hurt and I felt like dying.

The opened side simmered and new flesh appeared. Super regeneration was activated, and the wound was being regenerated.

However, it felt like the recovery was slow. It could be because the injury was serious or the magic that attacked me slowed it down.

I soon recovered from my injuries and rose from where I was sitting.

I felt as if my body was drained of strength.

Of all the risks I'd been through, this time was the most dizzying.

If I had been hit in the head rather than the side, I would have died. No matter how effective super-regeneration was, it wouldn't be able to restore even the head.

The light of the magic circle that was illuminating the space also disappeared when the monster died.

I stared at the dead man and looked back at Asher with a sigh.

Asher was sprawled against the wall and lay motionless.

I went over to her, picking up her messy clothes.

“Hey.”

I didn't know if her injury was serious or how should I wake her up, so I patted her cheek first.

As her eyelids fluttered, Asher slowly opened her eyes.

I asked her as she blankly blinked her eyes in relief.

“Are you okay?”

“...Yes. How much am I... that monster?”

“Dead.”

Asher, who was confused, let out a small sigh, as if she understood the situation, and then became devastated.

To be honest, it was fortunate that she was only hit once and flew away and then retired from battle. I could see the level, but she couldn't. So, this must be another blow to her self-esteem.

“Sorry. Nothing else...”

“He was as strong as the overlord.”

At that, Asher widened her eyes and looked at me.

I took a Scarlet potion out of my arms.

The attack hit her right below, so she was fortunately safe.

Asher shook her head, planted her sword on the floor, and stumbled to her feet.

“It's okay.”

“Just drink a little if you don't want it to be poured on your wounds.”

“No. It’s really fine.”

How stubborn...

She kept repeating that it was okay even if I was practically forcing it to her, so I pretended to bring it to her mouth.

Startled, Asher stepped back, tripped over her foot, and fell again.

I looked down at her as she fell, a little startled by her furious reaction.

“Your condition is not normal, after all.”

“...”

Asher’s eyes looked this way, and I felt a faint mix of embarrassment and resentment from her gaze.

Who kept insisting on rejecting the potion here?

“It’s an order, so drink.”

Eventually, Asher took the Scarlet potion and drank it.

She was an irreplaceable talent for me. How could even a hundred bottles of this potion be wasted?

If there was any trouble, I had to fix it right away, so that there was no problem.

By the way...

I sighed inwardly and turned my head back to the fallen monster.

What the hell was that bastard?

Why was there a monster of such a crazy level in this forest?

No matter how many strong mages were there in the golden age of ancient magic, at level 97, they would have been one of the strongest on the continent.

He said he's Enpyrus Deima.

It was a name I didn't know about the ancient NPCs because the game rarely mentioned them.

The ancient era almost had no records other than the ruins buried all over the continent.

I moved and went up to the altar.

Looking around the dead man, there was something like a book.

I picked it up and paused.

This was because the book crumbled at the slightest touch. How old was this?

I had no choice but to crouch down in front of the book and flip through the front pages as carefully as I could.

“...”

What?

I stared blankly at the letters written in the book.

So... these were ancient characters, but I could interpret them perfectly.

Earlier, I paid little attention because all I could think of was to survive, but I actually had a natural conversation with the monster in an ancient language.

Being able to understand and speak ancient language, I easily concluded.

Because I had experienced this sensation once before.

It was like that when I first possessed this body.

The first time I entered this game, I communicated with the prisoner in the common language of the continent with no problems.

I didn't know the details, but I wondered if something similar to that time had happened.

Is the conversation a trigger?

It made sense if the trigger was having a direct conversation with someone in a language I didn't know.

I planned to check it out later, but for now, I turned my attention back to the contents of the book.

Chapter 30.2: Super Sensory (4)

Chapter 30.2: Super Sensory (4) Bonus chapter! Thank you to Reikichi for the donation! ^^

– I wanted to be an eternal being.

The first sentence of the book began like that.

– All living beings are born with a mortal destiny. Even if aging is delayed by magic or other powers, even if the living body is discarded and the dead body is resurrected, the end will eventually come. I wanted to overcome that limitation. I wanted to shed my mortal shell and become an eternal being.

What followed word by word was about magic research.

Even after reading it, I didn't understand it, so I skipped it.

– But in the end, I couldn't fulfil my dream even with so many efforts.

– The end has come to the body that has lived for thousands of years. Originally, I could have lived longer, but the burden accumulated through various studies came to a limit.

– If I use the necromancer to resurrect as the body of the dead, I can prolong your existence. However, if that happens, I can never return to being a living being again, and I will have to live the rest of my life in the body of the dead. It's denying me everything.

– I met my end here, where I have been with my whole life. I don't want to leave a legacy. All that remains is this diary.

– Loneliness. I never imagined that the day would come when I would feel this feeling. If I had known it would be like this, it wouldn't have been so bad to raise a few decent guys as disciples.

Up to this point, it seemed like an ordinary life of a mage crazy about magic.

But why did he stay alive like this without dying?

The answer to that came immediately after.

– At the moment of death, I have everything down, and then a new realization came.

– I realized how to increase the lifespan of this body, but it was useless. For me, the body of a high-ranking being was needed as a sacrifice. Far from looking for a sacrifice, his now dying body could only survive within the barely opened barrier. What a cruel fate.

– The way to be reborn as an eternal being, a flawless existence, was dimly visible. It can't end like this. Even if I can't move because I'm confined to this place, I will wait for someone who will find this place someday. Even if eternity of time passes, I will not disappear and will wait...

Sacrifice... was that why he went wild with joy when he saw me?

Perhaps because of the [Soul of the King], I seemed to be a high-ranking being in his eyes.

What followed that was increasingly messy.

I could see in the writing that his mind was getting more and more broken, perhaps because I was confined alone for so long.

After skimming through the contents, I closed the book.

Nothing special.

I was just dumbfounded.

So this place wasn't the place written on the map, and this guy named Enpyrus wasn't the creator of the dungeon.

I accidentally, unluckily, found the place where the crazy ancient mage was sealed instead of the dungeon I was originally looking for.

...What kind of crazy coincidence is this?

Did I receive any penalty for possessing this body?

If I could see the stat window, wouldn't the luck stat displayed be -99?

It was like when I was looking for super regeneration, when I was looking for the floating veil, just whenever I tried to find a mystery, it felt like a crisis always happened.

Once again, I cursed inwardly and got up from my seat.

In his diary, he wrote he would not leave any legacy, so it didn't seem like there would be any relics to look for.

Still, I went out of the aisle just in case, went around and looked around, but couldn't find anything.

I just found out that this underground space is absurdly large, no less than my castle. Could a space this huge be buried entirely in this forest?

Feeling empty, I said to Asher.

"Let's go out."

When we returned aboveground, I couldn't see Railo.

Where did she go?

I waited, wondering if she had gone to see something, but after a while she did not come back.

If she was attacked by something, there should be a sign of battle here, but there wasn't anything like that.

Asher looked around and said.

“There doesn't seem to be any sign that she's still here.”

“...”

I pondered and concluded.

She must have run away.

It was a situation that could only be explained that way.

When she saw Asher's skills, it intimidated her, so she decided to just leave.

Because she witnessed where the dungeon was, she could have thought we might try to kill and silence her.

The way back is not complicated, so it doesn't matter...

I sighed inwardly.

So where the hell was the dungeon that Tair found?

It was a pity to just go back like this, so I looked for more.

We continued moving in the direction the branch pointed.

After quite a while, I found another luminous tree.

The luminous tree grew close to a fairly large rock, and the surrounding area was full of bushes.

I went closer and looked.

Examining the overgrown bush revealed a small passageway between the rock and the ground.

“...”

I stared at the passageway, then turned my head.

Asher came closer too, staring down the passageway, and then our eyes met.

Fuck...

A string of curses rose in my throat before it finally subsided.

So, because I chose that first luminous tree, we went through all that hard work looking for something that wasn't there.

Kwaaang!

I had Asher widen the passage and went inside.

When a wide space appeared after passing through a narrow corridor, I saw wooden giants standing in the center like wooden dolls.

【Lv. 48】

Looking at the shabby level above their heads, I clicked my tongue slightly.

Yes, it's right here. The dungeon that Tair discovered.

Soon, blue light lit up in their eyes, and letters in ancient languages appeared on the wall next to them.

– Adventurer, face the ordeal.

– Overcome the trials and claim my legacy hidden in this dungeon.

– If you destroy the magic stones on each edge to avoid the guardians, their movement will gradually slow down, and if you destroy them all, it will stop.

I looked around the space.

As the saying goes, each of the walls at the edge of the space was studded with magic stones. Destroying all the magic stones seems to be the condition for clearing the dungeon.

Cooong.

Soon, the Guardians began to move and approach us.

I told Asher.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Destroy them.”

Waa!

Asher’s blow swept away all the Guardians.

Chapter 31.1: Super Sensory (5)

Chapter 31.1: Super Sensory (5) 3 ! Thank you to transhumanist Sykes and Zxz for the donations! ^^

It wasn't a high-level dungeon, as I thought.

After dealing with all the guardians and moving on, a trap came out this time.

Magic circles were engraved on the walls of the long, straight passage.

– Salute to those of you who passed the first ordeal.

– Break through the magic arrows raining from all sides and go to the passage on the other side...

Kwaaang!

Asher's sword strike destroyed all the magic circles on the wall.

After that, traps continued to appear, but we easily passed it.

These traps appeared while telling us we had to pass the trials.

I didn't think the one who made these traps expected us to move forward while dealing with everything like this, so I feel a little sorry.

Most dungeons were created in ancient times.

Because of this, there were many cases where the guardians and traps prepared by the creators were too old and did not work. Just like the dungeon where the floating veil was hidden last time.

However, the creator of this dungeon didn't seem to be a very good mage. The devices were still working properly, at least.

Perhaps it was created relatively late in ancient times, or it was not an ancient dungeon at all.

Eventually, a huge stone gate appeared, as if advertising that this was the final stage.

Is it the end?

I found nothing like a hidden space on my way here.

So the mystery I was looking for must be in there.

I wondered if this was the end of an ordeal that was really not an ordeal. Then a letter glowed on the floor right in front of the door.

– The last ordeal is an ordeal to test your luck.

– Armed Forces, Wisdom, Companions, Trust, and Powerful Weapons. Even if you have all of those things the most important thing is luck.

– Pick up the marble placed right in front of the door and insert it into one of the two holes in the door.

– If you choose the correct answer, the door will open. If you choose the wrong answer, the door will not open forever. Opportunity comes only once.

Asher couldn't read the ancient language, so she just stared blankly at it, not understanding the meaning.

After reading all the explanations, I moved on.

I picked up the orb from the pedestal in front of the door and walked closer.

Clap.

With little hesitation, I inserted a bead into the hole in the left, and there was no response from the door.

The letters shone on the floor again.

– Wrong answer, adventurer.

– Unfortunately, you do not deserve to claim my legacy. Throw away your regrets and go back.

I scratched my cheek and said to Asher.

“Asher, break it.”

Waa!

The huge stone gate was shattered.

It seemed to have been strengthened with magic, but it meant little in front of Asher’s power.

After going through all those traps, we finally reached the end of the dungeon.

I stood in front of the collapsed door, peeked inside, and spoke to Asher.

“Wait here.”

“Yes.”

I left her and went inside.

After passing through the narrow passage, what appeared soon was a space resembling a laboratory.

In the middle was a luxurious wooden box, like a treasure chest.

When I opened it, there was an old book and a letter inside.

“...”

Judging from the title, the book seemed to be a magic book in which the creator of the dungeon organized his magic, and the letter was also a letter from the creator.

After looking at the contents roughly, congratulations on coming this far, and since his own magic is a one-person transmission, he should pass it on to only one person.

I closed the letter with a smile.

Looking at the devices in the dungeon, one could roughly tell the maker's magic skills, but the letter was written as if he had left a great magic book of some century.

I looked around.

There was no passage to go further, so this was the only space where the mystery could be.

However, there was no mysterious pattern anywhere in the immediate sight.

Could it be that after all this hardship, was it all in vain again?

Feeling a little impatient, I took a more thorough look around me.

“...Ah.”

And when I moved the bookshelf in the corner and looked at the wall behind me, I could finally grin.

A mysterious pattern engraved on the wall.

It was shimmering in a blue light and was exquisitely covered because it was the size of a bookshelf.

I reached out my hand without hesitation toward the pattern.

Hwaaak!

As always, the pattern glowed brightly and was absorbed into my body.

I stood there blankly for a moment, then slowly looked around again.

...What is this?

I felt it.

As soon as I absorbed the mystery, I felt it clearly.

The sound, the smell, all the stimuli flowing in from around.

I clearly recognized the presence of Asher standing outside the room, as if I could see it.

As I concentrated more, my senses sharpened and I could even feel insects crawling on the floor.

It felt like crossing the threshold of a whole new world.

Was this?

Was this the sensation that superhumans in this fantasy world usually feel?

And it wasn't just a sensation.

My reflexes were also noticeably improved.

I picked up a stone from the floor and threw it.

The stones flying in a parabolic arc to the other side looked slow, like slugs crawling.

In addition, the visual acuity was enhanced, so even while flying, every angular part of the stone could be seen clearly.

What a cheat, really.

This was a skill I really shouldn't have missed.

After being properly beaten by an ancient mage earlier, I realized it once more.

Even if I had defensive abilities, if I couldn't react to an attack, it's useless.

However, with this level of cognitive ability, he could cope with the speed of most superhumans.

I'll have to adapt quickly.

I clenched my fists and closed them, calming the sharpened senses again.

I just got it, so I was not used to it yet, but it didn't seem like it would take long for my body to get used to it.

Come to think of it, this mystery had no name.

In the game, Tair never gave it a specific name.

After thinking about it for a while, I immediately came up with a suitable name.

There was the mystery of super-regeneration, and this one roughly had the same feeling.

‘Super sensory.’

With this, I had already obtained three mysteries, including super sensory.

Chapter 31.2: Super Sensory (5)

Chapter 31.2: Super Sensory (5)

We left the dungeon.

I had no need for the magic book, the legacy of the creator, but there was no reason to leave it either, so I brought it with me.

I didn't have the talent to learn magic, but wouldn't this be helpful to the possible people I would recruit later?

After leaving the dungeon, I told Asher what I was thinking.

"Asher."

"Yes."

"Expand your power once and swing your sword."

"...Yes?"

She flinched and turned to me.

She probably had misunderstood something, so I shook my head.

"I'm not asking you to attack me. I'm asking you to do it to an empty space."

"Ah..."

The reason I made this request out of the blue was because there was something I wanted to check.

Asher looked puzzled, but she didn't ask why and she meekly drew her sword.

I spoke again to her, who was about to wield her sword.

“Do it with all your might. You can even use any of your special abilities.”

As a member of the White Moon, Asher had a racial trait that enhanced her magical powers.

I wanted to see her in full power while using that trait.

A little taken aback by my request, Asher hesitated, then she nodded her head and showed off her ability.

Saaa.

Asher's body glowed softly, and soon the skin all over her body turned white.

It was the first time I had ever seen her use this. Because she hadn't used it until now.

Adjusting her stance, she caught her breath and began swinging her sword.

Waa!

A sword strike was drawn in the air, producing an unbelievable sound from just her swinging the sword.

I maxed out my super sensory and stared at her sword dance.

...I could see it.

I could see the sword movement, enough for me to react even if that sword was directed at me.

My senses had become so good that I could detect even the movements of a level 81 person. And there was even still room for it.

It seems like it's enough to respond to a level 80 to a certain extent.

But what if the enemy was stronger than that?

I recalled the movements of the warrior I saw on the escort ship or the mad blows I encountered in the hallway during the Lords' meeting. The ancient mage's attack that had completely razed my side earlier.

The attacks before gaining super sensory were not visible at all, so there's no way I could guess them even if I recalled them... but I don't know. Unless I checked it again myself.

Anyway, after confirming the somewhat satisfactory results, I opened my mouth.

“Stop.”

Asher stopped and took her breath lightly.

She didn't even wield it much, but it seemed that she really used her strength with all her might.

And for some reason, she was staring at me as if she was expecting something.

“...”

Why was she looking at me like that?

I tilted my head and realized why.

Did she think I ordered her to do that so I can evaluate her skills?

Looking at those strangely expectant eyes, that seemed to be the case.

I was silent for a moment and then said.

“There is definitely potential. Keep trying.”

“...All right.”

She nodded her head with a slightly regretful expression.

I felt apologetic because she seemed to expect more, but what advice could I give her with my skills?

It was dark at night, but we went straight through the forest without stopping.

It exhausted me but I could endure because I had super regeneration. I wanted to sleep as soon as we reached the carriage.

It wasn't until the sun rose in mid-sky that we arrived at the carriage and saw Baros, who was eating alone

“You're here, my lord.”

He must have been hunted somewhere, seeing as how he was eating a well-groomed rabbit and roasting it.

Asher and I joined him and ate on the spot. Then went back to the city.

Back in the city, I stopped by the Adventurer's Guild again to find out what happened to Railo.

I heard from another adventurer that she had returned to the city and that she had rushed off to another city the moment she did.

She must have felt terrified.

Her situation was kind of funny. Anyway, I just made sure there wasn't anything wrong with her, so I could put my mind off her.

After we stayed for one more day, we immediately left the city.

The next destination, as originally planned, was the territory of the First Lord, the Wiseman. It was a bit far this time.

From the current location, we planned to go through the Fourth, Third, and Second Lords' territories in a curved line and traveled the shortest route.

After so much time, we arrived at Cubax, one of the large cities on the border of the Third Lord's territory.

I was lost in thought as we waited at the checkpoint at the castle gate and waited for our turn.

This is now a fork in the road...

I was a little worried.

One of the most necessary abilities for me was blood magic. Elrod Forest was the place to get it.

Elrod Forest was far to the west of this city of Cubax.

Should I continue on to the First Lord's territory as it is, or should I stop by Elrod Forest?

According to the original plan, I was going to put aside getting blood magic and just focus on mysteries.

However, after gaining the floating veil and super sensory, I became more confident in my ability to save myself, so I felt a bit of regret just passing the forest like this.

After a short thought, I decided it would be better to just go to the First Lord's territory.

No matter how I thought about it, there were too many variables if I went to Elrod Forest.

Even though I was sure of my safety, I had to talk to the vampire tribe living there in order to get blood magic. But was that even possible?

So, as originally planned, it would be best to put off blood magic and focus on the mysteries.

“...?”

I was lost in my thoughts, but I looked out the window as there was a commotion outside.

There were several wagons passing proudly to the side, ignoring the checkpoints standing in front of the gate.

I could see the sight of the passers-by standing in line, hesitating and looking away.

One wagon's luggage compartment was barred with iron bars, making it look like a prison in which young boys and girls were imprisoned.

...Slave traders?

I rested my chin on my hand and stared at them.

Chapter 32.1: Vampire (1)

Chapter 32.1: Vampire (1)

Armed men pulling wagons loaded with people, they gave off a somber atmosphere.

When I glanced at the levels, they were all over 30.

【Lv. 57】

The long-haired man at the head of the procession who appeared to be the captain, was close to 60.

I wondered what they were doing when their levels were too high to be just a simple slave trader.

I heard the whispering of passers-by with my hearing that super sensory had heightened.

“...Valkilov.”

“Hey, don’t stare at them.”

Valkilov?

I could recall their identities with that name that sounded familiar.

If it was Valkilov, surely it wasn’t them? The largest and most notorious group under the Third Lord...

That’s right, those guys.

Information came to mind one by one.

A dangerous group whose focus was the sale of slaves, and a whole other plethora of dirty jobs.

In the game, was there a side story of assassinating a high-ranking official of the monarchy who attended the secret auction held by them as a VIP?

I stared at the slaves behind bars.

All of them had dead eyes, and they had no desire to live at all.

Of course, slaves also existed in this fantasy world where the caste system was fully alive.

I remembered there were countries where slavery was illegal, but that wasn't the case here in Calderic.

It could be illegal in certain Lords' territories if the Lord wanted to.

"Hey, you guys! Interrupting the line like this?!"

A young man with a disgruntled face got off the carriage that was in front a short distance away from our carriage.

An aristocratic man, accompanied by an escort knight, strode toward the slave traders passing by.

The atmosphere of the passers-by who were watching the scene subsided quietly.

The leader, the long-haired man, saw him approaching and smiled.

"As you can see, we have a lot of commodities with us, so it's cumbersome to stand in line. Please forgive us."

Then he pointed to the slaves carried behind him. They were called 'commodities'.

“Excuse me? Are you kidding me? For a reason that doesn’t even make sense...”

“Sir, may I ask what family you are from?”

The man laughed and said.

“Family, my family? Are you intimidating me right now? My father is the deputy mayor of the city of Volcasion Chail, the First Lord’s territory! The lowly slavers who dare...”

The men who were listening to him laughed.

The man was taken aback by the unexpected reaction.

“H-how dare you...”

“Oops, I didn’t know that you’re the deputy mayor’s son and committed disrespect. I’m sorry.”

“Yes, yes. I...”

“But since the young master is from a different territory, I guess you didn’t know who we are.

The long-haired man whispered into the man’s ear.

Because I had super sensory, I could hear the whisper clearly in my ears.

“...Stop being a bother and get out of here, kid. Don’t act as if you are in a position to look down on us. Or shall I just twist all your limbs and pull them out?”

At that, the man turned white and stepped back saying nothing.

Long-haired smiled as if he had never said such a thing, bowed his head and went on his way.

I laughed out loud as I watched the series of scenes.

He's a funny guy.

Valkilov probably had deep connections with several high-ranking officials in the Third Lord's territory. It wouldn't be the most notorious organization in this territory for nothing.

There's no need for them to care about a noble from another territory, and was only the deputy mayor's son.

The man watched them leave, then went back to his carriage trembling with a look of humiliation on his face.

The guards at the gates, as if familiar with this situation, exchanged a few words and then let their wagons pass right into the city one by one.

"It's a dirty scene."

As Asher looked at them with her cold eyes, she spoke.

I asked as I withdrew my gaze.

"Are the slaves pitiful?"

"...Yes, honestly."

"So you want to help?"

"No. I know that there's nothing I can do about it."

It was as she said.

This was a different matter from helping that waiter in the Fifth Lord's Territory the other day.

The slave trade was legal in this world, and they were just merchants who bought and sold slaves within that framework.

If one dig deeper, they might find a lot of illegal things, but on the surface, it's very much legal.

Still, what if they pitied the slaves and killed all those men and saved them?

What were we going to do with the slaves we saved? Would we take responsibility until the end and lead them to live a normal life?

And what about the Valkilovs?

Of course, with a Lord's power, even a single cancerous tissue could be extinguished.

Even if it was a group belonging to the Third Lord, it was an act that would never be tolerated in Calderic if they opposed a Lord first.

But what could that mean?

It's just momentary self-gratification.

Besides that Valkilov, there would still be countless slave guilds and slaves on this continent.

Would I kill them every time I ran into them? Freeing the slaves without thinking about the future?

It was no different from just a maniac. With no clear standards or beliefs, I just went around doing things as I saw fit.

I would help if there was someone in need, but it was difficult to overdo it without crossing that line.

My current priority was to collect hidden pieces and increase my chances of surviving.

I was not wandering around Calderic to pretend to be an apostle of justice.

Still, it's pitiful.

From the eyes of modern people, it was a pitiful scene of human rights violations.

I watched the wagons disappeared one by one into the castle gate.

“...!”

Then my eyes widened.

It was because one slave in the last wagon caught my eye.

The figure of a young girl with black hair and red eyes.

...*Vampire?*

As I boosted my super sensory to enhance my eyesight, I saw fangs protruding from her mouth.

Obviously a vampire

Black hair and red eyes were racial characteristics of vampires. Except for mutants, all vampires have black hair and red eyes.

I could also hear the men next to her talking.

“...But if a vampire appeared, who would bid? It was embarrassing.”

“She’s still a rare product. How many aristocrats have perverted tastes?”

As I listened to the conversation, I stared at the girl crouching inside the cage.

Until the wagon passed through the gates and was completely out of sight.

“...”

I leaned back and was in deep thought.

I didn’t expect to see it in a place like this because it’s a rare species that was hard to see. It was even a vampire who was captured as a slave.

Suddenly, something flashed through my mind.

Vampires... Elrod Forest...

Vampires were a rare race, so they had strong racial love.

Then, what if I rescued that young vampire and took her to Elrod Forest?

I didn't know if that girl was from the same tribe as the vampires in Elrod Forest, but they're still the same race.

Since I saved their own people and brought them back, at least I should be able to talk to them without being attacked.

Yeah, a method like that is workable, right?

In an instant, I drew an ideal picture in my head.

I thought this was worth doing.

Chapter 32.2: Vampire (1)

Chapter 32.2: Vampire (1)

After entering the city, we found a lodging, and Asher and I immediately went to the slave trade shop run by Valkilov.

When we passed the security guards and entered the building, I saw an employee at the counter.

A fat middle-aged woman who was scribbling something on her paper saw me and said hello.

“Welcome, young master. What kind of slave did you come to buy?”

I told her.

“I heard a vampire came in as a slave.”

“...Oh, that’s right. She just arrived.”

The woman looked embarrassed, but she continued her words with regret.

She said, “But you can’t buy that child because she’s already scheduled to be sold to someone else. I’m sorry.”

...Scheduled for sale?

I knew intuitively that she was lying to me. And also the hidden meaning of her words.

Come to think of it, they were talking about the bidding earlier.

They were talking about the one that would take place in Domihawk City. A secret auction hosted by Valkilov.

The vampire girl was scheduled to be auctioned there.

I said again.

“How much should I pay for her so you can sell her to me?”

“Yes, that’s...”

“Even if I paid 200 golds or two platinum coins? Is it still not enough?”

“...Yes?”

The woman lost her words for a moment, then she spoke hastily.

“Now, could you wait for a moment, young master? I’ll bring the manager right away...”

After saying that, the woman who went inside returned after a while.

She returned with two men, one of whom was familiar.

It’s him.

The long-haired guy I saw at the checkpoint earlier.

He greeted me as he approached me with a business-like smile.

“Oh, hello! Young master. I heard you came to purchase a vampire slave?”

“Yes.”

“By the way, as you’ve heard, it’s a product whose buyer was already decided, so we’re having a bit of trouble selling it...”

This guy was definitely trying to see just how much I would pay for the vampire by saying all these useless things.

“Three platinum coins.”

“...”

“I have no intention of offering more. Stop messing around and tell me if you want to sell it for this price or not. If not, I’ll go right back.”

As I said that, I took out three platinum coins in front of me.

The branch manager standing next to me looked back at me with shaking eyes.

The guy who was staring at me immediately replied with a grin.

“I understand, young master. As you wish, I will sell it for three platinum coins. Thank you very much for using our Valkilov Slave Shop.”

And Asher and I went down to the basement of the building following his guidance.

In the basement, slaves were locked in bars at intervals, and it was a sight that made me frown.

“Here it is.”

In the prison they finally arrived at, young boys, and girls were locked up.

Among them was the vampire girl I was looking for.

She was wearing iron shackles on her ankles, and her ankles were all scaly, visible with blood scabs.

The guy opened the cage with his key and went inside. He approached her who curled up in her corner.

“Stand up, vampire bitch. Your master is here.

The girl slowly raised her head and looked up at me.

I could feel a mixture of wariness and hostility toward me in the eyes filled with emptiness.

I also looked at her straightforwardly and said.

“Remove the shackles.”

“Yes, yes. I see.”

Soon the long-haired man released the shackles from her ankles and threw the girl out of the cage. Asher, who was following me, held the girl.

“If you want, we can give her a bath right away to make her clean.”

The guy said, looking at the girl.

The girl who received that look trembled.

“No need, I’ll take her right away.”

“Yes, I understand. Then, pay the bill... Ah, thank you.”

I immediately handed him three platinum coins.

After going back to the ground, I was about to leave right away because I didn’t want to talk any more, but he grabbed me and said.

“Young master, do you know about the secret auction we are hosting in Domihawk City?”

I looked back.

He grinned and took something out of his pocket.

“It’s an auction where quality slaves of various races come out and occasionally treasures excavated from ruins also appear. If you’re interested, this is...”

Saying that, he handed me an invitation in a luxurious envelope.

“If you go to the branch manager in Domihawk City, he will guide you through the auction.”

“...”

“Then I look forward to seeing you again, young master.”

Yeah, no thanks.

I turned around and left the building.

I could hear them talking inside with my super sense-enhanced hearing.

“John, is this really okay? It was an item to be auctioned off...”

“It doesn’t matter as long as I explained it to my brother well. And there’s another one, anyway.”

“But still...”

“It was a product that could not exceed 100 gold at most, but how much profit would we get selling for several times than that? Looking at him, he looks like a noble from another territory...”

I shook my head and headed for the inn with Asher and the girl.

Chapter 33.1: Vampire (2)

Chapter 33.1: Vampire (2) Thank you to Roachgoda for sponsoring 5 chapters! ^^

After returning to the dormitory, I took a bath first because I was not in a good mood.

Asher was the only one person who could help the girl wash, so I left it to her.

After the girl was finally clean, I tried to talk to her.

“Can you tell me what your name is?”

“...”

“If you’re hungry, it’s okay, tell me. I’ll prepare the meal right away.”

“...”

But the conversation continued to be one-way like this.

She just looked at me like a frightened herbivore and kept her mouth shut with a hint of restlessness.

Being a vampire didn’t mean that one couldn’t use the official language of the continent. Was she like this only to me?

“Vampire, are you going to keep your mouth shut?”

Baros, who was standing behind me, said with an annoyed look.

At the pressured voice, the girl shuddered even more.

I frowned and turned to Baros. He was bewildered and bowed his head.

“Sorry.”

I asked, turning to Asher on the other side.

“Was she like this when you’re cleaning her up?”

“Yeah, I tried talking to her, but she said nothing...”

How annoying.

Even in real life, I was far from getting along well with children, so I wondered what to do in such a situation.

First, I had to ask her something, then take her to the Elrod Forest.

“Are you possibly from the vampire tribe living in Elrod Forest?”

“...”

The girl didn’t even respond to that.

She just didn’t seem to understand what I was saying.

If she was from the tribe living at Elrod Forest, there would have been a response... Then, was she a vampire who lived in another place?

...That would make things more difficult.

A vampire who was not from Elrod Forest. I couldn’t just take her there if she belonged to a different tribe.

I was so distracted by the thought of going to Elrod Forest that I forgot about that possibility.

I sighed as I looked at the girl with her mouth shut.

“I have no intention of confining you. If you wish, I will take you back to your home.”

“...”

“You should at least answer. Or I can take you to Elrod Forest where the other vampires lived. Just say a word and I can take you there.”

“...!”

It was the first reaction that the girl gave me.

I wondered if her pupils were shaking, and then she finally opened her mouth.

“In Elrod Forest... are there other vampires...?”

I was right and answered right away.

“Yes, there is a very peaceful vampire tribe living there.”

“Eh, where is Elrod Forest?”

“It’s far west of this city... No, it’s not too far away. Do you want to go there?”

Say you want to go, please.

The girl rolled her eyes from side to side before nodding slightly.

I burst into joy and nodded my head.

“Okay, then I’ll take you right away.”

“...”

“But aren’t you hungry? It seems like you couldn’t eat properly. Let’s eat slowly and talk...”

...Huh?

I did not speak and narrowed my eyes.

I felt the girl's breathing becoming rough.

She was more restless than before, twisting her legs like that, and no matter how much I looked at it, she didn't look like she was in a normal state.

"Hey, are you okay?"

She shook her head violently, as if trying to regain consciousness.

"It's okay, it's okay... But..."

No matter how one looked at her, she didn't look good.

I got up and tried to get closer to see the girl's condition.

Then she reacted violently and distanced herself from me. I was also confused and stopped.

"Oh, don't come."

"..."

"I can't stand it anymore, the sweet smell... Don't come closer..."

Now watching her shake her head, shedding tears, I remembered something.

That's right, young vampires...

Vampires were basically a race that considered blood as a staple food. That's an innate instinct for vampires.

An adult could suppress that instinct, but I remembered that there was a setting that it was difficult for a young vampire to do the same. Instinct exploded and dominated periodically.

If I remembered correctly, adults gave their blood to the young vampires to satisfy their needs.

“Do you want to drink my blood?”

I rolled up my sleeves and reached out to the girl.

“Drink it.”

“...”

“It’s okay, you can drink. Come here.”

I said it in the most mature tone possible.

The girl’s expression gradually loosened as if possessed by something, then slowly approached me.

Waa!

A tingling and rising pain in the arm.

The girl grabbed my forearm, pierced her fangs, and sucked blood.

Baros and Asher, who were next to us, watched the scene with bewildered eyes.

“No, that’s... not Lord Ron’s blood, vampire—”

“It’s fine, just leave it alone.”

Baros, who was about to pull up his sleeves, stopped and sat down on a chair as if his strength had just left him.

For a moment, we could hear only the sound of a girl sucking blood in the room.

Chapter 33.2: Vampire (2)

Chapter 33.2: Vampire (2)

I looked down at the top of the girl's head, dangling from my arms and eating frantically, feeling a little awkward.

...But is okay?

Wasn't she eating longer than one would normally do?

It should be okay since I had super regeneration.

"...Fah."

Soon, exhaling a full breath, the girl opened her mouth.

And later, she looked at me with a look of embarrassment and said;

"I'm sorry..."

"It's fine."

I wiped the blood off my arm and checked it. The wounds quickly regenerated and disappeared without a trace.

After that, I could have a normal conversation with the girl as if her boundaries had been lifted.

The girl's name was Rudica.

She was a vampire from a place far north of Calderic, not from Elrod Forest.

The reason she ended up being a slave was like this.

“There was a fight between the tribes. The bad tribe killed our tribe and took over our homes.”

Because she was young, her vocabulary was poor, but I could understand it enough.

So, there was a war between the vampire tribes living in the mountains, and the tribe she belonged to was defeated and pushed out.

And those who barely survived scattered and left the mountain range, and Rudica’s group was said to have wandered around in search of another home and encountered slave traders.

“Humans said adults are annoying and killed them all. My mom and dad too. And they caught me and my sister.”

“...”

The humans they encountered were probably the slave hunters of Valkilov.

They probably thought they couldn’t control adult vampires because they use blood magic, so they must have killed all of them.

Vampires, elves, beastmen, etc., regardless of race, finding and capturing a few tribes living in nature, away from the world, was the best way to get slaves.

It’s nothing new, but it’s an annoying story just listening to it.

...But wait, a sister?

That meant she wasn’t alone and had a sister.

Rudica’s words continued.

“My sister was caught trying to protect me, and I was hiding and then caught.”

“Right.”

“Hey, humans keep saying something about an auction, and they said they moved my sister there first. My sister is probably at an auction.”

Rudica said in an urgent tone.

From what she was saying, she didn’t even understand what an auction was.

I became apprehensive inside as I looked into her earnest eyes.

Is she asking for help...?

Rudica continued to say, crying.

“C-can’t we get help from other vampires from the place called Elrod Forest? I have to save my sister. She was trying to save me...”

Now that I see it, this was the reason she reacted when she heard that there was another vampire tribe in Elrod Forest. It was, of course, an absurd idea.

I was silent for a moment, then nodded.

“Don’t worry, I’ll save your sister too.”

Rudica’s face brightened at that.

“Thank you! Thank you so much...”

...I said nothing, but the situation seemed to be troublesome.

However, her sister was still imprisoned, so I couldn’t take her alone to Elrod Forest.

Let’s go to the city of Domihawk for now.

I had an invitation to the auction.

First, I went to the city of Domihawk to learn more about the auction, and then decide what to do next.

After staying in the city for a day, we headed straight for the city of Domihawk.

It wasn't far from Cubax, so it didn't take long by carriage.

Whoops.

While on the move, Rudica continued to eat with my blood.

It's not that vampires couldn't eat ordinary food, but she insisted on only my blood because of the taste.

I ate my meal with one hand, with Rudica hanging from one arm.

Baros said, looking at her with distasteful eyes.

"Stop being rude to Lord Ron, vampire, and eat my blood. Do you know who the person you're drinking blood from is?"

I said it's fine, but he's still doing that tenaciously.

Rudica, who opened her mouth, looked at Baros, and shook her head.

"I don't like it... it smells bad."

"What?"

At those words, Baros gave a slightly shocked expression.

Vampires had blood that suited their taste and blood that didn't.

Apparently, elf blood didn't suit her taste. I guessed she liked human blood more.

...Human.

A thought suddenly came to mind.

Come to think of it, I naturally thought that the race of this body was human, but was that truly the case?

Although Asher did not differ from a human on the outside, she was still not a human, but someone belonging to the White Moon tribe.

There were many other races similar to humans in this world. Couldn't I be one of those races too?

It doesn't seem like this body has any special abilities, though...

So, it's probably true that he's just a human.

I brushed away all my bitter thoughts and focused on eating again.

After eating, we got back on the carriage and set off.

Chapter 33.3: Vampire (2)

Chapter 33.3: Vampire (2)

It was only two more days to arrive in the city of Domihawk.

Rudica, who was sitting next to me, was nodding her head as if she was about to fall asleep at any second, then immediately shook her head, and looked out the window as usual.

How many hours had she been like that?

“...?”

With my super sensory, I felt something happening far ahead. I strengthened my senses and narrowed my eyes.

A battle?

The sound of metal scraping, the sound of flesh being ripped, and the sound screaming.

Clearly, it sounded like a group fight was taking place.

It's the same road we're taking.

I wondered if thieves had attacked another passerby.

The distance was getting closer, and therefore the noise was also getting closer.

By the time the situation came into view, the battle was over, and there was no more noise.

“...”

I hardened my expression as I watched the scene unfolding in front of the carriage.

It was something very familiar.

A wagon carrying slaves, the members of Valkilov's gang and a long-haired man in the middle.

For a moment I wondered why they were here, but then I understood.

It seemed our route and time of travel coincidentally overlapped with those who were transporting slaves to be auctioned off at Domihawk.

I saw the figures of beastmen scattered around them, their blood sprinkled around.

The men of Valkilov had not yet pulled their swords, and were staring at the carriage over here.

I got off the stopped wagon with Asher and showed my face to them.

“...Hmm?”

The long-haired guy looked at my face and spoke with a wide smile.

“Ah, young master. How did we meet again in a place like this? Were you on the way to the Domihawk?”

Without answering his question, I glanced at the beastmen scattered around.

Half of them were already dead, and the rest were panting and staring at Valkilov's gang members.

I turned my gaze back to him.

“What's going on here?”

He replied in a nonchalant tone.

“Oh, it’s nothing. Just being attacked by these wild beasts.”

“Attacked?”

“These cubs planned to attack us to rescue their people imprisoned there. It’s not a big deal. It happens often.”

When he said that, there were young prisoners locked in iron bars where he pointed with his chin.

They had been locked up in the basement of the slave trader with Rudica before.

The men giggled and grabbed the fallen prisoners one by one and dragged them.

“They attacked us without knowing what they should and shouldn’t do, so they should pay the price? The dead are dead, and we will sell the living into slavery.”

At the long-haired man’s sarcastic words, a female beastman gritted her teeth and shouted.

“You cruel human beings! Aren’t you the ones who invaded our home first, killed the tribe members who went out of the forest and kidnapped our children?”

It was a desperate cry, as if blood was boiling from her throat.

I looked at her like that, then looked back at her long hair.

The long-haired man walked towards her with a grin and stomped on her head and slammed it to the floor.

“You’re saying something funny. Isn’t that the way nature is supposed to be? The strong tramples the weak, just like this.”

“You...!”

“Ah, I’m sorry for showing you such a filthy side, young master. Don’t worry and go on your way. It seems like it will take a while for us to clean up.”

As he said that, he giggled and rubbed the female beastman’s trampled head.

One young prisoner, who was locked in a cage, cried.

“Oh, my sister! My sister...!”

“Oh, was this your older sister? It’s good that the sisters will be sold as a pair. Those nobles with various tastes will be equally pleased with you two.”

The sound of the devil’s laughter echoed in my ears.

I looked at the sights and then looked up at the sky once.

I recalled the thoughts I had when I found the slaves at the checkpoint.

It’s just a momentary self-satisfaction.

Then I wondered, what if a person could only live doing what’s comfortable for them? Would that still be a person?

Sometimes, if one didn’t act as their emotions lead them, were they really a person?

This has crossed the line of my patience.

I lowered my head again and said to the long-haired man.

“How about letting them go?”

The long-haired man turned his head in this direction.

“Let go... What do you mean by that? Oh, are you saying that you’re going to buy them right here?”

“No.”

I said again.

“I don’t have any gold coins to give you. I’m telling you to just leave them alone.”

Silence descended upon my words.

All the members of Valkilov, who were dragging the prisoners, stopped their movements and looked at me.

The long-haired man wiggled his eyebrows and opened her mouth.

“Now what is that....”

“Can’t you?”

I nodded.

“So that’s it.”

Then he turned to Asher.

“Asher.”

“...Yes.”

My voice echoed coldly on the quiet road.

“Kill them all.”

Chapter 34.1: Vampire (3)

Chapter 34.1: Vampire (3)

Asher, who had been watching the situation with cold, sunken eyes, nodded and stepped forward.

The Valkilov guys looked totally bewildered.

“Young master, what happened to you suddenly?”

The long-haired man twirled his sword from side to side and shook his head.

“No matter how much you want to imitate an apostle of justice, choose a time and place to do it. We...”

I cut whatever he’s saying and pointed to him.

“Let him live for a while. I have something to ask him.”

It was the moment that the guy frowned.

Asher’s sword was pulled out, and a blue flash of light flashed through the darkness.

And then blood started gushing out.

That was the end.

The bodies of the men who had lost their heads were scattered on the floor one by one. The road was stained with blood, and dozens of corpses were created in the blink of an eye.

If this was before, I probably wouldn't be able to see anything, but now I can see clearly thanks to my super sensory.

Asher slashed her sword at the sides of the long-haired man and cut his arm with a single blow.

“...“

He grabbed the cut edge of his arm and let out a scream of pain.

Kneeling down on the floor, he groaned, then looked around urgently. Seeing the annihilated subordinates, his pupils shook like an earthquake.

“Hey, this is... what the hell is this....”

He didn't even properly see Asher wielding her sword.

Even if the level was close to 60, there was a far-off difference from Asher, who was over level 80.

I plodded.

I looked down at the trembling man and opened my mouth.

“Are there vampires at the auction in the city of Domihawk?”

“...”

“One of the vampire sisters you captured, the older sister.”

“...Yes, that's right. There is one.”

He became polite in an instant and nodded his head as if half insane.

“Please spare me, young master. I'll tell you everything you want...”

“Where and when is the auction held?”

“Ah, exactly fifteen days from now, the venue will open in the basement of a man named Horton on the outskirts of the city. From sunset to midnight, you just need to bring an invitation.”

Is it the basement of the mansion?

“Who takes part in the auction?”

“Usually, nobles from nearby cities take part... and some officials from the monarchy also attend.”

“It doesn’t look like it’s an auction only for nobles. Can anyone openly take part?”

“No, of course not. Everyone wears a mask and attends the auction.”

“Can only one person participate per invitation?”

“...No. One person per invitation could take part in the auction as the attendee’s escort.”

I nodded. All I needed to ask was this.

The guy got impatient and continued talking gibberish.

“Y-young master, I will take you to the auction house of the Domihawk. These guys are like consumables that you use and throw away anyway, so I have no problem with you killing them. With me, you take part in the auction as a VIP...”

I looked down at him without a word.

His face was stained with despair, as if he had read the future in my eyes that would soon happen.

“If you kill me, you’ll be in trouble too! I’m a Valkilov executive! All the high-ranking officials of the monarchy have business with our group! And my brother is the head of Valkilov...!”

I shook my head and said softly.

“Didn’t you say that if you are weak, you will be trampled?”

“.....”.

“As you said, it’s just the law of nature, so accept it.”

And I turned around.

I heard a desperate cry behind my back.

“Y-you bastard!”

He picked up the sword that had fallen on the floor, turned and ran towards me.

Asher flew past me.

Fwish!

A shattering sound rang out, followed by the sound of something falling to the floor.

Even if Asher didn’t move, I could still stop him with the floating veil.

Asher brushed off the blood on her sword, then came closer and bowed her head.

I felt a little strange and looked around. Corpses strewn with blood.

I had seen people die a lot since I fell into this world.

But this time, I could say that it was different since it was a massacre that I had committed myself.

Of course, the first murder in his life was when he killed the warrior, but he didn’t feel much at the time.

To be honest, it felt more like killing a monster than a human being, and I didn't feel like I had killed someone because he died in an instant.

And all the thieves he encountered while wandering around Calderic were killed by Baros himself before I could even step out.

This time, there was no feeling at all.

But it wasn't just the effect of the [Soul of the King].

What made me feel strange right now was not because of shock or guilt, but because, on the contrary, my mind was too calm. Even if these people were trash, they were still humans.

I didn't think deeply. I guess it's just because I already got used to it. Or maybe it's just how I was originally.

“Ugh...”

The fallen beastmen stumbled up one by one.

They looked at the annihilated Valkilov with bewildered eyes. Then, soon, their eyes focused on this direction.

“...Did you help us, human?”

The female beastman who had just been trampled by the long-haired man asked with a voice mixed with vigilance.

I nodded and said.

“Pack up the wagon and leave quickly. Over time, the organization where these people belonged to may try to track you down.”

“Oh, I see.”

Chapter 34.2: Vampire (3)

Chapter 34.2: Vampire (3)

She nodded and organized the situation by leading the other prisoners.

She looked after her colleagues who were seriously injured and rescued those who were imprisoned inside the iron bars.

The young prisoners who were released from captivity wept and cried and embraced them.

I watched the scene, and as I was about to turn to the carriage, the woman shouted.

“Thank you very much, humans! I am Kagor, the chieftain of the Hard Rock clan! I will never forget this favor on the honor of my clan!”

Hard Rock?

It was unnecessary to put any special meaning in this encounter, since it was a beastman tribe that was widespread on this continent.

“If we see each other again. Be more careful with slave hunters in the future.”

“...I will always remember this grace! Please tell me your name!”

“It’s Ron.”

I turned around and walked to the carriage.

Suddenly, I saw Rudica, who was sticking her head out the window.

There was a look of fear on her face, so I stroked her hair once.

“Your sister seems to be in the auction house. I’ll save her right away.”

After tidying up, the beastmen left first.

I thought about the future.

Auction house...

First, I had a rough idea about the auctions held in the city of Domihawk

It would be held a fortnight later, in the mansion’s basement owned by a person named Horton. That mansion must also be a mansion managed by the Valkilov.

Should I participate?

Two methods came to mind.

The first was to just quietly take part in an auction and save only Rudica’s older sister.

I had plenty of money anyway, so unless there’s a bidding competition with some vampire-crazed pervert aristocrat, I’d be able to win the bid with ease.

The second was to overturn everything in the auction.

I could do this with Asher.

It didn’t matter how many Valkilov fighters were in the auction house. Because the number of people in the face of a high level difference had no meaning.

Or maybe I could go to the mayor of the city of Domihawk and press him down with the power of a Lord to interrupt with Valkilov’s business.

An auction was being held in the city he managed. I could tie them all together like that.

“...”

After weighing for a while, I ended up choosing to do it quietly.

Also, I was reluctant to do something big like that in other Lord's territory.

Without getting involved in any more annoying things, let's just get Rudica's sister and head to the Elrod Forest. That was it.

And the ones I just killed...

There were no witnesses, but I thought they might follow the tail. Just because there weren't any witnesses didn't mean no one could track what happened here.

Of course, it wasn't much of a concern.

I just had to deal with them.

If they still bothered me, then I could turn the whole Valkilov over.

My thoughts were quickly organized.

The carriage, which had started again, crossed the road.

After some time, we arrived in the city of Domihawk.

There was still some time before they held the auction, so in the meantime, I just looked around the city.

And the night of the auction finally came.

I left Baros and Rudica at the inn, and Asher and I went out into the street.

I see.

There were already several people with masks in their hands circling the streets.

Judging by the fact that people who looked like escorts were also attached to them, they were nobles who came to the city to participate in the auction.

I looked around them and walked through the streets where the night market was open.

There was a street vendor selling masks just in time, so I stopped and looked at the masks hanging from the stalls.

There were various animal masks, and there were also masks that were ridiculous like the ones worn by clowns.

I chose roughly one of them, a fox animal mask.

“You choose one too.”

I spoke to Asher, and she glanced at the masks.

Considering her personality, I thought she would pick just one, but she was choosing more carefully than I thought.

“I’ll pick this.”

Soon, Asher picked up one mask. It was a rabbit mask with elongated ears.

She picked something that didn’t suit her, so I stared at it, and she said as if reading my mind.

“If it stands out too much, I’ll pick another one.”

“No, it doesn’t matter.”

After picking the masks, we headed straight for our destination.

Horton’s mansion was on the outskirts of the city, and the location had already been determined.

After walking down the street, we fell into an alleyway and came out on a narrow road again.

The surrounding people vanished, and the mansion began to slowly appear in the distance.

Although the size of the mansion was not very large, it didn't matter since the auction was held underground, anyway.

Near the entrance to the mansion, masked men were entering the mansion one by one.

“Now put on your mask.”

“Yes.”

Asher and I put on masks and snuggled between them and entered the mansion.

An old elf stood at the entrance of the mansion, which passed through a short garden.

Since he was examining the invitations of the people ahead of me, I also took mine out of my arms.

My turn came, and I showed the invitation to the old man.

He glanced over at Asher and I, then accepted the invitation and bowed his head.

“I hope you have a great night. Just go inside and go down the stairs right in front of you.”

Chapter 35.1: Vampire (4)

Chapter 35.1: Vampire (4) Thank you to Blah-ness for sponsoring 4 chapters! ^^

In a dark room.

A man was sitting behind a desk with his legs crossed and clenching his chair.

A massive body with one head larger than a normal person, and a muscular body that was about to explode. However, on the contrary, the surrounding atmosphere was gloomy and sharp.

Suha, who had just finished reporting, stood in the front, swallowing saliva and waiting for the other to respond.

“So…”

“Yes.”

“An unknown young noble bought a vampire for a huge sum in Cubax. Is this the only thing you’ve found out?”

“…That’s right.”

“You’re not even sure if he has anything to do with my brother’s death…”

The man’s voice drooped.

Suha felt like he wanted to close her eyes tightly. Because he knew it was the man’s habit when he wasn’t in a good mood.

Jack, the leader of Valkilov, that was the man's true identity.

Ahead of the organization's most important event, the auction, Jack was in a terrible mood.

His younger brother, John, was attacked and killed while escorting slaves to be auctioned to the city of Domihawk.

What made it even worse was that he didn't know who he should put this anger on.

The discovery was too late to track them down. He sent men to Cubax to check the circumstances behind the scenes, but what they found was only the report he just heard.

“Uhhh...”

Jack let out a shaky breath.

It had been a long time since he had such a hard time suppressing his anger.

John robbed money from time to time, touched slaves recklessly, and was hateful in many ways, but he was still the only blood relative Jack had in this world.

They had been together from the days when they were rolling on the street until they formed the Valkirov and raised them to become the number one organization in the Third Lord's territory.

He closed his eyes for a moment, suppressing the rising anger and emptiness again.

Soon, it was time for the auction to start. He would start a more detailed investigation after this.

Knock.

“Come in.”

The knock rang, and an old elf cautiously opened the door and entered the room.

He was a member of the cadre in charge of those attending the auction.

Jack slowly opened his eyes and asked.

“What?”

“Someone whose identity was unknown attended the auction.”

The attendees did wear masks, but that’s just to cover each other’s faces.

The organizer, Valkilov, was naturally aware of the identities of the attendees. They were the ones who gave the invitations in the first place, and most of the time, the attendees were mostly only those who regularly attended the auction.

Of course, sometimes there were attendees without information, and in that case, they paid a little more attention to them.

Normally, it was a report that he would pass on lightly, but Jack turned his attention to Suha, who had posted the report.

“You said John handed the invitation to the guy who bought the vampire.”

“Yes, that’s right.”

“The escort knight attached to the young human man was said to be a woman. What do they look like?”

“The man had black hair, and the escort knight had white hair.”

Jack turned his gaze back to the old man.

The old man nodded his head.

“Yes, it’s the same. It was a human male with black hair and a human female with white hair.”

“It’s them.”

Those who bought a vampire in Cubax, one that was about to be auctioned off.

Jack was silent for a moment, then slowly got up.

It was not known whether they had anything to do with his brother’s death, but that seemed to be the only thing to look forward to right now.

As we went downstairs, the scenery unfolding was quite surprising.

Seats and podium. It looks like an auction house just as I had imagined, but it was because the space was bigger than I thought.

The inside of the auction house was dimly lit by glowstones embedded in the walls, and quite a few people were already sitting in the seats.

At the very back, there were also seats placed on the second floor railing, which at first glance looked like VIP seats.

Following the guidance of the person standing at the entrance, I took a seat and sat down with Asher.

What’s this?

There was something like a numbered picket on the armrest of the chair, so I picked it up and looked at it. It’s probably used when bidding at an auction.

I put down the picket and turned my gaze back to the podium.

Are the slaves coming from there?

The host would introduce the slaves, and the attendees would watch them like a beast in a cage, and if they like it, they bid.

Even if I had never experienced a place like this before, it was a scene that I had already drawn roughly.

I glanced back at Asher, who just clicked her tongue.

She definitely felt uncomfortable seeing all this.

By the way, when would it start?

More and more people started gathering, and the seats were already more than half full.

Some, like me, were sitting quietly waiting for the auction to start, while others were chatting with their companions, and I could hear their conversation through my super sensory.

“This time, there are a lot of high-quality products among the prisoners. They say we should look forward to it.”

“Isn’t it? I wish they had a child I like. I made a special leash to hang it on....”

It was a conversation that was disgusting to hear, so I immediately turned off my mind.

After a while, the curtains on the podium were lifted and a man in a suit with a mask appeared on stage with lights.

“Hello everyone, ladies and gentlemen who took part in the auction!”

It looked like the auction was about to start.

Chapter 35.2: Vampire (4)

Chapter 35.2: Vampire (4)

The host, who greeted the audience with a pleasant voice, talked about something useless for a while, then moved on to the next one.

“Then let’s start the auction! The bid method is to call the bid price with the prepared picket on the chair you are sitting on. Now, this is the first product!”

A half-elf woman walked out from the side of the podium, bound. No life at all in her eyes.

“The first prize is a female elf! It’s hard to find an elf with this kind of beauty and red hair like this. Now, let’s start the bidding with 20 gold!”

One of those sitting in the seat immediately lifted the picket and the full-scale auction began.

30 gold, 40 gold, 70 gold, and quickly climbed to 100 gold with little fuss. Then there was no more bidding.

“It came up to 100 gold! Does anyone have any more bids?! I’m not saying this for nothing. Elf slaves of this quality are really hard to find anywhere!”

The host continued to push the bid, cut the last count, and shouted as if it were a pity.

“Congratulations! Gentleman 56 has won the elf for 100 gold!”

After that, the auction continued smoothly.

A lot of different races came out as slaves. Starting with humans, beasts, elves, and other rare races.

The host also tried to explain how they had captured some of the slaves. Because that was also a big part of raising their price.

In particular, when a fallen noblewoman from Santea came out, the bids skyrocketed and soared to 500 gold.

“...”

The dirty, sticky heat of the auction house seemed to cling to my body.

I patiently watched the auction quietly.

It was only after they had sold about ten people that the reason for my participation in this auction finally appeared.

“The next product is a vampire!”

I opened my eyes a little wide and looked at the person who was being dragged onto the podium.

A girl with black hair and red eyes, not only her hands, were restrained like other slaves, but she also had a gag in her mouth. At first glance, her face resembles Rudica.

“Vampires are called a cursed race, but let me warn you in advance that you don’t have to be afraid! Young vampires cannot use their own blood-handling abilities, unlike adults! The taste...”

She glared at those who sat in the audience seat with hostile eyes. For a moment, our eyes met.

It was the time when the host’s explanation continued and I was slowly preparing to lift the picket.

“Hello there.”

Someone came up to me and sat down next to me.

“Are you enjoying the auction?”

I turned my head.

The figure of a man whose muscles seemed to burst all over his body caught my eye.

[Lv. 68]

What was impressive was the level above his head.

A skilled person who is close to level 70.

He spoke to me out of nowhere and immediately revealed his identity.

“My name is Jack, the head of Valkilov.”

“...”

“I’m sorry, but I have something I want to ask you for a bit.”

As I stared at him, he smiled and continued.

“You bought a young vampire from the city of Cubax. You also received an invitation.”

“I did.”

“It was my younger brother who handed you the invitation. He was escorting slaves here to the Domihawk, and some assailants attacked and killed him.”

“Is that so? I’m sorry.”

“...Yes, I am also very sorry. That’s why.”

His eyes gleamed like a beast.

“The timing is really complicated, so I’m just asking, but do you know anything about it?”

I shook my head.

“I’m sorry, but I don’t know.”

He gazed at me, sighed, and leaned back against the chair.

“If I twist and pull out your limbs one by one, would I get the same answer?”

“...”

“I grew up with good observation skills, you see. You killed my brother, right?”

I got caught.

Did they catch up from the place where we killed those trash, or was it because of my participation in this auction?

It wasn’t important, really. Because he was already convinced that I had killed his brother.

Come to think of it, before he died, he said that his older brother was the chief or something. I didn’t think I’d come here and find out like this.

And here I am, trying to keep it all quiet.

But then it failed.

I said with a chuckle.

“I killed him.”

“Why did you kill him?”

“Well, why do you think?”

He let out another long breath, as if to quench his anger, and said.

“Looks like you still don’t know your situation. What do you think I’ll do to you from now on?”

“...”

“I will take you to the torture chamber. There are a lot of excellent torture technicians in our organization. I guarantee you will feel with the flesh and bones of your body that such pain exists in the world. You’ll beg and beg again. As well as that escort bitch sitting next to you.”

Said the guy, growling.

“If you want me to give you a chance to die comfortably, answer my questions sincerely. Who are you, and why did you kill my brother?”

“Can you afford it?”

He laughed at my words.

“Afford? Stop such pretentious bluffs, child. There is nothing I can’t handle in the territory of the Third Lord. Are you even the Lord’s hidden child? Or...”

“I am the Seventh Lord, Ron.”

The voices stopped abruptly.

He looked as if he didn’t understand what he just heard.

“...What?”

“Do I have to tell you twice?”

I rested my chin on my hand on the armrest and turned my gaze back to the podium in front of me.

He said indifferently while looking at the auction that had just begun and listening to the rising bid price.

“I am Seventh Lord, my name is Ron.”

Chapter 36.1: Vampire (5)

Chapter 36.1: Vampire (5)

There was no reply from him.

He was just sitting there, staring at me, frozen. For a moment, everything seemed to have stopped.

“...Kuh-hat!”

Soon the guy burst out laughing.

The guy, who had his head bowed and sobbed and laughed, said with a straight face.

“Are you crazy? Are you impersonating a Lord’s name in Calderic?”

“...”

“If you’re a Lord, I’m the hero of Santea, you crazy bastard. You’ve had a lot more flavor than I thought. Did you say it because you thought that such nonsensical bullshit would really work?”

Well, this was the reaction.

It wasn’t unexpected, so I didn’t say more.

To him, it sounded like nothing but bullshit I said to escape the crisis.

Of course that was normal. Why would the Seventh Lord who was supposed to be in Enrock be taking part in such a secret auction in the Third Lord’s territory?

“Yeah, you seem to have no intention of answering my questions, so don’t regret what will happen next.”

Saying that, the guy got up from his seat.

Then he strode to the podium, stopped the host, and stood in the middle.

“I’m sorry everyone, but we’re going to pause the auction for a while.”

The sudden situation caused a commotion in the seats where the participants were sitting.

“There is a person who participated in the auction by killing the members of our organization and robbing them of invitations. We will deal with the rats first and then proceed with the auction as normal, so we ask for your understanding.”

As for what he was going to do, he didn’t seem to have any intention of waiting patiently until the auction was over.

My eyes met the guy standing on the podium.

Naturally, the surrounding eyes turned all at once towards me.

I heard conversations from the participants. They seemed to also consider this a fun event.

Haaa...

This was tiring.

I had been patient with this disgusting auction until now, and this was what it all came about.

I didn’t bother thinking about how to sort this situation out. There was no need for that.

There’s no need to question how things ended up at this point, I just had to go with the flow.

“I’ll give you one last chance. Will you be captured quietly, or will they sever one or two of your limbs while resisting?”

Suddenly, armed men appeared around me and surrounded the place where I was sitting. Were you fighters of Valkilov?

All of them were over level 50, and there were some who were over level 60, so it seemed like an elite force.

I looked at the guy standing on the podium.

Judging from the fact that he was just talking, he acted like he was going to tear everything apart with his hands right away, and yet he didn’t order this elite force to attack right away.

It’s probably because he didn’t know exactly how strong my side was, so I guessed he was on his guard for now. It was a very prudent decision.

Seeing me still sitting still, he clicked his tongue and gave an order.

“Don’t kill them yet. Just enough to leave a few breaths.”

The other participants around them retreated outside, and the combatants gradually narrowed the distance.

The hall became quiet for a moment.

The heat, which had been filthy and stinky until a while ago, turned into coolness and ugliness in an instant.

I smiled lightly.

Ironically, this atmosphere, which would soon be filled with corpses and blood, felt more comfortable than an auction of buying and selling people.

Humans were animals of adaptation, but had I already adapted to this world to this point? I didn’t know if that’s a good thing or a bad thing.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

As soon as I opened my mouth, Asher, who was sitting next to me, got up from her seat. And put her hand on the sword.

I spoke softly.

“It doesn’t matter if you kill them all.”

Opponents were dozens, and all were skilled in the 50s and 60s level.

On the other hand, there was only one Asher on my side.

But I didn’t care in the slightest. Even before the fight, the outcome was already decided.

Until now, she had only encountered monsters that are too out of the ordinary, but Asher was a strong person who belonged to the highest rank in this world.

If I hadn’t persuaded her and recruited her as an escort, she would have become a knight in the Black Star Order, the elite power of the Overlord Castle.

Even if Valkilov was the best organization in the Third Lord’s territory, the status itself was quite different. It was a wolf among a herd of rabbits.

The difference in level in the RaSa worldview was so absolute and absurd.

“Ah...”

One combatant tried to open his mouth.

That was his last word.

Aah.

A huge beam of light emanating from Asher’s sword split in all directions.

Then, their bodies were torn apart in an instant and collapsed.

It couldn't even be called a battle. Valkilov's fighters were wiped out without being able to resist once.

For me, it was a natural result, but for those who watched, it was not.

“Uhhh!”

The participants, who could not grasp the situation for a moment, started screaming and running away in all directions.

While the hall was engulfed in chaos, I stared at the guy on the podium, Jack.

“...!”

As I looked at the situation with disinterest in my eyes, the pupil of the man who made eye contact with me shook as if an earthquake had occurred.

Then he flew straight away from the podium.

Wow...

He's running away like that?

Asher immediately ran after him.

Chapter 36.2: Vampire (5)

Chapter 36.2: Vampire (5)

The sword swung from behind, frightened, he tried to defend himself. For a moment, the two of them exchanged blows.

Being level 70, he could hold out a little, but that was the limit. Shortly thereafter, one of his arms was cut off, and he was thrown against the wall and thrown to the ground.

“Keuk...!”

Asher put down her sword and turned around.

It’s all over really quickly.

I nodded in admiration for her overwhelming power.

The auctioneers, as well as the hosts and members of the organization, had already fled, leaving only the slaves in the podium’s corner.

They were looking this way in fear, unable to escape anywhere. There was also Rudica’s older sister.

“Release the restraints.”

“Yes.”

“There will be more inside, so bring them along and gather them in one place.”

I left the slaves to Asher, and she trudged away.

Asher's sword ripped his stomach apart and cut off one of his arms, and the dying man barely raised his head.

"You, what the hell are you...?"

I stopped right in front of him.

"I told you, the Seventh Lord."

"..."

"You still can't believe it? It no longer matters anyway."

"Why why..."

As if he still couldn't believe it, he repeated those words with a completely exhausted face.

Why the hell was the Seventh Lord here? Why the hell did I kill his younger brother and do this?

It was a question that I could understand without him having to say anything else.

I looked down at him and said.

"Just because."

"..."

"Of all the garbage in this world, you just accidentally, unluckily, bothered my eyes. That's all."

It was really just that.

I found a vampire by chance, and happened to see his brother's evil deeds, so I killed him, and then I took part in the auction and got caught.

I didn't particularly have a grudge against them. Things just happened.

Of course, as a result, the auction was over, and the chief would soon die, so it seemed that Valkilov would be finished as of today.

The guy who had been glaring at me with eyes with resentment squeezed his last strength and got up as if he was bouncing.

His still good hand pulled a dagger from his waist.

A cold steel aimed at my neck and stabbed me with a warlike cry, but it was a futile effort.

Because his movements seemed too slow and clear for my super sensory.

The blade blocked by the floating veil could no longer advance in the air and stopped.

The guy opened his eyes and the hand holding the dagger shook, then he stumbled again and collapsed to the floor.

I placed my hand on the head of the man, who could no longer move as if he had reached the limit. Then I activated [Instant Kill].

That was his last moment.

I turned to the slaves, not paying attention to the corpse. Asher had released them from restraint and they were looking at this side.

Shortly thereafter, Asher brought out some more slaves from the inside.

“Is that all of them?”

“Yes, that’s right.”

I tilted my head as I looked at them gathered in one place.

It seemed that there were fewer people than the number of people in the auction earlier... Were there people who escaped on their own?

“Human, what are you going to do with us?”

Then someone opened her mouth with a ferocious voice.

Rudica's older sister was a vampire. Her eyes still glared at us as if we were the enemies.

It was unfair since we saved them, but I understood.

Her families died at the hands of humans, and since they had captured her as a slave, it was natural for her to hate humans.

I asked her.

"Are you Rudica's older sister?"

She was startled by my words and widened her eyes.

"Ru, Rudica? How can I you know my sister..."

"I came to rescue you at the request of your sister. So there is no need to be wary."

I outlined it to her. The circumstances from meeting Rudica at Cubax to coming to the auction house here.

After hearing the whole story, she looked at me with a look of joy and relief, but she was still half vigilant.

"...Are you really here at the request of my younger sister? Really?"

"Yeah. Or how would I know your sister's name?"

"..."

"She's in an inn in this city, waiting for you to come. So follow me."

She hesitated and looked back at Asher and I.

As I gave her a wink, Asher grabbed her by the shoulder and pulled her away.

So she slowly came to where I was standing.

I looked around at the other slaves.

I achieved the goal by securing Rudica's older sister, but what would happen to the rest of these people?

Oh, I really hated doing things like this in another territory.

I remembered about the Third Lord—the Heavenly Palace.

He was as unpredictable as the Overlord, and I did not know how he would react if this event reached his ears.

Even in the game, he appeared to be indifferent to everything in the world, while being strangely tenacious over trivial matters.

It's not about who was killed and what damage the Lords care about. Would the Third Lord care about the Valkilov?

He could still be dissatisfied with the fact that another Lord had made a riot in his realm.

Even the Sixth Lord—the Tyrant, who did not differ from a madman, didn't act arbitrarily in another Lord's territory.

Of course, this wasn't a huge problem since I was the one who was first attacked... Anyway.

"You are now free."

I spoke as if declaring to the slaves, who were looking at me with anxious eyes.

Even after that, they just stood there looking at each other with bewildered faces.

Even if I suddenly gave them freedom, there were some people who had nothing and had no place to return to.

It's impossible to leave this mess and leave them here.

So, I was thinking of doing a minimal clean up first.

Chapter 37.1: Vampire (6)

Chapter 37.1: Vampire (6) Two ! Thank you to Hillpond for the donation!
^^

The mayor of the city of Domihawk, Ballon, was living a normal life.

After having a late dinner and enjoying tea time alone on the terrace, he was reading until dawn before going to bed.

It was then that an unexpected guest came to the mansion.

“No... Sir Begos, what are you doing here at dawn?”

Seeing the man who had entered the central hall of the mansion being guided by the knights standing on the guard, Ballon blinked.

Begos, a high-ranking official of the territory.

Ballon was acquainted with him.

Because it was the mayor Ballon who tacitly allowed Valkilov's secret auction to be held in this city, and Begos was the VIP of that auction.

Today was the day of the auction.

Aside from visiting at dawn like this, Begos' expression looked somewhat urgent, so Ballon looked at him suspiciously.

Begos took a deep breath and said.

“I'm sorry that I came to you at such a late hour, but... something happened at the auction.”

“At the auction, what...”

“Some madman massacred the people of the auction house. All the managers died, and so did that Jack. The Valkilov is over.”

“...Yes? Jack? Over? You mean the Valkilov’s chief is dead?”

Ballon asked in surprise.

The demon Jack of the Domihawk, the biggest tycoon in the shadow of the Third Lord’s Territory, was killed out of nowhere.

He was resourceful, but also had skills strong enough to back up his reputation.

“Who the hell did you say they were murdered by?”

“That, I don’t know. It’s not even many people, but only one.”

“There’s only one person... shouldn’t they be someone well known in the territory?”

“Then I should have known about them. Anyway, that’s why I came to have a discussion with you in a hurry... Let’s go inside.”

It was then...

“Mayor.”

One knight who rushed in said in a trembling voice.

Ballon looked at him curiously.

“What’s going on again?”

“Well, that’s... the Seventh Lord has come.”

For a moment, Ballon blinked for a few seconds, wondering what kind of bullshit this was, and then asked.

“Who’s here?”

“The Seventh Lord has come to visit you.”

Now the knight’s words didn’t sound any different to Ballon’s, telling him that everyone in the auction house was dead.

So... the Seventh Lord?

...*Why?*

Why did the Seventh Lord suddenly come to visit him?

Was it someone impersonating him? It couldn’t be. What kind of madman would come to the mayor of one of cities of Calderic under the guise of a Lord?

“...!”

It was a natural flow of thought, so the knights on guard suddenly came to the mansion and had no choice but to bring the man who called himself the Seventh Lord and the people of various races behind him.

Ballon’s eyes widened at the sight of strangers slowly entering one by one.

The gaze of the man standing in front of them turned to him.

“Is this the house of the mayor of Domihawk?”

“...Yes! I am Ballon, Mayor of Domihawk.”

Ballon immediately bowed his back at a right angle, feeling a sense of incomprehensible pressure.

No matter how far they were from the Seventh Lord’s territory, they in the Third Lord’s territory knew at least the least information about the Seventh Lord. That he was a human male.

So, the man in front of Ballon right now could really be the Seventh Lord.

Meanwhile, Begos was astonished to see the man, the Seventh Lord, and Asher standing next to him.

W-what...

At the auction house, the two were wearing a mask, but he could still recognize them.

An unidentified man and woman who annihilated Valkilov's fighters and turned the auction house into a slaughterhouse.

The Seventh Lord turned his head and looked at Begos.

Begos lost his mind for a moment, then hurriedly bowed his back.

“...It is an honor to see the Seventh Lord! I am Begos, an officer in this territory!”

Now he understood the situation.

It was truly weird at first. Because just where could such a formidable talent come from?

He thought it had something to do with some other big organization, but it turned out that it was a Lord himself.

Jack, you crazy bastard, what the hell have you done?

It was obviously Valkilov's side who tried to attack the Seventh Lord first at the auction house, saying that the invitation was stolen.

Begos couldn't understand what the hell was going on and how it had been twisted into such a non-funny situation.

The Seventh Lord's mouth opened again.

“Mayor, I have come to request you something.”

...Request?

Ballon answered, still bowing his head and rolling his eyes dizzily.

“Yes, please tell me!”

“Did you know that Valkilov’s secret auction is being held in this city?”

For a moment, Ballon and Begos had their hearts pounding.

“That, that’s....”

“Of course you knew. I’m not trying to blame you for that. I’m talking about the people behind me now. They were sold as slaves to the auction house, but they didn’t deserve it such treatment.”

Begos, who knew the context of the situation, swallowed his saliva.

Ballon also remembered the story he had heard from Begos and the other’s reaction and quickly inferred the situation.

...Was the Seventh Lord the one who carried out the massacre at the auction house?

The Seventh Lord glanced back and spoke.

“So, I want you to take responsibility for their personal affairs. I want you to give money to those who have a place to go back, and I want those who have nowhere to go to find a suitable job.”

It wasn’t a very difficult request, but Ballon was puzzled.

It was because it felt bizarre that a Lord was taking care of the affairs of slaves.

Was this the original inclination of the Seventh Lord, or did it mean something else?

He couldn’t guess, but he didn’t dare question it.

“Leave it to me. I will thoroughly guarantee their safety.”

“Yeah, that’s the end of the business. Then I’ll leave.”

Then the Seventh Lord immediately turned away, leaving the slaves behind.

An escort knight and a vampire followed him.

Chapter 37.2: Vampire (6)

Chapter 37.2: Vampire (6)

Ballon and Begos looked at each other in embarrassment because of the Lord's sudden appearance and sudden departure.

“It was an honor of a lifetime to see the Seventh Lord!”

The two did not straighten their backs until the Lord and they could no longer see his entourage.

On the inside, they were very relieved.

Just thinking about how terrifying it would be if they had been held responsible for anything related to the auction.

Of course, this was the Third Lord's territory, and it was entirely the mayor's authority to manage this city of Domihawk. But still.

“...I suddenly feel 10 years older.”

Begos muttered with a face like he was exhausted just as he said.

Ballon nodded and agreed.

“Why the hell did the Seventh Lord come to the city of Domihawk...?”

“How can we guess the thoughts of the great people? Think of it as fortunate that it passed like this safely.”

Ballon sighed as he looked at the slaves left by the Seventh Lord.

“So, the person in the auction house Sir Begos was talking about is the Seventh Lord, right?”

“That’s right.”

“So what about Valkilov now?”

“What are you asking about something obvious? It’s completely over. If you have any connection with them, cut it off as soon as possible. Huh... I’ll have to go back to the castle in a hurry, too. What kind of lightning bolt is this?”

The slaves’ personal problems were handled simply and reliably using the mayor.

The reason for the massacre at the auction house was that Valkilov attacked first, not because I was going to enforce some kind of justice.

We immediately returned to the inn.

Rudica was waiting patiently in the inn’s room with Baros.

Rudica’s eyes widened when she saw her sister.

“Sister!”

“...Rudica!”

The two immediately ran to each other and hugged each other.

Maybe she didn’t completely trust me, and she, who was still on the verge of breaking point, burst into tears as soon as she saw her sister and hugged her in her arms.

I looked at them and asked Baros.

“Did nothing happen?”

“Yes.”

After the sisters’ reunion was over, she thanked me with a face that was completely dispelled by doubts.

“Thank you so much for helping us.”

The older sister’s name was Rubica.

I told the two sisters to sit down. It was so we could talk about the Elrod Forest.

Rudica had already heard the story, but her older sister, Rubica, did not know about it yet.

Rubica listened to what I was saying while clasping her sister in one of her arms.

“Elrod... forest?”

After listening to all the stories, Rubica, who seemed to have a vigilant personality, showed a slightly uneasy look as expected.

“It’s the home of another tribe, and we don’t know if they’ll welcome us....”

They were sisters who lost their hometown because they were driven out by their own people from where they originally lived.

If I asked them to visit another vampire tribe, the other’s reaction was just normal.

There were many reasons vampires had a bad image in this world.

Adults could suppress their vampire instincts, but not all adults suppress their desire for blood.

It was just like humans. Adults could control their desires better than children, but where in the world were there only such great adults?

Especially the Sixth Lord, the Tyrant, he's the best example of a bad adult vampire.

When such people gather to form a tribe, they literally became a swarm of who hunted other races.

The tribe that had invaded the land of the two sisters probably also belonged to that kind.

“Don’t worry about that part.”

I said in a confident voice to wash away their anxiety.

“The vampire tribe living in Elrod Forest is a very gentle tribe. Humans like me will be rejected by them, but if they are of the same kind, they will accept it.”

Of course, I had never seen them in person.

Still, the reason I could be so sure was because I had played the game.

When the episodes related to Elrod Forest in the game story progressed, vampires who went to the Elrod Forest for reasons similar to these sisters appeared.

The tribe from Elrod Forest embraced all of them and lived peacefully amongst themselves.

Except for one ‘problem’.

And by solving that problem, there’s a chance that I would get the blood magic I needed so much.

Rubica said nothing as if she was in trouble for a moment, then asked me.

“But you... no, he....”

“It’s Ron.”

“Yes, is Ron friendly with the vampire tribe that lives in the Elrod Forest? Hearing the story, it seems like you know them well.”

These two probably now thought that I was trying to introduce them to the tribe at Elrod Forest out of pure goodwill, but it was the opposite.

I was going to use these sisters to connect with the vampires there.

I nodded, feeling a bit of a prick in my conscience.

“I met a vampire from there. That’s why I know about Elrod Forest.”

Anyway, I have to take them to Elrod Forest, so it was important to reassure them first.

Rubica, who looked like she in agony again, nodded as if she had decided.

“Okay. We’ll go to Elrod Forest as Ron said. Thank you for being so kind to us.”

“Good decision.”

The persuasion was over.

Now it was time to head to Elrod Forest to get blood magic.

Chapter 38.1: Blood Magic (1)

Chapter 38.1: Blood Magic (1)

Elrod Forest was a vast forest in the northwest of Calderic.

It was in Calderic's territory. It was one place that remained in its natural state since civilization blossomed on this huge fantasy continent.

In Calderic alone, there were many large and small cities in the Overlord's territories and the other nine Lord's territories. However, there were still lands that remained abandoned on the outskirts.

Oh, it's shaking badly.

And that meant that the road to Elrod Forest had not been reclaimed at all, unlike the roads to cities and such.

I looked at the other side of the carriage, which was shaking more violently than usual, keeping my expression expressionless.

The vampire sisters sitting with Asher, leaned on each other and had fallen asleep.

A few days had passed since we started heading from the city of Domihawk to Elrod Forest.

It was the same journey as always, but if there was something different, it was that the two vampires were accompanying them.

“...”

I gazed at the two sleeping sisters.

Rubika was obviously trying to act more like an adult as she was an older sister, but looking at them like this, she was just a child sitting side by side with her sister.

Asher, who was sitting next to them, was also looking at them with strange eyes, but when our eyes met, she looked away as if hesitating.

She probably thought of her dead brother as she looked at the vampire sisters.

Then Asher muttered and said;

“Can I ask the Lord something I’m curious about?”

“...?”

My eyes widened in surprise.

Because she had never asked me anything before.

“Go ahead.”

“That... No, Sir Ron has been looking for places like ruins until now.”

Asher stuttered and asked a question.

During the journey, I told them to call me by my first name, not the title of ‘Lord’.

But Asher rarely called me in the first place, so she looked unfamiliar with using my name.

But why did she suddenly ask that question?

“It’s just that I’m curious what your purpose is for doing that.”

Ah... that’s it.

She is asking that now too.

I was continuing a very fruitful journey, finding and absorbing the mysteries, but I didn't consider Asher's point of view, so it was natural for her to wonder what the hell I was doing.

Besides, the reason she's following me as an escort right now was because of my promise to make her name known all over the continent.

However, what I was doing was not like something a Lord would do, so maybe she was frustrated in her heart right now.

I'm going to do a lot of things in the future, that's what I said to her...

But I didn't mean to say anything like that.

Even after completing this journey and returning to my territory, there were still piles of obstacles to overcome.

In particular, the Invasion of the Demons, the Hero of Santea, the Succession of the Holy Sword...

These events were too big to plan anything right now.

Anyway, when the next Lords' meeting comes, the Overlord will probably trust me enough to order me to do something.

Once I found all the mysteries in Calderic, I had to think about the overall situation.

I felt sorry for Asher, but I hoped she would wait until then.

I thought to myself and said.

"I'm looking for something. I know you're curious, but I can't tell you what it is yet."

"..."

"Don't worry. I'll definitely keep the promise I made to you."

“...Yes?”

Asher blinked, as if not understanding what I said. Then she said, “Oh,” and nodded.

“I was just curious. I never doubted what Sir Ron said.”

“...”

My conscience pricked me again because of her undeniable trust.

I slowly looked out the window.

As the sun was rising in the middle of the sky, the carriage stopped for lunch.

The sisters, who had been asleep, also woke up.

The menu was meat, soup and bread as usual.

Baros finished getting his meal quickly and sat down to eat in a suitable place, while Rudica stopped eating the soup and looked at Rubica.

“What is it, Rudica? Do you want blood?”

Rubica immediately noticed her sister’s condition and raised her arms.

But Rudica hesitated and just looked to the side where I was sitting.

I opened my mouth.

“It’s okay, come here.”

Then Rudica looked at her sister once more and approached me as if she had been waiting.

Rubica put on a puzzled expression as Rudica clenched my forearm and sucked blood as if it were familiar.

“Ru, Rudica?”

It was the first Rudica drank my blood after Rubica joined the party. For her, it must have been an embarrassing sight.

“What are you doing, Rudica? Come and drink your sister’s blood. Don’t do that to our benefactor.”

But Rudica shook her head and continued to focus on drinking my blood.

Seeing that, Rubica had a shocked face. It looked just like how Baros had looked the last time.

“You, you. You always said that my blood was the best…”

…Why did I have a feeling that I was the bad guy in this situation?

Seeing her crying and muttering, I became embarrassed and just asked.

“Are you okay without blood?”

Although older than Rudica, Rubica was not yet a fully grown vampire. I wondered if her vampire instinct was running wild.

As I wondered about that, Rubica stared at me, swallowing her saliva.

And she shook her head in my amazement.

“…I’m fine. I’m a grown vampire, so I can stand it.”

It didn’t look like that though, but I didn’t want to ask for more because I didn’t want a scene where these two vampire sisters were stuck on both my arms, drinking blood.

Then Baros stepped forward and said to Rubica;

“Hey, vampire. If you want my blood….”

“No. It smells bad.

With the same reaction as Rudica before, Baros grew a little pale again.

Apparently, the blood of an elf was not appetizing to a vampire.

Chapter 38.2: Blood Magic (1)

Chapter 38.2: Blood Magic (1) 2 ! Thank you to transhumanist Sykes for the donation! ^^

After that, the trip went smoothly.

And as time passed, we finally arrived at Elrod Forest.

The others and I stood still for a moment and looked around the entrance to the forest.

It was a forest with that kind of spooky atmosphere because the trees were much larger than the trees from the ordinary forest.

The Elrod Forest here was just a huge forest that was not that known to the world.

The many mountain ranges and forests that existed on the continent were not individually named.

It was just that the vampires living here called the forest by that name.

“Then let’s go.”

Except for Baros, who had to protect the carriage, we immediately set out into the forest.

I don't know how long it will take.

The forest was so large that it was impossible to know how long it would take to find the vampires.

Still, I wasn't worried we wouldn't be able to find it.

As long as we kept moving deep into the forest, we would eventually run into them somehow.

And I also bought an expensive compass from Domihawk because I thought we could get lost.

Compared to a normal compass, it was a pair that showed each other's location. It was not a magical item, though, but probably something made of a material with properties similar to a magnet. Because this was a fantasy world.

Anyway, the other one was with Baros, so there would be no problem going back.

"It's kind of spooky."

As she was walking through the forest, Rubica looked around and said.

The trees were so large that the sun was obscured, so it was a dark forest overall.

I suddenly got curious and asked.

"Do vampires hate sunlight?"

Even during the day, they walked well under the sun, but I wondered if they hated it or something.

Rubica looked at me curiously and shook her head.

"No? It's not. Rather, I hate darker places like this."

Right. That solved one question.

It would take quite some time to wander around the forest to find the vampire tribe, so I brought plenty of food.

However, they also supplied food through hunting. Of course, the hunting was up to Asher.

And, of course, not only ordinary beasts but also monsters appeared.

Kuung.

A huge boar fell to Asher's sword and became a cold corpse.

It was quite disgusting to see tiny thorns all over its body.

Among the monsters that appeared in this forest, there were definitely some that I did not know.

This was because the Elrod Forest itself was an unfamiliar field that had hardly been explored in the game. When I met vampires in related quests, I just passed by it for a moment.

“Wow...”

Rudica's eyes lit up as Asher quickly defeated the monster and watched the other retrieve the sword.

Because she had never seen Asher fought.

Rubica, who had seen the massacre at the auction house, seemed to be a little afraid of Asher.

“How can I be as strong as you?”

At Rudica's question, Asher scratched her cheek in embarrassment.

“You just have to train.”

“How do you train?”

“...Swinging the sword without a break every day. And also fight against stronger opponents.”

It didn't seem easy to explain to a child.

Rudica nodded and shouted.

“If I live here, I will train every day! I have to become stronger to protect my sister and my new friends!”

“...”

At those words, Rubica also had a gloomy look.

Asher looked at the sisters with a slightly pitiful look.

She also had a past when her clan was annihilated, so she could understand their experience.

Anyway, it was already the third day after we started wandering around the forest like that.

“...”

As we were walking down the forest road as usual, I felt something approaching us quickly.

Asher and I turned our heads in that direction.

From afar, I saw a figure leaping over the branches of the trees and sprinting towards us.

Even from a distance, the other's image was clearly visible through my super sensory.

A man with dark hair, red eyes, and dressed like a hunter suitable for the forest.

【Lv. 51】

Vampire.

A vampire.

The level seen above his head was quite high at 51.

The vampire we were searching for had finally appeared in front of us, and I felt joy, but I was also a little nervous.

Then the vampire landed on a branch of a nearby tree, stopped and looked down at us. I also stared at him.

Naturally, in the eyes of the other person, friendly feelings were not visible at all.

“Humans... and vampires?”

The guy who was looking at us asked in a slightly confused voice.

“What are you? Why did you come into this forest?”

It must have been a very unusual situation for him.

No one usually came to such a deep part of the forest in the first place, but if the unexpected visitor was a combination of a human and a vampire.

I asked him, perplexed.

“Are you from the vampire tribe of Elrod Forest?”

Chapter 39.1: Blood Magic (2)

Chapter 39.1: Blood Magic (2)

He furrowed his brows in response to my question.

“How...? How do you know vampires live in this forest, human?”

I replied in a no-nonsense tone.

“Do you think there is a perfect secret in this world? I’ve heard that your people have lived in this forest for a very long time. To think that no one knows, that’s arrogance.”

“...”

He just stared at me with eyes full of hostility, without saying a word.

Beside me, the vampire sisters were staring at the other with a look of restlessness.

I continued to speak.

“I have no malice when I said that. There is only one reason for coming to this forest. It’s so these vampires who had lost their homes and tribe could have a new home here.”

“...What?”

“These are vampires who lived in the mountains north of Calderic. The tribes who lived there had a fight, so most of the tribe members died. They barely survived and escaped.”

His gaze turned to the sisters.

There must already be a few such vampires in the tribe of Elrod Forest, so he would have understood the situation right away with my explanation.

“So, can’t you be merciful and accept them as a member of your tribe? That’s the only reason we came here.”

He looked at the sisters and I silently, and said;

“...I don’t understand. Aside from the circumstances of those young vampires, why did you, a human, bring them here?”

“I saved them from slave hunters. And I just knew that there was a vampire tribe living in this forest.”

It was then that I felt other signs of people coming this way.

Vampires, who just appeared, landed on either side of the branch in the direction the male vampire appeared.

And when they found us, they looked startled, then frowned.

“...Humans and vampires? What’s happening here, Floke?”

The name of the vampire I was talking to was Floke.

He explained the situation to his colleagues.

The vampires glanced at us and made a strange expression after hearing all the explanations.

They quietly discussed what to do for a moment. But I heard everything because of my super sensory.

“First of all, let’s report it...”

“Yeah, then one should watch them...”

They concluded what they should do and told me.

“Do nothing there and wait patiently, human. If you really have no other intentions and you’re only here to help those young vampires, you should be able to do that.”

“Okay.”

I answered obediently.

It seemed that they were going to bring in a high-ranking vampire to decide what should they do to Rudika and Rubica, so we should wait here.

The other vampires left again, and only one remained, watching us warily.

He stood there silently, waiting for someone else to come.

A space with a gloomy atmosphere.

A female vampire stood still, closed her eyes, and caught her breath.

She was standing in front of a huge rock in the center of the room, and in a notch in the middle of the rock was a single red stone the size of a fist wrapped in black chains.

An ominous stone that alone illuminated this underground space without a single light from the outside with fiery red light.

Below the rock, there were other vampires watching it with anxious eyes.

“...”

The woman slowly opened her eyes and put her hand on the red stone.

When her hand touched it, the stone blew out an even more intense blood red light.

An ominous energy emanating from the stone filled the space.

The energy that made even vampires watching it tremble. The woman alone was receiving it.

Then, the blood that flowed from her body was slowly absorbed into the stone.

The woman's expression, who had maintained her composure, was then distorted with pain.

But it wasn't just the blood being absorbed by the stone.

Khahahahahahaha...!

A bizarre and terrifying laugh that gnawed at the soul.

That overwhelming mental wave echoing in her head was something she couldn't get used to, even though she had experienced it dozens of times.

The woman kept her consciousness that was about to collapse and waited for the end.

The light from the stone slowly faded away.

And the stone that returned to its original state seemed to have a little less red light than before.

“...Ha.”

The woman who had successfully completed the ceremony stumbled down the stairs.

The vampires waiting below rushed towards her.

“Sister... are you okay?”

A man came forward and supported her.

Throughout the ceremony, he was watching with painful eyes, as if he were doing it himself.

The woman nodded and gently removed his arm.

“It’s okay. Don’t make a fuss about.”

Seeing her still trembling while saying that, the man’s face became even more troubled.

A ritual to suppress the energy of blood.

It was a duty that the chieftains have inherited from generation to generation, and it was also a responsibility that must be fulfilled for the peace of the tribe.

Therefore, as the ceremony progressed, there was nothing the man could do while watching her sister lose her lifespan.

The man turned his gaze and looked again at the stone embedded in the rock.

How long did the tribe have to waste the lives of their brethren for that damn thing? Until when...

“Rest, sister. Take care of the chieftain.”

Out of the underground space, the woman left with the other vampires.

The man looked back at her and sighed.

At that time, a vampire from the other side ran towards this side quickly. It was a warrior tasked with periodically reconnaissance of the forest.

“Chief Warrior.”

The man looked at the other with puzzled eyes.

“What’s going on?”

Hearing the report that followed, the man frowned slightly.

“...Humans brought young vampires? How did he know about our tribe?”

“I don’t know myself. That’s why I hurriedly reported it to you.”

“How many humans were there?”

“Only two.”

The man glanced in the direction the woman had disappeared and then nodded.

“I will go directly with the warriors. For now, please do not report to the chieftain.”

Chapter 39.2: Blood Magic (2)

Chapter 39.2: Blood Magic (2) Thank you to Blah-ness for sponsoring 5 chapters! ^^

How many minutes did we wait?

I could feel many people coming closer from far away.

There were so many more than I expected, so I was a little perplexed.

...Why are so many coming here?

Eventually, the vampires appeared and climbed up on the trees everywhere as if besieging us where we stood.

The number of vampires was easily over 10. In addition, their level was all over 60.

As if they were coming to fight some kind of battle, Asher's expression hardened, and the two sisters looked around with a frightened face.

"It really is a human."

One vampire said as if muttering.

I made eye contact with him.

It was immediately recognizable that he was the leader of their group.

It was because of the level above his head.

【Lv. 81】

After checking the level, I could immediately recognize his identity.

Of the vampire tribes of Elrod Forest, there was only one strong person who reached this level.

Chief Warrior Calderban.

The chief's younger brother and the strongest warrior of Elrod Forest.

As I recalled, five years later, his level was 83, which was higher than it was now.

I didn't expect him to suddenly come out of here.

"Human, answer the question properly."

He was exchanging glances with me, and then he opened his mouth.

"How did you know our tribe existed in this forest?"

I had given a moderate answer earlier, but it seemed like they were trying to get a more definite answer.

Probably because this was a very important issue to them.

For a long time, they had been quietly living in this forest, avoiding the eyes of the public, but out of nowhere, a human who knew their existence suddenly appeared.

After thinking for a while, I answered.

"Isn't it more strange that I don't know?"

"...What?"

"Even though this forest is not visited by others, this is the realm of Calderic. The eyes of the Lords are everywhere and there are many intelligence organizations. You have lived in this forest for nearly 100 years.

If you truly thought that no one would know of your existence, that's simply arrogance."

Indeed, the Overlord and some Lords were aware of their existence. They didn't think of them as a threat, so they just leave them alone.

And they had actually settled in the Elrod Forest for over 200 years. I purposely said it wrong.

It was to make them think I didn't understand everything. Because if I knew too much, their boundaries would become stronger.

I could feel Rubica looking at me with a puzzled look.

Because when I explained to her, I told her I had a relationship with the vampire tribe from this forest.

She might wonder why I didn't say that to these vampires, but it was a lie, so I couldn't say it. In the first place, the vampires of Elrod Forest lived and died in this forest for the rest of their lives, so how could anyone have met them?

Anyway, the chief warrior, who was staring at me without responding, seemed to be convinced to some extent. He changed the subject.

"You said you rescued the two vampires who were captured as slaves and you came here to bring them to our tribe. Are they those children?"

"Yes."

Rubica, who was watching, stepped forward and said.

"...We are vampires who lived in the mountains north of Calderic! And they rescued us with genuine good intentions and brought us here."

The atmosphere was harsh, so she seemed to want to defend me.

He glanced at her, then nodded.

“If you have lost a place to return to, our tribe will welcome you with open arms.”

“...”

“But not the humans. We can never bring them into the village. So, send the children there first.”

At that, they looked at me with anxious eyes.

I nodded my head.

“It’s okay, go.”

They hesitated and moved to the side of the vampires.

The chief warrior nodded to one vampire.

After receiving that nod, the vampire took the sisters in her arms and climbed the branches and moved into the forest. And then they disappeared in an instant.

I turned my gaze to the chief warrior.

Now it was time to bring my purpose out.

“I have a story I want to tell you.”

I stopped talking.

Because the atmosphere suddenly became serious.

The hostility felt from the vampires standing around us as if they were surrounding us grew stronger. And...

Aww!

The sudden attack from the front was blocked by Asher instead.

A thorn made of blood shattered to pieces by her sword.

Her expression ferociously distorted, and she glared at the vampires.

I looked at the chief warrior and asked.

“What are you doing?”

He answered in a calm tone.

“I’m sorry, but you can’t leave the forest alive.”

“Is it because I was aware of your tribe’s existence? Didn’t I just say that I wasn’t the only one who knew about you?”

“No, that’s not it.”

He shook his head.

“Thank you very much for saving our people. But we’ve never let an outsider who has entered this forest leave alive. That’s how we have kept our home and peace for many years, and there are no exceptions.”

The vampires around them immediately took a fighting stance.

The blood that flowed from their bodies gathered in the air and formed a shape. Some were huge, some are sharp.

“So die here, human.”

I sighed inwardly.

These dog-like vampire cubs....

Did I think too easily?

I saved their people, so I didn’t expect they would still try to kill us like this.

Soon there was blood rushing all over the place where we were standing.

I grabbed Asher's shoulder, preparing for battle, and pulled him closer.

"Uh..."

"Stand close to me."

And I immediately opened the floating veil.

At the same time, attacks poured in from all sides.

The non-stop blood flow saturated the place where the humans were standing.

While the other warriors were pouring out their attacks, the chief warrior Calderban also prepared an attack with all his might.

Uh uh.

The blood that flowed from his body condensed in the air and turned purple.

It was a unique blood skill he possessed. If somebody was hit by this extremely poisonous blood, no matter how strong the opponent was, they had no choice but to melt away without a trace.

Violet blood formed as huge thorns rotated like a whirlpool and swept the place where the humans stood.

Aww!

The site swept away by the bloodstream disappeared as it was, leaving ruins.

Without evading the bombardment of the elite warriors, the humans were directly hit.

Calderban had no doubts that this was the end.

However, his eyes widened in astonishment at the sight that was revealed after the blood and dust had disappeared.

“...!”

The humans were still standing in the same place. Even without a single piece of clothing ruffled.

The chief warrior and other warriors were in shock at the sight beyond the common sense and did not take any action.

This makes little sense...

The human man looked around leisurely.

“Is this the end?”

He spoke in an arrogant and indifferent voice, as if muttering.

“This doesn’t feel good.”

Chapter 40.1: Blood Magic (3)

Chapter 40.1: Blood Magic (3)

Oh, fuck...

I looked around the vampires everywhere while maintaining my poker face.

The floating veil brilliantly blocked all the rushing attacks.

Even in the game, this absolute defense, which was a 9-star skill, could not be penetrated by just this level.

But that was the end.

The only thing I could do in this situation was to stand still and defend, and I was just bluffing. If I opened my mouth, it would be over.

Still, the vampires all froze on the spot.

Now what?

If a full-fledged battle continued like this, we were going to lose.

I was too busy protecting my body, so it's hard to use instant kill.

And this was their home. It was possible for them to continuously replenish power.

No matter how much vampire Asher defeated, it would just be a fight with no end.

Damn, should I have been more careful about coming to this forest?

“...I.”

I turned my gaze away when I heard a bewildered voice next to me.

Asher, who was almost in my arms, couldn't find a place to turn her gaze.

I sighed and let go of her shoulders. I was so nervous that I forgot.

Asher looked around the ruined radius with a slightly puzzled face.

I had never used the Floating Veil in front of her, except for a brief use during the Orc King's attack.

I looked at the chief warrior again and said.

“Are you going to do more?”

The only thing I could do was to bluff, so I had no choice but to overcome the situation with that.

He didn't respond and just stared at me. There was a look of tension in his eyes that differed from before.

“You were so confident before. How stupid.”

“...”

“You don't know who I am, and you don't know how much power gap there is between us. You should be glad that I don't have any hostility towards you. Or your tribe would have all perished today.”

“Human, who are you?”

At my words, he asked with an angry expression.

It was the flow of conversation that I intended, so I tried to answer right away. And that was the moment.

“...?”

I sensed someone rushing from afar at a formidable speed.

Shwaah!

A bloody sphere that flew through the trees, drawing traces that were drooping.

The vampires looked at the sphere in surprise.

A sphere stopped in front of me. A little further from where I was standing, it slowly formed into a person and a woman appeared.

She put on the robe that she took out from the sphere and put it over her messy hair.

【Lv. 67】

“...Sister!”

The chief warrior shouted in amazement.

At that call, I immediately knew her identity.

Chieftain?

Aklina, chieftain of the Elrod Forest tribe.

It was just her unique blood technique to turn the body into blood itself.

After the chief warrior, now the chieftain had come out.

“You’re too close, sister! He’s a dangerous human, so step back!”

She looked around the ruins once and met my eyes.

“I heard that there are humans who rescued young vampires... Please explain what the situation is, Calderban.”

The chief warrior seemed to flinch at her cold voice.

“You did not report about what happened and then even attacked them?”

The chief warrior and the other vampires could say nothing.

The chieftain let out a small sigh and looked towards me. Her eyes and mine met.

“I am the chieftain, Aklina.”

“...”

“On behalf of the tribe, I sincerely apologize for the atrocities committed by my tribe members.”

I was relieved once I heard that.

It was because her attitude showed that she had no intention of attacking us.

Unlike the warriors, who were especially wary and hostile toward other races in the game, the chieftain had a relatively finite personality, like the head of a peaceful tribe.

Still, since they attacked first, I said.

“If it were any other ordinary human who came to this forest, they would have already died. Are you going to apologize to the cold corpse like you do now?”

The chieftain sighed once more and said.

“As you know, the awareness of vampires in the world is not very good. This is the only place we can live normally, so we have to be extremely sensitive to other races entering our tribe’s land. Please understand our situation a little.”

I just clicked my tongue once and said nothing more.

Anyway, I came all the way here, because I had my purpose.

But before that...

“I am the Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

Originally, I had no intention of saying anything. Because they would only be more vigilant.

However, given the situation, it's important to make sure that none of what happened earlier happened again.

The topic I wanted to discuss with them was also a very sensitive issue directly related to the fate of their tribe.

At my words, the vampires, including the chieftain and the chief warrior, all seemed to be startled.

Even those who lived far away from the world cannot be unaware of the status and strength of the existence of a Lord in Calderic.

“A Lord?”

In particular, it was noticeable that the expression of the chieftain, who had remained calm, collapsed in an instant.

She asked in a slightly trembling voice.

“... As I recall, the Seventh Lord is not a human, but a beastman.”

What she was talking about was the former Seventh Lord.

She didn't even know that the Seventh Lord's seat was vacated by his death and that I had recently occupied it. Because in this forest, it was almost impossible to be updated from the current news.

“The former Seventh Lord was dead. And I am the new lord.”

Chapter 40.2: Blood Magic (3)

Chapter 40.2: Blood Magic (3)

At my words, the chieftain only fell silent.

Now that a Lord had come to the forest, she must be feeling a great sense of crisis right now.

I went straight to the main topic.

“I have a story I want to tell you. Would you like to hear it?”

“...Story?”

“I came to this forest to take the vampire sisters, but I also have another purpose. It’s about the ‘blood crystal’ of your tribe.”

The vampires looked at me in amazement.

They wouldn’t have expected that the word ‘blood crystal’ would come out of the mouth of an outsider who came to the forest out of nowhere.

“How do you know about the ‘blood crystal’?”

The chieftain, who had come to her senses, now looked at me with hostile eyes.

Blood crystal.

It was the biggest trouble that the vampire tribes of the Elrod Forest currently harbored.

I couldn't remember all the details of the background, but I remembered some important things roughly.

Ancestor Gascalid.

A time in the past, far before the tribes settled down in Elrod Forest.

Among the ancestors of these tribes was a powerful vampire.

He was an evil and ferocious vampire, unlike his descendants, who became a peaceful tribe. He was more like the current Sixth Lord.

He was defeated by an unknown archmage and was mortally wounded, and in the end, it was said that he died at the end of his life.

The death of a vampire did not differ from the death of other creatures. The bones and flesh rotted, and the body returned to nature.

However, he tried to maintain his existence until the moment of his death, not letting go of the lust for life.

That's how 'blood crystal' was created.

A stone in which the soul and blood of Gascalid are sleeping.

I think one of the elder vampires explained how that was possible in the game, but I couldn't remember. It was just a setting anyway, so it didn't matter.

The important thing was that the descendants took care of the evil stone that was like an image of Gascalid.

Along with the prophecy that the day when Gascalid was resurrected was the day the tribe would be destroyed, they had been performing rituals for generations to quell the blood crystal.

But the problem was the aftermath of the ritual.

A ceremony in which the blood of the chieftain, who inherited the blood of Gascalid, sacrificed their own blood to calm the blood crystal.

It was a ritual that not only sacrificed the blood, but also ate away the vitality and spirit of the person who performed it.

In a word, the chieftain of the Elrod Forest was destined to be short-lived the more they performed the ritual.

Even now, it was barely sealed, so they couldn't move it anywhere, and it would be irresponsible if they left it alone and left the forest.

Without being able to do this or that, the tribes of Elrod Forest had been squeezing the lives of the chieftain for generations.

And the reason I came to Elrod Forest was to solve that problem.

My purpose was to gain the vampire's 'blood magic' ability that could be obtained in solving it.

"I know your ancestor, Gascalid."

Now that we're ready to talk to each other, it's time to speak up.

The chieftain, who was staring at me, widened his eyes at those words.

"What just...?"

"It's the reason I know about the cursed thing your ancestor placed on you."

I unravelled the story I had envisioned in my head.

"Halion, the chieftain sealed the blood of Gascalid himself. Do you know?"

"..."

"If you are a chieftain, of course you know, since the records of your ancestors remain. I had a relationship with him, and he entrusted me with a

request. One day, when the time is right, I was asked to completely annihilate the blood crystal.”

“Hold on, wait.”

She stopped me from continuing. She had obviously become increasingly confused by my words.

“So... you mean a few hundred years ago when our ancestors were still alive?”

“Yes.”

At that, Asher looked back at me with a slightly startled expression.

Of course, it was a lie, but even if it was true, there was nothing wrong with it.

As you can see by looking at the Lords, for the superhumans who have crossed their boundaries in this world, the basic lifespan of a body was several hundred years.

I spoke with a slightly solemn face.

“I came here to keep that request. So, guide me to the place where the blood crystal is.”

It’s very absurd, but it’s hard not to believe it.

Or how would an outsider know about blood spirit and their ancestor?

I waited for the chieftain’s answer.

She, who had a complicated face as if in agony, bowed her head.

“I’m sorry, but you don’t have to.”

...Huh?

“This is a matter for our clan. I can’t just listen to a few words and leave the matter of blood crystal to an outsider. I’m sorry if everything you say is really true, but if you care about us, please go back.”

The return was a resolute refusal.

I was a little embarrassed because I didn’t know that she would give me a knife-like refusal.

“No, sister. We need to hear more of the story...”

Rather, the chief warrior, who had been more hostile towards me, panicked and stopped her.

“Goodbye then.”

She bowed to me once more and turned around firmly.

I looked at the back with a bit of embarrassment and then opened my mouth again.

...At least, I couldn’t come this far and just give up.

“Then I’ll have to force my way in.”

At my words, her steps stopped.

Then she looked at me with a hardened face.

“Actually, I don’t need your permission. This is an oath between me and your ancestor, and it must be kept.”

“...Even though I said that you don’t need to?”

I said shamelessly in a cold voice.

“Yeah. So, if you don’t want more clashes, lead me to the blood crystal. I don’t want to see the blood of the descendants of my dead friend flow here.”

Chapter 41.1: Blood Magic (4)

Chapter 41.1: Blood Magic (4)

A chilly atmosphere.

There was only the sound of the grass swaying in the wind amidst silence.

The chieftain's eyelids trembled slightly. She made eye contact with me, who was staring at her.

It was us who fell behind in power. Would they rekindle a situation that had calmed down at best?

But it was unacceptable to give up blood magic so easily and go back.

So I would try to do everything I could.

If persuasion didn't work, I had no choice but to push through with threats or bluffing.

...*She's considering it.*

After gaining super sensory, he became especially sensitive to understanding other people's emotions.

Every minute change in facial expression was clearly visible, so it was not weird for me to understand it.

She was keeping her expression as expressionless as possible as if she would not show any emotion, but she could not completely hide it.

“You mean you’re going to go to war with our whole tribe now? Even though you’re alone?”

Was I crazy? Why would I do that?

But the opposite of what I thought came out of my mouth. And rather brazenly too. I shook my head.

“War is an appropriate term when two opposing teams have equal strength to some extent. You are not enough to stop me.”

A human who threatened to deal with a tribe that would be in the thousands alone.

But none of the vampires could laugh at me.

It was a world where several people was meaningless in front of one superhuman.

I had already stated that I was a Lord. I also showed an overwhelming prestige by completely blocking the previous attacks.

They could never dismiss my words as bluffs.

I spouted hostility and continued to look at the vampires staring at me full of tension.

“Even if you somehow killed me, nothing will change. Because the other Lords would surely intervene. Then I don’t think I need to explain what would happen to your tribe.”

“...”

“So choose wisely, Chieftain.”

She bit her lips

I was putting a lot of pressure on them right now.

The matter of blood crystal was a very serious thing that they couldn't just give to an outsider who claimed that he was a friend of their ancestor, and if they didn't guide me, I would still enter their tribe recklessly.

That's why she looked very embarrassed right now.

I apologized, but let's just say it's your fault for attacking me first.

If it wasn't for the floating veil, I would have died dozens of times already.

How peaceful it was to be blackmailed only with words like this.

"My only purpose is to destroy the blood crystal. That is a promise I must keep."

"Are you making these kinds of threats... and want us to trust you?"

"Trust, that's good too. Anyway, I was just trying to let you know you don't have a choice."

"..."

"How long will your clan hold that cursed object in your arms? I know the rituals of bloodshed. Are you afraid of a clone of your ancestors who will never be resurrected, and will you continue to force such sacrifices on your bloodline? "

Being too harsh was also not good. If you push too hard and threatened them, it's all over.

Instead of just a whip, I gave them a carrot.

After all, they couldn't trust me, so what's the hesitation if I was sure I could handle the blood crystal?

The chieftain seemed to be in deep anguish.

I said no more and waited for an answer from her.

“...At least explain how you intend to destroy the blood crystal.”

She’s asking that too.

Since this was an expected question, I answered calmly.

“I will completely annihilate the soul of your ancestor, who sleeps in the blood crystal. It’s not too difficult for me.”

To be honest, I wasn’t sure about how to deal with the blood crystal.

Because I didn’t mean to deal with it the same way it was dealt in the game.

In the game’s story, the player’s wizard ally destroyed the soul of Gascalid by borrowing the power of a powerful artifact.

And if the soul was treated like that, those who were nearby naturally absorbed the masterless blood magic left on the stone. Regardless of race, like a mystery.

I didn’t have any such relics and there were no conditions to get them, so the attack on the blood crystal I saw in the game was something that I couldn’t do.

But I believed in something.

The [Soul of the King] which protected my mind.

And an instant kill that could kill any target.

With these two abilities I had, I could block Gascalid’s mental attacks and completely annihilate his soul by coming into contact with the blood crystal.

I still don’t know if instant kill actually works on souls, but...

Still, it was the one and only 10-star skill in the game. It didn’t seem like it wouldn’t work on a spirit body.

It was just a hunch, but it was a feeling close to certainty. Just like the last time I met the Golem Guardian in the dungeon.

“...”

The chieftain, who had been silent for a while, took a deep breath and said.

“I don’t know what the promise you made with our ancestor meant. You are the one who threatens the long-standing peace of our tribe.”

She turned around and said.

“Follow me, I’ll guide you.”

...Done.

Her voice was cold and full of reluctance, but I didn’t care and was happy inside.

The vampires also came down from the tree one by one and escorted her around as if to protect her from me.

The chief warrior also glanced at me with a complicated face and stuck to her side.

So I followed them and walked along with Asher.

Chapter 41.2: Blood Magic (4)

Chapter 41.2: Blood Magic (4)

As we entered the forest, buildings appeared one by one.

There were tents and wooden huts, and some large stone structures stood out. It's like something you would see in the city.

Although they lived in the wild, the size of the tribe and the fact that they had been in this place for a long time, it was almost like a small city.

“What about the vampires I brought?”

When asked about the two sisters' whereabouts, the chieftain answered.

“Our tribe does not exclude vampires from outside the forest. We will help them adjust to life here without any difficulties.”

On the road leading to the village, I saw the sisters with a vampire. It was the vampire who took them away.

When the sisters found me, they screamed in relief and ran to me.

“Ron!”

It was a strong reaction, as if we hadn't seen each other for a while.

Rubica glanced at the chieftain once and said to me.

“We didn't even say goodbye properly, so I thought we'd never see each other again... Did something happen? I think I heard a fight before...”

At those words, the chief warrior slowly turned his head and avoided her gaze.

As soon as you disappeared, I wanted to say that they started a surprise attack, but they gave up and I won in the end.

“It’s nothing.”

“Are you going to leave now?”

She took turns looking at me and Asher with a slightly sad look.

“I still have a problem to solve here, so I’ll just deal with it and leave. Don’t worry about me. Now you can live well with them.”

“...”

“I’m glad you found a new home.”

Rudica burst into tears, and Rubica soon nodded with tears in her eyes.

I didn’t know that even Rubica would react like this, so I was a little perplexed.

“Thank you very much, Ron. I will live with gratitude for the goodwill you have shown us for the rest of my life.”

I nodded my head without a word.

“Keep going.”

I urged the chieftain, who was watching the scene with strange eyes from the side, and started moving again.

As we moved to the depths of the village, the chieftain paused for a moment.

“Please wait here. We must inform the elders first.”

A few vampires scattered in different directions, probably to call those elders.

After waiting for a while, the old vampires gathered one by one.

“Chieftain.”

They gathered around the chieftain and talked for a while as they glanced over here.

As soon as they reached a conclusion, an old man with gray hair, who seemed to be the oldest of the elder vampires, approached me.

“I heard you are a close friend of one of our previous chieftains who can solve the problem of blood crystal. We could only believe what you have said because we have no choice.”

“Okay.”

He looked at me quietly and said.

“Can we watch the process of disposing of the blood crystal? Please, this is our only condition.”

It meant that they would at least watch if I was doing anything stupid.

I nodded my head, as it was otherwise irrelevant.

So, along with the chieftain, the warrior chief, and the elders, I went straight to the place where the blood crystal was.

It was a cave quite far from the village. Other vampires stood guard at the entrance.

After going inside and going down the sloped cave path, a large underground space appeared.

There was a huge rock in the center, and the red stone embedded on top of it was shining brightly and illuminating the surroundings with blood red light.

Is that the blood crystal?

I gazed at the stone that was emitting an aura that was so ominous at first glance.

It was like the scenery I saw in the game that remained in my memory.

The chieftain said to me.

“That’s the blood crystal. We did a ritual a while ago, so its energy is weak now.”

“Right.”

“Do you want to start right now?”

I nodded and walked up the stairs to the rock.

The closer I got to the stone, the more the ominous energy stabbed me. I hadn’t even touched the stone yet.

【Lv. 95】

The level displayed just above the blood crystal was a very good sign of how strong the energy was.

But I wasn’t worried.

As in the game, what a mere ghost could inflict was not physical damage.

If it’s just a mental attack, I believe the [Soul of the King] would completely block it. So there was no hesitation in my steps.

Standing right in front of the blood crystal, I slowly reached out towards it.

And as soon as I touched the stone, I felt an overwhelming presence invade my mind.

‘…Ha ha ha ha ha ha ha!’

A loud laughter echoed in my head.

The soul of Gascaid.

I quietly put my hands up and heard him chatter.

‘What. Are you human? Far from inheriting my blood, someone who is not a vampire dares to touch my spirit?’

Whoa!

The color of blood emanating from the stone grew stronger.

As his presence grew stronger, I could feel him emitting a flash to shake my mind.

How strong the mental wave was. The cave vibrated weakly, and even the vampires below staggered while holding their heads.

But it was as if I was alone in the middle of the eye of the typhoon.

With a very peaceful mind, I watched him riot. I was a little nervous at first though, but it’s really nothing.

Shortly thereafter, a voice of a bewildered man was heard.

‘What, what are you...? Why haven’t you lost your mind yet?!’

I also talked to him.

‘Hey, ghost.’

‘.....Huh?’

‘Oh, can you hear me? Anyway, thank you, I will use your abilities well.’

It was a very sincere thank you.

Now, I immediately activated instant kill to make it easier.

‘Die.’

Coo coo.

Its presence disappeared in an instant, and the vibration stopped.

As the energy that filled the cave disappeared as if it had evaporated, the vampires looked up at this side.

I ignored their gaze and stared down at the fading blood color on the stone.

Soon, even that faint blood color was all scattered and was absorbed into my body through the hand touching the stone.

Chapter 42.1: Blood Magic (5)

Chapter 42.1: Blood Magic (5) Another bonus chapter from the accumulated donations of Jok, Kitten, and Roachgoda! ^^

In an instant, starting with the hands, a foreign sensation filled up.

It's a strange sensation that was different from the uplifting feeling I get when I absorbed a mystery.

It felt as if the absorbed energy of blood flowed through the blood vessels and swept through the entire body once.

“...”

Soon, the stone did not emit even the slightest light anymore.

I looked at it and checked my body.

I already knew what kind of ability Gascalid's blood magic was, but this ability this was also intuitively engraved in my mind, just like when I absorbed the mysteries.

“What-, the light of blood crystal...!”

I heard the sound of the vampires from below.

I wanted to try using blood magic right now, but I couldn't because there were many eyes around.

I got up and trudged down the stairs.

The chieftain, who had been staring blankly at the crystal, turned her gaze to me.

I told her.

“It’s done.”

“...”

She just had a bewildered expression on her face.

It was an understandable reaction because the problem the tribe had suffered for many years was solved so easily. Because it’s really over with just the use of my one hand.

“Did you destroy the soul of our ancestor in the blood crystal?”

“Yeah. That rock won’t go wild anymore.”

Since I destroyed the soul and ate even the blood magic, there was no more energy left in it. It was now just an ordinary stone.

The elder vampires looked at each other and let out a sigh of relief.

In particular, the chief warrior could not contain his emotion.

“Sister! There is no need to perform any more ceremonies. You don’t have to waste your life anymore!”

Looking at it, I remembered the Elrod Forest episode in the game.

It was said that the chieftain at the time of sealing the blood crystal died.

The chieftains had given their life force to suppress the energy of the blood crystal through rituals.

As the years passed, it had become a natural responsibility of the chieftain and a tribal custom.

The chief warrior also inherited Gascalid's lineage, but he was such an accomplished warrior for the tribe that no one wanted his life to be wasted in rituals.

In fact, the chief warrior always had great guilt and regret for his sister who became the chieftain by replacing himself.

Knowing this background, it was understandable that he was so happy now.

Well, anyway, that's all.

My body was itching because I wanted to go out quickly and check the blood magic I just received.

After looking around for a long time to see the vampires that had lost their energy, the vampires finally accepted that the issue of blood crystal had been resolved.

Coming out of the cave, they formally thanked me.

“Thank you very much. I also sincerely apologize for doubting your promise to our ancestor. Thanks to the Lord, our tribe has finally found true peace today.”

The chieftains, warriors, and elders bowed their heads deeply.

Their attitude towards me was instantly the opposite of how they had been before, but I had no intention of blaming them.

It was me who pushed in recklessly in the first place, so that was a natural response. I didn't treat them with pure good intentions either anyway.

“I'm really sorry, Lord.”

Even the chief warrior apologized once again to me as if he was guilty.

Yes, you should be sorry.

He bowed his head, and I wanted to slap the exposed head of the other once, but I resisted it.

Instead, I spoke to confirm the newly gained ability.

“Try using blood magic once.”

“...Yes?”

At my sudden request, the chief warrior raised his head and blinked.

I said again.

“I told you to unleash your blood skills. Just like the attack you did to me before.”

“Uh, why are you...?”

“Hurry.”

As soon as I told him to do it, the chief warrior finally tilted his head and stretched out his hand in the air.

Then, slowly, his complexion turned into a look of embarrassment, and he made a bewildered sound.

“.....Uh?”

As if something was not going well, the chief warrior could not spread his blood skills at all. The surrounding vampires looked at him strangely.

This is it.

After checking the performance roughly, I took back my ability.

Then, the chief warrior could practice blood magic again normally. Blood pooled on his hands.

“What, what?”

“Why are you acting like this, chief warrior?”

“Elder, just for a moment, the blood magic... No, it’s nothing.”

He looked at his hands in bewilderment.

A unique ability of Gascalid’s blood magic.

It was to take the blood of other vampires as they were and use them.

This was an ability that could be unfolded if the opponent was within a certain range, as there was no condition of contact like instant kill.

Vampires exposed to Gascalid’s blood magic could not use their own blood magic as they did before.

In a word, if the opponent was a vampire, the ability that did not differ from fraud. Of course, if the opponent was stronger or equal to you, the blood magic wouldn’t work at all, or it would take time to fully control it.

Now that I rarely meet a vampire, it’s not a very useful ability.

It was good to have such a unique ability.

The only thing I needed in the first place was the ability to freely control my blood, which was a common passive of all blood magic.

There was nothing more to do, so I immediately left the forest with Asher.

Then the vampires caught me.

“You can’t let the benefactor go like this. If you have anything you want, please tell me. As much as possible...”

“Then, the vampires I brought, please take care of them.”

I already had what I wanted, and there was nothing to gain from this tribe other than that.

At my answer, the vampires looked at me with more reverence.

They didn't know that I had absorbed the power of their ancestor.

Chapter 42.2: Blood Magic (5)

Chapter 42.2: Blood Magic (5) And this one is a bonus chapter from me because y'all have been such amazing readers! ^^

Before leaving the forest for the last time under the vampires' send-off, one elder spoke to me.

It was the vampire who seemed the oldest.

“Can I ask the Lord about one thing about the world outside?”

“...?”

“Is the Tyrant still positioned as the Sixth Lord of Calderic...?”

...The Tyrant?

I nodded at his question.

At that, the elders all had a sullen face.

I understood their reaction.

Because if there was only one person who made the greatest contribution to making the reputation of the vampire race on this continent sink to the bottom as it was now, it was the Tyrant.

He probably wondered if the Tyrant was still doing that kind of shit outside, so he asked me that question.

“Then please take care. I will never forget the kindness that the Lord has given upon our tribe.”

Anyway, that's how I left the vampires' home.

After getting some distance, I said to Asher.

“Wait here for a minute.”

“Yes.”

Asher answered with a puzzled look.

I left her and moved into the thick forest.

Soon, when I couldn't feel her presence completely, I stopped and looked around.

I stretched out my hand in the air and properly spread the blood.

Uh uh.

The blood that passed through the skin from the palm and seep into it floated up.

I looked at it curiously, moved it around, and tried to put it together in the shape of a ball.

The blood swam through the air at my will.

This is the feeling.

It did not differ from a telekinetic force that only worked on my blood.

It felt like I was flapping my wings for the first time, even though those wings didn't exist at all.

I filled the blood I was controlling and shot it at the tree in front of me. Make it sharp like a thorn.

Whoops!

A powerful shot of blood collided with the tree and broke the bark a little.

...*Well, it is quite fast.*

It was much faster than an arrow, but it had no power at all.

Earlier, when vampires attacked me and used blood magic, they blew up the entire forest and showed tremendous power.

But I couldn't.

Because I was a human, not a vampire.

To remember, in the game race setting, vampires said that their blood density and regenerative power itself differed from other races.

That's why it was possible to extract such an absurd amount of blood from a body of a size no different from that of a human and use it as a weapon.

So, no matter how much blood I got, unless my race was a vampire, I couldn't produce such an abnormal power.

In short, the weapon was a machine gun, but the bullet inside was a BB pellet.

Gascaid's unique ability, blood stealing. It looked like I could use it with its original power, considering that the chief warrior's blood skill was completely sealed earlier, but blood manipulation was limited to this level.

There is a lot of heterogeneity.

In the first place, there was a sense of disparity felt when manipulating blood. It was not suitable for me because I was a human being.

If this sense of heterogeneity was reduced, I could increase the speed even more than it was now.

Does it increase as you continue to use it?

Actually, for me, power wasn't the most important part.

If the enemy came into contact with my blood anyway, I could kill them, so what did it matter? It was just a little sad.

And there is also super-regeneration, so there will be no pressure to use blood magic.

This time, I shot the blood floating in the air by dividing it into three branches.

It was a lot more difficult to control when I tried to shoot them separately.

In any case, it was very encouraging to get the ability to maximize the efficiency of instant kill.

The defense was floating veil, and the attack was instant kill using blood magic, and even super sensory.

With these abilities combination, now, most things wouldn't be a threat to me.

There are still weaknesses.

It was still difficult to use instant kill if the enemy was too fast to hit with blood, or if they were wearing a full body armor and using a shield.

But the strength of my instant kill was that no one knew about this ability.

Even if I encountered such an enemy, if I was vigilant enough, I could deal with them somehow.

I stood with my arms crossed and thought about it, then turned my head to one side.

There was something approaching this way.

It was a huge wild boar the size of a house.

It was also the monster we encountered the most while wandering through the forest.

The guy who found me snorted and rushed right in.

I put a drop of blood on my finger and shoot it at him.

As soon as it came into contact with the blood, its body relaxed and it slipped as it had been running and rolled on the ground noisily.

I stared at the wild boar, who was lying on the ground and no longer moving, then I turned around, stirring up the dust that had risen.

“Should I stop?”

I had tried enough of my newly gained blood skills, and now I had to go back to where Asher was.

Chapter 43.1: Space Leap (1)

Chapter 43.1: Space Leap (1) Thank you to Kaz for sponsoring 10 chapters!
^^

We exited the forest and rejoined Baros, who was waiting for us.

While our carriage was moving, I practiced how to make various shapes by floating blood on my hands, or how to divide them.

I wasn't used to the controls yet, so I was thinking of steadily accumulating proficiency in this way.

There was time and nothing left to do while traveling in a carriage, so it's better to be more familiar with my new ability.

I had no intention of hiding the existence of blood magic from Asher or the others.

Because they would find out, anyway. There would come a time when I would have to use it openly, so there was no reason to hide it.

As it was the first time she saw me using blood magic, I felt her constantly glancing at me.

"Do you have anything to say?"

As I spoke, she looked carefully and asked.

"Sir Ron... are you a vampire?"

I answered with a laugh.

“Do I look like a vampire?”

“...No, you look like a human.”

“Yeah, I’m human.”

But how could you control blood?

I could feel Asher staring at me with that kind of question in her gaze, but I had no intention of answering that question.

There was no need to tell her I had absorbed the blood magic from the blood crystal.

After practicing blood magic for quite some time, I stopped.

Now the next destination...

The original plan was to leave the Elrod Forest and go directly to the next mystery.

That’s how the plan turned out when I found a vampire in the middle. As a result, I successfully obtained blood magic and everything went well.

The next destination was the First Lord’s territory, as planned.

The mystery to be obtained there was a mystery that was close to a defense-type ability.

Space leap.

As the name suggested, it was a mystery that could teleport.

Space-related abilities were very rare in this world.

In normal games, if you are a wizard, you could use magic to teleport, but in the world of RaSa, this was not the case.

There were very few magicians who could use space-based magic, and there were also many restrictions.

This one must be difficult to find...

Already, it felt like a tightness was accumulating in my chest.

Finding the mystery had never been easy, but this time it was especially so.

Gaitan Lake, in the First Lord's territory.

The mystery of space leap was hidden somewhere in that great lake.

In short, there were a lot of things to prepare for because I had to do underwater exploration.

Anyway, after getting that, there is only one mystery left.

The last mystery I plan to get after getting space leap was not something I was planning to use.

But it was also a mystery I must get above all else.

It was something that I should prevent that person from getting.

However, since its location was in one of the magical places that existed on this continent, it was inevitable for me to find other mysteries and raise my specs first...

Maybe it's already too late.

In fact, I didn't know exactly when that person discovered the mystery, so maybe it was already too late.

No, it was likely. If you look at these and other things, that person might have been looking for it years ago and prepared to get it by now.

Still, nothing is certain yet, so I'll have to look to make sure.

For now, though, I should focus on finding the mystery of the space leap.

The present, five years ago from the background of the game's play.

More time had passed, so there were less than five years left until the main story began.

Had it been almost half a year since I started wandering around Calderic?

I looked out the window, thinking that the journey was slowly ending.

Asher glanced at the Seventh Lord, who was staring out the window.

At first, she thought all she had to do was do her duty as an escort without worrying about this or that.

However, it had already been almost half a year since they started wandering around Calderic, and the many unexpected appearances he showed during that time made her curious about the Seventh Lord.

Sometimes he was so ordinary that she didn't even think he was a Lord, and at other times he seemed like a good man who couldn't stand injustice.

At other times, he looked like a cold-blooded person without blood or tears, and at other times he looked like a transcendent who had no interest in everything in the world.

Not only the disposition, but also the ability.

Like the ability to kill an opponent with just words, or that invisible shield.

The ability to manipulate blood that he had just shown was also something she had never seen before.

Considering the conversations he had with the vampires, he had a deep connection with their ancestor hundreds of years ago, but it was unknown whether his blood magic ability had anything to do with it.

A person who is hard to fathom.

However, there was one thing she could be sure of, that he wasn't close to a villain.

He did not turn a blind eye to the dying; he rescued the captives, and he solved a major problem for a tribe's peace.

Although his actions might have some intention in them, she still wanted to believe that it didn't originate from a bad place.

“Are you focusing on your escort duty?”

“Yes?”

“It seems like you keep looking at my face.”

“...Sorry.”

Asher blamed herself for being preoccupied by useless things, and just focused on her escort duty again.

Chapter 43.2: Space Leap (1)

Chapter 43.2: Space Leap (1)

A lot of time had passed since they passed through various cities of the Third Lord's territory.

One of the major cities north of the First Lord's territory, Feuselt...

The first thing I did after arriving in the city on the shores of the Great Lakes of Gaitan was to find someone.

A person who was absolutely necessary to explore the lake.

After finding a place to stay, as always, I went to the Adventurers' Guild first.

One of the main tasks of the guild staff was to connect the client with the adventurer, and that was the biggest reason for their existence.

Therefore, it was usually quickest to find a guild that met the conditions. Even if the conditions were strict.

"Um, so..."

The staff of the Adventurer's Guild who listened to me asked as if to confirm.

"You mean you're looking for adventurers who can use both enchantment magic and underwater breathing magic at the same time?"

I nodded.

“And it would be better if they had some knowledge about the Gaitan Lake.”

The staff smiled a little awkwardly. It was a laugh showing that she’s a bit troubled by my request.

I understood her reaction.

Because the conditions I was requesting were pretty difficult to meet, and I really wanted to find an adventurer who would fit them perfectly.

Enchantment magic.

As the name suggested, it was a magic that granted magical effects to targets other than the caster.

In this world, items imprinted with magic were only auxiliary tools for mages to use magic more easily.

The more complex the engraving was, the more quickly it would be erased from the mana stone, or something like that. I read a book about it at my castle, but I couldn’t quite remember it.

So, mages engraved only the important parts of the rite and used it by filling in only the middle, but those who did not know magic cannot use it because it was not possible.

In ancient times, there was a technique for storing magic skills for a long time, but that technique no longer existed until the present day.

So, even in the game, items with active magic that could be used by people other than mages were quite rare.

Anyway, for that reason, enchantment magic had a very high status in this world.

Even more so because there weren’t many mages that could use it.

In this world, magical power must also be innate. So if the nature of someone's magic did not match a certain type of magic, no matter how high their mana was, it was impossible to use it. This was the case with space-based magic or enchantment magic.

There must be someone who could at least use underwater breathing magic.

There's a question on why should a mage even learn such a skill.

Of course, there's nothing wrong with learning it, but it's normal to learn much more useful and powerful magic.

In a word, it would be very difficult to find a mage who could use underwater breathing magic along with enchantment magic.

In order to explore the lake, I had to find it, so I had no choice but to tell the truth to the guild staff.

“Aren't there any adventurers who meet these conditions?”

To be honest, I didn't have high expectations, so if she said no, I thought of giving up and looking for another way.

If I used my influence as a Lord, I might find someone who met the criteria somehow. Or I could visit the market in this city and looked for some appropriate items.

However, an unexpected reply came from the staff.

“That's... There is only one adventurer that comes to mind, but I know he's not in this city right now.”

“Then where is he?”

“I'm sorry, I also don't know. But he often stops by the city. If you're staying here, I can send you a message once this adventurer appears here?”

I nodded and handed the employee a silver coin.

“I’d appreciate it if you let me know. You can send a message to room 305 of the Teria Inn. You can tell him there’s a client looking for him.”

“Oh, yes! I see!”

Pricking her animal ears, she quickly accepted the money.

For now, I decided to stay in the city a little longer and wait for the adventurer to come.

Had a week passed like that?

The news I had been waiting for at the inn came.

“He’s in the city now?”

The staff who came to the front of the room nodded and said that she was a little sorry.

“Yes, young master. I was going to come with him after telling him about you, but the person himself said that you have to come in person...”

I smiled and left the inn room.

Yes, the one who needed the service should be the one to go.

I and Asher immediately followed her and moved to the tavern where there were adventurers.

“That’s him.”

She pointed to the bearded man sitting alone at a table in the tavern’s corner.

I approached him.

He, who was drinking beer alone, looked at me and the staff behind me, and asked with a good smile.

“Ah, are you the one who is looking for me?”

I imagined he would be rude because he demanded that I came in person, but it didn't seem like that was the case.

I glanced at him once and opened my mouth.

“Are you an adventurer who can use enchantment magic and underwater breathing magic?”

He scratched the bridge of his nose and snorted.

“Well, yes. First, may I ask what you're going to hire me for?”

“I'm going to explore Gaitan Lake.”

“Ah, Gaitan Lake...”

The man smiled and said.

“Did you get any treasure map? Anyway, if you're thinking about exploring that big lake, it seemed that you know what you need.”

I sat in front of him.

“Okay, let me ask you a little more about enchantments and underwater breathing magic first.”

Chapter 44.1: Space Leap (2)

Chapter 44.1: Space Leap (2)

Underwater breathing magic.

Of course, I couldn't breathe underwater, so it's a magic I needed to explore the lake.

And enchantment magic was also important since it's how underwater breathing magic could be cast on me.

"You can ask anything."

I asked the man some questions about these two magic skills. From the most important.

"Is it possible to enchant another person with underwater breathing magic?"

Since enchantment magic was in effect, the magic that could apply to the target were very limited.

In the game, I knew that underwater breathing magic was also a magic that could be enchanted to another person, but I asked again to confirm.

The man chewed the snacks and nodded.

"Yes, it's possible."

"How many people can you enchant one at a time?"

"The number of people is limited to one because my skills are not that high."

“How long does the enchantment last?”

“The duration varies from person to person, but for an average person who has accumulated no magical powers, it should still last about 2 hours.”

He continued;

“If my magic and your temperament don’t match well, or if your affinity for magic is low, the duration will be shorter than that. However, if you don’t move your body violently, it’s not a magic that consumes a lot of mana.”

If one person was the limit, it meant that I had to leave Asher and go in alone...

Two hours.

It was not enough time to explore the huge lake and find the mystery, but of course, it was unnecessary to find it on the first attempt, so I thought that was good enough.

Even if the duration of the magic was short, I could not miss this guy because such talent could not be obtained anywhere else right away.

“How long does it take to use up all of your magic power and fully recover it again?”

“It takes at least half a day to meditate with concentration.”

I pondered in my mind for a while.

Considering one hour of exploration, three hours of charging, and rest, was it possible to dive roughly two or three times a day to explore the lake?

Well, no matter what the efficiency was, I couldn’t find such a talented person anywhere else right away, so the hiring was confirmed immediately.

This man also didn’t seem to have any intention of rejecting the request, so I made the offer right away.

“I want to hire you.”

He snapped his finger at my words.

“If you only pay a lot of deposits, of course I’m fine. By the way, when and how long are you planning to explore the lake?”

“The departure is tomorrow. And there is no set period. It could be a few days or a few weeks.”

“...Yes? Wait, that’s a bit...?”

“As you said, I’ll give you a generous amount of the commission. I’ll give you two gold as a start-up and a daily allowance, and five gold on the day you finish the quest.”

After a moment of hesitation, he widened his eyes at the next words.

The money was a lot as usual, and the effect was outstanding, not to mention.

I looked around the party and said.

“I pay for all the drinks you had here.”

“...This is a very generous offer, young master.”

Soon he smiled cheerfully.

“I’m late to introduce myself, but my name is Havel, a first-class adventurer. Excuse me, but what is the young master’s name?”

“I came from a distant city. You probably won’t know which family I belonged to.”

“Oh, right? Anyway, please take care of me. I will do my best to assist with the exploration so that I do not waste the commission you pay! Hahaha!”

And he immediately ordered a few more drinks.

I paid a generous amount in advance and left the pub on the road.

I have a lot of work from tomorrow.

The day was bright, and I met Havel at the promised place.

“Oh, are you here?”

Unlike last night, he had a calmer tone of voice.

Apparently, he was a little drunk when we met yesterday.

We went straight to Gaitan Lake by a horse-drawn carriage.

As they moved, Havel talked about himself and more. It was just a story about the past or something like that.

“...So that’s when I first learned the underwater breathing magic.

“Right.”

I asked him with a soulless reply.

“How much do you know about the Gaitan Lake?”

“I honestly know little about it other than that it’s a dirty, big lake. There are also rumors that terrifying monster fish appear when you go deep into the depths of the lake. But, really, how big would the fish living in the lake be?”

I knew Gaitan Lake as one of the largest lakes on the continent.

The creatures living under the surface were also terrifying.

As in a fantasy world, there were terrifying monsters that could not be compared to ordinary sharks or whales.

I have no intention of going deep, anyway.

The mystery I was looking for was attached to the outskirts of the lake, so there was no need to go deep into the center.

If there was a mystery somewhere in the middle of that big lake, I wouldn't have even dared to find it.

And even if I met some monsters, there wouldn't be any problem in dealing with them, since I had already gained blood magic.

I thought of the scene of the place where the mystery of space leap was hidden.

Again, this was not a mystery I found myself. I just saw another user's play video, so I couldn't pinpoint its exact location.

On the side of the wall on the outskirts of the lake, there were rocks like sea urchins... and there was a cave.

Like the last time I found the floating veil, this time it might be a complete mess again.

That thought got stronger after arriving at Gaitan Lake and seeing the lake's size in person.

...*Crazy.*

As I gazed at the endlessly expansive water surface in front of me, I spit inwardly.

It was an overwhelming size that did not differ from looking at the sea from the shore.

And I needed to find a mystery hidden somewhere here.

I really thought this might take a few months. Even then, I might not still be able to find it at all.

“It’s been a while since I’ve been here.”

Havel said as he looked around the lake.

The carriage stopped near the lake, and Asher, Havel, and I walked right in front of the lake.

A lush forest near the lake. This was the earthly landscape that I vaguely remember.

The probability of finding the mystery was high if you searched this area.

I looked around the lake for a moment and then turned to Havel.

Chapter 44.2: Space Leap (2)

Chapter 44.2: Space Leap (2)

The other asked;

“Are you starting right away?”

“Yes.”

“Okay. Then... if something goes wrong with your body, please tell me right away.”

Havel immediately unleashed his magic.

Blue light gathered in his hand, and I slowly absorbed the light into my body.

I felt the magic that filled my whole body. After gaining super sensory, I felt the energy such as magic much better.

- ··*Ha.*

The magical effect appeared immediately.

Even if I didn't breathe in or breathe out, I didn't feel stuffy at all.

“This is amazing,” said Havel with a slightly startled look on his face.

“The young master has never used magic, but the enchantment's efficiency is considerable, isn't it?”

“Efficiency?”

“I think you have a high affinity for magic. Whether its martial arts or magic, if you honed your magic properly, you’ll be great.”

What, he meant I had a talent for magic?

I thought it was lip service, but looking at his expression, it didn’t seem like that.

It didn’t matter now, so I turned my attention back to the lake.

Then...

Where should I begin?

There’s no reason to drag things out.

I started taking off the clothes I was wearing one by one.

It was impossible to swim in the water in these thick clothes.

So I took it all off except for the thin T-shirt and pants I was wearing underneath.

“I’ll leave it to you.”

“...Oh, yes.”

With a slightly bewildered face, Asher carefully accepted the clothes I had taken off.

“Oh, and be careful not to move too vigorously in the water, young master.”

I listened to Havel’s warning and sent the two back to the carriage.

I was going to be in the water for a while, so they didn’t have to stay it here.

“HMMMMM...”

Alone, I relaxed lightly and approached right in front of the surface of the water.

There wasn't much pressure on diving.

This was because one of the other specialties I could show off, having been immersed in games all my life, was scuba diving.

Unlike me, my brother, who was very active, would take me out of the house and carry me around on holidays. Skiing or climbing.

Among them, scuba diving was the one that my brother and I especially enjoyed together. Because it suited my taste.

Of course, I was naked right now, but I had super regeneration and could move without getting tired, so I was not worried.

Splash!

I dived into the water and immediately checked my breathing again. There's no problem.

The mana consumed while holding my breath was also clearly felt through my super sensory, so there was no problem here either.

...

Havel said that the enchantment efficiency of my body was good, so that's why.

I swam slowly, moving my limbs.

The super sensory made the vision in front as clear as on the ground whether I didn't expect that the effect would be the same underwater.

As I went deeper, fishes passed by me one by one.

I stopped at a suitable point and started moving sideways, looking at the wall of the lake.

From now on until I found the mystery, it was an endless struggle in this way.

. . . And roughly two hours passed.

I grabbed the stone beak protruding from the wall, stopped my body, and sighed inwardly.

There is no end to this.

I expected it, but after experiencing it myself, it felt different.

I went back for once because my magic power was slowly dropping.

I went back to where I marked the starting location and went up to the ground.

Returning to the carriage, Asher and Baros were having a meal with Havel.

“...Are you here, sir?”

Seeing my wet look, Baros briefly twitched the corners of his mouth and lowered his head.

It may have been subconsciously, but I could see it very well because of my super sensory. The other obviously wanted to laugh at my current appearance.

Havel asked me.

“Did you find what you’re looking for, young master?”

I shook my head.

“I think it’s going to take a lot longer than I thought.”

Drying myself over the campfire, I ate with them.

And in the late afternoon, I went back to the lake and continued the exploration, but again, the mystery could not be found. That day's exploration was over.

A week passed like that.

I came to the lake early this morning, and I swam in the water in search of the mystery.

However, because I still couldn't see even the tail of this mystery, doubts arose whether this could actually be done.

Is it really possible to find it?

If I could, I would have already used a lot of manpower for this, but I can't because I was looking for a mystery.

I lay in the water for a moment, drifting blankly, meditating.

If I had the certainty that I could find it, I would invest no matter how long it took, but the problem was that I wasn't sure.

It was when I was thinking about whether I should postpone the search for the space leap until later...

“...?”

I could sense a huge monster approaching quickly from afar.

The next thing that appeared in sight was a gigantic shark. Almost the size of a ship.

【Lv. 51】

- Why did such a guy come out when I didn't even go deep into the lake?

As soon as it saw me, it opened its mouth wide and rushed towards me.

This bastard.

I immediately tried to shoot a drop of blood using blood magic.

But then, again, I sense another one approaching quickly from the other side.

Blue magic energy cut through the current and hit the body of the shark that was rushing towards me.

Whoops!

The shark that was hit directly by the attack struggled in pain and lost consciousness.

Then I felt something approaching me, grabbing my waist.

- *..Uh?*

I looked at the one who grabbed my waist.

A woman with blue hair covered with scales.

It seemed like she thought I was in danger and was trying to save me.

I couldn't speak because I was in the water, so she caught me and dragged to the ground in an instant, knowing nothing. Why was this girl so fast?

“...Whoa!”

The woman who came out to the ground exhaled heavily, then looked at me as I sat blankly and shouted.

“Hey! Are you crazy, human? Did you go so deep intending to die?!”

“...”

“Hey, I'm totally blown away. You're so lucky. I was really planning to ignore you, but I still ended up saving you.”

She grunted like that and started wiping away the moisture from her body.

Then, the scales that had been covered with water began to slowly return to the human skin.

I opened my eyes a little when I saw that.

- ..*Seawater tribe?*

Chapter 45.1: Space Leap (3)

Chapter 45.1: Space Leap (3)

Seawater tribe.

One of the many rare races that existed in this world.

The woman in front of me right now definitely belonged to that tribe.

Because the only race that appeared to be an ordinary human on the ground and the appearance of a whole body covered with scales in the water was them.

I was a little surprised because I didn't expect to see such a rare race in a place like this.

“What are you staring at? Are you curious?”

“...”

He's a bit of a funny guy.

The scales that had sprouted on the skin almost disappeared.

She was completely naked because she wasn't wearing a single piece of clothing, so I glanced away.

...Come to think of it, they weren't the kind of people who were ashamed of showing their naked body like humans.

The woman glanced at me and then continued with a tongue-in-cheek tone.

“How long are you going to be stunned? Aren’t you going to say thank you to me for saving you from becoming fish food?”

I also got up and shook my head.

“There’s no need for you to save me.”

“...What?”

“It wasn’t even dangerous. You just did something useless.”

I could just say thank you and move on, but the way she spoke was annoying.

“Wow, hah! So, that was not dangerous.”

“Yes.”

“You’re really shameless. Is it so hard to say thank you? Did you think I’d ask for anything in return for saving you, like you humans do?”

“I was just telling the truth.”

“Okay, that’s all right. Boy, anyway, that’s why human bastards are...”

She shook her head and turned around.

I stared at her back.

‘Do the Seawater tribe also live in Gaitan Lake?’

It was a fact I didn’t know at all.

Because it was such a rare race that I only saw it once while playing the game.

And I knew that the Seawater tribe was definitely a tribe that inhabited the ocean... Why the hell were they in a lake like this?

As it was an unexpected encounter, I felt a little strange, but a thought suddenly came to my mind.

...*Then do they know some important information about the lake here?*

Could they know where the place I was looking for was?

After thinking about it up to that point, I immediately called after the woman.

“Hey, Seawater person.”

She stopped walking at my call and turned her head back. She had a slightly bewildered face.

“Who are you? Do you know about our race?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Because I’ve seen it in a book. A legendary race that has a human form on the ground and scales like fish in the water.”

“...Me, a legend?”

The corners of her lips twitched.

“Hmm, hmm. It’s a legend. Is our race so famous to you humans?”

“...”

Did she like hearing the word “legendary”?

I just meant that it’s a race that was rarely seen.

As she stared at me, she suddenly gave me a look of disappointment.

“Oh, no? I’m not a Seawater person? You’re wrong, human.”

Why was she acting like that suddenly?

“I’m right.”

“No, sir. Don’t go around saying that you saw me here, huh?”

She started murmuring that she saved me for nothing.

Like the vampires of Elrod Forest, I wondered if they were concerned that their home would be exposed.

Still, she didn’t want to kill me, but she tried to save me.

“So what? Why are you calling me?” she asked.

I asked her.

“Are you aware of the rock formations in the lake? Or is there a cave?”

She made a strange expression, then frowned and replied.

“I don’t know. Why are you asking that?”

I didn’t miss that subtle change.

After gaining extra sensory, I could read other people’s facial expressions better, but she especially could not hide her emotions.

So I was half sure. That she knew the place I just said.

“You know.”

As I spoke again, I saw her flinch. So, she really knew about it.

“Please. I want you to guide me there.”

“No, I don’t know.”

“If there is anything you want, I will repay you in the best possible way.”

She snorted and turned back.

“Well, don’t hold on to me with useless words. If you chase me, I’ll throw you back into the lake, so don’t chase after me.”

Then she ran and disappeared into the forest in an instant.

I brushed my hair once more and stared at the forest.

I wasn’t worried about losing her.

It seemed that they settled here by the lake, anyway.

How should I coax that?

I’d go back and try again later.

After returning to the carriage, drying myself and eating, I immediately took Asher back to the place where I had met the woman.

I followed the trail she left.

Footprints on the floor, tread marks, etc., were enough to figure out where she was headed.

There were traces that would be difficult to find normally, but it wasn’t too difficult to notice with super sensory. It was also very useful for tracking.

The place we reached after chasing the trail was a cave located deep in the forest.

I saw two men standing at the entrance of the cave, chatting.

They looked like they were standing guard, and when they saw us, they stiffened their faces.

“…Humans?”

It seemed to be the right place.

One hurried into the cave, and the other shouted at us as we approached the cave.

“Stop, human!”

I quietly stopped.

I felt others coming from inside, so I waited quietly.

Soon, dozens of Seawater tribe people came out of the cave. Fortunately, this time they were all wearing clothes, so there was no need for me to look elsewhere.

“...Hey you!”

One of them, a woman with a familiar face, saw me and pointed a finger at me and shouted.

“How did you know we’re here?”

Chapter 45.2: Space Leap (3)

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I answered calmly.

“I’ve been following your trail.”

“Then why did you chase me? I even saved you...!”

“What do you mean, Anne? You saved a human?”

The eyes of others who were looking at me with tense eyes shifted to her.

“Uh, no, that’s not it...”

She panicked and waved her hands.

The noise was getting louder and louder, but we heard a sound from inside the cave.

“Everyone, be quiet!”

Suddenly, silence fell upon them.

The man walking out of the cave was an old man with a strong build. With blue hair and a beard.

An old man who passed the others and walked forward met my eyes.

【Lv. 87】

- ○ Close to 90 level.

Is he the chieftain of this tribe?

Although the Seawater tribe was born with a fairly strong affinity for magical powers, that was already a very high level, even if one considered that.

I hid my surprise inside and exchanged glances quietly. The old man's eyes were as deep as the sea.

The old man who was staring at me immediately burst out laughing and opened his mouth.

“Heh heh, this is true. I guess you're not a normal person.”

“...”

“Tell me why you came here. It looks like you've already had a small encounter with my granddaughter.”

The old man glanced at the woman.

She let out a small sigh and scratched her head.

I looked at the two and asked.

“Are you the chieftain of this tribe, Sir?”

When I said that, I felt awkward.

Because it was the first honorific word I used after possessing this body.

But, now, I had something to ask, and I was the one who came here suddenly, so I had to be polite.

The old man nodded at my question.

“That's right.”

“I have no intention of harming you. I’m just here to ask that woman a favor.”

She caught my gaze and tried to shout again with an angry face.

“Hey, I already told you I don’t know!”

“Stop it, Anne.”

The chieftain stopped her and spoke to me again.

“Would you like to come in first? If you want a conversation, I’ll offer you a cup of tea.”

I nodded.

The old man smiled and turned back into the cave as if gesturing to follow him.

I looked at his back and furrowed my brow.

...A wound.

Because it looked like he had a pretty big scar on his back.

The wounds were being treated, and herb-like grasses were glued together.

“Hey, if you’re coming in, come in quickly.”

The woman, who was looking at me with a dissatisfied gaze, pointed with her chin.

Well, luckily, it seemed like they were going to treat me like a guest, so let’s go inside.

As we entered the innermost part of the cave, a simple space appeared.

There was grass on the seat, and around the bonfire, things like fish bones were gathered and scattered.

“Just take a suitable seat and sit down.”

As Asher and I hesitated about where to sit, the chieftain said that.

So, as he said, we just sat down randomly.

The Seawater person, who gave tea to the chieftain first and set down the teacup in front of me, glared at me before leaving.

The chief clenched his tongue and raised the teacup.

“Please understand. Because of what happened recently, everyone has a lot of hostility towards humans.”

The woman, who was crouching in the corner and looking at me as well, said.

“I hated humans from the beginning, Grandpa.”

“It’s noisy, girl.”

“No, look at that brazen thing. I was the one who saved him from being fish food earlier. But even though I told him not to follow me, he kept chasing me all the way here. Without knowing grace.”

The chief tilted his head at her and asked, as if he did not understand.

“You said you saved that man?”

“That’s right!”

“Did you really get help from my granddaughter?”

He looked away and asked me again.

I shook my head.

“It was just a pointless meddle.”

“Well, then.”

“No, wow! What a shameless...!”

The old man ignored it and continued.

“My granddaughter seems to have misunderstood something, so please ignore it. Although she has a rough mouth, she has a good heart, so it’s probably not something she did with bad intentions.”

How much did this old man know about me?

I nodded my head as I looked at the woman screaming with a face about to die from unfairness.

“Anyway, I have a favor to ask of your granddaughter...”

“Hey, are you going to ask me to show you the place you asked me about earlier?”

“Yes.”

She said, sticking her tongue out.

“I will tell nothing to a brazen bastard like you.”

“Thank you so much for saving me earlier. I’m late to thank you.”

“...Do you think I’m a fool?! I will never tell you, so fuck it!”

It’s not that simple.

I shook my head and turned my gaze back to the chieftain.

Mystery was a mystery, but I also had a question for him.

“By the way, I knew that the Seawater people lived on the seashore, but have you been living in this lake from the beginning?”

At that question, their faces darkened slightly in an instant.

The chieftain shook his head.

“No. Right now, we’re just staying for a while.”

I intuitively seemed to know what the situation was.

“Is it because of the wound on the back?”

“That’s right. It’s been quite a while, but recovery is slow, so it’s still like this.”

“Can I ask how it happened?”

Considering his level, he wasn’t weak enough to be attacked by anyone.

The chieftain replied with a bitter smile.

“I had a conflict with a human like you.”

“If it’s a human....”

“He’s a powerful mage. He called himself the chief mage of the Imperial Family of Santea.”

...What?

A completely unexpected person popped out, so my eyes widened.

Chapter 46.1: Space Leap (4)

Chapter 46.1: Space Leap (4)

The chief mage of the Santea Imperial family.

One of the Archmages belonging to Santea, and a strong man on the same level as the Five Stars.

It was not known how they came into conflict with such a strong man.

But soon a guess flashed through my mind.

...Hunting races?

In the Imperial House of Santea, hunting of non-human races was carried out in secret. Just like how they hunted the White Moon tribe of Asher.

It was the emperor's twisted beliefs, and it was a setting that occupied a fairly large part in RaSa's main story.

And if it's the Seawater tribe, obviously...

One setting about the Seawater people also came to mind.

The reason they were a special race was that it was very difficult to see them, but there was one more reason.

Magic Crystal.

Perhaps it was called by that name.

It was said that when the Seawater people almost reached their set lifespan and died, they create a 'Magic Crystal' just before they died.

It was like the inner core of a spirit beast in any martial arts novel.

Magic crystal had an extremely high purity compared to ordinary mana stones, for mages, they were nothing less than heavenly treasures.

Then you can understand roughly.

I wanted to ask more details, but I decided not to mention the magic crystal.

That would be a very sensitive issue for them as well, so it would be bad if I mentioned it since I was an outsider.

“How did you come across such a person?”

To my question, the chieftain drank tea and answered.

“We met him on our way back to our hometown in the sea.”

“Did he attack your tribe for no reason?”

“It’s not that... it’s just the result of greed. There were various circumstances.”

It didn’t seem like he was going to explain any more by saying that with a smirk.

The result of greed.

Again, I was convinced that my guess about the magic crystal was correct.

The woman who had been listening to the conversation with dissatisfied eyes intervened.

“What is Grandpa saying so uselessly? What if he goes around and talks about it to other humans?”

“Tsk, did the person who cares about that saved a human and even brought him all the way here?”

“...No, when did I bring him here! He was just chasing after me!”

I wanted to tease her that she should not have meddled in the first place, but I resisted.

It’s a pity that I needed her to be on my side, so there was nothing good about getting on her nerves.

The chieftain stroked his beard and continued.

“Anyway, that’s why I got hurt like this. All the members of the tribes escaped into the water and barely saved their lives.”

I could imagine how the situation at that time must be.

The chieftain came forward to buy time for other members of the tribe to escape, but eventually got attacked.

If his enemy was the mage of the Santea Imperial Family, he had to be at his level to compete with him at all.

“Well, I have little time left anyway, so I’m glad that all the members of the tribe survived...”

“Grandpa!”

Suddenly, the woman screamed and glared at the chieftain.

“...I told you not to talk like that!”

“Child, don’t shout, it’s painful in the ears.”

The chieftain simply drank his tea.

An awkward silence fell for a moment.

I felt the warmth in my hands as I fiddled with the teacup, then opened my mouth again.

“The wounds appear to be very serious.”

“Honestly, yes. There is no sign of getting better.”

“I don’t know how much it will help, but I have one remedy.”

At that, the woman looked at me in amazement.

“Re, a remedy?”

The chieftain also opened his eyes and asked me.

“If it’s a remedy... are you talking about a healing potion?”

“Exactly.”

So, they’re familiar with it.

Because they lived in the wild, I thought they would not know about potions, so it was a surprise.

I immediately took out Scarlet, which I always carry in my arms.

I had used it quite a bit so far, so I had less than half left, but it’s a good enough amount.

I said while looking at the woman whose eyes were completely fixed on the potion.

“This is the best potion among the potions floating around in the world.”

“...”

“If you tell me where the place I’m looking for is, I’ll give it to you.”

I seek a place of mystery, and the chieftain has his wounds healed.

It was a suggestion that benefit everyone.

“How can we believe in what humans give...”

After muttering like that, she shut her mouth again, glanced at the chieftain, and changed her words quickly.

“Oh, no. I’ll believe it, so give it to me.”

“Can you tell me where the place is?”

“Yeah! I’ll tell you, so hurry!”

It was a desperate cry.

It was a more intense reaction than I had expected, so I continued to speak, even though I was a little perplexed.

“Then make a promise.”

“What else?!”

“I don’t know how effective this potion will be for the chieftain’s wounds. So even if the effect is minimal, you must still guide me to that place.”

Chapter 46.2: Space Leap (4)

Chapter 46.2: Space Leap (4)

Scarlet was definitely a great potion.

But I wasn't completely sure if it could heal the chieftain's wounds.

Because, first, he was not a human, and if it was a wound from an Archmage, something could be a little different from normal.

To be honest, I was reluctant to put conditions on the treatment of an injured person, but I couldn't help it.

The woman also looked at me without saying a word, and answered.

"I understand, so give it to me. I will guide you to places like that 100 more times."

Originally, I was going to hand over the potion after being guided to the location, but I changed my mind.

The order didn't really matter even if it's possible that she could change her mind later.

Well, I hope that's not the case.

I handed her Scarlet.

After accepting it, she stood still and looked at the chieftain.

He gestured

“Give it to me.”

The chieftain opened the potion bottle and glanced at the contents.

Then he looked surprised and nodded.

“Seeing that the scent of magical power is so strong, it’s definitely not an ordinary thing. Can I really accept this?”

“I get something in return, so I didn’t just give it for nothing.”

“Well, I guess the place you’re looking for is quite important to you. Anyway, I’ll put it to good use.”

The woman snatched the potion from him again.

“Show me your back, Grandpa. I’ll treat you right now.”

“Do you know how to use it?”

“…Well, can’t it just be poured into the wound?”

She turned to look at me.

“Just let me do it.”

However, having used it a few times, I know how to use it better.

After laying the chieftain on his seat, I examined the wounds on his back.

The wound was torn at an oblique line, and there were black marks around it. The color was like that of a bruise, but the severity was incomparable to it.

Crooked.

I poured the potion little by little from top to bottom along the wounded area.

Contrary to expectations, the effect appeared shortly after.

It was a little slow, but the wounds slowly healed.

“...Ah!”

The woman who was watching the scene, restless next to him, let out a sigh.

When the wounds disappeared without a trace, the chief rose again. And he looked at me with bewildered eyes.

I asked him.

“How are you?”

“...There are still some wounds left, but the trauma seems to have completely healed. This is a really great thing.”

I nodded and gave him all the potions I had left.

“Drink all that’s left. Those wounds will recover to some extent.”

The chief drank all the remaining potions at once and set the empty bottle on the floor.

Then, with a much more lively face than before, he smiled and looked back at the woman.

“Child, what are you crying about?”

As he said, the woman’s eyes were red as if she was about to cry.

“...Are all better, Grandpa?”

“Yeah. Now we can head to the sea again. Without exception, everyone.”

“Uhhh!”

She rushed into the chieftain's arms and hugged him, and burst out crying like a child.

The chief patted her on the head.

As I didn't know the details of what had happened to them, I just sat still and watched the scene awkwardly.

After exiting the cave, we returned to the carriage.

After receiving the underwater breathing magic enchantment, I headed straight to the designated place by myself.

After sitting with my back against a tree and waiting for a while, a woman appeared from within the forest.

“...What you looking at?”

The corners of her eyes were still red, so when I looked up, the blunt words returned.

I shook my head and got up from my seat.

“Let's right away.”

The woman threw down her clothes and walked towards the lake. I followed her too.

Now it was time to go find the mystery of space leap.

She, who had been staring at the water surface, glanced at me and asked.

“But you're human. You can't stay in the water for long, can you?”

“It doesn't matter because I had someone put magic on me.”

“Oh yeah...”

She hesitated as if she had something else to say, then said in a crawling voice.

“Thank you.”

“...?”

“Thank you, for treating my grandfather. Thank you so much.”

“It’s fine.”

I answered briefly.

There was nothing she had to say thank you for since I got something back for it.

As she spoke, she wiped her face with a sullen look, then stuttered and shouted.

“...It’s fine? I’m just saying thank you! Because I’m not as brazen as you!”

Was she thanking me or asking for a fight?

I sighed and said.

“Before we go in, tell me about the place I’m looking for. Somewhere in the lake.”

She glanced around the lake, pointed in one direction, and said:

“See over there? You have to go over there and go down to the point where you can almost see the bottom. It’s pretty deep.”

I also looked where she was pointing and nodded my head.

Chapter 46.3: Space Leap (4)

Chapter 46.3: Space Leap (4)

“Well, what worries me is that if you go that deep, you might run into those damn spiny fish...”

“A spiny fish?”

“Yeah, it has a dirty long, pointed nose, and it’s twice as big as you.”

If it’s a fish monster with a long and pointed nose...

She’s talking about a charging fish.

Their level was not high, but hundreds of them flock together and hunt.

Their whole body is covered with hard scales, and they use sharp thorns protruding in front of them as weapons to charge and attack as their name suggested, so the greater the number, the more lethal.

“Well, it’s fine. There are only a few, I can handle them easily. You just have to trust me and follow me.”

She said smirking.

I looked at the level above her head.

39 wasn’t a level where one could be so confident, but...

As she continued to speak, she asked as if she was curious.

“But why are you looking for that place? Are there any hidden treasures?”

She must be thinking of gold and silver treasures.

There was a hidden treasure that couldn't be compared with anything like that.

"I don't know."

"Aha, I see. Are you trying to find a treasure ship? I've seen a lot of people like that when I was living at the beach... Wait, but this is a lake. You're not doing anything stupid to find a treasure ship in the lake, are you?"

"Stop talking and guide me now."

At that, she snorted and jumped right into the water. I followed and jumped in.

Splash!

Seeing her in the water, she instantly changed into a figure covered with scales.

I looked closely and I couldn't see any gills under her ears. It's interesting.

As if she was telling me to follow her, she swam first, waving her fingers and moving.

She's too fast.

I worked hard to pursue her, but of course I had no choice but to fall behind.

How can I, as a human being, caught up with a race that lives in water?

She shouted when she saw that I was lagging behind. Even though she was underwater, her voice was clearly pierced in my ears.

– Why are you so slow! come fast! Do you want me to leave you alone?!

Were the Seawater people capable of raising their voices underwater?

Anyway, while saying that, she started moving slowly at the same pace as me.

As we got to a fairly deep place, big fish appeared and passed by.

– It's okay, these aren't the kind that attack first...

The expression on her complexion, who had been speaking with ease, hardened for a moment.

Something huge was approaching fast from below.

A monster with black scales that look hard like armor, and thorns pointed forward like a lance.

Damn.

I also looked at it and frowned.

It was the charging fish she mentioned before going into the water. We were really encountering this now.

– Be careful!

Whoops!

She flew in as if she was shooting at the guy who was charging towards this side and smashed it with her fists.

Even in the water, it was as fast as running on the ground.

A charging fish that had been properly hit in the body spit out blood and sank down the shaft.

Unlike her, who was relieved, I looked around.

This was because they were much more likely to travel in groups than as single individuals.

I could feel a huge amount of presence starting to gather around me.

– Huh, huh?

She also looked around with a puzzled face.

The charging fish that flocked in an instant surrounded us and spun around like a tornado.

The number gradually increased and soon passed hundreds. It was like a black wave.

I watched the scene as if tired.

This was the way they hunted.

They surrounded their prey and spun around to prevent it from escaping, and they stabbed from all directions at once.

After all, it was a hunting method that could be done because they did not get hurt because of their hard scales.

– Me, get your mind right.

A trembling voice was heard.

Looking to the side, she was completely in panic.

Now who was going to save whom?

– Hold my waist. I'll try to pierce the top somehow...

– What are you doing just floating there, hurry up...!

I smiled, ignoring her words, and placed my hand over my head.

The blood that oozes out of my palms was lumped together in the form of a sphere.

She was about to shout again, but stopped when she saw blood cells floating on the palm of my hand.

Shall we properly test my blood magic?

As a swarm of charging fish spinning around us rushed towards us, blood cells exploded like a bomb.

Whoops!

Drops of blood that burst out in all directions broke through the current and shot at them.

And that was the end of it.

The black waves that rushed in like a suffocation lost their strength and sank to the bottom of the water. It was annihilation.

Chapter 47.1: Space Leap (5)

Chapter 47.1: Space Leap (5)

What a cheat.

It was a brief impression of the blood magic that I had properly unfolded for the first time.

It was just what I imagined, but seeing it in reality was different.

The synergy of blood magic and instant kill.

When used in this way, most enemies, especially when dealing with a group of enemies, I was virtually invincible.

– ...What?

She stared blankly at the group of charging fish that had sunk to the bottom after I had killed them, then turned to me.

She obviously did not know what just happened.

– Yes, did you just...? What and how... Is there any poison in your blood?

As she said that, she fluttered in horror at the blood mixed with the water and floating around.

– Whoa, whoa!

Soon after realizing that there was nothing wrong with her, she asked again, bewildered.

– I'm fine, right? Huh? I will not die, am I?

I nodded. It's not poison.

Then she became relieved.

– But what kind of magic did you use? You didn't say you had that kind of ability.

Why did I have to tell you that?

I pointed my finger at the bottom to tell her to keep moving.

She nodded and swam forward again.

I could hear a small mumble in my ear.

-...Then, it's not really dangerous back then. Was it just my meddling?
Aww, it's embarrassing...

I could see a few more monstrous fishes appearing suddenly, gulping down the pouring charging fish carcasses. They ate well today.

I passed them and followed her down into the depths.

How far down?

Gradually, we entered the depths from which hardly any light could enter.

I had never been so far out of the ground and never dived so deep when exploring on my own.

Still, there was no problem with vision because of the super sensory, but the pressure on the body was the problem.

But even if there was a problem in one or two places, I believe that super regeneration would fix it on its own...

She still showed no sign of stopping.

Slowly, when it felt like the limit, I could see a visible land.

It was not the bottom of the lake, but a naturally made terrain.

...!

And the sharp rocks that stretch out like stalagmites around them.

Some of them curved sideways, making them look like bamboo shoots or huge teeth. It was a strange sight.

I stopped and leaned against the wall.

She got down to the floor first and pointed to the rocks as if she had arrived.

– Is this what you said? Speaking of sharp rocks, this is the only place that comes to mind.

Probably right.

I remembered that the place I saw in the play video definitely felt like this.

I didn't think there would ever be another such unusual natural topography.

Then there must be a cave nearby...

That was where the mystery of space leap was hidden.

I signaled her.

I mouthed the word 'cave'. She shrugged her shoulders as if she understood right away.

– Cave? I don't know. But if you look for it, it looks like it's there.

As she said, the area where the pointed rocks were spread out was very wide and uneven, so it was enough to find a hidden entrance if you looked for it.

I scattered and tried to send a hand signal to find out.

If she found the cave first, she could go inside and discover the mystery.

So, he opened his palm to signify that she should wait patiently in this place.

– What? Am I waiting here?

I nodded.

– Why? Aren't you trying to find the entrance to the cave? I can help too...

I shook my head violently. *I'm begging you, just be still.*

She nodded her head reluctantly. She even muttered a little.

– I have no interest in treasure, but you still think I will covet it. After all, human greed is...

It seemed like she misunderstood something, but it didn't really matter, so I left her.

I moved around and started looking around the rocky area.

I remembered it was a small entrance that barely even one person could fit in.

I was looking at everything from the flat side, then turning to the side and looking at the part that was sloping down quickly.

Wow!

- ..Found.

I looked into the entrance, which was exquisitely hidden among the rocks with joy.

Without a single thought, I put the glowstone tied around my waist in my mouth and slowly pushed my body inside.

It was quite difficult to get in because the passage was narrow, but not impossible. Still, it was much easier with water.

How far did I move by picking up and pulling on the wall with my outstretched arms alternately?

As I went further in, the passage became wider and wider, to where I could move my limbs completely freely.

At about that time, a small passage appeared, not in the front, but in the side. It was about the size of the entrance where I came in earlier.

- ..?

I stopped because I thought it was a fork in the road, and immediately opened the floating veil.

A gigantic snake protruding from the hole like hit the veil with its wide-open jaws.

【Lv. 35】

It wasn't a fork in the road; it was this water snake's nest. No, was it its hunting ground?

The snake that collided with the veil lost its mind in shock and squirmed backwards.

I shot a drop of blood at it, and it immediately stopped breathing. Was that snake just planning to make a surprise attack?

I continued on the way I was going.

If I kept going inside, wouldn't a monster worse than that one just pop out? For a moment, I had that thought.

But it was irrelevant. It was easy to kill, no matter how big a bastard popped out.

There was nothing I could do on my own before. But even though my physical abilities were still poor, I became a lot stronger now.

The passage bend along the way and continued upwards for a while.

And when I got to the end, it wasn't the monster that appeared; it was the one I had been looking for for a week in this lake.

A small space the size of a room.

On the floor in the middle, a mysterious pattern was shining brightly in purple.

I smiled and swam towards the pattern.

Chapter 47.2: Space Leap (5)

Chapter 47.2: Space Leap (5) One more bonus chapter! Thank you to Talosfanboy for the donation! ^^

Whoa!

When I touched it, the pattern shone brightly, as always, and was absorbed into my body.

As I was groping for information about the mystery that flooded my mind, I immediately tried it.

As soon as I used space leap, my position was teleported some distance forward.

There was no side effect, and there was no casting delay like the floating veil.

It was too narrow to test the space leap properly, so I went out first.

When I went back through the passage I had passed and came out, I saw a woman swimming here and there from afar.

I teleported towards her.

— …Whew!

She was startled by the sudden appearance in front of me and stopped.

— What, what? Where did you come from?

I stretched my finger upwards.

She glanced around at me and gave me a puzzled expression.

– Do you want to go up? Did you get what you're looking for?

I nodded.

With this, the mystery of space leap was also obtained safely.

After rising to the ground, I tested my abilities, unfolding the mystery of space leap.

First, the maximum distance traveled was a little over 100 steps when measured in steps. I couldn't gauge it, but it seemed to be about 75 meters.

And above all, this ability was a rechargeable type that could store several times.

Up to three times, the cooldown is 10 seconds.

If the storage value was maximum, it could be used continuously without a cooldown up to 5 times, and it was recharged once every 10 seconds.

It was not surprising because I knew that the mystery of space leap in the game was this kind of skill.

However, in the game, I remember the total number of times it could be used in a day was 10, but there seemed to be no restriction like that here.

I raised my head and looked up at the sky, then used my power again.

This time, when I teleported upwards, my body floated high in the air for an instant.

When I used the floating veil in that state, my body remained fixed in the air and did not fall, giving it the appearance of being completely levitated.

This was possible with floating veil because it could maintain the body at a fixed point.

So I can also use it this way.

I was wondering if there would be any use for this, but there was nothing wrong with learning a new way to use it.

I teleported back to the floor before I fell and landed.

The mystery of space leap was also like floating veil. When I used my ability, the force acting on my body disappeared altogether. This meant that even if it was used while falling, the falling power would completely disappear.

With these two abilities, dying from a fall was the least likely to happen.

I stood with my arms crossed and thought about the synergy of my other abilities or more efficient use of my abilities.

Splash!

Then a woman came out of the lake.

In her hands were several large fish.

She walked over to me, wiping away her water.

“Hey, let’s go.”

She was told me to wait here for a moment and then she jumped into the lake again. So I waited, but I didn’t know where we’re supposed to go.

I looked at her silently, and she continued, scratching her head.

“No, what... Just let’s go back and have dinner together. You didn’t intend to leave right away anyway, did you?”

“I was just about to.”

I already found the mystery. Was there any reason to stay longer in this lake?

I was thinking of going back to the carriage and leaving as soon as morning came.

At my words, she pouted.

“Isn’t that rude? You treated my grandfather, and you also saved me earlier... how could we not thank you?”

“You don’t have to. Let’s just separate here.”

“Hey, You—!”

She sighed in anger and suddenly said with a serious look.

“Can’t you just come over for a while? My grandfather said he has a very important story to tell you.”

...An important story?

What was that all of a sudden?

Is this a story about the chief mage of Santea’s Imperial Family?

It was the only thing I could think of.

Anyway, it’s not like a person like the chieftain would say something useless.

I nodded my head helplessly.

“Okay. Let’s go together.”

Her expression brightened up.

“I know you will agree. I’m going to die of hunger, so let’s go quickly. It’s amazing how soft this fish is.”

She hummed and walked forward.

“Hey, but what’s your name?”

“Ron.”

“My name is Anne, Ron. Remember me.”

I already knew because I heard the other Seawater tribe people and the chieftain calling her.

She continued to hum, and we walked towards the cave.

“Uh, Anne. Are you here?”

When we arrived at the cave, the chieftain, who was standing with his back at the entrance of the cave, greeted us.

“I hope you can come again. I wanted to treat you to something, at least a little, before you leave...”

I nodded and asked.

“I heard you have an important story to tell.”

The chief tilted his head at him.

“A story to tell? There’s no such thing.”

...?

I turned to Anne.

She smiled awkwardly and avoided my gaze.

“Sorry, that was a lie.”

“...”

“Now that you’ve come all the way here, you can just enjoy dinner and go, right? I’ll cook you delicious meat right away!”

I looked at her back as she ran into the cave with puzzled eyes.

Chapter 48.1: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (1)

Chapter 48.1: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (1)

...Didn't she say that it would be just a simple dinner?

However, in the meantime, other members of the Seawater tribe also gathered around, and the number of bonfires increased, and the atmosphere quickly became like a festival.

“Are you the person who healed the chieftain's injuries? Thank you so much, thank you! Haha!”

“I apologized for the way we treated you before. And thank you for taking care of the chieftain. You're a good human being.”

Tribe members passing by me said a word at a time. It was mostly just them saying thank you.

Their attitude was the complete opposite of how they had been before, treating him like an intruder.

Everyone seemed to really appreciate how I healed the chieftain's wounds. If it's because of that, I couldn't really do anything about it.

“Okay, try this.”

Anne held out a large piece of freshly baked fish meat on a skewer with team rising.

I took it and blew on it with my mouth to cool it, then took a small bite.

Her confident smile reflected the blazing bonfire.

“How about it? How does it taste?”

“Good.”

The taste was as expected

Fruits, smoked meats, fish that Anne had caught, as well as other fish dishes, came out, so it became a complete feast.

“I’m glad it seems to suit your taste.”

The chieftain chuckled pleasantly and chewed the fish to the bone.

“By the way, it would have been nice to have had alcohol, but unfortunately, there was nothing here since it’s not our home.”

Alcohol.

Come to think of it, I hadn’t drunk even a sip of alcohol since I came to this world. I wasn’t in a position to do that.

I glanced around.

Once again, I caught the sight of the Seawater people sitting around each seat and enjoying their meal.

Those who cook the meat, those who raise their voices, and the children who were asking when the meat would be done.

And on one side, I could see men walking across the forest with spears, probably wanting to catch more fish.

They were free and unconstrained. It was such a sight to behold.

“We always get together to eat like this. It’s a really fun and rich time.”

The chieftain also looked around at the tribe members.

I asked him.

“Now that you have healed your wounds, are you going to leave this place right away?”

“I think so. Even if not, we have already wasted a lot of time, so we should leave as soon as possible.”

This time, the chieftain asked me.

“I wonder if you found what you were looking for.”

I nodded.

“Fortunately, I found it thanks to your help.”

Anne, who was eating meat hard said while chewing the contents in her mouth.

“That’s right, Grandpa! I almost died when I was caught in the water by a swarm of fish? But blood came out of his palm and killed them all at once!”

“What do you mean?”

“No, I mean, there’s blood on his hands like this, then the swarm of fish just died...”

It was an explanation that could not be easily understood if they didn’t know exactly what Anne was talking about.

But the chieftain only had a smile on his lips.

I suddenly got curious and asked.

“You seem to have understood a bit about me from the first time you saw me, right?”

“Exactly.”

“Is that also an ability of the Seawater people?”

I remember that the Seawater tribe probably didn't have any special abilities in that way. Was it just because the chieftain's sixth sense was good?

He chuckled and shook his head.

“I could hardly call it an ability. It's just that as the time of death approaches, things you've never seen before have become visible. The supreme level that is

leaking out of your soul.”

Ah, the [Soul of the King]...

I had nothing to say, so I said nothing.

Instead, Anne spoke with a straight and hard face.

“What's wrong with dying again, Grandpa? Don't keep saying things like that? Your wounds are healed, so why are you talking about death again?”

The chieftain laughed out loud.

“Child, can I go against the rules of nature that you've denied? Don't make me keep saying things I've said a few times already.”

“...Even so!”

He must really have little time left, so he said something like that.

The chieftain seemed to be convinced that his lifespan was ending. How? And why?

“Our tribe's home is the Poluv Sea in the northern part of the continent.”

Before I could ask, he spoke first.

“I left there a long time ago, riding rivers, sometimes walking on land, and roaming the seas extending from the north to the west of the continent until now.

As our ancestors did, and as our descendants will, it is our Seawater people who do not stay in one place and wander for the rest of their lives. This is the way we live. That’s the cycle.”

Chapter 48.2: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (1)

Chapter 48.2: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (1) Thank you to Gelfling92 for sponsoring 4 chapters! ^^

It was a muffled voice, as if reminiscing about days gone by.

I quietly listened to the chieftain.

“When I was a child, the elders of the tribe used to say that when it is time to return to nature, I will miss my home, and all the Seawater people do. I miss my home’s sea.”

…So you were going back to your home?

To meet his last moment in the place where he was born.

“So, I’m really thankful to you. Otherwise, I might have been lying here without ever reaching my home.”

The chief patted Anne’s head next to him with a detached smile.

“…”

She had an annoyed face, but she did not avoid the touch with sad eyes.

A chieftain whose life was ending. Reasons to return home.

Then I could understand. Why was she crying so sadly then?

For the members of the tribe, especially for being his granddaughter, she would surely want to fulfill the chieftain's last wish.

After dinner, it was time to go back.

The chieftain, Anne, and other members of the tribe saw me off.

"Ron, I wish you happiness for whatever path you wish to take."

I also told the chieftain.

"I hope that you too can arrive at your home safely."

It wasn't a pretentious statement; it was what I truly hoped.

The chieftain smiled and nodded his head.

"Hey, you can come back tomorrow and have breakfast as well."

Anne scratched her nose and said so.

Of course, I didn't have to answer because I didn't want to come.

I left the cave and returned to the carriage, not looking back. It was quiet.

Maybe it was because I heard stories about the chief's home.

Feeling a strange feeling, I turned around and walked through the forest.

After tidying up the dining table, Anne was looking up at the night sky in front of the cave.

A member of a tribe her age who passed by and entered the cave asked her.

"What are you doing, Anne?"

Anne waved her hand in annoyance.

Then he laughed mischievously.

“Are you thinking of that person?”

“...What?”

“No, that’s right. You haven’t been able to take your eyes off him since earlier. Wow, is it really like that? I didn’t know you had that kind of taste.”

Her fist smashed into the man’s side.

He staggered back and complained.

“It’s a joke. What are you hitting me for...?”

“Shut up and go to sleep.”

All the members of the tribe entered, and Anne, who was left alone, glanced at the other side of the forest. Then she was filled with regret.

“...The face was indeed a bit to my liking.”

Would he come again tomorrow morning?

She shook her head and tried to enter the cave.

“...?”

Then she heard something slowly approached through the bushes.

Anne’s face lit up with a blush. Maybe it was Ron.

“Hey, why did you come back?”

Anne’s expression, which was about to call him with a slightly excited voice, hardened in an instant. And then it turned pale.

It was a middle-aged human male in a robe who came out through the bushes.

The man calmly spoke to her.

“Is the chieftain inside?”

“...”

Anne couldn't answer anything.

She could only feel her hands trembling and stare at the man with fearful eyes.

A monster-like human who attacked a tribe passing through the realm of Santea and seriously injured her grandfather.

Why did he appear here again?

“You...!”

It was the moment she was about to squeeze her voice into the cave and shout, footsteps sounded.

The chieftain was already walking out of the cave.

“Hey, Grandpa.”

The chieftain, who found the man, was silent with a hardened face and asked.

“How the hell did you come all the way here?”

The man ignored the question and said.

“Chieftain, hand over the Magic Crystal. At least I will send them all away without pain.”

“...”

“The water isn't close this time. You can't run away as you did before.”

Aww!

As the man waved his hand, a gigantic magical energy shot out at a formidable speed and struck the chieftain.

He raised his arms in place to block the attack and staggered back a step.

In the commotion, the tribe members in the cave rushed out.

“What is this!”

“...That human!”

When they found the man, they were terrified.

The chieftain took a deep breath and then shouted.

“Everyone, run away! Gather the members of the tribe that are still inside, and run into the lake without looking back!”

Chapter 48.3: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (1)

Chapter 48.3: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (1)

The man said indifferently.

“Do you think they can survive?”

As if the previous blow was just a greeting, an even greater amount of magic flowed around him.

The chieftain, who raised his magical powers with all his might, swung his fists.

A punch, which was shot like an island war, aimed at the man, but suddenly it was blocked by the unfolding shield and disappeared without a trace.

The chieftain swung his fists incessantly and hurled attacks on the man.

In the collision of two huge energies, the surrounding land was turned upside down and the bushes were torn off.

The hesitant tribe members had no choice but to follow his orders and run towards the lake.

“...No! No way! Grandpa!”

Other members of the tribe forcibly grabbed and dragged Anne, who was screaming desperately.

The chieftain was pushing the man away as if burning the last embers of his life. But that was it.

“Argh…!”

The chieftain, who had been moving wildly, stopped for a moment, and then sat down, spitting blood from his mouth.

The effect of moving violently while still having internal injuries came quickly.

“Is it over?”

The man, who was still standing in the same place with his shield wide open, without moving even a single step, said as if it did not impress him.

“…Anne! No!”

Anne got out from the hold of her tribe members and ran towards the chieftain.

“Girl, I said to run away…”

“Shut up! What the hell is this?! Why do you keep doing it all by yourself?”

With tears in her eyes, she struggled to support the chieftain.

The man who had been watching the struggle with subdued eyes stretched out his hand slowly.

A huge flame rose in the air and swept the two of them like a wave.

Whoa!

The other tribe members who were running away watched the scene in vain.

The man turned around. All the other members of the Seawater tribe had to be dealt with.

“...?!”

But soon he had no choice but to furrow his brows and turn his head back.

A man stood where the flames and smoke had gone.

Whatever was blocking the flame, he and the other two Seawater people did not sustain any damage.

Anne, who was sitting down, looked up at him blankly.

“Ron...”

A young human male with black hair and golden eyes.

He didn’t even feel a sign of approaching from where the other suddenly appeared.

At that fact, the man asked with a sense of humility.

“Who are you?”

...Ha.

I fixed my gaze on the man in front of me and sighed in relief.

While moving in the carriage, I suddenly felt a huge amount of magical power, so I hurriedly came back. What the hell was this?

I could block the attack by using space leaps from a long distance away, but...

【Lv. 91】

The situation was absolutely the worst.

I know who he was.

If I remembered that crazy level and the story the chieftain told me, I could guess it easily.

The chief mage of the Imperial Family of Santea, Rakiul.

Had he been chasing the Seawater people all the way here?

The man who was silently staring at me opened his mouth.

“Who are you?”

Instead of answering, I glanced at the chieftain and Anne, who were lying behind me.

Ahh... this was really crazy.

I couldn't let them die, so I reflexively took action, and this had become the current situation.

I swore a bit and then stared at the shield surrounding Rakiul.

Fuck.

If he spread the shield like that, there's no way I could rely on instant kill. It was a fatal weakness.

If the battle took place like this, the best thing I could do was defend and run away.

“If you don't want to talk...”

The man raised his magic again.

In an instant, many thoughts ran through my mind.

How about continuing to defend? Or run away? Then what about the rest of the Seawater people? Should I reveal myself as a Lord? Then would he believe it?

It was then that the sound of laughter was heard from the other side of the forest.

Everyone's eyes turned to the source of the laughter.

“Wow, what the hell is this?”

It was a woman with red hair that came out through the bushes.

When I saw her appearance, I was astonished, and the mage's complexion also hardened. He murmured in a bewildered voice.

“...Mad King?”

The Fifth Lord—the Mad King.

Her sudden appearance in a chaotic situation made me even more confused.

The Mad King giggled as she looked at the mage's hand that looked like he was about to attack me.

Chapter 49.1: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (2)

Chapter 49.1: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (2)

In the stillness of silence, the mage looked alternately between me and the Mad King.

There was an obvious tension on his face that wasn't there just a moment ago.

Why the hell was the Fifth Lord here?

It seemed that he did not understand this situation as well. The doubts, tensions, and feelings of disappointment reflected on his face were clearly visible.

Why is she really here?

I sighed inwardly and looked at her.

I didn't know how things were going, but the immediate crisis seemed to have passed.

Even if it's just like a stranger, the Mad King was an ally of the same camp. Now it was the mage, not me, who was cornered.

“Are you going to fight, Fifth Lord?”

The man opened his mouth in a hoarse voice.

It was a tone that felt close to resignation rather than a warning or threat.

No matter how strong he may be as the chief mage of the Santea Imperial family, the Calderic Lord was a higher rank than that. Even a simple level difference was a whopping 4 levels.

If the Mad King was going to kill the mage, there was no way he could survive here.

But she shook her head.

“It’s the other way around, you idiot. You don’t even know how to express gratitude when I just saved you.”

“...What?”

“Do you know who the person you are facing right now is?”

The Mad King shook her head and asked me.

“By the way, what are you doing here in the First Lord’s territory, Seventh Lord? Did you come here to fish?”

At those words, the mage looked at me with astonished eyes.

I made eye contact with the Mad King answering nothing.

“...The new Seventh Lord? The one who killed the warrior?”

I heard him mumble.

Of, so they actually knew about that.

After all, the death of one of the Five Stars must have been a huge event in Santea.

At first, I was a prisoner of the convoy, and coincidentally, a new Lord appeared in Calderic when the convoy was attacked.

Unless you are an idiot, Santea’s side would have figured out who the culprit was, based on the circumstances and investigation.

Of course, even if they knew I was the culprit, it meant nothing.

Even if Santea and Calderic still formed a temporary alliance against a huge enemy called the Demons, that was only superficial. Behind the scenes, countless armed conflicts were still taking place.

It was impossible to pull me to a political conflict even if they had physical evidence, unless I did the killing openly.

And in the first place, it's not something I should be concerned about right now.

...*By the way, did she just say that she saved this guy?*

I stared at the Mad King and fell in thought.

From what she said, she had no intention of fighting the mage, but I couldn't figure out why.

In Calderic's realm, she suddenly encountered a great power on the side of Santea.

Since she especially enjoyed fighting, wasn't there no reason for her to let this guy go?

"That guy is the chief mage of the Imperial family of Santea, Seventh Lord. Are you planning to kill him?"

The Mad King asked me.

I wondered how I should answer.

It was difficult to affirm what her stand was because she seemed unwilling to join the battle. So, what could that mean?

In this case, the answer was to just hold on to remain silent. Then the other person would just interpret it for you.

The Mad King seemed to interpret my silence as a 'yes'.

She scratched her hair and said with a curious expression.

“Hey, Seventh Lord. I don’t know what’s going on, but can you just spare him this one time?”

In the words that followed, I could see why she didn’t want to fight the chief mage.

“Because I owe that guy one favor. So if you want to kill him, I can’t just stand still.”

…A favor?

They seemed to know each other somehow, but was there such a relationship between them? It’s information that wasn’t even in the game.

I opened my mouth, narrowing my eyes.

“What if I refuse?”

To that, the Mad King replied with a chuckle.

“Didn’t I tell you? I’m not going to just stand still.”

“…”

I glanced back again.

I could see the chieftain lying on the floor with a pale complexion, and Anne crying, holding him.

His pulse, which I felt through super sensory, was weak, as if it would break at any moment.

“Please, please…!”

To be honest, if she just did what he said and ran away, there wouldn’t be such a risk and the Seawater people had probably now escaped.

Although I felt saddened by what happened to the chieftain, there was nothing I could do to change his situation.

It was meaningless for me to hold on to the chief mage here. It would only make the situation even worse.

However, perhaps because of the [Soul of the King], after possessing this body, sometimes the reason and the mouth had different thoughts.

Now the mouth said something again that I didn't mean to say.

“Then are you going to die together with him, Fifth Lord?”

“...”

At those words, the pupils of the Mad King were split vertically like that of a wild beast.

Then she twisted the corners of her mouth and slowly took her hand to the hilt of the great sword on her back.

“...S-stop.”

At that moment, the chieftain's dreary voice crushed the sharp atmosphere.

The members of the tribe, who had been observing the situation with their breaths stopped, suddenly came to their senses and gathered around the chieftain.

“Hey, Grandpa....”

I stared intently at the Mad King before turning around.

The chieftain coughed and barely spoke.

“Ron, I'm sorry, but can I ask you one last thing?”

As if foreshadowing the end, he seemed to want to leave his final will.

“I want you to prevent that human mage from harming the tribe... until everyone enters the lake. That’s all.”

Anyway, the mage had no choice but to step down as it was, so it’s easy to keep that promise.

I sighed and answered.

“Don’t worry.”

“...Thank you. And Anne.”

She was sobbing and shook her head helplessly.

“After all, this place has become my grave.”

“...”

“Don’t think about revenge. It was only a few days left, anyway. It’s a pity that I couldn’t return to my home sea in the end... but that’s okay too. There’s no need for everyone to be angry or sad.”

“Ugh, uhhh...”

“When I die, bury my body in the ground, and release the crystals in the lake. So that I can ride the river and flow to the sea...”

His voice, which had been sparsely speaking with open eyes, gradually faded. And there were no more words.

Chapter 49.2: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (2)

Chapter 49.2: Seawater Tribe's Treasure (2)

The members of the tribe who had listened to his will closed their eyes one by one as if mourning his death. Anne was weeping endlessly with empty eyes.

Shit.

Not long after, the chieftain's chest ripped open, revealing a blue jewel from within.

Anne reached out and slowly picked it up.

The wizard, who was watching the scene, widened his eyes.

“Magic Crystal...”

A crystal formed by the fusion of the magical powers accumulated over a lifetime. The essence of pure magic.

A treasure from the heavens that mages could not artificially create.

Anne turned her head and looked at the mage as if to kill him.

“Only because of this one stone!”

She cried out in a shriveled voice.

“Half of this world already belongs to you humans! You conquered and took possession of the land, resources, and everything in abundance!”

“...”

“But when are you going to be satisfied?! How much more do you have to take to be satisfied?”

“It is a treasure of no use to you.”

The mage opened his mouth, furrowing his brows.

“And you’re talking really foolishly, Seawater tribe. We humans are the ones who have finally saved this continent during the long war. The hero beheaded the demon king and finally stopped the invasion of the evil demons. The peace of this land so far. Whose power do you think it is that’s keeping it intact?”

“Mage.”

I jumped in to stop him from talking.

“Shut up when I’m still giving you a chance to live.”

He turned silently and looked at me.

My tone was more sarcastic than normal because the other just made me feel dirty.

“And it’s not just humans who stopped the demon invasion. What brazen voice are you talking about?”

“...That the one who finally sealed the Demon King.”

“Yeah, that was done by the hero. But was that what you guys did? It’s just the achievement of the hero alone, not the whole Empire.”

“That hero is the guardian of our Santea.”

“A guardian of an empire who hunts and slaughters innocent races. You know it too, don’t you? The hero despises your emperor and the imperial family.”

There was only one reason the hero had left the imperial family’s secret evil deeds until now. No, she had no choice but to leave them alone.

Because she was a hero who truly cared about the peace of the continent.

And the mouse-like emperor used that very well as a shield.

I stopped the guy who was about to react with an angry look and said.

“Stop it now. If you run into me again, I will kill you no matter what the circumstances are.”

The Mad King, who had her arms crossed with a sullen face, gestured with her chin.

“Go. I paid off the debt with this, so I’ll kill you if you appear in Calderic again.”

He flew into the air, biting his lips, and in an instant, he crossed the air and disappeared to the other side.

So the situation was settled.

The Mad King, who was looking at the sky, shifted her gaze to me. Then she asked, making a slicing movement across her throat.

“Are you really going to kill me?”

“...”

“If we kill each other, don’t you know how the Overlord will react? Well, it seems like you’re like me who doesn’t even care about that...”

“What were you doing here?”

She answered my question by tapping her sword.

“I’m not doing anything in particular. I was just on my way back after leaving a few swords with Agor.”

…The First Lord?

Apparently, she appeared here by coincidence.

“So, what were you doing in this lake? What are those other things?”

“I don’t know.”

The Mad King giggled and turned around.

“It’s terribly chilly. There’s nothing else to do, so I’m leaving. See you at the next meeting.”

Seeing her back disappearing through the bushes again, I let out a small sigh, as it exhausted me for nothing.

“…Ron.”

Anne, who was holding the crystal blankly, looked at me and called my name.

There were no words to follow.

Several members of the tribe stood up and wrapped their arms around her shoulders.

I looked down at the chieftain’s corpse and briefly prayed for his repose inwardly.

Although he died, everyone else survived, so his death would not have been meaningless.

I stayed by their side until dawn.

They buried the chieftain in the back of the cave where they were staying and held a ceremony for a long time. It looked like a tribal funeral.

They left the cave only after dawn and lined up in front of the lake.

Anne stepped forward and released the crystal in her hand into the lake.

The crystal then emitted a bright light and slowly dissolved in the water and disappeared.

The magical crystals of the Seawater tribe would dissolve and disappear when they came in contact with water. It was a fact I already knew.

And, as one could see, it was also the way the Seawater people honored the dead.

When the crystal was completely dissolved in the water, Anne stood up and said,

“Grandpa said. This crystal is made with the magic we’ve absorbed from the water all our lives. We have to release it back into the water to keep the cycle going.”

“...”

“Thanks, Ron. Thanks to you, at least the last funeral was done properly.”

I asked her as she looked at the lake with a little blank eyes.

“Are you planning to leave right away?”

“It should be. Now I’m going to the sea without stopping.”

A river that originated in Gaitan Lake and ran to the North Sea of the continent.

They seemed to plan to ride it straight to their home.

Splash!

They thanked me and said goodbye, and one by one they started jumping towards the lake.

I said to Anne, who remained until the last to make sure that no one was left behind.

“Someday, after I’ve finished all the things I have to do, I’ll visit your home.”

“...Huh?”

“When we meet again, I hope I can see you with a smile. Goodbye.”

She glanced at me blankly, raised the corners of her lips, and jumped straight into the lake.

I stood still for a while, staring at the surface of the lake, then turned around.

Chapter 50.1: Hallmenta (1)

Chapter 50.1: Hallmenta (1)

A figure was running, leaping over the peaks of the mountain range.

With each leap, the ground cracked and trembled. It was a sight that could cause doubt to anyone who saw it.

The Fifth Lord—the Mad King had already left Gaitan Lake and was crossing the mountain range to the southeast.

She stopped in front of a peak for a moment, not breathing a single breath.

“...Ha.”

The Mad King, who had been quietly staring into the air, burst out laughing out of nowhere.

It was because the thrill she had felt before had not yet completely gone away.

‘Then I’ll have to kill you too.’

It was such a feeble threat, but she felt eerie for a moment that she had goose bumps all over her back.

The Seventh Lord, when he spoke those words, really wanted to kill herself. She was sure of it.

However, some bastard who was about to die intervened, and the other forgot about it.

“Should I have pushed him harder?”

With great regret, she licked her lips with her tongue.

The battle to fight and kill each other was the most intense bliss she felt in her life.

Who would have survived if the iron rule of Lords not fighting against each other had been broken and they properly fought one another?

She was confident that she could kill all other Lords except for the Overlord, but she wasn't so confident that she could do the same to that human, the Seventh Lord.

The Seventh Lord was never under her in terms of power. Even with a brief friction, she instinctively sensed it.

“Ha, shit. I can't get the excitement down.”

Aww!

The Mad King, who clenched and opened her hand, clenched her fist. The huge peak in front collapsed completely.

She slammed the ground and flew high into the air again, continuing her movement.

She was getting tired of hunting monsters again. Maybe she should go to the eastern border to hunt demons.

After finding the mystery of space leap, and seeing the Seawater people left for their hometown, all work to be done on the Gaitan Lake had been completed.

After paying the commission promised to Havel, who enchanted him with underwater breathing magic, we separated and we left for the next destination.

“Are you talking about the chief mage of the Santea Imperial Family...?”

Asher’s expression hardened.

When I told her about what had happened at the lake, this was her reaction.

Because it was such a huge collision, she felt the presence from afar, but after thinking about what to do with the order to stay where she was, she stayed in the wagon. It was a good thing, as it wouldn’t have helped much if she had come, anyway.

“The chieftain died during the battle, and the rest of the Seawater people started their travel back to their home safely.”

“...I see.”

After hearing all the stories, Asher’s expression was a mixture of sadness and anger.

Perhaps it was her past that overlapped.

Because her tribe was annihilated by Santea’s forces and by one of the five stars.

“...”

I stared at Asher, whose eyes were sullen.

To be honest, I felt sorry for her.

Because, having played the game, I already knew that no one had survived the annihilation of the White Moon tribe other than her.

Of course, there was no way she could tacitly believe what she said, and there was no way to prove how I knew it.

But anyway, I knew the truth and needed her, so I was using it as a bait.

Her purpose in life was to find survivors of her clan and to take revenge on Santea.

Once she found out that there were no survivors in her clan, the only meaning left in her life was revenge.

In the game, she had already made valuable friends before she found out about that fact, so she no longer wanted to get involved in revenge. But I didn't know what would happen now that I had changed the story.

The image of Anne screaming desperately in front of the chieftain's corpse flashes through my mind.

If possible, I wanted to support Asher so that she would not go astray even after learning the truth, but this was a matter of emotion, not something that game knowledge could solve.

I think I've broken down quite a few of her barriers in our journey together so far, but the intimacy she has with me right now wasn't that deep.

"Are you sure you want to get revenge on Santea?"

Asher looked at me, startled at my question.

Soon she answered with a complicated face.

"Honestly, I don't know. Right now, I'm just concentrating on finding surviving members of my tribe."

...Right.

I nodded and looked out the window.

Originally, I had planned to procrastinate as much as possible, but I changed my mind.

Whatever the outcome, if the opportunity arose, I would take Asher to that place as soon as possible.

Anyway, now there is one place left.

The search for the mystery was now at the end.

However, I had a foreboding that finding this mystery would be the most difficult road on the journey so far.

Because the hidden place was none other than a demonic land. So I put it at the last place we should go to.

If I didn't get either the blood magic or the floating veil, I might have postponed the search for this mystery altogether.

Demonic land, Hallmenta.

As the name suggested, the term "demonic land" referred to an area where ordinary creatures cannot live.

A land of death where all kinds of bizarre terrain, environments, meteorological phenomena, and monsters beyond common sense existed.

On this continent, there were five demonic lands.

And now the place I was going to go to was a place called Hallmenta, which was very close to Calderic, a long way to the northwest of here.

It has a lot of monsters, but the terrain is also no joke.

Anyway, as long as I had blood magic and a floating veil, no matter how powerful the monsters I faced were, there's no big risk.

And since I got the space leap, I didn't have to worry about the terrain with many obstacles, even if I didn't have Asher. I would still take her with me, though.

No matter how much magic I had, unless the opponent was a named boss, I could deal with almost any monster. Even Asher could do that as well.

I suddenly got curious and asked.

“Have you ever been to a demonic land?”

Asher answered with a puzzled look.

“I have not.”

“Then you’ll be able to experience it this time.”

“...Yes?”

“The next destination is the demonic land called Hallmenta.”

Asher blinked at my words.

Chapter 50.2: Hallmenta (1)

Chapter 50.2: Hallmenta (1)

The carriage traveled a long way and came to a city on the western frontier of the First Lord's territory.

From there, I decided to just let Baros stay in the city.

He wasn't at a low level per se, but to be honest, it seemed like it would be a bit of a burden to go with him in the demonic land.

Anyway, this was like telling him to wait while guarding the carriage, just like how it was usually during our travels.

This demonic land was so terribly wide that it was impossible to know how long it would take to find this mystery.

Of course, because of Baros' personality, he insisted on following us. But I simply used my authority to stop him from doing so.

"Then let's go."

Baros saw us off at the entrance to the city gates.

I left the city on horseback with Asher.

I practiced riding a horse while I was staying in the city for a few days.

It was the first time I ever rode a horse in my life, but I was able to quickly learn it thanks to my super sensory.

As my senses developed, my motor nerves seemed to have also improved.

After practicing for a few days, my horse riding skill had reached a level where I could ride without holding the reins.

While riding my horse, I opened the map and looked at the road.

It was a map which was obtained at an expensive price. It roughly marked the topography of the northwestern part of Calderic and even the topography of the demonic land.

We couldn't find a guide to guide us, so this mystery search had to be done completely on our own.

Ha...

To be honest, I couldn't really tell anything much just by looking at the map

These were the areas where I used to come and go while playing the game, as if I was just traipsing through a park.

However, as one might have seen through the journey so far, the game and my current reality had different standards, so my geographic knowledge based on the game was meaningless.

It's better to not have the expectation that we could travel comfortably and just roll with whatever might come our way.

A long time passed while we travelled on horseback.

Gradually, as the landscape of the demonic land drew closer, changes occurred in the surrounding environment and topography.

Dark clouds in the sky blocked the sunlight even during the day, and the grasses gradually disappeared, making it difficult to find anything remotely green.

Instead, only the desolate stretch of land and rocks glowing with dark red light often came into view.

Perhaps the horses also felt the ominous energy floating in the air, and the more they moved, the more they stopped and trembled.

“Let’s take a break before we continue.”

“Yes.”

We settled down and had lunch.

It was a scenery that wasn’t really suited for eating, but we had to fill our stomach.

It was always Baros’ job to prepare the meal, but now Asher was taking his place.

What was surprising was that, although not as good as Baros, she was also very good at cooking.

She used to live in the mountains, so that’s probably only natural. Especially considering that she was a wanderer for a long time before entering the Overlord Castle.

kugugu.

Amid our meal, a group of monsters came from across the plains.

It was a bipedal bird-type monster that looked like a giant ostrich. It was called a Mad Bird, if he remembered correctly. They inhabited the plains.

Asher got up silently and tried to deal with the monsters, but when she looked back, she saw another huge thing behind them.

【Lv. 61】

A giant lizard with two heads.

I raised my super sensory and zoomed in on the giant lizard.

- ◦ *..Twin Headed Lizard?*

When asked to pick out bizarre monsters from the demonic land, one of the representative ones was the monsters with multiple heads.

Twin Headed Lizard was one of them.

So, the Mad Birds were not running in our direction to attack us, but they were being pursued by the Twin Headed Lizard.

As we got closer to the demonic land, it seemed that monsters that were near the border were already appearing.

Of course, there was no mercy in Asher's hands.

The huge sword energy fired by Asher rushed towards the group of monsters.

The sword aura tore up all the Mad Birds and cut down even those at the back. But...

Keek!

Surprisingly, the lizard withstood Asher's attack.

While its blood poured on the ground, it frantically shook its head and rushed with a scream.

Asher raised her eyebrows and fired a sword energy once more. It was a sword aura with a much stronger energy than before.

It finally split the lizard that was hit by it again in half.

Asher drew her sword with a slightly uneasy expression.

I could see why she looked worried.

The monsters of the demonic land are mostly like that.

They were not only strong but also aggressive and ferocious if compared to normal monsters.

If it was just a normal monster, it wouldn't be strange if it immediately died right after Asher's first attack. But this one was clearly different.

Of course, there were also monsters that were incomparably weaker. In short, there were a lot of annoying monsters here and there.

Even in the game, hunting monsters in the demonic land was like committing suicide unless you were at a certain level.

“Ah.”

As she sat back down to eat, she sighed briefly when she saw her soup bowl spilled.

Because she suddenly stood up earlier, it fell over and spilled.

I looked at the scene and smiled, then our eyes met. She coughed in embarrassment and poured another soup into her bowl.

“Eat more.”

“...Yes.”

Chapter 51.1: Hallmenta (2)

Chapter 51.1: Hallmenta (2) 6 ! Thank you to Reikichi, Orphylia, Hillpond and Shinonema for the donations! ^^

The environmental characteristics of the demonic lands existing on the continent varied.

In some places, lava pillars spewed out of the earth, in some places lightning struck a dry sky, and in some places, even the water that was poured out in the extreme cold immediately froze.

Compared to such other demonic lands, Hallmenta's environment and topography belonged to the mediocre axis.

This was why even after entering the entrance, Asher and I could still ride horses.

The sun is no longer visible.

I looked up at the sky filled with almost black dark clouds.

Because of those clouds, it was almost as dark as night when it was still broad daylight.

It was a landscape with that kind of atmosphere that would come to mind naturally when one thought of the end of the world.

Keek!

And the monsters that popped out from time to time were a bonus.

Asher's sword cut a monster in half that had fallen from the cliff and rushed at them.

The monsters that they encountered were all on the weak side, so whenever they appeared, Asher took care of them.

There are really a lot of monsters here.

The number of encounters was incomparable to the ones we usually encountered when passing through forests or mountain ranges. That's probably why it's considered a demonic land.

It's not a big deal, but I already feel tired just thinking of how annoying it would be when we had to sleep at night.

I looked at the map again and thought about the place where the mystery was hidden.

A huge rock in the shape of a tower in the center of the demonic land.

And a cave somewhere.

It was a place that appeared during that *bastard's* flashbacks in the game.

Still, for this mystery, all I had to do was go to the central area of the demonic land and find the rock, so I could pinpoint the exact location.

After a few days of travel, we finally entered a forest.

They were not green trees that were expected of a typical forest, but rotten old trees with only black-colored leaved.

As we walked along the eerie forest path, I looked around.

The trees also had dark-colored fruits, which I examined.

Although Hallmenta was quite ordinary, there was a point that clearly set it apart from other demonic lands. It was the plants.

There were plants that seemed to grow without undergoing the germination process.

Some had deadly poisons, while others had great medicinal effects.

That's...

Among them, I found one fruit and my eyes widened.

A round fruit the size of a melon with a black rind and reddish cracked texture.

The fruits hung like grapes until they almost touched the ground.

As I got closer, the large insects that had been eating a single fruit that had fallen to the ground flew and scattered.

I picked one fruit in good condition.

In the game, because of trying to get more achievements, I had to spend a lot of time gathering herbs and fruits in Hallmenta, so I knew what this was.

Monstache fruit.

It didn't really have any beneficial effects on the body.

However, unlike its appearance, it was the fruit with a setting of having a heavenly taste that was to die for.

It was pretty hard to find in the game, but I was lucky enough to come across it here.

I couldn't help but wonder about the taste, so I took a small bite of it. The flesh had a crunchy texture.

Wow...

As soon as I ate it, I was overwhelmed by the intense sweetness that spread in my mouth.

I could see why the game called it heavenly taste. As soon as I took one bite, I had to admit it right away.

As I savored the sweetness, I turned my head.

Next to me, Asher was looking at me with a slightly bewildered look.

It probably looked strange that I suddenly picked a fruit and ate it. Especially since the fruit in question looked like a lump of cold lava.

“You should try it as well.”

As I grabbed another one and held it out, Asher was silent and shook her head.

“...I’m fine.”

“I’m not forcing you, but if you don’t eat it, you’ll regret it.”

It’s a waste to taste this delicious food alone.

When I said that, she seemed to be curious about it, so she accepted it with hesitation.

Then she took a small bite and opened her eyes.

I smiled and ate the fruit I was eating. It was so large that I was full after eating just one.

“Let’s keep going.”

As I was about to move forward again, I heard a popping sound from behind.

When I turned my head, Asher picked another fruit and put it in her mouth.

She gulped the fruit she was chewing with a look as if she was a kid who had been caught stealing candy.

“...Sorry.”

“It’s fine.”

What’s wrong with eating more if one wanted to?

Chapter 51.2: Hallmenta (2)

Chapter 51.2: Hallmenta (2)

A few days had passed since we entered the demonic land.

The landscape unfolding in my sight was a repetition of endless black land and bushes, and there was nothing special about it.

The only thing that changed was that the deeper we went into the demonic land, the stronger the monsters we encountered.

【Lv. 64】

【Lv. 68】

【Lv. 71】

The ones we met this time were swarming around us.

There was a monkey monster, there were also some that looked like a mixture of a lion and a rhinoceros, and some giant spiders with countless disgusting eyes.

What are these?

I couldn't help but tilt my head at the alien sight.

It was because they were not of the same species, instead, it was a group of monsters that didn't fit together at all.

Waa!

I told Asher after thinking about it, because we needed to take care of this first.

“Take care of that monkey.”

“Yes.”

Asher rushed towards the monkey monster that had the highest level, which was separated from the rest of the crowd.

The remaining monsters rushed towards my side with ferocious momentum.

I stretched out my hand and popped the drops of blood and shot them towards the incoming monsters.

All monsters were at a level where it could destroy a small city alone, but that level was meaningless to my abilities. I wiped them out in the blink of an eye.

Whoa!

Shortly thereafter, Asher also killed the monkey with no difficulty.

She turned to me and saw all the other dead monsters, cleared her breath and drew her sword back.

After that, we often encountered a group of monsters with such a heterogeneous combination.

As we continued to slay them, an idea came to my mind.

- *..Oh, could it be because of that?*

There were a lot of monsters with all kinds of tricky and bizarre abilities in the demonic land.

Starting from those that could evoke fear, there were those who fired powerful magic cannons, spit out fire or electricity, or those who could cause hallucinations. They were mostly classified as named bosses.

And among them, there were also very rare monsters with the ability to control and control other monsters.

Seeing the ferocious monsters, that were often eager to eat and kill one another, suddenly became friendly with each other... I thought that maybe a monster with the power of dominance might be in this land right now.

But as I remember, there was no boss with the ability of the dominant type in Hallmenta...

Well, this was at a point in the past of the game's background that I played, so there may be boss mobs I didn't know about.

I didn't take it too seriously.

Even if there was a guy with real dominance, it wouldn't pose a huge threat.

A few more days passed as they turned all the monsters that attacked like that into corpses.

Seeing the dark red mist that spread faintly in the air, I wondered if we had slowly entered the center of the demonic land.

That's why I prepared in case we got lost.

I buried one of the compass that showed the mutual location of each other, which was used in the Elrod Forest, at the entrance to the demonic land. And, on our way here, I also sprinkled the guide powder I had brought along.

I stretched my field of vision to the max with my super sensory, trying to find the rock.

It's a huge rock that looked like a tower, so it would be easy to spot from afar...

And just as I thought, after wandering around the area for about half a day, I was able to finally find the rock.

- *..That's it.*

Beyond the fog, I approached the huge rock that looked like a tower at first glance. There were no monsters nearby.

Arriving right in front of it, I circled around the rock to find the entrance to the cave.

And I soon found it.

One wide passage opened in the middle of the rock.

This was the place where the last mystery I seek was hidden.

“Wait for me here.”

Saying that to Asher, I walked alone into the dark cave.

I didn't feel any presence inside. It's like everything was still.

I moved inside for a while.

The straight passageway was much longer than I thought, and even after walking for several dozen minutes, there was no sign of it ending.

When will I reach the end?

I got tired of walking slowly, so I just ran. I did not feel tired anyway, so why walk?

How many more minutes would I have to run?

Finally, the straight passage ended, and a huge cavity appeared.

I looked around the joint.

Now, there seemed to be no more passage to the inside.

Then this was the end... it was just dark with nothing in the cavity. There were no brightly shining mysterious patterns.

I thought I came at the wrong place, but I was sure that this was definitely it.

There could be no other cave inside a tower like rock formation like this other than here. That being said, that was...

“...”

I approached the center of the cavity with a hardened face.

There was a faint stain of dried blood on the floor.

A sign that someone else had been here before me, and the traces showed that it had been a very long time since that happened.

There were enough traces to understand why there was no mystery pattern here.

“Had that person already taken it?”

I muttered in despair.

Apparently, that *bastard* had already discovered this place a long time ago, and eventually absorbed the mystery.

It was a failure to get the last mystery.

Asher was waiting in front of the cave, vigilantly waiting at the command of the Seventh Lord.

She stood with her hand on the hilt of her sword, staring intently into the cave.

How did the Seventh Lord come to know these places? And what was he doing every time inside?

- *Useless thoughts.*

She brushed off her curiosity and refocused her attention.

Although she was an escort by name, she has always been of no help in battles with powerful enemies they had met.

At least she had to prevent monsters from entering the cave to not interfere with whatever the Seventh Lord was doing.

“...?”

Asher, who had stood like a stone statue for such a long time, suddenly recognized a sense of alienation.

It was because the fog around the area seemed to have gotten a little thicker.

An instinctive feeling of discomfort crept up.

Her hand, which was about to draw the sword, with her forehead wrinkled, stiffened.

Then, slowly, her eyes closed, and he staggered dangerously and fell to the floor.

In the place where she fell, a disgustingly tangled plant stem appeared.

The stems wrapped around her crawled to the ground and disappeared somewhere in an instant.

“...?”

I came out of the cave in deep thought and looked around me with puzzled eyes.

It was because the figure of Asher was nowhere to be seen.

I stood with my arms crossed and waited, wondering if she had temporarily gone somewhere, but she did not appear even after I waited for a long time.

“...”

I looked around again with a hardened face.

Where did she suddenly disappear to?

Chapter 52.1: Hallmenta (3)

Chapter 52.1: Hallmenta (3)

In the middle of a dark forest, a man and a woman were sitting in front of a bonfire.

A man with various weapons on his waist and a woman in a thin robe.

Next to them lay the corpse of a giant wolf that had been mutilated and dead.

As if used to it, the woman sliced off the monster's flesh with her dagger and put it on the fire, whistling and waiting for the meat to be cooked.

"Just because it's a monster from the demonic land doesn't mean that you will die if you eat it. Some people say it tastes much better than the meat of ordinary animals."

The man did not respond to the woman's words. He just stared at the burning meat full of dissatisfaction.

She clicked her tongue and fumbled through the meat skewers.

"So, we've come all the way to the central area, what are you going to do from now on?"

"I need to find it."

"So, what's the detailed plan? You've been keeping your mouth shut all the way here."

“There is no such thing. Search all of Hallmenta to find it and kill it. That’s all.”

The woman sighed in response to the man’s ignorant answer.

“I told you, what kind of place is the demonic land? A stronger monster could have killed and eaten it by now. So what would you do then?”

“If you’re going to keep meddling like that, you should have not followed me here.”

She furrowed her brows in dissatisfaction.

“Did I tell you not to talk like that?”

“...”

“Rand was a precious colleague who was like family to me. His older brother suddenly declared that he would get revenge for him, so how can I not interfere?”

“It’s useless worrying. I’m a lot stronger than you think.”

“Yeah, it’s okay. You’re right. You’re from the infamous ranger of Barcato, can an adventurer like me dare to compare? I just have to lead the way and work hard on grilling meat.”

The woman nervously rummaged through the meat.

The man glanced at the scene and said,

“...It was you who went out of your way to grill that meat.”

“Ah, so you’re going to be like that, huh?”

“If you can make any excuse, go ahead.”

“Then I’m just going to eat this alone.”

She smiled inwardly as she spoke bluntly.

Although their personalities are completely opposite, the reason they could get along was because both had a soft heart.

Crung!

While the meat was cooking, the bushes shook, and the monsters appeared again.

It was a huge scorpion, a six-legged crocodile, and a deer with ferocious horns. A bizarre, unpredictable combination.

Unlike the woman who grabbed the staff that had been laid down next to her with a nervous face, the man drew a single dagger from his waist.

Push!

A dagger shot like a beam of light pierced the deer's forehead.

Then, the man drew his long sword and rushed towards the scorpion. On the blade of the sword, a dark blue light was formed.

The scorpion raised its tail with a poison stinger; he avoided it, and swung his sword to cut it in half.

The man slashed the body of the writhing scorpion, then cut off the head in an instant, killing it.

Waa!

The crocodile jumped up from the side and could only bite the air.

It was a surprise attack, but the man had already landed on the ground and leapt into the air.

Then he slammed on a wooden pole and jumped straight down again, then fell to the crocodile and pierced its head.

“...Hey.”

The woman looked at the man who killed the three in an instant and was leisurely picking up his sword, dazzled by it for a moment.

The battle was over with no room for help. She had skills and enough experience to go to this place, but every time she saw him fight, she was still amazed.

“These monsters appear more often.”

The man glanced around at the dead monsters and said.

Deer, crocodiles and scorpions. A strange combination.

“Are the monsters in the demonic land all like this?”

“No, it can’t be. They’re just weird.”

The woman who said that also looked at the monsters’ bodies with strange eyes.

The demonic land was a place beyond common sense, and it was a daily routine to face various incomprehensible things.

But if it happened repeatedly, not just once or twice, she couldn’t help but be concerned.

They came across a bunch of monsters like this all the way here.

She went on without thinking deeply so far, but she also felt a sense of wonder and strangeness.

Kkiing!

When she lifted her head, there was a bird in the sky spinning around them, making an eerie cry.

She looked at it for a moment, then turned her attention back to the meat.

While fighting the monsters, the meat seemed already cooked.

Chapter 52.2: Hallmenta (3)

Chapter 52.2: Hallmenta (3)

This was difficult.

This was even more so because I had never imagined such a case before.

I came out of the cage, and Asher had disappeared without a trace. Then the horses also disappeared.

While in the cave, I did not know what was going on outside.

“What the hell is it...?”

Had a monster attacked her?

That was the only possibility that came to mind.

She wouldn't have disobeyed my orders unless something unavoidable happened.

But if they really attacked her, what kind of monster was it?

First of all, no matter how magical this place was, the only monsters that could overwhelm her were named bosses.

And if there was a battle with those strong monsters, no matter how deep I was in the cave, I would have noticed it with my super sensory...

It's strange.

Anyway, something was strange.

I turned my head to look up at the top of the rock tower and then use a series of space leaps to climb to the top in an instant.

From such a high place, I looked around at the panoramic view of the demonic land.

The road we passed in the front, the forest to the left, and the plain to the right and back.

Of course, even if I looked through every detail with my vision enhanced as much as possible, I couldn't even see the appearance of Asher's nose.

I slumped to the ground, scratching my head.

Suddenly, there was a ripping sound from somewhere, and a huge monster bird flew towards me.

I shot it with a drop of my blood and the bird who flew with great momentum fell straight down.

I looked at the bird falling to the ground, then got up again and went down the rock.

Maybe if I looked around the traces, I might find something.

This is where she stood.

Starting from the spot where Asher was standing, I thoroughly scanned the surrounding traces.

There were no footprints left as it was a hard stone floor, but I did not miss a single trace by raising my super sensory as much as possible.

And, soon after, I discovered that there were faint traces of something on the ground.

- *..What's this?*

Traces of something messed up.

I used my super sensory, but I couldn't figure out more than that. Because the traces were too faint.

But I could tell where it went.

I turned my gaze towards the trail. It was in the forest's direction.

“...”

I used my super sensory again.

The only traces that could be found on the floor were these scratches, and nothing else.

First, the owner of this mysterious trail was probably not a huge guy.

If it was, then its weight would have made deeper marks on the ground. But there was no trace of that kind.

Something light and not too big.

Something like that attacked Asher and dragged her into the woods? No, was it correct that it dragged her?

I was unsure. But now that Asher was gone, I could only think in that direction.

I thought of the named bosses that inhabit Hallmenta.

They were all as big as a mountain, so it was not one of them that attacked Asher.

I trudged.

In the end, I still didn't know what it was, but all I could do was to follow the trail.

It's Acher and nobody else. I had to find her at any cost.

Fortunately, there were no bloodstains. I moved towards the forest hoping that she was still alive.

Starting from the forest, the traces were much clearer because the ground was easy like the previous one.

I thought it might be a monster with many legs like a centipede, but looking at the traces, it wasn't.

It's like, what should I say... tentacles?

It was like a tangled tentacle crawling on the floor, it's the only one I could think of that could create these traces.

Crumble.

【Lv. 56】

As I continued to pursue the trail, a monster came out through the bushes.

It was a huge deer whose horns on its forehead resembled that of a devil.

It looked at me, then lowered its head and scratched the floor with its front paws. It looked like it was getting ready to rush at me.

I stretched out my hand and tried to shoot drops of blood, but at that moment, the floor I was standing on vibrated.

“...?”

What else was happening?

A completely unexpected scene unfolded before my eyes.

Whoops!

Suddenly, a huge paw protruding through the ground grabbed the body of the deer and crushed it.

The sound of cracking flesh and crumbling bones. It was crushed to the ground like a rotten fruit and died a terrible death.

Then, the whole ground in front turned over, and the owner of the paw buried under it slowly raised the body.

【Lv. 82】

A bear that was as huge as the Bellevagorah that I had encountered before in the Rutus Mountains.

I blinked my eyes and stared at it.

- *..Vulcantier?*

One of the named bosses inhabiting Hellmenta that I know of.

Truly, the bear that suddenly jumped out of the ground was probably buried there for so long that a tree was growing on its back.

I muttered out of embarrassment.

“Have you been hibernating?”

Vulcantier shook its body and brushed away the grass and trees growing on its back.

It was so large that it was like it’s dusting off the trees.

Crung!

Before long, its eyes shone with a reddish glow and its entire body radiated ferocity, as if it would tear me to death at any moment.

It stretched out its hand upward, as if he had just woken up from a long sleep.

At that moment, a voice came from the other side.

“...Step back!”

Then, a huge flame flew in and hit Vulcantier’s body.

When I turned my head, I saw two people, a man and woman.

【Lv. 73】

The bear who was hit by the fire lost its mind for a moment, and then the man who came close to me pushed me away.

“Don’t get in the way.”

Then, without listening to my words, he threw himself at Vulcantier. He came close and launched a slash of swords.

However, he couldn’t tear off its tough skin, he couldn’t even scratch it.

Soon the bear regained its senses, let out an angry roar and swung its gigantic front paws violently.

Dodging the attack and barely stepping back, the man looked down at his sword with a stiff face.

Then the woman walked beside me. She prepared a spell and yelled at me again.

【Lv. 59】

“What are you doing alone in a place like this? We’ll fight, so run away!”

“No...”

I tried to speak, but she also ignored me and looked forward again.

Who were these people, all of a sudden?

Aww!

Seeing the man struggling, the woman bit her lip.

A huge bear that made all the monsters they had encountered so far feel like cubs.

She had never encountered such an absurd monster when she was walking around the demonic land with my colleagues in the past.

Even the man who had easily dealt with monsters until now was barely avoiding attacks.

She raised her wand and raised her magic power to prepare the most powerful magic she could unleash.

But at that moment, the bear suddenly changed direction and aimed at her.

“...!”

The man who was thrown by the bear turned sharply towards this direction.

He tried to get up in a hurry, but the bear was already too far away. It was an unbelievable speed for its size.

...Ah.

So stupid?

She didn't even have time to unleash her defense magic. No, it would be shattered even if I managed to cast it.

It was the moment when the two of them sensed death as they saw the huge front paw of the bear was about to slash her body, when something suddenly appeared in front it.

The ground around it exploded in a shock wave.

“...?”

The two looked at the scene unfolding in front of them with bewildered faces.

A man they had just met was standing right in front of her.

And the bear's front paws stood tall in the air. It's like being blocked by an invisible wall.

The bear grunted in bewilderment and then backed away.

What is this...?

The man's figure vanished from her sight once more.

At the same time, there was a roar and the bear's body collapsed.

Woohoo!

The two stared blankly at the man standing on the back of the fallen bear.

He looked down at them both and opened his mouth.

“Listen when people talk.”

Chapter 53.1: Hallmenta (4)

Chapter 53.1: Hallmenta (4)

After looking down for a while, I used space leap and came down.

When I suddenly appeared in front of them, it startled the two who had just stood up.

“Te, teleport...?”

The woman muttered with a look of astonishment.

I asked them.

“Who are you?”

A woman who was a wizard and a man who was a swordsman.

In particular, the level of the man was quite high at 73.

I never thought I would meet people like this in the center of the demonic land. What were they doing?

The man was silent. He looked alternately between me and Vulcantier who had fallen behind me. I saved them, but he seemed to still be pretty wary of me.

Instead, the woman answered with a bewildered voice, wiping the dirt off her head.

“Yes, yes. We are just adventurers.”

“Adventurers? Were the two of you roaming around like this?”

“Yes, just like that...”

“Why?”

“Hey, were adventurers, so we just want to go on an adventure...?”

She smiled awkwardly and glanced at the man.

He was still showing signs of being wary.

“Thank you for saving us. May I ask who you are?”

I thought about what to say and answered.

“An adventurer.”

“...Why is an adventurer in the demonic land?”

“Because I want to go on an adventure?”

Silence fell for a moment.

I was just a stranger they ran into unexpectedly in the middle of the demonic land.

There was no need to explain my circumstances to them, pretending to be an adventurer was an appropriate answer.

I decided not to pay any more attention to them, thinking that they might have their own situation.

“I don’t know what’s going on, but please be careful.

Saying that, I tried to turn around.

“Ah, wait...!”

“Sir, wait a minute.”

They both called out to me at the same time.

When I glanced back to ask why they were calling me, the woman spoke first.

“Hey, if it’s not rude, just for a moment, can we ask something...”

The life or death of Asher was still unknown.

I needed to find her as soon as possible. I didn’t have time to worry about anything else.

I was about to tell the two that I had no time when the man suddenly spoke.

“There’s a monster we’re looking for, and I want to ask if you’ve ever seen it.”

“...Monster?”

I shook my head.

“I’m sorry, but...”

I stopped while talking.

I didn’t know who they were, but since they were wandering around the central area of Hallmenta alone, I thought they might know something.

“There is something I want to ask you first.”

“Yes?”

“My colleague suddenly disappeared.”

Without high expectations, I told them quickly and concisely about my situation.

Even the fact that Asher disappeared while I was away for a while, that there was no trace of the battle at the scene, and that I was currently wandering around this forest in pursuit of the traces.

They silently listened to my nonsensical explanation.

“Can you guess what happened?”

When the explanation was over, the man looked at the woman.

“Well... Ah.”

She tilted her head and let out a small sigh.

“Maybe it was something that put your companion to sleep, or caused hallucinations, or was it captured by a monster with that kind of ability?”

That was also my guess.

However, since Asher had a high level, I thought it would only make sense unless the monster had stronger abilities.

And if that’s the case, I didn’t know why it dragged her out instead of dealing with her on the spot.

Above all, according to my game knowledge, there were no monsters specialized in hallucinogenic abilities in Hallmenta.

“Oh, come to think of it, there is a monster that comes to mind...”

But the woman seemed to have remembered something. She said that as if trying to recall the memory.

“A few years ago, there was a time when I was in the middle of walking around Hallmenta with my colleagues. I ran into it at that time and almost died.”

“What kind of monster are you?”

“Well, I still don’t know what it was, actually. I just lost my mind at some point, and when I came back, I found myself tied to something like a plant stem.”

- ··Plant stem?

I looked down at the traces on the ground that I was chasing.

It was a description that somewhat coincided with the image of something I was imagining.

“But while I was tied to the stem, my colleagues later said to me they all had nightmares. We were all lost in memories that were painful to recall. In the end, one person woke up and saved all the others, so we barely survived.”

Nightmare···

I furrowed my brow. I was slowly getting the full picture.

Many of the monsters in the demonic land had all kinds of bizarre abilities.

And among them, there were those who dug into the weak part of another person’s heart and used that pain as their own food.

In particular, it was the kind of ability that people with weak mental power or great trauma were more prone to.

Is it that monster...?

As far as I remembered, there were no monsters like that in Hallmenta, but since this was in the past, there could be many monsters that I didn’t know.

What if this guy was a monster with that kind of hallucinogenic ability, so he easily subdued and dragged Asher away?

I followed the trail again and started walking.

The two hurriedly followed me.

“Where are you going?

“I’m chasing the trail it left behind.”

“Trace...?”

The man narrowed his eyes and looked down at the ground where my gaze was directed, then opened his eyes wide and muttered.

“Were you chasing this faint trail?”

“Yes.”

“Uh, what do you see? Why can’t my eyes see anything?”

The woman looked around the ground, nodded her head, and said.

“Anyway, if you’re going to rescue your colleague, we’ll help you first.”

“Thanks for the information, but I don’t think I really need any help.”

“Uh, you look really strong, so it’s true... But there could still be something that we might be of help, right?”

The woman asked the man for consent.

He looked like he was going to say something, but he just nodded.

So, two unexpected strangers suddenly accompanied me and started the chase together. There was no need to refuse the help.

“It turned that way.”

And the man was well versed in tracking, so whenever I was confused by the traces, he correctly identified the direction and pointed them out.

Thanks to this, I saved time and gained speed. The traces were getting clearer, showing that they were not too far off.

“...”

And it didn't take long before I finally found what I was looking for.

I looked at the landscape unfolding in front of me, lost for words.

【Lv. 70】

A plant stem that wrapped around the surrounding trees and stretches into the air. In the middle of it, a person was tied like a prey caught in a spider's web.

It was Asher.

“Hey, it's that monster!”

The woman, who had been in awe for a moment, shouted that, and the man immediately drew his sword and prepared for battle.

Woo woo.

At that moment, a wave spread like a force field around the plant.

The two people who were exposed to the waves staggered precariously and collapsed to the floor.

I looked at those two with bewildered eyes, then moved my gaze back to the plant stem.

What?

Was this its ability?

But because of the [Soul of the King], it didn't seem to work on me.

From the moment I heard that its ability had something to do with illusions, I expected this to happen.

I took a step back.

Seeing that I was fine, it started wriggling as if in bewilderment, and then shot out waves one after another. But there was no way to get through.

As the mental attack failed, it swung the few remaining stems like a whip at me. But those were blocked as well by the floating veil.

The high level was all because of the hallucination ability, so it was a terrible destructive power.

Piis.

Drops of blood from my fingers hit its trunk.

It died instantly, and no longer writhed annoyingly.

I teleported to the upper stem where Asher was tied and stood in front of her.

“...”

I had to pause for a moment.

It was because she could see Asher’s face exposed through the stems, and the tears that were constantly flowing down her cheeks.

I roughly guessed what kind of nightmare she was having now.

I silently tore off the stems tied to her body one by one.

Her whole body was tangled up in the stalks, so it looked like I would have to struggle a bit to get her out.

Chapter 53.2: Hallmenta (4)

Chapter 53.2: Hallmenta (4)

“What’s your dream, Sister?”

Asher stopped the sword she was wielding and turned her head.

It was the question of my younger sister, who had thrown away the water lily and was lying on the grass.

“What are you talking about?”

“Literally, what do you want to do? Or what you want to be.”

She had never thought of that.

My sister would often ask her such silly questions from time to time.

Asher pondered for a moment before answering.

“I don’t know what I want to do... I want to become the best warrior in my clan.”

Her sister pouted her mouth.

“Ah, is that really what you want to be, Sister? That’s what the adults wanted! Every day, they praise my sister as a genius, and all they say to you is to train hard.”

“No. I want to do it.”

“That’s a lie. Don’t do it, consider it carefully, you dull older sister. What you really want to do in your heart. Surely there must be something?”

Asher thought about it again.

But nothing came to mind.

“I don’t think there’s much. I’m satisfied enough even now.”

That answer must have sounded boring to my brother.

Her sister sighed deeply.

“I don’t really understand you sometimes, Sister.”

“What about you? What do you want to do?”

“Me? Of course I’m going out of the mountain range!”

She jumped up and pointed to the other side of the mountain range and shouted excitedly.

“One day I will definitely go out to the outside world and explore the continent! And I will make my name known as a great adventurer all over the world!”

“You’re saying that again. Are you serious?”

“Then, are you going to live here for the rest of your life until you die of old age?”

Asher shook her head.

It was taboo for the members of the tribe to go out into the world outside the mountain range.

If that happened, all the tribes in the mountain range, that was, the entire tribe, would come forward to block it.

Because that was the only way they could protect their home from the outside.

Her sister was having an absurd dream that would be blocked from the start.

“Aren’t you curious about the outside, Sister? What kind of world lies outside the mountain range?”

“Well, if we go out, we will just be rejected.”

“Grandpa Plovik told me. To the north of the continent, there is a land called Calderic, where all kinds of races live.”

Plovik was the eldest of the tribe and was one of the few who had experienced first-hand what it was like in the outside world.

“He said that no race was rejected there. And the one who rules it is a dragon!”

She said, with a twinkle in her eyes.

“So, if we go out, we’ll start there. A new adventure! A new companion! And a new love!”

“Hmm.”

“How come there are only boring and pathetic men around me? If I go out, I will find a true companion for me.”

Then she suddenly turned her head and asked.

“How about it, Sister? You train, eat and sleep, train, eat and sleep, and after living like this, who else are you going to marry?”

“Why are you suddenly talking about marriage?”

“You need to find someone you really love! As long as our parents bring some guy, you’re probably going to marry him. Like the son of the chieftain, for example.”

“I won’t.”

Her younger sister rolled over the grass again with a dissatisfied face and murmured.

“Anyway, so... Yeah, that’s all right. Later, when I’m going to leave the tribe, my older sister, who became the best warrior in the clan, could stop all the others by herself.”

At the absurd remark, Asher started laughing.

“Why are you laughing? I’m serious? Still, it’s your sister’s lifelong wish, so won’t you grant it?”

At that moment, the sisters turned their heads at the same time at the voice calling from afar.

A woman was smiling softly and beckoning them. It was their mother.

“Ah, I think the rice is done. Training is over.”

“You didn’t even swing your sword a few times.”

“Hehe, let’s keep it a secret from Dad? Mom!”

Seeing her younger sister running fast first, Asher also moved slowly.

In her mother’s arms, she waved her hand to Asher as if asking her to come quickly.

Peaceful, warm, and comfortable

Asher wanted nothing more special.

She practiced, she hunted, she ate with her family; she laughed and talked, and she chatted with her little sister.

Even if it’s just a monotonously repeated daily life, she wanted the happiness of the present to continue forever.

...But the peace that seemed to last forever collapsed too suddenly and easily.

“Run away, Asher! Don’t look back!”

Her father, who was covered in blood, stopped the assailants and shouted desperately.

In his arms was her mother’s body, which had already turned into a cold corpse.

A stormy night.

Those in armor slashed the members of her tribe with their swords, and those in robes burned them. A monster with a spear brutally slaughtered all the warriors of the tribe.

Even the ferocious thunder could not hide the clan’s screams echoing throughout the mountain range.

Asher took her sister’s hand and ran. Stepping on blood, jumping over corpses, wielding a sword like a demon, and moving her body that was becoming crippled.

When they reached a place so far from the village that she could no longer hear the screams, there were no more monsters.

However, the monster who seemed to be their leader did not lose sight of them.

He walked towards the two of them, who were thrown at the edge of the cliff. His spear blade, soaked in the tribe’s blood, gleamed coolly.

Asher pushed her sister behind her back. She raised her sword with the thought of dying, fighting to the end here.

Then, suddenly, there was a pain in the back.

“...!”

Her sister's hand was holding her wound tightly.

Why, there was no time to even ask questions.

Her sister suddenly pulled her body towards the cliff. Asher was thrust into the air helplessly.

She reached out and tried to grab her sister's hand. But it didn't reach.

Her body slowly fell into the river below the cliff.

Only the murmur of her smiling little sister with a sad face reached her ears faintly.

“...Survive, Sister.”

The younger sister, who turned right away and rushed towards the monster, and the silver spear that pierced her chest, finally reflected in Asher's sight.

Asher slowly sank into the water.

Vision was blurred. Silence descended on the world.

Soon something hot flowed down the cheek, without stopping.

Why...

She wasn't even curious about the outside world. If she could live in the mountains in peace forever, that was enough.

It filled her with regret and anger.

She shouldn't have turned her back on her father. It should have been her sister who survived. She should have died fighting to the end with everyone.

Why the hell did she survive alone?

Now there's nothing left by her side. No clan, no home, no parents, no younger sister, nothing. But for what?

Crumble.

The body that had been sinking down endlessly came to a sudden stop.

I heard an unknown sound. A faint light shone through the closed eyelids.

Asher slowly opened her eyes.

The scenery unfolding before her eyes was not in the water, but in the forest. She saw a face looking down on this side.

“...I was worried about whether you are alive, but it seems that you're just sleeping.”

Asher blinked her eyes, unable to grasp the situation.

The Seventh Lord, who brushed away the tangled stalks of grass, stretched out his hand.

“Let's get up.”

Asher stared blankly at the white hand, then reached out to it.

Whatever it was, she didn't want to lose it again, so she grabbed it.

T/N: Correction, Asher had a younger sister not a younger brother. In the earlier chapters, the author used the word '***dongsaeng***' whenever he's referring to Asher's younger sibling. It's a general term, so I just kind of assume that it was a brother. Only in this chapter did I know that it was actually a sister. Since she's using the word '***unni***' instead of '***noona***' when she's calling Asher. ><

Chapter 54.1: Hallmenta (5)

Chapter 54.1: Hallmenta (5) 10 ! Thank you to Shinonema, Dubolic, Avarco, 中二病, and Jok for the donations! ^^

A deep tunnel in Hallmenta.

A monster stretched out its long, huge mouth like a cylinder to the ground. Hundreds of eyes lodged in its body fluttered and looked around.

Birds flying around it chirped loudly, as if speaking a word.

The monster, which evolved rapidly over several decades and became intelligent, noticed the presence of intruders killing its subordinates.

Four very tiny little bugs.

The monster knew what they were. Unpredictable creatures that occasionally entered this place from the outside.

Some were too weak for their size, while others had an enormous power that could not be ignored.

In particular, the red bug that swept this land recently was a disaster.

The only thing the monster could do against the red bug was to hide and hold its breath in this haven. Waiting for the bug to slaughter its subordinates to their heart's content and then leave.

Oh oh.

They were just the right prey for it to vent its anger.

A giant figure raised from the ground. It emitted a low and heavy roar, calling out all the subordinates in the area.

Before long, black and huge waves rushed from the horizon on all sides.

“Are you okay?”

“Yes, I’m fine.”

Even after waking up, Asher was stunned for a while, as if her sense of reality had not returned.

But after a few minutes, she was completely back to normal, as if nothing had happened.

“I’m sorry. It’s really embarrassing.”

“It’s fine. Just be careful in the future.”

I glanced at the dead horses entangled on one side of the plant stem.

The monster took them away together with Asher and died.

I was glad she’s alive, but the horses had been together with us for quite some time. So, I briefly prayed for their repose.

The two, who had lost consciousness and fell to the ground, also came to their senses.

The woman stood up with a blank face, looked around and found us.

“...What happened? When did we faint?”

I pointed to the droopy plant stem.

She sighed as if she understood the situation. Then, when she found Asher standing next to me, she smiled brightly and said,

“Did you save your colleague safely? I’m glad.”

The man looked at himself as if to check the condition of his body with a not very good expression on his face, then he got up.

If I fainted without realizing why, that would also be my reaction. The woman was a bit weird in that regard.

Asher looked at the two with puzzled eyes.

“I met them by chance. They said they were adventurers.”

“Ah…”

I told them.

“Thanks for your help. Tell me about the monster you’re looking for. If I know anything, I’ll let you know.”

They must have been chasing me so they could ask for help.

Anyway, thanks to the two of them, I got information about the monster that took Asher and their help also significantly shortened the time to pursue it. So, I was willing to help them.

Of course, I didn’t know if I would be helpful at all, but if I knew of the monster they’re looking for, I would tell them its hunting area if I remembered it.

Kiik!

At that time, the birds flying in the sky spun around and roared loudly.

I glanced up at the sky.

Come to think of it, it seemed like those birds had been wandering around since a while ago. I wondered why.

“Yeah, what we’re looking for is a monster that looks like a toad…”

She explained about the monster they were looking for.

As soon as I heard the word toad, something immediately came to my mind.

Devil Toad?

A gigantic poisonous toad with a black body and a three-pronged tongue.
The level was probably close to 70?

Speaking of toad-type monsters in Hallmenta, the only thing that came to mind was that monster.

“...The whole body was black, and the tongue was forked. Uh, and also poisonous...”

“I think you know what kind of monster it is.”

The man reacted more violently to my words than the woman did.

He opened his eyes wide and asked with a look of urgency.

“Am I right?”

I looked at the two of them and asked.

“Before I answer that, can I ask why you’re looking for that monster?”

There were two reasons for asking why.

One was just curiosity, the other was concern for them.

Devil Toad was one of the weakest monsters among the named bosses in Hallmenta, but it was still a boss.

Even in the game, most of the users’ poison resistance was negligible against it.

No matter how high the level of the two were, they would die quickly if they were careless while dealing with it.

The man stared at me and then spoke calmly.

“There’s no particular reason. We just want to kill it.”

“Why?”

“Because it killed my brother.”

Ah... was it for revenge?

It was a very simple and clear reason.

But what was the younger brother doing here in the demonic land, dying like that?

The woman’s words that followed solved the question.

“He was my colleague.”

“Colleague?”

“Yes. Him, three more others, and I explored every corner of the continent, which included this demonic land. After he died, we separated and disbanded our group.”

Come to think of it, it was weird to find them wandering around the demonic land like this.

The woman’s level was lower than that of the man, but her level was not low at all if compared to other mages.

At level 59, she had skills that even a large aristocratic family would want to employ. Not to mention, it was more than enough to be an adventurer.

But it’s not like she wandering around the demonic land recklessly again.

The woman smiled shyly as she read the puzzled look in my eyes.

“We all got along so well, so even if we encountered a strong monster, we could defeat it somehow if we worked together...”

I could tell the story behind it without even having her say it.

After encountering the Devil Toad, he died and only the rest survived.

She took a deep breath and looked at the man.

“It’s been half a year, and suddenly this person came to me, claiming to be his older brother. He was trying to get revenge for his younger brother, so he asked for information about Hallmenta. And somehow, we ended up coming here together.”

I turned my gaze to the man.

To be honest, I was more curious about his identity.

He didn’t seem like an adventurer like the woman, and he probably wasn’t an ordinary person either.

“Oh, and this guy was a ranger from Barcato.”

- ◦ ··Barcato?

The woman revealed the man’s identity instead. I was a little surprised inside.

If it’s Barcato, wasn’t it the most elite force of the ranger group that protected the southern border of Santea? No wonder he had a high level.

As if the woman’s arbitrariness dissatisfied him, he glanced at the woman once, and said as if urging me.

“Now, tell me what information you know about that monster.”

Well, it’s revenge. There’s nothing I could do about it.

It’s not my place to persuade them not to do it.

“I know the terrain or environment it would most likely to appear.”

“...!”

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“But it’s just a guess, not a completely exact thing. I don’t know if that’s okay with you two.”

“It doesn’t matter. Let me know.”

I pointed out to him the characteristics of places where the Devil Toad lived and even pointed out a few places directly.

I wanted to tell them about the attack patterns I remembered, but I was not sure how different the game would be from reality. I decided not to tell them about it because I was afraid it would only have the opposite effect.

After hearing all the explanations, the man asked with a curious expression.

“How do you know so much?”

What I said was not a common knowledge, so it’s no wonder that it would puzzle him.

“You are free to believe it or not.”

Explaining further would just be too troublesome, so I just left it at that.

The man was silent for a moment before nodding his head.

“...Anyway, thank you.”

With this, it was the end of this encounter.

We had to get out of the forest, so we accompanied them until then.

All the baggage originally carried by the horses was now carried by Asher.

While walking in the forest, the woman suddenly opened her mouth.

“By the way, we don’t even know each other’s names yet. My name is Chercy.”

When she looked away, the man said his name too.

“It’s Kellip.”

We’re going to separate soon anyway, but they suddenly wanted to exchange names.

“I’m Ron. This is Asher.”

Chercy asked again.

“Umm, Sir Ron. I’m just asking out of curiosity, but can you please tell me who you are?”

“I said I’m an adventurer.”

She looked at me with a puzzled look.

“…No matter how I see it, it’s not like your real identity. And if we look at the person walking beside you, she’s not just a colleague, but an escort knight instead.”

When she didn’t get an answer, she asked no more, but asked other questions instead.

“Then can you tell me how you killed that bear from before?”

Because she was an adventurer, she was a curious woman. She asked all the things she wanted to ask while looking at me.

It was difficult to answer all of them, so I just ignored them moderately.

She licked her lips in regret and just changed the subject.

“By the way, it seems like birds have been spinning over our heads since earlier. Is there some kind of reason behind it?”

That still bothered me, so I gently raised my head.

Birds hovering above us while roaming around since a while ago. Just why?

They were almost out of the forest.

I could feel a faint presence with my super sensory.

“...?”

No, that faintness was just because of the distance.

It was a very large group of monsters pouring in from afar.

Soon, even the vibrations of the ground were felt minutely, and the other three also recognized the strangeness.

“Uh... what is it? The ground is shaking?”

And when we finally came out of the forest, everyone could see.

A huge black line stretching along the horizon to the land ahead.

It was a large army made up of many monsters in the demonic land of Hallmenta.

“...”

For a moment, I thought of something.

I looked at the scene with bewildered eyes. No, really, what was that?

“...Is this a dream?”

Chericy patted her cheek with a puzzled look.

Next to them, Asher and Kellip, had a hardened expression on their face.

I looked at the horde of monsters again.

Upon closer inspection, there was one that stood out among the monsters.

It's very huge, and had long, thick tentacles in the middle of its body...
Aside from its odd appearance.

【Lv. 91】

The most impressive thing was its level.

Level 91.

A monster equal to the warrior and one level higher than Bellevagorah,
which I had met in the Rutus Mountains before.

- ..Ah

I only realized it after checking its level.

That it was that guy.

The fact that we often encountered hordes of monsters with weird combinations that were difficult to understand while wandering around, the birds that were bothering us from above, and the group of monsters unfolding before our eyes were all its actions.

Dominance.

The ability to dominate other monsters and treat them like their own slaves.

At the present time, there was a named boss with domination-type ability in Hallmenta.

Anyway, what kind of crazy number is that?

It wriggled its gigantic tentacles and stretched out toward this side.

Light soon gathered from the tip of the tentacle, and it created a huge purple photosphere.

I frowned at the eerie, magical energy I felt and took a step forward. Then I spread the floating veil as wide as possible.

Flash!

The light completely engulfed my vision.

The mana cannon fired from it completely covered the veil.

When the light faded, and my vision returned, I saw the ruined surroundings. Behind me, the sound of falling trees echoed.

Only the blocked part of the veil was intact, and the middle of the forest was open as if it had been erased.

“...What — crazy.”

Kellip, who understood the situation, muttered in a muffled voice.

Chericy, who had been lost in thought, suddenly came to her senses.

“Bah, did you just stop it?”

I stared intently at the monster in the distance without answering.

The last blow must have been a signal for an all-out-attack.

The monsters seemed to burst into roars all at once, and then they started flocking towards us like a tidal wave. The distance quickly drew closer.

“Go, run away! Hurry!”

Chercy turned white and shouted. Kellip looked at me as if asking why I was just standing still.

“Sir Ron.”

Asher rarely called my name with a sign of urgency.

A large army of monsters numbering more than a thousand. If you bump into it head-on, it would be difficult to leave a single bone fragment.

But there was no need to run away.

It was a situation I had never imagined at all, so I was a little embarrassed, but that was all.

All I could see was a swarm of fire moths running around to death.

I slowly raised my hand forward.

Uh uh.

Blood from the palms rose high into the sky and clumped to form a sphere.

Without stopping, he continued to spread and draw blood.

The red blood, which was getting bigger and bigger, soon became as huge as my body.

After compressing it as much as possible, I blasted it forward with full force.

Whoops!

Countless drops of blood that burst out of the air poured down like a torrential rain towards the monsters that covered the ground.

Chapter 55.1: Hallmenta (6)

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For a moment, the vision in front was dyed red. It was like a baptism, with the blood pouring out like rain.

Small, thin drops of blood covered all the monsters that were flocking to them.

And the collapse was instantaneous.

The battle lines of the rushing monsters collapsed. They jammed, tangled, fell, and wildly wallowed, and slipped on the ground. A thick layer of dust spread.

Silence fell. That happened in just a few seconds.

“...”

Asher's eyes lit up with astonishment.

There were no more living and moving monsters. Only the hills of corpses piled up remained.

It didn't take time to understand what had happened.

The scene unfolding before her eyes was incomprehensible no matter how many times she might have seen it.

What the hell kind of power was this?

She thought that she had seen all the abilities of the Seventh Lord being by his side until now. But it was just an arrogant delusion.

Asher turned her gaze and looked blankly at the Seventh Lord.

With his hands down, he stared at the other side with indifferent eyes.

Beyond the corpses, a gigantic monster wriggling tentacles and moving swiftly. It was like it was running away.

The figure of the Seventh Lord, who shed a trivial laugh, disappeared.

She came to her senses and turned her head again. Suddenly, he was in the air in the distance.

Complete annihilation.

It wasn't much of a thrill because it was the expected result from the time the monsters came in ignorantly as a swarm.

“...”

However, Asher and the other two were completely at a loss.

It was natural to think of what they had just seen as something incomprehensible. Especially since they didn't know about my abilities.

...*But look at that weak bastard.*

I looked at the monster boss who was running away with its tentacles wriggling. Was it running away after all of its subordinates died?

I used space leaps in succession, narrowing the distance with him in an instant.

Ugh!

With a sign of urgency, it once again gathered a magic ball from the tentacles. This time, instead of shooting like a beam, it threw it whole towards me.

I spread the floating veil in the air.

The magic ball that collided with the veil exploded as it was. It was a formidable force, but it couldn't break through the veil's defense.

As soon as the flash went off, I immediately spread my blood and made it into an elongated thorn.

We were still far away from each other, but we were close enough that my blood could hit it.

The blood spurted through the air and hit its huge body.

Woohoo!

After checking the figure of the monster that had collapsed with a loud roar, I landed gently on the ground.

The surrounding area was a field of corpses of monsters.

I looked around at them for a while and then he felt sorry.

It was because I felt regretful about the fact that I couldn't get a single experience point even after slaughtering an army of monsters like this.

How many people have I killed after falling into this world? If I could have leveled up, how many levels would I have now?

I used space leap and got closer to the fallen monster. Then, I looked around.

By the way, why wasn't this guy a named boss in Hallmenta a few years later?

There were many reasons that come to mind. Either it was attacked by a stronger monster, or a superhuman from outside killed it.

In particular, I thought the Mad King might have killed it since the other often hunted in places like this.

Soon, Asher came running to where I was.

The other two people were already nearby.

They were staring at something among the corpses of the monsters, so I was wondering what they were looking at, but it was the corpse of a giant toad monster.

...*Uh.*

Wait a minute, was that?

I approached them and looked at the monster's corpse together.

Devil Toad. A monster that the two were looking for so they could take revenge.

Apparently, this guy was also under domination and was mixed among the group of monsters earlier.

"...This is that monster. It's dead."

Chercy murmured.

Kellip didn't take his eyes off the corpse. It was a gaze with complex emotions, including emptiness.

I stood there a little embarrassed, then he turned his gaze to me and said,

"It's a pity I couldn't kill it with my own hands, but thank you."

I nodded.

Chercy also looked at Devil Toad's corpse with a somewhat sad face.

It would probably feel like such a waste for them, but it would have been good for them to leave the demonic land cleanly with this.

Squeak!

Kellip, looking at the monster's body again, cut off the tip of its toe a little, and put it in the leather pocket on his waist.

I didn't ask why he did that. He probably just wanted to take it to his brother's grave since it's the one who killed him.

Anyway, this was finally all over.

We're done here, but the time was delayed because of the disappearance of Asher.

This time around, a lot of stuff happened. And I didn't get the mystery I was planning to get.

There was no reason to remain in the demonic land any longer, since Chercy and Kellip both achieved their goals.

We went in the same direction anyway, so we continued walking together until we went out. And after leaving Hallmenta, we said our goodbyes.

“Goodbye then, Sir Ron! And Sir Asher! Thank you so much!”

Chercy waved her hand vigorously, and Kellip nodded his head in one final thank-you note.

Me and Asher moved again as two.

We lost our horses, so we had to travel differently compared to when we came. Thanks to the super regeneration, it mattered little to me even if I had little stamina.

After a long time of such diligent movement, we returned to the city where Baros was waiting.

Chapter 55.2: Hallmenta (6)

Chapter 55.2: Hallmenta (6)

Hee hee hee!

As always, in the moving carriage, I watched the scenery outside the window.

This was the end of the mystery-finding journey. It was time to return to my territory.

Except for one, everything else was obtained as planned, so I could say that the result was satisfactory.

‘Still, the last mystery... it’s regretful not getting it.

I ended up thinking about the last mystery I didn’t get from Hallmenta.

A mystery with the ability to throw away one’s own body and take the body of another who met the conditions.

In a word, it was the ability to possess.

However, there was a penalty that one could never return to the former body that was thrown away after using it.

There was only one reason I was trying to gain that mystery, which would be of no use to me.

Because there was one villain who would cause a huge disaster in the future through that mystery.

I have cleared all the main story of RaSa.

Naturally, I was aware of the existence of major villains who would cause major problems along the way.

However, unlike other villains, that ‘*bastard*’ was a person who annoyingly changed his broken body with his possessor ability.

Because of that, it’s hard to know what kind of body he was in, where he was, and what he was doing.

So, I was trying to take that mystery and block the problem altogether...

It can’t be helped.

I brushed off my anger cleanly. What’s the use of thinking about the past?

All I could do was continue to do my best in the future.

The wagon ran and ran, passing through the territories of the First and Third Lords, and then arrived at the Sixth Lord’s territory.

It was possible to go directly from the First Lord’s territory to mine by passing through the Overlord’s territory, but I wanted to check the news about Valkilov, so I deliberately went through the Third Lord’s land.

“Whoa....”

So, the current location was Mahea, the capital of the Sixth Lord’s territory.

I stood before the windowsill of the inn room and looked up blankly at the sky.

There were several months left until the next meeting of the Lords. After returning to my territory, I was contemplating what to do first.

It would have been nice to have the time to go to Santea, but time was tight.

There was nothing to do until the next meeting.

Then there was a commotion in the street.

I lowered my head.

A man was grabbing a young boy by the collar and yelling at him.

Hearing what he said, it seemed that his wallet was stolen. Pedestrians around them glanced at them.

“Hey, what’s going on?”

Then two armed soldiers approached them.

The man who was holding the boy by the neck explained the situation with a slight smirk.

Then the soldiers smiled mischievously and looked at the boy.

“Hey, a pickpocket? Get out of the way. You can’t just talk like that to a nasty bastard.”

Then, after pushing the man, he suddenly swung his spear and slammed the boy in the head. The boy screamed and fell.

The soldiers did not stop there. Rather, as if it was just the beginning, they began to thrash the boy who had fallen.

“Argh, ahhh...!”

A crackling sound came from the boy’s arm, which was trodden by the soldier’s kick. The boy let out a louder scream.

The man who had been pickpocketed watched all this with restlessness.

All the passers-by around them were all quiet, and they just went on their way avoiding the soldiers.

I clicked my tongue as I looked down at the scene.

If the water above was rotten, the water below would also rot.

The security of the Sixth Lord's territory, ruled by a tyrant, was such a thing.

They enjoy stealing money from travelers like a gangster in a back alley or using violence under the guise of punishment. It was the same when I played the game.

So the soldiers trampled on the boy for a few minutes and then left.

“Uh, uh...”

The boy, whose body was covered in dirt and blood, squirmed on the floor. Of course, no one was there to help.

As I was contemplating whether to help with that, an old man passing by then approached the boy.

An old man with an orange beard with a small body like a dwarf.

As he looked at the boy's condition, he clicked his tongue, pulled something out of his bosom, and started pouring it all over the boy's broken arm. It was a potion.

So the old man cured the boy and went straight back on his way.

I saw the boy who got up from his the ground, bowed his head with a bewildered expression.

“...”

I watched the series of events with a bit of interest.

In this world, potions were precious, even the low-quality ones. He was a rare virtuoso who could freely give such a potion to others.

The old man who was moving away quickly went into an alley and disappeared.

I stared at the place where he disappeared, then stopped looking at the streets and laid down on the bed.

As I stared blankly at the ceiling for a while, something flashed in my mind.

I opened my eyes wide and jumped up as if bouncing.

Wait a minute...

That old man, maybe?

Because of his distinctive appearance, it immediately convinced me of the old man's identity. I let out a small sigh.

Why is he in this city?

At this point in time, he was in the capital of the Sixth Lord?

It was an unexpectedly big discovery.

After thinking about what to do for a while, I hurriedly put on the robe hanging on one side of the room and went out of the inn. Alone, leaving Asher.

I went out into the street and went into the alley the old man had entered.

As I went inside and continued along the road, I soon found a sign for a potion shop in the distance.

I thought it was over there and was about to approach, but I heard a voice coming from the side road.

“Hey there! Stop it!”

I turned my head to something.

Two soldiers I had seen on the street before were approaching me.

Chapter 56.1: Refrigon (1)

Chapter 56.1: Refrigon (1)

The soldiers who approached this way looked around me.

Then he scrunched up his chin and said,

“What are you? You look suspicious? Are you walking around alleys like this in broad daylight wearing robes?”

…What was he saying now?

I wondered what kind of bullshit this was, but I quickly understood the situation.

Are they trying to rip me off?

Compared to other Lord’s knights or soldiers, the Sixth Lord’s soldiers was the worst in many ways.

It was not unusual here that the soldiers who were supposed to keep the security robbed passers-by’s money bags.

One soldier put a mean smile on his lips and waved his hand. The other clacked his spear threateningly from behind.

“If you want to pass quietly, give us money. Or you can just get beaten up and go with us.”

I just laughed out loud because this sudden robbery dumbfounded me.

“…This kid is laughing? Are you kidding me right now?”

The men's expressions were severely distorted.

I ignored it and looked up.

There was no middle ground in my abilities, so there was no way to properly subdue them other than to kill them.

It's a legend in itself to slaughter monsters like that in the demonic land, but not be able to subdue two soldiers who were less than level 20.

I was thinking of simply jumping up the building with space leap to get out.

"Hey."

I heard another new voice.

Someone from the potion shop I was just heading to was approaching this way.

A short-haired woman with a sword on her waist and a long, oblique cut across her face. In one hand, she held a bottle of potion that she had just purchased.

The soldiers who saw her were startled and retreated.

She looked back at them and me once and said in a cool voice.

"Get out of here, you bastards."

She said it to the soldiers.

One of them tried to open his mouth with an angry expression, but his colleague hurriedly stopped him.

"Hey, hey, let's go."

The two men could only stare at the woman, and then quickly escaped through the side road.

I could hear the murmurs of those walking away.

“Fuck, what an arrogant bitch when she’s only nothing but a slave...”

...Slave?

I looked at the woman who drove the soldiers away with a single word.

But she didn’t even look at me and went straight past me and went on her way.

I think she helped, so it’s absurd that she left without saying a word.

I stared at her back, then immediately stopped paying attention and went my own way. I moved towards the potion shop where she came out.

Kriiing.

I opened the old wooden door with a sign and went inside.

The inside was as old as the outside, but the atmosphere was neat. However, it smelled like a mixture of things.

Potions of various colors were displayed here and there. It reminded me of the scenery I saw in the Alkimas workshop.

As I looked around, an old man walked out of the shelf in the corner. It was the old man I was looking for.

I’ve come to the right place.

He glanced at me and walked over to the cashier’s chair and sat down.

“You’re a guest I haven’t seen. What potion did you come to buy?”

I pondered for a moment and answered.

“I’ll look around first.”

“Do what you feel comfortable with.”

The old man leaned back on his chair and picked up a cigarette from the desk.

He took a leaf fly from the drawer, stuffed it, lit it, and smoked it.

I glanced at the old man and turned away.

I looked through the potions on the shelf and fell into deep thought.

The reason I took a look around first was because I needed to be careful about how to open up a conversation with him.

Great Alchemist Gulpiero.

One of the most prestigious great alchemists on the continent in the present day.

And the person who created the elixir, ‘*The Holy Blood of Diferi*’.

That was the identity of the old man.

Why was he running an old potion shop in such a sparsely populated alley, but knowing what his situation was at the moment, it was roughly expected...

After organizing my thoughts, I turned my gaze back to the old man.

I spoke to him, who was exhaling cigarette smoke with a languid face.

“Master, how long has this store been running?”

He narrowed his eyes.

“That, young guy... It’s been about a year now, why?”

It’s been one year

I asked again.

“What’s the master’s name?”

“My name? Pleon. You can just call me with that.”

“No.”

I shook my head.

“I’m asking for your real name, not a pseudonym.”

At that moment, the atmosphere cooled down.

The characteristic languid atmosphere of the old man disappeared, and instead he was filled with a sense of intimidation.

He put down his cigarette and looked at me with a smirk.

“Who are you?”

I answered calmly.

“Seventh Lord.”

“...What?”

The old man’s eyes widened.

I told him, who was speechless.

“I don’t intend to threaten you. I’m just talking to you for a while, alchemist Gulpiro.”

He glanced out the shop window with a hardened expression on his face. I added;

“I came alone.”

“...Are you really the Seventh Lord? The one who had just been enthroned?”

“Yes.”

“How can I believe that?”

“If not, I must be a madman pretending to be a Lord and using his name. Why would I lie when it’s something that could be easily discovered with a little investigation?”

The old man, Gulpiro, frowned and let out a sigh.

“It would be meaningless to ask how you came to know about me. So, what’s the reason you’re here?”

He asked why I had come to see him.

Chapter 56.2: Refrigon (1)

Chapter 56.2: Refrigon (1)

“If you’re going to ask me to make an elixir, then stop. I can’t make it anymore.”

“No.”

“Or are you planning on recruiting me? It’s useless even if you threatened to kill me, so stop that too.”

“Not that either.”

He had a history of producing new potions that were recognized as elixir.

Of course, it would be nice if I could recruit him, but I didn’t come to this person for that purpose.

Grand Alchemist Gulpiro.

He appeared as a powerful ally in RaSa’s main storyline, providing a big help to the allied faction once during an important time.

He was also a good man, as one could see from the way he helped the boy on the street earlier.

Therefore, even if it was not possible to attract him as an ally, it was good enough to protect him from danger.

Because now he probably...

“You must have come all the way to Calderic, avoiding the eyes of Santea.”

Gulpiro clicked his tongue.

“You already know everything, so what are you asking?”

He was originally a member of the Santea faction.

Magic Tower, the largest and most powerful group of mages in Santea.

As an alchemist who originally belonged to that place, the Magic Tower and the Imperial Family betrayed him for some reason. It was an issue with the elixir.

And he saved his life and escaped from the chase, and in the future, he was not here in Calderic, but in the land of the South Continent.

I was curious and asked.

“Is there any reason to settle in the capital of the Sixth Lord?”

No matter how much I thought about it, Mahea was not a good place to settle down for him, regardless of his personality and other things.

Because it was a city where the Tyrant ruled, and there was even a ‘slave gladiator’ every day.

He shook his head and said.

“I happened to ended up here because of circumstances. I’m thinking of leaving as soon as possible.”

“Then you can come to the capital of my territory.”

I said so naturally.

Gulpiro looked at me with an absurd look.

“Didn’t you say you will not recruit me?”

“It’s not about recruiting, it literally means coming to the land that I rule.”

“So what is that...”

“I want nothing, Gulpiro. I just want to protect you completely from the pursuit of Santea.”

He said with a look that seemed more and more incomprehensible.

“You want nothing, but you’re going to protect me? What do you mean?”

A Lord and no one else would protect him without asking for anything in return.

For him, of course, that would be unbelievable.

But what could I do, it’s all true.

“Know this first, Gulpiro.”

I decided to be honest about my thoughts.

It would not work anyway to attach clumsy reasons to a character like Gulpiro.

“You are one of the best alchemists on the continent. Such a person has turned his back on Santea and came to Calderic, and it’s good for us just to keep you here. There is no reason Calderic should not take care of you.”

“...Even if I have no intention of being your ally?”

“Yeah, because your opinion can change soon. To be honest, you can think of it as me scamming you.”

I am well aware of Gulpiro’s character.

Even in the main story of the game, he helped the players until the end because of a small debt that wasn’t too big.

In a word, he was the type of person who couldn’t live without paying back what he had received.

So it didn't matter if he didn't want to be allied with me right now.

Anyway, if I kept him by my side and continued to build trust between us, I could get help someday when I needed it.

"...A scam, huh."

Gulpiro let out a laugh.

"I don't know what to do when a Lord of Calderic say such a thing."

He said so, but he was a person no less than a Lord because of his continental fame.

It's just that, because of an alchemist's lack of power, he was forced to live in hiding from Santea's eyes.

"Can I smoke for a bit?"

Gulpiro pointed to the pipe he had put down.

I nodded, and he put the cigarette to his lips again.

He stared into the air with thoughtful eyes and smoked for a moment, then opened his mouth.

"Does the Overlord know of my existence?"

"No."

"Then what about the Sixth Lord?"

"He doesn't know either."

For some reason, Gulpiro let out a small sigh and continued.

"If I go to the Seventh Lord's territory, I guess I'll have to stay at the Lord's Castle?"

“It can be an option. But you can also stay in any place you wanted.”

In an instant, the Alkimas Workshop came to mind.

It wouldn't be a bad idea to secretly connect Gulpiro with her.

Scarlett was a talented alchemist, and it would be great if she could learn even a bit of alchemy from Gulpiro.

As if in thought again, Gulpiro only smoked a cigarette for a while without saying a word.

Then, after a few minutes, he nodded slowly.

“Okay. I will go to Enrock just as you said, Seventh Lord. Even if I refuse anyway, you'll still keep your eyes on me.”

...Well, I was not really planning to.

However, he seemed to have taken that into account in accepting my proposal, so I did not have to deny it.

I was about to say that he made a good decision, but before I could, he added,

“But before that, there is one condition.”

Chapter 57.1: Refrigon (2)

Chapter 57.1: Refrigon (2)

...Condition?

I put on a puzzled look. Was he trying to get some materials for alchemy research?

But what followed was unexpected.

“I want you to save someone.”

“...Save someone?”

“Do you know about Actipol’s slave gladiator in this city?”

I nodded. There’s no way I wouldn’t know.

But why asked that suddenly?

Gulpiro continued the conversation, exhaling cigarette smoke with a sigh.

“I’ve been quite close with one person since the time I settled in this city. A young guy named Van, who ran a small fruit stall. He hasn’t shown his face lately, so I found out he couldn’t pay off his debts to the city’s lenders and they picked him up.”

It was a rather random story, so I just blinked my eyes.

“They say he’s already sold as a slave to Actipol, and is about to compete in a match, but I hope the Seventh Lord can rescue him. I’m begging you.”

He was asking in a more polite tone than before.

I asked, scratching my chin.

“Does he have a bit of a debt to pay off?”

“I heard it was over 30 gold because of the interest. When I visited Actipol, the ransom had already doubled. So, I was thinking about whether I should make a proper potion so I can help the guy.”

I didn’t understand what this meant for a moment, but then I understood.

It meant that he was trying to pay the ransom for the man who was caught by making a potion. And then I came here.

...

I sighed inwardly.

Because I realized I had come to Gulpiro at an amazing time.

It looked like he’s running a shop by making just simple potions right now, but what if he makes and sells great potions?

Naturally, he had no choice but to attract the attention of those in power in this capital. And in the worst case, his identity could even be revealed.

It occurred to me that him not remaining here in the not-too-distant future and moved to the South Continent might have something to do with this incident.

Anyway, it’s not something too difficult.

Money was rotting in my pocket. A few dozen gold was not even a penny for me.

And even if it was something that money could not do, I could solve it with power.

If there's only one thing that bothered me...

"Okay. Let me bring him right away."

"Thank you."

I readily answered.

And after talking with him a little more, I finished the conversation and left the store.

The Sixth Lord's territory ruled by the Tyrant.

In particular, Mahea, the capital city, was a place full of various vices and corruption, as befitting his notoriety.

One of the most representative of them was the slave gladiator.

After returning to the inn, I went straight out again with Asher and headed west of the city.

I looked at the huge structure that was appearing in the distance, standing in the middle of the streets and buildings.

Actipol.

It was the name of that huge stadium that looked like the Colosseum.

A death game in which only the victors could survive, in which armed slave gladiators fight for their lives.

All around, knights and soldiers stood guard, and many passers-by were seen entering and leaving Actipol.

Even now, the match was in full swing, and loud cheers and boos from the crowd were resounding inside the stadium.

“Tsk.”

I clicked my tongue slightly.

Even in the game, the episodes related to Actipol had a dark storyline.

That was why I could clearly see how desperate the struggle was going on inside.

It was a world where the weight of life was infinitely light, especially in this city of Mahea.

To them, the desperate struggle of the slaves was just a moment’s entertainment, and it was only a means to win a lot by gambling.

I continued to walk.

The destination we were heading to now was not the stadium, but the slave prison building attached to it.

As Gulpiro said, the man named Van must be locked up there by now.

Let’s try to solve the problem with money.

What I was concerned about was if the other side kept trying to raise the ransom price, or if they said they wouldn’t sell him back at all.

In that case, it was enough to just press it with power, but this was also ambiguous.

If I revealed my identity as the Seventh Lord, of course, it would immediately reach the ears of the Tyrant in the Lord’s castle.

I wanted to avoid letting him know I was in this city. Maybe he would even come in person to meet me.

The reason I was wearing a robe like this now was because I was afraid that someone would recognize me. Because it was the Sixth Lord’s territory was just right next door to my territory.

Baltegger the Tyrant.

I thought about him for a moment.

There were a lot of words that could describe him, but to make it simple, he was;

Garbage, scumbag, tyrant, demon, monster, and many more...

He was the worst vampire in the world, acting only according to his own desires and enjoying the suffering of others more than anything else. That's why the slave gladiator Actipol was built.

There were many villains in this RaSa universe, but if I had to pick the most primitively disgusting, it was the Tyrant.

“...”

Come to think of it, when I think about him, another character would come to mind.

In fact, the Tyrant was also a person to watch with more attention than the other Lords.

He's just plain trash, so there's no need to worry about it.

Even though he was a villain, as long as we were the same Lord, there was no harm in me.

There was only one reason.

Because he was deeply connected with one other important character in RaSa's main story.

Flesh-headed Refrigon.

Chapter 57.2: Refrigon (2)

Chapter 57.2: Refrigon (2)

The original owner of the Seventh Lord's throne.

The person who should have originally sat on the Seventh Lord's seat that I had now occupied by chance.

He was the Seventh Lord of Calderic from the point of view of the gameplay, that was, several years later.

I didn't know who he was.

Because there was almost no information about him in the game. Despite being on equal footing with the other Lords.

He always wore a mask, so he never showed his face.

Therefore, the only information I knew about Refrigon was that he was a human male, in a word, only his race and gender.

And I didn't know the reason, but he hated the Tyrant very much.

Even in the main story, he killed the Tyrant during the Santea terror episode and then self-destructed in vain, so there was not even a small background about him.

So it was selected as one of the biggest mysteries of RaSa among the players.

A lot of players scolded the game devs for making a guy with no backstory into a Lord.

There were a lot of players who were looking for a hidden piece related to Refrigon, but in the end, they found nothing.

And even if it's not just Refrigon, RaSa's main story had a lot of unresolved parts, so there were a lot of complaints from players.

Anyway, that's why the Tyrant was the one I should keep paying attention to in the future.

Because of the presence of Refrigon. Who, by the way, I did not know where or what he was doing right now.

Since I didn't know what kind of variable that mysterious monster would become in the future, it was natural to understand his identity, if possible.

For now, let's focus on taking that guy, Van, out of here.

After I finished thinking about it, I turned my attention to what I had to do again.

As we headed towards the prison building, I heard a shout nearby.

“...Oh, it's that guy!”

It was a group of soldiers walking around the arena.

One soldier pointed at me and yelled, and they rushed over this way.

I frowned, but when I looked closely, they were the guys I had met in the alley before.

“What? What's going on?”

“No, I met him in the alley earlier...”

One man explained the situation to his colleagues, and the other stood in front of me with a wide smile on his lips.

“You bastard, you got it right. Did you get out like that earlier?”

- ..Ah, this was annoying.

He tried to put his hand on my shoulder.

At that, Asher stepped forward and grabbed him by the wrist.

“What, what? Don’t you let this go?”

He struggled to get his wrist out of her grasp, but there was no way he could.

I shook my head.

“Let him ho.”

When Asher lightly pushed him aside, he jumped for a moment, then screamed and rolled to the ground noisily.

The other soldiers raised their spears in amazement.

It felt funny to see the stereotypical appearances of third-rate villains. What were these guys really doing?

“Go, you dare attack the soldiers....”

“What a fuss!”

Then there was a new person coming here again.

It was a man who looked like a knight armed with light armor.

He approached this way, looked around at the soldiers, and turned his gaze to me.

“It looks like you attacked a soldier, am I correct?”

I answered with an annoyed face.

“And so?”

“And so? Do you not know what it means to dare to resist the military power in Mahea?”

The knight pulled out his sword with a harshly distorted impression.

“Both of you surrender obediently and follow me. Otherwise, I will execute them immediately.”

Wow....

This city was really very sleazy.

It seemed as if he was really planning to kill us if we didn't obey his words.

A small crowd gathered around the commotion.

The guy who had just been thrown by Asher and flew away was looking at the knights and smirking at us as if he we were dead.

I was thinking about how to deal with these assholes, but for a moment, I furrowed my brows and turned my head to the side.

“...?”

I had no choice but to do so.

A huge energy was coming closer from afar.

Soon after, on the road leading to the entrance to the stadium, it was the appearance of two people, a man and a woman.

A large man with black hair and red eyes, and a woman who appeared to be an attendant behind him.

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I let out a small sigh as I looked at the man's appearance.

Damn, I didn't want to meet him here, but...

“...!”

Silence fell all around.

At the appearance of the man, people passing by the stadium all knelt on the floor and bowed their heads.

It was the same with the knight who was pointing his sword at me.

He dropped his sword and hurriedly knelt down and put his forehead on the floor.

Sixth Lord, the Tyrant.

Everyone was lying flat on the floor, and it was only me and Asher standing.

“You, you idiot. What are you doing? You’re in front of the Sixth Lord! Come on, get down on your knees!”

The knight who glanced up at me whispered in a trembling voice.

I ignored it and stared intently at the Tyrant approaching this way.

Soon, the one who came close to me stopped walking and met my eyes.

The Tyrant smiled and opened his mouth first.

“This is a surprise. What brought you here to my territory, Seventh Lord?”

Chapter 58.1: Refrigon (3)

Chapter 58.1: Refrigon (3)

A small hiccup sounded.

I heard it from among the knights and the soldiers who were lying on their sides next to me.

At the Tyrant's remarks, the attendant beside him bowed her head at me in amazement.

Seeing this, Asher hesitated for a moment, and then bowed her head to the Tyrant.

I glanced at her and opened my mouth.

"I have something to do here for a while."

"Really? If you're coming here directly to the capital, you should have contacted me. Then I could have prepared a very grand welcome."

He spoke in a friendly tone, as if he were dealing with an old friend.

Fortunately, he didn't ask about the purpose of my visit.

With a smile on his lips, the Tyrant shifted his gaze to the knights and soldiers next to me.

"By the way, it looked like there was some sort of quarrel... What's the situation with this?"

Their bodies trembled.

The knight turned to me and banged his head on the floor once more. Then he stammered in a voice terrified.

“Lord, I have committed a mortal sin. In ignorance, I did not dare to recognize someone as great as you. Please have mercy.”

I stared at him.

Then the Tyrant burst out laughing.

He narrowed his eyes and looked down at them with a smile.

“Yeah, well, somehow I saw some bug pulling their weapon at you, Seventh Lord. So, I thought there was something wrong with my eyes.”

Aww!

The eerie shattering sound and the knight’s body were separated into several parts.

Then, even the soldiers who were lying on their backs were mercilessly torn.

Red blood splattered and corpse fragments rolled across the floor. At the sight, Asher took a small breath.

“My apologies, Seventh Lord.”

As if expelling insects, he transformed the six of them into shredded pieces of meat with just one flick of his hand.

I sighed inwardly and looked at the man, who withdrew his hand indifferently.

Crazy guy...

Originally, I knew he was such a bastard, but when I saw it in front of my eyes, that fact was proven again.

A tragedy that happened in an instant on one side of the street.

But there were no screams from all around. Some of the passers-by lying on their backs covered their mouths and barely held their breath.

As if everyone knew well that with even the slightest breath, they would be the same as the corpses lying around.

“Uh, uh...”

Then there was a small sound from one side.

A young child could not stand the tears that came out of his mouth.

The woman who appeared to be the mother holding the child turned white. She covered his little mouth and hugged the child even tighter and prayed with an earnest voice.

“Sa, please save me. Please save me. Please...”

It is a scene that was difficult to watch.

I caught the attention of the Tyrant with my words when he just turned his head towards the woman.

“I’ll accept the Sixth Lord’s apology if you can do me a favor.”

The man turned his gaze to me again and tilted his head.

“A favor? What?”

“I want to take a slave from that prison cell.”

Ah... I didn’t really want to reveal my purpose to this guy.

I was in a hurry to find a story to turn his attention to, and this happened.

Anyway, since this was already the case, I would just ask for the guy and take him out of there.

He asked with an interesting look.

“Hey, did you come all the way here to save a slave? What kind of guy are you looking for? Why are you looking for it?”

It’s not good for him to be deeply interested in this.

I ignored the question and asked in the guise of indifference.

“Will you grant it?”

The guy who stared at me for a moment smiled and nodded his head softly.

“Then, of course, it’s not just anyone’s request. It’s yours. Take one slave or a hundred as you please.”

What?

He grinned as he looked over my shoulder at the arena.

“The game is in full swing right now. Please take a moment and watch it with me. How about it? Is that okay?”

“...”

I furrowed my brows silently.

What kind of bullshit was this suddenly?

Chapter 58.2: Refrigon (3)

Chapter 58.2: Refrigon (3)

Perhaps the Tyrant's visit was sudden. That's why when he entered Actipol, people who seemed to be high-ranking officials rushed in to serve him.

A huge amphitheater the size of a modern soccer field.

The spectator seats were packed with crowds of people, just like the sounds heard from outside.

I sat down on a fancy chair like an emperor at the highest point of the arena and looked down.

The Tyrant sitting right next to me with his chin on his hand. I wondered why he looked like he was having fun.

Tsk.

I clicked my tongue inward.

Somehow, it became a situation where I had to hang out with this guy for a while and watch the game.

Did he want to get to know me, or did he want to make friends, or was it just a whim?

I had to take out a slave without friction as much as possible, so I accepted without refusing, but it was a very annoying and uncomfortable place.

“Doesn't your mouth feel empty, Seventh Lord? You could have a drink while watching.”

Alcohol was shit.

I responded bluntly, holding back my desire to swear.

“No need.”

“Ha ha, yes. It looks like the game will resume soon, so let’s enjoy it.”

He was humming and eating something his subordinates had brought him.

Something red shaped like a sugar cube filled a golden glass.

Glancing at him, he picked up another cube, put it in his mouth, and chewed it softly.

“Ah, this? It’s a snack made with blood. Fresh blood is good, but blood that has been aged for a long time has a special taste.”

...Disgusting.

Like the worst vampire, the Tyrant had a non-stop craving for blood.

Did you say that hundreds of lives were sacrificed in Mahea every year just for his meal?

Waa!

I looked forward again.

The crowd cheered as the match was about to begin.

The iron gates facing each other at the end of the arena went up with a roar, and a slave gladiator walked out of each.

A human man armed with a sword and shield, and the other a beastman with a huge sword the size of me.

– Og, a monster rookie who has already maintained an overwhelming winning streak for 10 games! And that opponent is the gatekeeper of the

third realm, Kateri!

The duel began immediately with the voice of the moderator resounding throughout the arena as if he had used some sort of loudspeaker magic.

As soon as the match started, the beastman rushed ahead with a loud roar.

In response, the human pulled out his body to the side and skilfully attacked the opponent with his shield.

It was a fierce battle for a while, but I could easily see which side had a higher chance of winning.

【Lv. 26】

【Lv. 23】

Because the human with sword and shields had a higher level.

The result came out similar to their difference in level.

He, who had been skilfully defending against the raging attack, was aiming for an opening momentarily and cut off the beastman's side.

The beastman, who had been cut to his arms and legs in succession from the attack, fell to his knees on the floor.

Actipol's Gladiator was a game that only ends when one person died.

So, in order to finish the game, the man had to kill the beastman like this.

However, he didn't finish the game right away and approached the beastman with an evil smile.

Then he drew a dagger from his waist and held it into the other's eyes.

“...“

The beastman, whose eyes were pulled out by a dagger, rolled down the floor, pouring tears of blood. The audience cheered.

The man leisurely walked around the beastman, waving his hand to the audience.

Soon after, the beastman fumbled to pick up the weapon that he had dropped and swung it at random with a desperate howl.

However, there was no way the attack could hit without being able to see ahead. Laughter erupted from the audience at the ridiculous appearance.

The man, who had been making fun of the beastman like that, finally cut off his head as the atmosphere cooled.

I watched the whole scene with an expressionless face. Inside, I frowned.

That's crazy, really...

The gladiator of Actipol.

Of course, I knew this match was going to be like this, as there were related episodes in the game as well.

The game ended only when all opponents are unconditionally killed, and there were no rules in the process. It didn't matter what torture one did to the other person.

Therefore, in order to show a higher performance to the audience, there were many slaves who killed their opponents cruelly and provocatively. That way, he could raise his own ransom even more.

In Actipol, they did not confine slaves of a certain grade or higher to prison, but they could gain a certain freedom and accumulate wealth.

So they became desperate not only for survival but also for wealth and freedom.

The matches that followed were not a one-on-one duel.

It was a team battle in which one side fought until all died, and in the other one, they released a captured monster to cause a fierce battle.

In the team match, one person was left behind, and the other team chased after him like a joke from all directions and killed him mercilessly.

In the game against monster, it was several times larger than the slaves, and in the end, all the slaves it faced died and no one survived.

Watching that series of matches, I felt nothing but dirt.

Were these people happy watching this?

How could one be so passionate about watching people die and kill each other? I just couldn't understand.

Looking back at the Tyrant sitting next to me, he was looking down at the stadium with eyes filled with boredom.

I was a little skeptical of that look. If that's the case, then why did he bring me in to watch the game?

– Now, the next match is the fifth order game everyone has been waiting for!

As the host shouted, it reminded me of Actipol's gladiator rank.

From the lowest first order to the highest fifth order, and at the top, there was a champion.

So, it was a match between the strongest gladiators in Actipol, except for the champion.

– First, the gladiator who defeated the gatekeeper Luton and was promoted to the fifth order, Paul of the strike!”

A man walked out into the arena with a much louder shout than in previous matches. He was carrying a huge mace with an iron ball the size of a head as a weapon.

– And that opponent has already survived the fifth order for over half a year! Except for the champion, the most powerful gladiator, Reef the Fighter!

Then, coming out of the iron gate on the other side, was a short-haired woman holding an ordinary sword.

I checked her face, and my eyes widened.

Because it was a familiar face I had seen somewhere.

It was the same woman I had met in the alley before who drove the soldiers away.

“Hahaha!”

The Tyrant, who had only made an expressionless expression until now, for some reason, lit up his eyes and burst into laughter.

The crowd in the stands filled with excitement, chanting the names of the two gladiators repeatedly.

..*Reef?*

I tilted my head and looked down at her.

Chapter 59.1: Refrigon (4)

Chapter 59.1: Refrigon (4)

Amid the shouts resounding from all directions, the woman stood with an expressionless face and the sound in her hand stretched out.

As for protection, just like the slaves that had come out so far, all she had was a weapon without a single piece of armor. So did the man on the other side.

The man swung his mace and glared at her with ferocious eyes. It looked like he was raising his fighting spirit.

“Which one do you think will win?”

The Tyrant asked me. A voice that sounded strangely excited.

He had only talked about useless words until now, but he suddenly brought up something related to the match for the first time.

I looked at him once, then looked back to the pitch and answered.

“The female side will win.”

He looked back at me with curious eyes and smiled.

“Are you asserting right away? Are you sure?”

I didn't have to answer.

【Lv. 43】

【Lv. 42】

I wasn't sure.

One level at level 40s wasn't that big of a difference.

The female side had a higher chance of winning, but one level difference was enough for a variable to occur.

Even so...

Somehow, it didn't seem like that variable would ever happen.

This was just intuition.

I stared down at the two gladiators standing opposite each other.

– Alright then, let the game begin!

As soon as the match started, the man turned the mace and shot it straight at the woman.

The woman turned around and approached. The man skillfully picked up the mace and swung it again.

He seldom gave up the distance. He pulled himself back and swung his heavy mace without hesitation. The thorns attached to the iron ball rubbed all over the woman's body, and blood spurted out.

She kept trying to get close to her opponent, barely dodging the rushing attack by a slight margin. It seemed like it didn't matter if the mace hit her. It was a bold and reckless move, almost like a beast.

“You bastard like mouse...!”

It was the man who was pushed out of the momentum.

He quickly grabbed the mace and struck it hard.

The woman lowered her posture for a moment. Avoiding the attack, she wrapped the sword around the chain that connected to the iron ball, and then pulled it out.

The man missed the mace. She also threw away the sword entangled in the chain and rushed forward, drawing another sword from her waist.

The man who quickly drew his sword also responded to the woman's attack.

The gladiator match continued for a while. Even though I didn't know swordsmanship, it was the woman who clearly had the better ability.

The man could not come to his senses with the fierce sword attack, and he was in a hurry to defend himself.

Whoa!

And at one point, in the blink of an eye, one arm of the man flew away.

He let out a tearful scream, lost his balance, and fell to the floor. The cheers of the audience erupted.

“Sa, save me! Please!”

Without time to struggle with pain, the man cried out in an earnest voice.

“I have younger brothers waiting at home! Without me, they will all die! Please...!”

The words didn't go any further.

The man's head, floating in the air, fell to the floor and rolled.

The woman who had brushed off the blood on her sword let out a rough breath with an unrelentingly heartless face.

She turned around, not paying attention to the man's corpse, nor to the crowd. Then she walked straight to the exit.

If the match was bland, the boos from the spectator stand would fill the arena. But this time, the boos and the cheers were equally great.

“Haha! After all, Reef, that bitch is the best!”

“What’s the best? It was fun before, when she was still rolling at the bottom. But nowadays, she only ends the fight like that.”

“By the way, there are no opponents in the fifth order anymore? Would she challenge the champion soon?”

“Ah, no matter what, she’s still not good enough for a champion...”

The sound of the audience talking resounded in my ears.

The Tyrant said with admiration.

“This is as you said.”

“...”

He looked down at the woman leaving the arena with a strange gaze, then asked me.

“How about it, Seventh Lord? Did you enjoy the game?”

I opened my mouth softly.

“Is this fun?”

As if it was the expected reaction, he said with a big smile.

“Well, quite?”

“...”

“Battles between insects are also fun in their own way. They scramble to spare even such a trivial life, bite each other, and then eventually despair. Isn’t that interesting?”

All the other Lords were like that, too.

The guy who said those words yawned and got up from his seat.

“It looks like there are still a few more matches left. Would you like to keep watching?”

It was as if he had seen everything he could see now.

I shook my head and got up from my seat.

“Okay, then you can finish what you came here to do. This guy can guide you to get the slave you’re looking for.”

Saying that, he pointed to one man standing behind him. A man with long shaggy hair and a blunt impression.

“It was nice to see you again, Seventh Lord. Let’s go.”

After saying that, the Tyrant waved his hand and moved forward. The servants followed behind him.

I stared at his back, then shifted my gaze to the man who was pointed out by the Tyrant.

He bowed politely and opened his mouth.

“I’m Gillock, the prison chief. I heard the Lord is looking for slaves in the prison. If you tell me who it is, I’ll get them right away.”

I glanced down again.

The figure of the woman had suddenly disappeared outside the exit.

In the still uncooled heat, there was only blood, and a corpse left in the stadium.

Chapter 59.2: Refrigon (4)

CHapter 59.2: Refrigon (4) ! Thank you to Baccano998 and Blah-ness for your donations! ^^

Gillock offered to bring the slave I was looking for, but Asher and I went directly to the prison.

A hallway full of disgusting smells mixed with things.

I spoke to him as we walked past the iron bars where the slaves were imprisoned.

“The girl who played in the last match, is her name ‘Reef’?”

Gillock replied with a puzzled look.

“Yes, that’s right.”

I asked him again.

“Does she have anything to do with the Sixth Lord?”

It’s something I had been curious about for quite a while now.

Because the Tyrant, who had no interest in other games, seemed to be only interested in her game.

The game itself was nothing special

Even if the level was higher than the previous matches, at most, it was a confrontation between level 40s. It wouldn’t be enough in the other’s view.

If so, it meant that he had some interest in the woman's existence, not in the game...

As if my prediction was correct, Gillock hesitated to answer with a slightly stiff face.

"Is this a difficult question to answer?"

"No."

"Then answer me."

As soon as I rushed, the story flowed out.

"Her younger brother is addicted to the Sixth Lord's blood magic."

"...Addicted?"

At that point, I immediately understood.

The Sixth Lord's blood magic, poisoning.

- *..Is he talking about light blood disease?*

The unique blood magic possessed by the Sixth Lord was as vicious as his inclination.

His blood magic was basically the ability to amplify physical abilities.

However, if he raised his blood skill to the limit and entered a berserk state, he would emit blood mist from his body, but the problem was that the subject who came into contact with the mist would lose their mind and run wild. Blood would boil all over their body and would burn their own life force.

There's a reason it's called a disease.

This was because even after the berserk state ended and they barely saved their life, his blood remains latent in their body.

It was like living with a time bomb in one's body that could be detonated anytime.

That's why his existence itself is a disaster.

His evil personality wasn't the only reason he was called the worst vampire, but the existence of that ability also played a big part.

In the game, it reminded me that there was a setting where there were several cities or villages that were destroyed in the past because of his abilities.

Resistance was possible if there was even a bit of magical power or a high level of spirit, but it was impossible for civilians living ordinary lives.

“For the gladiator who wins the championship, the Sixth Lord grants them one wish. That's why she became a gladiator of Actipol.”

“...”

It was a short explanation, but it was enough to solve all the questions.

If one became a champion, they could make a wish to the Sixth Lord.

So, she became a champion and became a gladiator to help heal her brother.

Naturally, another question arose.

“Who's the current champion?”

“It's me.”

- ..What?

As I looked, Gillock spoke again.

“I am the current champion of Actipol.”

“...Aren't you the prison chief here?”

“Yes, it’s because I used my wish so I could manage the prison here. That’s why I am also serving as the head of the prison.”

Oh, was that the case?

I didn’t quite understand, so I asked.

“Why the prison chief? There must be much better positions.”

Even if it was a wish, of course, there would be limitations, but it would have been possible to gain a fortune to live and play for the rest of his life, or to gain the title of a knight in the territory.

I remembered there was a knight who was a champion of Actipol in the Sixth Lord’s castle in the game, too.

He didn’t say a word for a while, but then answered bluntly.

“At that time, I wanted nothing else. I was just living because I couldn’t die, and I became the head of the prison intending to do something better for the conditions of the slaves I lived with.”

“...”

For an unexpected reason, I was a little surprised.

A place where all the humans whose lives are thrown into the gutter.

They played a match in which someone must die every day. It’s hard to think that there could be camaraderie. Still, to take care of the conditions of the slaves, he became the head of the prison, using that one wish everyone here coveted.

It was enough to get a rough idea of what kind of character this man named Gillock had.

I didn’t talk to him further and just walked without a word.

The thoughts that ran through my mind were of the woman named Reef.

Gillock said she was trying to become a champion to cure his brother's illness...

【Lv. 48】

I felt a sense of unease in my heart.

It wasn't because Gillock's level in front of me right now was much higher than hers.

Even if she defeated Gillock and became the champion... Because, as far as I know, there was only one way to cure the light blood disease.

The death of the Tyrant, the source of the disease.

There was nothing other than that.

That was why, until now, there had been no one who had survived from the light blood disease.

- *..Well, I don't care.*

It was enough for me to take out the man named Van, as Gulpiro asked.

With that, there was nothing more to see in this territory or here in Actipol.

Soon, Gillock stopped in front of a prison cage.

Several slaves were scattered randomly in the dark iron cage.

“Open the door.”

“Yes.”

Geeek.

At Gillock's command, the guard opened the cage's door.

He pointed to the squatting young man sitting with his knees wrapped in the corner.

“That’s Van.”

The pointed Van looked at him with eyes full of fear.

He was dragged and beaten, so his face was full of scabs and bruises.

“Is that Van who ran a fruit stand?”

“...Yes, yes? That’s right.”

I beckoned to him.

“Come out.”

The outer corridor of the stadium.

Gillock, who had just come out of the prison and was walking down the hallway, stopped when he saw a woman walking in the opposite direction.

But the woman only glanced at him once and did not stop walking.

While watching her passing by, Gillock opened his mouth.

“Is your brother okay?”

Then she stopped walking.

She turned her head and looked at Gillock with cold eyes without saying a word.

Gillock murmured, choosing what to say, and finally sighed.

“Don’t challenge me for the championship, Reef.”

“...”

“You can’t defeat me. I don’t want to kill you. And even if you win, the Sixth Lord will surely...”

“Shut up.”

Reef cut what he’s saying with a fierce growl and turned around and went off the road.

Looking at her back, Gillock sighed once more.

He looked up at the sky and murmured.

“...Fuck, really.”

Chapter 60.1: Refrigon (5)

Chapter 60.1: Refrigon (5)

Asher and I took Van out of the prison and brought him straight to the potion shop.

I moved with my super sensory to the maximum in case the Tyrant sent someone to monitor me, but no one followed me. It was a useless worry.

“Thank you, Mr. Pleon! Thank you so much!”

“It’s all thanks to this friend here. What are you thanking me for?”

So arriving at the shop, he thanked me and Gulpiro repeatedly.

It surprised me at first that Van called him ‘Pleon’ until I remembered that that was his current pseudonym.

“Are you going to leave right now?”

Gulpiro answered my question by looking around the inside of the store.

“Could you give me a few days? Most of them will be thrown away, but I still have a lot to organize.”

Well, that was true.

It would take some time to organize and pack all his luggage.

Staying in the Tyrant’s city was no good, but it probably wouldn’t matter for a few more days.

“Anyway, thank you so much for saving Van. I will consider this a debt and keep it in my heart.”

Gulpiro said with a soft smile.

Saving Van was a condition for him to follow me to my territory, so there's no such thing as a debt.

But he seemed to think that it was a debt that he should pay back later. It was a good thing for me, anyway.

“Just in case, I'll keep my escort here until you're ready.”

I looked at Asher and said.

The Tyrant didn't seem interested in what I was doing in Mahea, but there was nothing wrong with being careful until we left.

But Gulpiro firmly shook his head.

“It's okay if you don't. I have enough strength to protect myself.”

【Lv. 56】

I looked over his head.

Of course, the level of Gulpiro was considerable.

Although he was an alchemist far from combat, he was not an ordinary alchemist as he had a continental reputation.

I know that the level of his magic was also quite high, so there was no danger at all, but...

“Okay. How long will it take for you to organize everything?”

“A week is enough.”

“Then, we'll come back then.”

After talking a little more with Gulpiro, we left the store.

I told Asher.

“Keep watching the shop from a distance. If you see anything suspicious, report it immediately.”

Asher glanced around the store and nodded.

“Yes, I understand.”

There’s nothing wrong with having this kind of safety device in place just in case.

So, I left Asher behind and I went back to the inn.

As I was passing through the alleyway, a woman with a familiar face was walking by from the other side.

“...”

I paused for a moment and turned my head.

I stared at her back as she entered the potion shop I just came out of, and then immediately turned around again.

“I’m sorry, but we have received no information yet.”

The man wearing a black robe said in a calm voice.

Reef, who was sitting on the other side, just stared at him without saying a word.

“There’s really nothing! It’s light blood disease. Do you think it’s so easy to find a survivor of that?”

“...”

“We’re doing our best, but it’s something that needs a little more time. If you still want to cancel the request, there’s not much we can do...”

Biting her lower lip, she pulled out a purse from her arms and held it out.

The man smiled and took the money bag.

“I will try to expand the search area by mobilizing more manpower. Next time you come, I will prepare good news.”

Watching her get up from her seat and go out in a hurry, a subordinate, who was standing behind the man, asked quietly.

“Are you really going to increase the number of people investigating?”

“Are you crazy? We will not waste scarce manpower on such a useless thing.”

The man shook his head and leaned back on the chair.

“A survivor of light blood disease, there is no way to find it. Even if there is one, there is no way to know a cure.”

“But it’s already been half a year, isn’t it? At this point, the request can be canceled, but it’s tenacious.”

“She must have all known that deep inside. It’s all useless, anyway. She’s just doing this because she can’t put away her hope.”

The man burst out in laughter.

“Well, it’s okay if we just keep pretending in moderation and accept the request money.”

Reef came out of the information guild building and walked down the street.

Ignoring the surrounding glances, the next destination was the potion shop.

As she opened the door and entered, Gulpiro, who was smoking at the checkout counter, looked at her.

“Are you here?”

As if familiar, he pulled out a red potion bottle from the drawer.

Reef, who had a potion, took out a few silver coins and put them on the table. And without a word of conversation, she walked towards the door.

Gulpiro took the pipe he was biting from his mouth and said.

“I’m leaving Mahea soon. Maybe in a week.”

“...?!”

At that, she hurriedly turned around.

“Don’t worry. I have left the recipe for the potion to Marik at the Blue Dew Shop. Now you can get it from there.”

“Why are you leaving suddenly?”

“It’s just happened.”

She stood still for a moment, then walked out of the store.

“Tsk.”

Gulpiro, who clicked his tongue slightly, put the cigarette in his mouth again. Looking at the closed door with sad eyes.

Chapter 60.2: Refrigon (5)

Chapter 60.2: Refrigon (5)

Pak.

A stone flew into Reef's head as she was walking down the street.

She stopped walking and turned her head.

A middle-aged man was staring at this side with his red and angry eyes.

“You fucking monster bastard! You killed my son! Do you remember who he is!”

People around them hurriedly stopped the middle-aged man.

Reef expressionlessly brushed the dirt off her head and started walking again.

Pedestrians flocked to the commotion. Some were looking at her as if she was an enemy. She heard whispers from all sides.

“Tough bitch, how long will she survive after killing so many...”

Slave Gladiator of Actipol.

To keep surviving that death game, you have to keep on killing.

It also meant that more and more people wanted her to die.

There were many slave gladiators who had blood in this city like her.

Reef bit her lower lip.

She pulled the potion she was holding in her hand and held it tight, and continued walking.

Upon returning home, a woman came out the front door and greeted her.

“Oh, are you here?”

The woman was the caregiver of her brother.

The house had a guard and a caregiver.

Gladiators of the third order or higher could spend their daily lives freely in the city except during games and had a lot of money in their hands. Not to mention Reef, the top gladiator in the fifth order.

“He just finished eating.”

“How is he today?”

“Well, he coughed up blood several times a few hours ago, but now he’s stable again, so don’t worry.”

At her words, Reef nodded with a firm face and went upstairs to the room.

She opened the door and saw a boy sitting on the bed.

A boy with gray hair just like her.

He was looking at the window and beamed when he saw Reef who came into the room.

“Welcome home, Sister.”

Reef smiled faintly and approached the chair and sat down.

“How do you feel?”

“It’s okay. Didn’t I tell you? I seem to get better day by day.”

For a while, an awkward conversation ensued. It was mainly the boy talking and Reef listening.

The two siblings didn’t even talk about the gladiator fight, as if they had made a promise.

The boy who received the potion given by Reef took a sip and made a weeping noise.

“I drink it all the time, but it tastes terrible. Can’t you just ask the maker to make it more delicious?”

“Don’t say nonsense and drink it all right away.”

The boy frowned dissatisfied, but continued to drink the potion.

The boy’s arms were exposed through the rolled-up sleeves.

Bare, pale, and abnormally bulging dark red veins.

Reef’s eyes, looking at it, subsided.

“...By the way, Sister.”

The boy who drank all the potions hesitated and opened his mouth.

Reef picked up the empty bottle and stood up straight away. Because she knew what he’s going to say.

“You’re tired. Just rest.”

“No, I’m not tired... Eup.”

The boy suddenly covered his mouth and bowed down.

Reef, startled, tossed the bottle and walked up to him.

“Cool, chump!”

Blood gushed out of the boy’s mouth with a strong cough.

“...Olia!”

Reef urgently called the caregiver.

The woman rushed into the room and checked the boy’s condition. She laid his body down halfway, calmed him, and wiped the blood from the corners of his mouth.

Barely stabilized again, she sighed.

“It’s fine now. If he sleep like this and wake up, he’ll feel better.”

“...”

Reef looked down at the unconscious boy with troubled eyes, then she walked out of the room.

Clap.

Closing the door, she rested her chin and forehead against the wall next to her.

A deep tiredness descended on her face.

A small town located near to the capital of the Sixth Lord’s territory.

It was the original home where the siblings lived.

Her younger brother was called a genius in the village.

The wandering knight, Sir Baek, who spent the rest of his life in the village as a swordsmanship instructor, and the mage, Sir Takio, who boasted every day that he was a mage from the tower, said that her younger brother was a genius that would never exist again in the world.

Even Reef, who knew nothing at the time, knew that their words weren't an exaggeration.

Because, not long after learning swordsmanship and magic, the appearance of the younger brother, who cut down a large tree with a single sword and hurled fireballs to hunt animals, was abnormal to anyone's eyes.

Her brother was a genius.

To such a younger brother, the fences of a rural village seemed too narrow.

So he decided to leave. Wandering knight Baek said he would be happy to help him find a place in the capital with his personal connections.

The family had a big party the night before his brother left.

The villagers gathered together, filled with joy and sorrow, and prayed for my brother's future.

It was a late night with a joyful atmosphere.

The sky on one side of the village suddenly turned dark red

Her ears were pounding, and a storm raged. After waking up, the scenery that unfolded before her eyes was collapsed buildings and the corpses of villagers.

A thick fog of blood covered the whole town. The terrifying screams of the residents rang out. There was no memory after that.

She only vaguely remembered her younger brother who was trembling while hugging her and radiating blue light from his hands, and the unknown energy that filled her body.

After waking up, the first thing she saw was her brother, who had lost consciousness by her side.

The whole area was in ruins. No villagers were alive – parents, relatives, and friends.

She thought she was dreaming. But it was a cruel reality.

She and her brother barely lived, and they barely moved to the capital.

Hearing what the passers-by were saying, she finally understood what had happened in their village.

It was said that a spy from Santea was hiding in the Lord's castle. It was said that the Sixth Lord directly pursued him after he slaughtered the castle officials and ran away.

The place where the battle took place was near her village.

It was said that his brother had a disease called light blood disease. A death disease that inflicted on targets that came into contact with the Sixth Lord's blood magic.

He could have resisted it if he had even a bit of magical power, but for some reason, her younger brother contracted the said disease.

Only then did she realize what the unknown energy that filled her body at that time.

That the younger brother poured all of his magical power into her and was exposed to that terrible mist of blood.

The village was destroyed, the whole family was dead, and the only remaining brother had contracted an incurable disease. It was a life trapped in a gutter in an instant.

She found out that in the capital there was a slave gladiator called Actipol held every day. It was said that if one became a champion, the Sixth Lord would grant their wish.

Was there really any other choice?

She walked directly into that mountain hell and became a gladiator.

Over the past three years, she could have died countless times, but she had survived.

The gladiators of the fifth order could challenge for the title of champion whenever they wanted. Now, the long-awaited goal was right in front of her.

“...”

Reef, who had a cold expression on her face, lifted her head off the wall.

Fight, win, survive and cure her brother's disease.

It was three hellish years that she endured with only that thought.

As long as she could heal her brother, she didn't hesitate to get more blood on her sword. It didn't matter if she built a mountain with dead bodies.

Now, there was nothing to fuss about, and I was not afraid of death either.

There was only one thing I was afraid of.

If you try to challenge the champion and lose, her brother would be left alone.

That was the reason why she was still hesitating, even though there was only one step left.

She looked at the closed door once more and walked to her room.

Her body and her mind were all tired. She wanted to rest.

Chapter 61.1: Refrigon (6)

Chapter 61.1: Refrigon (6)

A large intelligence organization headquartered in Mahea, Nolhave. Chief Dersan's office.

“What’s going on? Why did you return in a hurry?”

Dersan, who was half lying on the sofa and chewing a cookie, looked at the man and asked sarcastically.

The other closed the door and entered the room and sat down opposite Dersan with a sign of urgency.

“Brother, I think I’ve figured out something great.”

“...What? What kind of bullshit are you talking about suddenly?”

“I’m not joking, so get up and listen carefully. Do you know the unknown potion shop in the alley of 1st Avenue east of the city?”

Dersan frowned at what this guy said out of the blue and got up.

“Unnamed potion shop? I don’t know. Why?”

“Its owner is an old man named Pleon.

The man held out some sheets of paper on the desk.

Dersan picked it up and glanced over it.

His eyes slowly widened as he skimmed the contents with an annoyed face.

After rummaging through the paper for a while with his forehead furrowed, he asked softly with a serious expression on his face.

“...Is this real?”

“Then do you think I’m lying?”

This was what the man investigated.

A few months ago, a person named Horden, who runs a small inn, fell ill with an incurable disease.

That he was suddenly cured of a disease that could only be cured by paying a large sum to an excellent mage specializing in treatment was suspicious enough.

The man who found out about it while investigating other things, out of curiosity, investigated things lightly.

The person who stood out in the process was Pleon, the owner of an unknown shop.

The man who judged that it was Pleon who cured the inn owner’s illness, conducted an investigation into the other this time.

A person who settled in Mahea at least a year ago.

In fact, there was not much noticeable information related to him, and the investigation, which started out of curiosity and whim of a moment, could be stopped there.

It was pure coincidence that the man then came up with a vain idea.

Because the disappearance of Gulpiero, the great alchemist of Santea, who had made a lot of noise on the continent in recent years, was also about a year ago.

It was just an interlocking of times that could be a coincidence.

However, the man continued his investigation into Pleon, even though it was hopeless.

And, to his surprise, he found circumstances that added confidence to the absurd assumption.

The most definitive among them was the information about the appearance of Gulpiro.

Unlike Gulpiro, who had a green beard and hair, Pleon's appearance was orange hair and beard, but during the investigation, it was revealed that it was dyed.

The man had dug up testimony from a few people who knew that Pleon's beard and hair were green when he first came to the city.

Unless one was trying to avoid being seen by someone, why would an alchemist who was good enough to cure incurable diseases run such a small potion shop and even changed the color of his hair and beard?

So the man was almost convinced that the real identity of Pleon was Gulpiro, the great alchemist who had fled from Santea.

“...”

Dersan rubbed his chin and silently scanned the paper repeatedly.

After not responding for a long time, the man said, seemingly a bit frustrated.

“Even with circumstantial evidence, this is almost 100 percent, brother.”

“...Yes, that's right.”

“Is there still something to worry about? Let's report it to the Sixth Lord.”

Dersan frowned at the man's words.

The two were vampires from the Leocell Mountains, like the Sixth Lord, the Tyrant.

When he went out into the world to slaughter and destroy his tribe, Dersan was one of the tribesmen who followed him.

At first, he could still raise the number one intelligence organization in the territory, relying on the halo of the Tyrant, but now, that was just the glory of the past.

It was because the Tyrant's interest in them gradually waned, and annoying rival organizations appeared one by one, and even the officials of the territory were slowly poking at the organization while monitoring them.

“Are you the only one who knows of this information?”

In response to Dersan's question, the man replied as if it was something obvious.

“Yeah, my subordinates did the investigations, but I put it all together...”

The man who was talking to him shut his mouth.

And looked at Dersan with a hardened face. There was suspicion in his eyes.

“Sleep...”

Hwaak!

Blood-colored flames rose in the air and covered the man's body in an instant. And then it disappeared without leaving a trace. Including the man's body.

Looking at the place where the man had just stood, Dersan clicked his tongue.

“You idiot, do you think the Sixth Lord still has any remaining interest in us?”

Even the few remaining tribes from his homeland were meaningless to him, someone who was gradually becoming a demon out of the box.

Even if it was in the past, there was nothing they could offer that the Tyrant would like. Dersan knew the other well.

Dersan, who casually killed his step-brother who had been with him for several decades, showed only a slight sign of pity, and immediately stood up.

A great alchemist from Santea who created an elixir.

The only way to be sure was to visit him in person.

The man said that the only person who knew about this was him, but there may be other members of the organization who noticed something during the investigation. So he had to hurry.

His eyes flashed with excitement and greed.

Chapter 61.2: Refrigon (6)

Chapter 61.2: Refrigon (6)

Late at night, Gulpiro, who was cleaning up the store, greeted a late customer.

Seeing Reef entering the store, he straightened his bent waist.

“What’s going on at this hour?”

She glanced around the cluttered interior of the store and opened her mouth.

“...Before you leave, please check my brother’s condition one more time. I’ll give you any amount of money you want.”

Gulpiro shook his head and sighed.

“Money is not the problem. How many times have I already told you? There will be no change even if I examined him again.”

Gulpiro was also well aware of Reef’s situation.

It’s hard to find people who didn’t know about her in this city of Mahea.

He was the one who made potions suitable for her younger brother in the first place and provided them until now.

Was it half a year ago when she first came to the store?

Hearing about her circumstances, Gulpiro went to the house and inspected her brother’s condition.

The blood mist that the boy ingested was completely incompatible with mana.

Someone with magical power could protect themselves from the poison. But for someone who had already been poisoned, magic power was nothing more than a deadly poison.

Therefore, Gulpiro made a potion that did not contain any magical power and could ease her brother's condition even a little.

But that was it.

It only played the role of barely holding onto the poison so that the boy's condition would not get worse.

Just by looking at Reef's increased frequency of visits to the store these days, the potion's medicinal effect was gradually declining.

Eventually, her brother would die unless they found a fundamental solution. It was an unavoidable result.

Light blood disease, an incurable disease suffered by those who came into contact with the unique blood magic of the Sixth Lord.

It was an unknown area that even the great alchemist Gulpiro had no way to cure.

He sympathized with Reef's plight, but he also knew that there was nothing more he could do for her.

"I'm sorry, but there's nothing I can do anymore. Go back."

"..."

Reef's eyelids trembled.

She clenched her fists in her hands and half-glared at Gulpiro, then turned around with a sign of resignation.

“...Thank you, so far.”

The moment she was about to get out of the store, the door opened first.

Their gaze shifted to the stranger who came in.

A man wearing a robe that made his face difficult to see.

He looked at Gulpiro and Reef one after another and opened his mouth.

“There is a potion I want to purchase....”

Gulpiro’s complexion hardened slightly.

Because he felt an unusual atmosphere. It was not the time for ordinary guests to come in the first place.

“Tell me. Is there anyone who needs urgent treatment?”

“No, no, that’s not it.”

The man pulled up his hood and said in a low voice.

“The thing I want to buy is an elixir, the great alchemist Gulpiro.

“...!”

Gulpiro’s eyes widened for a moment.

The man, Dersan, did not miss the reaction.

He exposed his fangs and put a creepy smile on his lips.

“As expected.”

“Who are you?”

Dersan reached out toward Reef without answering.

In response, Gulpiro hurriedly raised his magic power and performed magic.

Aww!

Blood and magic collided in the air.

Thanks to Gulpiro's defense, she didn't get hit directly, but the impact caused Reef to fly to one side of the store and crash into the wall.

“Uh-huh...!”

It was time for Gulpiro to perform the next magic right away.

Dersan, who had approached a short distance in an instant, was aiming the dagger he drew at his neck.

“...”

Gulpiro glared at him, then slowly lowered his hands.

Dersan smiled and nodded his head.

“It's a wise choice.”

“Why are you attacking us?”

“Oh, don't get me wrong. I'm not at all hostile to you. I was just trying to get rid of the disturbers in the conversation... was that woman important to you?”

Dersan scratched his chin with an empty hand and looked carefully at her face, then burst out a small sigh, as if realizing it.

“Oh, aren't you the slave gladiator bitch of Actipol? Was it Reef?”

Reef got up from where she crashed and glared at him fiercely.

“Well, anyway, don’t move and stay still. If you want to save your life, that is.”

Dersan turned his gaze back to Gulpiro.

“I only want one thing, Gulpiro. Where is it, the Blood of Diferi, the elixir you crafted?”

Gulpiro replied with a chuckle.

“It’s not with me.”

“Even if you don’t have it in your hands, of course you have the recipe. Give it to me.”

“Crazy bastard. Did you think I would do what you said if you threatened me with just a knife to my neck?”

Dersan lit a crimson flame in his hand and aimed it at Reef. At that, Gulpiro gulped.

Dersan let out a mean laugh.

“Yeah, that’s right. You had a pretty special relationship with that gladiator bitch, didn’t you?”

“...”

“Give me the Elixir’s recipe quietly. Otherwise, she will burn without leaving a single bone fragment on her body.

That was the moment.

A blue sword energy shot through the window and hit Dersan.

“...!”

He hurriedly twisted his body and barely defended himself, and then bounced off to one side of the store.

Shortly thereafter, another person jumped through the window and landed on one side of the store.

The woman with the sword, Asher stared at the staggering Dersan with cold eyes.

Gulpiro looked at her with surprised eyes.

“You…?”

Then the door of the store opened, and another voice intervened.

“Didn’t I tell you she would be around to keep you safe?”

A man walked in and looked around the messy interior of the store.

Then, his gaze stopped on Dersan, who had an even more bewildered face.

The man, the Seventh Lord, opened his mouth

“What are you doing, vampire?”

Chapter 62.1: Refrigon (7)

Chapter 62.1: Refrigon (7)

Late at night, I got out of the inn and took a light stroll along the street.

Asher was still watching Gulfiro's shop, so I was alone.

I wasn't just being overly worried.

Whether it was someone from Santea or someone sent by the Tyrant, it wouldn't be strange if either side approached Gulpiro for the meantime. Even if the possibility was slim, we still need to be vigilant.

Just look at what happened at Gaitain Lake. Would one even imagine that as soon as I left, the chief mage of Santea's Imperial Family would suddenly appear and attack the Seawater tribe?

"How much is this?"

"It's just 10 copper coins, my dear."

I bought a snack to eat on the night street where the night market was open.

After I left, I thought I should bring some to Asher, so I bought her share as well.

And as I was moving to the potion shop, my super sensory felt a weak energy.

"...?"

I hurriedly ran towards the potion shop with a hardened expression.

When I reached the store while avoiding the eyes of passers-by and using space leap, I saw the messy interior seen through the window and Asher holding a sword.

Whew....

What happened?

But luckily, I was not too late, so I stopped running and entered the store.

As if my appearance was sudden, Asher and Gulpiro looked at me in amazement.

“Didn’t I tell you she would be around to keep you safe?”

Saying that to Gulpiro, I turned his gaze away.

A man and a woman in robes.

I checked the woman’s face and tilted my head. Reef?

Why is she here again?

She, too, was looking at Asher and I with a look of bewilderment.

【Lv. 63】

The one who appeared to be the intruder was a man. From the outside, it looked like a vampire.

Could it be that the Tyrant really send someone?

“What are you doing, vampire?”

There was no reply from him.

The man who had been silent suddenly stretched out his hand to me. Blood-red flames rose in the air.

I immediately used Gascalid's blood magic.

Then the flame went out and disappeared without a trace in an instant.

“What, what?”

The guy let out a hoarse voice.

I unleashed the blood magic that I had stolen from him and gave it back as it was. An explosive burst of blood covered him.

The guy fell to the floor. He held on to one arm the explosion had completely torn that out and let out a suppressed scream.

“Ahhh!”

That's pretty much what this ability was.

Gascalid's blood magic was a perfect counter against vampires.

I stood in front of the other.

“Did the Sixth Lord send you?”

When I asked that question, blood rose again in my hand, and he shook his head urgently.

“Oh, no! It has nothing to do with the Sixth Lord!”

“Then what?”

“That, that's...”

He hesitated to answer with a pale, tired face.

Come to think of it, were there quite a few vampires from the same homeland as the Sixth Lord and living in Mahea City?

Some were in the territory's castle, and some were forming separate organizations and licking the feet of the Sixth Lord... Ah.

Is it that one?

Nolhave, the number one intelligence organization in the Sixth Lord's territory.

I suddenly thought that he was related to the information organization, so I asked.

“Are you from Nolhave?”

“...!”

For a moment, the man's eyelids trembled.

I was convinced that my guess was correct and asked Gulpiro.

“Did this guy come to you knowing your identity?”

“...Yes. I'm not sure how he found out.”

Then it's enough to find out now.

I looked back at the vampire and asked.

“From now on, if you hesitate to answer even a bit, I will kill you. How do you know that Gulpiro is here?”

As I made the flame bigger, he hurriedly opened his mouth.

“It's just a coincidence! I found out by chance!”

“Please explain.”

The following explanation was as follows.

The time when the great alchemist Gulpiro and his arrival in the city overlapped, the treatment of a patient with an incurable disease, and even the appearance.

After hearing all the explanations, I looked back at Gulpiro with a slightly puzzled face.

He, too, burst into laughter.

“You only found out because of that? Heh...”

Anyway, I was relieved.

If it was really from the Tyrant’s side, I’d be entangled with him again and things would be annoying.

“So, it means that you eventually raided the store after coveting the Elixir.”

I frowned and looked down at him coldly.

He knew the true identity of Gulpiro, so there was no reason to show mercy.

His complexion grew even whiter as he had foreseen his end.

“Come on, wait a minute...!”

His whole body was engulfed in flames.

The wildly fluttering flames burned him up in an instant, leaving no corpse behind.

“Heh, really....”

Gulpiro sighed and said to me and Asher.

“Thank you. Thanks to you two, I survived. I could have been in real trouble.”

I nodded and looked at the one remaining.

The woman who caught my gaze was startled and stepped back.

- ..So why was she here?

I was curious about the details, so I was going to ask Gulpiro, but he asked me something first.

“By the way, how did you do that? It looked like you stole the vampire’s powers.”

I answered simply.

“It’s true that I stole his blood magic.”

“Hey, how is that even possible? There’s no way it’s magic, maybe it’s a mystery?”

I didn’t give him a detailed answer.

“Tsk, take away blood magic?”

At that moment, the woman who had still kept her mouth shut and let out a trembling voice.

When I looked again, she was staring blankly at me with a confused expression on her face.

“You can steal blood magic? Really?”

“Yes...”

I couldn’t even continue speaking.

Because she fell to her knees on the floor out of nowhere.

“Please help, my lord. My, my brother has light blood disease.”

“....”

“If you can steal blood magic, you can also cure that disease, right? So please...”

I looked down at her desperately begging with narrowed eyes.

Understanding what my gaze meant, she put her forehead on the floor and bowed her head.

Chapter 62.2: Refrigon (7)

Chapter 62.2: Refrigon (7)

“Please, my lord... If there is anything you want me to do, I will do anything. I will give all of my possessions. If you want me to bark like a dog, I will bark like a dog. Please only my brother...”

“Stop.”

I cut her off.

“I can’t cure your brother.”

“...”

“This is taking away the blood magic itself, not the ability to heal someone who was affected by another vampire’s blood magic.”

Light blood disease was a disease that disappeared from the world only after the death of the Tyrant. At least as far as I know, that was the case.

Even if I take away the Tyrant’s blood magic, there was no way to cure someone who was already suffering from light blood disease.

That’s because it wasn’t an ability that he could control arbitrarily.

She slowly raised her head and looked up at me in vain. It was a face full of despair.

She hurriedly turned to Gulpiro this time.

“Eh, Elixir. If it’s an Elixir? If it’s an Elixir, isn’t it supposed to heal my younger brother? Yes?”

“It cannot be cured.”

Gulpiro firmly shook his head.

“Didn’t I tell you what kind of disease light blood disease is? Any potion that contains even a little magical power will only be poisonous. Even if it’s an elixir.”

Her body hardened like a stone statue.

After sitting still for a long time, she muttered.

“...Why?”

With an expression full of anger and resentment, she shouted like a scream.

“Why, why! Why not! It’s an elixir! It’s a new drug that brings the dead back to life! But why!”

“...”

“Why are you saying you can’t cure a single disease, damn why... why is everyone saying no... why...”

She staggered and stood up.

She then walked out of the store with a precarious pace that seemed to collapse at any moment.

I, Gulpiro, and Asher also just stared at her like that without saying a word.

After wandering the streets, returning home, Reef hurried up the stairs to the noise from upstairs.

The caregiver was holding the boy with her whole body; he was vomiting blood. Dark red veins were oozing out of his body.

“...!”

Reef wrestled with the caregiver for a while, barely calming the boy.

Around dawn, she called a doctor to check on her brother’s condition.

The boy who examined the boy’s body shook his head and said.

“The limit has come. Didn’t I tell you, just being alive until now was already a miracle?”

“...”

With the doctor and the caregiver gone, Reef was left alone in the room, looking down at her brother, who was breathing heavily.

My head felt like it was going to break.

She grabbed her forehead with both hands and bowed her head. And she sobbed quietly.

Now she really didn’t have a choice.

From early morning, a huge crowd gathered at the stadium of Actipol.

It used to be a place where many people usually gathered during games, but today it was especially severe.

It was a perfectly normal phenomenon.

Because today’s match in Actipol was more special than anything else.

All the spectators flocked with anticipation to watch the championship match, something that rarely occurred.

“She challenged the champion. Can we finally see Reef’s neck fly off today?”

“Haha, we don’t know. She’s a tough bitch who had survived all the battles everyone expected she would never win.”

“That’s right, too. So you’re betting on Reef?”

“No, I still have to bet my money on the champion. She’s still not enough to defeat Gillock.”

“What? Haha!”

Gillock, the champion of the iron wall, who had achieved overwhelming victories in over 10 defense battles so far.

The challenger was Reef, who had risen to the rank of a gladiator of the fifth order faster than anyone in the past few years.

Even before the match started, the audience was already full of excitement and enthusiasm.

The beaters urged people to place their bets, and each raised their voices to predict the outcome of the match.

“But, somehow, it feels like she rushed to challenge for the title of champion.”

“It’s understandable though? Her brother has light blood disease. It looks like he’s already close to dying.”

“Oh, right? Then, if she loses this time, even the younger brother will immediately follow his sister and die, huh?”

Few were ignorant of the circumstances of Reef, the most famous of Actipol’s gladiators.

Trying to become a champion in order to cure her younger brother who has light blood disease.

Of course, no one in the audience sympathized with Reef, even if that was the case.

Even that earnestness was only an exciting background for them that would make her final ending even more miserable.

In the waiting room, Reef sat in a chair without moving.

She bowed her head and looked down at her clenched fists.

Her mind was strangely calm. No, rather than calm, it was empty.

“...”

Yeah, she didn't know what she was expecting.

From the beginning, there was nowhere to lean on.

She didn't need anyone's sympathy or help. She expected nothing like that.

Didn't she decide on the day she entered Actipol, the day she desperately won her first match?

She must become a champion and heal her younger brother...

“Come out. It's time to enter.”

Now the end had just come.

At the words of the soldier who entered the waiting room, Reef stood up. And she drew the sword from her waist.

As she walked down the long, dark corridor and passed through the wide open iron windows, she saw the blue sky and the crowds in all directions.

Waaa!

Disgusting shouts filled with anticipation and excitement rang out.

Reef shook her head.

At the highest point of the stadium, she could see the Sixth Lord with his chin resting on his hand that was on the armrest of a chair.

-...Next, the current champion, Gillock, enters!

She lowered his gaze again and stared at the iron window on the other side, which was slowly rising.

Her eyes were full of murder as she looked at Gillock as he walked into the arena.

Chapter 63.1: Refrigon (8)

Chapter 63.1: Refrigon (8) ! Thank you to Damoon for the donations! ^^

Gillock put on his clothes with an expressionless face.

He pulled his sword from his waist, looked around, put it back in its sheath, and then fastened his belt tightly.

After getting ready, he went downstairs, and a woman approached him with a smile.

“Are you done preparing?”

“Yes.”

“Now, here. It’s an ade mixed with lemon and sugar. Drink it all the way.”

Gillock gulped down the drink the woman gave him and handed over the empty cup.

“I’ll go.”

As he walked out the front door, he looked at the woman who was seeing him off.

She was smiling brightly, but on the other side of her face, he could feel a slight darkness that could not be hidden.

It was like that every game, but today it felt darker.

The woman was Gillock’s wife.

The relationship began when Gillock saved her, who was unfairly caught by a slave trader and dragged to the prison.

Gillock thought again. You never know where life was going to take you.

He thought he would die alone wielding a sword for the rest of his life, but he met the woman and fell in love with her so deeply.

“Don’t worry, Ellie. I’ll come back victorious.”

After kissing his wife’s cheek, Gillock left the mansion.

After passing through a familiar street, he arrived at Actipol and went straight to the waiting room.

“The time is up.”

As he walked down the dark hallway to the stadium, thunderous shouts poured out.

Gillock looked around the stands once and fixed his gaze on the front.

He saw the figure of a woman standing on the other side of the iron fence.

...*Reef*.

He stared at her, who was glaring at this side with sullen and deeply sunken eyes.

Championship match.

He had defeated many challengers so far, but this match was special for Gillock.

The first time he saw Reef’s game was about three years ago.

It was around the time when Gillock had just become the new champion.

A young girl who could not yet be called a woman stood in the arena holding a sword.

The opponent was a man the size of a ship. A match that no one would have thought she would win.

As everyone expected, Reef was easily subdued, and the man tried to attack her without killing her right away.

Because in Actipol, whatever you did to the opponent gladiator, it was all just a performance.

But in the end, it was Reef who survived.

The scene was still clearly etched in his mind.

The figure of Reef, who had caught the man on top of her and bit his neck like a beast.

The man in fright drew his dagger and stabbed her on her side repeatedly, but Reef did not let go.

Even after the man's body drooped and became immobile, Reef bit his neck and didn't let go.

“...”

Gillock turned his head slightly and looked up at the arena.

He also didn't forget.

The gruesome and evil smile on the lips of the Sixth Lord who watched that match.

‘That girl, I heard her brother has light blood disease.’

‘...Yes, that's right.’

'Heal her so she doesn't die. Teach her how to fight so that she can survive in the future.'

As ordered, Gillock taught Reef many things. How to build up magical power, how to wield a sword, how to move her body...

Of course, Reef didn't reject him either. Because she had to learn anything she could learn from anyone in order to survive in this hell.

He just taught her. Other than that, there was no exchange of emotions.

Obviously, Gillock taught her a lot, but the two had a strange relationship that could not even be considered as apprenticeship.

She got strong so amazingly fast. Yes, she was desperate, but it's also true that she had an innate talent for fighting.

And as time passed, she became a gladiator of the fifth order in an instant, and now she was standing right in front of him to challenge for the title of champion.

It became like this, in the end...

Gillock finished his brief thought.

In the past, if it was a time when I was just living because it meant nothing, I might have just given up on this game.

But now he had a reason to survive.

Just as she had a younger brother she must save, he also had a happiness to protect.

-The championship game everyone has been waiting for! The long-awaited match begins now!

At the start of the match, Reef flew first.

Seeing her fiercely charging, Gillock calmly raised his sword.

Kaang!

The swords of the two gladiators collided.

Gillock deflected Reef's sword strongly. She bent her back and narrowly avoided the attack that followed. He immediately swung his sword again and aimed at her leg, but was simply blocked.

The two blades, engulfed in a blue energy, collided and entangled. A dizzying parry came and went.

The main attacking side was Reef. Like a madman, she drove towards Gillock like crazy, as if she had more than one life.

Gillock was still dodging and blocking all the rushing attacks with the same blunt expression as the first time.

Reef's appearance looked like she had lost her mind and was simply wielding her sword, but Gillock knew that wasn't the case. There was still a cold coolness in her eyes.

She knew best that she could not defeat Gillock, the one who taught her swordsmanship, if she only relied on pure skills.

So it's just a matter of who would get distracted first.

First, revealing a gap and finding the opponent's gap, even if it's just a little carelessness, prying through the gap and inserting the blade somehow was the only way to win.

However, it was only a small possibility.

Gillock, of course, had already seen her intentions. If he had been a careless human in the first place, he wouldn't have been able to survive so long as a champion until now.

Whoops!

Gillock's kick pierced Reef's abdomen.

Reef sighed and stepped back. The attack continued immediately without giving her a moment's notice.

As if he was about to launch a full-fledged counterattack now, Gillock pushed her fiercely. Reef just stepped back and was desperate to defend.

The scars were growing all over her body. It looked like she could never reverse this match to her advantage.

Reef bit her molars tightly and struggled to regain the momentum she had somehow lost.

At one point, Gillock's sword slashed through her side like a flash.

“Argh...!”

Chapter 63.2: Refrigon (8)

Chapter 63.2: Refrigon (8)

Gillock withdrew his sword for a moment and stared mercilessly at her as she staggered.

If Reef had more time, she could have defeated Gillock and became the champion someday.

However, there was a fundamental difference in ability that was difficult to overcome between the two at this moment.

Reef straightened herself up, grabbing her bloody side. Her eyes glowed.

It still looked like he had not broken her fighting spirit in the slightest, but that was all.

Gillock raised his sword again and took a stance. To finish the game without further dragging.

Even if you become the champion...

After all, her brother's life could not be saved from the beginning.

Gillock was sure of that.

He was well aware of how much of a vicious demon the Sixth Lord was.

So it might be better for her to die here like this.

“...Sorry.”

He opened his mouth and muttered a little.

“I will see off your younger brother in your stead.”

Reef’s face contorted like a ghost.

Gillock slammed the ground and flew away.

Whoa!

Gillock’s sword strike slashed through her body.

Even in a normal state, it was only possible to barely block his attack. Now that Reef was injured, she was no match for the other.

“Argh!”

Reef roared fiercely and swung her sword in anger. But it didn’t even touch Gillock.

Red blood splattered on the floor. Reef’s body was shattered to the extent that it was surprising that she was still standing without falling down. Despite that, she was still desperately protecting her vital points.

Gillock was about to put an end to it. He raised the magic of his whole body. After deflecting this sword attack that cut through her side, he intended to pierce her heart as it was.

That was the moment.

“...?!”

With a sense of nausea rising from within, Gillock felt his body paralyzed for a moment.

Reef didn’t miss the gap. Squeezing out her last remaining strength, she desperately stabbed her sword to his chest.

“...!”

Gillock looked down at the blade that pierced his chest in disbelief.

His body was heavy and cold. As if poisoned.

It wasn't just because of the sword that pierced his heart.

This is...

Something flashed through his mind.

The last drink his wife gave him before he left the house.

Gillock barely turned his head and looked up at the top of the pitch.

He could see the figure of the Sixth Lord smiling happily as if he couldn't stand the joy he's feeling.

...Ah.

Only then did Gillock realize.

That everything had been decided from the beginning.

He looked at Reef with empty eyes. Blood covered her whole body, and she stood there desperately, holding her sword hilt.

At the end of the day, you and me...

We would both die playing in the devil's grip.

The sword was drawn, and Gillock's body was torn apart.

Taking a rough breath, Reef looked at Gillock, who had fallen to the floor, with blank eyes.

...I won.

Won.

Killed Gillock. Defeated the champion.

An indescribable feeling surged inside her. Opposite things such as joy and sorrow, achievement and guilt mixed like a mass.

Reef bit her lips tightly and staggered away.

She heard not even the slightest cheers from the audience.

The spectators all kept their mouths shut as if they had made a promise and looked at the scene.

Reef, who had moved to just below where the Tyrant was seated, fell to her knees.

“...I have won!”

As if she wanted everyone to hear it, she shouted with a cracking voice.

“I am now the champion of Actipol!”

In the quiet stillness, the Tyrant had a smile.

“Yes.”

He looked down at her and opened his mouth.

A quiet but loud voice resounded clearly throughout the arena.

“Tell me your wish.”

“My little brother!”

Reef was forced to pause for a moment at the rising excitement, then shouted again.

“I beg you, the great Sixth Lord! Please cure my brother’s light blood disease! This is my only wish!”

The smile on the Tyrant’s lips grew stronger.

“You want to cure your brother’s illness?”

“...”

“Your affection for your blood relative is commendable. Okay, let me treat your brother according to your wishes.”

It was when Reef’s face was about to fill with joy.

“But before that, there is still something you have to do first.”

“...Yes?”

She looked up blankly at the Tyrant.

He was smiling.

It was as if he had just reached the moment of picking the sweet fruit he had been working hard on for a long time...

The Tyrant turned his gaze to the commentator on the other side of the stadium.

The commentator, who caught the attention, immediately exclaimed.

–Well then! The event match to celebrate the birth of a new champion after years begins right now!

There was a commotion in the audience.

Because there had never been such an event match before when someone won the championship.

Kurur.

An iron fence on one side of the stadium went up.

But that was the door where captured monsters came out, not the gladiator.

Reef's expression, who had been staring blankly at the scene, gradually distorted and became incomprehensible.

Stepping out of the door was the figure of a familiar boy.

However, the only difference was that his whole body was dyed dark red, and he had a completely monster-like appearance.

“Ahh...”

Reef looked at the boy, at his younger brother, and let out a groan of despair.

Krrr.

The boy glared at her with a flash of red eyes.

It was as if he was looking at an enemy who he was going to tear to death at any moment, not at his sister.

“I'll cure your brother's illness as much as you want. Of course, you have to finish the rest of the game before that, right?”

The sound of the Tyrant's laughter mixed with words echoed in her ears, like the whispers of the devil.

Looking at Reef, who was sitting there in a frenzy, he burst out laughing as if he couldn't stand it.

“Now, what are you doing? Come on, kill that monster.”

A boy, who lost had lost his mind, ran wildly towards her.

Chapter 63.3: Refrigon (8)

Chapter 63.3: Refrigon (8)

“...”

I sighed as I looked down at the tragedy unfolding in the arena.

I came to watch the championship game because I just wanted to check the results before leaving the city. Because the last time he saw Reef, it bothered him.

But the game was going in a direction no one expected.

He was thinking of doing this in the first place.

I stared at the Tyrant sitting in the distance, high in the arena.

Did he intentionally inject more blood into her younger brother, causing the light blood disease to run rampant?

I thought he must have some kind of ulterior motive, but the Tyrant, his malice was beyond my imagination.

At this rate, she had to either kill her brother with her own hands, or die by her brother's hands. Because Actipol's match ended only when one side died.

Asher, who was next to him, was also watching the game with a terribly hardened face.

The crowd was cheering more excitedly than when she played against Gillock.

Unfortunately, I couldn't help her.

In the first place, light blood disease was a disease that disappeared only when the Tyrant died.

It was absurd to fight the Tyrant and kill him just to save Reef's brother.

Because if a Lord killed another Lord, it was the same as turning the entire Calderic into an enemy.

Because of that absolute iron rule, Lords with different tendencies did not interfere with each other, and Calderic's order and system could be maintained for hundreds of years.

"Tsk."

I turned around and clicked my tongue.

It was even more disgusting to be here. It was the moment I was about to leave the stadium...

"...?!"

I grabbed my forehead and staggered at the sudden overwhelming headache.

Asher was startled and grabbed me.

"...Sir Ron? What's wrong?"

I pushed her away and frowned.

What's this...

Unknown memories were running through my mind.

Dizziness? Deja vu?

A strange feeling, as if it had happened once.

[All, I will kill them all!]

I saw a dead woman, a boy crying over Reef's corpse.

[You made a contract with the demons? Ah, you are born with a rare quality, but you threw it in the trash and it turned into a waste.]

As time passed, the boy who had changed completely from before, and the Overlord standing in front of him overpowering him like that, flashed past in my mind.

[How about playing a game with me? I'll spare your life. Instead, you will become the 7th Lord of Calderic. Just five years. After that, no matter what you do, I won't stop you.]

...In a certain city.

Amidst the blazing heat, the image of a boy who was carrying out a massacre with a bright smile flashed past me for the last time.

“...”

The headache went away, and there were no more memories.

I looked down at the arena again with a confused look on my face.

I stared blankly at the boy, who was running madly to kill his sister.

Reef desperately moved her body, that was about to collapse.

The boy ran like a wild beast, grabbing her and trying to bite her. It was a monster that was far beyond normal.

There was nothing she could do against him. She couldn't counterattack by swinging her sword, and she could only dodge his attacks.

Aww!

Even if she called out her younger brother's name and shouted for him to come back to his senses, the only thing that came back was a scream full of murderous intent.

Amid the resounding shouts of the crowd, Reef wrestled with her brother for a long time. However, her body had already reached its limit.

“Argh···!”

Reef barely grabbed the boy's face as he was gnashing his teeth at her.

All she could do was stare at her younger brother, who was frantically trying to bite her throat with his red, bloodshot eyes.

Could there be any more terrifying nightmare than this?

The strength in her grip was getting weaker.

If it was a dream, she would wake up. If it was reality, she just wanted to end it like this.

But before that, it was the boy's side that ran out of energy first.

The boy's body slipped to the side. His rampaging state had ended.

Reef looked blankly at her brother, who had lost consciousness and collapsed, and then turned her gaze to the Tyrant.

He was still staring at this side with a smile that said he would die of joy. As if urging me to put an end to it.

Kill it! Kill it! Kill it...!

Voices echoed from all directions.

She was on the verge of losing her mind.

Not because of the many wounds all over her body, but because of the shouts of those demons.

Reef got up from her seat, shedding tears incessantly with her open eyes.

She picked up the sword that had fallen on the floor, and brought the blade to her neck, and not to the boy who had fallen. To finish the game as they wished.

That was the moment.

Tup.

Someone grabbed her hand, holding the sword.

Her hand went down slowly.

Reef turned her head blankly.

There stood a man with a familiar face.

The shouts that had just been resounding were nowhere to be found, and a terrible silence fell on the arena.

“...Huh?”

The expression of the Tyrant, who was smiling happily, was severely distorted.

The man who had been staring down at the boy who had fallen turned his gaze to the tyrant.

The man, the Seventh Lord's mouth opened softly.

“End this game, Sixth Lord.”

Chapter 64.1: Refrigon (9)

Chapter 64.1: Refrigon (9)

My head was confused.

I looked down at the boy with my eyes focused everywhere.

What the hell was that?

The boy's appearance was clearly the same as the one he had seen in the flashing memory.

Interrupting the match was just an action close to instinct.

My intuition was telling me that these siblings should not be allowed to die like this...

“...”

Come to think of it, I think I had felt this kind of feeling once before, not just this time, but when was it?

I could recall the memory as I furrowed my brows.

When I used the box of chaos and entered the game for the first time.

At that time, an unknown voice resounded along with the dizziness of the world turning upside down.

[Do not give up.]

...Yes, that's it.

It's definitely the same as I felt then.

It was as if I had glimpsed a future that had not yet happened, but might have occurred someday.

My head got more confused about what the hell happened, but that's not what's important right now, so I put it off temporarily.

After the agitation went away and reason came back, I understood what I was doing now.

I lifted my hand from holding on to her and turned my gaze to the Tyrant.

The guy was staring at this side with the most ferociously distorted face.

It looked like he's really pissed off because I interrupted and ruined a show he made with care.

I only stepped forward to stop Reef from killing herself, but it ended up being a face-to-face confrontation with the Tyrant. It was even in front of this huge crowd.

...What should I do now?

I probably would regret it later, but I couldn't undo what I had already done.

Amid such a complex situation, a sense of uneasiness that still lingered in my mind, and these unknown emotions, I opened my mouth and said;

“End this game, Sixth Lord.”

Silence fell throughout the arena.

The spectators were staring at the Tyrant, even holding their breath.

The one who was staring at me with eyes full of rage that could not be hidden opened his mouth.

“What are you trying to do right now, Seventh Lord?”

...I don't know either, damn it.

If I thought about it rationally, I was doing something stupid right now.

I ruined another Lord's event in order to save one a pair of siblings who I barely knew.

However, the decision was solidified soon .

This time, I was just going to do what I wanted.

Take them out of here alive.

If it had anything to do with this unknown phenomenon that just happened to me, leaving them to die was probably not a good option.

I said after exchanging glances with the Tyrant.

“I'll take these two with me.”

“...What?”

He had an expression full of absurdity. His anger was obviously boiling now.

“Tell me if there is a way to cure light blood disease.”

“...”

“If you tell me the cure and hand over these two to me, I will consider this as a debt and pay it back later.”

At least, the only cure I knew of was the death of the Tyrant, but the other might know other methods.

Of course, I knew that this wasn't a suggestion, it's almost an order.

Still, I had to do this.

If there was a way to end this situation in a gentle way, of course, I had to choose that way.

“Heh, heh heh...”

But it also didn’t seem to matter.

He burst into laughter, then raised his head and laughed loudly, then slowly stopped the sound.

The man lowered his head again and opened his mouth with a smirk in his eyes.

“You’re out of your mind. Is that all you dare to say after ruining my event?!”

Aww!

A thick cloud of dust rose with the explosion of a huge energy.

With the floating veil that had been opened in a narrow reaction of my super-sensory, I looked around.

Three gigantic marks, as if scratched by a beast, divided the arena in half.

Screams and commotions erupted from all sides. It was seen that the spectators caught up in the attack had died in large numbers. People running away in confusion and fear.

Suddenly, the Tyrant rose from his seat and was spewing out so much blood that it gave the illusion that the surrounding air was dyed red.

“Sir Ron.”

Asher, who came downstairs and stood beside me, looked at me with a hardened face.

I looked at Reef, who still had a puzzled expression on her face, and the boy who had fallen.

“Take these two of you and leave here.”

“...Yes, I understand.”

Asher nodded and immediately ran out of the arena, holding the two in her arms.

I turned my gaze back to the Tyrant.

“This is not it, Seventh Lord. Don’t you think you’ve crossed the line?”

The man, who was releasing his vicious blood, roared and said.

“This is my territory. You need to respect my way. If I had visited yours, I would have respected your way. Yet, ruining the game I worked hard for myself right in front of my eyes? You can’t disrespect me like that!”

There was nothing wrong with his every word.

Of course, that was if I only considered the law of the Lords not fighting and killing each other.

“Apologize formally to me and bring those siblings back, Seventh Lord. Kill them right in front of me with your own hands. Then I’ll forget this ever happened.”

I ignored his words and looked at the level above his head.

[Lv. 94]

The unique blood magic that amplified physical abilities, and was a superhuman close to pure physical strength.

...I could roughly do it.

After thinking about it, I said again.

“Tell me the cure for light blood disease.”

He seemed to have realized just then that I had no intention of changing my attitude.

The man who twisted the corners of his lips slowly dyed his body red.

“They said that you killed the warrior in one blow?”

Pew!

In an instant, with the sound of an explosion, his new form reached me in an instant.

I opened the floating veil again and closed my fists. The entire surrounding ground turned over, and rocks were scattered in the air.

It had a different level of destructive power than when I had previously blocked the strike of the Orc King.

After teleporting to the other side of the arena, I performed blood magic and floated drops of my blood into the air.

The guy who turned his head and looked at me, frowned and muttered.

“...Blood magic?”

Because I was not a vampire, he probably couldn't understand how I could use blood magic.

There was no reason to answer that question. He also rushed towards me again, as if it didn't matter.

Fortunately, he approached me, ignoring the drops of blood floating around me, and swung his fist.

The attack was again blocked by the veil, and his body was exposed to the drops of my blood.

I teleported into the air again. A tornado of blood rose straight up like a dragon from below, and it, too, was blocked by the veil.

“You have an annoying ability!”

Chapter 64.2: Refrigon (9)

Chapter 64.2: Refrigon (9)

I escaped and defended using the right mix of space leap and floating veil, and he continued to pursue me and fire attacks on me.

The Tyrant basically belonged to the physical type of super being like the Mad King, but he not only fought purely physically but also used blood magic.

Every time the Tyrant's power or blood rushed in, one side of the stadium collapsed in shock. The spectators who could not get out yet were killed in droves.

As the rushing attack became faster and stronger, a thick fog of blood erupted from his body and covered the entire area.

“...!”

I felt dizzy, and as soon as I teleported, I barely blocked the blood magic of the man who flew in.

Slowly, I was reaching my limit of responding to his attacks.

Even the super sensory that was raised to the maximum seemed to be insufficient to respond to the speed of a level 94 superman.

If the floating veil or space leap were abilities with even a slight delay in activation, my body would have been already torn apart.

“How long are you going to run away like a mouse?”

He looked at me floating in the air with my floating veil open and roared with equal momentum.

The only thing I could do against that monster was to defend and run away. Unless I killed him.

So, as a safety device, I spread my blood from time to time in the middle of the fight and buried my blood in him.

Because if I could no longer block his attacks, I had to just kill him instantly.

I wouldn't even start a fight with that monster if I didn't believe I could do that.

And besides instant kill, there was one more thing I believed in.

Gascalid's blood magic that had been activated on him since the beginning of the battle.

Gascalid's level was 95 while he was alive, and the Tyrant's level was 94.

It didn't seem to take effect yet, because the level difference between the two was too small...

• ◦ ■ ■ ..*Come.*

After a certain moment, power slowly flowed into my body.

I defended myself with only the floating veil.

The momentum of the Tyrant who had been pouring out blood magic just below me began to slowly subside.

Slowly, the other who sensed that something was strange stopped attacking and looked at me with a puzzled expression.

“What is this...?”

Even amid this, the energy flowing into my body was growing exponentially stronger every moment.

I came back down to the ground and stood facing the Tyrant.

The bewildered vampire asked me.

“What the fuck did you do?”

“Well.”

The other, with a distorted look, roared wildly and ran towards me.

But his attacks were no longer as powerful as before, nor fast enough to be unresponsive.

I leisurely dodged and blocked his attack, waiting for the riot to end.

【Lv. 90】

【Lv. 89】

【Lv. 88】

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The interesting thing was that his level information was also changed in real time as his power was taken away.

I could see that his level reflected the power of his attacks.

And when his level continued to go down and down, he was now much lower than Asher.

【Lv. 70】

“This human bastard! What the hell did you do to my body?”

The vampire growled and cried out.

I slowly approached him, feeling the unprecedented power that filled my body. He turned pale and stepped back.

“This···!”

He turned around and ran away.

I looked at the back of that guy and then stamped my foot on the ground.

Kwaang!

With a single step, the distance between us shortened in an instant.

He hurriedly raised his arm to defend himself, but it was in vain.

Even if I was a novice who had never had a physical fight, there’s already a wall between me and him that couldn’t be overcome.

The guy who was hit by my fist flew away and crashed into the rubble of the collapsed stadium.

I looked around, shaking my hands a little, and picked up the sword that had fallen to the floor. It was Reef’s sword.

“S-stop...”

I walked over to the wriggling vampire on the floor and pointed the blade at his neck.

“What is the cure for light blood disease?”

As if he hadn’t imagined being defeated like this, the guy who was making a futile expression burst into laughter as if he had lost his mind.

“There’s no such thing.”

“If you don’t tell me, I will kill you.”

“No, you bastard! No! No matter what you do, that bastard is dead anyway!”

“...”

“Stop with nonsensical threats. Let’s put it at the next Lords’ meeting. This one was obviously your fault!”

I sighed and looked up at the sky.

• ◦ ■ ■ ··After all, was there really no other way?

It was a futile effort to subdue him, and in the end, it meant that there was only one option from the beginning.

When I said nothing, he slowly stopped talking and looked up at me.

“Actually, there is a way.”

“...What?”

“It’s a very simple method. You just need to die. Then the light blood disease will completely disappear from this continent.”

He looked at me stupidly and then opened his mouth.

“What kind of bullshit are you talking about, that if I die, it will cure the light blood disease? How can you be so sure?”

“Well.”

Because it was mentioned in the game.

Even if I explained it, he wouldn’t be able to understand it, anyway.

I looked down at him coldly.

The guy swallowed his saliva and said.

“Are you really going to kill me? A Lord killing another Lord?”

“...”

“Come on, wait. Wait a minute. Are you going to turn Calderic into an enemy? The Overlord is going to take your life herself! You’re going to kill me right now for those bastards...!”

Whoa!

The blade slammed down, and his head rolled on the floor.

“Well, the dead don’t have to worry about that.”

Chapter 65.1: Refrigon (10)

Chapter 65.1: Refrigon (10)

The body that had lost its head collapsed to the floor.

It was a shabby end for someone who became a Lord of Calderic.

After looking down at the corpse for a moment, I threw the broken sword at the floor. The blade of the sword could not withstand the impact of his decapitation and was broken.

Hmm.

I felt a slight lethargic feeling all over my body.

It was because the enormous power that had filled my body until recently had all vanished as if it had evaporated.

When the Tyrant died, the power of blood magic that I had stolen from him had disappeared.

I didn't expect it, but it was not possible to permanently absorb the robbed ability just because the original owner died.

Well, that would be a big scam if it did.

If permanent extortion was possible, wouldn't even Gascalid, during his lifetime, slaughter all his people and absorb their blood magic?

As I thought that, I turned my gaze to one side.

Suddenly, the thick blood mist was lifted, and I saw people in a distant place on one side of the completely ruined stadium. It was Asher and Riff.

I walked towards the two who were staring blankly at this side.

The boy Asher was carrying was still unconscious.

However, there was no longer the dark red blood or bulging veins that had been circling his body a while ago. The body had returned to its normal state.

“...Ah.”

Reef, who was sitting on the floor, bled like that, but she still hadn't lost consciousness.

As I stared at the boy, her gaze shifted to her brother and her eyes widened.

I said quietly.

“Your brother's light blood disease seems to get better.”

“...”

Reef looked up at me with a bewildered face and stood up.

But then her eyes lost focus, and his body staggered over. In the end, this seemed to be her limit.

Asher quickly supported her as she collapsed.

Both siblings had infinitely weak breathing and pulse, but they were still alive.

There were no potions in hand because we had used up all the Scarlet potion, so we had to take them to Gulpire quickly.

I told Asher.

“Let’s go. We must hurry with treatment.”

“Yes…”

Asher’s gaze turned to the other side of the stadium again. To the place where the Tyrant’s corpse was lying.

She couldn’t hide the embarrassment on her face as she didn’t think that I would even kill the Tyrant.

But what could I do? I had no choice but to choose between killing these siblings or the Tyrant himself.

And I just killed him and save the former.

Thinking back, I did something really crazy.

But strangely, my heart was relieved, and I had no regrets.

I didn’t know if I was feeling this way myself, but I felt that this was the right choice.

Of course, the reason in my head was still cursing me for being a crazy bastard and urging me to think about what I had to do in the future.

Still, not that I didn’t really think about what would happen next.

First, the treatment of the siblings was given priority, so I moved on to the potion shop after thinking about it.

“…?”

At that moment, a rushing force from one side drew near.

Knights armed with armor. I could tell right away that they were knights belonging to the territory.

If it was the knight order under the direct control of the Sixth Lord, was it perhaps the Dark Soul Knights?

At first glance, the number of knights in the castle seemed to have flocked, and their estimated number would be at least over a hundred.

It was natural that they were mobilized because such a riot happened in the middle of the city. They were all entering the stadium with a look of bewilderment over the wreckage and corpses.

【Lv. 72】

Soon they found us and stopped in amazement.

The knight, who seemed to be the leader at the forefront, carefully opened his mouth.

“...Are you the Seventh Lord?”

Apparently, they knew that there was a fight between the Sixth Lord and I, so they rushed to the scene.

I didn't have to answer.

Their eyes turned to my back, and when they found the Tyrant's corpse lying on the floor, they opened their eyes wide.

I staggered towards them.

“Stand back.”

Even after confirming the death of the Tyrant, the knights could not stop me.

They simply backed away from the road where I was walking.

Even if their Lord had been murdered, there was nothing they could do to stop me.

I walked along the road split on both sides by the knights, and Asher followed behind me with the siblings in both hands.

Until we disappeared, the knights stood still for a long time, immovable.

Chapter 65.2: Refrigon (10)

Chapter 65.2: Refrigon (10) ! Thank you to Damoon for the donations! ^^

After coming out of Actipol, we went straight to the potion shop of Gulpipo.

He was smoking in front of the store with a restless face, and when he found us, he was happy.

“Seventh Lord! You’re safe.”

“...?”

I tilted my head.

He spoke with a hint of urgency.

“What’s going on? There was an uproar on the side where Actipol was. I heard people say that you and the Sixth Lord were fighting, but what the hell happened?”

Ah, the commotion had already spread throughout the city.

He asked, glanced at the siblings Asher was holding.

“...Did you fight with the Sixth Lord to save them?”

I replied calmly.

“It’s not a big deal. It worked out well.”

“Then it’s good, but... did the Sixth Lord surrender them to you?”

“He had no choice but to give it away. Because he’s dead.”

“...?!”

Gulpiro widened his eyes in shock.

“Lord, did you kill the Sixth Lord?”

“Let’s go in and treat them first.”

“Oh, that’s right. Come on in.”

Soon after, he also hurried Asher to bring the unconscious siblings into the store.

Asher put the two of them on the bed inside the store. Gulpiro looked at their condition for a while, then he came back with some potions.

“How is it?”

“For now, Reef is not in a life-threatening situation. Although she is bleeding heavily, she only needs to recover from the trauma. The problem is the younger brother, I can’t use effective potions on him because of the light blood disease, but it’ll be okay...”

I told him.

“If it’s light blood disease, it’s completely healed, so you can use a potion with magical power.”

“...Well? What does that mean?”

Gulpiro looked at me with puzzled eyes. I gestured to the boy.

As the other looked at the boy’s condition once again, he slowly opened his eyes wide.

“No, what is this... How?”

After looking at me and the boy alternately for a while, he thought that treatment was the priority, so he went outside again and brought another potion.

Then, the boy was fed potion first, poured it on his body, and then he treated Reef.

Asher and I stood still on one side of the room, watching the scene.

As soon as the treatment was over, Gulpiro let out a light sigh and straightened his back.

Reef's entire body was instantly restored and even her younger brother's pale complexion became full of life. It was indeed a potion made by the great alchemist himself.

"Tell me now. How did you treat light blood disease?"

To Gulpiro's question, I answered while looking down at the siblings lying next to each other.

"I killed the Sixth Lord, and it got better right away. It seems that it is a disease that disappears only when the Sixth Lord died."

It was actually the opposite, since he already knew that beforehand and killed him, but it didn't matter, anyway.

Gulpiro sighed slightly and stroked his chin.

After a while, Reef's eyelids trembled, and she opened her eyes.

She got up and looked around at us.

Gulpiro spoke first.

"Are you awake?"

"...Here is?"

“It’s my potion shop.”

After being silent for a while, she soon found the boy lying next to him, and she hurriedly tried to check his condition.

“It’s okay. You and your brother have all been treated, so don’t worry.”

“Ah, no. Light blood disease...”

“Yeah, the disease in your brother’s body had completely disappeared. It seems that light blood disease is a disease that can only be cured by killing the Sixth Lord.”

At Gulpiro’s words, she let out an agonized sigh, then looked at me and then turned to the boy again.

Tears soon fell from her eyes.

“Uh, uh...”

She touched her brother’s body with trembling hands, then pulled him into her arms and hugged him.

“Thank you, thank you, thank you...!”

Constantly repeating only those words, she bowed her head for a long time and wept.

Asher brought Baros to the inn, and we had a meal with Gulpiro.

Baros simply prepared the meal with ingredients from the store.

“Tsk, he’s going to have a hole in his face if you keep staring.”

Gulpiro clicked his tongue slightly as he watched Reef staring intently at her younger brother. She was still sitting on the side of the bed in the room.

She had a share of soup as well, but she didn't eat it until it had cooled down.

I thought it was worth it.

After spending a few years in Actipol to save her younger brother, her wish had finally come true.

"But will you going to be okay? You killed a Lord..."

Gulpiro asked me in a worried voice.

"Now that things had already turned out this way, there's nothing I can do about it. You don't have to follow me to Seventh Lord's territory."

"No, that's aside from the problem."

I nodded my head without a word.

Since a Lord had killed another Lord, we know how the Overlord would come out. I had also thought about that.

Gulpiro shook his head in response to my reaction and said.

"Well, if you have an idea of how to solve this, I have no intention of reneging on our deal. I will still follow you to your territory."

"Okay..."

I answered with a frown.

It was because I was recalling the memories that suddenly flashed in my mind at the stadium earlier.

A memory that passed by in an instant, now hazy and hard to recall.

The thing that remained most intensely was the image of the man carrying out a massacre...

[You made a contract with the demons? Ah, you are born with a rare quality, but you threw it in the trash and it turned into a waste.]

[How about playing a game with me? I'll spare your life. Instead, you will become the Seventh Lord of Calderic...]

“...!”

My eyes slowly widened.

The boy who was overpowered by the Overlord, the Overlord who was making an offer to him.

I hurriedly turned to the side of the room where the siblings were, and then asked Gulpiro.

“By the way, what’s that boy’s name?”

Gulpiro tilted his head and answered.

“You don’t know yet? It’s Rigon.”

“...”

I stared blankly at the boy lying on the bed.

And only then, I could realize what his true identity in that passing memory was. (T/N: Really? You only realized that now??)

Reef, Rigon...

Flesh-headed Refrigon.

That he was the vengeful devil who lost his sister to the Tyrant and even used her name as his.

Chapter 66.1: Emergency Call (1)

Chapter 66.1: Emergency Call (1)

The boy, Rigon, woke up late in the evening after half a day had passed.

“Ummm... Sister?”

After crying for a long time even during the day, when his younger brother woke up, she burst into tears again.

As soon as he got up with a puzzled face, he hugged her and comforted her.

Reef explained to him, who had no memory of what occurred, what had happened at the stadium.

His expression distorted, then his eyes widened as if in surprise, and after hearing all the explanations with various expressions on his face, the first thing he did was to thank me.

“Thank you. That, uh...”

“It’s Ron.”

“Oh, Sir Ron. Thank you so much for saving my sister and I. I, really...”

Rigon, who was trying to get out of bed, staggered like he was dizzy, and then collapsed back down.

“Don’t move. Lay back quickly.”

Reef hurriedly laid him back.

“It’s still a long way before your body returned to normal. It’s not just because of how you rampaged earlier, but your body was already in a debilitating state from the beginning.”

Gulpiro clicked his tongue and said with help.

“I used the most effective potion out of all the things in my hand, even so, for the time being, don’t move and take it easy.”

“Yes, I am also very grateful to Mr. Pleon.”

The situation was cleared up, and the story shifted back to the future direction.

“How do you plan to treat these children?”

At Gulpiro’s question, I looked at the siblings.

First, the situation I was in right now was serious without even thinking about it.

The death of a Lord was a major event that would turn the whole of Calderic upside down, and the person who killed him was not a person from another faction, but the same Lord.

In the in-game setting, there had been only two instances of a Lord dying at the hands of another Lord in Calderic’s history. That’s what I remembered.

And the two Lords who carried out the tragedy were both purged.

One was at the place where all the Lords were gathered because of an emergency call, and the other escaped, but was eventually caught by the Overlord and killed directly by her.

This was also a fork in the road presented to me.

Return to the Seventh Lord’s territory or escape.

But, in fact, I couldn’t choose the latter even if I thought about it.

Because that would be really turning the whole of Calderic into an enemy, one of the four major powers of the continent.

Aside from them tracking me, would I be able to solve the many difficulties ahead of me as planned?

And above all, it's so irresponsible.

If I escaped like this, the rest of those who were related to me would of course be in big trouble.

Even in the capital of the Seventh Lord's territory, there was the Alkimas workshop. I was not sure what the Overlord would do to them.

In the end, the only option left was to return to the territory.

If we go back to the territory at this rate, an emergency call would probably be sent immediately.

To convene all Lords by the authority of the Overlord when such a critical situation arose.

And I, too, will have to respond to the call as a half-sinner.

I have no choice but to go.

I didn't know how things would go in the future. Maybe I would really die.

But there was nothing to think about.

First, I would obey the call and speak with the Overlord.

At least it was best to resolve everything there.

First, I explained to the siblings. Because they needed to know what's going on.

That I was the Seventh Lord of Calderic, the death of the Sixth Lord, and roughly what would happen next.

Rigon opened his mouth as he listened to the story, probably feeling the scale was too big, and Reef gulped with a stiff face.

“...So you too are moving with me to my territory.”

Even if my situation was precarious right now, it would have been the safest for both of them to be by my side.

I thought about taking them away with Asher, but it would be useless if things went wrong during the emergency call, anyway.

Fortunately, the two of them did not show any resentment or rejection at my words.

“No matter what, I have received a grace that cannot be repaid. Whatever you want, I will gladly follow your word.”

Reef said so, and Rigon agreed.

I stared intently at Rigon.

Anyway, thinking about it again, it was really absurd.

When I first found out her name was Reef, I immediately thought of Refrigon, but I dismissed it as just a coincidence.

But then, it turned out that her younger brother, this innocent-looking boy, was Refrigon...

I don't know if that's a good thing or not.

In the end, was this the cause of that unknown memory?

To rescue and secure a boy who would fall into the future and become Refrigon.

...Ah, I don't know. This issue was not something that could be resolved by simply thinking about it.

I shook my head and said to Reef.

“For now, both of you have to eat.”

Not only Rigon but also Reef, who had been awake for a while, ate nothing because she had been watching her brother.

I asked Baros to prepare dinner.

But Reef put aside her portion and tried to feed Rigon with soup first. It was such a terrible sisterly love.

Eventually, after Rigon took the soup bowl and started eating it himself, she also ate her own.

Gulpiro asked, watching me from the table outside the room.

“When are we going to leave?”

“When Rigon’s condition is restored to a certain extent.”

“Then it must be too late... Don’t you have to go home in a hurry?”

I shook my head.

Nothing would change even if I hurried up, so it didn’t matter.

Three days passed like that.

During my stay in the store, I could feel the occasional glances from outside, but that was all.

Meanwhile, Rigon’s condition was restored quickly enough to move on his own.

He was still emaciated, but his complexion improved to the extent that it was incomparable to when he had just woken up.

We have to move soon.

It's time to return to the Seventh Lord's territory.

Chapter 66.2: Emergency Call (1)

Chapter 66.2: Emergency Call (1)

Burkhorn, the capital of Enrock.

After a considerable amount of time had passed, the carriage arrived at the castle.

Although I had returned after more than half a year, there was no particular feeling of returning home.

It hadn't been that long since I stayed here in the first place.

The first person to greet me at the castle gate was Floto, the butler.

He, who had always maintained a good poker face, seemed a little nervous.

Not only that, but the atmosphere of the knights standing in line were also the same, and the reason was obvious.

“Who came to the castle?”

“...Yes, the Knights of the Overlord's Castle visited just recently.”

It seemed that the news had already reached the Overlord.

There was no reason to think that the response was quick.

I didn't act in a hurry, and the Overlord must have had enough time to understand the situation.

I also brought Gulpiro and the siblings into the castle.

And I spent my time casually.

Because if I wait, there would be a reaction from the other side soon, so there was nothing I could do.

In the meantime, I could feel the eyes constantly watching me from far away places around the castle.

I didn't care because it was obvious that it was a watcher sent by the Overlord Castle. I might leave the castle, so they monitored me.

Then after about a half an hour had passed.

Kkiiig!

I got up from my seat and looked out the window at the faint sound in the distance.

Three huge creatures flying towards the castle from the other side of the sky came into view. It was a wyvern.

And the people who were on it...

They're here.

I went out of the room and said to Asher, who was at the door.

"Take the siblings and Gulpiro and wait in the castle. And if you hear bad news, do as I said."

She looked like she had a lot to say, but then nodded her head with a firm face.

"...All right."

I left her and went downstairs to the atrium.

The butler immediately approached me in the cool atmosphere outside and spoke to me.

“They said they came to deliver the Overlord’s message.”

Soon after, three people appeared in the hall.

A dwarf, a man wearing a robe, and a knight.

I stood face to face with them and looked at them in turn.

There was a chilly atmosphere in the central hall.

【Lv. 96】

【Lv. 89】

The two were familiar faces.

The First Lord, the Wiseman and chief of staff, Dayphon.

【Lv. 95】

And the knight in black armor standing on the right is probably...

He’s the leader of the Black Star Order.

Their leader, Kradiel.

If the Chief of Staff was the Overlord’s left arm, he was the Overlord’s right arm and the most powerful knight in Calderic.

Unlike the Lords, the Knights of Black Star were loyal to the Overlord and only obeyed her orders.

“The Overlord has declared an emergency call, Seventh Lord.”

The Wiseman, armed with armor and a sword that emits a subtle five-color brilliance, spoke first.

“I don’t think you don’t know the reason, so I’ll start by checking the facts. Are you the Seventh Lord who fought the Sixth Lord in Mahea City and

killed him in the end?”

There was no point in denying it, so I nodded my head.

“Yes.”

“Why did you kill the Sixth Lord?”

“It doesn’t seem necessary to say that now.”

“Can I take that word as a meaning of obediently complying with the summons?”

The Wiseman asked with sullen eyes. A force field roared like a haze around his armor.

The leader of Black Star also gently squeezed the hand that was on the hilt of the sword.

A chilly yet suffocating tension permeated the hall.

I sat quietly facing them, then opened my mouth.

“Yes.”

If that wasn’t the case in the first place, would I even return here?

And that would have been well known to all three of them.

Then the chief of staff came forward and said:

“I heard that you saved a human brother and sister from Actipol’s gladiator match. If it has anything to do with them....”

“I’m the only one going.”

I cut off the conversation adamantly.

He looked back at Wiseman with a stiff face, and the other nodded.

“Okay. Then we’ll go straight to Overlord Castle.”

Had all the other Lords gathered by now?

I was curious about that, but I didn’t have to ask, because I would find out soon anyway.

I looked at the chief of staff.

Returning to the castle right away, it was obvious that he would use his teleportation skill. As expected, he walked out first.

“Come to my side. I’ll teleport you.”

I walked over to the three of them and stood there.

Soon, with a huge flow of magical power, the surrounding field of vision was distorted.

Chapter 67.1: Emergency Call (2)

Chapter 67.1: Emergency Call (2)

Vision returned to normal, and what unfolded was a dark cavity.

The magic stones embedded in all directions, the magic circle under my feet, and the magicians in the robe surrounding me.

It was the same scene when I escaped from the convoy and set foot in the Overlord Castle for the first time.

As I climbed the stairs leading to the ground and walked down the hallway, it felt similar to when I first came to Overlord Castle. It felt like entering a tiger's mouth.

And it wasn't really that different.

Depending on the outcome of this emergency call, this place could be my execution site today.

However, unlike back then, the reason my mind was calm was probably because I was used to this world that much, and also because I had prepared enough before coming.

As I continued to act as a Lord, I seemed to have assimilated with that role.

I walked down the dark hallway and arrived at the place where the knights were lined up and standing.

All of them were wearing the same jet-black armor as the leader of the Black Star Order, and their levels were over 80. All of them seemed to be Knights of Black Star.

And at the end of it was a huge door.

We walked past the knights and stood right in front of the entrance to the conference hall.

...Hmmm.

I felt a huge presence that could not be hidden beyond the door.

At that moment, I was convinced that all the Lords were gathered inside, and at the same time, I realized it.

If things didn't go according to plan, there's really no way to survive.

"This convening is open to hear the explanation of the Seventh Lord on why you killed the Sixth Lord."

The Wiseman opened the door and opened his mouth before going inside.

I glanced back at him.

"I don't know if you know, but it's pointless to speak a lie in front of the Overlord."

"..."

"I hope you will be able to honestly reveal your true feelings and persuade the Overlord."

The First Lord was the most special among the nine Lords.

First, he had the highest level among the Lords, and above all, he was the first one to have maintained his position as a Lord since the founding of Calderic.

To that extent, he did not differ from being the largest pillar of Calderic, and he was a person who sincerely thought about Calderic's peace more than anyone else.

Perhaps he, like me, wanted no more clashes from this incident.

Without answering, I looked forward again.

The Wiseman took a step forward and opened the door himself.

Coo coo.

The door opened, and the scenery inside the conference hall came into view.

A huge round table, and the Lords sitting around it.

All their eyes were already on this side.

“...”

From the First Lord standing next to me, to the Fourth Lord, the King of the Dead, and the Ninth Lord, the Giant King, who did not attend the previous meeting.

All the Lords had gathered.

In particular, I looked at the figure of the Ninth Lord, who was filling up one side of the seat by himself.

A giant who appeared to be at least 5 meters tall. One of the rarest races, the giant race.

Unlike the other Lords, he sat alone in a huge chair that fit his body and looked down with calm eyes at where I was standing.

No one was hostile or murderous, but enormous pressure filled the conference hall.

Because all the Lords seated in their seats were properly armed.

“Come and sit, Seventh Lord.”

The Overlord, sitting at the top of the round table, smiled and opened her mouth.

She was wearing the same black dress outfit I had seen before.

I was a little puzzled by the laughter that didn't suit the situation at all, as well as her not showing any hostility.

“You came earlier than expected. There were no major collisions?”

The Mad King, who was resting her chin on the armrest, straightened her posture and said in a voice mixed with laughter.

I walked over to my seat and sat down with a blank expression.

The Wiseman also sat in his seat, and Dayphon and Kadriel approached and stood behind where the Overlord was sitting.

There was silence in the meeting room for a moment.

Soon the Overlord spoke again.

“Now, since we are all gathered here, shall we begin?”

She pointed to the empty seat of the Sixth Lord.

“The reason I declared an emergency call is that of the death of the Sixth Lord, as everyone knows. And the one who killed him was the Seventh Lord, who gained that position recently.”

Her gaze shifted to me again.

“Do you have anything to correct about what I just said?”

“None.”

This was also a formal confirmation.

The Overlord continued speaking after I answered.

“Okay, first, this is the situation that I understood. In a gladiator match hosted by the Sixth Lord, the Seventh Lord suddenly broke in, and unilaterally declared to the Sixth Lord that he would take away the slave gladiators from the match, and there was a clash with the Sixth Lord who became angry with that declaration. After a fierce battle, he killed the Sixth Lord.”

“...”

“How is it, Seventh Lord? Is there anything you want to correct?”

I said quietly.

“First, Sixth Lord’s side attacked first.”

“Oh, yes. But that’s not important, is it?”

The Overlord shook her head.

The Second Lord, Thunder Lord, intervened and joined in.

“Even if the Sixth Lord attacked first, wasn’t it said that it was the Seventh Lord who first intervened in the event that the Sixth Lord was hosting? So, the one who started it first was definitely him.”

I glanced at the Thunder Lord.

She was the one who mostly resisted the decision of me being appointed as a Lord, and now she’s also the one who’s active in this meeting.

The Overlord looked at me with a smile.

“Seventh Lord, can you give me an answer? Even if the Sixth Lord attacked first, did you already have the intention to kill him?”

“...”

I clicked my tongue at the question that stabbed me directly.

I expected it, but it didn't seem like it would go easily.

The ability to see through truth and lies, which the hero of Santea also possessed.

As long as the Overlord had that ability, it wouldn't work for me to play clumsily in this place.

Whether I had the intention of killing the Sixth Lord before the other attacked?

I couldn't say no at all.

Because at that time, I had already decided.

If I couldn't figure out another way to cure the light blood disease, I would kill him and take the siblings and leave.

"It's not that it wasn't there."

The Overlord asked again.

"Then, it's not that you were forced to kill after the battle became too intense, but that you killed the Sixth Lord with clear intentions, right?"

"Yes."

Chapter 67.2: Emergency Call (2)

Chapter 67.2: Emergency Call (2)

This was also an undeniable fact.

I killed him after taking away most of his physical abilities and then subduing him.

Each of the Lords responded to my answer.

The Wiseman and the Thunder Lord slowly furrowed their brows, and the Black Sea Empress and the Mad King smiled strangely as they did when I first entered, and the rest of the Lords did not show their emotions.

“Now that I’ve confirmed the facts, I’ll have to listen to the reason.”

The Overlord asked with a smile on her face.

“Seventh Lord, why did you kill the Sixth Lord?”

I shut my mouth for a moment and answered nothing.

Why did I kill the Sixth Lord?

This convening was happening so they could hear the reason for my actions, and to execute me if the reason was not reasonable.

So, I could say that whatever answer I would give would decide my life or death.

…*But I cannot give a good reason.*

It was natural.

Two human beings who would be nothing more than insignificant bugs of no value to them.

What if I answered I killed the Sixth Lord only to save them?

Of course, there was also a reason.

The fact that one sibling was the person who would kill the Sixth Lord in the future, and that the other would have died in the not too distant future if I hadn't intervened, anyway.

But, of course, this was inexplicable.

Of course, an Overlord capable of distinguishing between truth and lies would know that my absurd reason was indeed the truth.

But what if that happened? Again, things would get complicated. If I openly revealed Rigon's existence to the Overlord, one never knew what would happen.

[How about playing a game with me? I'll spare your life. Instead, you will become the Seventh Lord of Calderic.

...Which could make the siblings unhappy again, who barely escaped from hell.

Giving out that information to the Overlord to escape this immediate crisis and save my life was not the worst, just a lesser evil.

So, I took a risk.

The best answer I could give her was this.

"It was for the best."

"...Yes?"

The Overlord narrowed her brow slightly, as if she did not understand what I was saying.

“Killing the Sixth Lord, at least in my opinion, was the best thing. It was less detrimental to Calderic’s future.”

This was the truth without a lie.

The Sixth Lord, who would have died in the future anyway, just died a little earlier. And Rigon, who would have become a ghost in the future, had not fallen.

I didn’t know if this could be called an advantage for Calderic, but I didn’t think it was a loss, anyway.

The Overlord tilted her head with an expression of more incomprehension.

“So now, you want to say that the existence of the Sixth Lord was harmful to Calderic?”

“...”

“I’d like you to explain why you made such a judgment, Seventh Lord.”

“This is all I have to say.”

If I explained further here, I had to somehow reveal Rigon’s existence, so I said nothing more.

The Overlord let out a small sigh.

“Don’t you think you’re being too forceful? If you don’t give a proper reason, we can’t decide. If you keep going like that...”

“What is there to hear more?”

The Thunder Lord interrupted in a cold voice.

“Another Lord has killed a Lord. If it goes on, the order of Calderic will be shaken from the very core. Whatever the reason or how reasonable it may be, we must execute the Seventh Lord right here and correct this order.”

The Mad King opened her mouth.

“Hey, but you hated the Sixth Lord so much. To be honest, aren’t you still bearing a grudge because of what happened at the last meeting?”

“…Are you really joking about this situation?”

“Look, I think I was correct.”

She giggled and picked up the sword she had set aside.

“Still, I agree with the Second Lord’s opinion. The reason for the murder, whatever it was, doesn’t really matter.”

“That’s right, Overlord. He doesn’t even want to actively explain it, so don’t waste your time and just kill him.”

The Black Sea Empress also intervened and fluttered laughter as she flapped her wings.

I looked at the Overlord.

“Seventh Lord, I’ll give you one last chance.”

She said with a look on her face that something had cooled off.

“Tell me something that will change my mind or persuade me, or you will die here today.”

The tone was as if she had planned to execute me from the beginning, no matter what the reasons the Lords said.

I exhaled and folded my arms.

The Overlord was a ruthless but reasonable person.

By being reasonable, I meant she wasn't the type to put her pride first.

So she decided to execute me here only because it was in Calderic's advantage.

I dared to break the iron rule and kill a Lord? It's not an emotional choice.

No matter how much she judged me as a talented person, I was someone who had just taken this position and I, in fact, still lacked credibility.

She must have judged that there was no merit enough to continue leaving the element of anxiety that shook the fundamental order of Calderic that had been maintained for hundreds of years.

So I thought.

If there was no benefit in saving me, she would imprint the damage I had done to the people here as a warning.

The Lords, who were seated around the round table, slowly raised their resolve and stared at me.

I glanced at them once and opened my mouth.

"If there is a battle, there will be no way for me to survive."

This was true.

No matter how many abilities I acquired, I never thought about the possibility of surviving the joint attack of all the Lords, including the Overlord.

"But keep this in mind."

Here, the Lords without shield-type abilities were the Fifth Lord – the Mad King, the Ninth Lord – the Giant King, and the Eight Lord – Black Sea Empress...

The number of space leaps in a row was three times, and blood magic.

In the limited space of the conference room, if I spread blood and spill blood in all directions, how well would the Lords respond?

I couldn't know. Maybe I couldn't hit even one, or I could hit more than I thought because of their carelessness.

In other words, no one knew what the outcome would be.

I might die in vain killing no one, or conversely, the Lords might be annihilated.

“Half of the people here.”

So, what I was saying now was not a bluff, but pure sincerity from an unpredictable future.

And the Overlord would know it.

“If you're going to kill me, more than half of you must be prepared to die.”

Chapter 68.1: Emergency Call (3)

Chapter 68.1: Emergency Call (3) ! Thank you to Void, Fastus, transhumanist Sykes, sroat, Senki, FallenVI for the donations!

Silence fell in the conference hall.

Freezing, suffocating silence.

While all the Lords' gazes were gathered, I spoke to the Overlord while still pretending to have a calm expression on my face.

“Would you like to check it out, Overlord?”

“...”

She stared at me with a terrifyingly expressionless face.

The Overlord and the nine Lords, and from the head of the Black Star knights to the chief of staff.

If there was no hero, they alone would be able to completely wipe out Santea from the continent with no other forces.

I am speaking to them now.

I told them that even if I fought them alone, I could take half of them to the underworld.

This was how the Lords reacted.

The First Lord—the Wiseman, the Third Lord—the Heavenly Palace, and the Fourth Lord – the King of the Dead, did not show any signs.

The Fifth Lord—the Mad King raised an eyebrow, and the Eighth Lord—the Black Sea Empress and the Ninth Lord, the Giant King, frowned in displeasure.

“You’re arrogant.”

The Giant King let out a voice as heavy as his size.

“Yes, yes. This is it. This is how it feels…”

The Mad King delightfully murmured, exhaling a breath full of excitement and heat.

“You really are a crazy person.”

And it was the Second Lord—the Thunder Lord that uttered a voice full of absurdity and anger.

The eyes staring at me full of murderous intent seemed to overlap with what I had seen at the last meeting.

“If you thought that such a bluff would really work, you’d be foolish.”

Blue sparks flickered as it wrapped around the entire body of the Thunder Lord.

Then, suddenly, the Overlord burst out laughing.

The Lords turned their eyes to see her holding on to her stomach and giggling.

Slowly, she stopped laughing and met my eyes.

She had a cold, stiff face just a moment ago, but now she had an innocent smile on her lips again.

“…Are these not empty words, Seventh Lord?”

At the Overlord’s words, the Thunder Lord narrowed her eyes.

“You honestly think you can deal with all the Lords here? Is it arrogance as the Ninth Lord says, or is it the truth?”

I didn't reply.

If one had nothing to say, keep silent and let the other think of the reason for themselves.

It was a great way of communication that had never gone wrong, at least until now.

So, for a long time, I was staring at the Overlord.

Perhaps by now she was thinking about it in her head.

Maybe she thought that it's just the ignorant remarks of a human filled with arrogance. If one used their common sense, it was right to judge it that way.

However, the Overlord knew nothing of my abilities yet.

And by actually killing the Tyrant, I once again proved my strength.

Because of this, the Overlord could not judge or measure me, who was hiding myself thoroughly.

What if there was really a battle and more than half of the Lords died?

It wasn't just a power cut in half; it was a matter of Calderic's existence at stake.

If such a catastrophe really happened, Santea, Calderic's greatest adversary, would not stand still.

...To be honest, on one hand, I knew I was being completely forceful right now.

First, if they're going to kill me because I broke the rules, then they should also be prepared for some retaliation.

However, no matter how blatantly coercive it might be, if it hadn't been for these threats, whatever I said would have been to no avail.

Imprinting my last remarks in her head, making the execution feel like a gamble that cannot be decided in haste.

If that was the case, the first aim had been achieved.

And now, looking at the Overlord, it was going the way I hoped it would.

...*Now I have to take a step back.*

It wouldn't work if I kept my mouth shut like this.

I timed it and prepared to speak again.

Even if I temporarily put a stop to my execution, that was all.

Anyway, I thought this wouldn't change the Overlord's decision.

Those who were here now were the rulers at the top of Calderic.

Like the Thunder Lord a while ago, they were not the ones who would back down from such threats.

Prestige aside, even if I kept myself alive from the moment I said these words, it would be like holding a large bomb that could explode again.

So, if things went on like this, there was a high probability that the Overlord would eventually decide to execute me just for the sake of it.

I had to end this situation gracefully, when the mood had not yet fully shifted in that direction.

I opened my mouth.

“My opinion is still the same. Killing the Sixth Lord there has an advantage for Calderic.”

“...”

“But I also admit that my actions have disrupted Calderic’s order. There is no excuse for that.”

The Overlord blinked.

“Then I swear. It’s never going to happen again in the future. Of course, if I remained alive, that is.”

These words were sincere.

I ended up killing the Tyrant because of various circumstances overlapping. What else would I have against the other Lords?

“Huh...”

The Overlord smiled strangely and tapped the armrest of the chair with her finger.

I could see some Lords looking at me with a look of absurdity.

It must be absurd to them that they should quietly pass this convening with just a few words.

The Overlord soon spoke again.

“I’ll ask you one last question, Seventh Lord. Did killing the Sixth Lord have anything to do with the human siblings whom you saved?”

“...”

“Yeah, it seems that’s the case. I see.”

I said nothing, but the Overlord nodded as if she had heard the answer.

She asked, looking around the Lords with a happy face that seemed to be intrigued again.

“What do other Lords think? It seems sincere that the Seventh Lord will not cause such chaos again.”

Chapter 68.2: Emergency Call (3)

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The Thunder Lord immediately protested.

“This is unacceptable. If you break the rules, pay for it, for whatever reason!”

The Overlord nodded her head.

“Okay then, we seem to have varying opinions, so let’s do a vote. The Second Lord is obviously in favor of execution, and what about the other Lords?”

The Black Sea Empress was the first to step forward.

“I’m also in favor, Overlord. That man is so shameless. It’s unlucky.”

“Ah, I’m also in favor.”

The Mad King immediately seconded.

It was as if she had been gearing to fight because she had been holding the hilt of her sword since earlier.

“The First Lord?”

In response to the Overlord’s question, the Wiseman said with a calm face.

“I will obey the will of the Overlord.”

Her gaze then turned to the Third Lord.

He opened his mouth, who had been staring blankly into the air with a face full of annoyance.

“...I will also do as the Overlord tells me.”

Now, only the Fourth Lord- the King of the Dead and the Ninth Lord—the Giant King remained.

The King of the Dead, who glanced at me, was silent for a moment, then spoke.

“I will oppose execution.”

The other Lords looked at him in surprise.

“What is it, Fourth Lord? With your personality, I thought you would be in favor? Were you scared?”

At the Mad King’s words, the King of the Dead only laughed.

I was also a little surprised inside, because I didn’t know he would object.

At least, as far as I knew, the King of the Dead thought that keeping the proper order of things was the most important alongside the Wiseman and the Thunder Lord.

...Maybe he was trying to pay off the favor for the body of the warrior that I gave him?

Anyway, now only the Ninth Lord’s decision was left.

He sat quietly with his arms crossed and his eyes closed, then opened his eyes and said.

“I will also obey the will of the Overlord.”

The Thunder Lord frowned at him.

Three in favor, one against, but three left the decision to the Overlord, so the overlord had four votes.

With this, it ultimately left the decision of what would happen to me in the Overlord's hands.

“Well then, can I decide?”

The Overlord spoke calmly, as if she had roughly expected it, and fixed her gaze on me again.

I waited for her decision.

What if she decided to execute me here?

...Then I have to survive even if it things turned ugly.

Of course, I had no intention of giving up my life.

Even if I had to give her information about the future, if it could lead to my survival, they I had no choice but to bring everything I knew out in the open.

But in the end, if there was a battle, it would be unfair if I was the only one who would die alone, so I would still take out as many as I could.

After quite a long silence, she opened her mouth.

“Seventh Lord, I still think you have to take some responsibility for this. A Lord killing another Lord, it's not just something that could be easily overlooked.”

She smiled brightly.

“So, I want you to grant me three favors.”

“...?”

“Of course, it will not be an unreasonable request, so don’t worry. The first one would be to attend with me to the Neutral Nations Conference that would be held shortly after.”

Neutral Nations Conference?

As I looked at her with puzzled eyes, she explained.

“Some time later, there is a meeting between Santea and the neutral countries. I would like you to accompany me. This would be one favor and the remaining two would be decided later. How about it?”

I thought about her proposal for a moment.

Three favors: Lords could not be completely free from the orders of the Overlord as much as they enjoyed all the privileges of being a Lord.

That’s why each Lords’ meeting decided what each Lord was supposed to do according to the Overlord’s decision.

Of course, if the justification for an order was not enough, even the Lords could reject the Overlord’s orders, but...

I don’t have the right to refuse those favors.

But, well, it wasn’t a bad suggestion to get through this situation safely.

Besides, it’s a request that wasn’t too difficult if one was to accompany her to a meeting with Santea.

I didn’t know why she suddenly wanted to take me to that conference out of the blue.

Of course, the Overlord wasn’t such an easy-going person, but I could not reject the offer, anyway.

“I accept it.”

I answered obediently.

The Overlord laughed softly.

“Okay, so that’s it. The Seventh Lord won’t be executed.”

At the Overlord’s declaration, the Mad King murmured with dissatisfaction.

“Tsk, and I thought we will finally be able to fight...”

The Black Sea Empress also looked at me with an expression that showed her displeasure, and then she turned her gaze away.

I breathed a sigh of relief inwardly.

I really wondered what would happen, but I finally overcame this crisis safely.

Just as I was wondering if it would all end like this, suddenly a shout rang out.

“...I cannot accept it!”

All eyes were focused on one side.

The Thunder Lord who got up from her seat was vigorously staring at me as if she was about to kill me.

Chapter 69.1: Emergency Call (4)

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“Do you think it makes sense for everyone to move on like this?!”

She looked around and shouted.

However, the Lords reacted with disdain.

“Isn’t it something that has already been decided? And he paid the price in a different way, rather than just leaving it like nothing.”

“...This is unacceptable! A Lord has been murdered at the hands of another Lord! It is a felony among felonies that can only be paid for by death!”

“Oh, that’s over and done with, right?”

The Mad King clicked her tongue.

The chief of staff intervened and said.

“In the event of a battle between Lords, or when a Lord kills another Lord, it is enacted in the Constitution to determine the level of punishment under the authority of the Overlord through an emergency call...”

The Thunder Lord turned her gaze to look at the Chief of Staff, then looked at the Overlord.

Even with her gaze full of protest, the Overlord just put a smile on her lips without saying a word.

She said, biting her lips.

“Someone who was just enthroned like this was already causing such a commotion.”

“Thank you for thinking so passionately about Calderic’s future, Second Lord.”

“...”

“Still, I didn’t decide this on my own. It’s a matter that everyone decided by a majority vote, right? We have to admit what we have to admit.”

The Overlord’s voice, which seemed to admonish, contained pressure that was hard to resist.

“Yes, Second lord. I don’t like it either, but what can I do? It’s not like the little kid arguing would change what had already been decided.”

The Mad King burst into laughter at the sarcastic tone of the Black Sea Empress.

Little kid, that’s what the Mad King called the other at the Lords’ meeting before.

I knew why the two of them were making fun of the Thunder Lord by calling her that.

Because she’s the most recent Lord aside from me, and she’s also the youngest.

She’s only been sitting in her seat for a few years, so it might sound like a joke to them.

Well, her family was one of the oldest in Calderic though...

“This...!”

The Thunder Lord, who had been glaring at the two of them, closed her eyes tightly and exhaled. It looked like she was suppressing the anger that was about to explode.

Soon after, she opened her eyes again and looked at me with cold, subdued eyes.

“Please allow me this time, Overlord.”

“Yes?”

“I want a formal duel with the Seventh Lord. I will check if he really has the skills to make the remarks that he did.”

At that, I sighed inwardly.

- *..Again?*

She did the same thing at the last meeting, and she’s doing it again this time.

No, why was this woman so eager to take a bite off of me?

Did she still hold a grudge because of the argument that had happened last time?

“Um, a duel...”

The Overlord shook her head and looked back and forth between me and the Thunder Lord.

“Well, if you want to understand something, I have no intention of stopping you...”

Then she smiled and asked me.

“How about it, Seventh Lord? Hearing those words earlier, I also wanted to see the Seventh Lord’s skills in person.”

“...”

Fuck.

I swore to myself. I could already feel a headache coming.

Last time, I managed to somehow get over it, but this time, the Overlord seemed to have no intention of letting it go.

Because I just passed the crisis of execution, and I was in a situation where I did not have the right to speak.

“Oh, then me too! I want to fight the Seventh Lord too!”

When the Overlord’s permission fell, the Mad King shouted with her eyes shining.

Please shut up.

I shook my head and came up with a solution before things got even worse.

The duel here was, of course, a duel in which the opponent was suppressed, not killed. In other words, there was no way for me to win because I couldn’t use instant kill.

Because the Tyrant was a vampire, that’s why I was lucky enough to be able to use Gascalid’s blood magic, but this time that wasn’t the case.

At best, all I had to do was defend with a floating veil and dodge with a space leap...

- ..Ah.

Yes, would that be okay?

“Let’s do it like this.”

I said, looking at the Thunder Lord.

“Like I said, I’m not very good at being moderate. If I kill another Lord after killing the Sixth Lord, I be in trouble.”

“Ha! I don’t think you’re going to avoid a duel with that kind of excuse again...”

“So I’ll just defend.”

“...I beg your pardon?”

“I mean, I’ll just stand still and defend against attacks.”

Perhaps it was an unexpected proposal. The Thunder Lord paused for a moment and then exploded angrily.

“Are you doing your best to insult me, Seventh Lord? Your arrogance knows no bounds. You’re only going to defend yourself against my attacks?”

“Yes.”

I answered calmly.

“Second Lord—the Thunder Lord, the Elementalist of Thunder. Supposedly, you have the best destructive power among the Lords.”

“...”

“If I completely block all three of your attacks, it’s my victory.”

Turning my gaze to the Overlord, she had a face showing that it terribly intrigued her.

Conversely, the Thunder Lord was trembling up to her ears and seemed unable to control her body full of anger.

【Lv. 95】

It wasn’t an incomprehensible reaction.

Among the elves that existed on the entire continent, she was almost the strongest elemental magician.

I had declared that I would just stand still and block her attacks like that.

Especially if she had a strong personality. Wouldn't she feel that what I did was simply a big insult to her?

“...Good.”

Soon after, she said in a ferocious voice.

“Instead of proceeding with the duel, as you said, I will add a condition. If the Seventh Lord loses, get down on your knees and apologize to me for your arrogant words and deeds.”

“I will.”

- ..Done.

I nodded my head in joy.

“Tsk, what kind of duel is that? It's not fun...”

The Mad King, who had just been brimming with energy, luckily, had her excitement died down.

The Overlord cleared the situation.

“Well, the Seventh and Second Lords are going to have a duel according to those conditions? Let's go to the right place right away.”

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The place they moved to from the conference hall was a gigantic gymnasium on the other side of Overlord Castle. At first glance, it appeared to be several hundred meters in diameter.

The Thunder Lord and I stood facing each other at a reasonable distance in the middle of the arena, while the other Lords stood around watching the spectacle.

Tsutsutsu

Blue sparks erupted all over the Thunder Lord's body.

There was no need to delay, and she was ready to start the duel right away.

“It's still not too late, so it doesn't matter if you change the conditions, Seventh Lord.”

I folded my arms without answering her words, which seemed to be mixed with a little sneer.

She looked at me with contemptuous eyes and smirked, raising her energy even more.

Tsutsutsu.

Soon, a blue figure like a giant eagle appeared above her head.

I knew what that was. Kogos, one of the many Thunder Spirits who made a contract with her.

Was that spirit about in the middle of all her spirits?

It didn't look like she was going to come out with all her might from the start.

As I watched the surrounding thunderbolts grow stronger and stronger, I leisurely spread the floating veil.

The eagle spirit that flapped its wings once flew towards me with its mighty thunderbolts wrapped around it.

A thunderbolt exploded, and for a moment, it dyed my vision with a pure blue light.

However, the eagle was completely blocked by the veil and vanished in vain, giving no damage.

I removed the veil and looked at the Thunder Lord.

With her hands removed, she said, narrowing her eyes.

“Now, this is the true start.”

Quarreung!

The next form that appeared along with the ferocious thunder... Pegasus?

It was a horse with a pair of wings on its back and huge horns on its head.

Is the name Requisacron?

There were so many spirits that the Second Lord had a contract with, so I could only remember some vague names.

Still, I knew it was the closest to the highest spirit among the spirits of the Thunder Lord.

The lightning that spread around her became much stronger than before.

It engulfed the Thunder Lord that I could barely see her form.

There was only a confident smile on her lips.

Tsutsustu!

An energy in the form of a sphere gathered at the tip of the spirit's horn.

I took a breath and opened the floating veil once more.

Soon, a flash of light exploded from the massive sphere, and at the same time, a formidable thunderbolt rushed in.

My vision was dyed with a much stronger light than before, but this time, too, it was not enough to cause damage.

Shoo woo.

I removed my veil and looked around the ruins.

I hadn't even exerted my power yet. Was this enough?

Inwardly admiring, I shifted my gaze to the Thunder Lord again.

She also seemed a little embarrassed this time.

Even though she had done this far, she hadn't been able to scorch even a single trace of my clothes, so that's understandable.

"Now there is only one left."

At my words, she bit her lower lip.

"...At least you seemed to have a slight ability to back-up your words."

Her hair slowly rose upwards.

And a powerful energy that could not even be compared with the two spirits just before blew like a storm.

Kwrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrrring!

The Thunder Lord was so strong that it covered the whole area with blue light. I could not see the surroundings at all, as if trapped in a barrier.

I felt a tingling sensation all over my body and stared blankly at the humanoid spirit that appeared in the air like a giant.

Finally, she took it out.

The strongest thunder spirit she possessed, Laxia.

An elongated spear was formed in the giant's hands, and energy slowly gathered together.

The giant held the spear in the opposite direction and aimed it as if it was about to throw the huge spear directly at me.

The same technique that was the ultimate skill of the Thunder Lord in the game.

Wait a minute, this...

As I opened the floating veil, I couldn't help but feel a sense of creepiness.

Is it impossible to stop it?

In the first place, I didn't even think that I was going to lose.

No matter how powerful the attack was in the game, there was no attack that could break through the floating veil, which was an invincible defender.

...But seeing this in person was no joke.

Moreover, the ultimate skill of the Thunder Lord was an instant death attack that inflicted fixed damage in the game, so I had no choice but to feel threatened.

Anxiety arose in my mind as to whether the floating veil would break.

“Come on, stop this without avoiding it!”

The Thunder Lord shouted like that and stretched out her hand.

In the end, I chose my instincts. I removed the veil and used blood magic.

Drops of blood flew towards Laxia, who was about to throw the spear, and as soon as it touched the spirit, it burned and disappeared in an instant.

coo coo.

And like that, along with the drops of blood, Laxia also disappeared in an instant, as well as the huge energy surrounding it.

“...Huh?”

The Thunder Lord, who was about to launch an attack with great force, uttered a confused voice.

Chapter 70.1: Emergency Call (5)

Chapter 70.1: Emergency Call (5)

She had a face that showed she did not know what had just happened.

Ugh...

I breathed a sigh of relief inwardly.

I just I used instant kill without realizing it.

But it seemed like my decision was right.

Who knew what would have happened if the floating veil had been destroyed?

By the way, instant kill works on spirits too.

At the same time, I also gained stronger convictions.

Whether it's a soul or something, if it's just an object that could be alive in a broad sense, instant kill would generally work.

The foggy energy that covered the surrounding was lifted, and the Lords who were watching the duel came into view again.

They looked surprised to see me in perfect condition.

I turned my gaze back to the Thunder Lord.

She had a more perplexed expression on her face than before. As if something was terribly wrong.

She closed her eyes and opened her eyes, looked down at her hands, then raised her head again and looked at me. Her pupils were shaking as if an earthquake had occurred.

What's wrong?

I looked at her like that with puzzled eyes.

Well, she must have been embarrassed because the spirit she summoned suddenly disappeared, but somehow I felt like she had lost composure...

【Lv. 90】

- ..?

I checked the level floating above the Thunder Lord's head and my eyes widened. For a moment, I thought I was wrong.

Her level, which was at level 95, had dropped sharply to level 90.

I wondered what had happened, but I immediately understood the situation and burst into exclamation inwardly.

- *..Maybe the Laxia has completely disappeared?*

That's possible, right?

Since it was instantly killed and destroyed, the Great Spirit of Thunder, Laxia, no longer existed in this world.

That meant that it would be impossible for her to summon Laxia again. How could she summon a spirit that had already been destroyed?

Having lost one of the greatest powers she had, of course, her level had also dropped that much.

Wow, wait a minute.

It was then that I realized that I had done something terrifying.

So, you're saying that the power of the Thunder Lord had been permanently cut off by a whopping five levels?

It's not just a normal five levels, but five levels in the 90s, which was a really amazing value.

I was dumbfounded at the unintentional catastrophe and laughed out loud.

When the Thunder Lord made eye contact with me, she flinched.

"You, you, you. What the hell did you..."

Then the Overlord and other Lords came around.

She hurriedly shut her mouth.

The Overlord looked at me and her one turn at a time and said with a smile.

"It seems that the Seventh Lord has won. Second Lord, will you accept this defeat?"

Even after the Overlord's words, the Thunder Lord did not answer, just stood there blankly with a bewildered face.

I tried to talk to her with an apologetic tone.

"Second lord, the spirit..."

She freaked out and opened her mouth.

"Hey, I admit it! I admit my defeat!"

"..."

"Seventh Lord... it's your victory."

In response to that reaction, the other Lords looked at the Thunder Lord with a puzzled look.

She looked at me once more with panicked eyes and then ran away.

“What’s wrong with her? Is it because she’s embarrassed?”

The Mad King murmured.

I looked at her back as she moved away.

- *..What a troublesome woman.*

To be honest, it’s none of my business whether or not the Second Lord lost her power, but I couldn’t help but feel sorry for what I did.

At level 90, not to mention the other Lords, wasn’t she weakened to a level even compared to the Five Stars of Santea?

It must have been because she was conscious of the eyes of the Overlord and other Lords that she was running away in such a hurry right now.

Hmm...

What could I do?

A little, no, I was very sorry, but there was no way I could take responsibility for anything.

How would I restore the spirit that had already been destroyed? My only ability was to kill, but I could not revive a dead being.

Sorry.

I apologized to her inwardly once more. And immediately started rationalizing what happened.

No, who was the one who started the fight? She was the one who started it first, so it’s not like everything was my fault...

“It’s really great.”

Then suddenly a huge shadow fell behind me.

When I turned my head, the Giant King was looking down at me with his eyes shining. Why suddenly?

He said softly in a voice of admiration.

“The Second Lord’s Laxia, I know because I’ve bumped into it with my whole body once before. It’s a formidable spirit that seems to burn to the bone.”

“...”

“It truly amazed me that you did not avoid it and faced it head on. As I heard, you’re an outstanding warrior, Seventh Lord.”

- ..An outstanding warrior?

I was dumbfounded looking at the Giant King praising me with a straight face.

Hmm... I wonder if this was just the Giant King’s character.

Typical warrior character.

Even in the game, the Giant King used to show one-sided favor to the outstanding warriors he recognized. Even if it’s from a different faction.

An excellent warrior here meant not backing down from any attack, but only facing each other head-on. Honest at best, ignorant at worst. However, the Ninth Lord wasn’t the kind of character whose brain was just pure muscles.

“Anyway, is this the end of the emergency call?”

The Mad King, who was looking at me with regretful eyes, turned around.

“I came with a lot of anticipation, but it all ended up in such a bland conclusion.”

As she strode forward, she stopped as if she remembered something, and turned her head back to me.

“By the way, Seventh Lord, I heard you encountered something in my territory before?”

“...?”

“Was it Wilpeck? Anyway, with the mayor somewhere.”

- ..Oh, that.

It was referring to that noble girl who went crazy at the restaurant where she met Tair. Yeah, how did that go?

The Mad King scratched her head and continued.

“Anyway, I heard from the butler that he did something wrong, so I roughly told him to take care of it. Is there anything else you want?”

“...It’s up to you.”

I had no interest in that.

The Mad King smiled, waving her hand, and then she turned around.

“Well then, shall we disband as is? We’ll see you all at the next meeting.”

The Overlord also clapped her hands, signalling the end of this emergency call.

“Ah~ it’s difficult. When will this vacant seat be filled again...?”

She muttered like that and turned towards the castle.

Chapter 70.2: Emergency Call (5)

Chapter 70.2: Emergency Call (5)

Soon, the other Lords dispersed one by one.

It was a pretty refreshing ending for the serious atmosphere until now.

“Seventh Lord, you are welcome to visit my territory at any time.”

The Giant King left those words and took a heavy step.

“How strong were the Sixth Lord?”

The Black Sea Empress asked me that before leaving.

I looked at her without answering.

She raised an eyebrow and spoke again.

“I’m just curious. As a vampire with no taste, I’ve always wanted to chew him up and swallow him.”

“...”

“But now, I’m starting to lose my appetite. This time, we’re just going to move on like this. So, do be careful in the future.”

I glanced at her back, wiggling her antennae as she moved away, and then I turned to the other side.

By the way, what about the Heavenly Palace...?

I tried to talk to him about the Valkilov case in his territory, but he was already gone before I knew it.

Everyone had left, and now only the First and Fourth Lord were left.

The Wiseman spoke to me first.

“I’m glad everything seems to have been resolved smoothly.”

…Was it smooth?

Well, if one put the process aside and looked at the results, it was indeed smooth. At least there wasn’t a life-or-death battle.

But what’s his purpose?

Seeing that he had been waiting for me, I wondered if there was anything else.

The next thing that came out of the Wiseman’s mouth was a random story.

“Remember the giant snake monster you killed Seventh Lord in the Rutus Mountains before?”

Bellevagorah?

I wondered how this dwarf knew about it, so I looked at him with curious eyes.

“You left the body to the mayor, so I took some of those scales and used them. They’re great materials. So, I just wanted to say thank you.”

Ah… was it that?

I had nothing to say, so I did not reply.

For him, as a blacksmith, scales of monsters like that would have been a good material.

“If you have any equipment you wanted made, please come to my territory. Well, then...”

As if that was all he had to say, the Wiseman greeted him and left immediately.

I turned my gaze to the remaining one—the King of the Dead.

He, too, was still waiting for all the other Lords to leave.

“There is one thing I want to ask you.”

Said the other.

“The corpse of the warrior that you gave me before, it was impossible to resurrect it as an undead. The soul was completely annihilated.”

What?

I was astonished at the words.

“The remnants of the soul remain on the body of the dead. Undead magic is basically a magic that starts by capturing and subordinating the soul. However, the corpse of the warrior that the Seventh Lord killed did not leave a small remnant, and the soul was completely wiped out.”

“...”

Hearing that, I fell in thought.

Because there was something that suddenly came to mind.

The soul disappeared?

He said that the soul of the warrior, who died instantly, was completely annihilated.

So, was it possible that instant kill was the ability to annihilate the soul of the target itself? So, was that the reason it worked on souls and spirits?

No, wait a minute...

Then, what about the guardian that was killed in the dungeon? Do Guardians have souls?

I asked the King of the Dead.

“Fourth Lord, do you know about ancient golems?”

He tilted his head at my sudden question.

“Is the magic of creating golems also related to souls?”

“Um, puppetry magic? I know little about it because I’m not interested in it.”

“...”

“It’s a magic that injects the remains of the soul harvested from another object into the doll’s body. Whether it’s already dead or never alive in the first place, to make anything move, not only magic but also the remnants of the soul are essential.”

In short, it meant that even those golems had a soul.

Then it’s probably true.

If the essence of instant kill was the ability to annihilate the target’s soul itself, it fit all the targets that had been killed so far.

It was a new discovery about this ability, but the fact was that knowing it didn’t really change anything.

By the way, I haven’t used it on undead yet, but as he said, it would work well on an undead, regardless.

“So, do you want to complain about it?”

At my question, the King of the Dead laughed and shook his head.

“No, it can’t be. I was just curious if my conjecture was correct. From your reaction, it seems that’s the case.”

As if curiosity had been resolved, the King of the Dead also turned around.

“Then I will go as well. See you at the next meeting, Seventh lord.”

I also had one question, so I stopped him and asked.

“Why did you oppose the execution?”

Now that I look at it, it didn’t seem like he was doing it to pay off a favor.

The King of the Dead looked back at me and said with a smile.

“It was just a personal decision. If we all fight you, I felt like your threat would come true.”

“...”

“But I don’t have any ill feelings towards you. I want to build a friendly relationship with you, Seventh Lord.”

I looked at the King of the Dead and said,

“The corpse of the Sixth Lord will probably be revived as an undead.”

“...Hmm?”

I did not kill the Tyrant with instant kill, so the remnants of his soul would remain

At my words, the King of the Dead tilted his head and then smiled again.

“Is it? Thank you. I suddenly got a very good ingredient. I’ll have to tell the Overlord.”

I looked at the back of the leaving King of the Dead, and soon I turned around.

Whoa.

The execution trial, the duel, I was tired physically and mentally.

I just wanted to go back and rest.

T/N: Hi! So, I will temporarily take a break from posting . So, please, don't donate. >< I think I kind of overestimated myself, thinking that I could just pour out chapters left and right like this. But it's honestly taking a toll on me. Don't worry, there will still be regular updates every other day. Just no .
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There are still 2chaps left from the donations. I will post it together with the regular update tomorrow. ^^

Chapter 71.1: Short Break (1)

Chapter 71.1: Short Break (1)

I returned safely to the Seventh Lord's territory.

I arrived in the middle of the night, but Asher and Reef were still awake by this time, and they came out from the entrance with the butler to greet me.

"I'm glad you came back safely..."

Asher said with a look of sincere relief.

It was a very intense reaction for her, so I nodded, thinking that it was surprising.

After all, the Wiseman and the head of the Black Star Knights dragged me away. It probably came off as a shock to her.

Reef, who was next to her, hesitated, then lowered her head and opened her mouth.

"I'm sorry. Because of us..."

"It's fine."

In the end, it all happened because of my own choices, so I had no intention of blaming the two siblings. Of course, I had no regrets either.

Well, I might have regretted it if I was really in danger of dying, but it all worked out, anyway. What mattered was the result, wasn't it?

Upon entering the castle, Gulpiero met us, his face showing that he had just woken up.

“I’m glad you returned safely, Seventh Lord. I thought something terrible was going to happen.”

I told them in moderation that everything worked out with no problems.

Gulpiero seemed to be very curious about how there was no problem after I killed a Lord, but I felt no need to explain the process.

After telling them the situation roughly, I went back to my room, threw myself on the bed, and went to sleep.

I woke up late the next morning and thought about eating.

It's been a long time since I felt relaxed.

As the Overlord said, it would take about a month before I accompanied her to the conference of the neutral countries.

The issue with the Sixth Lord was also successfully resolved, so there was nothing to do for the time being.

For my next goal, I had to head to Santea, but I hadn’t decided yet when I would go.

After acquiring the mysteries and increasing my specs, I had stabilized my personal safety and my position as a Lord to some extent.

The primary goal for surviving safely in this world was successfully accomplished.

Of course, my physical ability was still at the level of a normal person, but that’s not something that could be solved unless I gained the ability to use mana.

The hero and the heir...

I thought of my next goal as I munched on the meat I picked up with my fork.

The main story of the game.

The things I planned to do in Santea in the future were related to the main story and the fate of this world.

I didn't want to make it sound so grandiose, but it was, in a way.

Because it was a job to find the next successor to the Holy Sword that would block the resurrection of the Demon King and bring her into contact with the current hero safely.

This was something I had to do, no matter how much I didn't want to do it.

If not, the world will perish, so I have to make sure that such an outcome will be avoided.

I could only live well if the world was not on the brink of destruction.

Anyway, that was the story that a player would experience as they progressed while playing RaSa. An adventure centered around the heir of the hero.

Right now, I didn't have a system or a good guideline, so I had to do everything by myself from scratch.

The problem was that I had a rough context, but no concrete plans yet.

It's a long way to go, really.

It was a matter of meeting the heir and the hero first, so there was no meaning in worrying about it right now.

Still, I didn't know what kind of butterfly effect my actions until now might have had. I had to find out about it as soon as possible, though.

After thinking about it, I concentrated on the steak in front of me again.

Then, with a sudden thought, I asked the butler who was standing nearby.

“Are the Wyverns that the First Lord and his party rode still in the castle?”

He answered.

“No. They went back on their own.”

…Did they go back on their own?

For a moment, I tilted my head, but I thought there was nothing strange about it.

The Wyvern was a brilliant creature that people considered it as a spirit beast.

A Wyvern, huh...

By the way, it would be nice to have something like a Wyvern.

Seeing some of the Lords riding it, I suddenly felt the need. I could move around quickly if I had one.

Now that I had various mysteries, I didn't have to worry about falling off and dying while riding.

The Wyvern was almost the only means of flight in this world, and it could be said that it was the fastest means of transportation.

A sub-dragon that was strong, agile, and clever enough to be incomparable with other ordinary monsters.

However, they were very rare, and it was almost impossible to catch or breed them, and because of their unique ‘demanding characteristics’, very few people actually rode them.

If I wanted to get a Wyvern, I would have to go to their habitat myself...

I have to think about that after I returned from the conference.

After I finished eating, I got up.

Anyway, for the rest of my free time, I was thinking of just lazing about in the castle and resting.

It had been a while since I could rest, anyway.

Even if I took a break, my life didn't change much. I just lived a little more relaxed than usual.

I read books, chatted with Gulpiro, and checked Rigon's condition from time to time.

"You said you didn't want to stay in the castle?"

"That's right. A place with so many people and has a lot of space doesn't really suit me. I'll leave as soon as Rigon fully recovers."

I said to Gulpiro.

"What do you think of having a disciple?"

He blinked as if he couldn't understand why I said something so out of the blue.

"Disciple, I've never really thought about it. But why did you ask suddenly...?"

"It's nothing. Just that, there's a talented young alchemist among the alchemists I know."

Fortunately, Gulpiro seemed to be interested.

"Who? Are they an alchemist in this city?"

I nodded.

“She’s the owner of a workshop called Alkimas in this city. I hope you can visit her if you feel like it.”

“Um... well, I understand. I’m a little curious when it’s the Seventh Lord who recommended her like this.”

So I told Gulpiro about Scarlett.

Hopefully, the relationship between the two of them would develop into an apprenticeship, if it’s possible.

Chapter 71.2: Short Break (1)

Chapter 71.2: Short Break (1) Last ! Thank you to Zaped, Baccano998, and transhumanist Sykes for the donations!

One day, while walking around the castle alone, I encountered an unexpected sight.

In the corner of the outdoor gymnasium, some soldiers were gathering and playing chess.

“...Huh? Huh!”

The soldiers who saw me got up and saluted.

I gestured to them and looked down at the chessboard.

“Never mind me, and just keep going.”

“Yes? Yes, milord!”

When I tried to watch them, the soldiers’ hands shook and could not move their pieces properly. It was like their lives were suddenly at stake.

Eventually, I left them alone and returned to the castle.

Chess...

Well, in this world, when it came to board games, chess was probably the best.

Out of curiosity, I had the butler prepare the chessboard and the chess pieces.

Actually, I knew how to play chess quite a bit.

When I was young, my brother had various hobbies, and I often accompanied him to play. Chess was one of them.

The first thing that came to mind when thinking of whom to play with was Asher.

“...”

Asher, who came into the room after receiving my call, looked at the chessboard on the table with a bewildered look.

I motioned to the other side.

“Do you know how to play chess?”

“Yeah, I know, but...”

Asher looked like she didn't understand why they suddenly have to play chess, but she sat down anyway.

She said that while she was an apprentice knight at the Overlord Castle, she learned from the other knights and tried it a few times.

She's a beginner.

It wasn't bad, though.

It was because there's a unique feeling of teaching a beginner while playing against each other.

“We're just going to play lightly, so don't feel burdened. If there's something you don't know, I'll teach you.”

“Yes...”

For some reason, Asher answered with a strange expression on her face.

I let her took the white pieces, and I took the black pieces.

The game started with Asher moving a pawn first.

How many minutes have passed like that?

“...”

I stared blankly at the chessboard. My King, completely trapped by Asher’s chess pieces.

...*What?*

Why was she doing so well?

Wasn’t she just a beginner?

As soon as I moved a chess piece, Asher moved one of her own and said,

“Checkmate.”

“...”

I admitted defeat with a hard face.

“I lost.”

The shame came later.

Before starting the game, I even said that I would teach her if she didn’t know something.

“It was a good fight.”

As she looked at me, she said cautiously.

Of course, it only stimulated the shame even more.

I was silent for a moment, then asked, not understanding.

“Did you really learn how to play chess just a few months ago?”

“Yes.”

Asher replied with a puzzled expression.

With her personality, there’s no reason to lie about something like this.

So, was this really the skill of someone who only had learned to play a few months ago?

Is she a genius?

The information that Asher was good at chess was a fact that had never appeared in the game.

I thought she was a character who couldn’t do much other than use her strength. Why did I think that way?

In any case, it’s difficult to acknowledge the level difference between the opponent with just one match.

“One more match.”

“All right.”

And she defeated me in the second round much faster than the first.

A third match followed immediately.

“...”

Asher looked at the Seventh Lord, looking down at the chessboard with a cautious face.

She felt like she was about to burst into laughter, so she bit her lip and held it in.

She had never seen him so focused on something, it seemed that he was really serious about chess.

...*He's a very mysterious person.*

What was this person's purpose, and what did he want from her?

At first, she was constantly thinking and doubting.

But all those worries had now disappeared.

The time she spent with him wasn't that long, but it wasn't too short either. At least it was enough time to be sure of what kind of person he was.

In order to save two human siblings who he barely knew, he allowed himself to be dragged to the Overlord Castle.

But he came back as if nothing had happened and was just living as usual.

Asher only vaguely guessed. How heavy a burden was now placed on his shoulders.

Perhaps playing chess without meaning right now was to lighten the atmosphere that had become heavy recently.

At times, he was infinitely cold, but at other times, the goodwill and kindness within him were evident.

.....

Asher thought and shook her head, startled.

What useless thoughts...

When she looked up, the Seventh Lord, who had completed his move, was looking at her with puzzled eyes.

"It's your turn."

“Oh, yes.”

Asher moved a piece immediately.

“Checkmate.”

“Ha...”

Chapter 72.1: Short Break (2)

Chapter 72.1: Short Break (2)

Reef and Rigon were looking for something to do while staying in the castle.

I thought it was unavoidable given their situation, but it was especially severe for Reef.

According to the butler's report, she asked a maid if she could do chores or anything, whatever that she could do.

"It seemed to me that she was very anxious because of her brother."

Gulpiro clicked his tongue and said.

"She always asks me if her brother's light blood disease has been completely cured, almost obsessively."

"Hmm..."

"I think she wants to stay with the Seventh Lord because she thinks that the disease may break out at any time."

Was that so?

With the death of the Tyrant, the light blood disease that Rigon was suffering from had completely disappeared. There was no way it would appear again.

I had already explained it to her enough, but it still didn't seem to completely erase her anxiety.

Even if she could understand it with her head and reason, it would be an anxiety that was close to the realm of obsessive compulsiveness, as Gulpiro said.

She had been living like that for the past few years, so it's not that she didn't understand.

I haven't really thought about what I should do to the two of them.

That was natural. Because I didn't save them for any particular purpose.

Of course, I had no intention of expelling them, like what Reef was concerned about.

Rather, I knew Rigon was the future flesh-headed Refrigon, so I wanted to keep him by my side for as long as possible.

And it was a good thing that they seemed to feel the same...

Should I help them grow properly?

There was no doubt that both of them were talented.

Reef had grown from an ordinary person to level 40 in just a few years. Needless to say, she was a genius.

And especially for Rigon...

He became a Lord of Calderic within five years from now.

Judging from the memories that flashed in my mind that time, the Overlord said he made a contract with the demons, so he was most likely using demonic powers then.

But even considering that, it was an abnormal growth that far exceeded common sense.

He had become a strongman at the same level as a Lord in just a few years from his current mediocre level.

“Is Rigon fully recovered now?”

“Yes.”

His body was in disrepair from suffering from light blood disease for several years, but he recovered quickly thanks to Gulpiro.

As the alchemist said, I only needed to procure the ingredients for the potion and he would do the rest.

Anyway, it would be a waste to just leave such talented gemstones alone.

Doing nothing and staying in the castle all the time seemed to make them uncomfortable, too.

The next day, I immediately called the siblings and Asher.

“Gulpiro will leave the castle soon. Do you two want to stay here?”

When I asked the siblings, Reef hesitated and then nodded.

“Yes, I’m sorry, but if you give me permission, I’ll do anything you want me to do, my lord.”

I nodded and shifted my gaze to Asher.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Teach these two swordsmanship.”

That surprised both Asher and Reef.

“Do you mean teach them?”

“Yeah. Maybe you don’t like it?”

“No. It’s not like that, but...”

Asher looked at the two of them.

The request to teach swordsmanship seemed quite embarrassing to Asher.

There were plenty of knights in the castle, but the strongest among them was, of course, Asher.

So, if possible, I was trying to make her do it...

“What do you think?”

I shifted my gaze to the siblings and asked.

Rigon answered with a look of enthusiasm.

“Of course it’s great! Just teach me, and I’ll do my best to learn!”

Reef said cautiously.

“Thank you, but we are only receiving too many undeserved graces.”

I shook my head.

“It’s not just giving. If possible, wouldn’t it be better to learn swordsmanship properly and remain in the castle as a knight?”

“...Yes?”

At that, Reef gave a slightly bewildered expression.

“Anyway, if you both want to learn, study hard. Asher is the strongest warrior here in my territory.”

At my compliment, Asher said with a little embarrassment.

“I’ve taught no one before, so I don’t know if I’ll be able to do it well...”

“It’s okay. Just try it first.”

If it didn't work, then I could ask the other swordsman instructors in the castle to do it.

As such, the lesson of Asher began right before my eyes. I stood on one side and watched the scene.

First, Asher put the two of them side by side and put her hands on their backs, starting with Reef.

When I saw the flow of magic that I felt with my super sensory, it looked like it was flowing inside.

I knew nothing about magic training, so I was just guessing if she was trying to figure out the level of the two.

After taking her hands off Reef's back, Asher asked with a surprised face.

"...You said that it's been about three years since you learned to practice?"

"Yes."

"You have accumulated this amount of magical power stably in such a short time."

As expected, Reef's talent was outstanding.

Next, Asher placed her hand on Rigon's back and let out magic. Then she opened her mouth right away.

"The magic path has already been opened. Have you ever learned to practice before?"

"Oh, yes. Before getting sick, swordsmanship and magic little by little..."

I tilted my head at that.

Has he already learned?

I thought it wasn't because there was no magical power that I could feel from Rigon.

But if he had magical powers, but I wondered how he suffered from light blood disease. Was it because the accumulated magic power was too weak?

“Sir Asher.”

Rigon suddenly called out to Asher.

“The magic that is flowing through my body. Can I just move it like this? I thought I could do it.”

“...Uh?”

Then he closed his eyes and furrowed his brows with a focused face.

At this, Asher's expression showed wonder, and soon it turned into astonishment.

“...!”

Chapter 72.2: Short Break (2)

Chapter 72.2: Short Break (2)

I watched the scene blankly, unsure of what was happening.

The only thing I could feel was that the flow of magic flowing inside Rigon's body had changed slightly.

After a while, Rigon opened his eyes with a much more refreshed face than before, and Asher blankly removed her hand from his back.

“How is it?”

I was curious about the reason for that reaction, so I asked quietly.

She murmured as she looked at Rigon, who was stretching with a fresh face, as if she was looking at a monster.

“...Unbelievable affinity. No matter how much magic enters his body, he could freely manipulate it as if it was his own...”

I looked at Rigon, who was looking this way with a puzzled face

Even if I didn't quite understand what Asher was saying, it's obvious that he possessed an incredible talent if he surprised her this much.

I guess he's not a normal genius either.

If he developed properly, he might be of great help later, right?

There wasn't much time left until the main story, so if he grew in an explosive manner, it would be great.

It was time to go to the gym and tell Asher to continue fully instructing the siblings.

“Lord.”

The butler, who showed up, reported.

“The Second Lord has visited the castle.”

“...?”

Second Lord? Suddenly?

I left the three of them alone and went downstairs.

After entering the castle’s hall, I saw the Thunder Lord, who had a rather haggard look. Like someone who hadn’t slept for a few days.

“What’s the matter?”

She stared at me quietly and then opened her mouth.

“Let’s talk in a quiet place.”

“Tell me what business you have by coming here.”

“I came here to talk about the last duel.”

I could feel the suppressed anger in her trembling voice.

I also thought it was because of that.

“Follow me.”

I walked to my room and sat down opposite the Thunder Lord.

“Speak now.”

“...”

She could hardly speak.

She was just staring at me with ferocious eyes and showing only one-sided hostility.

In the silence that had settled down for a long time, I was tired of waiting, so I spoke up first.

“It must have been related to your spirit.”

“...!”

She bit her lower lip and then opened her mouth.

“What the hell have you done? Why have I completely lost my connection with my spirit? No, I can’t even feel its presence at all!”

I answered briefly.

“That’s because it’s gone.”

“...What?”

“The Thunder Spirit Laxia that you have has completely disappeared. Since it no longer exists in the world, you can’t feel its presence.”

I had nothing to hide, so I told the truth to her face.

She looked at me blankly, with a face in complete shock.

I thought while waiting for her to come to her senses.

Spirit art, a racial trait of elves.

Spirits were natural beings completely separate from elves.

However, only elves could contract with spirits and borrow their powers, so it was called the racial trait of elves.

Elves, who were born with a strong affinity for spirits, could make contracts with many strong spirits.

In a word, spirit art was a realm of talent that must be innate.

And Thunder Lord was one of the most powerfully blessed elves on this continent.

That's why she could make a contract with a great spirit as strong as Laxia, and she could also become a Lord of Calderic.

But now that great spirit is gone.

She lost her strongest power in one day.

I looked at her level once more and felt a little somber.

With a pale, weary face, she soon stuttered;

“It- it no longer exists? Laxia...?”

“Yes.”

“...Why? Why?”

“That's because I destroyed it.”

A look of distrust and deep despair filled her face.

“Ooh, don't be ridiculous. Don't be funny. How can Laxia suddenly be extinct...?”

To her, who was muttering in denial of reality, I stopped her and said.

“There is no way to revive it. Throw away the regrets and give up neatly.”

“That’s... what—”

What followed was anger.

The Thunder Lord looked at me as if to kill me with tears in her reddened eyes. I was a little baffled.

Is she going to cry?

She immediately got up from her seat.

“Seventh Lord, I will kill you. I will truly kill you someday.”

“...”

“I will definitely make you pay for this!”

Then she spun around and walked towards the door.

I looked at her back and thought.

Our relationship wasn’t a good relationship from the beginning, but somehow it seemed like I had extinguished any possibility of reconciliation.

...Then should I let it be?

I also wanted to maintain a somewhat okay relationship with the other Lords if possible.

However, if there was a monarch who was irretrievably estranged, wouldn’t it be better to have a clear advantage? So that it wouldn’t become an obstacle in the future.

And to be honest, I got annoyed because she started the fight first and was now acting like this, so I opened my mouth.

“The Overlord and other Lords don’t know this yet.”

The Thunder Lord stopped at my words.

“I think you lost a lot of power after losing Laxia. If the Overlord knew about it, would you still be able to maintain your position?”

She turned her head slowly, and her face was much paler than before.

“All, you...”

There was no way she couldn't understand that it was a threat.

Her face was filled with a mixture of shame, anger, and all kinds of emotions.

I said calmly.

“If you don't mind losing all your other spirits, you can attack.”

“...”

Her whole body trembled. She slowly forced herself to calm down.

I pointed to the opposite of where I was sitting.

“Come back and sit down.”

Chapter 73.1: Short Break (3)

Chapter 73.1: Short Break (3)

As if frozen in place, she just stood there and stared at me. I could see her clenched fists trembling.

I told her to return to where she was just sitting, not caring if it would hurt her pride to do so.

I leaned back in my chair and said again.

“If you don’t want to talk more, I don’t mind you leaving.”

“...”

However, no matter how much she seethed and complained inside, the threat of falling from the position of a Lord must be quite fearsome.

Gritting her teeth once more, she slowly returned to her seat and sat down.

“You... are you threatening me right now?”

Without answering, I pondered what to say. Because I didn’t really think about what I should say next.

What should I do? Should I push her further, or...

“If the Overlord finds out, do you think you’ll be safe?”

While I was thinking, the Thunder Lord was the first to open her mouth.

I blinked my eyes at the sudden counter-threat and looked at her.

“You killed the Sixth Lord, now you even shamelessly lowered the power of the same Lord?”

Oh, so that’s what she was going for.

Of course, it wasn’t entirely wrong.

The Lords were Calderic’s greatest power, and even if I didn’t kill her like the Sixth Lord, it would still be considered a sin if it was revealed that I purposely lowered her power.

I couldn’t guarantee that the Overlord wouldn’t hold me accountable if she found out.

But anyway.

In the first place, this was a problem in which the weight of the risks to each other did not match at all.

Unlike me, the Thunder Lord was bluffing with unreasonable threats. It’s not my side that’s desperate, it’s hers.

I got up from my seat and said.

“Then let’s go tell the Overlord the truth right now.”

The Thunder Lord was terrified and she jumped up at the same time.

“Come on, wait!”

There was an awkward silence for a moment.

I smiled and sat back down. It’s like she admitted she was the one in an unfavorable situation right now.

Realizing that I had fooled her, she glared at me with her pointed ears dyed red. Now, I could see just how much shameful must this be for her.

“This, this despicable human...!”

“...”

“You must have destroyed my spirit with this thought in mind from the beginning. Do you have neither honor nor pride? A Lord making such a crude and dirty threat!”

Suddenly, it’s about honor again.

I replied with a sullen face.

“Who was it that came here, acting unsightly and twisting the truth?”

“...The, the truth?”

“Who was the one who rejected the result of a decision that had already been concluded? Who else suggested a duel first?”

“...”

“Even that last blow you made was meant to kill me. You don’t think you’re responsible for your own actions, so you’re going to keep blaming others like this? Now I understand what the other Lords were saying about you.”

As I poured out the harsh words, she stared blankly at me.

“Oh, don’t be ridiculous. What do you know... Anyway, you killed what you killed...”

She stammered, as if the words just got stuck in her throat.

She could only slump in her seat, unable to continue what she’s saying.”

I clicked my tongue and said.

“Second Lord.”

“...”

“From now on, don’t make the same threats or intimidation in front of me like before.”

She still looked at me with eyes full of resentment and anger.

“Looks like you still can’t comprehend what I’m saying.”

Her eyelids trembled, and she spun her head away. She seemed to hold to the last bit of pride she had left, but she just looked miserable.

I sighed inwardly and looked at her, sniveling.

Blood was dripping from her lips, which she bit it because of so much anger.

She’s really pissed.

From the other side’s point of view, that was only natural.

She had lost a lot of power, and that fact was now being used to threatened her.

When was the last time she suffered such disgrace while sitting on the seat of a Lord?

First, even if they had established who was in control of the situation, that wouldn’t solve the fundamental problem.

Even if the resentment had subsided right now, as it continued to grow, it would only flourish and not decrease.

That would happen if I just left it like this now. At least I would have to tie the knot of this problem properly.

There seemed to be roughly two ways for that to happen.

One was to completely subdue it so she wouldn’t be able to lift her head so easily.

Anyway, that is going to be a little difficult.

A Lord was a powerful threat, but that didn't mean I have to kill her.

If I pushed her to the end of the cliff, there was a high probability that she would just explode because of her proud personality.

And the other one...

Now that I just hit her with a stick, I should now give her carrots.

There was one thing that suddenly came to my mind.

Spirits were a natural existence independent of the racial characteristics of elves, so it was not something that could be viewed only through their spirit skills.

In the game, spirits sometimes appeared as monsters that could be hunted, or as helpers or enemies in the story.

And among them, the thunder spirits handled by Thunder Lord also appeared, and there were also other great spirits as strong as Laxia.

If that was the case, she might regain her former level after she signed a contract with a spirit as strong as Laxia.

Honestly, I'm not sure if that spirit could be contracted by anyone...

This was because, as it appeared as a boss to be defeated in the game, it was not a gentle spirit who would make a contract with someone.

But even so, it was a fact that it really existed.

That possibility alone would have been enough to overflow with a carrot.

“I know of a place where there is a Thunder Spirit as strong as Laxia.”

Chapter 73.2: Short Break (3)

Chapter 73.2: Short Break (3)

The Thunder Lord, who had been gritting her teeth at my words, was startled and turned around.

“...I beg your pardon?”

“If you’re going to continue with that attitude, the conversation ends here. Go back.”

She said urgently.

“What, what attitude? Just keep talking, okay?”

“As I just said, I know of a place with a thunder spirit as strong as the Laxia you contracted with.”

Hearing it again, her eyes widened.

“That’s a lie. How can I believe that?”

“If you don’t want to believe me, then don’t.”

I crossed my arms and said.

“Do you think I really need to show such kindness to someone who only spews such one-sided hostility? What do you think?”

“...”

“Answer me, Second Lord. Or this conversation would end here.”

She looked at me with unsure eyes.

Then she seemed to be in deep anguish for a moment, then she finally closed her eyes tightly and said,

“Sorry... I’m sorry. I was too emotional.”

At that apology, I chuckled.

Seeing how she became so compliant in an instant, it seemed that the spirits were really important to her.

I was curious about how her expression would change if I said it was a lie, but that was only a passing thought.

“So tell me. Where is the spirit?”

“Do you think one apology will be enough?”

“...”

Her expression darkened again.

“Does that mean there is something you want from me? You really are...”

“No, I don’t really want anything from you.”

I cut off whatever it was she was trying to say.

“It’s just that I don’t feel comfortable handing over this much information. Think the other way around. Would you do the same?”

“...”

“So, I’m thinking about whether to tell you about it.”

The Second Lord—the Thunder Lord.

Even though she lost a lot of power, at level 90, many could still consider her as a powerhouse on the continent.

This bait would make it easy to borrow her help when needed.

My words must have sounded like I was just making things up. That's why the Thunder Lord's face became ferocious again. Of course, she had the right to feel that way.

But what could she do? Having a new powerful spirit was important to her, and I was the only one who possibly knew its location.

"If you deceive me and just end up telling me nothing until the end, no, if it was a lie in the first place..."

I stopped her and said,

"Then I will swear on that part. Staking my name and honor."

"..."

"You wouldn't insult me by even calling this a deception. Right, Second Lord?"

As the Lordship of Calderic was determined only by the appointment of the Overlord, there was no such thing as succession by blood.

Just as the people in Santea believed in the sacred blood of the royal family and take their rule as something absolute, in Calderic, the Lords' rule was also absolute. Like a supreme being that no one dared to go against. That was why this system could be maintained.

Still, some of the Lords formed huge families by blood or tribe, and the Thunder Lord's Cerionne family was like that too.

As she came from the most ancient family in Calderic, she had a higher sense of self-esteem and authority than anyone else.

If I, the same Lord, risked my name and honor in this way, she would take it as a promise I could never break.

Of course, I had no intention of keeping that promise if things went wrong later.

“...Good. I believe you.”

The Thunder Lord replied with a reluctant expression.

“Then let’s end the conversation here.”

I said, compromising.

“I feel like I should tell you I did not intend to annihilate your spirit. That last attack of yours was a powerful blow that could otherwise have killed me.”

I didn’t know if my relationship with her would be restored. Nevertheless, I still wanted to lead her in a good direction.

“...I’m leaving.”

She turned around with a complex face that seemed to be a mixture of dejection and other emotions.

I thought as I looked at that weak gait, as if she had lost strength.

Where can I use her?

Even though she lost some strength, she was still a big player who could be of great help.

Now that I could ask for her help when I needed it, I had to think about it a bit...

...Ah.

Then a thought popped into my mind.

Wyvern.

As they are a rare sub-dragon species, there were only a few places where they lived on the continent, and one of them was the Glide Mountains, located far west of Calderic.

If one travelled normally, it would take a long time to arrive, but if they travelled by riding a wyvern?

“Second Lord.”

I called her.

She stopped and looked back as if she was asking, ‘what else do you need?’.

“Did you ride a wyvern to get here?”

“...Yes, why?”

“How long does it take to ride a wyvern to the Glide Mountains from here?”

She looked at me with her eyes showing confusion as to why I was asking something like this out of the blue and then she replied.

“It should arrive in at least five days. Why are you asking that suddenly?”

I nodded.

“Let’s go right now.”

“...I beg your pardon?”

She blinked.

The time left until the conference was about a month.

I had enough time to do some things before that.

Chapter 74.1: Wyvern (1)

Chapter 74.1: Wyvern (1)

“Wait a minute.”

The Thunder Lord said with an absurd face.

“Are you asking me to take you, Seventh Lord, to the Glide Mountains with my wyvern?”

“Yes.”

“Why should I...!”

She tried to protest, but soon shut up again.

It must be because it reminded her of what we just talked about. I told her I would give her information about a powerful spirit if she came to my aid.

“If I take you there... you mean you’ll tell me the location of the spirit?”

After a moment of silence, she asked in a voice that couldn’t hide her anticipation.

I shook my head.

“Of course not. Do you think that this amount of help is worth the weight of that information?”

I didn’t intend to use the opportunity to borrow the other’s power by asking her to take me to Glide Mountains with her wyvern.

I was thinking of accepting as many of these small help as possible until I had to ask for her help for something big.

As long as I was using this information as bait, she wouldn't be able to refuse my trivial request anyway.

“...Is this your strategy? Are you going to keep using me like this until one day you ask me to do something big for you?”

“...”

It seemed that she finally caught on. A Lord was still a Lord after all.

But even if she noticed that, it didn't really change anything.

I gave a sly expression to the Thunder Lord, who was looking at me with an astonished look.

“So, are you going to refuse?”

The Thunder Lord let out a deep sigh as she closed her eyes, as if trying to regain her composure.

“Why do you want to go there out of nowhere?”

“I'm going to catch a wyvern.”

“Why do I have to take you there?”

“Because it's faster that way.”

Originally, I planned to go to the Glide Mountains after attending the conference. Because there's not enough time to do that now.

But if I could go there faster with the help of the Second Lord, there was no reason not to go right away.

I thought I would rest well until the conference, but honestly, after taking a few days off, I was already feeling like I was wasting time.

Was it because of all the life-or-death situations that I experienced? Or was it because I was diligently searching for mysteries until recently?

I had never been this kind of a diligent person before.

“Anyway, I’m planning to leave right now, so get ready, Second Lord.”

There were a lot of things to do, but if one wanted to survive, they had to move without a break.

This was the end of the leisure I had briefly enjoyed over the past few days.

“Are you talking about the Glide Mountains..?”

“It’s where the wyverns live.”

While I was talking with the Thunder Lord, Asher was looking after Reef and Rigon. Now she looked a little embarrassed.

It was because of my words that I would suddenly head to the wyverns’ habitat.

“Wow...”

Rigon, who was sitting on one side as if he was meditating, was looking this way with his eyes sparkling.

Looking at the reaction, the word ‘wyvern’ probably attracted his attention. But, of course, I couldn’t take him.

I ordered the butler to quickly get ready and then I went outside.

I saw the Thunder Lord and a knight wearing a blue armor in the clearing located inside the castle.

And two gigantic creatures, wyverns, standing next to each other.

I tilted my head at the sight.

Did an escort knight accompany her?

【Lv. 83】

The level was also a whopping 2 levels higher than Asher. In addition, he also had a wyvern of his own.

The Thunder Lord's family was such a huge family that it wasn't surprising, but...

Anyway, those wyverns are much bigger than I thought.

【Lv. 67】

【Lv. 62】

Seeing it up close, the size of the wyvern felt much larger. And the levels were just as great.

The one with a higher level was the Thunder Lord's wyvern.

After seeing me, it was frowning from afar.

Grr.

Then her wyvern also showed hostility to me and let out a low cry.

Did it even understand its master's emotions and recognize me as its enemy? Smart.

The Thunder Lord stroked her wyvern down the neck, calming it.

She said, "I don't see why I should do this."

While she was waiting, thinking about it, her voice became fiercer as if more anger had risen.

I was using a Lord like a courier, so she had the right to be angry.

“Can the wyverns carry two people each?” I asked.

Originally, I hadn’t intended to take Asher with me, but since there were two wyverns, it didn’t seem to matter.

However, the expression of the Thunder Lord hardened.

“…Two people each? Are you saying my wyvern is going to carry another person as well?”

“Can’t you see?”

I pointed to Asher, who had followed me to see me off.

The Thunder Lord looked at Asher and frowned at her.

The Thunder Lord’s escort knight stepped forward and bowed his head to me.

“Seventh Lord, you and your escort knight can both ride on my wyvern.”

I looked at his wyvern.

It’s big enough that three people could ride together, but… wasn’t it better if there’s only two riding it?

When I looked at the Thunder Lord again, her expression had gone from complete disgust to relief.

Did she hate letting other people ride on her wyvern, or did she just hate riding with others?

If it was her, it was most likely the latter.

“Do you have any saddles for three in the castle? If so, please.”

“Oh, please wait a minute.”

In response to the escort knight's question, the butler standing next to him tried to move.

I stopped him.

“It's fine. I'll just go by myself.”

Asher didn't really have to accompany me.

I told Asher.

“I'll be back in a fortnight, so in the meantime, wait while teaching the siblings.”

“Yes, I understand.”

Chapter 74.2: Wyvern (1)

Chapter 74.2: Wyvern (1)

The escort knight's saddle was originally designed for two people, so there was no need to change her saddle.

She probably rode in a two-man saddle, in case she had to carry guests, as she did now.

“Shhh, it's alright.”

As I approached, the escort knight calmed down the wyvern, who was openly showing its dislike for me, by patting its neck.

This was the reason it was impossible to breed wyverns like livestock.

It was so strong and ferocious that it was very difficult to capture it. A wyvern would also never follow anyone that it did not recognize it as its owner.

Until now, many people tried to tame the wyvern, but the reason they failed from the start was the same.

Because if they were captured and locked up, they wouldn't eat until they died of starvation, or they would just simply turn to suicide by harming themselves.

That's why it's impossible to ride another wyvern unless you ride with the owner.

The escort knight who had calmed down the wyvern jumped onto its back first.

Seeing that, I hesitated for a moment, then used space leap to get on the back of the wyvern.

Because I suddenly appeared behind her, she jumped and put her hand on the hilt of her sword. Then, after realizing that it was just me, she was stunned again and then lowered her hand.

“...Apologies, Seventh Lord!”

“No. I was the one who startled you.”

Teleportation was not a common ability in this world, so it was natural to react that way.

Anyway, that’s roughly how things were prepared.

“Have a safe trip.”

Asher greeted me from below.

I nodded and looked away.

Flutter!

The Thunder Lord’s wyvern flapped its wings first and flew up. There was a gust of wind all around.

I watched it and grabbed the handle on the front of the saddle.

Soon the wyvern I was riding also flew up into the sky following the Thunder Lord’s wyvern.

As soon as it flew in the air, it sped up in an instant, and the wyverns flew at terrifying speed.

The castle below looked like a dot as it receded in the blink of an eye.

Hmmm.

Enjoying the feeling of riding for the first time in a while, I put more strength into the handle I was holding. Because it felt like I would be thrown off if I wasn't careful.

I was told that it would take five days to get to our destination. That actually starting to worry me.

If one saw it in an animation or a movie, didn't people ride wyverns and griffons comfortably?

In reality, fiction was just fiction.

With the wind blowing nonstop from the front, the balance rattled precariously with every flap of its wings.

Riding a flying beast was really incomparable to a horse or a carriage.

The escort knight should consider it fortunate that this body I possessed had a constitution that hardly suffered from motion sickness. Or I would have vomited on her back long ago.

If I want to have a wyvern, flying at this speed was something I had to adapt to, anyway.

I tried to enjoy the current flight with that mind-set.

I didn't really enjoy it, but fortunately, I quickly got used to it to some extent.

Although the ride still did not feel comfortable, at least the scenery was excellent.

Oh...

I admired the verdant mountain peaks below.

I wanted to check where we were passing while looking at a map, but unfortunately I couldn't because my hands were both full.

The wyverns flew at a constant speed without a break for half a day, as if they didn't feel tired.

After moving for a long time, it was only when the sun slowly set that the wyverns came down to the ground.

"How far have we come?"

"About this."

The escort knight answered by pointing to a place on the map.

I nodded and put the map back.

We reached a distance that would have taken more than a week by carriage in just half a day.

It must have been because there were no restrictions on the terrain since it was flying, but it was really an incredible speed.

The escort knight prepared dinner.

She took out the utensils from the bag attached to the wyvern's back and started preparing the meal.

There was no one else to do this job, so of course, she could only do it herself. But when I thought about it, it was a little dumbfounding.

Because she was a level 83.

Was she not a knight?

Leaning on the side of the wyvern on one side, the Thunder Lord opened her mouth.

"Viola..."

Then, when she looked at me, she shut her mouth again.

Rising from her seat, she sneaked up to the escort knight and whispered. But because of my super sensory, I heard it all.

“What are you going to do for dinner?”

“It’s a cheese stew.”

“I’m tired of stew. Grill the meat.”

“All right.”

Then, as if nothing had happened, she returned to her seat and sat down.

I couldn’t help but laugh inwardly.

Judging from the informal way of talking, what they had was not just an ordinary master-servant relationship.

Until the Thunder Lord became a Lord, she must have been a precious lady within the family.

Conscious of my gaze, the Thunder Lord said bluntly.

“What do you keep staring at?”

“Nothing.”

I shook my head.

In an instant, the escort knight set up a mold to grill the meat, took out the smoked meat, and started roasting it over the fire once more.

Soon, the meat was grilled to taste, and the meal began in a quiet atmosphere.

Near the end of the meal, the Thunder Lord opened her mouth and asked.

“You said you’re planning to tame a wyvern.”

“Yes.”

“Seventh Lord, you have to go to the conference in a while. Can you tame one before that?”

She said in a slightly proud voice.

I know why she said that.

Looking around for wyverns and hoping that even one would choose me as its master, luck was not the only thing needed.

***Correction:** Thunder Lord’s escort knight is actually a girl. I only realized it when she called her ‘Viola’. (◡_◡;)

Chapter 75.1: Wyvern (2)

Chapter 75.1: Wyvern (2)

“It’s none of your business.”

Hearing my words, the Thunder Lord snorted lightly and said nothing more.

Wyvern.

I was well aware of this guy’s difficult nature from the beginning because it was the same in the game as well.

Even when playing the game, the quest to get the wyvern was notorious enough to break some users’ keyboards.

It wasn’t even a hidden or a special quest; it was just a quest that had to be cleared in order to get a ride through the story.

When I was crazy about RaSa and played all day except for sleeping time, I barely got it by staying up all night for three days.

I didn’t hesitate to look for one when the opportunity came. Not only because it was a pity to be idle for the remaining time, but because there was one more important reason.

A wyvern that I had acquired in the game.

The guy that came to my mind the moment I thought of having my wyvern, the one I gave a catchy name to – ‘Ti-Yong’.

The place where it lived was, unfortunately, the Glide Mountains, our current destination.

Even if I visit that mountain at this point, I wonder if its nest is still in the same place?

I couldn't help but be curious.

Would it still exist like other named NPCs and monsters even now when the game became a reality, and if it encountered me, would it recognize me as its owner?

Still, if I were to get a wyvern, I wanted to get the one I was with in the game.

"I'll ask you one thing, Seventh Lords"

Then, after a while the Thunder Lord spoke again.

"What is your true intention behind killing the Sixth Lord?"

With my eyes on the burning bonfire, I turned my head to her.

"I already answered that question in front of everyone at the emergency call."

"Are you talking about that nonsense? Some crappy excuse about it being the best course of action or something?"

I shrugged my shoulders without answering.

"Ha," she said with a laugh.

"The Overlord can tell the truth from lies in words. That's why she decided to watch you a little longer, but I never trusted you."

Why was this woman always making things awkward?

I asked her back.

"You've been showing dislike for me ever since we first met. Is there any other special reason for your attitude?"

“...Isn’t that obvious? To put an outsider of unknown ability or identity on the seat of a Lord with no hesitation, even if it’s the Overlord’s decision, there’s no way I can just accept it without hesitation.”

“...”

“In the end, you killed even the Sixth Lord and caused great chaos in the order. So I still don’t think my actions were wrong. Even though I lost Laxia because of your unknown bizarre abilities...”

While talking, she took a deep breath and continued talking.

“I don’t know about the other Lords, but I sincerely want Calderic’s stability. Of course, it was a mistake to go to you today and rant and argue with you like that. But aside from my personal hatred, your existence is an unstable factor.”

Speaking in a dry voice, the Thunder Lord definitely seemed to have found a sense of calm unlike in the castle earlier.

I knew what she was trying to say to some extent.

Aside from her attitude problem, even in the game, she appeared as a person who sincerely wished for Calderic’s peace.

In fact, if one thought about it, the Overlord and other Lords were the ones who defied common sense. One couldn’t really say that it was all the Thunder Lord’s problem.

But then again, if they were more ordinary, could they have become a Lord in the first place?

“As I said, I have no plans.”

The Thunder Lord responded right away.

“And I still don’t trust you.”

The brief conversation ended there, and there was no further exchange of words.

The day was bright, and we continued to move.

It took just under five days to reach the Glide Mountains, exactly as the Thunder Lord had said.

Oh.

The Glide Mountains were a unique landscape compared to other mountain ranges I had seen while passing by.

In particular, it was because there were many peaks that rose more minutely than other mountain ranges.

It took a while to leisurely observe the scenery, and I soon looked around eagerly.

Now that we've reached our destination, I needed to find out where its nest was.

Wyvern was said to be a creature that did not live in a group and preferred being alone.

Their dwelling place was called a nest, but it was usually a cave-like place.

I remember that Ti-Yong's nest, which I needed to find now, was also a fairly large cave... It must have been in the middle of the rock wall.

Kiaag!

Then, along with a scream that came out of nowhere, something quickly approached from below.

A huge white wyvern was flying towards us, flapping its wings.

Oh.

It was the first wyvern we encountered, but unfortunately it seemed that it was trying to attack us.

The Thunder Lord's wyvern and the escort knight's wyvern also let out a roar.

As if it was going to head-butt, the escort knight raised her magic power and swung her arm at the guy who rushed towards her.

Whoa!

Then, the wide wave of magic raged like a storm and hit the wyvern hard.

It lost its balance and staggered in the air for a moment, then turned and hurriedly ran away.

Ha.

I looked at the rapid change of attitude with a little absurdity.

Wyverns were basically ferocious and tyrannical, but they were also brilliant.

As soon as an attack hit it, it judged that the opponent was too strong and quickly retreated.

There was a brief interlude with that wyvern, but I continued to look at the vast mountain range and figured out the direction to go.

Fortunately, I remembered exactly where the guy's nest was located.

This was because it was in a very conspicuous and heterogeneous terrain, that was noticeable especially in these mountains.

An incredibly large, flat rock wall.

Chapter 75.2: Wyvern (2)

Chapter 75.2: Wyvern (2)

Such a rock formation that looked like a tree stump existed in this mountain range.

And the place where the nest was located was right nearby.

One could probably spot it at a glance from afar if they flew like this from above.

I asked the escort knight just in case.

“Do you know a huge rock wall that looks like a tree stump?”

She shook her head.

“I’m sorry, but I’m not sure.”

Well, then there’s nothing that could be done about it.

I said again.

“Let’s look around the mountain range until we find the terrain I just described.”

“All right.”

That’s how another search started, just like when I was looking for the mysteries.

Although the difference was that this time it would be much faster and more comfortable.

Even while looking for a nest, various wyverns occasionally showed up.

Most of them didn't pay attention to us and went their own way, but some attacked like the white wyvern earlier. As for those guys, the escort knight kicked them all away.

In the game, they classified wyverns into five types according to the color of their scales.

Green, Blue, Red, White, and Black Wyverns.

Not only were they different in color, but they had distinctly different characteristics.

Although it was different depending on the individual, on average, from green to black, it was much larger, stronger, and had a dirty temper. It was also rare.

So even in the game, Black had the best ability among Wyverns, but the difficulty of finding and taming one was also the highest.

Ti-Yong, which I rode in the game, was also a black wyvern.

The difference in stats according to color wasn't so significant in the game, but I really wanted to ride the best wyvern, so I was working really hard to catch it.

“...Seventh Lord! You said you were going to catch a wyvern?”

As we continued to fly without intending to land, the Thunder Lord flying next to us shouted,

“You said there's a place you're looking for?”

Before I could open my mouth, the escort knight answered her instead.

The Thunder Lord glanced at me with disgruntled eyes and asked no more.

“It seems to be the place you told us about.”

Anyway, within a few hours of starting our search, we finally found the place.

A huge rock wall located alone in the middle of large and small mountain peaks and not in harmony with the surroundings.

Flying slowly along the rim, I scoured the rock wall with my super sensory maximizing my vision.

...*Found.*

And soon I found it.

A large cave located exactly in the middle of the rock wall.

“Go down there.”

As per my request, the escort knight landed at the entrance of the cave.

The Thunder Lord that landed after her also looked around the cave with puzzled eyes.

“...Is this the place you’re talking about? What on earth did you come to a place like this for?”

I didn’t answer, and I moved to the inside of the cave with anticipation.

It was because there was a presence felt from the inside.

The passage leading to it was short, and soon what appeared in sight was a large black creature lying crouched in the dark.

“...It’s a Black Wyvern.”

The Thunder Lord and the escort knight also looked a bit surprised when they found the wyvern.

Kreureung.

I stared at the sleeping wyvern snoring in the cave.

...Is this Ti-Yong?

What, maybe, right?

To be honest, there was no way to tell them apart by appearance.

Because in the game, each wyvern's appearance was not that different from each other.

But even so, if it was a Black Wyvern building a nest in this cave, there would be none other than the one I had in the game.

“...”

After feeling that strange feeling for a while and just staring at it, the snoring stopped, and it opened its eyes.

Then it yawned, and it stared at me with long, slit pupils.

I trudged towards the black wyvern.

I heard a slightly mocking voice from behind.

“Did you know that there are only a handful of people on the continent who have tamed a black wyvern?”

The guy just kept staring at me as I slowly approached, then it raised its huge body.

If it didn't acknowledge me as its owner, it would attack right away, so I prepared to defend myself.

The distance between me and the wyvern was less than ten steps. And...

Purr.

“...?”

It let out a mild cry and thrust its head at me first.

While embarrassed, I stroked the guy who was forcibly trying to bury its huge head in my arms.

Why is this...?

It seemed that I was recognized as the owner right away.

But as far as I knew, this wyvern didn't come to me so favorably at the beginning? Was this still the same dirty-tempered Black Wyvern?

“Uh...”

The Thunder Lord, who was watching the scene from behind, let out a bewildered exclamation mixed with amazement.

Looking at the guy who showed a very favorable attitude to me, I was sure for some reason.

This guy was definitely the wyvern, Ti-Yong, that I used to ride in the game.

Nice to see you again.

I said hello inwardly, feeling pleased.

I was stroking the neck of the guy who kept poking its head at me.

With this, the wyvern was successfully obtained.

Bonus chapter! ^^

Chapter 76.1: Wyvern (3)

Chapter 76.1: Wyvern (3)

As I stepped out of the cave, Tiyong followed me in a very natural manner.

It seemed to be in a good mood, scratching the wall of the aisle with its wings and trying to hit me, so it was a little burdensome.

It had been less than 10 minutes since we met, but anyone who saw us would think it had been 10 years.

“...It’s really different.”

The Thunder Lord, who had been looking at me with eyes that seemed difficult to understand, spoke.

“Could that also be an ability of the Seventh Lord? Controlling and understanding the minds of monsters?”

I was dumbfounded and replied.

“You think there’s an ability like that?”

“Isn’t it abnormal for a wyvern to follow people like this from the beginning?”

Well... she had a point.

I didn’t know why this guy followed me so well.

Could it be that it really acknowledged me as its owner because I was with it in the game?

That's good if it was so, but it's also kind of worrying.

“Maybe it's not you, but it's just that this wyvern follows everyone well...”

After saying that, she quietly approached Ti-Yong.

Then, the growling guy suddenly turned into a ferocious force and burst into a roar.

Kiaag!

She frowned and stepped back.

I, who was right next to her, also suffered a blow to the eardrum, so I tapped its neck. This kid could still roar like there's no tomorrow.

【Lv. 70】

Ti-Yong's level was a whopping 70, higher than the wyverns of the Thunder Lord and the escort knight, and all the wyverns we encountered along the way.

In the game, because of system limitations, it could only be used for riding and flying, but here it could be used for combat.

At level 70, even if it's not a very strong power, it's a level where it could slaughter even a fairly strong combat unit alone.

The wyvern's scales also had a high resistance to magic.

We quickly came out of the cave.

The Thunder Lord and the escort knight's wyverns, who were standing on the cliff and waiting for their master to come out, let out low cries as if they were wary of Ti-Yong.

In terms of body size, the Black Wyvern, Tiyong, was noticeably bigger than the others.

Despite their hostility, Ti-Yong let out a short breath and ignored them. Did it just snort?

“Anyway, this should be the end of our business, right?”

The Thunder Lord looked back at me and asked.

I nodded.

Since I got the wyvern I was aiming for right away, there was no reason to stay in this mountain range any longer, as well as to stay with these two.

“Let’s separate right here.”

“It’s really nice to hear that.”

Then the escort knight opened her mouth.

“If you need a saddle, I’ll give you mine.”

I admired her inwardly.

It would be uncomfortable without a saddle, so I was wondering how I would ride back to the territory, but the other surprisingly offered a solution first.

“Can I?”

“Yes.”

I felt a little sorry, but since this person was an expert, she would probably be less uncomfortable than me riding without a saddle.

I didn’t bother to refuse and willingly accepted her kindness.

Although, of course, the Thunder Lord, listening to our conversation, looked at her and at me with disapproval.

Kreureung!

The wyverns spat out harsh cries.

I turned my gaze to find that Ti-Yong, who had quietly approached the Thunder Lord's wyvern, was arguing with the other.

“That little creature...”

The Thunder Lord's face erupted into a mixture of bewilderment and anger.

Startled by this, Ti-Yong hurriedly ran behind me and hid.

I was dumbfounded too, so I looked at the guy.

What are you doing?

Was this guy originally like this?

In many ways, it seemed very far from the usual wyverns.

Anyway, after receiving the saddle from the escort knight, she put it on Ti-Yong.

Of course, I didn't know how to do it, so she had to do it for me.

“Stay still, Ti-Yong.”

Ti-Yong tried to struggle, perhaps because the saddle was uncomfortable or because it didn't want to be touched by others, but the wyvern soon calmed down when I petted it.

Maybe because it was smarter than ordinary wyverns, communication seemed to be somewhat easier.

“...Ti-Yong? Have you already given it a name? It sounds unusual.”

At the sudden words of the Thunder Lord, I couldn't hold back my laughter for a moment and almost exploded.

The reason it might sound unusual to her was because it's Korean, not the continental language. But it was a bit funny to hear someone say the name so calmly.

Anyway, after putting on the saddle, I climbed on Ti-Yong's back.

It flapped its wings and prepared to take off at any moment.

Finally, I looked back and said.

"See you at the next meeting, Second Lord."

"...That's right. Don't ever think of using me for useless things like this again."

I also said to the escort knight.

"Thank you for the saddle. I'll keep it in the castle and return it later."

"Yes. Then, take care on your way, Seventh Lord."

Flutter!

The two of them flew up first. I tapped Ti-Yong on the neck as I watched them quickly move away across the sky.

"Let's go too. That way."

Ti-Yong flew up with a mighty roar, flapping its wings in the direction I pointed.

Chapter 76.2: Wyvern (3)

Chapter 76.2: Wyvern (3)

I went back the way I came and headed for the Seventh Lord's territory.

Since Ti-Yong would continue to be with me, I observed it closely to learn more about it while we were travelling.

Kreureung!

Among the things I observed, if there was one thing that impressed me the most, it was its incredible appetite.

I stared at the figure of Ti-Yong, who had caught several huge wolves from somewhere and was gnawing at them through the bones.

The other prepared its own meal by hunting while I was eating, just like how the Thunder Lord and the escort knight's wyverns did.

However, the amount of meat it ate in one meal was so huge, it was most likely a third of its body size.

I remember that the Thunder Lord and escort knight's wyverns didn't eat this much.

In any case, the only behavior I could accurately observe was its eating habits.

It's because Ti-Yong followed me so well with no sign of dislike for anything I did.

And I also found out one more thing...

Could it understand what I'm saying?

I could communicate so well with it even without making gestures.

So I thought of the possibility that it might understand what I was saying.

Otherwise, there's no way communication would be this easy with a guy who wasn't even trained to listen to other's orders.

While taking a break after eating, I made eye contact with the crouching guy and said,

“Stand up.”

Then the other jumped up.

“Sit down.”

It crouched back down.

“Roll.”

Kreung?

This time, it seemed to be a little flustered, then it shrank its wings and rolled on the floor.

I admired inwardly and stroked him.

He really understands everything.

I wondered how this was possible, but since it was a fantasy world in the first place, there was nothing to be surprised about.

I continued petting the other.

Anyway, since it listened carefully to my instructions, I didn't think there would be any problems in the future.

Time passed, and we arrived at the castle.

After crossing the wall, I looked for a place to land while watching the knights flocking below.

Ah, did they misunderstand it as an attack?

Seeing the knights pulling out their swords, I slowed down my landing.

It was the first time the knights of the castle had seen my wyvern.

As the distance got closer, I shouted to see if anyone had recognized me and stopped whatever they were doing.

“Sorry, Lord! We mistook you for an enemy trying to attack!”

“It’s okay, let’s take care of things.”

After getting off the wyvern, I made the knights disperse.

After waiting for a while, the butler came out.

“Are you home, my lord?”

The butler’s slightly surprised gaze reached Ti-Yong.

I pointed at the wyvern and asked.

“Is there a place in the castle for this guy?”

“Yes, of course there is. I’ll see to it right away.”

The place we walked to, along with the butler, was a cage surrounded by a huge iron fence and roof on one side of the castle.

It was very wide, so it was almost like an empty lot.

When I went inside, Ti-Yong immediately followed.

As soon as it entered, it looked around the surrounding, as if it had noticed that this was the space it would stay in.

“I will immediately prepare exclusive servants to manage the wyvern.”

After saying that, the butler immediately brought in a few people.

Ti-Yong growled as more strangers approached it. The servants flinched and retreated.

“Stay still.”

I calmed it down and added calmly.

“These people are the ones who will help you adapt to this place in the future. Never attack or show hostility. Do you understand?”

Greureung.

As if it understood, it immediately became docile again.

After leaving Ti-Yong with the servants, I went into the building.

Where is Asher?

It's not strange that the other wasn't there when I arrived. But I thought she would still immediately appear before me right after.

Entering the hall of the castle with a curious mind, I suddenly faintly felt the magical energy that was rushing downstairs.

“...?”

Was this Asher's magic?

It was something I felt every day, so I was able to notice it at once.

I went straight down to the gymnasium located downstairs.

And soon as I did, I was able to find Reef and Rigon. Asher was standing in front of them with her eyes closed.

She even used her racial traits to dye her entire body white, and a faint pure white magic haze swirled around her like a flame.

As I wondered what the situation was, the siblings spotted me, and their eyes opened wide.

“What’s going on?”

Reef answered my question in a bewildered voice.

“I don’t know. Sir Asher was teaching Rigon, and she suddenly stopped, closed her eyes and...”

Rigon, who was holding his sword while breathing hard, also looked bewildered.

I looked at Asher, who was still standing motionless, and a small exclamation escaped my mouth.

Oh, no way...

Did you reach some kind of enlightenment?

Listening to what Reef said, I wondered if something like a sudden enlightenment came to her while sparring with Rigon.

Seeing her calm face, it didn’t look like there was anything wrong with her body, so I stood still and watched.

Swoop.

Soon, the raging magic was captured in her body in an instant, and I was able to witness an amazing sight.

【Lv. 82】

- ..The level floating above Asher's head had risen.

Returning to her normal state, Asher slowly opened her eyes and put on an expression that seemed to be a mix between satisfaction and regret.

She was startled when she found me standing to one side.

“Sir Ron, since when...”

I couldn't find anything to say, so I just nodded my head and spoke softly.

“You've grown even more.”

Asher, who was taken aback by that, smiled awkwardly.

But really, what kind of sudden level up was this?

Chapter 77.1: Shadow Freon (1)

Chapter 77.1: Shadow Freon (1)

After the situation was settled, Asher explained to me what had happened.

“While giving Rigon swordsmanship instruction, a sudden enlightenment came.”

Enlightenment came during swordsmanship instruction?

Hearing the details made me even more amazed.

While doing free sparring, Rigon instantly learned the magic exercises and swordsmanship she had just taught him.

She said that a sudden enlightenment came while watching Rigon following her instructions and applying what she saw in her own way.

People said that one could also gain something by teaching others, but I never thought that Asher would actually level up while teaching Rigon.

I didn't know.

However, it wasn't only Asher who grew up.

When I finally checked Rigon's level, I doubted my eyes for a moment.

【Lv. 21】

21 levels.

It's not level 11, it's level 21.

Wasn't he only level 3 before he left?

Gulpiro said that Rigon was like a blank slate with nothing accumulated because his broken magic power was barely restored.

But in less than 15 days, he had grown to a whopping 20 levels.

At the abnormal growth rate that transcended imagination, I spit out astonishment one beat later.

What is this really...

Wasn't that a completely insane talent?

Was it because of this level of genius that Asher, the teacher, could also reach enlightenment?

"Congratulations on that achievement, Sir Asher."

Reef said awkwardly.

I was thinking about what I should say, but Reef had already beaten me to it.

"Thanks."

Asher smiled lightly and looked at Rigon.

"Thank you very much. Thanks to you, the wall that has blocked me for a long time seems to have been broken down a little."

"Ah, yes. I am very glad to have been of help to you."

Rigon said with a bright smile before adding;

"Well, if you don't mind, could we continue the sparring?"

"Huh? Ah... I see."

Asher nodded and raised her sword again.

Rigon's expression changed to serious in an instant, and he took a stance.

I watched the scene with interest.

Although it was a sparring whose purpose was to teach, not to win, I was curious about Rigon's swordsmanship, which brought enlightenment to Asher.

Dig!

Rigon stamped his foot, and the blade quickly aimed at Asher's neck.

The level difference was so far away that it wouldn't be dangerous, but it's a real sword sparring, so there's no hesitation at all in aiming for vital points.

Did Asher tell him to do that?

Asher lightly deflected the sword strike with a calm face.

And the subsequent attacks were all blocked in place, swinging the sword here and there. A very fast-tempo battle ensued.

From the top to the bottom, Rigon swung his sword, aiming at all areas in various ways. He sometimes held his sword in reverse, his body flexibly bent, and then launched a surprise attack from an odd angle.

“....”

What should I say about that?

I knew nothing about swords, but as I kept watching, there was a distinct feeling that Rigon's swordsmanship was very natural.

It's very free.

His swordsmanship had a big frame, but had no system within it.

But it felt much closer to unfettered freedom than to crudeness.

And it wasn't just the sword that was visible to the naked eye that made me feel that way.

The flow of magical power felt in Rigon's body was also freely flowing within him.

When Asher was fighting, she didn't use her magic like that.

...Ha.

【Lv. 22】

Rather, the level rose again during the battle. Rigon was getting stronger by fighting.

Rigon swung his sword faster and faster with a face soaring with exaltation.

Caang!

Asher, who continued to receive attacks and occasionally fired appropriate counterattacks at some point, pushed Rigon's sword down and pressed it to the floor.

“Ah...”

Rigon smiled awkwardly with an expression of embarrassment.

Asher also looked at me with a little tired eyes and said.

“As the battle intensifies, his sword swing became closer to instinct.”

“Ah, I'm sorry. When I get excited, I keep losing my control...”

“It doesn't mean that it's bad. What I meant was for you to refine and control that instinct more elaborately. So, Rigon, you...”

Asher gave Rigon advice by pointing out various points about the sparring they had just had. Rigon nodded and listened.

“Then let’s finish here for today.”

“Yes, thank you for your hard work!”

“Thank you for your hard work, Sir.”

Rigon responded loudly, and Reef politely bowed her head.

The two siblings went out first, and Asher and I were left alone at the gym for a while.

I looked at the back of the two as they left and asked.

“You seem to teach them well, though.”

“Ah, yes... It’s not that I’m a good teacher, it’s that both of them are great students.”

“Especially Rigon.”

Asher nodded her head in complete agreement with me.

“His innate talent is really outstanding. If there is such a thing as a genius, I wonder if it would be like that.”

Was it that overrated?

I asked playfully.

“Asher, how does he compare to you?”

“Yes? Of course, he’s much better than me.”

Asher said, without the slightest hesitation.

Well, she’s not the type to take pride in things like this.

The conversation was cut off and there was silence for a while, then Asher exclaimed, as if she had just remembered it.

“I’m sorry. You came back, but I couldn’t go out to meet you...”

“It’s fine.”

“Did you get a wyvern?”

I nodded.

“Would you like to go look?”

Then I led Asher to where Ti-Yong was.

Chapter 77.2: Shadow Freon (1)

Chapter 77.2: Shadow Freon (1)

About a week had passed since I returned to the territory.

While here, I observed Asher's swordsmanship training, played with Ti-Yong, learned about the situation in neutral countries, and held meetings.

I waited for the date of the conference to come.

"A knight test?"

I turned my eyes from the book I was reading and looked at the butler.

"Yes. It is a test to select new apprentice knights and also to select those who will be promoted to official knights among the existing apprentice knights."

"I see. But why are you informing me about this?"

"It's nothing important. I just wanted to know if the siblings, Reef and Rigon, would also want to take part in the test..."

Oh, was it about that?

The head butler must have seen that I was paying close attention to the siblings.

I closed the book and pondered for a while.

A test.

If it's a knighthood, I could give it to the two of them at any time.

However, if there was a formal rite like an exam, it wouldn't be bad to have them go through that.

Because Reef was good enough to become an official knight right now.

And I'm also a little curious.

Although I continued to live in the castle, I had never been interested in the knights.

I decided to put Reef in the test to see what the test was like.

"I will take part!"

When I called her and asked if she wanted to take part in the test, she answered immediately, as expected. As if she didn't have any worry.

Rigon next to her made a sad face.

With Rigon's level, he could become an apprentice knight, but he was still a little short of becoming an official knight.

Of course, with his current growth rate, he would reach that level in an instant after a little more time.

A few days passed like that, and the day of the knight's test approached.

"It's an honor for us to have the Lord watch the test!"

The leader of the Iron Blood Knights gave a salute with a face that looked really thrilled. Was his name Akin?

A huge number of knights gathered in an orderly manner in a huge outdoor arena.

Currently, Asher and I were sitting on chairs on the side of the arena, looking down at the scene.

I saw Reef armed and mixing among the knights.

“The Lord himself stepped here to observe the duel of the knights! So do your best...”

After the short speech of the knight commander, the test began immediately, without delay.

First, it was the test of apprentice knights who were trying to be promoted to official knights. Most of the knights were level 30.

The format of the test was a duel with the Iron Blood Knights, the elite knights of the territory, and if they endured for a certain amount of time, they would pass.

Even though the time was only three minutes, more than half of the knights could not stand it and dropped off.

Hmm...

I watched the scene with slightly bored eyes.

It didn't really leave much of an impression.

I didn't know what I was expecting when I came to watch the test, but seeing it myself, it wasn't as much fun as I thought.

It wasn't long before Reef's turn came.

Her opponent, a knight of the order, was an elf knight with a level in the mid-50s, but he wielded a spear, not a sword.

Wedge!

As soon as the duel started, Reef turned her head to avoid the spear blade aiming at her face.

She tried to narrow the distance by narrowly dodging and blocking the one-sided attack by using the difference in reach.

As seen in Actipol's match, she made a bold move that seemed to not care about her life at all. The knight who attacked her was also a little surprised.

Caang! Kakakang!

Of course, the difference in skills between the two was so great that the distance never narrowed.

Reef was in a hurry to defend against the increasingly fierce attack, and the three minutes ended.

Even though the battle was much fiercer than the other knights, there was regret on Reef's face as she withdrew her sword.

After the duel, the member who was the opponent burst into laughter and said,

"If I was careless, I thought I would be beaten, so I raised my force a little more. It's a great achievement at such a young age. You should take pride in such a result."

Wow!

A short cheer erupted from the knights standing around after hearing the unprecedented praise.

I smiled and looked at her, who was at a loss because of the praise.

It was then.

"...?"

I abruptly averted my gaze.

On one side of the arena, away from the knights, was the area where the administrators were recording the results of the test.

【Lv. 67】

Among them, one administrator had a very abnormal level.

I narrowed my eyes and fixed my gaze on the brown-haired woman.

...*What is that?*

It was a distinctly foreign sight.

That's because the administrator was at a level close to 70.

"Butler."

"Yes, Lord."

"Who is that woman over there?"

The butler, who was standing next to me, looked at where my gaze was directed and answered.

"She is the new Administrator named Kate, who was newly appointed a few months ago."

...How many months ago?

The conclusion came naturally. It was a spy.

If she was hiding her skills, I could only think of such a case.

Even so, if it was a level 67 spy, from which faction...

"...!"

Soon, I opened my eyes wide.

Level 67 brown haired woman, spy.

This was because the character matching this keyword popped up in my mind.

Crazy, I can't believe that...

I shook my head amid astonishment and absurdity.

How should I check it? Should I call her quietly?

However, if that administrator was really her, I wondered if she would immediately run away if I tried to call her out.

Wait a minute, think...

Ah.

I must have been staring at her too closely, because as she was scribbling on a piece of paper, she suddenly turned in my direction as if she felt my gaze.

She hastily lowered her head.

I kept staring at her.

As I continued doing that, the cheering atmosphere in the arena slowly disappeared and the knights turned their heads one by one to the place where my gaze landed.

So naturally, everyone's eyes were focused on the woman.

Asher and the knight commander standing next to me also looked at the woman with a puzzled expression.

Only then did the woman who had been bowing her head slightly raise her head.

My eyes met hers for a few seconds. Her expression hardened weakly.

“...”

In the arena's silence, after making my decision, I pointed at her and opened my mouth.

“She’s a spy. Catch her.”

Bonus chapter! ^^

Chapter 78.1: Shadow Freon (2)

Chapter 78.1: Shadow Freon (2)

The capital of Santea, Kelia Road.

A man wearing a robe was walking down a deserted, dark alleyway.

The man soon noticed a faint pattern painted on the wall and stopped walking.

He looked around once and opened his mouth.

“Come out.”

Swoop.

Then, a black haze rose from behind the man.

The one who appeared out of the darkness without a trace was a tall woman wearing a robe, just like the man.

Looking up at the half moon floating in the night sky, the corner of her mouth drew an arc.

“It’s been a while since I’ve received a request from the imperial family.”

The man who noticed her presence only after she opened her mouth turned his head in surprise.

He clicked his tongue with a look of displeasure.

Shadow.

There were many and varied names the woman was called on the continent, but this was the most well-known name.

She was dark and elusive, like a shadow, and disappeared into the darkness with no one knowing. Just like her moniker.

“So, what is this request? Assassination requests are still not accepted, so if that’s your purpose, you can return as it is.

Her leisurely attitude annoyed the man, but he focused on the purpose of coming this far.

“It’s about the Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

The woman narrowed her eyes.

“What we want is information. Whether you infiltrate the castle of the Seventh Lord or not, you just need to collect as much information about him as possible.”

“Hmm, was it information gathering? It was also information about the newly enthroned Lord...”

She smiled.

“They said that the warrior died at his hands? There are even rumors that he might be a human from Santea.”

The man’s expression darkened again.

There’s no rumor going around like the woman implied. The fact that the warrior died at the hands of the new Seventh Lord was still only just a guess by the high-ranking officials of Santea.

The woman knew it, but she still made that statement.

If there was one person who, despite being an individual, possessed information power equal to that of any other large intelligence organization, it was her.

“Ahaha, I’m sorry. Anyway, if it’s a request like that, you’ll have to pay a little more. How much did you bring?”

Without answering, the man took something out of his bosom and threw it at the woman.

It was a purse containing over 10 platinum coins.

The woman who checked the contents whistled and put the money bag in her bosom.

A terrifying amount of advance payment that it wouldn’t be strange if she just picked it up and ran away with it without completing the request.

But the man who handed over the money didn’t care about that at all.

There was no way she would try to destroy the trust she had built until now and burn the bridge with the imperial family for just this measly amount.

“Then I’ll go first. I don’t know how long it will take, but I’ll see you with good news at least within a year.”

The woman erased the pattern drawn on the wall by rubbing it with her finger.

Squeak.

Once again, the same black haze as before shimmered, and the woman’s figure disappeared before his eyes as if evaporating without a trace.

The man, who had been staring at the spot where she had disappeared for a while, also moved on and left the alley.

Thus, the secret meeting in a dark alley ended with only the moon rising in the sky as a witness.

And after some time, Calderic.

“Kate, grab a pen and paper and follow me.”

“Yes? Paper and pen, why?”

“There’s a knight test today, right? Mr. Lefi, who was to record it, is sick and lying down, so you and I have to do it. Don’t talk nonsense and just hurry.”

“Oh, that’s right. I see!”

The woman responded to her superior’s command with a cheerful smile. She swore inwardly.

What a bother.

Her identity, which differed completely from the one seen in the alley before, was the Shadow.

It had been several months since she came to Enrock—the capital of the Seventh Lord’s territory—and entered the castle.

It was not that difficult for her to infiltrate the castle as an administrative officer.

“Ugh... Did the Lord come out himself?”

There were already many knights gathered in the arena where she followed her superior to, and even the Seventh Lord was there.

Listening to her superior’s muttering voice, the woman glanced sideways at the platform where the Seventh Lord was sitting.

Seventh Lord...

It had been several months since she had been living in the castle, but she had gotten no important information about the Seventh Lord yet.

Because he spent far more overwhelming time outside than in the castle. Did he have a wanderlust?

What she found out was just his race, gender, physical characteristics, and a personality that didn't give unnecessary power to the castle's officials.

And recently, there was a huge incident where he killed the Sixth Lord and was called for an emergency summon by the Overlord. But no matter how much she dug into it, there was a limit to what she could do.

How did he come back alive? I thought he was going to die.

So recently, she was investigating the human siblings, who were speculated to be related to the reason the Seventh Lord killed the Sixth Lord.

Even recently, Asher, who was supposed to be his escort and had a great skill, had been in charge of teaching swordsmanship to the siblings.

It meant that the Seventh Lord was clearly paying attention to the brother and sister, and of course she couldn't help but smell something.

Now that there's nothing more to dig up here, she planned to head to the capital of the Sixth Lord, eventually to learn more about the siblings' past.

The trial began, and she recorded the results with her attention secretly on the Seventh Lord.

There was Reef among the knights. She passed the test with much better skills than the other apprentices did .

As the test ended, she felt a gaze.

When she turned her head slightly, the Seventh Lord was staring at her.

...?

What?

A sense of doubt and inexplicable ominousness rose for a moment, but she pretended it was nothing and quickly bowed her head.

As she lowered her gaze, the surrounding noise slowly subsided.

When she slowly raised her head again in the suffocating silence, all the surrounding eyes were focused in this direction.

“...”

Recognizing that something was firmly wrong, she looked at the Seventh Lord with a weakly stiff face.

He pointed this way and opened his mouth.

“She’s a spy. Catch her.”

Chapter 78.2: Shadow Freon (2)

Chang!

Members of the Iron Blood Knights drew their swords immediately after my words, and the other knights came to their senses a beat later.

Standing on either side of me, Asher and the Iron Blood Knight Commander also fixed their eyes on the woman with their swords in their hands.

Soon, all the knights who were filling the arena were aiming their swords at her.

“Uh, huh, huh? Whoa!”

The other administrators standing next to the woman stood dazed and then backed away in fright.

She looked around with a look of total bewilderment and suddenly raised her hand.

“Excuse me.”

It seemed like she had something to say.

She opened her mouth with a serious face.

“Does anyone know? What’s on the lunch menu today?”

“...”

However, the words that followed were incomprehensible nonsense that did not fit the situation at all.

The knights also looked at her with eyes wondering what kind of bullshit this was all of a sudden.

I clicked my tongue a little.

That woman.

That was just meaningless nonsense to distract the knights, even for a moment.

And what followed immediately...

Whoa!

A mist suddenly spewed from her body and covered the whole area in an instant.

Even though the sun was up in the middle of the sky, the pitch-black fog was so dense that no light came through.

“...The spy is on the run! Catch her!”

Someone shouted, but the knights surrounded by fog were just wandering around inside.

At that, Asher and the Iron Blood Knight Commander immediately jumped into the arena and swung their swords at the same time.

A huge two-pronged sword wind parted the fog and their vision returned.

But the woman's figure was nowhere to be found.

Even Asher couldn't feel her presence and where she had fled. I looked around with my eyes narrowed and maximized my super sensory.

Because I knew what her abilities were.

And soon my senses caught up with her. Sensing her, who was quickly moving away while hiding herself.

She's so damn fast.

I immediately used Space Leap in succession to move into the air on one side of the arena, and I spread the floating veil.

She collided with my veil, which blocked her, and then fell straight down.

“Argh...”

Before she could return to her senses, a sword was already pointing at her neck.

Asher, who had caught up with her, coldly looked down at her as she collapsed on the floor.

The knights then completely surrounded the place and blocked the escape routes with no chance of escape.

She smiled subserviently with a slightly pale face and slowly raised her hands.

“Ha, surrender. I surrender.”

Landing on the floor, I let out a small sigh as I watched the situation ended.

I ignored the burdensome gazes of the knights, who were looking at me with eyes filled with awe.

Shadow.

So, what the hell was this woman doing here?

After sorting out the situation, Asher and I dragged the woman to my room.

After letting her sit on the other side of the table, I quietly sat across from her.

I said as I watched her looked around.

“No matter what tricks you do, it’s impossible to escape, Shadow.”

“...”

“It’s useless to use that mystery to hide yourself. If you try to escape again, I’ll cut your throat right then, so give up.”

The reason even Asher couldn’t catch her in the black mist was because of her stealth mystery.

I had super sensory, so I could apprehend her while she’s running away.

She probably did not expect that I had discovered her true identity and abilities. She looked at me with her eyebrows furrowed and then lowered her head.

“Ha, I got caught by a monster like this...”

She’s probably ready to have a conversation now.

I crossed my arms and asked first.

“Who sent you?”

Shadow Freon.

If one was to pick a unique existence on this continent, this woman would probably count as one.

As the continent’s best informant and thief, she usually did espionage under anyone who could pay her well.

If it’s a force that could move this woman, then they had limited options. I could roughly guess who it could be, though.

She asked with a half-resigned look.

“Will you save me if I tell you?”

“Tell me who it was first.”

“I can tell you, but I want to know what you will do to me once I do.”

“Then you can just die here. Asher.”

At my words, Asher, who was standing next to me, reached for the hilt of the sword at her waist.

Her mouth opened immediately.

“...Santea Imperial Family.”

Chapter 79.1: Shadow Freon (3)

Chapter 79.1: Shadow Freon (3) ! Thank you to Zxz, Kryo, Avarco, and mjspixel for the donations! ^^

So it was from the side of Santea?

But if one thought about it, there was no other force besides them who would dare bring a spy directly to Calderic.

And as far as I remembered, the Shadow was a person who carried out the imperial family's request several times and was in close contact with them.

I continued asking her.

“What is your purpose of infiltrating this castle?”

“Gathering information about the Seventh Lords”

“Why did the imperial family request such a thing?”

“I don't know the detailed reason, because I'm only receiving a fee and carrying out the request. But... A mysterious person has become the new Lord of Calderic, so wouldn't it be natural for Santea to send someone to investigate?”

Well, that's not really surprising.

They requested the Shadow to spy at the Seventh Lord, even infiltrating the castle. Certainly, what other purpose would there be besides me?

I didn't ask further and just stared at her.

She averted my gaze with a worried expression on her face.

It didn't matter that the one behind her was Santea.

Anyway, whether it's Calderic or Santea, they planted spies in each other's camps without stopping.

Of course, having a spy infiltrate a Lord's castle was still a pretty serious matter.

However, in a case like this one, it would be unfair to blame the castle's security. Because the opponent was the Shadow.

"Hey, my lord. May I say something?"

She looked at me and cautiously opened her mouth.

"It is a great honor that you recognized me at first glance, and I think you probably know a lot about me, but I am not someone who's affiliated or entangled with any faction."

"..."

"This time, too, I was just accepting the request from the imperial family in a very thorough, business-like manner, and there was no personal intention. Of course, it might sound shameless to say this when I'm caught like this..."

"What do you want to say?"

I stopped her from talking because all I could hear was nonsense.

"I understand that there will be a Neutral Nations Conference soon. If you wish, I could make a full confession to the fact that I was a spy sent here at the request of the Imperial Family. If you would just show a little mercy on my life..."

She said with a nervous laugh.

Since the emperor would directly take part in the Neutral Nations Conference representing Santea, what she's suggesting would give Calderic a strong cause to squeeze them openly.

I said, "Huh," and laughed.

I knew that the Shadow's character was roughly like this. For her, nothing was above her own life.

That's why there was no hesitation in selling her client like this.

I wondered if she knew nothing would come out if she continued talking nonsense, so she sold out her client to survive.

But her offer wasn't very appealing.

Because I wouldn't really get anything by putting pressure on Santea. It would not help my next goal.

Now more than anything else, I was more interested in her existence itself.

What should I do with this woman?

Being a spy was a crime that could immediately send her to be executed, but I had no intention of killing her.

It was a waste to just execute such a talented person.

Few people in the continent was as quick as her, with excellent information gathering skill and tracking abilities, not to mention a fighting power equivalent to level 67.

She's not a character who played a specific role in the game, like helping the player or something. But it's not like she had ever done anything villainous.

I needed an excellent informant more than anything else.

I had so far been concentrating on finding mysteries, but now my aim going forward was to focus on the full-fledged main story.

For events that would occur in the future, my game knowledge might not be enough to solve it. I needed to gather important information.

The only problem was that she's not a person who I could put under me and let her obey my orders.

If I let her go collect information, she would surely run away and disappear.

The problem is that there's no way to catch her easily and deal with her.

If I released her to collect information, they would run away and disappear. Or maybe she would then stab me in the back if it's convenient for her.

Those whose names or nicknames spread throughout the continent didn't have such a reputation for nothing.

She wasn't the kind of person who would easily succumb to halfway threats or weaknesses.

Even if she was now acting with a low posture, as if she would lick my feet at any minute, she was still looking for ways to survive out of this situation.

...Ah.

Locked in my thoughts, I let out an exclamation inwardly.

That's because it reminded me of one thing she possessed. It would be extremely useful in the current situation.

"I have no intention of killing you. Yet."

"...Really? Thank you."

She replied, but her face did not brighten at all.

Maybe it's because I added the word 'yet'.

And she was right being anxious.

“Stigma ring.”

“...Yes?”

“The ancient artifact you have. There’s no doubt you have it now. Take it out.”

Her eyes trembled.

But it was only for a moment, and soon she asked again with an expression as if she didn’t know what I was talking about.

“Stigma ring...? Ancient artifact? Excuse me, what are you talking about?”

Chapter 79.2: Shadow Freon (3)

Chapter 79.2: Shadow Freon (3)

I thought that was fairly good acting.

Was this her reaction to the fact that I talked about the existence of something that no one but herself should know?

I shook my head and continued.

“It’s no use even if you act like that. How do you think I know the name of that ring?”

“No, I really do not know what you’re talking about...”

“Asher, if she takes nothing out before I count to three, cut her throat.”

Asher immediately drew her sword.

“One.”

I crossed my arms and started counting.

And before the count of two, her mouth opened again. With a confused gaze, showing that she didn’t understand what was happening.

“...What the hell is this? How do you even know about the artifact that I have?”

I shrugged.

“That’s not really important, is it? Just take it out.”

In the golden age of ancient magic, they said that all kinds of magic existed.

A stigma ring, an ancient artifact that could leave a magical mark on someone that any means couldn't erase.

And the owner of the ring could locate the branded target no matter how far away they were.

I remembered the Shadow used this artifact in the game before.

She hesitated with a more determined expression.

Aside from how I knew of the existence of the stigma ring, she couldn't have guessed why I asked her to take it out at this moment.

"I'm tired of warning you again and again. Are you really planning to die like this?"

"..."

In the end, she was almost in tears and had no choice but to take out the ring from the bosom of her robe.

I took the ring she took out and looked at it.

It was an old, dirty silver ring with a small hexagonal pattern engraved in the middle.

"Here."

When I handed it to Asher, she accepted it with a puzzled face.

I couldn't activate the ability of the artifact because I didn't have magic power.

If you inject magical power, you will activate the artifact's ability.

"Ah, yes."

Although Asher seemed puzzled why she had to do it herself, she did not ask further and just injected magic into the ring.

Then, a purple light radiated softly from the hexagonal pattern engraved on the ring.

I turned my gaze to the Shadow.

“Where would you like to be branded?”

“...Wrist.”

She held out one arm weakly, looking extremely reluctant.

Asher took the ring that radiated with light and stamped it on her wrist. Then, according to the pattern of the ring, a purple hexagonal pattern was engraved.

I took the ring from Asher again and examined it.

A thin, faint beam of light emanated from the ring, pointing exactly where she was.

Good.

This result satisfied me.

Now I could locate her no matter where or how far away she was.

In short, she was in a position where she could not escape from me for the rest of her life.

That magical brand would stay with her forever until I used it on another target.

I said to her, who was staring blankly at the brand on her wrist.

“Don’t feel too down. I swear I won’t kill you if you do what I ask you to do. I would even give you your ring back.”

She replied in a sharp voice.

“Do I have a choice? What do you want?”

“It’s information gathering.”

The first thing I ordered was related to the terrorism in the Santea Empire’s capital.

The Mystery of Possession, which I had previously failed to get in Hallmenta. A terrible disaster caused by the villain who got that mystery.

First, the unit of damage was the biggest disaster among future events I knew, so I thought to investigate that first.

Anyway, after this, I got myself one very good informant.

At my request, she immediately left for Santea to investigate.

I suddenly felt like I was making threats here and there lately, just like the situation with the Thunder Lord.

But what could I do? I was just trying my best for a peaceful future.

Time continued to pass.

Reef was formally knighted, and Rigon continued his explosive growth and reached level 26. Asher continued to teach the two siblings diligently while not neglecting her training.

As usual, I was sitting in my room reading a book, and then I received news from the Overlord’s castle.

Are we leaving in three days?

Now was the time for us to move to a neutral country for the conference.

After I finished my preparations, I got ready to fly to the Overlord's castle with Ti-Yong.

“You just have to remain in the castle and continue to focus on guiding the siblings.”

Rigon's growth was unusual, so this time he didn't dare to take Asher and left her in the castle, but...

“I want to go with you, Sir Ron.”

I looked back at her, a little surprised.

It was the first time she had asserted her will against my orders.

Is it because of Santea?

This meeting was a place to discuss the conflict between the two neutral countries and directly face the royal family of Santea.

I looked at her, saw her head lowered, and said.

“Okay. Then, I'll let you accompany me.”

So, I took Asher and headed to the cage where Ti-Yong was.

I had already ordered the servants to ready the saddles.

Purr.

I stroked the neck of the guy who was still pushing its head in, and climbed on its back with Asher.

It seemed displeased with the fact that another person was riding its back, but after whining and shaking its body a few times, it didn't make a fuss any more.

“Safe travels, my lord.”

“Yes.”

After receiving the butler’s farewell, I tapped Ti-Yong.

It flapped its wings with a mighty roar and soared into the sky.

Chapter 80.1: Neutral Nations Conference (1)

Chapter 80.1: Neutral Nations Conference (1)

Confederation of the Santea Empire.

It was an alliance of several human-centered nations united around the Santea Empire, and the core of the main storyline of RaSa's worldview.

Calderic did not have direct borders with Santea.

This was because there were several neutral countries in the middle between the two powers.

However, even though they claimed to be neutral, it was only for show. Most of the countries were almost absorbed by Santea after the invasion of the demons.

So far, only two countries could be said to have remained in the realm of neutrality.

Earth Hill Kingdom and Kajor Kingdom.

Two countries that claimed to be neutral between the two giant powers of Santea and Calderic.

Two weak states, whose total national strength was less than one of Calderic's Lord's territory, had remained in the camp of neutrality for several reasons.

There were political reasons.

The Neutral Nations Conference held in Earth Hill was a gathering place for Calderic, Santea, and the royalty of the other neutral countries.

It's here.

I rode Ti-Yong and quickly flew to my destination. I looked at the castle of the Overlord that appeared in the distance.

As I lowered my altitude and approached the entrance of the castle, I saw the figures of two people who seemed to wait for me. They were the Overlord and the chief of staff.

Ti-Yong flapped its wings and landed right in front of them.

I landed first by using space lead, and Asher, who followed me, bowed her head to the Overlord.

“You’re here, Seventh Lord.”

The Overlord greeted me with an innocent smile, as always.

She looked at Asher with a strange look, and then flashed her gaze to Ti-Yong with a twinkle in her eyes.

“I heard you went to the Glide Mountains to get a wyvern. Was it this black wyvern?”

When the Overlord stared at it, Ti-Yong turned its head away with a look of reluctance.

In response, she smiled and turned her gaze back to me.

“By the way, Seventh Lord, I heard you rode the Second Lord’s wyvern and went together to the Glide Mountains. The two of you were so at odds during the emergency call, so how did you even get close?”

Did she even know about that?

I changed the topic without bothering to answer.

“When are we leaving?”

“Um, well? As long as the Seventh Lord doesn’t mind, we can leave right now.”

I looked at her attire as she answered indifferently.

She was wearing a black dress, as always. Was she going to leave in that attire?

We’re now about to head to a neutral country, so I was a little taken aback by her atmosphere. It seemed as if she was going out for a drink rather than a meeting.

“Are only the four of us going?”

“No. The chief of staff will remain, so there will only be three.”

“I thought we would move in a procession, but it seemed that that wasn’t the case.”

The Overlord smiled and said.

“It’s useless and cumbersome. I’m going there myself, so what else is needed?”

It sounded quite arrogant, but there was nothing wrong with it.

Anyway, as soon as we arrived at the Overlord’s castle, they decided to travel to Earth Hill immediately.

Soon after, the Overlord brought her own wyvern, a black wyvern like Ti-Yong. If there was something different, it was the eyes. This guy had blue eyes instead.

I asked the Overlord.

“Is there a particular reason why you want me to accompany you to the conference?”

To my question, she just smiled and didn't answer.

I really couldn't figure this woman out.

“Shall we go?”

Darkness shrouded the Overlord, and her attire changed.

Rather than the dress from before, it was a simple and moderately flashy garment.

After changing her outfit, she lightly jumped onto her wyvern's back.

Looking at the scene, I couldn't help but feel a slight sense of alienation.

I already knew that the Overlord owned a wyvern, but that she rode a wyvern herself was just a little weird. It's because of her actually being a dragon.

Oh oh!

The Overlord's wyvern roared vigorously and flew into the sky first.

Asher and I, riding on Ti-Yong's back, soon followed and set off.

The distance to the neutral country was only a little longer than the distance between two territories, so it wouldn't take much time.

They held the Neutral Nations Conference this time in the Earth Hill Kingdom.

This grand summit, which began with the intention of mutual solidarity and cooperation, was held in neutral countries every three years.

A place to peacefully discuss the future of the continent, including Calderic and Santea, as well as royalty from neutral countries.

...Of course, those things were just for show, and in the end it was all about power struggle.

In particular, looking at the current situation, it's not expected that this meeting would end with a mere war of nerves.

It was because the Kajor Kingdom was intent on declaring war with the Earth Hill Kingdom at this meeting, planning to present their cause in earnest.

That was also the reason I followed the Overlord and took part in this meeting with little hesitation.

Earth Hill Kingdom...

I remembered a man I had previously met in the Fifth Lord's territory.

Tair Bamon, the second prince of the Earth Hill royal family.

If he returned to his kingdom, we would probably meet again at this meeting.

Chapter 80.2: Neutral Nations Conference (1)

Chapter 80.2: Neutral Nations Conference (1)

“You pitiful bastard. Now you’ve crawled into the castle and shamelessly showed us that foolish face...”

“...”

“I don’t want to see you, so go away.”

The King of Earth Hill, Longford, glared at the man in front of him. His eyes were filled with love and hatred, but he soon withdrew his gaze.

The man, Tair, bowed his head and stepped out of the room.

The Earth Hill Kingdom, the capital city of Seraf.

The capital, which he returned to after a long time, had not changed at all. But because of the upcoming meeting, the atmosphere was much stricter than usual.

Tair, who reached the garden outside the palace, let out a small sigh.

I’m already regretting it...

He wondered if he had come back for nothing.

After leaving the capital for a long time, he suddenly returned without warning, so it’s natural that he had nothing to do in this situation.

He was just wandering around in and out of the palace like he was doing now.

Tair was lost in thought as he touched the leaves of the bush.

Originally, he had no intention of returning to the royal castle just because the meeting was approaching. It had nothing to do with him, anyway.

Nevertheless, there was one reason for returning home after a long wandering.

A man I met before in the Fifth Lord's territory.

It was because of his words that kept on lingering in his mind after he introduced himself as the Seventh Lord.

...Go back to where I belong.

What did he mean by that?

He even said that he might be of help to Earth Hill someday, in relation to the unusual situation in the two neutral countries.

Tair couldn't figure out anything.

Was that man really the Seventh Lord of Calderic?

"Hey."

Hearing the voice calling him, Tair turned his head.

A woman in a neat dress was standing on one side of the garden before he knew it.

Tair stared at her for a moment, then smiled faintly.

"Are you here to greet your brother, Seri?"

She replied with a slight frown.

“Do I have to treat the idiot who came back after wandering around for almost two years like a brother?”

“...”

“So, what are you really doing here, Brother?”

She said that, but she still didn’t hesitate to call him ‘brother’.

Tair continued to fidget with the leaf he was touching and quietly passed the answer.

Seeing his listless attitude, Seri’s expression was filled with pity, sadness, and regret.

She opened her mouth again and asked.

“Why did you suddenly come back? You left after saying that you would never come back.”

“That’s right. I’m sorry for making it even more confusing, returning at a time like this.”

“Argh, that’s not what I’m saying! Who said I didn’t like my brother’s return?”

She groaned and let out a deep sigh.

There was an awkward air for a moment, followed by a calm voice.

“Why did you leave in the first place? You clearly...”

“Stop.”

Tair cut off her words adamantly.

“Stop it, Seri. You know that wasn’t the problem.”

“...”

“Rather than that, what are you doing here? Have you finished all the preparations? Are there any problems?”

Seri couldn't say anything more as he forcibly changed the topic.

She swallowed the suffocation welling up inside her and calmed herself down.

“Don't worry about it. If there was a problem, I wouldn't be here.”

At the blunt reply, Tair smiled bitterly and said.

“The people from Santea have arrived, and now only Calderic is left.”

“...Yes.”

Not only the royal family of each neutral country but also all the people from the Santea side, including the emperor, arrived at the castle just yesterday afternoon.

Seri suddenly thought of an annoying person, and her mood sank even more. The first prince of the Kajor kingdom.

She said to Tair.

“Anyway, don't hang around outside and just stay in your room. Until the meeting is over...”

Then footsteps were heard.

Seri looked away and frowned at the people coming this way. A man and a woman in colorful outfits and an escort knight.

“You are here, Princess Seri.”

Among the two who came closer, the man opened his mouth with a greasy smile.

Jordan, the first prince of Kajor Kingdom, and Olivica, the Second princess.

They were one of the representatives of Kajor who accompanied the King to take part in this meeting.

“I was looking for you. It’s a nice day and I’m going to have tea with the other princes and princesses. How about joining us?”

Seri swallowed the irritation rising inside and managed her expression.

There was still quite a bit of time left until the talks, so the neutral countries who came to the castle were interacting with each other and building friendships. And it was all centered on Kajor’s first prince, Jordan.

In fact, when all sides were already divided, Earth Hill had no allies. She was well aware of that fact.

Even so, they continued to come and showed their face to her with the obvious purpose of embarrassing her in front of everyone.

“I’m sorry, but I’m busy preparing for the conference, so I don’t think I have time for that.”

“You keep giving that reason. But looking at it, aren’t you relaxing now? This is really embarrassing.”

Princess Olivica intervened.

“It would be better not to refuse this time, Princess Seri. The fifth princess of Santea will also join us.”

“So what?”

“I mean, we’re giving you a good opportunity to have a private conversation with a precious person. So stop refusing and hang out with us.”

There was a subtle condescension in his voice as he said that.

Chapter 80.3: Neutral Nations Conference (1)

Chapter 80.3: Neutral Nations Conference (1) ! Thank you to LeTucan, Metatin, and Effervescence for the donations! ^^

The royal family of the Santea Empire were noble beings who were of a different rank, even to the royal family of other countries.

It was to show off his friendship with the fifth prince by preparing a private tea party including the other royals of other countries.

“Ah, yes. Come to think of it, you’re here too. Aren’t you Prince Tair, the pride of the Bamon royal family?”

Jordan said with a slightly surprised expression, as if he had only found Tair standing next to Seri.

Seri frowned at the openly sarcastic tone.

“I heard the news that you ran away, but it seems that you came back. How about it? Would you also like to join us?”

“It’s fine, so I’ll decline.”

Tair replied with an expressionless face.

At that, Jordan smiled.

“Well, I understand. I hope the princess doesn’t intend to reject my invitation again.”

“I’m sorry, but I already said I’d decline because I don’t have time.”

Jordan’s eyebrows twitched, and Olivica frowned and snorted.

“Princess Seri, do you think anything good would come out of being so stiff? Don’t you even know the situation you’re in right now?”

“Okay, Olivica. Let’s go.”

The two turned and walked out of the road garden.

“By the way, princess. In what direction do you think this meeting will go?”

Jordan paused for a moment and looked back at Seri.

“If you think it will end halfway like last time, you are very mistaken. You know it doesn’t matter if we declare war on Earth Hill, neither Santea nor Calderic will try to intervene.”

“...”

Seri glared at Jordan with a stiff face.

Jordan laughed, seeing her like that.

“Let’s see if you can continue to act like this after the meeting is over. Then...”

Ohhhh!

At that time, a huge roar rang throughout the castle.

Jordan and Olivica raised their heads in surprise. It was the same with Seri and Tair.

From the other side of the sky, two huge black objects were flying rapidly toward the capital.

“Wyvern...?”

Jordan and Olivica, who had been staring blankly at the scene, hurriedly left the garden.

The sudden appearance of a wyvern meant only one thing in the current situation.

Finally, the Overlord of Calderic had arrived at the royal castle.

“...Overlord of Calderic.”

Said Seri as she also hurriedly moved on.

Tair hesitated, then followed.

Suddenly, many people gathered at the main gate of the castle.

Not only King Longford of Earth Hill but also the kings, princes and princesses of each neutral country, and many retainers.

The royal family of all the neutral countries who took part in the conference gathered at the meeting, except for those from Santea.

Even though the organizer of this meeting was Earth Hill, the other participants couldn't dare not to show their face in front of this incoming guest.

In a chilly, frozen atmosphere, everyone stared with eyes full of tension at the woman walking towards the entrance of the castle.

The overlord of Calderic, Rashtain.

There was only a young human male standing beside her without a single procession.

However, with just that, the two overwhelmed everyone present.

Longford calmly stepped forward to greet the two.

“Thank you for taking the time to come to Earth Hill, Overlord.”

The Overlord snorted and looked around.

“Yes, King Longford. We must be the last. Let’s go inside.”

“Yes. But this person...”

Longford looked curiously at the man standing next to the Overlord.

This is because, until now, she has rarely accompanied anyone to a meeting.

The Overlord smiled and said calmly.

“He is the new Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

“...!”

Everyone stared at the man in amazement.

The new Seventh Lord of Calderic.

The person who recently killed the same Lord, the Tyrant, and was currently causing an uproar on the continent.

The person who had been shrouded in a veil, knowing nothing about him, was walking with the Overlord in this meeting.

“...”

Even before the Overlord spoke, there was a person who had been staring blankly at the Seventh Lord. It was Tair.

The man I had met before in the Fifth Lord’s Territory, with the appearance I remembered in my head, was standing next to the Overlord.

Tair realized that his identity was really the Seventh Lord and thought, what the hell was going on?

The overlord and the Seventh Lord walked and the crowd split on both sides.

The young royals, who had taken part in the meeting for the first time, and meeting the Overlord of Calderic, could not raise their heads recklessly because of a sense of intimidation.

Likewise, Seri, who was glancing at the two with her gaze down, suddenly looked back at her brother standing next to her.

Because he was staring at them so blatantly.

What is this fool doing?

She stabbed Tair in the side to warn him, but then hurriedly lowered her head again.

It was because the eyes of the Seventh Lord were looking this way for some reason.

I thought it was a simple glance, but the Seventh Lord soon stopped walking in front of the two.

“...”

Everyone's eyes were focused on the Seven Lord who stopped walking.

The Overlord looked back at him as if wondering, and Longford's expression hardened as he stood beside her.

Seri tried to calm her thumping heart, thinking if they had made a mistake.

After a brief silence, the Seventh Lord's mouth opened.

“It's been a while, Tair.”

Everyone looked at Tair in amazement as the Seventh Lord greeted him casually.

Chapter 81.1: Neutral Nations Conference (2)

Chapter 81.1: Neutral Nations Conference (2)

Tair couldn't help but be taken aback by the actions of the Seventh Lord.

Even though they knew each other, he didn't expect that the other would not pretend to recognize him in a place like this.

Of course, it wasn't just Tair who was surprised.

King Longford widened his eyes at the incomprehensible situation unfolding in front of him, and Seri was half stunned.

It's only natural to be so. Why the hell was the Lord of Calderic saying hello to Tair out of the blue?

How did they know each other?

Under the focus of attention, Tair hesitated, not knowing how to react at the moment.

The Seventh Lord opened his mouth again and asked.

"When did you return to the kingdom?"

"...Ah, yes. I just returned today."

Tair replied in a bewildered voice.

The Seventh Lord nodded and moved on again, but not before saying one last thing.

“See you later.”

It was only a few words of conversation, but it caused the atmosphere to turn into a calm storm.

The Overlord and the Seventh Lord went inside the castle, and there was a chaotic commotion with the people who remained.

What is that, really...

Tair looked at their backs as they walked away, then turned his head at the gaze he suddenly felt.

Jordan and Olivica were staring this way, unable to close their gaping mouths, as they stood on Kajor's side.

“Oh, Brother. What the hell was that? Huh?”

Seri, who came to her senses belatedly, asked in an urgent voice.

Tair sighed lightly without answering. That was also the most confusing thing for him right now.

As soon as we arrived, I ran into that guy.

As we entered the palace following the King of Earth Hill, I thought about Tair.

‘Go back to your place’—those were the words I told him before.

It was just something I said that could easily be ignored with little thought, so it wouldn't be strange if nothing had changed. But in the end, he still came back.

“Seventh Lord, if it’s not a bother, could I ask how you know Prince Tair?”

Then the king of Earth Hill opened his mouth.

He seemed to be very concerned since earlier. He’s probably curious about my relationship with his son.

I answered without hesitation.

“It’s nothing special. It’s just a chance meeting in the Fifth Lord’s territory.”

And I owed a debt that I was very grateful for.

Thanks to the map Tair gave me, I gained the mystery of super sensory. Something that I probably would not have been able to get originally.

“...Is that so?”

The King nodded with a strange expression and did not ask further.

Come to think of it, it would probably be absurd from his point of view.

Maybe he would think that his son went around Calderic to meet all the Lords and that the other might be planning something.

I was walking through the halls of the palace, thinking about this and that, when I saw a group of people approaching from the other side.

A young woman, an elderly man, and a small old man standing in the middle of them, looking a little older.

A few attendants and knights followed behind the three.

“...”

As soon as I saw them, I immediately guessed their identities.

The old man in the middle is the emperor of Santea – Grandios.

The man standing to the left was General Cayden, one of the Five Stars of Santea.

And the woman on the right... was probably one of the princesses, but I didn't know who exactly.

The steps stopped for a moment, and the Overlord looked at them, facing the front with a smile.

After a brief silence, the first to speak was the emperor.

“Long time no see, Overlord. It looks like you just arrived.”

A low, cracking voice echoed through the hallway.

He had a level that could not be said to be high, but he certainly exuded a strange sense of intimidation that was difficult to describe.

I couldn't help but feel that it was like the time I arrived in this world and met the Overlord for the first time.

Not that the emperor himself felt as powerful as the Overlord, but for other reasons.

For one, he was the emperor. He was the leader of the faction where the hero belonged.

The hero who was the most important part of the main storyline of the RaSa worldview.

“Yes. Long time no see, Emperor.”

The Overlord answered in a voice mixed with laughter.

She used honorifics with minimal respect for the King of Earth Hill, but not for the Emperor.

And the emperor didn't seem to pay much attention to that either. His gaze fell on me.

“...You must be the new Seventh Lord of Calderic. Nice to meet you.”

Apparently, he recognized my true identity at a glance.

No surprise. Of course, the emperor must have found out information about me, and right now I was standing right next to the Overlord.

Naturally, the conclusion that I was the new Seventh Lord was inevitable.

“By the way, didn’t the hero come to this meeting?”

“That’s right. She didn’t come.”

“Ah, that’s too bad. I couldn’t see her face last time, so I was looking forward to it this time.”

The Overlord grumbled like that with a sign of genuine regret.

“Then I’ll see you again at the meeting.”

And there was no further conversation.

It wouldn’t have been a chance meeting. The emperor’s purpose was just to meet the Overlord for a moment.

The woman standing next to the emperor lightly bowed her head to me and the Overlord, while General Cayden glanced at Asher standing behind me.

Then they passed by and went on their way.

“...”

I slowly looked back.

Asher’s expression hardened. It was an expression I had never seen before.

Her clenched fists were trembling, and I could feel that she was barely suppressing the seething anger that was about to explode at any moment.

Her gaze was fixed on the back of one of the three walking away. I followed her gaze and looked at their backs.

The General...

I knew why she reacted this way.

Chapter 81.2: Neutral Nations Conference (2)

Chapter 81.2: Neutral Nations Conference (2)

General Cayden.

Who could keep their composure when the enemy who annihilated their whole tribe was right in front of them?

Just not pulling out the sword right away and not attacking was already great.

“Asher.”

When I called her name, Asher closed her eyes once, then opened them, then looked away from the three people walking away.

“...Apologies.”

I wanted to say something, but I couldn't think of anything to say, so I decided to just stay silent.

Turning my head, I saw the Overlord looking at Asher with a gaze full of interest.

After being guided, we moved to the accommodation where we would stay during the conference, and since it was just the right time, the Overlord and I had lunch together.

The reason for not having a meal with the king was because the talks were about to begin, and there was a banquet after that.

While sitting face-to-face with the Overlord at an unnecessarily long table and eating in silence, she asked.

“The escort knight of the Seventh Lord, is her name Asher?”

I stopped the knife I was cutting the meat with and looked at her, feeling perplexed inside.

I thought she didn’t care because she had said little until now, but she suddenly mentioned Asher like this.

“The Chief of Staff said that the Seventh Lord had taken an apprentice knight, so I was interested. If the Seventh Lord hadn’t taken her, she would have been able to join the Black Star Knights.”

“...”

She said it with a smile, but somehow it sounded like she was blaming me a little.

Come to think of it, the first time the Overlord saw Asher was at her castle before we left for Earth Hill.

If it was her, of course she would have known Asher’s level at first glance.

To be honest, I also had a bit of a guilty feeling for taking Asher away, so I just kept silent.

“Is it true that Kajol might issue a war warning to Earth Hill on this conference?”

When I subtly changed the subject to talk about the meeting, the Overlord let out a small smile and nodded.

“Yes. Why did you ask?”

“Are you willing to get involved?”

“No, no. Of course, the emperor will also not.”

The answer to the question came right back.

The war between Earth Hill and Kajor was one of many episodes in the main story.

Even in the game, neither Calderic nor Santea interfered in the war, so I already knew the Overlord’s intentions.

Of course, I also knew why she didn’t want to interfere in the war.

“By the way, Seventh Lord seemed to care about that prince, don’t you? You said hello to him on purpose. I wonder what kind of chance meeting you two had.”

“There’s no need for the Overlord to care about that.”

The Overlord shook her head.

I thought for a moment.

As the Overlord said, talking to Tair on earlier was partly intentional.

Because, first, I was thinking of helping the Earth Hill Kingdom.

I had a debt to Tair, and above all, in the game’s main story, this war ended with Earth Hill’s victory.

It was because of the activities of the player playing the game.

So, in fact, it was not an act of trying to calculate what could be beneficial.

I just want to minimize the potential danger as much as possible by following the game story line as closely as I could.

Well, I had to see how things would go once the talks start.

“Brother, can you talk to me? What the hell were you doing outside to get acquainted with a Lord of Calderic! Huh?!”

“It’s not like that...”

Tair moved on, thinking that Seri, who was chattering next to him, was noisy.

King Longford was already seated and waiting when he opened the door to the room.

Next to him stood another man, Lucas, his older brother and the first prince.

“...Welcome.”

“Uh, yes.”

Tair responded awkwardly to Lucas’s awkward greeting.

Longford clicked his tongue and gestured his chin towards one seat.

“Sit down.”

“...No. I’ll just stand there.”

Tair stood at a distance on the other side of Lucas, and Seri quietly stood beside him.

The atmosphere calmed down for a while.

Longford, who was looking at Tair with complicated eyes, finally opened his mouth again.

“Tair, my son. What the hell have you been doing outside?”

“...”

“The Seventh Lord said that you had a chance meeting in the Fifth Lord’s Territory. Can you explain it more clearly?”

“Yes...”

Tair obediently explained what had happened in relation to the Seventh Lord. From the story of the crazy young lady who tried to cut off his own arm until how they parted.

The three of them all tilted their heads as if they didn’t understand.

“Is that really all?”

It was because they couldn’t understand why the Seventh Lord showed interest in Tair just from the story they heard.

Seri, who was deep in thought, opened her mouth with a slightly excited expression.

“Anyway, he’s a Lord of Calderic. I don’t know why, but if he liked my brother...”

“That’s the problem. You can’t be sure of their intentions, so we have to be more careful. They’re dangerous people you can’t handle.”

At Lucas’ words, Tair thought to himself.

No matter how much he thought about it, he couldn’t believe that the Seventh Lord had any special ulterior motives. Why would he even have that in the first place?

It’s probably not just because of that map.

Of course, this was an understandable reaction because he couldn’t figure out the reason for the Seventh Lord’s action in the end.

Longford, who was rubbing his forehead with a distraught expression, asked again.

“Tair, what kind of person was the Seventh Lord from your point of view?”

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What kind of person was the Seventh Lord?

Tair thought for a moment.

It was only a brief encounter. There's no way I could judge a person just by that.

...Still, I don't think he's a bad person after all.

Didn't the other save him from getting his arm cut off from their first meeting?

Although suspicious, Tair only felt gratitude towards the Seventh Lord, and there was no negative emotion at all.

"I don't think he's evil. And I don't think he has any ulterior motives. At least from what I could see and feel."

Hearing Tair's confident voice, Longford stared at him, then sighed softly.

He truly couldn't understand this situation.

Even if what Tair was saying was true, they're still under the threat from Kajor. His son, who returned after two years, gave him another big worry.

It was hard for Longford to think that someone like a Lord of Calderic had helped Tair out of pure goodwill.

It didn't matter if this Lord was evil or not.

Not knowing the other person's intentions was too dangerous.

The opponent was a strong force that their side could not handle.

No one properly knew the new Seventh Lord of Calderic.

He had killed the Sixth Lord not too long ago, and yet he could still accompany the Overlord at this conference.

And that Seventh Lord seemed to be interested in Tair...

Longford cleared his mind of many questions.

First, things should become much clearer once the meeting started. There's no use worrying about those things right now.

"I understand. Do you have anything else to say?"

Tair hesitated, then shook his head.

"None."

"..."

"If you have no more questions, I'll go back."

It was time to say goodbye and leave the room.

"Why don't you have Tair join the meeting in my place tomorrow, Father?"

At the words of the first prince, Lucas, Tair turned around in surprise.

"...What are you saying suddenly, big brother?"

"It is as you heard."

Lucas spoke calmly.

“The Seventh Lord talked to you in front of everyone. If you don’t take part and I did, wouldn’t it seem like we’re being disrespectful towards him?”

One representative from each country party and one spectator who did not have the right to speak may take part in the meeting.

Suddenly, Lucas, the first prince, changed his plan to take part as a spectator to Tair.

“What do you think, Father?”

Longford seemed to be worried about Lucas’ words, but then nodded.

“You’re not wrong. Tair, could you join us in the meeting?”

“But...”

Tair could only nod his head after seeing the expression of the two.

It was because he couldn’t refuse the request since he finally came back after running away for two years.

He only had to stand still during the meeting, anyway. It’s easy to do that.

“Yes, well... Then I understand. I will join the meeting.”

“Okay, thank you.”

Tair hesitated, then bowed his head.

“If you have no more questions, I’ll leave.”

Tair left the room, Seri followed him out.

Longford looked at the closed door and sighed once more.

Lucas, who stood there with a bitter expression for a moment, spoke cautiously to him.

“Father. Even if we don’t know the intentions of the Seventh Lord, it’s true that he took a friendly stance towards Earth Hill. If so...”

“Expect nothing.”

Longford said firmly.

The Overlord had never been involved in the slightest in the situation of neutral countries. Would this meeting suddenly break that solid stance?

In the end, it was right not to expect Calderic’s help, no matter what.

Longford continued to think about the meeting to be held tomorrow, feeling his body and mind getting more tired.

A day passed, and the day of the meeting came.

Earthhill, Kajor, Mator, Plagas, and Rajane.

The kings of the five neutral countries entered the conference room early and took their seats at the round table.

It was because the disaster of coming later than the Overlord of Calderic or the Emperor of Santea should not happen.

Behind them stood one prince or one princess, who had entered as spectators of the meeting.

Neutral Nations Conference.

As the name suggested, the agendas of this meeting were related to issues between neutral countries.

And the top agenda of this meeting, as everyone already knew, was the confrontation between Earth Hill and Kajor.

Before the arrival of the emperor and Overlord, the atmosphere was quiet and no one spoke.

Jordan, the first prince of the Kajor, kept a sidelong glance at the seat on the Earth Hill side.

...Not the first prince, but the second prince attended.

The person standing behind the King of Earth Hill as a spectator was not the first prince Lucas, but the second prince Tair.

Because of what happened just yesterday, Kajor's side also had their thoughts complicated for the day.

It was because they couldn't figure out what kind of connection there was between the new Seventh Lord and the second Prince Tair.

Although the Overlord of Calderic has never been involved in matters between neutral nations...

They couldn't figure out what the exact intentions of the Seventh Lord were.

A variable came from a completely unexpected place.

“The Emperor of the Santea Empire is entering.”

All five kings rose from their seats at the announcement.

Soon after, the emperor appeared in the meeting room accompanied by Princess Aren.

As they were seated at one side of the round table, there was more tension in the air flowing through the meeting room.

A little more time passed in that state...

“The Overlord of the Calderic Monarchy and the Seventh Lord are entering.”

The kings rose from their seats again.

Footsteps echoed in the silence, and a man and a woman walked into the meeting room.

The Overlord of Calderic and the Seventh Lord.

They approached the last two remaining seats and sat down. It was right across from the Emperor.

Originally, one representative and one spectator would take part in the conference, and those who took part as spectators would not sit at the round table.

They had to stand in the back, but the Seventh Lord sat side by side next to the Overlord.

Strictly speaking, the Calderic Monarchy could be said to be an alliance of ten countries, and the Seventh Lord was the head of one of them.

It was only the first time that another Lord accompanied the Overlord to a conference.

There was no one present who dared to raise objections against this.

After everyone was seated at the conference room, Longford looked around the round table and opened his mouth.

“Then let’s start the meeting.”

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The first issue was a small trade dispute between the Kingdoms of Rajane and Plagas.

“As you know, the trade route in the Northeast is very rough. The customs finance is a matter to be considered carefully considering that, King Solik.”

“Of course, I admit that, but I think it’s an issue that needs to be addressed here. The amount of salt imported from Rajan...”

They held the meeting in such a way that countries with conflicts discussed with each other, and countries that had nothing to do with it, sometimes offered their opinions and helped.

It reminds me of the first time I took part in the meeting of the Lords.

I heard words I couldn’t understand well with one ear and let it out with the other.

Because the little problems between them had nothing to do with me.

And all the while, neither the Overlord nor the Emperor said a word to intervene.

The Overlord just wasn’t interested in the first place...

I glanced around.

She was drumming her fingers on the armrests and humming in a low, inaudible tone.

She didn't seem to be interested in what was going on at the meeting.

And the Emperor's side probably doesn't step forward because the Overlord was sitting still and there's no need to provoke her.

The meeting went much more smoothly than I thought in that manner.

The agenda passed one by one until it was Earth Hill and Kajor's turn.

"We declare territorial claim to the Lowalf Plain, which lies on the border with Earth Hill, King Longford."

The King of Kajor's direct remarks made the expressions of the King of Earthhill, and Tair standing behind him, harden.

I crossed my arms and gently lifted my back from the chair.

As expected, this happens.

Before participating in the meeting, I already knew Kajor would do something like this.

Lowalf Plains.

The Golden Land, one of the largest granaries of the Earth Hill Kingdom.

"Kajor has no claims of the Lowalf plains. The Lowalf plains are within the borders of Earth Hill. It is clearly our territory."

Despite King of Earth Hill's resolute words, the king of Kajor continued his argument without blinking an eye.

"We have been claiming the rights to Lowalf Plains continuously for 20 years."

“Are you referring to the absurd data that was presented at the last meeting? Where is the credibility of that data?”

Listening to the war of words between the two kings, the situation was like this.

The King of Kajor, citing the records of his ancestors left in their royal family, insisted that Lowalf Plains was originally an important territory for Kajor, and Earth Hill refuted that this could not be supported.

No matter who heard it, Kajor’s claim was far-fetched, but the king still continued with this absurd claim.

In fact, there was no way the other three countries on the side of Santea would express opinions contrary to the emperor.

So, in fact, no matter what Kajor said, the justification was not important at all. This was just a struggle of rights and interests between the two countries.

“We have already tried to claim our rights to Lowalf Plains peacefully, countless times. But Earth Hill continued to ignore us. If you still continued on in this manner, we would not just stand by any longer.”

The King of Kajor declared.

“If Earth Hill intends to continue to adhere to its current position, Kajor will not hesitate to go to war with Earth Hill.”

War.

The atmosphere in the conference room became chilly.

It was a very calm declaration compared to the contents, but no one in the seat was surprised. Of course, everyone knew about this.

Not only did they know it, but the other three countries were all close to Kajor’s side in the first place.

I glanced at Tair.

He was quietly looking at the King of Earth Hill with an extremely hard face.

The King of Earth Hill glared at the King of Kajor with angry eyes.

“How can you say the word war so easily?”

“It was not a decision made lightly. It means that you should recognize that our resolve is firm, King Longford.”

“...”

“I’d love to hear what other people think about this.”

As the King of Kajor looked around, the other three kings said their opinions.

“I think Kajor’s argument is justified enough. I don’t think it’s a matter for Rajan to interfere.”

“Mator is of the same opinion.”

“So is Plagas.”

The King of Earth Hill’s expression distorted once again.

Soon the emperor’s mouth opened.

“Santea has no intention of interfering in the dispute between the two countries.”

The Emperor had no reason to interfere in their warfare.

It was for a simple reason. Of the two countries, the one that was a little more cooperative with Santea was Kajor.

It was also because if things went sour later, he could simply take back his words and used this incident to grab Kajor's leash.

The only person left was the Overlord.

The King of Kajor glanced in the Overlord's direction.

The Overlord, who was sitting in her seat with a bored look, yawned and opened her mouth.

"Calderic has no intention of interfering, either. You all can do whatever."

At that moment, the slightest hint of anxiety that had been seen on the King of Kajor's face disappeared, and a feeble joy rose up.

I thought for a moment.

The war between Earth Hill and Kajor.

In the main story of the original game, it was not yet time for the war between the two countries.

I didn't know if the war had just started late after this declaration, or my presence simply caused some kind of butterfly effect.

Anyway, now Kajor was going to start a war to swallow Earth Hill completely, eating their lands one by one, starting from Lowalf Plains as an excuse.

The national power of the two countries was similar, but Kajor had also attracted the military support of the other three countries in the game, so it was difficult for Earth Hill to stop the invasion.

"What will you do, King Longford? Kajor is ready for war."

The King of Kajor's voice was relaxed, as if there was nothing to hold him back.

His concern about Calderic's interference was completely wiped out by the Overlord's remarks.

But he was mistaken. There was still someone here who could block him.

Even though the Overlord had declared that Calderic had no intention of interfering, that did not mean that I couldn't.

"If you intend to start a war, I will support Earth Hill."

Everyone focused their eyes on me after I spoke.

Bewildered, astonished, and shocked gazes.

The King of Kajor could not speak and blinked his eyes, then looked at the Overlord and asked.

"Certainly, Calderic won't interfere..."

The Overlord nodded and looked back at me.

"Seventh Lord, I have no intention of granting the military authority to you."

I already knew that.

Exercising military authority outside of Calderic was only possible with the permission of the Overlord.

I stared at the Overlord.

She narrowed her eyes. Then, as if she understood what I was trying to say, the corners of her mouth lifted and she burst into laughter.

"Puh, hahaha! Oh, did you mean that? Then I will not get involved."

Others were just making dumbfounded faces, as if they didn't understand the situation.

“I guess you misunderstood what I said.”

I moved my gaze back to the King of Kajor.

“As the Overlord said, Calderic would not engage in war. Even a tiny army, not even a single knight or wizard, will be mobilized.”

I said to him who blinking his eyes with a blank expression.

“It’s not Calderic who wants to support the Earth Hill Kingdom, it’s just me.”

Chapter 83.1: Neutral Nations Conference (4)

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The King of Kajor was completely at a loss for words.

Seventh Lord, what the hell was this person talking about?

...If we start a war, he will fight alone on the side of Earth Hill?

It's a strange declaration.

No, it's so absurd, like a nonsensical thing that wouldn't even make anyone laugh.

However, if the person who made that statement was a Lord of Calderic and no one else, it could no longer be nonsense.

He had reigned for a long time as the king of a neutral country sandwiched between two giants, Calderic and Santea. That's why he knew better than anyone.

How far beyond common sense was the power possessed by a real, transcendent person, not a mediocre strongman.

The Lords of Calderic, the power that each of them possessed alone, could literally overwhelm a nation.

“...”

Longford and Tair looked at him in a half-fazed state at the sudden remark of the Seventh Lord. So did the others.

“Isn’t that strange to say?”

The King of Kajor tried to use sophistry, trying to turn around the situation.

“A Lord is definitely Calderic’s military strength, even if only an individual will take part in the war...”

The Seventh Lord stopped him from speaking.

“Calderic is not a single nation, but a coalition of ten Lords.”

Lords were said to be independent powers who were in partnership, not subordinated and led by the Overlord.

The Overlord also laughed and helped.

“There was room for misunderstanding in my statement that Calderic would not interfere. Just accept that as my will.”

The King of Kajor felt something rising inside him and gritted his teeth tightly.

In terms of the formal system, it was indeed the case. But the words of the Seventh Lord and the Overlord were still sophistry.

But he couldn’t refute them.

In the end, all the contents of this meeting were ultimately made only by the will of both Calderic and Santea.

The neutral countries just asked for their tacit permission to take care of their interests.

If either side stepped forward directly, no matter what the justification or reason, it could not be resisted.

Just as Kajor mentioned the war in Earth Hill, the important thing was not just cause, but power.

How about Santea...

So the King of Kajor looked back at the emperor.

Since Calderic raised itself, only Santea could stop them.

However, the emperor was just looking at the Seventh Lord with a nonchalant expression.

Soon his mouth opened.

“Why do you want to support the Earth Hill Kingdom, Seventh Lord?”

The Seventh Lord answered.

“Is it right to cause warlike chaos by territorial issues at a time like this?”

“...”

“I just want the stability of the continent. And that’s probably the same for the hero. She seems to be still concentrating on her recovery, so I couldn’t help but take care of this problem for her.”

At those words, the corner of the emperor’s eyes twitched slightly.

The Overlord, who laughed at the emperor as if she was having fun, opened her mouth.

“Anyway, it looks like the Seventh Lord is really going to take part. How is it?”

The Emperor, who was silent for a moment, shook his head.

“There is no change in Santea’s will.”

“...”

“It’s not the best for peace on the continent to suppress unresolved conflicts by force. I was trying not to interfere in the dispute between the two countries. However, if it is the will of the Seventh Lord, I will respect that too.”

In the end, even if the Seventh Lord were involved, Santea would not intervene.

The King of Kajor let out a small laugh with a vain face.

The Seventh Lord asked him like that.

“The King of Kajor, do you still have the determination to fight the war against Earth Hill?”

“...”

“If there is no change, you can officially declare war here.”

After saying that, seeing the arrogant appearance of the Seventh Lord, who leaned back on the chair and crossed his arms, the King of Kajor clenched his fists tightly.

It was as if an ogre would suddenly intervene in a war between goblins.

The existence of the kingdom would be in jeopardy, even if that one thing came out.

“...My decision was premature. I will retract all the above statements. Kajor has no intention of going to war with Earth Hill.”

In the end, he had no choice but to raise his hands in surrender.

Other kings also sighed inwardly at the King of Kajor’s swift reversal.

But he had no choice either.

If Santea didn’t step forward, there would be no answer, no matter what.

“Do you think we still need to talk about this issue, or should we move on to the next one?”

Longford gazed at the King of Kajor, who meekly bowed down, then moved his gaze to the Seventh Lord.

With just a few words, he easily made Kajor back down, and he looked calm, as if being a wolf was natural.

He couldn't help but feel awed by Calderic's status once again.

But why in the world...

Why did the Seventh Lord help Earth Hill?

He still couldn't help but feel doubts and anxiety about him, so the relief was short-lived.

While the talks continued like that, Longford couldn't take his mind off the Seventh Lord.

Chapter 83.2: Neutral Nations Conference (4)

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After the long meeting, I sighed inwardly with a tired face when I saw the King and Prince of Kajor as they fled the conference room.

Anyway, I prevented the war with this.

Since I had clarified that I would support Earth Hill, Kajor would not attack Earth Hill in the future.

Although I had already stopped it, but even in the possibility that the King of Kajor really went crazy and invaded Earth Hill, there wouldn't be a problem.

All I had to do was really join the war and help Earth Hill.

There was no ability specialized in genocide in war as much as mine.

Of course, I didn't want to do anything like that, so it was a very good thing to stop the war with just a few words.

And the emperor is really that kind of character...

As shown in the game, he was a very snarky person.

In fact, there was another reason Kajor could declare war openly on Earth Hill this time.

The absence of the hero.

I could make sure of it after mentioning her to the emperor once.

Kajor trying to go to war, the king must have known that the hero wouldn't be here to stop the situation.

Did Kajor know about it because Santea leaked this information, or did he try to decide based on the reaction at the meeting?

I didn't know, but that didn't matter, anyway.

The war with the demons was a long time ago, but the aftermath suffered by the hero in the battle with the demon king continued to affect her.

Therefore, sometimes she had to focus on recovery irregularly to slow it down, and during that period, she couldn't afford to intervene with worldly affairs.

If the hero was here right now, there's no way the emperor would have been able to ignore the war issue at today's meeting.

It would have been nice to have met the hero at this meeting.

I haven't found the heir yet. But even if it's out of order, it would probably have been fine to meet and talk to the hero first.

I got up from my seat feeling a little sad.

The King of Earth Hill and Tair, who were still there, slowly approached us.

He looked at me and the Overlord once and bowed respectfully.

“Thank you for helping Earth Hill, Seventh Lord.”

Was it to say thank you?

I had nothing to say, so I just nodded.

Tair, who was standing next to him, asked me.

“...Seventh Lord, can I ask you one thing?”

“Ask.”

“No matter how much I think about it, I don’t know why the Seventh Lord is helping Earth Hill this much.”

The King of Earth Hill looked back at Tair in surprise as if he hadn’t expected to ask openly.

Looking at Tair waiting for an answer with a nervous expression, I pondered what to say.

If one thought about it, this situation was something that could be completely incomprehensible to them.

Why did a Lord block Kajor’s declaration of war even by directly stepping forward, even if it wouldn’t benefit Calderic at all?

In fact, even if I hadn’t met Tair in the Fifth Lord’s Territory, I would have helped Earth Hill.

The biggest reason I helped them was because of the main story of the game, not my debt to Tair.

It’s just that I unintentionally came into contact with Tair, and the reason to help became clearer.

I was going to say thank you for the map at this point, but decided to just stop.

Because the Overlord was listening, I was reluctant to bring up this or that.

“ In the name of my honor as a Lord of Calderic, I don’t have any ulterior motives. So, you can rest assured about that.”

I said to the King of Earth Hill.

It was because after the agenda regarding Kajor was over, he kept looking at me and showing a distraught expression.

He seemed to be misunderstanding that I might have some hidden plan, so I should give him some reassurance.

He shook his head with a puzzled expression as if my words hit the mark.

“I didn’t think of that.”

I moved my gaze to Tair and said.

“The reason I helped Earth Hill is as I said earlier. I don’t want unnecessary confusion on the continent. That’s all.”

Especially since the time was right.

Few people were aware of the shadows that were quietly covering the continent, but I knew very well.

The main story. The full-fledged movement of the demons would take place in a few years, but even now, dangerous movements were taking place all over the continent.

Because of my position, there were often big incidents that came to my ears on its own even if I didn’t look into it.

There were traces of a demon, presumed to be one of the ‘primordial demons’, in the village that was recently slain on the side of Santea.

Even if there was still time left, there was no time to relax.

It was because I didn’t know how my presence might affect the flow of the main story.

That’s why I had to control the variables I could control as much as possible, and keep moving toward my goal without rest.

“I see.”

Tair or the King of Earth Hill didn't seem to fully believe my words, but it was okay.

A Lord of Calderic wanted peace on the continent.

If the dead tyrant or the Black Sea Empress had said such a thing, I would have laughed out of embarrassment.

I made eye contact with Tair for a moment, then said.

“It's good that you returned to your kingdom.”

“...”

“There is nothing that can be done even if you continue to avoid things. Don't forget what I said then, and do your best where you need to be.”

Tair nodded, bewildered.

The Overlord, who had been quietly listening to the conversation, looked at me with an interesting gaze, but ignored it lightly.

I bowed to the King of Earth Hill and went out of the meeting room with the Overlord.

For a long time until the distance increased, I could feel Tair's gaze looking at me from behind.

later! I'm still editing it. ><

Chapter 84.1: Neutral Nations Conference (5)

Chapter 84.1: Neutral Nations Conference (5) ! Thank you to Baccano998, mjspixel, and Pop for the donations! ^^

After the meeting, we returned to our accommodation.

In the evening, a banquet with dinner was prepared, so once that was over, the schedule in Earth Hill was over.

I spent time leisurely in the room provided for me since I prevented the outbreak of war and accomplished all goals, so there was no reason to leave right away.

I leaned back on the sofa and stared blankly up at the ceiling, thinking about what I had to do.

The top priority was to find the heir to the Holy Sword in Santea.

This was something that I had to be really careful about. That's why I didn't entrust the collection of information to the Shadow either.

Like when I was looking for a mystery, I have to run and find it myself...

The problem was that the location of the heir at the present time could not be accurately specified.

There was a place where she was supposed to be, based on the information from the game.

However, the range was so wide that it would take considerable time and effort to eventually find it.

There are also those things.

In the realm of Santea, I knew the hidden places of two mysteries.

However, neither of them were abilities that I desperately needed right now.

I had already obtained various mysteries from Calderic and my specs had improved, and I was no longer a sunfish who would die easily.

But of course there's nothing wrong with getting it.

Absorbing a lot of mysteries didn't have any side effects, so it's better to get the mysteries that were still available.

The full-fledged search for the heir would have to be done after I took care of those two mysteries.

Of course, there was no guarantee that I would get it. For one, those hidden locations were hard to find.

And the meeting of the Lords...

The meeting of the Lords that would happen shortly after could overlap with what I was trying to do and thus becoming a variable.

There were still two commands remaining from the Overlord. I was not in a position where I could refuse it.

I still didn't know why she asked me to attend this meeting with her, so it was unknown what else she would try to order.

I still have a lot of things to do, so I hoped she wouldn't bring up something annoying...

“...”

While thinking about this and that, I slightly turned my gaze to one side.

I scratched my head as I felt Asher standing motionless outside the door.

I saw her when I came in earlier. She had an unusual atmosphere since yesterday. Without thinking, it must be because of the existence of the General.

General Cayden was the one who slaughtered Asher's family, and the emperor and the imperial family was the one behind it.

How would it feel to not be able to do anything even with their tribe's enemies right in front of them? I couldn't possibly imagine what that feeling would be like.

In fact, the massacre of the White Moon tribe, ordered by the imperial family of Santea, was not something that was quietly buried with no one noticing.

It was a catastrophe that had already caused outrage within the Empire.

And the person who was pointed out as the culprit was the fifth prince and his aides.

The real mastermind behind the massacre was the emperor, but the one he pushed as the culprit was the fifth prince.

Lagging among his brothers, he was just following his father's words to be acknowledged. But in the end, his own father threw him under the bus.

Asher was the only survivor of the annihilated White Moon tribe.

This incident that had already been concluded in such a way. Even if a survivor like Asher revealed her identity now, it would not threaten the emperor. So, there's nothing she could hold on to.

At best, she could at least receive an apology from the imperial family. But who needed something like that?

So, if Asher really wanted revenge, the only way to realize it was to get blood on her own hands.

There would be no proper way for her to avenge her clan's enemies unless she killed the emperor and the General with her own hands.

But it seemed to me that she hadn't quite decided yet. She didn't even have the ability to do that in the first place.

How could she, who was still only level 82, handle the emperor, who was the head of a huge power called Santea, and a level 91 general?

It's also not a matter I could easily get involved in.

To kill the Emperor and the General.

Obviously, Asher was a precious person to me.

I wasn't simply saying that because she was an outstanding talent.

I had already been with her for almost a year. We were together most of the time.

It was not simply a question of whether I could solve that problem for her. There was no way she would want that.

No matter how much I thought about it, she wouldn't want to get revenge on her enemies by asking me to do it for her. For her, there would be no point in doing that.

In the end, the best I could do was just help her grow.

So that when she had decided, she would have the strength to do whatever she wanted.

“...”

To do so, I had to quickly take Asher to that 'place'.

It was a place where Asher could achieve dramatic growth by exploding her potential, and it was also a place where a being, who could tell her the information about her tribe, was sleeping.

Of course, I already knew that there were no surviving White Moon tribe members other than Asher.

But telling her that directly would only arouse her suspicion, so it's better for a third party to do it.

Then my trouble deepened.

Should I prioritize finding the mysteries and the heir first, or should I take Asher to that place?

...Ah, I don't know.

I shook my head and laid down on the sofa. Let's just think about it slowly.

Chapter 84.2: Neutral Nations Conference (5)

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“I expected she wouldn’t come, but it’s still a pity. I wanted to introduce the Seventh Lord to the hero.”

The Overlord stirred the teacup and said lamentably.

The emperor who sat across from her watched in silence, then opened his mouth.

“What do you really mean, Overlord?”

“Hmm? What?”

“Helping Earth Hill, I don’t think it’s the Seventh Lord own action.”

“Ah... that? Right? I didn’t know that the Seventh Lord would suddenly come forward like that.”

It was true.

It was a fact that she did not know that there was a connection between the second prince of Earth Hill and the Seventh Lord, so she hardly expected the latter to intervene so actively in the conflict between the two countries.

It didn’t matter to her, that’s why she didn’t interfere.

However, the emperor narrowed his eyes in disbelief.

He opened his mouth again and asked.

“I’m afraid that maybe Calderic’s prestige will fall. It looks like the Overlord is protecting those who broke the rules and even killed another Lord...”

“Ah, thank you for your concern.”

At those words, the corner of the Overlord’s mouth went up.

“By the way, Emperor. If you say such nonsensical things again, do you want me to rip your mouth off?”

The expression of the second princess standing behind the emperor hardened at the Overlord’s sudden abusive words.

The emperor also looked at the Overlord with a weakly stiff face.

“Don’t act like we’re equal. Get the subject, you little rat. You should know that the only thing I respect about Santea is the hero.”

“You’re talking too much...”

For an instant, the terrifying feeling of intimidation enveloped her whole body, causing the princess’ legs to give up and almost sinking to the floor.

The Overlord, who had regained her momentum, smiled and leaned back in her chair.

“I didn’t come here to threaten you. I have a question for you too.”

At her words, the emperor’s complexion hardened.

“Prisoner transport ship, the warrior.”

“...”

“What the hell were you trying to do after catching ‘that’, Emperor? Even hiding it in a convoy and transporting it to a concentration camp?”

The emperor was just silent, not answering.

The Overlord, who drank all the tea, stood up.

“I’m warning you, Emperor. I don’t know what you’re trying to do, but stop doing useless things. If you don’t want to let precious workforce, like the warrior for example, to die.”

The emperor asked her as she headed outside her room.

“What does the Overlord want?”

“...”

“There’s no way you don’t know that the demons’ movements are unusual. If Santea collapses, it’s Calderic’s turn right after. Why are you showing such an ambiguous attitude towards Santea?”

The Overlord only looked back at the emperor and grinned.

Evening came, and the banquet began.

There were many people who attended besides those who directly took part in the meeting, so it filled the banquet hall with many people.

The royal family gathered in a corner and chatted about the outcome of the meeting.

Asher, who followed the Overlord and the Seventh Lord to the banquet hall, tried hard not to turn her attention to one side of the banquet hall.

It was because the emperor and the General, who accompanied him, were also seated there.

“...”

She could feel the eyes of the Seventh Lord staring at her.

Asher struggled to control her expression, thinking that she should not get distracted.

“Asher, go back to your room and rest.”

At the words of the Seventh Lord, she shook her head. The other must have noticed her current state.

“No. It’s fine.”

She was an escort knight, so it’s not right to go back alone and rest first.

But this time, the Seventh Lord seemed to be quite determined to get her out of the banquet.

“Then go out to the terrace and get some fresh air.”

Asher hesitated, bowed her head, and moved her steps to the terrace.

She felt the heat in her head subside a little as she went outside and caught the cool breeze.

“...”

Asher looked up at the night sky and recalled the memories she had buried deep within.

The enemy who annihilated her tribe—Santea and the General.

Asher couldn’t keep her composure at the sight of the Emperor and the General sitting calmly in the banquet hall just inside.

She lowered her head, feeling sorry for herself, thinking that she wasn’t really able to do anything she should.

No revenge, no tribe member found. Even though 10 years had passed since that terrible day, she still hadn’t been able to do anything properly.

...In fact, deep inside her heart, she might have already known. That there was no surviving tribe members anywhere.

She was just simply denying reality.

Was that why she couldn't even decide to get revenge and was wasting her time pathetically?

Even with the enemy right in front of her eyes, she couldn't even pull out her sword... How could she have the courage to look at her dead family members with the way she was now?

Asher closed her eyes and breathed, controlling her mind.

It was something she was used to. Until a few years ago, these thoughts surfacing was a daily and common occurrence.

After breathing for a few minutes and regaining some composure, Asher turned around to enter her banquet hall again.

It was then.

“...!”

A man walked into the terrace.

General Cayden.

He looked up at the sky as he stood on the opposite railing after glancing at Asher.

Asher's heart skipped a beat.

She thought, even if she made a fuss here, even if she tried to spew murderous intentions at him, it means nothing, and it would only harm Ron...

It was when she tried to move her steps, suppressing her boiling anger with superhuman patience...

“I’ve been thinking since yesterday, but I finally remembered.”

His mouth suddenly opened and stopped Asher.

She slowly turned her head and looked at him with cold eyes.

“Ten years ago, the Great Mountains of Alten. Were you the only one from the White Moon tribe that I failed to kill?”

Chapter 85.1: Neutral Nations Conference (6)

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She felt like her mind suddenly turned completely white.

For a moment, the anger and embarrassment she had been holding back rushed, tightening Asher's heart as if it would explode.

How...?

How did he notice?

It was a dark night 10 years ago, and it was just a moment when they met each other.

Asher didn't think he would recognize her, but apparently he did.

...No, those things were irrelevant.

Asher quickly came to her senses. She glared at the General with eyes full of murderous intent.

His gaze was indifferent and cold. It was the same look he had when they met at that cliff, something that remained in her memory until now.

A wind blew, and silence lingered for a while on the terrace with only the two of them.

"I thought you would die in the end, but I didn't expect you to be alive and well."

He obviously didn't like that fact, as evidence of his displeased voice. It brought a bit of joy to Asher, though.

"Do you remember me?"

"I just said that, didn't I?"

"..."

"There was one pesky White Moon that I had a hard time catching because it was quite ferocious. I remember it clearly."

The General glanced at the banquet hall inside and continued.

"Looks like you're an escort knight for the Seventh Lord. Did you commit yourself to Calderic for revenge?"

Asher opened her mouth, but shut it quickly once again.

Before she knew it, she realized one hand was already resting on the hilt of her sword.

Her throat trembled as she swallowed the rising rage.

If this conversation continued any more than this, she felt like she really could not control herself anymore.

Asher breathed in and out several times, and continued walking without paying attention to the General.

The General looked at her with a strange expression, then opened his mouth again.

"Aren't your attitude too lukewarm? The enemy of your tribe is right in front of you, you know?"

Asher ignored it and continued moving.

However, she had no choice but to reflexively stop again at the words that followed.

“It seemed that you value your life greatly. It’s a pathetic but wise choice. Keep running away from me like that from now on.”

Asher looked back at the General with a distorted face.

Did she value her life more? Was she running away?

What the hell was he spouting?

She couldn’t control her trembling body and finally opened her mouth.

“Shut up. I will surely kill you with my own hands someday.”

The General snorted.

“Yeah, that’s what I mean by making excuses and running away.”

“I’m not running away...!”

“Was the White Moon who was with you on the cliff at that time your younger sister?”

The string of reason suddenly broke.

“Then you abandoned your sister and ran away, and today you run away like this again. Your younger sister in the underworld will resent you. Crying out revenge when you’re just a coward.”

“...!”

Asher’s whole body was dyed pure white.

A huge black spirit rushed from her sword, which was pulled from its scabbard.

Wow!

Asher went out to the terrace, and soon after, the General, who was on one side of the banquet hall, got up from his seat and went out to that direction as well.

I, who was having a conversation with the King of Earth Hill, narrowed my eyes as I watched this scene.

I apologized to the king and stood up accordingly.

It could be just a coincidence, but it was still worrying.

And I was right to feel that anxiety.

It was because as I walked to the terrace and raised my super sensory, I heard two people talking.

– It seemed that you value your life greatly.

– Was the White Moon who was with you on the cliff at the time your younger brother?

– Then you abandoned your sister and ran away, and today you run away like this again. Your younger sister in the underworld will resent you. Crying out revenge when you're just a coward.

I tried to move faster with a cold, hard expression on my face. But that was then.

Wow!

A huge magical aura, and then an explosion.

Everyone in the banquet hall turned to that direction in amazement.

The smoke cleared, and I saw two people standing on the half-destroyed terrace.

I sighed inside.

This...

Asher's whole body was dyed pure white, even her racial trait was activated.

She drew her sword, and her eyes were bloodshot with anger.

And right in front of him, the General, standing calmly with one hand outstretched.

It was the sight of Asher launching an attack and the General blocking it.

Amidst the turmoil, the knights who had been guarding the surroundings quickly gathered, and the others retreated far away from the terrace.

I slowly approached the two people who were confronting each other.

“Asher.”

When I called her name, she glanced back at me, but soon turned her gaze back to the General and glared at him.

The Overlord, who had come nearby, tilted her head and said.

“What, isn't that the escort knight of the Seventh Lord? What kind of fuss is this all about at a fun banquet?”

The General, who looked at me and the Overlord, withdrew his outstretched hand and said.

“I was just defending against the attack. The knight here misunderstood something.”

I laughed.

I was dumbfounded because I had heard all the conversations the two had with my super sensory.

What kind of bullshit was that bastard saying just now?

The Overlord moved his gaze to Asher and tilted her head.

“Hmm... More than that, did you know about this Seventh Lord? Looking at that figure, she’s not a human, but a white moon?”

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The Overlord had never seen Asher use her racial trait, so this was the first time she knew about it. And there's really no need to tell her, so I never did.

People around her groaned at her remarks.

“White Moon tribe? If it's White Moon tribe...”

“Yes, at the Santea Imperial Family...”

It was 10 years ago, but at the time, there was no one who didn't know about the incident that made the empire buzz.

No matter how low-ranking a prince was, it was a great case in which they directly executed an imperial family member to save the name of that same imperial family.

I looked around and then looked at the two again.

“The woman who attacked me just now is a survivor of the White Moon tribe, as the Overlord said.”

The General's voice instantly calmed the commotion, reverberating throughout the banquet hall.

“And the reason she attacked me is because of the grudge she holds against the royal family of Santea. So I understand that.”

Then, looking at Asher again, he spoke in a polite voice.

“As one of the Five Stars of Santea, I express my sincere regret for the past mistake of the imperial family.”

“...”

“However, it was a cataclysmic event carried out by the fifth prince and the people under him. It was not the will of the imperial family. They had already been judged and executed under strict justice. I understand your hatred towards the imperial family, but I’m not the enemy who destroyed your tribe.”

Asher’s body trembled.

His heinous words completely dumbfounded me.

The General, this bastard, was the main culprit in directly annihilating Asher’s tribe following the emperor’s order.

That same guy was saying he had nothing to do with it.

The imperial family completely covered up that terrible massacre by pushing all the blame to the fifth prince and his aides.

The only ones who knew the truth were the emperor, the General, and Asher, the only survivor. Of course, except for me who played the game.

The emperor, who had come and stood nearby, watched the situation with calm eyes.

It was an expressionless face. He seemed startled at first, but then just looked at the General.

The General, who glanced at the emperor, exchanged glances with him before opening his mouth again.

“Survivor of the White Moon tribe, if you still want to burn such fleeting hatred, I’ll gladly accept it.”

“...”

“It means that you can formally challenge me to a duel. If your sword touches me, then I will give you my head.”

At those words, it was only then that I understood the purpose of the other.
Duel.

He provoked Asher with this thought from the beginning.

What then was the purpose? Did he want to take Asher’s life by doing this?

Whatever it was, it was just an obvious provocation that didn’t have to be reciprocated, and there’s no way that Asher wouldn’t have noticed that.

But she seemed to have already lost half of her reason.

“Asher, stop it.”

Asher turned to me.

I was telling her with my gaze to not fall for this obvious provocation, and that she could have her revenge later.

“I’m sorry, Sir Ron.”

“...”

“This time... just this once, I beg you, please don’t stop me.”

It was a dangerously trembling voice, colored with many emotions.

She turned her gaze to the General, spewing out her murderous intentions again.

“I will challenge you to a duel, General Cayden. I will slit your throat as you said.”

The crowd stirred once more, and the General looked at me.

“Will you allow it, Seventh Lord? It’s a matter of life and death, risking each other’s lives. Please swear that you wouldn’t interfere in the duel until a clear victory or defeat was decided.”

“...”

The crowd’s eyes turned to me.

The Overlord next to me looked back and forth between Asher and me with an interesting gaze, as always.

I sighed inwardly.

A duel between Asher, who was level 82, and the General, who was level 91.

The result was already determined.

The nine level difference between the 80 and 90 levels was a vast gap that could not be crossed no matter what.

It was impossible for Asher to win against the General, one of the five stars.

And from the way he spoke, it’s obvious that he wanted Asher’s life.

However, Asher didn’t seem to be in a state where she could do anything about it.

This was the first time I had ever seen her release such a vicious killing intent.

The magical energy I felt inside her body was boiling unsteadily, and her hand holding the sword was twitching, as if ready to be swung toward the General’s neck at any moment.

...Should I stop this?

If I tried to stop it, I had to force Asher.

There was no reason to allow a duel in which the outcome was obvious, anyway. But...

“...”

Seeing Asher’s expression once again, I decided not to.

No matter what the outcome, if I stopped this duel I felt like she would go astray.

In the end, I had to nod my head.

“Do it.”

Thus, the duel between the two was concluded.

The duel took place in the gymnasium located outside the banquet hall.

As spectators, only me, the Overlord, the emperor, and the kings of other neutral countries were seated.

Asher and the General stood facing each other in the middle of the gymnasium.

The General was holding a spear much longer than his height in one hand as a weapon.

The General immediately spoke to Asher.

“I will yield the first move.”

Chapter 86.1: Neutral Nations Conference (7)

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General Cayden recalled the memory of that day as he looked at Asher standing across from him.

One member of the White Moon tribe that he failed to kill because of a moment's carelessness.

That little mistake was a memory that had haunted him like a thorn in his flesh to this day.

I never thought we'd meet like this.

That's why the current situation made him happy. It's an opportunity that came by chance.

This time, he would kill and eliminate the last remaining one and tie a complete knot.

The General lightly swung the spear in his hand and opened his mouth.

"I will yield the first move."

"..."

Asher's whole body turned white again.

The momentum she radiated was still quite menacing, but unlike before, she had regained her composure to some degree.

General Cayden of Santea.

In her memory, he was nothing short of a monster when he massacred her tribe ten years ago.

He swept away even the warriors of such a strong tribe without them being able to fight properly.

Even so, Asher did not think of defeat.

No, she didn't dare think of such a possibility.

Over the past 10 years, how many times had she overcome and destroyed walls to become stronger?

She didn't think about how big the gap between them was. Right now, she just believed in herself and raised her fighting spirit.

Swoop.

Magical power that had been purified to the limit with her special ability sped up further and circulated through Asher's body.

It was an opponent she had to fight with everything she had. Asher raised her power from the start.

Pure white brilliance dyed her sword, and white magical rings appeared vaguely all over her body.

The General stood calmly and looked at her like that. Whatever she did, he seemed willing to wait. A blue aura also appeared in his spear.

And in the next moment, the energy from Asher's sword was fired at the General like a flash.

Kwaaang!

The blade of the sword and the spear interlocked with a roar.

The General, who lightly blocked the attack without retreating a single step, turned the spear and threw it upward. Asher moved.

She immediately bent down and dodged the attack aimed at her neck, then thrust out her sword again. A blow aimed at his leg. Again, the General simply blocked it.

An intense skirmish ensued.

Sword and spear collided nonstop, sometimes cutting through the empty air. The white and blue auras intersected and intertwined in a dizzying manner.

A mighty shockwave arose from each collision. It felt like you would be slashed if you even came a little closer.

Among the spectators, those who were not of high level could not follow their movements with their eyes at all.

They retreated further from the boundary line, tired of the magical impact and shock wave spreading in all directions.

The flow of the battle flowed toward Asher attacking and the General defending.

The General also counterattacked from time to time, but mostly Asher seemed to push him.

A feeble pleasure welled up in Asher's heart.

The General was clearly strong.

But it wasn't as overwhelming as she thought. It seemed as though a gap was slowly opening in his defense.

Asher added strength and speed to the limit of her offensive attack.

She just needed to dig a little more, just a little more. Then it really felt like her sword could land on his neck.

However...

“...”

As time passed, Asher's complexion slowly hardened.

It was because she gradually noticed their gap.

No matter how much she swung her sword, at some point the gap wasn't closing at all. As if she couldn't reach him from the beginning.

Caang!

The blade of the sword and the blade of the spear meshed together, and the momentary battle stopped.

Asher met the General's eyes. His eyes were as cold and dry as they were at the start of the duel.

'Did you know now?'

He seemed to say that.

Only then did Asher realize. From the beginning, she had been toyed with and played in his grasp.

The gap between the two of them was not just a little, but, on the contrary, it was far beyond imagination.

Wow!

He fired a blow at Asher, who was trying to step back with terrifying speed. It was a different speed than before.

Blood spurted down Asher's cheeks. Barely turning her head to avoid the attack. She had to block the attack that followed without a break.

Swing, stab, and strike. The fight intensified.

The energy in the General's spear was similar to that of Asher's sword. But each blow was incomparable.

He didn't give Asher the slightest bit of leeway. However, he also didn't land a blow that would completely end the duel.

Asher could see what he was thinking as she narrowly countered the dizzying rain of attacks.

...Are you sure you intend to kill me?

For a moment, reason flew, and she accepted the duel with the General, but Asher was not an idiot, so she vaguely understood his intention.

Chapter 86.2: Neutral Nations Conference (7)

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What was the reason for provoking her to reach this situation and bringing it to this point?

The only reason was so he could take her life legitimately through a duel.

But he couldn't win quickly and show to everyone their overwhelming difference in skill, so he must be adjusting his level of attack in moderation.

Only by feigning such a fierce battle could he gain the justification that he inevitably killed his opponent during the duel.

But if she surrendered now, the General would have no choice but to end the duel.

A declaration of surrender obviously overshadowed the outcome of the duel, and he couldn't do more tricks in front of everyone watching.

But she didn't plan to do that.

Even if she had to die fighting right here, she didn't want to.

She knew it's not a rational choice at all, and it would be just a meaningless dog death.

The words of the General about her running away to save her life stuck deeply in her heart like a knife and erased her option to back down.

Asher gritted her teeth.

If her sword couldn't reach his throat, then she would take at least one of his arm.

The pure white ring around Asher's body emitted a stronger light.

A method of mana management that divided mana into three cores and amplified them through resonance between them.

Even in the history of the White Moon tribe, no one other than the founding father succeeded in fully mastering this skill, which was extremely imperfect.

Asher activated all three cores to the maximum without hesitation.

Her strength had now surpassed the limit. Even she herself didn't know how big the price she had to pay for this.

Wow!

The area around the General's eyes frowned slightly after he blocked the sword attack from the suddenly amplified energy.

He, too, energized his spear and parried Asher's attack.

While running wild like a madman, she moved her eyes here and there to keep track of the spear's path.

The physical ability beyond the limits, and the senses.

The chaotic lines drawn by his spear, which she couldn't understand just a moment ago, were more clearly imprinted on her head.

Within seconds of the unsteadily rampaging mana, pain came to Asher's body. But she didn't care.

In a battle where even one's life was lost, a sudden enlightenment came for a moment after she crossed her limit.

She hung on tenaciously to that elusive, faint enlightenment.

Just a bit more...

Despite Asher's awakening, it was the General who still had the upper hand. He had never done his best in the first place.

The spear through Asher's side with a shallow cut. Next were the legs and shoulders. Her blood spurted out and her sword still did not reach him.

The balance of her body was on the verge of collapsing because of rampant magic, and what held her consciousness was just a momentary superhuman concentration.

A window of ever-changing creativity. The realization that she came across accidentally while teaching Rigon, but couldn't understand it fully.

It was only for a moment that the small pieces that had been playing separately in her head connected like a line.

Peit.

Blood spurted up the General's face.

Asher stretched out her sword and realized what she had done a beat later. There were fine lines of blood on his cheeks.

...Ah.

In the end, she couldn't reach it.

It was only a shallow graze.

Asher poured everything into that last attack. She staggered as she felt all the energy draining from her body.

“...!”

The General's face twisted like a demon.

He hurled the spear blade straight at the collapsing Asher. It was so powerful that it could turn her body into a handful of blood in an instant.

Wow!

A spear that stopped mid-air.

The blade of the spear stood still, unable to move further, as if something invisible had blocked it.

The sudden appearance of a man in front of him startled the General, and he withdrew his spear and retreated. It was the Seventh Lord.

After accepting the collapsing Asher, he stared at her who had lost consciousness, then moved his gaze to the General and opened his mouth.

“The duel is over. It’s your victory.”

The General’s eyelids trembled at the fury that welled up inside him.

Victory, it was natural from the beginning.

He was feeling indescribable shame at the fact that even a little of his blood had been shed for such an obvious result.

“Seventh Lord... didn’t you swear you wouldn’t get involved in this duel?”

“And?”

The Seventh Lord said with arrogant eyes.

“What do you want to say?”

“...”

It was as if the other was asking what he would do if he didn’t keep his promise.

The General, lost for a moment, glared at the Seventh Lord. That was all he could do.

Chapter 86.3: Neutral Nations Conference (7)

Chapter 86.3: Neutral Nations Conference (7)

I ignored the General glaring at me and looked at Asher's condition.

Although her mana was unstable, she seemed to have only fainted from exhaustion.

More than that...

I shifted my gaze to Asher's level.

【Lv. 85】

After a sudden surge of energy, her level spiked mid-battle.

It jumped three levels from level 82 to level 85.

Did she cross the wall during the battle?

It was a fierce battle, so I wondered if there was anything strange about it.

It is one of the representative clichés to gain enlightenment and grow while fighting a mighty enemy. Of course, this was reality and not some webnovel or comics, but...

In any case, it was a great achievement to have landed an attack on someone nine levels higher than her.

I looked at the General again. Then I pointed my finger on my cheek, obviously referring to his wound.

“It’s a pity. If it was a little deeper, your mouth would have been ripped out.”

The guy gritted his teeth and said as if he was chewing.

“...I was just careless. If only I had done my best in the first place.”

“Yes, today will be the last time you can make excuses like that.”

It wasn’t intentional, but this made Asher’s growth much faster than the main story in the game.

I looked back and forth between the bastard and the emperor and said in a low voice.

“I assure you. There is not much time left before you pay the price. Both you and the emperor.”

The General forced a laugh.

“It was just a once-in-a-lifetime coincidence. The white moon woman’s sword will never touch me again.”

“Even so, nothing will change. If she couldn’t kill you, then you will die by my hand.”

Both the Emperor and the General were villains who would pay the price for their crimes in the main story of the game.

It’s just that this was not the right time yet.

At my words, his expression hardened.

“What is that...?”

“So, take good care of the short life you still have.”

The duel was over.

Under the eyes gathered in all directions, I turned around with a sneer while supporting Asher.

“...”

When she opened her eyes, she saw the ceiling.

Asher stood up and looked around blankly. It was the room provided to her in the castle of Earth Hill.

“Oh, are you awake?”

A woman was sitting next to the bed, and several maids were standing in the back. The woman sitting there was Seri, the princess of Earth Hill.

It also took aback Asher because she knew who the other was.

Seri explained the situation with a slightly awkward smile.

“You passed out during the duel. I thought you would wake up much later, but you woke up earlier than expected.”

Looking out the window, it was dark because the dawn hadn’t completely broken yet.

Asher searched her memory. The attack of the General after her last attack failed, and the Seventh Lord.

Recalling the fact that the Seventh Lord blocked the General’s attack and stopped the duel, she closed her eyes tightly.

Again...

Was it because she poured everything into the duel with the General?

The emotions that had been burning like a fever until she passed out seemed to have faded and left only the embers.

Rather, she felt guilty that she had troubled the Seventh Lord again by going wild. What face could she show him after that?

Asher looked at herself.

All the wounds from the spear had almost healed. It looked like he gave first aid with a potion.

Rather, the burden on her body was greater because of the reaction of using his ability to the limit. It felt like her whole body was twitching.

She thought about the duel in a daze for a moment, then suddenly came to her senses and apologized to Seri.

“I’m so sorry. I completely ruined the banquet.”

“It’s fine, don’t take that to heart, Sir. Are you feeling better now?”

“It’s okay. By the way...”

Why was the princess looking after her?

Seeing as if she had read her puzzled expression, the Seri smiled and said;

“Don’t mind me. I was just trying to stay here for a while until the Sir Knight woke up.”

“Yes, thank you. It must have caused a lot of trouble, moving me here and the treatment as well..”

It would have been cumbersome to move her from the gymnasium outside the palace to her room.

But Seri shook her head.

“Ah, it wasn’t us who carried you here. The Seventh Lord did it.”

“...?”

She got up from her seat with a mischievous look on her face, and stretched out her arms, lowered them, then raised them.

“So, after holding the fallen Sir Knight in his arms like this.”

Then she pretended to let go of her raised arm.

“The Seventh Lord came all the way to your room and put you on the bed and left.”

“...Yes, yes?”

Asher’s face, stuttering in embarrassment, turned red.

Chapter 87.1: Ruins of Cabolissa

(1)

Chapter 87.1: Ruins of Cabolissa (1) ! Thank you to Detro, Pop, and Ymmm116 for the donations! ^^

As the dawn rose in the morning.

I woke up to the sound of voices coming from the next room.

Has she come to her senses already?

I couldn't sleep, so I was just lying in a daze on the bed, but it seemed that Asher had already woken up.

I didn't know why the princess of Earth Hill said that she would look after Asher, but I really cared little for the reason, so I just left her in Asher's room.

– So, after holding the fallen Sir Knight in his arms like this.

– Yes, yes?

...What nonsense were you talking about?

I opened the door and went outside, not expecting that the princess actually had that kind of personality.

I walked over to Asher's room next door and knocked.

“Asher.”

There was a commotion inside for a while, and the lady-in-waiting immediately opened the door.

I saw Asher getting up from the bed and the princess sitting next to her. Both looked quite bewildered.

“Ah... Seventh Lord, she just woke up and...”

I looked at Asher and asked.

“Are you okay?”

The traumatic wounds were treated with potions, and looking at her body with super sensory, her mana had already stabilized.

I asked that as I moved closer to the bed, Asher looked restless.

She avoided my gaze and couldn't seem to know where to look, but in the end, she lowered her head and opened her mouth.

“...Sorry.”

The first thing she did was say an apology with a choked voice.

To be honest, this time it was clearly her fault, so I didn't respond much. Of course, I fully understood how she must have felt. Still.

“Well then, I'll just leave you to it.”

I nodded my head at the princess' words.

“Yes. Thank you for looking after her.”

“No, my lord, it's nothing.”

The princess nodded and went outside with the ladies-in-waiting.

I sat down in the chair she was sitting on.

“...”

Silence passed between the two of us for a while.

I had only come to check on her, and since I had confirmed that she was fine, I had nothing to say.

What should I say in the first place? Since she had leveled up, should I say congratulations on your progress?

But while I was thinking about it, she, who had been hesitant, opened her mouth again and spoke first.

“I’m sorry, Sir Ron.”

As expected, it was an apology again.

This time, I responded with a click of my tongue.

“Are you going to keep apologizing?”

“...”

“It’s true that you’re at fault this time, but I don’t really want to scold you for that, so stop let’s just stop talking about it.”

“But I caused too much trouble. Sir Ron even broke his oath because of me...”

...Oath?

I wondered what she was talking about for a moment, but then I realized what she meant.

She seemed to speak about how I promised the General that I would not interfere with the duel before they concluded it.

I was a little taken aback because her expression looked so guilty.

Well, in this world, there was an idea that promises and oaths were sacred and equivalent to one's honor.

Especially if it's someone in the position of a Lord in Calderic.

She probably thought I had taken a great insult by breaking my oath.

I don't really mind.

Of course, I didn't feel any humiliation or shame.

Could I feel embarrassed about breaking a promise I didn't intend to keep in the first place?

She's probably worried that I would lose my prestige as a Lord. But that's not something I cared about.

On the side of Santea, the hero was the only one who I needed to give importance. There was no reason to maintain a good relationship with the imperial family.

And more than anything else, I just wanted to mess with that General bastard by breaking the oath and preventing him from doing what he planned to do.

I stared at Asher and said.

"Your life is no less important than my honor."

At that, she flinched and raised her head.

The corner of her eyes were gradually turning red, so I changed the subject while panicking inwardly.

"You seem to have grown again in this duel. Even more than last time."

"...Yes that's right."

Asher nodded, answering in a slightly choked voice.

I pondered for a moment, organized my words, and then opened my mouth.

“Behind the massacre of your clan, the emperor is behind it.”

Aside from the General whom she had seen with her own two eyes, Asher probably wouldn't know who was truly the mastermind. She probably would have guessed it roughly though.

When I pinpointed that fact, Asher's expression changed.

But she didn't seem to doubt how I knew about that or how I was sure of it. That meant she already trusted me that much.

I continued talking.

“The Emperor is a madman who only thinks of the prosperity of humans. The reason he ordered the slaughter of the White Moon tribe simply had to do with that.”

“...”

“Your vengeance against Santea is perfectly reasonable and justified. I can guarantee that. If that's the reason for your hesitation in taking revenge, there's no need to even remotely feel that.”

“...No, I—“

Asher shook her head in pain.

“I'm just afraid. If any of the members of my tribe survived, I must find them. I can't just leave them alone just because my vengeance blinded me too much.”

I sighed and thought to myself.

Should I prioritize my plans, or respect Asher's choice and prioritize it?

It was something I had been thinking about for a long time.

I said that her existence was indispensable only until I found all the mysteries I needed and could protect myself without her help. But honestly, I couldn't give that excuse now.

From the beginning, my relationship with her was one that began with my deception.

Even though I knew the truth that no members of her tribe had survived the massacre, I told her I would help her look for them as an excuse to use her.

The deeper my relationship with her had become, the greater my guilt was.

I had been indebted to her so far.

If it wasn't for her, I wouldn't have dared to search for mysteries while wandering around Calderic with a weak body that couldn't even wield a sword.

In the end, after much deliberation, I finally decided what to do.

"Whatever it was, your choice was not wrong."

I said that and got up from my seat.

Asher looked up at me with a bewildered face.

First, I have to take Asher to that place.

Chapter 87.2: Ruins of Cabolissa

(1)

Chapter 87.2: Ruins of Cabolissa (1)

The place differed from other ruins and dungeons. It needed an item to enter.

An ancient magic stone.

This magic stone differed from the ones usually used to make magic items.

The limitation of magic stones was it could not be stored for a long period, no matter its purity.

That's why there were always mages present at the teleportation point in the Overlord's castle.

Although during the golden age of ancient magic, the magic stones produced and used by mages could store magic spells for a very long period.

That was why ruins and dungeons that remained and operated normally could exist.

However, in modern times, there was almost no similar magic stones left on the continent anymore.

This was because the materials necessary for crafting magic stones like this were no longer in existence.

It was also impossible to mine the remains of ruins and dungeons.

Of course, it didn't mean that there were no remaining pure magic stones out there.

I remember the Overlord possessed one.

I didn't go looking for her right away, but first I looked for the King of Earth Hill.

"Magic stone... Unfortunately, our royal family doesn't have one, Seventh Lord."

"I see."

The King of Earth Hill said, looking apologetic.

I didn't expect much anyway, so I wasn't too disappointed.

In the first place, that kind of magic stone was a great treasure whose value could not be converted into money.

I let go of my lingering feelings and went straight to the Overlord.

"You need a magic stone the size of a fist?"

The overlord snorted in response to my words.

"I have some, but I couldn't just give it to you for free."

"What do you want?"

"Well... there are two more times the Seventh Lord has to do my request. If you agree to increase it by one, I will it to you."

At those words, I clicked my tongue inwardly. Couldn't she just give it for free?

He was reluctant to increase the Overlord's request by one more.

"Are there other Lords who have magic stones?"

The Overlord replied with a smile.

“First Lord, Second Lord, Fourth Lord, and Eight Lord. As for the others, I don’t know. They may have them, or they may not.”

“...”

“I’m sad that you’re being so coldhearted, Seventh Lord. Do you really hate following my order?”

I thought as I listened to her sly words.

Except for the Eight Lord...

Fortunately, I could ask the rest of the Lords who had magic stones.

Because the First and Fourth Lords owed me, while I had the weakness of the Second Lord.

I thought about whom to go to and soon decided.

Actually, there was nothing to really think hard about.

Rather than going to the First or Fourth Lord to pay off their debts and receive a magic stone, it was much more profitable to go to the Second Lord.

Because she couldn’t settle her debt cleanly just because she did a favor for me.

After all, I had made a vague promise to give her an important information as long as she helped me

Maybe if the conversation went well, I could get it for free.

In the morning, we slowly prepared to leave the castle.

There was no proper cage, so Ti-Yong was in a large space on the side of the castle. When it saw me, it fluttered and tangled with excitement.

“Thank you again for helping us, the Earth Hill Kingdom. Have safe travel.”

I rode on Ti-Yong’s top while being escorted by the King of Earth Hill, Tair, the princess, and first prince.

I made eye contact with Tair one last time.

Since the war has been stopped, there would be no more dark clouds in Earth Hill.

However, looking at the awkward atmosphere between them, the conflict between the royal family must not have been resolved yet.

Tair also looked back, hopefully, he would reconcile with his family and solve their misunderstandings.

“Let’s go.”

When I tapped Ti-Yong, it flew up with a loud roar.

When we came, the Overlord accompanied us, but we separated as we returned.

The Overlord headed for her castle and I headed for the Second Lord’s territory.

Because the speed of the wyvern was so frightening, I definitely saved a lot of time after I got Ti-Yong.

If it had been in the past, there wouldn’t be much time left until the next meeting of the Lords, so I wouldn’t have had time to do this.

It took an instant to get from Earth Hill to the capital of the Second Lord’s territory.

I immediately visited the castle and met the Second Lord, and I quickly brought out the business I came there for.

“...You mean, you need a magic stone?”

“Yes, roughly the size of a fist.”

“You came out of nowhere in the middle of the night to ask me to give you a magic stone?”

“Yes.”

I shamelessly nodded to answer the Thunder Lord sitting across from me.

Her expression distorted with astonishment.

Chapter 88.1: Ruins of Cabolissa

(2)

Chapter 88.1: Ruins of Cabolissa (2)

“There’s a certain level to being shameless...!”

The voice of the Second Lord was full of sharp edges.

It was an expected reaction.

I came to her suddenly and asked for a precious magic stone. Even I think I was being shameless.

Anyway, looking at her reaction, she definitely had one.

“I already warned you before. If you keep trying to use me like this...”

“I will make sure the last one would be the last.”

I didn’t want to continue arguing with her, so I just cut off whatever she was trying to say.

It startled the Thunder Lord.

“...The next request will be the last one?”

“Yes. If you give me the magic stone I needed, I will definitely tell you the location of the spirit I promised you at the end of the next request.”

I glanced at the level floating above her head. It was still 90 like before.

A place with a powerful spirit comparable to Laxia, the great thunder spirit that I annihilated.

As long as that was a bait, she definitely couldn't refuse.

She said, looking at me with her eyes narrowed.

“Do you even know how precious magic stones are? To be honest...”

“If you're going to talk nonsense, I will just find another Lord.”

I immediately blocked what she's trying to do.

At my words, she frowned again and stopped.

“Where are you going to use the magic stone?”

“Is that important?”

“...It's not important. Please keep your promises properly, Seventh Lord. You must give me the information I needed at your next request.”

“Of course.”

Contrary to the earnest voice of the Second Lord, I nodded with a light heart.

She clicked her tongue with a very uncomfortable face and stood up.

“Wait here.”

Apparently trying to get it herself, she went out of the room.

I leaned back in my chair and waited patiently for her to return.

If she gets the spirit, she'll definitely be antagonistic again.

But no matter what attitude she showed, I had no intention of not keeping my promise.

Unless she's an idiot, she wouldn't recklessly attack me again after being beaten like that.

Soon after, she returned to the room. She was holding something the size of a fist in her hand.

The magic stone she held, unlike normal ones with a faint bluish tinge, had a completely transparent light.

I took what she handed over and examined it.

“Thank you. Then I'll leave.”

Having obtained the magic stone, I immediately left the Second Lord's Castle.

It was late at night, but I didn't want to stay at the castle of the Thunder Lord. I was certain neither did she, so I moved right away.

There were many ruins and dungeons in the game.

Some of them had nothing to do with the main story, but there were, of course, some that had to do with it.

Ruins of Cabolissa.

A ruin left by a great mage who was praised as a great sage during the ancient time.

The place I was visiting with Asher was also a ruin related to the main story in the game.

It was an episode in which Asher found out the truth that there was no survivor and finally decided what she should do.

Oh oh oh!

As we continued to slow down and change direction from earlier, Ti-Yong let out a roar, perhaps feeling frustrated.

I patted its neck to calm it down and then looked down intently.

The present location was a vast plateau to the west of Santea.

As the Ruins of Cabolissa was a place I passed through in the game as part of the main story, I definitely remembered the place.

It was a terrain like a deep pit...

It was a fairly large terrain, so it shouldn't be difficult to find.

And as I thought, I was able to find it soon.

In the middle of the field, the terrain suddenly protruded like the crater of a dormant volcano.

"Let's go down."

He guided Ti-Yong to land in the middle of the pit and got off its back.

It looked small from above, but when we came down, the protruding surface was so high that it completely blocked my view.

Let's see...

I looked around and found the entrance to the ruins with my super sensory maxed out.

I didn't have to look for long. Soon, I found the thing I was looking for at a distance. It was a rock embedded in a slope, a huge magical energy was emanating from it.

That's it.

Asher and I moved closer to the rock.

It was a long and wide rock reminiscent of a stone gate, and in the center of it were three fist size magic stones in a triangular shape.

Two emitted a soft golden light, but one only emitted a transparent light because it was half broken.

I examined the half-broken magic stone here and there and touched it with my hand. I tried to pull it with a bit of strength.

Hmm.

It didn't even budge.

Even though half of it was broken, the magic stone stayed firmly embedded in the stone gate and did not move.

I pretended nothing was wrong and said to Asher.

"Pull this out."

"...Ah, yes."

She, too, seemed to have sensed the mighty magic power within the rock, and was distracted by it. She then stepped forward at my words.

Then, the broken magic stone was easily pulled out of the hole.

She looked at me with a puzzled expression as I inserted the magic stone I had brought into the hole.

Although the size was not right, the magic stone stuck like a magnet as soon as it touched the hole.

And soon the magic power felt from the rock stirred like a simmering fire, and even dyeing the magic stone golden.

I stepped away from the shaking rock and spoke to Asher.

"Try injecting magic into the rock."

Asher hesitated for a moment, then put her hand on the rock and created magic.

Then, her blue mana and the golden mana mixed, and the rock split apart and opened on both sides.

Coo coo coo.

Chapter 88.2: Ruins of Cabolissa

(2)

Chapter 88.2: Ruins of Cabolissa (2)

Even in the game's story, this place was a ruin that a lot failed to enter when it was first discovered because of the broken magic stone.

If it was just a simple ruin, one could just break inside, but this place wasn't that simple.

Eventually, an inner passage was revealed. Luminous stones densely studded the ceiling, so it wasn't dark.

“Let's go.”

Asher, who was staring at the passageway with a puzzled face, turned around as if she was a little surprised.

It must be because whenever I found a place like this during my search for mysteries, I always let her stay outside and entered alone.

However, this place was a ruin only for Asher. Even if I couldn't explain that to her.

I moved first, and as always, Asher silently followed me asking nothing.

It's wide.

I walked through the wide aisle, feeling the cool air on my skin.

And we quickly arrived at a much wider space with a magic circle engraved on the floor.

Magic stones were everywhere, lines connected by magical power, and a magic circle in the center, just like the underground scenery seen in the Overlord's Castle.

Asher and I fixed our eyes on the top of the magic circle.

It was because something like a translucent blue light was wriggling in the air. It looked like some kind of spiritual body.

Knowing what that thing was, I calmly waited.

Rather than a guardian of the ruins, should I say that it's more of a guide?

This guy was to guide any visitors for the ordeal prepared by the owner of this ruin.

Soon the guy took shape and changed into the appearance of an old man.

– ...How long has this been? Someone finally came!

A very excited voice rang in my head.

The guy grinned and looked at Asher, and I, then continued.

– Welcome, adventurers! This is the place that the great sage Cabolissa arranged for her successor. Those of you who have found this place are qualified to challenge the ordeal. There are two trials prepared. Choose one of the two trials. If you pass, a reasonable reward will wait for you at the end.

As the guy said, I looked at the two entrances on one side of the space.

Asher followed me a beat later and moved her gaze.

– The entrance on the left is an ordeal that tests brute force, and the entrance on the right is a test of mental strength. If you fail the ordeal, you will lose

your life. So, choose wisely. If you don't want to challenge the ordeal, you can leave the ruins now.

I fixed my gaze on the entrance on the right.

A trial of mental strength.

This would bring out the painful memories of the challenger, would drive the mind to the limit. It was an ordeal where one had to overcome agony and suffering.

It could be said that it was like the hallucinations that Asher suffered from monsters in Hallmenta before.

The only difference was that the degree would be much higher than then.

However, since this was an ordeal to the end, if Asher herself was determined, she could somehow overcome it. Like how it happened in the game.

If you fail, you lose your life.

Although there was a big risk to take, I didn't worry because I had something to protect myself from it.

Because I had [Soul of the King], mental attacks wouldn't work on me.

In the event of an emergency, I planned to take Asher and escape.

Of course, I didn't know what other dangerous devices were in place in this ruin, but I would have to take that level of risk.

"Go through the right entrance, Asher."

I said that and walked to the right entrance.

Asher followed me with a look of confusion, not knowing what this ordeal was all about. The guide also floated and followed us.

Inside the entrance, another magic circle covered the entire room, but the magic I felt was much bigger.

— You have chosen the trial to test your mental strength. So let's start the ordeal right away.

The guide raised magic power, and the magic circle that responded to it emitted a bright light.

“...!”

Asher, who was staggering, immediately fell to the floor. The magic that was activated blew her consciousness away.

On the contrary, I was still standing.

However, I feel the memories of the past rushing through my head like a tidal wave.

Oh...

It's roughly like this.

All the painful memories I had experienced in my life so far passed by clearly. It amplified my negative emotions to the limit.

But apart from the fact that there were no difficulties in my past life, I was also not mentally disturbed because of the [Soul of the King].

I just watched everything with a novel feeling. But came after that were unknown memories.

“...?”

...What was this?

I was running away, bleeding to the point of darkness, chased by some pursuers.

A burning town, screaming people, and me standing blankly in the middle of it...

The unknown memories confused me, but I was able to realize it soon.

It's the memory of the real owner of this body.

Fragments of irregular and tangled memories rose to the surface and then sunk back down.

I furrowed my brows and recalled the past memories.

However, the memories that had already passed once quickly faded like a dream and did not come to mind.

– Ho, you held up quite a bit?

The guide smiled as he saw me standing there.

– But if you keep holding on like that, you will go crazy. Come on, lose your mind like your colleague. This is an ordeal designed to be overcome, not to be endured soberly...

“Hey.”

I cut him off and said.

“Could you make the hallucination magic you're currently using even more powerful?”

– ...Huh?

“It's not coming back because the memories have passed. Hurry before I forget.”

He looked at me with a puzzled expression. It was as if he was looking at a madman.

Chapter 89.1: Ruins of Cabolissa

(3)

Chapter 89.1: Ruins of Cabolissa (3)

Unknown memories.

I hurriedly urged the guide to strengthen the magic to see if those memories would return, but the answer that I got was disappointing.

– I only activated the already engraved spell, so it's not something I can control. No, more than that, why are you fine...?

Shit.

I clicked my tongue and scratched my head.

Memories that have now completely disappeared only linger in my mind, with only fleeting moments remaining sparsely.

What was it?

It differed from the déjà vu memories I experienced last time in Actipol.

I knew it instinctively. It must have been the memories related to the original owner of this body.

It was regrettable that the memories ended there.

There's no reason to know this body's past. But anyway, it's a body that I possessed, so I have no choice but to be curious.

I was immersed in my thoughts as I recalled the fragments of the faint memories that remained, and then I looked up.

– Was there something wrong with the magic? There’s no way that could be the case... But it makes little sense to resist with pure mental power...

“Hey.”

I asked the guide, who was circling above me and behaving frantically.

“Is this the end of the ordeal?”

– ...

The guy grunted and groaned and eventually answered reluctantly.

– Yes... You have passed the ordeal. It’s the first time I’ve seen such an absurd case.

It ended very simply.

Since I had the [Soul of the King], I already expected this result from the very beginning.

I turned my gaze to look at the collapsed Asher.

I passed, but it would take a while for her to overcome the ordeal and wake up. It was like that in the game.

It took a whole day and a half.

When she challenged the trials in the game, she was at a lower level than now.

The higher the level, the easier it would be to pass through the ordeal. The situation wouldn’t be worse than what it was in the game.

All that’s left now was to wait patiently.

I moved closer to Asher.

I turned her over and laid her upright, then moved to the wall at the corner and sat down with my back leaning against it.

The guide, who was looking at the scene curiously, asked me.

– A really strange person came in. Is there anything else you want to ask about the ordeal? Your colleague is probably going crazy inside her mind.

He probably thought that my carefree attitude was strange.

He probably initially just thought of me as an adventurer who stumbled into the ruins by accident.

I asked the other.

“Since I passed the ordeal, would I receive a reward?”

– Uhm, yes. But if you leave this place alone, the ordeal would be void.

Of course, there was no way I would leave Asher alone and go out on my own.

Rather, I should prepare just in case she did not pass the ordeal...

Will leaving this space lift the effect of the hallucination magic?”

– Yes.

“Then, is it against the rules if I forcefully take out a colleague who has not passed yet?

– Of course it’s a violation! Once you challenge the ordeal, no one can interfere. If such a case happened, I will punish you myself.

The guide shouted resolutely.

I stroked my chin and looked at his level.

【Lv. 83】

Fairly high level.

It could be called a spiritual body, but it was not a mere soul, since I could see his form clearly.

Judging from the aura I felt, it was mixed with magic power... It must have been the magic of a great sage.

The source of power was not the energy of nature, but magic power. I wondered if it was like that of a spirit.

If Asher failed the ordeal and he prevented us from escaping outside, then we would have to fight.

It would be difficult to spread a shield, so if a battle broke out, was it best to annihilate the other with a surprise attack?

As if he knew what I was thinking, the guide had his arms crossed with a solemn expression.

I spoke to the guy again.

“I’m bored. Let’s talk.”

– Talk? Hmm, good.

He appeared uninterested, but he couldn’t hide his excitement.

Like the initial reaction earlier, he must have been stuck here alone for a very long time.

If I tried to become close to the other like this, he might let his guard down and then it would be easier to do a surprise attack later when needed.

Of course, there was the fact that he was the only one I could talk to here. It could at least ease my boredom.

– The last group of challenger came here over 100 years ago. There were five people, and they challenged the ordeal of force.

– I don't know how it is in this era, but the great Cabolissa was the greatest sage of her day...

I quickly tired of his nonstop chatter and just kept my mouth shut.

I tried to dig up some information about the ancient times, but there was no useful information I could get from him.

Time passed that way.

I ate the food I had brought little by little and looked at Asher's condition.

I knew by now what she was going through in the illusion that she's experiencing.

It would be painful, but in the end, in order to grow, she had no choice but to face and overcome everything.

Chapter 89.2: Ruins of Cabolissa

(3)

Chapter 89.2: Ruins of Cabolissa (3)

A night of storms and thunderstorms.

There was a woman who was running on a mountain road through heavy rain.

Asher held onto her sister's hand and swung her sword. She cut down the monsters that attacked from all sides.

In that desperate escape, the destination was always the same.

Asher, who stopped at the edge of the cliff, looked down at the river that was raging because of the heavy rain. She was panting.

She looked back.

A monster holding a spear was slowly walking toward them.

“...Aaaaaaa!”

How many times was this already?

Asher screamed and tried to run towards him. But it was just futile.

Tuuk.

As always, the body did not listen, and only the bitter smile of the younger sister who pushed her down the cliff was the last thing she saw.

Spash!

Asher sank below the surface. She no longer had the strength to struggle.

She knew about this situation that was repeating several times, dozens of times, and hundreds of times. Like a terrible nightmare.

She stood at the scene of the massacre again. She felt her heart slowly crumbling in terrible agony.

“...Run away, Asher! Don’t look back!”

Father cried as he held her dead mother in his arms.

Asher ran away with her sister again.

She fled while the assailants slaughtered her father and tribesmen. Once again, she was driven to the edge of a cliff.

Falling down the cliff again. Again, the cold spear’s edge pierced his sister’s chest.

Again, again, again.

“...”

Asher realized at some point that this was all an illusion.

She just recalled that the Seventh Lord, and she found a certain ruin... and then she followed the other to challenge some kind of ordeal without really knowing why she should.

Was this the ordeal?

Then what was the ordeal for?

What had passed cannot be undone. She couldn’t change anything in reality, the same could be said for this illusion.

That fact made her so miserable that Asher burst into tears.

She saw the General walking towards them with heartless eyes.

The younger sister, who was holding her hand, looked back at her. She looked bewildered after seeing her sobbing.

“Sister, what’s wrong? This isn’t the time to be like this. Come on...”

Yeah, nothing would change in the end.

Even if she returned to reality, the only thing she could do was revenge. Neither the dead family nor the dead tribe members would come back alive.

Maybe she was really the only one left in the world.

Whatever it was, your choice was not wrong.

It was only after her heart was driven to the brink of collapse that Asher could finally admit everything.

An irresistible sadness came over her, but she was no longer confused.

Asher grabbed her sister’s hand as the other tried to push her away.

She grabbed her arm and pulled her closer. Then she hugged her tightly.

“I’m sorry, I’m really sorry...”

“...”

“So... stop it now.”

The younger sister, who was embarrassed and tried to get out of her arms, halted.

Asher held her for a long while before slowly pulling away.

Her younger sister was smiling.

It was a smile that was a little less sad than before, and a little less bitter.

Squeak.

Her younger sister's body scattered like a mirage and disappeared.

Asher wiped the tears from her face and looked ahead. The General was standing there.

The surrounding scenery had changed. From the cliff, into the endless darkness of nothing.

She injected power into the hand holding the sword. Asher ran towards him.

And the very next moment, the blade of the spear blew Asher's neck off.

Darkness raged, and time went backwards.

Asher, who had died in an instant, stood face to face with the General again.

She pounced again, and this time she couldn't hold out even three times, and he pierced her heart with his spear.

“Argh...!”

Strong.

It was a strength that could not even be compared to when he fought her at the banquet in Earth Hill before.

She too had grown significantly since that day's duel, but the gap was still far away.

This was the General's strength, and it must be the true gap between him and herself.

However, this place was only an illusion, only in one's memory, but what on earth was its existence based on?

Consciousness? Imagination?

A small question arose, but whatever it was, it didn't really matter.

Asher stared at the General in front of her with emotionless eyes, then attacked again.

Dozens of duels, and well, hundreds of attacks came and went.

Asher also died and resurrected just as much.

There was no reason to worry about one's life in this fantasy, where death would not be the end.

She gradually got used to it. She lowered her fighting spirit and emotions to a minimum and contemplated calmly.

Even while fighting, she looked at the battle between the two as if she was seeing it through a third person's eye.

She examined every movement and imprinted it on her head. She jumped back and recreated the action.

In the endless repetition, she finally understood and accepted them one by one until she broke down the wall.

3056th death.

Asher's body split in half and regenerated again.

There were faint bloodstains on the General's arms as well. It was a wound from her sword.

It's not enough...

She didn't know how close she had to be to his level or to what level she had to reach to end this ordeal.

But Asher hoped it wouldn't end that soon.

Even in this fantasy, she hoped she could continue to wield her sword until she overcome him.

About half a day passed, and for the first time, a change appeared in Asher.

She was still lying like a dead log, but the level floating above her head changed.

【Lv. 86】

One level up.

Looking at the scene, I felt some relief.

That her level had risen meant that she was safely passing through the ordeal without collapsing in the illusion.

A little more time passed and her level went up one more level, reaching level 87.

It was an abnormal speed, but after stopping there, it did not rise for a long time.

And maybe half a day or so had passed.

“...?”

I, who had been staring at the ceiling while lying in a daze, jumped up.

It was because Asher’s body, which could not move until now, trembled weakly.

And...

【Lv. 90】

...She leaped three levels from 87 all at once and finally broke the 80 wall and reached level 90.

It was the same level she had reached in the game after overcoming the ordeal.

– Ohh...

The guide's low exclamation rang out.

Soon Asher's eyes slowly opened.

Standing up, she looked around with calm eyes and met my eyes.

I hadn't decided what to say, but I involuntarily asked, reflexively.

“Have you overcome everything?”

She stared blankly at me for a moment, then slowly nodded.

“...Yes.”

Sadness and joy, emptiness and sense of accomplishment, and regret and relief.

With a smile as if all conflicting emotions were mixed, she said;

“It seems to be the case.”

Chapter 90.1: Ruins of Cabolissa

(4)

Chapter 90.1: Ruins of Cabolissa (4) ! Thank you to Little Mermaid for the donation! ^^

After regaining her consciousness, it felt like the atmosphere around Asher changed a little. It's like it became calmer or something.

I didn't know if it was because she had reached level 90 or because she had a big change of heart during the ordeal.

At least it didn't seem like it was going in a bad direction, so I was a little relieved.

– Since both of them escaped from the illusion, the ordeal is now over.

The guide said so and moved to one side.

It was a wall with nothing blocked, but as soon as the guy created magic and seemed to do something, a change appeared.

Coo goo.

The wall cracked and slowly opened on both sides.

Asher and I looked at the scene revealed within.

There was a magic circle at the end of the short passage, and a staff was embedded in the middle.

A space that I once saw while playing the game.

A space that would be a major turning point for Asher.

Recalling that faint scene in my memory, I felt a little strange.

– Since you passed the ordeal you deserve to be rewarded accordingly.

I knew what the price was, so I didn't bother to ask.

I glanced at Asher and followed the guide toward the staff.

Asher also followed me with a questioning look.

– Alright then...

As the two of us stood in front of the staff, the guide used a much bigger magic than before.

Magical power flowing in golden light quietly swirled around and the magic circle flashed.

As I was watching this scene, I looked into the air and noticed that the guide had already disappeared.

Saaaaaa.

It took an instant for all the enormously turbulent mana to be absorbed by the staff.

A faint shape slowly emerged from the staff in the quiet surroundings.

A translucent spiritual body that resembled the guide, but appeared to be a young woman.

Great Sage Cabolissa.

A great mage who ruled the golden age era of ancient magic.

With a hazy look, she glanced at Asher and I alternately.

– Haa... Did someone finally passed the ordeal? How many years had it been before the magic...

The voice of lamentation resounded in my head first, and then her words continued.

– Nice to meet you, adventurers. I am Cabolissa Orbilt, the mage who created this ruin.

“...”

“Why is there no answer? If you know who I am, introduce yourself too.

I only blinked my eyes at her, but I opened my mouth briefly.

“It’s Ron.”

Asher, who was looking at the great sage as if she was curious, also answered.

“This is Asher.”

The great sage, slightly displeased, continued her story.

– Well, good. I also have a lot of questions about the outside world, but I have little time. The fact that you came all the way here and woke me up must mean that you passed the ordeal I prepared.

“Yes.”

– The reward for that is my knowledge. Until the magic that holds me now runs out, I can answer any of your questions. But the time would only be 10 minutes. Originally, it was much longer than this, but considerable time had passed and there has been a small error in the magic formula. I can’t believe that no one had passed the ordeal for such a long time.

It was she who spoke as if lamenting once again.

I remembered she was a person from ancient times, so this ruin must be the same.

– I was once the most adept at the truth of this world. If you want magical enlightenment, I will help you, and if you crave other knowledge, I will also answer to the best of my knowledge. So, you can ask me anything.

I had little time, so I asked without hesitation.

The reason I came here was to ask this from the beginning.

“Do you know about the White Moon tribe?”

My question took aback Asher.

The great sage replied.

– It’s the White Moon tribe, of course I know. Aren’t they a race with the ability to increase purity by purifying mana? I also had a few close friends there with whom I had a personal connection.

“This woman is from the White Moon tribe.”

I continued talking while looking at Asher.

“In the current era, the White Moon tribe is almost exterminated because of certain... circumstance.”

– ...Hmm?

“What I want to know is whether there is at least one member of the White Moon tribe living on the continent other than this woman?”

The great sage looked at Asher with strange eyes.

Asher looked at me with a rather perplexed expression.

She’s probably thinking no matter how the other was a great sage or not, she’s still not a god, so how could she know of such a thing?

But I knew that the sage could figure it out.

– You’re making a pretty novel request.

“Is it impossible?”

– No, it’s not impossible. As long as it has all the necessary conditions.

I heard a loud gasp.

At the great sage’s words, Asher’s eyes were shaking as if an earthquake had struck.

The great sage said to Asher.

– I need some of your blood, so just drop a few drops on the floor.

“...Yes, yes.”

Asher hurriedly cut his palm with a knife, causing blood to flow.

I watched the scene quietly from the side.

Her blood dripped onto the floor and formed a small puddle.

Chapter 90.2: Ruins of Cabolissa

(4)

Chapter 90.2: Ruins of Cabolissa (4)

– I will explain briefly. The magic that I will use is a magic that searches for beings that have the same roots as your blood. In short, it's a magic that can find your people.

The great sage raised her magic power and explained.

The stunned Asher asked in a trembling voice.

“With that... you mean it's possible to find my people, no matter how far away they are?”

– It's basically impossible. No matter how much magical power I possessed, is it possible to search across the entire continent?

“Then how...?”

– But if I combine it with one of my mysteries, it's possible for a very short time. Even if I explain that part, you won't understand it, anyway.

Asher kept her mouth shut.

It really didn't matter what the principle of it was, the important thing was if it could find her tribe members.

Wooo.

The golden and black auras were mixed and dwelled in Asher's blood.

One was the magic of the great sage, and the other was a power of unknown origin. It's probably the mystery the great sage said.

Soon, a translucent sphere appeared in the air just above the blood, and the magic wriggling inside the sphere drew an arrow.

Asher swallowed saliva with a nervous face, and I also watched the results with sunken eyes, a little nervous in a different way.

To be honest, I also had a bit of hope.

In the game, there were no survivors except for Asher, but it could have been different here.

So, I also deeply wished for that tiny possibility to exist. But...

Squeak.

The arrows that had been spinning dizzily in all directions, like a broken compass, had disappeared.

I sighed inwardly.

Small expectations were betrayed, and the natural result came out.

Not understanding what that meant, Asher turned her attention to the great sage.

– Hmmm...

The great sage nodded slightly and said.

– They no longer exist.

“...Yes?”

“There is no member White Moon tribe on this continent except for you. That's the result.

Hearing those words, Asher froze.

She stared blankly at the sphere floating in the air, not moving.

Finding a surviving member of her tribe.

It had been Asher's only purpose in life since that massacre, the only driving force for her to endure.

...But now, that's all over.

It wasn't until we reached this point that I felt a bit of regret. Was I too hasty?

Was I swayed too much by the main story, so I threw her into unbearable pain without considering her current condition?

“...”

But as if putting shame to my concern, Asher's expression didn't waver at all.

No sadness, no denial, no anger, no reaction whatsoever.

She just closed and opened her eyes once, muttering with the most bitter eyes.

“I see.”

It was a calm voice that even sounded relieved.

I looked at her like that and asked the great sage.

“...Is there even a single possibility that the result will be wrong?”

“No. The magic unfolded perfectly. You can cast it again if you wish, but it won't change the result.”

The great sage looked back at Asher and said.

– I’m sorry, child of the White Moon tribe. I don’t know why they exterminated your clan, but...

Asher shook her head.

“No. Thank you for using your magic.”

Asher seemed to have fully accepted the truth the great sage had told her.

To be honest, I wasn’t expecting such a calm reaction, so it surprised me inside.

Even if she had little expectation of the existence of a survivor from her tribe, now even that glimmer of hope has disappeared. And it’s basically confirmed that she was the only White Moon tribe left in this world.

I wondered if maybe she had finally decided on something during the ordeal.

...Anyway, things went well just fine.

I couldn’t find anything to say for a moment, then opened my mouth.

“Are you okay?”

Asher nodded.

“Yes, I’m fine.”

“...”

“I’m really okay, Sir Ron. It’s just that my heart is a little empty. The fact that I am the last White Moon tribe on this continent, and that my clan would just end with me...

Then the great sage intervened.

– What do you mean your clan would end with you?

“Yes? Well, since I am the only White Moon tribe left on the continent...”

She looked at Asher in a puzzled way and said, as if she understood.

– Oh, did you not know? The White Moon tribe is a race capable of interbreeding with humans.

“...Yes?”

– When White Moons reproduce with humans and give birth to offspring, there is a half chance that White Moons will be born. You are the only White Moon tribe left in this world, but that didn’t mean it’s impossible to leave descendants.

Asher blinked blankly.

– So, you reproduce with a human male and give birth to a White Moon, and your children reproduce with another human and give birth to a White Moon. If the descendants continue to carry on the lineage of the White Moon in that way... Well, it might take a very long time before the tribe flourishes again. But at least, it wouldn’t end with you. Do you understand?

“...”

– So find a human male, marry him, and leave as many offspring as possible. That’s the only advice I can give you.

Asher nodded with a bewildered face and murmured softly.

“...Human male.”

Then she glanced at me, and when our eyes met, she shook her head in amazement.

“Oh, no...”

“...?”

“No, it’s not like that... I’m sorry.”

What was she talking about?

I wondered what it was, but soon I just ignored it and moved my gaze to the great sage.

Now that time was short, I also have a question I want to ask.

“Great Sage.”

– Hmm?

“Do you know about the existence of another dimension?”

Chapter 91.1: Ruins of Cabolissa

(5)

Chapter 91.1: Ruins of Cabolissa (5) ! Thank you to Avarco for the donation! ^^

The continent of Rachronia was originally just nothing more than a game.

Earth was the original real world.

The phenomenon of possession, where I became my current body and a character in the game, was the beginning of everything. It was the biggest question I currently have in my mind.

And, of course, I had never talked to anyone about it before. Because there was no point in doing that.

But what if I asked that question to the great sage?

I asked her about it with a bit of expectation.

– Another dimension?

“Yes, I’m talking about a world where laws and civilizations differ completely from this world. Do you know of the existence of such a world?”

The great sage looked bewildered at my question.

– Well... I don’t know. I don’t have any knowledge about a world from another dimension. At least, to the extent of having meaningful evidence to back it up.

“Are you saying you don’t believe it?”

– Yes. I remember hearing similar hypotheses put forward by some idiots a few times, but they were all unfounded. It’s just the realm of wild fantasy.

“...”

As expected, even the greatest sage could not give the answer I needed.

I changed the question a bit.

“Then do you feel any sense of alienation about my existence?”

Since I was from a completely different world, I wonder if she could see anything different about him.

I asked this without expecting much, but the great sage looked at me blankly and answered immediately.

– Now that you say that...

“...?”

– Well, I thought it was just my mood, but after hearing that, I understand. There’s a subtle sense of disparity in your soul. It’s the subject I delved deeply into the most in my life, so I’m quite confident about that.

“A sense of disparity?”

– Yes, it’s like the soul didn’t fuse with your body properly.

I opened my eyes wide at the words that pierced my heart.

The soul and the body did not fuse.

Wasn’t she talking about the phenomenon of me possessing this body?

“And?”

– And what? It’s just the feeling that I got. If you’re going to ask me the cause, I also have no way of giving you an answer.

I was a little excited for a moment, but then I calmed down again.

Yes, she didn’t know about the existence of other worlds, so could I even dig up more information related to this?

Still, if there was some harvest from this situation, it’s the hope that the phenomenon of possession that happened to me would not be a completely unknown territory where there was no answer.

A sense of disparity between the body and the soul...

The great sage, who was looking at me with strange eyes, tried to say something.

– I wish I could, but you...

Waaa!

But at that moment, the magic circle on the floor shone brightly and the great sage’s shape distorted and slowly faded.

She let out a small sigh.

– Looks like the time is up already. Unfortunately, the conversation ends here, adventurers.

I asked her.

“Is your existence completely gone now?”

– Yes. In the first place, my spirit was barely holding on to this dead body with magic.

If there was more time, I could have asked more questions.

Feeling regretful, I stared at her as she slowly disappeared.

– You can take any items left in the ruins, including this staff. Then...

Soon, her soul completely disappeared.

I stared into the space where she was for a moment, then reached for the staff.

Even if she didn't tell me, of course I was thinking of taking it.

I pulled out the end stuck on the floor and examined it.

The staff of the great sage.

She didn't explain in detail, but having played the game, I was well aware of the abilities in this magic item.

Of course, it was useless to me, who didn't have a drop of magic.

Anyway, it was a very good item, as the great sage used it during her lifetime, so I could give it to anyone later.

Since Rigon was also talented in magic, I could let him use it when he grew up much more than he was now.

“...”

I grabbed the staff and looked back at Asher.

She seemed to be a little stunned from earlier.

The news about her being the only White Moon tribe out there must be a big shock even if she said that she was fine. Or was it because of what the sage said about how she could continue her bloodline? I couldn't really tell.

Well... it must be embarrassing.

What the great sage said earlier about the latter was quite absurd, but it was realistic advice.

Now there was only one White Moon tribe left in this world, the fate of her tribe rested on her shoulders.

Even if I were in her position, I would have felt so absurd and burdened in my heart.

She would make the choice, but given her personality, there was no way that she would cut off the bloodline of her tribe forever.

In the end, all she had to do was to find a human she love and leave a descendant of the White Moon tribe as advised by the great sage.

“Asher.”

When I called her name, it startled Asher, then she turned to me.

“Yes, Sir Ron.”

I asked her calmly.

“What are you going to do from now on?”

There was little reason for her to remain with me now.

Because she finally found out that there was no surviving member of her tribe.

The choice from now on was solely up to her, and even if she said she would leave me like this, I had no intention of stopping her.

“The reason you became my escort in the first place was because I told you that being with me would make it easier for you to spread your fame on the continent.”

Chapter 91.2: Ruins of Cabolissa

(5)

Chapter 91.2: Ruins of Cabolissa (5)

I continued talking to her who looked at me with a slightly stiff face.

“But there is no need to do that anymore. You have confirmed that there are no survivors of your tribe. And you also achieved tremendous growth in just a year.”

“...”

“Your choice was not wrong, no matter what. You may leave my side as it is. Either for revenge or, as the great sage said, to continue the bloodline of your clan...”

Asher was silent for a long time without opening her mouth.

I waited patiently for an answer.

I say this, but of course in my heart I didn't want Asher to leave.

Where else would I find a person with a level 90 strength and who I could also trust at the same time?

Having played the game, I knew very well that she had even more potential for further growth.

I just wanted to leave the choice completely to her own will, because that's how much I respected her.

After a long silence, Asher opened her mouth.

“If by any chance you don’t want to keep me by your side, please tell me honestly. In that case, I’ll gladly leave.”

“...”

“If it’s not like that, if you’re really just being considerate of me... I’m sorry, but I’ll continue to stay by your side even with my lack of ability.”

The end of her voice trembled slightly.

It was me who should be nervous, but she looked much more nervous than me.

Without knowing why, she was taken to an unknown ruin and challenged an ordeal, and also learned the truth about her tribe.

She must have had a lot of questions about my strange behavior, but she didn’t ask me anything.

...She had been really patient.

I thought while feeling joy and relief inside.

Perhaps the reason she would continue to stay was because of the grace or the sense of debt she felt towards me.

There were quite a few situations where I saved her life, after all.

This was my last remaining small selfishness, so I did not bother to ask her why.

“There’s no reason I wouldn’t want to have you around.”

“...”

“So you can do whatever you want.”

Relief passed over Asher's face at my answer.

I chuckled.

I was concerned, but she would not leave my side after all.

This solved all the problems that bothered me at once.

"Can I ask just one question?"

Then Asher asked me.

I nodded.

"I wonder what purpose Sir Ron is acting for."

It was something she had never asked me before.

It's not something unanswerable, but it's a really vague question.

I thought for a moment and then answered.

"It's for the peace of the continent."

"..."

"Why, is it something unbelievable? Or is it too simple?"

Of course I knew it myself.

I was not a hero, and that's not a word that was suitable for a Lord of Calderic.

But it wasn't a lie.

In order to preserve my life, I had to make sure that this world was safe first.

Asher blinked, but soon smiled and shook her head.

“No. If that’s what you choose to do, I’d be happy to join you.”

There was also one thing I was curious about, so I asked.

“What are you going to do with the continuation of the bloodline of your tribe?”

“...Yes?”

“Fortunately, the sage said you can leave offspring with a human. So, I’m asking what you’re planning to do in the future.”

Asher was now the only White Moon left in the world, so if something happened to her, the White Moon tribe would be forever gone.

I was glad that she had stayed by my side, but there’s still that matter regarding her tribe. So, I couldn’t help but worry.

“Ah, uhm...”

Asher’s face turned a little red.

She rolled her eyes here, and there, then lowered her eyes to the ground before answering.

“...The bloodline of the White Moon tribe, of course, will not be cut off no matter what, but I still need to consider what to do more carefully.”

Even though the sage suggested a way for her, it must have disturbed her, as it was hard to find a worthy human partner out there.

“If you find someone you like, tell me immediately. I will help you wholeheartedly.”

“...Yes.”

“Then let’s go out.”

The business of visiting these ruins was now over.

I stopped walking as I was about to exit through the entrance we had entered.

I wondered if there might be another item besides the staff I had packed, so I took a closer look at the ruins.

...There are no more useful items.

After looking around the ruins for about 30 minutes, there was nothing useful I could find.

Well, even if it wasn't an item, if there was a magic book, I would have taken it with me, but there wasn't even such a thing.

She said in a patronizing tone that we could take any remaining items from the ruins, but she didn't even have anything she left behind aside from the staff.

Anyway, after such a simple search, we went outside.

The sun had risen in the middle of the sky when we came in, but the sun had already set, and it was dawning again.

I looked at the sky dyed with sunset for a moment, then looked away.

I saw Ti-Yong, who had been sleeping curled up on one side, woke up when he found me.

"Let's go."

I jumped on the back of the guy who waddled up and flew straight away.

By the time we return to Calderic, the meeting of the Lords would be right around the corner.

Chapter 92.1: Task

Chapter 91.1: Task ! Thank you to Bebe and Ymmm116 for the donations!
^^

After returning to the Seventh Lord's castle, there was a very short time left until the Lords' meeting.

While waiting until then, I rested quietly. After participating in the meeting, I would then start with my plans.

He just leveled up again.

Reef and Rigon were sparring with each other at the gymnasium.

I looked at Rigon and clicked my tongue.

[Lv. 29]

Was he at level 23 the last time I saw him before leaving for Earth Hill?

In that time, he had risen another 6 levels and was on the verge of reaching level 30.

Kakakakang!

Reef, who was blocking the dizzying attack, accelerated as if to end the duel.

Reef's sword sharply cut Rigon's sword upwards, but in an instant, Rigon slashed towards her.

Reef threw away her sword and kicked Rigon with her foot at the surprise reverse sword attack.

Rigon was thrown up in the air, and he rolled several times on the floor before stopping.

“Ouch...”

She could not control her strength at the moment because of the surprise counterattack.

“Are you okay?”

The sparring ended with Reef approaching the fallen Rigon in embarrassment.

As the level went up, the growth rate would gradually slow down, but at this rate, Rigon would surpass Reef’s level within half a year.

I wondered if it would be possible.

I heard the current situation from Gulpiro, who just came to the castle to see the faces of the siblings.

He said that he was spending a leisurely time in a mansion on the outskirts of the city.

“She was a really great woman.”

And as I suggested the other day, he had visited and met the workshop master of Alkimas once. From the looks of it, he seemed to like her.

“Are you going to make her your disciple?”

“No, what disciple? I just stops by the workshop from time to time and give advice.”

I wondered if he realized that just by doing that; they were almost like master and disciple. No matter, it’s a good thing, anyway.

I took a walk around the castle and thought about various things.

I thought about not attending the meeting, but it wouldn't really change anything.

The messenger would send the contents of the meeting to the Lords who didn't attend, so there was no big problem in not attending.

The only downside was one wouldn't be able to express their opinion during the meeting.

Presumably, the odds that the Overlord wouldn't command me to do something during this meeting were very low.

Since she had the right to command me anything two more times, there was no way to escape, even if I didn't attend the meeting.

I was very reluctant, but it felt very selfish to be dissatisfied, and I didn't want to do that.

The position of a Lord was not free. There were rights and interests that I had enjoyed so far, so it was only natural to return as much.

Of course, it wasn't even a position that I wanted from the beginning.

Had it already been a year since I first possessed this body?

I seemed to have fully adapted to my current situation.

To be honest, I felt I could relax now.

I gained many abilities, and I was no longer in a position to spend every day in tension with threats that could come at any moment.

I enjoyed absolute power in a higher position than anyone else and lived a life completely separated from my previous world.

It's not too bad as it was, but...

It's pathetic.

If I settled for complacency like this, it's over.

I knew better than anyone else that there was only destruction awaiting me in the future.

I still had a long way to go. I haven't even started yet. Again, I made a decision.

Time passed, and the meeting of the Lords came.

Accompanied by Asher, I rode Ti-Yong and quickly headed for the Overlord's Castle.

I arrived at the Overlord's castle just in time, almost before the meeting started.

Asher, who couldn't enter the meeting room, left me in the hall and I went to the meeting room alone.

“...”

While walking through the hallway, I accidentally ran into the Third Lord – Heavenly Palace.

For some reason, he was standing in the middle of the hallway, staring at one of the stone statues on display.

He turned around without saying a word and immediately looked away. And then he took a step towards the meeting room.

I looked at his back, and then I continued walking.

I didn't know what he was doing just now, but since he's an elusive character anyway, I stopped trying to understand him.

In the meeting room, only the First Lord, the Wiseman, had arrived.

“Welcome, Third Lord. And Seventh Lord.”

I nodded and walked over to my seat and sat down.

After a little more time passed, the Fourth Lord, the King of the Dead, arrived, followed by the Ninth Lord, the Giant King, with a heavy echo.

It didn't take long for almost all the Lords to arrive, one by one.

Only the Second and Eight Lords did not enter the conference hall until the Overlord and chief of staff appeared.

I thought as I looked at the vacant seat of the Thunder Lord.

Did she not attend on purpose?

She had lost a lot of power, so maybe she's trying to avoid facing the Overlord.

It wasn't my business, so I no longer thought about it.

“The Second and Eight Lords are not attending, so shall we start?”

The Overlord clapped her hands and immediately began the meeting.

The aspect of the meeting did not differ from what I had experienced once before.

One after another, the agenda was discussed, and the Overlord entrusted several Lords with reasonable tasks according to the cause.

And the Lords accepted it with little disagreement and moved on.

Chapter 92.2: Task

Chapter 92.2: Task

After the agenda prepared by the Overlord was over, some Lords also brought up personal agendas, and further discussions took place.

I kept my nerves high throughout the meeting, wondering what the Overlord was going to order me, but...

“Okay, this meeting ends with this!”

The meeting ended there.

The Overlord announced the dissolution without entrusting me with any work until the end.

...What?

I couldn't help but feel a sense of wonder.

I thought she was going to make me do something at this meeting.

I suddenly became hopeful that she wouldn't give me a task until the next meeting in a year.

Then the Overlord's eyes met mine.

She smiled at me and opened her mouth.

“Ah, Seventh Lord, will you stay? I have a story I want to share with you for a while.”

...So, it came.

At that, the other lords cast their eyes at the Overlord and me with a puzzled look.

They probably wondered what the two of us would talk about that we couldn't bring out in the meeting. And I was wondering the same thing.

After the other Lords went out of the meeting room, the only ones left were me, the Overlord, and the chief of staff.

Soon she put her clasped hands on her lap and spoke.

“There is something I want to entrust to the Seventh Lord personally.”

“...”

“The master of the Flaveros Magic Tower, Ankh Gaindera. The Seventh Lord knows his name, right?”

A fairly unexpected person jumped out, so I quietly narrowed my brows.

Master of the Magic Tower of Flaveros?

Santea's greatest mage force, the Magic Tower.

Here, the Magic Tower was not just a single tower, but a name that referred to three towers.

Among them, the Flaveros Magic Tower mentioned by the Overlord was not the main tower, but the Magic Tower that corresponded to one of the two sub-towers.

The three masters of the Magic Tower represented Santea and were renowned archmages on the continent, so it was impossible not to know them.

Also, if it was Flaveros' tower master, he was a person who I especially remembered with certainty, because...

“I’ve been getting some pretty crazy news lately from the informants I’ve planted there. What do you think it is?”

I could guess what the Overlord was going to say.

Because there was only one thing that could be called ‘crazy information’ about Flaveros’ Magic Tower master.

“The Flaveros’ tower master is secretly conducting research on the demons by capturing the demons himself.”

...Was it like that?

Then the chief of staff came closer to me and handed me something.

A few papers. It was the information about Flaveros’ tower master that the Overlord just talked about.

The approximate circumstances of the study of demons, the material resources used in it, the estimated scale of sacrificed lives, and other things, etc. were all written in detail.

I skimmed the notes, then stared at the Overlord.

What mattered now was why she brought this up to me.

“What are you trying to say?”

And what followed was quite beyond my expectations.

“I want the Seventh Lord to kill him. Of course, don’t make a big fuss and do it as quiet as you could.”

I sighed inwardly, remaining expressionless.

Assassination.

In a word, she wanted me to assassinate Flaveros’ tower master.

“Why?”

I asked, without hiding my doubts.

Because I really didn’t know. Why was she suddenly asking this?

From what she said, I could understand that research on demons was a trigger, but why did she care about that?

The Overlord replied.

“That’s because they’re demons. It’s not something that idiots who are blinded by greed can touch easily. Who knows when it will explode? It’s better to deal with this ticking time bomb quickly.”

“So, I’m asking why you care about something that has nothing to do with Calderic?”

I know very well that demons were extremely dangerous beings.

What I didn’t understand was why she cared about the damage that this would cause Santea.

But she didn’t answer my question and just smiled.

“I can still give you an absolute command for two times, right? I don’t think it’s too difficult, given the ability of the Seventh Lord.”

“...”

I thought for a moment.

Even in the game, the Overlord had always been this way.

Not even once did her true intentions or inner thoughts come out clearly, and she always behaved erratically.

I even thought it might be a trap, but the chances of that happening were very slim.

Why would she even deal with me out of the blue using a trap?

But she could have already decided to deal with me because of the last emergency call... No, that couldn't be the case.

She didn't decide to deal with me on her own territory, but instead send me to Santea for me to fall into a deadly trap. It's absolutely nonsensical.

Assassination...

Anyway, even if her purpose was unknown, it wasn't that bad for me.

It was because Flaveros' tower master was a villain who had to be dealt with someday, anyway.

As the Overlord said, because of the atrocities he was carrying out, a great disaster would happen someday.

It's something that should be done sooner rather than later. Plus, the number of commands of the Overlord that I must absolutely follow would decrease by one.

The question was whether it would be possible to deal with Flaveros' tower master—a level 90 archmage covertly.

Even if I think I could do it somehow, assassination was another area.

But there was no option to refuse, anyway.

After quickly recalling the information about him in my head, I asked the Overlord, who was staring at me.

“When is the deadline?”

“There's no need to rush. You just have to bring in the result until the next meeting.”

So, a year.

I nodded and got up from my seat.

If it's that long, then I could do anything.

Chapter 93.1: Weapon Crafting (1)

Chapter 93.1: Weapon Crafting ! Thank you to Pop and Violet for the donations! ^^

I came out of the meeting room and organized what I was going to do next.

Finding the heir or assassinating one master of the Magic Tower.

It wasn't hard to decide which of the two to do first.

First, deal with the tower master.

The Overlord gave me a long grace period of a year, but nothing good would come out of procrastinating.

Because I didn't have any plans about what should I do or how I should deal with it.

If I didn't solve it in time, they could question my ability. That could make things difficult.

It would be better to start the search for the heir after finishing all chores without distraction.

Still, wouldn't it be better to take care of the mystery first?

Two mysteries hidden in Santea.

It wouldn't take much time, so it would be better to find those before assassinating the tower master.

They might be even of some help in dealing with the target.

First find the mysteries, then deal with the tower master, and finally start looking for the heir earnestly...

“...?”

I noticed a person in the distance and tilted my head.

It was because the Wiseman was standing where Ti-Yong was waiting.

Purr.

Ti-Yong was constantly crying out as if he was wary of the Wiseman beside him.

And the Wiseman kept a distance and looked at Ti-Yong with curious eyes.

As soon as I got closer, he turned his gaze to me and started talking.

“Did you finish your conversation with the Overlord?”

Was he waiting for me?

I didn't have any business with him, so I wondered why he would.

I looked at him blankly without answering and asked.

“Do you know what I talked about with the Overlord?”

“I don't know. Asking that means nothing. I just asked it as a greeting.”

The Wiseman shook his head and then said.

“I've been waiting because I have something I want to ask you. Regarding the Neutral Nations Conference you took part in last time...”

“...”

“I heard that the Seventh Lord sided with the Earth Hill Kingdom and prevented the outbreak of war.”

I wondered why that subject suddenly appeared here, but I still nodded.

“I did.”

“Is the reason you helped Earth Hill because of a personal connection? Or is it for some other purpose?”

“I don’t think I have any reason to answer that.”

The main story, Tair, and various other things were the reasons, but there was no need to explain that to him.

Rather, why was the Wiseman suddenly interested in this?

“I didn’t mean to pry. Just consider it as an old man worrying.”

He saw my blank expression and continued.

“As I said before, I don’t want any cracks in the current system of Calderic. All the Lords have their own thoughts and opinions. But it doesn’t mean that it should lead to a conflict. “

“...?”

“Even if we have different beliefs, we can coexist as long as we know when to step back and when to not. So many people had sat on the seats of a Lord and there had been so many conflicts in between. The fact that Calderic is still standing strong until today proved that the current system is not a failure.

I couldn’t understand the context of his words.

I wondered what this dwarf was talking about out of the blue.

“I don’t know what you’re trying to say.”

The Wiseman tried to say something more to him, but seemed to give up.

“That’s probably a long and useless statement for you. What I want to say is that if there’s a conflict with another Lord in the future, I hope you wouldn’t solve it in a radical way, just like you did when you killed the Sixth Lord. I know you already made a promise with the Overlord, so you probably don’t have to hear this. But still...”

His gaze suddenly turned to Asher, who was standing behind me.

“...And child of the White Moon tribe, what is your name?”

At those words, I furrowed my brows.

He must have heard everything that happened at the Neutral Nations Conference, and he seemed to know that Asher was a member of the White Moon tribe.

At the sudden question, Asher glanced at me and answered.

“This is Asher.”

“Last name?”

“...It’s Gronhilde.”

A strange look passed over the Wiseman’s eyes for a moment.

He nodded and said.

“What a happy coincidence. Do you know the name Gabrom Gronhilde?”

...Gabrom Gronhilde?

I was able to immediately remember where I heard the owner of that name.

A distant ancestor of Asher that was mentioned in the game.

Because he was the founder who created the fighting technique used by the White Moon tribe, which Asher was currently learning, albeit still imperfect.

“Of course I know...”

Asher murmured in a bewildered voice.

“It’s a story from hundreds of years ago. I had a small relationship with him during your ancestor’s lifetime. I made a bet once and lost, so I made him a sword.”

“...!”

Asher’s eyes widened at the Wiseman’s words.

I was a bit surprised because I knew nothing about it either.

What does he mean by this?

There was a connection between the First Lord, the Wiseman, and Asher’s ancestors who created the fighting technique of her tribe?

There was never anything related to it in the game.

However, since that fact was mentioned, I couldn’t help but think of something that was related to the game.

Come to think of it, Asher’s sword...

Asher, who first appeared as a knight of the Black Star Order in the game, had her own dedicated weapon, unlike now.

A famous sword that was called ‘Spear Sword’, whose entire blade was completely blue.

But I didn’t know until now where she got it. It’s because the information didn’t come out even in the setting book.

Later, when she joined the player group and her colleagues asked her about it, she avoided answering and never properly informed them.

But looking at it now, it seemed that the person who made the sword was the Wiseman.

As a Black Star Knight belonging to the Overlord Castle, if he had a relationship with her ancestor, he would have made a weapon for Asher.

When she became a knight of Black Star, she had already proudly revealed that she was a member of the White Moon tribe.

Was it really like that?

Chapter 93.2: Weapon Crafting (1)

Chapter 93.2: Weapon Crafting (1)

Feeling the puzzle fit perfectly, I looked at the two in turn.

Asher was momentarily speechless, not knowing how to react.

A person who had a connection with her ancestor appeared out of nowhere, so it must have been confusing.

“I express my regret for the disaster your tribe had suffered.”

The Wiseman said.

“I heard you fought a duel with Santea’s General in Earth Hill and lost unilaterally.”

“...Yes.”

“But what I see now differs from what I have heard. You can compete with him to some extent if you fought with all your might. Were you just careless, or did you achieve rapid growth in that short period?”

He muttered, as if he didn’t understand.

At that, Asher’s expression changed.

The Wiseman’s words just now were clearly telling her that her level was close to Santea’s General.

She’s really close now.

Of course, I, who could see the level, was well aware of that fact.

Asher's current level is 90, and the General was level 91, so the discernment of the Wiseman who judged that she could compete with that bastard to some extent was not wrong.

Before passing the ordeal of the ruins, it was really an overwhelming difference, so she had no choice but to be defeated unilaterally.

I glanced at Asher and said to the Wiseman.

“First Lord.”

“...?”

“Can you make a sword for her?”

Asher looked back at me in surprise, and the Wiseman also gave me a strange look.

At the last emergency call, the Wiseman said that I could request a weapon or equipment for Bellevagorah's corpse.

I didn't need any of that anyway, so it wouldn't hurt to take this opportunity to make a proper weapon for Asher.

The Wiseman nodded and replied.

“Even if you didn't say that, I was already planning to do so. Thanks to you, Seventh Lord, I got good materials, so I'll even add an armor. But...”

“...?”

“Then should we go to my territory right now?”

“...Right now? Does it take such a short time to craft a weapon?”

“No, I'm not saying that I will make it right away it. In order to properly produce a matching weapon, there are things I need to see with my own

eyes.”

He said that and looked at Asher.

I took one look at her and answered.

“Then let’s go.”

It didn’t really matter if they had to stop by the First Lord’s territory.

“Sir Ron...”

Asher panicked and called me.

I ignored her, climbed on Ti-Yong’s back, and said.

“Come on, Asher. We’re going to the First Lord’s territory.”

The Dwarf race with excellent dexterity was usually famous as a blacksmith’s race.

And in the current era, the person who stood at the pinnacle was the Wiseman, Agor.

The opportunity to get a weapon made by him was invaluable.

I’ve never seen the First Lord’s castle.

Accompanying the First Lord, we quickly flew to his territory.

I followed the Wiseman through the entrance of the castle and looked around.

It was the first time I actually saw the First Lord’s castle, which I did not see when I was playing the game.

I didn't stop by the capital when I passed by this territory when I was still searching for mysteries.

Unusually, there was another building as huge as that behind the main castle, which looked more like a huge chimney than a tower.

I knew that place was a forge because I had seen it in the game.

The closer I got to the forge, the louder the sound of the metal hitting and the stronger the heat that touched my body became.

Upon entering, I saw that all the people busily wandering around inside were Dwarves.

Even when the Wiseman appeared, they only nodded lightly, but soon focused on what they were doing silently.

The atmosphere was completely opposite to the Tyrant I had seen before in Actipol.

The Wiseman didn't pay attention to them and continued to walk into the forge.

Soon after arriving in a large space, the Wiseman said to Asher.

"I will look at your swordsmanship."

Asher looked this way as if asking for permission.

I nodded and stepped back.

Sureureung.

She pulled out her sword, took a deep breath, and immediately began swinging it.

In the empty air, many sword strikes rang out, making a vicious roar.

I watched her with my arms crossed.

Being ignorant of swords, I had no way of knowing about the progress of swordsmanship.

However, I could definitely feel the fact that the sword attack was much faster and much stronger than what I saw in the duel with the General last time.

“...”

The Wiseman, who had been watching Asher’s sword dance for a while, opened his mouth.

“Wait a minute.”

After saying that, he disappeared somewhere, then reappeared with several swords.

They were swords of slightly different sizes and shapes.

“This time, try your swordsmanship with these swords.”

Although Asher looked puzzled, she meekly followed the request and practiced swordsmanship again with the swords he brought.

To me, there was nothing different from before.

However, the Wiseman watched all of Asher’s sword dance with a serious expression, as if he could see something different in his eyes.

“Enough. You can stop.”

After using the last sword, the Wiseman took Asher and I and moved to another place.

We went out of the forge and went underground to the main building.

After going down to the deepest part of the underground, a huge warehouse came out, and in it, countless ores glittered in the dark.

I started by looking at gems that have a natural blue glow. Asher's Spear Sword I saw in the game was blue.

However, the Wiseman, who was walking in the lead, stopped in front of the ore that was emitting purple light.

"Try injecting magic into this stone."

As he said, Asher put her hand on the stone and infused her magical power.

Then, the purple ore emitted a bright light.

The Wiseman, who stared at it with a cautious gaze, nodded with a satisfied look.

"It's much more suitable than I thought. I'll have to look at the other things once."

Was he deciding what materials to use for making the sword?

Watching from the side, I didn't know what it meant, so I asked.

"What are you doing?"

"I'm looking at what materials are suitable for the weapon. High conduction to magical power is not necessarily good. It's also important how well it responds to the user's magical properties."

...I couldn't understand what he was saying, so I just nodded moderately.

The Wiseman took Asher, and she went around injecting mana into the ores one by one, and I felt a bit bored following them.

And it was then.

"...?"

I narrowed my eyes at the ominous energy I felt as I approached the back of the warehouse.

T/N: These are the last bonus chaps. We'll now be back to our regular update shedule. I'll open the donation again once I have more free time. ><

Chapter 94.1: Weapon Crafting (2)

Chapter 94.1: Weapon Crafting (2)

It's subtle, but I clearly felt it.

A gloomy and hideous aura, like muddy darkness.

Raising my super sensory, I gazed, half-glaringly, at the warehouse beyond the darkness.

What came into sight was an ink-colored box.

At first glance, it seemed unusual that something like a chain surrounded it. I could feel the magic in the chain.

It was tucked away in a corner alone, away from other ores, and the source of the energy I felt seemed to be in that box.

“Can you feel it? You have an excellent sense indeed.”

The Wiseman suddenly said and looked towards the inside of the warehouse.

Asher put on a puzzled expression, as if she couldn't understand what the other had said.

“What's in there?”

I thought it was a warehouse for storing ores, but did it contain some magic items?

Even though it only flowed out faintly, it made me feel uncomfortable.

When I asked the Wiseman, he stroked his beard and answered.

“It’s an ore. It’s no different from what you see around you.”

“...Ore?”

“Of course, it’s not an ordinary ore. Would you like to look at it yourself?”

The Wiseman moved and walked right in front of the box.

Then he simply unlocked it and opened the box.

What was inside was, as he said, an ore.

An ore that emitted a black glow.

The only difference was that it was full of ominous energy.

I didn’t know what material it’s made of, but the box itself seemed to block the energy coming out from it.

“This was something I accidentally found from the demonic land of Ochtea. I haven’t given it a name yet, but it’s one of the finest ore I’ve seen in my entire life. However, it is a difficult material to use in crafting equipment.”

...He got it from Ochtea?

It was a different demonic land from Hallmenta, which Asher and I had been to before.

The Wiseman continued to explain why it was a material that was difficult to use for crafting.

“There are infinite kinds of mineral ore that are generated in nature. There are very few of them that are not only strong in magic conduction but also have unique properties. This is an ore with turbid thoughts infused with it. It’s not surprising since it’s found in a place where many things that go beyond common sense take place.”

“...?”

“If you put your hand on it, you’ll see what I mean.”

I stared down at the black ore and touched it as he said.

And I could feel it right away.

A mighty presence that existed within the ore and tries to penetrate my consciousness.

– Chiaaah...!

A bizarre echo that seems to be mixed with laughter and screams lingered in my head like an echo.

Hundreds, thousands, tens of thousands... I could feel the existence of countless thoughts within it, as the Wiseman explained.

Thanks to the [Soul of the King], my mind did not shake, but if it was a normal person, it would not be strange if they lost their mind just by touching this ore.

It reminded me of Gascalid’s blood, which I had experienced before when getting blood magic.

“You’re crazy.”

When I removed my hand again showing no signs, the Wiseman looked quite surprised.

“Is it difficult to use it as a material because of this?”

“That’s right. It’s not a thing you can endure just because you have strong mental strength.”

The Wiseman turned his gaze to the side.

I said to Asher, who was staring at the ore curiously.

“If you’re curious, try to touch it. If you can withstand the thoughts of this ore, I’ll gladly use it as a material to craft the best sword and armor for you.”

Asher hesitated for a moment before reaching out her hand.

I wondered if she could take it.

Results came right away.

“...!”

As soon as she put her hand on the ore, she gasped, and within a few seconds, she removed her hand as if frightened.

In that moment, Asher’s complexion turned pale as if she had seen a ghost.

Was it that much for her despite having grown to level 90?

The thoughts dwelling in this ore were far more threatening than I thought.

“Is there any way to get rid of only evil thoughts?”

The Wiseman shook his head.

“I asked the overlord a long time ago, but he said it would be difficult to get rid of only the evil thoughts without destroying the ore. It’s not something that can be solved with magic or simple smelting.”

I turned my gaze again and stared blankly at the ore.

Suddenly a thought came to me.

...Wouldn’t my ability work on this too?

My instant kill ability was an ability that could dissipate the target’s soul itself.

That's why it was possible to get rid of Gascalid's residual thoughts back when I was trying to get blood magic.

So maybe this was possible too.

Wouldn't there be no problem if I could also eliminate the thoughts dwelling in this ore with instant kill?

The Wiseman said it was one of the best ore he had ever seen in my life, so if he used it as a material, I wondered what kind of amazing weapon or armor would be born.

It was a very good thing because the more good equipment Asher used, the more helpful it was for me.

The best armor made by the Wiseman was Gaeldid which was made of orichalcum. If it could be better than that, wouldn't it be exciting?

"If the problem of the evil thoughts is resolved, can you use this ore as a material to craft Asher's weapon and armor?"

"Yes. But I haven't found the right way yet."

I nodded and put my hand on the ore once more. And I used instant kill.

At the same time, the scream that had been ringing in my head was suddenly cut off and disappeared. The ominous aura coming out of the ore disappeared as well.

As expected, the evil thoughts had been successfully extinguished.

Chapter 94.2: Weapon Crafting (2)

Chapter 94.2: Weapon Crafting (2)

The Wiseman looked at me with puzzled eyes, perhaps feeling what happened.

“Now what...”

I said as I removed my hand from the ore.

“I got rid of the thoughts dwelling in the ore.”

“...?”

The Wiseman brought his hand to the ore as if making sure.

And soon his eyes widened.

“Huh?”

He looked at the ore in disbelief, then burst into a small exclamation.

“...It’s amazing. Really, the thoughts have completely disappeared. What did you just do?”

He was evidently really surprised, as his usual calm voice even leaked a bit of excitement.

It was natural for him to be surprised, as it would appear to him that I had merely touched the ore and then suddenly the evil thoughts from it disappeared.

“Are there any more problems?”

The Wiseman smiled and nodded his head.

“As I said, I’ll use this as a material to make a weapon and an armor. Heh, it was a treasure that I had kept in the warehouse for a few decades...”

The size of the ore was considerable, and it was so large that even if Asher’s sword and armor were made, more than half would be left over.

I suddenly remembered what the Wiseman had said and asked.

“By the way, didn’t you say that it’s also important to respond to the user’s magical power?”

Was this black ore compatible with Asher’s magical power?

From the outside, the colors are completely opposite, so it didn’t seem like they would match at all.

The Wiseman shook his head.

“It doesn’t matter since this ore’s efficiency is much better compared to other ores, whether it’s magic transfer or durability.”

...Well, I was sure he would figure out what to do and make good equipment out of the ore.

I didn’t ask him any more since he was too preoccupied with the ore.

After leaving the warehouse, we decided to leave the First Lord’s territory immediately.

There was no reason to stay any longer, since our business was over.

He said that he would send a messenger to the Seventh Lord’s territory when he was done making the weapon and armor.

“Thank you very much, First Lord.”

Asher gave the Wiseman a slightly belated thank you.

She must be feeling quite reluctant at first since she was dragged here regardless of her will. But since the best blacksmith on the continent had promised to make her a weapon, she could only feel grateful.

The Wiseman nodded and saw us off.

“Then take care, Seventh Lord.”

I was about to climb on Ti-Yong’s back when he suddenly called Asher again.

“But it seems you haven’t mastered Gronhilde’s ability yet.”

“Yes.”

“As far as I remember, it seems to be a technique of dividing the magical core into three. Is that correct?”

“...Yes, that’s right.”

As if she hadn’t expected the other to know her tribe’s ability in such detail, Asher became a little flustered.

“Don’t get me wrong. I just heard it directly from your ancestor. I only know the rough principles.”

The Wiseman said.

“The reason I mentioned this story is because I have something I want to tell you. I don’t know if you already know...”

He said as if he was remembering.

“Don’t think of the separate cores as separate. Treat them as one and control them.”

“...”

“It’s what your ancestor said as the key to passing the last wall in relation to your tribe’s ability.”

Asher’s eyes widened.

In response, the Wiseman nodded.

“From the look on your face, it doesn’t seem like you knew about it.”

“Yes...”

“Your ancestor at that time was someone who achieved a level comparable to those of a Lord. If you also fully accept his legacy, you could reach the same level as well.”

The Wiseman said that in a calm tone and turned around.

Asher looked at his back with bewildered eyes.

I was also a little curious. What was the relationship between Asher’s ancestor and the Wiseman?

Just remembering the distant relationship from hundreds of years ago and giving advice like this, it seems like they were quite close.

“Let’s go.”

I took my eyes off him and opened my mouth.

Ti-Yong flapped its wings and soared into the sky.

Since they were done here, it was time to head to the next destination as originally planned.

To the place in Santea where a mystery was hidden.

A barren wilderness located north of Santea.

I looked down, rubbing my eyes as the dry wind hit my face incessantly.

There was a mystery to be found in this place where only dull rocks were visible without a single plant.

The mystery of acceleration.

As the name suggested, it was a mystery that increased speed.

A mystery that allowed the body to move faster and more agile.

It was an almost useless ability for me since I already had space jump, but I still planned to take it.

The more diverse the ability, the better, so I came here to find it.

The mystery of acceleration was a mystery that I discovered myself in the game, and the topography of the hidden place was also noticeable, so there was no great difficulty in finding it.

Flying on Ti-Yong, I was able to locate a small puddle in the middle of the plain and a cave nearby swiftly.

“Wait here a moment.”

As always, I went into the burrow alone, leaving Asher outside.

This was the place where the dungeon was located, just like the mystery of the floating veil that I searched for before.

After going all the way inside the cave and exploring the surroundings, I was able to find the door that was the entrance to the dungeon. However...

“...?”

I narrowed my eyes.

It was because the door was wide open, as if someone had entered the dungeon first.

What?

Raising my super sensory, I looked closely the road I had passed, and now there were traces that caught my eye.

The rubbing of the ground, the faint footprints, the traces of someone who first discovered this dungeon and entered it.

I couldn't help but feel a little embarrassed.

No...

In the game, that was sometime in the future, there was no one who discovered this dungeon before me.

Something unexpected happened.

Why? Was it an illusion? Or was it a variable caused by the butterfly effect due to my existence?

“...”

Seeing that there was no sign of returning, it seemed that the uninvited guests were still inside.

Thinking about what to do, I stepped into the open door.

Anyway, I came all the way here. At least I had to make sure that the mystery was really gone.

Chapter 95: A Vain Attempt (1)

Chapter 95: A Vain Attempt

I looked around as I walked down the dark, downhill passage.

No matter how powerful my super sensory was, I couldn't see through this complete darkness with no source of light. So, I had to rely on the glowstones I brought with me.

There hadn't been any danger yet, but since it's a dungeon, one wouldn't know where something would pop out of nowhere.

It's a place I found myself in the game, but it was so long ago that I didn't remember much.

All I could think of was that it was a dungeon with far more guardians than traps.

I wonder how many levels the guardians of this dungeon were.

Were they level 30 or 40?

Among them, the bosses were probably over level 50.

Whatever it was, there would be no danger to me now, so there was no problem.

I continued to walk with no tension.

The traces of the previous uninvited guests were still there, so it was easy for me to follow.

The one that appeared at the end of the straight path was a road that was cut off in the middle.

There is no such thing as an obstacle, but a road that was completely cut off like a cliff.

“...”

Feeling a little bewildered, I looked down far below.

It was because the terrain did not feel very natural since it was in the cave's underground. Come to think of it, was there a road like this at the entrance?

I picked up a stone and threw it down the cliff, and after a while I heard a small sound. It seemed to be at least a few hundred meters.

I looked across in the distance and crossed it using space leap.

Nearby, the ground was marked with particularly rough sweeping marks. Was it a sign of someone landing?

Apparently, the uninvited guests just jumped across.

As I continued to move, what appeared this time was a fork in several roads.

Looking at the aisle divided into six, I was lost in my thoughts for a while.

When I was playing the game, the first passage I entered was probably the one in the middle.

However, the memory was hazy as to which passage led to the mystery.

I was confused because I had memories of going round and round as the pathways connected to each other from the inside and returned to the same spot.

Did I find it in the passage leading to the far right after all? No, it was on the left...

I was pretty sure it was either the far left or the far right.

The traces of the uninvited guests led to the second aisle from the left.

I soon chose the aisle on the far left and moved on.

If I made the wrong choice, I wouldn't die, and if I made a mistake, I just had to go back and check the other passages.

As I moved further into the passage, a space with an artificial feeling gradually appeared.

Magic stones and magic circles that were scattered and painted everywhere.

I could see dozens of other passages piercing the walls on all sides. Another crossroads?

Kwaaang!

As I was looking around, the entrance I came in suddenly closed.

Subsequently, the magic stones and magic circles began to glow brightly, and the magic energy became stronger.

It was only after that that countless figures emerged from the passageways that were scattered everywhere.

Cooong. Cooong.

Guardians in the form of four-legged animals whose bodies were made of rocks.

The eyes and joints of the monsters that appeared in droves from the darkness shone with blue light.

All levels were level 31, and the number easily exceeded dozens, even at a glance.

Wait...

Did such a space exist?

A vague memory came to mind.

As if in a siege, the guys surrounding me rushed all at once. I teleported upward into the air.

Those who missed their target tangled and collided with each other for a moment, then looked up.

The veil blocked a few who tried to jump up and attack me.

I clicked my tongue inwardly.

The entrance I entered was blocked, and the guardians were released in a pile with no space to escape.

At this level, it was a dungeon that made it so that anyone who entered it would just die.

I wondered if the wizard who created this dungeon had a rather dirty personality.

Pew!

As soon as I released the veil, I fell down and performed blood magic.

The blood that burst out in all directions soaked the bodies of the guardians who were looking up and they stopped moving all at once.

Landing lightly on the floor, I looked around at the fallen guardians and then moved my gaze to one side.

It was the passageway with the largest entrance. No guardians had yet emerged from that place.

Waa.

Soon, with a heavy trembling, a huge figure appeared.

A guardian that took the form of a four-legged beast no different from the ones that just jumped out.

But the size was as many times much bigger than the earlier guardians.

[Lv. 52]

...Yes, come to think of it, there was a guy like this.

The guy rushed in this direction. Formidable speed, completely out of proportion to its size.

I immediately performed blood magic and shot drops of blood at him.

However, the flying droplets of blood were blocked by the magic screen covering its body and did not reach it.

“Huh.”

Waa!

I sighed and evaded it by using space leap.

The guardian who hit the rock wall in my place completely destroyed one side of the wall and stood up like a machine.

I looked at it with bewildered eyes.

I didn't even think that it would have a passive shield.

I didn't have time to relax for a second, and it jumped right back towards me.

Feeling like a bullfighter, I blocked and dodged the attack by alternating between floating veil and space leap.

...*What to do?*

It wasn't difficult to fight it, but the problem was that there was no way to defeat it.

I glanced at the entrance through which I came in.

It looked like a magical veil covered it, shining with a soft blue light.

Thinking of a plausible way, I moved right in front of the passage.

I turned around and avoided the rushing guy with space leap.

Kwaaang!

It collided violently with the magical veil surrounding the entrance.

It could not withstand the shock and shattered at once.

As I made my way through the opening, the guardian continued to pursue me relentlessly.

I used space leap and floating veil repeatedly to lead it to the cliff at the beginning of the passage.

Finally, I teleported into the air in the middle of the cliff and opened the veil.

Then, sure enough, it leaped toward me without hesitation, crashed into the veil, and then fell straight down the cliff.

“Ugh...”

Landing on the ground again, I sighed, feeling a little tired.

If I had known this was going to happen, I would have just brought Asher along.

I was about to go out and bring her, but I changed my mind and just went back inside.

I passed the exit of the place where the Guardians were.

Another long passage followed, no more traps or guardians popping out.

Soon, I opened my eyes wide as I looked at another huge passage in front of me.

It's here.

On the upper wall there was a pattern that looked like an eyeball. I clearly remembered that the mystery of acceleration was beyond this passageway.

I passed the entrance of the passage with a lighter step. And...

“...?”

I couldn't help but frown at the presence that soon began to be felt from the inside.

“...Hey, Captain. Can't we just go back now?”

Clark opened his mouth cautiously, looking around with anxious eyes.

Nine people – composing of both men and women–walked down a dark passageway.

As a new member of the adventure group and also a porter, he had little right to speak, but he had no choice but to speak up.

Even the group of guardians that just popped out were so dangerous that at least one of them died.

It wouldn't be strange if the adventurers were wiped out if a more threatening guardian came out from inside.

“Boy, didn't I tell you to shut up?”

The woman, who was alert to the rear with her bow on her string, said nervously.

“If you’re that scared, don’t whine and get out of here by yourself, huh?”

“Hey, focus.”

The man at the forefront interrupted in a stern voice. She clicked her tongue.

“Even if I try to do that, that idiot keeps annoying me.”

Clark groaned inwardly.

The reason that woman was so rude and the others just let her was because she was the most capable member of the group.

“Clark, you should focus as well. We’ll go in a little further, then come back if there’s nothing. Or is it that you don’t have that much trust in me?”

“...No, no. Sorry, Captain.”

On the other hand, the leader, Regneel, was very polite.

Clark obediently apologized, and once again hardened his heart.

Yes, it’s still a dungeon. It would be a waste if we give up like this...

There was no doubt that the captain valued the lives of his members more than anyone else did .

Besides, wasn’t this the chance to make a fortune that all adventurers aspire to?

The rewards waiting there must be more than worth the risk...

Clap.

Everyone’s footsteps stopped.

“Uh, huh?”

The woman with the bow looked down at her feet in bewilderment.

The members’ expressions hardened all at once.

Coo coo coo.

As the vibrations approached, guardians in the form of small bugs rushed like a tidal wave from the road they passed.

“...Run!”

Everyone realized as soon as they saw the guardians that they weren’t something they could deal with.

With the captain’s urgent cry, the members hurriedly sprinted.

Clark also went white and ran, holding back the urge to scream.

“...Argh!”

At that moment, a woman running right next to her tripped and fell.

“He, help me! Don’t leave me alone! Ah!”

Clark stopped running and looked back.

I saw the woman rolling on the floor, entangled with several bug guardians who had already come close to her.

The members who were already running in the lead were running into the passage that was closing in front, as if they couldn’t even see her.

He hesitated and finally approached her with a swear word. He drew her sword and slashed the bug guardians as they attacked her.

“Quickly! Go in before the door closes...!”

Fuck!

Suddenly, Clark's body fell backwards.

The woman who stood up whimpering kicked his body as he was supporting her arm. Then she started running alone.

Clark, who jumped to his feet, looked at her back with amazement.

“That crazy bitch...! Gup!”

He hurriedly ran after an insect guardian had bitten his wrist.

However, it was a long way off to catch up with the members who took the lead in a situation where he had already fallen behind.

Clap.

To make matters worse, Clark stepped on another trap, which made his body sway.

On the downhill that suddenly appeared as the ground collapsed, his body rolled back and forth as if it were about to fall.

After hitting the wall, he barely balanced himself, but the disaster wasn't over yet.

He screamed as he saw the guardians rushing down in front of him.

“Ughhhhhh!”

Waa!

At that moment, the stone wall that suddenly fell in front of him cut off the space and blocked the guardians.

Clark sighed heavily, and his throbbing body rose.

“...Fuck.”

Where was this?

He didn't know where it was, but he couldn't help but be aware of the fact that he was definitely in trouble.

He barely survived, but the stone wall suddenly appeared and blocked the way out.

He looked around and soon found another passage on the side.

With no other way to go, Clark cursed again and slowly moved down the passage.

As he walked through the dark passage where he couldn't see an inch ahead, what appeared immediately was a wide cavity.

“...”

There were huge stone statues all over the common area.

Clark stared at something in the middle of the cavity with bewildered eyes.

It's a pattern engraved on the floor that glows in a subtle red color.

He mumbled.

“A mystery?”

Chapter 96: A Vain Attempt (2)

Chapter 96: A Vain Attempt (2)

The red patterns emitted a strange feeling that differed completely from the magic circle made of magic.

Clark couldn't help but gulp down his saliva, even though he thought it was unlikely.

The treasure that adventurers heard about through rumors, discovering mysterious pattern, one could get extraordinary abilities beyond common sense.

“Is it really a... mystery?”

Clark cautiously approached the pattern and reached out his hand as if possessed.

In an instant, the pattern emitted a bright light and was absorbed into his body through his arm.

Soon after, the pattern disappeared without a trace, and Clark blinked his eyes and looked down at his hand.

It was when he was lost in a strange sensation that he had never felt before in his life...

Kugukung.

“.....?!”

Suddenly, he turned his head at the abrupt noise.

He saw stone statues wielding weapons, looking at him with fiery eyes.

Quaang!

Clark was startled and threw himself to the side. A giant stone spear flew towards his previous position and pierced the ground.

He was surprised that he had avoided the attack and moved much faster and more agile than usual.

The mysterious ability he absorbed was the ability to increase the speed of his body.

The knowledge that flowed into his mind since he absorbed the mystery made it possible for him to use the acceleration power naturally.

“Aaaahhh!”

Clark screamed as he moved at maximum speed, dodging the attacks of the rushing stone statues. It was an instinctive evasion.

However, it was difficult to adapt to the suddenly amplified physical ability.

He stumbled and fell to the ground, unable to withstand the intense pain that hit his legs.

As he desperately tried to get up, a stone statue’s attack grazed his leg, tearing his thigh apart.

“Kkeuk!”

He fell to the ground once again, rolling in pain, unable to control his body.

As he closed his eyes tightly, stone statues suddenly fell one after another.

Clark opened his eyes and exhaled a trembling breath.

The statues lying on the ground appeared to be completely motionless, not even twitching.

Then, someone walked in, accompanied by the sound of footsteps. It was an unfamiliar young man, and he wondered if the other was in grouped with the stone statues.

“What did you just do?”

Did he defeat the guardians?

Clark, who was unaware of the situation, involuntarily shuddered as he felt the man’s gaze on him.

After looking around once, the man walked towards the center of the group and stopped right beside him.

“Who are you?”

The man asked with a cold gaze.

Clark, who was momentarily dazed, replied, “I’m an adventurer. Who are you?”

“There was supposed to be a symbol here. Have you seen it?”

The man asked, looking down at him with a chilling gaze.

Clark’s mind froze for a moment. He felt a shiver running down his spine like a frog in front of a snake and swallowed hard.

He knew that the man was asking about the mysterious power he had just absorbed. He didn’t know who this man was or where he had suddenly appeared from, but he was sure of one thing. He was in trouble.

“I haven’t seen it.”

....It’s too late.

I looked at the man, who was sitting hesitantly and was full of fear, and clicked my tongue.

This space was undoubtedly the place where I had discovered the mystery of acceleration.

However, since there were no markings visible anywhere, there were only two possibilities: either the mystery had not yet been generated, or the man in front of me had absorbed it first.

Judging by his reaction, it was easy to tell that it was the latter.

This man had already absorbed the mystery of acceleration that had been present in this place.

“I really saw nothing. I really didn’t,” the man repeated those words and looked at me with an earnest gaze, as if pleading with me to believe him.

It seemed as if he thought I would kill him if I found out that he had absorbed the mystery.

Although it was annoying, there was no way to make him spit out what he had already absorbed.

Anyway, the mystery was not that useful to me, and this time it was just a bit of bad luck.

“By the way, there were traces of others coming in.”

I wondered where the other people were and why he was all alone here, but it wasn’t important, so I turned my attention away.

Then, when I was about to turn my body away from the frozen man...

Kugugugugu.

Suddenly, vibrations occurred, and the central floor of the space slowly opened up.

The man sitting nearby was startled and stepped back.

Buried in the hole that suddenly appeared was a pile of sparkling silver and gold treasures.

Come to think of it, were there rewards like this in these ruins?

Since there was no reason to take the treasure, I lost interest and was about to leave.

“....?”

As I felt another sensation at the entrance, several men and women soon appeared.

“....Chief!”

Hearing the man’s shout, I was able to quickly assess the situation.

They were the owners of the trace that I found when I had just entered the dungeon. Were they adventurers?

I wondered if the reason one person was separated here was because of a trap. It was a common case.

They also showed a surprised expression when they found the man.

“Clark, are you alive?”

“I barely survived! Didn’t you see me?! Heyrun tried to use me as bait and run away alone! I barely helped her!”

The woman who was holding a bow trembled and shouted in surprise.

“Oh, don’t be funny! Why are you blaming me when you just collapsed on your own?”

“You’re talking nonsense, you bitch! Are you even a human being?!”

A vulgar conversation continued.

I didn't know what was going on, but roughly listening, it seemed that they fell into a trap and then the woman holding a bow over there hit the man.

The man looked courageous and glared at the woman, asking, "But how did everyone get here? I fell into a trap...?"

"We don't know either. The path we were going was blocked, so we kept moving forward and ended up here. But..."

The man called the 'chief' looked at me with suspicion. Then he discovered gold and silver coins on one side and his eyes widened. The others also did the same.

"..."

The adventurers' greedy eyes were all focused on the gold and silver coins in an instant.

Silence descended on the group for a moment.

As I felt a sense of annoyance that the situation might become troublesome, the leader exchanged glances with some of the others and spoke again.

"But who is that man, Clark?"

"Ah? Well, I don't know either..."

The man replied as he looked at me.

As I was about to open my mouth, the woman with the bow intervened.

"Did, did you all see that? All the gold and silver coins piled up in that hole! We're rich now! Right?! But..."

Thunk!

At that moment, a sword pierced through the woman's chest.

The person who had stabbed her was the leader.

Other members who were nearby turned around in shock.

“What is happening right now?!”

At that moment, some members continued on and ambushed the rest of the group. One member with a spear stabbed the throat of the person next to them, while a robed woman threw a fireball at two members who were a little further away.

One member who avoided the attack tried to retreat, but was quickly killed by another member who blocked the exit.

Those who were ambushed were all killed instantly, without even responding.

The group who had just killed their own colleagues looked towards the onlookers while wiping the blood off their weapons without a hint of emotion.

“What, what is happening...?”

The man stared blankly at the scene and I couldn't help but frown. What a mess.

“What is happening right now...?”

Clark doubted his own eyes. The bodies of the members scattered on the floor.

The leader, Regneel, Thomas, Ann, and Barock, the four oldest members of the adventure party, had ambushed and killed all the other members.

“Why?”

His mind was confused, but he soon realized the reason. Because the four of them had decided to take the treasure of the dungeon and kill all their comrades with no hesitation.

“Are you crazy? Did you plan this from the beginning?”

Barock, a mage, smirked at the man’s muttering.

“Did you not notice anything? Of course, we discussed this before we even entered the dungeon. If there really was a treasure, we would just swallow it among ourselves.”

Clark couldn’t believe it and looked at Regneel.

He had joined the adventure party because he thought highly of the leader’s character, but he had been betrayed in an instant.

Regneel didn’t even look at Clark and pointed his sword towards the unidentified man.

“Are you an adventurer too? When did you enter the dungeon?”

“...”

“Well, it doesn’t really matter. I don’t know where you suddenly popped out from, but you’re just unlucky.”

The man stood in silence for a moment after hearing Regneel’s words, then muttered with a fake laugh.

“Well, nothing to be done about it. I got nothing for all my work, but all these annoying things keep happening.”

The man casually glanced at the treasure pile in the nearby pit.

“What are you looking at? You’re not trying to kill us all and hoard the treasure, are you?”

Regneel’s eyes twitched.

“Di—“

He didn't finish his sentence.

The man vanished in a blink of an eye, then appeared right in the midst of Regneel and his companions.

“!”

The four of them were too shocked to react.

The next moment, they all fell to the ground.

In the situation's chaos, Clark, who had just finished dealing with the guardians, was completely stunned and just stared at the scene.

In the blink of an eye, the man had killed them all, just like he had dealt with the guardians before.

All Clark could remember seeing was something like blood spraying from the man.

“Ah...”

As he watched the scene, Clark let out an involuntary groan.

He felt a mix of confusion, betrayal, the emptiness of losing his companions who had been with him for so long, and fear of the man.

The man turned towards him and walked closer.

Clark wanted to run away immediately, but his legs were too weak to stand up from the torn ground.

He felt like he was about to die, as he thought it was his turn.

However, he showed him a small glass bottle containing a reddish liquid.

“Since you obtained this mystery, use it well.”

The man put the potion on the nearby ground, said those words, and then turned around without looking at the abandoned treasure, and walked towards the exit.

Clark watched him until he completely disappeared and then collapsed, his body trembling in exhaustion.

“What the hell was that?”

Chapter 97: A Vain Attempt (3)

Chapter 97: A Vain Attempt (3)

After leaving the dungeon, I looked up at the gloomy sky. Asher and Ti-Yong, who were standing around me, noticed that I had come out and approached me.

“Let’s go.”

“Yes.”

I felt tired. This time, I really wasted my effort.

While riding on Ti-Yong with Asher, my mind wandered to the next destination: Raphid, the biggest city in eastern Sanctia. The renowned Elphon Academy, a prestigious institution for fostering talent in Sanctia, was located there. The mystery I was trying to find next lay hidden in the public library of the Elphon Academy.

Most of the mysteries I found before were located in a sparsely populated wilderness of nature, but there were very rare exceptions. Just like this next one.

In a sense, it could be said that its location was the most ambiguous in all the places I visited so far.

Shuuu!

I descended into the forest below while looking at the giant city in the distance.

Ti-Yong was supposed to stay in the forest near the city and I was going to enter Raphid on foot to quietly obtain the mystery and then leave. I couldn't attract attention by dragging a Wyvern into the city and wandering around.

"I'll be back soon, so wait here. Avoid people as much as possible and don't attack, even if you meet someone."

Grunt.

The creature flapped its wings and nodded its head.

Since we left it in the middle of this forest, there would hardly be any people to meet, so nothing was likely to happen.

Asher and I proceeded towards the city on the road, leaving Ti-Yong behind in the forest.

"Hmm."

We passed through the city gates with no problems and entered the city.

I walked along the main street, looking around at my surroundings.

As the largest city in the eastern part of Santea, the streets were crowded with numerous pedestrians.

Among them, there were people who were particularly noticeable, dressed in similar uniforms like those belonging to the same organization.

"Oh, Professor Humil. You're going out for the first time in a while. Did you take a vacation?"

"What vacation... Professor Taizi started a new experiment again. I'm just going to the store to get the necessary materials, you know."

A man conversed with a woman he met while passing by, with tired eyes.

As I passed by them, I listened to their conversation and looked at a huge building in the middle of the city, partly visible beyond the buildings.

It was a building that looked different from castles or palaces and was somewhat reminiscent of a school.

The Elphon Academy.

That was the academy located in this city of Santea.

As in most fantasy settings, the academy was an institution that educated students like a real school, except that the subjects taught were different, such as swordsmanship or magic. This was a fantasy world, after all.

In RaSa's setting, the academy was the only institution of its kind in Santea, but in fact, it was not a major part of the game's main story, except for some minor side quests related to the Elphon Academy.

Anyway, my goal was to find the mystery hidden in the public library located within that academy.

For now, I need to take a look around.

I decided to find an inn and wait until nightfall.

While waiting for the sun to set, I reviewed my knowledge of the rough internal structure of the Academy by recalling my memories.

As time passed, complete darkness fell upon the night.

Walking alone on the street, I avoided the eyes of those around me and made my way to the vicinity of the Academy.

The place I had just arrived at was the western wall of the Academy.

The location of the public library was on the outskirts of the western side of the Academy.

While there were several libraries within the Academy, the public library was open to anyone associated with the Academy with no special conditions.

It was a good thing for me that the security wasn't very tight, as I would have to sneak into it from now on.

If the mystery was hidden deeper inside the Academy, I would not have even considered attempting to obtain it and would have given up.

It would be difficult to infiltrate the deeper parts of the Academy, and if I were caught, it could make things complicated.

I can try at least this much without much risk.

High walls surrounded the Academy on all sides, making it almost impossible to see the interior from the outside.

I looked up at the towering walls like a castle and heightened my senses.

Inside the Academy, I sensed that there were guards patrolling near the outskirts, around the wall in the direction I was currently located.

Judging from the faint magical energy, they were likely guards.

After confirming all of their positions, I immediately used space leap to jump into the airspace just above the wall.

It was unlikely that my presence would be revealed on this dark night.

Hovering high in the sky, I fixed my body in a floating veil and peered inside the Academy beyond the wall.

It was a vast area consisting of dozens of soccer fields combined, with numerous buildings spreading out around the giant central main building.

It wasn't long before I was able to easily find the public library building on the western side.

Since it was nighttime, there were hardly any people walking around inside the academy. There was no one around the public library, which was my destination.

I descended onto the ground and teleported onto the wall, lowering my posture and looking down.

It didn't seem difficult to get to the public library in the first place, as the property was very wide and my super sensory allowed me to detect all the surroundings. Plus, I had the ability to teleport.

I boldly infiltrated the academy and moved between buildings to avoid any suspicion.

I safely moved to the vicinity of the public library and hid my body behind a building.

The public library was a two-story building with only windows on the first floor.

Is that the librarian?

I saw a man sitting near the entrance of the library through the closed glass window. He seemed like a librarian.

Other than that, I didn't feel any other presence inside the library.

Now, how should I proceed?

I decided to secretly enter the library and find the mystery inside, then leave.

Coincidentally, the librarian seemed to be dozing off, and he might not even notice if I opened the front door and entered.

But it was better to be cautious, so I decided to enter through the window.

I couldn't teleport if there was an obstacle in the middle of the space, so I couldn't teleport past the closed window.

I checked the surroundings once again and approached the library's window. It was an angle where the librarian's line of sight couldn't reach.

I gently pulled the window open and immediately teleported inside.

Done.

I safely entered the library.

After confirming that the librarian was still nodding off, I closed the window facing outside and headed upstairs, passing by the bookshelves without hesitation.

The place where the mystery was hidden was the bookshelf on the second floor, where old books related to history were gathered.

The second floor was much narrower than the first floor, but I remembered the location of the bookshelf that was stuck in the corner, so I was able to find it quickly.

Looking around the books that were almost left unattended and covered in dust, I clenched and unclenched my hands.

I think this is the bookshelf.

I found it, but there was one last problem.

The place with the symbol of the mystery was the wall behind this bookshelf.

In other words, to see the mystery, I had to move the bookshelf and make it fall off the wall. But...

How am I supposed to do this alone?

It was not very big, but it wasn't small either. It was much taller than me, and the width was about the span of two outstretched arms.

I could try to pull it and move it away from the wall, but then the noise would be a problem.

In the end, I couldn't drag it on the floor and had no choice but to move it even a little by lifting it.

I tried to grab the bookshelf and apply force to it, but it didn't budge.

There was no other way.

So, I carefully took out the books that were stuck in the bookshelf and started to pile them on the floor.

If the bookshelf was empty, I could lift it a little.

After a considerable amount of time, I finally took out all the books from the bookshelf.

And when I tried to lift the bookshelf again, I succeeded.

Carefully lifting one side of the bookshelf and pulling it off the wall, I looked inside the gap.

I expected to find the symbol of the mystery on this wall. But...

“...”

There was nothing visible.

Only piles of dust.

Even after scouring the crevices again, nothing had changed.

I furrowed my eyebrows.

...*What's going on?*

Why wasn't the mystery here again?

I checked the surrounding shelves again, wondering if I had mistaken the location, but it was definitely the right spot.

I crossed my arms and got lost in thought.

Did someone else discover the mystery before me again? But how?

If someone had discovered it first, then they would have moved the bookshelf to check the back wall just like me, right? Even if my actions might cause a butterfly effect, could someone really have done this before me in this library?

...Or maybe the timing wasn't right.

Perhaps the mystery hadn't been created yet.

If the mystery was created sometime between now and the future gameplay point, then it was natural that it wouldn't exist right now.

I couldn't know for sure which was the case.

But one thing was certain: I had once again wasted my time.

Even if it was only two in a row, it was still disappointing. I couldn't help but chuckle.

I really have no luck.

Did I use up all my luck finding mysteries in Calderic?

I succeeded in finding all the mysteries in Calderic, but failed at every turn in Santea.

I felt a little disappointed, but there was nothing I could do about it.

I looked once more into the gap between the bookshelf and then turned around.

If I had another chance later, I would come back and check it again.

I left the books that were taken out as they were without being organized and headed towards the stairs leading down to the first floor.

Since all the errands were done, I was about to go out through the window and escape from the library again, but...

“Ah!”

I quickly stepped back on the stairs and hid behind a nearby bookshelf.

The reason was because someone suddenly came in through the door, which was located directly across from the main entrance of the library.

[Lv. 46]

...A student?

The person who entered the library was dressed like an academy student – a woman with blonde hair, a golden complexion, and a strangely lonely atmosphere.

The librarian, who had been dozing off, suddenly woke up and looked at her, then checked the time and cautiously opened his mouth.

“It’s time to start restricting entry and exit...”

The woman nodded her head and spoke politely.

“I’ll only be here for a short while today. I’ll leave before 10 o’clock.”

“Um, alright. Please return it on time tomorrow, since it’s a spare key.”

And then the librarian, having confirmed that all the windows on the first floor were closed, went out.

The woman who was left alone approached a bookshelf and began to look at the books.

I hid between the bookshelves on the second floor and narrowed my eyes, watching her engrossed in reading.

What now, seriously...

Since I happened to be standing near the stairs, it became difficult to secretly go down.

Since there was no need to take unnecessary risks, I decided to just wait a bit. It seemed like she was going to leave before 10 o'clock.

Shhh, shhh.

In the quiet stillness, the only sound that echoed through the library was the turning of pages.

It was when I was waiting for the woman to leave and staying quiet without making a sound...

“There, the rat on the second floor.”

The sudden voice of the woman startled me.

She slowly closed her book and looked up at the second floor.

“Since you’ve been caught, come out obediently. Are you an assassin who came to harm this lady?”

Chapter 98: Assassination of the Tower Master (1)

Chapter 98: Assassination of the Tower Master (1)

I couldn't help feeling embarrassed for a moment because I didn't expect to be caught.

I noticed a woman looking at me coldly through the gap between the books.

...But did she just refer to herself as a 'lady'?

It's a title used by nobles or royals when referring to themselves, wasn't it?

In the silence, I stared at the woman's face, and soon my eyes widened.

I thought she was familiar.

Seventh Princess, Armia.

The daughter of Emperor Grandios, the Seventh princess of the Santea Imperial Family.

It wasn't difficult to recognize her.

Because if there was a woman who was a child of the emperor and currently attending the academy at this moment, it could only be her.

Moreover, she was a character who had a considerable role among the emperor's children in the main story.

I couldn't help but think it was a strange coincidence.

No, more importantly...

So what should I do?

It seemed like I was mistaken for an assassin, which made the situation quite difficult.

Should I use space leap to move to the window and escape immediately? It would be difficult to avoid causing a commotion no matter what I did...

“If you continue to hide like that after being caught, then...”

As I didn’t reveal my appearance, she raised her magic.

It was when I had no choice but to use space leap towards the window on the first floor that...

“Hmm?”

At that moment, I felt another presence from the window.

Thunk!

As the window suddenly opened, someone in a black robe entered, flipping their cloak.

The Seventh Princess flinched in surprise and turned her gaze towards the intruder.

[Lv. 53]

The person in the robe immediately drew their sword and rushed towards the Seventh Princess.

I watched the scene in astonishment.

Was there a real assassin this time?

The Seventh Princess urgently raised her magic power and unleashed a spell. Beams of blue magic were shot towards the assassin.

Kwa-gwang!

The missed shots of magic hit the wall of the library with a loud noise.

The assassin, who easily dodged the attack, quickly approached the Seventh Princess.

Although the Seventh Princess had put up a defense, the assassin's sword strike shattered it, and she fell backwards from the shock.

“Ugh!”

At the moment when the assassin's sword was about to fall on the Seventh Princess's neck, I teleported between them and put up the floating veil to block the attack.

The assassin's eyes, beyond the mask, widened as they saw me. They withdrew their sword in surprise and backed away.

After removing the veil, I immediately performed my blood magic and shot out blood. The guy couldn't avoid it and died instantly.

“...”

Looking down at the assassin who had fallen to the ground, I turned my head back.

The princess, who was sitting on the ground with her eyes wide open, was looking at me with a dazed expression.

After briefly locking eyes with her, I turned my gaze and quickly approached the window, sensing a commotion gathering around the library.

“Just a moment...”

I heard the princess's voice, but ignored it and hurriedly escaped outside.

The library door opened and people rushed in.

The guards and a few faculty members who had rushed in upon hearing the commotion were there.

“What’s going on?”

They discovered the Seventh Princess, Armia, who was sitting on the floor, and the dead assassin, and approached them in surprise.

Armia looked at them and then shifted her gaze to the second floor, where the mysterious figure had hidden.

The man, whom she had naturally thought was the assassin, had prevented the sudden attack of another assassin and saved his life.

And then, just like he had suddenly appeared earlier, he disappeared as if he had evaporated.

...What happened?

Who was he, exactly?

She looked at the spot where the man had disappeared with a confused look in her eyes.

There was only moonlight coming in through the open window.

After safely leaving the academy, I returned to the inn.

Troublesome things keep on happening.

Not only did I unexpectedly run into the Seventh Princess, but I also ended up witnessing her being attacked. It was beyond absurd.

Saving her was more of a reflexive action than anything else. It was unthinkable to just stand there and watch as she was about to be assassinated right in front of me.

Also, in the main storyline, the Seventh Princess was someone who could be considered an ally, so it wasn't a futile act.

In any case, everything was finished, so I immediately prepared to leave the city.

Despite the approaching daylight and the absence of any foreseeable issues in leaving, there might have already been a disturbance at the academy, causing me to feel uneasy.

I quickly left the city with Asher and moved to the place where we left Ti-Yong.

The guy who was crouching in the middle of the forest stood up and came towards me with a happy expression.

“We'll rest for a moment and leave immediately.”

“Yes.”

I closed my eyes for a moment, leaning my back against Ti-Yong's body, then we left for our next destination as soon as dawn broke.

Our next destination was the city of Gadret, where the Flaveros Magic Tower was located.

The search for the mysteries turned out to be a waste of time, but now that that was over, it was time to resolve the assassination of the tower master entrusted by the Overlord.

How should I handle that guy?

The master of the Flaveros Magic Tower, Ankh Gaindera.

The guy's level a few years later was 90, so his current level was probably the same or lower.

To be honest, simply killing him wasn't a difficult problem.

Even though he was a level 90 mage, and his defense could be challenging, I had enough power to take him down.

Now that Asher had also grown to level 90, it wouldn't be difficult if she also joined the battle.

However, the problem was not just killing him. He had to be assassinated without causing any disturbance. That was the tricky part.

But it's not like it's impossible.

The information provided by the Overlord included the rough living pattern of the tower master.

Killing the guy inside the tower was, of course, impossible.

So the plan was to wait for the tower master to come out of the tower and handle him then. It would be even better if he came out of the city altogether.

Therefore, I needed to contact the informant who had already infiltrated in that tower.

There was no other way to get real-time location information on the tower but through that informant.

The problem is how long it will take.

I didn't know when he would come out of the tower, so it could take a considerable amount of time.

If finding the heir continued to be delayed, it could be problematic. So I hoped to finish this as quickly as possible.

Since Gadret was located in the west of Santea, it was a considerable distance from here.

After a fairly long time of continuous travel, we had almost arrived at our destination.

“There it is,” I said, pointing towards the distant city of Gadret.

The Flaveros magic tower loomed over the city even from a distance, its colossal structure clearly visible at the heart of the urban scenery.

As usual, we plan to leave Ti-Yong nearby and proceed to enter the city at a slower speed.

“Hmm?” I felt a sensation in the distance, a sense of battle.

What’s going on?

I wondered, curious about the commotion in the middle of the night.

Although it could have been ignored, my curiosity got the best of me, and I turned Ti-Yong towards the direction of the disturbance.

The magical lights illuminated the dark forest as a woman and her pursuers crossed paths on the forest trail.

The woman’s body was covered in wounds, half of which were from the pursuers she had killed, and the other half from her own struggles.

Kwaaang!

Despite a lightning bolt being hurled at her from behind, she managed to avoid it, resulting in an explosion on the ground and the surrounding trees collapsing.

She managed to avoid the constant stream of magical spells and persisted with her escape, even though she was in a precarious state where she could

easily have fallen.

With ragged breathing, the woman looked back at the relentless pursuers who were chasing her.

The woman's name was Serun.

On the orders of the Overlord, she had infiltrated the Flaveros Magic Tower of Santea as a servant and worked there for an extended period of time as a spy for Calderic.

The reason she was currently being chased was because she discovered information about the secret demon research being conducted by the magic tower master recently.

There was one mistake.

Underestimating the tower master, Ankh Gaindera and his closest aides.

They were quicker and more meticulous than she had anticipated. So, she couldn't avoid suspicion in the end, despite having gained great trust as a faithful assistant to them for the past few years.

In the end, one small detail led to her being caught and her identity being revealed, and she was now driven into crisis.

But Serun didn't give up yet.

Since she was also an experienced and skilled spy, she didn't detect the signs too late.

The tower master hadn't directly intervened yet. If she could somehow resolve the pursuers chasing her now, it wasn't impossible to escape.

Three, five, nine...

The number of pursuers didn't seem to increase.

Having confirmed the number of pursuers chasing her again, she took deep breaths and prepared for combat.

It was impossible to completely shake them off just by running away. She had to completely uproot them, even if it meant risking everything.

Suddenly changing direction, Serun's body shot towards the pursuer closest to her like lightning.

One of them failed to respond to the ambush and had his neck severed. Other pursuers around were startled and prepared their magic.

Kwakkwakwang!

Serun used all her strength to summon her magic and managed to eliminate two more of her pursuers by slitting their throats, disrupting their concentration until only six of them were left.

Without a moment's rest, she dodged the flames shot from the side while her magic unfolded in her hand. The magic, condensed into a point, shot out in the form of a solid line, piercing through the defense barrier and taking the life of one more pursuer.

“Just a little more!”

In the blink of an eye, the remaining pursuers, who had lost their colleagues to death, could not prepare themselves.

Seizing the opportunity, Serun burned both her remaining strength and magic, trying to turn the tide of the battle.

Jjeoeoeung!

Suddenly, she collapsed onto her knees under an immense weight that seemed to compress her entire being, emitting a groan of agony.

As she barely raised her head and looked up at the sky, she was amazed and frustrated.

A middle-aged man, Ankh Gaindera, who appeared out of nowhere high up in the sky, was leisurely descending towards them.

He is the tower master of Flaveros.

At his appearance, the pursuers stopped moving and bowed down in unison.

“Tsk...I thought there might be a rat, but I didn’t know it was you, Serun.”

Moving his steps, he glanced down at her with his waist bent slightly.

“Where did you come from? Calderic? Of course, the Overlord must have sent you.”

A resigned expression appeared on Serun’s face.

It was all over now that the tower master had personally intervened. Any further resistance would be futile.

She couldn’t move a finger or even sense her magic, as if it had been stripped away by some kind of spell.

All that was left for her was silence. Even the option of ending her own life was impossible.

The tower master looked down at her coldly and twisted the corners of his mouth.

“I’m curious about what the Overlord is thinking. Would she even go so far as to have me deal with you like what happened to the warrior?”

“...”

“No, I don’t think so. Even the Overlord wouldn’t go that far, haha. Well, the information has already been transmitted, so it doesn’t matter.”

The tower master laughed and reached out to grab Serun’s chin.

“Anyway, if it’s something the Overlord sent, it’ll be difficult to make you talk. You’ll be useful for experiments for at least four years. So forget about dying beautifully.”

Experiment materials.

Serun’s face was filled with despair, as she knew the meaning of those words better than anyone else.

It was at that moment when the tower master was about to order her pursuers again...

“...?”

He lifted his head at the muffled sound coming from afar. And he narrowed his eyes.

It was because something black and enormous was flying towards them across the night sky.

“...Black wyvern?”

Something fell from the wyvern that had reached the empty space above their heads at an incredible speed.

The attention of the tower master, Serun, and the pursuers all focused on that something. It was none other than a person.

Swoooooosh!

Falling down below, the figure suddenly appeared on the ground, as if teleporting in the middle of the fall.

The figure was a young human male.

The unidentified man who appeared so suddenly stared at the two people. His clear golden eyes flashed in the darkness.

“.....!”

Serun's eyes widened in disbelief as she recognized the man's face, and the tower master's expression gradually turned to shock and disbelief as well.

He murmured, as if he couldn't believe it.

“Seventh... Lord?”

Chapter 99: Assassination of the Tower Master (2)

Chapter 99: Assassination of the Tower Master (2)

As we approached the scene, the sight that greeted us was one that seemed to have already concluded in battle.

There was a woman lying on the ground, a man standing in front of her, people standing around them, and corpses scattered about.

I checked the man's level and furrowed my brow.

【Lv. 90】

Level 90.

Upon seeing his level, I could immediately guess the man's identity.

Is he the Flaveros' tower master?

Given his level and the fact that he was located near the city where the magic tower was situated, it was only natural for him to come to mind. His appearance also matched the characteristics I knew.

Was he really the tower master of Flaveros? What was he doing here?

I couldn't be certain, but I increased my flight speed.

If he really was the tower master, I couldn't just pass him by.

“Let's go down there.”

Soon we reached the airspace just above them.

Without hesitation, I stood up from the saddle and tapped Ti-Yong's back.

I did this to protect Ti-Yong in case an attack came while we were landing.

“Oh...”

Perhaps he didn't know we were going to jump, but I heard Asher's surprised voice just as we were about to fall.

Shuahhh!

When we got close to the ground, I used space leap to land softly on the ground.

When I looked up, the woman and the man were staring at us in astonishment.

“Seventh..... Lord?”

The man, who was presumed to be the tower master, muttered these words.

I looked back and forth between him and the woman whose identity I couldn't figure out before raising my head.

Kroooh!

With a loud roar, Ti-Yong suddenly turned and rolled in a circle.

Then, a single dot quickly approached the ground with a deafening sound. And it was Asher.

She calmly walked up and stood next to me, and TI-Yong also landed nearby.

I turned my gaze back to the man and the woman. There was a moment of silence.

“Flaveros’ tower master.”

As I opened my mouth to say that, the man’s eyes flickered with surprise.

His reaction confirmed that he was indeed the tower master.

What kind of coincidence is this?

I had been wondering how to deal with him, but we ran into each other before entering the city.

I felt puzzled and bewildered as I tried to guess the situation.

From the looks of it, it seemed that the woman had been chased by the tower master and was finally caught.

“Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

The tower master spoke again, seemingly confident of my identity.

I asked the woman who was lying on the ground, “Who are you?”

Although she seemed to be trying to say something, she couldn’t speak.

The tower master frowned with a suspicious expression and murmured, “You didn’t know? Then why...”

As I heard him murmur, something suddenly flashed through my mind.

I asked her again, “Were you the spy sent to the magic tower?”

The woman immediately nodded her head. As I suspected, she was the spy sent by the Overlord.

So, what’s happening now was... her identity was revealed, and she got caught? Was that why she’s being pursued by the forces of the magic tower?

That seems to be the case.

Only then could I roughly understand the situation we were in. At the same time, I felt a sense of relief. The situation was already set up perfectly for me to quietly dispose of the tower master, just as I had come here for.

I surveyed the area for any signs of danger. The only ones in this forest were the tower master and a few of his followers.

I'll take care of him right here.

It was a perfect opportunity. There was no reason to hesitate.

As if reading my thoughts, the tower master, with a confused expression, twisted his face into a fierce scowl and spewed sharp killing intent.

“Did you come here to kill me?”

“...”

“Why? Is it because of the experiment? Is this also the will of the Overlord?”

He seemed curious, but there was no reason to answer his question.

I said to Asher,

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Do you want to fight him once?”

Asher looked back at me and nodded calmly.

“Yes, of course.”

I didn't just give her the opportunity to test her grown power.

I looked at the tower master.

A translucent green field was faintly swirling around the tower master's body. It was the defense magic that he had already spread out.

Anyway, mages are tricky opponents.

The only counter to the ability to kill instantly was the defense barrier.

With a barrier like that, it was impossible to deal with him alone with my own strength, whether it was blood magic or space leap.

So while Asher was fighting with him, I just needed to find a suitable opportunity to intervene.

Or if Asher alone could handle it, there was no need to interfere. At that time, all I had to do was to stop him from escaping.

“There's no need to subdue him. Kill him with all your power.”

Swish.

Asher drew her sword and took a step forward.

The tower master looked at me with a displeased expression.

“You looked down on me too much, Seventh Lord. What kind of nonsense is this that you won't even face me yourself?”

Ugh.

Asher immediately used her racial traits as if she was going all out from the beginning. Her whole body turned white.

The eyes of the tower master widened as he looked at her appearance.

“...You're the White Moon tribe that had a duel with the General at the Earth Hill meeting!”

Asher's existence had already spread to some extent even in Santea.

The tower master also immediately raised his magic power.

A seeping spark crackled from his outstretched hand towards the spy who had fallen in front of him.

Seeing him ready to handle her first and go into battle, I used space leap.

The floating veil blocked the fierce lightning strike, and it quickly disappeared.

“...!”

The tower master could not pay attention to this side and could only retreat hastily.

It was because Asher jumped forward the next moment and poured her sword towards him.

Kwagwang!

As I watched the battle begin, I turned and helped the fallen spy.

Her condition seemed quite serious, so I took out a healing potion from my pocket and handed it to her.

“Treat yourself for now.”

“Yes, yes. Thank you, Seventh Lord.”

One of the tower master’s subordinates was shown panicking on one side, not knowing what to do.

“If you want to throw away your life in vain, run away.”

They froze in place, unable to even move after my warning.

I turned my gaze away from them.

The battle between Asher and the tower master was intensifying, turning the surroundings into ruins.

Aaaah!

The tower master's magic surged in all directions, unleashing several huge pillars of fire that rose up like swirling tornadoes.

The power was so overwhelming that it could have reduced a small village to ashes in an instant.

Asher quickly dodged the catastrophic pillars of fire and struck with her sword, while the tower master fired a green beam of magic. The two massive forces collided in midair, causing a massive explosion.

The aftershocks were so strong that I had to put up a barrier to protect myself.

Is Asher slightly ahead of the tower master?

Despite having only recently reached level 90, I had expected the tower master's experience to give him an edge. However, the battle seemed to be tilted in Asher's favor.

Even with the same level, there may be a slight difference in skill, so could it be that Asher has achieved a higher level than the tower master?

Or perhaps she was simply more skilled in combat than the tower master. Or maybe it was just that the matchup happened to be more favorable to her.

Krrrr!

The tower master, flying back and forth through the air, was unable to shake off Asher's persistent pursuit. The distance between them fluctuated unstably.

As Asher and the tower master's magic intertwined and clashed, the night sky was lit up with colorful flashes.

The magic spells unleashed by the tower master were diverse. They spread rings of magical power like thorn vines, and symbols scattered in the air exploded, either expanding or condensing to deliver delayed attacks.

Asher broke through the relentless magical onslaught, striking the defensive barrier that the tower master was continually regenerating and maintaining while distancing herself. However, if there were even a single moment of weakness, a gap to break through, it would be the tower master's downfall.

Of course, Asher had some dangerous moments as well, but she still seemed to have more room to spare than the tower master.

I wonder if I don't need to intervene?

Since Asher would be able to finish the fight immediately once the barrier was shattered, there seemed to be almost no chance for me to interfere.

However, I still kept my guard up and observed the battle.

Since the tower master had already delved into demonic research, I couldn't know what hidden tricks he had up his sleeve.

And then, in the very next moment, it happened.

Clang!

Finally, Asher's sword strike shattered the tower master's defensive barrier.

Startled, the tower master tried to regroup, but it was too late. In an instant, the tower master's eyes widened in astonishment.

“...!”

Asher's sword, shimmering with a brilliant white light, flashed and passed through the tower master's neck like a beam of light.

That was the end of it.

Asher landed on the ground, and the corpse, with its head and body separated, fell from the air with a thud.

After catching her breath, Asher wiped the blood off her sword and retrieved it into its scabbard.

“Ah...”

The spy who had been sitting and observing the battle still let out a small sigh with a dazed expression.

I turned my head and nodded once in the direction where Asher was.

“It ended more quickly than I thought.”

Even if Asher had won, I thought it would be a more difficult battle, but it ended in a moment with a perfect victory, without any injuries.

I felt a little proud and satisfied with her growth, which was even more than expected.

“Good job.”

I congratulated her as she approached and then checked the body of the tower master.

There was nothing else to examine or see, as he had died instantly with his head hanging down. As a dead person, he no longer showed any levels.

Confirming that he was definitely dead, I relaxed.

Is it still not the time yet?

In the future, the tower master of Flaveros not only conducted research on demons but also appeared as a villain who made a contract with them.

And not just any ordinary demon, but one of the top leaders of the demon faction, “Wonma”.

So he must have continued to use the power of demons until the moment he died.

But seeing that he didn't do that, I wondered if he had not yet made the contract with demons at this point.

Anyway, since the tower master was dead, the task assigned by the Overlord was now over.

Feeling more relieved than I expected, I turned my gaze towards the remaining mages and thought about how to deal with them.

Shh...

“...”

I was startled and turned my gaze to the sudden surge of black energy rising from the body of the tower master.

Chapter 100: Ditrodemian

Chapter 100: Ditrodemian

What is that?

I stared at the unfolding scene in confusion.

An unknown energy continued to emanate from the dead body of the tower master.

Magic? It was indeed magical power, but it had a subtle sense of difference.

It was a sinister and disgusting energy that made me feel uncomfortable just by looking at it.

I thought it might be the tower master's last trick, but he was clearly dead.

The energy seemed to be wriggling and gathering in the air as if it had its own will.

Reflexively, I looked back at the mages from the magic tower.

But they, too, seemed clueless about what was happening.

What was even more surprising was what happened next.

Whoosh!

The gathered huge energy extended like tentacles and pierced through the body of the tower master.

The red energy engulfed the body like a vine and was absorbed into the center of the energy.

Then the body of the tower master began to dry up and wither away, as if it had sucked every last bit of life out of it.

“...”

Did it just absorb the life force?

As I watched this eerie sight, I suddenly realized what the unknown energy was.

Those who made a contract with demons would pay for it in various ways.

It could be power, soul, life force, or just everything.

Because demons greedily took everything they could from a contractor the moment their life was cut off, it was easy to see that the source of the power in front of me was the power of demons.

Therefore, I realized that the tower master had already made a contract.

At the same time, I felt a slight chill down my spine.

Because I knew exactly which demon had made a contract with the Flaveros' tower master.

.....*Ditrodemian*.

One of the leaders of the demons, one with a very high authority, the seventh-ranking demon in the demon hierarchy, and the seventh-strongest demon in the entire demon force.

It was the identity of the demon who made a contract with Flaveros' tower master.

Zzaaack!

The power spread in all directions this time, even towards me and Asher.

I unfolded the floating veil to block the contact, and Asher drew her sword and slashed it right away.

However, the mages on the opposite side could not escape the power's attack.

The power easily pierced their defense barrier and pierced through their bodies.

“Ugh.....!”

The mages who were enveloped in the power, like the tower master just before, withered and died like a mirage in an instant.

The power that absorbed all their life forces even writhed, originally a mixture of black and red.

I just watched the spectacle, alert and unsure of what to do in this situation.

Do I just need to turn a blind eye and escape?

I had killed the target, the tower master, and didn't care what the demon who made a contract with him would say. There was nothing I could do from the start.

The energy rising high into the sky soon began to fly in a certain direction.

For a moment, the thought crossed my mind that if I followed that energy, I might be able to encounter Ditrodemian. It would be possible enough if I followed on Ti-Yong's back.

However, it was an extremely risky thought, so I immediately abandoned it.

...It's still too early.

The demons were beings more dangerous than any other race.

Although the source of their power was magic, their unique abilities were disorderly and unpredictable, like mysteries.

The demons, especially the ones at the top, the archdemons, would someday all have to fall. But it was not yet time.

Although I knew all of Distrodemian's abilities, there was no need to take the risk and face him with incomplete preparations.

“Let's retreat.”

I spoke to Asher, who stood still, waiting for orders, as I watched the energy move away.

And then, it was the moment when I tried to approach where Ti-Yong was...

“...!”

A sudden surge of enormous magic power.

I quickly spread out the floating veil.

From far away in the direction where the energy had flown, it seemed as if darkness was writhing, and the next moment, a fierce flame engulfed the entire area like a tidal wave.

Sssh.

The place where the flame had passed was completely ruined, with nothing left.

“Um, what is this...”

Asher and the spy looked around with shocked eyes.

An attack that suddenly flew without any warning.

It was a powerful and overwhelming force that couldn't even be compared to the magic that the tower master had unleashed a little while ago.

The two of them were protected by a barrier, and Ti-Yong was fortunately out of the range of the attack as it was far away from where I was standing.

Thud!

The guy flew over here in a panic and landed next to me.

I looked at it with a stern face.

This is completely unexpected.

After the emergency call from last time, the sense of tension and danger rose in my mind for the first time in a while.

I never thought that he would be around here...why?

Soon, I saw a man walking slowly from the darkness on the other side.

He was a giant with a head bigger than an ordinary person's and had an ashy skin that looked pale.

【Lv. 96】

Archdemon, Ditrudemian.

The guy who appeared calmly in front of me looked in this direction with a gloomy gaze.

The powerful and fiery energy emanating from him was more than that of a Lord. I could tell just by looking at his level.

The guy's gaze, which had been staring at me, moved to the corpse of the dead tower master.

Soon, his mouth opened.

“You are the Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

“...”

“I need to hear why my contractor was killed. Is it the will of the Overlord?”

I stared at him, or rather, observed him, without answering his question.

Around him, there were black flames that had just swept through the area, and I knew what that ability was.

The flames of annihilation – one of the unique abilities that he possessed, which could destroy anything that it touched.

“If you don’t answer, I’ll kill you.”

I laughed in response to his dry voice.

“If I answer, will you just let me go?”

He slowly raised the corners of his mouth.

“Of course not. You will die here.”

It was the expected response.

The unpleasant energy emanating from him, mixed with hostility, became even stronger.

I silently cursed and prepared for battle.

“Step back.”

At my words, Asher, who had been standing there with a slightly pale face, turned to look at me and nodded immediately.

She put away her drawn sword and obediently stepped back. She realized that it was not her place to intervene.

No matter how much she had grown, she was now only a hindrance, not a help. After all, the opponent was an archdemon.

Why is that guy here in the first place?

Did he come to see the tower master? But why did the timing have to be so coincidental?

Whatever the case, I couldn't avoid the battle since the situation had turned out like this. The guy seemed to be filled with a strong will to kill me already.

I shifted my gaze to Ti-Yong.

Normally, as per Wyvern's nature, it would never let anyone ride on his back other than me, but now was not the time to argue about that.

"Take these two and fly away as far as possible."

As an intelligent being, it seemed to realize the gravity of the situation and nodded without any resistance.

Asher took the spy and immediately jumped onto Ti-Yong's back.

I remained cautious of incoming attacks from Ditrudemian, but he just stood there, seemingly not interested in blocking them from leaving.

Ti-Yong, carrying the two of them, flew up with great force and disappeared to the other side of the night sky in an instant.

"You can fight all you want. In any case, you will still die."

I used a surprise blood art to shoot blood droplets at him.

However, the blood droplets were useless as the surrounding flames immediately burned them up.

"Tsk."

It was impossible to activate instant kill as long as he had the flames surrounding him like a defensive shield.

The guy waved his hand and shot out a giant flame like a wave, just as before.

I spread out the floating veil to block the attack again. Then I teleported behind him.

It was to create more distance since it was difficult to defend against attacks that were too fast to react to.

“Is it not magic, but a mystery?”

He muttered like that and then spread his hand before clenching it tightly.

At the same time, a sudden purple energy appeared around me and rippled like a gust of wind.

I felt a sense of danger as I once again performed a risky space leap.

Thunk!

At the moment after teleporting, a compressed burst of purple energy twisted and engulfed the space where I had been standing.

Part of the ground and bushes within the range of the purple energy vanished, leaving a smooth cut along the perimeter, as if space itself had been sliced apart.

...Spatial severing.

This was another ability possessed by Ditrodemian, along with his flame of annihilation.

As it literally involved cutting through space itself, if I had been a little slower to react and gotten caught in the burst, I would have been instantly annihilated. It was an attack that was almost a guaranteed instant death even in the game.

Without giving me a moment to rest, the next attack came flying in.

Ditrodemian stood still, only flicking his hand to launch the attack. But for me, there was no room for any hesitation.

I frantically blocked and dodged the surging flames and sudden bursts of purple energy.

Even now, barely managing to hold on, I knew that he was not using his full power.

I knew that in addition to the flames of annihilation and spatial severing, Ditrodemian had several more abilities up his sleeve.

What should I do?

The problem was that I had no means of counterattacking him.

Just one touch was all it would take, and even he would be susceptible to instant death.

But that touch was impossible. Since the flames completely blocked my blood magic, there was no way to make contact with him.

If the only way I could think of was to directly contact him using space leap instead of blood magic...

But that's not ideal either.

In that case, I would have to expose my entire body to his flames.

In other words, it was a method that would require risking my life.

But delaying the situation like this would inevitably lead to a predetermined outcome where I would eventually be defeated before he could even use his other abilities to their full potential...

What else can I do?

I had no choice but to try something, relying on my super regeneration ability.

After making up my mind, I blocked the raging flames and immediately activated space leap.

In the next moment, I teleported directly beside him, right into the midst of the searing flames.

“...”

An unfamiliar sensation of intense pain surged through my entire body like never before.

What I saw before me was an arm that had been burned to a crisp by the searing flames, so badly damaged that even the white bones were visible.

But I still couldn't let down my guard.

My vision immediately became blurry as darkness engulfed me, but I desperately reached out my hand towards my target.

In the next moment, his eyes widened in shock as my hand finally made contact with his body.

T/N: Correction! The word 'wonma' from last time is now changed to 'archdemon'. I actually thought it was the name of the demon, only to realized while translating this chapter that it's a title.

I'm sure you already noticed, but this author loved to give titles to their characters. Sometimes the title doesn't make sense (i.e. Third Lord, Heavenly Palace), and sometimes it doesn't even have a direct translation (i.e. the titles of the five stars of Santea). This 'wonma' belonged to the latter category. The closest I got and had made the most sense was 'archdemon'. So, we'll go by that. At least for now. (◡_◡;)

Chapter 101: Encounter (1)

Chapter 101: Encounter (1)

...It reached.

The appearance of purple energy around and the staggering of Ditrodemian's body were almost simultaneous.

It was an instant kill that even the ancient high-level mage would not have been able to withstand. No matter how strong they were, it would have made no difference.

As soon as I confirmed his death, I immediately erected a barrier without any hesitation.

The flames that surrounded us did not die out immediately, even though their master was dead.

Teleporting away would have been the best option, but it was impossible.

It was a surprise attack that barely succeeded. And now, because of my burnt eyes, I couldn't see anything.

I could feel the skin and the muscles in my arms burnt away though, leaving only bones.

It was only a short time, as short as a blink of an eye, but during that very brief moment, the part of my body that was fully exposed to the flames of annihilation became a pitiful sight that could not even be expressed as a "burnt to ashes."

Didn't they say that the greatest pain a person could feel was the pain of burning in flames?

Even in this situation, some useless information that I heard somewhere flashed through my mind.

I was sure that what was burning me right now wasn't real flames, but I could be certain of one thing. Compared to the pain I was feeling right now, a furnace would be nothing.

My head was still filled with this kind of thoughts even during this catastrophic moment. The only thing that was keeping me from losing consciousness before being engulfed in pain was probably the [Soul of the King].

Sh... shit...

I felt like I was about to die, but I held onto my sanity a little longer, thinking that I would endure just a little more.

To make matters worse, there was sudden pressure pushing hard against the barrier.

This was the first time such a situation had occurred, so I couldn't help but panic for a moment.

What now?

I couldn't see anything, so I didn't know what was happening, but I could definitely feel the shock coming through the barrier.

Could it be that the floating veil was breached?

I had been successfully defending against attacks all this time, so I wondered why this was suddenly happening. Then I remembered the purple energy that had spread around me when I made contact with Ditrodemian.

The guy had barely managed to unleash a spatial cut right before he was about to die.

Could it be that the pressure pressing against the barrier was due to his spatial cutting ability?

The shock coming through the barrier became stronger and stronger, to the point where it felt like my body would crumble if I kept enduring it.

However, I couldn't just release the veil. I had no time to even try anything, as I would simply disappear in an instant.

My body was still burning in the remnants of the flames, and outside, the twisting space was flashing to swallow me whole.

I was barely holding on to my consciousness, which was on the verge of reaching its limit, unable to move an inch.

In the eternal hell where one second felt longer than an hour, at some point...

Huh?

The pressure that had been pushing against the veil suddenly disappeared, like it had evaporated.

Since my burned eyes had not yet recovered, I couldn't exactly tell what had happened. Did the energy vanish before the barrier was breached?

Since I couldn't stay like this for long, I finally released the barrier after a little more time had passed.

"...Cough, cough!"

Fortunately, my body didn't crumble after releasing the barrier.

I exhaled as if throwing my body onto the ground and gasping for air that I had been holding in.

As I convulsed and writhed on the ground, my vision, which had been pitch-black, began to slowly return.

The arm that was bubbling and frothing with foam as it regenerated came first, as the flames had almost died down. My whole body was almost like a half-dead body.

Crazy...

It was amazing that I hadn't died in this state.

I waited for my body to regenerate, breathing in and out with difficulty while lying on the ground.

After quite some time had passed, my muscles and flesh, which had been burnt to the bone, were covered in new flesh and my skin had partially regenerated.

I blinked my eyes and got up with a completely exhausted body.

“Ugh...”

I barely managed to stand up with my trembling arms, gripping the ground.

I felt disoriented as I looked around.

The forest that had become a ruin due to the battle was nowhere to be seen, and the scenery of the intact forest was in front of me, as if asking if anything had happened just now.

And even the body of Ditrodemian, who should have been right in front of me, was gone.

“What...”

Did his body disappear along with his spatial severing?

...No, that's not it.

I looked around slowly again.

The landscape itself was different. This wasn't the forest where I had just been, it was a completely different place.

“...”

“Is it a completely different place?”

As I tried to stand up from my seat in confusion, my body went limp and I collapsed onto the ground.

I could still feel the aftermath of the flames. My body had regenerated, but my injuries had not been fully healed.

And it seemed that regenerating had used up all my stamina, as I had no strength left in my body.

Perhaps the little movement I had just made was the last bit of energy I had. I didn't even have the energy to move a finger anymore.

Soon, my consciousness began to rapidly fade away.

The state of mind that I had barely managed to hold on to, knowing that I would die if I lost it, had already reached its limit.

I didn't know what's going on... I couldn't take it anymore.

I slowly closed my heavy eyelids like a thousand-pound weight. My consciousness became distant.

A dark space.

A woman sat in a meditation position with her eyes closed.

In front of her was a black sword, emitting a golden light, stuck in the ground.

The aura of that golden light, which felt holy in an unidentifiable way, enveloped the woman in a dome-like shape.

“...”

Suddenly, the woman opened her eyes very slowly. It was like she had just woken up from a long sleep.

However, her gaze that appeared from under her closed eyelids was clear and sharp beyond words.

The woman, who had been staring at an empty space or something else for a long time, stood up from her seat.

As she reached for the sword, the golden light dissipated and gradually faded away.

The woman murmured a sigh.

“Well, there’s nothing else I can do.”

Ganesha, a nun from Robelgio Monastery, sighed as she touched her forehead.

It was early morning, after finishing the morning prayer with a devout heart. She was about to start her work. However, one troublesome young lamb in the monastery was already making her day difficult from the very beginning.

“So, Erica, could you please explain why Rex’s nasal bone was broken from this morning?” she asked the girl standing in front of her. The other had an expression that seemed annoyed by everything.

“I didn’t intend to break it. I just slapped him in the face, and his fragile bone was softer than my fist,” the girl replied calmly.

Ganesha, with patience in her heart, asked again, “Alright, no matter what happened, why did you hit Rex’s face?”

“That idiot...” the girl began to say.

“Erica,” Ganesha interrupted her.

“...That jerk keeps bothering me. You know, Mother Superior, he keeps talking about how I am from a lowly commoner family and irritating those around him. Ignoring him one or two times was fine, but...” the girl continued to explain.

Ganesha sighed quietly. Rex was a boy who had recently entered the monastery. He was from a noble family in northern Santea, but due to their downfall, he ended up here. However, he still could not blend in with the monastery’s environment and often caused conflicts. Although most children in similar situations knew how to get along, girls like the one in front of her were not always so gentle in nature, which inevitably led to clashes. Today, it was especially severe.

“How many times do I have to tell you to listen to me? I told you violence is never the answer,” Ganesha reminded her.

“I tried my best.”

With a stern gaze, Ganesha looked at the girl, Erica, who avoided her gaze and spoke.

“And it’s also in the scriptures, right? Love your kin, love your comrades, and love yourself.”

“...Yeah, but why? If you stay silent when you hear words that insult your lineage, isn’t that not loving your kin and yourself? So, I followed the teachings faithfully...”

“Erica!”

“I’m sorry. I’m reflecting on my actions. I won’t do it again.”

Finally, as Ganesha exploded, Erica immediately changed her posture and bowed her head.

Ganesha sighed deeply a few times before saying like she was giving up.

“Even though this had happened a couple of times, this time was too much. You know that, right?”

“...”

“Go to the forest and bring back some firewood before lunch. If you ever use violence again, it won’t end with a punishment like this. Do you understand?”

Erica didn’t think it was too severe, but she nodded her head obediently without arguing.

“Then, I’ll leave now. I’m sorry for shouting.”

“Yes, I’m sorry too.”

Erica came out of the room and scratched her head as she walked away.

As she came out of the monastery, a boy who had been swinging a wooden sword in the courtyard stopped his actions and cheerfully waved his hand at her.

“Hey, did you escape?”

Ignoring him and passing by, the boy quickly followed her.

“You should have controlled your strength. Even though that guy is really annoying, breaking someone’s nose is too much, isn’t it? What kind of cruel thing is that to do to someone who’s already ugly?”

At that time, another boy who was sitting on a nearby rock reading a book approached and asked, “What did the mother superior say?”

Erica shrugged and replied, “Go bring firewood until lunch.”

“What? You didn’t even get punished? Anyway, the mother superior must be too lenient. You should have been locked up somewhere for half a day...”

“Shut up.”

As Erica lifted her foot as if to kick, the other boy, Tom, who had been grumbling, flinched and stepped back. It was a reflexive action that he often did. The boy reading the book was named Heron.

“Well, anyway, let’s go. I’ll help you.”

Erica was the only one who had done something wrong, but the other two also took up their axes and moved into the woods as if it were natural.

The three of them, who had grown up together in the monastery since childhood, were like the Three Musketeers of Robelgio Monastery, always sticking together no matter what they did.

Puh-uck!

As they settled into their positions and chopped wood for a while, Tom wiped the sweat from his forehead and said, “Hey, did you guys hear about this? Sir Clendam, one of the knights in the monastery, is going to the sect in Santea Monastery.”

“I heard about it. He’s a really talented young knight among the knights in the monastery, so it’s not surprising.”

Clendam was a young, skilled knight among the knights in the monastery.

“Hey, I want to become a real knight someday and be called by those great people, too.”

“Wake up. What are you dreaming about?”

“What’s wrong with me? Is there anyone my age, other than Erica, who can wield a sword better than me?”

Tom asked Erica, who was silently chopping wood, “Hey Erica, how about you? Don’t you want to become a knight?”

“I’m not interested,” she replied.

Tom retorted, “Come on, you’re always saying that, but you’re practicing swordsmanship even harder than me. You’re just not honest with yourself.”

Erica rolled her tongue and threw down her axe, saying, “I’m going to get some water.”

She left the two behind and walked towards the flowing stream.

As she was walking alone on the forest path, something caught her eye.

“.....?”

She narrowed her eyes and looked at the figure in the distance. Soon, her eyes widened.

It was because a man had collapsed in the middle of the forest.

Chapter 102: Encounter (2)

Chapter 102: Encounter (2)

What's that?

At first, Erica thought she had seen it wrong, but there was definitely a person there.

Erica stopped in her tracks and looked around warily.

Having confirmed that there was nothing else particularly visible, she cautiously approached the unconscious person.

The unconscious person was a young man.

Erica blinked and looked down at him with a perplexed expression.

She had good reason to, as there was dried blood around him on the ground.

She brought her ear close to his face.

She could hear faint breathing, which confirmed that he was not a dead body, but a living person.

...He doesn't seem to have any wounds?

Erica examined his body from head to toe with a curious gaze.

It was strange that there were no visible injuries, even though there was so much blood on the ground.

She gave him a light kick, wondering if there might be a wound on his front.

However, there was no visible injury on his front either, only stubborn bloodstains.

Her gaze turned towards the lower half of the man's body, but then she furrowed her brows and looked away.

What should I do?

Erica was lost in thought for a moment.

It was not a particularly favorable situation for a person to be lying naked in the middle of the forest.

Moreover, this was a remote area where few pedestrians passed by. The only outsiders who occasionally visited were the residents of the nearby village.

He doesn't look like a resident of the village, no matter how I look at it...

First of all, it was a face that she had absolutely no recollection of.

With a beautiful face, fair skin, and an appearance that definitely didn't look like a villager from a rural village, there was even a strange sense of nobility.

Erica reached out and poked the man's body again.

"Excuse me... can you hear me?"

There was no sign of him coming to his senses or even flinching.

She briefly considered pouring water on his face to see if it would wake him up.

Suddenly, she heard a sound and looked around in surprise.

Rustle, rustle.

A few brown, furry animals appeared through the bushes. They were a pack of wild dogs that lived in the forest.

Did they smell blood and come running? Usually, there were no big predators that ventured this close to the edge of the forest.

She narrowed her eyes and looked around at the ground. She had left her axe behind, so she didn't have any weapons in her hands.

Fortunately, she soon found a thick wooden stick and quickly grabbed it.

“Why won't these damn dogs back off?”

She swung the stick around, but the dogs didn't retreat and continued to approach her cautiously.

So, Erica gave up on threatening them and grabbed the stick with both hands, assuming a defensive stance.

The dogs didn't seem to show any signs of backing down, even though their eyes seemed to be going crazy from hunger.

As they faced off for a moment, one of the dogs that was behind her suddenly lunged at her.

Erica didn't panic and quickly turned her body, swinging the stick.

Kehng!

With a lively thud, a wild dog was hit straight on the head, bounced off the ground and rolled over, motionless.

Other wild dogs, whining and barking, gave up on attacking and turned around to run away.

Erica sighed and threw her stick to the ground.

Then, a sound coming from the side was heard and Tom and Heron soon revealed themselves.

“Hey, are you okay?!”

The two hurriedly ran over upon hearing the dog’s howling.

Erica gestured that she was okay and turned her gaze to the side again.

As the two approached, they also discovered the unconscious man beside her, and their eyes widened.

“What, what is he?”

Tom alternated his gaze between Erica and the man, then covered his mouth with his hand.

“Goodness, did he commit a crime? Did you kill someone?”

“Are you kidding me right now?”

Heron slapped Tom on the back of his head and asked.

“What the hell is going on, Erica?”

“I don’t know either. He was just lying in the woods. I checked, and he seems to be breathing, but...”

Heron approached the man with a serious expression.

Then he examined the man’s condition and muttered in a curious voice.

“...It doesn’t seem like he’s injured anywhere, but what’s with all this blood?”

Tom stood next to him, scrutinizing the man from side to side, and said.

“More importantly, why is he lying here naked? There are no clothes nearby. Was he attacked by thieves?”

“Why would thieves appear in this area?”

Erica interjected, “Forget the pointless talk. What are we going to do?”

Tom replied bluntly, “What else can we do? We need to get to the priests quickly.”

Heron shook his head and disagreed, “We can’t just take him there blindly. We need to bring the priests here.”

“Why?” Tom asked.

“He’s an outsider with an unknown identity. Have any of you seen someone like him before among the villagers?”

“No, but...”

“That’s why we need to be careful. Let’s go back to the monastery quickly for now.”

At that moment, Erica quietly stared at the man and said, “Let’s just take him there now.”

“What?” Tom asked.

“With all the blood around and his condition, he could be in critical danger. What if he dies if we waste any more time?”

Then she quickly grabbed the man’s body.

Tom was taken aback and quickly approached her. “Hey, let me carry him.”

“Whatever.”

“Give me something to cover him with, Heron. We can’t just take him like this.”

With a sigh, Heron threw his shirt at Tom.

Thus, they took the unidentified man and hurried back to the monastery.

“.....”

When I opened my eyes, the first thing in my sight was an unfamiliar ceiling.

I quickly sat up, but was met with a piercing pain throughout my body.

Then I heard a voice next to me.

“Are you awake?”

A knight dressed in armor stood a little away from the bed. He spoke again.

“Please wait a moment. I’ll go get someone.”

Without saying anything else, he immediately left the room.

I looked at the closed door for a moment in confusion, then looked around.

“...What is this place?”

Where am I?

I shook off my drowsiness and tried to remember.

The battle with Ditrodemian, the gamble that risked my life to kill him.

And after it was all over, I found myself in this strange place for no apparent reason.

“.....”

But I couldn’t make sense of the situation, no matter how hard I tried to remember.

As I sat there in confusion, someone entered the room again after a short while.

It was the knight from before, along with another man who looked like a priest.

The man who approached me with a gentle smile asked,

“You’re up already. That’s a relief.”

“.....”

I couldn’t find any words to say, so he spoke again.

“The monastery people found you unconscious in the forest and brought you here.”

“...Monastery?”

“Yes, this is a monastery. Are you feeling alright?”

While wondering what all of this meant, I tried to answer, but once again furrowed my eyebrows.

Pain surged through me like a needle whenever I tried to move my body even a little.

The man raised his head and looked at me.

“You don’t seem to be doing well. Hmm, there are no noticeable external injuries, though...”

“...More importantly, where am I?”

He kindly answered my question.

“As I mentioned earlier, this is a monastery. It’s the Robelgio Monastery.”

“No, not that. I’m asking which area are we.”

“What do you mean?”

“Is this Gardret City?”

He looked at me with an expression that seemed to ask why I was asking something strange.

“If you’re talking about Gardret... are you referring to the city where the Mage Tower in the west of Santea is located?”

“Yes.”

“This is the Poston Territory on the south-eastern frontier of Santea.”

I couldn’t help but look bewildered.

Wasn’t this the complete opposite of Gardret City?

The magic tower and the place where I fought with Detrodemian were clearly near Gardret City, so what the hell happened?

“If you’re feeling confused, would you like to postpone the conversation for a while? You can take as much rest as you need.”

“No, it’s okay.”

I nodded.

As I talked a little more with the man, I was able to roughly piece together the situation. First of all, this place was a monastery called Robelgio, located in the south-eastern frontier of Santea. And apparently, the people at the monastery had found me unconscious in the forest and brought me here.

The man’s name was Tane, and he introduced himself as a priest of the monastery. He also asked for my name.

I was about to say Ron, but I said a different name.

“My name is Ethan.”

“Ah, you’re Mr. Ethan. May I ask how you came to lose consciousness in the forest?”

He was asking what I was doing there.

I tried to come up with an excuse and replied, “I was just a wanderer passing by. I don’t remember why I lost consciousness.”

The man didn’t seem completely convinced, but he nodded without asking any more questions.

He seemed more concerned about my physical condition and asked me various questions. Perhaps it was because he was a priest, but I was surprised at how kind he was to someone he just met for the first time.

“Since I’m feeling okay, can you give me some time alone to rest for a moment?”

“Sure. Then...”

“I really appreciate your help.”

“Don’t mention it. Please thank the children who found you and brought you here, not me.”

...Children?

He left with a cheerful smile, telling me to call him anytime if I needed anything, and walked out of the room with the knight.

I sighed and looked out the window.

What on earth is going on...?

I couldn’t figure out what had happened.

Why had I suddenly been transported from the west of Santea to a completely different region? It was as if I had been teleported in an instant...

Teleported?

Wait a minute.

Didn't I get caught up in Distrodeman's spatial severing at the last moment?

Could it be that it sent me flying to the other side of space instead of breaking through the barrier?

...I didn't know exactly what happened.

But it seemed like at least being caught in his spatial severing was the cause.

Otherwise, how could I have been teleported to such a far-off place for no reason?

"I'm going crazy, really..."

I scratched my head, feeling perplexed.

On the other hand, I felt relieved that I was still alive.

Considering that I had been engulfed in flames and my body had burned to the point where my bones were exposed, it was a miracle that I hadn't died in my unconscious state.

It was while I was lost in thought, staring into the empty space, that I felt a presence outside and the door opened once again.

Chapter 103: Encounter (3)

Chapter 103: Encounter (3)

Slowly opening the door, three people entered the room.

Two young boys who looked to be around 14 or 15 years old and a girl.

“Oh, you’re really awake,” muttered the big boy as he looked at me with some surprise.

As I looked at them, wondering what was going on, the girl came over to the chair next to the bed and sat down. The boys followed suit and stood near the girl.

The girl, who was sitting on the chair with her arms on the backrest, staring at me, soon opened her mouth.

“Who are you, Uncle?”

“...”

Uncle?

I was momentarily speechless at the unfamiliar title.

“And who are you guys?”

The big boy enthusiastically replied, “I’m Tom. And these are Heron and Erica. What’s your name, Uncle?”

“...It’s Ethan. But I wasn’t asking for your names.”

Looking at Tom as if he was pathetic, Heron said, “We are children who live in this monastery. And we are the ones who found you unconscious in the forest.”

Ah.

Come to think of it, didn’t that priest mention these children earlier?

I realized immediately that these were the children who had found me when I was unconscious.

“Is that all the reaction you have? Don’t you have any words of thanks?”

As I looked at the three of them for a moment, Erica, the girl, said that.

I answered immediately.

“Thank you very much. Thanks to you, I survived.”

Anyway, if they hadn’t found me, I don’t know what kind of trouble I would have gotten into while I was unconscious.

Since I had received a lot of help, I expressed my sincere gratitude briefly.

“Are you children raised in this monastery?”

The monastery was basically a place where clergy members lived, but it’s also a cradle where children who have nowhere to go were taken in and raised.

In the game, when you visit a monastery, there were usually children being cared for, like in an orphanage. And later, they became full-fledged clergy members.

Judging by their young age, I thought they might be in that category, too.

At that moment, the girl with a skeptical look scanned my body up and down and asked again.

“So, who are you, Uncle? You were lying in the forest like that, but you’re not from the nearby village, are you?”

I answered her, just as I had explained to the priest earlier.

“I’m just a traveler passing by. I don’t remember why I collapsed in the forest.”

But the answer didn’t seem to satisfy the girl, as she furrowed her brows a little.

“You don’t remember? Are you lying?”

“No.”

“Then why can’t you remember? It sounds like a flimsy excuse. It’s not like you had a head injury or anything.”

“Well, it could be that way.”

“...For someone who has lost their memory, you seem unusually calm?”

The girl persisted in questioning me, not believing my words.

Feeling annoyed, I responded in a cheeky manner.

“I just don’t remember the brief moment before I passed out. And my mind is just as confused.”

The girl, who was staring at me with an uncomfortable expression, spoke.

“Then I’ll just call you a pervert.”

“What?”

“You were lying naked on the ground. Isn’t that perverted?”

I looked at the girl in complete bewilderment.

Naked on the ground? What was she talking about?

Ah.

Come to think of it, was that what happened?

As I searched through my hazy memories, the last moment before I lost consciousness came to mind. I was definitely naked. It was only natural since the flames had burned my clothes to a crisp, along with my body. What I was wearing now was someone else's clothes.

“Wait a minute.”

So, they brought me here while I was lying naked on the ground?

My lips quivered, and I gulped as the thought crossed my mind.

“You’re trying to avoid answering by saying you don’t remember because something embarrassing happened, right?”

“No...”

“Then please answer properly.”

In that moment, a mix of indignation and embarrassment overcame me, leaving me speechless.

It was then that the boy named Heron stepped forward and reprimanded the girl.

“Erica, stop it. You’re being too rude.”

She let out a huff and decided to hold her tongue.

Kkorureuk.

At that moment, an unexpected sound echoed. The source of the sound was my stomach.

After a moment of silence, the girl got up from her seat.

“I’ll tell the priest to bring you food.”

“...Okay, thank you.”

I added.

“And I’m not really that kind of person. I hope you don’t misunderstand.”

“Don’t misunderstand? I’ll keep thinking that way until I hear your answer.”

The girl stuck out her tongue and walked towards the door.

Heron sighed and bowed his head to apologize.

“I’m sorry. She’s just naturally rude, so don’t take it personally.”

“Yeah. There’s no one in the monastery who acts as recklessly as she does, is there?”

Tom stopped drumming his fingers and shut his mouth as soon as he saw the girl’s angry glare.

“Anyway, rest well. We’ll be on our way.”

Suddenly, the three of them left.

As their presence faded beyond the door, the sound of their conversation could be heard.

“Is he a nobleman? The air around him is not that of an ordinary person.”

“Why would a nobleman be wandering alone in the woods without any attendants?”

“Um... is that so? Still, at least he doesn’t seem like a pervert, like Erica said. He’s very handsome with his clean face.”

“What are you talking about? If he looks like that, there’s even more possibility of him being one.”

...That’s how it ended.

After a while, time passed.

The door opened again, and a nun came in with a meal.

“Thank you.”

I thanked her and accepted the meal.

Bread and butter, and soup with meat.

It was quite a feast for an outsider like me.

I started eating right away, since I was weak and hungry. Let’s see how it tasted.

Asher looked down at the vast forest below with a stern expression.

The day had brightened, and time had passed.

She tried to suppress the anxiety and restlessness in her heart.

Where the hell are you?

She rode Ti-Yong away from the battle site as ordered by the Seventh Lord.

All that remained at the site were completely destroyed ruins and the corpse of the unknown demon he had faced.

The Seventh Lords disappeared without a trace, as if evaporating into thin air, and his whereabouts were completely unknown.

Despite continuing to search the surrounding area, the Seventh Lord could not be found anywhere.

Shoooo.

After going around a few times, Asher finally returned to where she started.

Serun, the spy, guarded the site where the Seventh Lord disappeared, greeted her.

“Have you returned?”

Serun was about to ask if the other had gained anything, but seeing Asher’s dark expression, she gave up.

Asher looked at the demon’s corpse with a bleak expression.

Serun had already found out the identity of the demon. It was one of the archdemons, and that it was a demon ranked seventh among them.

It wasn’t difficult for her, a top elite spy directly under the Overlord’s command, to deduce the identity of the demon who solely based on his outward appearance.

At that moment, Serun glanced at Asher and finally spoke cautiously, “It’s dangerous to continue staying here. With the death of the tower master and one of the demons revealing their appearance in person...”

Other mages from the Magic Tower side could come here at any time, or another demon could appear again.

From Serun’s perspective, the best course of action was to leave the scene immediately. However, she couldn’t do that because of Asher.

Asher, who had been silent, spoke up. “We still haven’t found Sir Ron.”

“If Lord Ron was safe and sound, he would have revealed himself first. But it’s already daylight, and still no sign of him...”

Asher turned her head sharply and glared at Serun.

Overwhelmed by the hostility that emanated from Asher's entire body, Serun paled and couldn't continue speaking.

"Sir Ron said that this was a task assigned to him directly by the Overlord."

"..."

"Explain yourself. Is this the Overlord's scheme to take care of Sir Ron, or to trap him?" Asher spoke in an icy voice, her hostility intensifying.

Serun barely managed to speak. "Ah... no. I had no idea that even the Seventh Lord would come here."

"..."

"Please calm down... and think rationally. What is the reason for the Overlord to harm the Seventh Lord?"

At the earnest plea of Serun, Asher slowly gathered her strength and closed her eyes tightly.

She knew that her words just now were completely forced, even she herself knew that.

Meeting Serun, who was being chased by the tower master, was also completely coincidental. It didn't seem like even the Overlord had planned that.

She was just venting her frustration and anxiety, unable to hold it in.

"Damn it."

She didn't want to think like that, not even once.

Asher would never admit the death of the Seventh Lord. No, she couldn't admit it.

Believing that he was still alive somewhere, she calmed her trembling heart.

Creak.

Hearing a loud whimper from beside her, she stroked Ti-Yong's neck.

“Don't worry. He's definitely alive. He's not someone who will die easily...”

After finishing the meal, I stepped heavily and looked up at the clear sky outside the monastery.

There's really no answer...

I was fortunate that my life was saved, but my situation had become quite difficult.

What is Asher doing now?

I wondered if she was desperately searching for my whereabouts since I suddenly disappeared. Maybe she even thought I was dead.

The truth was that the demon's ability teleported me here, but she couldn't have known that.

So I had to return to the Lord's Castle as soon as possible, but without Ti-Yong and with a long distance to cover, it would take a while.

And my body is not in good condition either.

Even though I was unconscious, it seemed like my body had been continuously regenerating and the trauma had been completely healed.

The problem was the internal injuries. It felt heavy just to move my body even a bit, probably because the injuries were so severe. It was to the point where I was sweating just from walking a short distance.

In short, moving immediately was not an option.

It would be better to recover my body to some extent and leave rather than leaving in a hurry.

Should I stay here for a little while?

I thought, feeling a secret gaze from somewhere.

It was the gaze of a knight standing near the monastery building.

As an outsider, it was natural for me to be treated with at least some caution from their perspective.

However, it seemed like they had no intention of kicking me out, so it wouldn't be a problem to ask for their understanding and stay here for a while.

Chapter 104: Encounter (4)

Chapter 104: Encounter (4)

“Hmm, I heard that Erica and the children found a person who had collapsed in the forest and brought them here.”

“Yes, he is a young man. He says he was just a traveler passing by the area by chance.”

“How did that happen?”

“I don’t know. He says he doesn’t remember anything before he collapsed, but there are some suspicious parts that make me think he might be hiding something.”

The abbot stroked his beard as he listened to the priest’s explanation.

“He is in such a bad condition that he can’t move, so he wants to stay in the monastery until he recovers.”

“Then there’s nothing we can do. We should provide him with convenience so that he can live comfortably. He’s an outsider, so we should be careful and observe him.”

The priest nodded his head as if he had expected the abbot’s response.

The other couldn’t just turn away from someone in need, especially since he was more faithful than anyone else.

Looking at the piles of documents on his desk, the priest suggested, “Rather than doing that, why don’t you take a break, Abbot? I’m worried that it might harm your health.”

The abbot smiled at the concerned words.

“It’s only for a day or two. Besides, I’m almost done with everything, so don’t worry about it.”

As the priest left, the abbot continued with his work alone.

...

After reading the documents for a while, he looked down at the bottom drawer under his desk.

The one that was locked with a padlock.

He took out a key from his pocket and unlocked the drawer, revealing its contents.

Inside it, there was a translucent black jewel the size of a finger joint.

“Hmm...”

Dehod picked up the jewel and touched it with a strange expression in his eyes.

The gentleness that he had just shown was nowhere to be seen, and there was only cold ruthlessness in his eyes.

As footsteps approached the room, he put the jewel back into the drawer and cleared his face. Soon after, there was a knock on the door.

“Come in.”

The door opened again, and another priest entered.

“What’s the matter?”

“Well, sir. There’s something I need you to check regarding the scriptures you mentioned earlier. Are you very busy?”

Dehod made a soft smile and gestured with his hand.

“It’s alright. Bring it over here.”

After explaining the situation, I asked if I could stay at the monastery until I recovered. They readily agreed.

I spent almost the entire day and the next day lying in bed.

Sometimes the priests came to use healing magic, but it didn’t really help.

If it took this long to recover, even with the help of super regeneration, Ditrodemian’s magic must have been truly deadly.

Of course, considering the fact that I had taken on the attack of an archdemon, I had gotten off cheaply.

I really lucked out.

It wasn’t the time to be relaxed, but there was nothing I could do in this situation.

To alleviate my body, I went out to the monastery courtyard occasionally.

Also, it was a hardship to endure restlessness all day long just lying in bed.

I wasn’t in a hospital, but I felt like a patient receiving care as if I were hospitalized.

“.....?”

While sitting in a chair and absentmindedly looking at the scenery, I saw familiar faces coming out into the courtyard.

Erica, Tom... and was that Heron?

The three of them noticed me, but they were far away, so they didn't come over to say hello.

Heron had a book in his hand, and Erica and Tom each had a wooden sword.

The two people holding swords briefly warmed up and soon began to clash swords with each other.

Are they sparring?

I had also seen a few other kids swinging wooden swords in the courtyard. Perhaps they wanted to become knights in the future.

Even though it was only for a day, based on the atmosphere I had observed, it didn't seem like the monastery imposed strict discipline and rules on the children.

Heron leaned against a nearby rock and read a book, while Tom and Erica clashed their swords fiercely.

I quietly watched their sparring.

[Lv. 11]

Erica, the girl, had a higher level than the two boys.

Among the three, she was the only one I could feel a faint magical power, even if it's very weak. She probably somehow learned how to accumulate Mana.

Since they all looked to be about the same age as Rigon, it was natural for Rigon to come to mind in comparison.

Compared to Rigon, they were at a pitifully low level, but Rigon wasn't a comparison target to begin with.

Even if they hadn't received systematic and proper training like those from prestigious families, they could be considered having a considerable level.

Clang!

Not long after, Tom's sword floated up in the air.

He grumbled loudly, flapping his hands, "Hey, be careful. You almost tore my fingers off!"

Erica snickered and turned to Heron. "He's not warmed up yet. Want to spar?"

"No thanks," he declined.

They chatted for a moment, then noticed me and approached.

"Hello, Uncle!" Tom greeted me enthusiastically. I nodded my head in return.

"If you're having trouble moving, why are you out here?" Erica asked shortly.

"Just came out to get some fresh air," I replied.

"Hmm, it's better not to wander around too much if you don't want to arouse suspicion. You're a suspicious outsider, after all. And it's not just me who thinks so," she said, putting her hand on her hip.

"I haven't even been walking around," I retorted, annoyed.

I knew that whenever I went outside; I was being watched by the priests and holy knights in the vicinity. I decided to leave and was about to turn when Erica suddenly reached out and grabbed my shoulder, making me stumble.

Since my body was so weak that walking was a struggle, even though Erica's touch was not strong, it was enough to make me stumble.

Thump.

Erica caught me urgently as I lost my balance.

Even though I stood still, my body ached, and a sharp pain shot up my back. My face twisted involuntarily.

I turned my head in confusion.

Erica also released her hand from my shoulder and looked at me with a startled expression.

“I didn’t even use much strength. Why are you so weak?”

“Hey, Erica.”

Heron interrupted her shameless remark.

I clicked my tongue and asked, “What is it?”

“Don’t go deep into the forest behind the monastery. It’s a place you shouldn’t enter.”

“A place you shouldn’t enter?”

I was about to ask why, but at that moment, a nun from the direction of the monastery shouted, “Erica, Tom!”

The two of them quickly turned to flee in the opposite direction, their faces anxious. Heron sighed and followed them.

The approaching nun asked me while catching her breath, “What were those children doing here?”

“They were practicing swordsmanship...”

“I see. Excuse me.”

She bowed her head and ran back in the direction where they had fled.

As the sound of mumbling faded into the distance, it seemed like the person had other things to do but was procrastinating and putting things off.

Almost a week had passed since I had been staying at the monastery.

I spent each day focusing solely on my recovery.

Although there was still stiffness when I moved, the constant pain that had been piercing my body had almost disappeared.

As I walked through the corridors of the monastery after finishing lunch, I saw the priest named Tane picking up books and papers that had fallen to the ground up ahead.

I watched him for a moment and then approached him, offering my help.

“I’ll help you with that.”

“Oh, Mr. Ethan. Thank you,” he said, smiling. “You seem to be coming out of your room more often now. Has your health improved?”

“Yes, thanks to your kindness.”

As I picked up the fallen books, I glanced over their titles. They seemed to be religious texts like the Bible.

“You’ve been moving all of these by yourself?”

“Haha, yes. I tried to take them all at once and it was too much...”

I was curious about why he was moving so many books, and he seemed to sense my curiosity and explained.

“I need to transcribe the scriptures, but I have some things to organize first.”

Transcribing the scriptures? At first, I couldn’t understand why he would do such a thing, but then I realized that there were no printing presses in this world, and each book would have to be handwritten by a person.

Or maybe there's something like a typeface.

I picked up all the books and grabbed the paper documents, quickly scanning their contents.

With a cursory glance, I immediately realized that the contents were a summary of passages from the scriptures.

This world was a world where transcendent beings that could be called gods really existed. My interest was piqued suddenly.

I briefly read through the passages written on the paper, and Tane, who had finished organizing all the books beside me, asked in a surprised voice,

“Ethan, can you read the ancient proverbs?”

“...?”

Oh, right. Come to think of it...

At his words, I recalled one of the settings from RaSa, which was in the far recesses of my memory.

In the church, they used ancient proverbs along with the continental common language.

The church had its own unique script that they had been using for a long time, and it was called ancient proverbs.

It was based on the continental common language, but the script was much more complex and difficult to learn.

That's why mastering ancient proverbs was said to be one of the biggest challenges for those who walked the path of priesthood.

...Why am I able to read this so easily?

I looked through the contents written on the paper once again.

Upon closer inspection, I realized that it was similar to the continental common language, but clearly different. However, I had no trouble reading it smoothly.

Was this because it's based on the continental common language, so interpretation was possible?

"Yes, I can read it."

Tane looked at me with surprise in his eyes at my answer.

"You can read ancient proverbs. Does that mean that you, Ethan...?"

Finally, I realized that I had caused a useless misunderstanding. It was because ancient proverbs were characters that only clergymen would learn.

I quickly shook my head. "No, I am not a clergyman."

"Then why do you know ancient proverbs...?"

"I just learned them out of personal curiosity. I enjoy exploring and analyzing ancient languages and various characters."

"I see." Tane nodded as if convinced, though a slightly disappointed expression remained on his face.

Nevertheless, I could still sense a considerable amount of goodwill in his eyes.

"Still, your effort is truly remarkable. Even gifted individuals born with talent would take at least a few years to fully learn ancient proverbs. The fact that you learned them out of curiosity rather than faith is truly something."

Advanced chapters on Patreon if you want to read ahead! ^^

Chapter 105: Encounter (5)

Chapter 105: Encounter (5)

“No, there’s nothing to be impressed about.”

Even though I was not a clergyman, he seemed sincerely pleased that I had learned ancient proverbs.

I continued to scan through the documents and suddenly had an idea.

“Would it be okay if I helped you with this?”

“What?”

“I mean, with organizing these scriptures. It looks like it would take a lot of time to go through the papers, but it doesn’t seem like a particularly difficult task.”

At a glance, it was just a matter of sorting and organizing the scriptures. So if one could read ancient proverbs, it seemed like something anyone could do, even if they weren’t a church member.

Tane blinked and responded.

“Well, that’s true, but I don’t know if I should ask you to do that, Ethan.”

“You’ve already been so helpful to me, so it’s really not a big deal. Plus, I really want to give it a try.”

All I did all day was lie in bed or look at the scenery in the monastery’s courtyard. Doing nothing and passing the time like that was beyond boring.

And as I had said, I was indebted to the monastery, so this kind of help wasn't a big deal.

“If I take care of half the volume, couldn't you just give it one final check, Father?”

Tane seemed to hesitate for a moment.

But seeing the dark circles under his eyes, and knowing how busy he already was, it seemed like an offer he couldn't refuse.

He smiled and nodded.

“Okay, I'll ask you to do that. Thank you so much.”

I came back to my room with the scriptures and paper and pen that Tane handed to me.

I sat at the desk on one side of the room and started working immediately. I unfolded the scriptures on one side and put the paper down on the other, scribbling with an inked pen.

I will try to finish it by tomorrow.

I searched for verses, categorized them, and recorded them. It was a task that was close to simple labor, but it was much less boring and more productive than doing nothing. And there was some enjoyment in examining each verse of the scriptures.

As I filled one side of the paper, I took a moment of rest and lost myself in thought.

God...

There were countless religions on Earth, but the concept of religion in this world was a bit different. That was because they truly believed and worshiped a transcendent being whose existence was clearly present.

The God of Light, Rael.

The only denomination in the RaSa's worldview that was recognized by all was the Raelian denomination that worshiped him. It was also the state religion of Santea, and at least within the realm of Santea, it was difficult to find someone who did not believe in Rael.

Compared to the past, the Raelian religion had become much stronger, and there were clear reasons and turning points why they had even more absolute faith in the existence of the God they believed in.

The onslaught of demon forces and the appearance of the Holy Sword.

In the abyss of despair, where nothing but destruction awaited, the transcendent being performed a miracle for humanity with a single sword. And the course of the war was completely reversed.

Only one human, who was chosen by the Holy Sword, eradicated the darkness that had spread over the continent with her transcendent power, and humanity ultimately succeeded in sealing the Demon King and driving out the demons.

Hero.

The current owner of the Holy Sword, a being celebrated as a great hero by all.

In the official setting, she was the strongest existence in RaSa's worldview.

Such a hero could be considered the axis that currently balanced the four major powers.

Even the powerful Calderic maintained a certain degree of surface-level peace by not invading Santea, and the fact that the demonic forces with superior power than Calderic were not running wild was all due to the existence of the hero.

Therefore, it was an expected future that a great chaos would return to the continent once the hero disappeared.

And there wasn't much time left until that moment.

She suffered from serious after-effects from the final battle with the Demon King, and even now, she was losing vitality.

“...Um.”

Thinking up to that point made me feel like my current situation was silly.

Why was I organizing scriptures so leisurely when it was not the time to do so?

I needed to recover as soon as possible and go find Asher... but.

Suddenly, I sensed someone approaching the room, and without even knocking, the door was abruptly opened.

“Dinner is ready.”

...It was Erica.

She stumbled with a piece of bread in her mouth and walked up to the desk, dropping the food she was holding on the table.

I quickly cleared away the papers as the soup almost spilled. Then, with a frown, I asked.

“Why are you...?”

There used to be a nun who would always bring meals, but it was odd to see this guy suddenly showing up.

Erica finished chewing her bread and shrugged before replying.

“She stopped me while I was passing by and asked me to bring it instead. It's a bit of a hassle for me too. Anyway, enjoy your meal.”

“Sure, thanks.”

“But why are you doing this with all these scriptures piled up?”

Her gaze went to the scriptures and the paper I was recording on.

“Oh, this? It’s organizing and copying the scriptures that need to be transcribed. Some of the priests have been working hard on it for a while now.”

“I see. Why is the Uncle doing it?”

“I’m just helping out since I’m indebted.”

She raised an eyebrow.

“But can you even read the scriptures?”

“Yes.”

“How come? Were you also a priest?”

“No.”

“Then how did you learn to read them?”

“I was interested in languages, so I studied them separately. I’d appreciate it if you left now and didn’t bother me anymore.”

I told her not to bother me and leave.

However, as she continued to glance around, I wondered what else she was planning to do.

“But Uncle.”

“...?”

“Why were you lying unconscious in the forest? Are you really planning to keep hiding the reason until the end?”

I frowned at her words.

Every time this guy saw me, she persistently asked about that incident.

“How many times do I have to tell you that I don’t remember?”

“That’s a lie. How long do you plan to keep saying that?”

She crossed her arms.

“I couldn’t help being curious. You look suspicious no matter how I look at it. You were covered in blood but didn’t have a scratch on your body, and you were naked without any clothes.”

The reason why there were no injuries despite being covered in blood was because of super regeneration.

It seemed like she still thought I was hiding something, especially about that part.

Of course, it’s true that I’m hiding something.

Since I had no intention of telling her, I just ignored her.

It wouldn’t make a difference even if I tried to explain.

Erica clicked her tongue at my reaction and turned her gaze back to the paper I was writing on.

After a moment of silence, she opened her mouth again.

“By the way, why do we have to use this kind of script separately when we can just use the common language of the continent? It’s needlessly complicated and takes longer to learn without any practicality.”

I looked at her with a slightly bewildered expression.

“Can a clergyman say something like that?”

“I haven’t been baptized yet, so I’m not an official member of the church.”

“Anyway, you’ll become one in the future, won’t you? Don’t you want to be a knight?”

“What are you talking about? Who said that?”

“Sometimes it seems like you were engrossed with the stories that your friends were telling,” I said with a deep frown.

“No, I didn’t. Why would I believe the nonsense that Tom spouts off?” she forcefully denied.

“I didn’t say that you believed it. I was just asking,” I replied.

“Well, even if it’s not true, I could still become a member of the congregation. I don’t have anywhere else to go after leaving the monastery, anyway.”

In other words, she would become a member of the congregation just to get by.

I couldn’t detect any sense of faith in her words, and I couldn’t help but wonder if someone like her existed.

She continued, “And I never believed in god to begin with.”

“...”

What was she talking about now?

I asked out of curiosity, “You don’t believe in god... Do you mean you don’t believe in the existence of god?”

Erica shook her head.

“No, that’s not what I mean. It’s just that I can’t understand it. The hero received the Holy Sword from the god of Light, right?”

“Right.”

“It’s just that I can’t wrap my head around it. God saved humanity, but so many people died in wars. Why did god wait until so many lives had been sacrificed before helping us?”

...I don't know either.

The game’s story didn’t explain it in detail.

“If god really had omnipotent power and could save humanity without any sacrifice, should I feel reverence and awe towards such a being? Should I just be grateful for the salvation without knowing the reason why?”

She trailed off with a soft, pensive look in her eyes.

“When I say things like this, the priests and nuns always say the same thing. They say that god only gives us trials and tests us.”

“...”

“But what is the purpose of these tests? If we overcome them, will god bring back the people we have lost? What is the point of all this for those who have already lost what is most precious to them in life?”

Her voice, though still quiet, now contained a hint of anger.

I looked at her intently.

She hesitated for a moment, as if unsure of what to say, then changed the subject.

“Uh, never mind. What do you think about god, Uncle?”

“I don’t really have any strong opinions about it.”

He was a transcendent being who bestowed the holy sword upon the hero of the RaSa universe.

And he held the key to solving the problems facing this world and me.

That was the extent of my understanding of Rael, the god of light.

“I spoke from my heart, but your response lacked sincerity.”

Erica pouted.

I asked her, “But can you talk about such things so casually to someone like me, an outsider?”

“What’s wrong with not believing in god?”

“That’s true.”

“It’s because you’re an outside that I say these things. Do you think I’d go around saying these things in front of the priests?”

“Well, I guess not.”

“Then what, would I go around shouting it in public?”

“Impossible.”

“And anyway, it doesn’t matter whether I say it or not. Even if I’ve never said it out loud, most of the people in the monastery know that my personality is twisted.”

As if all the talk had ended, she straightened her back from where she had been leaning on the edge of the desk.

“Anyway, enjoy your meal. I’ve been babbling about useless things.”

“Oh, now that I think about it...”

I remembered something I had forgotten and asked her.

“You said before that we shouldn’t go deep into the forest behind the monastery. What’s the reason?”

“Ah... about that?”

She scratched her neck and answered.

“Actually, I’m not sure either. They say that there’s a monster living deep in the forest.”

“A monster?”

“Several times in the past, priests and holy knights have gone missing in the forest without any trace. So nobody goes into the deep part of the forest.”

Chapter 106: Encounter (6)

Chapter 106: Encounter (6)

The forest behind the monastery was in a different direction from where I had collapsed.

It looked like an ordinary forest, but suddenly there was a rumored monster there?

“What... a ferocious monster lives there?”

“I don’t know. No one has actually seen it.”

“But why do they say a monster exists?”

“Just like I had said, there have been several cases of missing people from the monastery, so everyone assumes it’s the work of an unknown monster.”

So it’s just a rumor.

Well, it’s only natural for people to think that way if several people have gone missing.

“So, did everyone who went into the forest disappear?”

“No, only a few people. Before that, people used to pass through the forest without any problems. It was only after several incidents that people stopped going in there.”

Erica shrugged her shoulders.

“Well, it’s a story from before I came to the monastery, so I don’t know the details. Honestly, I don’t believe there’s a monster, either.”

“But if such a thing has happened, there must be something in the forest.”

“Maybe. Anyway, there’s nothing good about going in there, so I told you not to go that way when you leave later.”

She turned around.

“Well, I’m going out. Goodbye.”

As she left and I watched the closed door, I turned my gaze to the meal on the desk.

Pushing aside papers and books to make space for the meal, I picked up my spoon.

By the way...

Thinking back to the story Erica had just told me, it seemed like she had her own reasons for being here in the monastery. Most of the children in this monastery had nowhere else to go.

Did she lose her family to the demons, too?

Even after the war ended, the demons continued to wreak havoc across the continent, sometimes openly and sometimes in secret.

They slaughtered people directly, corrupted many through contracts, and, most importantly...

The demon’s seed.

The demons dreamt of resurrecting their Demon King.

They wanted to resurrect the monster to wither the seeds of all life on the continent and create a world only for themselves.

That's why they were secretly looking for those who possessed the "demon's seed".

The ones who carried the demon king's soul, fragmented by the Holy Sword in the final battle and spread throughout the continent, were the keys and sacrifices that could accelerate the demon king's resurrection.

Currently, the demons were wandering around the continent in secret, searching for those who possessed the seeds.

Therefore, finding the heir was the top priority, but after that, I also planned to somehow find and secure those individuals.

Lost in thought, I began to eat my soup.

I didn't know who cooked it, but the food was always delicious.

The day was bright, and Erica and Heron, who had come out to the yard, spotted Tom, who had already been out since early morning.

"Did you come?"

Tom stopped swinging his wooden sword and greeted the two of them.

He was already full of sweat and heat, making people wonder if he had been training since dawn.

"I feel great since this morning. When did you get up?"

"About two hours ago? Oh, I need to rest now."

Tom threw his wooden sword and slumped to the ground.

Both of them knew why he was so enthusiastic.

Heron said, as if he were scolding Tom, "Just practicing without any plan is not enough. You don't have much time left, so you should also manage your

physical condition.”

The Robelgio Monastery was a fairly large monastery located in the southeastern part of Santea.

Unless it was a fairly large monastery, there were no holy knights or other powerful warriors residing in it.

Therefore, as there were many children to manage, they even selected talented individuals and trained them properly. The selection test was now only a week away.

Tom was planning to challenge the selection test to become an apprentice holy knight.

“Hey, what’s so great about managing your physical condition?”

Erica, who was folding her arms, chuckled.

Although he felt bad, Tom knew that she was not genuinely laughing at him but just teasing him, so he laughed too.

“Shall we practice fighting?”

“Good idea. But since it’s almost time, let’s have breakfast and worship first.”

As a place of faith, gathering every morning to pray was the most basic rule of life here.

Erica made a look of annoyance and picked up the wooden sword that Tom had thrown.

As she swung her sword in the air, Tom asked her, “But are you really not going to do it?”

“What?”

“I mean, being a holy knight. With your skills, you could definitely pass.”

At that, Erica frowned.

“Oh, really. I’m not doing it.”

“No... I really don’t understand. Then why do you practice swordsmanship? Hey, Heron. Do you understand what she’s thinking? Hm?”

Heron just shrugged his shoulders and said nothing.

It was a pattern that was likely to escalate and end up with Tom getting hit with the wooden sword, so he didn’t want to get involved.

As expected, Tom ended up getting hit in the back of the neck with the wooden sword.

“Ow! That hurts!”

“Be quiet. I’m just swinging the sword because I’m bored. How many times do I have to tell you that I’m going to be a nun?”

“That’s ridiculous! What kind of nun just resorts to violence whenever someone doesn’t listen and needs to be disciplined?”

Tom complained and rubbed his sore back while Erica lifted her sword again with a fierce expression. He quickly hid behind Heron.

Heron clicked his tongue softly.

“Erica, calm down a bit. He’s still the one taking the test, and we can’t just mess it up by hitting him.”

“Right, that’s a fair point. If I mess up because of you, I’ll curse you for life.”

“You should also quiet down a bit.”

Erica sighed and threw her black scarf onto the ground.

“Let’s go to the chapel. If you keep grumbling like this one more time, I’ll smash your head in.”

“Oh, scary.”

“Stop it. She’s really going to do it.”

The three of them were about to enter the building again.

“Hey, it’s Mr. Ethan.”

A man was sitting on a bench in the courtyard. He looked like he just came out of the building.

Tom spotted Ethan in the distance and waved his hand.

Ethan, too, turned to look at the three of them and raised his hand.

“He seems to be coming out to the courtyard a lot lately. Is he feeling much better?”

“I guess so.”

Tom asked Erica.

“Hey, Erica. Are you still suspicious? Do you think he’s hiding something?”

“Huh.”

“Well, to me, he seems like a kind uncle, even if he’s a bit gruff. Last time I saw him, he was helping the nuns clean up.”

Erica remained silent for a moment before answering.

“I don’t think he’s a bad person or anything. I just feel like he might be hiding something.”

“Oh, is that so?”

He had spent quite some time at this monastery, but he hadn't talked much. They still didn't know much about him.

"Just staying here in the monastery would be nice."

As they passed by, a girl carrying a bucket of water interjected with a word. She was Kara, a friend of the three.

Tom turned to her and asked, "What do you mean staying here would be nice? What are you talking about?"

"Well, I mean, he's really good-looking, so it's easy on the eyes, right? Isn't that right, Erica?"

"I don't know," Erica replied shortly to her annoying question.

Tom responded as if he was pathetic. "Tsk, so it's just about having a good-looking face."

"Are you the one to talk? Tom, stop squirming every time you see Sister Raya and wipe the drool off your face."

"What? What are you talking about?!"

The girl stuck out her tongue and continued on her way.

Tom glanced nervously at Erica and made a hasty excuse. "I don't know what that weirdo was saying. I've never acted like that, Erica."

"What does it matter?"

Erica ignored Tom's comments and turned back her gaze to Ethan.

Tom cleared his throat and changed the subject. "Anyway, when do you think Ethan plans to leave? He seems really weak, and I'm worried he might collapse on his own."

"No way."

“Well, what about this? If he does leave, he’ll pass by the nearby city, right? So we can at least take him there to make sure he’s safe.”

“Are you suggesting we go out to the city as an excuse? Are you stupid? Do you think the priests would allow that?”

The three people talked as they headed towards the church.

I can hear everything, you guys.

I stood up from my seat and watched as they disappeared into the building.

I also went back to my room to have breakfast.

As I passed by, I saw a priest nearby. It was Priest Tane.

“Oh, Ethan.”

He noticed me and came over to greet me warmly.

“Good morning. You’ve been out here since morning.”

“Yes, I was just taking a walk. What about you, Father?”

“It’s time for morning worship now, so I was heading to the church.”

He was holding a scripture in his hand.

He looked down at the scripture and scratched his head before saying,

“Thank you again for helping me organize the scriptures. I feel like I’m causing unnecessary trouble for you when you’re not feeling well...”

“It’s just a matter of moving the pen, so what difference does it make? And I’m almost done now.”

“Really? You started yesterday, but you’re almost done?”

He was surprised, with his eyes widening.

“Yes, I think I can finish everything by this afternoon.”

“Well... you’re really fast.”

“If there’s anything left, I’ll help you more.”

“Ah, well... no, never mind,” he said, gesturing quickly, as if stopping himself from saying anything else.

He seemed to have something else he wanted to ask or request, but was holding back.

It wasn’t as if it was causing me great trouble, and it wouldn’t have mattered if he asked for more.

“Now, I will take care of the rest of it. Thank you enough for what you have done.”

He smiled again, thanking me once more. I was about to say goodbye and move on.

“...?”

I spotted a middle-aged man walking in the distance and fixed my gaze on him.

Tane also turned his head to follow my gaze.

“Oh, that’s the Abbot.”

...Abbot? Abbot of the monastery? I looked back at Tane and the other continued;

“Come to think of it, have you haven’t met the Abbot yet, right?”

“...Yes, I’ve been mostly in my room.”

“His name is Dehod, the Abbot of this monastery. He is a person full of faith, almost like a role model for all the priests here.”

I nodded my head and looked back at the abbot.

The reason he caught my eye was for a different reason.

[Level 64]

Because the level floating above his head was by no means a level that an abbot of a small monastery would have.

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Level 64.

A powerful being that could be compared to high-ranking knights or mages of a Lord's castle.

I stared intently at him and asked Tane.

“Excuse me, may I ask you something?”

“Yes?”

“Is the abbot skilled in magic?”

As soon as I heightened my senses, I felt that the abbot had a significant amount of magical power that matched his level.

Judging by his physique, he didn't seem to have trained his body, so I thought he might be a mage.

However, Tane responded unexpectedly, as if he didn't understand what I was talking about.

“No, I don't think he's particularly skilled in magic. He's just an ordinary person.”

“Is that so?”

Ordinary? The fact that the abbot was a strong person seemed to be completely unknown to Tane.

Could it be that the abbot was hiding his power from the people in the monastery? Why?

I had a moment of doubt, but it felt like prying, so I didn't ask any further.

Does he have a hidden past or something?

I looked back at the distant figure of the abbot again.

Time passed, and it was the day of the selection test.

At exactly noon, some knights and priests, as well as boys and girls, gathered in the courtyard of the monastery.

The head knight of the monastery, who had taken a look at the applicants, spoke up.

“Well then, let's begin the selection process for apprentice holy knights.”

The selection process was simple. After a duel with the holy knight in charge of the exam to prove their skills, it was over.

Tom calmed his mind and looked around.

Most of the applicants were boys older than him.

Challenging the position of apprentice holy knight was usually reserved for those who had reached adulthood when they received baptism, and Tom was definitely one of the younger ones among them.

Holy knights, especially as fighters who proved their faith with swords and armor, were much more admired by energetic boys than priests.

If he became an apprentice holy knight, he could establish a priestly relationship with the monks of the monastery and receive much higher-level teachings.

Meanwhile, children who did not apply for selection were watching the scene.

Among them, of course, were Erica and Heron.

“Look at his expression. He’s so nervous,” Erica pointed to Tom, leaning against a tree and giggling.

In the end, Tom was the only one who applied for the test.

Heron glanced at her and then turned her gaze back to Tom.

“Erica.”

“Yeah?”

“I’m seriously asking. You really have no intention of becoming a holy knight?”

Erica looked at Heron with a frown.

But instead of shooting back as usual, she remained silent for a moment before answering in a somewhat reluctant tone.

“There’s no reason for me to become a holy knight.”

“It’s just that it’s a waste of your talent to become a nun. The elders always say that you were born to be great.”

Some of the holy knights who recognized Erica’s talent early on hoped that she would become a holy knight like Tom and Heron.

If she became just an ordinary nun without learning swordsmanship or magic, she would likely spend her entire life in this monastery.

However, if she became a holy knight and honed her martial arts skills, she could eventually be recognized for her abilities and even move up to a larger organization or headquarters.

It was clear from the reactions of the holy knights who had taught Erica even a bit that her potential was outstanding.

Heron thought it was a shame. If his dear friend could receive great honor and recognition, it would be a good thing.

“I don’t know. Anyway, I’m not sure yet.”

Perhaps things could change later.

Heron nodded his head and didn’t ask any further questions.

Anyway, this selection test was not the last one, and there would be plenty of opportunities in the future.

“By the way, aren’t you uneasy about that?”

Erica pointed to a young knight who was in charge of this selection test.

Heron also looked at him with a worried expression.

It was Holy knight Varian, who had been eyeing Tom for some time now.

It was nothing important. He had corrected Tom’s swordsmanship stance before, but Tom had continued to practice swordsmanship according to the teachings of another holy knight, thinking it was more suitable for him.

From Tom’s perspective, he was just following a training method that he thought was more appropriate for himself, but from Varian’s perspective, it was a blow to his pride.

“It’s a test, so I’m sure he won’t mix personal emotions into it. And I doubt he’s still holding onto that.”

The exam was about to begin. Following the announcement, the candidates stepped forward one by one to face Varian in a duel.

“You still lack the overall basic foundation. It’s a shame, but you didn’t pass.”

“Your form is excellent, but your swordplay is too simple. Train harder and aim for the next opportunity.”

“You passed. You did great without any major flaws.”

The duel was conducted with a sword that did not have a sharp blade.

It was then Tom’s turn, and he approached Varian with his sword in hand.

Varian looked at him with a strange look and said, “Show me your best swordsmanship.”

“Yes.”

Tom took a deep breath and immediately attacked Varian.

Clang! Thud!

The dull blades clashed with each other.

Varian stood still and avoided all of Tom’s attacks.

It was natural that the attacks did not land, so Tom concentrated on showing his best.

“Stop.”

After about a minute, Tom stopped swinging his sword at Varian’s command.

Breathing heavily, he looked at Varian with a hopeful and tense look in his eyes.

But the words that came out of Varian’s mouth were firm and uncompromising.

“You didn’t pass.”

Tom’s expression hardened.

Heron's face darkened as he watched, and Erica frowned deeply.

“What? Not passed?”

There was a reason for Erica's strong reaction.

If Tom's ability had been clearly insufficient, there would have been no reason not to accept it obediently.

But in her view, Tom's skill was not much different from the one who barely passed among the two preselected people. But one passed, and the other failed.

“When swinging a sword, the body's center of gravity is not stable. You're not completely untalented, but you still seem lacking in various ways.”

Varian said so and turned to one side.

There were three people in charge of the evaluation, including Varian, who directly confronted the applicants.

However, even those who were ambiguous in expression nodded their heads to Varian's evaluation and ultimately came to the same result.

“Unfortunately, it's not passed. Work harder in training and aim for the next opportunity.”

Tom's skill was an ambiguous level that barely passed the pass line, whether passed or failed.

Therefore, if Varian had passed Tom, there was a possibility that the other two people would have followed suit and passed him.

It was unclear whether he had failed Tom because he sincerely judged him to be insufficient, or whether some personal emotions were involved.

However, Tom couldn't pursue it.

Anyway, there was no chance of reversing the result, even if he protested.

Thinking about the next test, he knew that it was better to quietly withdraw without attracting the attention of the other holy knights.

“Thank you.”

Tom muttered with his sword tightly gripped, and he had no choice but to bow his head, say goodbye, and step back.

And Erica saw it.

As Tom turned and returned to his spot, a faint smirk flickered on Varian’s lips.

Thunk.

Erica caught it and raised her hand, shouting, “I will take the exam!”

Everyone’s gaze was suddenly focused on Erica due to her unexpected shout.

Heron was also surprised and turned to look at her.

He immediately noticed from her expression, and voice that she was completely fired up.

“Hey, hey... Erica?”

“I have to give that bastard a punch.”

Erica muttered to herself and strode forward.

Although Tom usually lacked seriousness and was light-hearted, he was sincere about his dream of becoming a knight.

When she was convinced that Varian had only dropped Tom because of minor negative feelings, she couldn’t stand it anymore.

Tom approached the center of the field, looking surprised and flustered, and looked at the standing Erica. The holy knights all widened their eyes.

“Are you serious, Erica? You want to apply for the selection exam?”

She had always ignored their persuasion to become a holy knight, so it was natural for them to be surprised.

Erica took the sword from Tom and stood facing Varian.

“Let’s duel. I request it now.”

Varian’s eyes twitched.

“Fine. Do your best and show me your swordsmanship.”

Erica immediately rushed towards him with her sword raised.

I watched the situation of the field where the next duel had just started.

I was watching from a distance for a while, knowing that there was a test to select apprentice holy knights today.

Did she get angry because her friend failed?

Erica was wielding her sword fiercely against the examiner.

She seemed to have challenged the selection test in a fit of discontent over Tom’s elimination.

As I could tell from her level, Erica’s swordsmanship was the best among the applicants.

I was watching with some interest to see how the duel would turn out when I felt a sudden presence behind me.

“...?”

I slowly turned my head back.

I had no choice.

It wasn't just the feeling of a monastery person passing by. The energy contained in that feeling was quite large.

[Level 81]

What came into view was the appearance of a middle-aged man in a gray robe.

I didn't know all the faces of the monastery people, but I realized that he was an outsider.

He smiled softly at me and naturally approached this way. Then he asked politely.

“Excuse me. Are you a priest of this monastery?”

“...”

I glanced at him briefly.

A rosary with a symbol representing the Rael Church was hanging around the man's neck. I could guess that he was a priest.

I saw a sword on his waist and wondered if he was a knight. Was he from a different congregation?

Regardless, I could tell just by looking at his level that he was not an ordinary person. Level 81... Who was he?

“No, I'm just an outsider who is staying at the monastery for a short while. And you?”

The man replied.

“I'm just a believer who happened to be passing by nearby. But can you tell me what's happening here?”

He turned his gaze towards the open field where I was looking and asked suddenly.

I answered him.

“They’re holding a selection test to choose apprentice holy knights.”

“I see. An apprentice holy knight...”

The man let out a small sigh.

He didn’t reveal the purpose of his visit to the monastery.

After he turned his gaze back to watch Erica’s sparring for a while, he suddenly said with admiration in his eyes.

“She’s an excellent fighter.”

He stood next to me and began to watch the sparring naturally.

I looked at him with some surprise. What’s going on all of a sudden?

Varian defended himself against the attack with some amazement.

Erica’s attack was much more powerful than he had anticipated.

The knights of the monastery already knew about her exceptional sword skills, but he didn’t expect them to be this good.

Of course, she still had a long way to go before she could be compared to a full-fledged holy knight.

The two swords clashed low to the ground.

It was the moment when Varian was about to strike his sword to end the duel...

“...?!”

Suddenly, Erica’s sword drew a sharp arc and immediately aimed for Varian’s neck, thrusting forward.

Varian, who was somewhat relaxed due to the counterattack against that of a beginner, reacted late.

The duel was, of course, being fought without using magic, but he instinctively pulled in magic and struck an attack aimed at Erica’s neck.

Varian’s sword, which he couldn’t control, shattered Erica’s sword. It didn’t stop there and continued forward.

Erica’s frail shoulder was exposed to the full force of the sword strike.

At that moment, when her shoulder was about to be smashed, like her sword...

Clang!

A small magic bullet suddenly flew and hit Varian’s sword, shattering his sword as well.

“...Kuk!”

Varian, who had lost his grip on the sword, fell to the ground and grabbed his wrist.

Erica, who had lost her balance and fallen to the ground, looked at the scene dazedly.

The onlookers of the duel were momentarily confused as to what had happened and suddenly turned their attention.

A strange man was walking slowly in their direction.

“I apologize. The duel seemed to have escalated too much, so I interfered unavoidably.”

The man in the robe apologized with a polite but servile voice.

“...Who are you, sir?”

Varian, who stood up, glared at the man with hostile eyes. The other holy knights also looked at him with guarded eyes.

The inability to control power was clearly the fault of Varian, but it was natural for outsiders who suddenly intervened in the duel to not receive a positive reaction.

The man wearing a hooded robe responded with an incredibly gentle smile, “I am a believer who happened to be passing by.”

“A believer? From which congregation...?” asked a knight who was speaking.

As the man continued speaking, the knight’s eyes widened as he saw the emblem engraved on the man’s scabbard.

A brilliant golden cross engraved within a pure white border.

“The, the Radiant Knight...?”

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The Knight of Radiance.

The words spoken by the holy knight left everyone in surprise, including the knight himself.

No one in the room seemed to be unaware of what that title meant.

The twenty knights of radiance, the highest force in the order, directly under the command of the Pope, the center of faith.

The priests, who had been stunned for a moment, regained their senses and looked at the man with uncertainty.

It was unthinkable for such a renowned figure from the order to suddenly appear in this remote monastery.

However, the man didn't deny it and introduced himself with a charming smile.

"I am Jerel, the sixteenth knight in the Order of the Knight of Radiance."

"Ah, Sir Jerel!"

The name of the sixteenth knight of radiance, Jerel, was well-known to anyone who had even a little interest in the prominent figures of the order.

The holy knights around him were all deeply moved.

The knight of radiance, who was the pinnacle of all warriors of the faith, was an object of admiration and awe among his fellow holy knights.

Jerel turned his gaze to one side and walked over to Erica, who had fallen to the ground. He reached out his hand.

“Are you alright, child?”

Erica, looking bewildered, took his hand and stood up.

The highest-ranking priest among those gathered asked, “It is truly an honor to meet you, Sir Jerel. But may I ask why you have come to our monastery?”

Jerel answered, “As I mentioned, it’s just a coincidence. I was passing by the area and found out that there was a monastery here, so I came to take a look.”

“I see.”

“Could you guide me to the monastery? If it’s inconvenient, I’ll leave right away. Please don’t hesitate and treat me like any other guest.”

The priest hurriedly waved his hand and said, “Of course, how could we refuse? I’ll have someone show you right away. The abbot will certainly welcome you with open arms.”

“Thank you. Then...”

Jerel turned to Erica and smiled before following the priest.

After the commotion subsided, the selection test for the remaining applicants continued.

Was he a radiant knight?

I watched the man disappear into the distance with my arms crossed.

As expected, he wasn't an ordinary person, given his level.

A radiant knight, one of the elite forces in the Raelian church.

They wielded practical influence in the church, second only to the Pope and the Cardinals.

It's a relief that he didn't recognize me.

My appearance had already spread throughout the continent.

However, it was unimaginable for a Lord of Calderic to be at a monastery in the remote outskirts of Santea.

Even if he did think of me, he would have dismissed it as a mere misconception. I wasn't the only one with black hair and golden eyes on this continent.

"I wondered why someone of that caliber would come to this remote monastery," I thought to myself. He said they were just passing by, but I couldn't be sure if they had some other motive.

Of course, unless it was related to me, there was no need for me to worry about it, so I decided to forget about it.

"I should go inside," I said to myself, leaving the spectacle of the duel I was watching and returning to my room.

"I'm honored that such a distinguished guest has come to visit our monastery. It's a pleasure to meet you, Sir Jerel," said the abbot Dehod, praising Jerel.

"No, not at all. I'm grateful for the warm welcome, even though my arrival was unexpected," Jerel replied politely.

After some formal greetings, the abbot cautiously asked, "By the way, is there a reason why you have come to our monastery?"

“Oh, no. It really was just a coincidence, as I mentioned before. I was passing by on my way back from a mission and stopped by the nearby village. The villagers told me about this monastery, so I came here on a whim.”

“I see. If you would like, I can personally guide you around the monastery.”

“Thank you, but that won’t be necessary.”

After some small talk, the conversation ended and Jerel stood up.

“Well then, please make yourself at home here as long as you’d like.”

“Thank you for your hospitality.”

As Jerel walked down the corridor after leaving the abbot’s room, he stopped a short distance away and turned his head to look at the closed door. Then he shook his head and muttered,

“...Is it just my imagination?”

He looked away from the door and continued walking.

“Wow. This is unbelievable. That legendary knight who we only heard about in stories has come to our monastery!”

Watching Tom shouting in excitement, Erica bit her tongue. She was annoyed by his ecstatic behavior, as if he had already forgotten his failure in the selection test.

“What’s so exciting about it?”

Tom responded as if he didn’t understand Erica’s blunt words.

“How can you not be excited? Who else could it be but one of the radiant knights? And he’s none other than Sir Jerel!”

“So, who is Sir Jerel?”

Unlike Tom, Erica had no interest in the famous figures of the church.

Although she knew that the radiant knights were remarkable people, she didn't know anything about their individual stories or legends. When Tom became frustrated with her vague reaction, Heron stepped forward to explain.

“He is the one who fought alongside the hero on the battlefield in the final battle against the demon king.”

Sir Jerel Lagness, a radiant knight, was a particularly exceptional figure among the radiant knights for a reason. He survived the great battle in which the hero sealed the demon king several decades ago.

“That's right! He's such a remarkable person! And he's come to our monastery?! We should shake his hand!”

Of course, Erica's reaction didn't change even after this explanation.

She was startled momentarily at the mention of the hero, but that was all. Heron interrupted Tom's continued praise and asked with a sarcastic tone.

“By the way, are you okay?”

“Huh? What do you mean?”

“I mean the test, stupid. You worked so hard, but you failed.”

Tom shrugged nonchalantly.

“What's not okay about it? I wasn't expecting to pass, anyway.”

“You're laughing, but you were really hoping to pass.”

“Shut up. Well, it's already in the past and we can't change it. It's not the last time, so I just have to work harder and aim for the next one.”

Erica frowned at Tom's overly optimistic words.

"You're an idiot. It's not because of that, but Varian intentionally made you fail."

"Come on, it's just a test. There's no way he would do that."

"It's because you didn't see it. He definitely sneered at you. Anyway, this jerk..."

"Hey, hey."

Heron looked around anxiously and stopped her.

They were at the back wall of the monastery courtyard. Even though it was unlikely that anyone would hear them, the language was quite vulgar.

Tom chuckled.

"Thanks anyway. You came out for me earlier, right?"

"What are you saying? I came out because I was annoyed, not because of you."

Erica growled.

That was the truth, but neither Tom nor Heron insisted further.

"So, what are you going to do in the end?"

"What?"

"The holy knight. You passed the test, didn't you?" Tom asked with a gleam in his eye.

There was a reason why he didn't feel so bad about failing the test.

It was because Erica had applied for and passed the selection test.

He couldn't help but be happy that his dear friend's talents would finally shine.

But Erica betrayed his expectations and shamelessly retorted, "No, I'm not going to do it."

"Huh?"

"I said I'm not going to do it. I thought about it and it's too much of a hassle. I'll just go see them later and tell them I'm not going to do it."

Tom, who had been staring at her, let out a deep sigh.

"Hey, come on... You passed the test, and you're not going to do it? What if the elders find out?"

"I don't care."

"What if I can't pass the next selection test because of you?"

His words made Erica flinch.

It was partly forced, but it wasn't an unreasonable thing to say. The three of them were famous as the Three Musketeers in the monastery.

As soon as her expression became serious, Tom awkwardly changed the subject.

"Ah, what I said was just a joke. Anyway, now that it's come to this, think about it again, okay? Say something, Heron."

"Is she the kind of person who can be persuaded by what we say? If she doesn't want to do it, there's nothing we can do," Heron replied.

Erica, who had been sitting with her back against the wall, shook her head in annoyance and then collapsed onto the ground.

"Ah, yeah. What's the point in talking about it?"

Tom and Heron slumped down beside her, gazing up at the sky for a moment. The blue sky had some peaceful white clouds floating in it.

Heron lowered her head again and suddenly noticed that there was something missing on Erica's neck.

He asked, "Erica, where is your rosary?"

"Huh?"

Erica finally realized what had happened and reached up to touch her neck.

Her necklace, which she usually wore around her neck, was gone.

"Where could it have fallen?" she wondered aloud.

As she got up to look around, a sudden voice startled them, and they turned around to see who it was.

It was the radiant knight, Jerel, who had suddenly appeared around the corner of a building.

"Sir J-Jerel!"

Jerel gestured for Tom to calm down, holding the broken rosary in his hand.

It was a wooden necklace with the symbol of the church carved into it.

He approached Erica and handed it to her.

"Here, take this."

After receiving her lost item, Erica looked at the rosary for a moment before belatedly thanking Jerel.

"Thank you for finding it, Sir."

"It's nothing. But can I ask you where you got the rosary from?"

“Huh? I just received it from the priest a long time ago.”

The children of the monastery wearing accessories that symbolize the cross were a natural thing.

Tom was wearing a bracelet, and Heron was wearing a necklace, which was different in shape but similar to Erica's.

Jerel smiled and nodded his head.

“I see. I was curious because there is a sentence engraved in the rosary that I personally like.”

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Erica looked down at the small sentence carved on the back of the rosary, which Jerel had just mentioned.

‘Oh, you seekers of salvation, the miracle you hold in your hearts will never wither away in vain. Even in eternal darkness, a handful of light will never fade away.’

Tom, standing next to her, glanced at the rosary and said, “That’s one of the sayings left by the hero during the final battle with the demons, right?”

The most famous phrase among them was the one engraved on Erica’s rosary.

Jerel nodded his head as if reminiscing about the past with a strange look in his eyes, and asked Erica, “You didn’t know that the saying was carved on your rosary? Do you admire the hero?”

It was a meaningless question. Who wouldn’t respect the hero who defended their land and this continent, at least as a human being?

Erica remained silent, holding the rosary in her arms.

Tom chuckled and said, “Of course. She’s the hero who saved the continent. Erica doesn’t show it, but she secretly admires the hero in her heart.

“Do you want to die?” Erica glared at Tom as if she wanted to kill him.

Jerel quickly burst into laughter and then Tom said to him, “And I greatly respect you too, Sir Jerel! Sealing the Demon King with the hero is really

an amazing achievement!”

“Haha, thank you. But it was the hero who sealed the Demon King alone, and I didn’t play such a big role.”

The person who faced both the demon king and the original demons in the final battle was the hero, while the rest of the members of the squad only dealt with the lesser demons.

What Jerel had said was simply the truth, but Tom and Heron only thought that he was being humble.

He turned his gaze back to Erica and asked, “By the way, can you tell me your name, young lady?”

“Huh? Erica.”

Erica responded with a puzzled expression.

He went on to ask calmly, “Yes, Erica. Do you have any interest in learning swordsmanship from me?”

Tom and Heron were both stunned by his words, wondering if they had misheard him for a moment.

Erica also widened her eyes at his unexpected words, then asked, “Are you saying that you want me to be your disciple?”

Jerel nodded, as if it were obvious. “Yes, that’s what I’m asking.”

“Y-your disciple...”

Tom murmured in disbelief.

It was inevitable. A radiant knight, the most noble and dignified holy knight in the order, was now asking her directly to be his disciple.

Heron also stared at Jerel for a moment before turning to Erica. Unlike the two of them, the person who had received the proposal was calm.

“Why?”

Erica asked Jerel.

It was a natural question.

Entering into a discipleship was not something to be taken lightly. It’s not similar to knights passing through a monastery, teaching children. It meant providing proper teaching and support for growth.

Right now, Jerel was proposing that she become his disciple, even though she knew nothing and had just met him today.

Jerel replied, “I watched your sparring match earlier. I noticed your talent.”

Erica looked a little flustered.

She was aware that she had considerable talent, of course. But was it really enough for someone like him to take an interest in her? She didn’t think so.

“You must have seen many people with much greater talents than me.”

Jerel let out a hollow laugh.

Normally, it wouldn’t be strange for someone to be unable to think straight after hearing such a proposal, but she seemed to be suspicious of him.

It wasn’t that she lacked a realistic sense of how big this opportunity was. He thought she was an exceptional child and spoke frankly.

“True. But it’s not just your talent that made me make this offer.”

“...?”

“I have a good intuition. So I often act according to my intuition.”

Intuition?

The three of them blinked, wondering what he meant.

“The reason why I stopped by this monastery instead of just passing by is because I suddenly had a feeling that I might have a pleasant encounter here. But watching the duel from earlier, I have a feeling that it might have been you. That’s why I’m making this proposal.”

It was a ridiculous proposal, so absurd that it almost seemed like a joke.

However, Erica, who was quick-witted, could tell that he was speaking sincerely.

Jerel chuckled and asked again.

“So, can you give me an answer?”

“...”

Heron, who had swallowed his saliva, turned to Erica.

Tom also urged her with his gaze.

Whatever the reason was, this was an outrageous proposal that could change her entire life.

To become a disciple of a radiant knight? Which person would miss such a tremendous opportunity? But...

“I’m sorry.”

After a moment of silence, Erica blurted out.

Jerel’s eyes widened, obviously not expecting a refusal.

Tom let out a sigh unconsciously and grabbed Erica’s shoulder with an impatient expression.

“Hey...are you crazy?!”

Erica shook off his hand with a resentful look and continued.

“I don’t have any intention of becoming a holy knight. So I appreciate your offer, but I don’t think I can become your disciple.”

Jerel looked at her in puzzlement and asked.

“I thought the duel you had earlier was a test to select apprentice holy knights. Did I make a mistake?”

Erica answered somewhat hesitantly, “I joined out of impulse... I never really thought about becoming a holy knight after taking the test.”

Jerel didn’t quite understand what she meant, but he didn’t press her for more details. “Anyway, that’s a shame. Can you tell me why you don’t want to become a knight?”

After hesitating for a moment, Erica said, “Aren’t knights supposed to be people who can fight to the death for god?”

“That’s right.”

“My faith isn’t as strong as that. So even if I became a knight, I don’t think it would mean much.”

Heron closed his eyes and rubbed his forehead. Erica’s talk of lacking faith in front of a radiant knight could be considered as blasphemy.

But fortunately, Jerel didn’t get angry or scold her.

“Faith, huh...” He looked at her with a strange expression. “I don’t think blind faith is necessary when it comes to god.”

The three of them were momentarily speechless.

Was this really coming from the mouth of a radiant knight, who could be considered the model for all holy knights?

Jerel laughed and asked Erica, “Have you ever had doubts like this? Even though there’s still so much pain and despair in the world, why doesn’t god

just save everyone? If he really is an omnipotent being, isn't that not a difficult thing at all? And if he's trying to test us, what's the point?"

"...."

"I always thought I couldn't understand it. And I tried to find the answer."

Erica listened to the story as if she were possessed and asked, "So, did you find the answer?"

"I haven't found it yet. I'm still searching for it."

"...What?"

"To me, it's enough just to have that. No matter what, that person saved humanity once, and I believe there must be some hidden meaning to it. That's my faith. Even if it's considered blasphemy, it's not strange, haha."

Jerel grinned broadly.

"I plan to stay here at the monastery for three days. The offer still stands, so if you change your mind, come find me. Well then..."

With that, he turned around and left, leaving only those words behind.

Ten days had passed since I stayed at the monastery.

I was finally preparing to leave.

My body wasn't fully recovered, but there was no longer any difficulty in moving, and the residual magic power that had remained inside my body was no longer felt.

I almost thought it's going to take forever.

My destination was to head straight to Calderic.

Even if I went back to the site of the battle with Ditrodemian, there was no way Asher would still be there. So, I had no other choice but to go back to my territory instead.

To travel from this remote area of Santea to Calderic required a very long distance, so it was necessary to move diligently. And the problem was not just the distance.

“I don’t even have anything right now,” I thought.

Although I had said I would leave tomorrow, Priest Tane had even offered some provisions and food, but it would certainly not be enough to travel all the way to Calderic.

For now, my plan was to stop by a nearby city and somehow raised more funds to cover my expenses. I had no more specific plans other than that.

Should I stop by an Adventurer’s Guild and take on a commission?

As I pondered that, a knock sounded at the door and Erica came in.

I wondered what she wanted.

“I heard you’re leaving tomorrow?”

I had only told the priest, Tane, about it, so she must have overheard it somewhere.

I nodded my head. Did she come just to ask about that?

“Not too long ago, you could barely move, but you’ve fully recovered now, right?”

“Yeah, more or less.”

“Well... I just wanted to say goodbye and to wish you luck.”

She paused for a moment before continuing.

“Oh, and do you know? Yesterday, a really impressive person came to our monastery. They called themselves the Radiant Knight.”

“I know.”

Of course I knew. I had been watching everything.

“Why are you telling me that?” I wondered, but she continued with her sudden statement.

“By the way, that person asked me if I wanted to be his disciple.”

“...?”

A disciple?

I blinked in surprise.

Sure, she had talent, but was she really at a level where such a giant would take an interest in her?

“Well, that’s good for you. So, what did you say?”

“...I’m still considering it. I was planning on refusing, but he said something strange.”

“Something strange?”

“He mentioned something similar to when I talked about the god or whatever last time. It was a strangely similar story. He was a really weird person.”

If she was talking about the time she mentioned the god, did that mean she was implying that the radiant knight had no faith as well?

I couldn’t believe that the radiant knight would say something like that.

She asked me.

“What do you think, Uncle?”

Chapter 110: Encounter (10)

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Without hesitation, I answered Erica's question.

"It's a good opportunity, so you should accept it."

Was there any reason to refuse this offer? She would be the disciple of a radiant knight. It could be an opportunity that would never come again in her life.

"Do you think so too?"

Still, Erica had a hesitant expression.

It seemed like she wasn't particularly drawn to the opportunity to rise in status so quickly.

Of course, it's her life and her choice, but if I were in her shoes, I would have accepted it without hesitation.

"Do you not want to become a holy knight that badly?"

"It's not that I don't want to. I just can't find the meaning in it."

"You said you wanted to become a nun. If you look at it that way, there's not much difference between a nun and a holy knight."

Erica hesitated for a moment before agreeing.

"Well, I guess so. But if I become that person's disciple, I'll have to leave this monastery."

“Ah, you don’t want to leave your friends and go somewhere else?”

“No... I’m okay with leaving those guys. I just don’t want to leave the monastery.”

She said that, but it seemed like that was the biggest reason.

I wonder if she’s telling me this story because she wanted to hear a specific answer from me.

During the time I spent in the monastery, all I did was exchange greetings with her whenever we crossed paths. Were we close enough for her to come to me for advice?

“Think carefully and do what you want.”

That’s what I told her.

Still, I decided to give her a more sincere answer.

“It would be good to follow the radiant knight and experience a wider world, but it would also be good to stay in this monastery and enjoy a modest happiness. Even if you choose the latter, I don’t think it’s foolish to kick away your fortune. No one knows the future, so we don’t even know which one is the regret-free choice.”

Erica replied, grumblingly, to my words, “It’s such a vague answer.”

“It’s your life, after all. And regardless of which one I suggest, you probably won’t listen to me, anyway.”

She fell silent, unable to deny it, and then burst out laughing.

“True. Anyway, thank you.”

As she turned to leave the room, she looked back and said, “Oh, and please say goodbye when you leave. I’ll send you off with a smile on my face.”

“That’s not necessary.”

“Well, if you don’t, I’ll ask Priest Tane. And will you keep hiding why you collapsed in the forest until the end?”

I waved my hand irritably.

“Just get out of here.”

“Okay.”

Erica replied indifferently and went out again.

I continued to ponder my thoughts as I stared at the closed door.

“Hey, if she became a disciple of Sir Jerel, will she have to leave the monastery?”

Tom murmured, tinkering with his cup absently.

Hearing this, Heron, who was sitting next to him and reading a book, closed it and answered.

“Probably, right? I doubt she will continue to stay in our monastery and maybe she will even receive a Pope’s decree.”

“Hey, the Pope’s decree... that’s really a great opportunity for promotion, isn’t it? But what’s Erica’s problem? If it were me, I would have kneeled down and bowed as soon as the Sir Jerel said so.”

“Why state the obvious? Does that girl have the personality to want that kind of thing?”

“That’s true, but I didn’t expect it to be this bad. Sometimes I don’t understand what she’s thinking at all.”

Tom, leaning back in his chair, let out a frustrated and dissatisfied sigh.

Looking at Tom like that, Heron asked him, “But are you fine with this?”

“What? What are you talking about?”

“If Erica really became Sir Jerel’s disciple and left the monastery, wouldn’t it matter to you?”

“What are you saying? If that happens, there’s nothing more I could ask for. Do you think I will be jealous of her or something?”

“No, it’s not that...”

Tom took the water cup he was holding and brought it to his mouth while letting out a sigh.

“You like Erica, don’t you?”

Then, at Heron’s continued words, he spewed out the water he was drinking.

Tom, who was coughing with a rattling sound, looked at Heron in complete confusion.

“What, what, what are you saying? Who likes whom? Me like her? Who would like a stubborn girl like her?”

“Tom.”

Heron looked at him with pity.

“Except for Erica, everyone else knows. Do you think you’re hiding it well until now? So, just put everything aside and tell me honestly. Do you really want Erica to become Sir Jerel’s disciple?”

Tom scratched his head, avoiding Heron’s gaze.

It had already been three years.

Tom, Heron, and Erica had entered this Robelgio Monastery almost at the same time.

Tom and Heron had lost their families to war, while Erica had become an orphan due to the havoc caused by demons.

When they first arrived at the monastery, they were despairing about their situations and were busy trying to get along with each other. However, they eventually became close through their fights and eventually, the three of them began to naturally hang out together.

And as Heron said, Tom had feelings for Erica.

He thought he had hidden it perfectly, but everyone except Erica, who was oblivious to such things, knew about it.

After a long silence, Tom said in a helpless tone, “I told you, I wished so.”

“....”

“Of course. Erica doesn’t want to leave the monastery. But I was hoping she would sincerely consider accepting Sir Jerel’s proposal. Then, she wouldn’t be stuck in this remote monastery forever. She has the potential to become someone much greater than she is now.”

Tom’s words were sincere, without any hint of falsehood.

Blocking the future of a precious friend due to such petty selfishness was unimaginable for him.

Heron shook his head.

“She didn’t want something like that in the first place.”

“Maybe she doesn’t want it right now. But who knows what might happen in the future? She doesn’t dislike becoming a holy knight, she just thinks there’s no reason for her to become one. Do you really hope that Erica will refuse the proposal?”

“Of course not. I’m just as frustrated as you are.”

“Should other nuns to help persuade her? Maybe it will have the opposite effect?” one of them suggested.

“Are you kidding? Give up,” the other responded.

They hadn’t yet told other members of the monastery about Jerel’s proposal because they knew Erica’s stubbornness.

If others found out, it would turn the monastery upside down, and they would likely pressure Erica as a group to accept the proposal. If the situation became too big, she might reject the proposal outright without further consideration.

“We still have a few more days, so let’s work hard to persuade her during that time. But if she doesn’t change her mind, there’s nothing we can do,” Tom said, nodding his head.

“And if she has to leave the monastery, then I’ll just confess to her,” he added.

Heron’s mouth dropped open in surprise. “Out of nowhere? Are you serious?”

“Yeah,” Tom replied. “It’s better to do it then. If she takes it seriously and rejects me, I might as well die.”

Tom stretched and said, “Time’s up. Let’s go eat dinner.”

The sun was almost setting, and the sky was painted with a crimson hue.

The two finished their conversation and stepped out of the room.

After leaving the building to search for Erica and head to the restaurant together, Tom and Heron saw a few of their peers gathered in the yard.

Among them, they saw a boy with a nosebleed and approached them.

“Hey, what’s going on? Matt, why do you look like that? Did you get into a fight with someone?”

The situation involved the injured boy being comforted by the surrounding children.

Another girl explained what had happened instead of the injured boy.

“He fought with Rex. That jerk provoked him and started asking for a fight again.”

Even without hearing the detailed explanation, Tom and Heron could roughly understand the situation.

The boy who had broken Matt’s nose before was Rex.

As he still could not mix with the monastery kids, he was always picking fights with other children.

While Heron examined the boy’s wounds, he asked, “Where’s Rex?”

“After I gave him a good beating, he ran away. He’s just a pathetic kid.”

The boy still seemed angry as he spoke.

At that moment, another boy spoke up.

“Rex ran into the forest behind the monastery.”

“What? Why there?”

“I don’t know. We were just discussing what to do now.”

The forest behind the monastery, where several priests and knights had gone missing before.

It was a place where the people of the monastery rarely went due to rumors of unknown monsters living deep within.

“Just leave him be, that jerk. He’ll get scared and come out on his own in a while.”

Tom frowned and looked back at the forest behind the monastery as he spoke.

“First of all, wash your face. I’ll look for him once, so do it quietly.”

“What? Just leave it.”

“What if he doesn’t come back? It’s already almost dark. And Erica broke his nose not long ago, so if the nuns find out, they can’t just let it go this time.”

It would be better to quickly find and bring Rex back before things get more annoying.

Heron said, “I’ll go with you.”

“It’s okay. Find Erica and go to the restaurant with them first. It won’t take long.”

Before Heron and the other children could say anything else, Tom immediately turned and ran towards the forest behind the monastery.

“Anyway, that brat Rex...”

Rex, who had recently come to the monastery, still wasn’t adapting well to the life here.

Tom, who was similar to Rex when he first came to the monastery, was understanding and letting it go, but it seemed like trouble was happening more often as time went on.

Thinking that it was time to properly deal with the situation, Tom went into the forest without hesitation.

“Where did he go?”

Since all the talk about monsters was just rumors, and disappearances were just past incidents, there was no real fear. In fact, Tom, Heron, and Erica

had come to the forest secretly a few times before, under the noses of the priests. Of course, they did it when it was bright out.

Since it was obvious that Rex couldn't have gone too deep into the forest, Tom searched around the outskirts of the forest. He had to find Rex before it got too dark.

“...”

Something finally came into his view after wandering around for a while.

A leg that suddenly sticks out of the dense bushes.

Tom immediately realized that it was Rex's leg, and he felt relief and doubt at the same time. He hurriedly approached to take a closer look and said, “Rex, you crazy bastard! What are you doing here?”

Tom pushed through the bushes and went inside.

But he could only freeze at the inexplicable sight that unfolded before him.

“Huh?”

At the sudden noise nearby, Tom turned his head. His face slowly turned pale.

Tom and Rex didn't return from the forest until morning.

Chapter 111: Encounter (11)

Chapter 111: Encounter (11)

On a late night as the day was drawing to a close, the Robelgio Monastery was completely overturned by turmoil.

The priests, who had explained the situation to the children belatedly, mobilized the knights and searched the forest.

However, nothing was found, and there was no trace of the two people who did not return.

“Another person...”

Sister Ganesha looked at the knights gathered in the courtyard with a bewildered expression.

The disappearance of people in the forest had happened a long time ago.

There were rumors that monsters lurking in the forest were responsible, but she was someone who did not believe in such things.

She had thought it was simply an unfortunate coincidence and that it would never happen again.

But once again, someone had disappeared. And this time, it was two children.

She turned her gaze to the two people standing on the opposite side. They were Erica and Heron.

They were especially shocked, because, together with Tom, they were the three closest friends among the monastery's children.

"I'm sorry, Erica."

Heron sobbed with tears in his eyes.

"I should have stopped Tom. I shouldn't have let him go into the forest alone... I thought nothing would happen and left him alone without thinking..."

Erica didn't respond to his guilt-ridden voice. Although she thought inwardly that she should comfort him, she couldn't bring herself to speak because she didn't have the emotional capacity to do it.

Her friend, Tom, had disappeared. According to the conversations she heard among the knights, nothing had been found yet.

It was just like those who had gone missing before. They too couldn't find even the smallest clue and eventually were never found.

She never imagined that it would become her own reality like this.

Erica stared into the forest with a boiling sensation in her chest.

The knights seemed to be in a mood to disband, without any intention of continuing the search.

She hurriedly walked closer to them.

She spoke to Muten, a knight who had been somewhat friendly to her.

"Muten, why aren't you continuing the search?"

Muten looked at her with a sad expression and replied.

"The abbot ordered us to stop until daylight. We don't know what might happen if we search too hard."

Among those who had gone missing in the forest, there were also knights.

Even for skilled warriors like them, the forest was not safe. Especially not at this late hour.

“I’m sorry we couldn’t find anything. I pray that your friend will return safely. If that happens, then surely it will be god’s protection.”

Muten said that and dispersed with the other knights.

Only a few knights remained, guarding the entrance to the forest.

In her heart, Erica wanted to go into the forest herself right away and search for Tom, but of course, the adults would never allow it.

Erica just stood there, clenching her fists.

“...”

There was someone watching that scene from afar.

It was Jerel, who had come out late after hearing the commotion.

Jerel watched her back quietly before shifting his gaze to the person walking towards him. It was the abbot, Dehod.

Approaching Jerel with a lamp in hand, he spoke with a dark expression.

“Once before, people from the monastery disappeared in the forest like this.”

“I see. Were they eventually found?”

“No, we couldn’t find a single trace. There were rumors of monsters in the forest, so I never expected something like this to happen again.”

Dehod’s expression twisted with sadness.

Jerel looked at his expression and asked, “Have you requested help from other denominations?”

“Yes, but there were no clues and nothing like this has happened since.”

Jerel nodded his head and said, “I will search the forest myself.”

“What? But you shouldn’t have to go through all that trouble...”

“Two children are missing. The longer we waste time, the harder it will be to find them. There’s no need to worry about appearances at a time like this, Abbot.”

At the bone-chilling words, the abbot’s eyes flickered for a moment. But soon, he became moved and expressed his gratitude.

“Thank you so much, Sir Jerel. Then, please do so. Please help the two children return safely.”

The priests and nuns sent the children away and did not allow them to leave the monastery building.

Erica looked outside through the window and peeked around the courtyard. In her hand, she held a lamp wrapped in a rag to hide the light.

Heron, who was standing at the back, spoke with a trembling voice filled with anxiety.

“Erica, going into the forest now would only be dangerous. You won’t be able to see anything properly with just the light from the lamp.”

“...”

“Even Sir Jerel himself went out to search. So just wait quietly...”

“Heron, be quiet. You’ve said enough. Go back to your room.”

Currently, Erica was thinking of going into the forest herself to find Tom. The knights had said they would resume the search once it was daylight, but by the time the night had passed, Tom could have already met with some unknown fate.

Although Jerel had gone into the forest himself as Heron had said, Erica was not the type to wait helplessly no matter what the outcome may be. Heron looked at Erica with frustration as he swallowed his words.

The knights who had gone out found no traces of Tom. Even if she were to secretly venture into the forest alone, there was no way she could find anything. However, Heron knew that she was not the type to be deterred even if he tried to stop her.

“Okay, I’ll go with you.”

Erica also had a sense of guilt for Tom’s disappearance. Heron, too, was frustrated with the situation and also wanted to go into the forest himself to find his friend.

“You’ve said enough. I’ll go alone.”

“Do as you please. If you keep insisting like that, I’ll go tell the other priests.”

Erica scowled at Heron.

In the end, the two of them decided to go into the forest together.

The two who sneaked out of the building through the window hid themselves in the building and looked towards the direction of the forest.

There were several holy knights standing at the entrance to the forest, but if they went in a different direction, it would be fine. It’s not like they couldn’t enter the forest just because there was no path.

So the two of them secretly turned around and entered the forest.

After they had gone a little further into the forest, Erica untied the cloth wrapped around the lamp.

Inside the forest, it was so dark that they wouldn't be able to see anything if it weren't for the lamp.

Moonlight was of little help. Even with the lamp, they could only barely see a few steps ahead.

"It's much darker than I thought...."

Of course, neither Heron nor Erica had ever entered the forest on such a pitch-black night.

Feeling like they were walking into the mouth of a monster, they relied on their dim vision to find their way forward.

Heron gulped and asked.

"Now what are we going to do?"

He was asking where they should start looking for Tom's trail.

Erica replied.

"We have to follow the path in the forest to find it."

There was no other way, so it was probably the best option.

Without hesitation, she continued to move deeper into the forest.

Heron followed behind, hoping to run into Jerel somewhere in the forest.

A considerable amount of time passed.

Erica kept her eyes wide open and roamed the forest, searching for any traces of Tom, whether it be footprints or anything else.

But, as expected, they found nothing.

Even the group of knights from the monastery could not find anything from the beginning, so how could they?

“Ha...”

Eventually, the exhausted Erica sat down on where she was standing and let out a frustrated sigh.

Heron also let out a sigh and said, “Let’s just go back. We can’t wander around the forest until it gets bright. People may already be worried about us.”

Erica just stared at the other side of the forest without any response.

Heron thought she was angry and did not say anything more.

However, that was not the case.

“Hey, Heron.”

Heron noticed that her voice was trembling.

Then he looked where she was looking and could vaguely see something beyond the darkness.

It was something like a tentacle.

Like a snake, the bundle of tentacles wiggled towards them, with a small sharp end at the end.

Erica and Heron turned pale. They both thought it was a nightmare.

“Uh, uh...”

Erica regained her composure and stood up.

She had brought a sword with her, but she had no intention of fighting such a monster.

Just as she was about to turn and run away, a tentacle stretched out like a beam of light and wrapped around Heron's leg.

“Aaah!”

Heron fell to the ground, screaming and struggling.

“Heron!”

Erica frantically swung her sword at the tentacle that was gripping Heron, but it was as hard as steel and wouldn't budge.

Another tentacle stretched out and wrapped around Erica's sword, wrenching it from her grasp and shattering it.

The tentacles seemed to have no interest in Erica, only in holding onto Heron and not letting him go.

“I'm done for, run away, Erica...!” Heron yelled in terror.

Ignoring him, Erica picked up the broken sword and struck the tentacle wildly, like a madman.

This time, there was some damage done as the tentacle's surface erupted with black blood.

The tentacle roared in anger and pushed Erica away with force. Erica, who had been hit by the tentacle directly, was thrown into the air and tumbled to the ground.

The tentacles continued to thrash about, wrapping themselves around Heron's arms and legs.

Erica, barely able to watch, turned pale at the sight.

The tentacles seemed to be tearing Heron apart.

“Just... stop! No!”

It was about to become a gruesome spectacle.

Flash!

Suddenly, a bright white flash illuminated the forest for a moment.

When her vision returned, the tentacles were thrashing around on the ground, completely defeated, and Heron was unharmed.

“That was a close call. Are you okay?”

Erica was staring blankly at the scene before turning her gaze in the direction of the approaching man with a sword.

It was Jerel.

Chapter 112: Encounter (12)

Chapter 112: Encounter (12)

Erica took a deep breath, her expression going from completely dead to alive again.

The two of them stared blankly at Jerel, who had suddenly appeared.

The pure white light, like a powerful energy, was emanating from the sword Jerel held, illuminating the darkness.

Erica realized that he had sliced the tentacles with his sword.

“Why are you here?” Jerel approached them and asked, looking at Heron and Erica alternately.

The two of them couldn’t answer and could only stutter.

It was because they had secretly entered the forest against the adults’ orders.

Jerel quickly understood the situation and tended to Heron’s wounds, which were swollen due to being tightly squeezed by the tentacles, though not broken.

He examined the wounds and then put his hand on them, emitting the same pure white light as his sword, healing the wounds instantly without a trace.

The healing speed, which was far faster than the recovery magic of the monastery’s priests amazed Heron and Erica.

“Thank you, Sir Jerel,” Heron said, getting up from his seat.

Jerel looked at them with a reproachful expression.

“You didn’t have permission to come here, did you? Did you do such a dangerous thing just to find your friend?”

Erica nodded while Heron avoided Jerel’s gaze.

Jerel let out a small sigh.

They knew very well that coming into the forest was not only dangerous, but also would not be helpful. Yet they couldn’t just stand by and wait, so they had entered the forest.

Humans were creatures whose emotions precede reason, and they were still children. Jerel could understand why the two had come into the forest with such emotions.

Of course, understanding was one thing, but the fact remained that they shouldn’t be here.

“As you can see, this is a suspicious forest. You two shouldn’t be wandering around like this.”

Jerel looked down at the tentacle corpse on the ground as he spoke.

Erica and Heron also looked down at it with stern faces.

The identity of this monster and why it existed in the monastery forest were questions that passed through their minds with doubt and fear.

The monster that Jerel had just killed was noticeably different from the typical monsters they had seen in books.

“W-What is the identity of this monster?”

“I don’t know either.”

Jerel shook his head.

He also had no idea why such a being existed in the forest.

He had fought countless monsters in the past. Of course, he had encountered much stronger monsters than this. However, it was not a matter of how strong they were, but how grotesque they were.

It was like something that would come out of a demonic realm...

Maybe a demon.

He thought to himself.

Jerel had felt a strange sense of alienation since he first entered this monastery.

The sense of unease grew stronger when Jerel faced the abbot, Dehod, and now that he was in the forest, it was even more pronounced.

At first, he thought it was just a misconception, but Jerel was now convinced that something lurking in this monastery's forest was undoubtedly related to Abbot Dehod.

Therefore, Jerel decided to explore the forest first.

Of course, first, he had to send the two children out.

"Is there any problem with your body moving?"

"Yes, yes... I think I'm completely fine."

"Take him outside. Wait quietly in the monastery building."

At Jerel's firm tone, Heron nodded quietly.

Since he had just been threatened by such a monster, he didn't even want to wander around the forest.

But Erica didn't follow his words obediently.

“Please let me search with you, sir.”

Erica was feeling the same fear as Heron.

Even though she had seen a monster like that for the first time in her life, she couldn't help but be scared.

But now, her worry for Tom was much stronger than her fear.

Now that they knew there was actually a monster in the forest, it was almost certain that Tom's disappearance was related to it.

“No, you can't.”

Her strong will impressed Jerel, but there were things that couldn't be done.

Since she didn't show any signs of listening to him obediently, Jerel spoke more firmly.

“If you don't listen, even if I have to knock you unconscious to take you out, I will.”

“....”

Erica had no choice but to back down when Jerel spoke in such a manner. She clenched her fists with a gloomy expression.

In any case, it was the moment when Jerel was about to lead the two of them out of the forest...

“...!”

Suddenly, Jerel turned his head to one side and fixed his gaze.

Erica and Heron also looked where he was looking.

There was nothing there, but soon a human shape slowly emerged from the darkness and revealed itself.

“...Abbot?”

Heron muttered blankly as he confirmed the person's face.

The identity of the person who suddenly appeared from the forest was none other than the monastery's abbot, Dehod.

Erica and Heron were suspicious of why the director had come here all of a sudden.

Jerel grimly picked up the sword he had retrieved and brought his hand closer to it.

“You were here, Sir Jerel. What happened to those two?”

The director stopped about ten steps away from the three of them and smiled brightly as he opened his mouth.

Jerel replied calmly, “They sneaked into the forest and I discovered them. We were just about to leave.” He looked down at the monster's corpse again and asked, “Director, do you know what kind of monster this is?”

At the question, Dehod shook his head. “How could I possibly know? I was truly surprised to hear that such a monster really existed in the forest.”

Even Erica and Heron could feel the clear sense of alienation at his words. His attitude was too casual and peaceful for the situation.

“When you see a monster like this dead, it's not strange to be surprised and unable to speak, right? Why did you come here alone without any knights in the first place? So, Abbot...”

“Yes, Sir Jerel.”

“What is your identity?”

Jerel's voice froze coldly.

Startled by his chilly tone, Heron and Erica looked at Dehod.

Dehod, who was standing with a poker face, smiled again.

But it was a creepy and grotesque smile, quite different from just a moment ago.

“It’s become quite a nuisance. We were almost done, and now one of our sacrifices is causing trouble.”

Dehod waved his hand.

Then the monster’s corpse turned into black smoke and dissipated into the air, absorbed by him.

Jerel drew his sword right away.

“As expected, you are a demon contractor.”

“Well, it might be a familiar sight to you, sir. You were someone who directly experienced the war with the demons in the past.”

Dehod, who had recovered the monster’s energy, shrugged and reached out his hand again toward Jerel.

“Anyway, since you’ve seen what you shouldn’t have seen, you have to die here.”

A black, ominous energy gathered in Dehod’s hand. It was darker than the darkness of the night that had fallen in the forest.

The mass, like a giant ball of thread, quickly extended toward Jerel in dozens of directions.

Erica and Heron, standing behind Jerel, shrank their bodies with their eyes tightly closed.

Watching the scene calmly with his calm gaze, Jerel drew his sword like lightning.

Flash!

In an instant, a brilliant and intense white energy covered the forest, much brighter and stronger than before.

Dehod's attack was engulfed by the white flash and vanished in an instant.

“...Aaaah!”

Dehod, with a giant black mark on his chest, knelt down while coughing out blood.

He had no trace of his previous relaxed demeanor, instead he looked pitiful and miserable as he struggled in pain.

After picking up his sword, Jerel walked towards him.

“Where are the missing children?”

Jerel asked in a cold and merciless tone, staring down at him.

Dehod, trembling, lifted his head and looked at him in confusion. He was extremely bewildered because he had no idea that one blow was enough to decide the battle.

The other was the strongest knight of the Order of Radiance, but he had no idea that the difference in power was so great.

“This damn fanatic...ugh!”

As Dehod tried to mutter nonsense, Jerel thrust his sword into his shoulder.

As if that wasn't enough, he ignited another pure white energy, just like the one before, and drove the sword deeper into Dehod's flesh.

Dehod's scream echoed throughout the forest.

Heron and Erica, who had been watching the situation in a daze, were shocked.

It was completely opposite to his usually gentle demeanor, and it was a brutal and gruesome sight.

Of course, it wasn't Jerel's true nature.

Jerel knew from his numerous experiences that showing mercy and leniency to demons and those who sold their souls to them for selfish gain was nothing more than a luxury.

"Where are the missing children?"

Jerel asked once again.

Dehod, who was writhing in pain, let out a half-mad, hysterical laughter.

"Kuk, kuk-kuk... You're really strong even when you're in a stupor."

"..."

"But nothing's going to change. Eventually, you'll die here..."

Jerel furrowed his brow and pulled out the sword that was stuck in Dehod's body.

It seemed difficult to get a proper answer from him right now.

Jerel turned his head and looked back at Erica and Heron.

He didn't forget his top priority. First, he had to get these two out of this dangerous place.

Saaa.

Energy of pure white gathered in Jerel's hand and instantly wrapped around Dehod's body, completely immobilizing him.

Jerel was about to motion the two to come closer when suddenly a massive force from one side caused him to quickly turn his head.

At the same time, a wave of bloody red struck the spot where Jerel was standing.

Erica screamed at the sight.

“Jerel!”

Fortunately, Jerel was unharmed, and a pure white barrier was spread around him.

The level of destruction was on a different level than what Dehod had just unleashed.

Jerel looked at the barrier that barely held up with a stiff expression, then turned his gaze to where the attack had come from.

There was a man standing there with a grotesque appearance and gray skin.

It was a demon.

Chapter 113: Encounter (13)

Chapter 113: Encounter (13)

When dawn broke the next day, I woke up early to leave. However, I was awoken by the commotion coming from the monastery.

Later, I found out that something unsettling had happened. Two of the children had gone into the forest behind the monastery and hadn't returned, causing a commotion in the monastery.

One of them was Tom, a friend of Erica and Heron, whom I also knew well.

Just when I was about to leave, this happens...

I stood by the window in the hallway, looking out over the forest beyond the backyard. It was a strange timing since I was scheduled to leave the next day.

Of course, the disappearance of the child didn't concern me since I was leaving as planned.

However, Erica, Heron, and Tom were the only children I had gotten close to during my stay at the monastery. It was natural to feel uneasy. I just couldn't like nothing had happened.

"Ethan."

Someone appeared on the opposite side of the hallway and approached me. It was Priest Tane.

Although it was midnight, the dark shadows on his face were clearly visible.

“Are you still awake when you’re leaving tomorrow?”

“Yes, because of what happened.” Tane sighed at my response and I asked him, “Did you find anything?”

“Unfortunately, no. I’m only praying that the children are safe.”

“I see. Are you still searching for them?”

“No, the abbot told us to stop the search for now, but the knights will resume the search once it’s daylight.”

“I see.”

According to Erica, there had been a time when priests and knights had gone missing in the forest.

It seemed like they had stopped the search for now, as they didn’t want to risk the knights’ safety by searching recklessly in the middle of the night.

Is there really something in the forest?

Was there really an unknown monster lurking about, as the rumors said?

But what didn’t make sense was that, if it really was the monster’s doing, could there be no trace of it whatsoever?

Tane said, “However, Sir Jerel is going into the forest himself to look for the children. If he can find anything at all...”

Jerel?

The radiant knight himself was going to search?

If that’s the case, then I could feel somewhat relieved.

His level was over 80. As someone with that much skill, he could find some clue that even the knights couldn’t.

But what if even the radiant knight goes missing in the forest?

What could be there that the other couldn't even handle with his own level of skill?

At that moment, one person flashed through my mind.

The abbot.

He was a skilled person over level 60, it was not weird to think that he was hiding something.

Of course, it was a huge leap to think that he had anything to do with this incident just because of that.

But for some reason, I had a feeling that I couldn't explain.

I asked Tane quietly, not ignoring my intuition.

“Where is the abbot now?”

Tane responded with a puzzled look on his face.

“Well, wouldn't he be in his office?”

It was as if he didn't know for sure.

I nodded my head without asking any further.

“Anyway, Mr. Ethan, don't worry too much and get some rest. It's already very late.”

As Tane left, I looked back at the forest outside the window.

For some reason, it felt like an ominous aura was emanating from somewhere in the forest.

I surveyed my surroundings and jumped down to the ground.

I had to go into the forest myself.

Jerel felt a chill run down his spine as he looked at the ashen-skinned man before him.

He knew very well what this endlessly fierce creature, emanating a threatening energy, was.

A demon.

The scourge of the continent that had taken the lives of countless colleagues in the past. The worst race.

“...You must be the demon who gave strength to the abbot.”

It wasn't difficult to guess the identity of the demon.

If a demon suddenly appeared in this situation, it must be related to the abbot.

Jerel focused all his attention on the demon and aimed his sword at it.

The destructive power of the earlier strike that flew was definitely not below its own level.

The demon looked around briefly and muttered to himself with a small sigh.

“Tsk, that bug-like thing... caused quite a stir despite after being told to be cautious.”

Dehod, who was held by Jerel, trembled.

With a face filled with fear, he cried out desperately in protest.

“Lord M-Mephrim! You misunderstand! This person is a radiant knight! I did my best to...”

“You’re being too loud.”

The demon interrupted him and waved his hand.

Hwaaak!

Then, a crimson smoke burst out of his body and was absorbed into the demon.

“K-aaah!”

Dehod screamed like a broken machine.

His body dried up and twisted like a mirage, as if his life force had evaporated in an instant.

Jerel watched the scene with a calm expression.

As someone who had seen people who made a contract with demons, he knew it was the process of regaining power. There was no way to stop it.

In an instant, the demon absorbed all of Dehod’s energy and turned his gaze back to Jerel.

Jerel stood in front with Erica and Heron behind him, and spoke up.

“Answer me, demon. What were you doing here?”

The other was not an archdemon.

They were monsters that were completely different from ordinary demons.

But it was clear that the opponent in front of them was a powerful demon who belonged to the upper echelon.

This demon had formed a contract with the abbot and was plotting something here.

Something suspicious and ominous was spreading over the Robelgeo Monastery. It was now a confirmed fact.

The demon glanced strangely at Jerel and muttered, “Looks like you weren’t sent here with all the information.”

“What do you mean?” Jerel asked.

“Well, if that was the case, the hero would have been dispatched instead of a lowly rat like you,” the demon replied, casually gesturing towards Jerel.

“After I take care of you, I just need to clean up this monastery and then I can retrieve what I came for,” the demon said.

At that moment, Jerel noticed the demon’s gaze shifted towards Erica.

But before he could think any further, the demon launched an attack. The same blood-red energy that had surrounded the demon’s hand moments ago shot out like a beam.

Jerel blocked the attack head-on with the golden sword.

He couldn’t dodge it because Erica and Heron were right behind him.

With a deafening explosion, the blood-red and golden energies mixed together and detonated.

Jerel expanded his shield to protect Erica and Heron from the blast and urgently shouted, “Run! Get out of the forest!”

Erica quickly regained her composure and pulled Heron’s arm, following Jerel’s order.

Even though she hated being in a helpless situation more than anything else, she couldn’t ignore the fact that their presence was only getting in the way of the fight.

A blood-red energy swirled around the demon and transformed into a massive sword that smashed into the ground, trying to crush the two fleeing

figures.

Jerel urgently shot out his sword and destroyed the sword blade. Another shockwave occurred in the air.

As if annoyed by it, the demon raised its energy once again.

The energy that gathered around him like a sphere shot out sharp thorns explosively in all directions.

Kakakakaka!

Jerel, who prioritized their safety, had no choice but to focus on blocking the thorns from hitting them.

Numerous golden traces were engraved along his sword in the dense darkness of the forest.

Jerel's eyes widened suddenly after deflecting the thorns for a while.

Suddenly, crimson tentacles sprang from the ground right beneath him and coiled around his ankles.

At the same time, a tremendous power that was dimensionally different from before flowed from the demon.

Urgently looking ahead, a huge crimson sphere was gathering.

The sphere, which gave the illusion of distorting the surrounding space, slowly but rapidly approached him, seeming to swallow him whole and make him disappear.

Jerel had no choice but to use his last resort.

Flash!

The rosary hanging around his neck emitted a dazzling light.

Even the demon was momentarily distorted by the bright light.

The light not only released the energy that bound Jerel's legs but also completely destroyed the huge sphere that the demon had shot out.

Jerel, now free, rushed toward the demon at an incredible speed.

At the moment when his sword blade was about to cut through the demon's neck...

Puk!

Jerel's body staggered.

He looked down at the sudden sharp pain that pierced his chest.

An unknown sharp red energy had penetrated his chest without him even realizing it.

Why...

Why was he attacked?

Jerel looked at the demon with an unbelievable expression as he coughed out blood.

The demon still looked at him with indifferent eyes, as if the result had been predetermined from the beginning.

Jerel finally realized that the other had never exerted his full strength from the beginning.

“Kugh...”

The red energy quickly penetrated his body, evaporating all remaining strength.

Jerel, who had lost even the strength to stand, kneeled on the spot.

Erica and Heron, who were running away, stopped and shouted.

“...Jerel!”

Jerel barely gestured for them to keep running, but the two just hesitated.

The demon spoke in a mocking tone.

“It’s pointless. You, and the bugs crawling in this monastery, will all disappear by morning.”

Jerel barely clung to his fading consciousness.

He couldn’t use the power of the relic magic that he had unleashed a little while ago.

He was now at the mercy of the demon and his life would soon be cut short, followed by the people in the monastery.

“What’s your purpose? Is it related to that girl?”

Jerel asked with a squeezed voice.

The demon’s gaze towards Erica before the battle had started was not a good sign.

The demons reached out their hands towards him without answering anymore. It was to put an end to it.

“Oh god...”

Jerel closed his eyes and even Erica and Heron, who were watching him, were filled with despair.

A crimson energy surged like a wave from the demon’s hand, covering Jerel.

Kwaaang!

If he was hit squarely by this blow, Jerel’s body would have disappeared without a trace.

However, he was still unscathed when the energy had passed.

Feeling puzzled, Jerel opened his eyes.

What he saw was someone's back standing right in front of him.

“Hmm?”

The demon whose attack was blocked looked at the sudden appearance of the man with a frown.

Erica and Heron also looked at the sight in a daze, unable to understand what had happened.

The outsider who had collapsed in the forest and taken refuge in the monastery.

The man was none other than Ethan.

Chapter 114: Encounter (14)

Chapter 114: Encounter (14)

From the forest, I could feel a collision of immense magical power from afar.

A clash of magical power that could only occur when two experts of at least level 80 clashed with all their might.

What's going on?

It was easy to guess that one of them was Jerel, the shining knight who was currently in the forest.

The problem was, who was the other person?

Until just a little while ago, I had a suspicion that the abbot might be involved in this incident.

But it didn't make sense that the person fighting right now against Jerel to be the abbot.

Because his level was at most in the 60s.

If he had fought against Jerel, who was over level 80, he would have been defeated or subdued in the blink of an eye.

And there was no one else in the monastery who had a level comparable to Jerel.

So who exactly was the person fighting now, if not the abbot? Then a third party?

“...!”

As I got closer to the scene, the first thing that caught my eye was the aura spreading through the forest like a mist.

An unpleasant, eerie aura full of foreboding.

I had felt this aura before. It was from Ditrodemian.

I had only experienced it once, but I could never forget the distinctive aura of the demons.

...Demon!

The golden aura was fiercely mingled with the crimson aura, but at some point it completely faded away, as if it had lost all its strength. Was it because Jerel was defeated?

I was a little late, but I managed to arrive just in time to prevent something irreparable from happening.

What began to come into view in the distance was Jerel, who had collapsed, and a man with ash-colored skin standing on the opposite side. He was a demon. And Erica and Heron were also watching the scene with pale, horrified faces from a little distance away.

Why are those two here?

No, that wasn't important right now.

The demon was gathering an enormous amount of power, as if it were about to completely destroy Jerel.

I immediately teleported to Jerel's front and put out a barrier. At the same time, a wave of bloody energy swept over the spot where I was standing.

Kugugugu.

The demon who had withdrawn his hand looked at me with suspicion. I briefly met his eyes before turning my head.

Jerel was looking up at me with a look of astonishment and bewilderment. “You are...?”

Although we had only met briefly before, his reaction indicated that he remembered my face.

“Ethan?”

Erica and Heron were also staring at me with a dazed expression. I simply gestured for them to step back and turned my gaze back to the front.

【Level 85】

The level floating above his head was 85. It wasn't very high, but it was still a considerable level of strength. He was an opponent who was too strong for Jerel, who was at level 81.

“Annoyingly, new bugs keep popping up.”

The demon muttered in an irritated voice.

He spoke as if nothing was wrong, but he was clearly observing me with a guarded look.

It's only natural to be cautious if someone suddenly appeared and easily blocked their own attack.

He's a demon who had crossed over into the territory of Santea and was scheming something.

Demons were generally arrogant and vicious, but few among them were willing to make deals.

By the way...

I noticed a dry, scattered corpse on the ground.

I narrowed my eyes at it.

The body of the abbot. I couldn't recognize his face, but his clothing matched what I remembered, so it was probably him.

"Was the abbot a villain?"

I asked Jerel.

He stared blankly and answered in a hoarse voice.

"...Yes."

"That demon must have made a contract with the abbot."

Typically, when demons engage in activities outside of their territory, it's simple. They would call upon their contractors and took payment in the form of souls or life force, or weaker demons simply prey on human flesh and blood.

That's why attacks on villages or small towns by hidden demons who attack and eat people were not uncommon, but this guy was probably not one of those demons.

He was a demon with a level in his 80s, making him one of the top demons. It was puzzling what he was up to in a remote monastery.

Okay, if it's about demons at this level...

No way?

A thought crossed my mind.

A concept that had appeared steadily in the dialogue during playthrough, even though it was not directly related to the episode in the game.

The demon's seed that demons sought to hasten the resurrection of the Demon King.

Could it really be that?

I glanced at Erica, who was standing on one side.

For some reason, I felt that the demon's gaze had been strangely conscious of her since earlier.

"The demon's seed."

As I spoke the words, the expression of the demon stiffened crisply.

I could be sure that my guess was correct based on his reaction.

This demon was here at the monastery because of the demon's seed.

And that seed of demons was probably Erica.

"The demon's... seed?"

Jerel murmured as he listened to what I had just said.

As it was still early for the demons to be rampant, and it was a top-secret matter even among themselves, there was no one who knew this concept except for the hero.

However, she couldn't talk about some things like the seed of demons because of various restrictions.

"That girl was a 'demon's seed'."

As I spoke with certainty, the demon who had been silent opened his mouth again.

"How...did you find out?"

The confusion was clearly written on the face of the demon, who had maintained a relaxed demeanor until a moment ago.

From his perspective, he must have wondered how I knew about the demon's seed.

"Answer me, human. How do you know about it?"

I just shrugged my shoulders.

There was no reason to answer his question. I confirmed everything I needed to.

I said to Jerel, "Can you stand up?"

"Yes, yes..."

"Then step back. You'll get in the way of the fight."

Jerel got up, wobbling, and stepped back.

The demon didn't wait patiently for him. After gathering a massive amount of crimson energy in his hand, he shot it out like a beam. I put up my floating veil again and easily blocked it.

"If you won't answer, I'll tear your flesh apart piece by piece and scatter it!"

The demon's ominous energy stirred around him. The rays from the crimson orbs that appeared in the air moments ago were fired chaotically. But there was no need to avoid them. I just stood still and blocked all the attacks.

The crimson energy exploded and dispersed, and a dense fog of blood enveloped the surroundings. Since most of his energy was crimson, it reminded me of the scenery from my fight with the Tyrant, but naturally, it was nowhere near as strong as that.

"...!"

Once the attack was blocked, the demon began to show signs of increasing anxiety.

In the end, was there any way that someone like him could break through the impenetrable barrier that even an archdemon could not penetrate?

I spoke dryly to the guy who had paused his attack for a moment.

“Your attack won’t reach me.”

“...”

“You’re the one who should answer when I show mercy to your life. Was an archdemon involved in this incident?”

The guy in front of me wasn’t the problem right now.

What I was worried about was the intervention of another demon, in other words, another archdemon.

The seeds of the demon king were the most important issue for them, related to his resurrection.

It was hard to believe that an archdemon didn’t directly get involved in such an incident.

“How dare you?! A human like you!”

However, he did not answer my question and just raised his magic with a look of contempt and anger.

It was not a good sign that he seemed to be trying to launch a full-fledged fatal blow this time.

The crimson energy whirled above the demon’s head.

Of course, there was no reason to wait for it quietly.

He didn’t have any defense shields around his body.

I hesitated for a moment about whether to cut off his life here.

If I cut off his life here, I wouldn't be able to extract any more information.

However, I couldn't just keep taking his attacks, and if this continued, I felt like I would eventually have to retreat.

“...?!”

Before he could even finish preparing his attack, I teleported right in front of him.

His eyes widened in surprise for a moment, and that was the end of it.

The body of the man who was struck by instant kill collapsed on the ground. His magical power, which had been stirring in the air, scattered in an instant.

“...”

I looked down at the demon's corpse for a moment, then turned my head. Jerel and two other people were staring blankly in this direction.

As I approached them, Jerel swallowed his saliva and asked, “What about that demon...?”

“He's dead.”

“...May I ask who you are?”

“I'll explain later. Let's get out of the forest first.”

Jerel's injuries were serious, and it wasn't the time to have a leisurely conversation. I looked back at Erica and Heron.

“Are you guys okay?”

“...Yes, yes.”

Heron stumbled and couldn't speak properly. The two of them looked very confused in this situation, as they had only seen my trembling figure in the

monastery before, so it was understandable.

“But, um...”

Heron tried to say something, but stuttered and couldn't speak properly. Erica stepped forward and said, “We still haven't found Tom.”

At her words, I remembered the fact that I had momentarily forgotten.

Right, come to think of it, we were originally trying to find the missing children. But honestly, it was difficult to believe they were still alive.

I nodded my head and said, “I'll search the forest again. Let's go back to the monastery, since Sir Jerel's injuries are severe.”

Seeing Jerel's terrible condition, Erica obediently followed my words.

“But why did you come into the forest?”

“We sneaked in and Jerel rescued us.”

I could roughly guess the situation. They couldn't just sit and wait since their friend was missing, so they came into the forest themselves. Since I wasn't their guardian, I didn't scold them about it.

Anyway, it was the moment when I was taking the three of them out of the forest...

I stopped walking abruptly and slowly turned my head to one side.

Suddenly, a dark energy rippled through the air, and something popped out like the space was splitting apart.

“What the hell is this?”

A woman with a large horn on her head and ash-colored skin appeared. The woman looked around swiftly and grumbled as if complaining before looking in my direction. When she made eye contact with me, she raised the corners of her mouth and smiled.

“Hello? What kind of human are you?”

I couldn't help but remain silent. I had immediately recognized her true identity from her appearance.

A demon, Akasha, the 13th rank among the archdemons.

The anxiety that was in my mind became a reality as an archdemon had really appeared.

Chapter 115: Encounter (15)

Chapter 115: Encounter (15)

I looked up at the level floating above Akasha's head and let out a small sigh.

【Lv. 94】

She was a true powerhouse, comparable to a Lord of Calderic.

I couldn't believe an archdemon really appeared.

Then, I noticed belatedly the faint, overwhelming magical power hovering in the sky and lifted my head.

It was an eye.

A tiny, magical eye hidden in the night sky, staring down at us.

...The Eye of the Demon.

A chill ran down my spine in an instant.

I knew of this ability as well.

The 10th in the archdemon hierarchy, Mephiros.

When did he start watching us? I didn't notice because the magical power was too faint.

Only then did I realize that Akasha's appearance, as well as the rift in space, was caused by Mephiros' spatial transfer ability.

Because not only Akasha but he was also nearby, I had no choice but to become more tense.

“Hey, are you ignoring me?”

I turned my gaze back to Akasha in front of me.

Despite her clearly displeased expression, her voice was filled with a playful tone.

The situation was at its worst.

Two archdemons, and high-ranking ones at that, had appeared at the same time.

“Akasha...”

I heard Jerel’s voice, as if he had lost his mind.

He seemed to have figured out who Akasha was.

Jerel was one of the radiant knights who had experienced the war with demons firsthand, and Akasha was also a notorious demon among the United Forces of Humanity at the time.

A surprise attack was impossible at the moment.

However, Mephiros was still not revealing himself and Akasha...

Her level disappeared.

The level display above Akasha’s head disappeared in an instant.

I could immediately understand the meaning of this phenomenon because I knew her ability as well. That was a mirage, not her real body.

It was useless to try to distinguish it with magic power because it was not very noticeable in the first place.

She must have been impressed by the ability I had just demonstrated, having watched the battle with the demon just moments ago.

Of course, I couldn't blame myself for using instant kill to deal with the demon.

She looked down at the demon's corpse and said,

"I'm curious how you know about the demon's seed more than anything else. It's probably a fact that only the hero knows, so what's your identity?"

She seemed to have not figured out my identity.

Instead of participating in the conversation, I glanced briefly in the direction of the three people not far from me.

Their existence was a burden in this situation.

However, I couldn't give a signal for them to run away.

It was almost certain that their purpose was Erica, who possessed the demon's seed, and if so, there was no way they would let us go willingly.

"Archdemons Akasha and Mephiros."

Akasha's eyebrows twitched slightly at my words. It seemed she hadn't expected me to also know about Mephiros.

"Your goal is that girl," I said with an unpleasant smile.

"I'm not sure about that. If you have a question, you should answer mine first. I'll answer if you tell me your true identity."

I didn't reply since I didn't expect an answer from them, anyway.

It was clear that Erica was carrying the demon's seed. The fact that they had come this far meant that they were going to take Erica back to their territory with them.

The demon's seed was a piece of the demon king's soul. Those who possessed it were scattered throughout the continent, and the demons used them as sacrifices to hasten the resurrection of the demon king.

This was a setting that hadn't been fully explored in the main story, so I didn't know all the details. However, I did know a few things. Only humans possessed the demon's seed, and demons couldn't handle it recklessly until they performed a ritual on the person who possessed it. That was roughly it.

The theme of the demon's seed first appeared in the middle of the main story. When the player and their party were adventuring with the heir of the Holy Sword, they happened to rescue a boy who was wandering in the back alleys of the city.

As they became friends with the boy and helped him live a normal life like others, they discovered that he was a carrier of the demon's seed.

Suddenly approached by an archdemon, they were in danger of being wiped out, but they managed to survive with the help of an ally.

I thought that situation was not much different from the present.

I heard Erica had spent several years in this monastery.

I didn't know at what point they became aware of Erica's existence, but it wasn't important now.

...There's no answer, really.

The enemy in front of me right now was an archdemon.

It was not just Akasha. I had to consider the existence of Mephiros, who had not yet revealed himself.

It was a precarious situation where I might have to face both archdemons at the same time.

I had already defeated Ditrodemian, an archdemon with a higher in rank than these guys.

But the fight with him in the first place was almost like risking my life and barely winning.

And just because I had experience that, it didn't make it easy to deal with other archdemons.

The ability I had was not simply the ability to have an absolute advantage, depending on the opponent's level.

Depending on the compatibility, for example, I was someone who could find it hard fighting a lower-level wizard with a single defense shield.

So what was important was not the level, but how lethal their abilities were against my instant kill.

And as I knew their abilities well, I could tell that it wouldn't be any easier to fight them than Distrodeman.

Moreover, now that there were two opponents, there were also two variables.

But I had no choice but to fight.

Otherwise, there was no way to make up for this situation.

“...”

I prepared for the battle.

Akasha tilted her head and twitched as if she had noticed something.

“I wanted to have a conversation before killing you. If it's going to end like this, I have no choice...”

Before she could finish speaking, I immediately used space leap.

Just like in the battle with the demon earlier, I tried to move in front of Akasha and use the instant kill.

But at the same time, the other disappeared like smoke.

The magical power that had been concentrated at the center exploded.

I blocked the explosion with floating veil and turned my head to the side.

Suddenly, Akasha was standing a little away from me, arms crossed and laughing.

“I’ve been watching since earlier. Don’t tell me that’s all you got with your ability?”

...This is why Akasha was such a frustrating opponent.

The Queen of Illusions, Akasha.

Her ability was to create illusions that were almost indistinguishable from reality.

She was a notorious demon who deceived and seduced her opponents in countless illusions before gradually withering them away and killing them.

Due to this ability alone, she was famous for being difficult to defeat among the bosses in RaSa.

If I couldn’t find the main body and strike, there was no way to deal damage.

Flash!

Suddenly, a crimson light shot out of Akasha’s eyes.

As I met her gaze, I immediately realized what kind of ability she had used.

In addition to the ability to create illusions, Akasha had the power to trap the opponent’s mind in an illusion itself.

But thanks to the effect of the [Soul of the King], it didn’t work on me.

I once again used space leap towards her. As it was an illusion again, it exploded.

“Hmm? Why didn’t that work? Is your mental fortitude strong enough to resist my abilities?”

Akasha, appearing in the empty space above, tilted her head in confusion.

“Well, whatever. It doesn’t matter. If you keep focusing only on my illusions, you’ll end up dying a miserable death. Try harder, Kukuk.”

Ignoring her words, I continued to attack silently. I kept approaching with space leaps even though I knew it was just an illusion, as there was no other way.

Kwaaang!

Each time the illusion disappeared, there was an explosion, and I surveyed my surroundings with super sensory. If Akasha was hiding, her level would have shown in the empty space, but there was nothing like that.

In other words, she was in a faraway place, completely separated from the battlefield.

At this point, she would have realized that her illusions alone could not harm me. To deliver a stronger blow, she had no choice but to reveal herself and attack.

Since her objective was to take Erica away, she couldn’t keep stalling indefinitely. She would try to surprise me at the decisive moment.

That moment will be the moment of her death.

I frantically chased after the illusions, looking desperate enough to look ignorant, searching my surroundings for any level indicators. That was where her true body was.

After disposing of dozens of illusions, I finally caught sight of a level indicator appearing suddenly on the opposite side. Immediately, I teleported

in that direction and used blood magic to scatter blood in the air.

“...!”

Then Akasha appeared with a surprised expression, looking at me with shock in the empty air.

However, all the blood I had scattered was blocked by the shield the guy had unfolded.

Damn, I aimed for the gap, but she blocked it.

Akasha and I landed on the ground and faced each other, and the fight was momentarily suspended.

“How the hell did you figure it out?”

Akasha seemed shocked that her ability was completely exposed.

But now I was also confused, so I could only feel a sense of defeat.

Finding the other’s real body was almost the only opportunity. I should have finished it just now.

Since she had unfolded the shield like that, there was no longer a suitable opportunity to use instant kill.

Akasha, who had been staring at this side for a while with a distorted impression, suddenly sighed and muttered.

“I understand, I get it. It seems like it’ll take a while if I do it alone, Mephiros.”

Mephiros.

As soon as those words came out of her mouth, I felt a secret flow of magic behind me.

At the same time, sharp magic thorns suddenly sprang out of the empty air and attacked my entire body.

I barely put up a barrier and blocked the surprise attack.

Swoosh.

As before, when Akasha first appeared, the air nearby split open.

The creature that sprang out from it was a demon with ashy skin.

He was holding a staff made of decayed wood in one hand, wearing a black robe.

Mephiros, the 10th-ranked archdemon among the demon hierarchy.

His ability was the reason for the magical eye hovering in the sky. It was an ability to cross space and appear wherever he wanted.

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Mephiros, who appeared as expected, looked at me with empty eyes.

Unlike the relatively ordinary Akasha, his eyes were like those of an insect, with no whites at all.

“I see now.”

As he stared at me, he suddenly nodded as if he had realized something and said something unexpected.

“You are Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

...Did he figure it out?

He seemed convinced that I was the Seventh Lord of Calderic.

Actually, it wasn't strange for my true identity to be revealed. My appearance and abilities were already somewhat known to the world.

Even the arrogant demons who believed themselves to be superior would not have failed to investigate the new Lord of Calderic.

“What? The Seventh Lord of Calderic? That human?”

Akasha turned her head with a slightly surprised expression.

Well, it didn't matter that much now that my identity was revealed here.

I glanced in the direction where Jerel and the others were.

“Seventh Lords...?”

Including him, Erica and Heron looked stunned.

Nevertheless, they seemed to have heard it clearly enough to react.

Mephiros, who had been staring at me carefully, spoke up as if observing my reaction.

“Yes, it matches in terms of race, appearance, abilities, information, everything.”

“Hmm... but isn’t it strange? What is the Seventh Lord of Calderic doing here? And now it seems like he’s siding with these bugs?”

Akasha said with an expression that she didn’t understand.

Mephiros didn’t respond as if he didn’t know, but he seemed to be convinced of my identity.

“Well, I guess you’re not wrong. That’s probably why I find human beings quite annoying.”

Akasha laughed and looked at me.

I was more wary of Mephiros than that woman.

Just like Akasha, Mephiros also had an annoying ability.

Mephiros opened his mouth again, “I don’t know how the Overlord noticed this matter, but she was careless. If she wanted to retrieve the demon’s seed, she should have moved herself.”

...He seemed to think that I had come here because of the Overlord’s instructions.

I didn’t reply because there was no need to correct him.

Anyway, even though he knew my identity, he didn't seem to intend to retreat easily.

Akasha and Mephiros were also strong enough to rival a Lord.

If it was a simple encounter, they could have avoided unnecessary fighting, but this was a situation where the demon's seed was at stake.

What should I do now?

I shook my head.

Two archdemons.

If the battle continued, I would obviously be at a disadvantage.

I had put the option of escape off in my head since earlier.

The most important thing to them was the demon's seed, so if I fled, they might not bother to chase me.

No... They probably won't chase me.

They knew who I was.

They must have realized from our brief skirmish just now that it wasn't going to be easy to overpower me.

I doubted one of them would track me, because neither would definitely not leave this spot with Erica here.

Besides, they probably didn't care that I knew of the existence of the demon's seed, as they likely assumed I had come here on the orders of the Overlord.

So it was possible to just abandon the three of them and flee.

It was the rational choice.

Of course, the demon's seed was an important element related to the resurrection of the Demon King.

But it merely accelerated the timing of his return; even if one of the demon's seed fell into their hands, it wouldn't necessarily result in the immediate resurrection of the Demon King.

It wasn't worth risking my life to prevent that from happening right now.

“...”

I turned my head to where the three of them were.

I was not noble enough to risk my life for others.

But I couldn't easily choose the option to flee.

If I abandoned them, Jerel and Heron would undoubtedly die, and Erica would be taken by the archdemons and offered as a sacrifice.

Maybe if these people were complete strangers to me and weren't in front of my eyes right now, I wouldn't have thought too much about it and chose the option that wouldn't have me killed.

But it wasn't an easy thing to calmly abandon them in this situation.

I let out a deep sigh inside.

If it really seems impossible, then at that time...

For now, let's just fight.

If I thought that the situation was really dangerous, then I would do it then.

One concern was that they might try to take the three as hostage, but it didn't seem like something to worry about for now.

They probably wouldn't think that I was willing to protect the three, being a Lord of Calderic.

And maybe from their perspective, they're worried that I could take Erica, who was the demon's seed, as a hostage.

Preparing for battle, I said nonchalantly to Mephiros.

"Don't worry. The Overlord will soon arrive, as you say."

I tried bluffing once.

Of course, there was no chance that the Overlord would come here even if I died, but I could still make them believe this lie.

Mephiros' eyes twisted.

He seemed to be trying to gauge whether my words were true or false, but soon, he smiled wryly.

"Then we should hurry up and deal with you and retrieve the demon's seed."

...There's no way they would back off.

Still, they couldn't completely ignore my words. If the Overlord really came, there was no way they could handle her.

If that could distract them even a little, it would be to my advantage...

Pwoong!

It was then that I felt a sudden jolt in my abdomen.

I lowered my head in surprise.

Without even being able to react, a red beam pierced through my abdomen.

"...?!"

Feeling the ominous magic spreading inside my body, I fell to my knees. The origin of the beam that had shot out was from Mephiros's spatial

transfer ability.

I didn't let my guard down, even with the two archdemons in front of me. I had heightened my senses to the maximum since earlier in preparation for a surprise attack.

Despite this, I was still too late to react to the blow just now.

What the hell...

This wasn't Mephiros' ability.

The space that had split apart grew larger, and another demon emerged from it.

"Have you arrived?"

Mephiros, who looked at me and sneered, politely greeted the new demon.

Akasha also showed no sign of being surprised and showed respect without any hesitation.

The demons were a race that operated solely on the principle of power. They would never bow or submit to anyone they didn't consider stronger than themselves.

Especially the archdemons at the pinnacle of the demon race. Their pride was beyond words.

【Level 97】

The new demon, with a level high enough to understand their attitude, was level 97, higher than anyone I had ever met except for the Overlord and the ancient mage from the underground ruins.

It was a demon with armor that looked as if it were burning like fiery flames. In one hand, he held a massive greatsword that was several meters long.

I couldn't believe it and stared blankly at the demon.

Level 97 and that distinctive appearance made me realize his identity immediately.

...*Kargos*.

The archdemon ranked 3rd in the demon hierarchy.

So, you're telling me that he was there too, not just Akasha and Mephiros?

Only then did I realize that I had made a serious mistake.

To the demons, the demon's seed was an essential ingredient for advancing their king's resurrection. It was more important than anything else.

It was not something that only two archdemons of appropriate rank could handle.

"The demon's seed is the girl."

Kargos' voice echoed through the forest.

It felt as if the space was trembling with just that one word.

I endured the pain and stared at him.

He seemed to have no interest in me and kept his gaze fixed on the three.

Heron was trembling so much from the pressure emitted by the three archdemons that he seemed to have lost his mind.

Jerel looked completely hopeless and despairing, and Erica was no different.

"We'll retrieve the demon's seed and go back."

Kargos said that and stretched out his hand towards me, as if trying to finish me off.

I bit down on my lips tightly.

If things continued like this, I would really die. Even if I used the floating veil or space leap, all I could do was buy time.

“Wait... just a minute.”

At that moment, Erica spoke with a trembling voice.

Kargos stopped his actions for a moment and turned his gaze to her.

“You, you’re after me, aren’t you? Right?”

Erica seemed to realize that she herself was the target of the demons.

It was a remarkable mental strength to be able to say such words in this situation.

“Very well aware, aren’t you? You will be sacrificed for the resurrection of the Demon King. Remember it as glory. Your insignificant life is being used for a noble and honorable cause.”

Akasha answered with a chuckle.

Erica swallowed her saliva and said, “I’ll do as you say quietly. So please spare the others.”

But it was a useless effort. There was no way they would grant her request.

Kargos continued what he was about to do with a sneer. Crimson flames rose in his hands.

“Stop it! Or else...”

Erica screamed desperately and picked up Jerel’s sword that had fallen to the ground and brought it to her neck.

Her action was immediately stopped. As Akasha reached out her hand, Erica lost consciousness and collapsed.

“Oh, really. I can’t even tear apart that arrogant brat.”

Mephiros clapped his hands, and Erica’s body floated in mid-air.

Jerel and Heron were too surprised to catch her.

Her floating body moved next to Mephiros.

Damn it.

It was over. I suffered a fatal blow before I could even attempt anything in a battle where I had no chance of winning, even in my best condition. I couldn’t even escape now.

Should I have run away earlier? Or maybe I shouldn’t have been so arrogant in the first place.

It was meaningless to regret it now.

Still, I wouldn’t die obediently.

I stared at the three archdemons and prepared for a final struggle.

It was at that moment...

Jeobuk.

The sound of footsteps echoed.

I turned my head in the direction of the sound.

A person was walking towards this place, piercing through the darkness of the forest.

What was surprising was that I didn’t notice any signs before hearing the sound or seeing their appearance.

The same was true for the archdemons, including Kargos, who turned their gaze with a surprised expression like me.

The one who revealed herself was a woman.

【Lv. 99】

I stared blankly at the level floating above her head.

Kargos muttered with disbelief and suspicion.

“...Hero.”

Chapter 117: Encounter (17)

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A woman with blonde hair and golden eyes.

The woman looked ordinary, dressed like a traveller passing by chance. It was an indescribably strange sight.

I gazed at the woman, feeling an inexplicable sacredness emanating from her.

【Level 99】

Even without Kargos' murmur, I immediately realized her identity when I saw the level floating above her head.

Of course, it was inevitable.

There was only one existence at a level like that, excluding the Demon King.

The hero who defeated the Demon King and the officially strongest person in the RaSa universe – Eindel.

“This is unbelievable...”

The owner of the trembling and precarious voice I heard was Akasha.

Her complexion, which had been relaxed just moments before, turned pale to the point that her grayish skin couldn't even cover it.

Mephiros also fixed his gaze on the hero's figure with a shocked expression.

...Not just them, I was also the same.

This was a development that I couldn't have expected at all.

How did the hero appear here?

The hero's golden eyes swept through me, the three archdemons, and the rest of us in turn.

For a moment, there was a suffocating tension in the forest.

I withdrew the strength I was trying to use to get up and collapsed to the ground.

It was embarrassing, but at the same time, there was a sense of relief that I wouldn't die.

Although I didn't know how the hero found her way here, it was clear what she was going to do from now on.

"Mephiros, Akasha, Kargos."

The hero who finally broke the silence listed the names of the archdemons one by one.

Akasha trembled in terror as her name was called.

"You've managed to keep those tough lives going."

Kargos glared at the hero with anger and mixed emotions.

"You disgusting human!"

The war where the hero sealed the demon king.

Many demons died at the hands of the hero, and the same was true for the demons, including the ones in front of her, who barely survived the war or just emerged after the war.

That's why they must have known very well.

The situation had completely reversed, and there was no way for them to survive and escape from here.

"How did you get here? Just a while ago, you were in Sondong."

The hero didn't answer Mephiros' question.

He looked at Erica next to him with an anxious expression before exchanging glances with Kargos.

Rumble!

The empty space around Mephiros split like waves.

It was Mephiros' ability to teleport through space, which he had shown several times.

At that moment, a golden line split the space that had opened vertically like a fortress. The open space disappeared without a trace.

The hero's hand, which had nothing a moment ago, was now holding a brilliant golden sword that emitted a dazzling light.

"Excalibur!" I exclaimed with a sigh.

It was the holy sword that sealed the Demon King, Balrotia.

The divine power emanating from the sword overwhelmed and buried all the ominous energy that the demons had been emitting.

Flash!

Then, as the hero reached out her hand, a hemispherical barrier expanded rapidly around her.

Moreover, a golden aura enveloped Erica, who was in Mephiros' arms.

Although Mephiros hastily tried to block it, it was useless. Erica, surrounded by the barrier, was pulled to the hero's side like a magnet in the blink of an eye. Even her location was secured.

Is this the power of Excalibur?

The energy that the hero exerted was not a simple magical power or even a mystical power. It was a transcendent power of a much higher level than those. It was the power of Excalibur bestowed upon the hero by the god of light.

The hero gently laid Erica, who had lost consciousness, on the ground and examined her condition.

Even though the demons had been openly robbed of the demon's seed, they dared not attack the hero.

"Indeed, it must have been the demon's seed," muttered the hero as she reached out her hand towards Erica.

Then, the golden energy flowing from the hero's hand was absorbed into Erica, and her eyes opened immediately.

"Um...!"

Erica, who had regained her consciousness, blinked and suddenly stood up.

She discovered the hero standing right next to her and looked at her with a bewildered expression.

The hero stroked her hair and said, "Don't worry, child. Just step back over there for a moment."

The hero turned to where Jerel and Heron were.

Jerel, who had been staring at the hero in a daze, flinched when he received her gaze.

“Hey, hero...”

Erica stepped back as the hero instructed, and the hero turned her gaze to me.

I felt an indescribable feeling as I looked at the hero for a moment.

Then, when the hero waved her hand, a golden veil appeared around Erica and me and the other two. Was it a shield?

She looked back at the three archdemons, saying, “Your game stops here.”

At the hero’s verdict, Kargos growled and exploded with energy.

He gave up trying to flee and seemed to have no choice but to fight.

Szzz!

Kargos’s body began to sprout tendrils like lava veins, akin to blood vessels.

Fierce flames spewed from his body and the great sword he was holding, like it was being processed.

It was as if I was looking at a volcano just before it was about to erupt.

I knew that this was Kargos, the boss monster’s full-power state, because I had tried to attack it in the game before.

“Will this Kargos try to run away? Hero, I also know that your physical condition is not as good as your prime!”

Even the surrounding bushes began to catch fire from the heat he emitted.

The next moment, Kargos charged towards the hero at an unbelievable speed and swung his sword.

Crash!

As the swords of Kargos and the warrior collided, the shockwave spread in all directions, causing the bushes to fly away.

However, the hero effortlessly blocked the blow in place.

“Kraaaa!”

Kargos roared again and swung his sword.

The flames, like lava, surrounding the sword blade, erupted and engulfed the forest in a dazzling light.

It was an unstoppable attack that was difficult to follow with the eyes.

The intense flashes of red and golden energy intertwined and blinded, exploding continuously.

It looked as if the entire forest was engulfed in flames, and the collision of the two massive forces colored the sky, making it seem like the end of the world.

Kargos’ ability was fire.

A flame that could instantly incinerate anything, leaving no trace and was like a raging inferno.

His ability was invincible, as no defensive equipment in the game could withstand it.

The floating veil barely blocked Distrodemian’s spatial cut. It was uncertain whether it could block his flame.

However, his ability seemed to have no effect on the hero.

The hero swung his sword with the same expressionless face as before.

Even amidst Kargos' fierce attacks, the hero's holy power was not disturbed in the slightest.

As the battle continued, Kargos' momentum gradually diminished.

Like burning the last flame in a massive tidal wave, Kargos' attacks looked like a desperate struggle.

Paat!

Thorns burst out, splitting the surrounding space, and covered the warrior who was pressing against Kargos. It was Mephiros' ability.

However, as soon as it touched the golden barrier surrounding the warrior's body, it vanished without a trace.

Akasha wasn't just standing still, either. If Kargos fell, they would be next.

Instead, she slowly approached the three, including Erica, as if targeting the children instead of the hero.

But before I could step forward, a sword beam shot out of the hero like a flash of light.

Ignoring Akasha's illusions, the sword beam accurately pierced through the body that was sneaking up on the children.

“Kiaaah!”

The hero's attack cut akasha's body in half.

With a terrible scream, the golden flame engulfed Akasha, and she disappeared.

It was a useless action to rush to her death, even if it was her fate in the end.

Thud!

Mephiros, who was targeting the warrior's weakness, followed Akasha's footsteps in an instant. A thin line was carved on his neck.

As if he didn't realize the attack was coming, Mephiros' head flew through the air with the same stiff expression.

The two demons died simply and anticlimactically, leaving only Kargos.

“Kraaaaaa!”

Kargos exerted his final strength, exploding with energy.

Still, being ranked third among the demons, he seemed to have held out for quite some time.

However, if the hero had decided to end it, Kargos would have lost his head a long time ago.

Even though there was only a 2-level difference between level 97 and 99, it was as big a difference as heaven and earth.

A flame sword beam shot up like a huge pillar from the great sword swung by Kargos.

The hero also swung his sword, facing the force that seemed to split the entire forest in one blow. It was a strike that didn't seem much different from before.

There was no explosion caused by the collision. Kargos' sword was buried in the warrior's strike and shattered like dust.

Kargos' sword was also split in half, and at the same time, his armor was also cut open and blood gushed out.

“Ugh...”

Kargos fell from the sky and writhed when he hit the ground.

Then, the holy sword scattered into golden light and disappeared from the hero's hand as she landed on the ground.

The hero stood in front of Kargos without even breathing heavily.

Struggling to lift his head, Kargos looked up at her and let out a bitter laugh.

“In the end... you won't be able to stop it. The miracle of that day will never happen again...”

It was his last words.

Whoosh!

The sudden flames rose from his body, but the voice that spoke calmly without any fear of death or anger towards the hero.

I wondered if he was trying to commit suicide, but the flames only engulfed Kargos' body.

He burned himself to ashes and disappeared in an instant, leaving no trace of his body.

“...”

Silence descended on the surroundings.

Without even realizing it, I held my breath and looked at the hero standing there.

The power of the hero who easily dealt with three high-ranking demons was truly overwhelming.

The woman, who had been looking at the place where Kargos had burned and disappeared, turned her gaze towards Erica's party.

The next words that came out of the hero's mouth were unexpected.

“I knew your face looked familiar. You’re Sir Jerel.”

Upon hearing the hero’s words, Jerel was at a loss for words, but soon nodded with a touched expression on his face.

“Yes, yes! Hero, sir... It’s truly an honor that you remember me,” Jerel replied.

Come to think of it, Jerel was a radiant knight who had fought alongside the hero in the war.

I let out a sigh of relief as the tension eased from my body.

I thought I was really going to die this time, but I didn’t expect to be saved by the hero.

“Who are you?”

I lowered my head for a moment, then perked up at the hero’s voice.

She was looking at me.

I couldn’t find the right words to answer for a moment and stumbled over my words, but there was no point in hiding my identity since it was already revealed.

I willingly answered the warrior’s question.

“I am the Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

Chapter 118: Hero (1)

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Even after hearing about my identity, the hero didn't show any particular reaction.

She just looked at me with a curious gaze.

“...The Seventh Lord of Calderic?”

I thought she was curious about what a Lord of Calderic was doing in a place like this.

But as I listened to her next words, I realized that wasn't the case.

“Weren't the Seventh seat of Calderic already filled?”

The hero seemed to have no idea that a new Seventh Lord had ascended to the throne in Calderic.

I wondered why she didn't know, but then I quickly understood.

Could she have just come out of Sondong?

During the meeting of the neutral country last time, I guessed she was in Sondong.

Sondong was a space solely for the recovery of the hero. The said space could completely cut off communication with the outside world.

If she came straight here after leaving Sondong, it was entirely possible that she didn't know about the new lord.

“A new Seventh Lord ascended to the throne in Calderic a year ago.”

The hero stared at me and asked, “Then why did you come here?”

...I was curious about the same thing myself.

The hero must have had a reason for coming here, and she probably knew everything that was happening at this monastery.

I met the hero’s gaze for a moment in silence.

At that moment, Jerel, who was next to me, interrupted and said to the hero, “Hero, that person... tried to protect us from the demons. I don’t know what his purpose is, but at least...”

Jerel looked confused, but he seemed to be on my side.

He quickly tried to help me, in case the hero misunderstood the situation.

Calderic and Santea were practically enemies in this situation, and it wouldn’t be strange if she slit my throat just because of my identity.

But I wasn’t worried about that at all.

I knew very well how kind and righteous the hero was.

I didn’t have any rose-colored glasses, thinking that I was important just because I was Calderic’s lord.

That’s why I revealed my identity without hesitation. Besides, there was no point in hiding it in the first place.

“I came here purely by chance. I didn’t even know about the existence of demons that were hiding in this monastery.”

I honestly explained my position without a single lie.

Of course, it would be an unbelievable story.

The fact that one of Calderic's Lord came to a small monastery in Santea's border, and that too by chance, where the demon's seed was hiding.

But she has no choice but to believe me.

The hero had to believe my words.

Because among the numerous abilities that the hero possessed, there was also one that was similar to the ability of the Overlord.

The ability to distinguish between truth and falsehood, one of the abilities of the Holy Sword.

So she would have known that I was only speaking the truth.

“...”

The hero, who had been silent for a moment, turned her gaze to the other three.

Erica, who had been watching this side, spoke hesitantly.

“Oh, we haven't found our friends yet. They're somewhere in the forest...”

Jerel added with a surprised look.

“The demons have kidnapped two children from the monastery, sir. They are probably somewhere in this forest.”

Jerel's face looked dark, as if it was covered in shadows when he spoke.

It's hard to imagine that the children were still safe at this point.

Regardless of their safety, we must find them as soon as possible.

The hero looked around before fixing her gaze in one direction of the ruined forest.

“Please wait a moment.”

Suddenly, the hero disappeared.

Within a few minutes, she returned with two boys in her arms.

“Tom!”

Erica and Heron jumped up when they confirmed Tom’s face.

Tom and the other boy were unconscious, but they were breathing normally.

The hero placed the two boys on the ground and said, “Don’t worry, they are unharmed.”

“Where did you find them?”

“They were buried in something like a stem and had their life force drained out. It was probably the work of a demon’s familiar.”

There were many demons who used life force as food.

Perhaps the abbot had hidden the familiar in the forest and occasionally fed people to it. Regardless, it’s good that they were safe.

The hero walked over to the dead body of the abbot and picked up something.

It was an object that looked like a black gem.

I knew what that was.

The object used by demons to find the demon’s seeds.

Many demons were secretly searching for the demon’s seeds for the resurrection of the demon king, and demon contractors who received their power also searched for it.

Lower-ranking demons or demon contractors could not recognize a demon’s seed even if they saw it, so they used the power of that object to distinguish it.

The abbot happened to learn that Erica being a demon's seed, so I wondered how the archdemons knew about her.

The abbot was not directly connected to the archdemons. He wasn't that strong.

However, since it was related to the demon's seed, the demon who gave the abbot the power must have called the archdemons himself.

Sigh.

The hero also knew well what the purpose of the jewel was.

The hero examined the jewel briefly and then destroyed it as it was.

The jewel, engulfed in golden light, disappeared instantly.

The hero who destroyed the jewel moved towards Erica again.

Erica, who was examining Tom who had lost consciousness, looked up and stared at her.

The golden light in the warrior's hand gathered again, and the holy sword reappeared.

Hearing the sudden sound of the sword being drawn, Heron, who was next to her, was surprised and stood in front of Erica.

"I-Is everything okay? Why are you suddenly...?"

"It's okay. I'm not trying to hurt your friend."

The hero gently pushed Heron aside and stood in front of Erica.

Then she raised her hand to Erica's forehead.

Ah!

With a flash of the holy sword, a sacred energy wrapped around Erica's body.

I have already guessed what the hero was doing. It seemed like she was removing the demon's seed with the power of the Holy Sword.

Heron looked at the scene in surprise, while Erica examined her own body in confusion.

Anyway, it seemed like the situation was roughly under control.

All the archdemons were dead, and the missing two children were rescued unharmed.

The hero turned her gaze back to me.

There were still many things she would want to ask me, but I felt the same way.

Meeting the hero and talking to her was something that had to be done sooner or later.

I had never imagined that it would happen in this situation, but it was an opportunity I could not miss.

"Hero, I have something to discuss with you."

We made it out of the forest and returned to the monastery.

As we arrived, priests and holy knights gathered in the backyard with frightened faces.

They were shocked to see us come out of the forest, almost as if they had seen ghosts.

The battle with the archdemons had turned the entire forest upside down, so it was impossible for the people in the monastery not to notice.

“Tom, Rex!”

“Everyone is safe!”

Some nuns hurriedly ran over when they saw the children.

The holy knights turned to Jerel with pale faces and asked, “Sir Jerel, what exactly happened in the forest?”

It was Jerel’s job to explain and organize the situation to the people in the monastery.

Since the abbot had died, there was no way to completely hide what had happened.

The abbot was a demon contractor, and demons who gave him power in the forest attacked him. They fought against the demons in this way.

Jerel did not explain why the demons were targeting Erica or about the appearance of the archdemons. There was no need to explain that.

The demon’s seed was something that he did not know about originally in the first place.

“Wow, the abbot was a demon contractor? That can’t be true!”

“But it is true. The abbot was also responsible for the kidnappings of children in the forest by using a demonic familiar.”

People denied it as if they couldn’t believe it.

The abbot seemed to have been highly trusted and virtuous among the people of the monastery, so their reaction was natural.

Especially since priests were those who hated and despised the demons more than anyone else.

It was only natural that they were shocked that the abbot they believed in and followed was a corrupt person who made a deal with the filthy demons.

“...There is the abbot’s corpse in the forest. We will send more people to investigate the details in accordance with the Pope’s order, but you can look into it for now.”

Jerel continued his explanation to calm the people down.

A few people looked at the hero and asked, “But what about her...?”

When the hero looked a bit embarrassed about what to say, Jerel covered it up nicely.

The sky was already getting light.

The atmosphere had somewhat calmed down, and a few priests took the children to treat them.

Jerel went back into the forest with the holy knights to finish cleaning up, and I went into the monastery building with the hero.

“Sit here.”

I took the hero to the room where I stayed.

There was no better place to have a conversation than here.

The hero looked around the room once before sitting down obediently on a chair. I sat on the opposite side of her.

“Let me introduce myself again. I am Ron, the Seventh Lord of Calderic.”

“Okay,” the hero replied curtly.

Since I was the one who wanted to have a conversation, she seemed to indicate that she would listen first.

She didn’t exude any particular energy, but just her gaze alone made me feel overwhelmed, as if I was being overshadowed by an incomparable level of intimidation, unlike that of the Overlord.

I organized my thoughts and went straight to the point.

“Did you deal with the demon’s seed the girl is carrying?”

The hero’s eyes narrowed at my question.

No one knew about the demon’s seed except the hero and the archdemons. Furthermore, the hero could destroy the magical seed with the power of the Holy Sword.

Therefore, among the things she was doing, she also sought out and destroyed the demon’s seed and protected those people from demons.

It was natural for her to wonder how I knew about them.

“How do you know about that?”

I didn’t answer that question.

It was a question that I couldn’t answer, and even if I did, she wouldn’t be able to understand.

Instead, I continued speaking.

“Hero, I know what your purpose and desire are. And also, that you have very little time left.”

“...”

As I kept talking without answering her question, she became slightly irritated.

“What do you want to say?”

She looked as if she had no idea what I was talking about.

The purpose of the hero, it was something that no one except the hero herself could know, and something that could not be spoken to anyone.

It was a kind of contract, and taboo that the hero had made with the Holy Sword.

That's why she had done everything alone, without anyone's help.

“The heir.”

“...!”

At my words, the hero was shocked, and her eyes widened.

The expressionless face that didn't even blink when fighting against the three archdemons was instantly flustered.

I confirmed my thoughts with her reaction and continued speaking.

“You're looking for someone to succeed the Holy Sword. I know that fact.”

Chapter 119: Hero (2)

Chapter 119: Hero (2)

The hero's face became so stunned that she looked like she had lost her senses. Her pupils shook as if there was an earthquake.

It was a natural reaction.

It was because the biggest secret of the Holy Sword, which only she should know, had come out of someone else's mouth.

The fact related to inheritance was unknown to anyone on the continent except for the Overlord of Calderic, the archdemons, and the hero.

“...!”

Suddenly, a huge energy burst out from the hero.

It's not a killing intent, but rather an oppressive feeling that was close to hostility.

Despite the [Soul of the King], it was a power that could still make me tremble a little. This was the first time I had encountered such an opponent.

Even though the [Soul of the King] was a 9th grade skill, was it not fully effective against a level 99 hero?

“How...”

The hero's voice seemed a little hoarse.

She looked at me with a glare and said,

“Explain, Seventh Lord. How do you know about the inheritance?”

If I didn't answer properly, a chilling feeling as if my neck would be cut off right away compressed the space.

It felt like standing on a judgment seat surrounded by sharp blades on all sides, but I soon regained my composure.

Because my purpose was purely to assist the hero.

The ultimate goal of the hero and I could be considered almost the same.

Even if I didn't give a proper answer to some of her more difficult question, I would only say the truth whenever I could, and the hero would know that I wasn't lying by using her ability.

“First of all, I will say this before we get into the main subject.”

I crossed my arms and met the hero's eyes.

“I cannot answer the question of how I know the secrets of the Holy Sword that only you and a few others should know.”

“....”

“But I swear everything I say is true, and the reason I cannot answer the question is not because I am hiding any intentions. It's because telling you would be meaningless, and you wouldn't understand it, anyway.”

The hero's expression twisted slightly.

She probably thought I was talking nonsense. Nevertheless, she would know that everything I said just now was sincere.

“You are saying something that is difficult to believe. Answer the question properly. This is not the kind of problem that can be passed over like this.”

“That's true. But can't you at least listen to what I have to say?”

“....”

“You’re the one that had the advantage in this situation. If something bothers you, you can just cut my throat. Isn’t it better to do that after hearing my story?”

I deliberately spoke in a way that made it seem like I was risking my life.

It wasn’t entirely empty talk, but it was a bluff that I could make because I knew what the hero was like.

She would never harm an innocent person. That’s why she was the hero.

Just because I didn’t reveal my reasons until the end, it didn’t mean she would threaten or cut my throat.

“....”

The hero looked at me with a deeply troubled expression, but eventually nodded as if to say, “Tell me your story.”

...Okay, things were going smoothly up to this point.

This conversation with the hero was the most critical starting point for my future plans.

Depending on whether I could persuade her or not, the future would be completely different.

I organized my thoughts once again before starting to speak.

“As I mentioned before, I know about the succession of the Holy Sword.”

“...”

“And I also know that you don’t have much time left due to the after-effects of your battle with the Demon King. So we need to find the heir as soon as possible and let them inherit the power of the Holy Sword.”

The expression on the hero's face seemed to stiffen slightly.

For her, I was revealing critical secrets one by one.

But she didn't say anything and just listened quietly. As she mentioned earlier, she would just listen to my story for now.

Since there was no point in dragging it out, I got straight to the point.

"I know who the heir is."

The hero's eyes widened at my bombshell declaration.

She stuttered, "What...?"

"As I said. I know who the heir of the Holy Sword you're looking for is."

The heir.

At this point in time, the hero didn't know anything about the heir. Not their race, gender, age, nothing.

She had only received a prophecy to find the heir somewhere in the world through the Holy Sword.

But I knew.

Playing RaSa, I knew a lot of information about the heir.

That information was the absolute card to persuade the hero in this conversation.

She was still in a state of restlessness, chasing after time and endlessly searching for the heir.

"It's hard to believe you."

It was the words uttered by the hero who had been silent for a while.

“Do you know who the heir of the Holy Sword is?”

Even so, the hero seemed extremely confused.

Because she knew I was saying the truth.

I nodded.

“Yes, I know.”

“How...?”

“As I’ve already said, I cannot answer that.”

“Are you asking me to believe that absurd story without even telling me the reason?”

“You have no choice but to believe me. You know very well that I am speaking only the truth, without a hint of falsehood.”

The hero seemed taken aback.

“So you knew about my abilities, too.”

“As I’ve said before, it doesn’t matter how I know these things. What matters is that I know who the heir of the Holy Sword is, and that it is the truth.”

I caught a glimpse of the hero’s expression.

It was clear that she was more agitated than before.

Now, the initiative in the conversation had passed to me.

“Do you understand now? I have the information you want more than anything else.”

“...”

“And this is not a story I brought up for the purpose of bargaining for something I want.”

The hero still seemed to not understand what I was trying to say.

I said forcefully.

“I will help you find the heir. That’s the only reason I brought up this story to you.”

The hero stared at me in silence.

I met her gaze, waiting for her response in silence.

“...This is confusing.”

The hero narrowed her eyes, trying to gauge my intentions with a perplexed expression.

It was natural for her to react this way when I suddenly offered my help.

After all, I wasn’t her ally, nor did I belong to Santea, and until a moment ago, I was just an outsider with no connection to her cause.

Moreover, I wasn’t even an ordinary person, but a Lord of Calderic, a position that made it natural to be hostile to the hero, and had no reason to help her.

However, I had no ulterior motives whatsoever.

There was no impure intention behind my desire to help the hero.

And that was all that mattered.

The ability to distinguish truth from falsehood in words was the strongest link of trust in such a situation.

“I swear it. I have no impure intentions in offering to help you.”

“Then why do you want to help me?”

“Our goals are the same. I want peace in the continent, and helping you, the hero, is the best way to achieve it.”

Yes, it was the best way.

To prevent the impending attack of the demons in the near future, this was the best and only way.

As far as I knew from the main story of RaSa, the resurrection of the Demon King was almost certain.

The only way to stop it was to go to the demon’s stronghold and destroy the Demon King’s resurrection base, but that was close to impossible.

If it were possible, would the hero waste time looking for the heir?

Even though the Demon King was sealed, the demons were still the strongest force on the continent.

They were currently lying low, cautiously planning to achieve a perfect victory unlike in the past.

The hero was barely maintaining a precarious balance as the deadline approached.

If the hero was in a normal condition, the story would be different, but...

Anyway, there was nothing the hero could do about it.

If it was possible, I would have made other plans, but no matter how much I thought about it, this was the only way.

To stop the resurrected Demon King, there must be the hero. Only the hero could stop the Demon King.

I couldn’t know for sure if my unique 10-star skill could work on the final boss of this world.

And even if it did work, it would be foolish to rely on it without any preparation.

So, this is the best option.

I would do everything I could to prepare for an uncertain and unpredictable future.

This was the first step.

“...”

The hero still looked like she couldn't understand.

“You want peace for the continent?”

“Yes. Is that strange, when a Lord from Calderic desires peace?”

I spoke honestly and added;

“There's nothing strange about it. I simply judged that only the hero with the power of the Holy Sword could stop the Demon King if he were to be resurrected. If we can't stop the Demon King, this continent will be finished. Even if I am a Lord of Calderic, would I wish for the destruction of the world?”

Actually, there was nothing grand like a great cause to save the world for me.

First of all, if this world was not safe, how could I guarantee the safety of my own life? So, I had no choice but to fight to survive.

“...Is that so?”

Anyway, although the hero didn't completely dispel her doubts, she showed some signs of understanding.

Even if I didn't completely gain her trust, it didn't matter.

The important thing was to establish a cooperative relationship with the hero. And when it came to the issue of succession, the hero was more urgent than anyone else.

She would not be able to easily dismiss my proposal just because of her suspicion.

“Even if you don’t trust me, it doesn’t matter. Like I said, I don’t want a deal. If you want, I’ll share the information with you right now.”

“...!”

“I don’t even know the exact location of the heir. It will take some time to find them. Of course, if you help, it could be shortened.”

That was all I had to say.

“Now, I hope you can tell me your answer, hero. Will you cooperate with me to find the heir?”

The remaining decision was up to the hero.

For the hero, all of this would be sudden, so she couldn’t answer right away.

I waited calmly for her response.

She asked me, “Are you also going to accompany me in finding the heir?”

I nodded.

“I don’t plan on just giving you the information and watching from the other side of the river. This is an urgent matter for me as well.”

“...”

“Even if I don’t feel inclined to get involved, I can’t compromise on this. Working together to find the heir and providing information is the only condition.”

It was somewhat unsatisfactory to just give the hero information about the heir.

I also had to keep planning for the future while observing the situation.

Of course, it was also to increase the hero's trust.

After a long silence, the hero spoke.

“...Alright.”

She said with a complicated look of mixed emotions.

“Seventh Lord, I will cooperate with you.”

Chapter 120: Return

Chapter 120: Return

I managed to successfully establish a cooperative relationship with the hero. It's a start.

For now, the hero probably didn't fully trust me yet, but that's not really a problem. The important thing was that we've formed a connection.

Now, what we needed to do was find the heir who would inherit the Holy Sword.

I didn't know the exact location of the heir, but I have a rough idea.

The Ramon Mountain Range in eastern Santea.

Somewhere deep in that mountain range.

In the game, or rather, a few years into the future from the middle of the story, I coincidentally meet another player and went on an adventure together. During that process, I became closer to the heir as a companion and naturally learn various things about her, including her past.

Based on that information, it could be speculated that the heir was currently living with her father, away from the world, somewhere in the Ramon Mountain Range.

Of course, it's just a guess, and even if it's correct, it could take a long time to find her if we had to search the entire mountain range.

But still, we had to do it.

My fate and life in the future depended on it, so how could I hold back anything?

Now that I had found the hero, if I could just find the heir, I could take another big step forward to prevent the end of the world.

Although, come to think of it, I hadn't talked about the conditions for inheriting the Holy Sword with the hero yet.

Well, I could discuss that after finding the heir.

"How's your injury?"

As I looked up at the sky in the back courtyard of the monastery, I turned my head at the sound of a voice. It was the hero.

The hero healed the injury that I had received from Kargos. Even the injuries I had received from Ditrodemian while staying at the monastery were completely healed.

Her healing ability was on a much higher level than elixirs, all thanks to the power of the Holy Sword.

"Thanks to you, I've fully recovered."

After hearing my story and accepting the proposal, the hero said she needed time to organize her thoughts and disappeared somewhere before reappearing now.

The hero approached me and asked, "But why were you staying in this monastery? I heard you were already injured when you arrived here."

She seemed to have heard the story about me from other people.

Even she couldn't help but wonder what a Lord of Calderic was doing in a place like this.

"Did you already know that girl Erica was carrying the demon's seed?"

It was a natural guess, but it wasn't truly correct.

I decided to just answer honestly, since there was nothing to hide.

"I came to this monastery purely by chance. I found out about Erica being the demon's seed due to an attack by the archdemons."

"What about the injury?"

"There was a battle with Ditromedean before. I got injured during the fight. In the process, his spatial ability swept me away, and I ended up here."

The hero asked again with a slightly surprised expression, "Ditromedean? Then what happened to him?"

"He died."

"I see."

The hero nodded her head, showing no interest in the circumstances that led me to fighting against Detrodemian.

"What are you going to do with this monastery?"

When asked about the aftermath, the hero answered readily.

"First, I'll inform the Pope and request support. I can't let the people here stay and live like this."

The monastery had already been exposed to demons, even archdemons.

The attackers who came to seize the demon's seed had been defeated, but they were still exposed to serious danger.

Therefore, it was a natural course of action for the hero to evacuate the people from the monastery.

"What about Erica?"

“I’ve already taken care of the seed she was carrying, but she still needs to be even more careful, just in case.”

I nodded my head.

“When everything is resolved, we’ll find the heir and leave.”

Afterwards, we stayed at the monastery for a while.

The hero would stay here until the troops arrived to protect the people, she said.

Leaving hastily and having other demons come to the monastery would be a terrible disaster.

Of course, there was almost no chance that other archdemons would reveal themselves after what happened to Kargos, who was ranked third among them.

If they realized Kargos had died, they would almost certainly think it was the work of the hero.

But the hero couldn’t overlook even the slightest possibility.

I had no reason to leave the monastery alone before the hero, so I had to stay here until then.

It was quite some time before troops arrived to take the people from the monastery.

Several radiant knights with level in their 80s and dozens of other high-level holy knights came.

And not just them, but also the Pope’s decree.

Sword Saint Ceriod...

I looked at the middle-aged man talking to the hero in front of the building from the window.

One of the five stars of Santea, along with the Fist Saint and the Spear Saint, the Sword Saint. Did he come in person?

Sword Saint was the only person in the five stars who was negative towards the royal family and close to the hero.

“Then I’ll leave it to you, Sir Ceriod. Please take care of yourself.”

“Yes, my lord.”

Not only the church’s troops, but also the royal troops, including the Sword Saint, gathered an enormous force beyond imagination at the monastery.

It was not surprising, given that it was a problem related to the archdemons and the hero requested direct support.

For the time being, they were tasked with protecting the Rosariel Monastery and nearby villages while conducting an investigation.

From the conversation I overheard, it seemed that their future situation had not yet been decided.

Evacuation was the best option, but it was realistically impossible to evacuate so many people indiscriminately.

Only a few people were aware of the demon attack in the first place, and it seemed they would watch the situation and decide on the future course of action.

However, Erica was to be transferred to the Pope’s decree under thorough protection.

The hero had dealt with the seed of the demon, but she couldn’t be left unguarded like that.

Erica also agreed to leave the monastery after hearing the explanation.

“Since it’s turned out like this, I’ve decided to become Sir Jerel’s disciple.”

“Is that so? That’s good.”

Erica came to find me before leaving and talked to me.

In the end, she decided to become Jerel’s disciple, or how she and her two other friends would go to the Pope’s order together.

“Thank you so much. Thank you for protecting me and my friends.”

And finally, she gave her gratitude.

Erica conveyed only simple gratitude without asking anything about me.

I asked her, Jerel, and her other friends who learned about me to keep my identity a secret.

Anyway, it was a short relationship, and I wished her future would be smooth sailing without being swept away by such events.

After the situation was resolved, I also left the monastery immediately with the hero.

The hero opened her mouth after looking around the vast plain that stretched out in front of us.

“First, you said we’d head to Enrock.”

“Yes.”

First of all, meeting Asher was a priority over anything else.

She wouldn’t still be in the place where she fought with Ditromdemian, right?

Since it was impossible to know what she was doing by now, it was best to return to the Lord’s castle.

I hope she didn’t tell the Overlord about anything else, at least...

No, since the Overlord's subordinates who were being chased by the tower master were also in that place, even if it wasn't Asher, it couldn't be kept secret.

I hoped the Overlord would not find out about the events here at the monastery and find the connection. It would be troublesome.

"Does the Holy Sword also have teleportation abilities?"

The hero turned back to me at my question.

I knew that with the power of the Holy Sword, the hero could accomplish most tasks that were difficult, even with magic. Like teleportation or polymorph.

"That's right."

"Can we teleport directly to Enrock from here?"

The hero shook her head.

"That might be difficult. I can't teleport unless it's a location I've set."

It seemed that even with the power of the Holy Sword, there were limitations to teleportation magic.

I felt a little awkward and could only bite my tongue inwardly because I didn't have the ability to move quickly to Enrock like the hero. I didn't even have a flying mount.

The hero could move quickly even without a mount.

I glanced at the hero and said, "I plan to move as quickly as possible from here to Enrock without delay."

"I agree. There's no reason to waste time."

"Actually, I don't have the ability to move as fast as you do."

The hero blinked.

Why did memories of being carried by Asher while climbing a cliff when I went to find the first mystery suddenly come to mind? The situation was particularly similar.

“I see. I understand,” said the hero, as if she had understood my words right away.

I wondered what she was trying to do when she reached out to me.

Then, a golden aura gathered and created a barrier around me. And it lifted me into the air.

“I’ll fly and move like this. It won’t take long to get to Enrock.”

“...”

I looked down at my feet while floating inside the barrier.

Although the shape was a bit strange, well, it’s better than not floating at all.

Then the hero, who had risen in the air, shot up into the sky. My body followed behind her as if pulled by a magnet.

The flight speed was much faster than riding a wyvern. As she had said, it seemed like we would reach Enrock soon enough.

We arrived safely in Enrock.

The hero decided to wait for me in the city since there was no reason for her to follow me all the way to the Lord’s castle.

“What if someone recognizes your face?”

She replied by immediately changing her appearance.

Her hair and eye color were reversed, and her facial features and shape were also changed. It was the polymorph ability of the Holy Sword.

So I went into the city alone after parting with the hero and headed to the Lord's castle.

As always, the butler came out to greet me.

“Welcome, my Lord. You must be tired.”

“Yeah. Was there something else that happened while I was away?”

He seemed very surprised for some reason, so I asked.

The butler replied, “Yes, that... Sir Asher returned to the castle alone a while ago...”

I could understand the situation from his words. Fortunately, Asher had returned to the Lord's castle.

The butler could only roughly explain the situation to me.

I immediately headed into the castle.

Not long after, I sensed someone coming closer, then a figure appeared in the hallway at the entrance of the castle.

I stopped in my tracks upon seeing the familiar face before me.

Asher looked at me dazedly before calling out with a choked voice,

“...Sir Ron!”

T/N: Because of the appearance of the ‘*Sword Saint*’, I could finally understand and properly translate the title of the first two of Santea's five stars that had already appeared. The one I called the warrior is actually the ‘*Fist Saint*’ and the one I called the General is called the ‘*Spear Saint*’. Sorry for correcting it only now. The words used by the author as their title

was really hard to understand for a novice translator like myself. Now, at least, their title finally makes sense. (ཐོས་ཐོས་ཐོས་)

Chapter 121: Heir (1)

Chapter 121: Heir (1)

Ramon Mountain Range, East of Santea.

A person was walking on a forest path filled with lush greenery.

The girl was walking with a wooden stick slung over her shoulder, tapping it lightly as she took unsteady steps.

“.....”

The girl, who looked a bit drowsy, suddenly stopped walking and turned to look at the bushes nearby.

The bushes rustled, and a small squirrel popped out.

The girl naturally crouched down and offered some acorns from her pocket to the squirrel, which accepted them eagerly, and started eating.

“Is it tasty?”

“Chirp.”

As the girl was petting the squirrel, suddenly the ground began to shake.

The startled squirrel jumped away, scattering the acorns, and ran off. The girl wrinkled her brows.

Soon after, a giant bear appeared, not just a simple animal but a creature more akin to a monster. The bear’s mouth was smeared with dried blood, evidence of a previous hunt.

Despite the terrifying and predatory gaze of the beast, the girl didn't seem to be afraid and only muttered while tapping her wooden stick on her shoulder.

"I didn't plan on having meat for lunch."

With a roar, the bear charges at the girl.

The girl raised her wooden stick, and a blue energy emanated from it.

The girl swung her stick towards the bear's snout as it approached her with its mouth wide open.

The sequence of actions seemed light, but the outcome was not.

With a loud noise, the bear's body collapsed and fell to the ground.

The girl stared at the dead bear and leaned against a nearby tree.

Returning to her drowsy expression from earlier, she looked up at the clear sky without a cloud.

"Hmm."

Upon returning to the lord's castle safely, the first thing I did was to calm Asher.

She must have been worried sick while I was missing, because she couldn't hide her surprise when she saw me.

"I had you worried. I'm fine, so don't worry."

"Yes, but what happened exactly...?"

Although Asher asked calmly, her voice was still shaky, unlike her usual self.

The last time Asher saw me was when I disappeared after being attacked by Ditrodemian, so I understood her intense reaction.

“Let’s go inside first.”

Since we were in the middle of the castle corridor, I took Asher to the room first and roughly explained what had happened.

Being teleported by Ditrodemian’s ability to the outskirts of Santea and encountering other demons there.

There was nothing to hide except for the existence of the hero.

Although I wondered if it was necessary to hide it from Asher, I decided to leave it out for now, as the story was already complicated enough.

“I see. You were swept away by the demon’s spatial ability.”

After hearing the explanation, Asher muttered.

She was probably able to safely return to the Lord’s castle with Ti-Yong. Ti-Yong wouldn’t let anyone ride on its back unless they were of the wyvern species or had a special connection with me.

I was not sure if Asher was recognized for her abilities or if Ti-Yong was just a clever guy who knew when not to make a fuss.

“What was the situation like after I disappeared?”

“Well, we searched the forest for another day and then returned to the Lord’s castle.”

“What about the Overlord’s spy?”

“We went separately, and she probably returned to the Overlord’s castle.”

Asher lowered her head with a gloomy expression.

“I’m sorry. I was just thinking that we need to find a way to quickly locate Sir Ron.”

“No, your judgment was appropriate.”

The butler had told me the story earlier. Asher wanted to inform the Overlord of the situation and request her help.

If I had any problems, the only person she could rely on was the Overlord.

It had been a while, so the Overlord had probably already received the news, but it was probably not a big deal.

There was no way to hide the fact that it was related to Ditrudemian, but the only thing that needed to be kept secret was the existence of the hero.

If the Overlord found out that I had formed a cooperative relationship with the hero, what kind of reaction would she have?

That was the one thing I couldn’t predict.

For some reason, the Overlord in the game seemed to have a strange fondness for the hero, despite the fact that the hero was a decisive obstacle to Calderic.

In any case, it wouldn’t be good to let the other find out about the hero.

“...”

I stared at Asher blankly.

The task to be done from now on was to finally find the heir.

I had been with Asher for almost all of my journey so far. Without her help, I couldn’t have come this far.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“Do you remember what I said about my goal in the ancient ruins before?”

After blinking, Asher answered.

“Yes, you said you wanted peace on the continent...”

I nodded.

“From now on, this is the real starting point. Does your will remain the same as the answer you gave back then?”

Asher had said that she would willingly lend her strength, no matter what I do in the future.

Asher replied with a firm voice, as if it was obvious.

“Of course. I’ll help you with whatever you want, Sir Ron.”

The fact about the succession of the Holy Sword was an extremely confidential matter, as it involved the fate of the entire continent.

There was no need to explain all the details to Asher and directly involve her.

Even if I didn’t explain the reasons one by one, she would always obediently follow my orders, as usual.

But I didn’t want to continue using her by hiding what I was doing from her forever.

I already trusted Asher as an absolute ally, a valuable colleague, and a subordinate.

So now, at least to her, shouldn’t I make my ultimate goal clear?

I stood up and said to Asher.

“There’s a place we should go to right now. Follow me.”

I left the Lord's castle to head to a high-end inn located on the outskirts of the city with Asher.

I had told the hero that I would come visit her by noon tomorrow.

Without any trouble, the hero was already having her meal on the first floor of the inn.

"You came right away," the hero said, putting down her spoon while looking at Asher standing behind me. Asher also looked at the hero with a puzzled expression.

I looked around the inn's hall and said, "You should finish your meal first."

"No, it's okay. I've reserved a room, so let's go upstairs."

The hero immediately finished her meal and stood up from her seat.

As far as I knew, the hero's body was unaffected even if she did not consume food. She was almost like a transcendent being, borrowing power from the Holy Sword.

However, there was a dialogue in the game where she didn't exercise her authority in such trivial matters.

We went straight up to the room upstairs and faced the hero, feeling her magical power spreading around the room. She seemed to block the sound from leaking outside.

"Sit here too, Asher."

Asher tried to stand behind me instead of sitting, so I placed her on the seat next to me.

Before getting into the main topic, I decided to introduce Asher first. However, the hero asked first.

“Who is that person?”

It was a voice full of suspicion and alertness.

We would now talk about the location of the heir, and it was a natural reaction since I had brought in a strange person who I hadn't mentioned before.

“Asher Gronhilde, she is my escort knight,” I said to the hero. “She will also be working with us from now on. She is a person who will be of great help.”

“The collaborator was only supposed to be you, Seventh Lord, wasn't it?” the hero replied with a slightly uneasy expression.

“I know what you're trying to say, but don't worry. She's someone I trust more than anyone else.”

While the hero looked a bit uncertain, Asher also turned to me, indicating that she didn't understand what's happening.

I also revealed the hero's identity to her.

“Asher, this person is the hero of Santea.”

“Yes, yes?” Asher turned her gaze to the hero, looking much more surprised than before.

I knew that even if I introduced her abruptly like this, she wouldn't be able to understand the situation.

“Asher, listen carefully. From now on, what I'm going to do is...”

I finally explained everything to Asher, including the Holy Sword, the succession of the Holy Sword, and the cooperative relationship with the hero.

As I explained everything step by step, Asher's expression changed in various ways.

After hearing all the explanations, Asher looked at the hero across from her.

Her gaze was filled with confusion, but that wasn't all.

“Are you really the hero of Santea?” she asked in a voice that seemed to have a strange sense of hostility.

I immediately understood Asher's attitude.

That's because, for Asher, anyone from Santea, especially the hero, she couldn't be friendly with.

The hero also looked at Asher with a suspicious expression, as if sensing something. After a moment of silence, Asher spoke again.

“I am a survivor of the White Moon tribe. We were exterminated by the Santea.”

“.....!”

The hero's eyes widened slowly at those words. She also knew well about the horrific massacre committed by the royal family.

I thought about whether I should intervene in the conversation, but decided to leave it be. It was also a problem that needed to be solved by them.

“I've always been curious. Hero, do you know about the massacre of the White Moon tribe committed by the Santea royal family?”

The hero nodded.

“I know very well.”

At that answer, Asher seemed to tremble for a moment.

After taking a deep breath, Asher spoke again.

“Then you knew about their actions and didn't stop them. Is that right?”

“That’s not true. At the time, I was in a place where all communication with the outside world was completely cut off. By the time I learned about the tragedy, it was already too late.”

“...”

“Asher Gronhilde, this will undoubtedly be a contemptible excuse for you.”

The hero stood up and bowed deeply towards Asher.

“I’m sorry.”

The hero only conveyed those words of apology.

It seemed like she felt it was too shameful to say anything more, as she only uttered that one word.

When Asher didn’t say anything in response, the hero finally lifted her head and spoke after a long pause.

“The emperor is the mastermind behind the massacre of your tribe.”

“I know. But if you know that too, then why...”

It meant, if she also knew about it, then why was she leaving the emperor alone?

In response, the hero answered with a face that seemed both ashamed and bitter.

“For now, I cannot hold the emperor accountable for the atrocities he has committed.”

Chapter 122: Heir (2)

Chapter 122: Heir (2)

He could not be held accountable for his crime.

It was only natural for Asher to express her incomprehension at the hero's words.

A hero who had once saved the continent, an embodiment of justice who had slit the throats of demons.

Why would such a being say that an old, decrepit emperor could not be killed?

“...Why, because it would jeopardize your status as a hero hailed by all?”

Asher's voice was choked with anger, but what she said was not the reason.

The hero was not someone who acted for the sake of her own honor. Even if the hero were to execute the emperor, as long as she had the justification, it would not greatly harm the hero's reputation.

In any case, she was an irreplaceable presence in Santea, and if she set her mind to it, she had more than enough ability to deal with him. There was only one reason.

“Because, as it stands, I cannot control the chaos that will ensue in Santea after I kill the Emperor.”

I pondered the hero's response silently.

The hero's principle of action was always consistent: peace in the world.

But she was also a person who knew better than anyone else the difference between idealism and reality.

She was not a hero from a fairy tale who would blindly commit any action to uphold her beliefs.

The emperor was a cunning and sly man. He understood the hero's mindset well and had already prepared all the resources he could muster to counter the hero's movements.

One prominent example was his incitement of even more dirty and brutal struggles among his children who were eligible to inherit the throne.

This was to ensure that his abdication or death would cause as much chaos and disruption to the empire as possible.

It was a time when the invasion of demons was imminent, and everyone needed to unite.

Therefore, the hero could not just kill the emperor.

She was someone who had more tasks and responsibilities than anyone else. It was impossible to uproot everything that was tangled up in the governance of Santea, like a spider web centered around the emperor, and set it right again.

At least for the time being, the Emperor was fulfilling his role well enough that she had no choice but to look the other way.

The hero did not bother to explain the complicated situation. Whether she thought it was just an excuse or not was unknown.

Asher watched the hero quietly and sighed.

She seemed to be looking at me, so I intervened and said, "It's okay. If you have something to say, say it all."

The hero also nodded her head.

Asher hesitated for a moment before speaking again. “I know it’s ridiculous to blame you like this.”

“...”

“It’s just my tribe’s business. The plight of a now-forgotten minority race in the world shouldn’t be your concern.”

“...I don’t think that way. You have the right to hold the Emperor and I accountable. Even if you resent and hate me, I have nothing to say.”

That’s not just talk, she really thought that way.

This was the most emotion I saw on the hero’s expressionless face since I met her.

Asher lowered her head.

“I was just curious about the reason. That’s all. I only follow Sir Ron’s will.”

With that, she bowed sharply.

“I apologize for the disrespect I have caused you.”

She apologized to the hero in a polite but emotionless tone.

The hero looked at Asher with a slightly embarrassed expression before turning her gaze to me.

The conversation ended awkwardly, but since Asher seemed to have nothing more to say, I decided to end it there.

“Asher, as I said before, we will now move to find the heir with the hero.”

I said to the hero.

“The location of the heir is the Ramon Mountain Range in the east of Santea.”

“...!”

“It’s not completely accurate. But the probability of the heir being somewhere around there is very high.”

“Ramon Mountain Range...”

The hero seemed to be lost in thought for a moment and asked, “Are we going to move right now?”

“Yes. There’s no reason to delay.”

It wouldn’t take long to get to the Ramon Mountain Range by riding on Ti-Yong, not to mention the hero.

After a moment of thought, I changed my mind and said, “No, let’s leave tomorrow morning.”

Since I would be away from my seat for a while, it would be better to organize anything that needed to be sorted out before leaving.

After setting the time for departure with the hero, Asher and I left the inn.

Asher’s feelings towards the hero seemed to be somewhat negative, but fortunately, there didn’t seem to be any major problems.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“I want you to tell me your honest thoughts about the hero.”

I asked Asher on the way back to the castle.

After a considerable silence, Asher replied, “Honestly, I don’t have good feelings for her.”

“Do you resent her?”

“As far as resentment—— no, it’s my job to deal with the emperor. Who am I to blame anyone else, just...”

She didn’t finish her sentence, but I understood what she’s trying to say.

The massacre of the White Moon tribe was clearly unrelated to the hero, but on the other hand, the hero could have prevented it.

Furthermore, even though the hero had the ability to judge the Emperor’s wrongdoings, she chose not to.

Even if she understood that the hero’s situation was complicated, it was hard for her to accept. Reason and emotion were not the same thing.

Then Asher said with an apologetic expression, “I’m sorry for causing concern, Sir Ron. I’m fine now. My heart was just briefly disturbed.”

“Okay...”

Anyway, there didn’t seem to be any immediate big problem.

It would be nice if they could maintain a good relationship with each other, but it was not as if the relationship between the hero and Asher was important for the future.

When I returned to the castle, I had to greet another guest.

“Chief of Staff?”

Chief of Staff Dayphon had arrived while I was out.

The Chief of Staff, who was standing at the entrance of the castle, greeted me politely.

“It’s been a while, Seventh Lord.”

It was the first time the Chief of Staff had come to the castle since the incident with the Sixth Lord.

When I looked at him with a curious look, he immediately stated his reason for visiting.

“I’m here because I’ve heard from Her Lordship regarding the Magic Tower incident, and I’m glad to see you’re alive and well.”

“...”

Well, there’s nothing else, really.

I went into the castle with the Chief of Staff, who said he wanted to talk.

“What did you come here to talk about?”

I asked as we sat down across from each other, and the Chief of Staff took a sip of the tea the butler had served.

Knowing my personality, the Chief of Staff quickly brought up the reason for his visit.

“Do you remember the intelligence officer rescued by the Seventh Lord at the scene?”

“Yes.”

“I heard from that intelligence officer that the Flaveros tower master had a contract with the Archdemon named Ditrodemian. Also, that the Seventh Lord executed Ditrodemian on the spot and that you hid your traces for a while afterward.”

I looked at him with a “so what” expression.

Honestly, I couldn’t completely rule out the possibility that the Overlord’s intentions were mixed up with Ditrodemian’s appearance.

Perhaps feeling pressured as I intently stared at him to read his intentions, the Chief of Staff spoke in a slightly tense tone.

“I want to hear directly from the Seventh Lord what happened at the scene.”

How should I answer?

I was lost in thought.

I didn't want to talk about the monastery at all.

The Overlord might already know about the emergence of the hero at the Robelgio Monastery.

But it was information she would have to learn eventually, and if she did, I didn't want her to find out about my connection to the hero.

“I understand that Seventh Lord had been following Her Lordship's order. If it's related to the Magic Tower incident, I hope the Seventh Lord could provide the necessary information.”

Since I didn't answer for a long time, the Chief of Staff spoke again.

The assassination of Flaveros Tower Master was what I had promised to do for the Overlord. Therefore, it was necessary to disclose what had happened during the process.

I purposely let out a fake laugh, slightly exaggerated. The Chief of Staff stopped talking.

“It's a little annoying.”

As if I hadn't gone through enough because of this incident.

Fighting with Ditrodemian, being stranded alone in Santea's border and meeting other archdemons in succession, I didn't know how many times I almost died. Of course, I also met the hero thanks to that.

Anyway, I went through such a hardship because of the Overlord, and the Chief of Staff's words were enough to piss me off.

If one didn't want to answer a question, then they shouldn't. And right now, I had every reason to do just that.

"Chief of Staff."

"..."

"Is it a coincidence that Ditrodemian showed up there?"

I asked as coldly as possible.

The Chief of Staff, swallowing his saliva cautiously, seemed to understand the meaning of my words and said,

"You are mistaken — The appearance of Ditrodemian has not the slightest relation to the will of the Overlord."

"I see. It's just a miserable coincidence that he appeared at the moment I was trying to handle the Tower Master, which happened to be his demon contractor."

"..."

"Tell the Overlord. I'm going to need a proper explanation for this that I can live with."

I said that and ordered the Chief of Staff to leave.

"I understand. I will convey it to Her Lordship."

The Chief of Staff had no choice but to leave without asking any more questions.

I figured if I came out this hard, I'd be able to get away with it somehow. After all, I'd taken care of that Tower Master as promised.

Nothing in particular happened while I was gone.

When I couldn't see the siblings, I asked and found out that Reef had gone on a mission with some of the trainees to a northern city, and Rigon had gone with her.

Reef and Rigon seemed to have settled into the castle by now.

I took a day off to rest and took Ti-Yong with me to leave the castle early the next morning with Asher.

I told the butler that I would be away for a while, so he should manage things well without any problems until I returned.

The hero had finished preparing in the forest outside the city and was waiting.

The hero gave Ti-Yong a curious glance.

"Is that your wyvern, Seventh Lord?"

"Yes."

"Black wyverns aren't easy to get along with, but it looks like you have a good companion."

The hero gently stroked Ti-Yong's wing.

For a creature that vehemently disliked being touched by anyone other than myself, it strangely didn't show any particular antipathy to the warrior. It merely purred and looked at me with an awkward posture.

Come to think of it, did the hero originally have a wyvern too?

I remembered the hero's wyvern must have died in the war with the demons.

It was killed by the demons while fighting alongside her.

“Will you fly on the wyvern with us?”

The hero shook her head.

“It’s okay. I’ll fly next to you.”

There was no problem since we weren’t going to fly directly to our destination without stopping at cities along the way.

“Then let’s leave right away.”

With that, we were ready to go.

Kroooh!

Ti-Yong roared loudly and took off into the sky first, followed by the hero.

Let’s go find the heir of the Holy Sword in the Ramon Mountain Range.

Chapter 123: Heir (3)

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“This way.”

The King of Kajor swallowed hard and followed the guide through the castle’s entrance.

The landscape of the Eight Lord’s Castle was even more grotesque than he had imagined it would be.

Massive black towers stacked all over the castle. But it wasn’t stone or wood that made them up.

Kiiyi.

Flesh, carapace, legs and antennae that protrude and wriggle out of the hodgepodge.

The tower was made up of countless swarms of insects. Each and every one of them was much larger than a human.

The Eight Lord, the Black Sea Empress, and the legions of bugs she ruled over. The Eight Lord’s Castle was their headquarters and nest.

Throughout the castle, servants bustled about, carrying away the corpses of monsters. Food for the worms.

When the servants threw a corpse at the tower, it was instantly sucked into the tower and disappeared without a trace.

The King of Kajor was completely at a loss for words as he watched the shocking sight, which could not be described as simply ugly.

Especially...

He turned his gaze to one side of the castle.

Unlike the other towers, where insects swarmed together, there was a single creature, larger than the castle's buildings, gnawing on the food brought by the servants with its mouth split into several pieces.

However, what it was eating was not the corpses of monsters, but living humans.

The guide walking ahead of us glanced at the sight and said.

“He's a picky eater and doesn't eat much other than humans. I hope you'll forgive me if you don't like the sight.”

Despite the mocking tone, the King of Kajor could only remain silent.

This was no way to treat the King of a nation, even if the other was a subject of the Eight Lord, but this was Calderic, not Kajor or Santea.

He was the one who had come all the way here with a purpose. Whatever the guide's demeanor might be, he was in no position to complain.

The inside of the castle was relatively ordinary compared to the outside.

The guide, who had stopped in front of a door after crossing the corridor, gestured to the door.

“Please come in here.”

The King of Kajor nodded and cautiously grabbed the door handle.

At that moment, the guide added a word.

“Please be careful what you say, lest you offend the Great One. No one here is responsible for your safety.”

“.....”

The guide smiled again and gestured once more.

As he opened the door and went in, the inside was a cold, dark, and very spacious area.

Only one glowing red stone was stuck to the ceiling, emitting a faint light.

The King of Kajor looked around for a moment, unable to adjust to the darkness, and then froze in horror.

This was because he discovered a presence that was looking down at him from inside a huge thread-like thing hanging from the ceiling, like a spider.

“King of Kajor, you said you wanted to see me?”

The voice, languid and distant, echoed in his heart.

The King of Kajor couldn't even meet her gaze and lowered his eyes.

As a king, he should not feel so inferior that he cannot even meet the gaze of a Lord, regardless of how much lower their rank may be, even if the country he ruled was much smaller and less significant than Calderic.

But the atmosphere of this room, and the look in the Black Sea Empress' eyes as if she were looking at something less than a bug, compelled him to do so.

...Was this what it meant to be truly intimidated by a Lord?

The King of Kajor couldn't help but realize it.

The Overlord and the new Seventh Lord seen at the previous conference of neutral countries, were both very mild in terms of the attitude they showed.

“It is my pleasure to meet the Eighth Lord——.”

“Cut the crap and tell me what you’re here for, though I don’t really need to hear it to know.”

The King of Kajor spoke, trying to calm down the shiver running through his body.

“Please support us with troops that can overwhelm Earth Hill.”

The Black Sea Empress snorted and spoke in a nasal voice.

“Santea said they won’t interfere in this matter. Since they didn’t help you, are you looking for an excuse to ask for help from Calderic?”

“...”

“But that’s beside the point. There’s another bigger problem, isn’t there?”

The Black Sea Empress, who had suddenly erased her smile, spoke with a serious expression.

“Our Seventh Lord has already declared his support for Earth Hill. Are you asking me to help invade Earth Hill while confronting the Seventh Lord?”

The Black Sea Empress’ two eyes gleamed fiercely in the darkness.

The next moment, the King of Kajor pulled out a small pearl that glowed with a dull red color.

The Black Sea Empress’ eyes widened slightly at the sight of it, and a creepy smile formed on her lips.

“Where did you get that?”

“It’s a treasure of the Kajor Royal Family recorded to have been discovered by our ancestors in the magical realm.”

King Kajor held out the pearl.

“If you promise to grant my request, I will give this to you right here and now.”

“Hmm...”

The Black Sea Empress snorted and fixed her gaze on the pearl.

“You said you had something I wanted, but I didn’t think you’d bring it as a trade.”

“...”

“But, King, did it ever occur to you? What if I don’t keep my end of the bargain and just swallow the thing whole, or—“

She smiled and pointed a slender finger at the King of Kajor.

“I could just get rid of you right here without even making a promise. You didn’t come to my nest believing that I would keep the end of the bargain, right?”

The King of Kajor knew that her words were not just idle threats, but were spoken with sincerity.

The Lords of Calderic were a force to be reckoned with, and the title of a king of a country did not provide him with much protection.

But he had expected this reaction, and replied calmly.

“There is more than just one.”

“...”

“I have two more in my possession besides the one I brought with me.”

The Black Sea Empress immediately understood the implications of his words.

“I will give you the other two after you keep your promise.”

“That is correct.”

“Now that I know this, why should I bother making a deal with you? I could just go to your kingdom and take what I want.”

The King of Kajor couldn't help but stiffen at those words.

He hesitated to speak, and the Black Sea Empress burst into laughter.

“You know, even I would have to face many consequences if I went that far. I may be able to get one, but I won't be able to get the other two, right? That's what you wanted to say, isn't it?”

“...”

“I know, I know, I'm just joking. Don't be so serious, it just makes your ugly face look even more disgusting.”

The Black Sea Empress remained silent for a moment, moving her fan from side to side.

The King of Kajor patiently waited through the suffocating silence.

Eventually, the Black Sea Empress spoke again.

“Very well. If you have nothing else to say, you may leave, and I will send a messenger back to your kingdom.”

The King of Kajor inwardly breathed a sigh of relief, knowing that he had gotten through this difficult situation.

At the same time, he felt a sense of unease, knowing that he had crossed a point of no return.

If only the Emperor of Santea had been a little more proactive, things might not have come to this point. But now it was too late.

If he didn't act now, it would take too long for another opportunity to arise.

“Thank you. Then...”

The King of Kajor left the room, and the Black Sea Empress reached out towards the pearl on the ground.

A slender thread emanated from her fingers and snatched the pearl, bringing it to her hand.

“It’s interesting. Quite interesting.”

The Black Sea Empress turned towards the door as it opened again, and the guide, who had brought the King of Kajor in, bowed in respect.

“I heard that the Seventh Lord has vacated his seat again?”

“Yes, that’s correct.”

“And his destination?”

“He never discloses it. But it seems he has left the castle for quite some time.”

The Black Sea Empress tapped her fan against her hand.

She didn’t know the details, but she was aware that there had been some kind of conflict between the Seventh Lord and the Overlord recently.

It was probably related to the agreement they had made during the previous incident related with the Sixth Lord, but that didn’t really matter in this situation.

“I wonder what his reaction would be.”

The timing was just right.

What if she supported Kajor to step on Earth Hill while the Seventh Lord, that arrogant human, was away?

The Overlord has declared that she would not interfere in this matter. So, there was nothing to worry about.

The Seventh Lord had already crossed the line once with the Sixth Lord. He had sworn to the Overlord that he would never do it again.

After what had already happened, no amount of rage could drive him to kill herself.

If he ever killed another Lord again, then he would truly pay the price.

There were few things to do in the mountains.

One could either take a walk and look at the sky or bushes, or go hunting for animals or monsters.

The Ramon Mountain Range was a vast mountain range where numerous monsters resided.

Kaen went far from her home to find a new monster somewhere in the mountain range to ease her boredom.

As she walked along the mountain path, she habitually tapped her shoulder with a wooden stick, then stopped and looked down at the ground.

“Hmm...”

Huge wolf tracks. And judging by the bipedal footprint, it was the trace of a werewolf.

It wasn't a new monster, but the length of the footprints was huge, enough to be measured in spans. It was the first time she had encountered such a huge creature.

Werewolves were fierce and ferocious monsters that even most adventurers avoided encountering.

But Kaen, on the other hand, started to follow the footprints with excitement in her eyes.

After a long pursuit, Kaen was able to discover a lone werewolf standing in the middle of the bushes.

“.....?”

And then she opened her eyes wide in surprise.

It wasn't because the werewolf was much larger than she imagined.

It was because she found someone collapsed on the ground near the werewolf.

“A person?”

A middle-aged man with an unknown identity wearing a robe.

This was deep in the mountains where no people usually stepped foot.

Kaen looked at the man suspiciously and then turned her attention back to the werewolf.

The werewolf also shifted his focus from the collapsed person to Kaen and revealed his hostility towards her.

Roar!

As the enraged werewolf rushed towards her, she calmly drew the sword at her waist instead of the stick.

A blue energy circulated around the blade as it clashed with the werewolf.

At the same time, the werewolf's chest was split open, and blood spurted out.

“Was it a little shallow?”

Kaen muttered to herself as she watched the werewolf turn and charge again, unaffected by the wound.

Although the werewolf's claws were strong enough to tear even trees apart, they were meaningless if they didn't hit their target.

Kaen avoided all of the werewolf's attacks with her extremely flexible body movements and struck back with her sword.

Chyaak!

After several more slashes, the werewolf finally ran out of strength and fell to the ground.

Kaen took a deep breath and wiped the blood off her sword. Then, she approached the man who had collapsed on the ground.

“...”

Upon examining his condition, she found that he was barely breathing.

There were no obvious injuries, but the man's complexion was completely white, and he didn't look like a werewolf had struck him down.

Kaen hesitated for a moment about what to do, but then lifted the middle-aged man on her shoulder.

He couldn't just leave the person lying there, so she decided to take him home for now.

“My father will probably be able to treat him.”

Chapter 124: Heir (4)

Chapter 124: Heir (4)

The cabin sat haphazardly in the middle of the woods, seemingly uninhabitable.

Pushing past the crude wooden fence and into the cabin, Kaen grabbed the kettle on the table and gulped down some water, then trudged upstairs.

Bang.

As she opened the door and entered the room, there was a middle-aged man inside.

The man, who was sitting in a chair drinking tea, seemed momentarily speechless when he saw Kaen enter the room with a stranger on her shoulders.

“Who is that?”

With a hint of embarrassment in her voice, Kaen replied nonchalantly, “I don’t know.”

“...” the man fell silent.

“I went east and found him collapsed and unconscious. But I couldn’t just leave him there,” Kaen said as she laid the collapsed person on the bed.

Watching the scene, the man rubbed his forehead in pain and got up to check his condition.

After taking a quick glance at the stranger's condition, he immediately diagnosed, "It looks like he's suffering from magic exhaustion."

"Oh, did I bring him here for no reason then?"

If it was just a simple magic exhaustion, he would recover on his own over time.

The man shook his head. "No, it's not that. It seems he forcefully raised his magical power to an extreme degree. If you had left him in that condition, he would have died."

He rolled up his sleeve and snapped his fingers.

"Go to the warehouse and get some root powder and pepperia leaves. Also, boil a cup of water."

Kaen went outside without asking any questions and brought back what the man had asked.

The man immediately started to mix a simple medicinal concoction on the spot, and Kaen watched him as if she were familiar with his actions and asked,

"Where did this person come from? Father."

The Ramon Mountains were located in a place completely isolated from cities or towns where people live.

There were naturally no passersby on the road, so for Kaen, humans outside the mountains were unfamiliar and strange existences.

The man also knew that she was curious about this outsider.

"I don't know."

The man replied briefly and focused on the treatment.

Kaen also leaned against the wall with her arms folded without asking any more questions.

An outsider who fainted from severe magic depletion. When he regained consciousness, she would be able to ask him directly what his identity was.

Rodiven, a professor at the Imperial Academy of Elphon.

The reason why he took a long vacation and came to this remote mountain range of the empire was simply to collect research materials.

One of his specialties, Taming Magic, required samples of many monsters.

In that sense, the Ramon Mountains were the perfect place. The untouched wilderness was a sight full of unknown creatures.

“Will you really go alone? Still, it would be better to bring a few assistants...”

“It’s okay. Why bother bringing people and make it into such a big deal?”

Rodiven couldn’t have imagined it.

He hadn’t expected to find himself in danger of losing his life in these mountains he had so lightly climbed.

In the deep parts of the mountains, he discovered a structure like an altar, where countless monster corpses were piled up beyond count.

And in the midst of it all, there stood a monster, covered in blood from head to toe, standing still.

Rodiven, who held the position of Professor at the continent’s largest academy, Elphon, was undoubtedly an outstanding wizard.

But he had never encountered such an ominous display of magic in his life.

“Human? A wizard? What an unlucky fellow to come all the way to this remote place to die.”

Rodiven knew instinctively that he was a demon, or at least a contractor for one.

There was no time to think about what such a being was doing in this place.

All Rodiven could do in the sudden attack by the monster was to escape with all his might.

The difference in power was evident, but Rodiven managed to survive by using a magical tool that he had received as a gift from the academy’s principal.

With a random teleportation spell engraved on the magical tool, he barely managed to escape the monster’s clutches. But...

“Um.”

Rodiven regained his senses and sat up in surprise.

Looking around, he realized he was in an unfamiliar space.

“Where is this...?”

Rodiven tried to recall what happened before he lost consciousness.

He was attacked by a monster; he managed to escape, and then he blacked out from exhaustion.

He checked his physical condition first.

The magic that had been completely exhausted before he fell was somewhat restored.

As he looked around the room with mixed feelings, the door opened.

“You’re awake.”

Rodiven looked at the unfamiliar man, who entered the room and asked tentatively.

“Who... are you?”

Was he the one who saved him?

At Rodiven’s question, the man replied simply.

“The owner of this cabin.”

...A cabin? In the middle of a mountain range?

Was there someone living in this rugged mountain range?

Seeing Rodiven’s confused expression, the man calmly explained.

“My daughter found you collapsed in the woods and brought you home. So we gave you some simple treatment.”

“Ah... thank you.”

Rodiven expressed his gratitude first.

The man asked, “How’s your condition?”

“Thanks to you, I think I’m okay. But...”

Rodiven sorted through the questions swirling in his head, wondering which one to ask first.

Who was this man and how did he manage to stabilize his condition so cleanly, given that it was clearly a serious case of magic depletion?

On the other hand, the man did not ask Rodiven anything.

He just nodded his head and walked back outside the room.

“I’ll bring you some tea, at least. Rest for now.”

The man went out and soon came back with a teacup.

Rodiven stared at the tea that the man had brought him, took a sip, and then put it down on the table.

The man saw this and said with a smirk, “I didn’t put anything strange on it. There’s no reason to. You can drink it without worry.”

“.....”

Rodiven cleared his throat in discomfort.

From his perspective, he was just being cautious in a completely defenseless situation, but from the other person’s point of view, it was certainly a disrespectful action.

If there had been impure intentions from the beginning, he wouldn’t have been treated like this.

“Sorry, things are still confusing. But are you someone who lives in this mountain range?”

The man nodded his head.

Rodiven thought the man might ask him something, but he got up from the road without saying anything.

“If your body recovers, please leave. If you need more stability, you can stay for a few more days.”

With that, he walked away, as if he had nothing more to say.

Rodiven thought of him as a strange guy and looked at the closed door for a moment before turning his gaze to the window next to him.

Outside the window, he could see the surrounding woods and front yard.

And in the front yard, a girl was lying on a tree with her eyes closed.

“Is that girl his daughter?”

Rodiven decided to go outside first.

The man was nowhere to be seen inside the house.

Coming out to the front yard of the cabin, he walked toward the tree where the girl was.

The girl had opened her eyes by then and was staring at him.

“You’re awake.”

Kaen, who had jumped down from the tree, looked at Rodiven up and down and asked, “Are you someone from outside the mountain range? Where are you from? Why did you come here?”

Unlike the man who seemed to have no curiosity, she seemed to have a lot of questions.

Rodiven hesitated for a moment about how to react to the barrage of questions.

He didn’t normally deal with girls of this age other than as students at the Academy, and they were generally very polite, so Kaen’s innocent demeanor was new to him.

“Are you living in these mountains with just your father?”

“I asked you first. Answer me first.”

Rodiven introduced himself simply, hiding his embarrassment.

“I’m Rodiven. A wizard. I’m also a professor at Elphon Academy.”

Kaenn tilted her head.

“Elphon? Academy?”

The road to the Ramon Mountains, accompanied by the hero, was very quiet.

Or should I rather say it was bleak?

I'd never been much of a conversationalist when I was traveling with Asher, but with the addition of the hero to the group, it was only natural that there would be no conversation.

The hero was the type to not say anything if it wasn't necessary, and Asher was even quieter, perhaps conscious of the hero.

After the sun had completely set, they descended to the ground for dinner and camping.

Asher looked around habitually and said, "I'll be back."

"Yeah."

Going back meant going with Ti-Yong to hunt.

We had brought our own food, but Ti-Yong's share required separate hunting. The other was a big guy, after all.

Its wyvern instincts had gotten the better of him once before, and it slaughtered too many monsters unnecessarily.

Ti-Yong was smart enough to listen, but from then on, I'd have Asher follow him and keep him under control, just in case.

Flutter!

Ti-Yong flapped its wings and took off into the sky, Asher running after it.

I sat there, staring blankly at the campfire burning for a long time.

The hero sitting across from me looked at me with a strange gaze, then spoke up.

“May I ask you something?”

“...?”

It was the first time she spoke since we departed.

I nodded my head.

“You said your goal is to achieve peace on the continent. It aligns with my goal, and that’s why you said you were helping me.”

“Yes.”

“Then, was becoming a Lord of Calderic part of the plan to achieve that goal?”

Ah... was she asking me about that?

In short, she was curious about why I became a Lord.

She must also know that I was a new Lord who recently rose to power.

“I didn’t become a Lord because I wanted to.”

I was only pushed into a situation where I couldn’t do anything else when I landed in this world.

Well, now that I think about it, it was also thanks to that that I was able to come this far.

I couldn’t give a clear answer to the question, so I remained silent.

“Are you not going to answer this either?”

But the hero didn’t ask any further questions and just let it go, as if my silence was the answer.

It seemed like she took it as a positive answer, but whether she misunderstood or not, it didn't matter.

"May I ask you one more question?"

"You don't need to ask like that every time you wanted to ask something. If there's an answer that can be given, I'll answer."

"It's about your escort, Sir Asher."

The voice of the hero sank a little heavily.

"The bond between you and Sir Asher does not appear to be the usual one, Seventh Lord, and I wonder how you came to take her under your wing."

"Well... "

Perhaps because she knew Asher's true identity, the hero seemed particularly interested in her. Probably because of guilt or remorse.

Since it wasn't something I couldn't tell her, I gave her a suitable answer.

How I accidentally found Asher at the Overlord's Castle, how I learned that she was a member of the White Moon tribe, and how I ended up taking her with me.

After listening to the story, the hero was silent for a moment before asking again.

"Do you also despise me?"

It was a sudden remark, but I understood its meaning.

I looked into the hero's eyes without saying a word.

Did I despise the hero? Of course not.

Her monologues from the game flashed through my mind.

I was probably the only human besides her who knew the blind faith she held in her heart for peace.

That's why, even though Asher couldn't, at least I could understand her.

I suppose that's because I didn't go through what she experienced myself.

I shook my head, feeling a little bitter.

"No matter how powerful you are, you can't save everyone unless you're a god. You know that better than anyone, don't you?"

"..."

"The emotions I have towards you doesn't include any contempt."

The warrior's expression was somehow weary.

I added a rather unnecessary afterthought.

"And for the time being, you are the only one I can rely on, Hero."

The words caught her off guard, and her eyes widened a bit.

After a moment, I sensed the presence of Asher and Ti-Yong.

Asher naturally stood by my side and resumed her escort duties.

In fact, there was no danger as long as the hero was present.

Therefore, Asher did not need to keep watch, but I respected her dedication to her duty as an escort.

But...

I glanced at Asher's face.

Her mood didn't seem to be as good as it had been before she'd gone out with Ti-Yong. Was it just her mood?

I wondered, then I turned my attention back to the campfire.

“Eat slowly,” Asher mumbled, watching Ti-Yong tore apart the monster it had caught.

Of course, the creature didn’t seem to listen to her and continued to eat at the same pace.

Looking around, Asher slowly approached Ti-Yong.

“Hmm...” she murmured softly and began to gently stroke the area between the scales on the Wyvern’s toes.

This was a behavior that she wouldn’t show in front of the Seventh Lord, but it was fine now that no one was watching.

Recently, she had discovered a part between the scales on the Wyvern’s toes that was slightly soft and pleasant to the touch.

Asher absentmindedly stroked its scales while lost in thought. It was about the hero.

In truth, her feelings for the hero were hard to define, even for herself.

It wasn’t anger, nor was it resentment or contempt.

It seemed to be more than just a feeling of frustration related to the tribe’s affairs. Then what could it be?

She had said to the Seventh Lord that it was nothing and that she would just follow his will, but that was not the case.

Asher still felt confused about her thoughts that were not neatly organized.

“If you’re done eating, let’s go.”

With Ti-Yong finished eating, Asher moved her steps.

As they arrived at their designated place, she heard faint sounds of the Seventh Lord and the hero conversing.

“And for the time being, you are the only one I can rely on, Hero.”

Asher stopped in her tracks.

She didn't move, as if frozen.

For some reason, she felt suffocated, as if one part of her heart was being torn apart.

Thinking back, Asher realized that she had felt something unpleasant towards the hero, not since she knew she was a hero, but since the Seventh Lord first introduced them at the inn.

Since the moment she realized the Seventh Lord was looking at her with an unusual gaze that he had never shown to anyone else.

“...”

What did the existence of the hero mean to the Seventh Lord?

She couldn't understand.

All she knew was that she was a hero to the world, a woman more glorious and greater than any of them. No one, at least not herself, dared compare.

Asher stood there for a moment before moving on.

She tried to ignore what the source of her rising emotions was.

Chapter 125: Heir (5)

Chapter 125: Heir (5)

“What is the Academy?”

Kaen asked with a tilt of her head. Having lived in the mountains since she was young, she was almost ignorant of anything outside the mountains.

Rodiven was a little taken aback and thought to himself, *Has she only lived in these mountains?*

Elphon’s academy was the largest on the continent and even among the residents of small rural villages, it would be difficult to find someone who had never heard of it.

Rodiven realized that she was completely ignorant of the ways of the world.

“Well, the Academy is...”

“I don’t know what it is, but you’re a mage, so what kind of magic do you know how to use?”

Rodiven felt a bit distracted. Did she know about magic, too?

Oh! This is not the time to be talking about this.

Rodiven belatedly recalled the existence of the monster that had driven him into a life-threatening situation.

Although he managed to escape with teleportation, he might still be traced. Skilled mages could even detect the faint traces of magic power.

And there was no telling how far away this place was from the point of teleportation.

Even if he wasn't being tracked by magic, he could easily run into him again if the distance wasn't too great.

Rodiven grew impatient and said, "Where did your father go? There's something I need to tell him..."

"I know a bit of magic, too. I haven't seen anyone else's magic besides my father's, so I was curious."

"No, this is not the time to talk about that..."

Rodiven tried to interrupt Kaen but ended up being momentarily speechless.

Kaen, who had lit flames in her hand, moved them around in the air and said, "I know how to do fire magic. Actually, I've only learned basic elemental magic so far."

"..."

Rodiven looked at the flames dancing in the air with astonishment.

Fire magic belonged to the elemental magic category, and it's one of the beginner-level magic spells that even novice mages could do.

However, Rodiven was surprised by Kaen's magic deployment.

She did it so naturally, with no signs of concentration.

Magic was the process of converting the nature of magic power. In the process, intense mathematical calculations took place in the mage's mind, requiring extreme concentration.

Therefore, even a simple magic spell like the one just performed by Kaen was only possible for mages at a high level of expertise.

To Rodiven, Kaen's simple act just now looked no different from a three-year-old juggling.

But did she say she only knows elemental magic?

Feeling a sudden surge of curiosity toward the girl in front of him, Rodiven asked, "Did your father teach you magic?"

"Yes."

"How long have you been learning?"

"It's been less than half a year. Why do you ask?"

...A beginner level mage who had been learning magic for less than half a year?

Rodiven wondered if Kaen was lying.

However, her nonchalant blinking eyes made it seem unlikely that she was lying or boasting.

Even if it was a lie from the beginning, the magic that she just displayed was definitely not the level of skill that only a few young magicians could show.

Genius.

That's what they call people who beat such common sense into the ground.

Rodiven looked at Kaen with weak chills running down his spine.

That was when a heavy presence approached, and a roar was heard.

Breaking through the bushes, a huge animal appeared in the yard of the cabin. It was a deer with four horns.

At the sudden appearance of the monster, Rodiven immediately raised his power and spoke to Kaen.

“Step back...”

No, he was about to say that.

With a sudden leap, Kaen shot forward like a missile and punched the giant deer in the jaw with her bare fist. There was an explosive sound as something burst.

The deer, with its head suddenly twisted, collapsed to the ground. It was killed instantly in one blow.

“Monsters sometimes come to the house. Most of these creatures have tough meat and taste bad.”

Landing on the ground, Kaen brushed off her fist and said nonchalantly.

Rodiven, who was about to cast a spell, withdrew his outstretched hand and looked at her.

This child, what level of martial arts does she have...?

Didn't she just know magic?

No, after seeing what just happened, her martial arts skills seemed much higher than her magic skills. She easily defeated a monster of that size.

“Well, there you are.”

The man who had disappeared appeared in the courtyard. A basket in his hand was filled with what looked like grass roots.

Rodiven turned his head, amazed again that he hadn't noticed his presence until he was so close.

He was beginning to seriously wonder who these two were.

“Father, did you go to gather herbs?”

The man glanced briefly at the fallen deer.

“Did another monster come?”

“Yeah.”

“Get rid of it quickly, before any other monsters show up. And don’t just leave it near the cabin, bury it properly.”

Kaen grabbed the deer’s antlers, shaking her head as if she was annoyed. As she dragged the massive deer away, the man turned his gaze to Rodiven.

“Are you planning to leave right away?”

“Oh, no. No, sir.”

Rodiven, momentarily distracted by Ka’an’s talent, turned his attention back to the important matter at hand.

“There’s something urgent I need to tell you about. It’s related to when I passed out and fell.”

“....”

Although the man didn’t seem particularly interested in Rodiven’s situation, he nodded his head for him to continue.

The two men went back into the cabin and sat facing each other at the table.

“So why did you pass out alone in this dangerous place?”

Rodiven pondered how to start the conversation before speaking up.

“Do you happen to know about demons?”

“I don’t really know much about them.”

“...It’s a bit sudden, but from now on, everything I say will be the truth.”

The man crossed his arms as if to listen.

“First of all, though it is late, let me introduce myself. I am Rodiven Pershma, a professor at the Elphon Academy.”

“Hmm... Elphon.”

The man’s reaction upon hearing his identity was ambiguous. At least he didn’t seem ignorant of what the Academy was, unlike Kaen.

Rodiven carefully observed his reaction and continued speaking.

“The reason I came to this mountain range was to conduct magical research, and I needed samples of various monsters.”

“I see.”

“But while I was here, I saw an unidentified monster. Judging by the aura of magic I felt, it was undoubtedly a demon or its contractor.”

Once again, the man’s reaction was extremely ambiguous.

Demons were beings that had once plunged the world into a pit of despair. Some people were so afraid of them that just hearing their name would make them shudder.

However, the man’s response was tepid at best. All he did was raise an eyebrow in surprise, as if it was unexpected.

“I see. A demon, huh.”

Rodiven didn’t understand his reaction, so he spoke a little more.

“He was no ordinary demon. I’m a pretty good mage, if I do say so myself, and I’d say I’m not too far behind the high-ranking mages of the Imperial Court or the Magic Tower.”

“...”

“He was playing with me like that. If it wasn’t for a stroke of luck, I would never have survived.”

“So what do you want to say?”

“No, it’s pretty obvious, isn’t it? It’s not safe here anymore. You and your daughter should leave this place as soon as possible.”

Rodiven had no intention of leaving without explaining the situation.

Maybe the demon was still after him, and if they were in danger because of his encounter with it, it would be his own fault.

“I am truly sorry for bringing this danger to your home. However, the demons may be searching this forest for me, so please...”

“No need.”

The man shook his head, cutting Rodiven off.

“Our business is our own. If you have no other business, you may leave.”

Rodiven stared at him in disbelief.

Hadn’t he given him a proper explanation?

They had to leave now, to avoid a catastrophe.

But the man’s demeanor didn’t suggest that he would.

Rodiven had a plausible guess at the man’s identity.

A man raising a daughter alone in the remote mountains, and a daughter whose abilities, both physical and magical, seemed far beyond those of a normal child of her age.

It was not unheard of for a retired knight or mage to retire to the mountains to live out the rest of his days; there had been others before him.

Of course, the man’s appearance was youthful for such a thing, but it was not uncommon for a man of his caliber to slow the aging of his body.

He hadn't gotten the hint earlier, and now that they were face to face, he couldn't get the slightest idea of the other's level.

Therefore, Rodiven assumed that the man was at least as powerful as he was.

"Do you think that even if you were to face this demon, you would be able to subdue it?"

If so, this man really needed to be stopped.

The difference in power between Rodiven and this demon was enormous.

No matter how skilled this man was, he didn't think he could stand a chance against him.

"Don't be silly, please. The magic I felt from him is really... Listen, do you hear me?"

Rodiven felt a pang of frustration as he watched the man turn his gaze to the entrance of the hut, paying no attention to the conversation.

Then the man spoke.

"I think it's already here."

"What?"

A moment later, Rodiven felt a shiver run down his spine.

That ominous aura of magic. It was the demon.

"Oh, oh no...!"

Rising from his seat, Rodiven followed the man as the other walked briskly outside.

Outside, the scene before them was a horde of things surrounding the hut on all sides, slowly closing in on them.

Black and massive, wafting with smoke, they had a strangeness and otherworldliness about them that made them far from ordinary monsters.

“...”

The man’s gaze shifted to the side.

There, in the middle of the unidentifiable horde, far in the distance, was the demon. It was the monster Rodiven had spoken of.

The journey was neither long nor short.

I looked at the great mountain peaks that began to appear in the distance.

We had arrived.

This was the Ramon Mountain Range.

The home of the current heir to the Holy Sword.

“Is this the place?”

“Yes.”

I answered the question of the hero flying beside me.

What they had to do now was to search the entire mountain range to find the heir.

“Asher.”

“Yes, Sir Ron.”

Riding behind me, Asher answered my call a beat too late.

What’s wrong with her?

She seemed uncharacteristically distracted.

On the surface, it seemed like it was because of the hero, especially since Asher started acting like this after talking to the hero.

What else could it be?

Taking care of Asher was important.

But now that we've reached our destination, we need to focus on the Heir.

“We're going down. Let's take a break and then start tracking.”

“Yes.”

I lowered my altitude and headed down the mountain range.

Chapter 126: Heir (6)

Chapter 126: Heir (6)

Rodiven stared at the scene unfolding in front of his eyes with frustration.

What he feared had become a reality too quickly.

At first glance, the black monsters brought by the demon numbered in the hundreds.

Rodiven knew how strong those monsters were because he briefly experienced it. Even if he did his best alone, they were at a level where even three or four individuals would have difficulty dealing with them.

This will eventually become my grave.

Now that the cabin was completely surrounded, there was no way out. Rodiven could already see the end.

“...Father! What are all those things?”

Kaen, who had returned from cleaning the deer carcass, hurriedly ran to the man's side.

The man wrapped his arms around her as if to calm her down. And he looked around at the monsters with sunken eyes.

Although there was the fear of death, Rodiven also felt sorry and guilty towards these two people.

In the end, this happened because of him. He wanted to take responsibility, but he didn't have the strength to stop that demon.

“Is it a ministerial authority? That’s quite annoying.”

Rodiven looked at the muttering man, who was still unmoved.

How could he be so calm in a situation like this?

No matter how strong the man’s abilities were, there was no way he could face an army of that size alone. It would be hard as long as the other was not a magic tower master or one of the five stars of Santea.

“I’m sorry. It’s all my fault. I’ll buy you time, so please leave with your daughter.”

Rodiven was determined to face the demon and its horde of monsters. He increased his magic. Even if it was futile, he would do it to give the two a little time to escape.

“How much of your magic did you recover?”

“About half...”

“Then don’t do anything stupid. Just let me borrow some magic.”

“.....?”

At the man’s words, Rodiven wondered what he was talking about all of a sudden.

“Borrowing magic, what is that...?”

“Okay, release all your magical energy towards me. They’re starting to move.”

The man urged. As if saying there’s no time to explain, so he shouldn’t ask.

Rodiven still didn’t understand what the other was trying to do, but he released his magic as suggested.

“...!”

Rodiven's blue-colored magical energy spun around the man and gathered around him.

The magic that was under Rodiven's control was passed on to the man.

“Uh, how?”

Rodiven's mouth widened in shock at the sight of the man handling his magic as if it was his own.

The quality of a magic power was the temperament that an individual was born with. Those who had developed magical powers had their own unique properties.

That's why it was close to impossible to manipulate someone else's magical power.

One could move their own arm as they wished, but they couldn't do that with other people's arms. Using someone else's magical power was no different from that analogy.

The man in front of him was doing such a nonsensical act casually.

The man deployed his magic.

Rodiven didn't know what kind of magic the other was trying to use. However, it was surprisingly fast.

“Release all your magic power. Don't stop.”

Rodiven, who had been lost for a moment, suddenly came to his senses. He raised all of his remaining magic power and delivered it all.

Coo coo coo.

In the next moment, dots flashed in the surrounding air, and it was connected by a line using mana, just like a constellation.

Countless lines connected the dots, and the lines formed planes. In an instant, a magic field, like a huge barrier, formed around the three people and the cabin.

“This...”

A shield to block the advancing monsters.

Judging from the shape, it didn't seem like that it was only just a shield. But what surprised Rodiven more than that was the size of it.

Such a large scale shield with just that little magic?

Even if it was the magic he had given to the other, Rodiven could see how absurd the man's control was.

Not everyone could draw out 100% of their magical power. A person who could draw 30-40% was considered an excellent mage, and if the person could pull out 80% or higher, then they were already in the realm of a great mage.

Even at the bare minimum, the man was able to draw 80% of the magical power.

Either his magic realm approached that of a great mage or he was exceptionally gifted with magic control, or both...

Rodiven could no longer think of the other as just an ordinary man.

Ohhh!

The monsters that hit the man's shield were engulfed in blue flames and started to burn. After all, it was not an ordinary defensive magic.

Some monsters launched attacks from a distance instead of just physically attacking the shield, but even that was consumed by flames. The shield firmly blocked those attacks.

Rodiven, who gave his magic, caught his breath and watched the scene nervously. It was the same with Kaen.

“Can you stop them, Father?”

“Yes.”

“Is there anything I can help with?”

“No. Stay still and watch.”

Kaen nodded at the firm answer.

The man’s gaze reached the demon among the monsters in the distance. The demon was also glaring at the man.

“Do you plan to rest here?”

“Yes.”

The Ramon Mountain Range was vast and finding the heir who might or might not be here would take a considerable amount of time.

Since we had just arrived at our destination, I planned to take a break, make a detailed plan, and start looking for the heir.

“Then I will start searching right away.”

After saying that, the hero was about to fly back into the sky. Her attitude was clearly that of someone who wasn’t planning on resting.

I asked the hero.

“Do you have any plans? How do you plan to find the heir?”

The hero’s answer was simple.

“Is there any other way? I’m going to fly all over the mountain and find them”

“Ah... is that so?”

“With the power of the Holy Sword, even if it’s impossible to cover the entire mountain range, the range of my perception can be greatly increased. I hope to find them as soon as possible.”

With the power of the Holy Sword, the hero was able to accomplish most things, except for the truly impossible.

As least she would be able to find the heir much more easily and effortlessly than me if I was alone.

“I’m going to look in this direction first, so why don’t you go the other way?”

“I will.”

I said before the hero left.

“And, hero, I hope you don’t forget what we promised.”

“...?”

“I said that I had no intention of missing out on finding the heir. I don’t know what will happen later, but at least until we find the heir, we are in a cooperative relationship.”

The hero stared at me. She seemed to understand what I was trying to say.

“If you find the heir first, please don’t hide them without telling me.”

“...I have no intention of doing that. I swear here on my name and my honor.”

I nodded. If the hero said as much, I had to believe her.

After the hero left, I stood in the dark for a while and organized my plan.

I had super sensory, but going around this whole mountain range while looking for the heir would just make me incompetent.

After all, I couldn't just do this ignorantly. So, the only way was to do this the same way I did when looking for mysteries in the past.

Rather than that, I spoke very confidently to the hero...

The possibility that the heir was not in this mountain range could not be completely ruled out.

I hope I could move to the next step without further complication.

“Let's start.”

“Yes.”

After taking a break, Asher and I got on top of Ti-Yong. My heart was half full of worry and nervousness.

The one they thought as a demon was actually a mage who became a demon contractor.

As a blessed human born with an abundance of family and talent, only he would know why he signed a contract with a demon.

He had a brilliant magical talent, but, tragically; he had a greater hunger and greed.

His encounter with a demon was accidental. Unsatisfied with his own achievements and limitations, he ended up swallowing a sweet, poisonous fruit.

He had no thoughts of regret. Starting with the massacre of everyone in his family, he walked this dark path and did any means and methods to gain

greater power.

The reason he temporarily settled in the Ramon Mountain Range was to follow the traces of a demon.

Demons could become stronger by preying on another demon. It was no different for a contractor who had received the power of a demon.

The power he obtained from the demon, after the successful hunting and fierce struggle, was enormous. It was incomparable to hunting humans or other races.

While he was digesting the power he obtained, he encountered a human on the part of the mountain where he settled down for a while.

It was a fairly high leveled mage, but nothing special. An easy prey that he could hunt anytime.

However, the human managed to escape. He never thought the other would have something like a teleportation tool.

He could let him go, but he decided to pursue the human. Just for the purpose of having a small entertainment for a while, however...

What is that human?

The demon contractor looked at the barrier in front and then at the man beyond.

Hwareuk!

When he gently touched the barrier, blue flames rose and completely repelled the invasion of another magic power. The demon contractor said, 'huh' and then laughed.

“At this scale and density?”

The magic that man unleashed without preparation possessed an absurdly solid defensive ability.

The total amount of mana itself was not large. The demon contractor realized that this was a magic so high that even he could not understand it.

It was a terrifying feeling, but this was the question that followed. Why was a mage who could perform such great magic only defending?

There could only be two answers. Either they're not doing it purposely, or they couldn't.

If the demon contractor was on the man's shoes, there's no reason for him to do the former, so the latter was the more likely answer.

So, the demon contractor decided to wait a little longer.

That human wouldn't be able to continue using this magic forever. So, how would he respond after the magic was dispelled?

Meanwhile, Rodiven was thinking the same thing.

Something is strange...

The man was clearly a high-ranking mage. Enough to unleash powerful defense magic that even that demon couldn't penetrate.

In other words, it also meant he could use offensive magic to the extent that he could effectively damage this horde of monsters.

So, instead of just defending and wasting magic, wouldn't it be better to actively attack?

And that's when Rodiven realized.

The man did not use his own magic, but rather borrowed his to cast this barrier.

The mana he was using was all Rodiven. It didn't include the man's mana.

He was surprised at the fact that he could use someone else's magic that he overlooked that.

“That demon seems to have no plans to retreat.”

The man clicked his tongue and murmured.

Kaen opened her mouth.

“Father, if it's not enough, my magic power...”

“No. You must have all your magic power.”

The man shook his head and turned his gaze to Rodiven.

“I'll open an exit at the back, so run away with this girl.”

Rodiven hesitated before asking.

“Perhaps you're magic...”

“It's because it's a broken body that can't build up mana. At this rate, those monsters will eventually break through, so hurry and go.”

The man who said simple waved his hand as if telling them to go.

Kaen glared at the man and said.

“Are you kidding me? You want me to run away, leaving you alone?”

“Daughter, you seem to have misunderstood something, but I have no intention of dying. Your presence will only get in the way of fighting.”

The man said that with all the mana almost used after making this defensive barrier. Rodiven wondered what more the man could do against these monsters. No matter how much he thought about it, the man seemed to be ready to sacrifice himself for his daughter.

Rodiven once again said with determination.

“I’ll try to recover as much of my magic, so why don’t you and your daughter go?”

“Don’t talk about it without me! I’m not going to run away alone!”

It was when the man sighed and tried to say something...

Kyaaaaghhhh!

Everyone’s gaze, including the demon, turned in the direction of the sudden sound.

Across the sky, a black wyvern was flying towards them from afar.

Chapter 127: Heir (7)

Chapter 127: Heir (7)

[……When I was young? Why are you suddenly asking about that?]

[I lived in the mountains with my father. There is a mountain range to the east of Santea. That's where we lived.]

[I learned all my swordsmanship and magic from my father. A promise is a promise, so I'll answer anything else, but don't ask me any more questions about him].

That's the part of the conversation with the heir that I remembered from the game's story.

The heir, who had opened up to the player and their comrades, told the story of her past.

Chronologically, the heir was definitely in the Ramon Mountain Range at this time in the past, unless she lied.

The only problem was, just because her location was most likely here, it didn't mean it was the end.

Even with the aid of a wyvern, scouring the entirety of this vast mountain range was a daunting task that would take forever. Even finding a needle in a haystack would be a bit easier.

About half a day had passed since we reached the mountain range.

Going the opposite direction from the hero, I looked down at the endless forest and sighed to myself.

“Let’s look around a little more and then rest.”

I patted Ti-Yong on the neck, and the other growled in response.

Both he and I were tired, our senses maxed out from earlier.

“...!”

It was at that moment that I sensed two incredibly subtle energy.

One was ominous, reminiscent of demonic energy, and the other was ordinary.

I was certain that the owner of the ominous energy was a demon, as I had encountered them many times before.

Another demon?

I couldn’t help but feel puzzled. I hadn’t expected to feel a demon’s magic all the way here.

An ominous assumption flashed through my mind.

If there was a demon in this mountain range where the Heir lived, was it just a coincidence? Could it have come here on purpose to target the Heir?

There couldn’t be a demon that knew of the Heir’s existence at this time. It was an absurd story.

The existence of the heir was a secret that only the hero and I knew, having received the revelation directly from the Holy Sword.

No matter how much my actions had affected this world, in ways both great and small, it was not...

“Sir Ron.”

As we closed the distance, Asher called out to me as if sensing the energy.

“Full speed ahead, Ti-Yong, in that direction.”

I looked in the direction where I felt the energy with a stern face.

I would have to go there in person to see what was happening.

A wyvern...?

Rodiven stared blankly at the huge object flying towards them from the other side of the sky. And soon, he realized that its identity was a wyvern.

A black wyvern of such gigantic proportions that even he, who was well versed in all manner of monsters, had never seen one in his life.

Wyverns were a rare and virtually extinct creature, except in a few places on the continent.

He wondered if there were wyverns that lived in the Ramon Mountain Range, but upon closer inspection, he discovered that someone was riding on its back.

“What is that monster?”

Kaen also looked surprised as she gazed at the wyvern. To her, the wyvern was a giant, winged monster that she had never seen before.

Whoooooosh!

With a gust of wind, the wyvern landed on the ground.

A man and woman descended from its back.

The demon contractor shifted his attention from the mage who had been casting a defensive spell and focused on them. His eyes flickered slightly as he looked at the two humans.

A palpable aura of power just from the distance.

The demon contractor, who had grown to a higher level by hunting demons, was able to sense the power of the magic that the woman was secretly emitting.

If the difference in power was ambiguous to the wizard who had erected a shield, this time the demon contractor immediately realized;

I am no match for her.

And the man who stood beside her as if she were his escort.

There was not an ounce of aura about him, as if he were a bug, but that made him all the more mysterious.

Moreover, a man with such a powerful person as a subordinate could not possibly be an ordinary being. It was a fact that could be easily inferred.

...Wait, a black wyvern?

The demon contractor felt a moment of fear as a particular information flashed through his head.

He was originally an ordinary human, still active within Santea, and therefore well informed about the world's current affairs. Naturally, he had heard things about a being that had been causing a stir on the continent lately.

A black-haired human male, a female knight from the White Moon tribe, and a black wyvern...

The Seventh Lord of Calderic.

A new Lord of Calderic, who killed the Sixth Lord, the Tyrant, and caused conflict with the Santea royal family even at the neutral country conference.

The outward appearance of the two people in front of him matched exactly with what he had heard through rumors.

It wasn't a hasty assumption. It was certain, given that even the black wyvern, which was tamed by a few people on the continent, was present.

Why is the Seventh Lord here?

Calderic's Lords, the demons who gave him his power, the Five Stars.

They were monsters that could only be compared to archdemons, the pinnacle of all demons.

The demon contractor stared at the man with bated breath, unable to make sense of the situation.

The man, the Seventh Lord, kept his gaze fixed on the three beyond the barrier, as if he had no interest in this side.

The demon contractor moved cautiously, hoping to take advantage of the Seventh Lord's distraction and escape. No, he tried to move.

"Not a demon, but a contractor?"

The Seventh Lord's mouth opened.

The demon contractor answered obediently, barely concealing his embarrassment.

"Yes."

The feeling of one's life being in someone else's hands was unpleasant, and it had been a long time since he had felt it.

The demon contractor tried to answer politely and read the Seventh Lord's expression. But it was useless.

The Seventh Lord turned to the woman and ordered.

"Take him down, but don't kill him, Asher."

When we arrived at the source of the energy, the scene that unfolded before them was difficult to understand.

There were many monsters under the control of some demon contractor, and three people who seemed to be defending against them.

“...!”

I couldn't help but be surprised when I recognized the face of the girl among the three.

The color of her hair, the color of her eyes, her appearance, though young, exactly matched the Heir I remembered.

The heir!

It was definitely the heir.

I felt a tingle of excitement all over my body and ordered Asher.

“Take him down, but don't kill him, Asher.”

I didn't know the identity of the one leading the monsters. Based on their magic power, they didn't seem to be a demon, but rather a contractor.

The coincidence of their attack on the Heir at this time made me wonder if the demons really did know about the Heir's identity...

No, they don't know.

【Lv. 73】

He's level was too low.

First of all, it doesn't make sense that the demons would know about the Heir's existence.

If they really knew, they wouldn't send a demon contractor like this, but would at least send an archdemon directly, since the hero was the biggest

obstacle to their king's resurrection.

It would be enough to subdue the contractor and interrogate him to find out what his purpose was.

As soon as my command was given, Ashr drew her sword and flew towards the contractor.

Kwagwaggwaggwang!

The monsters around the creature were swept away by her sword before it even reached the contractor.

The contractor panicked and created a defense magic, but it was a futile resistance. The gap between Asher, who was over level 90, and the other was too vast.

In an instant, Asher jumped behind the contractor, grabbed his head, and slammed him down to the ground.

“Argh—!”

“Stay still, or I’ll blow your head off.”

The contractor sagged in defeat at Asher’s warning.

I shifted my gaze back to the three.

They had already retracted their defensive barrier and were looking at us.

“They wiped all those monsters out, Father—?”

Kaen murmured with a bewildered look in her eyes.

The woman who had appeared out of nowhere had subdued the horde of monsters and their leader in the blink of an eye.

The man, whose magic was slowly reaching its limit, withdrew his shield. He looked at the two of them with a calm gaze.

“...”

Rodiven, meanwhile, was staring at them in horror. At the man, to be precise.

It took him a beat to realize who he was.

He can't be—— the Seventh Lord of Calderic?

The person's appearance, as well as the black wyvern, matched the rumors that had spread about him.

It was a mountain after a mountain. After the Demon Contractor, why would the Seventh Lord of Calderic be here?

In a mountain range where he had come simply to study magic, Rodiven wondered if he had been caught up in something far greater.

The Seventh Lord who had subdued the demon contractor began approaching them. He stopped just a dozen steps away and gave the three of them a quick glance.

Rodiven spoke first.

“Are you the Seventh Lord of Calderic...?”

He immediately regretted his words. He had spoken too rashly, given the situation where he didn't know why the Seventh Lord had revealed himself here.

“...Calderic's Lord?”

Even the man who had calmly faced the demon contractor showed a little surprise at Rodiven's words.

Kaen, who didn't understand, just looked back and forth at the three of them. She didn't know what Calderic or a Lord was.

The Seventh Lord, who had initially remained silent, finally spoke.

“And you are?”

Rodiven was slightly relieved to hear an affirmative, but unexpectedly gentle, response.

But his guard was quickly raised again, and he considered what his response should be.

He wasn't sure if he should be so forthright as to identify himself as a professor of Elphon to the Lord of a faction that was undeniably an enemy of Santea.

What is his purpose? No, he seemed to be looking this way for some reason ever since he appeared—

Rodiven's head swam dizzily.

That's when Kaen interrupted.

“I'm Kaen.”

The Seventh Lord's gaze shifted to her.

When she spoke, Rodiven felt that the Seven Lord was slightly surprised for some reason.

“This is my father, and this is someone who came from outside the mountains. I think he was a professor at some academy or something, but I'm not really sure.”

Suddenly, Kaen's words revealing his own identity made Rodiven flustered.

“Thank you for your help. But that extremely strong person over there, and the atmosphere... Is she also an amazing person? What's a 'Lord of

Calderic?’’

“... “

The Seventh Lord didn’t answer, just stared at her.

Rodiven screamed inwardly, scanning the Seventh Lord’s mood.

Even if she was ignorant about the world, how could she not know about the Lords of Calderic?

Who would dare to say such a thing right in front of a Lord of Calderic?

“This child only lives in the mountains and is ignorant of the world...”

If she happened to incur the wrath of the Seventh Lord, no one in this place would be able to survive.

Rodiven was about to explain in place of Kaen, feeling as if a cold sweat was about to break out at any moment.

Kuuuuung!

With a ripping sound, something shining golden from the other side of the sky was once again flying towards them.

Chapter 128: Heir (8)

Chapter 128: Heir (8)

Shooo!

A golden aura of energy flew by me at breakneck speed with a long tail like a comet.

I wasn't surprised because I knew what it was.

She's here.

She headed to the opposite side of the mountain range, directly opposite from where Asher and I went. So how did she get here already?

It was good timing, though, because it saved me the trouble of looking for her.

In no time, the hero who had reached this place effortlessly landed on the ground.

The three were stunned, having never imagined that the brilliance was actually a person. Even the heir, who had been chattering away, looked at the hero with wide eyes.

“Uh...”

The warrior looked at them, then at the demon that Asher had subdued, then at me, as if looking for an explanation.

I glanced at the heir and said with only my lips moving, “I think it's her.”

The heir to the Holy Sword.

The final purpose, the hope, of the hero's remaining life.

"..."

The hero's eyes, looking at the heir, shook violently.

This must have been an emotional moment for her, incomparable to what I had felt. She had finally found the heir she had been looking for.

The hero took a slow step towards her, looking lost.

I called out to her because it looked like he might even summon the Holy Sword right in front of everyone if she wasn't stopped.

"Hey."

The hero stopped abruptly and then took a deep breath, as if regaining her composure.

I approached the side of the hero.

"Is she the right one? Do we need to confirm separately?" I pretended not to know, even though I already knew the fact.

The meeting between the hero and the heir in the game was a pure coincidence.

After getting a strange feeling from the Heir, the Hero summoned the Holy Sword and gave it to the Heir, and when the aura of the Holy Sword, which should only respond to the Hero, reacted, he realized that she was the Heir.

So all that's left to do was for the hero to give the girl the Holy Sword and make sure that she was the heir.

The hero answered my question.

"I'll have to take the Holy Sword out and see for myself."

“I see. Then we should postpone that for a little while.”

The hero nodded in agreement. We couldn't just take out the Holy Sword and hand it over to the heir in this situation.

I looked around at people other than the heir. There were two middle-aged men who looked quite old.

The heir said she lived with her father alone in the mountains when she was young.

So I thought one of them might be her father, but I couldn't tell which one it was.

I saw the heir whispering to the man on the left while standing close to him.

“Dad, another person has joined us.”

I looked back at the man who first mentioned my identity, realizing that he was not the heir's father.

By the way, what's this guy's story? An academy professor?

The heir introduced the man as someone who came from outside the mountains.

By academy, was she talking about the Elphon Academy of Santea? I couldn't figure out why such a person would be here.

...Anyway, it seemed like a good time to clear the air, now that everyone was here.

“We're not enemies.”

I spoke to them in the softest voice I could muster.

It was to leave a good first impression on the heir and those related to her, as this was our first meeting.

To me, the heir was the most important figure alongside the hero. She was the only card that could defeat the final boss of this world, the demon king. I had to build a close relationship with her.

I had no intention of revealing my true identity at first, but it had already been revealed before I could even try to deny it.

So to get her to let her guard down, I had to give her a plausible reason for coming here. Luckily, there was a good cover-up.

“My purpose for coming here is because of that demon contractor. You have nothing to worry about, as it has nothing to do with you.”

“Yes, yes. Is that so?”

The professor, who was the most tense, answered hesitantly.

He seemed to have recognized my true identity, but not the hero.

Of course, it was natural since I had a lot of rumors about me, but the hero was currently in a state of polymorph thanks to the power of the Holy Sword.

At that moment, the father of the heir, who had been silently watching me, the hero, and Asher, opened his mouth.

“We received a great help. Thanks to you, no one was injured.”

Surprisingly, his first words were words of gratitude.

“Would you like to come in? It doesn’t seem like you’ll be leaving right away, so let me at least offer you a cup of tea.”

The man looked at the cabin behind him and asked.

What did he mean by not leaving right away? I said it had nothing to do with them, but did he notice something?

The heir's father was an unknown figure with almost no information even in the game.

I looked at the hero, sensing something strange about the man. The hero nodded.

“Well then, if you'll excuse us. I would like to hear what happened here.”

Our conversation over tea was uneventful.

First of all, the heir's name was indeed Kaen, as I had known. With that, I could be certain that she was the heir.

The professor's name was Rodiven, and he was indeed a professor from Elphon Academy.

He said he had come to the Ramon Mountain Range to obtain monster specimens for his research and happened to meet the father and daughter. In short, he was unrelated to the heir.

Upon hearing a detailed explanation, it seemed that the demon contractor was not related to the heir in any way.

It was the professor who first encountered him, and because of that, the father and daughter were involved.

So that's why you were in a fight.

The heir's father's name was Ben.

I wanted to know his information as much as possible, so I tried to change the subject after we finished talking about the demon contractor. But...

“I'm just an ordinary woodcutter.”

“You seemed to have extraordinary magical skills, though.”

“I used to be a wandering mage when I was young. It’s probably not a very interesting story for the Lord to hear.”

As he didn’t seem to want to talk openly about himself and the heir, my probing failed.

However, it was clear that he was an exceptional person.

His level was high, and he didn’t seem to be ignorant of worldly knowledge like the heir, and there was also no sign of being nervous in front of me.

If you were in front of a giant like a Lord, it would be normal to react like the professor did.

After the conversation was over, I stood side by side with the hero in front of the hut and spoke to her privately.

“This is just a minor thing.”

“...?”

“That man named Ben, I don’t think that’s his real name.”

I raised my head in surprise at the hero’s words.

The hero had the ability to distinguish between truth and falsehood in speech. It must have been a fact judged by that ability.

“Maybe he’s wary of us.”

“It’s more likely to be something else.”

“Hmm?”

“There is no clear black and white boundary between truth and falsehood. The man’s words were not entirely false.”

“What does that mean?”

“There is no absoluteness in names. For example, if a person abandons their birth name and lives for many years under a different name, it is not necessarily their true name.”

I pondered the hero's words and soon understood.

So, the man named Ben could have used multiple names in his life, and Ben could be his current name.

I didn't think much of it. Since I already felt that he was no ordinary man.

“I suppose we should check it out now.”

“Right. But shouldn't we deal with that first?”

I looked at the demon contract who was still subdued by Asher in a place far from the cabin.

“He seems to have nothing to do with the heir, but we should definitely confirm it in case something unexpected happens.”

I approached the demon contractor with the hero.

The hero looked down at the man with a cold gaze and asked, “Tell me your purpose for coming here.”

The demon contractor twisted his body in agony, unable to resist the force, and obediently spoke.

The demon contractor's story was nothing special. He was just a contractor of an ordinary demon, and coming to this mountain range was also just a coincidence.

The hero confirmed that everything the contractor said was true. The contractor had no relation to the heir, as expected.

“Please spare me, Seventh Lord... I'll do anything you want if you spare me...”

I put my hand on the head of the pleading contractor.

I had heard everything I wanted to, so there was no need to listen more. The demons and their contractors were a nuisance that should not be kept alive.

With a thud, I used instant death skill, and the man's body fell to the ground powerlessly. The hero looked at the scene with a slightly surprised expression.

"...That wasn't magic just now, was it? Was it a mystery?"

I didn't answer the hero's question and turned to look behind me. I felt a presence approaching from that direction.

The heir, Kaen, who came out of the hut, was walking towards us.

"Did you kill that man?"

She asked as she looked at the fallen contractor nearby.

I asked her, wondering if she had misunderstood something.

"Yeah, are you feeling sorry for him?"

"No. He almost killed my father. There's no reason to feel sorry for him."

She extended her hand to me.

"I'll say hello again. Oh, that's right. Thanks to you, my father is safe too. Thank you."

"..."

A handshake?

I wasn't sure how to react, but I still shook her hand. She smiled and shook it back.

“I just heard from Mr. Rodiven. So, a Lord of Calderic is one of the kings who rule the entire northern continent. You’re a really great person.”

“...Yeah.”

Asher next to me tried to intervene with a nervous expression. For some reason, I found this situation hilarious, so I smirked and waved my hand at her.

I knew that the heir had lived in the deep mountains since childhood, so I was aware that she might be ignorant of worldly knowledge. I just didn’t expect it to be to this extent.

Moreover, the current heir seemed much more lively than the one I knew from the game.

“So, are these incredibly strong people the Lord’s subordinates?”

“They are subordinates and comrades.”

Kaen changed the target and extended her hand to the hero and Asher, who also received the handshake with a slightly startled expression.

Now, this is the right time...

I looked towards the cabin in the distance. Rodiven and Ben inside the cabin still showed no signs of coming out.

It was a good timing.

The hero, who exchanged eye contact with me, spoke to the heir in a soft voice that I had never heard before.

“Can I ask you one favor, Kaen?”

“A favor?”

“Yes, it’s a simple one. Just hold my sword once.”

Kaen tilted her head in confusion before answering, “Okay. What’s the big deal? But where is the sword?”

Saaaah.

As the hero stretched out her hand in the air, golden light gathered and formed the shape of a sword.

Kaen’s eyes widened at the sword that suddenly appeared before her.

“Here, hold it.”

The hero pointed to the floating holy sword in the air. I could sense her voice trembling slightly.

Kaen hesitated for a moment, then brought both hands to the hilt of the sword.

And...

Flash!

The moment her hands touched the hilt, a brilliant light burst out of the Holy Sword.

Chapter 129: Heir (9)

Chapter 129: Heir (9)

The light that emanated from the Holy Sword filled my vision with brightness, a radiance so intense that I could hardly believe it.

The heir who was startled dropped the Holy Sword in her hand.

Then, the radiance gradually disappeared, and everything returned to normal.

“What was that just now? What did you ask me to do?” the heir asked while looking at the hero.

The hero stared at her like a statue, without saying a word.

I took the Warrior’s place and calmed the perplexed heir.

“We do not wish to harm you, so please do not misunderstand. It’s just a special ability of that sword.”

“An... ability?”

“Yes. It’s a sword that has the ability to determine how well it suits the holder. Some of the greatest swords have that sort of thing.”

The heir mumbled and examined her body. Then, she nodded her head with a slightly uneasy expression and asked, “So, you wanted to check if I’m suitable to use this sword?”

“Yes.”

The heir looked at the hero suspiciously. Her guard was up, which was natural since the sword emitted such a blinding light as soon as she held it.

The heir seemed to be somewhat naïve, but she wasn't completely so either.

Now what?

Anyway, the hero confirmed that she was the heir of the Holy Sword.

I looked at the hero and asked him with my eyes.

The succession of the Holy Sword was not a problem I could intervene in. Therefore, what would happen from now on depended on the hero's decision.

So, what should the hero do from now on?

Would she explain the situation to the heir without hiding anything and seek cooperation? Or should she wait and see for now?

I was already half convinced of what decision the hero would make.

She didn't have much time left. If it were possible, she would want to persuade the heir to take up the Holy Sword right away.

But that was impossible.

The heir's current ability was one thing, but there was an absolute problem before that.

Because there were certain 'conditions' that had to be fulfilled in order to inherit the Holy Sword.

"I'm sorry to surprise you."

The hero apologized to the heir and left after retrieving the Holy Sword.

After whispering to Ashel to take care of the successor, I followed the hero from behind.

“Is she the heir?”

I asked the hero who stood in front of the tree, her holy sword sheathed on the ground, deep in thought.

The hero opened her mouth, her gaze fixed on the leafy branch she was looking up at.

“Yes.”

After answering like that, she paused for a moment and continued.

“Seventh Lord, I am truly grateful to you. For it is thanks to you that I have indeed found the heir.”

“Your expression right now doesn’t really match your words.”

It was only then that the hero looked at me and asked, locking eyes with me.

“Do you know that there are conditions necessary for the inheritance of the Holy Sword?”

I had already provided all the information about the heir. There was no need for me to deny that I knew about it.

“Four trials.”

“.....”

The hero turned her gaze away from me and muttered, “As expected, you knew about it.”

The four trials that the heir must go through in order to inherit the Holy Sword.

They were not related to martial growth, such as swordsmanship or magic, but to inner anguish.

“[The sorrow of losing a loved one.]”

“[The despair of being betrayed by someone you believed in.]”

“[The ugliness of human greed.]”

“[The doubt that arises from what is believed to be just.]”

I recalled the prophecy that the Holy Sword bestowed upon the hero in the game.

To inherit the Holy Sword, the heir must go through these trials and overcome them.

“.....”

It was a difficult and frustrating problem, to say the least.

Finding mystery, deceiving others with false pretenses, it was a different kind of difficulty than the obstacles I had faced so far.

The main story of RaSa was an adventure story in which the player and the heir, along with other companions, embarked on a journey.

The place where the player and the heir first met was the guild building in Marker City, the Kingdom of Lognar.

As the user was performing quests, they coincidentally took on a request with the heir who had a mutual interest.

From there, the relationship leads to an epic adventure with many companions, and along the way, the Heir will encounter many events that will naturally fulfill the requirements for succession.

To pass on the Holy Sword to the heir.

The easiest and most reliable way to achieve this was to follow the game's story as it was.

But that was impossible.

Because of my actions up to this point, the main story of the game had already become twisted beyond repair.

I had already solved some of the problems that the player was supposed to solve in their adventure with the heir, and even now, meetings that should not have happened have occurred.

If I were to faithfully reproduce the game's story, the fact that the heir appeared at this point would be completely off-track.

However, I had no choice in this matter.

I was forced to become one of the Lords of Calderic and collect mysteries to survive in this place, and this had already had a significant impact on this world.

What if the butterfly effect prevented the heir from appearing at the time and place where the player first met her?

Then I might never be able to find out where she was.

In this situation, what should I do to faithfully reproduce the game's story?

Should I forcibly find her companions again and embark on another adventure?

It's an impossible story.

The bond between the player, the heir, and the companions they met later was a complex and tightly woven relationship that was built up through countless coincidences, catalysts, and events.

Furthermore, I could not look into or control the heir's heart.

Even if I were to follow all the game's episodes faithfully, there would be too many variables, and there was no way to reproduce the main story as it was in the current situation unless I became a god.

In addition, finding other companions was also a headache, as many of them might be doing something else at this point.

Therefore, there was only one way.

In a way that is different from the main story of the game, new catalysts must be created to satisfy the conditions for the heir to inherit the Holy Sword.

...But how?

The hero was probably thinking the same thing.

Death of a loved one, betrayal, human greed, justice.

The heir was just an ordinary girl who grew up with her father in the mountains.

How could she overcome such pain and become someone who could endure it?

I had been thinking about it for a long time, but there's no clear way.

Should I artificially set the stage and place the heir to it? Like a play?

I doubted it would be possible, but before the question of whether or not it was possible, it was also humanly impossible.

Suddenly, a movie came to mind. A movie where the main character was trapped in a giant set from birth and lives as if it's the real world, and everyone is tricking him...

"So, what are you going to do?"

I asked the hero again, but there was no answer.

After a while, the hero spoke up.

“I have never thought deeply about the problem of succession. Finding the heir has always been a daunting problem for me.”

“...”

“That’s why I don’t know. I don’t have an immediate solution now, either.”

The hero must have also thought about what I had thought.

But that would be an unacceptable option for her, no matter what. She wouldn’t even consider it.

“Now that we have found the heir, maybe a new prophecy will come down from the Holy Sword. For now, I plan to wait a little longer.”

The hero said that and gently gripped the hilt of the Holy Sword.

But despite what she had hoped, there would be no more prophecies coming down from the Holy Sword.

I knew that, but I didn’t say so. Both the warrior and I needed time to think about our future plans.

For now, it would be best for us to stay here and try to get as close to the heir as possible.

“Strange people.”

Back in the cabin, Kaen plopped down at the table, across from Rodiven, who was still sipping his tea.

She asked him, fidgeting, “Where did Father go?”

“He went upstairs a little while ago,” Rodiven replied, lowering his voice as he glanced at the front door. “By the way, did you talk to them outside?”

“Yes.”

“Can I ask what you talked about?”

“It was nothing special. We just shook hands and exchanged greetings.”

At the mention of shaking hands with the Seventh Lords, Rodiven let out a sigh.

There was a considerable distance between the image of the Lords in his common knowledge and the Seventh Lord he met in person. At the very least, they were not the kind of people one could share a cup of tea with or exchange a casual greeting with.

Recalling their conversation earlier, Rodiven guessed what the Seventh Lord’s motives was.

He had claimed to be here simply in pursuit of the demon contractor, but Rodiven hadn’t bought it, of course.

Perhaps it was just her imagination, but Rodiven felt that the Seventh Lord’s gentle demeanor was more directed at the father and daughter than at him.

... I wonder if the Seven Lords’ true purpose has something to do with them?

Of course, even if that were true, there was nothing Rodiven could do about it.

He was lost in thought again when he heard Kaen spoke up.

“Mister, can you tell me anything more about the world outside the mountains?”

“Hmm?”

“Calderic, Santea, and other major powers that you have mentioned. Please tell me more about them.”

At her request, Rodiven let out a dry chuckle and nodded.

“Alright. Where should I start?”

He then proceeded to explain the four major powers of the continent, including Calderic and Santea, as well as their leaders, and, of course, the demons.

Kaen listened with great interest.

“The Seventh Lord is the newest ascendant to the throne, and he is famous for murdering his fellow Lord, the Sixth Lord – the Tyrant.”

“Why did he kill him?” Kaen asked.

“I’m not sure and I don’t think it would be a very good idea to ask him directly,” Rodiven replied, regretting that he brought up the topic upon seeing Kaen’s curious eyes.

“Kaen, you don’t know much about the outside world, so you can speak comfortably with him, but Calderic’s Lords are really dangerous individuals. They’re monsters who can destroy a country with their power alone.”

“They must be incredibly strong,” Kaen exclaimed.

Of course, the concept of a country was not very meaningful to her.

“They don’t seem like bad people, though, although it was kind of weird to ask me to hold a sword all of a sudden.”

“A sword?”

Kaen shook her head.

“No. More than that, I thought you said you were a professor at some kind of archive?”

“It’s not an archive, it’s an academy,” Rodiven corrected her.

“Yes, the Academy. What’s that for, and what does a professor do?”

Rodiven let out a small sigh before answering.

“It’s a place where they teach something, be it swordsmanship, magic, or knowledge. And a professor is someone who teaches.”

Kaen nodded as if she understood.

“If a professor is a person who teaches, what is the person who learns called?”

“They’re called students. Thousands of kids your age learn from different professors, and they share their learning with each other.”

Her eyes sparkled with interest at his words.

Chapter 130: Heir (10)

Chapter 130: Heir (10)

Ensuring that the heir fulfilled the requirements to inherit the Holy Sword.

It was already an incredibly difficult task in itself, but there was a more pressing issue to solve first.

How should we put her in that position?

We needed to get the heir out into the world outside these mountains before we could start anything.

I realized that it wasn't just a matter of convincing the heir.

The ambiguous issue was the existence of the heir's father, Ben.

Even in the game, the heir was obviously very reluctant to talk about her father.

It wasn't hard to figure that out. Could something have happened to her father in the intervening years between now and then?

Otherwise, there seemed to be no reason for her to venture out of the mountains, no reason for her to be reluctant to talk about her father, and no reason for her personality to be a bit darker in the future than it was now.

And if that were really true, it was obvious what that change was. The attack of the demon contractor, which we prevented with the intervention of the hero and I.

I couldn't say for sure, but it was the best guess I could come up with at the moment, given the evidence.

Putting that aside, the father was the only family member the heir had.

The heir didn't seem likely to easily leave her father behind and go outside of the mountain range alone, and the opposite was true as well.

So, unless we were going to kidnap the heir by force, not only she but also her father, needed to be persuaded.

The hero is probably struggling with this by now.

I asked Asher, who was standing behind me.

"Asher."

"Yes."

"Do you have any good ideas about the inheritance of the Holy Sword?"

I had already shared all the information about the Holy Sword and its heir with Asher, so she should understand the current situation.

Asher tilted her head slightly with a confused expression.

"I'm sorry. I'll try my best to think of something."

"No, it's fine. I was just asking."

I couldn't think of anything either, so I didn't expect Asher to come up with any ideas.

I let out a small sigh and lay down on the grass.

As I lay there with my arms behind my head, I noticed Asher's expression in my peripheral vision.

There was something strange about her expression, as if a shadow had fallen over it.

“...”

When did Asher start acting like this?

It must have been around the middle of our journey with the hero.

I couldn't figure out why. I had a vague feeling it wasn't just because she was uncomfortable in the hero's presence.

I decided to address the issue with Asher and opened my mouth.

“Asher.”

“Yes?”

“Have you been feeling a bit strange lately, or is it just me?”

I didn't want to beat around the bush and decided to ask her directly.

Asher took a small breath and hesitated for a moment. There was definitely something going on.

“No, Sir Ron. I...”

“If you want to pretend it's nothing, go ahead. I believe you, and there's nothing wrong with that.”

Asher's eyes trembled.

“Just know that you don't always have to be composed or unshakable in front of me. I never expected that from you.”

I said that and turned my head again.

If she didn't speak up even after saying that, there's nothing else to do. I didn't want to force her to speak up.

After a moment of silence, Asher spoke up with a suppressed voice.

“I couldn’t tell you because it was too pathetic of a reason.”

“...?”

Pathetic?

I said, tilting my head.

“There’s nothing new about that. I’ve seen your pathetic side many times.”

“Excuse me?”

“Forgetting to put salt in the stew, secretly petting Ti-Yong, or making a pouty face... or...”

“Um, yes?”

Asher stumbled over her words as if she had malfunctioned.

“Just kidding.”

She seemed so crestfallen that I tried making a joke, but her response was extreme.

She blushed until her face was completely red, as if my joke had shocked her beyond belief.

“Whatever the reason, you don’t have to worry about disappointing me. Just tell me.”

Asher calmed down and returned to her usual state, letting out a sigh.

“I started feeling unsure about how I could be of help on our journey.”

There was no need to ask why she felt that way.

The hero was already an uncomfortable presence for her because of what happened to her tribe, and now, the other even became a collaborator.

...Ah, come to think of it.

That's right, I guess that's when it started.

The conversation with the hero, when I comforted her and told her that she was the only one I could rely on right now.

Asher seemed to have felt a sense of doubt after hearing that conversation.

If that was the case, then this guy really was firmly mistaken about something.

“Do you remember the conversation we had in the archmage's dungeon?”

“.....?”

“I talked to you about what I want and my purpose, and you willingly agreed to help me.”

As I slowly stood up, I looked straight at Asher.

“Those were my true feelings that I spoke out loud for the first time, the first true words I've ever spoken to anyone.”

“.....”

“Do you understand, Asher? You were the first one. Think about what that means. And stop having such pathetic thoughts.”

It had nothing to do with one's power or force.

In this lonely world, Asher was, and always would be, the one person I could rely on.

Asher stood there motionless for a while and soon nodded her head with a blank expression.

“Yes...”

I thought it was serious, but it wasn't that big of a deal after all. Anyway.

I brushed off my clothes and stood up from my seat.

I could faintly hear the hero talking to the heir in the distance.

Aindel, the hero, watched Kaen wield a wooden sword in the courtyard.

She had gone inside the cabin, and now she was back out in the courtyard, practicing her swordsmanship.

“.....”

The movement of the sword she drew one after another, the balance of her body, and the movement of her muscles.

Everything was perfect, without any flaws.

She was wielding a perfect sword that she could exhibit at her current level.

One could tell at a glance whether it was the fruit of hard work or a natural talent bestowed by heaven.

A genius.

Kaen was the heir of the Holy Sword. So it was not surprising, but she was the latter. It would have been more surprising if she was anything less.

“You're observing quite closely.”

Kaen stopped swinging her sword and turned her gaze to Aindel.

Although Aindel was the one who was in the yard first, and it was Kaen who began to swing the sword in front of her, Aindel offered an apology.

“I’m sorry for the intrusion.”

“It’s not an intrusion.”

With her sword hanging from her shoulder, Kaen cleared her throat and asked.

“You’re Aindel, right? You’re also a swordsman, aren’t you? Can you tell me how my swordsmanship looks?”

“It’s absolutely excellent.”

“Really? It’s not just empty words?”

“It’s the truth. I have no reason to speak empty words.”

Kaen exhaled and shrugged her shoulders before sitting next to Aindel.

“By the way, why did you ask me to hold that strange sword and see if it suits me? What am I supposed to do after confirming if the sword is suitable for me?”

“To find a new owner for the sword.”

“A new owner...? Why?”

“Because my days of holding that sword are numbered. It is too precious to be buried with me in my grave.”

At those words, Kaen looked at her in surprise.

“What, did you catch some incurable disease?”

“You could say that.”

“If it’s an illness, my father can cure all sorts of things. Should I tell him about it?”

“Unfortunately, it’s not the kind of illness that can be treated. I will just appreciate your concern.”

“But, still...”

Kaen was about to say something more, but stopped, sensing an unrecognizable determination in Aindel.

“So, am I suitable as the owner of that sword? It seemed to glow brightly for some reason.”

Aindel shook her head.

“I’m not sure about that yet.”

“I’m sorry to hear that.”

Kaen spoke cautiously as she watched her expression.

“If there’s anything I can do to help, please let me know. I’ll do my best.”

Aindel smiled faintly.

“Then I have a few things I’m curious to ask you.”

“Of course, ask me anything.”

“It might sound strange, but why are you living alone with your father in this deep mountain forest?”

There was no immediate answer to her question.

Looking away and scratching the back of her neck, Kaen finally spoke.

“Well, there’s no particular reason. I’ve been living here with my father for as long as I can remember.”

“If there’s only one memory that I have from outside the mountain range, it’s that my father saved me when I was dying and brought me here. Even

that is fading from my memory, and I don't remember it well. Whenever I ask my father, he always avoids answering."

Aindel looked at her with a strange expression. Did that mean the man named Ben wasn't her real father?

"Have you ever thought about going outside the mountain range?"

Aindel changed the subject as she noticed Kaen looked uneasy. She had to take this girl to the outside world if she wanted to her to inherit the Holy Sword.

But she didn't have the slightest desire to force her to go.

Unless the situation became so urgent that it couldn't be delayed any longer.

She knew, and understood, the reality of sacrificing the little people for the greater good.

But she had no intention of passing on the responsibility if the heir refused to become the owner of the Holy Sword of their own will. That was the reason she was the hero.

"Well... I'm not sure. But I am interested in the outside world."

Kaen started to talk excitedly.

"I only know about it from books or stories my father told me. Places like cities where a lot of people gather, the Santea Magic Towers where all kinds of magess gather to study new magic, and adventurer groups that travel around the continent looking for ancient ruins."

"Yeah, there are things like that outside."

"And Calderic, where you came from, seems like an interesting place, too. The Lords who rule there are of different races, right?"

Aindel nodded, letting her words sink in.

Still, it was a good thing that she had an interest in the outside world. If she had no interest at all, convincing her would have been quite difficult.

“The most interesting thing is the academy that Mr. Rodiven told me about.”

“The academy...?”

“Yes, the academy. Or was it the Arcadia? Anyway, it’s a place where a lot of people my age gather to learn all sorts of things. They learn swordsmanship, magic, and gather to do research together.”

Aindel looked at Kaen with a strange expression as the other continued her story.

If she listened closely, her story was centered more on the idea of people coming together to do something than on the place itself.

Chapter 131: Heir (11)

Chapter 131: Heir (11)

Before long, the sun was setting, and night was falling over the mountains.

“...So, by the way, would it be alright for us to settle down here for a while?”

Since I had no intention of leaving this place until I resolved the heir issue, I asked Ben for his permission.

There was no real justification for staying here, but it was easy to come up with one. It was to search if there were traces of another demon contractor around.

Ben didn't seem to mind and readily gave his permission.

“Do as you wish. However, there are no rooms available in the cabin for three people...”

“We'll be staying outside the cabin, so it doesn't matter.”

I had grown tired of homelessness during my journey here, so it was not a problem at all.

We settled ourselves a little away from the cabin's courtyard.

After finishing dinner, I had a conversation with the hero.

“So, have you thought about how to take the heir with you?”

The hero, who was staring intently at the blazing campfire, raised her head.

“We don’t have much time. We can’t stay here indefinitely.”

“I know.”

“Do you have any plans to tell everything as it is? I can’t see any other way.”

After all, it was something that had to be done, eventually. The heir couldn’t inherit the Holy Sword without knowing any facts.

“If there really is no other way, then yes, but once it’s said, it can’t be taken back. I’d like to think about other options first.”

The hero’s words were correct. Given her lack of basic knowledge about the world, it was hard to predict how she would react if the hero brought up the whole Holy Sword and heir thing.

“Putting that aside, do you have a plan for how to fulfill the conditions of succession?”

“No... I don’t. That’s an even more difficult problem than convincing her.”

I glanced at the hero, subtly gauging her reaction.

“What about artificially creating a situation to fulfill the conditions of succession?”

“I don’t think it’s possible. And even if it were, I have no intention of doing such a thing.”

The hero responded firmly.

Seeing the prompt response, it seemed that she had indeed contemplated the matter.

Artificially setting up a situation to fulfill the conditions for inheriting the Holy Sword.

That’s what it meant.

Forcing the heir to create companions, build bonds with them, sacrifice them, create rifts, trample upon their hearts and emotions, and bring about despair...

It's like you're messing with their lives and destroying them.

While the heir needed a lot of experience and adventures, we couldn't force it upon her.

"Even if the invasion of demons and the resurrection of the Demon King are imminent, are you saying you wouldn't do it?"

"Yes."

Even if she were to utter the worst possible future, the hero's resolute gaze showed no wavering.

"If that time comes, I don't care about the succession. I will personally end everything and head towards Altelore."

"....."

Altelore, the land of demons.

The land of the sealed Demon King, the Archdemons guarding him, and countless high-ranking demons and monsters.

The hope of succession was the only thing holding the current hero, who had little time left, together.

If even that hope crumbled, she had no other choice.

At that time, she would undoubtedly cross into the territory of demons and seek the end, just like in the game's story.

After a brief silence, the hero spoke again.

"Still, through our conversation, I feel like I've learned a bit about the heir."

“Is that so?”

Earlier, the hero was having a conversation with the heir, and I was also listening attentively from a distance.

There didn't seem to be much content. Wasn't the heir excitedly talking about the world beyond the mountains?

“That child seems to be interested in the outside world. I felt like she especially wanted friends.”

“That's right. It seems she has only been in these mountains since she was young.”

After hesitating for a moment, the hero spoke.

“So, I had a thought...?”

“What is it?”

“Well... for the child to fulfill the conditions of succession, they need to experience a wider world and feel many emotions and realizations. To do that, they would have to leave these mountains, meet many people, and build connections with them.”

“That's true.”

“As a somewhat suitable method, I thought about the Academy.”

...The Academy?

I couldn't help but be surprised by the sudden mention.

“When I talked to the heir, she seemed particularly interested in the Academy.”

“She must have heard about it from that Rodiven fellow.”

“Yes. Anyway, it’ll be easier to convince her if it’s something she wants for herself.”

“No, wait...”

What on earth was she talking about?

“So, you’re saying you’re going to get the heir into the Academy and fulfill the requirements for the Holy Sword there?”

The hero nodded.

“I thought about it once. There are many children of the same age at the Academy. Wouldn’t it be the optimal place to make friends?”

“Well, that may be true, but still...”

Indeed, it was almost like the Academy itself, the place where young talents gathered, so the hero’s words were not wrong.

But was it not a bit too much to expect the fulfillment of the succession conditions there?

“Well, do you have any other ideas then, Seventh Lord?”

“.....”

Of course, I didn’t have one.

I fell into brief contemplation.

Upon further consideration, the hero’s opinion had its own reasoning.

When thinking about the path toward succession step by step, the top priority task was for the heir to create comrades.

And the best way to create comrades was to enter a group.

The question then becomes, ‘where is that group?’ ... There were certainly no other options that came to mind.

Is the Academy the best we can come up with?

If the heir truly wanted it, it could also serve as a good excuse to take her outside the mountain range.

I felt somewhat dumbfounded and shook my head.

“Of course, it’s unlikely that she’ll be able to fulfill the conditions to inherit the Holy Sword there, but I can’t think of anything else.”

“Well... now that I think about it, it doesn’t seem entirely illogical.”

Of course, there was a crucial problem.

Was it even possible for a significant event worthy of fulfilling the conditions of the Holy Sword to occur in a place like the Academy?

And before that, was it possible for the heir to build such a deep bond with a friend there?

But that uncertainty was a problem that couldn’t be solved even without the Academy.

That’s why the hero spoke in that manner.

“Well then, how about trying to persuade the heir using the Academy as an excuse, just as you said?”

After organizing my thoughts, I spoke.

“First of all, if we can take the heir out of the mountain range, that alone is sufficient. As for the rest, let’s give it some time and think it over a bit more...”

The hero nodded as if in agreement.

“Not only the heir but also her father needs to be convinced. I’ll try to have a conversation with him as well.”

Yes, that’s also a problem.

He had raised the heir alone in this mountainous place, cut off from the outside world.

To persuade him, one probably needed to understand the reasons first. It didn’t seem likely that someone like him would willingly send his daughter out into the world.

As the day brightened, I went straight to find the heir with the hero.

“Do you have any thoughts about entering the academy?”

She looked at me with a puzzled expression while sweeping the yard.

“What is entering the academy?”

“It means becoming a student of the academy. Living there with other students and learning various things.”

The hero explained calmly.

“Why are you suddenly making such a proposal to me?”

“Because I don’t think your talents are worth spending all your time in these mountains. As I said yesterday, your talent is very great. If you go out into the world and learn more, you will be able to fully realize your abilities.”

In this way, the hero and I laid out various stories to persuade the heir.

However, for some reason, she only responded with a strange expression and a bland reaction.

“Well, I am interested... but leaving home is a bit...”

Feeling somewhat disappointed by her underwhelming response, I asked.

“Do you want to keep staying in this mountain range?”

“It’s not that. I’m just not sure.”

The heir scratched her head.

“I’ve never really given much thought to going outside before.”

“.....”

“But I don’t feel inclined to do it right now. My father is here too. So, I’m going to decline.”

With that unsuccessful persuasion, we returned to the area where we spent the night.

The hero and I stood side by side in silence, thinking.

Should we try to convince her father first?

From what she said, her father’s presence was part of the reason she didn’t want to leave the mountains.

Originally, we planned to persuade the heir first and then persuade her father, but would it be better to change the order?

“Shall we go and talk to her father first?”

The hero seemed to have a similar thought and spoke.

“Yes, let’s do that...”

That’s when it happened.

I lowered my head, catching a glimpse of a sparkling light from the bracelet on my wrist.

“...?”

This bracelet was something I had instructed the butler to bring before we set off to the mountains.

I wanted to receive signals in case anything urgent happened at the lord's castle during my absence.

What's going on?

Receiving a signal at this moment meant that something had occurred.

I had no idea what it was. Something related to the Overlord? Or something involving demons?

Of all times...

I furrowed my brows. I didn't want to go back to the monarchy without the heir at this point.

However, it was unimaginable that they would send a signal for something that wasn't even important, so I couldn't help but check.

“What is that?”

I looked at the hero.

I didn't have to worry about the heir's safety since she's here.

And I trusted her. She wouldn't try to stab me in the back while I was away. If she wanted to do that, she could have done it a long time ago.

“I think I need to return to my territory for a moment.”

“To Enrock? Is it something urgent?”

“Yes.”

The hero nodded in response to my words.

“Understood. There’s nothing to worry about the heir, so go ahead. I won’t betray your trust.”

Trust, huh.

The fact that the hero said it directly made me feel that she also considered me somewhat of a comrade.

Thus, Asher and I rode on the wyvern to return to the Seventh Lord’s territory.

“Let’s go home.”

I returned to the monarchy as quickly as I could.

The atmosphere in the castle seemed no different from usual. It didn’t seem like they were attacked or that the Overlord or other Lords had come.

As soon as we arrived at the castle, the butler came out to greet us.

“Welcome back, my lord.”

“What’s the matter?”

I demanded to know what the hell was going on, and the butler’s expression became serious.

What came out of his mouth was unexpected, unrelated to the Overlord or the demons.

“It’s related to the Earth Hill Kingdom.”

“...?”

“About a fortnight ago, Kajor declared war on Earth Hill, and the Eighth Lord has given Kajor military aid.”

“What... did you say?”

Chapter 132: Siege of Gadfalk (1)

Chapter 132: Siege of Gadfalk (1)

On the north-western border of Earth Hill, Gadfalk Fortress on the Lowalf Plains.

An iron-walled fortress where many troops were stationed as it was a key area of conflict with Kajor.

“.....”

The soldiers on the ramparts looked at the plain beyond the fort with pale, weary eyes.

The Gadfalk warriors, reputed to be the bravest in the kingdom, were nowhere to be found in the gloomy atmosphere.

Even the commander of the fortress, Masto, who had never lost his fighting spirit in any desperate and terrible battle, had nothing but despair in his eyes.

It had to be.

A black army that covered the whole vast plain.

It was almost impossible to maintain morale even in the face of such a disastrously large army.

Why is the Black Sea Empress...?

Commander Masto could not understand the situation. It was the same for everyone present.

It was only a short time ago that the Seventh Lord had declared his support for Earth Hill at the Neutral Conference.

But why was the Black Sea Empress, the same Lord of Calderic, sending troops to support Kajor?

Even though they were both Lords of Calderic, everyone knew that these Lords rarely cooperated with each other... Wasn't this the same as the Eighth Lord openly fighting the Seventh Lord?

If not, could it be that the Seventh Lord had a change of heart?

Then it would make sense that the Eighth Lord didn't care about his promise to Earth Hill and supported Kajor. Yes, that was more likely.

...Whatever it was, it's a disaster.

Whether it was the former or the latter, her will was clear just by seeing how the Eighth Lord directly mobilized her forces.

Even if all the power of the kingdom was gathered, there was no way that the strength of this fortress could stand against that army. Now, this Gadfalk Fortress was in a more precarious position than a candle in the wind.

Although the enemy forces were still camped on the plain, the fortress would collapse like a sand castle the day this army advanced.

"Your Excellency, Commander! His Majesty has arrived!"

Commander Masto took his eyes off the plain and nodded heavily at the news delivered by the sergeant.

The reason why the enemy forces were still waiting without invading was because of the final negotiations with Earth Hill.

Besides Longford, the king of Earth Hill, only a few knights and mages entered the fortress.

In order to be as quick as possible, they arrived at the fortress before the troops from the capital.

“How is the situation?”

In response to Longford’s question, Masto gave all the details in a miserable voice.

“Envoys from the enemy camp have come twice. One demand was that there would be no invasion if we completely relinquished our rights to the Lowalf Plains and withdrew the north-western border to Kabaon.”

“.....”

Longford’s eyes trembled.

Because Kajor’s demands were just as absurd.

Complete surrender of rights to Lowalf, plus a withdrawal of the border to Kabaon. It was far worse than what they had demanded at the last meeting.

If they accepted all the demands, even if this invasion was over, Earth Hill could no longer maintain the balance of power with Kajor.

It was then...

“Your Excellency! It’s an emergency!”

“What’s going on?”

“There’s a huge monster in the enemy camp...!”

Longford and Masto quickly walked up to the wall to see.

A gigantic monstrous spider, almost as tall as the fortress, was slowly approaching the fortress alone.

“That’s the power of the Eight Lord. But why...?”

“Someone is riding the spider.”

The troops were concentrated on the walls where the spider was rapidly approaching. But it didn't look like it was about to attack.

Soon, the spider that had been approaching the fortress stopped at a small distance from the fortress wall.

Someone was riding on top of the spider, and he was also from the Eight Lord's side.

He had a human appearance, but his entire body was covered with the skeleton of a blackish insect, and several antennae were wriggling on his forehead.

“Hello, King of Earth Hill. You arrived at the fortress sooner than expected.”

Hearing these words, Masto had no choice but to bite his lip.

Of course, the Eight Lord was fully aware of the movements within the fortress. He didn't know what her intentions were, but she must have acted immediately after learning that the king had arrived here.

The other one immediately mentioned why he had come here.

“I came as an envoy to deliver the message of the Eight Lord.”

“A message...?”

“If you wish to further negotiate Kajor's requests, the Lord has said that she will allow you to meet face to face. If you agree, I will lead you now.”

Longford's eyes widened.

Masto, who was standing next to him, understood the words a beat too late and was shocked.

“Wait, does that mean the Eight Lord is here in person?”

The emissary looked at Longford with a broad smile, as if wondering what he would do.

Longford furrowed his brow and pondered, then replied.

“Okay. I want to meet the Eight Lord right away.”

“Your Majesty!”

Masto and the others immediately stepped forward to object, but Longford shook his head.

“Don’t you know? If the Eight Lord has an ulterior motive, there’s no reason to do such troublesome things.”

If the Eight Lord was here in person, there was not the slightest hope for them. The power differential was literally between heaven and earth.

Taking him hostage? Why would she do that?

If she set her mind to it, she could destroy the entire fortress and slaughter all of their forces in the blink of an eye.

Still, sending such an envoy really meant giving them a chance to talk.

It would be ridiculous to call it a chance, but now he had no choice but to grab at least this thin straw.

“Then we will accompany you, Your Majesty.”

The aides stepped forward and spoke sternly. When Longford looked at the envoy, the other just shrugged.

“It doesn’t matter.”

So Longford and some of his aides climbed onto the monstrous spider the emissary was riding.

Cooong. Cong.

When the spider reached the place where the Eight Lord's army was, the bugs and insects split to make way for them.

On the other side of the army, where the spider stopped, there was a huge tower of insects that stood in the middle of the army.

“Come this way.”

After getting off the spider, Longford followed the emissary into the tower.

Inside the tower, there were things like spider webs and foils that were tangled with insects to form walls.

Among them, there were also glowing bugs that emitted light from time to time. They were the light that illuminated the dark space.

Kiyi...

Seeing them wriggling in all directions, Longford swallowed his disgust and continued walking. The grotesque cries of the insects seemed to eat away at his mental strength.

After such a long walk, they finally reached their destination.

“Lord, as you commanded, I have brought the king of Earth Hill.”

The envoy bowed his head into the dark room and moved to a corner to stand.

Lying on a huge, unfamiliar cocoon hanging in the air, she slowly rose to her feet.

Lordford and his aides nervously watched the scene.

“Welcome, King of Earth Hill.”

As she opened her mouth, the cries of the insects that had been buzzing inside stopped immediately.

The air, which had been sticky and disgusting, added a chill that seemed to suffocate them.

The Eighth Lord of Calderic, the Black Sea Empress.

She looked down at Longford and lifted the corner of her mouth.

The Black Sea Empress supported Kajor.

It was then that I received a detailed report from the butler on the current situation of Earth Hill.

“They say they fought for the fifth day in the fortress on the Lowalf Plains...”

“Yes. Apparently, when the King of Earth Hill arrives, he will give an ultimatum.”

The Lowalf Plains, it was the same as in the last conference, and it was the territory of Earth Hill that Kajor persistently coveted.

Was that why Kajor invaded Earth Hill?

But why the Eight Lord?

What I didn't understand was the Eight Lord's intervention.

Why was the Eight Lord suddenly supporting Kajor?

Did she have something to do with Kajor? At least, as far as I knew, she did not.

“Why did the Eight Lord support Kajor?”

The butler answered my question.

“We haven’t figured out the exact reason yet, but it seems Kajor was the one who first persuaded the Eight Lord.”

Persuaded? How?

I wondered at first if the Eight Lord was inciting Kajor for her own benefit, but that didn’t seem to be the case.

What price was Kajor willing to pay for the Eight Lord’s decision to intervene in the war?

She should know that I decided to support Earth Hill during the Neutral Nations Conference...

Of course, she was under no obligation to follow my will.

But to do so without telling me was tantamount to openly tearing her face with me.

I couldn’t say that the Eight Lord and I were on good terms, but what the hell was this about?

“You said they were still in confrontation?”

“Yes. But once the King of Earth Hill arrives, we don’t know what will happen.”

“Did the Eight Lord move directly?”

“I’m sorry. I also haven’t found out that yet.”

The butler bowed his head apologetically.

“What is the exact purpose of Kajor? Is it Lowalf?”

“Yes, it is.”

“Do you think Earth Hill will abandon Lowalf?”

“Given the nature of the King of Earth Hill, I think it is likely.”

It was a question that didn't even need to be asked.

What if he didn't surrender? Would he still stand against the forces of the Eight Lord?

It's not a war at all. It's like a fight between an adult and an infant.

What should I do?

I was worried.

Why the Eight Lord supported Kajor was unimportant.

What if Earth Hill surrendered to Lowalf and Kajor's invasion ended there?

If Kajor got what they wanted, there would be no more armed demonstrations.

Attacking Earth Hill without any justification would be suicide.

And if that was the case, there was no need for me to rush. I didn't have to clash with the Eight Lord right away, and I could settle things later.

What's more, now even the hero had come out of her sleep. If the hero intervened, she could blame Kajor without me suffering anything.

...It was the intention of the Eight Lord that made me feel uncomfortable.

It wasn't her intention to support Kajor, it was her intention to openly go against me.

I don't know why she moved and did that.

It's probably no coincidence that the invasion began while I was away.

Even if Earth Hill were to surrender, would the invasion really end there?

Kajor must know that what they're doing was useless once I got the news and I intervened, right?

This is not a good feeling.

For some reason, I had an intuition that I shouldn't be so casual about the situation.

Wouldn't the Eight Lord assume that I would hear the news and intervene directly on the battlefield?

Or was it that she was confident enough even if I were to go to Lowalf right now?

The Eight Lord might be in Lowalf. I was reluctant to face her directly, but there was no other way.

"I'm going to Lowalf right now."

Together with Asher, we immediately climbed onto Ti-Yong's back.

Chapter 133: Siege of Gadfalk (2)

Chapter 133: Siege of Gadfalk (2)

“There must be a lot of things you want to ask me, right? King of Earth Hill. This is a place prepared for you, so feel free to ask.”

Contrary to the atmosphere, the voice of the Black Sea Empress was innocent, as if she was welcoming a guest.

Longford asked her, trying to regain his composure.

“I want to know why the Eight Lord is supporting Kajor.”

It was the most curious question for him and the key to all current situations.

The Black Sea Empress smiled and answered.

“You’re asking for the obvious. There are only two reasons why a war is waged. Either you hate the opponent, or there is a benefit to be gained from the war.”

“...”

“I personally don’t have any reason to hate the Earth Hill Kingdom. So, what do you think it is?”

“Profit...”

“The King of Kajor has given me what I wanted. Troop support is the price I pay for it. Do you think you can give me what I want?”

Longford bit his lip softly.

If he gave her what he wanted, she could switch sides right away like flipping the palm of her hand. It was clear from her words that she treated this situation of the two kingdoms as a trivial joke.

It was a joke that meant nothing to her in the first place.

Longford couldn't even fathom what she wanted or what Kajor had given her.

Why would a Lord of Calderic...

"What did Kajor give the Eight Lord?"

As if she had no intention of telling that, the Black Sea Empress just smiled without answering.

"...What can I do to end this war?"

Longford asked in a more subdued tone.

There were no other options. He came here thinking of surrender from the beginning.

If they resisted, it wouldn't be war, it would only be carnage.

All that's left was to figure out her intentions as much as possible and end the war with minimal loses. So, their kingdom could still have a future.

"Didn't Kajor already tell you the condition? Recognize that the rights to Lowalf Plain belonged to Kajor and retreat the border to the Kabaon region."

"I think the Eight Lord has a reason for calling me here separately."

If all he had to do was accept the conditions, there would be no way they would arrange this meeting. It shouldn't have been made just for him to answer the Eight Lord's question.

The Black Sea Empress stared at Longford, tearing up the corners of her mouth and laughing.

“Aren’t you ignorant? Commenting on things as if you have read my inner thoughts when you’re just a human is kind of unpleasant. To the point that I want to tear your tongue out.”

“.....”

“Huh, I’m kidding. Anyway, that’s the correct answer. I have something else to suggest to you.”

The lines of the cocoon stretched, and her body slowly descended.

When she landed on the floor, she took a step. Longford and his aides were utterly daunted by the direct approach of the Eight Lord.

The Black Sea Empress, who stopped right in front of Longford, whispered in his ear.

“Don’t surrender and fight until the end, King of Earth Hill.”

“.....!”

“Let the fortress collapse, build a mountain with the corpses of soldiers, and fight foolishly until the blood drenches the entire earth red.”

The king had goosebumps all over his body.

For a moment, Longford didn’t understand what she was talking about.

The Black Sea Empress, who whispered to his ear, continued with a single smile.

“Then, I’ll stop right there.”

“That’s... what...”

“The fortress will be destroyed, and the Lowalf Plain will be taken over by Kajor, but it will all end there. After the war, I will personally stop Kajor from coveting Earth Hill. A promise made in my name and honor.”

If they didn’t surrender and fight until they were annihilated, then she would put an end to the war.

“What the hell are you talking about, Eight Lord?”

Naturally, Longford couldn’t understand it.

Why did the Black Sea Empress make such a bizarre and terrible proposal?

“Didn’t I just tell you the reasons why people waged war?”

“Do you mean it’s more profitable for us to resist than to surrender?”

“Whoops, that’s not it. As I said, I already got the benefit I wanted.”

“Then, why?”

“Actually, there is one more reason.”

The Black Sea Empress laughed.

“Profit is also profit. But there’s a person, a very arrogant person, who I don’t like. I wanted to check his reaction. What will happen if I do something like this?”

Longford could at once guess who she was talking about.

A being related to this war, a human, a person worthy of her doing all this.

Seventh Lord.

During the last meeting, the Seventh Lord defended Earth Hill and prevented Kajor from declaring war.

To interpret her words, it meant that she had bad feelings for the Seventh Lord, so she was trying to provoke him by touching Earth Hill.

It was only for that reason.

For such trivial reasons, she was casually telling him to make this place a mountain of corpses.

“The Seventh Lord, he is an erratic person in many ways. However, if one would look at his actions, there is a strange corner. Like the circumstances of the killing of the Sixth Lord. Does he have a cold-blooded personality? Or does he have useless things like pity in his heart? What would be his reaction once I completely annihilate your forces?”

Longford trembled with a feeling of rage and contempt that was hard to contain.

As always, to these absolute beings, these little kingdoms were just chess pieces that could be played with and destroyed at will.

“Do you think I will accept such an offer?”

“Ah, it doesn’t really matter if you leave the fort before the war begins. Your life isn’t particularly important, anyway.”

“I’m not saying that I will leave... Eight Lord. I will not leave my subjects behind and run away to save my own life.”

“Is that so? Anyway, I’m not trying to force you.”

The Black Sea Empress turned back and climbed onto the cocoon again and lay down, wiggling her antennae.

“However, if you refused my offer, your kingdom’s future will be even more bleak. Kajor, who occupied Lowalf, will raise an army again after some time. They might ask for reinforcements from me again like this time.”

It was nothing more than a threat to accept her offer despite saying that she had no intention of forcing him.

Since the person who uttered the threat was none other than a Lord of Calderic, it was unknown how much he would pay if he refused the offer, but...

“There’s nothing to think about. I refuse.”

“Huh, is that your immediate answer?”

For an instant, the Black Sea Empress’ expression hardened coldly, then returned to smiling.

“You don’t have to decide here. I’ll give you time to go back and think about it.”

“My answer will not change.”

“I told you to think about it, so do it, worm.”

With the sudden change of tone and murderous spirit emanating from the Black Sea Empress, Longford felt his consciousness go numb.

The Black Sea Empress, who had gathered her energy, waved her hands as if this was the end of the conversation.

“You’ve come this far, so it’s better not to end it in vain. I’ll give you a day’s time. Go and think it through.”

Returning, Longford walked on the ramparts and took in the view of the interior of the fort.

Gadfalk Fortress, one of the most important strategic points in the kingdom, had a history of well over half a century.

For a long time, the valiant warriors had defended the frontier by completely blocking external aggression.

It's not just a place with people who fought with spears and swords.

This was not only a fortress to block the enemy but also a city at the same time. The difference with other cities was only its good defense. Inside the walls, inside the fort, there were people living ordinary lives.

“.....”

A deep wrinkle formed between Longford's brows.

Because it was a sudden invasion, there was no time or energy to evacuate the people.

To accept the proposal of the Eight Lord was to sacrifice not only the soldiers but also the civilians.

It was to annihilate all life living in this fortress.

It was an absurd choice that didn't need any thinking, but the last words of the Eight Lord still lingered in his head.

She was a Lord of Calderic. If he ignored her proposal, would they be able to handle the aftermath?

Memories suddenly went back to the distant past.

The war that started with Kajor's massive invasion, and the battle of Kagosh Castle in the fierce final call.

The previous king gave up on them, who had endured desperately for 15 days and waited only for reinforcements. Instead, the king's army raided the enemy's camp.

It was a lethal move that caught Kajor off guard, and in the end Kajor returned with only a heavy blow and the war ended.

...Longford was unable to ask his father, who successfully commanded the war and defended the kingdom.

Did you really have to give them up?

If support was sent to Kagosh Castle, thousands of lives there could have been saved, even if the war was prolonged. The end of the war was the result of sacrificing them.

A king was a being who had compassion, but must constantly know how to adjust that compassion.

He wondered if the former king, who always gave such teachings, had the slightest pity for those people he chose to sacrifice.

Returning to the present, Longford was also put at a crossroad.

What kind of king was he?

Was it a king who would sacrifice tens of thousands of lives for fear of an absolute being, or a king who would bring a greater crisis to the kingdom by failing to make a calm judgment?

If this war could not be ended now, could only disaster wait for them at the end?

After finally understanding his father, the former king, he smiled bitterly.

Another day passed, and Longford summoned Commander Masto and gave orders.

“Send an envoy to surrender to the enemy camp. We do not want war, and we will accept all conditions.”

“.....”

“Also, send messengers to the reinforcements coming here. They should have almost arrived by now. Do not enter the fort, and tell them to immediately withdraw from the spot and return to the capital.”

Those words puzzled Masto.

Surrender was a natural decision. There was no way they could do something like resistance in a situation where even the Eight Lord was directly on the battlefield.

What was curious was the order to send back the reinforcements who had come down from the capital following the king and not enter the fortress.

If they were going to surrender anyway, there was no reason to make the reinforcement suffer by not giving them a chance to rest.

“Your Majesty, may I ask why you are issuing the withdrawal order?”

Longford answered.

“Just in case.”

Understanding the meaning of those words, Masto gulped.

“I will follow Your Majesty’s will.”

“I will remain here until everything is sorted out. Now go and lead the troops.”

In this way, the envoy that would deliver their decision to surrender rode to the enemy camp.

About half a day had passed, and the sun was about to rise in the middle of the sky.

Woo woo woo.

A huge horn echoed through the fort several times.

Climbing up the rampart with the commander in confusion, Longford saw the scenery unfolding before his eyes.

“That, the enemy...”

Kajor's army was slowly advancing towards the fortress, led by the Black Sea Empress' insect army.

Longford closed his eyes tightly.

....*At last.*

It was not the case when Kajor's attacked the fort directly. Doing that was a considerable burden for Kajor as well.

The existence of the hero who they never knew would break her seclusion, and the declaration made by the Seventh Lord during the last meeting.

Besides, it was unknown if Santea knew about this in advance, but Kajor would have to bear a considerable burden for purposely attracting the Eight Lord.

This could have been just a bloodless war by accepting Earth Hill's surrender, but directly attacking the fortress like this was a cost Kajor had to bear later in many ways.

But in the end, it was their choice.

Was this Kajor's will, or was Kajor merely a puppet of the Black Sea Empress?

"Unleash the amplification magic."

Longford, who opened his eyes again, ordered the mage preparing for battle.

"Listen, all soldiers! This is the last message from Longford Bamon, the king of Eath Hill, to you!"

"What the Eight Lord of Calderic wants is the annihilation of this fortress! Currently, the Eight Lord is sitting directly behind enemy lines with her forces and have no intention of accepting surrender."

“So, open the back gate, and get as many people out of the fort as possible before the enemy arrives! The same goes for the soldiers! Those who risk their lives escort them and get out together! It’s not dishonorable! This is not war. It’s one-sided massacre!”

When he said this, everyone had blank faces.

Abandon the fort and run away? Those were the words that came straight from the mouth of their king and no one else.

“But those who remain must remain! To gain even a little time to evacuate, those who will die and fight to the end, prepare for battle right away! It is not a meaningless death! I will also remain in the fortress and fight until the end!”

In the midst of the quiet desolation, after a while, a huge shout erupted from the soldiers.

“Fight to the end with His Majesty! We are the warriors of Gadfalk!”

No one got scared and ran away as if this was only natural.

Only the minimum number of people to lead the civilians moved to the dwelling.

Commander Masto and the other aides looked at Longford with dark eyes.

It seemed that their king had already designated this spot as his tomb.

But they couldn’t say anything.

What could they say? Please reconsider? From now on, leave the soldiers who were ready to fight to the death and run away?

As long as the situation was like this, they wouldn’t be able to stop the king.

Coo coo coo.

As the rumble of the ground grew louder, a huge army approached as if it were about to devour the fortress.

Soon, the advance stopped with the fort in front.

Among them, the king of Kajor stepped forward with his escorts.

“King Longford! Did you choose to fight until the end, despite us giving you a chance to surrender?”

Longford glared at him and stood on top of the castle wall to answer.

“It’s disgusting to say that when you already received our letter to surrender.”

“Are you not completely sane? I don’t know what you’re talking about. It’s already too late. Gadfalk Fortress will perish because of your stubbornness.”

Longford replied coldly, without raising an eyebrow.

“We will fight and die here today, but your choice of involving a Lord of Calderic will one day lead Kajor to destruction.”

The king of Kajor snorted and raised his hand.

Black waves rushed towards the fortress.

When he heard the news of Kajor’s invasion, Tair was in a city outside of the capital.

It was not a simple invasion, but a slaughter involving the Eight Lord.

The first thing that came to Tair’s mind after hearing the news was the words of the Seventh Lord before they parted.

He said that if one day Tair faced a crisis he could not handle, he should ask him for help.

But it was too late. The enemy had already invaded the kingdom.

If he sent a messenger to the Seventh Lord to ask for help, it would have already been over by the time it arrived. The Seventh Lord would have heard the news anyway, so it was meaningless.

After moving straight to the capital, Tair found out that his father had already left for Gadfalk Fortress, followed by the first prince, Lucas, with reinforcements.

Tair also followed them to the fort.

On the fifth day after leaving the capital, just before reaching the fort, Tair was able to catch up with the reinforcements.

“...Tair? Why did you come all the way here?”

“Why are you in command of the army?”

“Of course, it’s His Majesty’s order. Didn’t you hear the situation at Gadfalk Fortress?”

“That’s not true. Father had already headed for the fortress, there was no way he would send Brother to bring reinforcement.”

Lucas couldn’t answer and just frowned.

“It’s just Brother’s own decision.”

“It’s none of your business.”

“That’s right. I’m not in a position to tell my brother what to do.”

It was when the two brothers were in the middle of arguing...

“Your Highness, the messenger!”

A soldier on horseback reached them and delivered Longford’s message.

After reading the message, Lucas let out a small groan.

“Immediately withdrawing and returning to the capital... what is this?”

I felt something unusual about this message.

The remaining distance to Gadfalk Fortress was only half a day.

What the hell was going on in the fort right now?

“Your Highness, this is...”

Turning to Lucas, who was immersed in his thoughts, Tair said.

“Brother, please return to the capital. I will go to the fortress.”

“Don’t speak nonsense.”

“You read the message, so you should understand. If something goes wrong with you, what will the royal family do?”

“Ragmas and Seri are there, and Uncle Durak is also at the castle. Now I should worry about Father’s safety, not the royal family. Are you still asking me to go back?”

“Why are you twisting my words like that again?”

“Stop talking. I’ll have to see the situation in the fortress with my own eyes.”

Looking at Lucas, who seemed to have made up his mind, Tair let out a small sigh and mounted his horse again.

“I’ll go too.”

“You don’t have to go to the fort. Go back to the capital.”

“I won’t. Brother can’t interfere with my actions either.”

Lucas sighed and said nothing more. Because even if they left the other here, he would probably just keep on chasing them anyway.

He looked back at the soldiers around him and shouted.

“...I will take responsibility! Continue to advance towards Gadfalk Fortress!”

Acrid smoke, red blood. Desperate shouts and screams.

“Stop them! Enemies are trying to focus their attack on the North Gate!”

“Open the defense barrier! If the inner wall is pierced, everything will be over!”

In that chaos and frenzy, everyone fought desperately.

The soldiers stabbed the insects that came up to the wall with spears, and the knights took charge of the strong enemies while going around the wall. The mages lined up in the rear and used defensive and offensive magic alternately.

While the insects climbed the walls, the Kajor's forces tried to break through the gates, and water-based weapons bombarded them without a break.

However, it was a battle that could not be won in the first place, both quantitatively and qualitatively.

In an instant, the battle line was destroyed and was put on the defense by the army coming from all sides – a mixture of insects and humans.

Chow!

After cutting off an insect that was chewing on a soldier's head, Longford wiped the body fluids from his eyes.

Poisonous ingredients seemed to stiffen the facial muscles, and the field of vision in one eye gradually darkened.

He immediately used healing magic and let out a tired breath.

He looked around. The sight that welcomed him were the knights surrounding a giant mantis monster being cut in half.

He saw a mage who collapsed with a spear thrown into his neck while casting magic, and he saw soldiers falling down when the castle wall collapsed by bombardment.

He saw people getting eaten by some insects that had broken through the defense and intruded into the fort. They were civilians who could not get out and fled far away from the wall. He saw a woman torn to death trying to protect her child from the insects.

...It was a long-forgotten sight, tainted by false peace.

The armies of the Black Sea Empress in the distance were still so vast that they seemed to cover the whole land.

Longford knew. He knew that if she had launched an attack properly, the fortress would have been destroyed long before.

Perhaps she wanted them to try as hard as possible. They were only able to survive up to this point because she only sent a portion of her army.

Of course, that didn't change the fact that the situation was the worst. At this rate, it was only a matter of time before the fortress fell.

A shout rang in Longford's ears as he tried to move his creaking body again.

“...The reinforcements are here!”

The reinforcements breaking through the enemies through the western wall and entering the fortress.

Longford muttered in a voice mixed with a sigh as he watched the scene.

“Why...?”

He must have told them to retreat and not set foot on the fort.

With the arrival of the reinforcements, the morale of the soldiers rose instantly.

They tore through the enemies and soon fully entered the fortress. They participated in the battle in earnest.

“Where is His Majesty?”

“He’s in the northern wall!”

“Clear the way! Go ahead and protect His Majesty!”

Lucas and Tair advanced to the northern wall, cutting through the swarm of insects as they moved.

Several giant insects came towards them. The knights who were covering them split up and dealt with the insects.

“...Ugh!”

At that moment, the tentacles wielded by the insects wrapped around Lucas’ body.

Tair immediately jumped in and swung his sword to cut off the tentacle.

Lucas, who fell and rolled on the ground, suddenly raised his head and shouted.

“Avoid...!”

Waaa!

A huge magic bombardment that flew in from somewhere hit the spot where they were.

Tair's body, which was bounced off by the shock wave, floated to the outside of the castle wall.

Tuuk!

Lucas barely caught him as he fell.

Insects flocked towards them as they straddled the edge of the wall. The surrounding soldiers who tried to stop it exploded along with the insects in the bombardment that flew in again.

“Stop...”

Tinnitus rang in his head. His eardrums ruptured, leaving his left ear deaf.

After barely getting out of range, Lucas managed to regain balance and pulled Tair up.

The two brothers sat down for a while, took a breath, and looked around the battlefield.

Amid piles of broken wreckage and corpses, insects and humans mixed and killed each other again and again.

It was a real mountain of hell. They wondered if the demon attacks they only heard would be similar to this.

Even with the arrival of the reinforcements, the situation was only slightly alleviated.

Clutching the hilt of his sword, Lucas opened his mouth softly.

“If not now, I won't have time to apologize to you anymore.”

Tair turned to Lucas.

“What are you saying all of a sudden?”

“What change would it do now, and how can I expect you to trust me... I’m sorry, Tair. I really didn’t know anything.”

At those words, Tair was silent.

A story from the past that no one had tried to talk about until now.

Lucas and Tair were siblings from different mothers.

But bloodlines didn’t matter.

They had been good friends since they were children, they sincerely cared for each other. They were brothers with a deep friendship more than anyone else.

Until the day when Lucas’ mother, the first queen, tried to poison Tair.

Tair was a genius.

He’s good at swordsmanship, magic, and academics.

Originally, it was common for Lucas, the eldest son, to inherit the throne, but Tair’s talent was enough to make the first queen feel a sense of crisis that Tair could become the successor, overcoming such convention.

She was the first queen who had extraordinary greed for power.

She treated Tair kindly, telling him to regard her as his mother, as someone who had lost his mother early on. But behind the scenes, she planned to assassinate him.

After drinking the poisoned tea and collapsing, Tair was fortunately found by a servant and his life was saved.

The first queen’s thorough poisoning attempt was eventually caught.

She was dethroned by the enraged King Longford. However, starting from that incident, the relationship between brothers could not go back to the way it was before.

After some time, Tair left the castle without saying anything, leaving only a letter.

“...I never thought that you’re not my brother just because we have different mothers. Ragmas treated you bluntly, but his heart probably wasn’t different.”

“I know. Why wouldn’t I know that?”

Lucas smiled bitterly.

“On that day, with what feelings did you leave the palace? I want to hear your honest answer at least once. Did you doubt me and our younger siblings? Or did you resent us?”

Tair, who was silent, shook his head.

“Brother, I never doubted or resented anyone.”

“.....”

“Rather, it was the opposite. I thought my older brother and younger siblings would resent me for dethroning your mother. That’s why I left. No matter what, we won’t be able to go back to the way it was. So, it’s better to let time solve everything.”

“...You had an outrageous idea.”

“I did. If I had any regrets now, it was that I realized too late that my decision was wrong and I returned too late.”

Tair raised his broken body.

Lucas, who had been staring at the scene happening in front of them, stood up as well, stepping on the ground with his sword.

“I wish I could have properly apologized to our younger siblings as well.”

“That’s why I told you to go back to the capital. From before, your stubbornness couldn’t be broken.”

“Haha... isn’t it the same for my brother?”

Tair, with a bitter smile on his darkly shaded face, muttered.

“If we can return alive, I would like to sit down and talk on the garden at the back of the palace, just like before.”

Lucas nodded with a similar expression.

“... Yes, if we can return alive.”

It was just empty talk. The two knew each other well.

Unless a miracle happened, there was no way they would survive this hell.

It was the moment when the insects started climbing the wall again and rushed towards the two brothers...

Flash!

A dazzling white light suddenly covered the sky.

The huge glow soon split into dozens of branches and rained down towards the outskirts of the fortress.

Kwangwagwagwagwak!

Earth-shaking vibrations shook the fortress.

More than half of the insects that were rushing towards the fortress exploded in that blow.

“.....!”

Slicing down the bugs, Tair and Lucas looked up at the sky.

Before they knew it, they saw something flying over the fort. It was a huge black wyvern.

Tair, who spotted those riding on the back of the black wyvern, stood blankly and muttered involuntarily.

“...Seventh Lord.”

In the darkest moment, a miracle really came.

Chapter 134: Siege of Gadfalk (3)

Chapter 134: Siege of Gadfalk (3)

“...Perfect timing, Seven Lords.”

The Black Sea Empress lifted herself lazily from her cocoon.

In her enchantingly shining eyes, she caught sight of the Seventh Lord who had arrived on the battlefield.

I glanced down at the demolished fortress with a cold gaze.

I had wondered, and it turned out my speculation was correct.

The King of Earth Hill had chosen to fight rather than surrender?

To my knowledge, he wasn't the type of person to make such foolish decisions.

No matter what, it was incomprehensible that he would continue the war against the forces of the Black Sea Empress.

There was only one possibility remaining: he surrendered, yet the other side did not accept it.

The reason I came straight from the capital to this place was because I anticipated such a development.

...But in the end, I was too late.

The war had already begun before my arrival, and many people had already died.

Earth Hill seemed to fight desperately, but they couldn't withstand the power of the Black Sea Empress.

Still, I should be thankful that I had arrived before the fortress was completely destroyed.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

Asher, who had drawn her sword and waited for the next command, immediately responded.

Half of the insects that were approaching the fortress were already dead from the blow Asher had just struck.

She was ready to rush down and sweep away the remaining insects at a moment's notice.

For her, such a massacre was unacceptable.

“Go and protect the fortress.”

Nodding, Asher leapt from Ti-Yong's back toward the fortress, swinging her sword.

A huge storm of sword energy once again swept across the fortress's outskirts, annihilating the insects.

As I watched that scene, I shifted my gaze.

Towards the military force of the Black Sea Empress, visible in the distance.

Apparently, she had mobilized only a fraction of her forces to attack the fortress.

There were massive insects that could have brought down the walls of the fortress if they wanted to, but they didn't move a muscle.

“...”

As I examined her military force, I soon realized.

Massive towers filled with enormous insects stood throughout the army.

These towering structures were known as “Mother Towers.”

They represented the central power of the formidable military force commanded by the Black Sea Empress.

Deep within the roots of the Mother Towers, reproductive nuclei merged with the queen body. Through the magical energy supplied by these nuclei, the queen could continuously breed the insects without limit. This was the concept designed within the game.

There's 31 of them.

The current number of visible Mother Tower was 31.

Considering that she wouldn't have more than 40 queen bodies, it was safe to say she had almost fully mobilized her power. Naturally, she would also be present in this place right now.

I understood its implication.

She brought such a large number of queen bodies to attack just one Earth Hill fortress?

It was beyond display, an action that defied common sense. There was no reason to bring the queen bodies here in the first place.

She was prepared for my arrival.

She was assuming I would arrive here on time.

If I hadn't come or if I had been late, Earth Hill would have been completely destroyed.

I was confused about the intention of the Black Sea Empress.

Did she intend to attack the fort until I arrived? Or was her goal to draw me in from the start?

If it was the former, I didn't understand why she would risk a conflict with me to take Earth Hill.

What exactly did she hope to gain by going to such lengths in this war?

In the case of the latter, I also couldn't comprehend the reason behind it.

If she was going to drag me into this, what was the point?

I knew that she harbored negative emotions towards me since the last emergency meeting.

However, if that was the reason she mobilized such forces to engage in a fight...

In any case, she could not kill me. Likewise, I could not kill her.

In the first place, engaging in battle without the permission of the Overlord was prohibited. Even if it came to combat, if she had the intention to kill me, she won't be able to handle the consequences.

What are you thinking?

That's when it happened.

I could feel immense magical power flowing from the towers of the Black Sea Empress.

Wooom...

I watched with an impassive expression as a massive entity began pouring out from all the towers.

They were swarms of insects.

An enormous horde of insects attacking the fortress, numbering hundreds of times the visible overwhelming amount.

An endless stream of them, clustered together and soon darkened the sky. It was like the word 'scourge' had taken on a tangible form.

As the massive insect legion gradually approached this way, the voice of the Black Sea Empress resounded on the battlefield.

"If you can stop it, then try to stop it, Seventh Lord. You have to protect the people in the fortress, right?"

Her voice carried a mix of amusement and mockery.

...Finally, I could grasp the intention of the Eighth Lord.

It seemed like this crazy woman really did all this to provoke me.

"Ha."

I let out a hollow laugh as I gazed at the towering waves crashing down from the sky.

If I didn't stop it, the fortress would be swept away in the blink of an eye.

I didn't want to collide with the Black Sea Empress if possible.

Until I came here, my intention was to avoid collisions as much as possible.

After all, I'd already killed the Sixth Lord, and if I continued to clash with others, the Overlord would definitely take action.

However, if the bitch came at me like this, I had no choice.

No, it wasn't that I had no choice, but rather that she really touched my nerves.

“Let's give it a try.”

Descending a little lower, I immediately activated my blood magic.

The legion of the Black Sea Empress charging from the front was truly overwhelming.

It was completely different from the horde of monsters I faced previously in Hallumenta. It wasn't a scale that could be overwhelmed by just scattering droplets of blood like back then.

Dealing with them in that manner wouldn't even kill one-tenth of them, and they would reach the fortress before I could attack again.

However, I had an idea.

I had constantly contemplated and researched how to efficiently utilize the abilities I have acquired and adapt them to different situations.

Among them, the synergy between instant kill and blood magic was the most important aspect I focused on, of course.

I hadn't had the opportunity to utilize it in actual combat yet, but I had prepared methods to confront enemies of this scale and magnitude.

A method to strike a much wider range with much less blood, compared to scattering droplets of blood.

The blood emitted from my body swirled like mist.

A transformation in nature from a liquid state to a state no different from gas.

In order to make this possible, I tirelessly trained in the art of blood manipulation, enhancing my ability to control blood.

The unleashed blood magic quickly spread in all directions, centered around me.

However, this level of skill was still insufficient to confront such a formidable force.

I focused my super regeneration ability solely on the regeneration of my blood to continue spreading it.

This was one of the achievements I obtained through research and training. I could also concentrate my regenerative ability on specific parts of my body.

Ahhh!

In no time, a massive blood mist formed, extending hundreds of meters in radius.

I gazed indifferently at the horde of insects swarming towards me, flying into hell.

“This is...”

Commander Masto was at a loss for words.

The woman was moving like a beam of light across the battlefield, single-handedly slaying the insects.

With each swing of her sword, hundreds of insects were swept away, instantly reversing the dire situation of the fortress on the verge of collapse.

Longford also gasped for breath as he stared blankly at the Wyvern floating in the sky.

“...It’s the Seventh Lord of Calderic. The Seventh Lord has come to aid us.”

He felt an indescribable mix of emotions, then belatedly regained his composure.

When the opportunity arose, they had to quickly overwhelm the enemy and exterminate them. Of course, the majority of the enemy forces had already been decimated by the powers of the Seventh Lord.

“Your, Your Majesty! Over there...!”

At that moment, a change occurred in the force of the Black Sea Empress far in the distance.

A terrifying number of flying insect monsters began to pour out of the insect towers.

In an instant, they covered the entire sky, gradually closing in on the fortress.

An overwhelming force, as if the previous attack was only a joke.

The soldiers, who had briefly been filled with hope, once again found themselves overwhelmed by despair as they gazed upon the scene.

Asher also paused the battle momentarily and looked up at the sky with a stern face.

A moment later, a thick cloud of blood rose from the Seventh Lord atop the wyvern.

It quickly grew to a size comparable to the approaching forces of the Black Sea Empress, covering the surroundings of the fortress.

“...What is he trying to do?”

The Black Sea Empress, who had been calmly observing the situation through the eyes of her insects, narrowed her eyes. Blood mist?

She had guessed that the Seventh Lord could manipulate blood, but she didn't know the extent of his abilities.

On the other hand, it appeared to resemble the ability of the Sixth Lord he had killed.

Perhaps poison or mind control? She naturally assumed so.

“If it’s just that, I’m disappointed.”

The insects under the control of the Black Sea Empress were inherently poisonous.

Born of her magic, poison didn’t work on them.

The same applied to mental domination. The insects were no different from a part of her; they were completely bound to her control from birth.

Even if the Seventh Lord employed some trickery, it would be impossible to take away her dominion over them.

“Now, come at me. No matter what you do, my children will destroy this fortress much faster.”

The Black Sea Empress sneered and observed the situation.

And at that moment, the insect legion completely entered the Seventh Lord’s Blood Mist territory.

“...!”

The Black Sea Empress stood up in astonishment.

In an instant, all life signals of the bugs were severed.

The bugs within the Blood Mist descended rapidly towards the ground.

I raised my eyebrows as I watched the beetles falling to the ground like scattered ashes.

That's that, I guess.

Instant Kill was an ability whose trigger condition was met just by somehow touching the opponent.

It didn't matter if it's a drop of blood or a thousandth of a drop, it just needed to make contact somehow.

That's why even this was possible.

The moment I let the bugs into the blood mist, my victory was sealed.

“Let's descend, Ti-Yong.”

I assessed the situation in the fortress and descended to the ground.

I had defended against the attack, but I had no intention of ending it here.

The Black Sea Empress had crossed the line.

She must face the consequences.

“Sir Ron.”

Asher, who had suddenly approached, quickly scanned my body. She had a worried expression.

Considering how it must have appeared as if I had collided head-on with the horde of beetles, it was understandable for her to be concerned.

“I'm fine.”

I had lost quite a bit of blood, but thanks to super regeneration, I was okay. I still had some energy left.

I turned to Asher and gave her an order while surveying the fortress.

“You keep guarding the fortress.”

“What about you, Sir Ron...?”

“It’s not over yet.”

Leaving Asher and Ti-Yong behind, I approached the formidable force of the Black Sea Empress visible beyond the horizon.

By repeatedly using space leaps, I quickly closed the distance.

Where could the Black Sea Empress be? Well, she’s probably inside the largest tower, I suppose.

As I focused my senses on that place with my super sensory, I could clearly sense a massive presence.

I had no intention of dealing with her.

I slowly activated my blood magic as I approached her presence.

Ssshhh.

The blood mist that started emanating from my body once again slowly engulfed the insects.

Even the small creatures the size of humans and the giant insects as big as castles died instantly upon contact with the blood.

They were not my targets.

Continuing to disperse the blood mist, I moved closer to the nearest tower. The surrounding insects couldn’t approach and continued to perish.

“...Stop!”

Once again, the voice of the Black Sea Empress resounded.

Unlike before, when it sounded cheerful, it was now a voice filled with confusion.

For the Black Sea Empress, the queen body was the core that maintained her immense forces.

But why did she have only a few of them? The reason was, of course, simple.

It was hard to make.

That's why I had the intention to kill all the queen bodies here.

Shudder.

As the blood mist spread densely throughout the tower, the immense magical reaction vanished, withering away like rotten timber.

After dealing with one, I immediately changed direction towards the next target.

The surrounding insects swarmed more intensely than before.

Some of them shot spider-like webs or magical blasts from a distance, but all their efforts were in vain.

Those who came closer died in the blood mist, and long-range attacks had no effect on me.

I continued to evade and avoid attacks using space leaps and floating veil.

It was when I was traversing the camp of the Black Sea Empress, killing the sixth queen body...

“Seventh Lord!”

The Black Sea Empress flew into the air from a towering structure in the distance, exuding a vibrant aura of vitality.

I unfolded the floating veil to block her attacks and then leaped away into the distance.

Although she immediately pursued me, I ignored her and continued with my tasks.

I managed to block and evade her attacks while systematically killing each of her queen bodies.

She didn't realize it, but of all the Lords, the Black Sea Empress had the worst matchup with me.

Her boasted overwhelming force was ineffective against my instant kill.

It wasn't even possible for her to maintain a simple protective shield. She was not a mage like the King of the Dead.

The insects that grew stronger by absorbing her magical power might have had high durability against most attacks, but my ability to instantly kill rendered that defense meaningless unless she prevented contact altogether.

Moreover, excluding her military strength, the Black Sea Empress had the lowest personal ability among the Lords.

Her reason for being a Lord was solely due to her control over this massive force of insects.

When considering personal abilities alone, she possessed lower physical abilities than the Tyrant, who was known to have the lowest level among the Lords.

Furthermore, she hadn't even learned how to handle her body like the Tyrant did.

Despite her persistent pursuit, it was not particularly difficult for me to fend her off.

“Stop, Seventh Lord! Stop! Halt!”

One day, by mere chance, she became a monster with intellect and overflowing power.

That's the essence of the Black Sea Empress.

The abilities she boasted meant nothing to me.

The Black Sea Empress, fuelled by anger, shouted for me to stop. But more than half of her queen bodies had already perished.

She suddenly changed direction as if she thought it wouldn't work like this, and charged towards the fortress.

"If you don't stop, I'll slaughter the humans in the fortress, you damned human!"

As I tried to shift my focus since it was unavoidable, someone stopped her from rushing towards the fortress.

Asher.

It was Asher who stopped the Black Sea Empress.

With her unique abilities, she faced off against the Black Sea Empress, covering her entire body in a pale white color.

"You arrogant woman, how dare you!"

Amidst dozens of exchanges of blows, Asher blocked the Black Sea Empress's fist with a sword and was knocked away.

Even though the physical abilities of the Black Sea Empress were weak, Asher at level 90 was still no match for her.

"....."

However, Asher quickly got up and blocked the path of the Black Sea Empress once again.

Though it may not be enough to defeat her, it seemed possible to delay her for a while.

With a mocking tone, I spoke to the Black Sea Empress.

“Just wait for a moment. I’ll quickly deal with the rest and come to you.”

As I said that and teleported, the Black Sea Empress had no choice but to hurriedly chase after me.

Of course, nothing changed.

I soon killed all the remaining queen bodies while she watched.

“Ah, ahh...!”

Amidst the piled-up corpses of insects, the Black Sea Empress sat on the ground, partially losing her mind.

I stood in front of her, looking down at her.

She glared at me with a face mixed with despair and anger, as if she couldn’t wait to kill me.

“It... It wasn’t necessary to go this far. Just because of those insignificant humans... You, you...”

“Eighth Lord.”

I whispered to her, getting close to her face.

“Do not dare to oppose me.”

“...”

“If you ever pull such a stunt again, it won’t matter if you’re a Lord or whatever. I will just send yourself straight to the side of the Tyrant.”

The Black Sea Empress trembled slightly but didn’t respond.

She must have clearly understood the difference in power now.

I left her behind and headed towards the fortress.

Asher approached me and bowed her head.

“Thank you for your hard work, Sir Ron.”

I nodded my head.

“You too. Thank you for your hard work.”

On the way to the fortress, I noticed a group of panzers gathered on one side. It was the Kajor Army.

As I purposely approached them, they reluctantly made way with pale and weary faces.

In the midst of them, I saw the King of Kajor.

When I stopped in front of him, he knelt down slowly with an expression mixed with helplessness and despair.

“Please... spare me, Seventh Lord.”

Ignoring him, I continued walking the path I was on.

I intended to leave the decision on how to deal with Kajor to Earth Hill.

Finally, when we arrived at the front of the fortress, people crowded in front of the broken gates.

Earth Hill’s soldiers were in a pitiful state, some even on the verge of death.

There were familiar faces among them. The King of Earth Hill and Tair.

Without anyone speaking, they all stared at me with vacant expressions.

As I surveyed them, I opened my mouth and made a declaration.

“The war is over.”

...Waaaaaah!

There was silence, then a tearing roar erupted from them.

Chapter 135: Decision

Chapter 135: Decision

I looked down at the bustling people moving around.

Inside the fortress, the able-bodied were moving the wounded, while outside, the King of Earth Hill was taking his soldiers to subdue the surrendering Kajor army.

The Black Sea Empress seemed to have disappeared without a trace, leaving behind countless insect carcasses on the ground.

Ti-Yong wandered around here and there, rummaging through the insect corpses. Perhaps it didn't think they were edible, as it eventually returned to my side.

With the situation somewhat cleared up, I stood side by side on the ramparts with the King of Earth Hill.

"What do you plan to do with the King of Kajor?"

He spoke cautiously. "We'll see how things play out and then decide."

No matter how the war started by the King of Kajor, he was still the ruler of a nation, so it was only natural to be cautious.

Whether to execute him or capture him as a prisoner and negotiate compensation from Kajor, it was his responsibility to decide.

"The Eight Lord will not interfere further in the affairs of both countries. Don't worry and do as you please."

“Yes, thank you very much, my lord.”

I looked around and spoke to Asher.

“Just in case, stay here until the cleanup is complete, Asher.”

“Understood.”

The King of Earth Hill seemed surprised.

“We are unworthy of such meticulous care.”

“No, it’s not over until it’s over. I will leave my escort knight in the fortress until you return to the capital.”

If the Kajor Army, who had failed to assess the situation, were to gather and attack, it could cause unnecessary trouble.

I could see the First Prince’s expression brightened as he stood beside Longford and heard what I said.

I exchanged glances with Tair, then turned away.

Asher asked, “Are you leaving right now?”

“Yeah. I have to return to the mountains.”

I couldn’t stay here until everything was settled.

Especially since I had left the heir behind in a hurry. It should be fine since the hero was there, but...

When I hopped on the Ti-Yong’s back, the King of Earth Hill bowed deeply.

“We have received great grace from the Seventh Lord. I will never forget the kindness you have shown today. If the day comes when I have the opportunity, I will definitely repay the favor.”

Tair and the first prince also belatedly lowered their heads.

I called out to Tair, “Tair.”

“Yes? Yes.”

“You ignored what I said. I clearly told you to ask for help if you encounter difficulties.”

“Yes? Ah, no! I meant to ask for help, but by the time I realized it, it was already too late...”

Tair was greatly flustered by my joking remark.

I smirked and asked, “So you’ll continue staying in the royal palace from now on?”

“Yes, I plan to do so.”

“That’s good.”

I looked at the King of Earth Hill and the first prince in turn, then lightly tapped Ti-Yong’s neck.

“I’ll see you again when I get a chance. I’ll treat you to a cup of tea, or you can come to my territory.”

With a powerful flap of its wings, Ti-Yong soared into the sky. Asher and the three of them quickly shrank to a speck.

As I flew toward the mountain range where the hero and the heir were, I thought to myself.

How will the Overlord react?

However, I didn’t worry too much about that.

This was clearly a fight the Black Sea Empress had brought to me first.

Despite clearly expressing my intentions during the previous meeting, she disregarded them and attacked Earth Hill.

The Overlord had also made it clear that she would not interfere in the war between the two nations.

That's probably why the Black Sea Empress had been able to support Kajor so casually.

Therefore, it was also my freedom to stop her.

If the Overlord questioned me about it, she should hold the Black Sea Empress responsible for her involvement in this war from the start. Otherwise, no party could be held accountable.

Of course, even so, I couldn't be completely at ease.

For the Black Sea Empress, someone equivalent to a single army, to lose almost all of her queen bodies was quite a significant loss of power for Calderic.

The Overlord could reprimand what I did as an excessive response.

However, even in such a case, there was one hidden card. The hero.

This time, Kajor was only able to do what they did because of the absence of the hero.

Anyway, the hero had also mentioned that she would soon reappear officially in the world.

While she was in retreat, there would have been various actions taking place in the royal palace, and there would be many things to sort out.

If the Overlord held me accountable, I could simply sacrifice her a little.

It could be said that I had no choice but to prevent the insane actions of the Black Sea Empress because I had prior information about the hero.

Wiping out an entire nation while the hero just came out of her retreat, it would be a detrimental act for Calderic.

The only thing I had to hide was my relationship with the hero, so there was no reason I couldn't talk about her.

After organizing my thoughts, I moved on to other worries.

There were more important things than the Overlord right now.

So, how should the heir be handled?

By now, the hero probably hasn't convinced her yet...

I put aside my unlikely expectations.

I hope the story progressed even a little.

Kaen took a step forward and brought her sword down.

It wasn't very fast, but the rock it struck snapped in half with a loud crack.

"Like this?"

She asked the woman standing beside her, still in the same stance, and the other nodded.

"Excellent. You're quickly getting the hang of it."

The hero, Aindel, looked at Kaen with bright eyes.

Right now, she was teaching Kaen a bit of the basics of how to manipulate her magic.

What she had just done was just a simple movement, but a flow of complex energy accompanied it within her body.

She already had a strong foundation, and with her talent, it seemed like she would grow quickly no matter what she taught her.

Was she this good because she was the heir to the Holy Sword, or was she chosen as the heir because of her exceptional qualities?

Aindel pondered these thoughts and let out a small sigh.

Rodiven had left a long time ago, and the Seventh Lord had suddenly encountered urgent matters and returned to Enrock.

The only ones currently present here were her and Kaen.

Aindel had also talked to Ben in an attempt to persuade him, but the answer he returned was simple.

“If my daughter truly wants to go outside, I have no intention of interfering. Talk to her directly.”

I thought there would surely be conflict, but surprisingly, he didn’t oppose it.

However, even though the issue on the father’s side was resolved, it was still difficult to persuade Kaen by herself.

Continuing to subtly bring up the topic, Kaen only showed ambiguous reactions.

Since Aindel wasn’t particularly eloquent, this kind of situation didn’t suit her well. It would have been much better to deal with archdemons instead.

“Whoa.”

Kaen, who had been repeatedly swinging her sword, seemed exhausted and collapsed onto the ground.

She, who had been absentmindedly gazing at the sky, suddenly started laughing.

Curious about what was funny, Aindel asked, “What’s wrong?”

“No, it’s nothing, really. I mentioned before that no one has ever come to visit from outside. That’s why I find it enjoyable to do this.”

“.....”

“It’s almost lunchtime. Shall we go hunting together again, Del? If we go deep into the forest, there’s a pink rabbit that comes out. It’s a bit difficult to find, but its taste is out of this world.”

While Aindel was about to bring up the topic of the outside world again, she gave up.

Kaen was an innocent girl.

She approached unfamiliar people with kindness and curiosity instead of caution, finding genuine joy in the small things of everyday life.

The reason why Aindel wanted to take Kaen outside the mountains was not to show her a broader world.

Even if that was not a lie, it ultimately became an excuse.

To create a new hero, to take her place and stop the demons before her time was up.

To put the heaviest burden of all on an innocent child who had lived her whole life in the mountains.

Suddenly, Aindel felt a sense of unease.

Was this truly the right thing to do?

The inheritance of the Holy Sword, even if it was considered the will of the gods, it was not her own will.

The Holy Sword had given her transcendent power, but she had always acted of her own volition.

From the beginning, the Holy Sword only granted power; it never dictated a direction. Fighting against the demons and sealing the Demon King, all of it was her own choice.

Perhaps that's why she's still so unsure.

For the first time, the Holy Sword, which had never commanded anything, revealed its intention. Find the heir.

Of course, Aindel didn't have much time left.

If she was to die like this, with the power of the Holy Sword disappearing and the Demon King resurrecting, the future would be bleak.

She knew the power of the Demon King better than anyone else. Without the divine power of the Holy Sword, nothing would be able to stop the incarnation of that evil. But...

"What's wrong?"

Kaen looked at Aindel with a puzzled expression as she stood there in silence.

Aindel shook her head and pondered.

If Kaen's heart didn't change until the Seventh Lord returned, then it would be necessary to think deeply about her course of action once again.

Life has been pretty good for Kaen lately.

It was because there was a change in the repetitive daily life. The people who came from beyond the mountain range brought vitality to her.

Although everyone else had left, leaving only one person now, Kaen found it quite enjoyable to be with her. They would talk about the outside world, learn swordsmanship together, or go hunting together.

Ben, who was sipping tea at the table, wrinkled his nose and asked when she entered the cabin.

“Did you grill meat outside?”

“Yeah, I ate it with Del.”

“But you didn’t even bring a single piece for Dad, tsk tsk.”

“Well, if you wanted to eat, you could have come out, though there wasn’t enough for the three of us.”

Kaen, who was sitting across from Ben, sipped her tea from the cup.

While she quietly drank her tea for a moment, Ben casually asked her.

“Daughter, do you want to go outside the mountains?”

“...?”

Kaen raised her eyebrows at the sudden question.

“What’s with Dad again?”

“That woman named Del asked me. She wanted to know what you think about going outside.”

“Um... What did you say?”

“It doesn’t matter to me. What’s important is your own will.”

Kaen looked at him suspiciously and asked.

“Is it really okay?”

“Yeah. Well, until when were you planning to live confined to the mountains? When the time comes, you should go out.”

Kaen felt a little perplexed.

Until now, he had always subtly avoided talking about the outside world whenever she asked about it.

But now, he was suddenly asking until when she was planning to live in the mountains.

“Well, anyway, do as you please. You can go to the Academy and make friends your age, or you can wander the world and have adventures. You’ve been taught enough, so wherever you go, you won’t starve due to lack of skills, as long as you don’t act recklessly.”

“.....”

Kaen stroked the handle of her cup with her finger and asked.

“Hey, Father.”

“Yes?”

“I never really thought deeply about it before, but now that we’re talking about the outside world, I suddenly have a curious question.”

“What is it?”

“Why don’t I have any childhood memories? How did you and I end up living here?”

Ben remained silent for a moment, then responded briefly while looking into the distance.

“Generally, people don’t have memories from when they were young.”

“I’m not asking about when I was a baby. I mean, I don’t have any memories around the age of five or six.”

“Well, then. Did you perhaps get a major head injury?”

“Seriously? Don’t twist the conversation like that.”

“Daughter, don’t bother people with unnecessary questions. I already told you that there wasn’t much during your early years. Your mother and I lived a normal life in the city until she was alive, and then we moved to this mountain range.”

“In this mountain where there’s no one but monsters roaming?”

“...Isn’t the air clean and nice here? I had my personal preferences, too.”

Kaen was bewildered and gave up on asking further.

Ben casually changed the topic.

“Anyway, follow your heart and do as you please. If it doesn’t concern me, there’s no need for you to worry.”

“It’s not like I’m particularly concerned about what Father thinks.”

“Tsk, you stubborn child. Finish your drink quickly and get up. Stop indulging in contemplation on your own.”

Kaen snorted, finished the remaining tea, and stood up from her seat.

The day grew dark, and night arrived.

Lying on the bed, Kaen stared at the ceiling, lost in thought.

The outside world...

Outside the mountains, meeting new people, experiencing new things.

It was undoubtedly an attractive story.

But there was something nagging in the back of her mind that made her hesitate.

It wasn’t just the anxiety and fear of leaving the familiar daily routine and the place where she had lived her whole life.

She couldn't quite put her finger on what it was.

“.....”

But it was also true that she was drawn to Del's stories more than anything else.

She was one of the first people she had met who came from the outside world. Moreover, she could tell that Del was a good person.

If she missed this opportunity because of that hesitation, she would surely regret it later.

After tossing and turning for a while, Kaen got out of bed and went outside the cabin.

It was a bright moonlit night, and she looked up at the full moon in the sky as she walked across the yard.

When she reached the place where the fire was visible in the distance, she saw Aindel sitting in front of the bonfire.

Aindel asked her.

“What brings you out in the middle of the night?”

“May I sit for a while?”

“Of course. Do you want some tea?”

“Yes.”

As Kaen sat across from her, Aindel took out a cup and put tea, leaves and water in it.

There was no need to heat it over the fire. The tea inside the cup started bubbling and steaming directly in her hands.

Kaen hesitated as she held the tea and then spoke.

“Del hopes that I could go beyond the mountain range and enroll in that academy, right?”

Aindel looked at her with a slightly surprised expression.

“Yes.”

“Come to think of it, I haven’t asked you until now. Why?”

“That’s because... your talent is too precious to waste.”

Aindel hesitated for a moment and then spoke.

“The aptitude you possess is considered a genius by the world. Anyone would find it a waste to let it rot away in these mountains.”

“Hmm... Is that really the only reason?”

“Yes.”

“It feels like there’s a more serious reason behind it for Del. It’s not because if I become stronger, Del wants to pass on her sword to me?”

“Huh?”

She was momentarily taken aback, but quickly understood Kaen’s words and let out a small sigh.

Come to think of it, she made up that excuse when Kaen held the Holy Sword. She said that the sword was a sacred weapon that chose its master.

Kaen unintentionally hit the nail on the head.

“Well, it doesn’t matter what it is. I don’t care about my talent or anything like that. I just...”

Kaen hesitated for a moment, then spoke decisively.

“I think I want to go outside, Del.”

After a few days of traveling through the mountain range, I could finally see the figures of the hero and the heir from a distance.

“Let’s go down, Ti-Yong.”

I dismounted in front of the two of them and climbed off Ti-Yong’s back.

The heir swung her sword, and the hero stood beside her, seemingly guiding her in swordsmanship.

The heir, lowering his sword, looked at me with surprised eyes.

“You’ve returned? I thought you had left.”

I didn’t know what to say, so I raised my hand once in greeting.

When I shifted my gaze to the hero, she spoke up.

“Have you resolved the matter and returned?”

“Yes.”

“Can you explain what happened?”

It felt somewhat awkward to explain in front of the heir, so I glanced briefly at her and she seemed to understand.

“Oh, my father will be preparing the meal, so I’ll go and tell him to make enough for four. I’ll head back to the cabin first, so you two can take your time, and you can teach me after we’ve eaten, Del.”

With those words, she dashed off towards the cabin.

As I watched her retreating figure, I turned my gaze back to the hero and asked again.

“Del?”

“Ah, that’s the name I told her.”

She mentioned that she had given the heir an alias instead of her real name. Her original name was Aindel, so perhaps Del was short for that.

I was about to ask if they had become closer or made any progress with the heir, but I decided to answer her question first.

“Kajor invaded Earth’s Hill territory, and I stopped it.”

“What...?”

I explained the situation slowly to the astonished hero, starting from the incidents at the neutral country conference to the involvement of the Black Sea Empress.

After hearing the entire explanation, she fell into a contemplative silence.

She seemed to blame herself for not realizing such events were taking place while she was unaware.

“So, such a thing happened. I’m sincerely grateful to you for preventing a war, Seventh Lord.”

“I only did what needed to be done.”

The hero glanced at me with a somewhat new look and spoke.

“Wasn’t it a burden for you to clash with the same Lord?”

“No need to worry. But speaking of the heir, did you have any progress?”

I redirected the conversation towards the heir.

I asked, not expecting much, but the warrior paused, then gave a surprising answer.

“Kaen has made up her mind. She’s going outside the mountains.”

“What? Did you succeed in convincing her?”

“I’m not sure if I can say I succeeded in convincing her. She just suddenly changed her mind.”

I was momentarily surprised and unable to continue speaking.

If we succeeded in persuading the heir, it meant we had overcome the first major obstacle.

“How about her father’s side?”

“He didn’t show a negative response. He said he would let her do as she pleased.”

“Hmm...”

After a moment of silence, I asked.

“So, are you really going to proceed as we discussed before? Enrolling her in the Academy?”

“I did tell her that already, but...”

The warrior trailed off, then nodded.

“I suppose I should. I’ve been thinking about it while you were gone, but I can’t think of anything else.”

I let out a small sigh, questioning if this was truly the right decision.

“However, if we enroll her in the Academy, we’ll need to keep an eye on her nearby.”

“That’s true. We can’t just admit her and then leave her alone.”

“I have thought about that as well.”

“What is it?”

“I could either enroll as a student with her, or become a part of the Academy’s teaching staff. That way, I’d be able to watch from the sidelines without too much trouble.”

“What? Is that possible—— ah.”

As I was speaking, I realized something.

With the Holy Sword’s Polymorph ability, she shouldn’t have any trouble doing what she just said.

Hmm? Hold on a moment.

A sudden thought flashed through my mind.

Lost in thought for a moment, I asked the hero.

“Can the polymorph ability of the Holy Sword work on others?”

“It can. Why do you ask?”

The hero looked at me with a puzzled expression.

...Now that I thought about it, this might be a good opportunity.

I quickly organized my thoughts and spoke to the hero.

“If you plan to enroll the heir in the academy, how about I, instead of you, accompany her as a guardian?”

Inheriting the Holy Sword. The four conditions for it.

The death of a loved one. Betrayal. Human depravity. Doubt about justice.

The hero was not a person who could forcibly impose the fulfillment of those conditions onto the heir, and she would never allow it. She had said so herself.

In other words, if I entrusted the issue of succession to the hero... honestly, I couldn't expect any progress.

But I was different.

As someone who knew the future that would unfold better than anyone else, I was determined for the heir to succeed in the inheritance of the Holy Sword by any means necessary.

Of course, I was not capable of resorting to any means or methods solely for the sake of achieving my goals.

However, if necessary, I was willing to artificially create a situation within certain limits.

Suppose, for example, after getting as close as possible to the heir, I deliberately fake my own death.

To ensure the succession of the Holy Sword, I was willing to go that far.

No, if I couldn't even do something like that, then I should just give up on the succession.

I reached the point of considering such thoughts, and I concluded that the Academy was a suitable stage in many ways.

What if I were to enter the Academy with the heir?

I could take control of the situation while blocking the hero's perspective and interference.

It would be much easier and more natural to approach the heir as a friend.

"You instead of me? Why...?"

I answered the hero's question.

"Because you don't have the luxury to do so. You have to find the demon seeds, suppress the demons, and solve the problems that have arisen during

your disappearance. There will be a lot to do. Isn't that right?"

"..."

"You can't afford to let go of all those things just because the issue of succession is important."

She didn't deny it.

She simply let out a faint sigh and said.

"But it's also not my place to irresponsibly burden you with everything. You, as a Lord, must also have many tasks at hand."

I shook my head.

"You may think so, but the truth is different. I have time to spare. The monarchy runs itself while I'm away, and I don't have any specific responsibilities that I need to take care of unless it's an order from the Overlord."

It sounded very pathetic when I said it, but it was all true.

The hero looked at me with a somewhat ambiguous gaze.

"Is that so?"

"Yes. So why don't you leave the matter of the heir to me, it's something that either you or I will have to do. We cannot speak to anyone else about the succession of the Holy Sword anyway."

The hero couldn't easily respond to that.

I could sense her thoughts and spoke.

"Although we have a cooperative relationship, we haven't built enough trust between us yet."

"It is not that. I do not doubt you, Seventh Lord. I just..."

“No, I understand your feelings. So, I will make a firm oath here.”

I looked straight into the hero's eyes and said;

“I will always prioritize the safety of the heir. I will do my best for the succession of the Holy Sword, but I have no intention of manipulating or trampling on the will and personality of the heir.”

The hero sighed with a complex expression and replied,

“I repeat, I no longer doubt you. So, for now...”

“Will you follow my proposal?”

“Yes. Once the admission is confirmed, I will follow your intentions. We can discuss the details at that time.”

Good, I successfully persuaded her.

I nodded and asked, “But what's your plan for admission? Do you have a method?”

I wasn't familiar with that side of things.

Even in the game, the Elphon Academy had little significance, so I hadn't paid much attention to the details. Did they have to take an entrance exam or something?

The hero answered.

“I have an acquaintance in the Academy. If we ask them, there shouldn't be any problem with admission.”

“I see. Is it a high-ranking official?”

“He is the headmaster of the Academy.”

The headmaster?

That was unexpected, so I wondered what kind of connection it was.

Perhaps noticing my puzzled expression, the hero spoke with a slightly bitter face.

“He was a comrade with whom I experienced life and death during the war against the demons. Now he is retired and dedicated to nurturing talents.”

Chapter 136: Preparation (1)

Chapter 136: Preparation (1)

I decided to leave the mountain range immediately.

There was no reason for me to stay here now that a plan had been decided.

I would return to my territory, learn more about the Academy, and make the necessary preparations.

The hero said he would stay here for now and take the heir with her when the time was right.

She said she would keep me informed as soon as she could, but I found this part of the conversation difficult.

“We can’t risk sending information about the Holy Sword back and forth, so why don’t we arrange a meeting point?”

This fantasy world, strangely enough, lacked almost any instant long-distance communication means.

For long-range magical interaction, each magic stone needed to contain the same type of magical power. Like the teleportation magic circle reserved for the Chief of Staff in the Overlord’s Castle.

However, magic stones were extremely rare, and an enormous amount of magical power was needed for communication to be possible, regardless of the distance. Such long-distance magic could only be used by those who possessed that particular talent.

To my knowledge, the Holy Sword did not possess any means of long-distance communication.

It would be inconvenient for the hero to come to my castle with the heir.

So, it would be easier for me to go and find them instead.

“Oh, there is a way.”

The warrior suddenly pulled something out of thin air and handed it to me.

It was an old rolled-up parchment. When I unfolded it, it was completely blank with nothing written on it.

“What is this?”

“It’s an ancient magical tool with communication capabilities.”

The hero said that and then pulled out another object that looked exactly the same and held it in her hand, unfolding it.

“When you manipulate the magical power on this paper and write, as you can see...”

When the hero infused magic into her finger and wrote on the paper, the same writing appeared on the paper she handed to me.

“No matter how far apart we are, the characters we engraved on the paper we have would appear on the other’s paper. Let’s use this to communicate with each other.”

“Huh...”

I was amazed and examined the paper. It really had all sorts of magical properties.

“Then I will wait for your message.”

Anyway, after finishing the conversation like that, I bid a light farewell to the hero and hopped onto Ti-Yong's back.

I would see her again soon enough.

Back in my territory, I looked up information about Elphon Academy.

Things like the general admission process, the teaching style, the rules, and profiles of key personnel.

I also investigated the headmaster that the hero mentioned.

As she had said, he was a powerful magician who played a significant role in the Demon War and was also famous as a close friend of the hero.

After sustaining severe injuries in the final battle with the Demon King, he retired and was now pursuing the path of an educator.

I prided myself on knowing most of the major figures in this world, but seeing this, I realized there were still many things I didn't know.

As I delved further, I discovered an unexpected fact: Calderic also had the authority to recommend admissions.

Each Lord received recommendation letters every year and had the ability to recommend talented individuals to Elphon Academy.

I wondered why such a trivial authority existed, but I thought it might be a symbolic system to demonstrate the apparent alliance between the two nations.

And indeed, there were Lords who made good use of this authority.

Unlike other Lords, the noble family of the Second Lord, which suffered from a decline in power, regularly sent family members to the academy to strengthen their position in Santea.

“...”

And as I became aware of that fact, a sudden thought came to mind.

Rigon.

It was about Rigon.

Rigon was a genius no less than the heir, and his age was roughly the same.

So, what if he became close to the heir and became her comrade?

What I needed at the moment were as many variables as possible. Not in a negative sense, but in a positive sense.

To fulfill the conditions for inheriting the Holy Sword, the heir needed a lot of experience and interaction.

That was not something I could control, so it would be good to assign someone to the heir for now.

Even if Rigon didn't contribute to the succession, there was nothing wrong with simply becoming a comrade of the heir.

...Should I recommend Rigon to the Academy?

It wasn't a difficult question, as I knew that I had the power to recommend someone for admission.

Of course, Rigon's will was the most important.

I tried to call Rigon and his sister to ask for their opinions. But...

“Currently, Sir Reef is heading to the Mazlak Canyon for the Enrock Base Expedition.”

“...Expedition? Why?”

“Newly recruited knights of the Ironblood Knights Order are sent on expeditions to the treacherous areas of Enrock as part of their training...”

I see. So, she’s working hard.

“If you command, I will immediately arrange for her to return to the Lord’s castle.”

“It’s fine. There’s no need for that.”

I decided to leave Reef alone and call Rigon for now.

【Lv. 29】

“You called, my lord?”

Rigon, who had come in response to the summons, greeted me with a pleasant expression. It had been a long time since I last saw his face.

Level 29?

Wasn’t he level 21 the last time I saw him?

During that time, Rigon had rapidly grown and was now on the verge of reaching level 30.

“How have you been these days?”

“Thanks to the Lord’s care, I’ve been doing very well. Thank you.”

After listening to a brief update on his situation, I immediately got to the point.

“Rigon, do you happen to know about the Elphon Academy in Santea?”

Rigon tilted his head in confusion.

“I’m not quite sure. What is it?”

Considering that Rigon and his sister were originally from Calderic, it was understandable that they didn't know much about Santea.

I briefly explained the concept of the academy to him.

After hearing the explanation, Rigon nodded as if he understood.

"Oh, I see. So it's a place where people are gathered to be taught. That's interesting."

"Are you interested in it, by any chance?"

"Huh? Yes, a little."

"Well, then. Have you ever thought about enrolling in the academy?"

"...What?"

Rigon blinked his eyes, seemingly taken aback by the sudden remark.

"As I said, the Elphon Academy is the premier educational institution on the continent. While it's good for you to continue learning the sword from Asher, it suddenly occurred to me that it wouldn't be a bad idea for you to learn and experience a wider range of things there."

"But I want to be a knight of the castle, like my sister, no, like Sir Asher—"

"I have no intention of forcing you to do anything. Encouraging you and your sister to become knights was just one path I suggested."

I crossed my arms and spoke.

"You have numerous choices. Among them, you can do whatever you want. It's fine to become a knight like your sister, or enter the academy as I just mentioned, or consider a different path."

"....."

“Regardless of your sister, is it entirely your will to become a knight? If not, then take some time to deeply think about what I just said.”

“Yes, I understand. I will think about it.”

Seeing that he couldn’t respond immediately, it seemed that Rigon wasn’t wholeheartedly committed to becoming a knight.

Since I was the one who brought up them being a knight, and since Reef had become a knight, he probably assumed that he should be one too.

After a few days, Rigon came to me again to share his answer.

“I’ve thought about it, and going to that academy doesn’t seem like a bad idea, as my lord mentioned.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes. I think it’s great that my lord is thinking of me and giving me this opportunity, and I’m curious to hear that it’s a place where all the kids my age go to learn together.”

Thinking it went well, Rigon scratched his head and continued.

“But... if Sister opposes it, I’d prefer to stay in the castle. It would be too uncomfortable for me to leave for a distant place and upset Sister.”

I nodded my head.

For Reef, his little brother’s matters were more important than anything else, so I naturally thought of asking her too.

But since she’s not in the capital... sending her a message would...

I didn’t know when the warrior would contact me, so I needed to make a decision and be ready.

But it would take too long if I waited until Reef returned to the castle.

At the same time, if I called for her, it would be troublesome and time-consuming.

It will be fine if I just go where she is.

Even if she's at Mazlak Canyon, it wouldn't take even a day if I rode on Ti-Yong.

I decided to go find her myself and immediately prepared to leave.

"Rigon, I'm thinking of meeting your sister. Will you come with me?"

Rigon replied with a tense expression, "Uh, by any chance, are we going by Wyvern?"

"Yeah."

"I will go! Please take me with you no matter what!"

Come to think of it, this guy had wanted to ride a wyvern even before this.

Tyongyi seemed uncomfortable with the idea of carrying someone other than the familiar Asher, but it didn't complain too much.

With the excited Rigon on board, they immediately departed for the Mazlak Canyon, where Reef was said to be.

Runkelcid Base in Mazlak Canyon.

The knights stationed here were tasked with searching and surveying the canyon on a daily basis.

Mazlak Canyon was inhabited by various species of monsters, including some that caused disturbances. If they didn't regularly investigate their activities, a disaster might suddenly strike from beneath the canyon.

"Well, shall we give it our best today?"

A man hummed as he checked the gear on his body.

“I never understand why you’re always so cheerful.”

The woman standing beside him already complained with a tired expression.

The man chuckled and said, “But isn’t it a bit easier these days? The newcomers are here, so we have less work to do. It’s fun to teach them a thing or two as well.”

“What’s fun about teaching? It’s lucky if we go without any accidents caused by those scatterbrained idiots.”

“They may lack experience, but their skills are not inferior to ours, Mamelas. They are talented individuals by nature. Didn’t you hear about the incident in the previous investigation that could have gone wrong if it weren’t for Reef’s intervention? That guy risked her life.”

Mamelas’ expression hardened as soon as the name Reef was mentioned.

One of the men, who had been humming a tune, lowered his voice slightly and spoke again.

“By the way, there have been rumors about her connection to the Seventh Lord. Could it be true?”

A secret rumor had been circulating among the knights of Runkelcid.

The rumor suggested that Reef had some ties to the Seventh Lord.

However, most dismissed it as baseless gossip.

The idea that a Lord would pay attention to a single knight was an absurd notion, and if she were truly favored by the Seventh Lord, she wouldn’t have come on this mission with such a change of scenery.

“It’s nonsense. Do you believe in such baseless rumors?”

The man sneered inwardly at Mamelas' curt reply.

It was obvious to anyone that her dislike of Reef stemmed from her own feelings of inferiority.

In a few months, they would finish their training and return to the lord's castle, walking the path of elite knights.

So it would be wise to build friendly relations with the members of the Ironblood Knight Order whenever there was an opportunity. It was pointless to waste emotions on something so trivial; it could only be seen as pathetic.

"Oh, Reef."

At the mention of Reef's name, the man raised his hand to someone walking towards them from the other side.

Approaching Reef, he nodded in greeting.

"Are you ready?"

"Yes."

"Good. Then let's go. Let's work hard today as well."

With a tap on Reef's shoulder, the man walked out first.

Mamelas glanced at her and then followed, taking slow steps.

Thud.

The bump on her shoulder made Leaf take a step back.

She turned her head and watched Mamelas, who was moving away, with an expressionless face.

In fact, Reef was famous to the point where almost everyone in the Lord's castle knew about her. But here, the rumors about her only reached as far as vague gossip with uncertain sources.

That was because Reef had personally asked the officer in charge to keep it a secret.

It was unthinkable to receive special treatment for training under the name of the Seventh Lord.

She didn't want to disappoint the person who had given her and her younger brother a new life.

Compared to the days when she was a slave gladiator in the city of Actipol, this was nothing more than a minor dispute.

Reef fell into step behind the two of them.

“Haam...”

The soldier standing guard yawned in boredom.

Due to the geography of Runkelcid, it was not uncommon for monsters to descend upon the base.

So when he first started his shift, he'd been on edge, shaking with anxiety, but now he was so used to it that he could sleep if he wanted to.

“Don't space out and stand properly. The knights will be back soon.”

“Don't act all strict just because I yawned. Are you my wife?”

As the soldier responded to his colleague's remark, he turned his gaze forward again, suppressing his drowsiness.

“...?”

The soldier's eyes narrowed at the tiny dot in the distant sky that was getting closer and closer.

“Hey, what's that over there?”

“What?”

“Can’t you see that in the sky? Uh, uh?”

When the identity of that thing became discernible as it approached, the soldiers turned pale.

A gigantic wyvern was flying towards the base at an alarming speed.

“Emergency! Emergency!”

The soldiers panicked and sounded the alarm.

Even the knights who rushed out from inside the base were wide-eyed upon discovering the wyvern.

“What... What is that?”

Why was a wyvern here?

The commanding officer of Runkelcid couldn’t hide his perplexity as he looked at the wyvern approaching at a close distance.

Then he realized there was someone on the wyvern’s back, and he gasped.

“Halt! Do not attack! Everyone lower your weapons!”

The mages, who had been preparing to intercept, canceled their spells.

A wyvern descended from the sky, landing slowly on one side of the base.

The commanding officer couldn’t help but gulp as he watched the man descend from the wyvern’s back.

Crazy.

...It’s really the Seventh Lord.

The new Seventh Lord, whom he had only heard about in rumors, had actually walked onto the Runkelcid base.

The commanding officer hurriedly ran towards the man, who was looking around, and lowered his head respectfully.

“It is an honor to have you visit Runkelcid Base, Seventh Lord!”

The knights and soldiers, who belatedly grasped the situation, also bowed their heads in panic.

The man, the Seventh Lord, opened his mouth.

“And who might you be?”

“I... I am Zakran, the commanding officer of Runkelcid!”

“So, you’re the commanding officer. You’ve worked hard to uphold the base. My visit has no special meaning, I just came here to meet someone. So, relax.”

Upon hearing those words, the commanding officer felt a sense of relief and a thrill surging through his body. Even if it was just a word, who would have the chance to personally serve the Lord in their lifetime?

The next thought that came to his mind was curiosity. Why did the Lord personally travel to this remote region to meet someone? Who could it be... Ah.

“Is Reef currently at the base?”

As the commanding officer realized and had his epiphany, the words of the Seventh Lord continued.

While the other knights might not know, as the person in charge of the base, he knew a bit about the situation.

He had received a message from someone on the castle’s side, directly from the leader of the Iron-blood Knights.

Among the newcomers coming to Runkelcid this time, pay special attention and observe the knight named Reef. Without drawing attention.

The commanding officer only heard from the messenger that the reason behind it was simply the fact that she was a person associated with the Seventh Lord, and he was instructed to keep quiet about it.

...So, it was true.

The commanding officer felt a chill running down his spine for no reason and glanced at the knight standing behind him.

The knight, catching his gaze, spoke.

“S-Sir Reef is currently conducting a search in the Mazlak Canyon.”

“Is that so? The timing is unfortunate.”

The commanding officer said hurriedly.

“I will have her returned immediately, my lord.”

“Never mind. I’ll just go there myself. Is Mazlak Canyon in that direction?”

With that, the Seventh Lord rode back to the wyvern with the boy he had brought with him.

Flap!

With the powerful beat of its wings, the wyvern quickly disappeared in the direction of the canyon.

The commanding officer absentmindedly stared at the scene, then suddenly regained his senses and gave orders to those around him.

“Start tidying up the base immediately. Summon all the knights and mages in the base. We need to clean up as neatly as possible, without anything catching the eye, until the Seventh Lord returns.”

“Yes!”

“And place the guards more densely along the outer wall. If you don’t want to die, stay on high alert.”

The entire base was put on high alert due to the sudden visit of the Seventh Lord, which was like a storm passing through.

“It’s the trace of Gargari.”

The deputy leader muttered as he examined the blue fluid on the ground.

Currently, the knights were conducting an investigation at the entrance of the canyon.

“The blood hasn’t hardened much, so it must be close by.”

“Yeah. Let’s hurry and find it to take care of it.”

“Sigh, it looks like today’s search will be long.”

It was a frog-like monster with a thick body and a deadly venom.

Since it had a habit of spreading its poison continuously in the area it chose as its habitat, if it wasn’t dealt with quickly when traces were found, it could descend to nearby villages without anyone knowing and cause a terrible disaster.

The knights divided into teams of two and started searching immediately.

Reef formed a group with Mamelas and moved towards the direction of the forest.

“Keep an eye on the rear. Don’t miss any small traces and report everything.”

“Yes.”

Mamelas glared at Leaf, who complied immediately, and then turned away again.

It was after a while of silence while moving.

“...!”

Mamelas spotted a large frog-like creature through the bushes and raised her hand. It was Gargari.

Gargari also noticed them and glanced around, emitting a low growl.

Found it.

She stared at the creature while holding her breath, then briefly glanced back at Reef and spoke.

“You stay here quietly.”

“Are you planning to deal with it alone?”

“Yeah. Any problem with that?”

Reef remained silent for a moment and then spoke.

“You could be in danger by yourself.”

“Ha, danger? You getting involved would only be a hindrance. Just focus on guarding the surroundings.”

Reef frowned slightly at her forced words. They didn’t pair up and start the search for no reason.

Regardless, Mamelas drew her sword and approached the Gargari alone.

She didn’t want to give Reef even the slightest opportunity to make a move or contribute.

Mamelas charged toward Gargari.

Gargari, with her mouth wide open, extended its tongue and launched an attack.

Mamelas twisted and dodged, approaching from the side. Her sword sliced into Gargari's side.

If it began to spread its poison, it would be a nuisance, so she did everything in her power to deal with it as quickly as possible.

Amidst the relentless sword strikes, Gargari leaped around in all directions, counterattacking.

As Mamelas inwardly prepared for the final blow, Reef suddenly shouted.

“Watch out!”

In that instant, Mamelas also realized her mistake.

Gargari's tongue, shot forward and then recoiled, unexpectedly coiled around her relaxed leg.

“Ack!”

Mamelas was thrown violently into the air and slammed into the ground.

Her fallen body was targeted again as Gargari's tongue descended.

Snap!

Reef, who had rushed over, skillfully severed the tongue before swiftly decapitating Gargari.

Reef wiped the bodily fluid off her sword and approached the fallen Mamelas.

“Are you okay?”

Mamelas, who was groaning, quickly got up.

She nervously wiped off the mud from her head and, standing up, glared at Reef with a face full of embarrassment and resentment.

“Didn’t I tell you not to interfere?”

Reef looked at the disheveled Mamelas with a bewildered expression.

“Even if you didn’t step forward, I would have handled it myself! Disobeying orders? Don’t you think my words sound like commands?”

“...While you are my senior, you don’t have the authority to formally command me according to regulations.”

Mamelas lost her temper for a moment and raised her hand, slapping the floor with her sword.

Crack!

Reef’s head snapped sideways.

After being slapped on the cheek, Reef didn’t say a word and looked at Mamelas with a cold glare.

Startled, Mamelas clenched her teeth and raised his hand once again.

“This arrogant woman is really...!”

Shuuuu!

Suddenly, a loud booming sound echoed in her ears, causing her to jolt and stop her movements.

The source of the sound was the sky.

Both of them looked up with widened eyes.

A giant creature with wings was plummeting towards them at an alarming speed.

“...A wyvern?!”

Though various monsters inhabited the Mazlak Canyon, wyverns were not among them.

Having only heard about them before, Mamelas was frozen in place by the overwhelming presence of the dragon-like creature.

“...”

Reef, too, quietly observed the scene and let out a small sigh.

Mamelas hastily tried to escape towards the bushes.

However, Reef grabbed her arm.

“What, what is it? Are you crazy?! Let me go!”

“It’s the Seventh Lord.”

Mamelas momentarily paused, wondering what she was talking about. The Seventh Lord?

While they were talking, the wyvern had descended and landed on the ground.

Only then did she realize that someone was riding on the wyvern’s back, and she stared, completely frozen, at the man who had descended from its back. It was a black-haired human.

“My lord.”

Reef, who bowed her head in greeting, looked at Rigon, who was standing next to the Seventh Lord.

Rigon, who met her eyes, waved his hand with a bright smile.

“Long time no see, Reef.”

“Yes. But what brings you here...?”

The Seventh Lord glanced briefly at the Gargari’s body and the frozen Mamelas.

Finally understanding the situation, Mamelas reflexively kneeled down and lowered her head.

“I greet you, Seventh, Seventh Lord...”

The rumors that seemed absurd turned out to be true.

Indeed, there was the Seventh Lord behind Reef.

Mamelas felt her mind go blank like a blank sheet of paper.

And she immediately remembered what she had just done.

The Seventh Lord, sensing the subtle atmosphere, finally noticed that Reef’s cheek was red and asked her.

“What happened?”

Reef glanced at Mamelas.

Mamelas trembled uncontrollably with fear and prayed inwardly.

P-Please, spare me... Please...

Reef lowered her head.

“No, nothing happened, my lord.”

Upon hearing this, Mamelas felt a surge of relief throughout her body and unknowingly shed tears.

I looked down at the knight besides Reef, who was breathing heavily, unable to lift her head.

It was easy to tell that something was amiss with such an intense reaction.

But I didn't dwell on it, since Leaf seemed to want to let it go.

I spoke to Reef.

"I have something to ask you about regarding Rigon. I've come here to speak with you and also to get some air."

"Ah..."

"Let's get back to base. Get on the wyvern."

I said, climbing back onto the wyvern with Rigon.

The wyvern snorted and showed signs of discomfort at the thought of carrying more people, but I stroked Ti-Yong's neck to calm it down.

Reef looked at me hesitantly.

I thought it might be because it was unfamiliar for her to ride the wyvern for the first time, but she opened her mouth and spoke.

"My lord, I apologize, but if it's not urgent, may I return separately?"

"...?"

"The reconnaissance mission is now over. I would like to clean up the mess and return to base with my companions."

I tilted my head in confusion. Why would she want to go back separately when we could return together?

Ah.

Then, I realized that I had been ignoring an obvious fact.

Currently, she was in the midst of performing a mission here in this canyon with other knights.

I suddenly appeared out of nowhere and tried to take her away.

Of course, it shouldn't be a problem since I, the Lord, allowed it. But it was obvious how this behavior would be perceived by the other knights.

I know what Leaf's mindset was.

She's desperately training to become a knight of the monarchy, just like she said she would.

My current actions showed no consideration for her whatsoever.

...Maybe I've changed a little too.

Although it was just a trivial matter, I was surprised at myself once again.

Was it because I held such a high position? Since when did I stop caring about even the smallest things?

You never know how a person can change when those little things continue to pile up.

Even if I didn't turn into a madman like the Tyrant or the Black Sea empress.

Even if it's said that I saved the lives of these siblings in my pursuit to secretly save the world.

Those things couldn't shield me from acting according to my own desires without considering those around me.

The lordship I obtained by chance was nothing special to begin with.

It's merely an illusion, and who knew what would happen to it in the future?

It would be better for me to have some caution in my heart from now on.

“Reef.”

“Yes.”

When I called her name, Reef closed her eyes tightly and lowered her head.

She looked anxious, as if she had offended me.

Feeling pity for her appearance, I let out a faint smile and spoke.

“I lacked consideration for you. I’m sorry.”

“Oh, no. My lord.”

“Then we will wait for you at the base. I know well that you’re working hard.”

At that, I saw the corners of Leaf’s eyes flutter. She probably hadn’t expected to hear this from me.

“Yes, thank you...”

Rigon looked like he wanted to stay and go back with Reef if he could, but he didn’t say it.

Although he usually appeared very carefree, he was observant in situations like this.

Leaving Reef behind, Ti-Yong soared into the sky.

Looking at the fellow who seemed happy not to have to carry Reef, I smiled and said to the wyvern.

“You follow Asher obediently, even without me around. Are you just pretending not to like people?”

Kyaak!

Upon hearing those words, the wyvern unexpectedly let out a sharp cry and showed its temper.

Anyway, Ti-Yong understood words amazingly well.

“Just kidding, just kidding.”

After returning to the base, it took a few hours before Reef returned with the knights that were with her.

We sat around a table in a quiet room.

After giving the two siblings time to catch up, I spoke about why we went here.

“...Are you talking about entering the Academy in Santea?”

Reef, who had listened to the story, responded with a puzzled expression.

Of course, I expected that reaction.

I was asking if it would be possible to send her younger brother inexplicably far away, not only beyond Calderic, but to Santea.

“Is that possible?”

“Yes. The Lords are given one recommendation letter from Elphon Academy each year. It’s an authority that even the Second Lord is making good use of.”

Reef didn’t say anything more.

She seemed confused and couldn’t find words to say.

“Reef.”

“Yes, my lord.”

“There’s no need to be confused. Just comfortably express your thoughts.”

I glanced briefly at Rigon and spoke.

“Rigon said that he doesn’t want to go to the Academy if you oppose it. So, if you oppose it, I have no intention of forcing or persuading him.”

Finally, Reef seemed to calm down and became lost in thought.

Honestly, I thought there was a higher chance she would oppose it.

Based on what I had heard before, she didn’t want Rigon to leave her side, fearing that her brother’s old disease might relapse at any moment.

I didn’t know if that obsession had subsided now, but regardless of the outcome, Rigon was a precious presence to Reef above all else.

It wasn’t just a distant place; sending him to Sainte, which was practically in a hostile relationship with Calderic, was something she probably didn’t want. Even if she could learn and experience more than he did now.

After being lost in thought for quite some time, Reef finally spoke up and asked. Not to me, but to Rigon.

“Rigon, what do you want to do?”

Rigon said.

“You heard what His Lordship said. I won’t go if Sister opposes it.”

“It’s not about that. I’m asking about your heart. Not me or His Lordship. Do you really want to enter the Academy?”

“That’s right.”

“Why?”

Rigon scratched his cheek and replied.

“There’s no special or grand reason. I’m just curious. And rather than living day by day in the castle, only wielding a sword, I thought that if I experience something more, I might find what I really want.”

“...”

Reef had a complicated expression on her face.

It was the moment when I wanted to tell her to take more time to think if necessary.

“I will also follow my younger brother’s choice.”

Surprisingly, I looked at her in astonishment at the refreshing decision.

“Are you really okay with it?”

“Yes. Of course, I have concerns, but it’s what Rigon wants. I don’t want to oppose it.”

Because it’s what her younger brother wanted. It was a simple reason.

However, there must have been countless struggles that crossed her mind before making up her mind.

I knew better than anyone else how much she cherished her younger brother.

Rigon’s expression brightened with Reef’s response.

Actually, there was no need to worry about any unfortunate events happening to Rigon.

Of course, she had no way of knowing, but Rigon would not be separated from my side once we got to the Academy.

Anyway, with this, Rigon’s admission to Elphon Academy was finalized.

Chapter 137: Preparation (2)

Chapter 137: Preparation (2)

After concluding the conversation with Reef, I returned to my territory.

I continued to prepare for my entrance into the Academy, but I also thought about what I needed to take care of before the time came.

As always, I wasn't concerned about the affairs of the territory because it always managed well, even in my absence.

What needed to be sorted out was not related to the territory but rather some personal matters.

It was about Shadow Freon.

That woman, I don't know when she will return.

The woman who infiltrated the territory as a spy and was now somewhere diligently gathering information.

What I had assigned to her was regarding the villain with the mystery of possession, who would later terrorize the capital city of Santea.

I don't expect her to have discovered much with the meager clue I provided.

I didn't have high hopes that she had discovered anything significant based on the tiny speck of information I had given her. It was a long shot, to begin with.

When I tasked Shadow Freon with gathering information, I had instructed her to report back within a maximum of one year.

I wanted to keep the intervals shorter if possible, but having her travel long distances would interfere with her operations.

So, I had to delay the time as much as possible. There was still quite a lot of time left until her return.

If I were to be admitted to the academy, external activities would become difficult.

Therefore, it would be wise to check on the Shadow's current progress before that.

I retrieved the item that I had taken from the Shadow before.

An ancient magical tool that revealed the direction of the stamped target.

I had coerced the Shadow into collecting information by threatening her with the seal of this ring.

Even now, the ring emitted a faint light, pointing in a certain direction.

I don't know how far away it is, though.

Still, no matter how far it seemed, it wouldn't take an incredibly long time. Because Ti-Yong was there.

With the thought in mind, I quickly prepared to leave.

Asher still hadn't returned, so this outing was one of the rare occasions when I was alone, without a companion.

More than ten days had passed since following the light indicated by the ring on the map.

As expected, the Shadow's location was beyond Calderic, in the direction of Santea, with a considerable distance.

This is...

I gazed down at the endless forest below in wonder.

This forest was a massive one located outside the Santea territory. It had no specific name.

The reason for my confusion was that once you crossed this forest, according to the map, there was nothing but a sea in the deserted wilderness.

I had no idea what kind of investigation she was doing, but I couldn't imagine what she was doing all the way out here...

Could it be that she's not properly investigating?

As long as I had the ring, I knew better than anyone that there was no way for her to escape from me.

Amidst that thought, a slight uneasiness arose.

It was because I knew someone who lived in the depths of this nameless forest.

Curel the Witch.

Naturally, the powerful individuals of RaSa were not solely those with continental fame.

There were also many reclusive masters, whose names were not well known to the public due to various reasons.

Among them, Curel the Witch was a remarkable figure, comparable to the Five Stars of Santea.

Her background and details were not well known even to me, as she had never appeared in the game.

However, what I did know was that she was a bizarre mage who had been referred to as a witch in the past due to her eccentricities.

Being secluded in such a forest, conducting solitary magical research, was a clear indication of who she was.

Although it's unlikely to encounter her in this vast forest...

What made him uneasy was that the direction of the light pointed by the ring happened to be in the direction where the forest was.

I couldn't help but wonder if she had come here to find the witch.

Shortly after, that intuition became a reality.

Sigh.

I let out a small sigh.

It was because I could gradually sense a massive magical presence from afar.

The ring's light was pointing towards the source of magic and had been tilting slightly downward for a while now.

It was an unmistakable sign that the Shadow was here.

And in a forest devoid of any human presence, there was only one reason why magical energy could be felt.

Is that the witch's territory over there?

Considering how the magical energy was spreading across a wide range, it seemed likely to be a barrier.

The Shadow would undoubtedly be within that barrier. Did she really come here to meet the witch?

“Let's go down.”

I descended to the ground for now.

As I stood there, having disembarked from Ti-Yong, I gazed at the other side of the forest, where I could feel the magical energy.

Should I go in or not?

While I didn't know if the witch, Curel, was an evil person, she was certainly a formidable individual.

If I were to recklessly enter her domain, she wouldn't welcome me with open arms or anything.

However, my contemplation was short-lived.

I felt like I'd bought myself a bad deal, but I couldn't just turn around and go home.

"Wait here for a moment."

I said as I gently stroked Ti-Yong's neck.

Curel the Witch was a formidable opponent, on par with the Archmages of Santea. She was probably around level 92.

Although I had confidence in protecting myself, even if I was alone, it could still be burdensome.

As I ventured alone into the depths of the forest, the aura of magic gradually thickened.

Once I entered the mysterious magic barrier, an eerie stillness enveloped the surroundings.

The sky seemed to have become even hazier, perhaps due to the barrier, as I looked up for a moment before continuing my steps.

A voice of unknown origin echoed shortly after.

– Who are you?

A young woman's voice, as if it were muffled by noise.

It was Curel the Witch.

I stopped in my tracks, surveyed the area, and spoke.

“And who might you be? Are you the mage who cast this barrier?”

I asked in a nonchalant tone, not wanting to draw attention to myself by feigning that I knew more than I did.

After a brief silence, the voice resounded again.

– Answer the question. Who are you? Why have you entered this forest?

“There might be a woman within this barrier, or perhaps she passed through here. I've come this far to pursue her.”

–

“I don't know who you are, but that's the only reason I've come here. Do you happen to know the whereabouts of the person I mentioned?”

Suddenly, I heard a sigh, and this reply followed.

– What's your relationship with that Freon girl?

Freon was the name of the Shadow.

So the witch had some connection with the Shadow. Judging by the way she addressed her, it didn't seem like they were on good terms.

“What's your relationship with her?”

– I ask the questions, intruder. If you want to save your life, stop pissing me off and answer it.

I shook my head and spoke.

“We have no reason to fight. As I said, all I want is Freon. She is my captive. So if she’s not that important to you, hand her over to me. Otherwise, explain your reasons first.”

Suddenly, the surrounding magical energy fluctuated and surged towards me. It wasn’t a physical attack.

Having experienced a similar sensation in the ruins of Cabolissa, I could immediately recognize what it was.

“It’s pointless. Mental magic doesn’t work on me.”

Then, once again, the magical energy surged and this time, offensive magic was unleashed.

I erected a barrier and blocked the blades of magic attacking from all directions.

Quagwaggwaaang!

Now I realized that this barrier was essentially the witch’s domain. Quite literally.

Although I couldn’t sense the witch anywhere nearby, the flow of magical energy composing the barrier was as if it was being manipulated right here, freely.

I wondered if such a thing was possible, but it was a futile question, since I was a stranger to magic in the first place.

Well, she had been living here for a long time, so she must have a lot of devices prepared here lying around.

Still, there’s no danger.

These attacks couldn’t even scratch the floating veil that could withstand the full force of the Thunder Lord’s power.

Only after completely reducing the entire area to ashes did the witch's attacks cease.

I withdrew the barrier and spoke.

“Pushing back with firepower doesn't work, either.”

As I stood still in my place, calmly warding off all attacks, the witch seemed a bit flustered.

After a moment of silence, the magical energy gathered around me again, enclosing me.

I immediately escaped through space leap upon witnessing the formation of a barrier that seemed like an attempt to confine me.

“Give it up. With your abilities, you cannot overpower me.”

– Fair enough. It seems like you're right. Although it doesn't seem like magic, what exactly is your identity?

“Isn't it better not to be curious about each other? If you just let me know where Freon is, that would be enough. You must also find it tiresome that I continue to stay here.”

The witch replied with a chuckle.

– Tiresome? That's amusing. You also have nothing you can do within this boundary. Keep wandering around until you find a way out.”

The witch's response displayed a disgruntled and uncooperative attitude.

It would have been easy enough to ignore her and follow the light of the ring, but the way she was talking, it seemed that she would continue to be a hindrance.

The witch was capable of unleashing various strange magics. Even if there was no direct connection to me, she could easily confuse my path or divert Freon elsewhere.

Annoying indeed.

I heightened my senses to their maximum and thoroughly examined the witch's magical presence.

The intentionally confusing and scattered waves of magic power.

Amidst them, I felt a faint thread of magical power extending far in one direction.

I was certain that the direction led to where the witch was, so I focused my gaze in that direction and spoke.

“Don't assume I wouldn't know your location. Are you there?”

—

There was no response. Even without looking, it was evident that the witch was taken aback and surprised.

In a slightly softer voice, I addressed the silent witch.

“Hey, witch. As I mentioned, we have no reason to fight. I apologize for intruding into your territory unannounced. However, the person I'm looking for is within this barrier, and I can't afford to wait until they come out from the outside, can I?”

Since I had no intention of actually confronting the witch, I restrained myself appropriately.

Mages didn't have a good compatibility with me. Even if I were to continue searching, it would be inconvenient for me if she had prepared defensive magic and was waiting for me.

Of course, there was no way the witch would know that, so she wouldn't be able to ignore me now that I knew her location.

— ...The least she could do is give me a heads-up.

Suddenly, magical energy gathered in the air and formed an arrow shape, pointing in one direction.

Since the witch's words only sounded like she was trying to save face, I smiled inwardly and thanked her.

“Thank you.”

– By the way, what does the term ‘captive’ you mentioned earlier mean?

“It’s nothing special. It means she was caught trying to gather information about me like a little rat.”

I asked the witch,

“Can you tell me anything about your connection with Freon? I’m curious.”

The witch clicked her tongue and replied,

– Nothing at all. I owed him a small debt once upon a time, a debt I’d already paid, and now he’s here with a strange demand.

“Demand?”

– She asked me to remove the magical inscription engraved on her body. Now I see that it was because of you. Damn bitch, what kind of monster did she bring into my dwelling?

The witch grumbled.

Only then did I understand the exact reason why the Shadow had come here. It seemed she wanted to escape from me after all.

The witch must have been knowledgeable about various types of magic, so perhaps she thought she could remove the inscription from the ring.

– I had her confined in the direction I just pointed. Take her out. I hope you will never return here again.

With those words, no more voices echoed around.

I moved my feet since I didn't have anything else to ask the witch.

After moving for a while in the direction where the Shadow was, a cave appeared.

It seemed like the place where the witch had confined the Shadow. There was a sense of presence coming from inside.

There was a magical barrier at the entrance of the cave, but as I approached, it seemed that the witch had released it, and it disappeared on its own.

Passing through the entrance and entering inside, I could see someone curled up on one side of the cave.

“...Ah!”

The Shadow opened her closed eyes and jumped up, startled to see me.

It was no joke that she had been trapped in the cave for quite some time, looking disheveled.

I pitifully looked at her and then spoke.

“Come out, Shadow.”

The Shadow cautiously approached me.

She looked around with her eyes and then laughed softly before speaking in a sarcastic tone.

“So, Seventh Lord, you've come to rescue me? Thank you. Did you kill the witch?”

Her audacity left me speechless.

Did she really expect me to not know the situation?

“The witch is unharmed. I’ve heard that you came here to remove the seal of the ring.”

As soon as I finished speaking, the Shadow fell to the ground, hitting her forehead.

“Please spare me just this once, Seventh Lord.”

I asked, clicking my tongue.

“How far along is the investigation?”

“.....”

“Have you not done anything at all?”

“I have committed a grave sin. From now on, I will not engage in petty tricks and will do my best to gather information with the utmost dedication.”

Since my expectations were not high to begin with, I wasn’t particularly disappointed, but I let out a sigh.

“Shadow.”

“Yes, my lord. Please give your command.”

“Do you see that over there?”

I pointed to a spider web hanging from one side of the cave ceiling.

A single beetle was trapped motionless on the web.

“Yes, I see it.”

“That represents you now. Do you really think that by erasing a mere seal, you can truly escape from me?”

“...”

“There won’t be a second chance. Do what you’re told properly. Don’t forget who I am and what your position is.”

I gestured towards the outside of the cave.

“Leave. Come back exactly one year from today to my territory and report your achievements.”

The Shadow, who quickly stood up, lowered her head and swiftly exited the cave.

Watching his figure, I let out another sigh.

In truth, there was no way to chase after the Shadow once the ring’s seal was erased. What I just said was merely a hollow threat mixed with bluff.

Still, since I personally came all the way here, this should serve as a clear warning.

But still, I can’t completely trust the Shadow either.

I couldn’t just trust that woman and wait endlessly, so I needed to continue thinking of separate measures to deal with the terrorism that would happen in the future.

I too moved my steps out of the cave. I had to return to the Lord’s castle.

Chapter 138: Preparation (3)

Chapter 138: Preparation (3)

The new semester at Elphon Academy was about two months away.

That was when the heir, myself, and Rigon would enter the Academy as freshmen.

Since I had to send my letter of recommendation, which was based on my authority as a Lord, earlier than the regular application period, I had already instructed the butler to prepare the documents and send the recommendation for Rigon.

The hero would take care of my recommendation, as well as that of the heir, so I didn't have to worry about that.

In the meantime, Asher returned to the castle, and I explained my plans to her.

I also had occasional contact with the hero.

The hero said that she was currently traveling around the eastern part of Santea with the heir, showing her various cities.

Anyway, I had roughly looked into the things I needed to know and organized everything, so I had plenty of time.

Of course, I had no intention of wasting my free time just idling around.

No, even if I wanted to, I couldn't do that.

There were still important tasks left to be done.

“I should learn how to manipulate magic.”

As far as I knew, the departments at Elphon Academy were primarily divided into the Swordsmanship Department and the Magic Department.

Of course, there were other academic subjects such as politics and history.

However, all students were basically assigned to either the Swordsmanship or Magic Department, and they could choose additional subjects based on their aptitude.

In a world where a single individual could rival an entire nation, and there were no limits to the abilities one could possess, what was the greatest power?

Naturally, it was physical strength.

The foundation of noble families was also based on such power.

Of course, one had to be skilled in politics and have a sharp mind, but without strength, no matter how exceptional other abilities were, they would be useless.

Perhaps the educational structure of Elphon Academy was a natural product of that law of power.

Regardless of academia or anything else, it's probably the most important thing for them to get you to build up your magic and learn how to use it.

That's why I had to learn magic from now on.

What would someone who couldn't even handle a trace of Mana do by entering the academy? I would already consider myself lucky if I didn't get expelled.

After learning about the rules of Elphon Academy, I found out that if my grades dropped significantly, I could be expelled shortly after admission.

If such a disaster were to happen, I wouldn't even have the face to look at the hero.

That's why I had to somehow develop at least a minimum level of ability before admission.

"Are you referring to Mana training techniques?"

Asher asked with a slightly bewildered expression.

I nodded.

"As you may have guessed, I have no control over magic."

"I see."

"So, I want you to teach me directly, Asher. Considering the future, I think I should learn it."

I chose Asher as my teacher for magic. The reason was simple. She was the most suitable candidate, and there was no reason for me to learn from someone else.

She was also the only person I felt comfortable around without the mask of a Lord, not to mention her skills.

"Teach me from the basics, as if you're teaching a complete beginner."

"Yes, I will do my best."

Thus, I moved to the training ground with Asher and began receiving lessons from her.

"Everyone possesses a unique Mana, they just aren't aware of it. The first step in learning magic is to become aware of this latent power, the seed of magic. That's all there is to it."

I listened attentively to Asher's explanation.

So, her words meant to feel the dormant Mana within the body. It was simple, if you could call it that.

This is a little different from what I thought.

I had no detailed knowledge about cultivating Mana, so I didn't know it would be like this.

I thought it would be something like breathing techniques in martial arts novels, but there were already seeds of Mana within my body?

As if she could read my puzzled expression, Asher spoke.

“While I mentioned latent Mana, it's just a way of expressing it. It's the potential of undeveloped Mana that hasn't yet materialized. Even if you try to feel the Mana, it probably won't feel the same as what you usually sense.”

“I see,” I nodded and heightened my senses as much as possible.

Of course, that didn't mean I suddenly felt the presence of latent Mana.

It seemed that having keen senses alone wasn't enough to perceive it.

“The methods of developing Mana vary from person to person, but in my case, I simply moved my body and trained it. Most warriors develop their Mana in this way. By providing physical stimulation and continually focusing on their body's sensations, they eventually feel the flow of Mana.”

“What about the methods of mages?”

“I'm not entirely sure about mages... Many of them develop Mana through meditation. However, this is just a matter of individual aptitude. There's no reason to separate warriors and mages when it comes to the development of Mana. Even someone walking the path of magic can develop Mana through physical stimulation, just as warriors can, and warriors can develop it through meditation, just like mages.”

In other words, regardless of the process, as long as one succeeded, it didn't really matter.

As I was pondering which path would be more suitable for me, Asher spoke.

"For you, Sir Ron, I'm thinking of swordsmanship training to stimulate your Mana, as I did. What do you think?"

I nodded.

"That sounds good."

Since I intended to learn swordsmanship from Asher anyway, it seemed like a good approach.

It seemed to have more benefits than meditation, since I was already physically strong enough to handle any amount of physical abuse thanks to my super regeneration.

"Do you know how to use a sword?"

"No, I've never handled a weapon at all."

I picked up a training wooden sword placed on one side of the practice area.

I had never even considered the possibility that I would learn swordsmanship someday.

Asher looked at me for a moment as if lost in thought and then picked up a wooden sword herself.

"In that case, it would be better to have a swordsmanship duel first."

"A duel?"

"Yes. To improve efficiency, wouldn't it be better for me to have a better understanding of Sir Ron?"

“I’m just a novice in swordsmanship... Well, fine.”

I stood facing Asher, awkwardly gripping the wooden sword.

Since Asher seemed a little tense, I felt uneasy and spoke.

“My physical abilities are pathetic, at an average person’s level. Can I even participate in a duel?”

“Oh, of course, it’s a duel without Mana. I won’t be using Mana either.”

Asher took a step back and swung her sword.

I easily lowered my head to dodge and swung my sword.

Even though my movements felt awkward and sloppy even to myself, the duel seemed quite plausible.

Thanks to my heightened senses, it was not difficult at all to block and evade Asher’s attacks without using Mana.

After a while, Asher stopped her sword, and nodding her head, spoke.

“You truly are a complete beginner.”

“Didn’t I just say that?”

“Sensory and cognitive abilities are much higher than mine, so I think if you learn swordsmanship, you would quickly grow.”

That’s how I started learning swordsmanship from Asher in earnest.

At first, posture correction was the focus. Starting with basic techniques such as horizontal and vertical cuts, diagonal cuts, I progressed to more advanced movements, constantly receiving corrections on my posture.

Since I wanted to learn properly, I diligently followed Asher’s instructions despite the inconvenience.

About three days later, I began to feel the presence of Mana.

While swinging the sword, I suddenly stopped as a faint energy started wriggling inside my body.

“It seems like Mana has awakened.”

“Is that so?”

Asher placed her hand on my chest and infused her Mana. Her eyes widened.

“Congratulations. I thought it would take at least ten days...”

After awakening the Mana, it was time to learn how to control it properly.

This was the point where the paths of warriors and mages diverged.

I could learn how to enhance the body using Mana or how to transform the nature of Mana to unleash spells.

“Mana is similar to the muscles of the body. The more you use it, the more it continues to be trained and strengthened, up to a certain extent, without any special techniques.”

The Mana currently present in my body was extremely weak, but there were various ways to increase it quickly.

I asked the butler to bring me the finest Mana potion. There were already several of them in the castle’s warehouse.

Ever since becoming a Lord, it seemed like I was finally starting to make meaningful use of the estate’s resources.

“I will guide you through the overall flow. Sir Ron, please focus on controlling the Mana so it doesn’t run wild.”

I sat in the center of the training ground and with Asher’s assistance, successfully absorbed the energy of the potion.

Receiving the assistance of elixirs had its limits, so it was naturally impossible to endlessly increase my Mana. However, as a beginner on the path of magic, I had accumulated a considerable amount of Mana.

After the awakening of my Mana, about a month had passed.

During that time, I learned and mastered the method of enhancing my physical body with magic from Asher.

Asher mentioned that my Mana affinity and my ability to control it were quite exceptional.

Come to think of it, the adventurer I had met on the Gaitan Lake before also remarked on my strong Mana affinity.

Kwoong!

I sheathed my sword and looked at the fallen tree on the ground.

In just a month's time, I had reached a level where I could imbue magic into my sword and cut down a small tree.

The rapid growth I had achieved in such a short period was due to Asher's excellent teachings and also thanks to the elixirs and mysteries I possessed.

My heightened senses, maximized through super sensory, played a significant role in controlling Mana, while super regeneration allowed me to continue training without getting easily fatigued.

Starting from the basic ability values enhanced by super regeneration, coupled with the assistance of elixirs, my growth speed exceeded imagination.

Indeed, this world is all about power-ups.

Of course, to the transcendent beings in this world, it was nothing remarkable, but it felt different experiencing it directly with my own body.

Excluding my instant kill ability and mysteries, I wondered what level I would be at now.

Although I was curious, my own eyes couldn't see my level, making it an unknown matter.

“Asher, what would you say is my current level compared to Rigon?”

As I asked Asher, who had been watching by my side, she pondered for a moment and replied.

“Overall, I believe you are about three stages below Rigon.”

Three stages below.

Currently, Rigon had surpassed level 30 through his growth. So, I could estimate my level to be around the early 20s, give or take.

That level was definitely on par with the new students at the Academy, if not better. They're just 15-year-old freshmen, after all.

I wondered if I should have a duel with Rigon, but I gave up on the idea.

Losing to Rigon would have been a bit embarrassing to say the least.

While continuing to learn swordsmanship from Asher, I decided to delve into magic as well.

Now that I knew how to manipulate Mana, it was only natural that I wanted to try casting spells at least once.

Since Asher was also a novice in magic, I couldn't learn from her.

The castle was filled with exceptional mages, but for now, I decided to self-study using magic books.

And after a few days, I came to a realization.

I didn't have much talent for magic.

“.....”

I scratched my head and read the explanations with a puzzled expression on my face.

The manifestation of magic consisted of two processes: the release of Mana outward and the conversion of its properties.

Now that I was proficient in controlling Mana and releasing it, it wasn't difficult at all. The problem was the conversion of properties.

What is this even talking about?

Simply put, the conversion of properties meant unfolding the formula that composed the specific magic.

If this formula were something as simple as a math equation, I wouldn't have been so confused.

To my surprise, the magic book simply instructed me to “perceive” and “sense” the invisible formulas.

I was supposed to sense it rather than solve the formula? What kind of nonsense was this?

In the end, even consulting the most skilled mages in the castle didn't make a difference.

The only thing that did happen was that I finally understood, in my own way, what it meant to feel the formula.

So...

It seemed that the formula composing magic was a kind of synesthesia.

It was like perceiving colors from specific numbers or characters.

If one could sense a specific pattern in Mana and express it through a formula, that was considered magic.

It was a purely magical quality that had nothing to do with how good you were at manipulating Mana, so it was a very difficult concept to grasp.

Even if they said to perceive patterns, there was nothing to be felt. What were they expecting me to do?

“Well, the only way is to concentrate until you can feel it. I apologize, but at this stage, there is nothing I can do to help, my Lord.”

As my expression hardened, the mage slightly paled and bowed his head.

He was the most outstanding mage in the Lord’s castle. There was no doubt about the words spoken by such a skilled mage.

In order to feel that so-called pattern, I invested all my time outside of sword training.

However, even after more than three days had passed, I still couldn’t grasp any sensation.

Magic is truly difficult.

I had been arrogant to think that if I could easily learn swordsmanship, magic would be a piece of cake.

Magic was a field that required a natural talent more than the mastery of one’s body.

In fact, there was no need to learn magic, but my determination wouldn’t let me give up.

Finally, after about ten more days had passed, I could feel the slightest hint of that pattern.

The next step was to learn the basic magic derived from it.

Since my ability to manipulate Mana was already at a sufficient level, I focused solely on the formula and delved into magic.

Fwoosh!

I proudly gazed at the flames flickering above my palm.

After nearly a month since I started learning magic, I was finally able to unfold basic spells.

Even though it only consisted of a few elemental spells, including fire, and some defensive barrier spells, I could still consider myself successfully initiated into magic.

Time continued to pass.

I was mindlessly manipulating the tiny orb in the palm of my hand when I looked up.

Words were slowly being engraved on the scroll on my desk.

– It's the date of the Academy's new student enrollment in three days. Is everything okay?

Finally, I received a message from the hero.

I also infused magic into my fingertips and replied in writing.

– Yeah. Where are you right now?

– I'm in Raphid City. Can you come here right away?

– Of course. Let's meet at a designated location outside the city.

I put the paper back and stood up.

The time had come.

Chapter 139: Elphon Academy

Chapter 139: Elphon Academy

“You haven’t aged a bit, Aindel.”

Nuremberg, the headmaster of Elphon Academy, smiled as he looked into the face of a friend he hadn’t seen in years.

The hero, Aindel, also smiled and spoke.

“You have many wrinkles on your face, Nuremberg.”

“Who’s making fun of whom? Ask the Holy Sword once. Since I don’t expect rejuvenation, can’t you do something about these wrinkles on my forehead?”

The two sat facing each other, sipping tea and exchanging meaningless conversation for a while.

Nuremberg put down his cup and turned his gaze towards the window as he asked.

“So, when did you come out of your seclusion?”

“It hasn’t been long.”

“Do you plan to stay in the world for a while?”

“Yes, I do.”

“How’s your health?”

“Not good. I probably won’t last another ten years.”

At the casual response, Nuremberg let out a bitter laugh.

She was not the type of friend who would complain about trivial matters, always maintaining an upright and noble character.

“Is it even beyond the recovery power of the Holy Sword?”

Aindel nodded.

Nuremberg didn’t ask any further. Silence filled the headmaster’s office for a while.

“If you came here to bid farewell before heading to Alterore, then stop. Even if you can’t avoid death, I don’t want to witness such a last moment from you.”

“Your way of speaking has become quite gentle. But I suppose being a headmaster does shape a person.”

“Hey, Aindel.”

Aindel smiled.

“Don’t worry. There may come a time when I have to do that, but... not yet. I have no intention of throwing away my life in vain. I will resist until the very end.”

Nuremberg sighed and leaned back against the sofa.

“So why did you come here? I don’t think you came just to see my face, right?”

“Well, that’s true.”

His eyes widened at her next words.

“What? Recommended admission?”

“Yes. I’d like to get two kids admitted into the Academy, and I’m wondering if you could do it under your authority, without revealing my existence?”

“Of course I can, but why? You’re making a very baffling request. Do you have children that I don’t know about? So, who’s the lucky father?”

“Enough with the pointless jokes. Anyway, it seems it can be done.”

Nuremberg urged her to explain further.

“Alright, now give me a proper explanation. If you’re asking me not to reveal your existence, I can’t imagine you have any intention of raising an heir, so what is it?”

Aindel spoke with a subdued voice.

“Nuremberg, this is a matter of great importance. But I can’t explain the reason to you.”

“Why not?”

“Even if I wanted to explain, I can’t.”

Nuremberg immediately understood her words.

“Is it related to the Holy Sword? I see. If you say so, it must be.”

“Thank you for understanding.”

“Is that the only thing I need to do?”

“Yes. Just admit them to the Academy. You don’t have to pay special attention to anything else.”

Nuremberg was extremely curious about what Aindel wanted to do, but he didn’t ask anything.

That's how absolute the trust was between them. If desired, he could even give up his life without any suspicion.

Aindel emptied her teacup and asked.

"Nuremberg, is there still nothing visible?"

Nuremberg shook his head.

"No, nothing since that day. The dark omen is approaching, so something might appear soon."

I had Rigon escorted by the knights and sent to Santea ahead first. It was a long distance by carriage.

Although I could have let him ride on Ti-Yong with me, I didn't bother to do so.

I thought it might complicate things unnecessarily. It didn't hurt to be cautious.

There it is.

As soon as I received the message, I headed straight for the forest near Raphid City.

In the middle of the forest stood a woman wearing a robe. It was the hero.

I looked around and approached her.

"The heir?"

In response to my question, the hero answered.

"Kaen went inside the academy. He had to go to the dormitory before the start of the new semester."

I nodded. It seemed that they had already been admitted.

Before the admission date, meaning before the start of the semester, incoming students had to enter the dormitory located within the Academy and live there. It was to adapt to the atmosphere on campus and receive the necessary items as a student.

By now, Rigon was probably living in the academy as well.

“Well then, there’s no need to delay. I’ll go in right away. Are there any specific things I should be aware of?”

“Nothing special. It’s all as we discussed. Oh, one small thing has changed...”

“What’s going on?”

“You and Kaen will be entering the Department of Magic, not the Department of Swordsmanship. That’s all.”

I was a little surprised by the hero’s words.

Because when we communicated before, it was clear that I would be entering the Department of Swordsmanship.

“Kaen suddenly changed her mind. She said she wants to learn unfamiliar magic instead.”

“Hmm...”

“Is there a problem?”

The hero asked, puzzled by my reaction.

I shook my head.

“No, there’s none.”

Well, it should be fine.

My magical skills were a bit abysmal, but not enough to get me expelled.

It shouldn't be a big issue even if it's the Department of Magic instead of the Department of Swordsmanship.

This will completely separate me from Rigon because of the difference in departments.

I didn't specifically mention Rigon's existence to the hero.

Of course, it would have been right to tell the hero about Rigon in order for the heir to become closer to Rigon more easily. Then the hero could have asked the academy's headmaster to arrange for the three of us to be in the same class.

But I had one reason for not doing so: to be as cautious as possible.

The hero said she trusted the headmaster, but I didn't know anything about him.

Although the hero probably didn't mention anything about the succession, I didn't want to give any hints to a third party that there might be a connection between the recommended person by a Lord of Calderic and the people recommended by the hero for no reason.

The possibility that he might betray the hero and use that fact to his advantage politically was not zero, and my complacency might make things difficult for her.

I can't say the same for that professor we met on the mountain.

However, as a result, half of the students took the exam, and the departments were divided, distancing me from Rigon.

I felt a slight sense of complication, but I didn't worry too much.

Well, since we're in the same grade, there must be a way for us to meet and become friends somehow.

“Anyway, if there’s nothing more to discuss, then now...”

As I trailed off, the hero nodded and reached out into the empty space.

Gathering radiant golden light, the Holy Sword appeared.

“If you have a desired appearance, I will try to match it as closely as possible.”

“I don’t have anything specific. Just change the hair and eye color, and keep the rest simple.”

Now it was time to change my appearance with the Holy Sword’s polymorph ability.

It would be absurd for me to enter the academy with my current face.

By the way, the Holy Sword’s polymorph ability was ridiculously exceptional, to the point that it could even change one’s gender.

So, when the hero earnestly asked me before if I should become a woman, I was shocked.

Of course, from the hero’s perspective, it was a proposal that aimed to ensure the heir’s safety.

If I were of the same gender as the heir, I could share a dorm room with her, and that would mean I could always be by her side to protect them. However...

Changing even the gender is a bit too much.

I refused, because I knew I would feel a sense of self-doubt that not even the [Soul of the King] could withstand.

No matter how important the heir’s safety was, I couldn’t endure such a thing.

Ugh.

As the Holy Sword emitted a faint golden light, it enveloped my entire body.

A sudden wave of discomfort and nausea surged through me, but it was only momentary.

Soon the light faded, and I blinked my eyes, looking down at my hands.

“...Is it over?”

The hero used the power of the Holy Sword to create a mirror in front of me in the empty space.

Brown-haired with a slightly sunken cheek, the face of an ordinary, average boy.

I felt around my face, confirming the completely changed appearance.

There wasn't a particularly astonishing feeling. Not only had I already experienced this once before, but I was still in a state where I hadn't fully adapted to my original face.

My physique had also become slightly smaller, matching the age of a young boy.

As I looked at the hero, she asked me.

“How do you feel?”

“I think it's okay. Hmm.”

Ah, even my voice has become younger.

I pulled up the slightly loose robe once again.

Although I couldn't deny the unfamiliarity with my suddenly transformed body, I knew I would adapt to it quickly.

“I hope there won’t be any incidents where the polymorph is undone or revealed.”

“There won’t be. Even if an archmage comes, it is impossible for them to penetrate or dispel it.”

If the hero asserted it like that, then there was nothing to worry about.

I approached Ti-Yong.

“Return to the castle, Ti-Yong. Go back the way we came through the uninhabited area. We won’t be able to meet for a while now.”

Ti-Yong let out a low whimper, as if disappointed, and gently rubbed its head against my hand before swiftly taking flight.

While watching the wyvern quickly disappear into the distant sky, I turned my gaze.

“Now, let’s go.”

The hero nodded and handed me something.

It was a badge engraved with the emblem of Elphon Academy. It was an item necessary for identification.

“...I will trust and leave it in your hands, Seventh Lord.”

With that, the hero departed, and I, left alone in the forest, stood still for a moment before turning my body around.

To the city of Raphid, in the direction of the Elfon Academ

“Wow.”

As Kaen passed through the main gate of Elphon, she exclaimed in awe while admiring the interior view of the academy.

She'd seen many cities since coming out of the mountains and following Del, but she'd never seen buildings this large and tall.

The guide who had been walking ahead stopped, urging her to catch up.

"This way, student Kaen."

"Oh, yes."

Kaen wanted to quickly go to the dormitory and see her assigned room, but she couldn't check-in immediately.

Since she had been bombarded with questions and verifications since earlier, she had to wrestle with officials for a while.

Del had told her to just do as people instructed, so Kaen obediently followed the instructions.

Only after completing all the admission procedures could she finally move to the dormitory.

Kaen's room was located at the end of the corridor, room 220.

She took out the room key and clumsily pushed it into the lock.

Click.

As she opened the door and entered, a spacious and tidy room unfolded before her.

The furnishings consisted of basic items, such as a desk and a bed.

Kaen briefly looked around the room before placing her luggage on one side of the room. Then she climbed up to the upper bunk of the two-story bed and simply lay down.

They said two people would share a room.

She wondered who her roommate would be as she lay on the bed, rolling around. Soon, she drifted off to sleep.

It wasn't long before a loud bang awakened her.

Kaen sat up, yawning and turning her head.

Someone opened the door and came in, standing awkwardly in the entrance of the room.

“Um...”

Kaen blinked her eyes and looked discreetly at the girl, who seemed to be around her age, then smiled broadly.

“Hello?”

“Uh? Uh, hello.”

“I'm in this room, and I fell asleep while rolling around in the bed. You're in this room too, right?”

The girl nodded in a bewildered manner.

“I'm Esca. Esca Marioles. And you?”

“I'm Kaen.”

“Kaen, huh? What about your last name?”

“Last name? I don't really have one. Just Kaen.”

The girl, Esca, let out a small sigh and shyly smiled as she spoke.

“Nice to meet you, Kaen. Since we're roommates now, let's take care of each other from now on.”

Kaen leaped out of bed and approached her, extending her hand.

“Nice to meet you too! Let’s get along!”

Once inside Raphid City, I headed straight for the academy.

Following the guidance of the guide, who was standing with the security guards at the main gate, I moved forward.

It was a place I had been to before when I was searching for mysteries, but now that I looked at it properly, it was incredibly spacious.

At the counter in the same building as the main building, I completed the necessary procedures, including identification and receiving my supplies.

The items I received were school uniforms, student notebooks, and other necessary supplies for the future.

After completing all the formal admission procedures, I immediately moved to the dormitory.

The dormitory was divided into male and female dorms, and the two buildings were located right next to each other.

The heir was supposed to be assigned to room 220.

I paused in front of the dormitory building for a moment.

With super sensory, I tried to figure out where the heir would be. It’s a room on the second floor, so...

Ah, there it is.

The room was at the far left on the second floor.

I could hear the sound of two people conversing inside the room, and upon listening, I recognized the voice of Kaen, the heir.

I thought she must have already become acquainted with her roommate, so I entered the men's dormitory.

It was the building right next door, and now that I knew where she was, it shouldn't be hard to keep an eye out for her in her room.

"Room 205."

The room I was assigned to was room 205.

As I stood in front of the door, I sensed a presence inside the room. It seemed like my roommate had entered before me.

Click.

Without much thought, I opened the door and went inside, only to be startled by my roommate's face.

Rigon, who seemed to be sitting at the desk reading a book, was looking in this direction.

"..."

What's this?

Such a coincidence?

They said room assignments were not based on departments but by grade, so it wasn't impossible for Rigon from the Swordsmanship Department to be assigned to the same room as me, but...

"Hello."

Rigon smiled and greeted me first. Of course, there was no way he would recognize me.

I also greeted him, hiding my bewilderment.

"Hello."

“So, you also got assigned to this room? They said we’ll be sharing a room together.”

“Yeah, I know.”

“I’m Rigon. What about you?”

I mouthed the new name I prepared.

“Ran. Let’s get along well from now on.”

Anyway, it was a fortunate occurrence.

I had to develop a close relationship with Rigon, and since we luckily ended up in the same room, we could become friends quickly.

The start of school, meaning the day when actual classes began, was about a week after I entered the dormitory.

During that time, I spent my time smoothly in the academy.

I quickly became close to Rigon. It wasn’t difficult at all to get close to him since Rigon had a very approachable personality even when he was at the Lord’s castle.

On the other hand, I paid attention to how the heir was doing.

Although we occasionally crossed paths while walking, I didn’t make an effort to pretend to know her.

We would be in the same class once school started anyway, and there was no need to forcibly establish contact when there was no special connection at the moment.

Of course, given the nature of the heir’s personality that I saw in the mountains, I doubted she would be wary of me.

I also made a visit to the public library.

Taking advantage of the absence of people, I once again examined the place where the mystery was hidden.

The bookshelf that had made a loud noise when I secretly infiltrated it before.

It's not here.

But the mystery was still absent.

I decided to come and check whenever I had the opportunity because I didn't know when it would be created.

Time continued to pass, and the first day of school approached.

On the day before the first day of school, we had to move to a place like the auditorium for the new student orientation ceremony.

“Welcome to the Academy, where we sincerely hope you can find your own path and talents and grow...”

I looked at the middle-aged man standing on the podium amidst the gathered students.

The headmaster of the Academy, a colleague of the hero who had greatly helped us enter the school smoothly.

After finishing his short welcome speech, he quickly stepped aside.

After the headmaster and a few others finished their speeches, it was time for the oath of the new student representatives.

Even though it was an entrance ceremony for a fantasy world school, it wasn't much different from an entrance ceremony on Earth.

“Lea Herwyn, Vaion Lexio. Please come up to the podium as the representatives of the new students.”

The two students climbed up the podium and stood side by side.

A burly boy, a head taller than the rest of the students, and a girl with striking violet hair.

I checked the level of one of them and was a little surprised.

【Lv. 36】

The boy had a high level, but the girl's level was over 30, surpassing even Rigon by one level.

Considering that most of the new students here were not even level 20, their levels were overwhelming and different.

If it's Herwyn, then surely...

After both of them read the oath quickly and fluently, they descended from the podium.

Next, there was a brief introduction of the professors in charge of the first-year class, and the entrance ceremony soon concluded.

A day passed, and it was the first day of school.

Since classes started at 8 o'clock in the morning, Rigon and I were busy preparing early in the morning.

“Pay attention in class. Let's meet during lunch!”

“Sure.”

After having a simple breakfast in the cafeteria, we greeted each other and parted ways.

Since Rigon and I were in different departments, even the buildings where we took classes were different.

I belong to the Isril class.

Among the three classes in the first year of the Department of Magic, my class was called 'Isril.'

When I arrived at the classroom, I entered through the wide-open front door.

The interior of the classroom was spacious, resembling a university lecture hall on Earth, with a similar structure.

The gazes of a few students who were already seated momentarily focused on me before dispersing.

I looked around and approached an empty seat, then sat down.

Hmm.

The students continued to enter the class as I felt a strange sense of déjà vu at the thought of actually being a student from now on.

Among them, there were people I recognized from my memory.

That person is...

The female student who was the representative of the freshmen at yesterday's entrance ceremony.

As she entered the classroom, the surroundings fell silent for a moment.

She approached and took a seat in the back row near the window. So she's also in the same class.

After a while, murmurs and whispers started to be heard.

"Is that her? The genius from Herwyn."

"I heard she even defeated an official mage from a magic tower."

"Wow, she lives in a completely different world..."

She seemed to have become quite famous among the students.

The Marquis of Herwyn was known as a prestigious magical lineage, even within Santea. I had thought of it when I heard the name at yesterday's entrance ceremony.

Lea Herwyn.

She was not a character who had directly appeared in the game. At least not in my memory.

Of course, that wasn't strange.

Even if someone was called a genius, they were still just a novice, and it's impossible for them to become a giant within just a few years. Or maybe they could have died in some disaster.

"Is this the place? It's quite spacious."

Resting my chin on the desk, lost in my thoughts, I turned my gaze.

The heir was entering the classroom noisily. The girl next to her... must be her roommate.

Amidst the curious gazes around, I heard the roommate asking the heir to lower her voice.

How lively.

It's not a bad thing to have a close friend already.

While having that thought, the heir suddenly looked in my direction, so I turned my gaze.

"Esca, let's sit in the middle."

"Huh? There are plenty of empty seats over there..."

"I prefer the middle."

After saying that, the heir briskly walked over and came to sit in front of me.

It was a peculiar choice of seat, so I looked at her, and she unexpectedly greeted me.

“Hello?”

“Uh, hello.”

Of course, the heir and I had never exchanged a single word.

The two of us sat side by side in the front row. I heard the heir’s friend whispering to her.

“Are you acquainted?”

“No, we’re not.”

Anyway, she was a girl with good charisma.

Now, how should I make this girl satisfy the conditions for inheriting the Holy Sword...

As the class time approached and there were no more students coming in, the professor entered.

Even the heir, who had been talking non-stop in front, finally quieted down a bit.

“That person must be the professor, Esca.”

“Kaen, let’s be a little quieter now...”

The professor was a middle-aged man with a somewhat cold impression.

As the classroom became completely quiet, the students’ gaze focused on him.

Approaching the podium in the center of the stage, he opened his mouth with a low voice.

“I am Rokel, who will be the homeroom teacher for this class for a year. My major is dimensional magic, and the subjects I will be teaching are magic composition and personal combat.”

After finishing the introduction, which couldn't be any shorter, Professor Rokel looked around at the students and spoke.

“Since the first period is my class, we will skip the formalities. Let's start the class right away.”

Chapter 140: Class and Adaptation

(1)

Chapter 140: Class and Adaptation (1)

Rigon's life was the complete opposite of peaceful.

His hometown was destroyed, he suffered from a terrible incurable disease, and his sister, for his sake, gave up everything and became a slave gladiator, living on the brink of life and death for several years.

Rigon walked through the corridors of the academy, feeling a strange emotion about how he ended up here.

In the Department of Swordsmanship, there were a total of five classes, and Rigon was assigned to a class called "Henrietta."

Is this the place?

With a hint of anticipation, Rigon entered the class.

The gazes of several students who were already seated naturally turned towards him.

Rigon wondered if he should greet them, but the atmosphere didn't seem right, so he just went to an empty seat and sat down.

As time passed, students started coming into the class one by one.

Among them, a male student approached Rigon's vicinity, sat down, and greeted him.

“Hey, hello.”

Since he didn't know him, Rigon felt puzzled but still returned the greeting.

“Hello.”

“Are you in room 205? I'm right next door, room 206. Haven't we crossed paths a few times? Don't you remember my face?”

The male student smiled and pointed to his own face.

Rigon let out a small gasp in response. Somehow, he seemed a little familiar.

“I didn't expect us to be in the same class. Let's get along well from now on.”

“Yeah, let's get along well.”

“Jace Mahop, that's my name. I'm the third son of the Mahop family. Have you ever heard of us? We're pretty well known in the south, although things have changed a bit in recent years.”

Since Rigon had no idea what the other was talking about, he awkwardly smiled and lowered his head.

The boy shrugged his shoulders.

“Well, as expected, you don't know either. Can you at least tell me your name?”

“I'm Rigon.”

“Rigon, huh? What about your last name?”

“I don't have a last name.”

Upon hearing that, the male student looked at Rigon with a slightly surprised expression.

“Ah... So you’re not a noble?”

“No.”

He chuckled and lightly tapped Rigon’s shoulder.

“Don’t worry, I don’t ignore or belittle people just because of that. On the contrary, it’s quite remarkable. You were admitted based solely on your abilities without any family background, right?”

“Well, is that so?”

“That’s right. Here, it’s considered foolish to judge someone based on their background. You have to prove yourself with your skills.”

Rigon thought he was a good guy and laughed together.

“By the way, where are you from? I’m curious. Can you tell me if someone recommended you?”

“Oh, I’m from Calderic. I’m not from Santea...”

Rigon replied casually, but the face of the male student, who had been full of laughter, suddenly stiffened.

“...Calderic?”

Instantly, all the students in the classroom turned their gaze towards the two of them.

They, too, stared at Rigon with similar expressions as that of the male student.

“Well, well, that’s how it is. Haha.”

The male student, who had gently removed his hand from Rigon’s shoulder, tightly sealed his lips.

Rigon wanted to ask him why, but stopped when he realized that he was scared.

“Did you hear that? It’s Calderic.”

“Wow, so people are even coming from there...”

In the slightly heavy air, surrounding students murmured among themselves.

Rigon didn’t know it, but this was the image of Calderic in the minds of the people of Santea.

A land of harsh, ruthless dominance, ruled by the continent’s only dRigon.

For the young nobles who grew up in the greenhouse, it was enough to be the subject of caution and fear.

Did he say something unnecessary?

Realizing the atmosphere belatedly, Rigon scratched his head.

It seemed like it wasn’t going smoothly from the start.

The first period was a class on the basic composition of magic: the emission of magical power and the deployment of spells.

In simple terms, it was an in-depth exploration of the process applied to unfold all magic.

“In other words, a formula is essentially shapeless. Trying to teach it through verbal descriptions of what it means to each individual is only slightly less stupid than trying to teach magic to a goblin. So why does this class exist? Do you think there is meaning in this class?”

Professor Rokel looked at a male student sitting in the front as if asking for an answer.

“Well, um...”

The male student became flustered and could only stumble, unable to give a single response.

I watched that scene and scratched my chin. Of course, it was a question I didn't know the answer to either.

The professor's gaze shifted to another student.

“To learn the theory that is commonly applied to all spell deployments...”

“That's something you'll have to learn in the next Theoretical Magic class. Next.”

Although responses from other students continued, no proper answers came out.

Since the professor's gaze reached me, I pretended to ponder for a moment and confidently answered.

“I'm not sure.”

The professor turned his gaze back without much reaction.

This time, his gaze landed on the female student sitting by the window. Lea Herwyn.

She opened her mouth and responded without showing any signs of hesitation.

“I think it's meaningless.”

Only then did a slight change in the professor's expression become apparent.

“Why do you think that way?”

“Because I already fully understand and accept the formulas of my magic. So, at least for me, this class has no meaning. Especially when it came to magic formulas, that is.”

The professor smirked and nodded.

“Well then, can you answer what meaning it might have for other students besides yourself?”

She glanced around once and spoke.

“As you mentioned earlier, magic formulas are essentially intangible. Therefore, inexperienced mages who haven’t fully grasped their own magic have the potential to perceive the form of magic formula differently, in a manner that is more suitable to them. I think this class is about confirming that possibility. So, it might have meaning for someone, or it might have no meaning for someone else for different reasons than mine.”

A smooth answer flowed like water.

Judging by the professor’s reaction, it seemed that her response was correct.

As I pondered her words carefully, I suddenly realized.

Ah... So, that’s what it was?

When I was learning magic in the Lord’s castle, the mage who played the role of teaching me had made great efforts to explain and introduce various forms of magic formulas using words.

It must have been because he had hoped that I had the potential to perceive and accept magic formulas in different ways, just as she had mentioned.

The professor scratched his chin and asked Lea Herwyn again.

“At what point did you come to fully understand your magic formula?”

“I realized it as soon as I started learning magic.”

“I see. Did everyone understand the explanation just now?”

He tapped on the desk and spoke.

“Since magic is intangible, there’s always the possibility of a different interpretation. A trigger would be good for that. This class is designed to give you as much of that trigger as possible, a foundation class that only exists in your first year here.”

“.....”

“As you heard, it’s a very simple reason. Anyone can understand it just by listening. But only one person answered the question correctly. Moreover, it was a student who didn’t need this class in the first place, someone who didn’t even need to know the reason. How did that happen?”

The students fell silent.

“The reason is also simple. You didn’t think for yourselves. You just followed orders and did what you were told. You encountered many magic rituals depicted in text or illustrations and memorized them. You didn’t question why you had to do it.”

I nodded.

I, too, didn’t question and just did as I was told.

“Of course, you can develop your skills that way too. With talent and effort, you can become an outstanding mage. However, the essence of magic lies in exploration. Every trivial doubt and curiosity. The magic rituals you have seen in books are the products of countless mages’ exploration. If you only walk the path others have shown you because it’s convenient, you’ll only be an ordinary mage. Even if you’re exceptional, you’ll never be great.”

As most of the students wore strange expressions, the professor’s face seemed to lose some of its vigor.

“Now, someone might think like this. ‘I’m not going to devote my whole life to magic or anything like that, so why am I hearing this nonsense?’

That's right. Those who want to do it moderately can do so. Learn moderately, focus on your studies moderately, and work hard enough not to be expelled. I don't have much interest in those mediocre people either. For those who are different, I hope my words can be even a small piece of advice."

The professor glanced at the time.

"We'll finish the first class here. Take a break for the remaining time. Since there's no closing ceremony, you can disperse after the class ends. I hope by now you've all familiarized yourselves with the rules."

The professor walked out of the classroom and said as a final remark:

"Tomorrow's field combat is not a class where we just talk like this class. Be well-prepared and come ready."

Even after he left, the classroom remained silent for a while, but soon the tense atmosphere dissipated.

Some students whispered softly, expressing concerns about the professor's strict personality and the challenges they might face in the future. Meanwhile, I looked at the heir sitting in front of me.

"There's something awkward about his way of speaking."

"K-Kaen, you shouldn't talk about the professor like that."

A female friend, taken aback, tried to dissuade the heir.

Nevertheless, it seemed that the heir didn't have a negative impression of the class itself, as a faint smile appeared on her lips, as if she found it amusing.

It was fortunate that she didn't suddenly find it boring and storm out of the class; that would have been troublesome.

The next class was a theoretical magic class.

The professor in charge was a relatively young woman compared to Professor Rokel.

“I am Professor Marind Philisteia, responsible for the theoretical magic class. My specialization is in deciphering magic. If any student has any questions about me, feel free to ask.”

None of the students asked questions.

“If there are none, let’s begin the class right away.”

The theoretical magic class was exactly what the name implied—an exploration of the theories behind magic.

It was an academic discipline that sought commonalities within the infinite forms of magic and visually represented them. It was the culmination of knowledge and wisdom that numerous mages had compiled and developed over many ages.

When I was taught magic at the castle, the mage who instructed me used this analogy:

“If the spell is the body, then theory can be likened to a sword or a spear. Understanding and accepting the spell is akin to training the body itself, while applying theory is like wielding a weapon.”

However, the weapon that suited each person varied.

A sword might work best for some, a mace for others, and a whip for a few.

That’s why it’s important to learn theories, to constantly explore what worked best for you, and to apply that regularity to your technique to increase your proficiency with the weapon best suited for you.

Creating completely new magic that did not exist in the world was also generally said to start from theory.

But it's really difficult.

Magic theory was a different field of talent than sensing magic.

However, it was equally difficult for me.

Because this theory was no different from studying mathematics.

Mathematics was the subject that I gave up on and dropped early even in high school.

Professor Marind surveyed the students and said, "It would be appropriate to divide into four people. Now, sit close to each other with four people. I will conduct my class in a group format."

Group class? Was that how it's done?

I thought it was a good thing.

If forming groups meant being with people who were sitting close to one another, then I was in the same group as the heir.

"Um, no. I should just divide based on the attendance list. Please sit back."

But suddenly, the professor changed her mind when she saw the students moving around.

Oh, well, let's just go with it.

"Arya Mankhast, Andy Grimmett, and Osilia Troang..."

Unfortunately, there was no heir in the group I belonged to.

Instead, there was someone extraordinary, and that person was Lea Herwyn, who became a part of the same group as me.

"The topic of the first class is fire magic. I will now share the materials, so please solve the problems I write on the board using the theories provided

in the materials. First, discuss and solve the problems among your group members, and then I will explain the solutions. You'll 30 minutes."

As I skimmed through the materials and the problems on the board, I already felt my thoughts becoming disorganized.

Fire magic, which belonged to the fundamentals of elemental magic.

Of course, it was a magic that I could easily perform at the moment, but theory was a different story.

Magical theory was a discipline that involved applying the basic forms of magic in various ways.

"Um... What should we do?"

One of my group members spoke up.

The gaze of the team members, including myself, naturally focused on one person—Lea Herwyn.

She, who had been reading the materials, glanced at us and said.

"We should divide the work and solve it."

"Yeah, that's right. But we should discuss how to approach it first..."

"No need for that. I've already interpreted everything."

She swiftly wrote something on a piece of paper and showed it to us.

"This is how we should solve the problem. I'll take care of the calculation part, so everyone can work on their own calculations. Any objections?"

The group members were left speechless, their heads nodding up and down.

I was surprised as well. She had received the materials just a few minutes ago, and now she had already solved the problem by herself?

She's a real genius.

Lea quickly divided the calculations onto four sheets of paper. The most difficult-looking equation was assigned to herself, while the rest was given to us.

With the interpretation done, all we needed to do was to perform the calculations individually and combine our results to complete the problem.

“...”

I diligently worked on my share of calculations, scribbling with a pen on the paper.

However, it was not going smoothly.

Because even simple calculations were not familiar to me as a beginner.

I was confused by the sign interpretation, so I started the calculations all over again from the beginning, and I had to redo the calculations I had done multiple times because the expected values were not coming out.

As I stumbled along like that, before I knew it, the other team members had finished all their calculations and were all looking at me.

Isn't this embarrassing?

For a moment, I wondered what I was doing here.

Amidst the focused gazes, I silently continued my calculations.

“There are 5 minutes left. Start wrapping up.”

After the professor's words, Lea looked at me in disbelief and asked.

“Is it still not finished?”

I nodded my head.

“Sorry, but I don’t think I can finish it in 5 minutes.”

She looked at my paper.

Glancing over the traces of miserable attempts written on the paper, she looked at me with a contemptuous gaze.

“...I wonder how you got into this school.”

She snatched my paper and started doing the calculations herself.

And in an instant, she finished the calculations and gathered the remaining papers, writing a lengthy explanation in one place.

While watching that scene, I thought to myself.

Nice.

Since I ended up in a group with this guy, I wondered if theory classes would go smoothly from now on.

After the theory class ended, it was lunchtime.

The day consisted of two classes in the morning and one or two classes in the afternoon, with a lunch break at noon.

It wasn’t as demanding as I had thought, but the class duration was 90 minutes, so it wasn’t that relaxed either.

Now... um.

I contemplated whether I should pretend to know the heir who was leaving the classroom with her friend, but I missed the timing.

Why did it feel more challenging to try to eat with a sixteen-year-old kid than to fight with the Black Sea Empress?

Part of the reason was that I was being overly cautious.

Building a relationship with the heir was crucial, so I felt a burden not to ruin things from the beginning.

For now, I decided to let lunch pass and planned to talk to her after the afternoon classes.

I encountered Rigon as I headed to the cafeteria.

Since breakfast, lunch, and dinner were all included in the tuition fee, we didn't need to pay separately.

"So, how was class? I'm sure there's a lot to learn about magic."

"Well, it's decent enough to listen to."

Come to think of it, Rigon seemed to have learned not only swordsmanship but also magic.

While chatting in line, I received my meal and looked for a suitable place to sit down... Oh.

Suddenly, I caught sight of the heir having a meal with her friend.

Coincidentally, there were two empty seats.

After a brief moment of consideration, I asked Rigon, "Rigon, would you like to go over there and sit?"

"Huh? Do you know them?"

"We're classmates, and I thought it would be nice to get to know each other."

It was more of a problem for Rigon than for me to make a connection with the heir, but this was a great opportunity, nonetheless.

Rigon nodded without much resistance.

“...?”

As the two approached the seat where the two of them were sitting, the heir's friend gave a curious glance first.

The heir, who had been focused on cutting meat, also looked at us shortly after.

I smiled brightly and greeted them.

“Hello. By any chance, do you remember who I am?”

The heir's friend seemed to recognize me.

“Did you sit in the back during the class earlier?”

“That's right. Can I join you? I happened to notice you while looking for a place to sit.”

She blinked her eyes and then turned to the heir.

“Do you want to sit together? I don't mind.”

It was the expected reaction.

Successfully, we ended up sitting together for the meal.

“I'm Ran, and this is Rigon. We're roommates, although he's not in the Department of Magic but in the Department of Swordsmanship.”

“Uhm, nice to meet you. I'm Esca Marioles. Since we're roommates too, we became close quickly.”

The heir's friend, Esca, responded with a hesitant smile.

“I'm Kaen. But by the way, both of you don't have surnames?”

The heir chimed in and asked us.

I nodded.

“Well, both of us are commoners.”

“Commoners, that means not nobles, right?”

I wondered why she was acting like that and looked at her curiously.

“Strangely enough, every person I talk to asked about my last name when I tell them my name. And once they found out that I don’t have one, they somehow just ignore me. Except for Esca.”

“…”

“Do you guys experience the same thing? Do you know why?”

At the innocent question, I scratched my cheek.

Esca seemed surprised that the heir looked like she really didn’t know the answer to that question.

The heir still lacked common knowledge about the world. Naturally, her understanding of social classes would be lacking as well.

Rigon, who was sipping soup, responded with an expression that seemed to question why she didn’t know something so simple.

“It’s because there are a lot of nobles who look down on commoners.”

“Really? Why?”

“Because of their low status?”

The heir looked puzzled.

“They ignore me just because of my lower status? Why is that?”

“It’s just the way nobles are. They look down on people who don’t have what they have. There are few nobles who don’t look down on commoners

like your friend. It's not necessarily unique to nobles, it's just human nature, isn't it?"

I was a bit surprised to hear Rigon say such a cynical thing so casually.

After all, he didn't live in the mountains like the heir, and had been through a lot with Reef.

The heir still looked as if she didn't quite understand, but she still nodded in understanding.

Suddenly, she stared at Esca and said.

"Esca, you're really a good girl, aren't you? Even though you're a noble, you get along with me."

"What? Why are you suddenly saying that? Ahaha..."

Esca laughed a little, seeming a bit embarrassed.

"I would never disregard others and think of myself as an amazing person. I'm just a noble in name only."

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"I'm simply saying that I'm no different from all of you. My family is just a small noble family from a remote region. We're not the kind of amazing nobles you might think we are."

So, she's a minor noble.

Of course, not all those who belonged to nobility lived well.

"Well, I don't really understand what you're talking about. Anyway, Esca, you're a good girl."

"Yeah, sure."

Esca seemed to be now used to the heir's casual remarks.

“Oh, but can I talk about my background as well? It feels like I’m deceiving you if I don’t say anything.”

However, at that moment, Rigon brought up an unexpected topic.

“I’m not from Santea; I’m from Calderic. I came to Elphon after being recommended by the Seventh Lord.”

It was a story he had already brought up before, so I wondered why he suddenly mentioned it.

The heir didn’t show much reaction.

So? That was the expression on her face as she looked at Rigon, but suddenly her eyes widened.

“Oh? If you’re from the Seventh Lord... Ah.”

The heir, who seemed like he was about to say something, closed her mouth as if realizing something.

I looked at her and inwardly felt slightly relieved.

She must have been told to keep our previous encounter a secret. She stopped herself from saying unnecessary things.

“Cal-Calderic?”

Esca was greatly surprised by Rigon’s words.

The heir looked at her with a puzzled expression, and Rigon let out a small sigh before speaking.

“I guess the kids here don’t like people from Calderic. I brought it up in class once, and they all avoided me.”

“Oh, really? But why?”

Ah, was that the case?

Having understood the situation, I chimed in.

“It’s because people here don’t have a favorable perception of Calderic. However, regardless of that, Rigon is a good guy, so I hope there won’t be any misunderstandings.”

“I don’t really care about misunderstandings. I don’t even know why there’s a negative perception in the first place. I don’t have any intention to avoid someone just because they come from Calderic, so don’t worry.”

Rigon looked a bit surprised at the completely nonchalant response from the heir, then he lightly chuckled.

“Isn’t that right, Esca?”

“Huh? Um... sorry. I was just a little surprised.”

Esca looked at Rigon and seemed to calm down.

That could be considered a typical response.

“But Rigon, what’s your relationship with the Seventh Lord? I heard that the Lords of Calderic are all very powerful people, so doesn’t that mean you’re from a powerful family?”

“It’s not like that. I just happened to have my life saved by that person.”

As the heir had also met me before, there was a sense of curiosity in Rigon’s story.

Observing the two people talking about me in front of me, I felt a slightly strange sensation.

Regardless, have they found a common ground?

Whatever the case, I decided to think positively since it seemed like the two of them would continue to get along well in the future.

Chapter 141: Class and Adaptation

(2)

Chapter 141: Class and Adaptation (2)

The next day, the second period class was a combat training class.

The professor in charge was Professor Rokel, who was also the homeroom teacher they met the previous day.

Instead of the classroom, the students gathered in a spacious training ground-like area and formed a circle.

“The combat training class is exactly what it sounds like, a class that trains combat against people,” the professor explained, standing in the center.

“You will first learn about magic battle, fighting against your fellow mages. What do you think is the most important thing in a magic battle?”

A question was asked, just like yesterday’s class.

This time, however, Professor Rokel didn’t wait for an answer and continued.

“Actually, there is no single most important thing in magic battles. The amount of mana you have, the speed at which you cast your spells, the variety of spells you’ve learned and the effectiveness of your combinations, the insight you have into reading and dissecting your opponent’s spells, the use of the environment, psychological warfare, all of these are important. Unless there is an overwhelming difference in skill, magic battle is a mass of variables where no single factor can determine absolute dominance.”

He suddenly pointed at two students.

“As I said, this class is not just about talking. What are your names?”

The students who were pointed at answered.

“I’m Sebastian Madir.”

“I’m Hunt Arsen.”

“Sebastian Madir, Hunt Arsen. Step forward and face each other in the center.”

They came out with a bewildered look and stood facing each other in the center of the training ground.

As I watched that scene, I pondered.

Instead of the professor teaching them, he’s going to have them fight each other in class?

“There are no specific rules or limitations. It’s a sparring session, but think of it as a real battle and give your best from now on.”

With those words, Professor Rokel stepped back and crossed his arms.

Suddenly being told to fight, they looked bewildered and just stared at the professor.

“Victory is determined by my judgment until I stop the contest. The content and results of the duel will be included in your grade.”

Upon hearing that the results were included in the records, the two students finally showed a serious expression.

“Start when I count to three. One, two...”

As the battle began, Sebastian took the initiative and launched a fireball.

The opponent also deployed a defensive magic almost simultaneously, but the fireball collided with the barrier and exploded, spreading flames.

Some students, unfamiliar with such a real battle, showed signs of tension.

Bang! Clang!

One after another, the loud sounds resonated as magical forces collided.

For a while, the battle unfolded with Sebastian continuously unleashing offensive magic and pressing forward.

However, at some point, Hunt suddenly took control of the flow and began counterattacking.

Sebastian struggled to completely block the impact of the magic wave from his opponent and staggered. It was then that the professor intervened.

“Stop. The duel is over.”

Hunt breathed out with a relaxed expression, while Sebastian displayed a slightly frustrated demeanor.

Professor Rokel looked at the two of them alternately.

“Sebastian Madir, the duel is your defeat. What do you think was the reason for your defeat?”

He glanced around and answered in a low voice.

“My mana and output were slightly insufficient compared to my opponent’s.”

“Is that the only reason?”

“It seems so. At least, if we were evenly matched, I would have gained the upper hand first.”

“Then you willingly engaged in a firepower battle without even realizing that your opponent had a superior total amount of mana, and you just threw your attacks against his shields?”

“...”

“Of course, if your total mana had been significantly superior, you would have had a higher chance of seizing the initiative and winning. However, the outcome became a defeat because you exhausted all of your mana first. Can you afford such a gamble even in a battle where your life is at stake?”

Finally realizing his own mistake, Sebastian displayed a look of frustration.

“I’ll ask again. What do you think was the reason for your defeat?”

“Well... Not only was my total mana insufficient, but I also didn’t take into account the opponent’s abilities from the beginning.”

“In that case, how do you plan to proceed with the battle when you don’t accurately know the opponent’s capabilities?”

“I think I will prioritize exploring the opponent while conserving mana as much as possible.”

Professor Rokel smirked.

“Yes, exploration. It’s the basics of basics. Even while speaking, you must have wondered why you forgot such an obvious thing. Learning through words and writing is one thing, but remembering and applying even the simplest things in practical combat is a huge difference.”

He then shifted his gaze towards Hunt.

“Hunt, do you think there are any points of improvement for yourself despite winning the duel?”

“At first, I let my guard down and easily gave the initiative to the opponent.”

“Right. If you hadn’t done that, you could have seized the advantage more easily. Apart from the total amount of mana, your levels were roughly similar.”

Professor Rokel nodded.

“Of course, there are plenty of other shortcomings, but let’s wrap it up for today since it’s the first day. The elements I just mentioned were the focal points for now. I hope you have studied enough. You may leave now.”

It was a short and clear feedback. It seemed that this was how the lessons were conducted.

The two individuals returned to their positions, their emotions contrasting.

Professor Rokel immediately scanned through the students as if searching for the next sparring partners. His gaze then stopped at me, directly.

And the next person his gaze landed on was none other than Lea.

“There, those two. What are their names?”

...Of all people, why was it her again?

Yesterday, starting from the theory class, it seemed quite coincidental how well everything was connected.

“I’m Ran.”

Lea looked at my direction for a moment and replied, “I’m Lea Herwyn.”

“Come to the center. From now on, all students will engage in one-on-one combat like this continuously.”

Lea and I stepped forward to the center of the training ground, facing each other.

I could feel some students looking at me with pity, probably because of my opponent.

Of course, there was no way I could win the duel with magic alone.

Her level was 36, while my magic skills probably didn't even reach 20 according to the level scale.

Shouldn't it be over in a few seconds?

Although there were no specific restrictions mentioned, it made sense to strengthen our bodies for combat in a magic combat class. It's not like we had swords or anything.

Once the duel began, I immediately prepared defensive magic in anticipation of an attack.

However, Lea, for some reason, stood still without launching an attack and just stared in my direction.

It was as if she was giving me an opportunity to attack as much as I wanted.

Well, if that's the case.

I smirked and unleashed my offensive magic.

Since my attack wouldn't pierce her defense anyway, I could use my full power without hesitation.

Boom!

The shockwave magic I had focused on a narrow range was blocked by her shield and dissipated.

Seeing the unexpected power, Lea's eyes widened slightly.

I quickly followed up by creating fireballs and spreading them around her.

She was using a shield in a disc shape that covered her entire body, but that meant if she missed blocking even one attack, it would be fatal, despite the low consumption of mana.

In short, she had the confidence that she could block all of my attack with just her manipulation skills, without the need to counter with her own magic.

I spun the fireball around chaotically and shot it from various angles.

In response, Lea didn't even blink an eye and formed several shield-like barriers, effectively blocking all the incoming fireballs.

It was blocked much more easily than I had anticipated.

There was no field where I could gain an advantage over Lea, who was already far superior to me in terms of magical control.

Since there were no attack patterns that came to mind anymore, I simply unleashed a flash spell with a throw-and-see approach.

Flash!

An intense light exploded, obscuring the field of vision.

In the meantime, I created another fireball and shot it again. However, it was still in vain.

An opponent of that level wouldn't be defenseless just because their field of vision was limited.

As the vision returned, I saw the opponent looking at me with an incredulous expression.

She retracted the shield and opened her mouth.

“Is there anything else you want to show?”

Then she reached out her hand and unleashed a shockwave spell.

I immediately cast a defensive spell, but as soon as the shield collided with the shockwave, it shattered into pieces.

I staggered back a step. The power was enough to cleanly destroy just the shield.

“The duel is over.”

Since it was clearly a decisive battle, Professor Rokel stepped in.

However, I had tried everything and lost, so I didn’t feel any regrets.

“Ran, what do you think was the reason for your defeat?”

It was a question that required no deliberation, so I answered right away.

“There was a significant difference in capabilities in every aspect.”

“Then how do you plan to lead such battles with opponents in the future?”

I paused for a moment, unsure of the question’s intent.

Lead? Lead what? The difference in magic between us was overwhelming in every aspect. Maybe he’s just asking for the heck of it.

“I guess I just have to fight as best I can.”

“Is that all?”

“I’ll leave it up to luck and even take chances if there’s even a slight possibility. I would try to escape if I can. But ideally, it would be best not to create a situation where I have to fight such an enemy in the first place.”

It was a somewhat serious answer, but a few students chuckled softly.

Professor Rokel also chuckled and nodded.

“I see. It was in your best interest to bet on your ability to control your mana, but before that, the difference in capability was too great. Your mana and control abilities were outstanding, but the rest were lacking. In the future, you should focus more on your progress in spellcasting rather than the magical aspect.”

I nodded my head.

As someone weak in spellcasting, I still had a limited repertoire of spells and a considerably slow pace in casting magic.

The reason I had time to defend was that the opponent gave me the leeway to put up a defense. Otherwise, I wouldn't have had a chance to deploy a protective barrier.

“Leah Herwyn, you were... flawless. But why didn't you give it your all?”

In response to the professor's question, she answered with a lack of enthusiasm on her face.

“Because if I had given it my all, it would have been over as soon as it started, and I don't think that's the point of a duel at all.”

“Are you showing consideration for your opponent?”

“I just didn't want to blur the meaning of the class.”

It was a statement that struck a chord with me.

Like she was saying that having students compete against each other in this way was not helpful to her.

And even if she truly meant it in that sense, it couldn't be called arrogance. It was a fact. Her level far surpassed that of a freshman.

Professor Rokel spoke with a faint smile.

“You two may now return to your seats.”

After a few students had their turns, it was Esca's turn.

She was nervous, but the Heir smiled and patted her on the back.

“Whoa...”

The duel began, and surprisingly, Esca took the initiative and unleashed her magic aggressively.

The shockwave magic flew towards her opponent, but the opponent's prepared defensive magic easily blocked it.

【Lv. 11】

I easily deduced the outcome of the duel while observing that spectacle.

It was because Esca's level was lower than her opponent's. Her level was among the lowest in the class.

Having roughly grasped Esca's power with that last strike, her opponent immediately launched a counterattack.

Esca struggled to defend against the fierce onslaught, but quickly reached her limit.

Boom!

Esca's defense barrier was completely shattered by the opponent's attack.

At the same time, another barrier formed around her, blocking the impact.

It was Professor Rokel who had set up the barrier before any danger occurred. The professor, who had withdrawn his hand, opened his mouth.

"The duel is over."

He said to Esca with a dry tone, looking at her.

"Esca Marioles, you have lost. What do you think was the reason for your defeat?"

Breathing heavily, Esca spoke with an unconfident voice.

"...I think my overall magical skills were lacking compared to the opponent."

“That’s correct. To put it bluntly, it was abysmal, even for a freshman. It seems that you need to improve your abilities in the realm of pure magic before you improve in the realm of combat.”

A shadow was cast over Esca’s face by an unreserved and harsh criticism.

As the two returned to their positions, it seemed like the heir was about to say something to Esca, but stopped herself.

The heir turned her gaze and glared at Professor Rokel. Perhaps she was angered by the harsh words her friend had received.

The heir’s turn came almost at the very end.

Well, most of the students were at the beginner level, so after a few exchanges, they exhausted their mana, and each match ended quickly.

As I observed the two people standing face to face, I thought to myself, ‘The level of magic is still that of a beginner.’

According to the hero, the heir had exceptional talent not only in swordsmanship but also in magic.

However, unlike swordsmanship, she hadn’t properly learned magic, so she only knew basic spells like me.

Of course, even so, the outcome of this match was already determined.

Although her magic skill was still at a beginner level, his mana was not.

【Level 32】

Her level was in the thirties, lower than Rigon and Lea.

But her mana level was definitely not that of a beginner.

As soon as the match began, the heir raised her hand and said, “I’m going to attack with fire magic. Properly defend yourself.”

“...Uh?”

Immediately after, she conjured flames, as if demonstrating.

Only after the opponent hurriedly cast a defensive spell did she launch a fireball.

Boom!

With a loud noise, it seemed like the opponent's defensive barrier was partially shattered.

The heir looked at it and ignited the flames once again, this time even more intense.

“Let's go once more.”

The opponent appeared terrified.

However, before that, the professor spoke up.

“The duel is over.”

The heir turned to the professor with a smirk, extinguished the flames, and asked him in an antagonistic tone.

“How was I? Professor.”

Professor Rokel stared at her and replied.

“The level of magic power was exceptional, and the speed of spell casting was outstanding. However, you engaged in actions that were difficult to comprehend. Are you planning to announce your attack to your opponent even in a real battle?”

“No. But this is a training session.”

“I told you to approach it as if it were a real battle.”

The heir was momentarily at a loss for words but retorted as if something had occurred to her.

“If I had done my best, the opponent wouldn’t have been able to block the first attack, and it would have ended right away. Doesn’t that blur the purpose of this lesson?”

I was dumbfounded and let out a small laugh.

The heir was clumsily borrowing the words Lea had said to the professor earlier.

It seemed like she was simply being difficult because she didn’t like the professor for no apparent reason.

Curious about the reaction, I turned to Lea, and she had an unpleasant look in her eyes.

Despite the heir’s rebellious attitude, Professor Rokel still spoke in a dry tone.

“Your rudeness will not save your friend’s face. Now, return to your seat.”

Hearing that, the heir turned around with an unsatisfied expression.

However, even so, it seemed like she understood from the professor’s words that she had done something not so good, as she said to the student who was her opponent.

“I’m sorry. I didn’t do that to tease you or to ignore you.”

“Uh? Yeah...”

After all the remaining students finished their sparring, it was the perfect timing for the class to end.

The class was even more intense than the first day, and the students seemed to be exhausted.

Professor Rokel clicked his tongue slightly.

“Now it’s just the first class. It would be better for everyone to adapt as soon as possible.”

Meanwhile, around the same time, the students from Rigon’s class gathered at the training grounds for combat training.

“So, what’s the big deal about him being so scary?”

Nearby, a conversation reached Rigon’s ear as he stood alone, motionless.

“People are just scared of where he came from, Calderic. It’s not like he looks particularly intimidating, all slender and delicate.”

“Hey, hey. He can hear us...”

“What if he can hear it? He can listen.”

“Do you really have no fear? They say the student from Calderic is recommended directly by the Lord.”

“That’s all just baseless rumors. Does it even make sense? He’s a guy with no family name, so where would he come from?”

Rigon turned his head, knowing that they were talking about him.

The male student, whose eyes met Rigon’s, flinched, then smirked confidently and quickly turned his gaze away.

Rigon let out a small sigh.

This won’t be easy.

Within a day, he had already been stigmatized within the class.

At this rate, he wondered if he would end up with no friends other than three people until graduation.

“Quiet down, will you?”

Suddenly, a deep voice interrupted, and the two chattering male students immediately shut their mouths in surprise.

The owner of the voice was a male student standing right next to them.

Rigon had seen his face before the start of the semester.

He was the male student who was the representative of the freshmen at the entrance ceremony. His name was Vaion Lexio, if he recalled correctly.

He was a promising talent from a prestigious martial arts school and he was already well known among the students of the Swordsmanship Department even before the semester began.

“Everyone, be quiet.”

Not long after, the assigned professor entered the training grounds. It was a woman dressed in training attire.

She glanced around and introduced herself.

“I am Gaon Cessilia, the professor in charge of hand-to-hand combat classes.”

“.....”

“Well, I guess my name doesn’t really matter. Stop standing there dumbfounded and grab the training swords over there.”

Once the students had all taken their swords, Professor Gaon smirked and said, “From now on, you will have a sword duel. The first two to volunteer, come to the center.”

“.....”

“Are you embarrassed to be asked to fight all of a sudden? This is the nature of hand-to-hand combat. Of course, every fight counts towards your grade. I’m going to give extra credit to the first person to step up. So are you going to sit on the sidelines?”

One student quickly stepped forward, and another student followed suit.

Rigon watched the scene with great interest.

Compared to the theoretical lessons from yesterday, this hands-on class was more to Rigon’s liking.

“Alright, let’s get started. Think of it as a battle for your life and give it your best shot.”

The class proceeded with the students engaging in sparring, followed by feedback from the professor.

However, Professor Gaon’s feedback was generally harsh.

“Why do you miss the opportunity to counterattack when you know it? Are you scared to even cut your opponent with a training sword, you coward?”

“Every time you swing your sword, your body’s balance is a mess. What are your legs made of, straw?”

“Why do you always waste your energy without any strategy? Fix that habit. You’re just wasting your breath for no reason.”

After the practice sparring, the defeated students returned to their seats with a gloomy expression, unable to escape from criticism.

Rigon watched, comparing the professor’s words to his own impressions. There were differences, but for the most part, they were in agreement.

“Next is…”

Midway through the class, the professor’s gaze fell upon Rigon.

She gave a strange smile and said, “You’re the guy who came from Calderic, right? Let’s see your skills. Come forward.”

Rigon stepped forward in the midst of the attention, walking slowly to the center of the training grounds.

“And you, come forward.”

“Yes? Yes.”

The next student who was called stepped forward.

He was the male student who had slandered Rigon earlier.

Both of them stood facing each other, holding their swords.

With a smile on his lips, the male student confidently raised his sword.

Rigon also extended his sword, thinking it would be better to show at least some courtesy.

“Begin the duel.”

As the professor’s words fell, the male student rushed towards Rigon with great momentum.

He had been thinking that he wanted to test himself against Rigon.

With everyone watching, if he could bring Rigon down, his reputation in the class would skyrocket.

I’ll knock him down to the ground!

The moment when the distance between the two people narrowed within the range of clashing swords.

Kaang!

The male student screamed in pain as if his hand was being torn apart in an instant.

The sword he had let go of was flying through the air, leaving him wondering what had happened.

Rigon, who had picked up the sword, scratched his head and looked at the bewildered face of the male student.

Did I use too much strength?

He had tried to control his strength, but maybe he should have just blocked it instead of attacking.

Regardless, the duel ended there. It was just one exchange.

There was nothing as fatal during a battle as losing one's own sword.

"It's over. That was anticlimactic."

Amidst the astonishment of the students, Professor Gaon spoke with a laughter-tinged voice.

The male student, regaining his composure, stammered.

"P-Professor, I... I was too careless..."

"Careless? I clearly told you to approach it as if your life depended on it. And now you're telling me that you couldn't even demonstrate your skills properly and lost in just one exchange?"

She looked at him with disdainful eyes.

"There's nothing to say since it ended so quickly. Just go back to your seat, you pathetic fool. Your mindset is the problem."

Professor Gaon turned her gaze towards Rigon.

"What's your name?"

“Rigon, ma’am.”

“Alright, Rigon. You were excellent. You got all the basics right in that one move. Go back.”

Praise instead of criticism for the first time.

Rigon went back to his seat, and the boy went back to his seat, looking devastated.

“Next up... You, come out.”

The student Professor Gaon pointed to next was Vaion Lexio.

Vaion walked to the center of the training grounds, picking out a sword that was more like a greatsword.

The male student selected as his opponent stood facing him, showing signs of great tension.

Kwang!

As soon as the sparring began, Vaion rushed forward at an incredible speed that didn’t match his size and swung his sword.

The opposing student hurriedly raised his sword to defend, but with a loud sound, he was sent flying in the air and fell to the ground without any strength.

Just like with Rigon, the sparring ended at a single strike.

The students gasped in awe at Vaion’s tremendous power and watched the scene unfold before them.

“...”

Vaion, having sheathed his sword, turned his gaze towards Rigon.

Rigon also blinked his eyes, confused by why he was being stared at all of a sudden.

Professor Rokel, walking down the hallway, had a slightly tired expression when he saw a woman walking towards him from the opposite side.

Professor Gaon gave him a friendly nod of recognition.

“Professor Rokel. Are you going back after finishing class?”

“Yes.”

“My class just ended as well and was on my way back. How was your class?”

Before Rokel could answer, she immediately continued speaking.

“Well, I was surprised. Did you know that there is a student from Calderic in the swordsmanship department?”

“I am aware.”

“His name is Rigon, and he was in the class I just had. He was amazing, already on par with a full knight.”

“I see.”

Professor Rokel thought it was somewhat surprising.

If even Professor Gaon, who was stricter than himself, praised him to that extent, it meant he was truly talented. However, he wasn't particularly curious about the students in the Swordsmanship Department.

“By the way, aren't there any geniuses in your class, Professor? Wasn't there a famous student named Lea Herwyn?”

“Don't show interest in other people's students.”

“Haha, I’m just looking forward to the future exchange class. You seem grumpy.”

Professor Gaon laughed heartily.

“Speaking of which, I have something to tell you about the semester exams. How about having lunch together?”

“Sorry, I’m busy. We can talk later.”

“Oh, don’t do that...”

After shaking off persistent Professor Gaon, Professor Rokel returned to his office.

He sat down and organized his documents, leaning back in his chair.

And for a moment, he lost himself in thought. About the students who left an impression during the personal combat class earlier.

Leah Herwyn. The famous prodigy from the Herwyn family.

Her performance in today’s class was indeed as rumored.

Even in the short sparring, Professor Rokel could clearly see her current level and absurd talent.

If she could grow at such a rate at the tender age of fifteen, he wondered if she would surpass the professors at Elphon before she reached thirty.

“And...”

The two students who were presumed to have been admitted through the direct recommendation of the headmaster.

Kaen and Ran.

Originally, Professor Rokel had no interest in the backgrounds of the students. However, he had a bit of curiosity about those two.

His colleague, the current headmaster, Nuremberg, had never used his authority to recommend students for admission since taking office. This fact alone sparked his curiosity.

There were certainly some peculiarities that caught his attention, whether it was their well-trained physique or their aura. Both seemed closer to warriors than mages.

The only difference was that the child named Kaen had talent in magic, while Ran did not.

From Rokel's perspective, Kaen was also a genius. Although there were some shortcomings, if she continued to learn well, she would become an exceptional mage in the future, comparable to Lea.

However, Rokel couldn't understand why Ran, that child, chose to enter the Department of Magic instead of the Department of Swordsmanship.

Lost in his contemplation, Professor Rokel resumed organizing his documents.

One thing was clear: this year's first-year students were much more interesting than last year's.

Chapter 142: Class and Adaptation

(3)

Chapter 142: Class and Adaptation (3)

A week or so has passed since I entered Elphon Academy.

In that time, I had grown quite close to the heir, Kaen.

There were always four of us at meals, including Rigon and Esca. I also purposely kept running into the heir and socializing with her as much as possible, so it was only a matter of time before we got to know each other.

Even Esca, who had been a little uncomfortable with Rigon at first, seemed to get over her prejudices as she got to know him.

“...”

When I woke up from sleep, I instinctively checked for the presence of Kaen in the room next building.

I could hear only the even breathing of the two as they were still asleep.

After checking the time, I got out of bed and prepared to wash up.

At Elphon, there was a six-day cycle, with five days of classes and one day off. And today happened to be the day off.

So there was no need to be so diligent in the early morning hours, but that didn't apply to me.

I always went to bed later than Kaen and woke up earlier, so I could be mindful of her routines.

I didn't expect anything dangerous to happen inside the academy, but that didn't mean I should let my guard down.

As if on cue, Rigon woke up and stretched.

"...Ran, we don't have class today. Do you have plans?"

"Well..."

Of course, it depended on what Kaen was going to do.

And I already knew what she was going to do today.

I'd listened to everything she'd said to Esca last night.

She said she would go out of the academy today.

On days with no classes, students were free to do whatever they wanted. They could play or engage in self-study.

And going outside the academy was also allowed.

Kaen was probably going to go out and explore the city with Esca today.

For me, it wasn't a bad thing. In fact, I had a little bit of anticipation.

My ultimate goal was to ensure that Kaen fulfilled the conditions for obtaining the Holy Sword, and going outside meant that anything could happen.

When it was time to eat breakfast, Rigon and I left the dormitory.

We met Kaen and Esca at the cafeteria and had breakfast together.

"So, Esca and I were planning to practice magic at the training grounds and then go outside. How about you guys?"

Kaen said with excitement, her mouth full of food.

Before I could answer, Rigon responded first.

“I wanted to go out at least once too. I haven’t properly explored the city since I came straight to the academy.”

“Really? That works out. Let’s enjoy sightseeing together today.”

“We were given permission to go out from 10 a.m. You’re going as well, right, Ran?”

“Of course.”

I nodded.

After eating, we trained together in the training grounds as planned.

Rigon trained in swordsmanship, while the three of us, including me, practiced magic.

I watched Esca, completely focused on unfolding her magic, sweat dripping down her face.

“So, it’s like merging the formulas in your mind with mana? Ah, it’s hard to explain in words.”

Kaen stood next to her, making an effort to explain her own technique.

Of course, since the formula was a highly personal area, it didn’t seem to be much help to Esca.

From what I could see, Esca had even less talent for magic than me.

She could barely unleash magic, just enough to pass as a mage.

The reason Kaen wanted to train with Esca today was probably because of our last combat lesson. More to help Esca than to improve herself.

But even if Professor Rokel's words were a bit harsh, he didn't seem to be wrong.

"Ugh..."

Esca, who had quickly exhausted all of her mana, collapsed to the ground.

She spoke with an embarrassed smile.

"It's still difficult. I guess I don't have much talent for magic."

"Oh, come on. It's not like that. If you practice more, you'll definitely get better."

Meanwhile, Rigon, who had been swinging his sword alone on one side, approached us.

"Shall we rest for a while and then head out?"

"Let's do that."

Rigon glanced at Kaen and suddenly asked.

"By the way, Kaen, have you learned martial arts as well as magic like Ran?"

"Oh, yeah. How did you know?"

"Well, it shows from your body. Your hands are calloused."

As I listened to the conversation, I suddenly wondered who would win in a sword duel between the two of them.

Although Rigon had a slightly higher level, the difference in levels in the 30s wasn't significant enough to determine the outcome of a fight.

Of course, I couldn't suddenly ask them to fight, so my curiosity ended there.

The permitted hours for going out on day-offs were from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m.

We filled out a sign-in sheet. We were warned to come back and check in with our supervisor on time or face demerits, and then we headed out of the academy.

Not only us, but there were many students who went out since morning, so the streets were quite lively. It was a precious outing time of only eight hours once a week.

“Do you have any place in mind to go?”

“No. Just strolling around and sightseeing, that's all.”

Raphid City was a big city, and there's quite a bit to see just by walking down the main street.

We watched a play in the square and wandered into the marketplace.

Looking at the food displayed at the street stalls, Kaen's eyes sparkled.

“That looks really delicious. Do you know what that is, Esca?”

“Well, it seems to be a food where potatoes are thinly sliced and deep-fried...”

Kaen and Esca bought something similar to potato fries, while Rigon got some skewers with heavily seasoned chicken from somewhere.

I bought a jar full of caramels and other goodies to share with the kids.

We walked through the lively streets, buying and sharing snacks.

“...?”

It was then, in the distance, that a somewhat familiar face caught my eye.

A middle-aged man standing in front of a fruit stall, looking at the fruits.

For a moment, I thought I must have been mistaken, but I wasn't.

...What's that?

Why was he here?"

Why was that person here and why didn't the hero warned me about this?

The distance grew closer, and Kaen, who had also spotted the man, showed a rare look of bewilderment.

"Huh?"

"What's wrong?"

"Well... Huh? Wait a moment."

The man also turned his head towards our direction.

He saw Kaen and greeted her with a friendly wave.

"My daughter!"

Kaen appeared to be momentarily speechless, standing still as if at a loss for words. Then, briskly approaching him, she examined his face from various angles.

"...Are you Father?"

"Well, I am your father, but how could you not recognize my face when it hadn't been a long time since we parted?"

"No, what's going on? Why is Father here?"

Listening to the conversation between the two, Rigon and Esca's eyes widened in surprise.

The man, Ben, asked casually.

“Anyway, have you been well during this time?”

“Why is Father here?”

“Well, what can I say? I came down from the mountains. I decided to settle down in this city.”

“But you never said anything to me!”

“Do I have to tell you everything?”

Kaen sighed several times in disbelief, then murmured.

“No, if that’s the case, why didn’t you come down with me...”

I also wondered what the situation was right now.

I hadn’t heard from the hero about Kaen’s father coming down to the city like this.

The way he was talking, did he just come down from the mountain by himself without telling them?

After quickly scanning me, Rigon, and Esca, he spoke.

“I see you’ve already made a lot of friends. Nice to meet you all. I’m Ben, Kaen’s father.”

When Ben greeted them, Esca responded first in a flustered manner.

“Ah, I’m Esca. I’m a friend who shares the same dormitory room with Kaen.”

“I’m Rigon. I’m also a close friend.”

“I’m Ran.”

Kaen scratched her head and turned to Ben in a puzzled tone.

“Why are you using honorifics?” (T/N: Ben is using formal speech.)

“You’re in the Academy, your classmates must be all nobles, I should be polite.”

“Well, there’s only one noble here, and it’s Esca. Besides, I speak casually too, so it’s strange when Father speak formally.”

“That’s correct. Please feel free to speak comfortably.”

Ben looked around at us once again and chuckled.

“Shall we do that then? Understood.”

I felt that his demeanor was quite different from the last time I saw him.

When I saw him in the mountains, he seemed more rough and unrefined.

“Where is Father staying?”

“It’s not far from here. Are you coming?”

“Yes. Is it alright if we go?”

In response to Kaen’s question, everyone nodded.

I never thought this would happen, but here we are, suddenly having a housewarming party.

Ben’s house was a small mansion located on the outskirts of the city.

It wasn’t particularly large, but it was a spacious house, more than enough for one person to live in.

“Where did you get the money, Father? Don’t you need a lot of money to buy a house like this?”

“I have fortunes you don’t know about. I brought back some beast and monster skins and sold them.”

The interior was sparse, with only a table and chairs as furniture in the expansive space.

We sat around the table and were served tea.

The awkward atmosphere dissipated quickly, and we soon engaged in lively conversation, mostly revolving around Kaen.

“So, when we lived in the mountains, this guy was...”

All Rigon and Esca knew about Kaen was that she had lived deep in the mountains since she was a child, and that she had been recommended for admission by an Elphon official with whom she had a casual connection.

Ben described what Kaen was like when she lived in the mountains, and both of them found it interesting.

“Wow, is that true? Kaen?”

“Aissh– stop talking about useless things, Father.”

Kaen tried to cover Ben’s mouth, showing a rare sign of embarrassment about her embarrassing past.

It was truly a heartwarming sight between a father and a daughter. It would make anyone who saw it feel good.

“...”

I stared at the two of them for a moment, feeling a strange sensation in my stomach.

What’s this? Was it just my mood?

Since it was a very brief moment, I felt curious but didn't dwell on it too deeply.

Time had passed quickly, and it was already well into the afternoon. We decided to tidy up and leave.

As Ben came out to see us off in the yard, Kaen suddenly asked him.

“So, are you really going to keep living here from now on?”

“Yeah. I didn't plan on staying in the mountains for the rest of my life either.”

Despite his nonchalant tone, Kaen seemed secretly pleased.

Perhaps she had been concerned about leaving him alone when she left the mountains.

“Well, then I guess I'll just have to come over and eat with you whenever I go out.”

“Can you go out without any restrictions?”

“No, only once a week.”

“That's good. If you come too often, it'll tire me out too. Come at a reasonable frequency.”

Kaen made a snorting noise and waved her hand.

“I'm leaving.”

“Go. Go.”

I started to walk after the three of them, but a low voice called after me.

“Take good care of her.”

I turned my head and looked at Ben. He was staring at me intently.

Suddenly, a faint smile formed on his lips.

“She might still be lacking in certain areas, but she’s pure and upright.”

I nodded my head.

“Yes, of course.”

As we walked back towards the academy, the three people chatted.

“Your father is such an interesting person. I envy you.”

“What’s there to envy? Anyway, even though he’s my father, I can’t understand what he’s thinking sometimes.”

When the distance grew, I turned my head again.

I couldn’t see him in the yard, as if he had entered the house.

“Why?”

Kaen asked me with a puzzled expression.

I shook my head.

“...It’s nothing.”

Chapter 143: Class and Adaptation

(4)

Chapter 143: Class and Adaptation (4)

Although it was called the Department of Magic, it didn't mean that the students there only learned about magic.

Among the subjects we took as part of our classes, there were also basic liberal arts studies, and history was one of them.

“About 30 years ago, along with the birth of the Demon King, the demons of Altera launched a large-scale invasion.”

I rested my chin on my desk and listened to the assistant professor in charge of the class.

The topic of this history class was none other than the demons.

“The demons' first target was the Santea Empire Union, which is directly adjacent to their territory. Humanity quickly fell into a dire situation before the wicked and powerful forces of the demons. However, there was a person who saved humanity from this unprecedented crisis. Who was it?”

It was a question that even a young child could answer. Some students responded.

“Yes, it was the hero, Aindel. With the power of the Holy Sword bestowed by the gods, the hero annihilated the demons who invaded Santea and ultimately succeeded in sealing the Demon King, the demons' leader. After the war ended, the power structure of the continent quickly changed...”

As someone who was already well-versed in the world of RaSa, the contents were not particularly interesting to me.

Perhaps due to the nature of liberal arts education, they taught only the major events without going into detail.

“Esca, have you ever actually met the hero?”

“What? Of course not.”

“Ran, what about you?”

At Kaen’s question, I shook my head.

“I haven’t either.”

“Really? I’d like to meet her once. I’m curious about what kind of person she is.”

I smirked at that.

I wondered what her reaction would be once the hero revealed her identity to her?

It’s probably not a good idea to talk uselessly, but I was suddenly curious, so I asked.

“Kaen.”

“Yeah?”

“If, let’s say, you were born with the destiny to save the world like the hero, what would you do?”

Kaen and Esca looked at me with eyes that seemed to say, ‘What random talk is this?’

“What are you talking about?”

“Well, I’m just imagining. I was wondering what you would do if you had to sacrifice everything to save the world.”

“Ran, you have some unique thoughts...”

Esca’s reaction seemed somewhat positive, while Kaen appeared surprisingly serious, considering the question.

After contemplating for a while, she answered.

“I don’t really know. I can’t figure it out. I guess I won’t know until I actually face that situation.”

“...”

“So, Ran, what about you?”

I shrugged my shoulders and replied.

“Well, I don’t want to be a hero at the expense of my own life. What’s the point if I die?”

Class Henrietta’s second hand-to-hand combat class was no different from the first.

“Now, students, step forward.”

In response to Professor Gaon’s words, a student immediately walked to the center of the training ground.

Vaion Lexio, representing the newly enrolled students in the Swordsmanship Department.

When he stepped forward, no other students followed suit.

Professor Gaon glanced around with a look of disappointment at the students, who only watched and hesitated.

She was about to choose his opponent when Vaion spoke up.

“Professor, may I choose my opponent?”

“Hmm?”

The direction Vaion’s gaze turned to was right where Rigon stood.

In response, Professor Gaon gave him an intrigued look.

Had he already anticipated this outcome? Even if not, she had been thinking of pairing the two up soon.

It’s obvious which side will win...

Professor Gaon smirked and nodded.

“Alright. Whom should we nominate?”

“Rigon, please.”

“Rigon, come forward.”

Rigon scratched the back of his head and walked towards Vaion from the opposite side.

Before the duel began, Vaion spoke to him.

“Give it your all from the beginning, Rigon.”

“Huh?”

“I hope you don’t let your guard down and make the duel end up being trivial.”

Vaion gripped his sword with a serious demeanor that didn’t match his age.

Rigon also smiled lightly, took his stance, and replied.

“Don’t worry. That won’t happen.”

As soon as the duel started, Vaion charged fiercely.

Rigon hesitated whether to dodge or block the attacking strikes that seemed like they would split his forehead, but he chose to block.

Vaion’s eyes twitched at Rigon’s gesture of raising the sword with one hand. Even after witnessing his own power in the previous class, he still approached the situation in this manner.

“I told you not to let your guard down!”

With the intention of completely breaking down his opponent’s stance, Vaion put all his strength into his downward strike.

Clang!

With a loud noise, Vaion’s sword came to a sudden stop.

“...!”

Vaion stared at the interlocked blades in disbelief.

Instead of crumbling, Rigon flawlessly blocked the full-force attack without any signs of movement.

No matter how hard he tried, Rigon’s one-handed blade didn’t budge.

For Vaion, who had never been pushed back by a peer through sheer strength alone, it was a great shock.

“Your strength is no joke. My hand is completely numb.”

After deflecting the sword, Rigon began his counterattack.

Vaion immediately assumed a defensive stance against the sword strikes aimed at his legs.

The blades met again at the bottom. Rigon took a step forward, attempting to pull the interlocked blades toward him.

Vaion, who almost lost his grip on the sword, withdrew while retrieving it.

The initiative instantly shifted to Rigon.

Even after that, Vaion continuously retreated while blocking the fierce sword strikes.

He couldn't understand. Why were the seemingly light sword strikes so heavy?

It's strong.

When Vaion first witnessed Rigon's sparring, that's what he first thought.

Perhaps among the first-year students, only this guy could be his match.

But it was a misconception.

His opponent was stronger than him. Vaion had no choice but to acknowledge that fact.

Even now, though the other had enough strength to overpower him, Vaion knew that Rigon was only relying on his swordsmanship for the battle. He didn't even seem to be exerting his full power.

The outcome was obvious at this rate.

Vaion clenched his teeth and concentrated his mana on the blade of his sword.

The victory or defeat didn't matter anymore. He wanted to collide with this guy with all his might.

“...?”

Rigon took a step back when he saw the sword energy pulsating in Vaion's blade. The watching students also murmured in awe.

For ordinary students, witnessing sword techniques used by knights was a rare sight.

Rigon looked towards Professor Gaon, who was standing nearby.

He looked to see if it was okay to use the sword technique, but she didn't seem to have any intention of stopping the duel.

"You should use sword techniques too, Rigon!"

Vaion swung the sword adorned with sword energy. If he tried to block the sword wrapped with sword energy with an ordinary sword, it would break.

However, Rigon did not use sword techniques. He did not evade the attack either.

The moment the two blades met, Rigon skillfully deflected Vaion's sword by tilting his own blade.

Vaion's sword struck the ground in vain, while Rigon's sword rested against his neck.

"Ah, what a pity. It's a half-success, I suppose."

Vaion, lost in thought, gazed at Rigon's sword.

The impact had damaged the edge of the blade, and there were scratches and wear.

"Huh..."

Professor Gaon, who had her hand on the sword hilt, also looked at Rigon with an incredulous expression.

When Rigon attempted to block Vaion's attack head-on, she had been surprised and tried to step forward.

Even so, attempting to deflect a sword adorned with sword energy using a regular sword was absurd. More incredulous than that, he had succeeded.

If the sword he's using had been a more durable sword instead of a training sword, it would have probably remained intact.

What a ridiculous fellow.

Professor Gaon declared with a smirk.

"The duel is over. Rigon won."

"Professor, but my sword is on the verge of breaking..."

"Don't worry about it. The student is not responsible for any accidents during the training."

Rigon let out a sigh of relief in his mind, thinking that he didn't have to pay for compensation.

Before returning to his seat, Vaion asked Rigon.

"Why did you block it instead of using your sword technique?"

"Huh?"

"With your skills, you could have overwhelmed me easily. Did you want to insult me?"

Rigon tilted his head to the side.

"What are you talking about? I just thought I could do it, so I gave it a try."

"...Did you forget that the results of the training are included in your grades? Did you gamble just for that reason?"

"I don't really care about grades. Dueling with you was quite enjoyable. That's all."

Upon hearing his words, Vaion stared at Rigon and slowly approached, extending his hand.

“I’m Vaion Lexio.”

“Yeah, I know...”

“I also know your name, Rigon.”

Thinking that he was an unusual guy, Rigon shook his hand.

After morning classes, I headed to the cafeteria and found Rigon with someone.

Somehow, I could quickly recall who the person was by his familiar face and imposing physique.

He must have been the other freshman representative...

I had never seen Rigon hanging out with others.

Kaen and Esca looked at each other in confusion.

“What’s with that huge guy? He’s wearing a school uniform, so he must be a student, right?”

Rigon waved at us when he discovered us.

“Who is this, Rigon?”

“He’s a classmate. He wants to have lunch with us, don’t you mind?”

Kaen let out an exclamation.

“Of course I don’t mind, but more than that, does this mean Rigon finally has a friend?”

The male student looked us over and spoke.

“It’s Vaion Lexio. Are you all students of the Magic Department?”

“Yes, that’s right.”

“That’s surprising.”

It’s probably surprising that all the friends of a student from the Swordsmanship Department were from the Magic Department.

Anyway, just like that, we had a new addition to our table.

We sat down and had a meal while exchanging stories with Vaion.

“...And that’s how I lost to Rigon. I thought it would be a good target point, so I wanted to become friends with Rigon.”

“Hmm, I see. But aren’t you wary of Rigon? You do know Rigon is from the Calderic, right?”

“What does his background have to do with anything? I don’t mind that kind of thing.”

“Thanks, but you know that the other students avoid me, right? If you hang out with me, they might avoid you too, Vaion.”

Vaion blinked at that.

“It doesn’t matter to me. I don’t have any other friends besides Rigon. Everyone else is just boring.”

Kaen burst into laughter at his words.

“Hey, I like you. Let’s be close from now on.”

As we were having this conversation, suddenly everyone’s gaze turned to one side.

Some students were causing a commotion in a corner of the restaurant, and among them, I saw a familiar face. It was Lea.

“Hey, aren’t you going to apologize? You made food splatter all over my clothes!”

The person Lea was having a conflict with turned out to be an upperclassman, not a first-year student.

At a glance, it seemed that they got into an argument because the upperclassman bumped into Lea and food splattered onto her clothes.

Lea didn’t seem concerned about confronting the two upperclassmen.

“I was just standing still, and it was the seniors who bumped into me. Do I have a reason to apologize?”

“This arrogant girl is really...”

Unable to say anything more in the face of her cold gaze, the upperclassmen muttered a few more curses and backed off.

The surrounding students observed the scene and started whispering.

“Isn’t she a new student? Why are the third-year students so afraid of her and backing off?”

“Don’t you know who she is? It’s Lea Herwyn.”

Esca asked Vaion quietly.

“Hey, Vaion. You’re the freshman representative of the Swordsmanship Department, right?”

“That’s correct.”

“Then you know Lea too, right? You stood together on the podium during the entrance ceremony.”

“We know each other to some extent. Our families have some connections. But we’re not particularly close.”

Vaion added a remark.

“She’s also my target. Besides Rigon, she’s the only one around my age whom I’ve lost to.”

Kaen chimed in with interest.

“Oh, really? She’s in the same class as us. I saw her during the classes, and she seemed strong.”

“She is.”

While having our meal, we continued such casual conversations.

I thought it would be just the four of us throughout my academy life here, but it seemed that one more member had been added.

Chapter 144: Class and Adaptation

(5)

Chapter 144: Class and Adaptation (5)

“Monster Exploration” was a class where you learned about monsters, as the name suggested.

It could be described as a class where you learned about the characteristics, habits, weaknesses, and methods of defeating monsters.

Until the previous classes, we had only learned theory in the classroom, but today the professor in charge announced that it would be a practical session.

The assistant professor led the way to a large common area in the basement of the main building.

“This place is creepy. It’s not like monsters will suddenly jump out from somewhere, right?”

“Well, I hope not.”

Kaen muttered as she looked around, causing Esca to flinch uneasily.

Indeed, considering it was a classroom location, the atmosphere was gloomy, and other students also displayed signs of tension.

I already had some knowledge about Elphon’s underground space.

I heard that this place was used for risky or challenging research, which couldn’t be conducted in the open spaces on the surface.

For instance, experiments involving monsters as subjects or taming magic, things like that.

That's why today's Monster Exploration class was held in this kind of place.

I'd seen huge wagons of monsters pulled into the academy a few times before, but it seemed they were all kept here underground.

Soon, the professor in charge arrived.

"Well then, shall we move? It's our first practical session, and today should feel more like an excursion, so don't be too tense."

Following the professor's guidance, we walked along a long underground corridor.

After passing through a magical barrier at a gateway, a space resembling an underground prison for prisoners emerged.

The students gasped softly at the sight of monsters confined behind iron bars.

Goblins.

The first monster we encountered was a goblin, one of the most common and weakest monsters.

The professor sought permission from the guards and allowed the students to get closer to observe the monsters.

So this was what they meant by an excursion. It felt like visiting a zoo or something similar.

"Wow, they're really ugly."

"Look at that guy over there. He's sitting alone in the corner, banging his head?"

“Ahh!”

At that moment, several goblins rushed towards them with a scream, crashing into the iron bars.

Some students who were spectating laughed but were startled and backed away from the iron bars.

The charging goblins pointed at the startled students with their fingers and laughed mockingly.

Looking at the students with scared faces, the professor spoke.

“Goblins may be weak, but they are malicious and provoke and exploit humans. Remember, no matter how weak a monster is, never let your guard down. If you encounter goblins in the wild, maintain composure and stay rational.”

Zap!

The goblins were startled by the sparks that occurred around the iron bars and fled back to their corner.

The professor withdrew his hand and moved the students to the next section.

Among the monsters we were observing, there were some we had learned about in theoretical classes and others they hadn't.

I glanced at Kaen, who was walking nearby.

Unlike the other students, she seemed surprisingly bored with observing monsters.

Perhaps she had encountered monsters so frequently in the mountain range where she used to live that it had become tedious for her.

The class finally arrived at a giant gateway that was a far cry from the gateways we had been through before.

“We will conclude the class after observing the final monster here.”

Considering the extraordinary mana of the magic barrier, I wondered if powerful monsters were trapped inside.

And my assumption was correct.

【Level 46】

Grrrr.

Beyond the iron bars, in the darkness, eerie red eyes gleamed menacingly.

A gigantic humanoid monster reminiscent of a giant.

A Koite?

As soon as I saw its distinctive gray skin, I immediately recognized its identity.

Some students seemed to recoil from the aura emitted by the creature.

The savagery of the monster was on a different level compared to ordinary beasts.

Since the students were not accustomed to such an aura, even a helpless monster in a prison cell was enough to make them tremble.

“This is the monster I briefly mentioned in the previous class, ‘Koite.’ It is also known as the Mage Hunter.”

Koite, the Mage Hunter.

The reason it was called the Mage Hunter was due to its exceptional resistance to magic.

Even mages of considerable skill were said to be unable to inflict even the slightest injury on it.

It's a level 40 monster at most.

By the way, was Elphon capturing such large creatures and using them as test subjects? It was quite astonishing.

At that moment, the professor gave a strange smile and made a sudden remark.

“Aren't you all disappointed to end the practical session like this? Shall we play one last entertaining game?”

...A game?

“As I explained, this Koite is a monster called a mage hunter, so it's incredibly resistant to magic. Is there any student here who believes they can inflict a wound on Koite? If anyone succeeds in causing even the slightest injury, I will award an immediate A+ grade in my class. It has nothing to do with the semester exams or future lessons.”

The students buzzed with excitement at this radical statement.

The Monster Exploration class had only just begun its third session. Yet, the professor was offering the highest grade right away?

Clank.

The professor coolly opened the door to the cage.

“Is there a student who wants to give it a try? I'll give you one chance. The challenging student should enter the iron bars and freely unleash their magic towards Koite.”

However, there was no one who volunteered readily.

Even if it was a restrained monster or if a dangerous situation occurred and the professor would step forward, it was not easy to muster the courage to directly attack such a monster with offensive magic.

“Should I give it a try?”

Of course, Kaen was an exception.

There was not the slightest hint of nervousness or fear in the way she scratched her chin and muttered.

I wondered if she would step up if no other volunteers came forward...

“I-I’ll do it.”

An unexpected person raised their hand before anyone else.

Kaen also turned to Esca in surprise. The person who raised their hand was Esca.

I didn’t think Esca had a proactive personality for this kind of thing. Was the allure of an A+ grade that strong?

“Hey, Esca. You’re not overdoing it, right?”

“It’s okay. I’ll give it a try.”

With a deep breath, Esca walked into the iron bars while everyone watched.

Facing Koite up close, her stance was no different from a mouse in front of a lion.

“How is it? Do you think she’ll succeed?”

“Is there even a chance? Her magical skills are the lowest in the class.”

Kaen glared fiercely at the students, who were laughing and gossiping around. They flinched and fell silent.

However, it wasn’t an inaccurate statement.

There was no way that someone of Eska’s level could deal damage to a monster of that level.

“Haah, haah...”

Esca's breathing became ragged again as she realized how much pressure she could feel now that she stood face to face with the monster.

She mustered her strength and unleashed her magic, barely pulling her power together.

A fireball emerged in the air and flew in Koite's direction.

She's targeting the eyes.

If it were the eyes, they would be vulnerable compared to the exterior and could be a suitable target to aim at, but...

Crack!

However, Koite vigorously shook its head and effortlessly annihilated the flying fireball.

With not a scratch on it, the Koite stood there swaying while opening his mouth wide and roaring towards Esca.

“Kyaaah!”

Esca clutched her hands over her ears and slumped to the floor.

The professor walked over and helped her to her feet.

“Nice try,” he said, “but you're not going to be able to land a single punch on Koite with that kind of power.”

Esca walked out of the cage, completely disoriented.

Kaen comforted her.

“Are you okay, Esca?”

“Yeah, I'm fine...”

The monster's roar also affected even the other students.

No matter how eager they were for good grades, it seemed unlikely that any student would dare to challenge further.

“I’ll do it.”

However, at that moment, someone else raised their hand. It was Lea.

Walking through the prison bars, Lea calmly stood in front of the Koite.

Despite the guy becoming even more ferocious after the previous attack, she showed no signs of intimidation.

I watched that scene with a slightly intrigued expression.

Would she be able to land a blow? Would she try to go for the eyes like Esca?

She immediately reached out her hand and unleashed magic towards Koite.

Kwaaang!

Koite, hit by the magic projectile that shot out like a beam, let out a pained scream.

With a sharp smoke, blood was flowing from Koite’s chest.

Such a simple success. It was a perfect strike that didn’t even aim for a weakness.

I stared at the scene, my head tilted. It wasn’t just a simple magic projectile...

Krooooo!

As the wounded Koitee tried to thrash violently, Lea flinched in surprise and tried to unleash magic again.

But before that, the professor stepped in.

The professor's magic spread widely, enveloping Koite and suppressing it.

After calming Koite down, the professor applauded and spoke in an amazed tone.

“Impressive, Lea Herwyn. I didn't expect you to succeed so easily.”

The other students also looked at her with admiration and envy.

Meanwhile, Kaen murmured with a disappointed expression.

“Oh, I wanted to do it first.”

Suddenly, I noticed Esca's expression standing next to Kaen.

She was looking at Lea with a slightly darkened expression, tightly biting her lips.

During the evening hours, we sometimes practiced at the common training ground after meals.

Originally, it was the four of us, but recently, an additional member joined—Vaion.

“Kaen, Ran. Your bodies are well-trained, not like typical mages. Have you perhaps learned martial arts too?”

“Yes.”

“You guys are a curious bunch. I heard that Rigon is learning magic as well as swordsmanship.”

“Why don't you try learning some magic too, Vaion?”

“It's pointless. My body and a single sword are enough for me.”

Vaion had a stern demeanor, but he wasn't a bad person by nature.

Should I say that his personality matched his appearance as a warrior?

“You guys go ahead. I’m planning to stay a bit longer and do some more training alone.”

“Really? Alright, got it.”

After finishing the training, the others left the training ground before me.

The promise of more training was an excuse. It had been a while since I’d checked to see if any hidden mystery had spawned in the library, so I wanted to go and confirm it.

I sat down for a moment, resting, and was about to get up and head outside...

“...”

I saw a student entering the training ground.

It was Lea.

Considering the late hour and the fact that I had never come across her on the training ground before, it was unexpected.

Why did she come to the shared training ground?

The training grounds were separated for the departments of magic and swordsmanship.

The faculty-specific training grounds had better facilities, but we came to the common training grounds because of Rigon.

Perhaps it was because the shared training ground was more spacious, or maybe there were fewer people?

Although our eyes met, Lea didn’t pay any attention to me and took her place on the other side of the training ground.

I decided to stay a little longer instead of leaving immediately.

I was suddenly curious about how she practiced magic.

The magic Lea displayed was a simple ice magic. A gathering of white cold air formed in the air.

While gazing at that scene and sensing something peculiar, I soon realized the nature of the unfamiliarity.

Is it the same as last time?

In the previous monster exploration class, she displayed a magical attack against Koite.

Even back then, I thought it was peculiar. It was clearly different from just unfolding magic.

As I observed her for a moment longer, I could immediately grasp the principle.

“Could it be an application of magic formula?”

Muttering like that, Lea suddenly stopped using magic and turned abruptly in my direction, looking surprised for some reason.

I wondered why she was staring at me, but she quickly approached me.

“What did you just say?”

“Um... What?”

“What did you say just now?”

Did she hear me muttering from that distance? She had good hearing.

But why is she acting like this?

I raised my head and replied.

“Yes. I was wondering if you had just applied some sort of formula to amplify your power, like in the previous monster exploration class.”

“How did you know about that?”

“What do you mean?... I just saw it.”

As I said that, I realized the reason for her reaction.

Normally, people wouldn't notice just by watching?

With my heightened senses, I could perceive the flow of magic in meticulous detail.

Besides, I had recently studied magic, so my magical knowledge had also increased to some extent.

So when her spell suddenly amplified in power at some point during its unfolding, I knew it wasn't just the result of manipulation. I naturally connected the dots with the formula.

Lea stared at me for a moment, as if observing me, and then spoke again.

“Your intuition seems quite good. You're right, I just took the elements of the formula that are responsible for magical amplification and modified them.”

“I see.”

So, it's possible to increase the power of magic in that way.

I thought it wasn't a technique suitable for a student level.

“...”

There was a brief silence.

Lea, for some reason, continued to stand in front of me. Did she have something else to say?

When I stared at her intently, she finally turned around and returned to her original position.

A variation on the formula.

I tried unleashing a fire magic spell once.

Of course, I completely failed to apply the principle of transformation.

I didn't even know the exact composition of my formula yet, let alone how to transform it.

Lea knew exactly what she's doing, making it possible for her, but it was an impossible task for me.

I withdrew my magic and turned my gaze away.

Lea, who had been glancing this way, suddenly showed a disappointed expression and turned her head.

What's wrong with her?

Thinking she was a strange person, I moved my steps out of the training ground.

I headed straight to the public library to confirm the mystery. However, there was still no mystery to be found.

Chapter 145: Class and Adaptation

(6)

Chapter 145: Class and Adaptation (6)

The combat class was one of the few classes in the Department of Magic where students could freely display their magic. The format of the class involved students sparring with each other or the professor directly engaging with the students to provide guidance.

After entering Elphon, about a month had swiftly passed. Today's combat class was different from usual. It was because we were going to have an exchange class with the students of the Swordsmanship Department.

“Oh, there's Rigon and Vaion over there.”

Kaen spotted two of the swordsmanship students standing across from us and waved.

Rigon smiled and waved back.

Coincidentally, the class of the Swordsmanship Department that we were about to have an exchange with happened to be Rigon's class.

“You've been learning about the battles of mages in our previous lessons, so how do you think the battles of mages and warriors differ?”

Before starting the class in earnest, Professor Rokel began his usual explanation.

“Battles between mages generally take place in fixed positions. Unless a mage is also skilled in physical combat, they wouldn't be able to dodge

attacks by moving around. That's why in magical battles there's no option for evasion; it's all about patterns of offense and defense. The key to magical battles lies in utilizing mana, the intricacy of spells, and psychological warfare to block the opponent's attacks while penetrating their defense spells with your own attacks."

I suppose that's true.

I listened to the professor's explanation with moderate interest.

"But combat between mages and warriors is different. You're not fighting a stationary target, but a constantly moving one, and you're trying to get your magic to hit it without closing the distance. As such, the importance of the required skill elements will also be quite different from magic battles. You will experience that difference firsthand in today's class."

After concluding his explanation, Professor Rokel turned to the Swordsmanship Department students.

The professor from the Swordsmanship Department, who had been waiting with her hands on her waist, spoke with a smile.

"Are you finished? Shall we start right away?"

Without the need for further words, the duel commenced immediately.

The first students stood in the center of the training grounds, facing each other. They were both nervous.

"Begin the duel."

With the professor's declaration, the mage student quickly unleashed their magic first.

The opponent seemed a bit distracted and couldn't avoid the incoming shockwave magic, getting hit and tumbling to the ground.

However, he quickly got up and quickly moved to the side.

Normally, it would have been over the moment the magic hit, but this wasn't a battle between mages, so the professors didn't stop the duel. The bodies of those trained in the martial arts were not built to be retired by a single light magic strike.

The swordsmanship student seemed fearless, willing to take a hit from even a small spell, as he sought opportunities to close the distance. On the other hand, our classmate showed signs of not knowing how to deal with the situation.

He knew that if he threw a spell, his opponent would either parry or dodge and then dive in.

Eventually, unable to bear the standoff, our classmate unfolded his magic once again.

The swordsmanship student rolled his body to the side, narrowly evading the attack, and swiftly moved inward.

There was a clash between the sword strike and the defensive barrier, creating a loud noise. From that moment on, our classmate appeared to be in a state of panic.

"Why is he just defensively blocking like that? He should counter-attack quickly," muttered Kaen while watching the scene.

However, it wouldn't be an easy task.

If he continued to allow them to attack, his defenses would crumble, and if he focused on maintaining them, he wouldn't have a chance to counterattack.

Of course, if he was significantly more skilled than the opponent, he would have plenty of opportunities to counter-attack. But based on his level, there wasn't a significant difference in skill between the two.

At the moment when the distance between him and the swordsman had been narrowed, the situation was already greatly unfavorable for the mage.

“Stop. End the duel.”

In the end, just before the defense barrier was about to shatter, the professor halted the duel.

Thus, the first duel ended in victory for the student from the Swordsmanship Department.

I pondered how I would approach the duel when it was my turn.

In the end, it's about maintaining distance and landing successful spells.

Both sides were lacking in experience.

While the students from the Department of Magic might not be accustomed to hitting fast-moving targets, the students from the swordsmanship department would also be unfamiliar with the unpredictability of magic.

So I planned to break their concentration by performing as many different spells as possible.

A few more students competed, and my turn came quickly.

In all but one of the five duels before, the swordsmanship students won.

Kaen nudged my shoulder from the side.

“Ran, you have to win. If we keep losing, it'll damage our pride in front of Rigon.”

I chuckled in response to Kaen's serious expression. Seeing this, she really was a kid.

The student I faced was a fairly skilled early-level 20 student from the opposing side.

He seemed quite confident, probably because the majority of the winners so far were from their class.

As soon as the duel began, I unleashed my magic towards the opponent, who came charging in with a strong momentum.

Flash!

A burst of light magic exploded, obscuring the vision. The opponent momentarily hesitated, but that was all.

Of course, it wasn't a spell that I expected to have a significant effect.

Immediately, I followed up with the next spell, scattering small ice magic spells to disrupt the opponent's footing.

I deliberately didn't use too much mana. I didn't let him close the distance by casting small spells quickly.

The opponent showed signs of becoming frustrated by my actions, but he didn't lose his composure.

He was waiting for my mana to run out, focusing solely on evading without pushing himself unnecessarily. Of course, I had anticipated that it would come to this.

The reason I only used weak magic was to catch my opponent off guard.

It was to deliver a powerful surprise attack on someone who didn't know the full extent of my mana output.

Although my magic skills were only average at best, my total mana was among the top, even in my year.

Whoosh!

The slightly misfired ice magic froze the ground and even the opponent's legs.

The opponent, momentarily immobilized by the magic spreading to such a wide range, looked confused.

I followed up with a fireball in the air. My opponent stared at me with a dumbfounded expression.

If I had continued the attack without stopping, the result would have been obvious, so the professor immediately halted the duel.

“Duel is over.”

Of course, the victory was mine.

“Well done. It was a duel that showcased the essence of a mage facing a warrior,” Professor Rokel complimented, rare praise coming from him.

On the other hand, the opponent, having received a scathing remark from the professor of swordsmanship, returned to his spot in a disheartened manner.

“Good job, Ran. I knew you could do it!”

As I returned to my spot, I brushed off Kaen, who came running towards me.

By the way, have I become quite proficient?

I hardly ever felt awkward or unfamiliar when I perform magic anymore.

Although I thought I had no talent for magic, practicing seemed to gradually improve my skills, even if only little by little.

Next up was Kaen’s turn.

As expected, Kaen easily overwhelmed the opponent and emerged victorious.

The only thing she lacked was the variety of spells she had learned, but after only a month of practice, even that weakness had disappeared, and her magic skills were now at the top of her class.

The sparring continued. As expected, Esca lost, and Vaion emerged victorious.

And as the end of the class approached, it was finally Rigon's turn...

“Wow, I can't believe it. They're really going against each other.”

I looked at the two people standing in the middle of the training ground: Rigon and Lea.

A strange tension began to fill the air among the students.

It was understandable. They were the two most famous individuals in their year.

The top-ranked newcomer in the Department of Magic and the top-ranked newcomer in the Swordsmanship Department—their duel was unlike any other match.

“No matter what, I bet Lea Herwyn will win.”

Interestingly, perhaps because Rigon was from Calderic, even the Swordsmanship Department students seemed to be rooting for Lea rather than Rigon.

Of course, I secretly hoped that Rigon would win.

Although, considering their levels, it was uncertain, since Lea had a slight advantage.

Lea had her usual expressionless face, as if she had no interest in who her opponent was.

And the same could be said for Rigon.

“Then... let the duel begin.”

With the professor's declaration, the duel commenced.

Lea took the initiative. A lightning magic spell spread out like a net, aiming to engulf Rigon.

Rigon lowered his stance, swiftly dodged to the side, and then quickly changed direction, charging forward.

Rigon's movements were incredibly fast, but Lea's response was even quicker.

This time, a whip-like binding spell extended, targeting Rigon's limbs.

In the blink of an eye, one exchange of attack and defense concluded. Rigon, forced to retreat, showed a slightly surprised expression.

He stared intently at Lea as he stood in place, a faint smile appearing on his lips, before he moved again.

Clang!

As a flurry of magical blades flew towards him, Rigon effortlessly parried and shattered them all with his sword.

Suddenly, Rigon's sword gleamed with a sharp edge, causing Lea's expression to slightly furrow as her magic was easily blocked.

The duel between the two intensified beyond imagination.

Rigon chose not to evade the magic and instead blocked it head-on, closing the distance between them. Meanwhile, Lea increased the intensity of her magic.

When Rigon approached, Lea boldly unleashed a shockwave from close range, pushing him back.

Rigon landed on the ground after spinning a few times in the air, seemingly undamaged, and charged back towards her.

The students, mesmerized by the advanced level of their combat skills, watched in awe.

Lea bit her lip in a rare display of determination as she struggled to shake off Rigon.

The situation indicated that Lea's mana might deplete faster than Rigon's stamina.

At that moment, Lea's mana began to change into something unusual.

...Huh?

Three small violet orbs appeared around her, resembling beads.

Those were not ordinary spells that students typically learn.

Rigon didn't react much to it and kept charging, but then the purple spheres reacted.

Flash!

Like guided missiles, beams of light shot out from the purple orbs, mysteriously curving and aiming at Rigon's entire body.

Rigon barely dodged the direct hit by throwing his body, but one of the beams grazed his arm, drawing blood.

Rigon was visibly surprised, his eyes wide open.

What kind of magic is that?

Well, could it be some sort of arcane magic from the Herwyn family?

No matter how good Lea was, it's impossible for her to control that kind of density of magic.

If she couldn't control it all, then it must be the nature of the magic itself. It was quite a formidable magic.

"I'll admit it. You are strong."

Lea opened her mouth while still displaying swirling violet spheres around her.

“But the victory is mine in this duel. It wouldn’t be appropriate to use this level of magic, so concede defeat.”

Indeed, engaging in a direct clash of that kind would result in more than just a minor injury.

Seeing Professor Rokel, it seemed he also felt the need to halt the duel, but...

“You’re quite strong yourself.”

Rigon spoke in a rare, elevated tone.

However, he wiped away the blood with a bright smile and rose to his feet.

“But aren’t you too arrogant? Just because you grazed me with an attack.”

Lea’s expression turned cold.

Professor Rokel cast a slightly awkward glance at the professor of swordsmanship.

But as she stood there with her arms folded, she smiled and shook her head.

“Isn’t this much fine, Professor Rokel? After all, you could definitely intervene before any accidents happened.”

Professor Rokel clicked his tongue, seemingly annoyed, but in the end, he didn’t stop the duel.

Ziiing!

Three streams of purple light were once again aimed at Rigon.

Rigon twisted and contorted his body to evade them.

Lea busily followed Rigon's accelerated movements with her eyes. The beams twisted and persistently tracked Rigon.

Even though it still seemed unfavorable for Rigon...

Crack.

Suddenly, Rigon stopped his movement and raised his sword high, fully exposing himself to an attack.

Lea also paused for a moment.

"What are you doing? Giving up?" she asked.

"No way. I thought I'd try gambling since it seems difficult like this," Rigon replied.

Rigon shifted his footing. At the same time, Lea unleashed a beam of light toward Rigon.

Then, in the next moment, Rigon skillfully deflected all the beams with his sword, tracing a graceful path.

The deflected beams momentarily escaped Lea's control, and that was enough time for the distance between them to close.

Kwaang!

Rigon's sword, controlling the beam of magic, shattered Lea's weakened defensive barrier in an instant.

Lea looked at the partially broken edge of the sword pointing at her neck with trembling eyes.

"I won."

"..."

Rigon said so while catching his breath and sheathed his sword.

The tide turned against him, and in the end, Rigon emerged as the victor in the duel.

I couldn't believe he managed to deflect all the beams.

Having trained in swordsmanship myself, I knew how absurd it was to do that at Rigon's current level.

Indeed, his talent was beyond imagination, as Asher had claimed.

"Did... I lose? Me?" Lea, still standing in the same spot, muttered in a daze.

She seemed so proud of her skills that she was shocked to lose, despite giving it her all.

Chapter 146: Class and Adaptation

(7)

Chapter 146: Class and Adaptation (7)

Professor Rokel was sitting in his office, flipping through the plan that Professor Gaon from the Swordsmanship Department had handed him.

It was for the semester exams, which were quickly approaching.

“Hmm...”

Professor Rokel, with his back sunk into the chair, crossed his arms with a peculiar expression.

Although he had only caught bits and pieces of it during the previous joint combat class, he thought it was quite an interesting concept.

The examination method seemed rather drastic, and there would be many things to prepare, but it wouldn't be enough to make a fuss on the committee...

“What do you think, Professor Rokel? It must be difficult, as expected, right?”

The assistant professor who delivered the plan asked awkwardly, with a smile.

“No, it's not too bad. I'll have to think about it a bit more.”

“Really? Are you sure?”

“What’s the problem?”

“Oh, nothing. Then I’ll deliver it to Professor Gaon like that.”

“Fine. No need to go through the trouble. I’ll personally talk to her later.”

Clack.

The assistant professor who came out of the office let out a small sigh.

Professor Rokel was reluctant to deal with Professor Gaon, considering her somewhat peculiar, but from what he could observe, the two of them seemed to have compatible personalities. It was evident in situations like this.

Was he really planning to subject the freshmen to such a merciless examination?

“These first-year students are going to have a hard time...”

The assistant professor shook his head and walked away, his steps trembling.

Nearly three months had passed since I enrolled in the academy.

Time here had been slow yet fast, with no significant events taking place.

“Where have you been, Ran?”

“Just went to the library for a moment. I had a book I was looking for.”

It was late afternoon after classes had ended.

Rigon, Vaion, and I headed towards the outdoor table near the dormitory building.

Gathering there for a casual chat before dinner was our usual routine.

As we walked down the hallway, Lea was approaching from the opposite direction.

Rigon, who made eye contact with her, greeted her without hesitation.

“Hello.”

“...”

Lea simply nodded her head without any notable response and walked past us.

As we continued on our way, I felt someone’s gaze, so I subtly glanced back.

I saw Lea glanced in our direction and flinched, then quickly turn away.

Watching her retreating figure, I couldn’t help but wonder what she wanted to do.

“What’s wrong?”

“Oh, it’s nothing.”

Ever since the previous exchange class, Lea’s attitude had been peculiar whenever she happened to run into Rigon. It was clear that she was conscious of him.

I hadn’t seen her try to socialize with the other students in the class.

The reason, of course, must be the duel between her and Rigon.

At first, I thought she might be expressing her animosity over her defeat, but it didn’t seem like it.

If anything, it seems quite the opposite.

It felt like she wanted to say something, but couldn’t.

Unless she had intentions to harm Rigon, there was no need to be concerned.

When we arrived at our destination, I saw Kaen and Esca already sitting at the table.

“Hey.”

Kaen waved her hand at us. We sat across from each other.

We passed the time with various trivial conversations.

“So, I was thinking, shall we hang out together this holiday, Esca?”

“Um... Sorry. We have exams coming up soon. I want to focus on studying until then.”

“Oh, come on...”

Kaen stretched out on the table, showing her discontent.

Esca gently placed both hands on her shoulders, trying to calm her down.

As Esca had just mentioned, lately she seemed too busy studying and didn't spend much time with Kaen.

“How about you guys? Rigon, Vaion. Are you preparing well for the exams?”

“Me? I'm not really doing any specific preparations...”

“I'm the same.”

The end-of-semester exams.

As the name suggested, they were exams taken at the end of each semester.

Elphon's education system was divided into two semesters per academic year, and they had a major exam at the end of each semester, similar to final

exams, if you think in terms of Earth.

I leaned back in my chair with my arms crossed.

There were a little over two weeks left until the end-of-semester exams.

It wasn't just someone else's problem; there was a part that worried me as well.

While I could manage other subjects to some extent, Magic Theory was still a daunting challenge.

Although grades might not matter much, I needed to score well enough to avoid failing or being expelled.

Magic theory is really annoying...

It's not like I had neglected studying theory just because it was difficult.

I tried my best in my own way, but I still felt overwhelmed just trying to keep up with the class material.

This wasn't the modern world where everything unknown could be easily searched on the internet.

The resources were scarce, and even finding them required a lot of effort, so I was frustrated in many ways.

Since I couldn't predict how I would perform in the theoretical exams in this state, I felt a slight sense of crisis.

I wish someone could teach me one-on-one like private tutoring.

If I could at least review the parts that were blocking me before the exam, it would be great.

However, it was impossible to ask Kaen or Esca for help. They weren't particularly strong in theory either.

While thinking about it, a person crossed my mind for a moment.

Although we didn't have any personal connections, she was the most outstanding student in the grade in terms of ability.

“...”

Should I talk to her once?

It wasn't completely without reason since Lea and I were in the same group for the theory class.

And...

“Huh? Why?”

When I stared at Rigon intently, he looked puzzled.

I nodded my head and said.

“Well, instead of going out on this holiday, how about studying together at the library?”

“At the library?”

“Yeah. Rigon, you also have theory subjects, right? There are common electives too.”

“Oh, then should we do that? It's a bit different from usual, so it sounds good.”

Kaen eagerly chimed in.

Vaion and Rigon also nodded, as if they liked the idea.

After a day had passed, it was time for the morning magic theory class.

“...What?”

After the class had just ended, Lea and the other team members had various expressions on their faces in response to the story I brought up.

“Now, it’s almost time for the semester exams, right? So, I thought it might be a good idea for all of us to gather and study on the holidays.”

The two team members naturally turned their gaze to Lea, their expressions filled with uncertainty.

I understood why they were reacting that way.

Since she usually made it clear that she built walls around herself, it was unlikely for her to participate in a study group or anything similar.

“Why should I waste my time doing something like that?”

And Lea’s reaction was as expected.

I calmly spoke in a composed tone.

“Since we’ve been studying in groups so far, it’s likely that the exams will be in groups as well, so don’t you think it would be a little more beneficial for your grade to study together and exchange information and opinions?”

Lea frowned, about to retort.

However, I added something before she could.

“”My friends and I decided to meet at the library this holiday to study. But as you know, I’m not very good at theory, so I thought I’d ask if you guys would like to join us. If you don’t want to, I won’t force you.”

As I spoke, I glanced at Lea’s reaction, and I felt her momentary hesitation.

She remained silent for a while before finally asking bluntly.

“When and for how long?”

Upon hearing her question, the team members looked at her with surprise.

I, too, was slightly taken aback.

This might actually work.

It was a story I brought up, thinking that using Rigon as bait might work.

“Starting around noon and roughly until evening. How about that?”

Lea nodded without saying anything and got up from her seat. Then she left the classroom right away.

When I shifted my gaze to the other two team members, they also nodded.

“But it’s surprising. I didn’t expect her to comply so obediently...”

“Yeah, right. Ran, are you close with Lea?”

Not really.

I shook my head.

“No, not really.”

The holiday arrived, and as promised, we met at the library.

I had previously obtained permission from Kaen and the others to have additional members.

“It’s surprising. I didn’t expect that we would end up studying together.”

Kaen was the first to take a seat and casually spoke to Lea, who was already sitting there.

Lea glanced at Kaen once and then turned her gaze back to the book she was reading.

The seating arrangement somehow ended up being centered around me.

On the left were the team members for theory classes, and on the right, Kaen, Esca, and Vion sat down to start studying.

“Lea, I’m having trouble understanding this part here...”

As originally planned, I quietly asked Lea about the parts that were blocking me one by one.

She displayed an annoyed expression, but she still taught me, more sincerely than I had expected.

Oh, so it’s solved like this.

And it was definitely a great help.

As I organized the things I learned from her, I made significant progress in studying the theory.

To cool down my overheated mind, I took a break for a moment.

I glanced back and forth between Rigon and Lea, who were sitting on either side.

She must have come because of Rigon for sure...

Surprisingly, Lea didn’t even look at Rigon and focused only on her studies.

The only conversation exchanged between the two was a greeting when they first met.

Watching them made me feel a bit frustrated, but at the same time, I appreciated Lea’s tutoring, so I maintained the atmosphere.

Rigon held a history book and scratched his tired face.

I casually struck up a conversation with Rigon.

“History? Is it a common knowledge study?”

“Yeah.”

“But why does your face look like that? Is there something you’re struggling with?”

“No, it’s just... The things I learned in class and the materials seem a bit different. It’s confusing.”

“Well then, why don’t you ask Lea? She probably knows history well.”

Upon hearing my words, Rigon looked at Lea.

Lea also paused her pen and looked over at us with a puzzled expression.

Rigon, who was aware of the situation, immediately smiled and asked her.

“Can you teach me a bit?”

“...What exactly is confusing?”

“I mean, it’s about the Jehak Disaster that happened in the 321st year of the Empire...”

Rigon stood up with the book and moved to sit next to her.

Lea explained to him without any apparent displeasure, unlike when she taught me.

I watched that scene for a moment and then turned off my attention and focused on my own studies.

As I concentrate on studying, before I knew it, it had become dusk.

Kaen let out a groan while stretching.

“Oh, I’m hungry. Let’s finish up and go eat dinner around this time.”

As the atmosphere started to settle, I also closed my book and organized my notes.

“You guys are going to have dinner together too, right?”

“Huh? Well, maybe.”

Kaen asked the members of our study group, including Lea.

Both of them replied that they would, but Lea ignored them and tried to leave her seat.

Kaen saw her and asked, “Hey, Lea. Where are you going? Let’s eat together.”

Lea replied in an annoyed tone, “What are you doing acting like we’re friends? I’m done here, so don’t bother me.”

“What?”

Kaen looked puzzled.

“No, we were getting along just now, so why are you acting like this?”

“I wasn’t getting along; I was just preparing for the exam. It’s because of my grades.”

“Well, isn’t that the same thing?”

Kaen hesitated and then asked, “No, but I’ve always been curious. Why do you insist on being alone all the time? It’s fun and nice to hang out together. Isn’t it boring not having anyone to be close to?”

Although Kaen probably didn’t have any ill intentions, it could be taken as an unpleasant comment. However, Lea remained expressionless.

“Getting along means being with people of the same caliber.”

“Caliber? Do you mean magical ability, or do you mean your family name, and why the hell would you care about that?”

Lea’s voice became even colder as she said this.

“Because they’re all just insignificant people. Those who harbor inferiority and jealousy towards me, those who hope for my failure, those who flatter and fawn over me, and those who are simply annoying because they’re foolish. Why should I endure and associate myself with such individuals?”

What’s with the sudden outburst?

I stared at her, wondering what was wrong with her all of a sudden.

Kaen spoke with a displeased expression on her face.

“I don’t feel inferior to you, and I have no intention of flattering you.”

“Then you must be just a stupid person. Should I stop talking to you now?”

That’s when Rigon intervened, his voice unusually cold.

“Your words are harsh. Do you have to say it like that?”

Lea glanced at Rigon in surprise.

She bit her lip, tears welling up, and turned away.

“As talented as you are, you shouldn’t waste your time playing friends. It’s all going to come down to what I say, if not now, then eventually.”

“...”

“Oh, and when I’m absolutely certain that I’ve surpassed you, I’ll challenge you to a duel again. Wait until then. I wanted to say this, but I never had the chance.”

Lea said this and left with determined steps.

Kaen looked perplexed, muttering to herself as she watched her receding figure.

“What a strange girl...”

I agreed with her.

Chapter 147: Semester Exam (1)

Chapter 147: Semester Exam (1)

Time flew and the day of the semester exams had arrived.

While having breakfast at the cafeteria, I could sense a different atmosphere among the students compared to usual.

“The semester exams are incredibly important. I heard that if you fail three or more subjects in one semester, you’ll be expelled without exception. This applies to freshmen as well.”

“Really? That’s pretty strict.”

At Esca’s explanation, Kaen shrugged and went back to eating.

Whether it was Kaen or Rigon, they seemed unfazed by the exam day. Vaion was the same.

On the other hand, even a glance at Esca revealed her full state of tension, as she left more than half of her food untouched, seemingly with little appetite.

“Are you not going to finish your meal? Don’t you need to eat well, Esca?”

“No, I feel like it’ll just upset my stomach for no reason.”

After finishing our meal, we immediately headed to the classroom.

The semester exams were scheduled to take place over a total of three days, and I heard that the exam formats varied greatly depending on the subjects.

It was announced that the first test of the day, Magic Theory, would be held in a traditional classroom.

“Please sit with some distance between each other.”

As soon as the time came, the teaching assistant entered the room and addressed the students.

It seemed that the exam would be supervised by a teaching assistant rather than a professor.

Since Magic Theory was primarily a written subject, the exam was also written.

I thought the exam format would be in groups since we had been studying in groups, but it turned out to be an individual exam.

And here I thought I could rely on others.

Unfortunately, the Magic Theory exam would solely depend on my individual abilities.

Well, as long as I avoid getting a failing grade, it shouldn't matter, but... I hope I wouldn't actually fail. I had worked hard, after all.

As Esca mentioned earlier, Elphon's regulations were quite strict. If one failed three or more subjects, they were expelled without any leniency.

Still, I didn't worry much.

Magic Theory was my weakest subject, but at least I managed to do average in other subjects.

Surely, even if I fail this test, they wouldn't kick me out. Probably.

“We will begin the exam.”

As the assistant professor spoke, the sound of students simultaneously unfolding their exam papers echoed.

Amidst the ensuing silence, I calmly unfolded my own exam paper.

The exam went surprisingly smoothly.

I quickly skipped any difficult problems and started with the ones I could solve, and before I knew it, I had completed about one-third of the exam.

Until the time was up, I successfully managed to solve a few more problems and finished the exam.

There were indeed some problems I couldn't even touch, but overall, I was quite satisfied with how it went, even better than expected.

The previous study session definitely helped a lot. Without it, I might not have even completed half of the exam.

"Oh, I totally messed up."

"Why is it so difficult? They said it would only cover what we learned in class."

"Yeah, seriously. Did they really intend for us to solve the last problem?"

After the exam, the classroom filled with students' complaints and sighs.

As I stood up from my seat, I happened to see Lea passing by, so I called out to her.

"Hey, Lea."

"...?"

"Many of the things you taught me last time appeared a lot in the exam."

"So what?"

"Just wanted to say thank you. I did okay, thanks to you."

In response to my expression of gratitude, she simply scoffed and continued on her way. What a bad personality.

I approached Kaen and asked, “Hey, how did it go? Did you do well?”

“Decently. I managed to solve everything except for three questions,” Kaen replied.

Compared to me, Kaen was generally better at theoretical studies.

I considered asking Esca as well, but gave up when I saw her expression.

“Esca, how about you?”

“Oh, just... you know,” Esca responded vaguely.

But instead of me, Kaen promptly asked the question.

Kaen wasn’t particularly perceptive in such matters.

I swiftly changed the topic of conversation and left the classroom with both of them.

After a short break, it was time for the next exam.

The Magic Theory, which I was most worried about, went smoothly, and I did reasonably well in other subjects too.

Lea demonstrated overwhelming skill in most practical exams, as expected, and Kaen did quite well, too.

It was the last day of the semester exams, spanning three days.

The final exam subject was none other than combat.

“Ha, exams are finally over.”

“But what kind of test is it that you have to take it in the basement, leaving the training grounds behind? Was there a training ground in the basement?”

“I heard from a senior that if it’s Professor Rokel’s exam, we should really be prepared.”

I heard a group of students chattering around me as I made my way to the exam venue.

The exam venue for the combat exam was not the usual training grounds where classes were held, but rather the underground area of Elphon, a different section from where we had our Monster Exploration class.

I was quite curious about what kind of exam it would be since we were going to do it underground.

Moreover, the announcement mentioned that it would be a joint exam with the Swordsmanship Department, just like during the joint combat class, which piqued my curiosity even further.

“I don’t suppose it’s going to be a normal duel, is it? Rigon.”

“Yeah, you’re right.”

The swordsmanship class taking the joint test was none other than Rigon’s Henrietta class, so we were all traveling together.

While listening to the voices of Rigon and Kaen chatting, I looked around the surrounding stone walls.

How extensive is this underground area?

After passing through a dim underground passage, we arrived at the examination venue, which was a spacious common area.

There, the assistant professors, who had been waiting, first arranged the students into two groups.

Kaen, Esca, and Vaion were in the same group as me, while Rigon ended up in a different group.

Observing the scene, I pondered. Could this be some kind of team battle? A combat between individuals?

After dividing all the students, they began distributing something. It was bracelets.

“Please wear the bracelets on your wrists. The professors will be here soon to explain the examination format.”

Bracelets out of nowhere?

“What’s this? I can feel mana.”

Kaen murmured as she examined the bracelet she received.

As she said, the bracelets were not mere objects, but magical devices. I still didn’t know their purpose.

And since the bracelets had different colors for each opposing group, they seemed to serve the purpose of distinguishing teams.

Anyway, as instructed, we wore the bracelets and waited. Soon, Professor Rokel and the professor from the Swordsmanship Department arrived.

After the assistant professors finished the final headcount, Professor Rokel amplified his voice with magic and began speaking.

“This place was originally designed for a specific purpose in Elphon’s early days, but has been left abandoned without any specific use. The personal combat examination for this semester will take place here. I will now explain the examination format.”

The professor shifted his gaze toward the assistant professors.

Upon seeing that, one of the assistant professors stepped forward and handed a bracelet to each of the two professors, just like us.

Professor Rokel wore the bracelet on his wrist as he continued speaking.

“This cavity is the center of the underground space, and as you can see, there are four passages running east, west, south, and north. The path you have traveled to this point is the eastern passage.”

“.....”

“The test is simple. When the test begins, myself and Professor Gaon of the Swordsmanship Department here will move to the ends of the south and north passageways, respectively. You will divide into teams according to the colors of the bracelets you have just been handed, and you will attempt to take the bracelets from either me or Professor Gaon.”

...Huh?

The students murmured in response.

It was a natural reaction. Taking the bracelet from the professors seemed absurd.

“Of course, there will be conditions and constraints within reasonable limits, so rest assured. And as I mentioned, you are not individuals but teams. You can use any means and methods available. If you manage to obtain the professor’s bracelet and make it to the common area located at the end of the western passage, regardless of your contribution, you will be guaranteed a grade of B+ or higher.”

“.....!”

The professor’s final words caused another uproar among the students.

“Besides taking the professor’s bracelet, it is also possible to take bracelets from other participants. Taking the opponent’s bracelet and moving to the western passage is another way to avoid failure. Of course, the test is relative, so the more bracelets you steal, the higher your grade will be. Anyone who has not earned a single bracelet by the end of the test, or is eliminated by losing a bracelet, will fail, no exceptions.”

The exam would last for a total of two hours. If a team was eliminated, the test would end immediately.

And there was only one team that could obtain the professor's bracelet and secure their scores.

Even if they acquired both bracelets, only the team that reached the western passage first would receive the benefits.

Why is the exam so intense?

Stealing each other's bracelets. I never thought the exam would be like this.

In any case, the rules of the exam explained by Professor Rokel were roughly as described.

"There are no restrictions beyond what I have explained. Now, do your best."

Professor Rokel finished his explanation with those words and left the seat as he had announced, just as Professor Gaon.

"I will begin the exam in 5 minutes. Until then, combat is prohibited, and movement is allowed," said one of the assistant professors to the students who were standing awkwardly.

The assistant professors then started dispersing magical objects shaped like balls throughout the corridors. They were probably observation spells meant to monitor the progress of the exam.

Meanwhile, bewildered students began to keep their distance while observing the opposing team.

"Ha," I couldn't help but let out a hollow laugh.

This interpersonal combat exam was completely different from the practical subjects we had seen so far.

To think they would make fresh-faced newcomers like us take such a test, essentially a real team battle.

“It could be fun, but it’s a shame that Rigon and us are on different teams. It would have been nice if we were all on the same team,” Kaen said, looking at Rigon standing on the opposing team.

Amidst the awkward silence, the muttering of someone from the same team was heard.

“Is this insane? Why are those two stuck on the same team?”

It was clear who they were referring to—Rigon and Lea.

Even I found it strange that the two top-ranking students were paired together on the same team.

On the other hand, it seemed like there were more high-ranking students on this side, but...

“Would you all listen to me for a moment?!”

At that moment, someone shouted loudly.

He was a student from my team, and naturally, everyone’s attention turned to him.

“There’s no point in fighting each other right now. That’s exactly what the professors want. Didn’t you all hear? If they take away your bracelets, you’re immediately eliminated. Even if the team wins, there could be many people who receive failing grades. Does everyone agree with this?”

“...”

“However, if we obtain the professor’s bracelet, at least one team can avoid failing. And there’s no rule that says the two teams can’t join forces to confront the professor. Isn’t that right, Assistant Professor?”

“Yes, that’s correct.”

One of the assistant professors nearby nodded in agreement, wearing an expression of interest.

“Did everyone hear that? So let’s first unite and take the professors’ bracelets. It will be easy if everyone works together. The professors probably won’t expect all the students from both teams to converge at once, right? Let’s easily secure the professors’ bracelets, and then we can decide whether to fight. What do you think?”

It was a reasonably tidy situation summary.

As he said, the benefits that can be obtained through students fighting amongst themselves were fewer than taking the professors’ bracelets.

So, the opinion was to unite and obtain the professors’ bracelets first, and postpone the fight for later.

The students generally seemed agreeable. They likely also had a psychological desire to avoid fights, if possible.

Next, the students’ gaze naturally turned towards two individuals—Lea and Rigon.

Lea furrowed her brows in response to the focused attention and spoke.

“Why are you all looking at me? I was planning to snatch the professors’ bracelets anyway, so do whatever you want.”

She took the lead and briskly walked towards the northern corridor, the direction Professor Rokel had moved towards.

Observing her back, Rigon spoke quietly.

“Shall we go with that plan for now? Let’s all go.”

And so, the decision was made.

The students from both teams started moving together towards the northern corridor where Professor Rokel was located.

Chapter 148: Semester Exam (2)

Chapter 148: Semester Exam (2)

“Hey, what do you think will happen?”

I heard the voices of my fellow teammates walking beside me.

“Even if it’s Professor Rokel, wouldn’t it be overwhelming to be mobbed like this?”

“More than that, the problem comes after obtaining the professor’s bracelet. It seems like it will be a complete mess...”

Judging from the atmosphere, it was already a foregone conclusion for them that we would get the bracelet from the professor.

With this many people gathering, even a professor would naturally be unable to handle it.

But I wonder if the professor really didn’t expect the students to work together.

I don’t think it will be resolved so easily.

Everyone rushed, and at the end of the passage, Professor Rokel stood still, waiting.

“Hmm.”

Professor Rokel, who looked around at the students gathered at the main entrance, calmly opened his mouth.

“I see. You made a reasonable judgment.”

I was certain as I looked at his expression, Professor Rokel had been expecting this outcome.

“There was no rule saying that teams from different groups couldn’t cooperate, right? So there shouldn’t be a problem, Professor?”

A leading student cautiously asked him.

A faint smile appeared on the professor’s lips.

“Of course, there is no problem.”

And then he suddenly raised his hand in the air.

As he did so, a line was drawn on the ground, forming a boundary between the professor and the students.

Amid the curious gazes of the students, the professor spoke.

“The rule is simple. Regardless of the method, I will give the bracelet to the student who successfully crosses this line first.”

A line?

The method to obtain the bracelet proposed by the professor was extremely simple. It was so simple that the bewildered students glanced at each other, and one student dashed ahead first.

Kwaang!

But before taking a few steps, the student floated in the air and tumbled heavily to the ground.

The professor, who effortlessly bounced the students away with a shockwave spell, continued speaking.

“Of course, it won’t be easy. I will only unleash three types of magic. Give it your best shot.”

As soon as those words were spoken, Lea took the next action.

She gathered her mana with such force that her hair stood on end and shot a lightning spell at the professor.

Zap!

The lightning bolt extended energetically, but the professor easily blocked it with a simple defense barrier.

I figured out her plan.

Is she trying to quickly deplete the count of the three types of magic restrictions?

If we knew which magic he would use, we could respond accordingly.

He had already used shockwave magic and barrier magic, so there was only one magic left.

Poof!

At that moment, the students rushed towards the professor in unison, but once again, they were all bounced away by the shockwave unleashed by the professor.

Though the impact was controlled, the students quickly got back on their feet, but none of them could get close to the professor.

After several failed attempts, someone shouted,

“Mages, support us with magic from behind! Spread out while defending, and then charge in together!”

Yes, that could be the best approach.

I didn't just stand still; I cast an appropriate offensive spell.

Meanwhile, the students from the swordsmanship department, who were observing the timing, charged forward once again. But...

Bang!

Poof!

The professor defended against all flying spells while repelling the rushing students one by one.

The students' combined attacks did not manage to distract the professor even slightly.

“You're still pushing with sheer numbers. You need to strategize.”

With expressions of frustration, the students looked at the professor, overwhelmed by the immense difference in strength.

I was a bit bewildered. Did these kids genuinely believe that they could defeat the professor just by overwhelming him with numbers?

Of course, the professor was still holding back to some extent.

If he really wanted to stop them, he could have just spread out his barrier and blocked their access.

“What is this? It's just impossible...”

However, whether due to their will being broken or not, nobody made any further attempts to approach the professor.

What followed was an eerie silence.

The collaboration between the two teams had initially been aimed at taking down the professor. But if they realized it was impossible...

“...”

The students split up into their respective teams, beginning to guard against each other.

Watching this pathetic scene, Professor Rokel unleashed a spell.

Kwaaang!

With an indiscriminate shockwave bombardment, the students screamed as, one by one, they were expelled from the battlefield.

Thus, the attempt to obtain the professor's bracelet ended in failure, and the students, who had been expelled from the battlefield, scattered in disarray.

"Phew, this won't be easy."

Kaen said, brushing the dirt out of her hair.

Esca sighed, and I shrugged my shoulders.

If it was up to me, I could get a bracelet from someone on the other team and finish the test.

"What about Rigon, though?"

"He's on the opposing team. Why look for him?"

"Well, can't we just go together, anyway?"

"Is that possible? Let him handle it on his own. So, what do we do now?"

At that moment, Vaion spoke up.

"I'm not interested in the other guys' bracelets. I want to get the professor's bracelet and pass the exam."

Kaen nodded.

“I feel the same way. Shall we take a break and try again later?”

“I’m talking about Professor Gaon’s bracelet, not Professor Rokel’s.”

“Gaon... Ah, the professor from the Swordsmanship Department? Why?”

“Because we’re both swordsmen. I want to confront the professor with swordsmanship using my full power.”

It was typical of Vaion, who had no interest in magic.

Kaen burst into laughter and said, “Well, I don’t mind either way. Shall we go challenge Professor Gaon this time?”

Was it really going to be like this?

At that moment, Esca chimed in and said, “Hey, Kaen. Wouldn’t it be safer to just get a bracelet from a student on the opposing team?”

“Well, then it would be too easy, right?”

“It’s not about it being easy or not, this is an exam...”

“It’s fine, it’s fine. Who cares about grades? Let’s try to defeat the professor somehow. Let’s all join forces.”

“...”

Esca nodded with a darkened expression for some reason, but Kaen didn’t notice and seemed excited.

Kaen shouted in a lively voice, “Well then, let’s go!”

Meanwhile, there was another person who was still eyeing the professor’s bracelet.

Lea, leaning against the corridor wall lost in thought, raised her head at the sound.

“...Oh.”

The students from the opposing team who had been roaming around together stopped as they noticed Lea.

Lea turned her gaze away with an annoyed expression, as if telling them to go their own way.

However, her reaction caused the students to look at each other and start chattering among themselves.

“Hey, should we give it a try? She’s all alone.”

While she was an object of admiration to some, she was also a target of jealousy toward others.

Considering her usual attitude toward other students, it was only natural for some to feel displeased with her.

“Look at her reaction. She must have used a lot of mana earlier, and she wants to avoid a fight.”

They approached Lea confidently.

“Aren’t you ignoring us too much, Lea Herwyn? You’re all alone right now...”

Bam!

As Lea waved her hand, the student who was standing in front of the group was violently knocked back.

The remaining students hurriedly tried to unleash their magic, but even that was slower than her second spell.

“Don’t act so annoying. I don’t even need your bracelets.”

The students who had been rolling around on the floor in unison paled and staggered to their feet.

Lea looked at them as if they were pitiful and spoke.

“More than that, there’s no rule that says you can’t take someone’s bracelet if it’s from the same team, so why are you running around like that?”

The students looked at each other, startled by those words.

Lea let out a snicker and turned her head away.

From the opposite corridor, other students were now approaching.

“That person has such a bad personality, saying nonsensical things.”

She furrowed her brow. Kaen waved her hand and spoke.

“We don’t really want to fight you, either. We’re just on our way to challenge Professor Gaon.”

“And what does that have to do with me?”

“Just saying. The way you’re talking, I’m guessing you’re after the professor’s bracelet, too, so do your best.”

Lea glanced at the crowd of students heading towards the corridor and clicked her tongue.

Ignoring the bothersome individuals, she immersed herself in thoughts of her own strategy.

“It’s not impossible. There must be a way.”

The professors wouldn’t have set up an impossible exam.

Professor Rokel had instructed them to devise strategies, not just rely on sheer numbers. So there must be some way.

She thought there must be a reason behind the joint examination between the Swordsmanship Department and the Magic Department.

Considering Professor Rokel's usual teachings, he always had valid reasons for his actions.

Moreover, crossing lines and physically engaging in combat would put mages at a disadvantage.

So maybe there was a solution to obtain the bracelet through cooperation with the Swordsmanship Department students.

“.....”

Cooperation.

For a moment, someone flashed through Lea's mind, but she quickly sighed and erased the thought.

Indeed, she didn't need a team. As always, she was confident enough to accomplish things on her own.

Lea, who had been contemplating for a while, moved back to the passage where Professor Rokel was located.

“There was a rush of people earlier, and now is it just one person?”

Professor Rokel, standing with his back to her, smirked.

Lea didn't reply, but instead drew up her mana. Her magic struck the shield.

Kwaang!

Of course, not even a small dent appeared on Professor Rokel's barrier.

Observing the scene, Lea took a step forward.

As far as she was concerned, there was only one way to make a breakthrough.

Distracting the professor's attention was not an option. It was impossible to break through the barrier and directly strike the professor.

The previous attempts were futile. Even if all the students had gathered, she couldn't succeed alone.

She was well aware of the gap in skill between herself and the professor.

Although Professor Rokel would not unleash lethal magic that would harm the students, if she so desired, she could deploy field magic to prevent any approach.

But he didn't do that.

Professor Rokel only erected the barrier when defending against the magic flying towards him.

The only method he used to repel the charging students was a shockwave spell.

So, without any residual defense, she should move forward, blocking the professor's magic from the front.

Perhaps the least plausible answer might be the correct one. A method that relied on individual ability rather than numerical advantage.

Of course, even if the professor allowed it, it would be impossible to gain an upper hand in a pure magic confrontation.

However, blocking did not simply mean straightforwardly deploying defensive magic.

Kwaagwak!

Lea rotated her field magic, as if narrowing it into a hemisphere.

The shockwave magic was scattered by the rotational force and bounced off in all directions. Professor Rokel looked intrigued.

“.....”

Even when dispersed, it still has this much power?

Lea regulated her breathing and moved again.

Professor Rokel once again released a shockwave, and Lea defended herself in the same way.

However, this time, the impact was stronger than before. Her defense barrier couldn't completely block the shockwave and was shattered.

“Ugh...”

Lea staggered, but managed to regain her balance.

The distance to the line was now about ten paces. Could she stop it one more time?

Lea clenched her lips and took a step forward. And the professor's magic came flying towards her.

Kwaang!

The defense barrier ultimately failed to block the shockwave and shattered into pieces.

Thrown backward by the unmitigated impact, Lea rolled across the floor before coming to a stop.

She pushed herself to her feet, trying to recover from the dizziness.

“.....!”

A blast of magic shot out of the common entrance, aimed at her. It wasn't the professor's magic.

She had no time to defend herself and was exposed to the attack.

Thud!

A newly arrived figure suddenly leaped in and deflected the flying magical force.

Lea held her ringing head and looked at the person who intervened. It was none other than Rigon.

“No matter what, that’s too cowardly. Isn’t it?”

Rigon twirled his sword and spoke to the student hiding near the entrance.

The student turned around hurriedly with a look of defeat and ran away.

Lea stared blankly at the back of Rigon.

Rigon turned his body and reached out his hand to her.

“Are you okay?”

“.....”

She frowned and stood up without taking his hand, standing up on her own.

Rigon withdrew his outstretched hand as if he wasn’t particularly worried.

“I helped you, but you don’t even say thank you.”

“I never asked for your help.”

“Oh, I see.”

Rigon glanced briefly at Professor Rokel and spoke.

“By the way, I was also aiming for Professor’s bracelet. But when I came back, I saw that you were already fighting.”

“...So?”

“No, it’s just that I think this is a test that requires the Department of Swordsmanship and the Department of Magic to cooperate. So, I was actually looking for someone to team up with.”

Lea’s eyes widened. Rigon’s thoughts were exactly the same as hers.

Rigon looked at her and smirked.

“So, what do you think? Instead of doing it alone, would you like to do it together?”

Chapter 149: Semester Exam (3)

Chapter 149: Semester Exam (3)

A proposal to join forces.

Lea thought to herself. After what had happened last time, Rigon didn't hesitate to interact with her again.

He must have decided he needed my abilities to get the Professor's bracelet.

Of course, setting aside other matters and joining forces was an agreeable idea to her as well.

Just now, while facing the professor alone, she realized once again that it wouldn't be easy.

"Alright."

Lea replied dryly.

There was no point in insisting on doing it alone if the other offered cooperation of their own accord.

Just cooperation for the sake of the test. They could use each other.

When she immediately accepted the proposal for cooperation, Rigon's expression seemed somewhat surprised.

"Oh, really? I didn't expect you to accept right away."

"Enough small talk. Tell me you have a strategy in mind."

Rigon shrugged his shoulders.

“I don’t have anything particular in mind. Somehow, I feel like honestly confronting him without overthinking things might be the best.”

“Why do you think that way?”

“Just a gut feeling? Well, I’m quite good at trusting my gut.”

Lea’s gaze became discontented at his careless words. Although she had come to the same conclusion.

“He’s the homeroom professor of your class. Don’t you know any weaknesses?”

“How would I know?”

“I’m kidding, but let’s do it, anyway. Let’s see what the professor does, and then we’ll deal with it.”

Lea focused her magic power and spoke.

“Shockwave spells will come flying immediately. Keep that in mind and move. I’ll support from behind with magic.”

Rigon nodded, turned his body towards Professor Rokel, and assumed a stance.

Kwaang!

The professor’s shockwave magic soared terrifyingly as he lifted his foot.

Rigon immediately dodged to the side and charged forward without hesitation.

The shockwaves continued to come one after another. Rigon gradually increased his speed and evaded them all.

Shockwave magic was something that could neither be blocked nor parried with a sword, so dodging was the best option unless you were willing to take it head on.

And Lea, too, chose a way to support Rigon accordingly.

She couldn't deploy defensive magic that would cover all directions around a moving target, nor was it ideal to launch offensive magic to block the shockwaves due to the angles involved.

In that case...

Barrier-type magic in the form of floating plates emerged around her and flew towards Rigon.

Bang! Kwa-gwa-gwang!

Consecutive loud noises resounded through the air.

The barriers created by Lea pursued Rigon's movements, floating around him and providing a maximum defense against the shockwave magic.

Although they couldn't completely neutralize its power and only weakened it to some extent, it was enough.

Rigon also moved swiftly, making the most of Lea's barriers.

"Oh..."

Professor Rokel quietly exclaimed as he watched the scene.

Typically, combining the strengths of two individuals doesn't necessarily result in a perfect synergy.

Moreover, such a method was an unsuitable strategy for two individuals who had never practiced coordinating with each other.

If the barriers were too far apart, it would be pointless to defend against them, and if they were too close, it would hinder their movement.

However, the two of them seemed to read each other's minds and were almost perfectly in sync.

“.....”

Lea could feel it, and so could he.

A shockwave flew in Rigon's path, which he dodged to the side with a low stance.

Lea's barrier blocked the next large shockwave, shattering it into pieces.

Without a moment's hesitation, Rigon pushed forward, absorbing the aftermath with his body.

How is this possible?

Lea couldn't understand.

How could Rigon have such unwavering faith in her abilities and act so fearlessly?

But thanks to that, the distance to the line was gradually getting closer.

The professor's attacks are not getting any faster. Is he not increasing his speed anymore?

Professor Rokel's magical attack, which had been gaining speed, suddenly stopped accelerating.

Having adapted to the increasing speed, Rigon took a bolder approach. The distance to the line quickly narrowed.

Watching the scene from behind, Lea focused all her attention on the professor's reaction.

Clearly, when the two of them combined their strength, the breakthrough became much smoother.

At this rate, they should be able to cross the line unless the professor suddenly increased his power. But...

There's still one more to go.

Professor Rokel had stated that he would only use three types of magic in this test.

Having used shockwave magic and barrier magic, there was one magic remaining. It had yet to be used.

There's still one more left. It's about time...

Rigon also kept that fact in mind.

The remaining distance to the line was now only about ten steps. What kind of magic would the professor use?

The probability of it being a magic that was highly lethal and dangerous was low. It was more likely to be a magic that could restrict movement. Freezing magic? Or maybe a binding magic?

If they didn't let their guard down and responded appropriately just once, the possibility of passing the line was high. That's what he thought at that moment.

“.....!”

A wavelike ripple emerged in the empty space right next to him.

Rigon immediately tried to create distance but was too late.

Due to the sudden force, Rigon's body was forcefully pulled towards the epicenter of the ripple.

Following that, a shockwave spell flew towards him, and he was mercilessly thrown backward.

Rigon quickly stood up, wearing a bewildered expression, and muttered.

“What was that just now?”

“.....”

Lea also narrowed her eyes and looked at the spot where the ripple disappeared.

A ripple that pulled objects around it? Some kind of suction magic?

In the world, there existed numerous unconventional and unique types of magic. Lea didn't claim to know all of them.

But even if she didn't know exactly what it was, Professor Rokel's intentions seemed to be clear with this.

It's a magic that is the opposite of a shockwave spell.

In other words, Professor Rokel intended to prevent their approach by using only the force of pushing and pulling.

“A magic that creates a force pulling objects in the vicinity. Do you know what kind of magic it is, Lea?”

“I don't know. But there won't be any new magic now. How's your condition?”

Rigon replied while swinging his arms.

“I'm still okay. You're the one who seems tired already, aren't you?”

“Ridiculous.”

“Alright then, shall we go again?”

Rigon, with a raised corner of his mouth as if enjoying himself, assumed a stance.

“Wait, now that we knew the three types of magic the professor was allowed to use, let's plan properly...”

Before Lea could finish speaking, Rigon's body shot out.

Lea clicked her tongue and drew upon her mana.

Rigon thought simply. He was just slow to react because he didn't know what kind of magic was coming.

If it was a pulling magic, couldn't he simply quickly move out of range before the magic unfolded?

However, it didn't take long for him to realize that it was a careless thought.

"Ugh..."

Once again, Rigon, caught in the ripple, was thrown back in the same sequence.

Lea narrowed her eyes as she looked around.

...If things continue like this, there's no way to avoid it.

Professor Rokel had already spread his mana widely throughout the area.

In this state, it would be difficult to read the flow of magic and determine the timing of the ripples in the air.

Lea felt her pride being hurt a little.

Magic output, control ability, speed of deployment – the professor matched all the elements to their level.

But even with all the conditions the same, how could there be such a difference in skill?

I have to do something.

She couldn't rely on Rigon's abilities any further.

As a mage, she had to find a way to block the professor's magic, no matter what.

But how could she stop a magic whose nature she didn't even know?

Even the barrier's defenses were useless, as the force was pulling Rigon through the intervening obstacles.

On the other hand, it was difficult for her to read the timing of the ripples, just like Rigon. If she made even a slight mistake, she could end up hitting Rigon, who was caught in the ripple.

So how the hell was she going to—

“Lea.”

Upon hearing Rigon's voice, Lea turned her gaze towards him.

“Put your barrier magic as close to my body as possible.”

“What? That doesn't make any sense.”

If they narrowed the gap any further, it would only hinder their movement.

The problem was the pulling magic at the moment, so how would narrowing the barrier help?

“I have a plan, so just do as I say for now. I trust your control abilities.”

Snap.

Rigon threw the sword down to the ground and propelled himself into the air once again.

If he was just going to avoid it, the sword would only be a hindrance, but he wanted to make his body lighter, even if it was just a little.

Lea bit her lip and controlled the barrier. Just as Rigon requested, she brought them as close to his body as possible.

With her concentration pushed to its limit, she controlled the barrier around Rigon, who was moving erratically.

Her exceptional control ability played a part, but Rigon skillfully avoided colliding with the barrier and made remarkable movements as he charged forward.

And in an instant, a shockwave appeared and pulled Rigon's body.

“...!”

At that moment, Lea instinctively understood Rigon's intention and maximized the stability of the anti-gravity fields between him and the shockwave.

Instead, Rigon jumped towards the shockwave, using the fields as a foothold, which propelled him away.

Escaping from the range of the shockwave, Rigon regained his balance and rushed straight towards his target.

Only about five steps remained.

The point where the shockwave appeared this time was right above their heads. Rigon's body was being pulled upward.

If things continued like this, it was obvious that the vulnerable body suspended in mid-air would be hit by the shockwave directly.

However, Rigon didn't resist and instead spun his body around, focusing all his remaining strength on his legs.

Because he believed that Lea would immediately move the barrier upward.

Shwooosh!

As expected, the barrier flew up above Rigon at the right timing.

Rigon pushed through the barrier and dropped back down to the ground.

Dodging the last shockwave by a narrow margin, he threw his body beyond the line.

Rigon rolled on the ground and then stood up, while Lea took rough breaths.

Silence descended upon the previously tumultuous area. The gazes of the two students converged on Professor Rokel.

Professor Rokel withdrew his outstretched hand and gave a faint smile.

“It’s a success.”

He hadn’t even thought that the two of them could pass together, but...

These students were truly extraordinary and beyond expectations.

He removed the bracelet from his wrist and handed it to Rigon before immediately stepping outside of the common area.

“Both of you did well. If you move to the end of the western corridor, the exam will be over.”

As he watched the professor’s departing figure, Rigon shifted his gaze to Lea.

Lea, exhausted to the point of staggering, was now sitting on the ground.

Controlling so many barriers in time with Rigon’s movements had taken its toll on her.

Approaching her, Rigon reached out his hand.

“Are you okay?”

“...”

Lea, still seated, glanced at Rigon’s outstretched hand with a somewhat vacant expression.

Chapter 150: Semester Exam (4)

Chapter 150: Semester Exam (4)

A friend.

It was an unfamiliar word to Lea Herwyn now.

When she was younger, there was someone she could call a friend. Just one person.

As a prodigy who was highly regarded, she had visited the Magic Tower since childhood and received teachings from several renowned mages.

Yuri. The girl was an apprentice mage she had met during that time.

Both of them, who were similar in age, quickly became close friends after their chance encounter.

At the age of 10, Yuri was Lea's first real friend.

"There's no one around me that I can talk to, and I don't really have any friends."

"That's why meeting you was really lucky, Lea. You can understand me, right?"

Yuri was the disciple of a high-ranking mage in the Magic Tower and a promising talent.

Lea could fully empathize with Yuri's words that she often blurted out.

They had different thoughts. They had different perspectives. It wasn't easy to reach out to the other person without pretense, and the same applied to the other person.

Becoming close to someone whose family, background, talents, and innate differences were so great was a rare occurrence.

Yuri never treated Lea with difficulty. That's why Lea liked Yuri more than anyone else.

She increased her frequency and time of visiting the Magic Tower, using studying as an excuse.

They shared trivial conversations, conducted magic experiments together, and accumulated enjoyable experiences while being together.

But at some point, Lea began to feel that Yuri was avoiding her little by little.

The other would say she had something urgent to do, or she wasn't feeling well, or some other lame excuse. Lea couldn't figure out why.

And then, that day happened.

Yuri brought up the idea of conducting a magic experiment after a long time. However, it would be just the two of them, without the other mages.

When conducting experiments, Yuri, the mentor, was always present as a supervisor."

Yuri, who was merely an apprentice mage, didn't have the right to conduct experiments as they pleased. It was because it was dangerous.

Lea, being the conscientious person she was, thought Yuri was making a strange suggestion, but she accepted it anyway.

Yuri was the one who brought up the idea this time, and it seemed like it would be fun to secretly engage in activities without other mages knowing.

Lea was asked for a favor by Yuri. She was asked to go to the laboratory first and prepare the necessary equipment and materials.

As Lea excitedly prepared for the experiment, she stumbled upon something by chance.

Dangerous ingredients that should never be mixed were skillfully blended together inside a storage box.

If Lea had carelessly taken them out without thinking, the entire laboratory would likely have turned into a sea of flames.

After calming her frightened heart, Lea thought of one sinister scenario.

At first, she denied it, thinking it was unreasonable. However, the more she thought about it, the clearer the situation became.

Lea went to find Yuri, who didn't show up at the laboratory even though the appointed time had long passed.

She thought it was probably a misunderstanding, but as soon as they faced each other, Lea could sense it from her expression.

“Why... would you do that?”

Why did you try to kill me?

Lea couldn't bring herself to ask directly.

As Yuri tugged at her like she didn't know what she was doing, Lea spoke word for word.

She went over the evidence, point by point, and said that she was going to tell the other's Master everything that had happened, and only then did Yuri break down and cry, her face contorted in horror.

“Don't you have any sense? This is why I didn't want to hang out with you anymore...”

“It’s all because of you. Ever since you came to the Magic Tower, Master has always compared me to you. I’m his disciple, not you!”

Yuri was a talented mage. However, Lea was a genius beyond her.

It was only for such a reason.

Lea, being friends with you is the worst kind of misfortune.

As Yuri sat on the floor, screaming like a madman, Lea said nothing more.

After that, she didn’t visit the tower again.

After some time had passed, she only heard one piece of news: that Yuri had been punished for a magic crime.

Even the master of the Magic Tower came to her family to apologize in person.

Lea hadn’t told anyone what had happened, but somehow it had gotten out.

She suffered from a headache for a long time, a headache that felt like it would break her head open.

Suppressed by the curse-like words of her closest friend who had tried to kill her out of a mere inferiority complex.

The conclusion she finally reached was simple.

She didn’t need friends anymore. She didn’t need to stoop down to fit in with inferior people.

From that point on, her personality and way of thinking changed dramatically, and she continued to live in that manner.

And now, back to the present...

“Are you okay?”

Lea looked at the hand reaching out in front of her.

Rigon. From Calderic. A peer who gave her a proper defeat for the first time.

When she lost to him in a practice match, the emotion Lea felt wasn't frustration or disappointment.

Upon reflection, it was a feeling closer to relief.

The relief of knowing that there was a genius as outstanding as herself, or even more so.

Naturally, curiosity arose. She wanted to strike up a conversation, but it wasn't easy, given her personality and upbringing.

Unlike herself, Rigon was a person who knew how to socialize easily with friends around him.

Regret often followed after she let out harsh words out of jealousy.

The sense of an unseen battle and a mixture of various emotions created a peculiar feeling.

Lea almost unconsciously reached out her hand but snapped back to her senses.

"...I can stand up on my own."

Lea tried to get up but her legs gave way, causing her to collapse to the ground.

It was a minor case of exhaustion. It was expected, since she had exerted her mana to its limit.

She let out a sigh, her expression showing frustration.

"Take the bracelet and go ahead. I can't move right now."

Now, if they just moved through the western corridor, the test would be over. There was no need for them to move together.

However, Rigon looked at Lea with a puzzled expression and plopped down beside her.

“Let’s go together once you recover.”

“...What?”

“What if another student comes and attacks you? You might win, but if you lose, you’ll get a failing grade.”

Lea was at a loss for words for a moment, unable to understand Rigon’s behavior.

“The test is based on relative evaluation. If my grades drop, it’s an advantage for you, isn’t it?”

“I don’t really care about grades.”

“...But you suggested cooperating with me because of grades in the first place.”

“What? No, I didn’t.”

“Why are you trying to play nice? There’s no reason to ask for cooperation from someone you don’t like unless it’s for a grade.”

Rigon’s expression turned slightly bewildered.

“I don’t like you? Why?”

“Because I insulted your friend...”

“Hey, that was a long time ago. Kaen doesn’t care, and I don’t really mind either.”

“...”

“I don’t think you’re a bad guy. You’ve helped me with my studies, and those words back then weren’t sincere, were they?”

Lea felt like she had become a fool for no reason with that response.

Honestly, she didn’t dislike Rigon. If anything, it was the opposite.

It’s just that her attitude, which had ingrained itself in her for years, wouldn’t change in an instant.

So, despite inwardly feeling relieved by Rigon’s words that he didn’t think badly of her, she responded curtly.

“What do you know? Don’t pretend to know about me.”

“Is that so? Were you really sincere? Anyway, nobles are all the same, with their damn sense of authority.”

Caught off guard by his sudden harsh remark, Lea stumbled over her words.

“What? I, I...”

But she realized belatedly, upon seeing Rigon’s laughter-mixed expression, that he had been teasing her.

Lea glared at him, her face turning red.

“Why are you like that? You told me not to pretend, but you’re upset when I actually say something.”

“...Say one more thing. I’ll cast a spell.”

“I won’t indulge you, haha. I understand, so now focus on your recovery.”

Lea turned her head abruptly, sitting in a dignified manner and closing her eyes.

Her body and mind were tired, and Rigon was annoying, but for some reason, she didn’t feel bad.

“Let’s see, four of you? I was expecting a swarm of people.”

A woman sitting alone in the center of a dimly lit common room.

It was the words that reached them as they arrived at the end of the southern passage, facing Professor Gaon.

“We already tried the swarm strategy with Professor Rokel, and it failed.”

Professor Gaon smiled with a twinkle in her eyes in response to Kaen’s retort.

“Yeah, well, I’m sure you did, but you still came to me, just the four of you?”

“Yes.”

“Why is that? Did I appear more approachable than Professor Rokel?”

“No, it’s because of the person here.”

Kaen pointed to the side where Vaion was standing.

Suddenly, Vaion drew his sword and aimed the blade at Professor Gaon with a more imposing demeanor.

“Even during the combat class, Professor Gaon never personally engaged with us.”

“Ah, is that so? Vaion, you always had an unruly disposition and an exceptional fighting spirit.”

The professor seemed to be pleased with Vaion’s attitude, smiled briefly, and then stood up.

“Determination is good. However, determination alone doesn’t guarantee good grades. Even if your bracelet breaks during the fight and you all end

up failing, don't blame me."

Immediately, Professor Gaon drew a circle on the ground using mana. It had a radius of a few meters.

"The rules are simple. I won't step a foot outside this area. Whether it's a sword, hand, or foot, if you manage to touch or brush against me even slightly, I will surrender my bracelet."

Although different from Professor Rokel, the rule sounded extremely straightforward.

"Of course, if you manage to drive me out of the area, it will be your victory. But that won't happen."

Having finished explaining, Professor Gaon crossed her arms and stood as if she was ready for the challenge.

"Vaion, do you have a strategy in mind? It won't be as easy as it was with Professor Rokel."

Kaen asked, and Vaion replied.

"Trickery won't work against this opponent. I'll confront her head-on with all my strength."

"Well, there's nowhere to hide around here. Is there no other way?"

Vaion charged at the professor first.

At the same time, Professor Gaon drew her sword, and a loud clang echoed as the two blades met.

I, Kaen, and Esca were naturally preparing support magic from the rear.

[Level 68]

Professor Gaon's level was slightly higher than Professor Rokel's.

Among the professors seen at the academy so far, she had one of the highest levels, so to speak.

How could a few people with an average level of 20 something, confront an opponent who was almost at level 70?

Naturally, there was no way. Even touching her clothes would be impossible under normal circumstances.

However, Professor Gaon, like Professor Rokel, could adjust her level, and the only way to defeat the professor was to find an opening and exploit it.

But as the battle progressed, the possibility seemed less likely.

It seemed like Vaion was somewhat advancing against Professor Gaon, but that was only on the surface.

Professor Gaon engaged Vaion within that narrow area, blocking and avoiding all magic. Very calmly.

Since we were the ones who would tire out first in a stamina battle, this approach was not the answer.

“Kaen, are you going to continue using only magic?”

I asked Kaen. Her specialty was martial arts rather than magic.

It would be much more plausible for her to directly engage with Vaion rather than support with magic.

“I’m in the Department of Magic! I have to rely on magic to win.”

“There were no such rules in the test. It shouldn’t matter much, right?”

“It’s not about the rules, it’s because I want to!”

Kaen was pouring out magic to the professor, drawing out her full power.

She seemed quite excited since she rarely had the opportunity to exert full power during classes.

Subjectively, a considerable amount of time had passed.

Both Vaion and Kaen were starting to pant and gasp for breath.

– Team 1, Mike Luber has been eliminated. Cease all actions and wait in place.

– Team 2, Hans Drake has been eliminated. Cease all actions and wait in place.

– Team 1, Rudy Wester has been eliminated...

During the fight, the names of the eliminated students continued to be announced through a sound amplification spell, just like an announcement broadcast.

More than that, how much time did we have left?

– There were 30 minutes remaining until the end of the exam.

Just in time, I heard the time remaining on the test.

There's not much time left in 30 minutes.

If they continued to challenge the professor like this, they wouldn't be able to avoid failing.

Of course, Kaen and Vaion were not concerned about the announcement; their focus was solely on the professor.

“There's not much time left, and you're still fooling around here? There aren't many students left. If you continue like this, you'll really fail. Or maybe fight among yourselves.”

At Professor Gaon's words mixed with laughter, Kaen, who was catching her breath, asked.

“Why should we fight among ourselves when we’re on the same team?”

“There’s no rule saying you can’t snatch the wristband of a teammate from the same team, is there? If you want to take care of your grades, you should stab your comrades in the back.”

It was a sarcastic and cruel remark. Kaen retorted, as if taken aback.

“Even if you try to provoke us like that, we would never do such a thing.”

“Is that so? Such a firm friendship.”

“And it’s not over yet. We just need to defeat the professor within 30 minutes.”

“Huh, really? Do you still think it’s possible?”

“Of course. And even if we fail, it doesn’t matter much.”

Grades didn’t matter to Kaen in the first place; she just seemed to enjoy the situation.

Kaen approached Esca, who was sitting on the floor, and reached out his hand.

Esca, having lower mana compared to the others, inevitably grew tired the fastest.

“Are you okay, Esca? Are you tired?”

“...No, I’m fine.”

“Oh, and Ran! I have an idea. From now on, let’s—“

Crack!

A small sound of impact interrupted her words.

I, along with Vaion, who was preparing for battle again, looked at the two in surprise.

Even though I saw it with my own eyes, I couldn't comprehend what had just happened.

Esca had unleashed a shockwave spell, aiming for Kaen's outstretched hand, specifically her bracelet.

“Ah—“

Kaen, retracting her hand at the last moment, looked at Esca with an incredulous gaze.

“...What did you just do, Esca?”

Chapter 151: Semester Exam (5)

Chapter 151: Semester Exam (5)

The Marioles family, where Esca belonged, was a noble family located in the eastern region of the Empire. They were a small and insignificant minor noble family with only a few small villages as their holdings.

The reason the eldest daughter was admitted to Elphon Academy was that she had a slight talent for magic.

She arrived at Elphon with the expectations of her family, her vassals, and her family's future on her shoulders.

However, her excitement about the new environment and people lasted only a few weeks. Reality was daunting.

Among the talented individuals overflowing in the academy, she quickly realized that her own talent was truly insignificant.

'If I try hard enough, I'll make it somehow,' she told herself, 'And even if I'm a little behind everyone else, all I have to do is graduate from Elphon —'

Once she graduated from Elphon, you can become a mage in the Imperial Palace, even if it's a lowly position.

If that happened, not only would her future be secured, but the revival of her family would no longer be a dream.

Esca was aware that her family had taken on a significant burden for her admission.

She had to produce results to repay those debts. She couldn't afford to disappoint their expectations.

The day arrived for her to take her first important exam after admission.

She knew she was lacking compared to others. So she sacrificed sleep and did her best to prepare, but unfortunately, luck was not on her side.

The practical exams were naturally below average, and perhaps due to excessive nervousness, she even made a mistake in checking the answers for the theory exam, which she had some confidence in. She was likely to fail.

If she failed only two more subjects, expulsion would be inevitable.

If she botched the final test, it would be a foregone conclusion.

So when she heard it was a team exam at first, she felt relieved in her heart.

For someone lacking in skills like her, a team exam was much more advantageous than going alone. Moreover, she ended up being in the same team as Kaen.

She felt a bit disgusted with herself, but she thought that if she stuck with Kaen, she might be able to avoid the worst. However...

“What did you just do, Esca?”

Eska withdrew her outstretched hand in surprise.

Kaen was staring down at her. With eyes that had grown round.

Ran and Vaion both stopped what they were doing and stared in astonishment in this direction.

“Oh, no. This is...”

What should she say?

That it was a momentary impulsive action? It would only sound like an excuse. That it wasn't his intention?

Time was running out, and she was getting anxious when she remembered what the professor said earlier.

“...”

She realized what the point of this exam was, so she gritted her teeth and stood up.

“Kaen, I clearly told you.”

“...?”

“This is a test. It's not about having fun!”

Her usual calm demeanor was nowhere to be found as she shouted loudly, and Kaen stared at her dumbfoundedly.

“Well, of course, you probably don't care. You're excellent! You probably got above-average grades on other tests too! But I'm not like that. I don't know how many subjects I might fail. If I fail this one as well, I might really get expelled. And yet, you...”

Esca laughed self-deprecatingly before finishing her sentence. Tears streamed down her eyes.

“I'm sorry. That was really pathetic.”

“...”

“Since I'm so desperate, I should have separated from you from the beginning and just get another student's bracelet by myself. I have no skills nor confidence and yet I'm still acting like this...”

Thud.

Esca took off her bracelet with her other hand.

Kaen, who was standing still in a daze, belatedly reached out to the empty space without a chance to stop her.

– Team 1, Esca Marioles eliminated. Cease all actions and wait in place.

“I’m sorry, Kaen.”

“Hey, Esca...”

“You said I was the first friend you made when you came down from the mountain, and I’m so sorry I screwed that up.”

Soon, an assistant professor appeared at the entrance.

The assistant professor walked up to Esca and looked at the professor, sensing something was wrong.

“Um, Professor Gaon?”

“Oh, it’s nothing. Just take her.”

Professor Gaon, who had been chuckling to herself on one side, waved her hand.

Until the assistant professor took Esca and exited the entrance together, no one said a word.

I watched as the two disappeared through the entrance.

I never expected something like this to happen.

I’d noticed how unstable Esca had been since the first day of exams, but this was—

What a disaster.

It was a complete mess.

Kaen, whether shocked or frozen, remained motionless.

Vaion didn't say a word either, and the professor just stood there watching us.

The atmosphere was stifling, and I was waiting for Kaen to speak first, but then the amplifying magic sounded again.

— Team 2 has successfully obtained Professor Rokel's bracelet. Proceed to the western corridor.

...Professor Rokel's bracelet? Who succeeded?

Naturally, Rigon and Lei flashed through his mind. If there were any students who could do it, it would only be them.

Anyway, if the opposing team had already obtained the professor's bracelet, all our efforts so far had become meaningless.

“Too bad. It looks like they succeeded first.”

Professor Gaon cleared her throat and spoke up.

She, too, seemed to be quite perplexed by that announcement. Her casual remark earlier had really divided the team.

I looked at Kaen. Finally, I noticed her raising her head, which had been lowered.

Then, the first words she uttered were incomprehensible.

“Ran, Vaion. Let's hurry.”

“What? What for?”

“We're running out of time. We need to obtain Professor Gaon's bracelet quickly.”

What was she talking about in the midst of all this?

Neither I nor Vaion could understand, so we looked at each other. Then—

“This is the only way Esca can avoid failing.”

I was so surprised by her subsequent words that I lost my ability to speak for a moment.

Indeed, it had been said that acquiring the professor’s bracelet would ensure good grades for the entire team.

That way, even those who failed could avoid a failing grade. But that’s not the issue here.

“...Are we going to continue? For Esca’s sake?”

Vaion questioned Kaen’s attitude, clearly not understanding.

Esca had tried to take Kaen’s bracelet. It was like being betrayed by their closest friend.

I thought it would be a big shock for her, but what exactly was she thinking?

“Yeah. I was too carefree. I didn’t pay attention to my friend and acted recklessly.”

I asked her.

“In any case, it’s true that Esca tried to take your bracelet. Aren’t you angry about that?”

“I’m not particularly angry. I just feel a little down.”

“.....”

“Why are you all staring at me like that, Ran? Am I weird?”

For a moment, Kaen and I locked eyes.

In that moment, a thought occurred to me once again.

Perhaps she was the heir of the Holy Sword, not only because of her exceptional talent in swordsmanship and magic.

“You’re not weird.”

I retorted, and then shifted my gaze to Professor Gaon.

“But we don’t have much time, Kaen. The opposing team has already obtained Professor Gaon’s bracelet.”

If the opponent moved towards the western passage, the exam would be over.

Only the team that first passed the passage with the Professor’s bracelet would get a grade advantage.

“But we won’t know until we try. We will definitely succeed.”

Even so, Kaen still seemed determined not to give up.

Kaen stepped forward. It seemed like she had no intention of stubbornly relying solely on magic anymore.

Watching her, Vaion tossed her his sword.

“You use it, Kaen.”

“What about you?”

“I’m fine with my bare hands.”

Vaion also stood beside Kaen, facing Professor Gaon.

Professor Gaon wore a smile on her face, as if finding the situation amusing.

“So, you’re going to continue? Even if you manage to obtain my bracelet, you’ll still be slower than the other team.”

Kaen gripped the sword, extending it in front of her, and lowered her posture.

“Because of you, our friendship was almost ruined. I can’t just let you win, can I?”

“I’m sorry, but even so, I can’t let things go your way easily. It’s an exam, after all.”

Kajak!

Kaen jumped in. It was an explosive burst of speed, drawing on her full mana.

Professor Gaon evaded, and Kaen relentlessly pursued. Their swords clashed rapidly, and the two circled around the narrow circle’s edge.

Professor laughed with a mixture of surprise.

“What’s a student like you doing in the Department of Magic? Were you throwing behind this kind of skill for magic?”

Similarly taken aback, Vaion, who had been observing the situation, also entered the circle immediately.

Since he didn’t have a sword, Vaion boldly swung his bare hands toward the professor.

I realized that it wasn’t a haphazard attack, but a strategy.

From the professor’s perspective, it would be difficult to swing a sword and sever the student’s arm. In fact, it seemed more challenging to confront her barehanded than with a sword.

“A bear-like guy fighting like a fox!”

Of course, the professor still didn't seem willing to give up the bracelet easily.

Vaion, struck by the sharp edge, was knocked back and tumbled to the ground. Kaen took advantage of that opening and aimed for the professor's flank, but failed spectacularly.

Kaen was exerting all her remaining mana and moving to her limits. Vaion was doing the same.

Meanwhile, I watched the scene intently, pondering.

Although Kaen was desperate, to be honest, Esca's situation wasn't that important to me.

There was no reason for me to unnecessarily interfere and secure victory against the professor. But...

Thunk!

In the midst of my distraction, the outcome was instantaneous.

Kaen, who had lost his sword and was forcefully thrown back, lay sprawled on the ground.

Professor Gaon, who had stopped moving abruptly, looked down at her own arm. Her sleeve was slightly cut.

For a moment, the professor was at a loss for words, and then he let out a stunned sigh.

Struggling for breath, Kaen lifted her head and barely managed to speak.

"Bracelet... please."

"What was that swordsmanship just now? Where did you learn it?"

"It's from an older sister I know. Give me the bracelet quickly."

Could it be that the sister she's talking about was the hero?

Professor Gaon, who placed her sword in the scabbard, untied the bracelet on her wrist and tossed it to Kaen.

“Unbelievable. Why did someone like you enter the Department of Magic?”

Kaen seemed oblivious to the professor's words as she focused on grabbing the bracelet.

Professor Gaon chuckled and turned in the direction of the entrance.

“You're Kaen, right? We'll meet again someday.”

With that, the professor muttered and disappeared out the common entrance.

Kaen, struggling to stand with the bracelet in hand, collapsed onto the ground as if her legs gave out.

I laughed at the sight, for some reason.

In a way, it wasn't unpleasant to see someone so desperate for the sake of someone else.

Vaion had already fallen and lay motionless in another corner.

I approached Kaen.

“Hey, Ran...”

“Kaen, take a rest. Leave the rest to me.”

I reached out and grabbed the bracelet she was clutching, helping her to her feet.

“It may be late, but if it isn't, I'll do something about it.”

– Team 1 has succeeded in obtaining Professor Gaon’s bracelet. Go to the west passage.

After finishing their rest, Rigon and Lea, moving along the west passage, heard a loud magical announcement in their ears.

“Did the team over there succeed, too? Could it be Kaen and the others?”

Rigon smirked.

Lea handed the bracelet she was holding to Rigon.

“You take it. I’ll stay here and block the opponents coming this way.”

“Do we really need to do that? We’ll be much faster.”

“Don’t argue, and just do as I say. It’s a reasonable judgment. I won’t let my guard down.”

Rigon, who was faster on his feet, carried the bracelet while Lea obstructed the opponents. Of course, it was the best decision they could make.

“What if you get eliminated...?”

“That’s why I’m telling you to take responsibility and make it to the finish line for sure. Now, hurry.”

Rigon didn’t like it, but he decided to do as she said. She was going to be stubborn about it, anyway.

“Fine. Then I’ll go ahead.”

As Rigon left, Lea stood alone and stared across the path they had come from.

Before long, the sound of someone running towards her echoed through.

Narrowing her eyes, she looked at the approaching figure. And soon, she could tell who it was.

“...Ran?”

They must be the ones who obtained Professor Gaon’s bracelet, just as Rigon had said.

Was Professor Gaon’s side easier than Professor Rokel’s? Or was it Vaion’s achievement?

Lea wondered how they’d managed to do it when they’d struggled so much themselves, but she quickly dismissed the thought and reached out her hand.

If it was just one insignificant person, there wouldn’t be a problem. She had enough energy left to deal with them.

Even after seeing her, Ran didn’t stop and continued to run towards her.

Leah chuckled and attempted to unleash a shockwave spell. But before she could, the opponent cast a spell first.

Flash!

She protected her eyes with magic against the bright flash that illuminated the passage.

There had been times like this before. Didn’t you still realize that this kind of trickery was pointless?

She thought as she tried to sense Ran’s movement.

“.....!”

Suddenly, Lea was startled as someone passed right by her side, almost losing her balance.

As the flash subsided and her vision returned, Ran had already passed her by and was running.

Lea couldn’t understand what had just happened.

“How...?”

It was a distance of more than thirty steps before the flash exploded.

That far distance narrowed in an instant without sensing any signs and passed by her?

She belatedly regained her senses and tried to cast a spell, but he was already far away.

She stared blankly at his retreating figure, her expression haunted.

As Rigon ran toward the destination at the end of the west passage, he felt someone following him from behind.

What's this? Did they pass through Lea?

Rigon increased his speed and ran.

It was an unexpected turn of events, but he was ahead of them anyway, so all he had to do was get there first.

Soon, the exit came into Rigon's view. There was a line drawn with magic to mark the endpoint.

The distance between him and the pursuer was still far.

It was the moment when he was about to rush and cross the finish line...

“.....?!”

Suddenly, at the far end of the finish line, as if rising from the empty space, a person appeared, surprising Rigon and causing him to stop in his tracks.

On closer inspection, it was someone he knew. Rigon murmured unconsciously.

“...Ran?”

With a vague smile, Ran raised the professor’s bracelet in his hand.

“Sorry, Rigon. We won.”

Chapter 152: Holy Sword (1)

Chapter 152: Holy Sword

I checked my report card as it arrived at my dorm room door, sealed in an envelope.

I failed a subject.

I thought I did fairly well, but in the end, I failed the theory portion.

I felt disappointed deep down. Looking at the scores, if I had answered just one more question correctly, I would have passed.

I put the report card back into the envelope and looked out the window before heading outside.

A few days had passed since the end of the semester exams.

Now, for nearly two months, it was the break period with no classes. In other words, it was vacation.

Half a year has already passed.

Half a year had gone by, and there was still no progress, just standing in place.

The human relationships around Kaen were forming as intended from the beginning. The problem was that it was all there was.

Something needed to happen, but expecting a dramatic event in this academy to meet the conditions for inheriting the Holy Sword was unrealistic.

I contacted the hero, thinking that something might have changed with the Holy Sword during the combat test, but she said there was no change at all.

Maybe it's time to do something different?

Even if there was no better option, I couldn't just waste time like this...

I should discuss it again when I meet the hero.

I had planned to meet the hero when the semester ended.

Asher would also come with her to report on what had happened in the monarchy.

“Ran! Where are you going?”

I turned my head at the voice calling me from behind.

Kaen was standing there, waving her hand with a usual smiling face.

“Just to the library. How about you?”

“I'm just taking a walk until dinner.”

“Our grades had arrived. Yours probably already arrived at your dormitory room.”

“Oh, really? How did you do?”

“Unfortunately, I failed one of the theoretical subjects.”

“I see. That's a shame.”

Kaen gave me a quizzical look, then turned away.

“I should check mine, too. Well, I'll go first. See you later at dinner.”

Esca should probably be fine. I heard her murmur like that. Kaen walked towards the dormitory.

There was an incident during the combat test, and Kaen and Esca immediately reconciled.

There was no need for actual reconciliation; one side apologized while the other side reassured them, and that was all.

The atmosphere was still awkward, but that was a problem that time would solve.

As I made my way to the public library, I encountered an unexpected sight.

Rigon and Lea were standing side by side in front of a bookshelf, engaged in a hushed conversation.

Rigon, upon spotting me, greeted me.

“Oh, Ran.”

“What brings you to the library? You said you were going to the training grounds earlier.”

“I finished training and came back. Since I don’t have much to do, I thought I’d read a book or something.”

I glanced briefly at Lea.

Unlike the composed Rigon, she seemed startled, as if caught in the act of doing something suspicious.

“But it’s an unexpected combination, isn’t it?”

“Huh? Haha, you think so? We happened to run into each other and were having a little chat.”

“Oh, earlier Vaion was looking for you. And the semester exam grade reports arrived in our rooms.”

“Really? You didn’t secretly read mine, did you?”

“Why would I?”

“It’s a joke. Well then, I’ll go first.”

Waving at me and Lea, Rigon walked out of the library.

As I was about to walk away, Leia stopped me.

“I heard it’s spatial magic. The magic you used during the exam.”

I stopped and turned to look at her.

“I heard it from Rigon.”

“Oh, I see.”

During the previous combat exam, I used space leap without hesitation to help Kaen, who was struggling.

Unless it was a really necessary situation, I didn’t intend to use my original abilities within the Academy.

It wasn’t without its problems. There were plenty of magical observers all over the testing grounds.

There were risk, but I did it anyway, and then I was summoned to speak to Professor Rokel.

I told Professor Rokel that it was my unique magic. It was the most convenient excuse.

The concept of unique magic meant that it was an entirely different field from existing magic systems, and it was impossible for anyone to realize it was magic just by observing it momentarily.

I’m lucky it didn’t cause any major issues.

The reason the professor didn’t ask further might be because I was admitted to the academy based on the recommendation of the headmaster.

In any case, I also told Rigon, who witnessed my abilities firsthand. Unique magic.

It seemed like Lea had also heard that from Rigon. Was that what they were discussing just now?

Lea expressed her displeasure.

“That’s annoying. Have you been deceiving people like that all this time, while laughing at them on the inside?”

“...What are you talking about?”

“You’ve never used that magic in our combat training before. You have the ability to get behind my back so easily, and yet you did it in moderation?”

So, what?

Was her pride hurt by the fact that I had been holding back against her?

“You’re not in the position to say that, right?”

“What?”

“You’ve never given your all in a combat or fought with full power, except against Rigon, right? It’s the same for me and the others. We’re all the same.”

“I can win easily even without giving my all! You, on the other hand...”

“Why should I reveal my unique magic in combat just to win against you? It’s common sense.”

Turning to Leah, who was speechless for a rebuttal, I waved my hand in the air.

“But when did you become so close to Rigon?”

“Well, what?! No way!”

“It’s not ‘no way.’ You’ve been interacting with him like a professor, having conversations alone together.”

“I’m telling you, it’s not like that!”

Lea glared at me as the surrounding gazes gathered and then hurriedly ran away.

She showed such a strange reaction. Did she really have feelings for Rigon?

Putting aside such pointless thoughts, I moved on to attend to my own business.

Visiting the public library every week to check if the mystery had appeared had become routine for the past six months.

Confirming that there was no one around, I absentmindedly examined the hidden spot on the bookshelf...

“...!”

Startled, I instinctively looked around again.

In a dark corner, there was a bright light emitting from a symbol, a mystery.

It has finally appeared.

I quietly pushed aside the bookshelf as quietly as I could and reached out my hand towards the symbol.

For a moment, it glowed brightly, and then the scattered symbols were absorbed into my arm.

Lost in a momentary sensation of faint excitement, I stood there absentmindedly when an urgent voice reached my ears.

“Hey there! What’s going on?”

I hurriedly stepped out into the hallway and bowed to the librarian, who was coming this way.

“I’m sorry, sir. I’m reading a spellbook, and I was just trying to control my magic a bit, and I accidentally cast a flash magic...”

At that, the librarian sighed with a relaxed expression, and then spoke up.

“Don’t you know that using magic outside the training grounds is strictly prohibited on campus? And you’re a first-year student, right?”

“Yes, I’m really sorry.”

“Follow me and write down your name and the name of your assigned professor.”

After fulfilling all of the strict librarian’s demands, I finally stepped out of the library.

There would probably be a penalty imposed later, but it wasn’t important at the moment.

The name of the mystery I’d acquired this time was “Soul Convergence.”

It allowed me to absorb the soul of a deceased being into my body and borrow their abilities.

In the game, it was an ability to randomly steal the target’s skills and use them for a certain period of time...

Until now, the mysteries I acquired had all been somewhat different from the game, and this time no exception.

The moment I obtain a mystery, I naturally knew how to use it.

It’s different in this way.

In this world, Soul Convergence was a onetime, or rather, a single-target mystery.

It could only be used once on a single individual.

Naturally, the target's soul must still be in the real world, not yet extinguished, and there was also a time limit.

Furthermore, since it involved borrowing power, there was a constraint that I couldn't use the mystery without the target's permission.

But despite these penalties, the ability itself was a very powerful mystery.

Because, unlike the game's setting of random skill acquisition, the return was exceptional.

I may use all the living abilities of the target whose soul I have taken.

If I were to accept the soul of the Overlord, it meant I could use her magical abilities, physical capabilities, and racial traits for a limited time.

However, even though the abilities were powerful, the conditions for using them were difficult in various ways, which was the problem.

I thought it was an obscure mystery before I got it, but this makes it even more obscure.

Anything is better than nothing.

Anyway, this was the fourth mystery I acquired, following super regeneration, floating veil, and space leap.

A few more days passed, and with the official start of the school year, I was fully cleared to go out.

I went outside the academy and moved to the meeting point to meet the hero and Asher.

I entered a tavern located on a main street and gently knocked on the door at the end of the second-floor corridor.

Clank.

The person who opened the door was an unfamiliar woman. I glanced at the level above her head.

The hero had changed her appearance from the last time I'd seen her.

I entered the room without saying a word.

Another person was sitting at one of the tables, and she stood up, bowing her head in greeting.

Blonde, even Asher has changed her appearance, though it never hurts to be cautious.

Immediately, the hero spread a barrier around the room to block the sound with magic.

I sat across from Asher.

Since it had been a while, it was a reunion that made me quite happy, so I opened my mouth to speak.

"It's been a while, Asher. You've worked hard."

"Yes, Sir Ron. Have you been well all this time?"

"Did anything happen in the monarchy?"

"Everything has been as usual. There hasn't been anything special."

I turned my gaze and exchanged nods with the hero.

Since we had been in regular contact through magic communication, we were always aware of each other's whereabouts.

"And as you mentioned, the Shadow came to the Lord's castle not long ago."

I nodded my head.

The Shadow was supposed to come this time of year to report on the information she had gathered.

Since I had to be away, I had already informed Asher in advance and entrusted her with that part.

“Did she find any significant results?”

“Yes, they found a trace of the target’s past.”

I couldn’t help but be slightly surprised since I hadn’t had high expectations.

Did she really manage to find something with such limited information?

“She said all the detailed information is compiled here.”

I took the scroll from her hand, unfolded it, and read it carefully.

“...A Shadow Division affiliated with the Santea Royal Family?”

Summarizing the information gathered by the Shadow, it went like this.

In the past, there was a secret organization within the Santea that handled the dirty affairs of the Empire, and all the members of that organization were wiped out after a certain incident.

Among them, it was suspected that one surviving member might be the person I mentioned.

The one with the mystery of possession, the very person who would soon launch a terrorist attack on the capital of Santea.

Comparing the knowledge I possessed with the information written on the paper, I concluded that it was a quite reliable assumption.

“Did the Shadow leave any additional message?”

“She said she would continue to track based on the collected information.”

Anyway, if all of this was true, it was reasonable to expect to catch the elusive scoundrel’s tail as well.

After putting the information sheet into my pocket, I asked the hero standing next to me.

“Let’s get straight to the point. Do you have something important to say?”

The hero responded calmly to my question.

“It’s about my physical condition, nothing else.”

“When you say physical condition...”

“This may not be of concern to the Seventh Lord, but I think I need to focus on recovery in Eastern Castle for a while.” (T/N: ‘Seongdong’ was the word used here. The direct translation for it is ‘eastern castle’. Which, most likely, was not the real translation. But since I couldn’t really find the right word/s for it, let’s just go with ‘Eastern Castle’ for now.)

Upon hearing those words, I involuntarily let out a small sigh.

Going back to Eastern Castle again meant that the hero’s condition had worsened.

“Is your condition not good?”

“To be honest, yes, it’s quite bad.”

“What happened during that time? Did you have another clash with—“

“No, it’s not that.”

The hero shook her head.

“While sealing the Demon King in the past, traces of his power remained within my body. It continues to gnaw at me, as you are well aware.”

“I know.”

“It seems that the resurrection of the Demon King is not far off. The presence of that bastard’s energy within me has been unusually restless lately.”

“...”

I couldn’t help but be surprised.

I was well aware that time was running out, but...

“If it’s not far off, how much time exactly do we have left?”

“I don’t know. It could be years from now, or it could be tomorrow. That’s why it’s dangerous.”

It wouldn’t be weird if it came back at any time.

According to the game’s story, it’s normal for the Demon King to be resurrected years later.

Had something changed, or was this just the way things were supposed to be? I wasn’t sure.

“Has there been any revelation from the Holy Sword?”

“No, there hasn’t.”

The hero shook her head.

I let out a deep sigh.

...It’s frustrating.

Suddenly, to my irritation, I realized that I still knew nothing.

In other words, there was no clear motive presented to me.

If Kaen successfully inherited the Holy Sword and defeated the Demon King, what would come next?

Why did I become trapped in the game world?

When everything was over, could I return to my original world, or would I have to live here forever?

The silent hero summoned the Holy Sword in the air.

“I’m sorry. Since the Holy Sword informed me about the heir, there hasn’t been a single moment...”

Flash!

Suddenly, a bright light burst forth from the Holy Sword.

At the same time, I felt a momentary detachment from reality.

“...!”

What was it?

What just happened? What did the hero do?

When I regained consciousness and vision, what I saw before me was not the room I had just been in.

It was a space enveloped in pure white.

A massive entity with a human form was sitting and looking down at me.

Feeling overwhelmed by its presence, I managed to open my mouth. Could it be?

“.....Who are you?”

As if responding like a god, that existence replied.

[I am the Holy Sword. Let us have a conversation for a moment.]

Chapter 153: Holy Sword (2)

Chapter 153: Holy Sword (2)

A peculiar voice that was difficult to discern whether it's male or female, young or old.

My heart pounded. A strange sensation that could not be described in words.

The Holy Sword?

The only existence in this world that could be called a god.

Certainly, the presence before my eyes was not an ordinary being.

I had never felt this way, even when encountering the hero or the Overlord for the first time.

Rather than that, what did it mean by wanting to talk for a moment?

And where was this place? Was it not reality but some kind of mental space?

The being who referred to themselves as the Holy Sword seemed to be waiting for me to settle down my confusion.

I regained my composure and asked them immediately.

“Where am I?”

[It is my mental world. You are unconscious in reality.]

“Why have you summoned me here?”

[As I said, I wanted to have a brief conversation with you.]

“What kind of conversation...?”

[You must have many questions for me.]

Questions... Well, there were indeed many.

If I ask right now, would they tell me everything? Just like that?

[There isn't much time for conversation.]

Upon hearing those words, I quickly collected myself and turned my head.

Whatever the case, the opportunity is here, and I need to get as many questions answered as possible now.

And the first question, of course, was.

“How much do you know about me?”

I'd been thinking about it for a while.

The Holy Sword, if they were indeed a god, they might be the only existence that knew the reason why I transmigrated in this world.

The Holy Sword replied.

[I know most of it. That you are an existence from a different world, the abilities you possess, and even your true nature.]

“.....!”

Was this real...

For the first time since I possessed this body, I met someone who knew my circumstances.

I calmed my mind and continued with the questions.

“In the world where I originally lived, this world, I mean...”

Did you know that this world was not reality, but a game?

I hesitated for a moment before asking.

If I say it's a game, would they understand? How should I explain this?

[I have heard of the concept of a game. I haven't seen it first hand, but I have a rough understanding of what it is.]

But it seemed like the Holy Sword already knew what I was trying to say, as it responded first.

They understood the concept of a game?

It was a strange response, but I let it pass for now. At least it meant they knew what I was trying to say.

“Then, this world is not a game but an existing reality. Is that correct?”

Unknowingly, I became anxious.

“If that's the case, why was it a game in my world, and why did I get reincarnated into the body of a character in the game?”

This time, the Holy Sword paused before responding.

[That is a question for which there is no answer, and it is meaningless to answer.]

“What do you mean? You told me to ask if I had any questions...”

[I will answer, excluding anything related to your home world.]

If they're not going to tell me the most important part, what's the point?

In that instant, a sense of absurdity and annoyance surged within me, but I recalled the Holy Sword's statement that there wasn't much time for conversation.

"...Then when exactly will the Demon King be revived?" I asked.

[It could be as soon as tomorrow, as Aindel mentioned, or it could be years later.]

"I'm asking for the precise time."

[That cannot be determined with certainty. However, it is a definite fact that it will be in the very near future.]

What good was this conversation if they couldn't even answer that?

Feeling slightly disappointed, I pressed on with the next question.

Fine, if I had to ask anything other than Earth-related questions, the one I was most curious about was...

"Can my instant-kill ability also kill the Demon King?"

A question that had intrigued me since the very beginning, when I set the goal of stopping the Demon King.

Because I couldn't be certain about it, I had been desperate to search for the hero and the Holy Sword.

[Yes.]

The answer came immediately.

[The power you possess can reach the Demon King. That much I can say for sure.]

"..."

I see.

So, even if Kaen failed in inheriting the Holy Sword, it wasn't as if I would be left with no option at all.

I felt a strange sense of relief and a heavy weight on my heart at the same time.

What else should I ask...?

I lowered my head, lost in thought, and then turned to the Holy Sword and asked again.

“I want to know clearly what your purpose is.”

[The extermination of the demons, the stability and peace of this world. Aindel's will is my will.]

“Then why don't you stop the Demon King yourself? You're such an incredible being, worthy of being hailed as a god...”

Perhaps it was a question that didn't even need to be asked.

[Because this is the best course of action. I am not as omnipotent as you think.]

“Can you explain in more detail?”

[If I had the leisure, I would, but time is running out. This conversation ends here.]

Already? It felt like only a few minutes had passed.

“Just a moment, then the voice I heard when I was first arrived in this world...”

I tried to ask at least one more question in haste, but the form of the Holy Sword gradually blurred.

[The doubts you hold, the short exchange we had, they hold no meaning. However, the reason I called you here is that I sensed your destiny is

undergoing a change for the first time.]

Slowly, my consciousness faded.

Like an echo, I heard the last words of the Holy Sword.

[There is no need to doubt whether you are walking the right path. You have not been wrong. Keep moving forward.]

When I came back to my senses, the space had reverted to the original inn room.

I blinked dazedly and was startled by the sight before me.

“...What are you two doing?”

Asher was exhaling aura as she drew her sword and aimed it at the hero, who appeared bewildered.

“Sir Ron!”

Asher turned to me and finally collected her energy, shouting.

The hero also looked at me, wearing a relieved expression for some reason.

“What’s going on, Asher?”

“Are you alright? You suddenly lost consciousness! And then the hero summoned the Holy Sword...”

The hero let out a sigh and asked, “Are you alright, Seventh Lord?”

“I’m fine. How long was I unconscious?”

“Less than a minute. What happened? Could it be... related to the Holy Sword?”

I nodded my head.

Finally, understanding the general situation, I gestured to Asher.

“Put away your sword, Asher. I didn’t lose consciousness because of the hero. I’m fine.”

Asher glanced at the hero briefly and obediently sheathed the sword.

Taking a deep breath, I massaged my forehead and organized my thoughts.

The hero seemed to be waiting for me to speak. I addressed her.

“...I had a conversation with the Holy Sword. That’s all. I don’t even know why the Holy Sword called me.”

“Can you tell me what you talked about?”

“Sorry, but it was somewhat personal. It’s difficult to explain in detail.”

It was a story that couldn’t be told to others, and even if I did, it would be incomprehensible.

I felt awkward about the possibility of the hero insisting on an answer, but fortunately, she didn’t inquire further.

“If the Holy Sword called only you, there must be a reason. I understand.”

I was about to say something more, but I gave up.

Originally, when I met the hero today, I intended to discuss new plans as well. However...

I shouldn’t have to question whether I’m on the right path...

What could that possibly mean?

The Demon King’s resurrection was imminent. Did that mean what we’re doing now isn’t a waste of time?

Ah, I don't know...

In any case, the conversation ended vaguely like that afterward.

We have been in contact all this time, but the hero never asked me about the heir.

I could sense her thoughts. Was she still unwilling to talk about the succession of the Holy Sword?

I stood up and asked the hero next to me, “Are you going to meet the heir now?”

“Yes.”

The hero turned his gaze towards Asher, who was standing beside me.

She offered an apology once again to Asher, who still showed faint hostility, and took something out.

“I will give this item to her, Seventh Lord.”

It was a magical tool that we had been using to communicate all this time.

“It’s something I don’t need once I enter the Holy City.” (T/N: This is the ‘Eastern Castle’ from the last chapter. I think it’s more apt to use ‘Holy City’ based on the context of the story. (◡_◡;))

“Why? Shouldn’t we at least maintain minimal contact?”

“The barrier of the Holy City blocks all external energies, so this magical tool won’t work, either.”

I see.

The atmosphere was already uneasy as we were parting ways, and now the contact with the hero was completely severed. It left me feeling uneasy.

“Well then, I’ll go. I don’t know when, but I’ll recover as quickly as possible and find you first.”

“Alright...”

As the hero left, only Asher, and I remained in the room.

I absentmindedly stared at the table, and Asher spoke up.

“I will also return to the Lord’s castle immediately. Please don’t burden yourself, Sir Ron.”

I looked at her. I could sense her concern and worry in her eyes.

Feeling a momentary comfort amidst the complexity of my emotions, I smiled faintly.

“Before you leave, let’s have a meal together after a long time. I know a good restaurant in the city.”

“Yes? Oh, yes. Understood.”

After parting ways with the Seventh Lord, Aindel immediately went to find Kaen.

“Del! I was really sad, you know. You said you would come to see me as soon as I enrolled, but why haven’t you visited me even once?”

“I’m sorry. I’ve been busy during that time.”

“Well, if that’s the case, it can’t be helped. But why is Father still not here? I’m starving to death.”

Ben went grocery shopping so he could feed their guest in their new home in this city

Aindel smiled as she watched Kaen, who was tapping the table with an excited expression after their long-awaited reunion.

“How’s life at the academy? Did you make a lot of friends?”

“Haha, I already have four friends. We eat and train together every day.”

Aindel already knew how Kaen was doing, thanks to the information she received from the Seventh Lord, but she quietly listened to her story.

“Thank you so much for bringing me to the outside. These days are so much more enjoyable than when I lived in the mountains with my father.”

Aindel fell silent for a moment and softly asked Kaen.

“Kaen, what do you want to do after you finish studying at the academy?”

“Well, I don’t really have anything I particularly want to do. I have many friends, and I’m satisfied with the present.”

Kaen flicked her finger.

“Oh, Del, you want to pass down your sword to me, don’t you? Is that right?”

“.....”

“Don’t worry. Thanks to you, I’m having a great time. Whatever Del desires, I’ll grant it.”

Aindel opened her mouth.

“Kaen, there’s something I haven’t told you.”

“Yes?”

“The act of inheriting my sword is not merely a simple gesture. It means that you will bear all the responsibilities and obligations I possess, including protecting and safeguarding others.”

“Responsibilities and obligations? What are those?”

“That means... protecting and guarding other people.”

Kaen tilted his head in confusion.

“That doesn’t seem too difficult, does it? Helping others is a natural thing to do.”

“It’s not that simple. If necessary, you must fulfill your responsibilities even if it means sacrificing everything you have. Kaen, it’s not just about the people who are precious to you, but also the ones you dislike or resent. It’s for the sake of everyone. Can you do that?”

“Hmm? Well...”

Caught in the suddenly serious atmosphere, Kaen hesitated, and then lowered her head.

“I don’t really know. How does Del handle such difficult tasks?”

A faint smile appeared on Aindel’s lips.

“That’s not something I can teach you. It’s a question you must find the answer to on your own.”

Creak.

The gazes of the two people sitting at the table simultaneously turned towards the entrance.

As the front door opened, Ben entered. The basket in his hands was filled with ingredients.

“I’m quite late. Sorry for keeping the guest waiting.”

“It’s not just a little late, Father. It’s incredibly late.”

“Enough. I’ll quickly show off my skills and serve the meal, so please keep our guest entertained a little longer.”

Chuckling, Ben disappeared into the kitchen.

Kaen stuck out her tongue at his retreating figure.

“Oh, so Del, about the conversation we just had...”

Aindel chuckled and shook her head.

“No, forget about that. Let’s eat when the meal is ready.”

In a dark, cold room, an old man stood silently, visibly worried about something.

Grandios, Emperor of the Santea Empire.

He was recalling a conversation from the past, not too long ago.

‘The movement of demons is unsettling. It wouldn’t be surprising if the world is soon engulfed in chaos.’

‘Your Majesty is not unaware of my physical condition. I have grown weak, and the resurrected Demon King will be even stronger than before. Yet, you don’t seem to know what should be prioritized.’

‘Do not test my patience any further. I have neither time nor peace of mind remaining.’

The warning of the hero who emerged from seclusion six months ago.

During that time, the emperor managed to evade the hero’s watchful eyes and attention to carry out many deeds.

But now, it had reached its limit.

If the hero had said so, then the calamity must not be far off.

Ironically, the emperor trusted and believed in a being that scorned and despised him more than anyone else.

“What should be prioritized...”

Though the preparations were not complete, it was time to witness the culmination of decades of work before it was too late.

“I have always had my eyes in one place, Hero. Only for us humans...”

The murmurs of the emperor dissipated into the darkness.

Chapter 154: Demon Worshipers

(1)

Chapter 154: Demon Worshipers (1)

The end of the Great War, which began decades ago with a demonic invasion, also changed the hierarchy and structure of the demon realm.

Chaos and disorder ensued due to the absence of the Demon King, who was the focal point of all demons.

Only one demon took it upon themselves to restore order and establish a new hierarchy in Altelore.

Ranked first among the demons, Azekel.

Azekel, the Demon King's closest confidante, seized the opportunity to sow chaos and crush any rebellious demons.

He created a new hierarchy and united the demons once again with the goal of reviving the Demon King.

Of course, not all demons followed Azekel.

Among the surviving demons from the war, there were also powerful individuals who were not inferior to the current archdemons.

Most of those who opposed Azekel perished in the end, but there were also those who survived.

Some of them still wander the desolate outskirts or have ventured beyond Altelore into the outside world.

“Hehehe. Hahaha. Is this it?”

The Off Fortress, a major stronghold in the Third Lord’s domain, located in the north.

The ground was dyed red with the shattered and torn bodies, as the laughing demon, clad in a formidable armor-like carapace, reveled in the carnage he had caused.

“Nothing but insects everywhere. It’s getting boring. How many more do I have to kill until the big one shows up?”

The demon had been a force to be reckoned with in the past war, when there had been no more than a dozen stronger than him in the demon faction.

Even if he had been a defeated fighter who had fled Altelore with his life after the war against Azekel.

It had been years of painful endurance. Scurrying from place to place like a mouse in a foreign land.

Now that he had regained some of his former strength, he was slowly breaking out of his long hiding to take action.

He had no intention of returning to Altelore anytime soon.

Azekel, even though he had regained his strength to surpass that monster, it was an impossible task for the immediate moment.

Therefore, he changed his goal.

The world was too peaceful now. It had already forgotten the horrors of the past, forgotten their existence.

Stupid, weak scums that would have been exterminated long ago if it weren’t for the abominable hero.

By hunting moderately strong insects, he could accumulate more power and become stronger than now.

Graaaaaah...

The wails of dreadful souls. The demon smiled as he looked at the blood-red gem in his hand.

“Wait for it, the day I return to Altelore...”

He mumbled, and then turned his gaze. Someone was approaching from that direction.

A man approached with a casual stride, as if he was on a stroll, and looked around before opening his mouth.

“You’ve really done a terrible job, demon.”

“Just this much? They were nothing but trash with no skill or taste for ripping and tearing.”

The demon sensed the energy emanating from him and smirked.

“Now, what I’ve been waiting for has finally come. Are you the Third Lord of Calderic?”

The Third Lord, the Heavenly Archer, fixed his gaze on a corpse and spoke. (T/N: I referred to him as ‘Heavenly Palace’ before since that’s the direct translation of the title in english. But this title seemed to suit him more, so I changed it. >_<)

“You must have been too afraid of the Overlord to go on a rampage in the middle of Calderic, so you’re doing something despicable here instead.”

“Hehehe, speak as much as you like before you die.”

The demon wiped off the blood on his hand and stood up.

“They call you the Heavenly Archer, right? I heard your specialty is shooting arrows from a distance like a rat. Now that you’ve revealed yourself right in front of me, what will you do?”

They were within a few steps of each other, close enough to reach out and touch.

With a still expression on his face, the Heavenly Archer reached out his hand towards the empty air.

“No need to worry.”

His wrist bracelet dangled and instantly transformed into the shape of a bow.

“From now on, until your body is scattered into pieces on the ground, you won’t be able to narrow this distance even a bit.”

The Academy’s vacation season had begun, and most students were preparing to return to their hometowns and families.

Lea sat on the edge of her bed, reading the letter that had arrived in front of her.

[How was life at the academy? If you haven’t made a single friend by now, this brother will be very disappointed.

Yuz will be there soon, so come home quickly. Bring as many friends as you can.]

Reading the playful content of the letter, Lea furrowed her brow and folded it back together.

“What about friends...”

She remained lying on the bed, glaring aimlessly at the ceiling.

It was because she couldn’t help but think of someone as soon as she finished reading the letter.

Even after the exams were over, Lea had occasional, or rather, quite frequent interactions with Rigon.

It could be said that it happened naturally.

Now, meeting side by side and having casual conversations was no longer a strange thing at all.

Rather, she found herself subtly looking for places where Rigon might be during her free time.

At first, she was confused and denied her own change, but now she simply accepted it.

She wanted to get closer to Rigon.

Once she admitted it, her pride was slightly hurt, but she convinced herself that it wasn't strange at all.

Rigon was a genius comparable to herself. He was an outstanding talent.

Perhaps the reason she hadn't tried to be close to anyone before was that there was no one suitable for her level.

So, there was no change in her attitude. There was no reason not to be close if such a person appeared.

True. It's just like that.

Besides, it's not easy to build a close relationship with a promising individual from Calderic, right? It's excellent networking.

Lea, who had never cared about connections in her life, rationalized it that way.

Anyway, he'll be at the academy even during vacation.

Rigon had said that he wouldn't return to his hometown.

Not only was it a long distance, but it was also not feasible to freely travel between Calderic and Santea.

“You want me to come to your house for vacation?”

When Lea encountered Rigon during dinner time, she seized the opportunity and casually brought up the topic.

In response to Rigon’s wide-eyed reaction, she avoided his gaze and hastily spoke the prepared words.

“The nobles of Santea are sensitive to favors, you know? So, I’m just trying to repay my debts on the test for the sake of my honor. You’ve helped me, and I’ve lost because of my own shortcomings.”

“No, that was unexpected of Ran, and it was more of my fault...”

“Anyway, are you coming or not? I’ll make sure you’re treated like a guest. You don’t have anywhere to go during vacation anyway, do you?”

Rigon scratched his head. Lea folded her arms and casually glanced at him.

“Well, if you invite me, of course, I’d be happy to go. But can’t the others come too? Ran and Kaen are also staying at the academy like me. Vaion and Esca said they’re going home, though.”

“Huh?”

...Those guys were also staying at the academy?

Honestly, she didn’t want to invite them, but if I refused, Rigon would definitely not go.

Adding a couple more people was within the acceptable range. After all, the important thing was that Rigon was going.

Lea nodded, concealing her excitement.

“There’s no reason to refuse. Do as you please.”

I lay on the bed, idly resting, when Rigon returned and said something strange.

“Lea invited us to her house? The Herwyn family?”

“Yes.”

I wondered what this was all about and quickly guessed the situation. Rigon and Lea had been getting close lately.

“She only asked if you wanted to go with her. She didn’t say we should all go together, did she?”

“Haha, got caught.”

Rigon chuckled awkwardly.

“She’s not a bad person either. It’ll be nice if you and Kaen also get along during this opportunity.”

“Well, I don’t really mind, but...”

Until just now, I was recalling the conversation I had with the Holy Sword yesterday.

Although I didn’t understand what they meant by “fate’s change” and all that, the Holy Sword had assured me that at least I didn’t need to doubt if I was going in the right direction.

What exactly did that mean?

Was it really okay to just keep going like this? Without worrying about the succession of the Holy Sword?

That’s too complacent of a thought...

Anyway, it would be better to go outside during vacation rather than being stuck in the academy. Besides, who knew if something would happen?

In that sense, Rigon's suggestion to go to the Herwyn family was not a bad idea.

"Yeah, let's go. Ask Kaen too."

"I already asked her when we ran into each other on the way here, and she said yes and was excited."

The next day at lunch, we packed our things and prepared to leave.

The destination was the city of Barontor, where the Herwyn family's ancestral home was located. I heard it's quite a long journey.

As we gathered at the main gate of the academy and headed out, there was already a carriage waiting.

"It's been a while, Miss Lea. Have you been well?"

An elderly man in the attire of a butler greeted Lea. Besides him, there were only two or three knights visible.

I thought it was a rather frugal greeting for someone of Lea's status, but the butler was certainly out of the ordinary.

I stared at the top of his head.

【Level 71】

A level that could be considered far from an ordinary servant.

I couldn't understand why someone who could be the commander of a knight order or hold a similar position would be working as a butler, but I had no interest in other people's household affairs.

The butler's gaze shifted towards us, standing behind Lea.

“And who are these people...?”

“They are my friends. I invited them as guests during vacation. Is that alright?”

At those words, he widened his eyes in surprise and then quickly formed a bright smile, nodding his head.

“Of course, Miss. I will accommodate your friends without any inconvenience.”

“Don’t overdo it. Just load the luggage quickly.”

“Yes, heh heh heh. There’s plenty of room in the carriage. I’m so glad I brought this big one, hehehehe.”

Lea, with a slightly flushed face, got into the inner seat of the carriage first.

The butler respectfully bowed his head to us and said,

“I am Yuz, the butler of the Herwyn family. Thank you very much for being kind to our young lady.”

“Oh, yes.”

“Then please take good care of her on the long journey.”

We loaded the luggage and got into the carriage one by one.

The carriage, which departed immediately, quickly sped along the road after passing through the city gate.

“Ah, it’s so comfortable.”

Kaen exclaimed with excitement. Lea spoke up right away.

“Calm down and stay still.”

“Alright, but it’s really surprising.”

“What is?”

“You said you don’t need friends, that we don’t match your standards, and yet you invited us to your house and everything.”

Lea looked at Kaen with a bewildered and embarrassed expression.

Although it sounded rude, I knew she didn’t mean anything by it. It was just her personality.

“Don’t misunderstand. I wanted to invite Rigon, not you guys.”

“What’s the difference?”

“R-Rigon doesn’t lack compatibility with me. Unlike you!”

Rigon shook his head next to them.

Kaen sighed and leaned against the seat, making a disgruntled noise.

“Well, whatever. Your family is supposed to be a great family. I guess I’ll eat a lot of delicious food when I arrive.”

Leaving the muttering pair behind, I rested my chin on the windowsill.

A cool breeze blew and gently shook my bangs.

During the journey, surprisingly, Lea was the most talkative person after Kaen.

This was because Kaen would get bored and spit out random words, and Rhea was the one who would respond the most.

“But why a carriage? Wouldn’t it be much faster to tame other monsters and ride them?”

“Please stop saying things that make even me feel dumb.”

...Generally, it went like this.

Since Rigon and I were already accustomed to Kaen being like this, we didn't really have much reaction to her questions.

"In Calderic, monster carriages aren't uncommon. I've heard that taming them requires a lot of money and skill, though."

"See? You heard, right? Rigon said so."

After a while, Lea seemed tired of dealing with Kaen and listened with one ear and let it go with the other.

Lea seemed interested in how Rigon had lived in Calderic, but Kaen persistently intervened and disrupted their conversation. It was a somewhat awkward atmosphere.

The carriage, occasionally taking breaks, stopped and settled around sunset.

Yuz, the butler, quickly prepared the camp alone, lighting a bonfire and preparing dinner.

I watched the scene and thought to myself that this was indeed a high-quality workforce, but then I smiled.

After all, I had been traveling with Asher and had been pampered to no end.

"This is delicious! Besides salt, what else did you sprinkle on the meat?"

"Shall we call it my secret seasoning? Haha. It's a secret."

Yuz's cooking was excellent. We ate warm soup and grilled meat while engaging in various conversations.

Since Yuz had a very affable personality, Kaen and Rigon quickly felt comfortable talking with him.

"Ah, really."

Lea waved her hand as if annoyed by the bugs buzzing around due to the firelight.

Yuz looked at that and said to us, “But the three of you seem familiar with camping. Unlike our young lady.”

“Oh, well, I used to live in the mountains.”

Kaen replied.

I was used to camping because of all the travels I did, not to mention Rigon, whose life hadn’t been easy.

“And what about you, Rigon?”

Suddenly, Lea nudged Rigon and asked.

Considering that she had been asking since the carriage, she seemed quite curious about Rigon’s life in Calderic.

Rigon wanted to just brush it off, but he had no choice but to answer.

“I...spent a lot of time outdoors during training and such.”

“If it’s training, what kind of training?”

“Let’s call it knight training. Something like that.”

“What? Knight training? That sounds impressive.”

Kaen interjected, slurping at her meat.

“But what kind of knight? Are they part of the Seventh Lord’s knight order?”

“...Seventh Lord?”

Yuz had a bewildered expression. It was because Yuz didn’t know yet that Rigon was from Calderic.

Lea glanced at Rigon and quickly explained to Yuz.

“Don’t misunderstand, Yuz. Rigon is a good person, regardless of his origin.”

Yuz showed a slightly surprised expression upon hearing the explanation, but he didn’t display any hostility or discomfort.

“Oh, Miss, you’ve made quite an amazing friend, huh, hehe.”

Kaen said.

“Hey, Rigon. Since we’re on the topic, can’t you tell us a bit more?”

Rigon usually evaded talking about himself when asked. I knew the reason roughly, but Kaen and the others had no way of knowing.

“Well, I can’t refuse if you insist...”

Rigon chuckled and began his story.

Of course, he excluded the terrible stories from his time at the Fourth Lord’s territory.

Rigon vaguely mentioned how I managed to save his life, and he talked about life in my territory.

“The Seventh Lord of Calderic seems like a really good person. Ah, that’s what I gather from your words.”

Lea, who had been listening to Rigon’s story with an interested expression, also chimed in.

“It’s unexpected. When you hear ‘Calderic Lords,’ you’d think they’re people without blood or tears.”

“Such Lords exist. However, it’s different for the Seventh Lord. That person is truly remarkable.”

I ate my meal in silence, feeling wonderful and alone.

After finishing the meal, I gradually prepared for bed.

Although the carriage was spacious, it couldn't comfortably accommodate four people lying down, so Yuz prepared the bedding outside.

As the sound of crackling firewood filled the air, I gazed at the night sky when Kaen suddenly approached me.

"Hey, Ran."

I considered pretending to be asleep, but decided to respond.

"Why?"

"Didn't you say something similar to this before, about what I would do if I have to sacrifice everything to save the world?"

...Was that the discussion from before? Why did that suddenly come up?

"Yeah, I did."

"Listen. I know someone who probably possesses an extraordinary magic sword or something like that."

"...And?"

"But that person wants to pass down the sword to me. To wield the sword, I have to protect others, even if it means sacrificing myself."

I was momentarily taken aback and couldn't find the words to respond.

What's going on? Did the hero talk to her about the Holy Sword? No, she wouldn't tell Kaen something like that without even telling me.

From the way Kaen was talking, it sounded like she'd said something like that, minus the fact that it was about the Holy Sword.

“It’s an intriguing sword.”

“Isn’t it? Thinking about it made me remember the question you asked. It’s a bit similar, right?”

“...”

“So I asked her what should I do, and she said that I have to find the answer to that myself. What do you think? What does that mean?”

I remained silent for a moment and then spoke.

“I think it means you have to figure out for yourself what your beliefs are that you’re acting on, because that’s not something someone else can tell you.”

“Hmm, beliefs... is that so?”

After that, Kaen didn’t initiate any further conversation.

I thought she might be lost in thought, and soon her even breathing filled the air. She fell asleep.

The journey continued uneventfully. No bandits or monsters were encountered.

However, while traveling along a forest path, a group of monsters suddenly emerged, but the knights quickly stepped forward and dealt with them in an instant.

“No need to worry. This forest is known to have quite a few monsters, but they’ll soon retreat back to their lairs.”

Yuz reassured us, probably sensing our unease, but nobody seemed bothered by encountering a few monsters here.

Since the monsters' corpses were blocking the path, we temporarily got off the carriage and took a rest.

Kaen seemed bored and instead watched with excitement as the knights cleared the corpses.

“If more monsters appear, leave it to me. Hunting monsters in the mountains used to be part of my daily routine, too.”

“Heh, is that so? Nevertheless, I can't burden our guest, so I'll leave it to the knights...”

Yuz, who laughed warmly, suddenly turned his head sharply.

Lea looked at him with a curious gaze.

“What's wrong?”

“...”

Yuz's expression gradually hardened.

I knew the reason. I'd been aware of it for a while.

What the hell are these guys?

They didn't seem like a simple group of thieves.

Yuz pulled out a sword from inside the carriage and spoke.

“Everyone, please get inside the carriage.”

“What's going on? What's happening?”

“It's nothing serious, miss. The knights and I will handle it soon.”

As Yuz pushed us, we entered the carriage for the time being.

He and the three knights surrounded the carriage, and for a moment, a strange stillness fell over the forest.

Rustle, rustle.

As the sensation of their presence grew closer, they revealed themselves from the bushes.

A group of sinister figures dressed in black robes encircled the carriage.

Chapter 155: Demon Worshipers

(2)

Chapter 155: Demon Worshipers (2)

The scene was filled with a tense atmosphere as the appearance of a group that looked suspicious caught everyone's attention.

I glanced at their levels.

They were all fairly skilled, with levels in the 40s and 50s, with the highest of them being over 60.

“What kind of people are they? A group of thieves?”

Rigon retorted in response to Kaen's muttering.

“It feels strange. They don't seem like ordinary thieves.”

“We should intervene and help, shouldn't we? We can't just stand here.”

Lea murmured quietly.

“Don't get involved. Just stay put.”

“No, look at their numbers. There are more than thirty.”

“Whether it's thirty or forty, Yuz will handle them all. You interfering will only be a hindrance.”

“Wasn't Mr. Yuz just a butler?”

At that moment, Yuz shouted towards the ‘bandits’.

“What ignorant fools are you? We are the Herwyn family’s entourage. If you value your lives, get lost.”

If Lea’s words were true, with Yuz’s level, it wouldn’t be difficult for him to handle all these people.

However, we were the obstacle in this scenario. For him, our safety was the top priority, so he would be reluctant to engage in combat.

“Herwyn? Ah, the Count of Herwyn.”

The one who appeared to be the leader, with the highest level, sneered and spoke.

“We don’t have time to waste. Kill them all and continue moving.”

The ‘bandits’ simultaneously unleashed their magic. Magic circles emerged from all directions.

“How dare you!”

At the same time, Yuz swung his sword, releasing a barrage of enormous sword energy.

Kwaaaang!

“Focus only on the carriage escort! I will deal with them alone!”

Yuz gave orders to the knights and began channeling his mana. He rushed towards the nearest enemies.

The battle that started was as one-sided as the level difference.

Those villains couldn’t offer any proper resistance against Yuz’s ruthless swordsmanship and were quickly overwhelmed.

Everyone watched the scene in the carriage, holding their breath.

The sight of people falling in pieces, dying one by one, was not a familiar scene to them, except for Rigon.

“...Mr. Butler was quite intimidating. I should have treated him with more respect.”

Kaen forced a laugh while throwing in a forced joke. No one was listening.

It happened when about a third of the villains had been killed...

As they struggled against Yuz and faced setbacks, a sudden change occurred in the leader.

...!

I recognized the aura immediately, and my face twisted into a grimace.

That guy was a demon contractor.

The crimson energy wavering from the leader of the villains extended like a stem.

Then, it formed into a shape resembling an iron club and swung towards Yuz.

Thud! Crash!

The surrounding ground and bushes were swept away by the attack, shattered and overturned.

Yuz also felt that the change in the leader was not ordinary and took a step back. That's when it happened.

“...Ah!”

Yuz urgently turned his gaze towards the carriage.

In a distant place, a dark and massive sphere was aiming for the carriage, flying towards it.

The speed of the sphere was exceptionally fast, and its energy felt different from ordinary mana, making it difficult to perceive at first.

The knights escorting the carriage hastily swung their swords, but the sphere remained unscathed.

Annoying.

I had no choice but to use my abilities. I surrounded the carriage and unfolded a barrier.

Within the calmness of the barrier, everything turned pitch black for a moment, then quickly returned to normal.

“What... What was that just now? Was it an attack?”

Kaen and the others couldn't properly comprehend what had just happened.

I spoke to the bewildered Lea.

“We need to get out of here.”

“What?”

“We were almost attacked just now, and if another attack comes, it will be hard to dodge inside the carriage.”

After saying that, I opened the carriage door and went out, followed closely by everyone else.

Having confirmed that we were safe, Yuz returned to battle with a relieved expression on his face.

“Miss, please stay close to the carriage!”

“We will protect ourselves! Don't worry!”

Lea assisted the knights by using magic against the approaching enemies. It was the same arcane magic I had seen before.

A purple beam pierced through the ground, aiming at the one of the people attacking the knights, effectively cutting off their breath.

Rigon and Kaen also drew their swords and began defending with the knights.

Since all three of them were skilled individuals, as long as they didn't directly confront the enemies, they wouldn't be harmed. However...

I turned my gaze in one direction.

In the distance, I could see a group of men hiding in the trees.

Among them, there was even someone with a higher level than the leader on this side.

That's something I should take care of.

If the recent attack had hit, the situation could have become troublesome.

Taking advantage of everyone's distraction, I moved using space leap.

“What? It's blocked? What is blocking it?”

The grotesque figure with a half-melted face frowned as he inspected the intact carriage.

Having split up to track the traces and arriving late, what kind of annoying situation was this?

Already, more than half of the people on the other side had been killed.

Kuks was fighting with his demonic powers unleashed, but that monstrous old man was much stronger than expected.

He tried to divert his attention by aiming for the carriage, but the attack was blocked by an unknown force and just dissipated.

It was clear that joining the fight in this state would result in significant damage.

“Ugh, we don’t have time for this...”

“What are you?”

The grotesque man turned around in surprise. There was a young boy standing there.

He didn’t even notice the other’s presence. When did he appear?

The boy glanced around quickly and spoke again.

“The demon worshippers are flocking together. What is your purpose?”

The grotesque man and his subordinates raised their mana but realized something too late.

They noticed that a mist-like substance had silently spread around them.

“It’s already too late.”

The grotesque man’s subordinates collapsed one after another, falling under the trees.

His eyes widened at the sight.

“Tell me your purpose. If you don’t answer, you’ll die too.”

“What? What on earth are you?”

“Answer my question...”

Kwaaang!

The grotesque man who launched a surprise attack on the boy immediately turned around and tried to flee.

At the same time, just like the other subordinates, he collapsed as if he were a severed puppet.

“If you have no intention of answering, then die.”

I descended from the tree and looked around at the bodies lying on the ground.

If I could have subdued them, I would have interrogated them, but the conditions didn't seem favorable for that.

The demon contractors acted only according to the commands of the demons they have contracted with, much like slaves.

They either searched for the demon's seeds or do something else for their masters.

I couldn't determine the exact purpose for which these guys were wandering around this forest.

I wonder if any of them survived over there.

Since the battle was gradually coming to an end, I returned to the carriage.

“Hey, have you seen where my friend went?! He was definitely right next to me just a moment ago...”

I teleported behind the carriage and saw Rigon and Kaen holding the knights, questioning them.

Lea sighed and poked Kaen in the shoulder as she made eye contact with me.

“He's over there.”

“Huh? Hey, Ran! You suddenly disappeared and scared us!”

“Where were you?”

I scratched my head and replied.

“I was hiding under the carriage.”

“What? Pffft! Were you that much of a coward? We were fighting hard!”

“What were ‘fighting hard’? The knights have all defeated them. Are you hurt anywhere, Ran?”

“I’m fine. I’m not hurt.”

Kaen burst into laughter but then slumped down, letting out a deep sigh. It seemed that her spirit was more exhausted than her body.

Yuz approached, wiping off the blood from his sword.

“Is everyone okay?”

“We’re fine. But what on earth are these guys?”

“I don’t know. The leader, in particular, was willing to sacrifice his life...”

Yuz glanced at one side, and the others followed suit, their expressions showing concern.

The leader of the group who had utilized the power of demons had exploded, making it impossible to recognize his true form.

“He committed suicide. Nonetheless, since there are still some survivors, we will interrogate them.”

“Find out thoroughly, Yuz. If there’s anyone behind this, they must pay the price for daring to touch the Herwyn family.”

Lea spoke in a chilling voice. Yuz nodded in agreement.

“Everyone, take a break. I’ll take care of the aftermath.”

As Yuz was about to turn around, he stopped in his tracks and looked at Lea.

“You did well, Miss. Thank you for your hard work.”

Lea nodded silently.

Considering the previous reactions of this group of demon worshippers, it didn't seem like they knew from the beginning that the ones they're attacking were from the Herwyn family.

I wondered if they just stumbled upon us and attacked to silence us...

Yuz still didn't seem to grasp that the power the leader used was the power of demons. It's not something ordinary.

I considered telling Yuz about that fact but decided to let it go. There was probably no need for it.

Surely they weren't targeting Kaen, right?

There was no possibility that they knew about the heir of the Holy Sword.

If they truly knew and aimed for Kaen, then it's natural for the top-level demons to be involved. Not these small fries.

From the beginning, these guys didn't show any signs of specifically targeting Kaen. I was being overly concerned.

So, was there really a need to pay any more attention to these guys?

But there might be more people like these lurking around, and we're just letting it slide without any action... sigh.

I turned my gaze away, lost in thought.

Lea was watching me, her trembling hand pressed against her chest.

She seemed unfazed, but as expected, she looked like she was worried sick.

“What are you looking at?”

She raised her head and glared at me. I shrugged.

“If it weren’t for you, that knight earlier would’ve either died or suffered severe injuries. You personally protected him.”

“What are you talking about? Who said that?”

“It means you don’t need to feel guilty for killing those guys.”

“Feel guilty? Don’t be ridiculous. I’m just a little shocked, that’s all.”

It’s only natural to be shocked if it’s your first kill.

Lea looked at me with an odd expression and spoke.

“You seem completely unfazed.”

“Well, I was just hiding quietly.”

“You said you were hiding under the carriage. Isn’t that a bit strange?”

“What do you mean?”

“You were the first to go out, saying that the carriage could be attacked. And you were hiding under the carriage?”

Uh, is that so?

I only thought about an excuse casually without considering that.

In that moment, unable to find the right words, without responding, Lea gave me a suspicious look.

“Where were you during the actual battle? Did you use your spatial magic to teleport somewhere?”

“Well, actually, yes. I was hiding in a safer place.”

“Why did you lie?”

“If I said I was the only one hiding far away, it would sound weak.”

“But why are you saying it so confidently?”

“Well... um...”

Lea shrugged her shoulders.

“Look, there were huge marks on the ground around the carriage. Just as you said, the carriage was indeed attacked. But it looked untouched, as if something blocked the attack.”

“...”

“Even when the carriage was under attack, you calmly led us out as if it was nothing.”

“What are you trying to say?”

She stared at me intently and spoke.

“What I want to say is, I have a feeling that you’re hiding something.”

Chapter 156: Demon Worshipers

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Chapter 156: Demon Worshipers (3)

Was she being unnecessarily perceptive? Or was I being too careless?

I decided to be more careful next time and just end the conversation.

“Hey, I really don’t understand what you’re talking about. What am I hiding?”

“...”

“No, I mean, are you trying to say that my magical ability is exceptional enough to secretly defend against attacks that could have hit the carriage? And I was hiding that from you guys? Why would I do such a thing?”

I scratched my neck and stared at Lea as if she were a really strange person.

Perhaps my facial expression deceived her quite well, as she seemed hesitant, and her gaze wavered.

“Huh? Lea, what kind of strange misunderstanding are you having...?”

“Quiet! Or forget it. It’s nothing.”

With that, Leah stormed off.

Rigon, who was patting Kaen’s shoulder, approached and asked, “What’s wrong? What did you talk about?”

“It’s nothing important.”

Then I heard Yuz’s voice as he approached Lea.

“I found more corpses in the direction where the surprise attack came from earlier.”

“...Corpses?”

“Yes. They seem to be from the same group, but their condition is a little strange. I don’t see any signs of combat around them, and there’s no trauma on the bodies at all. What the hell is going on in this forest...?”

Yuz was talking about the people I killed earlier.

Lea quickly turned her head and stared at me. I pretended not to notice her gaze.

“Sir Yuz, please come here!”

The knight guarding the survivors urgently called out to Yuz.

“They suddenly all died as if by some trick.”

Yuz, who had been staring at the dead bodies with a serious expression, sighed.

In the end, it seemed that the interrogation had yielded no significant results.

“I’m sorry, miss. But it seems like our priority is to quickly get out of this forest.”

They couldn’t expect any notable progress from the interrogation, and they couldn’t predict what other ambushes awaited them. That was the best course of action for now.

With that, the carriage immediately resumed its journey.

Kaen looked out the window and muttered.

“Just until a moment ago, it was a pleasant trip. What on earth is happening...?”

“Yeah, right. Since we don’t know what else might pop up, let’s stay vigilant until we leave the forest.”

Listening to the conversation between Kaen and Rigon, Lea’s expression wasn’t good.

I could sense her feelings. Naturally, she couldn’t be happy when such incidents occurred during the journey she had invited us to.

“Don’t worry. I’ll take full responsibility for your safety, even if it’s at the expense of Herwyn’s honor.”

“Huh?”

Kaen stared at Lea like that and burst into laughter.

“What’s up? You’ve become so timid.”

“I’ve never become timid.”

“It’s okay, it’s okay. Just be yourself, since it doesn’t suit you. All these things are part of life, you know.”

“Seriously, it’s annoying.”

Thanks to Kaen, the atmosphere, which had become somewhat heavy, quickly lightened up.

I heightened my senses and scanned the surroundings extensively.

There was no one within the maximum range of my senses, and there wouldn’t be any imminent ambushes.

The carriage stopped once again, but not because of the same reason as earlier.

A young boy was lying unconscious on the road.

Yuz, who was examining the boy without letting his guard down, wore an uneasy expression.

“This is...”

I also stared intently at the boy.

After the attack by the demon contractors, what could this be now?

Black hair, red eyes, and fangs protruding between his lips.

The boy was not a human, but a vampire.

“Is he... human?”

Kaen muttered with a puzzled expression. Yuz shook his head.

“I think he’s a vampire.”

“Ah, so he’s not human after all?”

“Yes. They are a dangerous race that feeds on the blood of other creatures.”

Why would a rare vampire be in the land of Santea?

The vampire boy had wounds all over his body, and it was quite a pitiful sight.

While keeping an eye on the boy, Yuz hesitated. Kaen urged him.

“Well, shouldn’t we treat him quickly, regardless? He seemed to be in a really bad condition.”

Yuz looked embarrassed.

I knew why he reacted that way. After all, the boy was a vampire.

Vampires faced the same level of stigma in Santea as they did in Calderic.

Moreover, they had just been attacked, and the situation was already tense, so it was only natural for him to be more sensitive.

Lea spoke up.

“Let’s treat him, Yuz.”

“The situation is too suspicious, miss. And the vampire is...”

“He’s just a kid. Are you saying we should just leave the injured child behind and go?”

I intervened and said.

“If there’s any connection to the attackers, wouldn’t it be worth hearing his story?”

“Hmm...”

Come to think of it, those people seemed to be in a hurry because of something.

The attack by the demon contractors and a collapsed vampire.

The chances of the two being unrelated coincidences seemed naturally small.

In the end, Yuz started treating the vampire boy by taking out medicines from the carriage.

We had to hurry, but they didn’t want to carry him in the carriage, so we decided to wait until he woke up.

“Ah, he woke up.”

Not long after, the boy woke up.

He opened his eyes weakly and groaned. He seemed unable to regain his senses.

“Blood, blood...”

Upon hearing his mumbling, Yuz frowned and reached for the hilt of his sword.

“Step back, as he might suddenly attack.”

“Oh, come on. What would a little kid like him use to attack? There’s no need to be so cautious.”

“Vampires can manipulate blood and possess unique abilities. So...”

He’s probably too young to use blood magic yet.

I sat down next to the boy and rolled up my sleeve, extending my bare forearm towards his mouth.

Lea asked in surprise. “Wait, what are you doing?”

“He’s weak because he needs to drink blood. I’m trying to help him regain his strength quickly.”

“Wait! That still looks dangerous...”

“It’s okay, it’s okay.”

“What’s okay about it? Yuz, hurry and stop the bleeding!”

Lea shouted, but the boy grabbed my arm first.

“Argh...!”

I calmly looked around at the people as if to say everything was fine.

“It’s okay, a little blood loss won’t kill me.”

Everyone watched in a mix of confusion and astonishment as the boy sucked my blood.

Kaen, who was the only one who looked intrigued, crouched down next to me.

“That looks like fun. Can I give some of my blood too?”

“...If you think it’s fun, just watch.”

The boy, who had just finished sucking blood, seemed much more energetic.

He struggled to get up and looked around in a daze.

I turned my gaze to Yuz. Yuz let out a sigh, released his grip on the sword, and asked.

“We were just passing through the forest. You have no enemies here, so rest assured. Why were you lying here in this state?”

The boy, who had shown signs of fear, finally seemed somewhat relieved.

But then the boy suddenly curled up and pleaded.

“P-Please, help me!”

“What do you mean, help? We’re already helping you.”

“The people of my village have all been captured by evil mages. Please help us, please...”

Evil mages?

Unable to understand the words, we looked at each other.

After calming the boy down, we listened to his story properly.

The story of a restless boy who was still in a daze could be summarized briefly as follows:

A group of villains attacked the village where the boy lived, killing or capturing all the villagers.

And the boy managed to escape alone from the hideout of those guys nearby, barely making it out.

Yuz asked, “Did those villains wear reversed black robes, by any chance?”

“Yes, yes! That’s right!” replied the boy.

The villains the boy mentioned seemed to match their attackers.

A group of demon contractors captured people?

That didn’t seem particularly strange.

It’s common for those who commit all sorts of evil deeds to destroy villages and abduct people.

There were more things about this vampire boy that didn’t make sense. It wasn’t just one or two things.

Starting with what I was most curious about, I asked the boy, “So, when you say people in the village, do you mean they’re all vampires like you?”

“Oh, no. They’re all humans. I’m the only vampire.”

“But you’re a vampire. Yet, you lived mixed among humans in their village?”

The boy nodded with a dejected expression. Was that even possible?

It was fascinating enough to see a vampire in the land of Santea, but there was also a village that accepted and lived with such a vampire.

I was curious about the details, but Yuz asked the boy another question.

“Do you know the purpose behind those villains abducting people?”

“I... I don't really know. I only heard rumors about offering sacrifices.”

Sacrifices?

The boy began pleading once again.

“People who were taken from the prison to elsewhere never came back. They're probably all dead. Because of my escape, those bastards might get angry and kill the remaining people. Please, help me!”

After a moment of silence, Yuz spoke up.

“Miss, there's no other choice for us but to take this boy and move on...”

“Of course, that's what we'll do. But what about the villagers who are held captive by those groups of villains?”

“It would be best to send reinforcements as soon as we reach the main city.”

“But we still have a long way to go until we reach the main city.”

Lea murmured softly. Yuz spoke firmly.

“Miss, ensuring your safety is my top priority.”

“...”

“If the boy's story is true, it's unfortunate for those villagers, but it's difficult to go rescue them in our current situation. The truth of the boy's words and the size of the enemies, everything is uncertain.”

“I-it's not a lie! Please believe me!”

Yuz turned to look at the boy.

“I'm sorry. Even if your words are true, I can't take the risk.”

Yuz had a point.

Normally, it would be insane to go into a stronghold when you know nothing about the enemy.

There was no way he would do such an outrageous thing when he had Lea to protect.

At that moment, Kaen interjected.

“Yuz, so you’re not going to help?”

“Yes, that’s correct.”

“But earlier, you dealt with those guys easily. But now, because of Lea’s safety, you’re not willing to take the risk?”

“That’s right. Even if you’re disappointed in me, I can’t help it.”

Kaen stared at Yuz for a moment and then turned away.

“Got it. Well, I guess there’s no other choice. Hey, what’s your name?”

“...Heppy.”

“Alright, Heppy. I’m Kaen. I’ll go alone if I have to, so tell me where their hideout is.”

What the heck.

Lea called out to Kaen before I, or Rigon did.

“Hey, you!”

“Why?”

“...Say something that makes sense! You said you’re going alone, but what are you going to do by yourself?”

“I have to save people. I don’t want to go back the way we came. It’s been fun traveling this far.”

Lea glared at Kaen.

I also spoke to Kaen.

“Kaen, it’s impossible with your skills. What if there are even stronger guys than before?”

“Well, then there’s nothing I can do. But maybe those guys earlier were their full strength. I’ll bet on that.”

“Why are you going to such lengths? Isn’t your life precious?”

Kaen looked at me.

“Ran, I’ve thought about it. That story about the magic sword I told you before.”

“...?”

“Sacrificing everything I have to help people or whatever, I still don’t get it, but at least I don’t want to turn away from people in danger and just pass by. I know my life is precious, but I just don’t like that.”

I let out a chuckle.

“You’re stupid if you don’t think your life is precious.”

For some reason, it didn’t seem surprising that she would be this stubborn.

I stepped to Kaen’s side, and Rigon naturally followed.

Kaen looked surprised and asked, “Are you two going to do it too?”

“Then should I just leave you alone and go? Let’s go.”

Yuz’s expression seemed bewildered, as if his wits had run away.

In his eyes, it would only appear as the foolish behavior of naïve teenagers. And that was the truth.

However, from my perspective, I couldn't just let the wretched demon contractors go without dealing with them, and I didn't see any reason to hold back if some event were to occur.

“Lea, we'll go then. If we die, make sure to take care of our bodies.”

Lea glanced at Yuz while biting her lip.

“We're just going to leave after being insulted like this? The honor of the Herwyn family will be brought to the ground.”

“Miss...”

“I'm not leaving. If Yuz won't come, then the four of us will just die together.”

Yuz let out a deep sigh.

“What would happen if they had sent you alone for real?”

“That arrogant guy wouldn't allow that, haha.”

“Shut up. If anything happens to Yuz or the knights because of you, I will never forgive you, Kaen.”

The carriage carrying the vampire boy headed toward the enemies' stronghold.

Chapter 157: Demon Worshipers

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Chapter 157: Demon Worshipers

“You still haven’t caught that vampire?”

An altar-like structure stood in the center of the massive magic circle drawn on the floor.

The man’s eyes flickered with a spark upon receiving the report from his subordinates.

“These useless bastards. Worthless creatures. Just because you can’t properly manage a single material, I have to deal with this mess?”

“I’m sorry!”

“He’ll be here soon. If anything goes wrong, we’ll all die, so find that vampire quickly at all costs!”

The man, who had driven away his subordinates, paced back and forth on the altar, biting his nails.

“Why would he come here in person? Why? Why?”

Since receiving power from him, there had never been a moment like this.

Finding the demon’s seeds, investigating and relaying information—always faithful as a servant, merely carrying out orders.

Had the great being ever shown an interest in insignificant beings like them?

Moreover, even if the sacrifices were of low quality, they were instructed to prepare as many as possible.

Putting everything aside, there was one thing that bothered him the most.

As a powerful contractor, the man was capable of receiving orders from the other through a mental connection with the other.

When he had previously received an order... the emotion he felt from him was nothing but urgency.

It was as if he was being chased by something frightening. Why?

No, no. He must not dare to doubt his master's power.

The man solemnly clasped his hands together like a devout believer and bowed his head.

“Oh, mighty god, your faithful servant awaits your glorious command.”

We got off the carriage and walked from the middle because there was no path.

I asked the boy, Heppy, what I had wondered about earlier.

“How did you end up living with humans? Aren't there any other members of your kind?”

The boy, who had an uneasy expression, responded:

“Well, there used to be, but then other tribes invaded... and I ran away and wandered around until I ended up here.”

Was it a war between tribes? It wasn't an unfamiliar story.

The vampire sisters I had helped before also had similar circumstances.

“The villagers seemed very friendly.”

What were the chances of a vampire who’d wandered into Santea’s territory finding a village that didn’t hate them and surviving?

Usually, their fate would be either death or being sold as a slave.

“...It’s not like that.”

“Huh?”

“They make you work your ass off from morning till nightfall. They swear at you, kick you, and starve you if you don’t do a good job. They took me in just so they could treat me like a slave.”

Everyone looked surprised at the unexpected story.

Kaen scratched her head with a perplexed look.

“What? They were such bad people?”

Naturally, I couldn’t help but feel puzzled.

“But still, you didn’t run away alone and seem to want to save the people in the village...”

Was it because he had nowhere else to go if the villagers die?

Heppy spoke with a teary voice.

“To be honest, there’s someone I really want to save more than anyone else...”

“Someone you want to save?”

“Her name is Enma. She’s my only friend in the village. She has always been kind to me.”

Ah, so that's what it was.

I roughly understood the situation.

Lea, who was listening to Heppy's story, glanced at Kaen, who spoke.

"He's amazing, risking his life in such danger to save others. Don't you think so?"

Lea shrugged her shoulders.

"To be honest, I already felt very drained, but what can we do? We have to do it."

"Then he's met an incredible hero."

While observing the two, I asked what I had been curious about.

"And you managed to escape from such dangerous people all by yourself?"

"Yes..."

"Can you tell me more about what happened?"

Happy hesitated for a moment and raised his arm.

And in the next moment, everyone was surprised.

Happy's hand transformed as if melting into red blood and floated in the air.

Blood art?

The blood art of transforming one's body parts into blood, a blood art that I had been seen before.

Wasn't it the ability used by the chieftain of the Elrod Forest Vampire Tribe?

"Wow, what's that? How did you do that?"

Kaen exclaimed, startled. Heppy, who returned his arm to its original state, explained.

“This is my ability. Vampires can use various abilities with their own blood.”

“Huh...”

I asked indirectly.

“It’s called blood manipulation, right? But I thought young vampires couldn’t use blood manipulation.”

“You know a lot, Ran.”

“I’ve read it in the inter-species encyclopedia before.”

“Well... somehow, even though I was trapped in prison, I suddenly awakened my abilities and became able to use them. So I managed to escape through a loophole in the surveillance.”

Did he awaken his blood manipulation ability in a life-threatening situation?

Kaen took the boy’s bloodied hand and looked it over, then smiled.

“Anyway, don’t worry too much! We will definitely rescue your friend.”

After walking for a while, Heppy spoke with a tense expression.

“We’re almost there. If we go a little further in this direction, we’ll reach the cave.”

“Alright. Let’s stop here for now.”

Yuz stopped everyone and spoke.

“Miss, and her friends. Please follow my lead from now on.”

“Yes, we will.”

“Good. First of all, if the boy is right, the passage structure to where the people are being held is not complicated.”

According to Heppy’s explanation, the demon contractors’ base is an underground cavern inside a cave.

A straight passage inside led to two paths, the left of which was where the people were being held.

“We don’t know the exact number of enemies or whether there are any trap devices. If possible, I would like to go into the cave alone and leave you and your friends outside, but...”

“I don’t want that, Yuz.”

“Yes, we can’t afford to scatter. There may be enemies wandering nearby from the outside. I will take the lead. The knights will cover the rear, and you, miss, and your friends will move in the middle.”

Yuz looked at Lea.

“If a really dangerous situation occurs, please use it to protect yourself.”

“Got it.”

Lea touched the cool bracelet on her wrist.

It was a bracelet she almost always wore.

I’d assumed it hid some sort of enormous power, but apparently it wasn’t just an ordinary tool.

After a short tactical meeting, we reached the enemy’s stronghold.

Yuz, who had been walking ahead, glanced back and spoke to the knights.

“I found a cave. There are two guards at the entrance. I’ll take them out first with a surprise attack.”

Yuz went ahead, and we followed behind, moving slowly.

Shortly afterward, faint footsteps echoed in my ears, one after another.

Finally, through the thickets, the cave came into view for everyone, along with Yuz standing in front and the bodies of the enemies.

“There’s a passage leading underground inside the cave. From now on, make sure you thoroughly guard the rear.”

The knights nodded in response to Yuz’s command.

Even the kids, including Kaen, became tense.

As we entered the cave according to the previously planned formation, just as Yuz had said, another entrance appeared inside.

“Let’s double-check one more time. We were supposed to take the left fork after passing through this iron gate, right?”

“Yes, yes, that’s right.”

Heppy nodded vigorously.

The iron gate led to a downward slope. Yuz unleashed a powerful sword strike toward the gate.

Crash!

The iron gate shattered into pieces, and Yuz rushed ahead, with us following closely behind.

There were lights at regular intervals on the ceiling of the passage, so darkness wasn’t an issue.

“...It’s an ambush!”

As we ran along the straight passage, enemies soon poured out from the inside.

Yuz drew on his mana again and poured sword energy forward. The enemies in his way were torn apart.

Yuz's attack was even more fierce than the previous battle because the situation was different.

Unlike before, where we were surrounded by enemies, this time we had them all in front of us and we were all positioned at the back.

As such, he didn't seem to have to worry about us getting caught in the crossfire.

Thanks to that, we ran safely, without any collisions, only looking at Yuz's back.

He has delicate control.

While attacking relentlessly, Yuz made sure not to cause any impact on the outer walls of the passage. It would be a disaster if the walls collapsed.

The enemies that emerged were all low-level minions, around level 40 to 50.

Unlike the two from before who directly used the power of demons, there was no one like that, so our advance was smooth without any significant obstacles.

I spread my super sensory to find any potential traps or the enemies' positions. I encountered none.

By the way, it's quite impressive that they built an underground cave in the middle of the forest as their base.

“Over there!”

As we swept through the enemies and moved forward, it didn't take long for the intersection Heppy mentioned to appear.

The stench of decaying corpses that had been bothering my nose made me look toward the path to the right.

For now, rescuing the people on the left path was the priority. We headed towards the left path.

“...There they are! People!”

Kaen shouted. Just as she said, we saw the people trapped in the prison.

Men, women, children, and even the elderly. There were approximately thirty people.

As we approached the prison, the faces of the people were filled with fear.

“H-hi, hiik!”

“Stay calm. We came to rescue you.”

Boom!

Yuz lightly sliced through the bars of the prison and let the people out.

Heppy, who was turning his head here and there as if looking for someone, shouted in frustration.

“Enma!”

One girl among the imprisoned people widened her eyes upon seeing Heppy.

“...Heppy! What's going on?”

“Well, long story short, I came to rescue you! These guys took down all the people who captured us!”

Watching the two embracing each other, I finally eased my suspicions.

To be honest, I didn't fully trust Heppy, so I had been observing him. But it seemed like his story was completely true.

"Is there anyone who can't move? Then hurry up and get moving. We're going to escape from here."

"Yes, yes! Understood, sir!"

The people followed Yuz's words with expressions that showed they had finally been saved.

At that moment, Enma, the girl, hastily spoke while taking care of others.

"Uh, excuse me. But besides us, there are others who were taken to a different location."

One of the people suddenly exclaimed.

"Enma, all those people are dead!"

"How do you know? They could still be alive..."

"Isn't it obvious? What's more important is the lives of the people alive here! Don't get in the way of our progress!"

"That's right! Stop talking nonsense!"

"Uncle Debbie's brother was also dragged away. Aren't you worried about him?!"

Lea gave the bickering people a pitying glance.

Speaking of the people who were taken, were they in the passage on the right?

I thought and then turned my gaze toward the entrance.

“I understand, so first...!”

Soon, Yuz turned his gaze towards the entrance with a stern expression.

I heard footsteps. It was the sound of one person’s footsteps. As the sound approached, the voices of people diminished.

“Ah...”

【Level 75】

What appeared before my eyes was an old man dressed like a priest.

The man raised his trembling hands to his face.

“Ah, ahh! How dare these insignificant worms...!”

His face contorted viciously, and a wicked and sticky mana enveloped the space.

Chapter 158: Demon Worshipers

(5)

Chapter 158: Demon Worshipers (5)

The faces of the people paled at the intensity of the magic. Kaen and Rigon, as well as Lea, were no exception.

“Step back!”

Yuz urgently shouted, gripping his sword tightly.

The amorphous mass of magical energy surrounding the man writhed before taking the shape of a spear.

Swish!

Yuz swiftly swung his sword, deflecting the massive spear that came flying at him.

The blade, engulfed in energy, was partially shattered, and Yuz took a step back in shock.

“How dare you interrupt a sacred ritual for him, aaah?!”

The man emitted a radiant glow and created even more spears this time.

The man’s level was 75, four levels higher than Yuz.

Was he the leader of this group of demon contractors?

I honestly didn't think there would be anyone stronger than Yuz, but this guy was much stronger than I expected.

What should I do?

Crack!

Considering the level difference, Yuz was holding his own quite well, but it wouldn't last long.

Dealing with the man alone would be difficult.

On the other hand, openly confronting him would obviously be a tricky situation.

So, the best course of action would be to secretly take his life without anyone noticing...

Currently, the man was surrounded by dense magical energy throughout his body.

It was impossible to sneak a drop of blood, as it would burn before it even touched him.

I felt sorry for Yuz, but fully stepping forward would be dangerous.

I decided to wait it out and look for an opening.

The magical spears rained down, enveloping Yuz. Yuz barely managed to throw himself to dodge.

The battle clearly seemed to be in favor of the male priest.

Kaen, Rigon, and Lea could only watch the spectacle, retreating along with the people to a corner.

“There's no room for interference. We need to help Yuz...”

Rigon muttered.

Kaen watched the battle silently, while Lea wrinkled her brows in helplessness.

I can't believe Yuz is struggling like that...

All three were realizing it. At their level, interfering would only get them killed.

“We have to get out of here.”

As Lea spoke, Rigon and Kaen looked at her.

“Let's take advantage of the opening and get the people out. We only have one shot.”

“What are you talking about? What about Yuz?”

“We won't be of any help if we get involved in that battle. It's like when we took the Academy exam. We have to do what we can to stay alive.”

Ran stepped in and supported Lea's words.

“Lea is right. Let's get the people out first.”

“But...”

“Don't be stubborn at a time like this, Kaen. We don't have time for that. Don't you realize that if we stay here, we'll only hinder Yuz from using his full power?”

Kaen couldn't argue any further, wearing a desolate expression.

“...I'm sorry, Lea.”

“Stop talking. Just take care of the people.”

At that moment, Yuz, who had launched a fierce attack, aimed for the man's throat and drew his sword.

The man stretched his magic spear like a stalk, wrapped it around himself, and swung it around, throwing himself out of the way.

A look of despair crossed Yuz's face as he failed to land a killing blow.

However, thanks to that, the blocked entrance was now open.

“Run!”

Ran pointed towards the entrance and ran ahead. People reflexively followed him and ran as well.

Kaen and Rigon also ran, but they suddenly stopped when they saw Lea at the entrance and turned their heads.

“Lea! What are you doing!”

“Quickly, take the people and escape!”

“Miss!”

When Lea didn't come out, the knights also turned their bodies to follow her.

Kaen and Rigon realized that from the beginning, Lea had no intention of escaping herself.

“Miss! Please go, I'm fine!”

“No! No master would abandon a vassal and run away!”

Lea tried to unleash her magic. Yuz urgently shouted towards the knights.

“Take the miss and escape! Hurry!”

At that moment, more forces came rushing in from outside the passage.

People were blocked from moving forward or backward and stood still in their place.

“This, this is...”

Kwaaaang!

At that moment, the balance of the battle between the man and Yuz shifted.

Yuz, who couldn't completely block the attack, was forcefully thrown to the ground. Lea rushed to his side.

“Yuz!”

The situation had reached its worst.

The man who had withdrawn his magic snapped his fingers at his minions. Within moments, they were blocking the passage.

The man straightened his disheveled priest's robes and glared at Yuz.

“So, where on earth did you little rats crawl in from?”

“.....”

“Argh, annoying! Annoying! I should be welcoming him with reverence! The materials have escaped, and those idiots couldn't even catch them properly! Everything is ruined! What's going on?! Why do you keep doing this to me?!”

The man kicked the floor and began to shine again.

Kaen and Rigon drew their swords with grim expressions. That's when it happened.

“P-Please, spare us!”

One of the people cried out, bowing their head to the ground.

“We didn’t know anything! It was that vampire bastard who escaped alone and brought people along on his own!”

“...Huh?”

Kaen turned his head to stare at the man who had screamed that.

Soon, one by one, the others also fell to their knees and started begging.

“*Sob, sob!* We were really just staying quietly in place!”

“The vampire and those people are the bad ones! Please, just spare our lives!”

Heppy’s face turned pale. Enma exclaimed in disbelief.

“What are you all doing now?! Heppy risked his life to save us!”

“Shut up! Because of those guys, we will all end up dead! Why should we die too?”

Rigon chuckled bitterly. Kaen looked blankly at those people.

She couldn’t understand it at all.

She came to rescue the people, even risking her life. But what are those people talking about?

“Don’t make me laugh. Yuz fought for whom exactly?”

Lea shouted, but no one listened.

The man, who had been staring at the pleading people with an amused face, raised an eyebrow at Lea’s ramblings.

“Well, well, it’s quite amusing. How amusing.”

“...”

“You there, woman. This is the wretchedness of you humans. You have no strength, no dignity. You’re just insects trying to save your own lives by any means possible. It’s repulsive. You’re no different. Did you come here out of a sense of justice to save people? Truly foolish, pitiful, and wretched. You’re nothing more than weak and feeble insects!”

At that moment, Ran spoke up.

“You’re no different, old man.”

“...Huh?”

“You’re also a human, you idiot. Have you gotten senile in your old age? And with your meager strength, you think you’re something among these trembling cowards?”

“What?”

Rigon and Lea looked at Ran in surprise, and the people who had been begging grew even paler.

Kaen stood there, holding her sword in a daze.

She recalled the words Del had said to her before.

“If necessary, you must fulfill your responsibilities, even at the cost of everything you have. Kaen, not only for the people who are precious to you, but also for those you dislike and hate, for everyone’s sake. Can you do that?”

It was Del’s wish that she should inherit her sword.

There must have been a reason deep in her heart why she couldn’t simply overlook injustice and forced herself into this situation.

She wanted to confirm her true will, and whether she truly deserved to inherit Del’s sword.

But... how could Del it?

Kaen didn't want to fight for the people here. A part of her wanted to beat them up so they wouldn't talk anymore.

They were people who only cared about themselves, even in this situation.

Why did she try to save these humans, even at the risk of endangering everyone?

...Ah.

Upon reflection, the answer was nothing special.

Her eyes caught a glimpse of Enma with her arms around Heppy.

She came down from the mountains and met many people along the way.

There was no reason to be disappointed. She already knew that not everyone was like them.

So, even if they were pathetic humans, it wouldn't be strange for there to be at least one person willing to protect them until the end.

If someone precious to her asked her to fulfill that role, Kaen would be more than happy to do so.

“Have you gone crazy because you're so scared? You must have lost your mind because you want to die, you damn bug!”

The man gathered immense magical power and shot it at Ran.

A rush of exaltation shot through her body. Kaen instinctively raised her sword. And she swung it.

The golden energy enveloping the sword split the magical power in half and cut through the man's body.

At the same time, in the Holy City.

Whoa!

Aindel woke up in surprise as a bright light covered the entire Holy City.

“What is this...?”

Two beams of light were emitting from the Holy Sword, shimmering in the air.

Poof!

The man’s body, engulfed in a golden sword blast, spewed blood and collapsed. At the same time, Kaen also fell.

Everyone’s eyes widened at the sight.

What...?!

What did Kaen just do? How did she execute such a powerful sword strike?

Yuz swiftly regained his composure and shot a blade of energy towards the fallen man to finish him off.

However, whether he was still conscious or not, the swirling dark aura surrounding him deflected the energy blade.

Yuz retrieved his sword and shouted, “Miss, hurry! Everyone, get out!”

Even though they couldn’t completely finish him off, this was their chance to escape while he was seriously injured.

The knights and Yuz rushed towards the enemies, blocking their way.

“Kaen! Snap out of it!”

Rigon took care of the fallen Kaen.

Kaen blinked her eyes, clearly exhausted. “I’ve completely run out of strength...”

“I understand, but hold on a little longer! We need to get out of here!”

Amidst the chaos, everyone ran along the passage.

The remaining enemies were swept away by Yuz, clearing the path. But then...

“Aaaaah! Where do you think you’re going?!”

The passage shook with the man’s scream.

Massive chunks of magical power began to pulsate, smashing through the walls.

The ceiling, which started to crumble and collapse, fell above Rigon and Kaen, who were the furthest behind.

At that moment, Lea rushed towards the two, tearing off her bracelet.

Powerful magic erupted from Lea’s bracelet, enveloping the surroundings and sweeping away all the falling rocks.

“Come quickly!”

“Thank you, Lea!”

Kukugugu!

But the entire collapsed wall enveloped them once more.

“Ah...”

At the moment when the three people’s faces turned pale with fear, someone forcefully pushed them aside.

Narrowly avoiding the falling rocks, they fell to the ground and looked to the other side of the falling rocks.

“Ra, Ran...”

Pushing them out of the way, a pile of rocks instantly crushed Ran.

Lea tightly clenched her lips and led the two dazed individuals out.

Eventually, everyone safely escaped from the cave. Except for one person.

“Whoa.”

I sighed as I watched my arm return to its original state, wriggling with blood.

I used Gascalid’s blood magic and borrowed Heppy’s for a moment.

I blocked the falling rocks with a floating veil and escaped through a crevice using Heppy’s blood magic.

Rocks completely blocked the front passage, but if I transformed my body into blood, I could easily escape.

By the way, what on earth happened?

I was thinking of jumping into the fight since there was no other choice. But...

Kaen’s golden sword strike that knocked down the enemy in one blow.

Compared to the hero, it was infinitely insignificant, but it was undoubtedly the power of the Holy Sword.

How on earth? Could it be that Kaen had finally fulfilled the conditions of succession?

Let's get out of here first.

I expanded my senses and explored the blocked passage behind me.

There was no sign of life. The contractor seemed either exhausted or had been crushed to death..

Using Heppy's blood magic once again, I slipped past the pile of rocks.

Having reached the junction I encountered earlier, I entered the right path that I had left untouched before.

“.....”

At the end of the junction, what appeared was a structure resembling an altar in a spacious area.

On one side, there were piles of corpses. There was no one alive.

I clicked my tongue and approached the altar.

In the middle of the altar, a large gem was embedded, and something squirmed inside it.

Whiirrrr...

I could easily surmise that it was the souls of the dead.

The wails of the horrifying souls echoed in my mind as if reverberating.

I could think of many reasons why they would do such a horrible thing.

Perhaps they were conducting some kind of magical experiment or offering it to the demons who granted them power.

“It's disgusting.”

I reached out towards the gem and used my instant kill ability. The souls vanished instantly.

All I could do was offer them rest to prevent further suffering.

When I was done checking for survivors, I escaped outside.

From the entrance of the cave, I heard people's voices.

"Ran died... because of me..."

It was the voice of Kaen.

I stumbled out of the cave, alive and well, of course.

Kaen, who was sitting on the ground, and Rigon and Lea standing beside her, came into view.

"...Huh?"

Lea was the first to notice me and was surprised. I waved my hand.

Kaen, who had been sobbing, turned her head and her eyes widened.

"Hey, you!"

I stopped Kaen as she rushed towards me and calmed her down.

Rigon, with an exhausted expression, asked.

"Ran, what happened?"

"I almost got crushed by a rock, but I barely managed to avoid it. Luckily, there was an empty space on the side, so I was able to escape."

Lea, who had been staring at me with a strange gaze, spoke up.

"You're definitely..."

"Yes?"

“Well, never mind. It’s really fortunate. Thanks to you, all three of us made it out alive. Thank you.”

I ignored her doubtful gaze and patted Kaen.

I couldn’t sense the aura of the Holy Sword from Kaen anymore.

“It’s really fortunate. Whew, I think we need some rest for now.”

“Yuz, are you feeling okay?”

“I don’t have any injuries. I just got a bit exhausted from exerting too much mana.”

At that moment, the group of demon contractors surrounded us.

“They really don’t give us a chance to rest.”

Yuz and the knights once again grasped their swords.

Were they the ones who were outside? Well, if we deal with them, it should be over...

“.....!”

A chilling energy that made the body shudder.

I quickly turned my head towards the source of the energy.

On the other side of the forest, something dark and massive was approaching this way at an alarming speed.

Kwaaaang!

Instantly, sweeping through the bushes, a monster appeared...

No, it was a demon.

His overwhelming presence caused everyone, even Yuz, to stop breathing and freeze.

【Level 95】

A constant black smoke emanated from the creature's body, covered in bone armor from head to toe.

I sighed as I looked at its level.

It's a demon on the same caliber as an archdemon. Was he the owner of that contractor? What a damn bastard...

At that moment, members of the demon contractors shouted at the demon, bowing their heads.

“Oh, mighty god! Your pitiful seedlings...”

Swoosh!

The demon swung its hand and crushed them all. Blood splattered on the ground.

“Useless fools! I told you to prepare sacrifices, and this is all you could offer?”

Breathing heavily, the demon turned its gaze towards us.

“Damn it! If only I had fully regained my power, I wouldn't have to suffer such humiliation!”

The demon reached out its hand towards us. Yuz trembled and tried to speak.

“E-Everyone, run...”

However, nobody could move their legs.

Kaen, Rigon, Lea—they all stood there, dazed and trembling.

I prepared myself for battle.

It was the moment when I was about to confront the demon...

A blue flash from nowhere pierced the demon's body. There was silence.

Beeeeep.

Like thunder, a deafening sound tore through the air a beat too late, causing ringing in the ears.

A massive shock, as if struck by lightning, turned the ground upside down.

“Kuh, kuhkuk. Just how far do you intend to chase me, persistent... bastard...”

With those last words, the demon's entire body crumbled into dust and disappeared.

I blankly stared at the scene and turned my gaze in the direction where the light had flown.

At the summit of a distant mountain peak.

With my vision heightened to the maximum, I could barely make out a person standing there.

...Heavenly Archer?

Chapter 159: Heavenly Archer

Chapter 159: Heavenly Archer

Why was the Heavenly Archer here?

This was not Calderic's territory, not the Third Lord's territory, but Santea's.

I couldn't help but feel bewildered by this unexpected arrival.

Thump.

As if her legs gave out, Kaen sat down abruptly.

“What... What's going on?”

No one knew what had happened.

The strike of the Heavenly Archer was so fast that it probably didn't even register in our eyes.

A blue light flashed, and all we saw was the demon in front of us dying.

By the way, the destructive power was truly unbelievable.

Was it really possible for such a devastating attack to be launched from such a distant location? Seeing it in reality exceeded their imagination.

The attack that the Heavenly Archer had just unleashed was probably one of his ultimate skills in the game, called 'Island Thunder'.

From the direction the sniper attack had come from, the forest evaporated as if a path had been cut through it, extending tens of meters back.

I looked back at the mountain peak where the Heavenly Archer should have been. But his figure was nowhere to be seen.

Where did he go?

Not long after, a figure quickly approached this direction.

I hardened my expression as the other approached.

“...!”

In the blink of an eye, the Heavenly Archer appeared in front of us.

The people, who were momentarily lost in their thoughts, looked at him in surprise.

The Heavenly Archer glanced around at the people, seemingly indifferent, and approached the spot where the demon had vanished.

In the place where the demon had disappeared, a single crimson gem was left behind.

The Heavenly Archer picked up the gem as if that was its purpose.

That is...?

I realized in hindsight that it was similar to the gem that trapped the souls of the people in the cave.

The Heavenly Archer, holding the jewel, turned his head towards me.

...This was dangerous.

Feeling a sense of crisis, I avoided the Heavenly Archer's gaze.

The Heavenly Archer's eyes were remarkably sharp, to the point where he could see through the polymorph of the Overlord, the only one among the Lords who could do so.

I hoped he didn't recognize me.

The Heavenly Archer, who had been staring at me intently, finally opened his mouth.

“Seventh Lord...”

“Cough, cough! Cough!”

I coughed forcefully. Everyone's attention turned towards me.

Please just pass by, please. Don't say anything more!

Rigon, standing beside me, grabbed my arm.

“What's wrong, Ran? Are you okay?”

“No, suddenly I feel a bit dizzy...”

I continued coughing desperately while glancing at the Heavenly Archer.

Then, the Heavenly Archer tilted his head and turned his gaze away from me.

Phew.

The figure of the Heavenly Archer disappeared. He had left.

I inwardly sighed deeply, feeling as if I had endured ten years of hardship.

After the ordeal, we returned to the place where the carriage was parked.

It was getting close to sunset, and the sky was turning a golden color.

Since it was becoming difficult to continue moving, we decided to camp there instead.

“What are we going to do?”

“I will ask the lord of Vibalte Territory for assistance. If we leave early, we should arrive by noon tomorrow.”

“Will the lord willingly take in the people?”

“It’s not a large number, and he will probably take them in if we explain the situation.”

Vibalte Territory was the next intermediate destination.

Yuz planned to leave the rescued people in the care of the lord there. It was not feasible to carry them all the way to their final destination, which was still far away.

“Don’t worry and rest a little, Miss. I will take care of the remaining tasks.”

Lea, with a tired expression, sighed while gazing at the flickering campfire.

“I still can’t stop trembling. What was that monster?”

“Perhaps it was a demon.”

“A demon?”

“Yes, given their strange appearance and alien mana, the only species that fit the description is a demon. And the group that we encountered was probably a group that worshipped demons.”

Finally, she understood.

I pushed Kaen, who was trying to rest her head on my leg, and listened to the conversation.

“Then who could have defeated that demon, Yuz? It was unbelievably strong.”

Yuz spoke with a serious expression.

“Miss, it would be better to only speak about today’s events to the Lordship.”

“Why? What do you mean?”

“I’m not certain, but I have an idea of who that man might be.”

Yuz glanced briefly at Rigon.

He nodded his head and spoke softly, “It’s probably true that it was the Third Lord. Although I haven’t personally seen him myself...”

Lea was taken aback, and her eyes widened.

Yuz spoke up, seemingly convinced by Rigon’s words. “The Third Lord of Calderic was chasing a demon in the realm of Santea. It’s a miracle that everyone survived this incident. We don’t know why he let us go so easily...”

Kaen interjected abruptly, raising her head. “Wasn’t it because of Rigon? Earlier, the Third Lord seemed to be looking in Rigon’s direction.”

Technically, it wasn’t Rigon. It was me.

Lea glanced at me briefly. Why was she bothering me again?

“Rigon is on the side of the Seventh Lord. So, he simply spared us,” Lea said.

“Well, the Third Lord wouldn’t recognize my face, anyway...”

Rigon tilted his head and asked Kaen, “Speaking of which, Kaen, what was that golden sword energy earlier? You were hiding something extraordinary.”

Everyone’s gaze focused, curious about the question.

Kaen scratched her head and let out a sigh. “I’m sorry, but I don’t know either. Suddenly, I felt a surge of power in my body. Then it disappeared

just as quickly.”

“What? What was that?”

“I really don’t know. Maybe an immense hidden potential within me exploded in a moment of crisis?”

I had been thinking about the power of the holy sword that Kaen used earlier.

If the hero hadn’t returned to the Holy City, I could have received some news about any changes in the Holy Sword.

“...”

I stood up from my seat. No one paid any attention to me.

Leaving by myself like this would seem like I was about to take care of that kind of ‘business’.

When Yuz saw that, he got up to join me.

“I will keep an eye on things for you.”

“Oh, it’s okay.”

“There might still be enemies in the forest. It’s dangerous to be alone.”

“It’s really okay. It’s just that, it’s a big one. I’ll be right back.”

Kaen and Rigon chuckled. Really, did it have to come to this extent...

Shaking off Yuz, I walked away from the campsite and back into the depths of the forest.

I found a suitable spot and came to a stop, then opened my mouth.

“Come out, Third Lord.”

A chilly breeze blew through the quiet forest.

A tree nearby rustled, and a person jumped down from it. It was the Heavenly Archer.

Without lowering my guard, I kept my gaze fixed on him and asked.

“What’s the matter? Why are you following me?”

I sensed with my super sensory that the Heavenly Archer, whom I thought had already left, had been lingering around.

The only reason I could think of was that because I was here, so I came to a place where I could talk to the other alone.

The Heavenly Archer stared at me intently without saying a word and asked.

“Seventh Lord, what are you doing in Santea? It seems like you’re hiding your true identity.”

“It’s a personal matter. I’d rather you didn’t take an interest.”

There was no reason for him to attack me suddenly, but he was such an unpredictable person that I couldn’t let my guard down.

Surprisingly, the Heavenly Archer nodded obediently.

“Okay, got it. Actually, I’m not interested.”

“Then what’s the matter?”

“I have something I want to ask you.”

After saying that, the Heavenly Archer pulled out a jewel from his bosom. It was the gem he had taken from the dead demon earlier.

The Heavenly Archer threw the gem at me. I accepted it while hiding my confusion.

“The Fourth Lord told me once, Seventh Lord, that you have the ability to completely annihilate a soul.”

It was the Fourth Lord who helped me realize the exact mechanics of my instant kill ability.

The Third Lord seemed to have heard about it from him as well.

“...And so?”

“Then is it possible to annihilate the souls trapped within that gem?”

Of course, it was possible. I had done it earlier in the cave.

I asked, looking at the wailing souls inside the gem.

“It’s possible. But why are you making this request?”

“I won’t take an interest in your affairs either. So I hope you won’t take an interest in mine.”

“What nonsense. Who is the one making the request now? Are you asking me to help you without any reason?”

Of course, since it was a trivial matter, I could simply grant the request. However, it’s still important to appear like a ‘Lord’.

It wasn’t a matter of pride; it was a matter of standing, of losing a war of nerves with another Lord.

The Heavenly Archer scratched his head as if he found it bothersome and clicked his tongue.

“Tsk, fine. Then if I tell you the reason, you’ll grant my request?”

“Naturally, I will listen and decide.”

“One of the souls trapped there is my younger cousin.”

Cousin? What did that mean?

“What does that mean? Did that demon guy harm your family?”

“That guy wiped out one of the strongholds in my territory. The commander there was my younger cousin.”

“...So, did you come all the way here chasing after that guy?”

“Yeah.”

The Heavenly Archer nodded.

“As you can see, the trapped souls have become completely intertwined, making it impossible to undo. If I destroy it, I don’t know where the mass of souls will scatter, and I don’t have the ability to cleanly eliminate souls, either.”

So, it was a request to me, asking for help in alleviating the suffering of his younger cousin.

Understanding the situation, I immediately activated my instant kill. The souls in the gems vanished cleanly.

Since they would have been victims of the demons anyway, I had no strange reason to refuse the request.

If I were to negotiate with conditions, it could have further provoked the Heavenly Archer.

“It’s done.”

The souls vanished completely from the gem, which I tossed to the Heavenly Archer.

The Heavenly Archer, who caught the gem, nodded with a slightly bitter look in his eyes.

“They vanished cleanly. Thank you. I’ll leave this as a debt.”

I spoke to the Heavenly Archer as he turned away.

“I hope you’ll consider our encounter today as if it never happened.”

“Yeah. I never intended to talk about it in the first place.”

And the Heavenly Archer’s figure disappeared.

I sighed and moved toward the campsite.

“Ran, are you feeling refreshed?”

“Shut up.”

Lea glanced at Ran, who had returned to his seat, with a trace of hesitation.

She still harbored doubts about Ran.

The more she thought about it, the stranger things seemed.

What happened at the semester exams, what happened in the carriage, what happened in the cave battle.

Even when they were about to be killed by the leader of those villains, Ran had still cursed and taunted him.

If he had always been such a person, she wouldn’t have been surprised, but Ran’s usual demeanor was indifferent, far from such a personality.

To Lea’s eyes, his behavior seemed as if Ran didn’t feel any danger or crisis in those dire situations.

It was the same when they escaped from the cave.

She had clearly seen himself crushed by the rocks, and yet he had emerged unharmed.

Those suspicions were almost confirmed with the appearance of the demon and the Third Lord of Calderic.

Kaen said that the Third Lord was looking at Rigon, but she saw it clearly.

Ran interrupted the words of the Third Lord and exchanged some kind of glance with him.

And then the Third Lord immediately left and vanished.

Lea came to a conclusion after much contemplation about Ran's true identity.

Ran must be the 'secret escort' assigned to Rigon by the Seventh Lord of Calderic.

...I'm sure of it.

He hid his true abilities and seemed to have some connection with a Lord of Calderic.

Moreover, now that she thought about it, Ran and Rigon shared the same dormitory room. Everything fit perfectly.

What if Rigon was more important to the Seventh Lord than they thought?

There was no way he would have left any safeguards in place when he sent Rigon to Santea.

Yeah, it was strange all along. He was definitely not an ordinary person.

Lea nodded her head, feeling a little refreshed by her deduction.

Chapter 160: Herwyn

Chapter 160: Herwyn

As time passed, we arrived at our destination, the ancestral home of the Herwyn family, in the region of Bayonte.

There were no further attacks or significant events during the remaining journey.

It's big.

A magic lineage that was undoubtedly considered one of the best in the empire.

The ancestral home of the Herwyn family was undoubtedly majestic and grand, to say the least. It might not be as imposing as Calderic's stronghold, but it possessed its own aura of magnificence.

"Welcome, Lea! Hahaha!"

It was a young man who greeted us at the entrance. Skinny and tall, with the same hair and eye color as Lea.

At first glance, he looked so much like her that I knew he must be her brother.

"Lea's older brother, right?"

"Shh. Kaen, don't be rude."

Kaen and Rigon whispered to each other.

The man spread his arms wide open, intending to embrace Lea, but she evaded his gesture, causing him to awkwardly step back.

“Aren’t you glad to see your brother after a long time?”

“It’s only been half a year.”

“Ah, Sir Yuz, you must have had such a hard time bringing my sister back. I heard something happened on the way.”

“Yes, young lord. I will tell you all about it in private later.”

Then the man’s gaze turned toward us.

“And... these are Lea’s friends, right?”

He seemed extremely moved for some reason.

“Oh my, even seeing after it with my own eyes, I can’t believe it. Lea has made friends? Is this really happening?”

Lea scowled, as if annoyed.

Regardless, the man grinned broadly and greeted us.

“Nice to meet you! I’m Cyan Herwyn, Lea’s older brother, ally, and protector.”

What’s with this intense introduction?

Both Kaen and Rigon appeared a bit flustered. It was because his fondness for his sister was a bit too strong.

“...I’m Kaen!”

“Wow, Kaen! You’re a very lively friend! Nice to meet you!”

“I’m Ran.”

“Ran! You seem a bit reserved. Nice to meet you!”

“I’m Rigon. Thank you for welcoming us.”

“Rigon! Nice to meet you. You’re a polite friend!”

“That’s enough. Shall we head back to the academy?”

Lea said through clenched teeth.

The man, Cyan, finally cleared his throat and adopted a more composed attitude.

“Anyway, welcome everyone to the Herwyn family. The Lord and Lady are out on business, so they couldn’t greet you personally. Please understand. Now, don’t just stand there; let’s go inside.”

Cyan welcomed us sincerely.

After being shown our respective rooms and freshening up, we rested for a while.

“It’s a really huge castle, isn’t it, Ran?”

Rigon said, lying on the bed and looking out the window.

He had stayed in a much larger castle when he was in Calderic, so what’s there to be surprised about?

In the evening, we followed the guide to the dining hall.

A sumptuous feast was laid out in the dining room as servants continued to bring in food.

The dishes ranged from various meats to rare seafood. Kaen exclaimed in excitement.

“Hey, what on earth is this? It looks weird, but it’s surprisingly delicious!”

After devouring a whole steamed octopus leg, Kaen exclaimed in surprise. It seemed to be her first time trying octopus.

I had a dish filled with plenty of clams, or rather, a clear soup closer to a broth than a soup.

Since it had been a while since I had this kind of food, I quite enjoyed it.

“Kaen, Ran, Rigon. I heard from Yuz about what happened on the way here. You really dealt with a big incident. You’ve been through a lot, and I appreciate your hard work.”

In response to Cyan’s words, Kaen replied wryly.

“Oh, no. It was because of my stubbornness that everything almost went wrong.”

“I’m glad you’re still self-aware.”

“Haha, don’t worry, even if she said that, she doesn’t really mean to blame you.”

Cyan laughed and then asked.

“I’m curious about how the three of you got close to my sister. It’s hard to imagine that this prickly girl would get along with others.”

Kaen chimed in.

“Right? Even I thought, ‘Are there really people like her?’ when I first saw her.”

“Hey.”

“Yeah, right, Rigon?”

Rigon chuckled and nodded slightly. Lea’s expression turned as if she had been betrayed.

“But I know she’s an amazing person. Even when her life was in danger, she still wanted to take care of her vassal till the end. Honestly, that was pretty cool, Lea.”

Upon the unexpected praise, Lea glared at Kaen.

“...As a descendant of the Herwyn bloodline, it’s only natural to do that. It’s my duty.”

“Haha, why are you being so shy? You can just honestly admit that you like it.”

“Shh, shut up. You’re a real—!”

Looking at the two bickering, Cyan smiled softly.

Considering Lea’s usual personality, one might have thought that even her family members would be like blocks of ice, but that wasn’t the case.

I thought they were quite a pair of affectionate siblings.

After dinner, Lea made her way to the room where Cyan was.

Cyan, who was sitting in a chair and reading a book, greeted her warmly.

“Oh, little sister.”

Lea sat across from him and glanced briefly at the book Cyan was reading.

“What book is that?”

“Just a book of magic. I found many old books while organizing the library.”

Lea frowned. Cyan closed the book he was reading.

“I’m just reading for fun, so don’t be so hard on me. I have the surname of Herwyn, too, and I can’t completely disassociate myself from magic.”

“No one would blame you if you gave up magic, so take care of yourself.”

Cyan chuckled and leaned back in the chair.

“You seem to get along really well with your friends. I was genuinely surprised.”

“.....”

“After that incident, you didn’t try to get along with anyone. I’m really glad, Lea. It seems like you found people with whom you can open your heart again.”

Lea remained silent with a somber look and retorted curtly.

“...I’ve only found people who can match my level now. If they were just insignificant individuals, I wouldn’t have bothered getting close to them.”

“Haha, are you even lying in front of me? You’re not someone who could even disregard a lousy brother like me.”

Cyan suffered from a condition related to mana.

When raising his mana, it would irregularly trigger seizures, which was a fatal and rare condition for a mage.

Because of that, Cyan had to endure the risk every time he used magic.

In the off chance that a severe seizure was to occur, not only would his life as a mage be completely cut off, but his life itself could be in danger.

Cyan was aware of this. She knew that her younger sister, Lea, had a kinder heart than anyone else.

Despite her situation, despite the fact that her succession was practically a foregone conclusion, her attitude towards her brother had always been the

same.

He, who had observed her for a long time, knew that her saying that she would only associate with people of the same level as her was nothing more than a self-deceptive excuse.

When their father, the head of the household, had forcibly tried to admit her sister to the academy, he had worried that it might have had the opposite effect, but it seemed to be an unnecessary concern.

The enormous wound that had been inflicted upon her heart seemed to have healed at least a little.

“Don’t be annoying.”

“Yeah, sorry. You grumpy kid.”

By chance, the gazes of the two people turned simultaneously toward the window.

In the comfortable silence, the siblings briefly looked at the night sky side by side.

During our stay at Herwyn Castle, we spent each day playing around.

They explored various parts of the castle and happened to enjoy a festival in the city while sightseeing.

Nevertheless, whether it was because we were her guests, Lea always stuck by our side and guided us no matter what we did.

“Is this Herwyn’s library?”

One day, they visited the library within the castle. It was Rigon’s suggestion.

Since he frequently visited the library at the academy, perhaps he had developed a hobby for reading.

“Spacious!”

Entering the library, Kaen shouted a brief comment.

She didn’t even bother to look around the first floor and went straight up the stairs to the second floor, while Rigon joined Lea and started looking through the books.

I walked slowly, entering the deep part of the library alone.

What kind of books would be in the library of one of Santea’s magic family?

Of course, there wouldn’t be any important spellbooks in a library open to outsiders, but it wasn’t a bad way to pass the time.

I stopped my steps at a bookshelf filled with old books.

As I pulled out the books one by one and looked around, Lea, who had approached unnoticed, spoke.

“This is a collection of old books, nothing much. There are some grimoires on spatial magic over there.”

“Oh, I see.”

It was a comment based on the fact that my unique magic was spatial magic.

Lea hesitated for a moment and then returned to where Rigon was.

I’m not interested in spatial magic, though.

I might not be able to travel long distances, but the space leap mystery was unrivaled by any other magic in its immediacy and spontaneity.

I continued to sporadically browse through the books while contemplating various thoughts.

Where did the demon that the Heavenly Archer killed come from?

Among the archdemons I currently knew, none of them had such an appearance.

And unless it's related to the resurrection of the Demon King, there's absolutely no reason for a demon of that level to attack the Third Lord's territory.

So, it was probably just a wandering demon, and there was no reason for me to pay much attention to it, but apart from that, I couldn't help but feel uneasy.

A warning from the hero and the Holy Sword that the Demon King would soon resurrect. The hero returning to the Holy City once again.

And not just demons, but villains I hadn't dealt with yet, and an Overlord I still couldn't figure out.

...Is it alright to be so relaxed like this?

Since the hero returned to the Holy City, and I was the only one left to take care of Kaen, I found myself in a situation with no freedom of action.

It was my own choice to take care of Kaen, so I had no one to blame but myself.

The Holy Sword said to keep moving forward, but at least it would be nice to hear some words that could be somewhat helpful...

“...”

While various thoughts were swirling in my mind, I suddenly noticed a book that caught my eye.

A book with a blank white cover was placed in the lowest section of the bookshelf where ancient books were gathered.

I didn't know why that book caught my eye all of a sudden.

Feeling a strange attraction for some reason, I pulled it out. I removed the thick layer of dust and opened the book.

It's a spell book.

It's a spell book, but... what's this?

I read a bit of the contents inside and quickly closed it.

It was interesting, but it also contained outrageous statements that would make anyone who knew anything about magic click their tongue. It read more like a book of delusions than a spell book.

Hmm?

The mana I felt in my arms made me look around.

Kaen was still on the second floor, and Rigon and Lea were far away.

I went deeper into the library and took out a scroll of paper.

It was the magical device that I used to communicate with the hero while I was at the academy. The hero had given hers to Asher when she went to the Holy City.

I had instructed Asher to contact me using this device in case of urgent matters.

What could it be?

Unless it was something significant, Asher wouldn't contact me. What could have happened in the territory?

I unfolded the paper and read the contents written inside.

–Sir Ron, the Chief of Staff has come to the castle to deliver a message from the Overlord.

Chapter 161: Adessa Great Forest (1)

Chapter 161: Adessa Great Forest (1)

...The Chief of Staff came to deliver a message from the Overlord?

That certainly wasn't normal.

A million thoughts raced through my mind in an instant.

Was it about the Black Sea Empress? Or was it another request, similar to when I dealt with the Tower Master?

—Keep reporting, Asher.

After sending the reply, a response came back shortly.

—Yes. According to the Chief of Staff, the Overlord received an intelligence report indicating the concerning movements of the Emperor of Santea.

Asher's account was not something I had expected.

The movements of the Emperor were concerning? What did that mean?

—It is speculated that the Emperor has secretly crossed the southern border and is heading towards the Adessa Grand Forest.

Upon hearing the continuation of the statement, I felt an instant chill in my chest.

Adessa. One of the last four great powers in the world.

An alliance of elves and demi-humans that ruled over the vast southern forest.

Wait... Why was the Emperor going to Adessa now?

The Emperor was one of the major villains in this world, holding significant influence.

The one with the ideology of human supremacy was bound to bring great calamity someday, and of course, I knew that.

But this was too soon.

If the Emperor was heading to the Adessa Grand Forest to invoke ‘that,’ it was supposed to happen much later in the future.

Since joining forces with the hero, I hadn’t paid much attention to the Emperor...

Has the future... changed?

Or was it simply a preliminary exploration before things happened? I could not tell.

What was certain was that the possibility of the future changing could not be ignored.

I couldn’t understand.

The hero should have clearly warned the Emperor, but the other ignored her and instead accelerated the time.

“...”

But what if some butterfly effect really did change the future?

What if the Emperor was really trying to bring about that terrible catastrophe right now by advancing time?

Adessa Grand Forest would likely perish.

Both Santea and Adessa would be in ruins, completely upsetting the balance of power.

At a time when the resurrection of the Demon King was imminent, things could get out of hand.

“Damn.”

Of all times, this had to happen when the hero had returned to the Holy City. It was the worst timing.

—So why did the Overlord relay that information to me?

—She wants you to head to the Adessa Great Forest, if possible, and help track down the Emperor yourself.

...Tracking?

I immediately doubted the Overlord’s motives.

—Didn’t the Chief of Staff explain why the Overlord made such a proposal to me?

—He said he had conveyed the same message to all the Lords he could contact. The Fifth Lord has already gone to Adessa alone, and the Second Lord would be travelling with the Chief of Staff.

So, it meant that the Overlord didn’t specifically ask me for a favor.

And the Second and Fifth Lords accepted the offer right away?

I felt like I knew the reason. It was because both the Second and Fifth Lords were from Adessa.

With regards to the noble lineage of the Thunder Lord, it traced back to the elves of Adessa, who departed from there long ago and settled in Calderic.

On the other hand, the Mad Lord ventured out alone due to a conflict with her own kin.

Therefore, these two individuals had reasons to be interested in matters related to Adessa, whether it was for better or worse.

—For now, I told the Chief of Staff I would relay the news when Sir Ron returned to the castle.

With a furrowed brow, I became lost in thought.

...What should I do?

The problem was what I should do. The deliberation was brief.

I should travel to the Adessa Great Forest and check on the Emperor's movements.

It was not the time to worry about other Lords or the Chief of Staff.

If the emperor truly took action, it must be stopped at all costs.

Kaen is the problem.

However, if I immediately head towards Adessa, I would be leaving Kaen alone...

No matter how urgent the situation was, the safety of the heir was of utmost importance.

I had no choice. In that case, I can only leave Kaen's protection to her while I was away.

After making the decision, I replied,

—Asher, bring Ti-Yong and come to where I am right away.

A few days later, I received word of Asher's arrival. So, I relayed the news of my departure to Kaen, Rigon, and Lea.

"What? You have to go back home?"

Kaen asked with a surprised expression.

I made an apologetic expression.

"Yeah, I was planning to stay here for a few more days and then go back at a suitable time. I also have some things to attend to at home."

"Why... Hey, why didn't you say that earlier?"

Both Kaen and Rigon were perplexed.

Even I found it absurd, but I had no other excuses to offer.

"I'm really sorry. Anyway, that's why I have to leave right now."

"Hey, Ran. Is something wrong?"

Rigon asked with concern. I shook my head.

"It's nothing. Let's meet again at the academy after the break."

"Wait, then can I come with you?"

Kaen said something troublesome again, and Lea chimed in.

"Hey, Kaen. Don't make things awkward for him. There's an urgent matter."

"Well, still, this is too sudden. He didn't explain it in detail."

"He has a situation that's difficult to explain in detail. You need to stop jumping into everything without thinking."

What's this? It was unexpected that she helped.

Lea looked at me and asked.

“How are you going to travel? If necessary, I can arrange a carriage and have some people accompany you.”

“No, it’s fine.”

“Okay, then.”

It was strange, as if she was already expecting me to react that way.

Anyway, thanks to her, I said my goodbyes to the kids and headed out of the castle.

Then I met Asher, who was waiting in the city square, and we moved to a secluded place.

“The heir is currently staying at the castle of the Herwyn family. There shouldn’t be any danger inside the castle, but you should stay close by and protect her.”

“Understood. When do you plan to return?”

“I can’t tell how long it will take. Well then, I’ll leave right away. Take care.”

After parting ways with Asher, I went outside the city and searched for Ti-yong, which she had ridden here.

Clank!

When I found Ti-Yong hiding in the woods, it howled with delight and trotted toward me.

“Shh, shh. Yeah, it’s been a while, buddy.”

I calmed down the excited fellow while stroking its neck.

Riding on Ti-Yong's back after a long time, I flew straight up into the sky towards the Adessa Grand Forest in the southern region of Santea.

It was only a day's ride at full speed from Bayonter to the southern border of Santea, even with a little backtracking.

Having arrived at the northern edge of Adessa, I looked down at the vast forest spread below.

There shouldn't be any conflict in this part of the forest.

The ruling power in Adessa was the alliance of numerous tribes, consisting of elves and giants.

Taken together, they were the size of a single, united nation, much like Santea and Calderic.

However, not everything within the forest was under their control. It was too vast.

If I ventured further, I might encounter their border defenses, but it was still manageable for now.

...From now on, there was only one thing I had to do.

Find the Emperor somewhere north of the forest, where he would be making preparations.

Of course, it was a difficult task.

In a forest with trees and grass everywhere, no matter how much I played the game, I couldn't remember and pinpoint where the Emperor was.

In short, it was no different from wandering around the mountains and finding the heir.

“How long will it take...”

Of course, I wasn't without help.

For now, I decided to go to the place the Chief of Staff had told Asher which would be reserved as a meeting place for the Lords.

What about Polymorph?

Before that, I pondered whether I should release the polymorph or not.

The current me was not the Seventh Lord, but that of a boy. I couldn't meet them like this.

But if I released the polymorph, I couldn't return to my form as 'Ran'.

If I released the polymorph once, I would have to use the power of the Holy Sword again to regain the form of 'Ran', but the hero was currently in the Holy City.

I even considered wearing a mask, but it wouldn't completely hide my physique or hair color.

If I run into the Overlord, I'll be in a lot of trouble.

They said that only the Chief of Staff had come to this place now, but no one knew if the Overlord would suddenly appear.

That's why I decided to deal with the aftermath later and release the polymorph for now.

Poof.

In an instant, my appearance returned to that of the original Seventh Lord.

I turned my head away from the stiffness and patted Ti-Yong's neck.

"Let's go, Ti-Yong."

A massive river runs through the northern part of the Great Forest.

If we followed the river inward, we would come across the lake mentioned by the Chief of Staff.

They said they would establish a base there and conduct investigations.

As soon as I found the lake, I extended my heightened senses to see if they were around. And I found them.

I saw the Chief of Staff and the Thunder Lord standing side by side in front of the lake, so I landed there immediately.

The Chief of Staff greeted me with a surprised expression.

“Thank you for coming, Seventh Lord. You came here very quickly.”

The Thunder Lord standing beside him had an uneasy expression.

I glanced at her briefly and asked the Chief of Staff, “What about the Fifth Lord?”

“the Fifth Lord intends to continue acting separately. She stated that she has no intention of cooperating with us or participating in the investigation, emphasizing that her actions are not influenced by the Overlord’s proposal.”

What did she come here for then?

It wasn’t important, so I turned my attention away.

“Has the investigation already begun? Any progress?”

“We are planning to start now. We intend to retrace the route that the Emperor might have taken from the capital.”

I felt a sense of restlessness within me.

Of course, there might not be any other way, but wouldn’t it take too long like that?

If the Emperor had already begun preparations, there was no time to waste in such a leisurely manner.

The Chief of Staff must have sensed my uneasy expression as he asked, “Is there any other good method?”

I stared at the Thunder Lord

Because even in the game, the method to find the hidden Emperor was to use the spirits.

“Thunder Lord, do you have any ideas?”

“No, I don’t.”

“Really? None at all?”

“I just said there isn’t. What kind of answer are you expecting?”

Could the Thunder Lord use that method?

There was no way for me to know, but I had to ask.

“I’m asking if there is a way to borrow the power of the spirits in the forest. I’ve heard that if you’re a powerful elemental, you can borrow the power of a spirit for a short time, even if it’s not a contracted spirit.”

Upon hearing that, the Thunder Lord gave me a bewildered look.

“If you’re willing to endure the spirits’ hatred and forcefully suppress them with your power, then it’s possible.”

“Alright, so there is a way.”

“Are you telling me to use such barbaric methods? In the first place, to find the Emperor whose whereabouts are unknown, one would have to absurdly dominate a wide range of spirits...”

“Of course, it would be impossible to cover the entire Grand Forest. However, wouldn’t it be sufficient if we focused on the northern edge?”

The Elf who used that method in the game was a spirit mage of a level similar to the Thunder Lord.

The Thunder Lord’s gaze became even more grim.

I anticipated her thoughts and spoke to the Chief of Staff.

“Chief of Staff, can you step aside for a moment? I have something to discuss with the Second Lord.”

“Understood.”

The Chief of Staff willingly left.

The Thunder Lord immediately uttered in a sharp voice.

“Yes, I suppose. If it were the old me, it might have been possible. As long as no one had destroyed my precious spirit.”

I nodded.

“I will let you know the location.”

“What did you say?”

“I will tell you the method to restore your power that I mentioned before. I will also inform you of the location of a thunder spirit that is as powerful as Laxia. Right now.”

The Thunder Lord’s eyes widened in surprise.

“Stop!”

The guardian warriors protecting the forest stood pale, blocking a figure.

The warrior chief, Garga, also swallowed his saliva with a tense expression and questioned the intruder.

“.....Mad Lord, why have you come here?”

The Mad Lord, who quickly scanned the warriors, smirked.

“Step aside, you pests, before I kill you all. I have business with the chieftain.”

Chapter 162: Adessa Great Forest

(2)

Chapter 162: Adessa Great Forest (2)

The power of Adessa could be divided into two major forces.

The Elf tribe dominating the eastern Great Forest.

And the beastmen tribe dominating the western Great Forest.

Despite being different races with different instincts and values, they had maintained a stronger cohesion than any other nations on the continent, existing together since ancient times.

What the two factions had in common was a very broad tribal social system, with many tribes united.

Unlike Elves, Beastmen had internal divisions, but it held little significance in Adessa.

The Beastmen of Adessa had long been united around the Gonark tribe.

A great clan that birthed the most powerful warriors, those with the ‘Spirit of Sacrifice’.

The current High Chieftain of the beastmen was Udakbat, the leader of the Gonark tribe and the most formidable warrior.

“Ignel.”

Udakbat looked at his fellow tribe member with complex eyes.

She raised her chin slightly and then opened her mouth.

“Do not address me by my name, Udakbat.”

At her words, many warriors and elders around them emitted a fierce aura.

On the other hand, Udakbat, who did not even raise an eyebrow, waved his hand to dispel the tension.

“Your insolence is beyond what I can tolerate, Ignel. So, why have you come?”

“Well, why do you think I’m here?”

“I’ve had enough of your rudeness. Did you come looking for a place to die after your rampage?”

Ignel raised the corner of her mouth.

“It wouldn’t be bad to wipe out all these useless old men, but let’s not do it today.”

Some of the elders stared at her and spoke up.

“You have a sharp tongue, Ignel. You, who betrayed the tribe and now act as a lapdog for the Overlord.”

“Letting those filthy feet touch our sacred land, just spit out your business and get lost!”

“Yeah, yeah, old folks. I didn’t come here because I wanted to face your disgusting faces, you know?”

The aura swirling among them made the young warriors of Gonark nervous.

The visit of a single figure had brought all the warriors and leaders of the tribe together for a power struggle.

For them, who had only heard of the Mad King as an old tale passed down among the tribe, the current situation felt unfamiliar and strangely unsettling.

“I’ll make it brief. It seems the Emperor of Santea is plotting something at the northern edge of the forest. So don’t just stand here like idiots, unaware of anything, and be on high alert.”

Udakbat frowned.

“...Emperor of Santea? Did the Overlord asked you to deliver that message?”

“No. This is just information I personally share with you.”

“How can we trust that?”

The Mad King scoffed.

“Hey, do you think I still have any remnants of loyalty to this tribe to volunteer as a messenger?”

“.....”

“I don’t care if the entire tribe is wiped out, or if Adessa becomes a living hell like it was during the Great War. All you have to do is protect that damned tree, even if it costs you old men’s lives and warriors’ lives, just like it did then.”

The fierce roar of the Mad King silenced the gaze of the Udakbat.

“You’re still a child, and you haven’t grown up at all.”

“Haha, really? I’m much better than a coward, that’s for sure. We’re done talking.”

The Mad King turned around. However, it wasn’t the direction she had come from.

The warriors standing in the path she was headed to froze.

“Where are you going, Ignel?”

Ignoring them, the Mad King continued walking. Udakbat let out a fierce howl.

“Stop. Who gave you permission to approach the World Tree?”

The forest was suppressed by the aggression emanating from him. The Mad King resisted without faltering and returned the energy in response.

“Permission? Whose permission do I need when I want to go see my brother?”

“You are no longer a part of Adessa or the tribe. Take responsibility for the path you have chosen.”

The Mad King let out a cold laughter.

“Responsibility! Fine. Then, as the Lord of Calderic, shall I just eliminate everyone who dares to block my path?”

“Ignel, do you really want to die?”

“Why, do you think I can’t?”

The Mad King reached for her sword hilt on her back. The warriors all gripped their weapons simultaneously.

“If you continue to obstruct, I will do it for real. Let’s see. How many can I slaughter before I fall?”

The elders also prepared for battle.

Some glared at her with murderous intent, while others looked at her with complicated eyes.

Amidst the suffocating confrontation, Udakbat raised his head and broke the silence.

“This is the only time.”

“Chief!”

“Are you willing to spill the blood of our tribe members for this matter?”

The elders couldn't argue.

They didn't know the damage that could be done if the Mad King went on a rampage in the middle of the tribe's base.

“Captain, follow her and keep an eye on her.”

Turaq, the appointed captain, immediately approached the Mad King. Udakbat spoke quietly.

“Do not engage in pointless actions, Ignel. At least, I don't want to kill you with my own hands.”

The Mad King snickered and continued on her way.

“Do you know the purpose of the Fifth Lord?”

I asked Thunder Lord as we rode the wyverns.

With a glance, the Thunder Lord answered, “Although I don't know the exact purpose, she has definitely moved towards the territory of the Gornak Tribe.”

“If it's Gornak...”

“It's a tribe led by the Chief of the Beastmen. Do you know the origins of the Fifth Lords?”

I nodded my head. The Gornak Tribe was a tribe governed by the High Chieftain, who was at the center of the beastmen in Adessa.

The Mad King was once a member of the Gornak Tribe before leaving the Great Forest and becoming a Lord of Calderic.

“Perhaps she went to share information about the Emperor with the High Chieftain.”

“Is that allowed?”

“If the Overlord hasn’t said anything, that means it doesn’t matter if she does or not, so she’ll do as she pleases.”

Thunder Lord kindly answered the question, perhaps because she had something at stake.

I thought for a moment about the character of the Mad King.

I also knew the reason why the Mad Lord abandoned the tribe and left the Great Forest to become a Lord of Calderic.

At the center of the Adessa Great Forest, there was one colossal tree.

The World Tree. It was a common setting that often appeared in comics or games when elves were involved.

Another name for Adessa Great Forest was the Blessed Land.

The World Tree, filled with immense vitality, was a sacred being that bestowed powerful strength upon the entire Great Forest and all its inhabitants.

However, Adessa could not avoid the war that began with the invasion of the Demons in the past.

Although it was only one demon who invaded the Great Forest, that creature was truly a living catastrophe.

It was the most powerful weapon of war possessed by the Demons during that time.

Even compared to the current archdemons, an overwhelmingly dominant existence that has no rivals except for Azekel, who stood at the top of the hierarchy.

Fogwigg.

They were faced with a crisis where the power of that guy eroded them, and the Great Forest was on the brink of instant destruction.

Pushed to the brink, the beastmen and the elves did the only thing they knew how to do.

That was to amplify the power of the World Tree.

It involved absorbing the body and soul of the most powerful warrior in the Great Forest into the core of the World Tree.

So, it means that the warrior with the Spirit of Sacrifice gave themselves up.

The ‘Spirit of Sacrifice’ was a legend passed down from generation to generation among the Gonark tribe.

Even the exact nature of it was uncertain.

However, throughout the history of the Gornak tribe, there had been rare instances of powerful warriors being born that far surpassed common sense.

Igrel and Ignel.

They were the Mad King and her twin brother, the warriors with the ‘Spirit of Sacrifice’ who saved Adessa.

That incident became the decisive factor for the Mad King to abandon her tribe and venture out of the Great Forest

...That’s the setting.

I only had a rough understanding of the details, and I didn't know the specifics.

Attachment to her homeland? Attachment to her tribe? Did the Mad King still hold on to such things?

Or was it because she couldn't let go of her attachment to the twin brother who merged with the World Tree?

There were many reasons that came to mind with a little thought.

In any case, if it was about those things, there was no need to worry about her.

More importantly...

We need to find the Emperor quickly.

The reason why the Emperor's actions were tantamount to a disaster lay in the contents of what I just thought.

Because the being he was trying to summon was the demon who almost brought about Adessa's destruction.

In the game, it was not revealed where the Emperor obtained the Fogwigg's demon core.

However, through his many experiments and studies, the Emperor had found a way to deal with its disastrous power.

He conducted research to enable humans to possess the immense power of demons, even those on the level of Archdemons.

Driven by his ambition, he resorted to all sorts of cruel acts and eventually succeeded.

Fogwig was a being with subpar intelligence and self-awareness compared to other demons, making it possible.

Once all preparations were completed, the Emperor would be reborn through fusion with Fogwigg.

He would not be as powerful as before, but that was why he had chosen the Adessa Great Forest as the site of his resurrection.

The Emperor planned to conveniently absorb all the vitality of the Adessa through the World Tree and fully restore Fogwigg's power.

"There are conditions for restoring your power, Second Lord."

"*Sigh*, I already told you. I'll use the power of the spirits to find the Emperor's location."

"Besides that, one more thing. If the Emperor intends to destroy Adessa, how will you act?"

Her brows furrowed.

"What do you mean?"

"Exactly as I said."

"Do you really think the Emperor of Santea possesses such power? What nonsense are you talking about..."

Her words trailed off as she looked at me intently. Then she spoke again.

"...I thought your behavior was strange. Do you know something, Seventh Lord? What is the Emperor trying to do here?"

"In general."

"How?"

"Since I also have my own informant, it would be good if we could just leave it at that. However, the emperor may engage in a very dangerous act."

Since I had agreed to restore her powers, she should be a complete ally for the duration of this.

“Why didn’t you tell the Chief of Staff?”

“Because I don’t know exactly what the Overlord’s intentions are.”

The Overlord didn’t know the Emperor’s intentions and wanted to track his whereabouts and investigate.

But if she knew exactly what the Emperor was up to, she might be more inclined to leave him alone.

After all, Adessa was a different faction.

In the game’s story, Calderic was never involved in this mission from the beginning.

So I didn’t know how the Overlord, the Chief of Staff, the Mad King, or the Thunder Lord would behave.

“I’m in favor of helping Adessa. If Adessa is in danger, even if we oppose the Chief of Staff, you must follow my will for now. That’s the condition.”

Of course, it could be an unnecessary worry.

After a moment of silence, the Thunder Lord spoke.

“Why do you want to help Adessa like this?”

“You ask something obvious. If Adessa falls, the balance of power will crumble. Now is not the time for that to happen.”

The Thunder Lord looked at me with an expression of not understanding, but soon nodded.

“I was trying to help Adessa from the beginning, for Calderic’s sake, not yours. If the Overlord wishes for Adessa’s destruction, I will not go along with it, even if I have to face the consequences later.”

I nodded.

“That’s good too.”

Time passed, and as the sun set and rose again, we arrived at our destination.

The northwest outskirts of the Great Forest, where the vegetation thinned, and rocky mountains appeared.

“There it is.”

I pointed to a rocky mountain that towered conspicuously alone.

Thunder Lord narrowed her eyes.

“Is that really it? I don’t feel any aura at all.”

“It is.”

As we reached the top, the Thunder Lord hurriedly dismounted from the wyvern and looked around.

I dismounted after her and said to her.

“If we wait, it will soon appear.”

That creature was a spirit trapped in this rock mountain, unable to escape.

Grrrrr...

Not long after, Ti-Yong sensed something and let out a low growl.

The Thunder Lord’s wyvern reacted in the same way.

Thunder Lord focused her gaze to one side with tense eyes.

It's here.

With my arms crossed, I also looked in that direction.

Kurrrung!

The sound of thunder echoed, and a dazzling aura gathered at the summit of the rock mountain.

Soon, a massive figure revealed itself before our eyes.

Chapter 163: Adessa Great Forest

(3)

Chapter 163: Adessa Great Forest (3)

Emperor Daed succeeded the throne at an early age and was hailed as the greatest sage among the emperors of Santea.

When he had just turned forty, his fifth child was born.

The child's name was Grandios. The Emperor and Empress were overjoyed and blessed his future.

Since the time of the previous Emperor Daed, one problem had plagued the empire.

The savage tribe of beastmen that had settled in the mountains to the west of the empire.

For some time now, they have been raiding travelers, and by extension, neighboring villages and cities.

Previous emperors attempted to completely subdue them by mobilizing their forces, but they repeatedly failed.

Not only was the scale of the conflict beyond imagination, but the geographical problem was even greater.

Whenever the beastmen disappeared deep into the mountains, it always ended up with a vague and inconclusive conclusion to the war.

Emperor Daed, unable to resolve the source of the conflict the way his ancestors had, decided to try a different approach.

Instead of blindly brandishing swords and spears, he sought to understand the circumstances of the beastmen tribe and engage in peace conversation.

Regardless of their differences in appearance or values, Daed pursued the path of symbiosis rather than confrontation.

Despite his best efforts, communicating with the beastmen proved difficult, but he refused to give up.

Young Grandios naturally observed his father's actions and was influenced by his values.

The unity of the races. That is the starting point to make the world more peaceful.

Although many races coexisted in Calderic, it was a system established through the power of the Overlord.

Grandios believed that there must be a way to achieve true harmony, not through forced power.

From that time on, Grandios devoted himself to studying and researching other races.

He sought to understand their characteristics, cultures, and values.

One day, Grandios presented to Emperor Daed the thoughts he had harbored for a long time.

"Father, what do you think about creating a dedicated residential area for the beastmen and taking some time to observe them?"

The beastmen were the most common race to be bought and sold as slaves.

In Santea, it had been impossible for beastmen to live among humans without attracting attention.

That's why Grandios thought about gradually changing people's perception.

It might be difficult to immediately change laws and institutions and bring about reforms, but he could free some of the beastmen slaves in the capital and allow them to live in freedom.

Perhaps it could even be an opportunity to open the hearts of the beastmen tribes in the mountains.

Emperor Daed was extremely pleased with Grandios' idea and immediately put it into action.

They created beastmen residential areas in the city and gradually established an environment where they could interact with humans in a normal way.

Several years passed.

The plan for the beastmen residential areas seemed to be progressing fairly smoothly.

Grandios continued to contemplate ways to foster harmony with other races.

One day, the Overlord herself came to the capital from Calderic to discuss relations between the two nations.

Grandios and some of his brothers also participated in the talks alongside the Emperor.

During the discussions, the topic of the beastmen residential areas happened to come up, and the Overlord burst into laughter, holding her belly.

"What's so funny, Overlord?"

"Well, how could I not find it amusing? To think there are sheeps who seriously ponder how to befriend wolves."

In that moment, Grandios couldn't control his emotions and raised his voice, almost shouting in front of the Overlord.

People turned pale, but the Overlord only smiled at him.

“An ideal that cannot be achieved is merely an ideal, Prince. Give up.”

Many years passed after that.

The beastmen on the mountain range were still causing trouble.

The period when there seemed to be some results from the efforts was short-lived.

Since there were no periodic large-scale subjugations like in the past, the damages became even greater.

There were increasing numbers of courtiers who argued that the emperor should abandon peaceful measures and subjugate the beastmen.

However, if they were to do so, everything that had been built up until now would become useless, and the relationships could never be restored. Thus, the emperor's anguish deepened further.

“Is there still not enough time? What more can be done in the future?”

Grandios wandered the capital in frustration and eventually arrived at the beastmen district.

He witnessed human soldiers in charge of the district beating a young beastman to death.

There was no significant reason. It seemed that the young beastman had collided with patrolling soldiers while playing in the street.

Suddenly, Grandios felt fear and futility.

What if his efforts didn't change anything?

What if even after making a change, everything would eventually return to square one after his death?

What if the idea that humans could live in harmony with other races was all wrong from the beginning...?

More time passed.

An imperial mage who intended to visit the western frontier fortress was killed in the beastmen ambush.

The mage was Grandios' master, who had taught him magic and etiquette since he was young.

When Emperor Daed reached the age of seventy, he succumbed to a chronic illness he had been suffering from.

Originally, the Crown Prince was to succeed the throne, but he suddenly died for unknown reasons.

Those who were next in line for succession also died for various reasons over time.

And Grandios ascended to the throne.

There was no longer anyone to hinder Grandios, who had long been tightly grasping power.

His surviving siblings and relatives cursed him as a monster.

Grandios didn't hesitate. The first thing he did after becoming the emperor was to exterminate the residents of the beastmen residential district.

Next, he mobilized his troops and initiated a large-scale subjugation of the inhabitants of the western mountains.

He forced other countries into war and used mass killing magic without hesitation, piling up mountains of their corpses using any means necessary.

As a result, the Empire suffered significant losses, but the beastmen that inhabited the mountains were ultimately eradicated.

Some said that it was the death of his master that made him like this, but that was not true.

Grandios did not feel anger towards the beastmen. He merely came to a realization.

What true peace he should pursue.

'If only a world where only humans exist can be created.'

Grandios dreamt of such a world, not because he considered humans superior to other races.

The discord and conflict between humans and other races were not the fault of humans or those races.

It was simply because they were born that way. It was a simple truth.

Since he was born as a human, he had the right and privilege to exist only for humans.

Likewise, they also had the right to exist only for their own race. It was not selfish; it was only natural.

“Because I am human...”

Grandios muttered, looking up at the sky.

Justice was not divided into good and evil, but into victory and defeat.

He would make himself the ultimate victor of this battle as a human.

“Preparations are complete, Your Majesty.”

The mages who were preparing the magic circle spoke.

Spear Saint Cayden nodded and looked at Grandios. (T/N: This is the one I referred to as ‘General’ before.)

Grandios lowered his gaze and stared at the wriggling mass in front of him.

The thunder spirit that appeared before our eyes had the appearance of a giant bird at first glance.

Kwa-rung!

The spirit emitted a menacing aura and released powerful lightning strikes.

Though it had no expression, its demeanor was clearly not friendly.

“What are you doing?”

I spoke to the motionless Thunder Lord.

The Thunder Lord slowly took steps toward the thunder spirit.

“It’s okay. I just want to be friends with you.”

The Thunder Lord spoke soothingly to the spirit, but the relentless lightning strikes became even fiercer.

Nevertheless, she struggled to break through the lightning strikes and continued to approach the spirit almost defenselessly.

If she had been any other race instead of an elf, she would have likely turned into ashes long ago.

I discreetly stepped back, increasing the distance between us.

Since I couldn’t let the Thunder Lord die, I prepared myself to intervene if necessary.

“Kruuuh!”

The distance between the Thunder Lord and the spirit narrowed by a few steps.

The Thunder Lord seemed to have suffered from internal injury as blood trickled from her mouth. Finally, she reached out her hand and made contact with the spirit.

As I watched the thunder spirit slowly withdraw its energy, I murmured softly.

“Did it work?”

Ah, this could be a flag.

Fortunately, despite my words, the spirit ultimately gathered all its energy and disappeared.

Exhausted, the Thunder Lord knelt down and sank to the ground.

【Lv. 95】

I looked up at the top of the Thunder Lord’s head. Her level had returned to its original state.

“Did you succeed in making a contract with the spirit?”

When I asked Thunder Lord, she nodded.

“Just barely. I’ve never seen a spirit so fierce before.”

“Well, it’s fortunate that you regained your strength.”

“Yes... I’m really relieved.”

Thunder Lord glanced at me and stood up.

“It looks like you’re injured.”

“It’s just a minor shock. I’ll recover quickly.”

“Then let’s move right away. We don’t have much time.”

She glared at me again.

Back in the northern part of the Great Forest, it was now Thunder Lord’s turn to find the Emperor, as planned.

She had been very reluctant to do so, saying that incurring the wrath of the spirits was inherently dangerous for an elemental, but a promise was a promise.

Gooooo.

Thunder Lord, who had finished her preparations, extended her power to all the spirits in the area.

As I observed with my super sensory, I could feel the spirits writhing in pain, and the Thunder Lord’s complexion grew darker.

“I never expected that the Second Lord would grant such a favor.”

The chief of staff looked at me with a strange gaze as he spoke.

From his perspective, the relationship between the Thunder Lord and me might seem peculiar.

Since it was going to take quite some time, the chief of staff and I were guarding her.

After what felt like a long time, the Thunder Lord opened her eyes and regained her energy as she spoke.

“I found it.”

“Really?”

“I felt an unfamiliar energy not far from here, towards the east. It must be the Emperor.”

We found it much faster than expected. With a distorted impression caused by severe aftereffects, she asked me.

“What is that energy exactly? Did the Emperor really join hands with the demons?”

“...Probably. We don’t have much time, so let’s move immediately.”

If the Thunder Lord had felt a demonic aura, did that mean the Emperor had truly taken action?

I felt the growing unease becoming more and more real.

We swiftly moved in the direction the Thunder Lord mentioned.

And after about half a day, we arrived in a dense forest.

In the distance, among the bushes, I gradually began to sense an unfamiliar energy.

A creepy, demonic aura that was unlike anything I had ever encountered before.

Oh no……!

Straining my vision to the maximum, I spotted the people there.

The Emperor, Spear Saint Cayden, and several mages.

The Emperor was standing in some kind of magic circle, accompanied by a conspicuous lump. As soon as I saw that, I shouted.

“Thunder Lord, attack him! Quickly!”

Upon hearing me, the Thunder Lord summoned a spirit.

A massive lightning bolt shot out and struck right where the Emperor was.

Chapter 164: Adessa Great Forest

(4)

Chapter 164: Adessa Great Forest (4)

The Thunder Lord's blow reduced the mages to ashes, and the Spear Saint was seen bleeding and blocking the emperor's path.

However, the Emperor remained unscathed.

As the distance closed in and the Emperor entered my range, I jumped from Ti-Yong's back using space leap, teleporting one after another.

And just before the blood I shot from close range made contact with the Emperor...

Ah!

A black current surged and swirled around the Emperor like a barrier.

Damn it...!

After narrowly missing contact, I blocked the shockwave with a floating veil and stepped back.

This time, an attack came from the side. It was the Spear Saint's attack.

But he was hit squarely by another bolt of lightning from the Thunder Lord and bounced off into the distance.

Kwaaarung!

Immediately after, the Thunder Lord descended from the sky, once again unleashing a tremendous lightning bolt upon the emperor's head.

But the barrier covering the Emperor seemed unaffected by the Thunder Lord's attack.

“What is this...?”

She couldn't continue her words, surprised by how easily her attack was blocked.

...It seemed like it's too late.

The Emperor has begun to fuse with Fogwigg.

All I could do was watch that spectacle in a daze.

Grrrrrrrr.

In an instant, the mana expanded into a massive entity.

A creature resembling a slime covered in black flames all over its body began to wriggle and move.

Its size was so colossal that it could be compared to a small mountain.

I stared blankly at the scene and used my blood magic. The droplets of blood landed on the creature's body.

...It's not effective.

However, the instant kill didn't activate.

The black mass was not his body, but merely a clump of mana.

I knew that the Emperor's body was buried in the innermost part of that magical mass. Because that's what the game said.

“Fogwigg... How is the Emperor?”

The Chief of Staff muttered.

He seemed to have realized the creature's identity.

"Fogwigg? Is that what it's called?"

"It seems so. It perfectly matches the calamity that invaded Adessa during the Great War. It appears to be slightly smaller, though..."

At that moment, the Spear Saint, who had been knocked away by the Thunder Lord's attack, walked toward us.

He was in a pitiful state. Our gazes turned towards him simultaneously.

"It's all over. I don't know how Calderic sniffed it out, but you can't stop it."

I spoke out of frustration.

"You foolish bastards, do you really think this is what's best for humanity?"

"Keep talking, Seventh Lord. You don't know anything..."

"No, I do know. That he will consume the World Tree from here, and that he will march straight to Altelore afterward."

The Spear Saint seemed surprised that I knew all about their future plans. He momentarily lost his words.

What the Emperor desired was the destruction of all races except humans.

A world where only humans existed.

He held the ridiculous ideal that a world exclusive to humans would be more peaceful than it was now.

Just by hearing it, one could tell such a thing was fundamentally impossible.

The Emperor would absorb all the power of the Great Forest through the World Tree, and then head for Altelore, where he would self-destruct.

It was a plan to completely annihilate the Adessa and Altelore factions.

Even if it meant sacrificing everything. And then, the only remaining Calderic would gradually be pushed aside by Santea.

As long as the hero still lived, the balance of power would fully tilt towards Santea.

The reason he intended not to attack Calderic and leave it be was also because of humans.

The races that were most dominant in Calderic were humans, elves, and beasts.

It was to avoid slaughtering them.

In time, all races but humans would be exterminated.

The Emperor was such a madman.

And I also knew very well that his plan would never succeed.

“You know nothing. Did you really think that resurrecting Fogwigg would be enough to destroy Altelore?”

The current leader of the demon clan ranked first among the Four Great Demon Kings.

The most fanatical follower of the Demon King.

The power of Azekel, who even hid himself under the shadow of the Demon King during the Great War, was beyond imagination.

No matter how powerful Fogwigg was, if the demons were a race that could be destroyed by just that, the hero would have annihilated them long ago.

“...The ones who will be victorious are us humans. Glory to humanity and Santea.”

With those last words, the Spear Saint aimed his spear at us without saying another word.

But he had been gravely wounded earlier, when he had blocked the Thunder Lord's attack from the front, unable to dodge it.

Thunder Lord snorted and unleashed a storm of attacks.

One strike, then another, then a third, and the Spear Saint was no longer able to block or dodge, and was charred to a crisp.

It was a futile end. I averted my gaze from the Spear Saint's corpse.

I had hoped that one day Asher would be able to take revenge on him in person, but now was not the time to worry about that.

“Chief of Staff.”

“Yes, Seventh Lord.”

“We must stop that. You don't have any objections, right? If Adessa falls and the balance is disrupted, everything will turn into chaos.”

The Chief of Staff remained silent and nodded.

“It seems like that's what we have to do.”

“Can't you go and call the Overlord?”

The Chief of Staff could teleport straight to the Overlord's castle and tell her what was happening.

But he shook his head.

“The Overlord is currently away.”

...Of all times, even the Overlord? It's impossible.

If only there was an Overlord or a hero, we would have been able to stop it easily.

Of course, I had no way of contacting the hero either.

Could we really stop that monster with just us?

While looking at Fogwigg, which was gradually moving further away, I spoke to the Thunder Lord and the Chief of Staff.

"For now, let's pursue it."

We climbed back onto the Wyverns and chased after the Fogwigg.

At the very top of his body was an area that emitted a blackish-red glow mixed with a faint purple aura. I pointed at it and said,

"That's probably its weak spot. The Emperor's body must be buried inside there."

"How do you know that?"

"I'm sensitive to energy. I can clearly feel where he is."

Of course, I only knew that because of the game.

Since I was the one who knew the Emperor's plan from the beginning, the Thunder Lord seemed to believe me.

"Second Lord, if you can pierce through even a small part of the Emperor's body, I can definitely cut off his breath. Is it possible?"

The Thunder Lord stared silently at the purple area and summoned the spirits once again.

With a thunderous sound, a giant bird-shaped entity appeared above her head. This time, it was a complete summoning.

“I will help.”

The Chief of Staff also exerted his mana.

To be honest, it didn't seem like the Chief of Staff's level would be of much help, but it was better than nothing.

Kurrung...

A massive sphere formed, with a blast of processed lightning energy that was nothing compared to the previous attacks.

Before the Thunder Lord's attack could land, the Chief of Staff fired a red magical beam first.

The magical beam hit the purple area accurately, but it seemed to have no impact at all.

Flash!

Next, a flash engulfed the surroundings, and the massive lightning sphere created by the Thunder Lord crashed down.

I looked on, squinting my eyes due to the brightness.

At first glance, the attack seemed to have worked, as the Thunder Lord's destructive power wiped out an entire vegetation of trees in an instant.

The purple area was deeply dented, and even the movements of Fogwigg stopped momentarily.

...Ha.

But the wound healed in the blink of an eye.

Seeing Fogwigg start moving again as if nothing had happened, the Thunder Lord let out a small groan.

“It's impenetrable. With unbelievable defense and regenerative power.”

I wonder if that's all the Thunder Lord could do, even at full strength.

If that's the case, then the power we have here was indeed insufficient.

The chief of staff turned his gaze to me with an expectant look, but I could only avoid his gaze.

Please don't look at me like that.

There was nothing I could do unless the Emperor's body was revealed.

"Fogwigg is accelerating."

The chief of staff said.

True to his words, the speed at which Fogwigg was moving was increasing, contrary to its size.

At this rate, he would reach the World Tree in no time, and then it's over.

"It seems we need more power."

"Yes, we must inform the elves and beastmen of the situation."

From the beginning, they were the ones who would be the most affected by this, so we could immediately gain their cooperation.

"Then I will go to the leader of the elves."

The Thunder Lord said.

Considering her family's amicable relationship with the elves of Adessa, there shouldn't be any problems.

I nodded and said.

"Understood. The chief of staff and I will go meet the leader of the beastmen."

We split up and headed towards the Eastern and Western forests separately.

We traveled day and night without stopping.

Once we entered the territory of the beastmen, we increased our altitude significantly to move.

If the beastmen spotted us on the ground, they could attack us first.

“We’re almost there.”

And in the middle of the land of the beastmen, as we entered the territory of the Gonak tribe, we gradually decreased our altitude.

Although approaching in this manner could be seen as an invasion from their perspective, there was no time to leisurely seek permission to enter the place.

Hmm.

As expected, a warm welcome awaited us from below.

The beastmen were already gathered in full force, observing us.

However, they did not launch an attack.

“Let’s descend around here. Let’s go, Ti-Yong.”

I tapped Ti-Yong’s neck lightly.

On the ground, the Chief of Staff and I landed in the midst of a camp of beastmen warriors.

With hostility pouring in from all sides, a beastman stepped forward and shouted.

“Calderic’s Chief of Staff and the new Seventh Lord. Do you know what you are doing?”

The beastman seemed to have guessed and figured out who I was.

After all, they were not oblivious to external affairs. The Chief of Staff spoke up before me.

“We apologize for this rudeness, but the situation is dire, and we had no choice.”

“What are you talking about?”

“It means that the existence of Adessa is in great danger. We have come to assist you. We don’t have time for this, so I hope you will guide us to the High Chieftain.”

There was commotion among the beastmen at his words. The Chief of Staff spoke again.

“We don’t have time for this.”

“Explain in detail. We have no reason to blindly follow your words...”

I interjected, speaking in a chilling voice.

“It seems you don’t understand what we’re saying. This matter is not for you to judge. Shouldn’t you inform the chieftain? Or should I summon them here?”

“...”

As they exchanged words among themselves, some of the attendants left the place, while the rest continued to confront us.

After a while, a group of individuals appeared.

I checked the level of the hulking figure standing in their midst.

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Udakbat, the high chieftain of Adesa's beastmen tribes.

Even without my insistence, it seemed like they were already on their way as they quickly appeared.

“What do you mean, Adessa's existence is in danger? Explain yourself.”

Approaching closer, he immediately went straight to the point. I thought that was very cool of him, so I answered.

“Literally. Didn't the Fifth Lord come looking for you?”

“Yes, she said the Emperor of Santea was up to something nefarious in the Great Forest.”

I nodded.

“Well, this will be quick. Those concerns have become a reality.”

“...What is the Emperor up to?”

“That guy resurrected Fogwigg. That monster that almost destroyed Adessa during the Great War.”

The chieftain's eyes widened, and the other beastmen also showed signs of shock.

At that moment, another voice interjected.

“What nonsense is that, Seventh Lord? Fogwigg?”

I turned my gaze towards the owner of the voice.

The Mad King was striding toward us, her face twisted into a fierce grimace.

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The voice of the Mad King not only conveyed her unpleasant emotions, but also seemed to show her murderous intent.

Knowing that it wasn't directed towards me, there was no need to concern myself unnecessarily. I calmly spoke.

"The Emperor has resurrected the Fogwigg near the northern part of the Great Forest. And he is now approaching in the direction of the World Tree. Though it actually appeared to be more of a fusion than a resurrection."

"So, what do you mean, how in the world did the Emperor resurrect Fogwigg?"

"Don't you get it? That creature is still approaching in the direction of the World Tree. It seems certain that the World Tree is its objective, but it's hard to predict how quickly it will reach the World Tree since its speed is accelerating. That's the entirety of what can be explained about the current situation."

The Mad King fell into silence. I shifted my gaze to the chieftain and spoke.

"There's no need for further explanations, Chieftain. We must stop it. Gather all your forces immediately."

The chieftain remained silent for a moment, then finally spoke.

"Everyone, be quiet."

At that single word, the restless beastmen fell silent. The Chieftain fixed his slitted pupils on me.

“I understand your words. However, how can we trust you?”

“.....”

“The Fifth Lord comes to us and tells us that the Emperor of Santea is scheming something, and then you come to us and tell us that the Emperor will now destroy Adessa. How can we not be suspicious?”

Well, from the Chieftain’s perspective, this situation would undoubtedly be confusing and doubtful.

All of a sudden, a Lord of Calderic was saying that the Emperor had resurrected Fogwigg out of nowhere and was going to destroy the Great Forest.

“Do you want to claim that we orchestrated this?”

“Even so, there might be intentions to take advantage of this situation. Since when did Calderic and Adessa have such a close alliance? What reason could there be for you to be so proactive in helping us?”

I clicked my tongue in frustration.

“Don’t ask me offhandedly, Chieftain. We have no idea how the continent’s power structure would change if Adessa falls, so this is not just your problem.”

The Chieftain narrowed his eyes.

“Yes, that’s true. However, I still lack sufficient grounds to trust you.”

Ah, this bastard.

I understood that from the Chieftain’s perspective; it was a delicate matter that required caution. But in such an urgent situation, if he kept responding like that, I couldn’t help but get frustrated.

“Hey, Chieftain. Let’s stop going in circles like this. So, what do you suggest we do? If we head north immediately, you can quickly confirm whether my words about Fogwigg approaching the World Tree were true or not.”

“.....”

“You only have two choices. Either turn us into enemies right here and now and try to stop Fogwigg with the depleted forces, or trust us and cooperate to stop the Fogwigg. Ah, perhaps there’s a third option. If all you want is for us to no longer interfere, then we’ll just leave immediately. After all, you are the ones who shot yourself in the foot. While you buy time, we will explore alternative solutions more leisurely.”

Finishing my statement, I stood still and stared at the Chieftain.

Whether my frustration and sincerity got through or not, the Chieftain’s expression relaxed.

“Very well. I suppose we have only one choice now. Seventh Lord, first of all, thank you for the important information. Will you assist Adessa?”

I nodded.

“Now we can communicate.”

I immediately got to the point.

At this point, we didn’t know exactly how far Fogwigg had traveled from where he’d been resurrected to the World Tree.

We didn’t know how fast he would have traveled.

After listening to my explanation, the Chieftain decided how to organize the forces to stop Fogwigg.

Time was pressing. There was no time to move troops in large numbers.

And in any case, the quantity of forces meant nothing when facing that creature.

The weak will be swept away like dust. What was needed was a single, powerful force, like the Thunder Lord.

A destructive force that would break through that ridiculously tough mass in one fell swoop.

“We must hurry to send word to the other tribes and the Elven chieftain.”

“No need to contact the Elves. The Second Lord has already gone in that direction.”

“Is that so? So the Second Lord is also here.”

“Yes. Just inform the other beastman tribes. And once this discussion is over, we’ll head straight to Fogwigg as planned, so we can also move immediately from this side.”

The individuals who were decided to move to Fogwigg’s location were me, the chief of staff, the chieftain, the beastmen warrior leader, a few elders, and the Mad King.

“Hehe, it’s truly absurd. How can such a wretched situation keep repeating? We should have taken down that dangerous Emperor long ago.”

The Mad King, who chuckled, asked the chief of staff.

“Is the Overlord not coming?”

“The Overlord is absent at the moment...”

“That’s some timing, Chief of Staff. Did the Overlord really not know the Emperor was going to do this, even what he was scheming?”

“What do you mean?”

The Mad King and the chief of staff locked eyes for a moment without saying a word.

“I mean, our Overlord is always a bit of a mystery.”

Mad King smirked and looked away first. Then she spoke sarcastically, this time to the Chieftain.

“Udakbat, why don’t you, as Chieftain, sacrifice yourself to the World Tree this time, just as Igrel did?”

The chieftain responded without even blinking.

“If that’s the best way, I can do it anytime.”

“If it’s just empty words, who can’t do that? You disgusting hypocrites.”

“Ignel! Shut up!”

One of the elders of the beastmen shouted impatiently.

The Mad King made a gesture of flicking her ear in response.

“Ignel, calm down. Don’t you know the state of the World Tree? Besides, because of the reckless attempt to amplify our power at that time, if we were to use such methods again, it would result in the complete destruction of the core.”

In response to the Chieftain’s words, Ignel snorted and replied.

“Before anything else, let’s get real here. Your abilities are way below par. Do you honestly think being absorbed by the World Tree would even make a damn difference, let alone match half of Igrel’s power?”

“You’re right about that. Igrel was the greatest warrior of all.”

As I observed the clan leader dealing with Ignel, I thought he had remarkable patience.

Perhaps due to the urgency of the situation, the Mad King stopped sulking when the Chieftain responded with indifference.

But the World Tree was actually in such a state?

Listening to their conversation, I roughly understood the situation in Adessa.

It seemed that absorbing the power of Igrel, Ignel's brother, had put a considerable burden on the core of the World Tree.

In other words, it didn't seem possible to use that method again in the current situation.

"Let's move."

Soon, the beastmen brought in a huge bird that looked like a hawk.

Hawkdi. They inhabited the Adessa Great Forest, and the beastmen tamed them as a means of transportation.

Kroooh!

As the Hawkdis approached, Ti-Yong let out a roar.

The frightened Hawkdis flapped their wings and went into a frenzy.

"Hey, stop fooling around."

Knowing that the wyvern was just being mischievous, I tapped its neck.

After completing all the preparations, we began to move right away.

Hawkdis were fast, but not as fast as the wyverns, so we had to match their speed.

They traveled for quite a while in the direction that Fogwig would have taken, and then—

“...My God.”

The beastmen looked down at the carnage below and gasped in shock.

Underneath the traces of something enormous being dragged away, there is a dark and sticky aura that engulfs the surrounding forest.

It was an eerie and grotesque sight that couldn't be simply described as ruins.

I couldn't help but stiffen my expression as I looked at it.

It's already traveled this far?

The scenery we were currently witnessing was the aftermath of Fogwigg passing through the forest.

It meant that the creature had already moved beyond this place.

“Chieftain, how much farther is it to the World Tree from here?”

The Chieftain responded to my question.

“It won't take us more than half a day with the speed we're flying.”

It's so close...

When I and the chief of staff began our journey, Fogwigg's speed was certainly not at this level.

However, it seems that the creature continued to accelerate as it moved with its massive size.

There was no further conversation.

The beastmen, seemingly aware of the gravity of the situation, took the lead and moved along the dark path.

And soon enough, we came face to face with the creature.

“Looks like he’s gotten even bigger.”

The chief of staff spoke as he observed the distant, black, gigantic mass.

For now, the creature seemed to be motionless, standing in its place.

I looked back at the beastmen. The impression of solemnity was firmly etched on their faces. The chieftain and the Mad King were no different.

Fogwigg was a presence that nearly brought destruction to their homeland.

And for the Mad King, it was a being that had taken away the life of her brother. It was a natural reaction.

“The elves haven’t arrived yet. Should we strike first?”

“Yes, it seems there’s no time to wait.”

I nodded and spoke to the chieftain.

“There is a spot on Fogwig’s upper part that emits a purple glow. The emperor’s body is buried inside.”

“You mean it’s a weakness?”

“Yes. All we have to do is kill the body and the great scourge will disappear without a trace.”

The beastmen prepared for battle. There was no need for elaborate strategies at the moment.

Just concentrate the attack on a single point and let the Emperor’s body be revealed.

“Do you know how it attacks?”

I answered the chieftain’s question.

“There was no counterattack when we fought it. How did Fogwigg behave when you encountered it in the past?”

“It would release its body parts and shoot them in all directions. We need to be cautious of that much, at least...”

“Why are you still hesitating? Just crush it!”

The Mad King drew her greatsword and advanced forward, charging straight toward Fogwigg.

Clang!

The Mad King’s blood-red sword struck down on Fogwigg.

Although she aimed precisely at the weakness, there was still no significant impact.

The Mad King frowned and withdrew the blade, which was only slightly embedded at the tip.

Following her, the Chieftain and other beastmen moved forward to join the fight.

When they saw that Fogwigg had not reacted to their attacks, they landed on its body, as did the Mad King.

“If it shows any sign of trying to do something, we must immediately retreat! Be cautious of attacks where it separates its body and launches projectiles!”

It looked like everyone was going to hit the weak spot at once. I and the Chief of Staff were still on our wyverns, observing the scene from above.

Since I couldn't do much in terms of offense, I had the intention to step forward and assist in defense if anyone was in danger.

Quaaaaaang!

Along with a deafening roar, the attacks from the beastmen simultaneously struck Fogwigg's weakness.

This time, it seemed like there was some impact as the vulnerable area of Fogwigg appeared noticeably concave.

Even more so than when the Mad King attacked.

“Chieftain, attack once again……!”

However, this time, a reaction emerged from Fogwigg.

As the mass showed an unusual response, I immediately shouted.

“Take cover!”

“Everyone, retreat!”

Simultaneously, the chieftain also shouted.

The next moment, as everyone jumped into the air, the surface of the mass, which had been shaking violently, exploded, sending fragments in all directions.

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Fragments rained down like cannonballs from Fogwigg. The beastmen and the fragments mixed in the air.

At that moment, the Chieftain swung his weapon.

His weapon was shaped like a crescent moon sword, and the massive blade sliced through more than half of the debris, hitting the beastmen.

The beastmen caught in the remaining fragments defended themselves by wielding their own weapons.

Oh no.

I initiated a space leap.

I approached the beastman, who was about to be hit by an unusually large chunk of debris, and shielded him with a floating veil.

“Thank you!”

The beastman, who had come to the brink of death and returned, shouted with a face full of gratitude before falling to the ground.

Returning to the back of Ti-Yong, I moved away from Fogwigg, keeping a safe distance.

After a brief lull, I confirmed that there were no casualties among the beastmen who had descended to the ground.

It seemed that no one was seriously injured.

It has regenerated again.

I shifted my gaze to Fogwigg's weakness. The areas hit by combined attacks were quickly restored, as I had expected.

"Tsk. Did that monster have this kind of ability before?"

The Mad King brushed off the black flames on her arm.

On the body of Fogwigg, the black aura was once again surging, just like when I first saw it. Judging from the felt energy, it seemed like the damage would only be significant unless someone on the level of a Lord made it, if not greater.

The people here were all level 80 and above, but was this still not enough?

In the state where the flames surrounded it, it was not easy to climb on top or approach it closely.

Kwaaaang!

At that moment, the Mad King exploded with rage and once again charged towards Fogwigg alone.

She swung her sword without care, whether the black aura stuck to her body or not, truly behaving like a madwoman.

The black aura of Fogwigg and the crimson aura of the Mad King mixed together, and a black-red light flashed.

Midway through, Fogwigg once again burst the surface and sent shards flying, but she didn't pause in her assault, slashing or smashing them all to pieces.

The Mad King did not easily succumb to Fogwigg's counterattacks, but the same could be said in reverse.

She unleashed an assault that could have toppled a mountain, and Fogwigg didn't even flinch.

She's just wasting her strength.

Ultimately, it would be impossible to break through on her own.

Realizing that it was all in vain, the Mad King also ceased her attacks.

The Mad King descended to the ground, stabbed the sword into the ground in frustration, and sat down, catching her breath.

The Chieftain looked at her and spoke to the other beastmen.

"It seems like it will be difficult with just our current power. Let's gather our strength and launch a joint attack when the elves arrive."

Indeed, that seemed to be the wisest choice given the current situation.

In terms of pure destructive power, the elves' elemental powers were probably stronger.

Therefore, when the Elf Chieftain and the reinforcements arrived, they would launch a unified attack.

...They arrived just as we were talking about them.

I felt their presence and lifted my head.

Suddenly, the dots appearing on the other side of the sky rapidly approached.

The Thunder Lord and the elven tribe had arrived.

Is it the power of the Wind Spirits?

Whoosh!

The elves, riding on hawkdis and stirring up strong winds, descended to the ground.

Among them, it was immediately recognizable who the Elf Chieftain was.

Shandra, Elven Chieftain of Adessa.

She gathered the energy of the spirits around her and stepped closer to the Beastmen High Chieftain.

“I’ve heard all about it from the Second Lord of Calderic, and I’ve brought with me the best men I can muster.”

“Thank you.”

“Is that Fogwigg?”

The Elf Chieftain looked at the Fogwigg with an intensely serious expression.

The other elves all had a weary expression as well.

The Thunder Lord standing near the Elf Chieftain approached me and asked.

“It seems we arrived late. How is the situation?”

I shook my head.

“We have already made one attack, but it was in vain. We need the power of the elves.”

There was no time for idle chatter.

After briefly sharing information with the Beastmen Chieftain, the Elf Chieftain immediately prepared for battle with the elves.

“It’s meaningless to reserve our energy since the enemy recovers quickly, even if it gets hit. We must put all our strength into a single attack.”

“Understood.”

The strategy was simple.

This time, the elves would launch the initial attack, followed by a coordinated attack from the Beastmen.

With this level of power, there was enough possibility.

“Akene.”

The chieftain summoned the Great Spirit of Wind. A goddess-like figure with closed eyes floated above her head.

Suddenly, a whirlwind erupted, and both the elves and the Beastmen floated into the sky.

They formed a circle around Fogwigg. Then the elves summoned their spirits in unison.

Various spirits such as the fire spirits, water spirits, thunder spirits, wind spirits, and other spirits shaped the air above Fogwigg.

The chieftain of the elves created a giant whirlwind in the form of a lance, and Thunder Lord created a lightning ball, compressing her lightning to the limit as before.

As if they were going to settle the score this time, the beastmen chieftain had spared no expense in summoning his power.

...Kwaaah!

And then an onslaught began.

In an instant, if an ordinary person were present, the blinding flash that engulfed the forest had blinded their vision. Explosions erupted, storms

raged, and lightning flashes flickered.

I focused my attention and watched that spectacle.

I could see the Fogwigg's weaknesses caved in, even more so than in the previous attacks.

“Kraaaaah!”

Amidst the piercing sound, the beastmen's roars resounded.

They dropped into the depression as soon as the elves' attacks were over.

The moment they struck Fogwigg's weakened body once more...

Dududud!

Fogwigg began to heal its wounds at a much faster speed than before.

The beastmen, who were widening the cracks within the vulnerable area, found themselves in danger of being buried by the masses closing in from all sides.

“Ah...!”

More than half of the beastmen narrowly escaped, but some could not get out.

The elven chieftain used the power of the wind spirit to pull out those who couldn't escape from the pit.

However, a few ultimately failed to escape and were consumed by Fogwigg.

Including the Chieftain.

The beastmen who had escaped looked at the wriggling Fogwigg with bewildered faces.

“Chief!”

Swoosh!

In that moment, a part of Fogwig’s body burst open, and the Chieftain of the beastmen emerged.

In his arm, he held another beastman who hadn’t managed to escape.

“Hoo...”

The Chieftain of the beastmen looked back at Fogwigg with a desolate gaze.

Despite everyone combining their strength, the formidable opponent ultimately persevered.

The massive wounds that had briefly appeared were now being replaced by other chunks, disappearing without a trace.

“...!”

At that moment, Fogwigg showed another reaction.

With such intensity that the ground trembled, it began to move its body once again.

The speed was unbelievably fast, causing the beastmen and elves in its path to be swept away without being able to avoid it.

“Oh no...!”

The elf chieftain and the Thunder Lord unleashed their attacks simultaneously.

The lightning bolts and wind blades struck a wide swath across Fogwigg’s body, but they only slowed it down a bit.

“We can’t let it escape! We must prevent it from reaching the World Tree!”

Everyone moved urgently without even a moment to fully recover.

In the midst of it all, while I was merely watching, riding on Ti-Yong, I rushed ahead of Fogwigg.

“To-Yong. Dodge.”

I jumped off Ti-Yong’s back and expanded the floating barrier as wide as possible in front of Fogwigg.

Although there was some uneasiness that it might not be fully covered, thankfully Fogwigg was stopped by the floating veil and its movement came to a halt.

However, the force pushing against the barrier was incredibly strong, and the impact transmitted through the barrier was quite alarming.

I can’t endure this for long.

It wasn’t enough to crush me, but if it kept going like this, I would suffocate to death.

Fortunately, as the elves and beastmen who followed behind attacked relentlessly, the creature once again ceased its movement.

“...These guys are no joke.”

Everyone stared at Fogwigg with exhausted faces.

While we managed to stop it for now, there was no guarantee that we could continue to do so if it started moving again.

Even a combined effort using all our strength proved futile. It was truly a hopeless situation.

In that manner, without proper rest or respite, a fierce battle raged on for three days and nights.

Fogwigg persisted in advancing, and we repeatedly struggled to stop it.

Although reinforcements arrived from other tribes in the middle, it held little significance.

“We don’t have much distance left. At this rate, the creature will reach the World Tree by tomorrow at the latest.”

The situation was desperate.

Everyone was exhausted, and we still hadn’t found a way to stop Fogwigg.

“.....Do you have any ideas, Chief Shandra?”

“I have none. It’s impossible to amplify the power of the World Tree as we did back then...”

The morale was depleted, and no one could utter a word.

In the face of the overwhelming power of Fogwigg, bravery and the will to risk our lives became meaningless. We had come to realize this after fighting for several days.

At that moment, the Mad King, who had been gazing blankly at the sky, let out a chuckle.

All eyes focused on her.

“Why are you so fixated on living? Wasn’t the forest already destroyed during the Great War? It was only preserved by sacrificing Igrrel’s life.”

“Igrrel...”

“No matter what methods we use, it seems impossible to stop that monster. Let’s just accept it. You are the proud warriors of the Great Forest, aren’t you? Let’s fight to the end and die here.”

Yes, if it’s the end, anyway...

Muttering those words, the Mad King turned her body and headed somewhere. It was in the direction where the World Tree existed.

“Ignel! Where are you going?”

“Chief! It’s about to move again!”

At that moment, Fogwigg trembled.

With Ignel gone, everyone attacked relentlessly to stop the enemy without any concern.

What is she trying to do?

Feeling a sinister premonition, I didn’t join the attack and instead chased after the disappeared Mad King.

“Mad King! Why are you here...!”

“Get lost.”

Mad King raised her fist.

The warriors guarding the entrance of the World Tree were easily knocked out and fell unconscious from her punch.

Having defeated all the warriors and entered the depths of the World Tree, the Mad King headed for its core.

To see the core of the World Tree.

“...Ignel.”

Mad King had a brother named Ignel.

She didn’t believe in legends or superstitions that descended upon the tribe, but there was one thing she believed in.

It was impossible not to believe in the existence of Ignel, her brother, even after all that sacrifice.

Igrel was that powerful. He was the strongest warrior of the Great Forest.

When he reached the age to undergo the coming-of-age ceremony, he had already surpassed even Udakbat, the current chieftain, and no one denied or opposed the fact that he would become the next chieftain of the beastmen tribe.

From a young age, they fought each other playfully or seriously until they grew tired of it.

However, Igrel had never once been defeated by Ignel.

To Ignel, Igrel was the only blood, brother, idol, and goal in the world.

Ignel stopped in her tracks in front of the orange gem covered with a tree trunk.

Standing still, she looked at the core of the World Tree and reached out her hand.

“Let’s end it all. You, me, and this forest.”

If they couldn’t stop that monster from devouring the World Tree, anyway.

Before then, she would rather crush the soul of his brothers trapped inside this damned stone with her own hands.

Igrel chuckled, clutching the core in her hand.

“...We made such a promise. Even if you become the chieftain, I will eventually become the strongest warrior of the Great Forest.”

In the end, the promise was not kept because Ignel could not surpass him until his death.

He left the Great Forest and traveled the continent, fighting numerous people.

Among them, there were petty individuals, formidable foes who could make her blood boil, and she even encountered a monster stronger than Igrel.

The world outside the forest was vast. However, her thirst was never quenched.

No matter how strong the enemy was, even if it was the Overlord of Calderic, there was no existence that could satisfy her thirst.

Excitement and exhilaration were temporary, and after the battle, emptiness always remained in her heart.

“If there is a world after death, let’s meet and fight again, Igrel.”

Igrel exerted strength into the hand holding the core.

There was a momentary hesitation in her eyes, but it was fleeting.

Crack.

It was the moment right before the core of the World Tree shattered.

“Stop, Mad King.”

Igrel turned her head.

The Seventh Lord was walking into the entrance of the tree roots.

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Chapter 167: Adessa Great Forest (7)

Chasing after the Mad King, I stared at the giant tree up ahead.

The tree was exaggeratedly tall, reaching the point where it touched the clouds. It was gigantic and enveloped in a divine power.

Is that the World Tree?

Feeling a sense of wonder, I descended to the ground.

Leaving Ti-Yong outside, I found the entrance to the World Tree and entered alone.

At the entrance and along the passageway, there were fallen beastmen and elves who appeared to be guards. It was likely the work of the Mad King.

What the hell is she doing?

I know that the soul of Igrel, the Mad King's brother, was absorbed within the core of the World Tree.

Thus, it was evident that the Mad King had come here for the core of the World Tree, but...

I used my super sensory and followed the trace of the Mad King.

Continuing down the passage where the guards had fallen, I eventually arrived at a vast space.

“...!”

And in that place, I could see the Mad King.

Even at first glance, she seemed to be reaching out to the orange gem that clearly resembled the core of the World Tree, as if she would shatter it at any moment.

Thump.

Seeing the gold infiltrating the core, I urgently spoke up.

“Stop, Mad King.”

The Mad King stopped her actions and turned her gaze towards me.

A moment of silence passed. Without saying a word, the Mad King looked at me, questioning why I had pursued her to this place.

Approaching her a little closer, I spoke.

“Is that... the core of the World Tree?”

The abyss obediently answered.

“Right. It’s the core of the World Tree.”

“—Why would you want to destroy it? If you do, there’s no hope of stopping Fogwigg.”

The Mad King let out a laugh.

“What does it matter? We couldn’t stop it, and the Great Forest is on the verge of destruction, anyway.”

“But there’s no reason to destroy it now.”

“No, there is. Instead of letting that monster devour the World Tree and absorb its power, I’d rather destroy it first.”

“Even if you do, it won’t make much difference. That creature will absorb not only the core of the World Tree but also the vitality of the entire Great Forest.”

Mad King seemed displeased as I continued to argue.

Ah...

Could that be the reason?

As I thought about it, I realized the real reason why she wanted to destroy the core. It had to do with his brother, Igrel.

She didn’t want his soul to be swallowed by Fogwigg, so she wanted to extinguish it with her own hands before that happened.

“The reasons you mentioned earlier were just excuses. Is it because of Igrel?”

At my words, the Mad King’s eyes twitched.

“Seventh Lord, you know a lot about me. I really don’t like shady bastards like you.”

“I haven’t done any research on you. I just happened to find out.”

“Are you done talking? Don’t bother me anymore.”

Mad King snarled, baring her fangs. I stared at her intently, then shook my head.

“I can’t let that happen. Adessa’s fate is not just Adessa’s problem.”

Snap!

The greatsword that had aimed precisely at my head was blocked by my floating veil and deflected away.

Apparently, the Mad King wasn’t in the mood for further conversation.

“Then I’ll kill you first. By the way, I remember there was a time when we almost fought, but it ended abruptly, right?”

I pondered.

It seemed unlikely that this could be resolved through words.

But if I let her go on her rampage, the World Tree’s core would be destroyed.

Nor did I have the power to subdue her.

Although I could kill her since she was a pure physical fighter, that would also pose difficulties.

Kwaang!

I used space leap to dodge her punch.

Mad King immediately changed direction and charged at me again.

I defended against her attacks and dodged, but I couldn’t make a decision.

What should I do?

Mad King was a warrior stronger than the Tyrant whom I killed in the past.

I couldn’t endure for long by simply stalling for time.

But how on earth should I handle this situation?

At that moment, a thought suddenly came to mind.

...Wait a minute.

Come to think of it, there was that. But could it really be done?

I had concerns, but since there wasn’t any other viable option, hesitation was brief.

I teleported in front of the core of the World Tree, evading the Mad King's ongoing attacks.

Upon seeing this, the Mad King paused her momentary rampage.

"Hey, what are you planning?"

I glanced at the core of the World Tree and spoke.

"You would rather destroy your brother's soul that let Fogwigg devour it. Isn't that right, Fifth Lord?"

"Hey, Seventh Lord..."

"Then I suppose you don't mind if I borrow his power for a moment."

I reached toward the core of the World Tree, entangled in the tree trunk.

"Borrow his power. What the hell are you talking about?"

Ignoring the Mad King's words, I made contact with the core of the World Tree.

Soul Convergence.

A new mystery I obtained from the Academy's public library.

The ability of this mystery allowed the user to temporarily manifest the abilities of the target's soul, enabling them to wield their powers for a short period of time.

In other words, if I could accept Igral's soul within the core of the World Tree, I would be able to borrow and use his abilities as the greatest warrior of the Great Forest.

Soul Convergence.

As soon as I used the mystery, I could feel the presence of a soul within the core of the World Tree expanding greatly.

Swoosh.

Soon, a translucent figure that flowed out of the core took on a vague form.

A humanoid with a face very similar to the Mad King looked down at me with tranquil eyes.

I stood still, momentarily speechless.

“Seventh Lord! What are you planning to do?”

It seemed that the Mag King couldn’t see Igrael’s soul in front of me at the moment.

It wasn’t a physical form, just an image in my mind, visible only to me.

However, perhaps sensing something, the Mad King rushed towards me once again.

She seemed to think I was about to do something with the World Tree’s core.

While blocking Mad King’s sword with a floating veil, I engaged in conversation with Igrael’s soul.

I needed the permission of the target soul to use Soul Convergence.

“Igrael, the forest you once protected is facing another crisis of destruction. The resurrected Fogwigg will devour the World Tree and absorb the vitality of the Great Forest.”

He continued to gaze at me silently.

“We don’t have much time. Please lend me your strength. Fogwigg is weaker than during the Great War. If we combine our powers, we might be able to stop it.”

At that moment, Igrael’s soul turned its gaze towards the Mad King, who was striking the barrier with a sword.

It seemed like a bitter smile appeared on his lips for a brief moment. And...

Saaaah!

Igrel's soul became even more vivid and began to flow into my body.

I felt as if I was withstanding a massive storm throughout my entire being.

My body contorted, and my consciousness was in turmoil.

The power overflowed to the point of an imminent explosion, yet I could sense that my body was undergoing a transformation.

In that moment, I was harmonizing with Igrel.

Kwoong!

Eventually, the harmonization came to an end, and I looked down at my hands.

They were no longer my usual hands, but tough, muscular ones.

The same applied to my body.

Even my flowing, elongated bangs had turned red.

I took a deep breath and exhaled, raising my head.

With a slightly heightened field of vision, I absentmindedly gazed in the direction where the Mad King was.

“...Igrel?”

She murmured absentmindedly, her voice trailing off.

Since there was no mirror, I couldn't see my face, but I realized that my current appearance resembled Igrel's when he was alive.

So this is what it's like.

Whatever it was, I succeeded in harnessing Igrel's power.

Now, before the duration expired, I must quickly defeat Fogwigg.

Kwaang!

I unleashed the overflowing power throughout my body and swiftly moved forward.

Ignoring the Mad King, I rushed through the passage and escaped beyond the World Tree.

I sprinted in the direction where Fogwigg was.

It's fast.

Igrel's full-powered speed was much faster than riding a wyvern.

Although such a drastic physical transformation would normally be challenging to adapt to, it posed no problem for me.

At present, I not only obtained Igrel's physical strength, but also assimilated his consciousness.

That's why I instinctively knew how to handle and control this immense power.

In an instant, I reached the location where Fogwig was without stopping and charged towards it

Despite the continuous onslaught from the beastmen and elves, I boldly charged at the relentless creature that refused to yield. With unwavering determination, I delivered a powerful punch directly at it.

Kwaaaang!

A deafening boom erupted from a simple strike, causing Fogwigg's body to tremble violently.

The creature ceased its movement once again.

As I landed on the ground, beastmen and elves gazed at me with astonishment.

I shouted at them.

“I am the Seventh Lord! I temporarily borrowed Igrel’s power, which was dormant in the core of the World Tree! Since the time to maintain this power is limited, everyone, prepare for our final assault!”

I instinctively knew that there were only five minutes left before the effect of Soul Convergence would end.

It was a waste of time to explain what had happened.

Upon my shout, the beastmen and elves immediately prepared for an attack.

“Now is the time to stop that creature! Squeeze out your last remaining strength, everyone!”

And so, the final assault toward Fogwigg commenced.

If this failed, it would truly be the end, but I had a feeling that it wouldn’t fail at all.

Kuuuuuu!

The spirits exploited Fogwig’s weakness.

Then the beastmen unleashed their sword strikes.

“Seventh Lord!”

The Elven Chieftain shouted.

The Great Wind spirit wrapped itself around me.

Once again, Fogwigg's weakness was pierced, and I leapt into it for the last time.

One chance.

This opportunity would only come once. It must be finished with a single strike.

Following my instincts and guided by Igrél's soul, I thrust out my fist.

This was Igrél's technique. A killing blow that compressed the power of the entire body into a single point.

...Quaaaang!

As my fist struck, a bloody aura exploded, and Fogwigg's body split apart like the sea being cleaved.

And then he was finally revealed.

The Emperor's body, buried inside the mass. My strength drained from my body, but I managed to squeeze out the last of it and reach him.

However...

Gruuuuuuh!

It seemed to be a final desperate act as clusters of Fogwigg exploded in all directions and were fired at me simultaneously.

With a level of destruction incomparable to anything before. The remaining elves and beastmen, who still had some strength left, attempted to assist me, but they were outnumbered.

No, this wouldn't work. If we provided an opening while defending, Fogwigg would only regenerate in an instant.

In a moment of hesitation, while considering whether I should risk my life and dig into the Emperor's main body, someone swooped in and swiftly

annihilated the remaining clusters.

Mad King. It was she who had suddenly caught up and intercepted the attack.

This is enough!

And so, without any hindrance, I was able to rush in the place where the Emperor's body was.

Then, once again, the surrounding clusters gathered and attacked me.

I was buried in the mass, but my floating veil bought me time.

Enough of this, Emperor.

His body was just within reach.

The floating veil gave me time to recover my strength for the final blow.

And...

Thud!

I tore through the clusters blocking my path and was able to face the Emperor's body.

The Emperor was a horrifying sight.

His skin was sickly pale, his eyes covered only with white sclera, and his body adorned with magical stones, like runic inscriptions.

Among them, there was a particularly striking gem of pure white color, and upon seeing it, I narrowed my eyes. Could it be?

“...Human.”

At that moment, I heard the Emperor murmur.

Though his appearance had turned monstrous, there seemed to be remnants of his former humanity in his voice.

“I exist for the sake of humanity.”

“Your dream was a delusional dream. Just die already.”

I placed my hand on his head and activated the instant kill.

As the emperor’s breath was cut off, the surrounding masses began to tremble and crack.

Kugugugugu.

Soon, all the masses disappeared, and I fell to the ground along with the Emperor’s corpse.

Looking around, I saw that the elves and beastmen were all staring blankly in my direction.

Wowww!

And then a scream resounded.

In the end, I had blocked Fogwigg and protected the Great Forest. I sighed and looked at the Emperor’s corpse beside me.

I found the pure white gem I had seen earlier and picked it up, holding onto it.

Anyway, was everything finally over with this?

The duration of Soul Convergence was almost over, and I could feel Igrel’s power fading away.

Struggling to rise with my sore body, someone rushed towards me.

Kwaaang!

I blocked the fist flying towards my face and took a few steps back.

“What are you doing, Mad King?”

The person who suddenly attacked me was the Mad King.

She had an excited expression on her face, as if she was enjoying herself, and she charged at me again.

“Let’s play! Igrel!”

Chapter 168: Mad King, Ignel

Chapter 168: Mad King, Ignel

“Ignel, why are you so eager to die today?”

Ignel said to Ignel with a sigh.

Unlike her, who looked like she had rolled around on the ground a few times, Ignel hadn't even broken a sweat.

Ignel glared at him with a grumpy face, then jumped to her feet and lunged at him.

He dodged a light punch, then he caught her by the back of the head, slamming her to the ground once more.

“Your attacks are still so obvious. Try fighting while guessing your opponent's thoughts.”

“Shit—“

“Enough of this. Let's go. Mr. Vick's been hunting red-horned buffalo for a while, and if we stay late, there won't be any tasty cuts left.”

As Ignel removed his hand from her shoulder, Ignel swiftly got up and grabbed his hair.

The two wrestled on the ground for a moment.

“You've got to be kidding me!”

Refusing to let go, she held onto his hair persistently until Igrel kicked her away.

Grumbling, Ignel got up again without getting discouraged and rushed at him once more, laughing when she saw Igrel's disheveled hair.

"Look at you! Pfhaha!"

"Are you having fun?"

Igrel swept his hair aside and looked at her with pity.

Then, at the sound of Ignel's refreshing laughter, he couldn't help but smile, too.

"Oh, shit. My whole body aches from laughing. I'm so beat up."

Igrel slumped to the ground, exhausted. Igrel crouched down next to him.

"With this, it's 305 wins for me and 305 losses for you. When will you win once?"

"Shut up. You were born with the 'Spirit of Sacrifice'. That's why you're so strong."

"When will you stop believing in such superstitions?"

Igrel, who had been staring blankly at the sky, asked.

"Hey, Igrel. What did the chieftain tell you when you were summoned yesterday?"

"It was nothing special."

"You may be able to deceive others, but you can never deceive me. Who do you think I am?"

Facing Ignel's intense gaze, Igrel smiled as if he couldn't resist and replied.

“Ah, okay. I understand. You probably have already guessed, anyway. He told me that he’s almost decided to pass on the next chieftain position to me.”

“Hmm...”

“Such a dull reaction. Your brother could become the leader of all the warriors in the tribe, you know.”

Even as he said that, Igrel couldn’t help but wonder why she was reacting that way.

Since she was young, Igrel had a stronger competitive spirit than anyone else in the tribe.

Although she hadn’t said it aloud since her brother was right there beside her, it was hard to believe she had no interest in the position of the chieftain. After all, the chieftain was the most powerful warrior among all the members of the tribe.

Igrel snorted.

“Don’t get ahead of yourself, Igrel.”

“Huh?”

“Chieftain? I’m not interested in such a position. Even if you become the chieftain, I’ll become the strongest warrior in the tribe someday.”

Igrel let out a small gasp.

“Is that possible? While you become stronger, I won’t be just idling around.”

“Of course. Then you have my word: When I am one day the strongest warrior in the Great Forest, I will be your older sister. Don’t be a jerk and treat me like an older sister.”

Igrel made a bewildered expression at her unexpected words.

If we were to insist on ranking their relationship, Igrel was born a few minutes earlier than Ignel.

Of course, Ignel had never treated him as an older brother before.

“If you can’t keep your promise, what will you do?”

“Huh? There’s no need for that. The deadline is until I die.”

“You’re just going to do whatever you want, anyway.”

Igrel clicked his tongue, but eventually nodded.

“Very well. Here’s the deal. I will be chieftain, and you, Ignel, will one day be the strongest warrior in the Great Forest.”

The two siblings locked eyes and chuckled.

Bang! Roar!

A deafening noise echoed each time I blocked the fists flying at me.

I stumbled backwards, parrying or knocking away the fists of the Mad King as they flew at me without pause.

Had it been my own body, not Igrel’s, I would have been crushed to the bone already.

Has this person gone crazy?

The Mad King attacked me like a rampaging monster.

With the power of the original Igrel, I could have easily subdued her, but I couldn’t do it now.

The duration of the mystery was nearly at its end, and my strength had been greatly depleted from the attack that had knocked down the Fogwigg

earlier.

...More than anything, what made me flustered was my current mental state.

There was no reason for me to face the Mad King barehanded.

I could evade it like before, using space leaps or blocking with the floating veil.

So why was I doing this?

The emotions I felt right now were not confusion or bewilderment, but rather excitement and a sense of thrill.

Every time I blocked with my fist, the shock ringing through my body felt refreshing.

Not just standing there to block, I wanted to counterattack immediately and smash that arrogant face.

And then I realized it. It wasn't me; it was Igrel.

The soul of Igrel, fused with my consciousness, wanted to fight her one last time before completely vanishing.

"Igrel, what are you doing?"

At that moment, the attacks from the Mad King ceased for a moment.

Other beastmen, including the chieftain, stood in front of the Mad King to protect me.

"Get lost, you old ones! Don't interfere!"

I observed the scene and spoke up.

"It's alright, everyone step aside. Don't stop her."

The beastmen who turned their gaze towards me wore puzzled expressions.

After a hard-fought battle, they probably wondered what was going on again.

However, the chieftain seemed to sense the atmosphere between the Mad King and me and willingly stepped back.

“Everyone, move aside.”

Thus, the interference vanished.

I faced the Mad King, who was breathing heavily as if she could rush at me any moment, and stretched out my hand.

“Come at me with all you’ve got.”

Thanks to Igrel’s power, I was able to bring down Fogwigg.

If this was his last wish, I would grant it.

At my words, the Mad King charged, laughing like a maniac.

“That’s how it should be!”

Kwaaang!

In an instant, the Mad King, who came close enough for her fist to reach my nose, attacked.

I returned the favor with a fist of my own.

A heavy shock ran down my arm.

The Mad King bent her arm and took another step inward.

At the same time, a hand came flying from the side, open-palmed rather than in a fist.

I lifted my elbow to fend off the hand that was blatantly trying to grab my collar.

As both of her attacks were thwarted, she followed up with a swinging punch, and I leaned back, raising my knee.

Blood splattered into the air.

A barely missed blow grazed the tip of my chin, and I stepped back and shook my head.

All this happened in the blink of an eye, a single exchange of blows.

Wiping the blood off my chin, I faced her again as she launched another attack.

This time, it was head-on, but her movements were more intricate.

Feinting like a pro, her hands and feet followed paths that confused my vision during the attack.

Her extraordinary body defied the conventional laws of physics with ease.

Even in what seemed like a simple punch, there were countless intricacies.

The exchange continued.

Thud!

Our fists collided, hitting each other's faces.

Both Ignel and I quickly turned our heads and clashed again.

Chasing her attacks with my eyes, I boldly retaliated.

I blocked, evaded, and intentionally allowed her to hit me so I could return it with a bigger counterattack.

A low kick aimed at my calves, and I retaliated with the same move on her other leg.

Next, she aimed for my chest with her fist, and I returned the favor by landing a punch in her abdomen, twisting my body to do so.

“*Kihak...!*”

The Mad King emitted an eerie noise, somewhere between a gasp and a laugh, and then slammed into me, knocking me back.

With another burst of acceleration, the Mad King attempted to attack again, but I stepped back, anchored my center, and grabbed her.

Then I lifted her up and threw her.

She smashed through several trees in her path before coming to a screeching halt against a rock.

“Ha! Huhak!”

This time, it was clearly a laughing sound.

Mad King burst into laughter, pushed the fallen rubble off her body, and got up.

I spat out the blood that had pooled in my mouth and turned my stiff neck.

Though our physical abilities were similar at the moment, Igrel surpassed the Mad King in the sense of combat and every other aspect.

But that wasn't the point.

This wasn't a fight to win.

30 seconds.

Now, there were roughly 30 seconds left. Would it be enough?

Such thoughts disappeared quickly amidst the thrill of battle.

Neither I nor the Mad King stepped back or created distance.

It was as if we were fighting surrounded by cliffs on all sides, only engaging in close combat where our arms could reach each other.

A battle of pure physical strength with no weapons, magic, or abilities.

Of course, I didn't use any of my mysteries either.

While fighting, at some point, the Mad King's appearance seemed to overlap with that of another figure, becoming blurry.

I realized that it was the younger version of the Mad King.

It's Igrel's memory.

The fist flying toward my face changed course midway.

I snatched the frantic hand that tried to hold my neck, and kicked her in the stomach once more, muttering to myself.

"It's so obvious what you intend to do."

The Mad King laughed loudly.

"Then how about this? Is it any good?"

Mad King lowered her posture and aimed for my lower body as if tackling.

As I tried to block her by pushing against her forehead, the Mad King suddenly lifted her head, opened her mouth wide, and bit into my wrist.

I swung my arm and slammed her down on the opposite ground.

Kwaaang!

The Mad King groaned as she was pinned to the shattered ground.

Then she staggered and got up immediately.

She had an endless amount of stamina.

10 seconds.

Now there's only that much time left.

If that time passed, the power of Igrael embedded in my body would cleanly vanish along with his soul.

I gathered up the last remaining strength.

Crimson mana enveloped my whole body.

Mad King, who had been standing still, also raised the corners of her mouth and gathered her mana.

As if sensing that this was the end, she assumed a stance and slowly extended her fist.

“Come at me with all your might. It doesn't matter if I die.”

And then, both I and the Mad King leaped at each other simultaneously.

Our fists collided, and our powers clashed.

Then a massive explosion engulfed the area.

“.....”

My vision returned to normal, and I withdrew my fist.

There was no strength in my body as it returned to its original state with the final blow.

Igrael's soul had completely vanished with this.

I stared at the Mad King as she bounced off into the distance, feeling drained and ready to collapse at any moment.

In the final moment, I had no choice but to spread my barrier to protect myself.

I attacked with the thought that it wouldn't matter if the Mad King died.

But just as my power was about to overwhelm her and sweep her away, Igrel withdrew his power.

The forest fell silent.

Even the beastmen and elves who had been watching the battle from a distance did not utter a word.

I approached the fallen Igrel to check her condition.

Not long after, Igrel, who had opened her eyes, looked up at me.

“.....You're the Seventh Lord.”

Having confirmed that she was alive, I sat down beside her without saying a word.

I could barely stand anymore. As she lay there, she asked me.

“What did you do with the core of the World Tree?”

I answered obediently.

“It's my ability. I accepted Igrel's soul and borrowed his power for a moment.”

“What happened to Igrel's soul?”

“It completely disappeared as the price for the ability.”

I spoke like that and subtly observed the demeanor of the Mad King.

It was hard to anticipate what reaction she would show.

Fortunately, the Mad King didn't reveal any enmity or hostility towards me.

Instead, she seemed rather satisfied.

“Seventh Lord.”

After a brief silence, the Mad King spoke.

“Thank you.”

I turned to look at her and then turned my head away.

The sun was already rising over the ruined forest.

Chapter 169: Raid (1)

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The Bayonte Territory in Santea, the city where the capital of Herwyn was located. As usual, there was a busy crowd in front of the city's gate, and the inspection was in full swing.

“Show your passes or any identification.”

New recruit guard, Puls, was conducting a thorough inspection.

Senior guard, Seld, watched him and rolled his eyes.

“Hey, ease up a bit and do it moderately. If you keep going like this, you won't last long in this business.”

“Ah, yes! I understand!”

“What do you understand? Kid, you still have a lot to learn. But compared to the clueless ones, you're much better, so learn some tricks in that state.”

This time, a carriage approached the gate without waiting in line. It was clearly not an ordinary cargo carriage; at a glance, it was a noble's carriage.

Seld stepped forward instead of the tense Puls.

“Excuse me. Can you please state your identity?”

“This is the carriage of House Wombel, rulers of the northern realm of Radrico! Your honor is on board. Please allow them to pass.”

Seld checked the pass handed over by the coachman and nodded with a smiling face.

“My apologies. Please proceed.”

As Puls watched the back of the carriage pass through the gates, Seld smirked.

“I thought it’s not a noble. Unfortunate, isn’t it?”

“Excuse me? Oh, no, not at all.”

“Sometimes, those mediocre merchant kids who think they’ll be treated like nobles ignore the line and come through. You can treat them without mercy. If they act too high and mighty, just throw all their luggage out the window in the cargo carriage. It’s the fun you can have while being on guard duty.”

At that moment, there was a commotion in the line.

“Hey, you guys! What’s the matter? Can’t you see the line here?!”

People standing in line heard shouting. Seld turned his gaze, assessed the situation, and furrowed his brow.

A group of people were blatantly ignoring the line and approaching the gate. They were wearing reversed robes.

“Hey! Stop right there. You need to follow the order. What are you doing?”

Despite Seld’s warning, they didn’t even acknowledge it and kept walking.

Seld momentarily wondered if they were nobles, but their demeanor and atmosphere didn’t seem like it at all.

Were they just crazy people?

“Hey, new guy. Pick up your spear.”

“Yes, yes!”

Seld held the spear out to them as they approached.

“I told you to follow the order—“

Snap!

Blood splattered as Seld’s body was split in half.

Puls, standing nearby, froze for a moment, then felt the warm blood on his face and screamed.

“Ah, aaah!”

The scream was short-lived, and Puls’ head fell to the ground.

The area in front of the gate turned into chaos in an instant.

People who had been standing in line scattered, screaming.

“What, what’s going on with that guy?!”

Soldiers on the city walls hurriedly prepared for an attack, aiming their drawn bows and casting spells.

“Shoot! Shoot them down now!”

The captain of the guard shouted in anger.

At the same time, a barrage of arrows and magical attacks poured toward the figures in robes.

The soldiers’ response was swift, but it didn’t hold any meaning at all.

One of the robed figures raised their hand in the air, and as they waved it, a gray light flashed, causing all the arrows and spells that were flying towards them to vanish instantly.

Thud...

At the same time, the forces on the castle walls also turned into piles of ashes in an instant. The ashes cascaded down the walls.

The robed being turned their gaze towards the fleeing people and gestured again.

They, too, were scattered into ashes like the soldiers before them.

“So weak. Utterly weak.”

The robed figure, who had reduced all the surrounding humans to dust, lowered the hood of their robe.

His face was deathly pale, and he had four eyes. He was clearly not human.

“How amusing. To be defeated by such weaklings and to think we’ve been cowering in Altelore for so long.”

The creature, a demon, laughed, spreading his arms wide.

“It’s been a long time since I set foot on Santea’s soil. Slay everything in sight.”

After Ran left Herwyn’s castle in a hurry, Kaen, Rigon, and Lea .

“Lea, can we pick and eat the fruits from that tree over there?”

“You fool, can’t you see they’re not fully ripe? If you’re curious how sour they are, go ahead and try.”

The three of them were strolling through the castle’s inner garden.

Lea clicked her tongue in frustration as she watched Kaen climb up a tree and frown at the unripe fruit.

“Why does she always do that?”

“She’s just very curious. It’s easier to just go along with her.”

Rigon took a seat under the shade of the tree Kaen had climbed and sat down.

Lea, after leaning against the tree, looked at the dozing Rigon for a moment before taking a seat beside him.

“Living in the castle for a week? How is it? Is there anything uncomfortable?”

“Oh? Of course not. We’re having a blast, enjoying the sumptuous feasts, and having fun every day.”

“Well then, that’s good to hear.”

As a cool breeze blew by, it gently swayed the hair of Rigon and Lea.

They sat side by side, watching Kaen sift through the branches above.

“How about you, Lea? It’s good that I’m not the only one you brought along, right?”

“Ran is not here, though.”

“Haha, well, it’s much more enjoyable with more people, isn’t it?”

Lea didn’t respond, but she didn’t deny it either. Seeing her like that, Rigon also smiled.

“Hey, guys! I finally found some well-ripened fruits here! Have a taste!”

Kaen took a big bite of the fruit and dropped it down. Rigon caught it, took a bite, ate it, and held it out to Lea.

“It’s delicious. You should try it too.”

Lea hesitated for a moment, then accepted the fruit and took a small bite.

In the short time she'd been with them, she'd experienced things that were new to her.

Inviting friends over to her home, showing them around the castle and introducing everything one by one, enjoying festivals in the city together, and sharing a single piece of fruit without hesitation.

It's fun.

It was all strangely uplifting and joyful.

Lea no longer tried to deceive herself. Making friends wasn't such a frightening thing after all.

Being together was enjoyable. Looking back, the time spent avoiding and pushing others away felt foolish. Why did she do that?

If only she had become friends with these people a little earlier...

Kwaah-aang!

At that moment, a massive explosion resounded. The gazes of Rigon, Lea, and Kaen all turned simultaneously towards the source of the sound, which came from outside the castle.

"...What was that explosion just now? What's going on?"

The three quickly rushed inside the castle. For some reason, the troops inside the castle were bustling about. Even the knights were fully armed.

"Miss!"

Yuz, who they met in the first-floor hall, urgently called out to Lea. She asked him, "Yuz, what's happening? What's going on?"

"It seems like the city is under attack. We haven't fully grasped the details yet."

"What? Who dares to—"

At that moment, another deafening noise echoed, but this time it came from inside the castle.

Sounds of battle came from the entrance of the castle. Followed by terrible screams. Herwyn's homeland was facing an unprecedented crisis.

There was no time to question who or how. Yuzu led Lea away with a grave expression.

"I will escort you, miss. Please, hurry...!"

Kwaaaaaang!

The entrance gate exploded, and the shockwave blew away those nearby.

The intruder that broke through the gates was a monster with a human body and a snake head.

The creature flung a knight's head out of his hands.

Recognizing that it was the neck of the Knight Commander, Rowald, Yuz couldn't help but let out a gasp.

The monster looked around with its tongue flickering.

"You insects gathered nicely. Die, all of you."

Demon.

Yuz, Kaen, Rigon, and Lea immediately recognized that it was a demon.

It emitted a peculiar and eerie energy, just like the demon they encountered before.

"Kill him!"

The knights and mages who were in the hall immediately launched their attack.

But the demon stalked through the hall at breakneck speed, slaughtering knights and mages with ease.

The scales covering the demon's bodies seemed impervious even to the lethal magic of the high-ranking mages.

"Yuz, quickly take Lady Leia and escape through the back door!"

In the meantime, the head mage of the Herwyn family, who had led more high-ranking mages to join the battle, shouted to Yuz.

The mages in formation began unleashing their magic toward the demons with determination. The air trembled with explosive sounds and flashes of light.

"Miss, hurry! We must escape through the back door!"

"But...!"

Kwaaang!

Yuz, who was about to take Lea, Rigon, and Kaen with him to escape, immediately doubted his eyes.

The mages were all blasted in one fell swoop by the aura that the demon had unleashed in all directions.

Though the head mage managed to survive for a short moment, he was soon captured by the demon and torn in half.

The power of the Herwyn family's top mages was like nothing, unable to buy even a brief moment of time. Was this even possible?

The strength of the snake-headed demon was truly overwhelming.

With the current forces present in the castle, it seemed impossible to stop that monster even if they evacuated everyone to the stronghold.

"Please, miss, move. Quickly."

Yuz said so and drew his sword. At the same time, the demon approached Yuz like a lightning bolt and struck him with its tail.

Yuz couldn't even respond properly before being hit and slammed into the wall.

“No! Yuz!”

Lea unleashed her magic, and Rigon and Kaen drew their swords. But their actions didn't matter.

It was the moment when the demon swung his hand like chasing away a bug, intending to slaughter them...

Kwaaaah!

A pure white sword energy flew out of nowhere and cut the demon's arm in half.

“Aaaahhh—!”

The demon who was hit for the first time let out a scream filled with pain and retreated.

Outside the castle, a figure dashed in. Witnessing the scene, Rigon shouted involuntarily, “Asher!”

The intruder was none other than Asher.

With her entire body already clad in a pale white hue, Asher relentlessly attacked the demon without giving him any respite.

Her fierce sword strikes tore through the demon's scales and flesh.

Though the demon held on for a while, facing a disadvantage because of the surprise attack earlier, his neck was soon severed in the blink of an eye.

Thud.

The demon, without a head, collapsed to the ground.

After retrieving her sword, Asher approached the three people standing there in a daze.

She confirmed that Kaen, the heir, was unharmed, feeling relieved inside.

“How did Asher end up here...?”

“Explanations can wait, Rigon. For now, follow me. Both of you.”

It was crucial to move quickly to a safe place at this moment.

After all, the city was under attack by demons.

However, at that very moment...

“...!”

An eerie aura that sent chills down her spine. Asher whipped her head toward the collapsed entrance.

She couldn't feel any presence at all. There was another demon standing there before she knew it. However, the other was incomparable to the one she had just killed. An incredibly powerful monster.

“You're a bit of a competent bug. The one who killed my men outside must be you.”

A pale-skinned demon with four eyes spoke up.

Asher immediately sensed his identity.

A demon with such a powerful aura could only be an archdemon.

Eighth in the Demon Hierarchy, Oxytodus.

An irresistible calamity had descended before them.

Chapter 170: Raid (2)

Chapter 170: Raid (2)

Clang!

With the last of the demons slain in one fell swoop, Aindel sheathed her Holy Sword.

Half the city lay in ruins, and she gazed upon the scattered bodies of people with a sorrowful expression.

The Academy building was also in a state of collapse due to the demons' attack, and the corpses of students were scattered among the rubble.

Aindel stopped her recovery abruptly and left the Holy City because she sensed an anomaly.

And as she had felt, the outside world was already engulfed in a terrible catastrophe.

Despite her quick arrival, numerous people had already perished.

A simultaneous invasion of demons. With only a handful of powerful forces, including the archdemons, they swept across Santea.

Starting from the capital and moving through the closest regions, Aindel had arrived here immediately, but...

She's gone.

No matter how hard she searched, she couldn't sense Kaen's presence.

Not on the Academy grounds, not at her home in the city.

Moreover, if the Seventh Lord, who should have been by Kaen's side at all times, had been here in the first place, he could not have stood idly by while this disaster occurred.

If the Seventh Lord, who should always be by Kaen's side, wasn't in the city, that meant Kaen wasn't either.

So, where could they be now?

“...”

Aindel turned, about to move to save those who were most in need, but when she turned her head, she saw the head of the archdemon she had just killed. It was rolling on the ground and had its eyes turned pitch-black while its mouth started moving.

– You have indeed grown weaker, hero.

Aindel narrowed her eyes. It was not the demon she killed who was speaking now, but another demon who had borrowed its body.

The leader of the demons who had organized this raid from beyond Altelore.

“Azekel”

The demon's head chuckled.

– It's not long now. The day of his resurrection is approaching. You should wait for that day.

Leaving only those words behind, the demon's head turned into ashes.

Aindel stared at the spot where the head disappeared with a stern expression, then moved her body.

Where are you, Kaen, Seventh Lord?

After the situation was settled, I planned to hurry back to where Kaen was.

It wasn't like something was going to happen, but it was not ideal to be far away from Kaen for an extended period.

After my tired body had somewhat recovered from the battle, around the time the sun rose to its zenith, I bid a brief farewell to the chieftains of Adessa.

"We truly received a great help. I will definitely repay the debt of saving Adessa, Seventh Lord."

After thanking me, the chieftain of the beastmen shifted his gaze to the Mad King.

"Well, why are you staring at me?"

"I believe we'll have a proper conversation again someday, Ignel."

At those words, the Mad King snorted.

"There's nothing left here to hold me back. I won't see your faces again."

The chieftain just clicked his tongue and didn't say anything more. After bidding farewell to them, I prepared to leave.

The Chief of Staff and Thunder Lord would be returning soon, so I would only accompany them as far as the Great Forest.

"Seventh Lord, are you going to Enrock?"

At that moment, the Mad King approached and spoke to me.

I replied briefly.

"No."

“Then where are you going?”

“Why do you care? Mind your own business.”

“Ha, don’t be a jerk. I’m just asking.”

The Mad King chuckled and shrugged her shoulders. I felt a strange change in the Mad King’s attitude towards me.

Could he be showing me some kindness because of what happened with Igrel?

It wasn’t as if I could see into her mind, so I couldn’t tell exactly what had changed in her.

Soon, I took off into the sky on Ti-Yong’s back.

In mid-flight, I felt a surge of magic and reached for the communication tool.

It was a message from Asher. What’s going on?

“.....!”

After checking the contents, I couldn’t help but make a surprised expression.

– The demons have invaded the city. There are three of them, and they are all extremely powerful.

– I don’t know yet if they have an archdemon with them, and I may not be able to reply to you right away, as I’m going into battle from now on. Please hurry back, Sir Ron.

The demons... invaded? In Santea? No, could it be an attack aimed at Kaen?

It made no sense for the demons to know of the Heir’s existence.

But why attack Herwyn's territory? My mind was in turmoil.

...No, it can't be.

I quickly regained my composure. Yes, this might just be that. Demon invasions were an event in the game.

As the Demon King's resurrection approached, they cautiously launched small-scale attacks on various areas of Santea.

The intention was to minimize the uncertainties of the hero coming to Antelore alone, just in case it might happen, and at the same time, to assess the hero's current condition.

The Emperor's plan was also hastened and had now taken place. There was no way to avoid calling it a demon invasion.

Even the hero had said that the Demon King's resurrection was near.

Damn.

I sent a message to Asher, but there was no immediate reply.

What if an archdemon was involved in the forces that attacked the city?

Even thinking about it was dreadful. My heart grew cold.

Right now, I must hurry back to where Kaen was.

But this way was too slow. Even with a Wyvern, it would take well over a day to travel at full speed without stopping.

What should I do? Wasn't there any way?

Racking my brain, one thought flashed through my mind.

“Chief of Staff!”

The Chief of Staff, flying next to me, looked up. I called out to him and dived down. As I hit the ground, the three stopped moving and followed suit.

“What is it, Seventh Lord?”

Their curious gazes gathered on me. I said to the Chief of Staff.

“Is there a teleportation point set up in Santea?”

The Chief of Staff made a strange expression. It was information that passed by like a breeze in the game. I barely recalled it.

Like the underground of the Overlord Castle, the Chief of Staff also had a long-distance teleportation point in Santea.

“Yes, there is.”

“Can we move there right now?”

“It’s possible, but... could you explain what’s going on first?”

As I hesitated for a moment, the Chief of Staff spoke.

“As you know, my teleportation consumes an enormous amount of mana and resources, especially for the distant locations I’ve secretly prepared outside Calderic. Even if it’s a task requested by the Seventh Lord, I’m sorry, but I cannot comply without a convincing reason.”

The Chief of Staff was a direct subordinate to the Overlord. As we didn’t have a superior-subordinate relationship, I didn’t have the authority to give him orders.

Feeling helpless, I briefly explained the reason.

“I just received a message from my subordinate. The demons have launched a sudden attack on Santea.”

Upon hearing this, both the Chief of Staff and the Thunder Lord were taken aback. The Mad King raised an eyebrow.

“Is that true?”

“Yes, and it seems my subordinate, who was executing my orders in Santea, is in danger.”

“Your subordinate, you mean...?”

“The last surviving descendant of the White Moon Tribe.”

Of course, I couldn't mention Kaen in this context, so instead, I created a reason involving Asher.

The Chief of Staff knew how much I valued Asher as my most trusted aide, so there should be no reason for him to object.

“We don't have much time, Chief of Staff. Are you refusing my request?”

I pressured him subtly with a cold tone. Soon, the Chief of Staff shook his head.

“I understand. If the demons have moved, I need to act quickly to assess the situation. Shall we move right now?”

“Yes, we should hurry as much as possible. Exactly where in Santea is the location of the teleportation point?”

“It's near the Kanteber Region, located to the east of Santea.”

Fortunately, if it's to the east of Santea, it's also close to the city of Bayonte.

“Hey, Chief of Staff, I'm going too.”

Suddenly, the Mad King interjected. The Chief of Staff looked surprised as he glanced at her.

“Will the Fifth Lord be accompanying us?”

“Do you have any objections? I’m sure the Seventh Lord is very tired, so I’ll help him out if he needs it.”

The Thunder Lord said after hesitating.

“I will accompany you as well.”

“Huh? Why would you do that?”

“If we’re going to teleport, there’s no reason for me to waste time going back alone.”

I didn’t bother stopping them. It wouldn’t hurt to have additional powerful forces in case we encounter strong enemies.

“Is it possible for us all to move together, Chief of Staff?”

“It would be a close call, but yes, gather around me, everyone.”

I, the Mad King, and Thunder Lord stood by the Chief of Staff’s side.

The wyverns also stayed as close to him as possible.

Rumble!

Soon there was a great surge of magic power, and the surrounding space warped with blue light.

Asher narrowed her eyes and focused his mind. The opponent was an archdemon. She wouldn’t be able to defeat him with her own power.

We have to escape.

Even if she was to die here, she had to ensure the heir would survive. It was an order from Sir Ron.

So, what she needed to do right now was clear.

“While I deal with this guy, all of you run away.”

Upon hearing Asher’s words, three people—Kaen, Rigon, and Lea—snapped back to their senses.

“Run away? That’s impossible, isn’t it?”

The archdemon, Oxytodus, sneered and raised his hand.

Then, a massive, hemispherical barrier rose around them, turning all obstacles into ashes.

Kwaaang!

Before the barrier could fully form, Asher hurriedly threw her sword energy at it, but it dissipated without dealing a single blow.

All escape routes were blocked. But Asher still moved quickly.

With all her strength, she rushed toward Oxytodus.

Oxytodus, who had been staring at Rigon with interest for some reason, shifted his gaze.

“But you really look like a White Moon tribe member, don’t you?”

Oxytodus stood still, merely waving his hand to effortlessly block Asher’s attacks.

“I heard you’re one of the top aides of Calderic’s Seventh Lord? Why would a Calderic knight be in Santea?”

Asher wasn’t surprised that her identity had been quickly exposed.

Even the demons of Altelore were not oblivious to events in the outside world.

The fact that a top aide of the Seventh Lord was a survivor of the White Moon tribe had already become well known, making it easy to deduce.

Asher solely focused on her attacks.

She tried to find the slightest opening, searching for a chance to strike, but it was futile.

The gap in power between them was enormous.

As Oxytodus counterattacked, Asher couldn't withstand it and was sent flying, blood splattering as she crashed to the ground.

Witnessing that scene, Kaen clenched her sword and desperately prayed inside.

Please, please!

Golden sword energy. If only she could use that unknown power once more.

However, no matter how desperate her wish was, her sword didn't turn golden again.

Oxytodus' gaze returned to Rigon.

“Hey, young human. Yes, I'm talking to you.”

Rigon, with a mix of despair on his face, looked at him.

“I have a proposal for you. Make a contract with me and accept my power. And obey me.”

“...What are you talking about?”

“I can sense potential in you. You can accept my power quite well. You can become much stronger than these pathetic worms. Even this one.”

Oxytodus gestured towards the decapitated snake-headed demon's corpse. Rigon stammered, trying to speak.

“I can't... accept something like that.”

Oxytodus raised the corner of his mouth.

“If you accept the offer, I’ll spare one person among the humans here, excluding you. What do you say?”

The devil’s whisper shook Rigon’s gaze. Lea clenched her lips, blocking the way in front of Rigon, and shouted.

“Never accept it, Rigon! Never...”

Swoosh. A sharp sound echoed.

Lea felt her consciousness fading and lowered her head. There was a hole in her chest.

“Ah...”

Her body turned to ashes and disappeared in an instant.

Rigon remained staring at the empty space, stunned, then collapsed to his knees.

“Wh-what...?”

Kaen also watched the scene in a daze.

Lea was dead. The process was so empty and unrealistic that she could only freeze in place.

“Now there are two left. Choose. Whether to save one of them or let them all die.”

Oxytodus’ voice snapped them back to reality. Kaen trembled and rushed towards him.

“Yo-you bastard!”

Roaring, Kaen charged at Oxytodes, who waved his hand in response.

At the same time, Asher leapt in, wrapping her arms around Kaen and rolling on the ground. It was a close call.

Half of Asher's face crumbled into ash from the attack, exposing every muscle.

"Ugh..."

Oxytodus reached out his hand toward Asher again. Rigon shouted.

"No! Please!"

"Well, make your choice. Next, it's the White Moon's turn. Will you make a contract with me?"

The demon's mockery echoed. An unbearable despair shadowed him.

It was the moment Rigon was about to open his mouth with a miserable face...

Kwoong.

A massive vibration echoed through the barrier.

And the next moment, a blue ray of light flashed across the surface of the barrier.

Kwaah!

A group of people walked through the shattered barrier, and Oxytodus narrowed his eyes at them.

"You are..."

Fifth Lord, Mad King, Second Lord, Thunder Lord, Chief of Staff, and Seventh Lord, Ron.

"Are you the archdemon? You really stirred up the hornet's nest, you demon brat."

The Mad King laughed and drew the greatsword from her back.

The Seventh Lord looked around at the three fallen people.

“Oxytodus.”

He opened his mouth with an icy gaze.

“Die here.”

Chapter 171: Raid (3)

Chapter 171: Raid (3)

...Thank goodness.

That was my first thought as soon as I realized that Asher, Kaen, and Rigon were safe.

After relief, the next emotion I felt was anger.

A demon with four eyes. Among the archdemons, there was only one with such an appearance.

He was probably Oxytodus, ranked 8th among the archdemons.

I teleported next to Asher in an instant. She was lying unconscious, holding Caan in her arms.

Kaen seemed to have lost consciousness, but she didn't appear to be seriously injured.

Asher, on the other hand, seemed to be pretty badly injured, but fortunately, her life didn't seem to be in danger.

“...Sir Ron!”

Asher shouted as she staggered to her feet.

I unfurled my floating veil without looking back at Oxytodus.

But before the veil could intercept the demon's surprise attack, the Thunder Lord shot a lightning wave and blocked it.

“Let’s play!”

The Mad King then leapt in. Oxytodus stiffened and began to deal with the combined forces of the two lords.

“I’m sorry, Asher. You’ve been through a lot.”

“It’s not... your fault. I apologize for showing you such an unsightly sight...”

Blood seemed to have pooled in Asher’s throat as she struggled to speak and choked. The blood stained the ground.

I let out a deep sigh and hugged Asher and Kaen together.

I set them down and walked over to the Chief of Staff, who was watching the battle from a distance.

“Protect my subordinates’ safety during the fight, Chief of Staff.”

“Yes, Seventh Lord.”

And Rigon. Rigon still stood there like a stunned man. As I approached, he looked up and muttered.

“...Seventh Lord.”

“Rigon. Are you injured?”

“No. But... it’s because of me, my friend...”

Friend?

It was only in hindsight that I noticed the scattered ashes in front of Rigon. These were the traces of Oxytodus’ power.

Wait, did that mean Lea...?

“For now, stay back over there. I and the other Lords will deal with him.”

With Rigon off the battlefield, I turned my attention to Oxytodus.

The battle was fierce.

Oxytodus was a Level 95 archdemon, like the Mad King and the Thunder Lord, but even among the same level, there were differences in power.

I remembered that even among level 95s; he had quite a bit of combat power.

Even against the three of us, it won't be easy.

A hail of giant thunderbolts rained down on Oxytodes' head.

He spread a gray aura and annihilated all of it.

At the same time, the Mad King swung her greatsword, seemingly to cut his body in half from the side.

Oxytodus blocked the greatsword with his bare hands, but it seemed to strain him.

Once again, the gray aura surged, covering the Mad King, but she didn't avoid it.

The crimson mana surrounding her body blocked the penetration of the demon's energy.

"Lowly vermin!"

"Vermin? Keep babbling! Before killing you, I'll rip that tongue out!"

Although we had the upper hand, Oxytodus was holding up quite well.

There was no need to drag out the battle. He wasn't putting up any defensive barriers.

While he engaged in battle with the Mad King and the Thunder Lord, I waited for him to reveal a significant opening.

And the moment it did, I leapt through space, shrouded in blood mist. Right next to him.

“.....!”

Oxytodus gasped and suddenly shot his ability towards me.

I erected a floating veil to block the gray mana and instantly teleported again to put some distance between us.

My actions caused confusion and made the three paused their attacks.

“Oxytodus. Why did you attack this city?”

I already had a suspicion, but I still asked him.

He smirked.

“Calderic’s Seventh Lord, do you really need reasons for crushing insects?”

“.....”

“Too bad. I thought I found some interesting prey, but I wasted time on useless pests.”

I did not reply.

“Well then, let’s see this through to the end. Since it turned out this way, even if it takes time, I’ll have to kill all of you before returning...”

“That’s enough.”

I turned my back.

“Just die.”

And as soon as I uttered those words, Oxytodus’ body fall over.

From the moment he was even slightly exposed to the blood mist, he was no longer among the living.

“What, did you kill him?”

With an astonished expression, the Mad King sheathed his sword.

The Thunder Lord and the Chief of Staff looked at his corpse in surprise. I walked towards the collapsed entrance.

Outside, I saw a city in ruins.

The air was thick with blood and ash.

I stared at the scene for a long time, feeling my heart sink.

Although I dealt with another one of the archdemons, that was the only relief amidst this dreadful disaster.

I organized the situation. First, I treated Asher.

Her physical wounds were completely healed with potions, and her internal injuries were also somewhat recovering.

After she regained strength, I asked her to explain exactly what had happened.

From what Oxytodus did to Rigon, to how Lea died.

Listening to the story, even though it had nothing to do with the current situation, a thought suddenly crossed my mind.

Reef and Rigon, the demon that would have corrupted Rigon into ‘Refrigon’ if I hadn’t saved their lives.

Now that I thought about it, Refrigon’s abilities in the game were quite similar to Oxytodus.

Perhaps the demon that gave strength to Rigon in the game was Oxytodus.

Of course, it wasn't essential now.

...More importantly, Lea is gone.

It was a tragic event. If I had been a little faster, maybe I could have prevented her death.

Regretting it now wouldn't make any difference.

Rigon and Kaen both seemed to be deeply affected emotionally.

Kaen had been staring blankly into space without saying a word since a while ago.

“Asher, please take Rigon and return straight to the Lord's Castle.”

For now, I sent Asher and Rigon away.

The Mad King, the Thunder Lord, and the Chief of Staff also left, their tasks finished.

Most of Herwyn's castle and the city had been destroyed, and there was no point in cleaning up the mess.

Lea's brother, Cyan, was alive. He was upstairs in the castle when the incident happened and had barely escaped with his life.

I relayed the situation to him, who had a stunned look on his face, along with several knights and vassals.

“Ah, ah...”

Upon hearing about Lea's death, Cyan remained still, frozen in place.

Instead, the vassals moved to organize the situation.

They, too, had lifeless expressions. I decided to leave immediately.

There was nothing more I could do here.

I stood firmly on one side and approached Kaen, who was looking at the ruined city.

“We’re leaving, Kaen. Let’s move together.”

I knew her, not only as Ran, but as the Seventh Lord as well. When Kaen didn’t answer, I spoke again.

“There’s a possibility that the demons attacked Raphid City. Let’s go quickly.”

“...!”

In the game’s story, Raphid City was one of the areas that demons invaded.

Only then did Kaen react to my words. Her father, Ben, lived there.

“Y-yes, let’s go quickly... Hurry...”

With Kaen in tow, we moved to Raphid City, where the Academy was located. I left Ti-Yong in a nearby forest and proceeded towards the city.

When we arrived, the city was just as I had expected it.

Bodies were scattered on the streets, and soldiers were forming lines to carry the wounded.

...How many people died? How many had perished in this attack?

Seeing Kaen’s face turn pale, I refrained from saying anything.

I couldn’t tell her if her father was alive or not.

Whatever words I would utter, they would be reckless.

On the way to find Kaen’s house, we encountered the hero.

As soon as the hero spotted us, a sense of relief appeared on her face.

It seemed that she had taken care of all the demons that attacked the city.

“Kaen!”

Kaen hurriedly ran towards her.

“Oh, what about Father? Del. Where is Father?”

Seeing Kaen trembling uncontrollably, the hero looked at her with pity and turned her head.

“He’s safe, so don’t worry.”

A man could be seen trudging through the crowd toward them. It was Ben.

“Kaen.”

“...Father!”

Kaen rushed into Ben’s arms and finally burst into tears of sorrow.

The hero and I watched them without saying a word.

“Six areas, including the capital, have been attacked. Their objective is...”

“I suppose figuring out your condition exactly is the most important.”

The hero nodded. I sighed and looked out the window.

Raphid City had suffered relatively less damage because the hero arrived early. Among the attacked areas, it was the least affected.

“The Emperor is dead, Santea is in chaos, and the resurrection of the Demon King is imminent.”

“...”

“Everything is going crazy, warrior. What are your plans for the future?”

While she was in the Holy City, I explained everything that the Emperor had done in the Great Forest.

I felt a sense of gloom that I hadn't felt since I arrived in this world.

The situation was truly hopeless to turn back. And there was still no progress in the succession.

The hero replied with a slightly weary expression.

“Seventh Lord.”

“Speak.”

“While I was in the Holy City, there was a change in the Holy Sword. Two of the succession conditions were fulfilled.”

“.....!”

Those words startled me. The succession conditions were fulfilled? Two out of the four?

Ah...!

I immediately realized. At that time, the power of the Holy Sword that Kaen used at the Demon Worshipers' base.

Could it be that Kaen fulfilled the conditions of the succession and momentarily connected with the power of the Holy Sword?

[The sorrow of losing a loved one.]

[The despair of being betrayed by someone you believed in.]

[The ugliness of human greed.]

[The doubt that arises from what is believed to be just.]

Given the situation at the time, Kaen probably fulfilled the third and fourth conditions.

Witnessing the ugliness in human greed and doubting her own sense of justice. And overcoming those things.

I promptly informed the hero about it.

“So, that happened. As you said, Seventh Lord, the conditions fulfilled are those two.”

...In the end, as the Holy Sword said, it wasn't entirely meaningless, was it?

Everything I had done so far. I muttered, feeling a strange sense of relief.

“I guess we're halfway there, then.”

“That seems to be the case...”

The hero's words trailed off. It seemed as though shadows had fallen upon her face.

Without saying anything further, I leaned back in my chair.

Losing someone precious. And being betrayed by someone you trusted.

Now, if those two conditions were fulfilled, Kaen could inherit the Holy Sword.

But how? I couldn't help but think it was cruel all over again.

...Was Lea's death not enough to fulfil the condition?

Apparently, Lea wasn't important enough to Kaen to fulfill the conditions for succession.

Which was natural, since they had only been close for the last month or so.

The depth of friendship didn't always depend on time, but still, it was too short...

...*Shit.*

I felt disgusted with myself for having such thoughts, but I was desperate as well.

The recent attack by the demons made me face reality once again.

The Demon King would soon be resurrected. And if Kaen didn't inherit the Holy Sword, this world would be doomed.

What should I do? What was I supposed to do now?

The [Soul of the King] quickly calmed my confused mind].

I sneered at my own mental state.

Yeah, somehow things would work out.

There's no use panicking alone. I would do what I could for now, as I had always done.

"If you have no other plans, I will continue to take care of Kaen's safety, hero."

"Are you sure about this?"

"You have many things to do."

Amidst the chaos caused by the demon's attack, even the Emperor perished.

The hero had to stabilize the imperial court, which would be the first to fall into chaos.

"If there's any conflict with Adessa, I believe I can somehow help to mediate."

“Thank you, Seventh Lord. It seems I always burden you with my problems.”

With her academy life now over, Kaen would continue living with her father here for a while.

Lost in thought, I spoke to the hero.

“And change me back to Ran’s appearance. It would be more comfortable for Kaen to have Ran by her side rather than the Seventh Lord.”

The situation in Raphid City was starting to recover, as it was semi-blockaded.

During this time, Kaen never once left Ben’s house.

On the third day since the hero’s departure, I decided to stop wandering around her house to watch over her.

Knock, knock.

When I knocked on the front door, Kaen opened it.

Her eyes widened upon seeing me.

“...Ran?”

I offered an awkward smile and waved my hand.

“Hello, Kaen.”

Chapter 172: Kaen (1)

Chapter 172: Kaen (1)

It was a sudden visit, but Kaen welcomed me warmly.

“Come in, Ran. Long time no see.”

Ben, who was drinking tea at the table, was equally welcoming.

“We just finished eating a while ago. Can I make you something to eat?”

“No, thank you. I’m fine.”

“Alright. Then you two chat. I need to take a nap. You can make me something to drink, Kaen.”

Ben picked up his tea and left for the room. Kaen scratched his head and asked me.

“Do you want some tea?”

“No.”

“Okay. Then have some water.”

Kaen and I sat facing each other at the table. She didn’t seem to have changed much from the outside.

“You must have been surprised. The city is a mess, isn’t it? The Academy building collapsed too.”

“Yeah, it’s true.”

“The demons suddenly invaded, and that’s how it turned out.”

“Yes, I heard the story.”

A brief silence fell between us.

Kaen fiddled with the container of tea leaves on the table without saying a word.

Just as I was about to speak, Kaen spoke first.

“Hey, Ran. Leia is dead.”

For a moment, I struggled to figure out how to react and ended up just looking surprised. Kaen continued speaking.

“The demons also attacked the Herwyn Castle. Lea died protecting Rigon.”

“...Are you okay?”

“Me? As you can see, I’m fine. Rigon is safe too, so don’t worry. It seems like he has probably returned to Calderic.”

Kaen let out a sigh.

“So, about Lea...”

“Kaen, you don’t have to say anymore.”

Even without hearing the details, I knew everything that had happened.

But I was more concerned about her mental state. There was no need to keep talking about Lea.

Kaen looked at me hesitantly and asked, “Okay. What about your urgent matter?”

“I handled it well.”

“I see. Um... Do you want another cup?”

I just nodded and picked up my empty mug.

“I’ll have a cup. Do you want me to boil water?”

“No need. I’ll do it, so just wait.”

After that, we didn’t exchange any further words, just sipping our tea in silence.

Normally, there was never a lull in the conversation when I was with Kaen, so the atmosphere felt quite awkward.

As time passed, it was already evening without me noticing. So I had dinner here as well.

After the meal, Kaen said to me, “Ran, you’re not going back right away, are you? Stay for the night.”

“Sure.”

Since I had to stay near Kaen, there was no need to refuse.

I watched her carrying the dishes and going to the back.

Kaen usually didn’t dream much.

But ever since the day he watched Lea die in front of her, she’d had the same dream every night.

She stood alone in the middle of a ruined village.

In front of her were the corpses of people who died horribly. As she looked at them, she found herself crying for some reason.

Then the view changed. Lea, wrapped in flames, turned to ashes and scattered in the wind.

“...!”

Kaen woke up from the dream, breathing heavily. She wiped the sweat from her forehead and got up.

She waited for her pounding heart to calm down for a long time, and eventually, tears streamed down her cheeks.

“Uh, *sob*...”

She finally remembered the things she had forgotten.

A week passed.

Somehow, I ended up staying at Kaen’s house.

Kaen never brought up when I should leave, or rather, it seemed like she deliberately avoided the topic.

Ben didn’t seem to care how long I stayed either, so I stayed.

“Asher.”

As I came out, I met Asher, who had come to Raphid City.

“How’s your body?”

“Yes, I’ve fully recovered.”

“Good to hear. What about Rigon?”

“He’s fine. Reef is taking good care of him.”

I let go of some of the worries that had been accumulating in my heart.

“Take a look at this.”

I pulled an object from my arms and handed it to Asher. A pure white gemstone, taken from the Emperor’s corpse.

Asher took the gem. A puzzled look crossed her face before her eyes widened.

“This, this is...?!”

Her reaction confirmed what I suspected.

The treasure of the White Moon Clan.

One of the reasons the Emperor had attacked the White Moon Clan in the past.

A magic stone that could contain purer magic than any other magic stone, closely resembling their racial trait.

Asher’s mana and aura were similar, so I knew what it was when I found it.

I told Asher the story I wasn’t able to share until now.

What happened in the Adessa Great Forest, what the Emperor did, and how he died.

“The Emperor met his end at my hands, and the Spear Saint met his fate at the hands of the Second Lord.”

“I see.”

“I’m sorry, Asher. It was something you should have dealt with personally someday.”

Asher lowered her head.

“No, thank you for your concern, and... I think it’s fine if it’s Sir Ron.”

“.....?”

“Oh, it’s nothing.”

What did she mean? Asher feigned a slight cough, carefully putting the magic stone in her bag.

“Thank you for finding the legacy of our clan. I will treasure it dearly.”

“Sure.”

“What are your plans from now on?”

I answered Asher’s question.

“It’s the same as before. I will continue to stand by the heir’s side. I entrust the monarchy to you.”

“Understood.”

Having seen Asher off, I returned to Kaen’s house.

Kaen stood in the front yard, gazing at the trees.

“What are you doing?”

“Hmm? Nothing, really.”

Kaen chuckled bashfully.

“Hey, Ran. I’m bored. Shall we go hunting? I noticed that the security checks aren’t as strict lately.”

“Why suddenly go hunting?”

“Oh, come on, just join me. I’m a complete expert in this field. I’ll teach you well.”

It had only been a few days since her mood seemed to improve.

Soon, Kaen acted as if she had fully regained her usual liveliness.

She engaged in friendly sparring in the courtyard or went out to the forest outside the city for hunting.

We played chess with the old, worn-out chessboard Ben had, or cooked and ate together.

Without realizing it, more than a month passed since we spent time together like this.

During that time, we did various things, so there was no time for boredom.

But I knew.

Kaen hadn't completely escaped from her torment yet.

Almost every night, she seemed to be disturbed in her sleep.

I could sense that with my heightened senses.

She'd wake up breathing hard, wondering if she'd had a nightmare, and sometimes she'd break down in sobs.

"Oh, caught a lot of big ones!"

Kaen shouted, holding up the net she had set up by the riverbank.

"Let's roast a few here and eat before we leave."

"The sun has already set. What about Ben?"

"He'll figure it out on his own. Hurry and gather some firewood."

Kaen, who spoke words of being unfilial, suggested they had dinner without even caring about her father.

In truth, it seemed like she got her personality from Ben, considering how similar they were. They were like two peas in a pod.

“Hey, this is delicious. Look at these fresh fish.”

Kaen tore into the fish with gusto. As I watched the scene, I spoke up.

“Kaen, do you have anything you want to talk about with me?”

“Huh? What’s with the sudden question?”

“I mean, we’re friends. We should be able to confide in each other when things get tough.”

If taking care of Kaen’s mental state was part of my role, then it was my role to do so.

I could tell that the topic I subtly brought up shook her.

“Is it that obvious?”

“A little.”

Kaen swallowed what she was chewing and let out a sigh.

For a moment, only the crackling sound of the bonfire filled the air. Then Kaen spoke up.

“Ran, I think I mentioned this before. I have no memories of my childhood. Remember?”

“Yeah, you did.”

“Lately, I’ve been having frequent nightmares. In the dream, I’m standing alone in a ruined village. All the houses around are destroyed, and people are dead. I’m stuck in that terrible place, unable to move, and then suddenly the scenery changes. It’s the same landscape from when the demon killed Lea.”

“...”

“At first, I thought they were just nightmares. But... it turned out to be more than that. It was my childhood memory.”

Childhood memory? Kaen stopped talking.

“The village of Azeta, on the western edge of Santea, was my original hometown. However, one day, a deranged mage attacked the village. And all the villagers perished—my father and mother too. The one who killed the insane sorcerer and saved me when my life was in danger was my current father.”

Kaen wrapped her arms around her knees and bowed her head deeply.

“...I remembered everything as if I was having a nightmare. My father and mother, who died right in front of me, and Lea’s death kept overlapping in my dreams. I wonder why I had forgotten it all until now.”

I listened attentively to Kaen’s story, unaware of this part of her past.

It was information that had never appeared in the game.

“So, then...”

Ben wasn’t Kaen’s biological father, and he saved and adopted Kaen when she was young.

And due to the shock of losing her family, she experienced memory loss until Lea’s death triggered those memories.

“Ran.”

“Yes.”

“Do you have to go back home soon? Can’t you stay with us longer?”

“...”

“Lea is gone, and Rigon has left. I miss Esca. So please don’t leave too. I don’t want to be lonely again...”

Kaen's voice trembled weakly, tears welling up in her eyes. I said to her.

"Kaen, don't worry and have some fish."

"..."

"I'm not going back home. No, actually, I can't go back. I'm a runaway. If you want me to keep crashing at your place, that's fine by me."

Kaen's eyes widened in surprise.

"What? But you said you had urgent business at home before..."

"That was a lie. It wasn't urgent business at home; it was something else that was urgent."

She looked at me in disbelief. I waved the meat around smugly and took a bite.

"Argh, it's annoying."

Kaen wiped her tears and finished eating the fish with a sniffle.

The subtle shadow that had been lingering on her face seemed to have disappeared completely.

Swoosh!

I put down the axe and looked up at the sky while tidying up the stacked firewood.

It had been snowing heavily since the morning, and the yard was covered in thick layers of snow.

A white breath escaped from my mouth. It had been some years since I arrived in this world, but it was my first time seeing snow.

In short, it was my first snow in this world. It had been nearly half a year since I had decided to stay with Kaen.

During that time, the city had fully recovered from the damage caused by the demons' attack and regained its former vitality.

Kaen no longer had nightmares.

Life just went on as if nothing much had happened.

Thud.

While moving the firewood, I turned my gaze. Kaen was holding a tightly packed snowball and grinning mischievously from a distance.

“Don't do it. It's bothersome.”

“Do it or don't.”

“Don't do it.”

I turned my head to avoid the snowball flying towards my face again. In the end, I threw the firewood aside and balled up some snow in my hands.

As we were having fun throwing snowballs at each other, Ben opened the door and came out. At the same time, a snowball got stuck on his face.

“Ah-ha!”

While watching Kaen wave her arms as if teasing him, Ben rubbed his face and chuckled heartily.

“Daughter, do you want to give it a try?”

The two people's duel, which started like that, was one-sided. Ben's movements weren't particularly fast, either.

However, he miraculously found an opening and hit Kaen's eye.

“Ah, for real!”

Eventually, Kaen, whose rage had risen to the fullest, began using magic, but nothing changed.

Because Ben had absorbed the magic contained in Kaen’s snowball and used the same magic.

I watched that scene with interest.

It’s fascinating.

Ben had an extraordinary ability to use other people’s magic as if it were his own.

Instead, I vaguely heard before that his body was damaged, so he couldn’t accumulate magic himself, but looking at the way he controlled magic, I could guess how skilled he must have been when his body was normal.

I hadn’t specifically asked about Ben’s past, so I didn’t know whether his body was injured to the point of being unable to accumulate magic.

At the end of the intense eye duel, Kaen, who was the only one left in a mess, burst into laughter.

“Father, you want to beat your daughter so badly?”

“Kaen, when did I ever take that into account?”

I smirked and picked up the firewood I had dropped on the ground. As I did, I felt someone’s gaze and glanced outside the house.

After arranging all the firewood, I said to Ben.

“I’m going to go out and get some groceries today.”

“Should I come with you?”

“No need. Just brush the snow off your head.”

Stepping outside, I entered an empty alleyway.

I stood still and waited, but soon someone emerged and approached.

It was the hero.

“It’s been a while, Seventh Lord.”

“Indeed. You’ve come. Why did you call me outside?”

“If I went inside directly, Kaen will cling onto me and won’t let go for even a moment. So, I’ll just visit her separately later.”

The hero said with a faint smile.

“More than that, it seems like you’re getting along well with Kaen.”

I made a slightly troubled expression.

“That’s true.”

On one hand, I thought that I was getting too close to Kaen than necessary.

After all, Ran was just a created figure to stay by her side.

So, even during our time at the academy, I always tried to maintain a certain distance.

But that sense of distance was gradually fading as we lived together.

... Honestly, these days, I felt like I was living comfortably and happily without worrying about anything.

Succession, Holy Sword, and all the conditions for the remaining succession, it was all just frustrating to think about.

I knew very well that time was not infinite.

“What about the imperial family?”

“They have stabilized, so you don’t need to worry.”

I heard that after the Emperor’s death was officially announced, the imperial family smoothly accepted the 1st Prince as the new Emperor without much noise or contention.

It turned out that the Emperor had left a clear will regarding the succession.

Although he had avoided the hero’s retribution under various pretexts, like a mirage, he had apparently taken care of posthumous matters before moving on to finish everything.

“More importantly, how is your physical condition?”

“It has improved a lot. He’s been quiet for a while.”

As I mentioned before, remnants of the Demon King’s power still lingered within the hero’s body.

And the closer it got to resurrection, the more it would react.

If it’s been quiet for a while, did that mean I could stop worrying about the Demon King for the time being—

Ah, shit. This shouldn’t happen. I was being careless again.

I thought this time I would have a proper discussion with the hero about the succession, but I put it off again.

We only exchanged updates about each other and finished our conversation.

“Why though?”

“It’s nothing. I should be going now.”

“Okay. Then I’ll visit your home later.”

We said our goodbyes and were about to part ways.

Swwoooosh.

Feeling a creepy aura from behind, I quickly turned my head.

“K-kuh!”

The hero collapsed, spewing blood.

A sickly aura was emanating from her body like a crimson flame.

The hero summoned the Holy Sword and began to fend off the evil energy with divine power.

After barely suppressing the persistent force, the hero exhaled and struggled to catch her breath.

I was taken aback and asked, “What happened?”

The hero lifted her head, and her eyelids trembled.

“The Demon King... just resurrected a moment ago...”

Chapter 173: Kaen (2)

Chapter 173: Kaen (2)

The ruined central tower of the Demon Castle of Altelore.

It was the site of a great battle in the past, where the hero sealed the Demon King.

For the demons, it was a mark of shame that imprisoned their god for decades.

Half of the Demon King's soul was torn apart by the power of the Holy Sword, and to postpone complete annihilation, the Demon King sealed himself in his final moments.

Like a giant crystal pillar, stretching high into the violet sky, seemingly supporting the world.

Sleeping within it was the incarnation of the demon that was once the terror and fear of all.

“It has been a long time.”

The demon standing before it looked up at the pillar with a trembling voice.

Solemn like a baptized believer, yet innocent like a child opening a gift box.

If someone had seen the eerie expression where two incompatible emotions coexisted directly, they would have been astonished.

The number one among the archdemons, Azekel.

The ruler of the current Altelore who reunited the divided demons with overwhelming power after their defeat.

The demons who witnessed his true power thought there was no need to resurrect the Demon King; they believed he would be enough to ascend to the throne.

The body of the hero, who was severely injured in the battle against the Demon King, was not in its prime.

With Azekel's presence, the current forces without the Demon King would undoubtedly be enough to engulf the world.

However, Azekel didn't do that.

Anyone who dared to mutter such impious words was completely eliminated.

In secret, he meticulously explored and gathered the demon seeds, preparing only for the resurrection of the Demon King. Because he knew.

What the true power beyond the heavens was, the pinnacle of the demon race.

A god who could create their own paradise in the world and fulfill the demons' desires.

“Let's begin. Unleash the demon seeds.”

In the midst of numerous demons, including the archdemons, they gathered, bowing their heads.

As Azekel's command was given, some of the demons began to move.

Beside the pillar lay a large black gemstone.

In response to the demons' energy, a black aura started to flow out of the gemstone like beads, one by one.

Soon, the beads intertwined and merged with each other, and like a waterfall, they were drawn towards the pillar.

Kugugugugu.

With a heaven and earth opening vibration, the pillar began to crack.

‘I’ll be back soon, Seventh Lord. I entrust the successor to you.’

The hero left with only those words, quickly disappearing somewhere with a wounded body.

Returning home, I could only remain lost in thought.

“Hey, Ran. Why are you staring into space instead of eating?”

From across the table, Kaen waved a spoon in front of my eyes.

I pushed her hand away.

“It’s nothing.”

...There was no appetite. The Demon King had been resurrected.

Only that fact was circulating in my mind.

Since the hero wouldn’t mistake something like that, it meant that the Demon King had truly been resurrected in Altelore.

After finishing the meal, I went back outside and wandered the streets.

Just going wherever my feet took me. The area where the snow was still falling was peaceful, in complete contrast to the turmoil in my heart.

The worst crisis had suddenly arrived. No, it wasn’t sudden.

The hero had clearly mentioned that it wouldn't be strange for the Demon King to be resurrected at any time.

I just tried not to force myself to think about it.

What should I do now?

I had no idea. To be precise, I couldn't figure out what I should do.

The final showdown with the Demon King was a storyline that remained unresolved, even until the end of the game.

So, I had never experienced how powerful the Demon King was or what abilities he used.

It was just consistently emphasized in the story that only the power of the Holy Sword could defeat it.

I stopped walking and looked up at the sky. Many thoughts rose and fell in my mind.

Your power can reach the Demon King.

It was what the Holy Sword had said before.

With my instant-kill ability, the Holy Sword had assured me that I could even kill the Demon King.

Of course, there was no guarantee that I could kill the Demon King.

Even if my instant-kill ability reached the Demon King, the condition was that I had to physically touch him.

Moreover, the Demon King would undoubtedly be stronger than any enemies I had faced so far.

I had no confidence that I could do it.

Fighting him would be like risking my life entirely. After all, from the beginning, my sole purpose was to survive.

The idea of sacrificing myself to protect this world? I had never considered it.

Even if the [Soul of the King] erased my fear, the instinct of not wanting to die wouldn't disappear.

I didn't want to die. I didn't want to risk my life and fight the Demon King with no assurance at all...

“...”

And I also didn't want to sacrifice Kaen. I didn't want her to go through the remaining succession conditions.

I just wanted to let her live happily as she was doing now.

Wasn't it too late for the succession at this point, anyway?

Now that the Demon King had been resurrected, the invasion of demons was a foregone conclusion.

Shouldn't I reveal my instant kill ability to the hero and think about defeating the Demon King together?

If I proposed such a thing, the hero would surely accept it.

After all, she's not exactly thrilled about passing on the Holy Sword to Kaen.

...But, could I really do that?

Could I truly defeat the Demon King without going through the inheritance process?

The reason I had considered inheritance so important until now was that it followed the flow of the game.

Could I defy that flow and defeat the final boss of this world's storyline?

Amidst conflicting emotions, the conclusion was not easy to come to.

I turned and started walking back home.

Once back, I found Kaen building a small igloo-like structure in the courtyard.

It looked like it was about to collapse, so I said, "Use magic to freeze it, or it'll collapse."

"I'm not going to use magic. Just wait and see."

I left her and entered the house.

While trying to boil water for a warm cup of tea, I sensed a familiar presence and turned my gaze toward the window.

Ah.

Come to think of it, it was about time for Asher to show up too, right?

Since I had returned the communication device to the hero earlier, I wouldn't receive any prior notice of Asher's visit.

I went back outside again. Carefully stacking the igloo, Kaen asked.

"Why do you keep going in and out? What are you doing?"

"I'll be back soon."

I moved to a less crowded alley and met with Asher.

Asher brushed off the accumulated snow from her robe and lowered her hood.

"You've been through a lot. It's been a while."

“Yes, Sir Ron.” Curiously, Asher asked with a puzzled look, “Your face seems a bit troubled. Is something wrong?”

“It’s nothing.”

Having known each other for a long time, Asher quickly sensed my mood. I decided not to mention anything about the Demon King for now.

We exchanged greetings briefly, and I shared some recent updates with her. There was nothing significant happening in the monarchy, either.

“Also, the Shadow brought some additional information.”

“Shadow?”

“Yes. She said they followed the target’s trail as far as they could, but she has reached a point where she can’t investigate further.”

I accepted the information sheet from Asher and bid farewell before heading back home.

I guess this is the least of my worries now.

It was about the whereabouts of the person with the power of possession, whom I had entrusted the Shadow to investigate.

He would become a villain who would terrorize the capital of Santea in the future, but I didn’t care much now.

I didn’t have time to worry about this anymore, not when the Demon King was about to rise and the world was about to end.

Still, since the investigation had been done, I thought I should confirm the results. I sat down on a chair and unfolded the investigation report.

Let’s see.

According to the information the Shadow had gathered, the man was said to be a former member of a secret organization within the Santea royal family.

He harbored resentment towards the royal family, which led him to seek revenge in Santea.

-Ten years ago, traces of his past were discovered in Shampeo City in the northeast of Santea. The investigation started at this point.

-Relatively trustworthy testimonies were confirmed by the innkeeper of the inn where the target had stayed.

-The target's gender is male, and his age at that time was estimated to be between 30 and 40 years old. His face was said to be extremely worn out with a tired appearance.

I took out the map and found Shampeo City to the west.

-As a result of investigating the nearby villages around Shampeo City, I confirmed another piece of information from a place called Hooter Village to the east of Shampeo.

-It is presumed that the target moved in the direction of the capital city. I gathered information about individuals resembling the target from the villages along the path leading from Shampeo to the capital city.

-The investigation was briefly interrupted in the capital city, but judging from the path the target had taken so far, it is assumed that he moved westward. I continued the investigation westward.

-Further west, in the small town of Nadarita, located in the Voldot territory, I reconfirm the target's passage.

I paused for a moment as I read on, realizing something odd: the area near Voldot that was described in the report was where the village of Azeta was located.

The village of Azeta was the village that Kaen had once told me was her home.

By the way, even if she was only on the tail end of something, she had done a pretty good job of researching a person's whereabouts from ten years ago.

I shrugged it off and continued reading, amazed at the Shadow's skill.

-Confirmed traces in Kamrel City to the west. It is presumed that the target had an unexpected companion.

-The companion is a young girl, estimated to be around 5 or 6 years old. There are no clues about the companion, so the investigation is inconclusive.

As I continued to trace the route, new information popped up.

Companion?

Suddenly, a companion? And a young girl at that?

I was puzzled, but soon I had a guess.

Ah, could it be that he brought the girl so he could possess her later?

The mystery of possession. Considering the requirements to use it, it was highly likely.

Information about the mystery of possession was not even mentioned in the game's storyline.

From the beginning, he was a character with hardly any revealed background.

However, since the setting book contained information about the mystery of possession, I knew about it.

To use the mystery of possession, there were two necessary conditions.

First, the possessor of the mystery and the body to be transferred must belong to the same species.

Second, the one whose body would be possessed must harbor a deep intimacy with the possessor of the mystery.

The first condition may not be difficult, but due to the second condition, one couldn't just use the mystery to switch bodies with anyone.

So, perhaps to fulfill these conditions, he tried to find orphans and raise them as vessels for possession?

If he cared for them like parents from a young age, it wouldn't be too difficult to build that intimacy.

I didn't know why he would go to such lengths to use the mystery of possession.

It could be that his original body was afflicted with an incurable disease or suffered from a severe injury.

Alternatively, he might have needed a body with much greater magical talent than his original one.

Of course, I didn't know the exact reason.

“...?”

Suddenly, I felt a twinge of recognition and looked at the map.

He suddenly got a companion in the city of Kamrel.

The town of Azeta was right between Kamrel and the Voldot territory that he'd passed through.

Was it a coincidence? It couldn't be...

-The target moved back toward the capital. Presumably continued eastward from there.

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-Eventually, all traces were lost in a village near the Ramon Mountain Range to the east.

Ramon Mountain Range.

That's where Kaen lived since childhood with her father.

“...”

After reading the remaining contents, I became frozen and speechless.

If, if it's true. If he really found and raised a young child as a vessel and had been taking care of her without moving for 10 years until now...

“...She's probably around fifteen now.”

With a creak, the door opened noisily. Kaen came in and shouted in an excited voice.

“Hey, Ran! Come out quickly and see! I've made an amazing igloo!”

“.....”

“Why are you just standing there? Stop daydreaming and come out! Hehehe!”

I watched her figure running out of the room, still dazed.

Chapter 174: Kaen (3)

Chapter 174: Kaen (3)

After thinking for a while, there were numerous parts that I couldn't understand, no matter how much I pondered.

Was Ben really the villain with the mystery of the possession, the one who would terrorize the capital of Santea in the future?

But the evidence seemed clear.

His passage through the village of Azeta, his disappearance in the Ramon Mountain Range, Kaen's gender and age, all of it.

It was easy to guess why he chose Kaen as his next host.

Ben suffered a fatal injury and couldn't accumulate mana on his own.

If he had stumbled upon Kaen by accident, and recognized her genius.

Then there was no reason for him not to covet Kaen as his next host. My heart sank.

Was there some misunderstanding? Was there an error in the investigation? Or was it all just a mere coincidence?

It was too elaborate and uncomfortable to brush it off as such. I tried to settle my confusion and organize my thoughts.

What if...

If he had indeed raised Kaen as a possession, then the situation was extremely dangerous.

Even if they weren't related by blood, to Kaen, Ben was no different from a real father.

He was someone more precious to her than anyone else.

The conditions for using the mystery were undoubtedly satisfied.

In short, the current Ben might be in a state where he could take over Kaen's body at any time. That was if he really was that person.

...I need to confirm.

In the end, there would be no certain answer until I checked it myself.

I had to get Kaen away from Ben and find out who he really was.

I shouldn't waste any time right now. I know nothing about the exact process of how the mystery of possession worked.

Making a wrong move could result in Kaen losing her body. It's a situation that left no room for complacency.

I gathered my thoughts and immediately took action.

I went out to the yard and spoke to Kaen, who was still playing in the snow.

"Kaen."

"Yeah?"

"Can you go out and buy something for me? It's the Rolphine Dessert Shop's chocolate muffin."

"What? The line there is ridiculously long. And why are you asking me to go out?"

“Sorry. I suddenly have something to do. I’ll cook dinner tonight and chop firewood tomorrow in return.”

Kaen looked puzzled. After all, I had never asked her to do this kind of errand before.

Perhaps because of that, she willingly accepted the request with a motivated look.

“Hmm, sure. Did you really want a chocolate muffin that bad? Haha, just wait here.”

Kaen took the money I handed her and headed out the door. I watched her go, then walked back into the house.

Ben was in his room. I slowly walked toward the room he was in.

As I opened the door and entered, he was sitting at the table, sipping tea and reading a book.

“What’s going on, Ran?”

Ben glanced at me casually.

Thud.

I closed the door and stepped inside.

He must have sensed that something was off, because Ben looked away from his book and turned his gaze back to me.

I broke the silence and spoke.

“The mystery of the possession you gained from Hallumanta.”

At my words, I could clearly see a subtle twitch around Ben’s eyes. The emotions in his gaze were confusion and surprise.

I could only instinctively sense it. As expected, it was Ben.

“I guess I was right after all.”

Soon after, Ben’s expression strangely changed. He closed the book and put it down on the table.

Then he spoke.

“How did you know?”

I thought he would deny it, but surprisingly, he admitted the truth willingly.

“Perhaps you have the ability to see through the mysteries of others, Seventh Lord?”

“.....!”

“No, even if that were the case, how did you not figure out that I obtained it from Hallumenta? Rather, are you done with the masquerade now? It’s quite perplexing in various ways.”

I couldn’t help but feel bewildered by Ben’s words. He knew my identity? Since when?

Ben looked at my face and smirked.

“I knew from the beginning that you are the Seventh Lord.”

“...How?”

“Because I saw you in the mountains. Polymorphs can’t deceive my eyes. Of course, I also know that Del is the hero. It doesn’t seem like magic, probably the ability of the Holy Sword, right?”

Ben continued to utter shocking words one after another and slowly stood up from his chair.

“The hero and the Lord of Calderic, haha. What an odd combination. But I don’t know what purpose you have in approaching Kaen. Can you enlighten me?”

I quickly regained my composure and replied calmly.

“Did you want to seek revenge against Santea by taking over Kaen and replacing your broken body with hers?”

“...How deep did you dig into my background? Truly, what a frightening information gathering skills.”

Ben clicked his tongue and moved toward the sword hanging on the wall of the room.

Swish.

“So, what will you do now? Are you going to kill me?”

“And if I am?”

“Just tell me one thing. What is your and the hero’s purpose? What do you want from Kaen?”

“Kaen will save this world. She doesn’t deserve to be sacrificed for your personal grudge.”

“Is that so? I see.”

Ben widened his eyes and let out a chuckle.

“My, my, my. The girl has taken on a grand burden. Not very comforting, I must say.”

With those words, he raised his sword.

His earliest memory was of himself shivering in a pile of corpses.

A giant monster had suddenly attacked the village, unleashing all of its murderous ferocity on the inhabitants, and then left.

‘We have a survivor here.’

‘You, what’s your name?’

‘...Ciel.’

Ciel.

That was Ben’s original name.

Having saved his life, unknown individuals forcibly took Ciel.

‘Ah, what a natural talent. To manipulate others’ magic.’

They forced him to undergo a grueling training regimen. Rolling around like an animal, Ciel learned many things.

How to wield a sword, how to manifest magic, and how to kill with it effectively.

One of the hidden shadows of the Santea royal family, the darkest aspect of the royalty.

As a palace hunting dog, Ciel had killed numerous people using the skills he had learned and had overcome countless life-threatening situations.

‘Never show your claws, Ciel. You just have to stop thinking about yourself. You never know, maybe one day we’ll have a chance to live as humans.’

The leader of the assassins, Euphia, was a strange person.

She was the most faithful hound in the pack, but she was also a leader who cared about her people more than anyone else.

She always took the biggest risks herself without using her members as disposable tools.

Ciel, too, owed his life to Euphia several times during their missions.

Because of that, even as his heart became dry, he never lost the feeling of longing for Euphia.

‘You have all done well so far. But the dogs with loose leashes need to be dealt with.’

One day, as they were returning from a mission, the Spear Saint suddenly attacked their group.

The power gap was enormous, and all the members were killed.

Only Ciel managed to escape through the opening created by the sacrifices of Euphia and the members he had been close to.

In the world Ciel had lived in, they were his only companions.

But they were all slaughtered like cattle in the hands of the Spear Saint.

‘I will kill them all, Commander. I’ll take them all down...’

However, with fatal injuries and a broken body, he couldn’t dream of revenge.

Ciel became a fugitive, wandering the continent in search of a way to heal himself.

He heard rumors that there was an herb in Hallumenta that could heal his broken mana power circuit.

Although it was a baseless rumor, Ciel grasped at straws and traveled to Hallumenta, risking his life.

When he arrived there, he found no herbs.

Instead, he accidentally found something else in a cave.

‘This is...’

A mystery. The most mysterious power in this world, whose origins could not be understood.

Ciel also had a mysterious power since he was young, so he reached out to the pattern without any hesitation.

The power he obtained was possession.

He could transfer his soul to another of his kind, someone he felt a strong affinity for, and take over their body.

With this ability, he couldn't repair his damaged body, but he could obtain a new one.

Ciel once again roamed the continent, this time searching for a suitable host.

A child with high magical talent, capable of enabling his revenge.

By chance, he arrived at a small village in Santea where a terrible tragedy had occurred.

An evil mage had slaughtered the residents, laughing among the corpses.

His skills were mediocre. Ciel dealt with him easily and then looked around the ruined village for survivors.

There, he found a young girl.

The girl was seriously injured, but Ciel found her in time to save her life.

'What's your name?'

'My name... is Kaen.'

Kaen seemed to be in shock, losing her memory due to the impact.

She couldn't remember anything except her name.

Ciel, feeling a faint sense of familiarity from his own childhood, decided to take care of her for a while.

Soon, he realized the incredible talent that Kaen possessed.

With this body...!

With such monstrous talent, she could undoubtedly reach a level beyond the Five Stars of Santea.

Ciel chose Kaen as her host and decided to take care of her to strengthen their bond.

And having lost all her memories, Kaen followed him like a baby bird.

‘Father.’

‘...Why are you calling me your father? Don’t address me like that.’

Ciel never explained anything, so Kaen had always considered him his father.

Though Ciel would feel irritation and guilt when this happened, he eventually stopped resisting.

Why bother denying it? If Kaen considered him her father and followed him, he could achieve his goal quickly.

Several years passed.

To completely evade any potential pursuit from the royal family, Ciel continued to live deep in the mountains.

Kaen had grown considerably from when they first met, now becoming a young girl.

Watching her run around the yard by herself, Ciel smiled slightly, then hardened his expression.

He felt that the conditions were nearly met.

‘...Just a little more.’

But he didn’t use the mystery.

He decided to wait a little longer. Transferring his soul to such a young body might lead to unforeseen side effects.

More years passed.

Kaen had reached around ten years of age.

Ciel decided to hold off on using the mystery for another year.

Year after year, time flowed on.

He continued to come up with excuses, but he knew deep down that they were all just excuses.

‘Father, what’s your favorite color of flowers?’

‘What now?’

‘Tell me quickly. What’s your favorite color of flowers?’

‘Um... red.’

Ciel gave a half-hearted answer and watched Kaen’s back as she giggled and dashed out of the cabin.

...What on earth was he doing?

Memories of fallen comrades surfaced, igniting a fire of vengeance within Ciel’s heart. If things continued like this, it would be beyond his control.

He would use the mystery.

After a few days had passed, Ciel made up his mind and sought out Kaen.

He called out to Kaen, who had been sitting in the backyard doing something.

‘Kaen, what are you doing?’

‘Huh? Ahaha. Come here, Father.’

Kaen laughed playfully and extended something towards him.

It was a roughly tied bouquet of red flowers. Ciel paused at the sight of it.

‘It’s a gift, Father. I’ve been collecting them diligently for a few days.’

Red flowers were hard to find in this area. To think she had gathered this many.

Ciel stood still for a moment, then accepted the bouquet and silently patted Kaen’s head.

Several more years passed. Kaen was now approaching adulthood.

Suddenly, she brought someone who had collapsed near the cabin.

He claimed to be a professor from Elphon Academy.

Then a demon contractor stormed the cabin, followed by the Lord of Calderic on a wyvern.

...Who is that person?

Apart from the mystery of possession, Ciel had another mystery he had possessed since long ago.

It was the ability to see a person’s soul visually.

Somehow, the soul of the Seventh Lord felt strangely disconnected from his body, which was fascinating.

But Ciel couldn't help but pay more attention to the woman with him than to the Seventh Lord.

It was understandable since he had only seen a human with such a brilliant soul from a distance once in his life.

The identity of the woman seemed to be none other than the hero.

Though he couldn't understand the reason, she seemed to take an interest in Kaen.

Later on, she even asked if she could take Kaen with her to the outside world.

Cie couldn't grasp why his heart felt relieved at that question.

As the hero, she wouldn't have any reason to harm Kaen.

Ciel left the choice to Kaen. After much contemplation, Kaen decided to follow her.

...Maybe I should find a new body.

It wasn't that he completely gave up on revenge.

During the time they spent together, Kaen had become just as precious. She was his only daughter.

Still, he wanted to see her for a while before he started wandering the continent again.

I wanted to see how she would fare in the world, who she would associate with, and what relationships she would form.

In the academy, Kaen made several friends.

On their days off, she often brought her friends home.

Ciel felt a part of his empty heart being filled.

Even if he left now, Kaen wouldn't be lonely anymore.

And...

Thump.

A sound of a sword cutting flesh echoed.

With the raised sword, Ben ended up cutting his own neck and collapsed to the ground.

I looked at the scene absentmindedly.

The red blood stained the floor. I could have stopped it if I wanted to.

But I didn't. Well, he was a dangerous person trying to take over Kaen's body.

I couldn't just let him be.

...But there were still many unanswered questions. Why hadn't he taken over Kaen's body until now?

Why he'd let such an important possession host slip from his grasp?

And did the person who appeared in the game not Kaen?

Now that he was dead, there was no way to answer those questions.

I approached the chair and slumped down. Then I looked down at Ben's corpse.

Was there another way? Should I have prevented his suicide?

I didn't know. My mind was a mess.

But anyway, since it had come to this...

Inside the dim room, I waited for Kaen to come back.

“Ran! I’m back!”

Kaen, who had returned home, loudly opened the front door.

Feeling an inexplicable strangeness in the quiet atmosphere of the house, she tilted her head but soon fixed her expression.

The smell of blood?

Kaen walked slowly towards Ben’s room. Then she opened the door.

The paper bag in her hand fell with a thud.

“Uh...”

Red blood-stained floor. Ben lying on top of it.

Ran, who was sitting on a chair, opened his mouth.

“You’re here, Kaen.”

Chapter 175: Kaen (4)

Chapter 175: Kaen (4)

Kaen's thoughts stopped. Ben was lying on the floor, bleeding, and Ran was sitting next to him.

“Oh, Father!”

Kaen rushed to Ben's side. She rolled him over and quickly checked his condition.

However, Ben's life had already been cut off, and he lay there as a cold corpse with his throat slit.

Kaen attempted to use healing magic.

Of course, there was no way to heal a wound on a dead body.

She kept channeling her mana and trying to use healing magic repeatedly, but eventually gave up.

“...Father.”

Kaen shook Ben's motionless body.

His head fell limply.

Was this a dream? Or was she trapped in a nightmare?

The sight of Ben's lifeless body felt unreal.

It didn't make any sense.

She had only gone out to buy the muffins that Ran asked for, so why was this happening...?

Kaen remained in a daze for a while and then turned her gaze.

Ran was looking down at her with an expressionless face.

“Ran, what happened? Why did Father...?”

Kaen realized belatedly.

The blood-stained sword in Ran’s hand. Ran spoke in a dry voice.

“Kaen. I did it.”

“What are you talking about? I don’t understand.”

“Can’t you see? I killed your father.” Ran replied indifferently.

Kaen couldn’t comprehend what Ran was saying.

“Why?”

Unable to utter anything more, Kaen barely managed to ask, and Ran replied.

“I’m actually a demon.”

“.....”

“The reason I first approached you was that you could be a crucial material for the resurrection of the Demon King. They call it the demon’s seed. But it’s probably meaningless to tell you.”

“...What on earth are you saying...?”

“I’ve been by your side all this time, watching and waiting for the demon seed to bloom. But now, there’s no need for that anymore. Because the Demon King has been resurrected.”

Ran dropped the blood-stained sword to the floor and stood up.

“Originally, I was going to kill you both and leave, but I thought it would be more fun this way. Kaen, I won’t kill you specifically. Take care.”

Ran walked out of the room.

Kaen sat down in a daze for a moment, then staggered to her feet. She left the room.

However, Ran’s figure had already disappeared and was nowhere to be seen.

Kaen’s legs gave out, and she slumped back down.

With only the pungent smell of blood lingering in the house, she was left all alone.

While traveling back to Raphid City, Aindel sensed something was amiss and summoned the Holy Sword.

Paaaat!

The Holy Sword emitted four brilliant rays of light.

Aindel looked at the Holy Sword with disbelief.

“Why...?”

How could all the conditions of the Holy Sword be fulfilled? She felt her heart sink and accelerated her speed.

...Could it be a demon? An Archdemon so powerful that even the Seventh Lord couldn’t handle it?

While I was away for a while, what happened to Kaen?

When Aindel arrived at Kaen's house, an unimaginable scene unfolded before her.

Inside the house, Aindel found Kaen.

The sight of her holding the lifeless body of Ben and looking down with a lost gaze.

"Kaen..."

Calling her name, Kaen raised her head.

Her gaze was as empty as that of a dead person.

Aindel swallowed hard and slowly sat beside her.

Ben, with a sword wound on his neck, looked as if he had been dead for some time already.

If he had died not long ago, she could have revived him with the power of the Holy Sword. But it was too late now.

Kaen spoke.

"Ran killed him."

"What...?"

"Ran killed my father. He said he was a demon, that he was lying to me all along..."

Confusion filled Aindel's mind.

The Seventh Lord killed Kaen's father...

And what did he mean by demons?

The Seventh Lord was not a demon. He was undoubtedly their ally.

There was no falsehood in that fact.

Aindel could only come up with one possible explanation.

Why the Seventh Lord killed Kaen's father.

No way.

Aindel bit her lip in disbelief.

She checked on Kaen first, who was in distress.

She placed her hand on Kaen's forehead.

"Kaen, rest for a while."

The power of the Holy Sword enveloped Kaen's body, and she lost consciousness as if falling asleep.

Aindel moved Kaen to another room and left the house immediately.

"....."

As soon as she stepped outside, she felt a presence. It was the Seventh Lord calling.

Aindel headed to where the Seventh Lord was.

In a narrow alley near the house, the Seventh Lord was waiting.

"...Seventh Lord."

Aindel's face froze into a grim expression.

The sun was setting, and darkness was gradually falling.

I went out and entered a deserted alley, leaning against the wall and sitting down.

“.....”

My head was a little dizzy. It was hard to keep looking at Kaen's face, so I ran away as if escaping.

I had done a terrible thing.

As I stepped out of the bloody house and into the cold wind, the realization of what I had done became clearer and clearer.

...What should I have done?

What the hell was I supposed to do in that situation? I couldn't risk letting Ben get close to Kaen.

Now that everything had been revealed, Ben had to be dealt with in some way or another.

I couldn't reveal the truth to Kaen, either.

In the first place, even if the mystery of possession or whatever was explained, who would believe such nonsense?

The Demon King had been resurrected.

I had to make a decision quickly, whether to abandon the succession or complete it somehow.

Meanwhile, Ben died, and the appropriate situation to fulfill all the conditions was created.

All those thoughts tangled together, and ultimately, I made this choice.

I did have regrets.

However, no matter how much I thought about it, this was the best option.

Kaen's expression flashed in my mind again. I lowered my head.

...Have all the remaining conditions been fulfilled?

If this satisfied all the conditions of the Holy Sword, the hero would return soon.

As time passed, I felt the presence of the hero returning to Kaen's house.

I channeled my mana and called the hero's attention.

She came to my location and looked at me coldly.

"...Seventh Lord."

I stood up. The hero walked unsteadily towards me.

"Explain."

A sharp voice that could make one's skin crawl. I asked first.

"...Have all the conditions for the succession been fulfilled?"

The hero summoned the Holy Sword without saying a word.

In the Holy Sword, four strands of light were faintly shimmering.

Looking at that, I could tell that all the conditions for the succession had indeed been met.

In the end, it meant that I was someone Kaen trusted enough to fulfill one of the conditions.

"Did you really have to go this far for the sake of succession?"

"Yes."

"Was it all for this, living in the same house with Kaen, being so close to her?"

“Not exactly. But it turned out this way.”

“Seventh Lord, what on earth are you...!”

The hero’s face twisted fiercely.

“Hero, listen.”

I began explaining slowly.

What happened while she was away?

About the person with the mystery of possession that I had been pursuing from before, and his intentions.

The whole truth, from the information Asher had brought me to the realization that Ben and he were one and the same, to my conversation with Ben, to his taking his own life, and how I had come up with a way to fulfill all the conditions of the succession.

After hearing all the explanations, the hero stood there for a while in silence.

Her expression changed rapidly, and finally, she spoke in a low voice.

“Seventh Lord, what secret are you hiding?”

“...”

“When you knew about the succession, when you spoke with the Holy Sword in private, I didn’t pry. I didn’t try to delve into your secrets, because I trusted that one day, when you trusted me more, you would tell me everything.”

“I know.”

“You have always spoken the truth to me. But now, it’s becoming hard to accept what you’re saying. That Kaen’s father possesses the mystery of

possession, that he intended to take over Kaen's body. How could you know all these things...?"

I interrupted her and replied.

"Because I have partial knowledge of what will happen in the future."

"...What did you say?"

"That's why I knew about succession. That's why I knew about the mystery of possession. That's the secret I've been hiding all along."

The hero stared blankly and asked again, "Was this really the best choice?"

"..."

"To betray that child, to make her lose his father, to make her go through such despair..."

"I know."

I still believed that this was the best method. But at the same time, I also thought it was the worst.

"I completely ruined that child's life. But now, I can't undo it."

I looked the hero in the eye and said, "Let her inherit the Holy Sword, hero."

The hero remained silent for a while, then turned away.

"...I am sorry, Seventh Lord. My indecision has driven you to this point.'"

The hero left with those words.

Alone, I gazed endlessly at the spot where she had left.

Aindel returned to Kaen's house. She was still asleep.

Aindel didn't force her awake and waited for her to wake up.

Soon, Kaen woke up. She looked around dazedly and then looked at Aindel sitting beside her.

"...Del, I must have been dreaming, right?"

Kaen asked with a pale expression.

"It was just a dream, right? Something like that could never happen. Ran would never kill Father..."

"Kaen."

"....Answer me. Tell me it's just a dream, please."

Aindel remained silent, lowering her head.

Kaen took a deep breath and got up from the bed, walking towards Ben's room.

Ben was lying on the neatly arranged bed.

Aindel had cleaned up the bloodstains and prepared Ben's body to prevent it from decomposing.

"Ugh, ugh..."

Kaen sat down beside him, sobbing and crying for quite some time.

Aindel stood by the door, watching her grief-stricken state.

Several days passed.

Aindel moved to the Ramon Mountain Range with Kaen.

They buried Ben's body in the backyard of the cabin and made a grave for him.

It was what Kaen wanted.

"Del, what is the demon seed?"

Kaen asked, glancing at the grave.

"He said I was an important ingredient for the Demon King's resurrection, so he kept me alive, and now that he's back, I'm useless."

Aindel let out a quiet sigh.

The Seventh Lord had lied to Kaen.

"The demon seed is..."

Aindel explained to Kaen about the demon seed, and after hearing the explanation, Kaen muttered.

"In the end, it was because of me that Father died."

"No, Kaen. That's not..."

"Lea died, and so did Father. Why do demons do such things? Why do they commit dreadful acts as if they're frustrated about not being able to make people suffer?"

Aindel responded, "There's no reason. It's because that's their inherent nature."

"Inherent nature..."

Kaen, who had been silent, stood up and said, "Del, I want to kill all the demons."

"..."

“If their nature is like that, then they should all disappear from this world.”

Aindel didn't answer. Kaen looked at her.

“So, I need to become stronger. Please pass the sword down to me.”

Aindel closed her eyes tightly, then slowly opened them again.

“Kaen.”

“Yes.”

“My real name is Aindel, the hero with the Holy Sword.”

In the end, everything was a result of her hesitation.

As the Seventh Lord had said, now there was no turning back.

I'm sorry.

Really sorry, Kaen.

“You shall inherit the Holy Sword and become the hero who succeeds me.
And defeat the Demon King.”

The Holy Sword, summoned in the air, emitted a brilliant light.

Kaen gazed at that light, seemingly enchanted by it.

And just like that, three years had passed.

Chapter 176: Clouds of War (1)

Chapter 176: Clouds of War (1)

“The magic cannons have been completed in the quantities you requested, and we have over 300 war golems, Your Lordship.”

“As expected, you are fast. And what about Gidantium?”

“Gidantium’s production is practically finished as well. Only the final verification remains.”

The Overlord nodded with satisfaction.

“As expected of you, First Lord. Thank you for your hard work.”

Three years have passed since the Hero announced the Demon King’s resurrection.

The Santea royal family, led by the hero, strongly proclaimed the formation of an anti-demonic coalition in preparation for a demonic invasion.

Upon hearing such news, the nations under Santea’s influence naturally expressed their intention to participate, and even the neutral countries, which had maintained ambiguous stances, did the same.

The beastmen and the elves of Adessa also joined the alliance.

Regarding the horrific invasion perpetrated by the former Emperor of Santea, Grandios, in the Great Forest, they had not yet reached a consensus among themselves.

Nevertheless, Adessa had put that aside and forged an alliance with Santea for the time being, not raising their voice against the fact that the previous emperor had harnessed the power of demons.

Such was the terror that the Demon King instilled in them.

It all began with the sudden emergence of the Demon King and the demon invasion several decades ago.

They hadn't forgotten the mistakes of the past when the entire continent was devastated without proper countermeasures.

The appearance of the hero miraculously repelled the invasion, but everyone knew that the chances of such a miracle happening again were slim.

To prevent annihilation, everyone felt the need for thorough preparation and cooperation this time.

And, as expected, Calderic also declared without any opposition that they would join the alliance according to the Overlord's will.

This was a great surprise, even to Santea.

The person whom they thought would be the most challenging to persuade turned out to be even more compliant than the neutral countries.

Thus, a coalition of all the continent's powers, with the exception of Altelore, was quickly formed.

However, the demons, in contrast, have shown no particular movement even after three years since the announcement of the hero.

Currently, the continent was like a frozen plate that could crack at any moment, with each faction sharing information and preparing for a war that could begin at any time.

“Your Lordship, why do you think the demons have not yet invaded?”

The first lord, the Wiseman, asked. The Overlord stroked her chin and replied.

“Well, it’s probably because of the hero. The hero’s physical condition is not normal, right? It seems to be getting worse over time, and that would favor the demons.”

“Instead, the allied forces are fully prepared, and they have had enough time to strengthen their alliances.”

“The demons probably consider the hero as an even greater variable. And, in fact, that’s true, isn’t it? Without the hero, the war would probably flow overwhelmingly disadvantageous for us.”

Glancing at the Overlord, who answered nonchalantly, the Wiseman opened his mouth again.

“Your Lordship, you should know better than anyone what I value most.”

“Hmm? That’s right. You’re the First Lord who’s been with Calderic since the beginning, and you love this Calderic more than anyone, right?”

The Overlord smiled, looking at the Wiseman. The Wiseman did not smile at all.

“Even I, who has been a Lord since the previous Overlord ruled over Calderic, have never been able to catch a glimpse of the true feelings you harbor within, Your Lordship.”

“Haha, is that so?”

“...Your Lordship, since the hero announced the resurrection of the Demon King, is it just my perception that something has changed in you?”

The Overlord that the Wiseman knew was someone who sometimes made indecisive decisions, but for the most part, she ruled Calderic reasonably and steadily.

However, from the time the Demon King's resurrection began to cloud the continent, he felt a strange sense of unfamiliarity.

Outwardly, nothing had changed. It was just a gut feeling, one might say.

The Wiseman felt like the Overlord didn't care about anything anymore. It was a gut feeling.

"Nothing has changed, First Lord. It's just needless worries."

The Overlord said with a smirk.

The Wiseman stood up from his seat.

"I'll take my leave now."

"Sure. I won't see you off."

As the Wiseman left, the Overlord remained alone, burying her back in the chair and closing her eyes.

"...It's almost time."

A faint smile appeared on her lips. Unlike before, it was a genuine, pure smile without a hint of pretense.

Kwaang! Kwaaang!

With each clash of their swords, shockwaves reverberated through the surrounding ground, and bushes flew into the air.

I watched from a distance as the two fiercely clashed.

The Mad King's sword strikes were relentless and merciless like a raging beast, but Asher showed no signs of faltering and continued with solid defense.

“Hah, quite impressive! Then try blocking this!”

The Mad King roared, emitting a crimson aura and increasing her speed.

In response, Asher used her special ability, her entire body turning snowy white.

The red and pure white auras collided relentlessly, gradually turning the forest into ruins.

Even though the Mad King was now giving her all, Asher didn't yield easily.

Kwaaah!

The two soared higher and higher in the sky, continuing their fierce battle. But ultimately, Asher couldn't completely block the Mad King's attack and crashed loudly onto the ground.

Following behind, standing on the edge of a cliff, the Mad King smiled with a greatsword on her shoulder.

“Each day, you're growing fast. Still, you're not good enough for me, White Moon Tribe's little brat.”

“.....”

“What's with that look? Are you trying to give me a dirty look with your eyes?”

Asher stood up silently and bowed her head to the Mad King.

“Thank you for your hard work, Fifth Lord.”

“No, but this brat...”

Seeing the Mad King's discomfort, I approached the two and said, “That's enough, Fifth Lord.”

The Mad King snorted.

“What did I do? It’s not like it’s my fault she always loses, but her attitude is still so arrogant.”

Well, you provoke her with your childish behavior. Would Asher act like that if you didn’t?

Perhaps because of what happened in the Great Forest, the Mad King had started visiting my territory occasionally.

And somehow, this led to these occasional confrontations with Asher.

It’s good for Asher’s growth, so I didn’t stop the Mad King from visiting.

【Lv. 94】

The sparring with the Mad King wasn’t entirely ineffective.

Asher’s level had risen to 94 in just a few years.

She had already completed the trials in the Ruins of Cabollisa, so there were no remaining obstacles. I knew she had the talent to reach this level, but her growth rate was faster than expected.

With her current abilities, she was not far from the level of a Lord.

“Oh, I’m hungry. Let’s go back and eat. Seventh Lord, how about going to the Great Forest together after eating?”

“Why to the Great Forest?”

“The Overlord asked me to deliver a message to them about forming an alliance. It’s such a bother to act like a messenger.”

The Mad King said while clicking her tongue.

Although she complained, her lack of refusal showed that she hadn’t completely turned away from Adessa since the Emperor’s incident.

Before I could respond, Asher immediately intervened and said.

“Sir Ron has other duties to attend to later.”

“Huh? What kind of duties?”

“He needs to visit the First Lord’s territory to receive the equipment. I guess he can’t accompany you to Adessa.”

It was the equipment that Asher was supposed to receive, made from the ore obtained from the First Lord’s last journey to the demonic land of Ocea.

We’d just gotten word from the First Lord that it was finished.

The equipment, crafted by the best blacksmith on the continent, known as the Wiseman, would significantly boost Asher’s power.

The Mad King left with a disappointed look on her face after she finished eating her meal.

As Asher and I prepared to depart for the First Lord’s territory, I asked her, “Asher, do you dislike the Fifth Lord?”

“No, not at all. I appreciate the frequent sparring matches that she provides for me to improve.”

“Really?”

“Yes. It’s just that every time she visits the castle, I feel like she’s giving Sir Ron a hard time...”

Certainly, the Mad King always asked for this and that whenever she visited the castle, which was a hassle.

Asher seemed displeased with that.

I smiled and mounted on Ti-Yong’s back first.

“Let’s go.”

“Yes.”

The Demon King had been resurrected, and three years had passed.

During that time, many things happened, but there were no major incidents.

After the Demon King’s resurrection, the hero announced it to the entire continent and quickly formed an anti-demon coalition, preparing for a demon invasion.

It was only natural that the countries under the influence of the Santea joined the alliance, and even Adessa participated.

The thing I was most worried about was how the Overlord would act, but surprisingly, the Overlord also willingly participated in the alliance without any opposition or conditions.

I still didn’t know what the Overlord was plotting.

However, for now, it could be said that the entire continent’s anti-demon coalition has been formed.

But the demons are still surprisingly quiet.

Even after several years, the demons remained motionless, not showing any signs of coming out of Altelore.

The reason, of course, could be easily guessed.

Because of the hero.

If the demons had launched a full-scale attack immediately after the Demon King’s resurrection, it wouldn’t have been strange. However, it seemed that they had chosen a more cautious approach.

The demons regained their full power with the resurrection of the Demon King, while the hero, the only one who could stand against the Demon King, would become weaker over time.

Thanks to this, the alliance had more time to prepare for war, but no matter what, the biggest threat to the demons was the hero.

If the current situation continued, the advantage would be with the demons.

One way to deal with the situation was to attack Altelore first, but that meant fighting within the demon territory, so it was also disadvantageous.

Sooner or later, you'll have to make a decision, hero.

Since that incident, I had been in periodic contact with the hero.

Currently, the hero was focused on training Kaen.

While all the conditions for inheriting the Holy Sword were already fulfilled, it was said that there was a need for Kaen to become a little stronger to inherit the power without any problems.

If the demon invasion had started immediately, she would have inherited the Holy Sword right away. However, given the time available, there was no need to take unnecessary risks.

Over the past three years, I had never gone to see Kaen even once.

Of course, Kaen didn't know that Ran and the Seventh Lord were the same person, so there's no problem with facing her.

However, I chose not to go see her. It was just because I didn't want to.

I only received news about Kaen from the hero, knowing that she was growing well.

Someday, we would meet again.

At that time, I didn't know how I should face Kaen.

Shooooo.

After about half a day's journey, we arrived at the First Lord's territory.

We slowly lowered our altitude as we approached the First Lord's Castle and its massive forge in the distance.

“Welcome, Seventh Lord. And Asher Gronhilde. It's been a long time.”

The First Lord, the Wiseman, came out to greet us at the entrance.

“The equipment is complete, as you requested. Let's go inside.”

After exchanging greetings with him, we stepped into the forge, which was blazing with heat.

Chapter 177: Clouds of War (2)

Chapter 177: Clouds of War (2)

After leading us through the forge, the Wiseman moved to the innermost room.

Several high-level dwarves guarded the entrance to what appeared to be his personal space.

As we entered, a large table that resembled a crafting station held a sword and a suit of armor.

“Is that it?”

“Yes, it is.”

A weapon and an armor made from the ore found in the demonic land of Octea, crafted by the continent’s greatest blacksmith.

The sword and armor shone with a jet-black luster, giving off a mysterious aura that was strangely absorbing.

The Wiseman carried them over and held them out to Asher. She accepted them with a slightly nervous look in her eyes.

She was still standing stiffly after taking them, so I said.

“Can she try wearing them right here?”

“Of course. Were you planning to leave without even showing the blacksmith who crafted the equipment how you use it?”

Without delay, Asher removed the armor she had been wearing and began putting on the new set.

The armor that the Wiseman had made was different from the light armor she usually wore. It was heavier, like something that could only be worn in war.

“How does it feel?”

I asked, and she shifted around in it before answering.

“I’m not used to heavy armor like this, so I honestly thought it would feel uncomfortable..... but it doesn’t at all.”

The Wiseman let out a chuckle.

“Give the sword a swing.”

Asher grasped the sword with both hands and swung it.

After a few swings, she activated her talent, channeling her mana.

Asher’s pure white mana intertwined with the dark edge of the sword.

I looked at the scene and quietly marveled inside.

When I first saw the sword and armor, my first thought was that the black color wouldn’t look good on her, but the combination of the two opposing colors was more atmospheric than I expected.

Asher looked at the black energy surrounding the sword in surprise.

“I was surprised when I made these, too. I had expectations, but I never thought such an outstanding item would come out. The magical conductivity is extraordinary, isn’t it?”

“Yes...”

Even though I didn't understand fully, judging from Asher's reaction, the weapon's performance seemed to surpass the imagination.

"Can I really accept these?"

The Wiseman nodded contentedly.

I also felt fortunate that Asher had acquired good equipment.

"Thank you for creating such great weapon and armor, First Lord. I'm grateful once again."

"It's all thanks to you, Seventh Lord, for removing the spirit from the ore. I'm the one who got the good stuff."

With that done, the First Lord said he was busy with other things, so I decided to head back.

As I walked out of the forge, I glanced briefly at the towering golems lined up next to the forge.

"These are the war golems that the Overlord commissioned."

The Wiseman, who had come along to bid farewell, spoke while looking at the golems.

"They were made with the assistance of the Fourth Lord. He's well-versed in matters related to spirits. They'll be used as weapons if the war against the demons begins."

"I see."

"Seventh Lord, what are you fighting for?"

At the unexpected question, I turned my gaze to the Wiseman.

"If the demons win the war, this continent will become a land devoid of any race except the demons. That's the kind of beings they are. That's why the Lords are all preparing for war obediently, following orders."

“...That’s right.”

“And you, Seventh Lord, wouldn’t want such a world either. It’s only natural. Isn’t it?”

Not knowing what the Wiseman wanted to say, I just looked into his eyes quietly.

Soon, the Wiseman let out a sigh and lowered his head.

“...It wasn’t a big deal. Lately, I’ve been having various doubts and worries. Anyway, when the war starts, you too should do your best. Even if it’s not for Calderic, do it for this continent.”

It was an entirely expected statement.

“Of course.”

After exchanging farewell with Shin-tae, I climbed onto Ti-Yong’s back with Asher.

“Let’s go, Ti-Yong.”

What was the deep-seated concern of the Wiseman, who was practically synonymous with being Calderic’s core?

As I flew along, I pondered, then soon gave up thinking about it.

Other matters seemed to be just fine. The only thing I needed to concentrate on right now was the Demon King and the Holy Sword.

If only I could defeat the Demon King...

But what if I managed to defeat the Demon King safely? What would be left afterwards?

That was still an unknown matter.

Santea, Elsando Domain, Manor of Nuremberg.

Clang! Clang!

Two women were clashing swords on the training ground.

Aindel raised her sword and deflected Kaen's strike.

Taking advantage of the recoil, Kaen swiftly turned her body and aimed for Aindel's side.

This time, Aindel deflected the blow, causing Kaen's sword to hit the ground.

"Ah."

Looking at Aindel's sword clashing against her own blade, Kaen let out a short sigh.

As Aindel sheathed her sword, she spoke, "Well done. Let's finish the morning practice here."

"Yes."

Wiping her sweaty hair and catching her breath, Kaen replied.

In her tall and grown appearance, there was no trace of the tense atmosphere from the past.

"Sir Nuremberg, what's for breakfast today?"

Responding to Kaen's question, Nuremberg, who had been observing the practice, answered, "I'm making egg soup. The priests brought some eggs."

"Oh, that sounds delicious. I'll go wash up then."

After she's done, Kaen hummed a tune and walked out of the training ground.

Nuremberg spoke to Aindel, “She seems to be growing more similar to you as time goes on. Don’t you think so, Aindel?”

“Similar? How so?”

“In terms of appearance. Could it be that the power of the Holy Sword is affecting that, too?”

“Is that even possible?”

Aindel shook her head.

Three years had passed. Aindel had brought Kaen to Nuremberg’s manor.

To hide Kaen’s existence and train her, they needed a secretive place.

So, instead of going back into the mountains, she chose the residence of a trustworthy comrade.

Nuremberg, now aware of the succession, was fully assisting in Kaen’s growth.

The three of them were the only ones living in the spacious manor.

Chores were all managed by Nuremberg, and visits were limited to the village chief or church priests bringing supplies.

“Are the demons still quiet?”

During the meal, Kaen asked Nuremberg while sipping on soup.

Nuremberg wiped his mouth with a napkin and replied, “Seems that way.”

“Are we just going to keep waiting like this? Aindel’s condition is deteriorating.”

“Well, probably. No one knows exactly what the demons are plotting, but...”

Nuremberg glanced at Aindel. She, too, spoke up.

“Kaen, don’t worry. You’ve grown strong enough. You can inherit the Holy Sword anytime.”

Under Aindel and Nuremberg’s guidance over the past few years, Kaen had achieved tremendous growth.

At this rate of growth, it wouldn’t be an exaggeration to say she’d reach the level of Five Stars of Santea within the next ten years.

Of course, if she inherited the Holy Sword, she wouldn’t even need that much time.

“I’m still not good enough.”

But Kaen immediately retorted with an expression that showed something didn’t sit well with her.

“There are still things I need to learn from Aindel. Don’t you think it’s too soon to inherit the sword?”

“.....”

“Thanks for the meal. I’ll get going first.”

With her soup bowl emptied, Kaen left the dining room.

Nuremberg and Aindel gazed at her departing figure.

“I’m sure she’s figured out what’s going to happen when she inherits the Holy Sword.”

“Indeed.”

“Tsk, what a frustrating situation. Why is the Holy Sword...?”

Clang!

A drop of fresh blood fell onto the dining table.

jumped to his feet, eyes wide.

“Aindel...!”

“Hush.”

Aindel raised her trembling hand.

“Lower your voice, Nuremberg.”

She wiped the blood from her lips and gestured to clean up the blood that had splattered onto the table and floor.

Nuremberg watched the scene with a somewhat helpless look in his eyes.

“No need for that expression. Didn’t you know everything already?”

“...How much time do you have left?”

“At most, half a year, I suppose.”

Aindel steadied her breath and asked.

“Nuremberg, if you’ve seen something, now is the time to tell. After all, my end is not far off.”

Back in the room, Aindel sat at the table and stared into empty space.

She remained that way for quite a while.

Now, Kaen had grown enough to inherit the Holy Sword without any problems.

Once she inherited the Holy Sword, the mission would be complete. There would be nothing left for Aindel but to entrust the remaining tasks to Kaen.

Furthermore, after inheriting the Holy Sword, Aindel's death was sealed.

Until now, the power of the Holy Sword had kept her broken body alive, barely keeping her alive when she should have died in the battle with the Demon King.

If that power was all transferred to Kaen, Aindel's fate was predetermined.

Kaen also vaguely understood this fact, so she hesitated to accept the succession warmly.

“.....”

Aindel looked around, finding that the surroundings had transformed into a pure white space.

Someone was sitting on the other side of the table.

She stared at the vaguely human figure and opened her mouth.

“How does the succession of the Holy Sword work?”

The Holy Sword answered.

-If you, the current wielder, wish for it, or if you were to die, it would happen immediately.

“Please explain more clearly.”

-Regardless of how far away the heir is from you, or whatever situation you may be in, the succession will take place.

Upon hearing this, Aindel nodded her head with a somewhat relieved expression.

-In the end, it's your choice.

“.....”

-It will become a tragic end. At least in the end, you can close your eyes by the side of your loved ones. You have that right, Aindel.

Aindel did not respond.

The appearance of the Holy Sword disappeared, and the surroundings returned to the room where she was alone.

At the same time, a knocking sound echoed.

“Come in, Kaen.”

Aindel spoke in a casual tone.

The door opened, and Kaen entered.

“What’s the matter?”

Kaen scratched her head and hesitated before speaking.

“Um... I want to apologize and say sorry. It seemed like I spoke too forcefully earlier.”

Aindel smiled gently as she stood up from her seat. He then patted Kaen’s head.

Kaen also smiled and spoke.

“Aindel.”

“Yes?”

“I don’t want to rush the succession. It’s okay to wait until at least the demons make their move.”

“I see.”

“...You won’t suddenly disappear somewhere, right? Promise me that won’t happen.”

Aindel's gaze wavered for a moment. But she quickly regained her composure.

She answered with a smile.

"That won't happen. Promise."

After collecting Asher's equipment and returning to my territory, I received an unexpected message.

The hero had sent word that she had something important to tell me and was coming to my location.

What could this be about?

I rode on Ti-Yong and headed to the forest near the Lord's Castle.

Within half a day after she made contact, the hero was waiting in the middle of the forest.

"Long time no see, Seventh Lord."

"...Yeah."

I went straight to the point.

"You mentioned an important matter. What's going on? Is it related to Kaen?"

The hero answered.

"I will now head to Altelore."

".....!"

"I have come to say a final goodbye to you before I leave, that's all."

I stood there, speechless, closed my eyes tightly, and spoke.

Was this how it would end, after all?

“You’re going to die.”

“Yes. I’m going to die.”

“.....”

“Kaen’s growth for succession is already complete. And I have less than half a year left in my lifespan.”

Once the Holy Sword was passed down, the hero would lose all her power and die.

So, with the remaining time she had left, she would cause harm to the demons before the war begins.

That was what the warrior was trying to say.

I remained silent for a while before speaking again.

“Wouldn’t it be better to lead the alliance and strike the demons first?”

“I understand what you’re trying to say, but that’s not possible.”

“Why?”

“There’s no need for the coalition forces to fight in their territory. As soon as I die, the demons will immediately launch an invasion. And this will give Kaen a little more time to adjust to the power of the Holy Sword.”

The hero’s judgment was highly rational, and I couldn’t say anything more.

“Have you told Kaen about this?”

“No. I haven’t. I don’t want to cause that child more pain.”

“Nobody still knows about the existence of the heir. What will happen after you’re gone?”

The reason the truth about succession had been hidden until now was, of course, because of the demons.

If they knew there was someone who could carry on the hero’s power, if they knew there was no point in waiting for the hero to grow weaker, they would stop dragging out the invasion.

However, there remained an issue. It was the unity of the alliance that had formed around the hero.

If it became known that the hero would die and a new hero would suddenly inherit the power of the Holy Sword, many people might become suspicious and chaos could ensue.

“If Kaen transforms into my form using the power of the Holy Sword, there shouldn’t be any significant problems.”

“....”

“Of course, Kaen might refuse. In that case, chaos would ensue, but I will make the succession official. I’ve already spoken with Nuremberg, and he’ll make it as smooth as possible.”

Was that so?

It was unlikely that Kaen would defy the hero’s intentions and cause chaos.

The hero spoke.

“Seventh Lord, when you mentioned before that you had the ability to see the future, I was genuinely surprised. Because my comrade, Nuremberg, also possesses a similar ability. Did you happen to know that, too?”

“...No.”

“Nuremberg occasionally sees unforeseen futures through a mysterious ability. However, the futures seen through that ability cannot be changed. It’s only possible to change the process leading to that future. He was able to minimize various damages during the past war using that ability.”

“....”

“Nuremberg saw a future where I die by the hands of the Demon King. So it’s a done deal. However, it is up to me to determine how much damage I can inflict on him and how much I can reduce his power before I die, so my death will not be for nothing.”

I knew.

I knew it all. Just like in the game.

The hero headed towards Altelore and there, she would kill many demons and face a splendid end alone.

Let’s go together.

I wanted to say that.

Even if you, the hero, were to die at the hands of the Demon King, I might be able to kill the Demon King with your help.

I still regret burdening Kaen with the responsibility of succession.

Maybe this was my last chance to end it all with the least amount of sacrifice...

“I will go alone to Altelore.”

Whether she had guessed my intention or not, the hero spoke firmly.

In an instant, a certain scene flashed through my mind.

The hero turning into ashes in front of the Demon King. And me, powerless and fallen, watching that spectacle.

Throughout various moments of choice until now, I often felt a sense of déjà vu.

This time, like when I saved Reef from the Tyrant, it was especially vivid and intense.

“So I ask for your help regarding Kaen. Help that child defeat the Demon King.”

In the end, I couldn’t say anything.

Aindel gave a faint smile.

“Thank you, Seventh Lord. Regardless of what you think of me, I have always considered you a comrade.”

The hero turned away. It was a hasty farewell.

I called out softly to her back.

“Aindel.”

She turned her head.

“I feel the same way. We will definitely defeat the Demon King.”

Aindel smiled once again.

A beam of golden light shot up from the ground and pierced the sky, quickly disappearing.

Altelore, the realm of the demons.

At the entrance to the Demon King’s fortress, the archdemon Metheus, who had stationed an army, raised his head.

Shhooo.

From the sky on the other side, beams of light resembling meteors were approaching this way.

Instinctively sensing what it was, Metheus shuddered with a cold sweat.

In the next moment, a flash as if the sun had exploded occurred.

Thousands of demons evaporated in an instant in the massive radiance that covered the land.

It was literal evaporation. They disappeared without leaving even a handful of ashes.

“Aaaargh!”

Metheus, barely clinging to life, screamed in agonizing pain as flames consumed his entire body.

With blurred vision, he could barely make out a presence that descended onto the ground.

“Hero...!”

Thud.

And just like that, he was split in half and met his end.

Aindel sheathed her sword and stared at the distant form of the Demon King’s fortress, then took a step forward.

The towering crystal that had extended high into the sky, sealing the Demon King for decades, was no longer visible.

“I have come, demons.”

In response, a massive energy emanated from the direction of the Demon King’s fortress.

“The human you feared so much has arrived.”

Chapter 178: Aindel (1)

Chapter 178: Aindel (1)

Aindel headed towards the Demon Castle, reminiscing about the past great war.

When the invasion of the demons began, Santea was the first to become a sacrificial lamb.

Geography dictated that Santea would have to fight the hardest against the demons, as it bordered on Altelore.

Aindel was an ordinary girl from a rural village. Her father was a retired knight, and the swordsmanship she learned was just a little self-defense technique her father taught her.

Then, one day, the village was destroyed by a demon attack. People were massacred, and in the midst of the horror, Aindel managed to escape only through her father's sacrifice.

In front of Aindel, who had lost her entire family and was stranded alone in the rugged mountains, it suddenly appeared.

It introduced itself as the Holy Sword, emitting a sacred golden light.

It urged her to accept its power and to defeat the demons.

Without any explanation or reason.

However, with no other choices, Aindel accepted the proposal of the Holy Sword. Thus, she became the chosen wielder of the Holy Sword.

Trapped in a white void where nothing existed, she swung the sword until her senses dulled completely. Only then was she able to fully embrace the power of the Holy Sword and return to her original world.

Since time in the outside world hardly flowed when trapped in the white void, nothing had changed.

Aindel first began by exterminating the demons that invaded Santea.

The demons were overwhelmingly powerful, and humanity was nearly extinguished, but with Aindel's arrival, they managed to barely overcome the crisis.

However, the war did not come to an end, and Aindel experienced and witnessed various atrocities within that hell.

And to bring it all to an end, she marched towards Altelore.

With the sacrifices of her companions, the coalition, and numerous people, she succeeded in finally sealing away the Demon King.

After the war ended, people hailed her as a hero, and believers attributed the power of the Holy Sword to the divine force bestowed upon her by the god they believed in.

Decades had passed.

But the war was far from over, and just as it was then, Aindel was on her way to the final battle.

Passing through the barren and rough land without a single trace of vegetation, when she reached the entrance of the castle, the castle gate was already wide open.

Beyond the scattered ash-gray mist, she could sense the presence of numerous demons. Overflowing with bloodlust and malice.

Without pausing, Aindel stepped into the hall.

There were still no demons blocking her way.

Like tamed beasts with their leashes held tight, they merely glowed with a restrained light, hidden within the mist.

“.....”

Reaching the fallen central tower where the Demon King had been sealed, Aindel came to a halt.

A demon was standing there, right in the center.

“I’ve been waiting, hero.”

Apart from slightly pale skin, he was no different from an ordinary human man in appearance and voice.

But he was the strongest archdemon, the second in command of Altelore.

“Where is the Demon King, Azekel?”

Hwaaah!

Aindel released the power of the Holy Sword. A sacred wave dispelled the surrounding mist.

Only then did the hidden demons within the mist reveal themselves, surrounding her from all sides. Among them were high-ranking demons as well.

But there was no sign of the Demon King. Even though she could feel his aura not far away.

Azekel let out a laugh.

“I sense impatience. Are you worried that the Demon King won’t respond to your final struggle?”

“.....”

“Arrogant hero. I had already taken into account the possibility of you coming to Altelore as a final struggle. You wouldn’t catch even a glimpse of his feet. You will die here. Right at my hands.”

Laughter echoed among the demons.

Aindel’s expression remained unchanged.

“You have a long tongue, Azekel. You, who haven’t set foot outside Altelore for the past three years. Was I really that fearsome to you?”

“After waiting for decades, can’t I wait a few more years? Look, ultimately, you’ve found yourself cornered and come to face your fate, haven’t you?”

Azekel extended his hand.

“You are defeated, hero, and with your death, the world will begin anew.”

Simultaneously, a massive pillar of emerald flames surged from the spot where Aindel stood.

Leaping forward to evade the attack, Aindel flew straight toward Azekel. And then she swung her sword.

Azekel’s lips curled into a smile, and he raised his shield. The golden sword energy burned as the hexahedral shield that surrounded him blocked it.

The shield exploded and slammed into Aindel. Aindel raised her own shield to block the impact.

This time, spears materialized in the empty air around Azekel and struck at the shield she had erected.

Sizzle.

As the corrosive green energy ate away at the barrier, Aindel widened her eyes in slight surprise.

Only when she channelled more power into the Holy Sword did the corrosive energy disperse.

Seizing the opportunity, the spears continued to fly, and Aindel managed to fend them off before approaching Azekel once more.

She continued her relentless assault with her sword. Azekel, who had reclaimed his shield, countered her attacks while fending off blows with his raised hand.

At first, they fought mostly in place, but soon the battle expanded to the entire tower.

Amidst the entangled clash of the two beings, the bodies of the ensnared demons were torn apart. Nearby demons recoiled in terror and put more distance between themselves and the battle.

The archdemons watched with stern expressions as the battle between the two monsters raged on in earnest.

The demons who experienced the Great War were well aware of the immense power of the hero Aindel.

The sanctity of the Holy Sword wasn't just a kind of power that could be simply described as strong.

It was a power that made them tremble in fear. Just facing it caused their very souls to be obliterated, a power akin to that of a god.

It seemed as if the very purpose of its existence was to eradicate demons from this world.

However, among the archdemons, there was one being of a different caliber. The mightiest demon aside from the Demon King.

Azekel's power was also overwhelmingly immense.

No matter how strong a demon was, during the past Great War, there was no demon who could stand against the hero except for the Demon King.

Even though the hero's power had significantly waned now, the fact that she was engaged in a battle that seemed evenly matched with Azekel filled the watching demons with reverence.

“Just how far have you fallen, hero! Your power from back then is nowhere to be found!”

Azekel's offense grew wild. The clash of bare hands and swords sent shockwaves reverberating through the air.

Amidst numerous exchanges of blows in a short span, Aindel, who had blocked Azekel's attacks, was pushed back.

Azekel smirked and drew upon more mana.

Thump, thump, thud!

Mana streams spread out beneath his feet like tree roots. A huge, semi-transparent deity-like form took shape.

Aindel momentarily halted her attacks and stared at the spectacle.

Each demon had their unique abilities. The stronger the demon, the more uncontrollable and overpowering their abilities tended to be.

And Aindel, who hadn't fought against Azekel even during the Great War, was unaware of his abilities.

The giant deity-like figure Azekel created was adorned with numerous eyes, making it incredibly eerie.

The eyes that had been restless now focused on her.

“...!”

As its eyes blinked, a massive explosion occurred around Aindel.

Aindel soared into the air to evade the explosion. The explosions continued to happen in succession with each blink of the other's eyes, relentlessly

pursuing her.

Aindel moved around, dodging and avoiding, until she closed in on the giant and swung her Holy Sword.

The sword strike, now infused with a much stronger force than before, hit it, but even so, the giant's body showed no signs of damage.

Azekel swung his arm, and it followed suit, pushing Aindel away with its arm. As she was thrown back, another intense explosion followed her.

Watching her land some distance away, Azekel spoke with a slightly disappointed expression, "Truly underwhelming. If I had known you'd become this weak, I wouldn't anticipate this moment in vain."

As Azekel raised his hand, the giant raised its hand as well.

As his hand lowered, enormous emerald spears fell from the sky like the gods' cudgels.

Kwaahhh!

At the spot where the attack concentrated, a massive pit appeared, rendering the ground invisible. Within it, a faint golden light flowed out.

Undeterred, Azekel pressed on with his assault. Multiple times, spears poured down like a torrential rain towards the pit.

Kugugugugu...

Azekel raised the corner of his mouth as he observed the pit, then his expression solidified.

Suddenly, the hero clad in golden armor emerged, rising into the air.

"This is more power than I expected, but....."

Aindel slowly raised the Holy Sword.

“You’re not worth it, Azekel.”

A brilliant radiance engulfed the blade of the Holy Sword, soaring up to the sky’s end and transforming into a massive sword.

Azekel raised both of the giant’s arms in defense.

Aindel’s sword cleaved the giant in half. An intense flash of light covered the entire area.

“.....!”

Azekel, narrowly avoiding a direct hit, distanced himself from Aindel.

At that moment, a flash of light once again illuminated the scene. It was Aindel’s second sword strike.

Simultaneously, blood splattered from Azekel’s body. Despite only grazing him, the impact resonated through his soul.

“Ugh...!”

Azekel, sensing that allowing another attack would lead to his demise, became desperate.

Only then did the other archdemons, who had been observing, intervene. However, their participation only served to buy a brief moment.

Valark, the fifth-ranked archdemon, distorted the space around Aindel and immobilized her. Aindel swung her sword once again, cleaving through the distorted space.

Immediately, Farkkuli, the ninth-ranked archdemon, took control of his demon underlings and launched a suicide assault on Aindel. Clenching and unclenching her hand, Aindel caused them all to explode in place.

Bandapmoshan, the fourth-ranked archdemon, summoned giant plant stems from the ground. Yukecil, the sixth-ranked, and Honka, the second-ranked,

directed frigid cold and bloody projectiles towards Aindel, who was surrounded by the stems.

Boom!

Once again, a burst of golden light erupted, annihilating all the attacks from the archdemons.

The attack obliterated the lesser demons and low-ranked archdemons, and even the higher-ranked ones couldn't escape unscathed.

Azekel continued to gaze at Aindel, who still appeared unharmed. A sacred energy emanated from her entire being.

“If you have no intention of summoning the Demon King, I'll just kill all of you and find him.”

Aindel raised the Holy Sword once more.

This time, she unleashed a strike intended to decisively eliminate most of the archdemons present.

It was that moment...

Ssueeeee.

The holy power of the Holy Sword, which had been spreading far and wide in all directions, disappeared as if being devoured by darkness.

There were no loud explosions or shockwaves. It simply vanished like that.

At the same time, all of the archdemons, including Azekel, bowed their heads to the ground.

In a situation where the battle had not yet ended, vulnerable and defenseless before Aindel.

“...”

Aindel lowered her sword and turned her head.

An ominous aura had quietly spread throughout the area.

It was a presence that she hadn't felt in decades.

“That's enough.”

The Demon King.

With a dry and lifeless voice, the darkness split apart, revealing its form.

Chapter 179: Aindel (2)

Chapter 179: Aindel (2)

White skin. Slightly larger build compared to an average human. Enormous horns protruding from the forehead. Violet-colored pupils.

But with his arrival, the presence of all the demons, Azekel included, was erased, and it wasn't because they had withdrawn their energy.

It was a silent, chilling presence.

Aindel wielded the Holy Sword. Once again, the blade brimming with divine energy flew towards the Demon King...

Crash.

But even that disappeared into thin air before reaching the Demon King, dissipating as if bursting in the empty space.

"I know you have reached your limit. Save the last of your strength."

With the Demon King's words, drops of blood trickled down from Aindel's mouth.

For an instant, the vision blurred, and the Demon King's figure split into two before merging back into one. Aindel pressed her temples tightly.

Seeing that the Demon King showed no sign of attacking, she also slowly sheathed her sword.

Because she knew. There was no use in showing unnecessary arrogance before that damn creature. It would only be a waste of energy.

Dealing with Azekel and the archdemons had already depleted most of her power. If even a brief moment of recovery time was granted, she should accept it as it was.

In the heart of the Demon King's castle, under the dim violet sky, a heavy silence prevailed.

The unresolved battle of the past was replayed on the same stage, decades later.

The only difference was that the hero had grown so weak, and the resurrected Demon King had fully regained his past strength.

A fight with an ending predetermined from the start.

It was when Aindel began to prepare for her final battle...

"It's hard to comprehend."

The Demon King spoke.

"Why did you make this choice? If you had led the coalition forces, there might have been a slight chance."

"....."

"Decades ago, the human I saw as a hero despised sacrificing others, yet still possessed discernment. You, more than anyone, would have known that. From the beginning, there was never a possibility for you to kill me alone here. Do you believe that the power of the Holy Sword can kill me or that the coordinated attacks of the remaining riffraff would pose a threat to me?"

The Demon King's gaze upon Aindel subtly shifted.

"What on earth were you thinking? It's unlikely for you to be this recklessness, so there must be something you trust in. Or perhaps..."

Before the sentence could conclude, Aindel's posture changed.

The blade of the Holy Sword aimed at the Demon King's throat like a flash of lightning. The Demon King reached out his hand. His palm blocked the strike of the sword, filled with divine power, and couldn't break through. Pushed back by the surrounding darkness, it could go no further.

The lingering darkness coalesced around the Demon King into the form of a sword hilt. Aindel retrieved the sword and stepped back.

The sword of darkness was aimed at her and shot forth. The swords multiplied, growing from one or two to dozens in an instant, and they swiftly surged towards her.

Aindel momentarily dodged and deflected the swords in a struggle, but faced with the relentless multiplication of the swords, she eventually unleashed a burst of energy in all directions.

A divine power akin to the sea pushed back the Demon King's strength. As if thorns on a hedgehog, the swords were embedded in the golden radiance, and the struggle continued. Eventually, the blades shattered and were destroyed.

Clang!

Aindel, once again, coughed up blood and staggered.

Her lips were pale, devoid of color, and now even tears of blood streamed down. Beyond her unfocused vision, the Demon King's form split into multiples once again before consolidating.

"Hero, do you remember? Our first conversation when you and I first met."

Wiping the droplets of blood from her chin, Aindel lunged at the Demon King once more.

This time, tendrils emerged from the swamp-like writhing darkness around the Demon King.

From the floor, from the walls, and from thin air, they were like the grasp of the dead rising from hell. They stretched out and grabbed her ankles,

clawing and tearing as they went.

The holy armor that had protected Aindel's body and even blocked Azekel's deadly strike began to crack little by little.

After the armor finally shattered, wounds started to appear on Aindel's body. Her flesh split open, and blood spurted out. Undaunted, Aindel pressed forward. Passing through the cracks of hell, she swung her sword at the Demon King's neck once again.

The Demon King clenched his hand around the blade of the holy sword. In that state, Aindel gathered the last of her strength. The Demon King also braced against that force.

Rumble!

The ground trembled, and the air churned.

As if the world was split in half, light and darkness that marked the boundaries surged and pushed against each other repeatedly.

“...!”

For the first time, a determined gasp escaped from Aindel's lips.

She was that desperate. Even if it meant using one arm or even suffering minor injuries, it didn't matter. This was what she started, and the place she had determined to be the end.

Thud.

The darkness, which seemed to be receding for a moment, swelled with energy.

And Aindel's left arm was devoured and disappeared into the darkness. The sacred power of the Holy Sword vanished without a trace. Aindel, now without strength, tumbled to the ground.

“Ah...!”

Azekel's eyes sparkled with emotion as he exclaimed in admiration.

How long had they yearned for this moment?

Never had they doubted the mighty god. However, it couldn't be denied that there was a tiny fragment of unease and worry, even though it was as small as a grain of sand, within their hearts.

It had been the same many years ago. On that day, when the outcome of the war was clear, the hero who had emerged among the insignificant beings wielding a single sword had performed miracles with a power distinct from this world.

But look now. Behold that wretched figure, writhing on the ground like a wingless insect.

They had waited a long time. The archdemons, including Azekel, could finally break free from the past and embrace complete confidence. This world would soon become their paradise.

“You once asked me, ‘Why do wars erupt? Why do we kill so many people and commit terrible deeds?’”

The Demon King spoke, looking at the fallen hero.

“And so, I asked you the same. ‘What are you fighting for?’ You spoke of peace, justice, and all those dull words. I wonder if your convictions remain unchanged. What has the world been like during the decades I slumbered? Has your desired peace arrived?”

The Demon King took a step forward.

“As a soul divided by the power of the Holy Sword, trapped in many bodies, I have watched the world outside of Altelore. There were those who devoted themselves to protect the hard-won peace, like you. But there were also those who wielded power recklessly and selfishly. They invaded, killed, watched indifferently, and even when one war ended, a new one swiftly began. Humans are just like that. Greed, compassion, ambition,

righteousness, desire for life, benevolence. Your emotions and desires are all so different, causing conflicts that never cease. What a contradictory and confused species you are.”

“...”

“Demons, on the other hand. Our only desire is to kill, to trample, to ravage, to dominate. No existence exists that transcends those instincts. If only demons were left in this land, then unending battles and slaughter would be the world’s justice. No one would have complaints about that paradise.”

The Demon King asked, seemingly genuinely curious.

“Hero, what is the justice you spoke of? For what are you still fighting?”

Aindel struggled to rise, staring at the Demon King with unfocused eyes.

When the Holy Sword appeared before her for the first time.

Aindel swung the sword. She had only one fervent desire—to become strong and save the world.

She became stronger than anyone else. She defeated countless visible demons and saved people.

Yet, Aindel soon realized. She was nothing more than a child wielding a massive sword.

There were many people she couldn’t save, no matter how powerful she was, and there were many humans who were no better than the beasts that shook his tattered heart.

Power-hungry rulers were willing to sacrifice armies to preserve their own lives, betrayers aligning with demons for personal gain, soldiers committing heinous acts against civilians without a second thought in the chaos of war.

Why were you struggling so hard to save these pitiful humans? What was it for?

Dozens of times such thoughts shook her mind. Aindel fought not only against the demons throughout the war, but also against her own inner turmoil.

Yet she was able to endure and fight to the end because of her comrades.

Some were adventurers, some were mages of the Magic Tower, and some were nobles from prestigious families. They fought bravely on the front lines, facing death more valiantly than anyone else, even without the power of the Holy Sword.

After the Demon King was sealed and the war ended, there were almost no comrades left by Aindel's side.

Aindel herself suffered great regrets and became terminally ill, and the Demon King didn't die completely, so it was uncertain when he might resurrect again.

Aindel devoted herself to repairing the damage of the war. Once some stability was restored, she followed the revelation of the Holy Sword and disappeared from the world to nip the remnants of the Demon King and find the heir.

Did the peace she hoped for come after the war?

There were no more demonic invasions, but the Emperor of Santea ostracized, slaughtered, and plotted against the other races.

The conflicts between the neutral countries located between Seintea and Calderic never ceased, and under the belief that she needed to prevent even greater chaos, she herself remained proactive in resolving these disputes.

As the Demon King said, conflicts were endless. Even if the demons were completely eradicated from this world, that fact would remain unchanged.

Still, at some point, Aindel no longer agonized over such matters.

Whatever it may be, she realized that one reason was enough. With a serene voice that contrasted the tragic battlefield, Aindel replied.

“Because I am human.”

The demons were absolute evil. They could not coexist.

To humans, no, to all races except demons, there was only one definitive truth.

A smile finally formed on the Demon King’s lips, as if he had received the answer he desired.

“Yes. And because I am a demon, your world will perish.”

Aindel lifted the Holy Sword with her remaining arm. In response, the Demon King also raised his hand.

As a hero, there were no regrets or lingering attachments in her life. She only felt a slight concern for a young girl.

And so, starting from Kaen, what emerged at the end of her flickering thoughts was oddly the image of the Seventh Lord.

“...I implore you.”

The Holy Sword, shrouded in a golden glow, was thrust downward.

A flash of light erupted, its brilliance devoured by the darkness, quickly fading away.

Swish.

As Aindel stood, sword lowered, her form gradually turned into ashes and dispersed.

The archdemons watched the spectacle, barely daring to breathe.

“....”

However, the Holy Sword did not disappear alongside the hero.

Even after she was gone, it emitted a faint light, hanging in the air with dignity.

The Demon King observed it, then took a step forward and extended his hand toward the blade's hilt.

-Vanish.

Flash!

With that voice, a powerful aura burst forth from the Holy Sword.

“My Lord!”

The surge of immense divine power startled Azekel. However, that energy quickly faded away.

After the light vanished, the Holy Sword was no longer there.

The Demon King looked at his smoldering hand, raised his head, and declared, “Gather the troops.”

No matter what the hero had believed, it was nothing more than a futile hope.

They would march to Santea.

Chapter 180: Heart

Chapter 180: Heart

Kaen wandered around the manor, waiting for Aindel.

She had said she would return around sunset due to some business at the palace, but she hadn't returned even after the sun had completely set.

"She's late..."

Suddenly, an unfamiliar foreboding feeling crossed Kaen's mind, but she shook her head.

Hadn't the atmosphere around Aindel been the same until this morning? It was time, so she would be back soon.

At that moment, Nuremberg came down from upstairs. Kaen asked him, "Aindel is late, Mr. Nuremberg. She said she would only talk briefly with His Majesty the Emperor and return."

"..."

Nuremberg's face was bitter without any response.

Kaen's expression also began to harden as she sensed an odd sign from Nuremberg.

"Kaen, Aindel, she..."

Woosh!

With a dazzling light, the Holy Sword appeared in the empty space right in front of Kaen.

Simultaneously, the surroundings were dyed entirely in pure white. Startled, Kaen looked at the enormous figure that had appeared before her.

-I will begin the succession. Accept the power of me and Aindel.

And in the next moment, an irresistible, immense power surged through his entire body.

At the same time, something continuously flowed into her mind. It was Aindel's legacy—the profound techniques she had learned and used throughout her life: swordsmanship, martial arts, magic control, all the way to the profound mysteries Kaen had yet to reach.

The seemingly eternal moment lasted no more than the blink of an eye in reality.

After the succession ended, when Kaen regained her senses, the surroundings had returned to the manor's hall.

Standing dazed for a while, Kaen gripped the Holy Sword before her.

At the sudden change in the atmosphere, Nuremberg realized that the succession had ended perfectly.

“What is this...?”

In an instant, the Holy Sword dispersed into light and vanished.

Tears streamed down Kaen's face as she sensed something had happened.

“What is this, Mr. Nuremberg? Where is Aindel right now?”

Nuremberg opened his mouth.

“Aindel... went alone to Altelore to fight the Demon King.”

“What did you say?”

“As you know, Aindel’s remaining lifespan was limited. So, instead of dying without accomplishing anything after the succession, she made a choice.”

What more could be said?

“Why didn’t you tell me? Why?!”

Facing Kaen’s gaze, filled with anger and despair, Nuremberg could only utter the words.

“I’m sorry, Kaen.”

Kaen, please forgive me for leaving this final farewell in a letter.

I will meet my death at the hands of the Demon King in Altelore. You probably heard from Nuremberg why I made this decision. It was a predetermined fate, but my choice was my own.

If you have successfully inherited the Holy Sword, not only the sword’s power but also everything I’ve accomplished would have been fully passed on to you. The training over the past few years was all meant to prepare you to receive those powers effortlessly. I sincerely hope that the succession has concluded without any major issues.

The invasion of the demons will probably commence very soon. Once my absence becomes known, there will probably be great confusion within the alliance. So, Kaen, I hope you can take on my appearance using the power of the Holy Sword and fight as the hero.

Honestly, I don’t know what else to write.

There are so many things I want to tell you, but I’m not sure what to say. Kaen, you must be curious as well, but you haven’t asked me many things

during this time. However, I don't want to lay out all the intricate stories in detail in this letter.

Kaen, on one hand, I had hoped that you wouldn't inherit the Holy Sword.

It's not because I don't trust you. If the inheritance had gone smoothly, you would have become a much greater hero than me. It's just that, like how you think of me, you were also a precious existence to me.

I lived my whole life on the battlefield. My family died in the war caused by the demons, and I, the sole survivor, gained the power of the Holy Sword. I killed countless demons and eventually sealed the Demon King, but the war still didn't end, and my task wasn't over. To prevent the resurrected Demon King, a new hero who would inherit the Holy Sword was needed.

Although it started because of the inheritance, the past few years were an invaluable time for me to temporarily escape from that battlefield. At the crossroads of life, the reason I could feel no regrets was largely thanks to you, Kaen. I truly mean it.

Kaen, I'm truly sorry.

Even until the end, there's a truth I can't tell you directly. So, all I have is a heart full of apologies.

Even if you were to learn of it later, I hope you would understand that it wasn't that person's fault. They could only inflict a great wound upon you, but their feelings toward you were entirely sincere. There is absolutely no falsehood in that.

And this is a story for a more distant future.

I have no doubt that, Kaen, you will be able to defeat the Demon King. However, even after that, there will always be an unending cycle of conflicts in the world. Even if the demons are completely wiped out.

I hope you won't be greatly disappointed by that fact. Remember the conversations we've had so far? I wish you could understand why I was

able to continue fighting.

As I write this, I realized I'm asking for a lot of things even though I'm someone who left without even saying goodbye.

Even if you forget everything, I won't harbor any resentment. I have no right to say this, but I truly only wish for Kaen's happiness.

Defeat the Demon King and surely find your own happiness.

Take care, Kaen.

Kaen read all of Aindel's letter that were passed on to her by Nuremberg and set it aside.

Her head was spinning, and the contents of the letter didn't quite register in her mind.

...Wishing for happiness? To defeat the Demon King and find happiness?

Kaen felt resentment towards Aindel.

Leaving without a final word and then saying such irresponsible things—how could she do this?

She had nothing now. There was really nothing.

Aindel, her father, Ran, her friends—they were all gone, vanished, betrayed, fallen into the hands of demons.

All that remained was a burning desire for revenge and the task she had to fulfill as the hero inheriting the Holy Sword.

“I can't be happy anymore, Aindel.”

Kaen folded the letter neatly, tucked it into her arms, and rose from her seat.

Saaaah.

The Holy Sword summoned into the air enveloped Kaen in light.

After the light disappeared, in her place stood not Kaen, but Aindel.

As she left the room and descended the mansion's hallway, Nuremberg, who had been standing there all along, was taken aback when he saw her.

“...Is it Kaen?”

Kaen spoke.

“I have to deliver the news to the Emperor. I'm heading to the capital.”

After the hero bid farewell and left, I gazed out of the window for a long time.

The crimson sunset descended upon the castle and, as time passed, darkness covered everything. It was only after the day had fully dimmed that I withdrew my gaze from the window.

Was it over?

I had a feeling that by now, the final outcome had been reached.

I sat down at the desk and took out the small notebook from the drawer.

After somehow becoming the Seventh lord, during the time I stayed at the Overlord's castle, I transcribed all the information I knew into Korean to not forget.

Back then, there was nothing I could feel assured about. I had survived without dying and made it this far.

-The top priority is survival. Obtain the mysteries that can be obtained and acquire the minimum abilities to protect oneself.

-I don't know when the Overlord will assign tasks to me. I must raise my specs while the Overlord is still firmly in the illusion about my strength. Don't be swayed by the [King of the Soul] as you were last time, and avoid conflict with the Lords as much as possible.

-Once a certain level of safety is secured, find the hero. By now, the hero is eagerly searching for the heir of the Holy Sword. If I share the information I know and propose cooperation, the hero won't reject me.

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On the back pages of the notebook were notes where I, a fledgling Lord, roughly organized my plans.

I skimmed through them and quickly closed the notebook. I could sense a figure paced the hallway outside the room.

"Come in, Asher."

A moment later, the door opened, and Asher entered.

She looked around the room and cautiously spoke.

"It's long past dinner and you haven't come out, so I thought I'd call..."

I nodded without saying a word.

Asher stared at me for a moment and asked.

"You didn't meet the hero during the day, did you? What happened?"

The hero turning to ash and scattering. Her endgame flashed through my mind again.

If the hero was dead, then what happened next would be just as she had said.

The invasion of the demons would start soon. And Kaen would take on the form of Aindel and fight as the hero.

“Sir Ron.”

Asher’s call snapped him out of his reverie.

“Are you alright?”

I looked at Asher.

Her gaze was full of concern as she looked at me.

Why was she looking at me like that? I haven’t even mentioned anything about the hero yet. Was it that obvious?

“I’m fine.”

I answered as usual and stood up from my seat.

But after standing in place for a moment, I slumped back down and hung my head.

“Sir Ron?”

Asher approached by my side.

I grabbed her hand. She seemed startled and let out a small gasp.

“To be honest, I’m not okay.”

“...”

“Asher, the truth is, I’m not strong at all. Neither physically nor mentally. I’m afraid of being exposed as weak, so I’ve always put up a front. I never wanted to become the Lord of Calderic, nor did I want to fight for my life

against archdemons or other Lords. In reality, I'm just an ordinary human..."

Facing death up close, and watching someone's death countless times, both were painful experiences.

The [Soul of the King] was only capable of defending against the shock to the mind. It's not an ability to kill emotions.

That's the only reason I had been able to endure without losing my mind.

I spilled out the tangled mess of my heart.

There was a moment of silence.

I realized I'd said something stupid and was about to let go of her hand.

Asher pulled me into an embrace.

Stunned by the suddenness of this unexpected gesture, I couldn't say anything as I was held in her arms.

"I had a vague idea."

"....."

"After being by your side for several years, how could I not know who Sir Ron is?"

Asher's voice was incredibly gentle and calm.

I could feel my heart pounding in my head, on the other hand. I couldn't help but smile.

Come to think of it, Asher was the only one who had been with me from the beginning to the end.

I felt fortunate that it was her and not someone else.

I know what kind of feelings Asher harbored for me.

I had known her for years. There's no way I wouldn't have noticed.

And now, I was not much different.

I slowly lifted my head from Asher's embrace.

"Asher."

"Yes..."

"The hero traveled alone to Altelore to burn the last bit of her life. The invasion of the demons will start soon."

The future I knew had finally come to an end.

If there's something beyond this...

"When it's all over, then I'll tell you my story. Who I am and what my real name is."

Chapter 181: Decisive Battle (1)

Chapter 181: Decisive Battle (1)

The Great Plains of Darrow, dividing the borders of Santea and Altelore. Rangers scanning the plains from the tallest hills nearby suddenly felt an ominous current and shivered.

A dark wave slowly rose over the horizon.

The rangers momentarily lost their thoughts and gazed at the sight. Soon, someone spoke with a resolute expression.

“Hasten to send a messenger.”

The time had come.

The invasion of the demons had begun.

The news of the demonic advance came a week after the hero's departure.

After the formation of the alliance and the hero's departure, constant reconnaissance forces were stationed in the Great Plains of Darrow between Santea and Altelore.

The center of the plain was controlled by Santea, the north by Calderic, and the south by Adessa.

Although an alliance had been formed, there was no need to intermingle reconnaissance forces, so each faction had divided the boundaries and monitored the movement of the demons.

A swift report came from them.

“Well then, since everyone is gathered, shall we go?”

The Overlord rose from his seat as all the Lords gathered in the conference room of the Overlord Castle, fully armed.

The Overlord would now head to the capital of Santea.

It was to attend the coalition conference requested by the emperor as a representative of Calderic.

The entirety of the monarchy – the nine Lords, and Calderic’s forces were ready to march into the plains at this moment.

Of course, the other factions were the same.

This would be the final discussion.

After consolidating opinions with Adessa and Santea, the Lords who were waiting and preparing would be informed of the conclusion, and then the war would commence immediately.

This matter was decided upon since the formation of the alliance.

“Did you perhaps receive the news incorrectly? Or did you receive additional reports that the demons are suddenly regrouping?”

The Overlord’s excessively optimistic demeanor, bordering on cheerful, seemed to baffle the Fourth Lord, King of the Dead, enough for him to remark with a single sentence.

Of course, nothing like that was happening.

The demons crossing the Great Plain would reach Santea’s borders within at least a month.

The Overlord said with a chuckle.

“There’s no need to be so serious. Let’s all just sit back, drink some tea, and wait.”

I had wondered a bit what the Overlord’s reaction would be once the war began in earnest, but it hadn’t changed at all.

Could it be that the Overlord was confident of victory, or did she think that any outcome would be fine?

There was no indication that this war would end with the defeat of the demons.

It was rather the opposite.

And because the Overlord was not a fool, she seemed to lean more towards the latter than the former.

Thinking to myself that she was a consistently unpredictable woman, I spoke up.

“I’ll accompany you to the meeting.”

The Lords’ gazes turned to me. The Overlord asked with a puzzled expression.

“Really? Why?”

“I simply want to see Santea’s hero with my own eyes. There’s no particular reason.”

There’s no reason for other Lords not to attend the meeting.

It’s just that the Overlord didn’t want to go through the hassle of traveling with them.

“Is that so? Then do as you please.”

The Overlord accepted as expected.

I left the conference room with her and rode on a wyvern.

“You seem interested in the hero, Seventh Lord. Is there some connection I don’t know about?”

I shook my head at the Overlord’s question.

“It’s just simple curiosity.”

“Oh, really? With war looming ahead, that’s quite understandable.”

The Overlord let out a laugh.

As always, that laughter had a subtly eerie feeling.

Without saying anything more, I soared into the sky.

It should be Kaen...

The hero I would meet in the capital city soon was likely to be Kaen, not Aindel.

It’s been three years.

Honestly, seeing Kaen’s face directly was still an awkward matter.

But there was no other choice.

There was something I had to tell her before the war began.

January 3, 765, Rachronia Continental Calendar.

After the demonic advance became certain, the representatives of each faction quickly gathered in the Imperial Palace of Santea.

Seated around the round table were the Emperor, the rulers of the Santea Dominion, the kings of neutral nations, the Overlord of Calderic, the

Seventh Lord, the Elf Chieftain of Adessa, and the hero and Nuremberg.

“At the current pace of the enemy’s advance, the vanguard of the demon army will reach the eastern border within a month.”

The Emperor’s calm statement marked the beginning of the meeting.

Some individuals sank into silence.

The invading demon forces were so vast that they were beyond estimation.

The most important thing from the start was not the size of the military force, but the existence of the Demon King.

No one paid much attention to that aspect.

Everyone expected this war to unfold as an all-out confrontation from the beginning.

The demons would simply trample and ravage the lands beyond Altelore with their full strength, just as they did during the Great War.

However, if there was one unexpected aspect to the demons’ movements...

“Furthermore, they are advancing with their forces divided into three groups. We need to discuss this.”

The Alliance had anticipated the demon’s all-out attack from the beginning and had devised their force deployment accordingly.

But that anticipation missed the mark a bit.

The demons did not concentrate their entire army in one place; instead, they divided it into three.

From the central plains, the north, and the south, armies of relatively equal size were advancing side by side.

Naturally, this gave everyone the same thought.

It felt as if they were intentionally dividing their forces to honestly face the three powers: Santea, Calderic, and Adessa.

Of course, it wasn't that we hadn't considered the possibility of the demons dividing their forces.

The problem was the Demon King's location.

There was no way to know which of the three groups housed the Demon King.

"Has anyone managed to gather information about the Demon King's whereabouts, by any chance?"

The Elven Chieftain's question was met with a shrug from the Overlord.

"As long as the fiend doesn't reveal himself directly, there's no way."

What purpose did the demons have in dividing their forces?

Was it merely psychological warfare to sow confusion among the Alliance? Or was there some other scheme at play?

While discussions and opinions were exchanged around the round table, nothing particularly significant emerged. The Emperor spoke.

"The choices seem to be only two: either splitting evenly or concentrating all resources in one place."

This wasn't a complicated war.

The terrain of the plain and the goal of mutual annihilation were both straightforward.

In the head-on battle, where pure strength clashed, the only consideration was the distribution of power.

"Is there a reason to accommodate the demons' pace? Concentrating our forces seems more logical no matter how you look at it..."

To put it a bit extremely, or rather, to say it without any exaggeration, this was a fight between the hero and the Demon King.

The moment one side fell, victory or defeat was nearly instantaneous, much like a fleeting breath.

From that perspective as well, it was indeed a better choice to concentrate power.

It would provide the hero with the most strength, and even if the Demon King wasn't with the initial army, the hero could defeat it and then move on to the next one.

However, everyone had this kind of thought.

Even if power was concentrated, would it truly combine efficiently?

Though they had several years, compared to the history of past conflicts, this alliance was essentially hastily formed.

The mix of factions meant that there were more variables in the battle.

Furthermore, the Emperor was thinking beyond the victory of the war.

In the end, the hero would face the Demon King.

If the hero defeated the Demon King but suffered a mortal wound?

If the tide turned decidedly in favor of the alliance, but the hero wasn't in a normal state?

At that moment, a change of heart by the other two factions would be fatal.

Calderic was always a conflicting force, and Adessa also had events involving the former Emperor.

It's possible that they had been trying to play both sides of the conflict from the start.

There was no way to predict the course of actual battle.

Even the idea of fighting by combining forces was perplexing in the face of such worst-case scenarios.

The hero, who had been silent from then until now, spoke up.

“I think it’s best to divide our forces.”

Her tone was firm, as if she wouldn’t accept any objections.

The Overlord asked, “Why is that, hero?”

“When we concentrate our forces in one place, the rest of the armies can cross the border of Santea.”

It was a simple reason.

And for the demons to set foot on Santea soil meant the slaughter of all life in their sight.

Innocent civilians would die in countless numbers.

No one dared to mention sacrifices for the sake of victory or anything like that in front of her, so there was a moment of silence.

Of course, if Calderic or Adessa were to face the demon’s main force without the hero, it would be a great crisis.

Even if they sent a messenger immediately, it was impossible to predict the extent of the damage by the time the hero arrived.

However, there was no room for complaints about that.

It was no different from demanding the hero to shoulder everything without being willing to take any risks.

In the end, the figure who should face the Demon King was the hero, and Santea bore the greatest burden in this war.

“I will definitely kill the Demon King. Please come to a conclusion.”

The Emperor stepped forward and calmed the uneasy atmosphere.

“The will of the hero is the will of Santea.”

The Emperor, who had difficulty making up his mind, came to a conclusion.

There was no reason to oppose the warrior’s strong stance.

“Well then, there’s nothing else to be done. Calderic will have to follow suit. Confronting the Demon King is the hero’s task.”

The Overlord also accepted it without resistance.

Finally, the Elven Chieftain also pondered for a moment and nodded her head.

“Adessa will follow the hero’s opinion.”

Thus, the intentions of the three powers converged.

After the meeting ended, I approached Kaen.

“Hero, could we have a moment to talk alone?”

Kaen, who was leaving the conference room with Nuremberg, looked at me.

Both Nuremberg and Kaen knew that Aindel and I were in a cooperative relationship.

And Nuremberg knew that I knew that she’s Kaen, not Aindel.

Perhaps that’s why Nuremberg gave a subtle gesture to Kaen and willingly stepped aside.

“What’s the matter?”

After moving to a secluded place and setting up a barrier to block sound, Kaen asked me with a stern voice.

I sighed softly and spoke.

“Kaen.”

“...!”

“I know that you’re Kaen, not Aindel. There’s no need to pretend.”

Kaen was momentarily taken aback, but she quickly regained her composure.

“Did Nuremberg tell you?”

“No.”

“...Then did you hear directly from Aindel?”

“Yes. She came to see me before heading to Altelore.”

Kaen let out a wry smile and muttered.

“Ultimately, only to me...”

I didn’t want to have a long conversation.

Kaen, who gained the ability to discern truth through the power of the Holy Sword.

I felt like I was about to reveal something I shouldn’t have.

So, I got straight to the point.

“Let’s act together from the beginning, Kaen.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Exactly as it sounds. I have the ability to instantly kill the Demon King. If you create an opening, I will definitely end the Demon King’s life.”

It would be much better for the two of us to face the Demon King together than for Kaen to trust only herself.

After all, this was their last chance.

If the situation wasn’t favorable, even acting alone was fine.

This time, she wanted to tie up all loose ends without any regrets.

But Kaen’s response was immediate.

“I refuse.”

“What?”

“I’m refusing. You’re the Lord of Calderic, so take care of that side properly.”

Then she turned away immediately.

I was taken aback and grabbed Kaen’s shoulder.

But she coldly brushed off my hand.

“If you had such amazing abilities, why didn’t you fight with Aindel?”

“That was... Aindel’s wish.”

“Right. That’s why I resent Aindel. You too, and Nuremberg, all of you.”

I was left speechless.

“I will defeat the Demon King alone. Nothing more to say.”

I just stared at her back as he walked away.

Without being able to hold her back.

January 4, 765, Rachronia Continental Calendar.

The Emperor of Santea officially declared war.

A total of more than 30,000 knights, including the royal family, nobles, and clergy, more than 20,000 mages including those from the Magic Tower, over 1 million soldiers, and a combined force of more than 50,000 knights, more than 30,000 mages, and over 2 million soldiers including nations affiliated with Santea and neutral countries.

Excluding the qualitative differences, Calderic's total mobilized force was approximately 70% of that.

Adessa also mobilized all combat-capable tribes, with a total of more than 3 million warriors and elementalists.

January 15, 765, Rachronia Continental Calendar.

Adessa forces fully assemble on the eastern outskirts of the Great Forest.

They began their march towards Darrow Great Plains.

January 17, 765, Rachronia Continental Calendar.

The Santea coalition forces completely assembled on the eastern borders of the Empire. They began their march towards Darrow Great Plains.

January 18, 765, Rachronia Continental Calendar.

The Calderic forces were completely assembled on the eastern boundaries of Calderic.

They began their march towards Darrow Great Plains.

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January 23, 765, Rachronia Continental Calendar.

More than a quarter of the way across the Great Plains from the west, Santea made first contact with a demon army.

“The enemies are in sight.”

The soldiers on the frontline stared beyond the horizon at the waves of black surging forward with resolute faces.

The Demon King and the hero.

The demon army and the Alliance.

The Second Great War for the fate of the continent.

The battle had begun.

Chapter 182: Decisive Battle (2)

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After the meeting ended, they returned to Calderic, and the march towards the Great Plain proceeded at an astonishing pace.

As commander-in-chief, the Overlord was in charge of all the Lords' armies

In this war, the Lords did not have the authority to directly command each of their own forces. This was true except for the forces of the Fourth Lord, the King of the Dead, and the Eighth Lord, the Black Sea Empress.

“Fight with all your might. We will achieve victory.”

Woahhhh...!

Standing before the numerous troops of the Seventh Lord, I delivered a speech that was far from heartfelt, despite my brave words.

Honestly, I hardly felt the sense of being the leader of these cheering masses before me.

Well, how different could it be with the other Lords?

Truth be told, I had no idea what even the Overlord was really thinking, and I suspected that the only who had genuine nationalistic feelings for Calderic was the First Lord.

My mind was filled only with thoughts of how to slay the Demon King and about Kaen.

Calderic's responsibility was the demon forces to the north of the plain.

To the northeast of Calderic lay a massive mountain range.

From the east of Calderic, the combined forces of all the Lords gathered and started their march, advancing along the northern borders of Santea.

“Hey, Seventh Lord. In your opinion, which direction do you think the Demon King is in?”

Three days into our march, the Mad King came up beside me and asked.

I answered vaguely.

“In the center.”

“Why?”

“Just a feeling.”

North, center, south. When you thought about it casually, there was no choice but to have a feeling that the Demon King’s location would be in the center.

Well, because it’s the center.

However, I hoped that the Demon King would be in the northern direction where Calderic’s forces would be.

Only then would Kaen avoid facing the Demon King alone, without me.

Moreover, on this side, we had the Overlord, the mightiest force, apart from the hero.

Hence, having the Demon King appear in the northern army was the optimal strategic move.

Given the situation where the exact strength of the Demon King’s forces couldn’t be determined, the key question remained whether the army going to the north could hold on until Kaen’s arrival.

Naturally, regardless, if the Demon King was indeed in the northern sector, Calderic would suffer significant losses.

But that wasn't my concern.

Whether it's Santea, Calderic, or Adessa, whichever side confronted the Demon King was bound to incur substantial losses.

It's merely a matter of which one of the three it would be.

And, for me, the utmost priority wasn't about preserving Calderic's strength.

It's about commencing the battle with the Demon King under the most favorable conditions.

Even if I held the title of Calderic's Lord, whether the greatest casualty of this war became Calderic or not was a trivial matter, if it is for that cause.

I fleetingly glanced beyond the numerous soldiers to catch a glimpse of the Overlord's figure on the opposite side.

While her true intent remained elusive, nonetheless, in this war, she would undoubtedly exert her utmost effort as an ally.

Defeat equated to Calderic's demise.

If, by chance, the Demon King is in the troops going to the central or south...

At that juncture, I must swiftly conclude matters here and relocate – even alone, if necessary.

If Kaen had accepted my proposition, I wouldn't find myself amidst Calderic's faction; I would remain at her side.

Since it aligned with the hero's wish, neither the Overlord nor Santea could intercede, regardless of whether I stood with the hero or not.

However, Kaen rejected the proposal as firmly as a sword. So, there was nothing else to be done.

Therefore, my options were limited.

“By the way, the Demon King is undoubtedly stronger than someone like Fogwigg, isn’t he?”

The Mad King muttered, then said in a nonchalant tone.

“Seventh Lord, if there’s ever a life-threatening situation for you in this war, I will save you at least once. I’d wager my life for it, even.”

“...What are you talking about?”

“I still haven’t paid my debt for what happened at the Great Forest. That’s what I mean.”

I hadn’t really labeled it as a debt, but it was a good deal, so I didn’t argue.

“More importantly, isn’t this war an opportunity for you too, White Moon Tribe? The position of a Lord might become vacant.”

The Mad King grinned and tapped the back of Asher, who was beside me.

She was referring to the scenario where any of the Lords died, leaving a vacant seat.

With Asher’s abilities, she could have easily become a Lord.

“I’ve never thought about it that way.”

“Heh, set aside the boring talk and tell me once. Among the Lords, who would you want to see bite the dust? Me?”

Asher gave the Mad King a sidelong glance, as if she was annoyed, then answered.

“If I had to choose, I’d pick the Eighth Lord.”

“...Oh?”

The Mad King seemed surprised by the unexpected answer and asked again.

“Why the bug bitch, do you have a grudge against her that I don’t know about?”

“Because she’s the most antagonistic Lord towards Sir Ron. There’s no other reason.”

...Was she talking about what happened back at Gadfalk?

Since the Mad King wasn’t ignorant of the incident either, she nodded in understanding, then alternated her gaze between Asher and me before chuckling.

“You’re always so polite, and now you’re so openly bitchy. Are you saying that you have nothing to fear in this situation, or has something else happened?”

“Why don’t you go back and lead your troops instead?”

“Tsk, look at you. Got it. I’ll go.”

The Mad King said to me for the last time.

“Now that you mention it, watch out for the Eighth Lord during the battle. She’s a demon bitch by birth. Who knows what kind of trick she might pull during this chaos?”

Even without a warning, I would still have been careful. After the Mad King left, I asked Asher.

“Asher, were you concerned about that?”

“Yes. She’s a dangerous woman, isn’t she?”

“That’s true.”

Asher said firmly.

“I will do my best to assist you. Please, don’t push yourself too hard in the war.”

“I have no intention of risking my life to fight. Don’t worry about me. Worry about yourself instead.”

“Yes. I will do that. After all, I need to hear Sir Ron’s real name.”

A promise made in the heat of the moment, swept away by the atmosphere. It was an awkward statement, so I let out a small laugh.

The massive army, numbering in the millions, continued to advance.

Across the plains, towards the approaching enemies on the other side.

And about a week after the march began, we finally reached the end.

I could see them.

It was felt from afar.

A disturbing sense of foreboding that covered the entire other side of the plain.

I confirmed the vanguard of the demon army revealed on the horizon, and our march came to a halt.

It was approximately a distance of 10 km.

Since they didn’t stop on their end, the battle seemed to start immediately.

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At that time, the Overlord suddenly soared high into the sky.

Amid the gaze of the soldiers, a massive flame rose around the Overlord.

It was not merely a simple fire magic, even though the amount of magic power was immense.

The crimson flames converged into dozens of spheres, forming a long tail, and flew towards the demon camp like meteors.

Roar……!

Huge pillars of flame rising one after another from the enemy's lines.

The power was so overwhelming that even though the distance was significant, the frontline soldiers staggered slightly from the delayed shockwave.

“Now, it's the beginning of battle! If we lose, we'll face total annihilation, and if we win, we'll survive! Fight!”

The Overlord's amplified magical voice resounded throughout the entire army.

There were no words, but the tearing roar revealed how high the morale of the army was. The Overlord's preemptive strike had worked.

There was no immediate counterattack from the demon camp. They continued to advance.

The sky was hazy, as if rain could pour down at any moment. The rumbling of millions of soldiers' footsteps on the ground, accompanied by shouts.

Monstrous creatures of all kinds, leading the demon forces, collided with the Calderic army.

In that instant, thousands of lives seemed to be on the brink of death, but the war had only just begun.

The center formation of Calderic consisted of regular soldiers.

Soldiers armed with spear-swords stood at the front, and mages supported from the rear with their magic.

Knights swung their swords, surpassing the demons, and magic bombarded from all directions.

On both sides of the formation, the Undead Legion of the King of the Dead and the Insect Legion of the Black Sea Empress fought separately from the regular army.

Given their monstrous strength, they fought like how monsters naturally would.

The Undead Legion continued to fight tirelessly, even rising up repeatedly with bodies torn to shreds until they could no longer move.

From the sky, the King of the Dead, riding an undead wyvern made of bones, observed the battlefield as he waited for the moment he would no longer move.

I was commanding the army.

The legion of bugs near the Black Sea Empress looked the same as before. Bugs poured out incessantly from the tower stationed at the rear, killing demons and replenishing their forces as they died.

The number of towers was just under twenty. After our confrontation before, it seemed she managed to replenish them quite a bit.

War. It was a massive battle on a scale incomparable to what I had seen at Gadfalk.

I flew on the back of Ti-Yong, observing the battlefield at a glance.

The Lords didn't engage in combat immediately. It was the order of the Overlord.

There were archdemons on the other side too.

And the presence of the Demon King was still uncertain.

And for sure...

Even at a glance, Calderic's overall forces were overwhelmingly greater.

Of course, it was natural.

The demons divided their forces into three, while this side remained as a whole.

No matter how powerful Altelore was, a third of their force couldn't compare to Calderic's entire might.

So, it was the demons who were falling behind. Until the archdemons intervened, there was no reason for the Lords on this side to engage first.

Especially noteworthy were the battle golems seen in the First Lord's command.

The golems began to be deployed onto the battlefield after a certain amount of time, and their power was substantial.

They advanced steadfastly against most attacks, sweeping and trampling the demons with their massive forms.

They also fired magical shots from the magical cannons mounted on their central bodies.

Several mages were on top of the golems, consistently replenishing its mana source. The soldiers nearby naturally cleared the path and fought while escorting the golems.

Of course, the demons weren't just passively succumbing either.

The most annoying ability of the demons was their power.

Whether it's spraying armor-melting poison or summoning spirit-like creatures, more advanced demons can unleash their powers to shake up the battlefield.

Quaaang!

Attacks were even launched towards me as I flew into the sky.

It was a serrated, spinning sphere of magic.

Before I could do anything to stop it, Asher unleashed a sword strike. The pure white sword energy cut through the serrations and exploded on the ground in the direction the attack had come from.

“I’ll leave the defense to you, Asher.”

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I couldn’t find anything particularly foreign or powerful that felt like the Demon King’s presence.

Of course, it was possible for the Demon King to conceal his presence, so I couldn’t be certain.

Found it.

And soon, although it wasn’t the Demon King, I was able to find a significant presence.

Some of the demons fighting against the battle golems were engulfed in a red light. Like madmen, they charged towards the golems and exploded upon impact.

Those suicidal attacks instantly destroyed three golems. It wasn’t a normal level of destruction.

I looked at a spot far behind the scene.

A demon with a conspicuously elongated neck came into view.

Ninth in the archdemon hierarchy, Farkkuli.

The self-destruction attack just now was his ability.

“Let’s go down, Ti-Yong.”

I lightly tapped Ti-Yong’s neck.

If the Demon King wasn’t here, I needed to swiftly end the war and join the others on the other side.

Since this archdemon had revealed himself, it was now time for us to step up from this side.

Chapter 183: Decisive Battle (3)

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Of course, it was possible for the Demon King to conceal his presence, so I couldn’t be certain.

Found it.

How many archdemons were left in the Demon Faction’s forces?

Detrodemian, Akasha, Mephiros, Kargos, Oxytodus, and two lower-ranked that I knew Aindel killed during the surprise invasion.

Only seven were known to be definitely dead.

As for the archdemons Aindel killed alone in Altelore, the exact number could not be determined.

Moreover, it could not be conclusively determined that only the existing archdemons were all there was.

There were also high-ranking demons who were driven away by Azekel, despite their strength rivaling that of archdemons.

Among them, it was uncertain whether some had rejoined the demon army.

But one had just been confirmed.

The ninth ranked archdemon, Farkkuli.

He had the power to self-destruct demons under his control.

The stronger the demon, the more destructive it was, as it exploded all of its magic and life force.

Just now, he simply detonated the lesser demons to destroy the golem.

“I’ll handle it.”

I scanned the area for other archdemons and slowly descended into the chaos of the battlefield.

At least at first glance, Farkkuli was not with the other archdemons.

However, he was surrounded by many high-ranking demons as guards.

“Asher.”

“Yes.”

“That long-necked demon over there, in the center of the circle. We’re going to kill him from this point on.”

Asher nodded with a slightly stiff expression.

“What is your plan?”

“I’m going to jump off the top of his head and ambush him. You will join me only if I fail to kill him in the first strike, or if another high-ranking demon appears.”

“Understood.”

Demons with flight abilities, a handful of wyverns ridden by high-ranking knights and mages, undead and insects, and even magical forces flying from all directions on the ground—engaged in battle. It was quite chaotic. Due to this chaos, I didn’t stand out particularly.

Farkkuli also didn’t seem to be aware of me.

It would be best if I could finish it in one surprise attack.

Descend around that bastard and finish him with blood magic and Instant Kill.

If I failed, I could retreat under Asher’s protection and buy time until the other Lords joined in.

There’s no reason for me to face the guy alone.

Lowering my altitude, Asher mowed down the demons in the path.

As I got closer to the ground, I leaped alone over Farkkuli’s head.

Hooong.

When I was about halfway there, Farkkuli, who was controlling his subordinates, seemed to notice me and raised his head.

One of the demons around him waved his hand and launched an attack towards me.

I fell defenselessly until the last possible moment, then unfurled a floating veil to defend against the direct hit.

This distance should be enough.

And then I immediately initiated a series of spatial leaps.

Blood scattered in all directions, exposing Farkkuli and the other demons to the blood mist.

Narrowing his eyes, Farkkuli reached out his hand.

Whispering softly from above the guy's head, I said.

“Die.”

Farkkuli died without being able to put up any counterattack.

And dozens of demons as well.

Since my abilities weren't completely hidden at this point, the demons might have had some guesses and precautions, but I succeeded more easily than I thought.

I didn't know if he didn't realize I was the Seventh Lord, or if he was caught off guard, but either way, I killed him, which was probably a good thing.

The place I fell was in the middle of enemy territory, so the demons quickly swarmed in from all sides.

But a baptism of sword energy that rained down from the sky quickly dispersed them.

It was Asher.

I had just recovered the cooldown time of my spatial leap and was about to jump onto the back of Ti-Yong, that had landed nearby.

“...!”

A giant blast of cold came from the other side, freezing the area.

I defended using the floating veil.

I blocked the attack, but I was trapped under the ice.

Asher used her special ability and tried to break the ice by swinging her sword.

But it only caused cracks and didn't completely shatter the ice.

Ranked sixth among archdemons, Yukesil.

With this much mana and ice-based abilities, it could only be him.

Damn it.

I was caught off guard.

I didn't sense his presence, so when did he get this close?

As a high-ranking archdemon that used magic, he was dangerous.

No matter how well equipped Asher was, she was not his opponent.

I wanted to retreat, but I was in the middle of my floating veil, so it was impossible.

Once the floating veil was withdrawn, the cold would instantly permeate from all directions.

In a critical moment, Asher's sword, once again soaring, finally succeeded in creating a small opening in the ice prison.

Without missing the opportunity, I immediately used spatial leap as soon as I released the floating veil.

And I succeeded in escaping outside through that opening.

“Sir Ron!”

I barely made it onto Ti-Yong's back and looked down at my frozen left arm.

It had only been touched for a moment, but it seemed to have frozen to the bone. I couldn't feel it at all.

Now is not the time to worry about my arm...

I quickly searched for Yukesil's location.

Since the immense mana was flowing again, I could find him right away.

The one preparing to attack again, emitting cold waves from a distance.

“Go up! Quickly!”

The situation wasn't favorable.

Even if I blocked it with the floating veil, the surroundings were all frozen, making it an incredibly bothersome ability to be trapped in.

If we stayed like this, the three of us would become a friendly trio of ice statues, so I tried to distance ourselves quickly...

Wooong!

Suddenly, a shield flying from somewhere stopped abruptly in the air, spreading iridescent waves of energy.

I realized whose ability that was and instinctively shouted to Asher, who was about to swing the sword.

“It's fine! Let go!”

The waves that covered the surroundings perfectly blocked the oncoming cold.

The area outside that range was all frozen.

Of course, none of the demons swept up in it survived.

The First Lord jumped down from the wyvern above and landed on the frozen ground of the battlefield, retrieving his shield.

“Prepare yourself, Seventh Lord.”

...He came at an astonishingly opportune time.

I sighed and followed Asher down to the ground.

Clad in armor, sword, and shield radiating a prismatic aura, the Wiseman looked in the direction where Yukesil was.

I spoke to him.

“Farkkuli is dead. The attack just now belonged to Yukesil.”

“Understood. Any other archdemons?”

“Other than those two, there’s been no confirmation.”

“Then let’s finish this swiftly. I’ll handle the perimeter guard.”

The Wiseman seemed ready to confront Yukesil personally.

With an explosive leap, the Wiseman flew toward Yukesil in an instant.

“Asher, hold off the demons around.”

“Got it.”

Leaving the ground to Asher, I rode on Ti-Yong and soared into the sky.

In that moment, I sensed an unusual energy from another side and turned my head.

From the source of the energy, a shape resembling a giant caterpillar was crushing and rising over the surrounding demons.

It was immensely large.

【Lv. 95】

...What was that?

I didn't remember that type of demon.

It's a demonic power I didn't recognize.

The caterpillar turned its head toward the direction of Yukesil and the Wiseman, and from its wide-open mouth, an unfamiliar magical energy began to gather.

As I hurriedly moved to intervene and prevent the interference, there was someone who rushed towards the creature from the ground before me.

“Hee-hee! Where should we fight?”

The crimson mana that crushed all the blocking demons and cleared a path in the midst of the enemy lines belonged to none other than the Mad King.

With a swift rise, the Mad King swung her greatsword at the caterpillar's head.

With a tremendous sound, the creature's head spun around.

Crack!

Furthermore, the Thunder Lord began to release lightning strikes from the sky, and suddenly, the King of the Dead, who had approached this way, also began to unleash his magic.

Other Lords began to join the battle in earnest as well.

If the three over there were fighting, there's no need for me to intervene.

I turned my attention back to Yukesil, who I judged to be more dangerous than the caterpillar creature.

The battle between the Wiseman, the oldest and strongest Lord, and Yukesil, the sixth strongest demon.

The Wiseman was indeed powerful.

His battle had a solid feeling, much like an impregnable fortress.

Amidst the frozen hell, he relentlessly countered even the biting cold, pressing on without hesitation.

Even Yukesil seemed to falter, struggling to keep up with the Wiseman's approach rather than maintaining his offensive.

When an opportunity arises, I'll finish him.

Although the surroundings were completely covered in the boundary of cold, it seemed that the energy was gradually waning.

As the Wiseman continued to pressure, a gap would soon reveal itself.

At that moment, I would approach and end it swiftly.

Waaa!

But the fight ended before I could intervene.

Taking advantage of the distraction caused by the Wiseman's retreat, a burst of blue light blew away one of Yukesil's arms. It was a sniper shot from the Heavenly Archer.

The Wiseman didn't miss that perfect opportunity.

The shockwave emanating from his shield immobilized Yukesil's movements, and the sword blade severed his head in an instant.

It's over.

Confirming Yukesil's demise, I turned my gaze towards the other Lords.

At best, the caterpillar could muster the strength of a mid-level archdemon.

As multiple Lords combined their forces, the outcome on the other side was determined swiftly as well.

Engulfed in the clash of intellect and magical power, the twisted figure convulsed and was dealt a final blow by the Mad King, splitting its body vertically.

Was this somewhat the end?

Three archdemons were dead.

Seeing that it's still quiet, it's safe to assume that the Demon King wasn't here.

If there are no more archdemons remaining, the victory definitely belongs to Calderic.

With all the Lords remaining unscathed, all that's left now was to clean up the remnants of the enemies.

That's when it happened.

“...!”

With a chilling aura, a massive green light emerged from beyond.

It was the direction of the Insect Legion, where the Black Sea Empress was located.

From her perch atop her tower, the Black Sea Empress laughed at the carnage beneath her feet.

“Sweep them all away, my children. Opportunities to feast like this don't come often.”

Even the demons who did not fear death and were crazed by bloodshed had no answer to the onslaught.

An absolute difference in quantity was an element that could not be overcome unless there was an overwhelming gap in power.

And the archdemons were on the entirely opposite side of her battlefield.

The Black Sea Empress indulged in slaughter without going there to fight unnecessarily.

There was no Demon King here. If that's the case, the war on this side was the triumphant victory of Calderic.

The Black Sea Empress felt a slight regret at that fact.

Her gaze turned in the direction of where the Seventh Lord was.

Her eyes were filled with malice and bloodlust.

If the war had flowed in a much fiercer manner, there might have been a chance to kill that human in the midst of chaos.

“Well, let's wait and see.”

The battle here might be over, but the war wasn't.

Following this flow, after dealing with the leftovers, they would assess the situation in Santea and join them.

There were still opportunities left.

It was when the Black Sea Empress was having such pleasant thoughts.

“What are you thinking? You look delighted.”

Suddenly, a voice was heard.

The Black Sea Empress turned her head in surprise.

Right beside her stood a demon.

When? She hadn't sensed a thing. Her instinct sent shivers throughout her body.

The demon who had been looking down at the battlefield under the tower gestured.

At the same time, a green energy swept the ground and burned tens of thousands of insects to ashes.

And all the other towers as well, except the one where they stood.

It was just a mere moment.

The frozen Black Sea Empress soon realized the identity of the demon.

A- Azekel.

She was going to die.

Swiftly, a massive hand appeared over the head of the Black Sea Empress, who had leaped from the tower.

Snap.

Her body was snatched up like an insect and crushed with a bloodless sound.

Chapter 184: Decisive Battle (4)

Chapter 184: Decisive Battle (4)

Santea, Calderic, Adessa—while there was a slight time difference in their encounters with the demon forces, in terms of scale, they happened nearly simultaneously.

While Calderic was in the midst of continuing the war, a fierce battle was also unfolding in the south of the Great Plain.

“Engrave Adessa’s pride into the filthy demons’ bones! Make them pay the price for defiling our forests!”

Beastmen fought with demons amidst the chaos.

The forms of countless spirits stretched across the sky, controlled by the elves.

Having suffered two major attacks from the demons, Adessa was no less determined than Santea.

When their weapons broke, they tore their enemies apart with their claws and teeth.

Even as they fell from exhaustion, they would bite and tear at the enemy until the last moment.

The spirit mages fought just as fiercely as these warriors.

Many pushed themselves to the brink, blood flowing from eyes, noses, and mouths, and those cornered by the enemy used the power of the spirits to self-destruct, taking the enemies with them until their last breath.

In the center of the battlefield, Udakbat, the beastman chieftain, and Shandra, the Elf chieftain, were battling two archdemons.

Bandapmoshan, fourth in rank.

Valach, fifth in rank.

It was they who blocked the two chieftains who were driving the demons back more than anyone else.

Kwaah!

Giant plant stalks stretched out from the ground and surrounded Udakbat.

Udakbat swung his crescent blade.

The sweeping arc of the blade cut through the stalks.

As he leaped, trampling on the falling fragments and charging like a beast, ripples spread through the empty space around him.

Udakbat leaped backward in a blur of motion.

Out of nowhere, plant stalks shot out of the rippling air and struck the place where he had just been.

More plant stalks followed suit, sticking to him confusingly.

Udakbat cut down the stalks on his left as he flew.

A blast of wind from elsewhere defended his right side, slicing through the stalks.

Paaaa!

This time, flowers bloomed from the stems of the plants on the ground, and they began to emit a thick cloud of yellow pollen.

Udakbat sensed the unfamiliar energy in the pollen and intuited that even a slight touch could be lethal.

Simultaneously, a massive whirlwind surged.

The whirlwind encircled Udakbat, blowing away all the pollen and safely guiding him down to the ground.

“Tsk.”

Landing on the ground with the wind, Udakbat clicked his tongue and sighed.

Then Shandra descended beside him.

Above her head, the great spirit of wind flickered.

“Not an easy situation.”

Shandra murmured, her gaze fixed on the rampant plant stems sweeping across the area and the two archdemons beyond.

Bandapmoshan’s ability was to summon and freely manipulate enormous plants.

And Valach’s ability was to distort space.

The plant stalks were not just large but incredibly tough, and contact led to the absorption of mana, limiting their movement.

Plus, the mysterious pollen.

With Valach’s spatial ability added to the mix, the chaotic attacks from all directions made the situation extremely challenging.

The only silver lining seemed to be that, apart from those two, there didn’t appear to be any other archdemons around.

The southern part was not the main base where the Demon King was located.

If they could defeat just those two high-ranking archdemons, the war would have turned into a victory for Adessa.

Of course, even if they achieved victory here, the war wouldn't be over.

Unless the Demon King was killed, the demon forces would remain formidable, no matter how many archdemons were slain.

Therefore, they had to quickly finish this battle and head to support the side where the Demon King was.

“If you can block the spatial attacks as much as possible, I'll break through the rest on my own so we can get closer.”

“Understood.”

Shandra created a path of wind in the air.

Riding that path, Udakbat charged through the plant stalks.

Once again, a fierce battle began.

Dreadful.

Blood, screams, corpses, agony.

Kaen looked down at the battlefield with empty eyes.

Whether by their own will or the will of others, everyone was fighting for their lives.

While some were paralyzed by fear, others remained unyielding in their determination, even until the moment of death.

For the nation, for family, for faith.

Or perhaps for revenge.

If there had been at least something to protect, what kind of heart could one have fought with?

She would never know.

Before the war began, she had pondered such thoughts.

Moving to face the advancing demons alone, as Aindel had done, was an option.

Not only did she dislike the idea of many people dying, but it was also her immature sense of revenge towards Aindel.

But in the end, it didn't come to that.

Kaen shifted his gaze to the other side of the enemy lines.

A massive and overt energy that seemed to overlook the entire battlefield.

It was the presence of the Demon King.

The main stronghold where the Demon King was situated turned out to be the demon forces in the central direction, which was exactly what Kaen had hoped for.

However, the reason Kaen hadn't joined the battle yet was due to Nuremberg's obstruction.

"How long do we have to wait?"

Nuremberg, who stood by Kaen with a determined face, answered.

"Wait until the Demon King makes a move first."

The enemy was the Demon King, an opponent against whom even the power of the absolute Holy Sword could not guarantee victory against.

Observe the opponent's actions and respond accordingly.

It was a natural way to start the battle a little more advantageously.

The demons divided their forces into three, so the size of their troops itself was in favor of Santea.

Of course, if the Demon King or the archdemons were to join the battle, numbers wouldn't mean much, but at least until then, there was no need to move first.

If one was willing to bear the sacrifices of the soldiers who were still dying miserably within sight even now, then yes, this was the best strategy.

Nuremberg had a firm resolve before the war began.

No matter what sacrifices they had to make, they would kill the Demon King and definitely see the end of this hell.

"...I'm done waiting."

But even so, Kaen was not like Nuremberg.

Out of respect for him as an ally of Aindel, she listened to him, but her patience was wearing thin.

Kaen, who summoned the Holy Sword, leapt high into the sky.

Nuremberg gazed at that sight.

He knew she'd been patient enough to wait this long, so he didn't think much of it and prepared to fight himself.

"Please emerge victorious, Kaen."

Flash!

A wave of golden light cleaved the battlefield in half.

The swept-up demons were eradicated in an instant.

And in their place, a massive chasm appeared.

Kaen gracefully descended into that spot and began to walk.

“.....”

The demons on either side of the path were paralyzed with fear, and no one dared to move.

Amidst the ongoing battle, where blood continued to splatter on the front lines, a bizarre and absurd spectacle unfolded in the midst of the demon camp.

If the Demon King had been synonymous with terror for humanity, then for demons, the hero was equally such a presence.

Furthermore, they couldn't understand how the hero they were certain had died was still alive.

Kaen kept walking.

Toward where he could feel the aura of the Demon King. Before long, someone appeared and blocked her path.

It was Honka, the second-ranked archdemon, with a head and horns resembling a goat.

“Who are you?”

Honka asked Kaen.

On the day when the hero had attacked Altelore alone, all the archdemons had been present.

And they had watched carefully.

The figure of the hero who had died by the Demon King's hand, who had vanished without a trace, turned to ash.

Just as Santea, Calderic, and Adessa had scouted the demons' movements, the demons had continued to use their spies to learn about the world outside of Altelore.

Of course, even during their advance.

And until the war began, there hadn't been any ripple in Santea regarding the deaths of warriors. Naturally, Honka scoffed and believed that they were hiding the truth to prevent chaos.

But the hero was alive.

Not some fake. The power felt from the Holy Sword was real.

Kaen raised the Holy Sword without a word.

Honka urgently summoned his power.

His crimson aura covered the surroundings densely.

Saaaah!

However, it was just a single blow.

The third strongest demon's power couldn't even temporarily stop the divine power of the Holy Sword.

A golden line carved through the air, slicing Honka in half.

Kaan took another step.

The more she walked, the further the surrounding demons receded, and a vast space was created.

Finally, she reached the end and stopped.

Standing alone, there was a demon with an appearance not much different from that of a human.

The Demon King stared at Kaen for a moment and then spoke.

“It did seem strange.”

“.....”

“There’s no way Santea, bereft of the hero, would choose to march separately from the other two factions. They’d be annihilated. There must be a compelling reason behind it.”

The Demon King asked.

“Who are you?”

“The hero. The successor of Aindel.”

“I see. Now everything makes sense.”

With each word, with each exchange, there was a chilling feeling seeping in.

She wanted to swing the Holy Sword right now, but Kaen refrained from doing so.

She had her own questions to ask.

“How did Aindel die in Altelore?”

The Demon King replied.

“She vanished after burning away her own life. It wasn’t a grand death.”

Kaen closed her eyes and took a deep breath. Then she asked.

“A grand death. What does a grand death mean to you?”

The Demon King found Kaen's question somewhat unexpected.

He had thought the new hero would want to believe that the death of the previous hero had been noble, and he planned to provide a vague answer with that in mind. But now, the conversation was turning in a different direction.

"Death is just death. No matter how you dress it up, it's meaningless."

"Knowing that, how can you still attempt to bring about the world's destruction?"

It was true. A dead life was nothing anymore.

They couldn't move their limbs, savor delicious food, or converse with anyone else.

The demons were trying to turn hundreds of millions, billions of lives into nothingness.

It wasn't for the sake of their own survival. They were just monsters driven by the instinct to annihilate.

Setting aside her anger, Kaen couldn't genuinely comprehend the breed known as demons.

So, she wanted to ask.

"You're a more boring human than Aindel."

The Demon King no longer felt the worth of continuing the conversation.

Having grasped what kind of being Kaen was, his interest waned.

Both of them were beings perfectly aligned along parallel lines.

Kaen also shared the same thought and asked a different question.

“One last question. Who was the demon that watched me because of the demon’s seed I carried?”

The enemy who killed her father.

The reason that led her onto the path of being a hero. Up until now, Kaen still didn’t know his identity.

But the Demon King was in the same boat.

The Demon King wondered what Kaen was talking about.

The demon’s seed was his torn-apart soul.

It was like the window where he had watched the outside world during the long years of being sealed.

There were no memories dormant in the flesh of the human woman before his eyes.

Without answering, the Demon King reached out his hand. Darkness enveloped Kaen.

At the same time, the divine power of the Holy Sword exploded.

Kukugugugu!

The clash of the two energies spread out in ripples in all directions.

“Fine, then...”

Kaen clenched her lips and grasped the Holy Sword with both hands.

“First, I’ll cut off all your limbs. Then, I’ll ask again.”

Chapter 185: Decisive Battle (5)

Chapter 185: Decisive Battle (5)

I heightened my senses and was able to witness a somewhat shocking scene from a distance.

The Black Sea Empress' army, wiped out in an instant, and a lone demon on top of a tower.

The Black Sea Empress, who was desperately trying to escape, was captured by the demon and exploded.

Literally, she just burst like a bubble.

That's...?

Even though the Black Sea Empress was vulnerable in open combat, she was still a Lord of Calderic.

And yet, she was killed as easily as squashing a bug.

A demon with an unremarkable appearance, not much different from a human.

I realized who it was.

The moment I saw his raw power and the level above his head, I knew it was him.

The first ranking archdemon, Azekel.

During the time when the Demon King was sealed, he had completely dominated Altelore, the undisputed second-in-command of the demons.

It wasn't the Demon King who's on this battlefield; it was him.

A bit unexpected.

Even if demons didn't know about Kaen's existence, it was natural to assume that he, the Demon King's fanatic and the strongest of the archdemons, would be by the Demon King's side.

As expected, it won't be easy.

There were nine Lords in Calderic.

Above all, there's the Overlord.

Of course, the demons probably didn't realize that the force they would encounter north of the Great Plain was Calderic. So, unless their intention was to waste their troops, they must have had a fitting force.

And that force, aside from the Demon King, only Azekel was there.

“...Azekel!”

As if realizing it in an instant, the Wiseman muttered with a stiffened face.

I didn't take my eyes off of him as he tossed the Black Sea Empress' corpse to the ground, crushed beyond recognition.

The Overlord must step in.

【Level 98】

Even if all the Lords joined forces to fight, that monster would still be overwhelming for us.

There's even a two-level difference between him and the Wiseman.

Only the Overlord of the same level could oppose that demon.

Kukukuk.

At that moment, Azekel made his next move.

Leaping from the top of the tower, he soared over the battlefield with a speed that could cut through the air.

A chill ran down my spine, and I shouted, “He’s coming!”

Azekel’s assault began immediately.

The green light that had wiped out the insect horde earlier now covered the sky, like an aurora, radiating a terrifying energy as it poured down to the ground.

If that hit, at least half of the central forces would be wiped out.

But there’s no way to stop it.

Desperately, with Asher and Ti-Yong, I tried to get out of the way.

The Wiseman threw the shield he was holding into the air.

Huah!

Around the shield, a multi-colored barrier spread extensively, starting to fend off Azekel’s attack.

Surprised, I looked at the Wiseman.

Did he block this?

But the frown on his face, and the fluttering of his eyelids, told me that he was struggling.

He was just barely holding on.

Azekel, standing tall in the middle of the sky, extended his energy and leisurely surveyed the battlefield.

Crreee!

At that moment, the Ninth Lord, the Giant King, aimed a massive spear, even larger than himself, at Azekel with determination.

A giant figure appeared around Azekel.

It was the true form of the arm that crushed the Black Sea Empress.

This was Azekel's power, the Giant of Antamara.

A boss skill that had a notorious reputation among players in the game.

The giant easily caught and shattered the full-powered spear thrust by the determined Giant King.

Other Lords also launched attacks, but none of them made even the slightest dent.

What is the Overlord doing?

Why was she still not moving when the situation had come to this point?

I glanced toward the rear of the camp, feeling impatient and puzzled.

However, the Overlord was nowhere to be seen.

Taking advantage of the temporary respite provided by the retreat, I quickly rode Ti-Yong and moved to where the command tent was located.

The chief of staff was watching the confrontation between Azekel and the other Lords with a stony face.

Upon noticing my approach, he turned his gaze toward me.

“Chief of Staff, it's Azekel.”

“...Yes.”

“Where is the Overlord now, and why is he nowhere to be seen?”

The Chief of Staff hesitated, then answered, his face darkening even more.

“That’s because— I don’t know.”

“What?”

“She suddenly disappeared without a word. I’m sorry, but I’m also confused because I don’t know what’s happening right now.”

What nonsense was this?

I couldn’t help but be bewildered by the Chief of Staff’s incomprehensible words.

The Overlord has disappeared?

She just disappeared without a word to the Chief of Staff? Why?

There’s no reason for the Overlord to behave like this.

Even if something urgent had come up, it would be normal to leave some sort of message.

Amidst a fierce battle, was it even reasonable that even the closest aide like the Chief of Staff didn’t know her whereabouts?

“Don’t play around. Where on earth did the Overlord disappear to?!”

If there’s no Overlord, who’s going to stop that monster?

I shouted in desperation, but the Chief of Staff remained silent with the same expression.

I turned my gaze to the man who walked beside him.

The Chief of Staff's closest aide, Kradial, leader of the Shadow Wolves.

He had an expressionless face, but his eyes revealed a sense of turmoil.

Seemed like he didn't know anything either.

"Chief of Staff! Where is the Overlord?"

Kradial followed, urgently asking the Chief of Staff.

Similarly, his expression twisted upon hearing the explanation of the situation.

"What reason could the Overlord possibly have to suddenly disappear? What absurd nonsense..."

Truly an absurd situation, just as she said.

Feeling like I might lose my mind, I turned my gaze back to the battlefield.

By now, the King of the Dead had joined in, layering his own magic on top of the barrier to help with the defense, but it didn't make much difference.

It was clear at a glance that Azekel hadn't exerted his full strength.

He was merely teasing the Lords, slowly increasing the intensity of his attacks.

Just when it seemed like true annihilation was imminent, a massive magical power surged from the direction of the Wiseman.

The fabric of space split wide open, revealing an abrupt appearance of a colossal golem.

...What's that? Was that from the Wiseman?

It was several times the size of the other battle golems, and the magic power it exuded was unparalleled.

As soon as the golem appeared, the Wiseman immediately removed the barrier he had put up without hesitation.

【Level 97】

The golem, towering at an impressive level 97, maneuvered its bulky body to forcefully push away Azekel's aura and charged forward.

Azekel's giant clashed with the golem as their arms collided.

A massive shockwave erupted from the sky in the form of a ring.

Remarkably, the golem stood its ground, unfazed by the impact, and continued its battle of strength with Azekel.

“Is that...?”

The Chief of Staff said, letting out a small gasp.

“Chronogear. A combat golem crafted using ancient magical technology.”

“Ancient magic, you say?”

“Yes. It was made by the First Lord using blueprints provided by the Overlord for the preparation of the war.”

To think they went as far as creating something like this.

Amidst the Overlord suddenly concealing their tracks, this was a piece of relatively good news.

“Chief of Staff, heal my arm.”

I extended my frozen arm toward the Chief of Staff.

The Chief of Staff unleashed healing magic.

After treating my arm, I mounted Ti-Yong once again.

“We need to quickly find the Overlord and restore this situation to normal.”

After giving the final order with the Chief of Staff, I returned to where the Wiseman was.

Kradial followed me.

Kwa-aa-aa-aa!

Azekel was exerting more energy to suppress the golem.

But this time, a dark aura rose from the golem’s body, slowly changing to a greenish color.

It was the exact same aura as Azekel’s.

I couldn’t help but gasp at the sight.

What, did it copy the nature of magic?

Was that an ancient magic technique?

It did not just copy any magic, but the power of a demon, the power of the strongest archdemon, Azekel.

No matter how powerful Azekel was, if a power of the same nature countered him, his opponent would be able to fight without being pushed back. Just like the golem.

Azekel seemed slightly surprised, but he soon showed a smirk.

“You’ve got an interesting toy. I will play with it well and break it.”

Kradial and I descended to where the Wiseman and other Lords were gathered.

The Wiseman, who had been sighing, spoke in a tired voice.

“That thing won’t hold out for long, either.”

I knew that too. Levels didn't lie.

Despite the golem's impressive copying ability, I distinctly felt the difference in magical power between the two.

Both in quality and quantity.

"Where is the Overlord? Why hasn't she moved since that monster appeared?"

I explained the situation to the puzzled Lords.

"Is this really true?"

The Wiseman's face was one of disbelief.

The Mad King muttered in an incredulous voice.

"What the hell is this nonsense? Are you telling me the Overlord fled alone?"

The King of the Dead chimed in.

"If that's the case, then I'll withdraw."

"What?"

"The Overlord has disappeared without leaving a word to anyone. A clear breach of responsibility as the head of Calderic. It seems I also no longer bear the responsibility to continue on with battle."

The Mad King furrowed her brows.

"Stop blabbering nonsense. You're saying you're going to run away."

"That's right, Fifth Lord. The Eight Lord also died in an instant. Is there a reason to risk our lives against that monster?"

"Sure, it's not like I have an immortal body, anyway."

“It’s not complete immortality. And who knows, Azekel might have the power to obliterate my soul entirely. I’m not willing to fight recklessly.”

The King of the Dead looked at Kradial and asked.

“Are you going to stop me, Kradial?”

Kradial remained silent.

In this situation, he had no right to stop the actions of the King of the Dead.

The Lords were not beings who swore loyalty to Calderic.

There was no loyalty strong enough for them to risk their lives and hold their ground in a place where the Overlord had vanished without a word.

Of course, the millions of troops fighting would be abandoned without a word and annihilated.

There was no way Azekel would just let us escape.

Currently, Azekel was facing a golem, but if the core rulers show any signs of fleeing, there’s a high probability he would chase after us.

In the end, someone had to stay and fight.

...I, too, was shaken by the words of the King of the Dead.

Even before the war began, I had one clear goal.

I must help Kaen deal with the Demon King.

Should I continue to stay here and engage in a fight against Azekel with a slim chance of victory?

Of course, I could kill Azekel instantly, but...

I looked up at Azekel.

With my access being completely cut off, I honestly had no confidence to make contact with that monster.

If he had been observing me when I killed Farkkuli, he definitely wouldn't let his guard down.

I recalled fighting against the third-ranked archdemon Kargos in the past.

Even then, I'd been taken down in an instant by an attack that even my super senses couldn't keep up with.

Azekel was far stronger than such a guy.

If I try to fight, my life could vanish in a moment.

I had no intention of dying in this war.

But even if I were to die, it would be better to not die in vain, wouldn't it?

"Yeah, then go away. I'll stay and fight."

With a growl, the Mad King placed her sword on her shoulder.

The King of the Dead turned without any hesitation.

"The choice is up to each of us. I wish you good luck."

Riding on the back of an undead wyvern, the figure of the King of the Dead drifted away in an instant.

"Is there anyone else who'll run away like that skull?"

At the Mad King's words, the Wiseman shook his head.

"Of course, I'll fight as well. But you're quite a surprise, Fifth Lord."

"What's that?"

"I didn't expect you to be so responsible as a Lord."

“What nonsense are you talking about? Don’t you know me? I don’t care how many soldiers die. I’m not concerned about that. Instead of running from demons, I’d rather fight until I fall.”

Even the Giant King chimed in.

“The spirit of a great warrior. I too will not retreat.”

The Wiseman looked at the Thunder Lord. She clicked her tongue and spoke.

“What can I do? My family members are fighting on the battlefield right now, and there’s no way I, the patriarch, would abandon them.”

Kradial spoke up, too.

“I will assist the Lords. The Overlord will surely return.”

Only I and the Heavenly Archer remain.

The Heavenly Archer looked at Azekel briefly and scratched his head before saying.

“To be honest, it feels like we’re all going to die, so I don’t want to fight... Well, I’ll fight for a bit and run away if it gets too dangerous.”

The Heavenly Archer was also leaning towards continuing the fight for now.

Everyone’s gaze turned towards me.

I sighed and looked around.

There was still no sign of the Overlord appearing.

“Sir Ron.”

Asher called my name softly with a determined face.

Asher would naturally follow my decision. But I knew what she wanted to say. She understood my thoughts, what I prioritized in this war.

I opened my mouth to speak.

“You do realize that this is a losing battle, right?”

Whether there’s a rational reason or not, not fighting would be no different from using them as sacrificial lambs and running away. So, even with a low chance, I must wager on this battle.

Here, I would kill Azekel and quickly move to where Kaen was.

“I have a plan.”

“A plan? What kind of plan?”

“Azekel’s power has a single weakness. I know what it is.”

The Lords’ expressions were filled with surprise.

“Is that really true?”

I nodded.

The Giant of Antamara.

An extraordinary ability that combined absolute attack and defense capabilities.

The body is adorned with numerous eyes, as one could clearly see.

And among them, one is the Eye of Antamara.

If we could accurately strike the vulnerable eye, Antamara’s defensive strength would significantly weaken in an instant.

That is, if Azekel’s powers don’t differ from the game’s setting...

I was well aware that there are many differences between this real world and the game's setting.

I couldn't be entirely certain that the description of Azekel's weakness would perfectly match the game's details.

Of course, I didn't have to tell the Lords about this uncertainty.

After all, there's no other way to beat him, so it's half a game of chance.

I explained Azekel's weaknesses and my plan.

After hearing the explanation, the Wiseman asked me, "But how on earth do you know Azekel's weaknesses?"

"There's no time to explain that right now."

I dismissed the question.

"As I just said, unless there's a decisive moment, there won't be a way to defeat him. If we can eliminate that power, I will personally finish off Azekel. I hope you can trust and follow along."

The Mad King was the first to respond. "Fine, let's give it a shot. There's no other option, anyway."

The other Lords also agreed willingly.

The Wiseman opened a space in the air and pulled out a hammer.

A somewhat peculiar hammer with a grayish tint.

The moment I saw it, I recognized its identity.

Mastion.

Forged by extracting the soul of the ancient Dwarven King who almost brought the world to ruin, the ultimate and most formidable weapon possessed by the Wiseman, a paradox of strength and malevolence.

A part of the hammer's handle was stained black, and from what I remembered, if the entire hammer turned black, the Wiseman would die.

In short, it was a weapon that consumed the owner's life force.

It was that powerful, hence the price it demanded was also that great.

"I'll have to put all my strength into a single strike. I'm going right now."

There was no time for further chatter.

All the Lords, including me, looked up at the sky.

The golem's strength seemed to have almost run out, as cracks gradually appeared on its body.

The Wiseman and I rode wyverns and ascended into the sky on opposite sides.

The Wiseman reached out his hand towards the golem, which was on the brink of breaking.

Then, the golem's core burst into a flash, releasing all its magic power and self-destructing.

Kugugugugu!

Through the massive explosion, the Wiseman approached the giant.

The sole weakness, located right in the center of the giant's forehead.

The moment the Wiseman's hammer struck, a black thunderbolt fell upon the giant's head.

With my heightened senses, I could see that his attack had accurately hit the giant's weak spot.

"Now!"

Next, the Lords who were waiting on the ground launched their attacks together.

The Thunder Lord's lightning poured out, the Mad King and Kradial spread their blades.

The Giant King, leaping greatly, collided his massive body with the giant, and the Heavenly Archer attack also hit its mark.

Finally, Asher's strike precisely pierced the center of the giant.

The giant, unable to withstand the damage, collapsed.

Azekel was left defenseless for a moment.

There were no more obstacles left.

I wielded my blood art and unleashed consecutive spatial leaps.

And...

Pwook!

A jade-colored thorn pierced directly through my chest.

Feeling my consciousness sway, I looked at Azekel in front of me.

The guy was looking at me with both eyes wide open.

Despite feeling a burning pain throughout my body, I managed to lift the corners of my mouth.

It was already too late.

You've lost.

Azekel's lifeless body touched the ground, devoid of any strength.

Unable to steady myself, I fell with him.

Someone caught my falling body. It was Asher.

“Sir Ron...!”

Amidst the complete darkness that had stained my vision, Asher’s urgent voice calling out to me reached my ears.

For a moment, it felt like I was about to die, but my vision returned to normal.

I realized that I had lost consciousness for a brief moment.

The Lords surrounded the fallen Azekel.

“Hey, are you alive?”

I felt like I was going to vomit.

The burning pain throughout my body persisted.

“Ugh...”

I groaned and tried to get up.

Asher supported me.

How am I still alive?

I took Azekel’s attack head-on.

It wouldn’t have been strange if I had died right then.

Looking at the pierced wound, I noticed that it wasn’t healing properly.

“I used the Elixir, but it seems recovery isn’t going well. Rest for now.”

With a face worn out from exhaustion, the Wiseman’s half-finished elixir was finally poured into my chest.

I must have survived thanks to the super regeneration that kept me alive for the briefest of moments.

“Azekel...?”

“He’s definitely dead.”

Where the gaze of my eyes fell, Azekel lay fallen.

This was it. Calderic had won.

“Sir Ron, your injuries are serious. Please rest and recover.”

“...Sure.”

Struggling to endure the pain, I leaned back against Asher and closed my eyes.

I just want to rest for a moment, no matter what.

Then, I felt mana from within my arms.

I immediately opened my eyes and pulled out the magical device from within my arms.

It was the communication magical device that I had given to Nuremberg instead of Kaen before the war began.

A precaution to quickly receive contact if Santea encountered the army where the Demon King was.

-Confirmed the Demon King’s location. The Demon King is with the central army.

-As you said, I’ll try to hold on to Kaen as long as I can. If you can join us, do so quickly.

“.....”

Having read the contents, I shook off Asher's support.

Asher held onto me firmly, not letting go.

"No, Sir Ron."

I shook my head.

"I have to go."

"It's not possible! How can you face the Demon King in this condition...?!"

"Asher."

I murmured her name softly.

"I have to go. I don't want any more regrets."

Asher looked at me with trembling eyes.

Soon, she bit her lip and nodded.

"I'll go with you."

I didn't stop her.

I honestly didn't want to take her with me, but it was clear that trying to stop her would be pointless.

"What's going on?"

I said to the other Lords.

"The Demon King is fighting against Santea."

"What? No messenger came, how could..."

"I received word through magic communication. I'll head there immediately."

The Mad King narrowed her eyes and asked.

“Seventh Lord, you’re going to move in that state, for what reason?”

“I will help the hero and definitively defeat the Demon King. Please take care of the aftermath.”

“Hey, wait...”

Brushing off her objections, Asher and I got on Ti-Yong and took off straight into the sky.

“Ti-Yong, it might be tough, but give it all you’ve got.”

With a powerful roar, Ti-Yong increased its speed.

The central plain where Santea was fighting wasn’t too far from here.

With Ti-Yong’s full speed, we would arrive within at least half a day.

Meanwhile, I struggled to keep my wits about me and focused on recovering as much as possible.

How much time has passed? Slowly, the battlefield came into view in the distance.

The Santea army, engaged in a battle against the demons, and the clash of two immense energies that could be felt even from here.

...*Demon King!*

It was Kaen who was fighting against the Demon King.

As I hurriedly tried to move towards that place, the figure of someone blocking the path ahead came into view.

I confirmed who that person was, and my eyes widened.

And for a moment, I could only come to a stop.

“Overlord...”

She, who was looking at me with curious eyes, soon smiled and opened her mouth.

“Welcome, Seventh Lord.”

Chapter 186: Decisive Battle (6)

Chapter 186: Decisive Battle (6)

The beginnings of the Calderic Monarchy dated back hundreds of years.

And it was deeply intertwined with the history of a species called dragons.

Located in the northwest of the continent where Calderic resides, that place was originally a land covered by an enigmatic barrier, rendering it inaccessible.

Some feared that ancient demons were sealed within that land, while others revered it as a sacred sanctuary where gods existed. Some even believed it to be the realm of the afterlife.

Thun. That was the name by which the mysterious land was known before Calderic's birth.

Nothing people thought about Thun was true.

In reality, dragons lived there.

Forgotten history from thousands of years ago, a distant ancient era when sentient beings had yet to properly comprehend or harness magic.

In an age predating the existence of even demons, dragons were considered the absolute beings.

From birth, they could instinctively manipulate mana, and the mere act of breathing blessed their bodies with mana accumulation.

Dragons lived freely, empowered by their absolute strength.

However, their freedom came without consideration for other species.

They would exterminate other races at a whim, bring tribes and nations to ruin, and plunge the continent into chaos.

As this era continued, the number of dragons who believed that things could not go on like this grew.

Recognizing the misconduct of their kin, they saw the need for limitations.

Fortunately, among them, there was a dragon powerful enough to enforce these intentions.

This dragon, along with their comrades, subdued all other dragons through might and became the Dragon Lord.

The Dragon Lord established their dominion in the northwest of the continent and erected a colossal barrier.

They compelled all dragons to live only there.

As ages passed, the existence of dragons gradually faded from the world, and all that remained were legends in the lush land.

The dragons spent most of their time within the realm and only occasionally, with the Lord's permission, could a dragon venture outside to enjoy brief leisure activities.

Of course, any activity causing even the slightest disruption in the world during their leisure was strictly prohibited.

And so, as time passed, a dragon was born.

The dragon's name was Gark.

Born with qualities surpassing even that of the Lord, Gark was the majestic being that concluded the millennia-long history of the realm.

Gark wasn't content with the prospect of spending a lifetime confined within the realm's boundaries.

Thus, eventually, he slew all his kin and shattered the realm's barriers, emerging into the world.

After experiencing numerous leisure activities, Gark harbored a desire to establish and rule a great nation.

And so he did.

He proclaimed his existence to the world and laid the foundation for his dominion in the realm's lands.

Though it began with a mere gathering of some primitive tribes from neighboring regions, the word of a powerful leader who treated all races equally drew countless followers.

Amidst the overwhelming might of Gark, the dragon, no force dared to obstruct him.

And thus, Gark forged a massive united nation.

The most exceptional individuals were appointed as nine Lords, while he assumed the title of the Overlord.

This marked the beginning of the Calderic era.

Dragons have genders, but in practical terms, they held little biological significance; whether male or female, they could propagate offspring without the need for a partner.

They also had an infinite lifespan, so they would not die of old age, but once a dragon had sired an offspring, their lifespan would no longer be infinite.

Around a century after Calderic's establishment.

Although Gark initially had no intention of creating a descendant, he inexplicably did so.

Once his descendant matured, he relinquished the position of Overlord, surrendering his own life to embrace death.

Rashtain, descendant of Gark.

Second Overlord of Calderic.

Rashtain was a dragon born with exceptional qualities, as formidable as Gark, who had been strong enough to kill all of his kind alone.

Just like her father had done, she ruled over Calderic as the Overlord.

Time passed. It kept passing. Hundreds of years went by.

Rashtain seemed to finally understand.

Why Gark had forsaken immortality and chose death.

“It’s boring.”

Everything was just tiresome and dull.

Rashtain was too strong.

If hundreds, thousands of years passed like this, she would become much stronger than she was now.

Dragons were such creatures. They grew stronger just by breathing, and if they set their minds to it, they would become much stronger even faster.

She was a being who inherited the blood of the strongest dragon among such dragons.

Of course, Rashtain knew that there were beings in the world who were strong enough.

The sage of Santea was a mage who transcended the limits of humans and was no less than her in comparison.

And there must be demons in Altelore who could rival her.

But Rashtain didn't feel much excitement about that.

After a long time, they would die of old age, and even if they didn't, she would eventually grow stronger.

That was a predetermined future.

Then, what meaning was there in whatever she did?

Should she set a goal to dominate not only Calderic but the entire world?

Trivial. It wouldn't be much different from ruling over a slightly larger Calderic.

Would she end up like Gark, buried in freedom and boredom?

As more time passed, a great war erupted alongside the demons' invasion.

With the death of the Sage, one of the most brilliant mages in the history of mankind, Santea was on the brink of total destruction.

Rashtain observed the appearance of the Demon King from afar, not involving herself in the war.

She wondered what kind of demon could be so powerful that he could bring all demons to his feet and unite the chaotic Altelore.

And upon seeing the Demon King, Rashtain immediately realized that this entity stood a dimension higher than herself.

Quite impressive.

For the first time, Rashtain encountered an opponent she believed she couldn't surpass, no matter how much time passed.

With such a monster, Santea would surely be doomed, and even Calderic might face the same fate.

Rashtain found some comfort in the fact that she could face her end in battle against such a formidable foe, rather than surrendering to fate.

And then, a hero emerged into the world.

Initially, when news of the hero reached her, Rashtain, preoccupied with the Demon King, didn't pay much attention.

But soon, news arrived that the hero had defeated all the demons and advanced to the Demon King's castle.

Rashtain's interest was piqued.

Thus, she decided to take a closer look at this human.

“Ah...”

The moment she witnessed the hero fighting the Demon King alone.

Rashtain felt an emotion she had never experienced before in her life.

An overwhelming excitement that she hadn't even felt when she first saw the Demon King.

The source of this excitement wasn't exactly the hero, but rather the Holy Sword she possessed.

Because she felt it instinctively.

The power contained within that sword was not of this world.

The hero finally sealed the Demon King and ended the war.

Rashtain wanted to find out the true identity of the Holy Sword.

In the process, she met the hero several times, but the only answer she received from her about the Holy Sword's identity was that even she didn't know.

Were there really beings beyond her own perception in this world?

Rashtain became curious about that.

Very much so.

If the power of the Holy Sword was truly the power of a divine being, she wanted to see that god's form with her own eyes.

A very clear and intense desire arose in her life, which had been full of emptiness.

"Welcome, Seventh Lord. Why have you come here?"

The Overlord asked me. I answered while keeping my guard up.

"...Isn't that a question that I should be asking?"

"Ahaha, you're right."

The Overlord, who had suddenly disappeared, was now on the battlefield of Santea.

I couldn't understand the situation at all.

"What do you want to do, Overlord? Your sudden disappearance nearly led to Calderic's annihilation."

"Oh, I know."

"What?"

“That’s why I’m surprised. Almost annihilated means you finally defeated him. Did I underestimate the Lords’ power too much? Even with the Chronogear, I didn’t think you’d be able to defeat Azekel.”

The Overlord shamelessly laughed.

“Anyway, I’m sorry. It seemed like I wouldn’t have been able to find the right timing to personally deal with that annoying guy.”

“What on earth are you talking about?”

“Look, Seventh Lord.”

The Overlord pointed towards the distant battlefield where Kaen was fighting the Demon King.

“Aren’t you trembling? The hero was giving it her all in the battle.”

“Hey...”

“You know, I’ve always wondered. What is the true identity of the hero’s Holy Sword? Why did such a transcendent being bestow its power upon a mere human?”

“...”

“So, this is a moment I’ve been anticipating for a very long time. I just hope to find that answer here today.”

She had never been a sane woman to begin with, but the aura the Overlord was giving off right now was that of a complete madman.

I couldn’t quite grasp what she wanted to convey.

I thought further conversation was meaningless and asked, “So, what’s the conclusion then? Are you just going to keep watching here without aiding the hero?”

“That’s right.”

“Well then, I’ll go. I don’t intend to just stand here and watch.”

I was about to sneak past when I sensed an unusual current.

The Overlord flew in front of me, blocking my path. As she shook her head.

“No, Seventh Lord. No one can interfere in there.”

“...Cut the nonsense, Overlord. What do you want to do?”

“I just said, didn’t I? I simply want to confirm the true form of the Holy Sword. If the hero ends up cornered like this, won’t something else change within the Holy Sword?”

As if I wasn’t already confused enough, the Overlord’s words confused me even more.

“Should the hero be defeated, the world will face destruction! Are you trying to stop me now out of mere curiosity?!”

The Overlord chuckled.

“Whether the world faces destruction or not is not my concern. You cannot go to aid the hero, Seventh Lord.”

Asher swung her sword. The gleaming blade struck the Overlord’s protective barrier.

In that moment, I attempted to pass the Overlord, but was sent flying by a sudden gust of wind.

“Ugh...”

I unfurled my floating veil to stop us from flying in the air.

However, at the same time, the Overlord’s barrier enveloped the surroundings.

We found ourselves completely trapped within the barrier’s confines.

“Stay right there. If you attempt any foolishness, I’ll have no choice but to kill you.”

Gritting my teeth, I glared at the barrier.

Damn it, I can’t stay trapped like this...

Swoosh!

Just then, an attack launched from behind shattered the Overlord’s barrier.

Quickly escaping the barrier, I looked at the group flying towards us.

The one who had broken the barrier with their attack was the Wiseman. Not only him, but also the Mad King and Thunder Lord were with him.

Why were they here?

“Overlord, why are you here? Why are you obstructing the Seventh Lord?”

Approaching us, the Wiseman held Mastion in one hand and coldly stared down at the Overlord.

The Overlord’s expression cooled slightly as she looked towards us.

“This is an order, Lords. Go back as instructed. I’ll return once the situation is resolved.”

“What? An order? You abandoned us to face Azekel alone and now you’re giving orders?”

The Mad King grumbled in dissatisfaction.

Thunder Lord asked, also struggling to comprehend the situation.

“Overlord, an explanation is needed. What are you doing here?”

The Lord sighed deeply.

“I won’t say it twice. Everyone, leave.”

In the frozen atmosphere, a moment of silence passed.

Facing the direction where the hero and the Demon King were fighting, the Wiseman looked at me and asked.

“Seventh Lord, you said you would help the hero defeat the demon king for sure. Can I believe those words?”

I immediately answered.

“Yes.”

The Wiseman nodded his head. Black currents flowed from the Mastion held in his hand.

The Overlord looked at it and licked her lips.

“You haven’t used more than half of it, First Lord? Are you saying you would die fighting against me?”

“If necessary, I might have to. Rashtain, you are not worthy of being the Overlord.”

Kwaaah!

The power of the Mastion and the Overlord’s magic clashed.

As the Overlord was momentarily held back, I rushed toward the battlefield at full speed.

Flying through the sky, Asher cut down all the demons blocking the path with her sword.

Soon, the battle between the hero and the Demon King came into clear view.

The closer I got, the stronger the pressure became, enough to make my flesh tremble.

It was the aura of the Demon King.

Kaen was alone in the middle of the battlefield, fighting against the Demon King.

Just as I was urgently trying to get closer to Kaen, a demon soared into the sky and blocked our way.

【Level 94】

A demon with four arms and wings attached to its back.

This was an unknown archdemon.

Asher leaped straight from Ti-Yong's back towards the demon and shouted.

“Go!”

Asher swung her sword and descended to the ground along with the archdemon.

I kept moving forward without looking back.

Toward where Kaen and the Demon King.

When I finally reached my destination, the sight that greeted me was Kaen with a divine shield, bravely blocking the attacks of the Demon King.

“...Kaen!”

I immediately jumped off Ti-Yong's back.

Chapter 187: Demon King

Chapter 187: Demon King

Darkness raged all around.

Kaen swung the Holy Sword, pushing back the ceaseless surge of darkness.

She slashed and slashed and slashed.

The scattered darkness repeatedly converged without dissipating.

It was as if cutting through water.

Kaen abandoned responding with sword strikes, releasing a burst of divine energy in all directions to repel the darkness.

Then she leapt towards the Demon King.

The tip of the Holy Sword aimed precisely at the Demon King's heart, but it didn't make contact.

The demon's outstretched hand blocked it when it was just a fraction of an inch away from the other.

As the Demon King clenched and then opened his hand, space distorted, and a massive shockwave erupted.

Pushed back slightly, Kaen stabilized herself in the air, deploying a protective barrier.

The shield blocked the shockwave and dissipated before it could spread further.

Kaen retracted the barrier and gazed at the Demon King.

Even before the battle began, she sensed it vaguely.

The Demon King's power had a foreign aspect compared to other demons.

It wasn't simply just stronger than others.

It was different in some way.

That difference was why Kaen couldn't quite figure out how to break through.

Attacks, like just now, were only noisy assaults.

What truly vexed her was the darkness surrounding the Demon King's entire body.

Even the divine power of the Holy Sword, capable of easily breaking the abilities of any demon, struggled to penetrate that darkness.

Kaen realized by intuition that one must never directly touch that darkness.

At that moment, the Demon King opened his mouth.

"If you avoid it, you'll only end up blocking my attacks."

The Demon King's gaze shifted behind Kaen.

It was the direction where the soldiers of Santea were gathered.

If Kaen hadn't blocked the shockwave, they would have all been swept away without even realizing their own deaths.

Kaen narrowed her eyes at the Demon King's strange tone.

Whooooosh!

Suddenly, the Demon King soared into the sky.

The place where the Demon King landed was right in the middle of Santea's camp.

Descending amidst countless human soldiers, he began to slaughter indiscriminately, unleashing darkness around him and killing anyone who approached.

Startled, Kaen hurriedly followed the Demon King.

However, the Demon King kept his distance and continued to kill humans.

In that brief moment, tens of thousands had already perished.

“You damn bastard...!”

The Demon King, once again soaring into the sky, dropped massive darkness like meteors onto the ground.

Kaen, who was trying to leap and catch up, had no choice but to once again unfold her protective barrier.

Crunch, rumble, rumble.

Although she managed to prevent a massacre, the aftermath of the shock still killed thousands of humans.

Kaen glared at the Demon King floating in the sky, with eyes brimming with determination.

The Demon King slowly descended to the ground and stopped his attacks.

“Do you know how the hero sealed me away in the past?”

“.....”

“She discarded her dying comrades while wielding the Holy Sword, determined to kill me. And using their countless bodies as stepping stones, she was able to pierce through my heart in the end.”

The Demon King reached out his hand.

“Do you understand? New hero. Isn’t this war? To pay attention even to such trivial things, to not even discard such mediocre compassion. How dare you come out and face me like this?”

Swoosh!

Once again, darkness swept through the soldiers.

“Until every human except you dies, you must play this game with me.”

Kaen gritted her teeth and charged at the Demon King.

The Demon King spread his distance once again and unleashed indiscriminate attacks all around.

Kaen didn’t care anymore.

Without looking back at the dying people, she stuck close to the Demon King and unleashed fierce sword strikes.

A faint smile crept onto the Demon King’s lips.

Clang!

The Demon King grasped the sword that condensed darkness in his hand.

The two swords clashed.

The Demon King’s fighting style, which had so far blocked Kaen’s approach and controlled only darkness, had changed.

The Demon King’s swordsmanship had no particular form or framework.

It was like the formless, transcendent entity beyond the limits, like Aindel and Kaen.

Countless afterimages appeared in the air, and thousands of attacks were exchanged.

With bloodshot eyes completely immersed in battle, Kaen swung her sword.

At one moment, the Holy Sword shattered the Demon King's sword and grazed his shoulder.

The Demon King immediately retreated, shrouding his entire body in darkness.

Kaen followed suit, pouring out her divine power.

The golden and pitch-black colors mixed and tainted each other, devouring one another.

It was when Kaen was sure as she watched the darkness recede slowly and took hold of victory.

The Demon King whispered, buried in the darkness.

“If this is your full strength, you cannot defeat me.”

At that moment, the darkness exploded, consuming the divine power of the Holy Sword.

Kaen barely shielded herself from the unstoppable force as she was pushed back.

“Now that I've been resurrected, I've become a more complete being. Did you think you could create two miracles with the same power as Aindel's?”

Once again, the darkness covered Kaen.

Kaen, without even a moment to catch her breath, plunged the Holy Sword into the ground and unfurled a protective barrier toward the encroaching darkness, much like a dam against the tide.

Kuoooooooo!

Kaen realized. This was the true power of the Demon King.

Blood trickled from the corner of her mouth.

She strained to draw out the power of the Holy Sword, but she couldn't completely block the advancing darkness.

It was the moment when the darkness, gradually infused with divine power, attempted to breach and pierce through the protective barrier...

“...Kaen!”

At the voice calling her name, Kaen raised her head.

Someone was falling from above.

Kaen's heart thumped.

For a moment, she thought it was Ran.

But upon closer look, it wasn't Ran; it was the Seventh Lord.

Yet, why could that be?

The urgent tone of the Seventh Lord who called out to her seemed to resemble someone else for a moment.

The Seventh Lord, who descended without being seen, unfolded a secondary barrier against the darkness that had pierced her divine power.

The Seventh Lord had the pallid complexion of a dying man.

Serious wounds were visible on his chest.

In that state, he was somehow managing to defend against the attack of the Demon King.

Kaen looked at him dazedly.

The contents of the letter Aindel had left flickered in her mind.

The truth that the other couldn't speak until the end.

The words about how it wasn't that person's fault.

"...Were you Ran?"

At those words, the gaze of the Seventh Lord trembled faintly.

Kaen was certain. Anger momentarily whitened her mind.

Quaaaang!

A massive divine power exploded, expelling the aura of the Demon King in an instant.

As Kaen exhaled, she glared at the staggering Seventh Lord.

"Yes, you...! You!"

And at that moment, a light flashed from the Holy Sword.

Memories flowed into Kaen's mind. They were Aindel's memories.

Starting from the moment she first met the Seventh Lord, to her final moments.

-Did you really do these things for the sake of succession?

-Trying to take over Kaen's body, how could it be...?

-I'm sorry, Seventh Lord. My indecisiveness pushed you to this point.

The conversation between Aindel and the Seventh Lord on the day her father died.

Kaen clutched her head and let out a moan.

The Seventh Lord stared blankly at her.

“Kaen...”

Immediately, Kaen lifted her head and glared at him.

With eyes that shed tears drop by drop.

“Explain it with your own words... After you survive here!”

With the Holy Sword in hand, Kaen leaped toward the Demon King.

Kaen rushed toward the Demon King.

I stared blankly at that sight.

The divine power of the Holy Sword, erupting like a volcano, intertwined and swirled with the darkness of the Demon King.

What happened to Kaen just now?

Everything was chaotic, but I too pushed away the distractions.

As she had said, survival comes first.

I must defeat the Demon King in front of me.

If I could get us both out of here alive, then I could explain and ask for forgiveness.

I stood up from where I fell.

The appearance of the Demon King, seen for the first time, was remarkably ordinary.

He wasn't much different from an average human male.

However, his presence was truly astonishing.

Devoid of vitality, hollow, and so dark that its depth couldn't be fathomed.

He seemed like the very embodiment of the word "death" manifested in the world.

And a sense of otherness that I couldn't quite put my finger on.

Whatever it was, my task was clear.

The Demon King was focused on clashing with Kaen.

Without any defense.

Once there's a gap, I would approach him and kill him.

I was not in the best shape, and the enormous pressure was crushing the surrounding space, but I had to endure and get closer.

Let's go.

I took a deep breath and exhaled.

With my mind focused, I unleashed spatial leaps, along with blood magic.

The Demon King allowed the approach very easily.

Let's end this.

Upon contacting the Demon King with my blood, I immediately activated Instant Kill.

However, the Demon King didn't die.

He just slowly turned his head, looking at me with eyes shedding tears of blood.

I met his gaze in astonishment.

His mouth opened.

“Why do you possess that power?”

At the same time, darkness enveloped me.

Feeling the Demon King’s power permeating my entire body, I realized.

What the unfamiliar sensation I felt was.

This is...

The power of instant kill, just like what I had.

It was the power of the Demon King.

[The end has come.]

Finally, a voice I had heard somewhere resonated in my mind, and my consciousness was cut off.

[Rise. Put an end to all of this with this.]

Standing in confrontation with the Demon King, Kaen looked back at the fallen figure of the Seventh Lord, who had been pushed far away and had collapsed on the ground.

Struck directly by the power of the Demon King, she could no longer sense even a trace of vitality within the other.

The Seventh Lord was dead. No, Ran was dead.

Kaen felt an indescribable emotion.

Her chest felt like it was about to burst, and her insides felt like they were turning inside out.

“Ughhhh!”

Kill the Demon King.

In the end, that was all that was left.

Tears of blood streamed from the Demon King’s eyes.

For some reason, the Demon King’s aura seemed noticeably weaker.

Whatever it was, Kaen realized it was the last thing the Seventh Lord had done.

Kaen, too, had pushed her strength to the limit and reached a state of exhaustion. This balanced the situation.

Let’s die together.

Kaen mustered up the last of her strength.

The Demon King, bound by the power of the Holy Sword, was fully exposed to the divine energy.

And Kaen, who had given up on defense and focused all her strength on the attack, was also completely exposed to the Demon King’s power.

It was that moment.

“...”

The gazes of Kaen and the Demon King turned to one side simultaneously.

The Seventh Lord, who should have undoubtedly been dead, was standing upright.

I had a dream that I have often had since I fell into this world.

In fact, it's probably all just a dream, and I woke up dozing in front of my computer.

It couldn't be real, could it? Possessing a character in a game world.

“...?”

As I regained my senses, I blinked my eyes blankly.

What's in front of me was RaSa's game screen.

What was that? Did I blink and fall asleep?

I felt like I had a very long dream, but I couldn't remember any of the contents.

I scratched my head and got up from the chair.

Wasn't it just a moment ago that I was throwing items and skills into the Box of Chaos to commemorate the end of the service, and now it turned out it wasn't true?

A notification window was popping up beyond the screen.

Ehh, what could have come out?

“Hey, seriously.”

As soon as I checked the synthesis results, I buried my back in the chair.

What came out was just a mediocre skill.

After raising the character for a lifetime, at least it should have been a first-rate 10-star skill.

I guess I had unnecessary expectations for this crappy game as well.

Ugh.

The phone placed on the desk vibrated.

When I checked, it was a text from my younger sibling.

-Have you left?

-Make sure to come by 6 o'clock without being late.

“Ah, right.”

We haven't gone out together as a family for a long time, so I should start getting ready and head out.

I couldn't believe I fell asleep while playing the game. I didn't understand why I was feeling so out of it.

It's nice to eat something expensive for a change, but I hate the nagging.

They would ask how my job preparation was going. It was obvious that I would be tormented throughout the meal, being told to get my act together and live properly.

I yawned and wiped my face.

“Yeah, let's try living more diligently from now on...”

RaSa's service had ended, and now, I need to quit the game altogether and live diligently. For real.

I moved the mouse to turn off the game.

But suddenly, the cursor became unresponsive and didn't move.

What was this lag again?

I nervously clicked repeatedly, but the game screen itself froze.

I was about to sigh and just turn off the computer.

“...?”

My character on the screen suddenly changed into a different appearance.

A male of the human race with black hair and a pair of golden eyes.

“What kind of bug is this?”

For a moment, I felt puzzled, but soon, I couldn't help but feel strange.

It was because the character was staring directly at me.

As if trying to see me, who was in reality, beyond the screen.

I looked at the name above the character's head.

【The Seventh Lord of Calderic – Ron】

The moment I saw that, I was frozen for a while and then let out a sigh.

“...Ah, right.”

The scenery in the room began to split like pieces of a puzzle.

As the pieces crumbled, darkness engulfed the surroundings.

I let out a bitter laugh and muttered to myself.

“It's not over yet.”

As consciousness returned, what I saw in my field of vision was still the figures of two transcendent beings pushing each other's energy away.

“How...?”

I felt a sense of surprise in the Demon King's voice, which had been as lifeless as an inanimate object before.

Kaen also looked at me with eyes that couldn't believe what was happening.

I was in the same boat. I couldn't understand my current state either.

I felt it instinctively. I definitely felt that I had died.

But then, how was I still alive?

Well, whatever. I took a step forward.

My mind was hazy, as if drunk, and my body was heavy like a thousand tons.

I felt like I could collapse any moment, but I didn't stop and continued forward.

The immense power of the Demon King was noticeably weakening.

I didn't know how he and I had the same power, but his condition couldn't be normal either.

“Ran...!”

I didn't have any grandiose beliefs about saving the world.

Standing against the Demon King was always for my sake.

Because that's the only way to survive. And maybe, when I reached the end of the main story, I might learn the truth of this world.

However, let's end it here.

There's no need for Kaen to sacrifice.

Only one person could die with the Demon King.

Grrrrrr.

The Demon King, bound by the power of the Holy Sword, raised his arm with a creaking sound.

I, who had reached in front of that bastard, also reached out my hand to meet his.

Our palms touched, and our voices overlapped.

“Die.”

“Die.”

Once again, a severe death spread throughout my body, and my consciousness flew away.

Feeling the sensation of sinking beneath deep darkness...

Chapter 188: End Point

Chapter 188: End Point

What happened after death was something I had always wondered about.

Would it simply end after death, or would I return to my original body in the original world?

The answer was neither.

I was now standing alone in a space filled with nothingness, only darkness.

“.....”

What happened and how did it turn out like this?

I looked down at my body.

The body that was a mess until a moment ago was now perfectly fine.

I felt comfortable, without any pain.

Looking at this, it's certain that this place wasn't reality...

Had the Demon King died?

Given the situation, there was no way to know.

I could only hope that my last-ditch struggle, even if it had cost me my life, wasn't entirely meaningless.

Would Kaen be unharmed? If the Demon King died with me, she's probably safe.

It's regrettable that I couldn't leave a proper apology for her.

Asher...

I sighed with bitterness.

I had promised to tell her the story about myself after the war ended.

But that promise would ultimately not be kept.

As I thought about each one, it seemed that nothing had been properly resolved.

I sat down heavily in my place.

There was still no change in the dark space.

Maybe I was supposed to look back at my past life before I died.

I wish someone would explain it.

"There's no need to look back on your life."

After hearing that voice, someone appeared in front of me without any warning. I couldn't help but be stunned when I saw the person's face.

...Me?

The man in front of me had my face.

More precisely, it was the face of the Seventh Lord, Ron.

I sat down in a daze and met the eyes of another me.

But wait, I had heard that voice somewhere before. Where could it be from?

For a moment, I couldn't remember, then I realized.

The voice I heard in my head when I lost to the Demon King.

Now that I thought about it, it was also the voice I heard when I first transmigrated into the game.

...Was it really my voice?

Now that I realized that, I frowned and asked.

“Who are you?”

The other me answered.

“I am you.”

“I know that from your face. What I want to ask is—“

“I'm not the owner of this body. I'm Kang Joo-won from Earth, who possessed this body.”

Kang Joo-won.

My original name before becoming Ron.

The other me seemed to be reading my thoughts and answered.

I hesitated for a moment and then asked.

“Was it you who dropped me into the game world?”

“Yes.”

“It seems like a lot of explanation is needed.”

So, I was the cause of all this?

That didn't make any sense at all.

Amidst my confusion, the other me spoke.

“Where should I start explaining? First, I can say that I’m the original you.”

“The original me?”

“Yes. The very first me before starting countless loops.”

Loop. That word was firmly stuck in my mind.

“Loop? What’s that supposed to mean?”

“I’ll explain everything. Just listen first.”

The other me began to speak.

“The original me wasn’t someone who got transmigrated to this world while playing a game. I was just a pitiful Earthling who fell into this world like lightning, without any knowledge, without the [Soul of a King]. It could be that the magic of this world inadvertently influenced Earth, or it could have been some cosmic error. Anyway, I ended up possessing the body of a prisoner trapped on a prison ship in this world.”

The prison ship... he was talking about the situation when I first possessed this body.

I was about to listen to the story in a daze when a question arose.

“Wait, if you had no abilities, how did you survive there?”

I wouldn’t have been able to escape the prison ship without Instant Kill.

“Just before the Fist Saint was about to blow up my head, I noticed the Chief of Staff’s hiding spot. And the two of them immediately engaged in a battle. Thanks to that, I was able to save my life.”

“What happened next? The ship was sinking, wasn’t it?”

“During the battle between the two, the shattered shockwave from an explosion broke the chain that had clung to my hands. After dealing with the Fist Saint, the Chief of Staff immediately got away from the sinking ship. I managed to avoid death by floating on a broken plank to a nearby island. It was simply a stroke of luck that allowed me to survive.”

Was it just an insane stroke of luck?

The other version of me continued the narrative.

“Escaping from the island was also largely thanks to luck, but that’s not the important part. Perhaps due to the influence of the original body’s owner, some memory remained, including the language and other world knowledge, which was a small blessing. However, having nothing, I had to strive relentlessly to survive in this world. I almost died hundreds of times, met a good mentor and learned swordsmanship, luckily discovered mysteries and grew stronger. I experienced many things, formed many connections. And the meeting with Kaen was one of those connections.”

“Kaen...”

As her name emerged, I found myself murmuring unconsciously.

“Kaen was truly a valuable comrade to me, but she eventually met her end as a hero. Kaen sacrificed her life to take down the Demon King. Compared to her, I, who was infinitely weaker, couldn’t do anything. Instead, I became a burden, forcing Kaen to expend the power of the Holy Sword to save my life.”

“...”

“Both the hero and the Demon King died, and a long time passed after the war ended. Thanks to Kaen, I survived, but a portion of the Demon King’s power remained within me and gradually assimilated with me over time. With that power as a foundation, I eventually gained divine power.”

“What? Divine power?”

What the hell was that?

“Divine power is the power of gods, much like the power of the Holy Sword. Although it’s not a perfect divine power like the death power possessed by the Demon King, it was a power that almost reached that level.”

“Wait, hold on...”

“Don’t think hard about it. A god is what you vaguely imagine a god to be. A transcendent who has transcended the limitations of living things and has become almost omnipotent. Anyway, still unable to come to terms with Kaen’s death, I used my divine power to turn back time. To change the past and bring Kaen back to life.”

...Was this what he called a loop?

I finally began to grasp where this story was going and asked.

“Countless loops, you said. Does that mean the first attempt failed?”

“Yes.”

“Why? You gained divine power and became a god. Wasn’t saving Kaen a relatively simple task, then?”

“Gods are beings beyond the causality of this world. With their abilities, anything is possible, but causality heavily limited their influence on the real world.”

Seeing my puzzled expression due to not understanding, the other me suddenly waved his hand in the empty space.

Then, a table and an apple placed on it, appeared.

“For example, let’s say an ordinary person reaches out and grabs the apple on the table. In that case, the apple is picked up by the person’s hand and floats in the air. The apple floats in the air because the person grabbed it. It’s a completely natural phenomenon and follows causality.”

“Right.”

“But if a god with divine power reaches out and grabs the apple on the table in the real world, the apple simply floats in the air without any causality. It’s because the god isn’t bound by the laws of that world. Even such a trivial action disrupts the causality of the world. Trying to forcibly break those limitations of causality could potentially lead to the destruction of the world.”

It’s starting to make sense.

“So, it’s difficult for the power of a god to directly affect the world?”

“Yes. And the same applies to reversing time.”

Well, that made sense. We’re talking about reversing time, after all.

“So, the way I reversed time had its limitations. I had to give up preserving my memories. But that’s the only way to reverse the time. Even if I tried reversing time without giving up my memories, nothing would change. So, I needed a variable. And that variable was the game, RaSa.”

“...Did you create the game, RaSa?”

“I know myself. There’s no better way for me to retain a lot of information over a long period of time than through a game. I know my tastes. I know what games I enjoy playing.”

Going back in time with memories preserved was difficult due to the limitations of causality.

So, he’s saying that he induced those memories into my mind by framing them as part of the game’s setting.

“Having separated the self that has divine power, I sent myself back to the past. I gave you information and even abilities like Instant Kill and the [Soul of the King]. All of those things, including the visions you often felt, were variables that would change the future.”

“But... why give the abilities in such a way? Couldn't you have just given them normally?”

I asked, recalling how I obtained the power of Instant Kill through the synthesis of the Chaos Box.

“It was a method to minimize the pressure of causality. Think about the Holy Sword. Weren't there various conditions for Kaen to inherit the Holy Sword? The god behind the Holy Sword also devised those conditions to provide his power in a way that minimizes the restrictions of causality.”

“...What does that have to do with the decrease in causality constraints?”

“That could be attributed to the issue of perception. Let's say there's a fairy tale book that tells the story of a hero's epic. If the hero in that story goes through all sorts of hardships and challenges to obtain the power of the Holy Sword, would you seriously doubt the plausibility of it?”

“Well... probably not.”

“Exactly. It's natural for a hero to gain strength through adversity. The causality of a world is closely linked to the perception of the entities that belong to that world. Your acquisition of the power of Instant Kill through the fusion of the Chaos Box is also nothing more than utilizing that perception.”

It was hard to understand exactly, but I moved on. It wasn't that important of a detail.

“Anyway, you went back in time like that, but you just kept failing? Why?”

“Because there was something else that mattered. One of the laws of the universe, along with the law of causality. It's something called fate.”

Fate?

“Like things that are destined to happen?”

“Yes. And Kaen’s death was exactly that fate. Only after dozens of loops did I realize that fact.”

I couldn’t help but be astonished by that statement. Kaen’s death was fated?

“However, I didn’t give up. I kept going back in time. Even if Kaen’s death was fated, I wasn’t willing to accept it.”

“Then how did you...”

“What I was aiming for was just a single bug. If I keep rewinding time and repeating the same period, I believed that even a predetermined fate would have errors occur at least once. There was no real basis for that belief, but I still did it.”

Once again, he reached his hand out into thin air.

“And in the end, I’ve reached this conclusion. Look.”

Waves like the surface of water appeared in the air, revealing a certain scene.

I quickly realized it was the reality I was in just moments before.

Kaen lying on the ground with her eyes closed, clutching her Holy Sword, and the Demon King and I lying in front of her.

And the soldiers of Santea surrounding such Kaen, guarding her.

“She’s not dead. She’s just unconscious.”

“.....”

“Kaen’s death was confirmed at the end of the battle with the Demon King. That fate has now been averted.”

Was that so? Was Kaen alive?

Feeling relieved, I looked towards where my body lay.

Then Asher, who had appeared from somewhere, was seen sitting down in front of me.

Asher was safe, too. That's a relief.

She stared at my face for a long while, then she started sobbing and embraced my lifeless body.

Two versions of myself watched over that scene.

"How many times have you rewound time?"

"It's been so long. I've lost count after thousands of times."

"...You've really gone crazy."

He nodded his head.

"Congratulations on fulfilling your lifelong wish. Let's end this now. It's hard to keep watching."

Now that I had destroyed Kaen's destiny, there's nothing I can do to turn back time from the end point I had finally reached.

Even after hearing my other's self's explanation, I couldn't ask for time to be reversed.

It's regrettable, but now I would truly meet my end.

"No, you won't die."

I opened my eyes wide.

"I will bestow my divine power upon you. Come back to life and return."

"What? The causality..."

"It hasn't been too long since your death, so you can endure that level of causality."

I looked at the other me in silence.

“If you give me your divine power and I resurrect, what will happen to you, then?”

“I will cease to exist. As I said, I am a separate entity, bearing only the divine power without a body.”

“...Then, couldn't you resurrect in that body instead of me?”

The other me raised his head.

“I have memories accumulated over countless eons, reversing time. My identity is already vastly different from that of an ordinary human. Resurrecting in this state would be meaningless...”

He glanced at Kaen and let out a bitter laugh.

“So, now I just want to rest. I'm satisfied with seeing the end. You should go.”

I nodded.

“Then I won't refuse. Thank you. Honestly, I felt quite unjust about dying like this.”

The other me burst into a wry smile.

“But are you really okay? Weren't you in love with Kaen? The person I care for now is...”

“It doesn't matter. Live your life. Return to Earth with divine power or stay in this world.”

Shhh.

A door to reality opened in front of me with a bright light.

I locked eyes with the other me one last time as I felt the immense divine power flow into my body.

“Thank you. For ending it all.”

The other me said.

“Now rest peacefully.”

Leaving my final farewell, I walked towards the door that led to reality.

My vision was engulfed in light, and my consciousness faded into obscurity.

When I opened my eyes, the first thing I saw was Asher’s hair.

I lightly tapped Asher’s shoulder, who was holding me so tight that I couldn’t breathe.

“Asher.”

Startled, Asher raised her head urgently.

I let out a small chuckle.

“Are you trying to suffocate me?”

“Sir Ron...”

Asher’s tear-streaked face lit up with surprise and excitement.

Feeling much the same way as her, and unsure of what to say, I said the first thing that came to my mind.

“My name is...”

Hearing the name, Asher stared at me blankly, then laughed uncharacteristically.

“It’s a difficult name to pronounce.”

What a trivial observation.

I turned my gaze to the side.

On the other side, Kaen was slowly getting up.

The Holy Sword she held gleamed faintly in her hand.

The god behind the Holy Sword would have remembered the countless loops the other me had made.

I should be grateful to him for his willingness to endure those endless loops.

With the death of the Demon King, the demons lost their morale, and the war was coming to an end.

I looked across the sky and saw the Wiseman, the Mad King, and the Thunder Lord flying this way.

Where did the Overlord disappear to?

Did she disappear after the death of the Demon King?

In any case, it was fortunate that the other Lords who stopped the Overlord were unharmed.

I looked at Asher again.

“Let’s go back, Asher.”

With the divine power bestowed by the other me, I could now return to Earth.

I hadn't decided what to do next, but for now, I should keep the promise I made.

"I'll tell you my story. It's not really anything extraordinary, but still."

T/N: Yes, this is the end of the story. I know, some will probably be disappointed by this rushed ending. I was. There's a lot of things that was brushed off, characters that were not utilized properly, foreshadowing that did not come into fruition, etc.

Then, I read somewhere that the author suddenly had a health problem and they had to rush the story. I'm not sure if it's true, but considering the start of the story and how abrupt it ended, and if we think of all the foreshadowing at the start and other characters that had been built up, I believe that the author really had no choice but to end it this way.